

Chapter 1

Snow drifted down from the sky of the twelfth lunar month. In the courtyard, a large cauldron of water was boiling, its steam melting the snowflakes before they could even touch the surface.

The snow on the ground had been trampled into a muddy slush. Next to the cauldron, a door panel rested on a pair of benches, serving as a makeshift table. Half a pig carcass was laid out flat upon it.

Fan Changyu's hand rose and fell, and with a single chop, she severed a hind leg. The board trembled as bone fragments and bits of meat flew into the air.

The bone cleaver in her hand had a thick spine and was pitch-black all over, save for its tip, which glinted as brightly as snow. The mere sight of it was terrifyingly sharp.

On the board also lay a skinning knife and a boning knife. With their identical black iron bodies and snow-bright blades, they were clearly a set with the cleaver in her hand.

Today, the Chen family of the town was butchering a pig for the New Year, and they had invited their neighbors and clan relatives to a lively feast.

The guests, warming themselves by the fire pit inside the house, glanced at Fan Changyu busying herself in the courtyard and began to whisper. "The Fan Er family just finished their mourning rites. Why would the Chens invite that girl Changyu to butcher their pig?"

"The Chens and the Fan Er family are on good terms; they aren't so bothered by taboos..." The speaker, perhaps recalling the Fan family's tragic circumstances, unconsciously lowered their voice and glanced outside.

Fine snow fell like catkins. In the courtyard, the young woman carving the pork wore a simple, half-worn, plain-colored blouse and skirt. She was tall and slender, her dark hair tied up, revealing half of a fair and delicate

profile. Though she was slender of build, her movements were deft and precise.

When Fan Er's wife had first arrived in Lin'an Town with him, she drew many covetous looks. Some jealous old women had even spoke ill of her in private, saying she must have come from a brothel—such were her striking looks. Her two daughters had inherited her appearance, and both of them had very fine features.

The younger one was only five, so it was hard to tell, but if the elder daughter hadn't been betrothed to the Song family's boy since childhood, the number of matchmakers at their door over the years would have likely worn down their threshold.

That person sighed. "Fan Er and his wife were killed by mountain bandits, leaving only two girls at home. And Fan Da is a heartless man, bent on seizing his brother's property. Life is hard for Changyu and her sister! We thought that once Song Yan passed the provincial exam, Changyu's life would get better after marrying him, but who knew that engagement would fall through too. That Changyu girl is tough, though. She followed in her father's footsteps, supporting her family by butchering pigs, and managed to prop the Fan Family up again. The Chens inviting her to butcher their pig is their way of supporting her business."

Hearing these private details, the crowd couldn't help but sigh. But then another voice, hushed extremely low, said, "How come I heard that it was the Fan family's eldest daughter who jinxed her parents to death? And that her younger sister has been frail since birth because she jinxed her too? The Song family went to have their birth charts compared and found out she was born under the Star of Doom and Isolation. That's why they rushed over to break off the engagement..."

The person who had spoken earlier let out a scoff. "Do you know where the Song family had those charts read?"

The crowd's sighs grew louder. For the Song family to break off the engagement at such a time. Anyone with eyes could see what they were up to.

The old saying goes: get promoted, get rich, and your wife dies. Song Yan had passed the provincial exam and was destined to become an official. Why would he still marry a butcher's daughter?

The makeshift table in the courtyard was not far from the main house, so Fan Changyu was forced to overhear the entire discussion about herself, though her face betrayed no emotion.

Her parents had been gone for over a month. She had long since come to terms with it.

As for her and Song Yan, it was nothing more than the old tale of Qin Xianglian and Chen Shimei.

Back then, the Song family couldn't even afford a coffin. Mother Song had knelt on the street with Song Yan, kowtowing to passersby and begging them to help buy a simple coffin to bury her husband. Even after her head was bleeding, no one helped. Her parents couldn't bear to see it and stepped in to buy a coffin for the burial.

Overwhelmed with gratitude, Mother Song had taken the initiative to propose an engagement between her and Song Yan, promising that he would marry her and let her live a life of comfort once he achieved success in the exams.

Later, the two families became neighbors, and her parents often helped the widow and her orphan son. Mother Song was determined for her son to take the Imperial exam but couldn't afford the tuition fee. Before Song Yan was accepted into the county school, it was her father who had paid for much of his tuition.

Song Yan had lived up to expectations. He had passed the prefectural exam a few years ago and then the provincial exam this autumn. Many country squires vied to curry favor with him, and even the county magistrate looked upon him favorably, with rumors that he was quite keen on making him his ideal son-in-law.

Mother Song's attitude then became subtle. It was as if she felt that the daughter of a pig butcher was no longer worthy of her son, the new provincial graduate.

Her mother had sensed that Mother Song was not as easy to get along with as before and, fearing they would be misunderstood as demanding repayment for their kindness, suggested calling off the marriage. But Mother Song had adamantly refused, insisting that her Song family was not the type to forget favors.

Then, after her parents' accidental deaths, a rumor started from who-knows-where, claiming that her harsh fate had jinxed her parents to death.

When Mother Song came to their door to break off the engagement, she used this very excuse, claiming she had consulted a fortune-teller who said her and Song Yan's birth charts were incompatible. If they were to marry, not only would she jinx Song Yan, but since she no longer had parents, she would go on to jinx Mother Song as well.

Thus, Song Yan had logically dissolved their engagement. He was not tarnished in the slightest by the infamy of being ungrateful, while she, Fan Changyu, became the Star of Doom and Isolation that everyone shunned.

Fan Changyu cut off her thoughts and let out a turbid breath.

It was a pile of troubles. Better not to think about it.

After finishing the butchering, she collected her wages and bid farewell to the hosts without even stepping into the main house. People valued auspiciousness during the New Year festival. Although the Chen family didn't mind and had hired her despite the recent death in her family, she knew her place.

The hosts didn't press her to stay, but as she was leaving, they gave her a bucket of offal.

This was an unspoken rule in the countryside. When you hired someone to butcher a pig, besides paying them, you were also supposed to give the butcher a piece of pork. Most of the time, however, offal was given instead.

Before heading home with the offal, Fan Changyu went to the apothecary to pick up two prescriptions of medicine.

One was for her younger sister, and the other was for the man she had rescued.

Yesterday, she had taken a job butchering a pig in the countryside. On her way back, she found a man covered in blood in the snow, looking as if he had been attacked by mountain bandits.

Because her own parents had also died at the hands of mountain bandits, Fan Changyu was moved by compassion and carried the man back.

Unexpectedly, none of the medical halls in town dared to treat someone with one foot already in the grave. She couldn't just throw him onto the street, so she decided to try a desperate remedy. She brought him home and asked her neighbor, an uncle who had been a veterinarian for over a decade before becoming a carpenter, to try and treat him.

Fan Changyu wasn't sure how the treatment was going, but at least he hadn't stopped breathing yet.

The prescription was also from her neighborly uncle.

With the medicine in hand, Fan Changyu headed home.

The Fan Family's house was located in the residential alleys of the west side of town, where houses were packed tightly together.

The alley was dark and damp, with moss growing at the base of the walls. The houses on both sides were old, their plaster mottled and their wooden doors and windows old and dilapidated, emitting a musty, decaying smell.

It must have been a case of enemies being destined to meet. Just as Fan Changyu entered the alley, she came face to face with Mother Song and her son.

Both were dressed in newly tailored winter clothes of excellent material. Mother Song even wore gold earrings, her expression no longer pitiful and timid as before, but rather quite proud.

After Song Yan passed the provincial exam, gentry and wealthy merchants had sent them money and houses. The Song family was now naturally prosperous.

As the saying goes, clothes make the man. Dressed in a raven-blue long robe embroidered with bamboo leaves, Song Yan exuded a scholarly and refined air, a far cry from his previous poverty-stricken appearance. He now had the look of a noble young master.

Fan Changyu had just come from butchering the pig at the Chen household. She carried a leather satchel with her butchering knives, and her patched old jacket was spattered with blood from her work. With a packet of medicine in one hand and a wooden bucket of offal in the other, she looked rather disheveled.

Mother Song subtly moved aside and even fanned the air before her nose with a handkerchief. She was wearing a gold ring on her hand as well.

She truly had become wealthy.

The alley was narrow. Neither mother nor son spoke, and Fan Changyu didn't spare them a glance. Acting as if she hadn't seen them, she walked

straight ahead with her bucket of offal. "Watch your step — —"

As they passed each other, the bucket of offal happened to brush against Song Yan's new clothes, and the bloody water on its side instantly left a large wet stain.

Mother Song's face turned green as she watched Fan Changyu's departing back. "That blind girl!" she said, her heart aching. "This is Hangzhou silk!"

Song Yan's eyes showed no emotion. He only said, "Mother, let it go."

Mother Song's face was full of disgust. "Fine! In a few days, we'll be moving out of this wretched place anyway!"

Meanwhile, just as Fan Changyu reached her front door, a five-year-old snowball of a child heard her and darted out from the neighbor's house. "Big Sis, you're back!"

The little snowball was as exquisitely carved as jade and utterly adorable. She opened her arms to hug Fan Changyu, a missing tooth visible in her smile.

Fan Changyu grabbed the back of her younger sister's collar. "Don't touch. My clothes are dirty."

Xiao Changning obediently stopped and, seeing her older sister's hands were full, took the medicine packet from her.

She had the same almond-shaped eyes as Fan Changyu, but due to her young age, the corners of her eyes looked rounder, and her cheeks were chubby, like a plump porcelain doll.

The neighboring aunt came out at the sound of their voices. Seeing Fan Changyu, she smiled. "Changyu, you're back."

The neighbors were an old couple. The husband, surnamed Zhao, was a carpenter who went out during the day crafting furniture for others or selling rattan and bamboo baskets at the market, only returning in the evening.

The two families were very close. Whenever Fan Changyu went out, she was uneasy leaving her sister home alone, so she would always leave her with the neighboring aunt.

"Auntie," she replied, then picked out a pig's liver strung on a palm leaf from the bucket of offal and handed it over. "Uncle enjoys this. You can fry

it up as a side dish for his wine.”

The aunt didn't stand on ceremony with Fan Changyu. She accepted it with a smile and then said, “That young man you carried back last night has woken up.”

Fan Changyu was taken aback. “Then I'll go over and see him in a bit.”

With her parents gone, it was just her and her younger sister at home. It wouldn't be proper to rashly let an unrelated man stay with them. After bringing the man to Uncle Zhao for treatment last night, she had borrowed a room from them and temporarily placed him there.

Xiao Changning tilted her head up. “That big brother is so pretty!”

Pretty?

Fan Changyu didn't know whether to laugh or cry. She patted the little topknots on her sister's head. “Who uses ‘pretty’ to describe a man?”

However, when she had found him, his face had been caked with dried, blackened blood, making him almost unrecognizable. It was already dusk when she brought him back yesterday, and in her rush to find a physician, she hadn't had a chance to wipe his face or anything.

She truly didn't know what he looked like.

Fan Changyu went back to her house to change out of her butchering clothes before heading next door.

Dusk always came especially early in winter. It wasn't even five o'clock, yet the sky was already dark.

When Fan Changyu entered the room, the light was dim. She could only see a raised shape on the bed.

The room was filled with an indescribable smell - a mixture of medicinal herbs, blood, and sweat.

The weather was frigid. Uncle Zhao and Aunt Zhao, likely afraid the man wouldn't make it through, had sealed the doors and windows tightly and even lit a charcoal brazier in the room. The heat only intensified the smell.

But Fan Changyu had been in pigsties while catching pigs, so she didn't have much of a reaction to the smell. After entering, she only frowned slightly before walking to the table to light the oil lamp.

A single beam of warm, orange light illuminated the small space. When Fan Changyu turned back to look at the bed, she saw the man's face clearly and was slightly stunned.

She now understood why Changning had called him pretty.

Chapter 2

The flickering candlelight cast a warm glow over the simple, dilapidated room. The man lying on the bed was quiet, his face washed clean of blood—pale, refined, and strikingly handsome.

He appeared quite young, with a lean but not frail build. Perhaps due to excessive blood loss, he had fallen asleep again. His long lashes rested against his eyelids, casting fan-shaped shadows under the lamplight. His nose was straight, and even in unconsciousness, his thin, cracked lips were pressed tightly together, suggesting a stubborn temperament.

Such a face paired with his battered body was like a pine tree broken by winter frost yet still standing tall, or a piece of unpolished jade wrapped in rough stone and chiseled full of holes, inevitably invoking pity.

Whether disturbed by the light or the prolonged gaze, his lashes fluttered, and he slowly opened his eyes.

His pupils were dark as ink, yet devoid of any emotion. The slightly upturned corners of his eyes carried an innate coldness.

Fan Changyu showed no discomfort at being caught staring and calmly asked, "You're awake?"

The man didn't respond.

Seeing how severely chapped his lips were, Changyu assumed his injuries were too severe or his throat too dry to speak. "Would you like some water?" she asked.

He nodded slowly and finally spoke: "You saved me?"

His voice was hoarse, like gravel scraping against a broken gong, a stark contrast to his face, which resembled fresh snow under a clear moon.

Changyu walked to the table, poured him a cup of water, and handed it over. "I found you collapsed in the snowy wilderness and carried you back. But it was Uncle Zhao who truly pulled you from death's door."

She paused, then added, "You're staying at his house now. He used to be a physician."

Though a veterinarian.

The man struggled to sit up. The hand that took the chipped earthenware cup was covered in abrasions, barely an inch of unmarred skin. After a few sips, he coughed into his hand, his disheveled hair falling forward, making his jawline appear even paler.

"Drink slowly," Changyu said. "You don't seem local. Since I didn't know your name or where you were from, I didn't report to the authorities. Were you attacked by bandits at Tiger Pass?"

He suppressed his coughs, lowering his gaze until most of his face was hidden in the shadows beyond the candlelight. "My surname is Yan, given name Zheng. I fled from Chongzhou in the north... because of the war."

Ling'an Town was just a small settlement under Jizhou Prefecture. Changyu had never even left Jizhou and knew little of the current situation. Still, when the authorities came to collect grain in early autumn, she figured it was likely for the war.

Her eyelid twitched. A lone refugee fleeing war likely meant his family had met tragedy.

"Do you have any relatives left?" she asked.

At this, the man's fingers around the cup whitened from gripping too tightly. After a long silence, he rasped, "No."

So his family was truly gone.

Having recently lost both parents herself, Changyu understood his grief. She pressed her lips together. "I'm sorry."

The man muttered, "It's fine," but then began coughing violently, as if blood were clogging his throat. The fit worsened until he couldn't hold the cup, and it shattered on the floor, as though he were coughing out his very lungs.

Changyu froze for a moment before snapping into action, calling for Aunt Zhao while stepping forward to pat his back and help him breathe.

He bore numerous wounds from blades and swords, with bandages wrapped tightly from his shoulder blades to his chest. To avoid pressing on the injuries, he wore only a loose inner robe.

Now, after that bout of agonizing coughing, his robe had loosened, revealing the defined muscles of his abdomen beneath the bandages in the

dim candlelight. But the violent coughing had torn open his wounds, and blood slowly seeped through the gauze.

Fan Changyu shouted louder toward the door, "Aunt Zhao, hurry and call Uncle Zhao back to take a look!"

Aunt Zhao responded from outside and rushed out to find her husband.

The man continued coughing violently, his originally pale face flushing crimson. By the end, he leaned over the edge of the bed and spat out a mouthful of clotted blood.

Fan Changyu was startled, afraid he might collapse to the ground, and quickly steadied his shoulders. "How are you?"

Cold sweat drenched his forehead, and his neck down to his chest was soaked as if he had been pulled from water. The thick scent of blood clung to him, his disheveled hair scattered across his brow and forming a picture of utter misery. "Better now, thank you."

He wiped the blood from his lips with the back of his hand, then leaned back weakly against the bedpost, gasping for breath, his neck exposed like a dying beast that had given up struggling.

His condition was far from "better," despite his words.

As Fan Changyu watched him, she couldn't help but recall the moment she first found him, half-conscious and forcing his eyes open to look at her, like a mortally wounded wolf.

By the time Carpenter Zhao finally returned, the man had already passed out from exhaustion, his breathing faint as a thread.

Fan Changyu sat at the doorway, her face as gloomy as a farmer struck by famine, pondering: If this man died, should she go all out in her kindness to buy a cheap coffin and bury him properly, or just dig a shallow pit and toss him in?

Feeling the few remaining copper coins in her pocket, she decided the latter was more practical. She and her younger sister still needed to eat. Digging a pit was already generous enough.

After a while, Carpenter Zhao emerged from the room with a grave expression, saying nothing as he first went to the main hall to pour himself a cup of cold tea.

Fan Changyu assumed the man was beyond saving. "Uncle Zhao, don't blame yourself. If he can't be saved, it's just his fate. Once he's gone, I'll carry him up the mountain and find a decent spot to bury him."

Carpenter Zhao choked on his tea, coughing for a while before recovering. "Nonsense! He's still alive and well!"

Fan Changyu froze, then scratched her head awkwardly. "He coughed up blood earlier, and you came out looking so grim. I thought he was done for."

Carpenter Zhao said, "That young man has a strong constitution. Spitting out that clotted blood means his life is saved for now. But whether he fully recovers depends on careful recuperation and his own luck."

The implication was clear: he would likely become a weakling, unable to lift or carry anything.

He asked Fan Changyu, "Do you know where he's from? Does he have any family left?"

Remembering the man's story, Fan Changyu sat back on the threshold like a famine-stricken farmer. "He said he fled from the north. His family's all dead, and then he ran into bandits here. Now he's got nowhere to go."

The old couple exchanged a glance, opening their mouths but finding no words to say.

Saving someone in the moment was one thing, but continuously caring for an invalid was another matter entirely. The man's injuries were severe, not to mention the expensive medicine required, and an extra mouth to feed meant another bowl and pair of chopsticks.

After a long silence, Carpenter Zhao asked her, "What do you think about this yourself?"

Fan Changyu picked up a stick and absentmindedly drew a few circles on the ground before answering, "I already carried him back from the snowy wilderness. I can't just drive him away now."

Aunt Zhao fretted for her: "Your parents have passed, and Ning Niang has been constantly ill, needing medicine. If you take in another idle person, how will you manage?"

Changyu also felt she'd brought back trouble, but there was no other choice at the moment. "Let him recover first. Once his injuries improve,

we'll see what he plans to do."

Inside the house, the man who had just been treated with a set of acupuncture needles by Carpenter Zhao slowly regained consciousness and overheard this conversation. His dark, jade-like eyes flickered slightly toward the door.

Outside, heavy snow began to fall again under the darkened sky, cast in a warm glow by the candlelight inside, making the cold seem less biting.

The young girl, dressed in an old apricot-colored padded jacket, sat crouched by the threshold. Her elbows rested on her knees, one hand propping up her snow-pale cheek while the other idly poked at the ground with a small stick. Her delicate brows were slightly furrowed, as if she had made some difficult decision.

The elderly couple sighed.

The man's gaze lingered on the girl's face for a moment before he slowly closed his eyes again, suppressing the cough rising in his throat.

That evening, after returning home and ensuring her younger sister was sound asleep, Fan Changyu retrieved the wooden box hidden in the rafters.

Opening it, she found several land deeds stamped with official seals and a handful of copper coins.

The land deeds were what remained after her parents' passing, while the copper coins were what Changyu had earned herself from butchering pigs.

Truth be told, her family had once been relatively well-off. Their current financial strain stemmed from her father's decision the previous year to invest a large sum in building a pigpen.

Her father had been a well-known butcher in town and thought it unwise to keep buying pigs from dealers. He planned to set up his own pigpen in the countryside and hire help to raise the animals. But before the pigpen could be completed, both he and his wife met with misfortune.

The funeral expenses had nearly drained all the available family savings. With no income left, Changyu had no choice but to take up pig-butcherer to make ends meet.

She had considered selling some of the land to ease their situation, but according to the laws of the dynasty, if parents passed away without a

written will, their daughters could not inherit any property. If the deceased had no sons, the estate would go to their siblings.

As a daughter, Changyu couldn't transfer the deeds to her parents' house and land into her own name, nor could she pawn or sell them for silver.

Her uncle was a gambler, drowning in debt, and constantly schemed to seize her family's property to settle his gambling dues. He would often come to harass her, demanding she hand over the land deeds.

Changyu naturally refused. The house was where she had lived with her parents for over a decade, and every plant and tree held a memory. If she lost even this shelter, where would she and her sister go? The streets?

Fearing her younger sister might inadvertently reveal the hiding spot if coaxed by someone, Changyu hadn't even told her where the deeds were kept.

She poured out the copper coins from the box and counted them, the total coming to three hundred and seventy. These were the meager savings she'd managed to set aside from her butchering work after covering daily expenses.

Truth be told, even without taking in the injured man, her family was already on the brink of destitution.

Making a living by helping others slaughter pigs wasn't a sustainable long-term plan. Business only picked up during the twelfth lunar month when many households slaughtered pigs for the New Year celebrations. After the New Year, there was hardly any business left. Fan Changyu figured she needed to reopen the family pork shop.

She did some calculations in her head: during the twelfth month, live pigs cost fifteen copper coins per pound. Buying an eighty-pound pig would require an investment of one string and two hundred coins.

After slaughtering, there would be about sixty pounds of meat left. Selling it all as fresh meat at thirty coins per pound would net her six hundred coins profit per pig.

If she braised the pig's head and offal to sell as prepared dishes, the price could go even higher.

During the New Year season, every household needed to entertain guests, but most ordinary families lacked a complete set of seasonings and

couldn't prepare decent dishes. Many would buy ready-made food from the streets, making braised meat quite marketable during this period.

The idea was good, but the difficulty was that she currently didn't even have enough silver to buy a single pig.

Fan Changyu sighed deeply, putting the copper coins into her sleeve pocket and placing only the land deed back into the box on the roof beam.

She needed to find a way to gather enough money to buy at least one pig first.

Chapter 3

Early the next morning, Fan Changyu left Changning with Aunt Zhao and went out carrying the three hundred wen and a silver hairpin.

The hairpin was given to her by her parents when she came of age, costing over two taels of silver.

If she pawned this hairpin, she should have enough to buy the pigs.

She entered the pawnshop, but the shopkeeper squinted at her hairpin for a long time before holding up three fingers. "Three hundred wen."

Fan Changyu nearly choked. She widened her eyes. "This hairpin is pure silver. Is it really only worth three hundred wen?"

The shopkeeper said, "Though it's silver, it's not heavy, and the style is outdated. I know your family is struggling, so how about this: Uncle will give you five hundred wen. That's the highest I can go."

"One tael. Not a single coin less."

The shopkeeper placed the hairpin back on the counter. "Then you might as well take it back."

Fan Changyu had hoped to pawn the hairpin to buy pigs, but she hadn't expected this unscrupulous shopkeeper to lowball her so badly. Without wasting any more words, she picked up the hairpin and turned to leave.

The shopkeeper hadn't expected this girl to be so stubborn, refusing to bargain at all. He quickly called out, "Hey, come back, come back. Fine, one tael it is. Consider it Uncle taking pity on you, losing money just to take this hairpin off your hands. It's early in the morning, and your business will at least help me start the day with a sale..."

Leaving the pawnshop, Fan Changyu now had an extra tael of silver.

To find out the market price of braised meat, she first wandered down the street where cooked food was sold.

Today happened to be market day. Though it was still early, the marketplace was already bustling. Many farmers from the countryside had

brought mountain goods to sell, exchanging them for money to buy New Year's supplies.

After walking around, Fan Changyu noticed that most cooked meat shops mainly sold roasted chicken and duck. Among braised pork, pork head meat and pig ears were the most common, while offal was the least sold.

A plump auntie, seeing Fan Changyu eyeing the food displayed outside her shop, called out, "Buying roasted chicken, miss?"

Fan Changyu asked, "How much for the pork head meat?"

The plump auntie said, "You've got a good eye, miss! This pork head meat was braised all last night and it smells amazing! Five wen per liang. How much would you like?"

That worked out to fifty wen per jin, but vendors often deliberately quoted higher prices to leave room for bargaining.

To test her, Fan Changyu deliberately said, "That's so expensive..."

The plump auntie immediately replied, "It's the New Year, and hasn't all the meat in the market gone up in price? Mine is the most affordable here. If you really want to buy, I'll give you nine wen for two liang."

Fan Changyu guessed that this was likely the usual selling price, meaning braised pork head meat cost about forty-five wen per jin.

Using this method, she went to other cooked meat shops to inquire about the prices of braised pig ears and offal. Braised pig ears were the most expensive at sixty wen per jin, but since a pig only had two ears, scarcity drove up the price.

By comparison, braised offal wasn't worth much, costing twenty wen per jin.

Not many people ate offal to begin with. The wealthy disliked it, while the poor didn't know how to prepare it properly, often ending up with a strong, unpleasant smell.

Butcher shops didn't even sell it. If someone really wanted to buy, they could get a whole bucket for less than ten wen.

Now that she had a clear idea, Fan Changyu left the cooked food street and headed to the meat market. Beyond that, there was also a livestock market.

The meat market was even livelier than the street selling cooked food. Fan Changyu's family owned a prime-location pork stall here. While all the other pork stalls were open, their chopping boards and iron hooks laden with meat, only her family's stall remained tightly shut, its doorway already taken over by other vendors setting up their stalls.

Changyu felt a pang of bitterness in her heart as she stood there, staring at her closed stall. She silently vowed to reopen it soon.

Turning away, she headed to the livestock market with her money.

The livestock market was far more chaotic. Pigs, sheep, cattle, and horses were all being hawked here. One careless step could land you in some unknown animal's dung, and the stench was far from pleasant.

Most vendors were middle-aged men in short coarse robes, with a few pigs or sheep tethered beside them. Their bargaining cries were filled with trade jargon that outsiders couldn't easily understand.

A young, pretty woman like Changyu stood out conspicuously here.

Some livestock dealers called out, asking what she wanted to buy, but Changyu ignored them all. She had come here with her father before to buy pigs and knew that dealing with these middlemen rarely ended well.

Today being market day, many farmers who raised pigs and refused to sell them cheaply to dealers had brought their animals to sell directly. Their prices were invariably lower than the dealers'.

Yet after looking around, Changyu couldn't find any pigs that met her standards. Her father, with over a decade of pig-slaughtering experience, had taught her to choose pigs with round hindquarters and short, thick tails, since such pigs had thick skin and ample fat, yielding premium meat.

Just as she was about to leave and look elsewhere, she spotted a thin, dark-skinned old man in a corner.

Beside him stood a plump, sturdy pig, its front legs and neck tied with ropes, apparently waiting to be sold. The pig was filthy, and with it still being early, there were few buyers at the market yet. Almost no one had approached to inquire.

The old man gazed hopefully at passersby but didn't dare to call out, clearly not one for smooth talk.

Changyu approached and asked, "Uncle, how much for your pig?"

Finally, someone was asking. The old man nervously replied, "My family's counting on selling this pig for the New Year. The dealers offered ten coppers per catty in the village, so I brought it to town myself. If you want it, young lady, twelve coppers per catty will do."

Changyu was surprised the dealers had driven prices down so low. Other dealers here were already quoting eighteen or nineteen coppers per catty for live pigs, and it took tremendous effort to bargain them down to fifteen.

The old man's price was truly a godsend.

Fortunately, the market wasn't crowded yet, or the pig would have been snapped up already. Changyu quickly said, "I'll take it!"

The market had large scales for weighing livestock. The pig tipped the scales at a hefty ninety catty. Changyu paid the old man one tael and eighty coppers, then drove the pig toward her home in the western part of town.

The meat market had already opened for business. If she slaughtered the pig now to sell, she'd only catch the tail end of the day's trade, facing both fewer customers and lower prices.

Better to go home and prepare thoroughly today, then slaughter the pig and bring it to sell tomorrow morning.

Once out of the livestock market, Changyu driving a pig through the streets made quite a spectacle, drawing frequent glances from passersby.

Fortunately, Fan Changyu had thick skin. When acquaintances asked, she could confidently promote her business, saying this was a pig she would slaughter tomorrow to sell at the meat shop, and they should come by to support her.

By chance, she ran into a chef from a restaurant who used to buy meat from her father's shop while he was out purchasing ingredients. Hearing that her family's pork shop would reopen the next day and seeing the plump pig she was herding, he immediately placed an order for twenty catties, paying two hundred coins as a deposit.

Fan Changyu returned home in high spirits. The alley was narrow, and as she drove the pig forward with a bamboo stick, the sound of her shouts and the pig's grunts echoed through the entire lane.

A nearly snow-white gyrfalcon soared from the direction of her house into the sky. Changyu glanced up, puzzled.

In winter, with snow covering the ground, it was common for falcons to steal chickens or rabbits from rural farms. But in this town, where no one raised such livestock, why had the bird landed near her home?

The houses on either side of the alley were cramped, built uniformly by the government years ago, each two stories tall.

At the end of the alley, in a small attic room, a man reclined by the window on a bed, draped in a dusty old coat that did little to diminish his noble bearing. A thin, burnt-out charcoal stick lay beside the brazier at the foot of the bed.

A piece of his original undergarment had been torn off and placed nearby.

The window was half-open, letting in cold gusts that stirred his robes and long hair.

His face, as pristine as fresh snow under a clear moon, was unmistakably that of the man Changyu had rescued.

The clamor in the alley drew his gaze outside. A striking woman walked cheerfully down the narrow, slushy lane, wearing the same apricot-colored short jacket he had seen the night before, like a sudden warm glow in an otherwise drab and ancient painting.

But what she was herding with the bamboo stick was... a pig?

The pig's squeals confirmed its identity.

The man's expression turned slightly bemused.

He had met refined noblewomen well-versed in poetry and books, as well as spirited daughters of military families. But a woman herding a pig? That was a first.

The woman soon passed by, disappearing from view outside the window. But he could hear her younger sister's delighted exclamation: "Elder Sister, where did you get such a big pig?"

The woman's voice, bright and full of energy, replied, "Of course I bought it!"

Outside, the noise grew as the family's matriarch presumably joined in herding the pig.

The man paid no further attention to the commotion, closing his eyes to rest. He needed to recover from his injuries as quickly as possible.

Fan Changyu, oblivious to all this, drove the pig into the side shed behind her house and shut it in. Then, carrying the bucket of offal the Chen family had given her as payment for yesterday's butchering, she went to the well outside the alley to fetch water and clean it again.

Fresh pork was best slaughtered the same day, so the pig she brought back had to be kept until tomorrow morning. There wasn't enough time to make braised meat tonight, but she could braise the offal to give away as a bonus for customers who bought pork tomorrow, offering one tael of braised offal for every catty of fresh pork purchased.

After touring the market today, Changyu had noticed many shops selling cooked food. More shops meant more customers, but also more competition.

If she started selling braised food outright, people might not be willing to spend money trying her braised dishes, especially given the price.

Fan Changyu thought it over. Offal was cheap and would make the perfect giveaway to attract customers. People might not necessarily buy it, but they'd likely be happy to take it for free.

This way, when the shop reopened, it could both draw people in to buy pork and build momentum for her future braised meat sales.

After tasting the free braised offal, customers would know whether her braising broth was good. Those who liked it would naturally return to buy when she started selling braised meat.

After washing the offal, Fan Changyu rolled up her sleeves at home and started lighting the fire. She added water to the pot, gathered assorted spices into a clean cloth bag, and tossed it in with ginger and garlic to boil into a braising broth.

Her kitchen was well-equipped. Her mother had been particular about food and took great care with meals. Since their family had been well-off before, stocking these ingredients hadn't been difficult.

Fan Changyu had learned many recipes from her mother, though she was only average at most. The exception was braised dishes, likely because she'd loved gnawing on braised pig's feet since childhood, so she'd learned this skill particularly well.

As she chopped the braised offal, her movements were bold and forceful from habit of butchering pigs and cleaving bones. The kitchen knife thudded heavily against the cutting board with such vigor that even a thief would have fled in terror.

An hour later, the rich aroma of braised meat wafted from the Fan family kitchen. Neighbors nearby sniffed the air in their homes, wondering who was stewing meat that smelled so delicious.

The fragrance drifted upward. Since the Zhao and Fan residences stood side by side, the man in the attic caught an especially strong whiff.

His Adam's apple bobbed as he closed his eyes heavily.

His body was too weak. Since his injury, he hadn't had a proper meal.

Chapter 4

Fan Changyu used a bamboo colander to scoop out the richly fragrant braised offal, letting the excess liquid drain. The blend of spices and meat aroma was just right, and the glazed color from the braising was exceptionally appealing, far superior to the braised food she'd seen at the deli earlier that day.

Changning stood on tiptoe by the stove, peering eagerly, but her face fell when she saw it was all offal. "No pig ears..." She loved pig ears.

Fan Changyu gently poked the pig intestines and stomach with chopsticks. They were so tender they yielded easily, thoroughly infused with flavor.

"We'll have fat intestine noodles tonight," she said. "Tomorrow I'll braise pig ears."

Only then did Changning's eyes brighten again.

With the stove fire still blazing, Fan Changyu ladled out the braising broth, cleaned the pot, and boiled fresh water, adding enough noodles for five servings.

"Go tell Aunt Zhao's family not to make supper tonight," she instructed Changning. "We'll all eat fat intestine noodles together later."

Changning obediently agreed and scampered off to deliver the message next door.

Noodles didn't take long to cook. Fan Changyu prepared four large bowls and one small bowl with seasonings in advance. For extra richness, she added a spoonful of rendered lard to each. When she poured the boiling noodle water over them, the lard and seasonings melted instantly, releasing an irresistible aroma.

Her preparation was simple—noodles topped with tender chunks of braised intestine and a sprinkle of chopped scallions.

Had her mother been cooking, she'd have simmered a pot of broth instead of using plain noodle water, and that would have been truly

fragrant.

She set her younger sister's bowl on the table for her to eat first, then carried the three large bowls of fat intestine noodles next door.

The wooden stairs connecting the attic to the ground floor creaked under steady, light footsteps, rousing Xie Zheng from his rest.

Moments later, the woman's voice came from outside: "Are you awake?"

"The door's unlatched," Xie Zheng replied. His voice remained hoarse but had improved since yesterday.

Fan Changyu nudged the door open with her elbow, carrying an oil lamp in one hand and a steaming bowl of noodles in the other. "Aunt Zhao just told me that a huge falcon came crashing down from the sky this morning and smashed straight through the window downstairs. What a bizarre occurrence."

Xie Zheng pressed his lips together, remaining silent.

He hadn't anticipated that gyrfalcon would be so foolish. Hearing his whistle, it had plunged headlong downward.

Fan Changyu glanced at his face. Though still pale, his complexion had improved since yesterday.

Accustomed to his reticence, she set the oil lamp on the table. "Luckily the bird didn't hurt anyone. The broken window will have to wait until Uncle has time to fix it. This attic may be cramped, but it's quiet at least."

Xie Zheng finally gave a faint "Mm" in acknowledgment.

She handed him the noodles. "I made you some noodles, hope it's alright."

The aroma had already reached him. The unfamiliar topping blanketing the noodles emitted the same meaty fragrance that had wafted through the entire alley earlier.

After days of unbearably bitter medicine and plain congee, the scent only sharpened his hunger, and this bowl might as well be a feast.

"Thank you," he said, accepting the bowl and immediately taking a bite.

The noodles were smooth, the broth rich. Though the flour used wasn't of the finest quality, at this moment it tasted better than any noodles he'd

ever had before. The meat topping the noodles was tender yet springy, releasing an exceptionally savory flavor with each bite.

Despite having prided himself on sampling many delicacies, he couldn't identify what this was.

Xie Zheng asked, "What is this?"

Fan Changyu was about to hurry back to eat her own bowl of fat intestine noodles when he inquired. She answered plainly, "Pork intestines."

Xie Zheng's chopsticks paused mid-air. Just hearing the word "intestines" gave him an ominous premonition.

Seeing his confusion, Fan Changyu explained more bluntly, "It's pig's large intestine."

His face instantly changed color.

Fan Changyu had seen people who disliked offal before, but this man hadn't shown any distaste while eating earlier. His current grim expression puzzled her. "What's wrong?" she asked.

"Nothing."

The reply came with difficulty.

Xie Zheng discreetly took several deep breaths to suppress his nausea.

Fan Changyu, still concerned about her cooling noodles, said, "I'll head back then. Just leave the bowl on the side cabinet when you're done, and the old lady will collect it later."

The door closed softly, followed by the sound of footsteps descending the stairs.

Xie Zheng stared at the bowl in his hands, brows furrowed in hesitation. He wasn't pampered; during hard marches he had gnawed on tree bark and wild roots, yet he had never once eaten an animal's intestines.

Pig's large intestine? Wasn't that where pig waste was stored?

The mere thought made his stomach churn.

Yet considering his injuries and how this was the most substantial meal he'd been given in days, Xie Zheng wrestled with himself before finally lifting another bite to his mouth, movements stiff.

When Heaven is about to confer a great responsibility on any man, it will first temper his heart and mind...

It was actually quite flavorful.

That night, Xie Zheng, who rarely dreamed, was haunted by visions of the woman who'd saved him. In the dream, she cheerfully herded a pig before suddenly drawing a large cleaver, slicing open its belly and pulling out a long intestine. "This is fat intestine," she declared, "I'll cook it for you."

The dream pig's squeals merged with real ones, jolting Xie Zheng awake to find himself still in bed.

Next door, the pig continued screeching. Dawn had barely broken outside his window.

But activity already stirred downstairs, likely the elderly couple rising to help the woman slaughter pigs.

Recalling his dream, Xie Zheng's expression darkened.

Herding pigs, slaughtering pigs, pig intestines... everything about that woman seemed pig-related.

He pressed his fingers to his brow and shut his eyes, trying to block out the piercing squeals.

Just a few more days. His gyrfalcon had already carried his message, and his former subordinates would come for him soon. He wouldn't have to endure this much longer.

He'd leave generous compensation for the woman and the elderly couple.

In the Fan family's backyard, Fan Changyu had already tied the pig to the slaughtering bench with thick rope. Like her father, she possessed extraordinary strength. What took several men to restrain, she could pin down alone.

Their slaughtering bench wasn't wooden, but a stone one specially commissioned by her father.

Once secured, no amount of struggling could budge the pig, eliminating the need to hold its tail.

The long, sharp bleeding knife plunged straight into the base of the pig's neck, nearly burying the hilt. The piercing squeals ceased instantly as blood gushed from the wound, filling the wooden basin beneath the stone stool to the brim.

In pig slaughtering, a single fatal strike was considered auspicious, and the more blood drained, the better.

Aunt Zhao, who had come to help, beamed at the basin of blood. "This'll last us several days' worth of meals."

Fan Changyu remained silent as she withdrew the knife, her expression uncharacteristically stern, with flecks of blood spotting her face and sleeves.

Whenever she delivered the killing blow, she seemed to become a different person entirely. People instinctively kept their distance, perhaps due to that peculiar ferocity unique to those who took lives.

After draining the blood, Changyu untied the ropes and dragged the carcass to the large pot of boiling water. She scalded the hide with ladles of hot water before scraping off the bristles with a skinning knife.

At the doorway, Changning peeked curiously into the yard. Aunt Zhao shooed her away: "Ningniang, go play outside. Children shouldn't watch things like this, or you'll have nightmares tonight."

"I'm not scared," Changning muttered, but shuffled reluctantly away.

Changyu rinsed the scraped carcass thoroughly, then hoisted it onto the iron hook on the courtyard post with minimal assistance from Carpenter Zhao and Aunt Zhao. With her skinning knife, she split the pig cleanly in two.

One half remained on the hook while she shouldered the other onto a door plank straddling two benches for butchering. The elderly Zhao couple gaped, murmuring, "This girl truly takes after her father..."

After portioning the meat, Changyu hurried to haul it to the market by cart. She entrusted Carpenter Zhao with delivering Chef Li's twenty-pound order to Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion from yesterday.

On impulse, she included some braised offal, not to court future business for her braised food (a master chef at such an establishment would hardly need her amateur efforts), but simply to thank him for his patronage.

Arriving early at the meat market, Changyu found only a handful of stalls open, where butchers were arranging their daily cuts.

An acquaintance spotted her and exclaimed, "Oh? Changyu reopening your family's stall?"

She answered briskly in the affirmative.

Unlocking the shop door sealed for over a month, she found everything meticulously arranged just as her father had left it, though veiled in a thin layer of dust.

The memory tugged at her heart, but she quickly steadied herself. After scrubbing the shop inside out, she displayed that morning's fresh cuts alongside last night's braised offal on the chopping block.

By mid-morning, scattered shoppers began appearing.

Fan Changyu's family butcher shop occupied a prime location. Compared to the neighboring stalls staffed by burly men and stout matrons, a young woman like her behind the counter seemed far easier to bargain with in the eyes of the market-going aunties. Nearly everyone passing by would pause to ask the price of the meat.

With a cheerful smile, Changyu quoted prices and announced her reopening special: one tael of free braised meat with every pound of pork purchased, for good fortune.

Tempted by the offer of free braised meat with fresh pork, most aunties ended up purchasing from her.

The market had just opened, and Fan Changyu's stall was the only one among the nearby pork shops to have already closed several deals.

The butcher from the opposite stall watched with envy and shouted, "Fan Er's girl, you can't break the rules in business! Everyone in this market sells meat at the same price. What's the meaning of giving away freebies?"

Fan Changyu knew this man had never gotten along with her father. Unfazed, she retorted sharply, "Uncle Guo, you're wronging me. Isn't the meat in my stall priced the same as everyone else's? How is that breaking the rules? The giveaway is just for good luck since my family's stall reopened today. Which guild rule says that's not allowed? Or is Uncle Guo picking on me just because I'm an orphan with no parents?"

The man couldn't argue back, his sallow face flushing red. "What a sharp tongue! I can't out-talk you!"

A butcher friendly with the Fan family chimed in, "Enough, Old Guo. Changyu is only selling one pig today. Why fuss over such a small thing with a junior?"

Not wanting to be known as a bully, Butcher Guo snapped, "Fine! Keep giving away your freebies today, but it won't be allowed tomorrow!"

Fan Changyu had only planned to offer the giveaway for one day anyway. Starting tomorrow, the braised food would be for sale. She replied coolly, "Naturally."

Only then did Butcher Guo back down.

Simply waiting for customers to approach made sales slow. Though Butcher Guo opposite her was nearly fuming with rage, those who had considered asking about his prices took one look at his fierce expression and didn't dare approach.

Since the giveaway was only for today, Fan Changyu wanted to make the most of it to build her reputation.

As the market grew busier, she decisively began calling out, "Fresh pork for sale—buy a pound of pork and get an ounce of braised offal free!"

The call proved highly effective, as many people immediately gathered around to ask the price of the pork.

Fan Changyu haggled while deftly chopping meat, occasionally putting on a pained expression to knock off a few coins. Before the morning market was even half over, the pork in her stall had been snatched up, far better than she'd expected.

Butcher Guo's face across the way had turned as foul as the stinking planks of his own privy.

Fan Changyu ignored him. After tidying her stall, she packed her knives into a shoulder bag, locked up, and set off for the livestock market with a bulging money pouch to buy two more pigs.

As she passed Butcher Guo's stall, he snarled, "If you dare give away any damn freebies tomorrow, don't blame me for bullying an orphan girl!"

Fan Changyu scoffed coldly through her nose and walked on without a word.

Tomorrow, she would no longer be giving anything away, she'd be selling!

As she walked, she quickly calculated the day's earnings. The ninety-pound pig, minus the head and offal, had yielded about seventy pounds of meat, all sold at fresh meat prices. The gross profit for the day came to over two strings of cash.

Tomorrow, the pig's head and offal would be braised and sold—another income stream!

After deducting the cost of the pig, she'd netted over a string of cash in profit!

Feeling the satisfying weight of the money pouch against her chest, her steps lightened, and Butcher Guo's earlier provocation was completely forgotten.

But just as she left the meat market and before entering the livestock market, she heard someone urgently calling her name from behind: "Changyu! Changyu!"

Turning, she saw it was Carpenter Zhao, running toward her with a face full of panic.

Fan Changyu quickly asked, "What happened, Uncle Zhao?"

Carpenter Zhao was so out of breath he could barely speak: "Hurry home and take a look! Your uncle brought people from the gambling den to smash your door. They're ransacking the place looking for the land deed. Your aunt and I, these old bones of ours, couldn't stop them at all!"

Chapter 5

The north wind howled, carrying fine snowflakes as the biting cold pierced to the bone. Pedestrians on the street hunched their shoulders, tucking their hands into their sleeves for warmth. Fan Changyu strode swiftly through the snowstorm, gripping a black-iron cleaver so tightly the veins on her hand stood out.

A crowd had already gathered at the entrance of the western city's residential alley, drawn by the commotion of curses, smashing objects, admonishments, and a child's wailing.

Someone with sharp eyes spotted Fan Changyu and called out, "Changyu's back!"

But seeing the cleaver in her hand, they couldn't help but gasp.

"Is that girl Changyu really going to raise a blade against her uncle?"

"Well, Fan Da's no decent man himself. Before Fan Er and his wife are even cold in their graves, he's trying to take their orphaned daughter's property to pay his gambling debts. You'd think he'd fear their ghosts haunting his dreams..."

"Those loan sharks are no pushovers. A young girl with a cleaver might not be enough to scare them off..."

The Fan family's doorstep was already in shambles. Shattered jars and overturned furniture trailed from the doorway into the house. Several burly men were still inside, smashing objects and rummaging through belongings, even tossing quilts and bedding onto the floor.

Changning was sobbing hysterically in Aunt Zhao's arms, while the older woman's eyes were red from crying as she pleaded in vain, "Stop breaking things! Please stop!"

No one paid her any heed.

Fan Da stood bowing obsequiously beside a man who appeared to be the gambling den's manager, clutching one hand while forcing an ingratiating

smile. "Boss Jin, once I get the deed and transfer it at the yamen, this house will be mine. I'll have the money to repay the debt, I swear!"

The man addressed as Boss Jin didn't even glance at Fan Da, scoffing, "If we don't find that deed today, I'll start by chopping off this hand of yours to take back as proof."

Fan Da clutched his hand tighter. "We'll find it, we'll find it..."

A furious shout from the doorway made everyone's eardrums throb: "Everyone stop right there!"

The commanding voice cut through the chaos, successfully drawing all eyes to the entrance.

The woman stood framed by the storm, her gaze as cold as the gleaming edge of the cleaver in her hand. The doorway that let in a sliver of daylight suddenly seemed to shrink before her presence.

Changning burst into fresh tears at the sight of her sister. "Elder sister..."

Fan Da avoided Fan Changyu's eyes, hunched submissively beside the gambling den manager without daring to speak.

Boss Jin, however, glanced at the cleaver in Fan Changyu's hand and chuckled dismissively. "Well, if it isn't the eldest Fan girl."

Fan Changyu's icy gaze swept over the wreckage of the room, her face taut with fury. "Take your men and get out of here!"

Boss Jin lifted his eyelids slightly, as if amused by the audacity of this orphaned girl. "The gambling house operates by rules. Fan Da claims this property is his, we're just here to collect the deed for his debt. Your family disputes are none of our concern."

Fan Changyu's dagger-sharp glare turned on Fan Da. "This house is yours?"

Fan Da couldn't meet Fan Changyu's gaze out of guilt, resorting to emotional manipulation: "Dear niece, your uncle was forced into this. I owe money to the gambling den. If I don't repay today, I'll lose a hand. With your father and mother gone, and you and Ning Niang having no brothers, you'll need family support after marriage to avoid being bullied by your in-laws. Just help your uncle now and hand over the deed to settle my debt. I'll treat you and Ning Niang as my own daughters from now on, and your

cousin will be like a real brother to you, giving you backing after marriage..."

Fan Changyu wasn't buying his nonsense. She sneered, "If you want to use property to pay gambling debts, use your own house! What kind of bullshit logic is it to take mine? That gambler son of yours is just like you—if he doesn't get his hands chopped off by debt collectors someday, it'll be a miracle. And I'm supposed to rely on him?"

Humiliated, Fan Da pointed at her: "How can you be so vicious? Cursing your own cousin like that? Your cousin still needs to find a marriage match. If we lose the house, how will he take a wife? You and Ning Niang are just girls who'll marry out someday. What do you need this house for?"

Changyu laughed in fury: "What my parents left for me and Ning Niang is none of your business."

Seeing her resolve, Fan Da dropped the pretense, his true nature surfacing: "Fan Er had no sons. By law, his property should go to me. What are you, a girl about to marry out, fighting for? To take it to your future husband's family?"

"Or is it because you're afraid no one will marry you after your parents died and the Song family broke off the engagement, leaving you with that 'jinx' reputation? That sickly sister of yours doesn't have long to live either, does she? Who'd dare marry a cursed woman like you?"

No one saw how she moved, but suddenly her butcher's knife was flying through the air, grazing Fan Da's ear before embedding itself in the wall behind him. Several severed strands of hair fluttered to the ground.

Fan Da's face turned white with terror, his legs shaking uncontrollably. His mouth opened and closed soundlessly.

The gambling den's manager, Boss Jin, and his thugs, who had been watching the drama unfold, suddenly straightened up, realizing this woman was not to be trifled with.

Changyu raised her eyes, glaring at Fan Da: "Everything my parents left is for Changning's medicine. You'd better take these gamblers and get out now, or else... while they only want one of your hands, I'll chop up your whole family before joining my parents in the afterlife!"

"You!" Fan Da shuddered violently, unable to meet her terrifying gaze. He stammered, "Then... then we'll settle this in court! Let's see who the

officials award the property to!"

Turning obsequiously to the gambling den manager lounging in the chair, he pleaded, "Boss Jin, could you... give me two more days?"

The manager scoffed: "Hui Xian Gambling Den has no precedent for extending debts. People might think we've gone soft if word gets out!"

He gave Fan Da a cold look: "Unless you'd like to pay with your right hand instead?"

Fan Da broke out in a cold sweat instantly, repeatedly saying, "No, no, but this girl..."

He glanced at Fan Changyu, still feeling a chill in his heart.

The gambling den manager only sneered, "If you're sure it's your property, then the boys can start searching directly."

Compared to taking Fan Da's hand, he naturally preferred the deed to the house that could be exchanged for money. The boss, Boss Jin, barked at the gang of enforcers, "What are you standing around for? Keep looking for the deed!"

The enforcers resumed ransacking the place, overturning cabinets and smashing things.

Fan Changyu clenched her teeth, her fists tightening until they creaked.

Boss Jin laughed, "Don't blame us, Miss Fan. These are the rules of the gambling den."

Aunt Zhao watched the scene, her heart burning with anxiety, but then she seemed to remember something and hurried outside.

She didn't go anywhere else but pushed through the crowd of onlookers at the door and knocked on the Song family's gate. "Song Yan! Fan Da has brought the gambling den thugs to Changyu's house to seize the deed! You're a scholar of the sages, Fan Er and his wife treated you well in the past. At least come out and speak up for Changyu! You're a provincial scholar, the gambling den will surely give you some face!"

The entire alley knew the Fan family was in trouble, yet the Song family's gate remained tightly shut. No matter how loudly Aunt Zhao pounded, not a single sound came from inside.

By the end, Aunt Zhao couldn't help but weep and curse, "Song Yan, did you stuff all those books up your ass? When your father died, you were so poor you couldn't even afford a coffin! Who was it that bought the coffin and buried him? Aren't you afraid your father's bones are being crushed under that coffin in the afterlife?"

Her shrill, grief-stricken voice carried through the entire alley.

On the other side of the gate, Mother Song trembled with rage. "That foul-mouthed shrew! You've already broken off the engagement with that Fan girl. Their family's mess has nothing to do with you! I ought to go out and give that shrew a piece of my mind!"

The man who had been bent over his books finally spoke up, "Mother."

Only then did Mother Song stop. "Fine, fine. That wicked woman just wants to drag us into this mess. If I go out, I'll be playing right into her hands! Don't you go out either, Yan'er. You're meant for greater things, so don't get tangled up with that family again."

Upstairs in the Zhao residence, separated from the Fan family by just a single wall, Xie Zheng naturally heard the commotion next door and Aunt Zhao's wailing curses.

The other side seemed to have the upper hand in numbers, while the woman stood alone, and the elderly couple couldn't help much.

Outside the window, the gloomy sky had cleared in the afternoon. The frost clinging to the eaves shimmered under the sunlight, casting a faint, cold golden glow.

Xie Zheng's face, bathed in the same light, was equally devoid of warmth. His lips pressed into a thin line, as if his mood had soured completely.

Those scum were truly grating on his ears.

His pale, blood-crusted hand gripped the pair of crutches placed by his bedside, and with great effort, he stood up. These crutches had been made for him by Carpenter Zhao just that day.

His wounds hadn't yet healed, and the sudden movement caused the bandaged injuries to slowly seep blood again. Yet he paid it no mind, planting the crutches firmly on the ground with each steady step.

If he didn't deal with those troublemakers next door today, he doubted he'd be in the mood for an afternoon nap.

Meanwhile, the Fan residence had already been turned upside down by the gambling den enforcers. Even the floor tiles had been tapped one by one with wooden sticks.

Changning cowered behind Fan Changyu, sobbing silently. Fan Changyu shielded her younger sister with one hand, her face half-lowered, making it impossible to see her expression at that moment.

One of the thugs rummaged through the table where the memorial tablets of Fan Changyu's parents were placed, knocking them to the ground. Just as he was about to stomp on them to see if there were any hidden compartments inside, his collar was suddenly grabbed from behind. A tremendous force hurled him out, and when the back of his head hit the threshold after landing at the doorway, the burly man was still dazed.

Everyone else in the room was stunned too.

Fan Changyu now stood where the man had been, silently staring at her parents' fallen memorial tablets. The cold wind whistling through the hall lifted the loose strands of hair at her temples, and blood dripped from her palm.

It was from the wounds she had inflicted on herself with her nails while suppressing her rage earlier.

"I'll give you one more chance. Get out or not?"

Her voice was unexpectedly calm, yet it sent an inexplicable chill down everyone's spine.

The gambling den's men exchanged uneasy glances, but Fan Da had already quietly retreated to the door, his legs trembling. The knife Fan Changyu had thrown earlier still haunted him.

Boss Jin, who had been collecting debts for years, had never been humiliated like this before. With so many people watching outside, if he failed to collect the debt today, it would be a disgrace to the entire gambling den.

He stood up and kicked one of the thugs beside him. "Are you dead? Keep smashing! I've been collecting debts in Lin'an Town for years, since when do I fear a little girl?"

The thugs tried to reassure themselves, but glancing at their comrade still lying at the doorway, they couldn't help but feel a twinge of fear.

This girl had freakish strength—it was downright unnatural.

After exchanging glances, they rushed at her together. Without even looking up, Fan Changyu flicked up a wooden staff one of the thugs had dropped with her foot, caught it with one hand, and swung it in a wide arc. Several thugs were struck in the abdomen, doubling over and crashing to the ground, some even vomiting bits of food.

Fan Changyu gave them no time to react. The long staff in her hands whistled through the air as she swept, thrust, chopped, and hacked... less like wielding a staff and more like swinging a long-handled blade without its edge.

One by one, the gambling den's thugs were beaten until they wailed for mercy, tossed out of the Fan family's gate like ragged sacks. The gasps of the onlookers rose and fell in waves.

When Fan Da saw Fan Changyu using this set of blade techniques, his face turned deathly pale, and he shrank into a corner like a quail.

Boss Jin, sensing the tide had turned, tried to flee. But before he could make it out the gate, a black cleaver flew from behind and embedded itself firmly in the doorframe ahead of him, nearly shaving off his nose.

Boss Jin gulped. "Miss Fan, this is all a misunderstanding..."

A commotion rose from the crowd outside. "The constables are here! Make way!"

For a group accustomed to wrongdoing, the arrival of the constables was an unexpected relief.

Carpenter Zhao led the sweating constables back in a hurry. "In broad daylight, bullying an orphaned girl—have you no..."

His words caught in his throat when he saw the gambling den's thugs sprawled outside the Fan family's gate and Boss Jin blocked at the entrance by a cleaver.

Xie Zheng, who had just descended from the Zhao family's loft with his cane, also looked surprised at the scene.

He had already noticed the woman's unusually steady breathing, no less disciplined than a martial artist's. It turned out he wasn't wrong.

The onlookers were all there for the spectacle, and no one noticed Xie Zheng. Seeing that the trouble had been resolved, he glanced at the bloodstains seeping through his clothes from his wounds and walked back expressionlessly, though his forehead was already covered in fine beads of cold sweat.

The scholarly man in a blue robe from the Song family, who had just stepped out after opening the gate, glanced at the constables outside and then at the Fan family with an inscrutable expression before retreating and closing the gate again.

Inside the house, Fan Changyu reined in the fierce aura that had erupted in her rage and knelt silently to pick up her parents' memorial tablets, which had fallen to the ground.

Her bloodstained hands smeared the tablets, so she wiped them clean with her sleeve.

This long-handled saber technique had been taught to her by her father, but he had never allowed her to use it in public.

Her father had said it should only be employed as a last resort, when her life was in danger, or else it might bring trouble.

Today, she had broken that rule, but not because her life was in danger, rather for the memorial tablets of her parents.

Holding the tablets, Fan Changyu closed her bloodshot eyes.

Father, don't blame Changyu...

With the constables' intervention, the aftermath was handled much more peacefully.

Fan Changyu had injured several people from the gambling den, but since they had trespassed and destroyed her family's property first, the constables reprimanded the troublemakers and only ordered Boss Jin to compensate for the damages to the Fan household, without demanding that Fan Changyu pay for the gamblers' medical expenses.

Fan Da muttered under his breath that, according to the law, the Fan family's house should belong to him. The constable shot him a sidelong glance and said, "This matter is separate. If you want the house, draft a petition and submit it to the Yamen for the county magistrate to decide."

Fan Da immediately fell silent.

The gambling den's men, linked together like a string of gourds, helped each other out of the Fan residence, while Fan Da slunk away in disgrace. Only then did the crowd of onlookers slowly disperse.

Fan Changyu turned to the head constable and said, "Thank you, Uncle Wang."

Head Constable Wang had been a friend of her father's in life. Carpenter Zhao had gone all the way to fetch him, hoping he could lend Fan Changyu a hand.

Head Constable Wang replied, "Today, they were in the wrong, so I acted impartially without favoring you. But if Fan Da really submits a petition to the County Government Office, your family's house might not be safe."

Fan Da hadn't filed a petition yet, partly because lawsuits were troublesome and partly because hiring a legal advisor would cost a lot of money.

But now that he knew forcing Fan Changyu wouldn't work, he might very well turn around and sue to get the deed to the house and settle his gambling debts.

Fan Changyu's face was etched with exhaustion and despair. "I've tried every possible way. I even consulted legal advisors, but they all said I can't inherit the house and land my parents left behind."

Legal advisors specialized in drafting petitions and lawsuits, and they knew the laws of the dynasty inside out.

Having handled cases for years, Head Constable Wang was experienced and knowledgeable. After a moment of thought, he said, "Perhaps there's another way."

Chapter 6

After Head Constable Wang left, Fan Changyu sat in the disheveled house holding her younger sister, with Carpenter Zhao and his wife, all silent for a long while.

After what seemed like ages, Aunt Zhao hesitantly spoke up: "Taking in a son-in-law... how is that an easy thing? In all my years, I've only heard of wealthy families with no sons taking in a son-in-law. For poor folks like us, who'd be willing to marry into our household?"

Fan Changyu remained silent, offering no response.

The solution Head Constable Wang had proposed was for her to quickly find a live-in husband. That way, her father would effectively have a son, and the family property would naturally pass to her.

But after the Song family broke off the engagement and her reputation as the "Star of Doom and Isolation" spread, even getting married had become difficult, let alone finding a man willing to marry into her family.

The legal advisors she had previously consulted probably knew her family's circumstances well enough that they didn't even consider taking in a son-in-law a viable option for her.

After all, society viewed marrying into a wife's family as shameful. Once a man did so, he was seen as abandoning his ancestral name and could never hold his head high anywhere. Forget ordinary families, even idle ruffians and good-for-nothings were reluctant to marry into a wife's household.

Carpenter Zhao, his calloused hands resting on his knees, looked even more aged with his wrinkled face. He sighed and said, "Marriage is a lifelong matter. You can't just hastily find someone to wed, or Changyu will suffer for it later."

Hearing this, Aunt Zhao felt even more heartbroken for Fan Changyu. Other girls getting married had parents carefully vetting their suitors, thoroughly examining their character and family background before sending them off in grand style.

Fan Changyu had lost both parents. Now, in her rush to find a live-in husband, she couldn't even afford to scrutinize a man's character. As long as he wasn't hideously ugly, it would be considered a blessing.

Just as she was about to wipe her tears, Aunt Zhao suddenly remembered something. Her gaze paused, and she looked up at Fan Changyu: "That young man you rescued, does he have a family?"

Before waiting for an answer, she dismissed her own question: "He probably doesn't. You said he fled from the north and was the only one left in his family."

Fan Changyu understood Aunt Zhao's implication but was stunned for a long moment.

Seeing no reaction from her, Aunt Zhao pressed further: "With his injuries, he has nowhere to go, right? How about... I ask him for you?"

Now that the idea of matchmaking had taken root, Aunt Zhao looked at Fan Changyu and felt she and the young man would make a perfect match. Changyu was capable. Even if the young man ended up disabled, she could support the household alone.

Moreover, after being turned away by the Song family today, Aunt Zhao seethed with hatred for Song Yan, that ungrateful wretch. The thought that the young man was even more handsome than Song Yan only deepened her satisfaction.

Fan Changyu's mind was in turmoil. She finally replied, "Auntie, don't ask him yet. Let me think it over first. I'll ask him myself when I'm ready."

Knowing Fan Changyu was always decisive, Aunt Zhao didn't press further. After helping her clean up the house with her husband, they returned home.

Changning, exhausted from crying earlier, had fallen asleep during her usual nap and was carried to bed by Fan Changyu.

Changyu herself lay down in her clothes, staring blankly at the canopy above.

Song Yan and the man who called himself Yan Zheng—their images overlapped in her mind.

Speaking of which, although she and Song Yan were childhood sweethearts and had been betrothed since they were young, her memories

of him were pitifully few.

Song Yan was always busy. Even before he entered the county school, he had been buried in his studies. Though both families lived in the same alley, she rarely went to see him to avoid disturbing his studies. If she did visit, it was usually because her parents had sent her to the Song family to deliver something—sometimes meat, sometimes pastries.

Back then, Mother Song had treated her with warmth, saying that Song Yan's hard work was all for earning scholarly honors so she could live a comfortable life in the future.

Later, when Song Yan was admitted to the county school, which provided meals and lodging, he spent even fewer days at home, and Fan Changyu found it harder to see him.

Once, when she went to the county town with her father for market day, Mother Song had made a new set of clothes for Song Yan and asked them to deliver it to him.

That was Fan Changyu's first time visiting the county school. She couldn't help but marvel at how grand the academy looked. After the gatekeeper relayed the message, Song Yan came out to meet her. She handed him the new clothes his mother had made, and he thanked her with a detached expression.

A passing classmate jokingly asked Song Yan who she was, and he replied, "My younger sister."

That day, Fan Changyu returned home with a heavy heart. She could sense that Song Yan didn't actually want her to visit him.

Having a fiancée who was the daughter of a butcher was probably embarrassing for him in front of his classmates.

Truthfully, even back then, she had considered calling off the engagement if Song Yan didn't like her. But her parents seemed fond of him, praising his ambition.

Mother Song had also been very fond of her at the time, often saying in public that once Song Yan passed the imperial exams, he would have the face to marry her properly. Outsiders would praise her for her good fortune.

So Fan Changyu only brought up ending the engagement privately with Song Yan. At the time, he was studying and barely looked up from his

books. His eyes, usually devoid of emotion, flickered as he asked, “Marriage is a matter of parental orders and matchmaker’s words. Do you take it so lightly?”

Fan Changyu took his words as a refusal to dissolve the engagement. Knowing his stance, she never brought it up again.

Later, after her parents passed away, Mother Song came to break off the engagement, citing some nonsense about their birth dates being incompatible.

Perhaps her parents’ deaths had drained all her sorrow, or perhaps there had never been much affection to begin with. Now, when she thought of Song Yan, she didn’t feel the slightest bit of sadness.

As for the man named Yan Zheng whom she had rescued, she knew even less about him.

He knew just as little about her. Asking him out of the blue, while he was severely injured and had nowhere to go, if he was willing to marry into her family—well, that carried a hint of leveraging kindness for repayment and taking advantage of his plight.

Her engagement with Song Yan had been arranged back then because her parents had done the Song family a favor.

Fan Changyu didn’t want to go through another mess like her engagement with Song Yan, but right now, she truly had no other choice.

After much deliberation, she thought maybe she should discuss it with the man named Yan Zheng and ask if he’d be willing to enter a sham marriage.

All she needed was to secure her family’s property. Once he recovered, he could stay or leave as he pleased.

If he chose to leave, Fan Changyu naturally wouldn’t stop him. She had saved his life, and he had helped her through a difficult time by pretending to marry into her family. That would make them even.

If he chose to stay... Fan Changyu thought of his face, as pristine as fresh snow under a clear moon. Well, she wouldn’t exactly be at a loss, would she?

—

In the Zhao family's pavilion, Xie Zheng, who had just retrieved a letter from the Gyr Falcon's leg, suddenly sneezed.

He frowned impatiently, his sharp brows knitting together. Could he really have caught a cold?

The pure white Gyr Falcon gripped the wooden windowsill tightly with its iron-hook-like claws, tilting its head slightly as it fixed its intelligent beady eyes on its master.

Xie Zheng unfolded the letter, and upon reading its contents, his expression instantly darkened, a cold sneer curling at the corners of his lips.

That person truly couldn't rest easy for even a day without seeing his corpse. So soon, they had already sent someone to Huizhou to take over his forces, and the one they sent was that very same person.

The letter was tossed into the charcoal brazier at the foot of the bed, quickly turning to ashes.

Xie Zheng leaned against the headboard, the cold wind blowing in through the wide-open window ruffling the stray hairs on his forehead but failing to dispel the gloom on his face.

The one who had taken over his military authority in Huizhou was probably even more eager for his death than the person in the capital. Right now, his former subordinates were struggling to protect themselves, not daring to make any rash moves lest that rabid dog caught their scent and tracked them down.

Until his injuries healed, he could only lie low here and plan carefully.

Xie Zheng glanced at the fresh bloodstains on his lapel, his expression growing even more self-loathing and impatient.

"Guh?" The Gyr Falcon, having waited too long for instructions, tilted its head the other way, continuing to stare at its master with those beady eyes.

"Get lost."

Xie Zheng closed his eyes impatiently, his handsome face unusually pale, revealing a rare hint of fragility.

The Gyr Falcon seemed accustomed to hearing this command. Satisfied, it immediately flapped its wings and flew away.

Xie Zheng had indeed caught a cold.

Fan Changyu had spent the afternoon rehearsing what she would say to him. In the evening, she even specially stir-fried two side dishes and sliced a plate of braised pork head meat to bring to him. But this time, no matter how many times she called outside the loft door, there was no response from inside.

Worried that something might have happened to the man inside, she pushed the door open and entered, only to find him lying in bed, his face flushed with an unnatural redness, his entire body feverish and unconscious.

Fan Changyu hurriedly called for Carpenter Zhao. After taking the man's pulse, Carpenter Zhao flipped through his tattered medical book for a long time before prescribing the most conservative remedy for colds.

Fan Changyu rushed to the already-closed medicine shop late at night, banging on the door to get the herbs. After brewing the medicine and forcing it down Xie Zheng's throat, he soon broke into a sweat.

However, when Carpenter Zhao wiped Xie Zheng's sweat and changed his dressing, he noticed that the wound seemed to have reopened and the gauze was stained with fresh blood. He found it rather odd.

Xie Zheng didn't wake again until the next morning.

His fever had subsided, and his head no longer felt heavy, but his throat was painfully dry.

To make it easier for him to pour water, the elderly couple had placed a round stool by his bedside with a teapot and a coarse clay cup.

Xie Zheng propped himself up halfway, about to pour himself a drink, when the door suddenly opened. The woman stepped in carrying a large bowl and, seeing him, said, "The tea is cold. You've just recovered from the fever, so don't drink it. I made you a bowl of pork lung soup."

Carpenter Zhao had said pork lung soup could clear heat, relieve coughs, and moisten the lungs. The pig slaughtered yesterday still had a bucket of offal left, so Fan Changyu had taken the lungs to make the soup.

Xie Zheng thanked her hoarsely. Since this meal wasn't intestines, he accepted it without hesitation and began drinking.

But the moment the soup touched his lips, his expression twisted strangely.

Under Fan Changyu's watchful gaze, he silently swallowed the mouthful of soup and asked, "Did you make this?"

Fan Changyu nodded, "Yes, what's the matter?"

Although it was her first time making this so-called pig lung soup.

Xie Zheng held the bowl but didn't drink any more, saying, "Nothing."

It was just a little hard to believe that this bowl of pig lung soup and the previous fat intestine noodles had come from the same person.

Fan Changyu continued to urge him, "You should finish it while it's hot. Uncle Zhao said pig lung soup helps with coughs and nourishes the lungs, which is good for your health."

Xie Zheng: "...It's a bit too hot. I'll drink it later."

He thought that with the conversation at this point, the woman before him would leave. Unexpectedly, she pulled over a chair and sat down. "I don't think I've told you my name yet. My surname is Fan, and my given name is Changyu. People in town just call me by my name, so you can do the same from now on."

Xie Zheng gave a faint nod. He had heard the old woman call her before and already knew her name.

With him barely responding, the room fell into silence again.

Forcing small talk was a bit awkward for Fan Changyu, but thinking of her purpose for being here, she had no choice but to press on. "Earlier, you said your surname is Yan and your given name is Zheng. Which 'Yan' and which 'Zheng'?"

Xie Zheng replied, "'Yan' as in 'words of reason,' 'Zheng' as in 'upright gentleman.'"

Suspecting that Fan Changyu might not have studied much and wouldn't recognize the characters, he dipped his finger into the cold tea in the cup and carefully wrote the two characters "Yan Zheng" on the round stool by the bed.

These two characters were each formed by taking a radical from his original name.

His index finger was slender and bony, its knuckles sharply defined, like a stalk of refined bamboo. It should have been a pair of hands beautiful for holding a brush, yet both the pads and backs of his fingers were crisscrossed with scars of varying depths, making it hard to imagine what he had been through before.

Even using his fingertip as a brush, the characters he wrote carried a bold, vigorous energy. Fan Changyu found herself inexplicably mesmerized.

Only when he finished the last stroke of "Zheng" did his low, hoarse voice break the silence. "These two characters."

She snapped back to reality, hesitating slightly before speaking again. "You were a scholar before, weren't you?"

His handwriting was excellent, seemingly even more refined than Song Yan's.

Xie Zheng, however, said, "Just a mere martial man—hardly worthy of being called a scholar."

His words sounded modest on the surface, yet carried an inexplicable hint of arrogant mockery, as if he held little regard for so-called scholars.

Fan Changyu let out a small sigh of relief and asked another question. "Then what did you do for a living before?"

Xie Zheng's brows furrowed almost imperceptibly. He felt she was being unusually persistent today, but considering she had saved him and was willing to let him stay to recover, it wasn't unreasonable for her to ask.

After a brief pause, he answered, "Nothing particularly respectable. I used to work for an Armed Escort Agency."

Unexpectedly, the woman's face suddenly lit up with excitement. "What a coincidence! My father used to work as a guard when he was younger!"

Xie Zheng: "...How fortuitous."

Fortunately, she didn't press further about the Armed Escort Agency. Instead, she clasped her hands together, seeming a little nervous, and asked him another question. "Then... are you married?"

Xie Zheng studied the woman before him. Under his gaze, she looked somewhat flustered, yet there was no trace of shyness at all.

For a moment, he couldn't quite grasp the meaning behind her question. He answered truthfully, "No, I'm not."

Fan Changyu's hands were nearly red from her own pinching before she finally threw caution to the wind and blurted out, "Well... I wanted to ask for your help. My family has run into some trouble. After my parents passed away, my uncle has been determined to seize our house and land. Yesterday he tried to forcibly take the deed but failed, so next he'll probably file a lawsuit. If it goes to court, since my parents had no sons, the property would rightfully go to my uncle. The only way to keep the house and land now is for me to quickly take in a live-in husband."

Xie Zheng's eyelid gave a sharp twitch. "You want me to be your live-in husband?"

Chapter 7

"It's a sham marriage," Fan Changyu said hurriedly.

She explained her plan to him in detail. "After we go through the wedding ceremony, we'll announce that you've married into my family. This will protect the property my parents left me. My family still has some modest savings. Once the property and land deeds are transferred, our finances will be more flexible. I'll hire the best physician in town and use the best medicine to treat your injuries. After you've recovered, you can decide whether to stay or leave."

Xie Zheng raised his eyes. The upward tilt at the corners of his eyes deepened the cold indifference about him. "Aren't you afraid that after I leave, your uncle will come demanding the property again?"

Fan Changyu said, "Once the property is transferred, I won't be afraid of him, no matter how much of a fuss he makes. Besides, when you leave, I'll just say you've gone on a long trip for business. No one will know the truth."

Xie Zheng said with an unreadable expression, "You've really thought this through."

Fan Changyu couldn't tell if he was praising or mocking her and asked awkwardly, "So... what do you think?"

"Let me think about it." His eyelids were half-lowered, his expression unreadable, as if he were genuinely considering it.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but feel a little nervous. She reviewed what she had just said. Although she had told him he was free to stay or go after he recovered, she hadn't mentioned what she would give him if he left, or what she could promise him if he stayed.

She quickly reconsidered and added, "If you want to leave after you've recovered, I'll give you enough money for your travels. If you have nowhere else to go..."

She glanced at his pale face and the wounds covering his body. Because the undergarments from yesterday were soaked in blood again, Carpenter

Zhao couldn't find anything for him to change into and had put him back in his own tattered coarse linen clothes.

His hands, aside from various scrapes, were covered in a layer of thick calluses and cracked sores. It looked like he hadn't had an easy life before.

Seeing how sick and poor he was now, Fan Changyu made a bold promise, "Don't worry, from now on, I'll slaughter pigs to support you!"

Xie Zheng was speechless.

The expression on his face at that moment was truly a sight to behold.

If anyone who knew him had been present, just hearing those words would probably have them thinking about what kind of death awaited them.

To have the audacity to say she would support him—in the entire world, this woman before him was likely the only one.

However, if she knew his real name, she probably wouldn't have said such a thing to him. She might have even left him to die in the snow without a second thought.

At this thought, a hint of mockery appeared in Xie Zheng's eyes.

He asked, "Why?"

Fan Changyu didn't understand what he meant. "What?"

He was surprisingly patient now, seemingly quite curious to know the reason behind her offer to support him. "We're complete strangers. If these injuries of mine don't heal, I'll most likely become a cripple. What do you stand to gain by supporting me?"

Fan Changyu answered with great sincerity, "You're good-looking."

Xie Zheng froze on the spot, not expecting such a superficial reason. After a long moment, he frowned and asked, "Just because of that?"

Fan Changyu blinked, as if to say, "What else?"

Xie Zheng naturally knew he was not unattractive, but this was the first time someone had praised his looks so bluntly. He said, "There are countless handsome men in this world."

Fan Changyu said, "But you happen to be the one I carried back from the snow."

She had only meant to respond to his statement about there being many handsome men in the world, but unexpectedly, after she spoke, the way he looked at her grew even stranger.

Fan Changyu belatedly realized her words could easily be misinterpreted and hurried to explain, "What I mean is, perhaps this is all fated..."

She, a person who judged by looks, had happened to rescue someone with a top-tier appearance. That was why she felt that if he had nowhere to go in the future and they got along well, it wouldn't be a bad idea to make do together.

If he wasn't interested, she certainly wouldn't force it. After all, you can't force love.

Unfortunately, he didn't give her a chance to finish her explanation, interrupting her with a frown. "After my injuries heal, I, Yan, will leave on my own and will not trouble you further, Miss."

His eyes and brows were filled with coldness, as if he had already decided she had improper designs on him.

Fan Changyu found it hard to explain herself. "...Alright."

The man seemed to want nothing more to do with her, nor did he wish to owe her anything. He spoke again, his tone just as cold, "Miss, please state a wish. For the grace of saving my life, I will surely repay you one day."

Fan Changyu waved her hand, disheartened. "You agreeing to the sham marriage to help me protect my family property is already a huge help."

She wouldn't speak so carelessly again; it was terrible to be misunderstood.

Unexpectedly, she heard him say, "The sham marriage will only count as repayment for taking me in."

Fan Changyu looked up in astonishment, staring at his exceptionally handsome face. "You mean," she said uncertainly, "you've agreed to the sham marriage?"

Xie Zheng gave a slight nod.

Fan Changyu almost wept with joy. "We can sign a contract as proof and set a time limit for the marriage. When the time is up, I'll immediately write you divorce papers and will absolutely not force you to stay. If you

want to leave early, I'll also provide travel money and the divorce papers, and I won't stop you."

This way, he wouldn't have to worry about her having improper intentions and refusing to let him go.

Xie Zheng said, "...That's not necessary."

He lowered his gaze and asked again, "What is your wish, Miss?"

Fan Changyu thought for a moment and said, "I want to get the pigsty my father left me up and running as soon as possible. In the future, it would be best if I could raise a hundred pigs."

"..."

That wish was truly simple and unadorned, and once again, it was about pigs.

Xie Zheng was silent for two breaths. "You can ask for something bigger, Miss."

Fan Changyu thought to herself, a hundred pigs are worth at least a hundred taels. Buying a two-courtyard house in town only costs a little over a hundred taels. Is that wish still too small?

She forced herself to name another number. "Two hundred pigs, then?"

Xie Zheng was speechless.

Forget it. He would just give her more silver when he left.

Seeing his silence, Fan Changyu thought she had asked for too much and said awkwardly, "As the old saying goes, saving a life is better than building... better than building a pagoda. I'm not actually looking for you to repay me..."

Hearing her stumble through the saying "saving a life is better than building a seven-story pagoda," Xie Zheng's eyelid twitched slightly. He cut her off, "I, Yan, will remember your kindness, Miss."

Since he had said so, Fan Changyu felt it was inappropriate to continue the topic. She asked, "Well... since you've agreed to the sham marriage, is there anything else you want to ask me?"

The man sitting by the window just shook his head slightly, seemingly unconcerned with this so-called marriage.

Fan Changyu thought about it and figured it made sense. It was all fake anyway; they weren't really getting married. There was no need to inquire about each other's entire family history.

She said, "The wedding might be a bit rushed, probably in the next day or two."

Xie Zheng only said, "You can arrange it."

His raven-like lashes were half-lowered, hiding the depths of his eyes. "However, the mountain bandits took my household registration documents. I'll probably have to go to the government office to get new ones."

Fan Changyu said, "That's not difficult. Since you're marrying into my family, we can just add your name to my household register."

Now that they had reached an agreement, Fan Changyu didn't stay any longer. She got up to go back and prepare for the wedding.

Before leaving, she saw that he had barely touched his bowl of pig lung soup and reminded him, "The soup should be cool by now. You should drink it."

Xie Zheng said, "...Mm."

Did she not know that the pig lung soup she made tasted very strange?

Only Xie Zheng remained in the room. He opened the window and looked toward Sky Deer Mountain, where the sky was clearing after the snow. His gaze deepened.

The man who had taken over his military command was a mad dog. If he couldn't find his body, he would likely start thoroughly investigating the refugees who had fled to nearby prefectures.

He could fabricate a false identity, but he couldn't forge household registration documents. If the Jizhou government office also began to investigate unregistered refugees, he would be exposed very quickly.

According to the laws of this dynasty, if a man married into a woman's family, his household registration could be changed to that of his new family.

This was the real reason he had agreed to the sham marriage.

As for that woman...

His gaze subconsciously fell on the bowl of pig lung soup placed to the side.

He had already granted her one wish, and she also had something to gain from the sham marriage. He no longer owed her anything.

Remembering the matter-of-fact way she had said, "You're good-looking," his own handsome brows furrowed unconsciously.

Hah, superficial.

He put his fingers to his lips and let out a clear whistle. In a moment, a pure white Gyr Falcon swooped down from the sky and landed steadily on the windowsill.

Xie Zheng held out the bowl. "Eat it."

The Gyr Falcon eyed the cooked pig lung slices in the bowl with its black-bean-like eyes and stubbornly turned its head away.

Xie Zheng shot it a look, and only then did the Gyr Falcon aggrievedly pick up a slice of pig liver and swallow it.

As luck would have it, just as Fan Changyu had settled the sham marriage, Head Constable Wang sent someone to secretly inform her that Fan Da had indeed found someone to write a complaint and submit it to the County Government Office. The case would likely be heard in a few days.

When the old Carpenter Zhao couple learned of this, they were so anxious that their mouths broke out in blisters. Fan Changyu, however, remained calm. "We'll keep the wedding simple. We'll just invite the neighbors for a meal so everyone knows I've taken a live-in husband."

To keep the old couple from worrying too much, and also for fear that others might see through the ruse, she hadn't yet told them that the marriage was a sham.

Aunt Zhao fretted, "But there's no time to make wedding clothes..."

Fan Changyu didn't think it was a big deal. "Can't we just make do with a red outfit?"

The money from selling pork and the compensation from the gambling den incident combined was only three taels. This little bit of money had to be spent where it was most needed.

However, while she herself had new clothes to wear, the man who was to marry into her family did not. His original clothes had been slashed to tatters. During his recovery, he had been wearing a loose undergarment with one of Carpenter Zhao's old jackets over it. No matter what, he had to have a new set of clothes made for the wedding day.

Fan Changyu gritted her teeth and spent half a guan of money to buy a bolt of ochre-red fabric from the clothier's, asking a seamstress who lived in the alley to make him a new set of clothes.

Fan Changyu had her reasons for buying this dark red fabric. It could be worn as a wedding garment on the wedding day, and it could also be worn as regular clothing on normal days.

When the seamstress heard that Fan Changyu was getting married, she smiled and offered a string of auspicious words. Knowing Fan Changyu's family situation was not easy, she refused to accept any payment for her labor, saying that making the wedding clothes was her wedding gift.

But the measurements still needed to be taken.

Fan Changyu had wanted to ask Uncle Zhao for help, but he had gone out to purchase various items for the wedding. She had no choice but to go up to the attic herself. "You don't have a decent set of clothes for the wedding day. I'm going to take your measurements to have a set made for you."

Xie Zheng nodded agreeably.

To get more accurate measurements, he didn't wear Carpenter Zhao's old jacket, revealing his back to Fan Changyu in just his undergarment.

Fan Changyu spread her thumb and forefinger, measuring from his left shoulder to his right. Through the thin layer of the undergarment, the muscles her fingertips touched were warm and firm.

Although she had touched him before when he was seriously injured and coughing up blood, helping him pat his back to soothe his breathing, her mind had been clear of distractions then, as a life was on the line. Now, perhaps because neither of them was speaking and the room was so quiet that even their breathing was clearly audible, she inexplicably felt a bit embarrassed.

On one hand, she was afraid he would again misunderstand that she had improper designs on him, so she tried to minimize physical contact. On the

other hand, she tried hard to ignore the warmth from her fingertips and concentrate on remembering the measurements.

"One chi and five cun." After taking the measurement, she quickly handed the old jacket back to Xie Zheng for him to put on, her actions almost suggesting she couldn't get away fast enough.

She muttered to herself inwardly. This man looked so lean, but his shoulders and back were surprisingly broad. His clothing size was almost the same as her father's.

Before leaving, she told him about the general proceedings for the wedding tomorrow. "The wedding is set for tomorrow afternoon. It's inconvenient for you to go downstairs, so Uncle Zhao will carry you down."

Since 'marriage' shares the same sound (hun) as 'dusk', dusk was regarded as the auspicious time for a wedding.

For some unknown reason, he refused flatly. "No need. I'll go down myself with a crutch."

Fan Changyu said worriedly, "Will it tear your wounds open?"

"It won't be a problem."

Seeing his insistence, Fan Changyu let him have his way and went home to continue preparing for the wedding.

A banquet for the guests was essential. She took out one tael of silver to buy a pig. Aunt Zhao, who would be the head cook, helped her go around the neighborhood and invite some aunts who were good at cooking to come and help tomorrow.

She also had to prepare some wedding candies and pastries.

Although she said everything would be simple, when all the miscellaneous expenses were added up, the three taels of silver she had were spent down to the last coin.

Fan Changyu was busy until hai shi and hadn't had a moment's rest. Aunt Zhao, who had no children of her own, helped her prepare for the wedding as if she were worrying over her own daughter, bustling about with her.

After Changning had fallen asleep, Aunt Zhao mysteriously stuffed a small booklet into her hand.

Fan Changyu flipped through a page and quickly closed it, half embarrassed and half mortified. "He's injured like that, this won't be necessary, will it..."

Aunt Zhao shot her a glare. "There will come a time when it's useful."

Fan Changyu had no choice but to accept the booklet with a stiff face.

The seamstress was very skilled and finished a set of wedding clothes that very night, delivering them over.

Fan Changyu had originally only intended to have a set made for Xie Zheng, but the seamstress had managed to save enough scraps of fabric to make a matching set for her as well.

The seamstress said with a smile, "How can the bride and groom wear different clothes for their wedding? I saw that there was enough fabric left to make a set for you too, so I rushed to finish it. Don't you complain if the craftsmanship isn't good."

Fan Changyu had had clothes made at the seamstress's place before, so her measurements were on file.

Fan Changyu's heart was filled with a mix of emotions. "Thank you, Aunt Fang."

The seamstress urged, "Hurry and go change so your aunt and I can have a look. If it doesn't fit, we can still alter it now."

There wasn't enough fabric, so the seamstress had cut the wedding clothes in a very simple style, not much different from ordinary clothes, but the style was elegant and graceful.

Fan Changyu went into the room to change and came out. Both Aunt Zhao and the seamstress said she looked beautiful. The seamstress teased, "Tomorrow, once that veil is on, you'll be a bride as beautiful as a flower!"

Fan Changyu asked, "Since he's marrying into my family, shouldn't the veil be for the groom?"

The seamstress and Aunt Zhao burst out laughing. "You silly girl..."

Fan Changyu was purely curious. After all, if she really made that fellow wear a veil to marry into her family, she was afraid he would flip out on the spot.

Speaking of the groom, the seamstress became curious. "I heard the husband you're taking in was rescued by you after being attacked by bandits at Tiger's Fork. Is he handsome?"

Before Fan Changyu could speak, Aunt Zhao answered for her, "Won't you see for yourself at the wedding tomorrow?"

The seamstress smiled and said yes, teased her a bit more, and then went home.

When Aunt Zhao was alone with Fan Changyu, thinking that this girl was getting married tomorrow, she couldn't help but feel a pang of sadness for her. "Girls from those wealthy families are carried down from their bridal boudoirs on their wedding day, seated in a bridal sedan chair, and sent to their husband's home with music and celebration all the way..."

Fan Changyu didn't feel sad. Instead, she remembered how Yan Zheng had coldly refused on the spot when she told him Uncle Zhao would carry him downstairs tomorrow.

Could that have been the reason for his refusal?

That night, the lights stayed on late not only in the Fan Family home, but also in the Song family home, just a few houses away.

Mother Song got up in the night and saw the light was still on in her son's room. She knocked on the door and said, "Yan'er, it's so late. You should be resting."

A man's calm voice came from inside the room. "I'll sleep after I finish reviewing this scroll."

Mother Song felt both heartache for her son and a sense of gratification. She said, "Don't stay up too late," and went back to her room.

Inside, the candlelight shone brightly. Song Yan held a scroll but hadn't turned a page for a long time. The inkstone and brush had long been knocked to the floor, leaving the room in a mess.

The hand holding the scroll was clenched so tightly that the knuckles had turned white.

She... was getting married?

Chapter 8

Fan Changyu was probably the first bride to have to get up early on her own wedding day to butcher a pig and prepare braised dishes.

The offal and pork head meat left over from the pig she had previously butchered and sold were also made into braised food. With two pigs combined, she finally had enough braised meat to fill two large basins.

The aunties who came to help all said it smelled delicious.

It was almost noon before Aunt Zhao hurried her back to her room to change into her wedding attire and do her hair and makeup.

It was only after asking Aunt Zhao that she learned there were two types of matrimonial traditions for a man marrying into his wife's family. One was for the groom to be carried to the bride's home in a bridal sedan, a custom known as "carrying the groom's head."

The other was much like a normal wedding: the groom would stay at the bride's home the day before, while the bride would depart from her maternal grandmother's house and be carried back to her own home in a bridal sedan amidst the clamor of gongs and drums, which was considered a way to preserve the groom's dignity.

Fan Changyu used neither method. For one, she no longer had the money to rent a bridal sedan. For another, the groom was right next door. He could come downstairs and proceed directly to the wedding ceremony, so why waste the effort?

The hired Matron of Good Fortune went to the bridal chamber to make the bed, then came to help her comb her hair.

"First comb, to the end; second comb, to silver hair and brows; third comb, a house full of children and grandchildren..."

Sitting before the dressing table, Fan Changyu listened to the Matron of Good Fortune recite the "Ten Combs" and to the clamor of voices outside. For a fleeting moment, she had the illusion that she was truly getting married.

The guests outside were mostly discussing today's groom. However, Aunt Zhao was tight-lipped, refusing to reveal the slightest detail no matter how the women pried.

A group of women sat together cracking melon seeds, inevitably speculating in private. "Don't you think the way the old Zhao couple is helping Fan Changyu hide him away means the groom must be hideously ugly and unfit to be seen?"

"I heard the groom injured his leg and can't walk properly!"

Someone immediately gasped, "Doesn't that make him a cripple?"

The person next to her nudged the speaker with an elbow, signaling for her to be quiet, before lowering her voice. "The Fan Family is taking in a live-in son-in-law, after all. If he were a perfectly able-bodied man, would he really agree to marry into his wife's family?"

The group couldn't help but sigh. Someone else brought up Song Yan. "It looks like the Fan Family and the Song family have truly fallen out. Everyone in the entire alley is here today, except for the Song family."

"Hah, if you ask me, it's better that the Song family isn't here for the wedding feast. Song Yan is the most handsome young man in all the surrounding villages. If he came, he'd make the groom look completely worthless. That would be embarrassing for the Fan Family!"

The crowd chattered away. When the auspicious hour arrived, they all swarmed to the gate of the Zhao Family's home, waiting to see the groom.

In contrast, when Fan Changyu, the bride, emerged with a red cloth covering her head, she was completely ignored.

The heavens were truly uncooperative today. Snow had begun to fall in the afternoon, and by now, a thin layer of white already covered the courtyard walls. The ground, however, had not yet accumulated any snow due to the constant foot traffic, leaving only a swathe of wetness.

The firecrackers hanging at the gate of the Zhao Family's home crackled and popped. The crowd, craning their necks to peer inside, saw a pair of crutches extend from the open doorway and sighed in their hearts, as expected.

The man Fan Changyu was marrying into her family was indeed a cripple.

As the crutches moved, the groom stepped one foot out of the door, and the hem of an ochre-red robe appeared in everyone's line of sight.

Snowflakes drifted down like catkins, melting the instant they landed on the fabric, leaving only a faint, almost invisible wet mark.

The noisy guests outside the gate inexplicably held their breath.

After the groom's other foot crossed the threshold, his entire person finally emerged from the shadows of the house. Specks of snow landed in his ink-black hair, which was tied up with a red ribbon. And the face between that black hair and red robe was handsome and refined, his complexion seeming even fairer than the falling snow. The glance he swept over the crowd was cold and distant.

The guests who saw his face clearly all sucked in a sharp breath.

In all their years, they had never seen such a handsome young man. Forget Song Yan, even the lead actor of the opera troupe couldn't hold a candle to this groom.

With sword-like brows, star-like eyes, and a face like jade, he was truly the picture of perfection.

After a dead silence, the crowd erupted again, far livelier than before.

"This groom is so handsome!"

"I knew it! A girl as good-looking as Changyu couldn't possibly find a husband who's lacking!"

"Who was it that said the groom was a hideous cripple? Is this face any worse than Song Yan's?"

Xie Zheng, leaning on his crutches, passed through the clamoring crowd with a blank expression. He frowned imperceptibly, as if finding this group of chattering women far too noisy.

He turned a corner and entered the Fan Family's gate. The people still cracking melon seeds and chatting in the courtyard couldn't help but stand up to watch the spectacle when they saw him. Amidst the noisy chatter, the most common comments were praises of his appearance.

Even the few women helping in the back kitchen, upon hearing that the groom was exceptionally handsome, couldn't resist coming out for a look.

Xie Zheng suppressed the impatience in his brow as he was stared at all the way to the main hall for the wedding ceremony.

He glanced casually toward the eaves ahead and saw Fan Changyu, dressed in wedding attire of the same color as his. Taking advantage of the fact that no one was paying attention, she had lifted a corner of her head covering from behind the crowd to peek out. His gaze had already swept past her, but it suddenly snapped back, a hint of surprise in his eyes.

He knew she wasn't bad-looking, but this was the first time he had seen her with makeup on.

Half-hidden by the red silk, her almond eyes looked this way, a smile shimmering within them. A light blush was applied to her cheeks. Although the application technique was a bit clumsy, it couldn't hide her beauty. Her lips, colored with rouge, were not as pale as usual, making her snowy cheeks stand out. A single glance was enough to find her dazzlingly beautiful.

Her gaze met his. After a moment's stun, she seemed to realize this was her own wedding and, like a thief with a guilty conscience, quickly lowered the head covering and stood properly.

She was clearly a natural beauty, but her actions... were always so peculiar.

The impatience that had been vexing Xie Zheng from the guests' clamor suddenly lessened a little.

This wedding wasn't entirely tedious and complicated after all.

He entered the main hall on his crutches. The Matron of Good Fortune handed one end of a red silk ribbon, tied with a floral ball, to him, and the other to Fan Changyu.

The elder presiding over the ceremony announced in a loud voice, "The auspicious hour has arrived! The new couple will now perform the wedding ceremony!"

"First, bow to Heaven and Earth—"

Fan Changyu couldn't see under her head covering. Aunt Zhao helped her turn to face outward before she bowed to Heaven and Earth along with Xie Zheng.

"Second, bow to the elders—"

Both her and Xie Zheng's parents had passed away, so only memorial tablets were placed in the seats of honor. The two bowed to the tablets.

"Husband and wife, bow to each other—"

As Fan Changyu bowed her head for this part, a gust of wind blew in, nearly blowing the wedding kerchief off her head. She subconsciously reached up to grab it, but a large hand beat her to it, pressing the kerchief back onto her head.

She could imagine with her toes that this scene must not have been very graceful.

Laughter had already broken out among the guests. "Look at the groom, he can't bear to let everyone see his bride!"

The wedding kerchief blocked Fan Changyu's vision, so she couldn't see the expression on Xie Zheng's face at that moment. However, she herself felt quite embarrassed by the teasing and could only hope he wouldn't mind.

"The ceremony is complete—escort them to the bridal chamber!"

With this shout, she and Xie Zheng were finally led by the red ribbon into the prepared bridal chamber.

It was called a bridal chamber, but it was very simple. It was merely that the doors and windows were decorated with red paper cutouts of the character for "joy," and the bed was made with festively colored sheets and quilts.

After saying a string of auspicious phrases, the Matron of Good Fortune had Xie Zheng lift the covering from Fan Changyu's head.

Her vision suddenly brightened, and the figures in the room became clear. Outside, after being caught peeking from under a corner of her head covering, Fan Changyu had quickly lowered it and hadn't gotten a very good look.

Now, with him just a step away, Fan Changyu looked at Xie Zheng dressed in red and once again marveled that clothes really did make the man.

If he were to walk down the street in this outfit today, he would probably mesmerize quite a few young ladies.

The Matron of Good Fortune smiled. "Look, what a beautiful bride. A truly heaven-made match with the groom!"

The women beside her covered their mouths and giggled.

Fan Changyu awkwardly curved her lips to match.

Xie Zheng's expression remained faint, making it impossible for anyone to guess what he was thinking.

The Matron of Good Fortune led the women in the room to pick up peanuts and red dates from a plate and sprinkle them over the couple's heads, chanting, "May you have a noble son soon."

These things actually hurt a little when they hit. Fan Changyu spoke up at the right moment, "Thank you, aunties, but my husband is injured. Sprinkling fruits is just for good luck, so let's stop here for today."

As soon as she said this, someone couldn't help but tease, "Look at that, our girl Changyu is already protecting her husband!"

Fan Changyu brazenly let them tease her. After seeing the roomful of people out, she asked Xie Zheng, "You weren't hurt, were you?"

Xie Zheng looked at her with an unreadable expression. "I was not."

Fan Changyu was relieved. She added, "I still have to go out and see the guests. You rest here. If you get hungry, have some of the pastries on the table to tide you over."

These were words a groom should be saying to his bride. Coming from Fan Changyu's mouth now, they sounded strange no matter how one heard them.

After a moment of silence, Xie Zheng gave a slight nod.

Having endured for so long with his injuries, his expression indeed carried an unmistakable weariness.

Fan Changyu went out to entertain the guests. Since she had no elders in her family and it was a marriage where the groom moved in, almost no one tried to make her drink during the feast. Everyone ate a lively meal, and seeing that it was getting late, they began to take their leave one after another.

After the feast ended and Fan Changyu was clearing the tables and benches, she discovered a brocade box on a table by the door, placed there

by an unknown person.

She asked Aunt Zhao, who was helping her clean up, "Auntie, whose gift is this?"

Aunt Zhao was also a bit puzzled. "The gift registry was finished before the feast started. I didn't see this box just now. I wonder who sent it later. Why didn't they say anything?"

Fan Changyu opened the box. When she saw that it contained a pair of clay dolls, her face instantly turned cold.

She flung the box into the pile of trash Aunt Zhao had just swept up, and the clay dolls shattered on impact.

Seeing Fan Changyu's reaction and recognizing the broken male and female clay dolls, Aunt Zhao's expression changed on the spot. She spat fiercely in the direction of the Song family's home. "That heartless wretch! When you were in trouble, he distanced himself faster than anyone. And now on your wedding day, he sends this to disgust you?"

Fan Changyu said, "Don't be angry, Auntie. Why bother with someone so insignificant."

Her anger wasn't because the clay dolls had stirred up any bad memories, but simply because she found it disgusting.

She had given him those clay dolls the year Song Yan's father passed away, seeing how depressed he was. How old was she then? Only seven or eight.

Over the years, Fan Changyu knew her parents had treated Song Yan well. But after her parents died, he was the one who rushed to their door to break off the engagement. When she was being harassed by Fan Da and the people from the gambling den, he was the one who shut his doors and refused to see her.

And now, on her wedding day, he sends a pair of clay dolls like this. What was he trying to say?

Because of this bit of unpleasantness, Fan Changyu's face remained expressionless all the way through her family's dinner that evening.

Xie Zheng's injuries made it inconvenient for him to move, so she brought his food to the room. "You're injured, so I picked out some lighter dishes for you."

Xie Zheng had noticed her strange expression the moment she entered, but he didn't ask about it. He only half-lowered his eyes and thanked her faintly.

By the time everything was cleaned up, it was almost the hour of Hai (9-11pm). Aunt Zhao was about to carry the sleeping Changning next door, but Fan Changyu said it wasn't necessary. "After my parents passed away, Ning Niang has always slept with me. Otherwise, she has nightmares and cries incessantly."

Aunt Zhao said, "On a normal day, that would be fine. But on the wedding night, no matter what, the young couple must sleep in the same room. Otherwise, it's bad luck."

Without giving Fan Changyu any room to argue, she carried Changning out of the house.

The courtyard, which had been bustling during the day, was now eerily quiet.

Festive red lanterns hung high under the eaves, casting a dim yellow halo in the vast, snowy night.

Fan Changyu sat on the steps by the door, hugging her knees. She stared blankly at the large snowflakes falling in the night sky for a while before getting up and going inside.

Since it was a fake marriage, Fan Changyu naturally had no intention of actually sleeping in the same room with him.

However, all the family's quilts were stored in the bridal chamber. That room was originally her own. After her parents passed away, Changning was too scared to sleep alone, so she had squeezed in with her. Now that it had been converted into a bridal chamber, the bed in the adjacent room hadn't been made yet.

Because it was the room she had lived in for over a decade, she habitually pushed the door open and walked right in. Only then did she realize that Xie Zheng was changing his clothes. He had already taken off his outer robe and, with his back to her, had his inner shirt half-off, one part hanging on his arm and the other draped to his waist.

It was a beautiful body. Between the gauze bandages, the exposed muscles showed a handsome honey color under the light of the wedding candles, and their sculpted shape was very distinct.

Because of her sudden entrance, he turned his head slightly. On his jade-like face, his cold expression at this moment seemed inexplicably ascetic and alluring.

Fan Changyu stared dumbly for several seconds, until he frowned in displeasure, pulled the half-removed inner shirt back on, and asked her, "Is something wrong?"

She snapped back to her senses, realizing she was acting like a hooligan lusting after a virtuous maiden's beauty. Her face burned, and she quickly turned around. "Sorry, I'm not used to it yet, I forgot to knock. I just came in to get a quilt."

"Take what you need," came the voice from behind her, cool and clear.

Fan Changyu tried her best to keep her eyes straight ahead as she took two quilts from the cabinet. Holding them in her arms, she walked out without daring to turn her head. Only after she had rounded the corner of the wall did she take several deep, relieved breaths.

How utterly mortifying! She hoped he wouldn't misunderstand her again.

Xie Zheng's hearing was exceptional; he naturally heard her sigh of relief.

There was no fluctuation of emotion in his eyes. After hearing her footsteps recede, he unwrapped his bandages and continued to apply medicine to the more severe lacerations.

This was the trauma medicine delivered by the Gyr Falcon, a priceless remedy with extremely potent effects.

The moment the powder touched the wounds, the pain caused his entire body to tense up. The veins on his arms bulged, a fine sweat broke out on his forehead, and he clenched his jaw so tightly that the faint taste of blood spread in his mouth.

To avoid getting blood on the bed, he sat on a wooden stool in the room, his hands clenched into tight fists resting on his knees. Beads of sweat, stained with blood, rolled down his straight back. It looked less like he was treating his wounds and more like he was being tortured.

Despite experiencing such inhuman pain, when a bead of sweat fell from his eyelid, he didn't even blink. His eyes, reflecting the candlelight, were dark and gloomy.

This body full of injuries and this skin-flaying pain were debts he would one day return in full.

The footsteps outside suddenly returned. Xie Zheng lifted a pair of eyes, the ferocity not yet concealed, and looked toward the door.

Chapter 9

Fan Changyu hadn't gone far from the bridal chamber, carrying two thick quilts, when her intuition told her something was wrong. She lifted her head and glanced over the courtyard wall, and two large, dark figures immediately ducked back down below it.

Fan Changyu: "..."

Fan Da and his wife. She'd recognize them even if they were turned to ash.

Had the two of them heard about her recruiting a husband and, fearing she had just found some random outsider to put on a show and deceive them, decided to stay up in the middle of the night to climb her wall and eavesdrop?

Outside the Fan Family's courtyard wall, Fan Da and his wife, the stout and sturdy Madam Liu, were each perched on a wooden ladder, their heads ducked below the wall as they conversed in low voices.

"See? I told you that girl just found someone for a sham marriage to fool us! They're sleeping in separate rooms on their wedding night! What were you so panicked about!" Madam Liu snapped at her husband.

The thought that there was hope of getting the house and land again made Fan Da unable to hide his excitement. "Let's keep watching! Keep watching!" he said.

When the two of them furtively poked their heads over the wall again, they saw Fan Changyu enter the adjacent room with the thick quilts, then come back out. She went to the kitchen, brought a basin of water back to the bridal chamber, and made it seem as if she had only gone to the next room to drop off some bedding.

Fan Da and his wife couldn't help but look at each other in bewilderment.

Could it be that they had guessed wrong?

After Fan Changyu entered the bridal chamber again with a basin of hot water without knocking, she met the icy gaze of the man sitting bare-chested at the table. She gestured with her eyes toward the courtyard, her tone half-embarrassed and half-resigned. "My uncle and aunt probably think I just randomly recruited someone for a sham marriage to deceive them. They're outside eavesdropping."

Xie Zheng retracted his gaze and slumped back over the round table.

He had just applied medicine, and a bone-deep, excruciating pain spread from the broken flesh through his nerves to his entire body. It drenched his forehead, back, and waist in a cold sweat. Right now, almost all his energy was focused on enduring the pain; he had no mind to care whether Fan Changyu stayed or left.

His shoulders and back were taut, and sweat-soaked strands of hair were plastered messily to his forehead. Beads of sweat even clung to his eyelids. He gritted his teeth, resembling a wild wolf that had been beaten repeatedly but refused to be tamed.

This was the first time Fan Changyu had seen the full extent of his injuries. Without the gauze to cover them, some of the once-gaping wounds had already formed scabs, while others had torn open again, a mangled mess of flesh and blood. In addition, many old scars were faintly visible on his body.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but think of her own father, who also had many such old scars. It seemed being a transport guard was truly a life-risking profession.

She set down the basin of water, walked over, and asked with a frown, "Is there anything I can do to help?"

The man, half-slumped over the table, did not look up. He picked up a medicine bottle with his pale fingertips and passed it back. "Sprinkle all the remaining powder on the wounds on my back."

He had always been cautious. The medicine brought by the gyrfalcon had long been transferred by him into the wound medicine bottle his father-in-law had bought.

Fan Changyu took the medicine bottle and did as he asked. But almost at that instant, the muscles in his back clenched even tighter, hard as rock. It was probably too much to bear, as he turned his head and bit down directly on the clothes piled on the table.

She frowned, thinking to herself that his reaction didn't seem this severe the last time he applied medicine. The thought that he might be exhausted from the wedding today made her feel a little guilty.

She glanced at the gauze on the floor, stained with blood and sweat, and went to the cabinet to take out a roll of plain silk.

This was leftover fabric the family had bought for the funeral after her parents passed away. She used scissors to cut it into long strips, convenient for bandaging him in a moment.

After a while, the taut muscles throughout Xie Zheng's body finally relaxed a little. He released the clothes from his mouth and slowly raised his eyes to look at Fan Changyu.

"Feeling better?" Seeing this, Fan Changyu quickly put down the scissors in her hand.

Xie Zheng was extremely averse to others seeing him tend to his injuries. At such times, he was like a feeble stray dog whose life could be taken by anyone.

But this woman before him had already seen him at his most wretched.

With this long-held habit broken, he instinctively recoiled, offering only a cold word of thanks.

Fan Changyu glanced at the wounds on his body and magnanimously decided not to hold it against him.

Perhaps he was in a bad mood because he was in so much pain.

Xie Zheng picked up the clothes on the table to put them on. The feeling of blood and sweat sticking to his back was not pleasant, but his good upbringing made it impossible for him to be at ease while not fully clothed in front of a woman.

Seeing this, Fan Changyu quickly stopped him. "You're sweaty, and there's still a lot of blood. Wipe yourself down first. I'll find you some of my father's clothes later."

It just so happened that she had brought in a basin of water, originally intending for him to wash up with. Now it came in handy.

Xie Zheng could wipe his front himself, but he still needed Fan Changyu's help with his back. She wiped much more meticulously than the two random swipes he had given himself. The wrung-out cloth carefully

avoided the wounds, bit by bit wiping away the bloodstains and the brown medicinal residue from before.

Her knuckles would occasionally brush against his back. They weren't soft, but they were distinctly different from his own calloused hands. It felt as if a tiny electric current was spreading from where her knuckles had grazed.

The novel tingling sensation made Xie Zheng frown subconsciously.

Seeing this, Fan Changyu stopped what she was doing. "Did I touch your wound?"

He pressed his lips together, his expression growing even colder. "No."

After she finished wiping his back, the basin of water was murky with blood and medicinal residue. Fan Changyu took the cloth strips she had cut and began to wrap them around him. This time, her fingertips inevitably came into more contact with his skin. Perhaps because he had just applied medicine and sweated, his body temperature was hotter than any time before.

Fan Changyu stood while he sat. Occasionally, when she bent down to wrap the strips, her long hair would fall and lightly brush against his shoulder and neck.

Tingling, itching, numbing.

Xie Zheng's brow was almost furrowed into a "川" character. He subtly shifted to the side to avoid her.

"Done." Fan Changyu didn't notice his abnormality. After tying the knot, she straightened up. After all that work, a thin layer of sweat had appeared on her own forehead.

She went to the chest, found an old garment her father used to wear for him, and then carried the basin of water outside to empty it.

The red lanterns under the eaves swayed gently in the cold wind. When the two bear-like dark figures outside the wall saw her come out, they both shrank back down below the wall, thinking they were extremely well-hidden.

Fan Changyu played along, pretending not to notice. "Whose wildcat is it, coming to steal meat from my house again!" she scolded.

She walked over with the basin, ladled two large scoops of cold water from the water vat into it, and then forcefully flung it over the courtyard wall. "Next time I catch you, see if I don't teach you a lesson, you beast!"

Outside the courtyard wall, Fan Da and his wife were drenched to the bone, shivering from the cold. Afraid of being discovered, they didn't dare make a sound.

Only after the footsteps in the courtyard had faded away did Fan Da, still shivering, spit out the water he had accidentally swallowed. He grimaced and asked, "What kind of water did that damn girl throw? What is this smell?"

Madam Liu wiped the water from her face with her sleeve and sniffed. "It smells of blood, and sweat."

The couple froze, then began spitting even more forcefully. "Damn it all, isn't that their bathwater!"

Their soaked padded jackets, when hit by the cold wind, became bone-chillingly cold, making their teeth chatter.

They didn't manage to eavesdrop that night. Instead, after returning home, Fan Da and his wife came down with a severe case of wind-chill and were too sick to get out of bed for several days, but that is a story for another time.

Fearing further complications, Fan Changyu thought it over and decided to make a pallet on the floor of the bridal chamber to sleep. Xie Zheng said nothing about it.

Fan Changyu fell asleep quickly. While Xie Zheng was still resting with his eyes closed, her breathing had already become long and steady.

According to folk custom, the wedding candles on the wedding night had to burn all night long. To keep up appearances for outsiders, Fan Changyu didn't extinguish them.

The steadily burning wedding candle suddenly sputtered, its wick popping with a soft sound. Only then did Xie Zheng slightly turn his head to look at the pallet on the floor.

Three feet of warm light spread across the floor. The woman was curled up amidst several thick quilts, her black hair splayed across the pillow. In the dim candlelight, her skin had the warm luster of jade.

Xie Zheng retracted his gaze and gently closed his eyes.

When she was awake, she carried an air of common vulgarity that could make one overlook even the finest features.

Asleep, she was rather pleasant to look at.

Realizing he was thinking about whether she was good-looking or not, Xie Zheng's eyes suddenly flew open, and his brows furrowed deeply.

What did it matter to him whether she was beautiful or ugly?

Once his injuries healed a little, he could leave this place. It was hard to say if he would ever have any contact with this woman again in the future.

He cut off his thoughts, turned over to face the inside of the bed, and closed his eyes again.

Fan Changyu had her own routine and woke up on schedule.

She sat up, finding herself sleeping on the floor. Changning was not beside her, and a man was lying on the bed a few steps away. She was dazed for a good while.

Then she remembered she had gotten married yesterday and suddenly breathed a sigh of relief.

Outside, the sky was just beginning to lighten. A small stub of the wedding candle in the room was still burning, a mottled collection of wax tears piled up beneath the candlestick.

Fan Changyu got up quietly. She had slept in her clothes last night, which saved her the awkwardness and trouble of getting dressed. After putting away the bedding for her pallet, she left the room.

The wind and snow had not stopped last night. After a whole night, the courtyard was now covered in a thick layer of snow. The top of the wall and the withered branches outside were all white.

Fan Changyu rubbed her hands together against the cold. She first went under the eaves to get firewood to light the fire pit, hung a pot over it to warm water for washing up, and then took a broom to sweep the snow in the courtyard into a pile.

When she heard Changning crying from the next room, she hurried over to bring her younger sister back.

Changning was usually very well-behaved, but since their parents' passing, she would cry for a while if she woke up and didn't see Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu soothed her younger sister and had her sit on a stool while she combed her hair.

Perhaps because she had been in poor health since childhood, Changning's hair was not thick and black like hers. Instead, it was fine, soft, and yellowish. Coupled with many flyaways, even tying it into two small buns was quite a chore.

Fan Changyu was still a bit clumsy, so the buns on Changning's head were ugly in a new way every day.

After combing her sister's hair and telling her to go wash her face, Changning touched the bun on her left, then the bun on her right. She felt something wasn't quite right. Taking her washcloth to the basin, she looked at her reflection in the water and discovered that today's buns were exceptionally crooked.

She fiddled with a bun and said, "Big Sis, my hair is crooked."

Fan Changyu gave a dry cough. "I have to go to the County Government Office after breakfast, so I don't have time to re-do it for you. Can you just make do for today?"

Xiao Changning was easy to placate and immediately stopped making demands.

When Fan Changyu brought a fresh basin of water into the room, she found that the person inside seemed to have been awake for a while. He was fully dressed and sitting up against the headboard.

He had probably overheard the conversation between her and her sister, which made Fan Changyu feel a bit embarrassed.

She placed the basin on the round stool by the bed, handed him a clean cotton cloth, and spoke of the promise she had made when she allowed him the sham marriage. "I'll go to the County Government Office later to transfer the property deed, get your household registration sorted out, and hire a physician to come see you."

Hearing this, Xie Zheng said, "No need to hire a physician. My injuries will heal on their own with rest."

He had already applied trauma medicine to his wounds; he just needed to rest quietly and wait for the flesh to grow back.

Fan Changyu scratched her head and asked, "Is there anything you need? I can buy it for you."

The other party still shook his head, which made Fan Changyu feel awkward.

This was different from what she had promised before, making it seem as if she was the one who had benefited from the sham marriage.

She thought about going to the county seat later. After finishing her official business at the Yamen, she would buy him some supplements on her way back so he could properly recuperate.

After a hasty breakfast, Fan Changyu left. Because her younger sister was no longer the only one at home, she didn't leave her at Aunt Zhao's house. She only instructed Changning before she left that if anything happened, she could go next door to ask Aunt Zhao for help.

Unexpectedly, the moment she left, the local ruffians who had been staking out the alley ran to the gambling den to report.

Just as the sound of loud, banging on the door rang out, Xie Zheng, who had casually found a book in the corner of the room, had only listlessly flipped through two pages. His languid expression hid a hint of extreme, bored impatience. His mood was truly not good.

Chapter 10

The journey from the town to the County Government Office wasn't far. With a brisk pace, it took only half an hour to reach.

Fan Changyu was fortunate enough to run into an acquaintance also heading to the county town, so she hitched a ride on their ox cart. By the time she arrived at the County Government Office, the Yamen Runners had just begun their duties.

She gave Head Constable Wang's name to the guards at the gate and was soon led into the duty room at the back of the Yamen.

"...Any vagrants or beggars you encounter while patrolling the streets are to be brought straight to the Yamen prison. With the New Year just around the corner, keep your eyes sharp!"

Inside, Head Constable Wang seemed to be giving instructions, so Fan Changyu didn't barge in and waited quietly outside the door.

Once Head Constable Wang finished, he caught sight of Fan Changyu waiting outside from the corner of his eye and waved his hand. The constables picked up their Yamen-issued sabers and filed out in twos and threes, presumably to patrol the streets.

Only then did Fan Changyu step inside and say, "Uncle Wang, you seem quite busy today. I hope I'm not disturbing you."

The cold outside was biting, but the room was warm with a charcoal brazier burning. Soon, a layer of mist formed on her eyelashes.

Head Constable Wang poured her a cup of ginger tea to ward off the chill. "Busy or not, it's always like this around this time of year. But this year, the bandits have been particularly brazen, taking many lives. The higher-ups are cracking down on outsiders, anyone without household registration or travel permits is being thrown into prison. These past couple of days, they've been rounding up vagrants and beggars too."

Fan Changyu's hands, already red from the cold, clenched tighter at this. She thought of Yan Zheng, who currently had no household registration.

Head Constable Wang noticed her unease and asked, "Did you come today about transferring your family's property?"

Fan Changyu nodded.

Head Constable Wang said, "I forgot to mention earlier, Fan Da's petition has already been submitted. Until the lawsuit is settled, the property can't be transferred. But don't worry. Since you've taken in a live-in son-in-law, even if this goes to court, the County Magistrate will rule in your favor regarding the property your parents left behind. It'll just be a bit more troublesome, that's all."

Fan Changyu hadn't realized the process would be so complicated.

She recalled the basin of water she'd thrown over the courtyard wall the night before and asked, "What if, on the day of the trial, my uncle doesn't show up?"

Head Constable Wang glanced at her. "Then the petition becomes void. Moreover, such an act would be seen as disregarding the law and disrupting court proceedings. He'd be given twenty strokes of the rod as a warning!"

Fan Changyu immediately regretted not emptying the entire vat of cold water over the wall the night before.

Head Constable Wang asked, "Why do you ask?"

Fan Changyu coughed lightly. "Just curious."

She cradled the steaming teacup, her fingers unconsciously rubbing the rim. "There's one more thing I'd like to ask for your help with."

Head Constable Wang said, "Go ahead."

Only then did Fan Changyu explain Xie Zheng's situation. "My husband's money and household registration documents were all taken by bandits. Now that he's married into my family, I'd like to help him get a replacement registration."

Head Constable Wang's smile faded. After a long pause, he said, "Given the current situation, getting a replacement registration won't be easy."

But if Fan Changyu and Fan Da went to court, and she claimed to have taken in a live-in son-in-law, the County Magistrate would surely ask where her husband was from. Without proof of registration to verify his identity, there was a chance her husband might be thrown into prison as well.

In that case, not only might she lose her property, but her husband could also suffer.

Head Constable Wang paced back and forth in the duty room a couple of times before finally stomping his foot decisively. He turned to Fan Changyu and said, "Come with me."

The Record Keeper in charge of household registration in Qingping County was a friend of Head Constable Wang's. Thanks to this connection, he managed to help Fan Changyu secure a replacement registration for her husband.

Fan Changyu expressed her endless gratitude to Head Constable Wang, but he merely said, "Just don't mention this to outsiders, or I'll be in trouble. Your father once saved my life, and helping you today is my way of repaying his kindness..."

Changyu quickly assured him, "You've done me such a great favor, I'm too grateful to even think of blabbing about it carelessly."

Head Constable Wang sighed, reminiscing about his old friend. "Your father was a strange man. With his skills, he could've easily worked in the Yamen back then, but he insisted on becoming a butcher."

Changyu replied, "My father used to work as a caravan guard when he was younger, and my mother was always worried sick. After he retired, he just wanted a stable job to ease her mind."

These were all stories she had heard from her parents.

Knowing his old friend's temperament, Head Constable Wang sighed again and said no more.

After bidding farewell to the constable, Changyu went to her younger sister's favorite candy shop and bought a pack of malt sugar.

Originally, she had planned to sell a few acres of land in the countryside after transferring the property deed, using the money to buy New Year supplies and funds for purchasing pigs and piglets.

But plans often go awry. With the property transfer temporarily impossible, all she had left in her pocket were the small monetary gifts from neighbors who had attended the wedding banquet the day before—less than one tael in total.

Naturally, she couldn't afford the tonic she had intended to buy for Yan Zheng. But she didn't want to return empty-handed either. Spotting a street vendor selling hair ribbons and bands, she spent a few coins to buy a dark blue hair ribbon for him.

Apart from their wedding day, he had almost never tied up his hair.

Changyu guessed it was because he lacked a hair ribbon, the red one from the wedding wasn't suitable for daily use. Might as well get him one.

As she paid, a ragged figure suddenly sprinted toward her, knocking over several stalls in panic. Several officers chased after him, shouting, "Stop!"

The fugitive didn't dare pause, fleeing desperately while the officers gave chase.

Changyu initially thought the man had committed some crime, but someone nearby clicked their tongue and remarked, "New officials love to make a show of authority. The newly appointed Military Governor of Huizhou is truly a member of the Wei family. Rather than sending troops to suppress bandits, he's targeting refugees fleeing from the north. How cruel to persecute these displaced, innocent people..."

So the officers were chasing a refugee. Changyu recalled Head Constable Wang's words and felt a strange unease.

She glanced at the speaker. He and his companions wore identical long robes, the same style Song Yan had worn. It was the uniform of the county school, meaning they were all scholars there.

One of his companions sneered, "The Wei family holds absolute power while the imperial authority crumbles. The entire Great Yin dynasty is already rotten to the core! Now, with Huizhou's military power in their hands, I say it's only a matter of time before the dynasty bears the Wei name!"

Though Changyu had never left Qingping County, she knew exactly who they meant by "the Wei family."

Wei Yan, the current Grand Chancellor, had seized control of the court sixteen years ago after the Chengde Crown Prince died in battle at Jinzhou and the Old Emperor succumbed to grief. For over a decade, he had ruled as regent for the young emperor. Now, the people of Great Yin knew only the Chancellor, not the Emperor.

His son, Wei Xuan, even compared himself to the Crown Prince, with his hands stained by the blood of countless loyal ministers and valiant generals. It would not be an exaggeration to say he was steeped in evil.

Commoners, preoccupied with their daily struggles for survival, only heard the news deliberately released by the authorities. The true intricacies of these matters were better understood by the scholars who sought to analyze the political climate for their examinations.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but prick up her ears to listen further.

The scholar who had spoken earlier continued, "Without Wu'an Marquis guarding the northwestern frontier, how long this peace will last is anyone's guess. Even if Wei Yan harbors such ambitions, he likely lacks the courage to sit on the dragon throne!"

The name of Wu'an Marquis, Xie Zheng, was indeed thunderous in the current dynasty, though opinions about him were sharply divided.

His birth father was Xie Linshan, the Guardian General of the Nation, who had followed the Chengde Crown Prince on the expedition to Jinzhou. Pierced by countless arrows, he had refused to fall, standing tall even in death, his body propped against the army's banner.

His maternal uncle was Wei Yan, who had held sway over the court for over a decade.

Such a background was inherently controversial, and to make matters worse, he had been raised by his uncle. Thus, court officials regarded him as a member of the Wei Faction.

Xie Zheng's methods were indeed as ruthless and brutal as his uncle's.

His famed battle at seventeen, when he recaptured Jinzhou, still sent chills down people's spines. It was said that after taking Jinzhou, he massacred the entire city, sparing not even children. The armor of his eight hundred personal cavalry was drenched in blood, earning them the moniker "Blood-Clad Cavalry" from then on.

The Northern Turks trembled at the mere mention of his name. The twelve prefectures of Liaodong, seized by the Northern Turks since the previous dynasty, were also reclaimed by him.

With such illustrious military achievements, he was granted the title of Marquis of Wu'an at the tender age of twenty.

To bring peace to the realm through martial prowess was the very ideal embodied in the title Wu'an, and across all past dynasties he was the only person ever deemed worthy of bearing it.

Wei Yan wielded him like an unstoppable blade, enabling him to occupy the position of chancellor, manipulate imperial authority, and control the court to this day.

Court officials condemned Xie Zheng as a member of the Wei Faction while simultaneously relying on him to defend the borders.

Some even asserted that as long as he guarded the frontiers, the realm would remain at peace; but if he turned his ambitions toward the court, chaos would ensue.

Now, hearing the scholar say, "Without Wu'an Marquis guarding the northwestern frontier," Fan Changyu felt a sudden unease. Someone else voiced the question before she could: "What happened to Wu'an Marquis?"

The scholar replied, "Haven't you heard? After the battle at Chongzhou, Wu'an Marquis's fate is unknown. However, his military authority in Huizhou has already been taken over by Wei Xuan. It seems he has perished."

The crowd erupted in murmurs, many questioning the veracity of the scholar's words.

Though the world despised Wu'an Marquis as Wei Yan's blade and feared his disregard for human life, no one could deny that he was the pillar of the Great Yin dynasty in the northwest.

With this pillar broken, it was uncertain who in the Great Yin court could now hold up the northwestern sky.

Bombarded by the crowd's skeptical questions, the scholar grew exasperated and retorted, "If you doubt my words, go and find out for yourselves! See if the Military Governor of the northwest has just been replaced!"

Fan Changyu, having absorbed these weighty matters of state, walked home with a heavy heart.

Jizhou bordered Chongzhou. If the flames of war spread to Jizhou, she had no idea where she and her younger sister could flee for safety.

Remembering that Yan Zheng had fled from Chongzhou, she thought she might ask him about it when she returned. Perhaps he knew something about Wu'an Marquis's fate on the Chongzhou battlefield.

Chongzhou was merely a rebellion by a Rebel King. How could it have claimed the life of the Great Yin's God of War?

Just around the corner from the alley entrance, she ran into a woman who lived in the neighborhood and greeted her warmly: "Aunt Tao, are you going grocery shopping?"

The woman nodded but seemed hesitant to speak, her expression looking rather odd.

Chapter 11

Fan Changyu found it strange and was about to continue heading home when the woman said with a peculiar expression, "The gambling den people went to your house again. Your husband....."

Before the words could fully register, Fan Changyu grabbed a carrying pole from the wall and rushed toward the alley.

The woman hadn't expected Changyu to be so impulsive and shouted, "Your husband wasn't hurt! It was the gambling den people who got their legs broken by him!"

But Fan Changyu was already too far away to hear clearly.

From a distance, she saw a crowd gathered outside her house again, and her heart tightened. Gripping the pole harder, she yelled, "Move aside!"

The onlookers quickly scattered to both sides as they saw her charging toward them with the pole.

Just then, the gambling den's small-time boss, Boss Jin, hobbled out of the Fan family's doorway, now missing its gate. He was leaning on a long staff, his face twisted in a vicious snarl. Before he could react to the furious Fan Changyu, he was struck by the pole and sent flying sideways, collapsing to the ground.

Fan Changyu planted the pole firmly on the ground and was about to shout threats into the courtyard when she noticed the gambling den's thugs staring at her in terror. Those who had been dragging their injured legs to escape now scrambled backward instead.

But under the eaves inside, a cold-faced man with a cane sat in the Grand Tutor chair, his expression shadowed and grim.

The thugs, caught between a rock and a hard place, huddled together in the courtyard, trembling. These burly, rough-looking men now resembled pitiful little cabbages, wilted and miserable.

Fan Changyu: ?

She looked incredulously at the man under the eaves. Did he take all of them down?

Injured like that and barely able to walk without a cane, how could he still fight?

A neighbor at the gate, thinking Fan Changyu was about to beat them up again, quickly called out, "Changyu, don't hit them anymore! Your husband already did. Every one of them has a broken leg! Who knows how much we'll have to pay for their medicine!"

Hearing about compensation, Fan Changyu immediately yanked the "dead" Boss Jin up by his collar.

Pale-faced and with two streams of blood from his nose, Boss Jin begged, "Miss Fan, Miss Fan, please be merciful! Spare me, I'll never dare again!"

He shielded his face with both hands. "No more hitting..."

Fan Changyu scowled and pointed at the demolished gate. "You dogs acting tough because of your master! You wrecked my family's gate. How are you going to pay for that?"

She needed to tally the damages fast, better to make sure they wouldn't dare demand compensation for their broken legs!

Her gaze swept the courtyard again, but apart from the cowering thugs, nothing else seemed broken.

The man under the eaves sat in the Grand Tutor chair, pale but exuding an intimidating aura. The door behind him was intact, making it clear that the thugs hadn't even made it inside.

Fan Changyu's eyes lingered on the man for a few moments before spotting a trace of blood seeping through his robes. Finally, she found another reason to vent and barked, "My husband is injured, and you ganged up on him, outnumbering him! Look at what you've done—forget the external wounds, who knows how serious the internal injuries are! How much silver will it cost to see a physician?!"

Boss Jin frantically dug into his clothes and pulled out a handful of silver coins and coppers, shoving them toward Fan Changyu. "I'll pay, I'll pay! Just let me go, Miss Fan!"

Fan Changyu: "..."

She had only intended to scare these gambling den thugs, but the situation seemed to have spiraled out of control?

Her momentary distraction loosened her grip on Boss Jin's collar. Terrified out of his wits, the man hastily dropped the broken silver coins and copper coins on the ground before scrambling away on all fours.

Seeing this, the trembling enforcers in the courtyard froze for a breath before each fished out some copper coins from their robes, placed them on the ground, and then limped hastily out of the Fan Family's gate.

The onlookers stared at Fan Changyu and her sickly pale live-in husband as if they were freaks.

These gambling den enforcers not only collected gambling debts but also routinely extorted protection money on the streets. This was the first time someone had taken money from them instead.

Fan Changyu was also somewhat stunned.

Only after the crowd dispersed did she point at the front gate, which looked as if its hinges had been kicked apart and had toppled inward, and asked, "They did this, right?"

The man under the eaves nodded, and Changyu finally exhaled in relief.

At least she hadn't wronged anyone!

With mixed feelings, she picked up the scattered silver and copper coins from the ground and approached him. "I see blood soaking through your bandages. Did your wound reopen?"

Xie Zheng remained silent.

Changyu recalled how all the gambling den thugs had limped away. "You're injured. If something like this happens again, try to endure it and wait for me to handle it..."

Still met with silence, Changyu grew slightly awkward. After all, these troubles had arisen because of her. "If your wound keeps reopening, you'll only suffer more."

Xie Zheng finally spoke: "They were too noisy."

The slanting sunlight cast a sharp divide across his face—his upper half shadowed beneath the eaves, his lower half illuminated. His pale skin took on a translucent, icy quality, aloof and detached, yet undeniably handsome.

But his temper was far from agreeable.

Hearing his reason, Changyu was momentarily at a loss for words.

Xie Zheng seemed disinclined to continue the conversation and rose to return to his room.

Xiao Changning timidly peeked out from the kitchen, calling softly, "Elder Sister."

Changyu walked over and patted her younger sister's head. "Were you scared?"

Changning nodded, then shook her head. "Big Brother... I mean, Brother-in-law is amazing!"

Changyu paused at the title, guessing Aunt Zhao must have taught her to say it. "Amazing at beating up bad guys?"

Xiao Changning nodded vigorously. "Those people called Brother-in-law a 'pretty boy' and mocked him for being lame. But then Brother-in-law made all of them limp away!"

The little girl's eyes sparkled with excitement. "Elder Sister, what does 'pretty boy' mean? Is it because Brother-in-law's face is very white?"

Changyu's mood grew complicated as she recalled her earlier words. She told her sister sternly, "That's a rude term. Ning Niang must never say it, understand?"

Xiao Changning obediently nodded.

Changyu handed her the packet of malt candy she'd bought, instructing her to play in the courtyard without wandering off. Then she fetched the household's wound medicine and hesitated briefly before knocking on Xie Zheng's door.

"What is it?" came the man's cool, magnetic voice from within.

"I brought you some medicine," Changyu said.

Silence lingered inside.

Pressing her lips together, she finally added, "I'm sorry. I should have realized sooner. After you married into my family, they'd say all sorts of horrible things..."

The door suddenly swung open, cutting Fan Changyu's words short.

The man seemed to have been tending to his wounds earlier. Now, his outer robe was draped over his shoulders, and only the lower ties of his inner garment were fastened, leaving the top ones undone. This revealed his striking collarbones and a glimpse of his well-defined chest. His strikingly handsome face carried an unpleasant expression: "You think breaking one of their legs wasn't enough?"

Fan Changyu quickly shook her head.

Xie Zheng half-lifted his eyelids: "A few pieces of trash talking nonsense wouldn't bother me. I told you, they were just too noisy."

He turned and walked back into the room. Fan Changyu followed him inside and instinctively asked, "Do you need any help?"

He suddenly turned his head and gave her an inscrutable look before fastening the last tie of his inner garment: "It's already taken care of."

Fan Changyu: "..."

As if she had some ulterior motive for helping him with his wounds!

She was still holding the newly bought hair ribbon in her hand. Giving it to him now would make it seem like she really had improper thoughts about him. When his gaze swept over it, she expressionlessly tied it around her high ponytail instead. "This is a hair ribbon I bought for myself."

The dark blue color wasn't typically suited for women, but on her, it looked unexpectedly dashing.

Xie Zheng's expression turned slightly odd.

Fan Changyu felt she had salvaged her dignity. Not one to hold grudges, she set the medicine bottle on the table and recounted her visit to the Yamen that day: "Uncle Wang told me that Fan Da has submitted a petition to the County Government Office. Until the case is settled, I can't transfer the property deeds. I suspect the gambling den, still smarting from their humiliation last time, colluded with Fan Da to drive you away this way."

In the eyes of the gambling den thugs, he was an outsider who knew no one in Lin'an Town and was already injured, which made him the easiest target to push around.

After all, most ordinary people would have been scared out of their wits after such intimidation.

If her live-in husband ran away, her entire marriage arrangement would have been for nothing, and the property would ultimately go to Fan Da.

The man, who had seemed indifferent to her words, suddenly remarked, "The Great Yin Law's section on female-headed households should include an amendment allowing orphaned girls to establish their own households."

Fan Changyu knew widowed women could head their own households, but she had never heard of orphaned girls doing so.

In cases like hers, where both parents had passed away, it was customary for clan relatives to seize the property and then "care" for the orphaned girls until they were married off.

But the quality of that "care" depended entirely on the relatives' conscience. Those with no conscience might sell the girls into brothels, while most would treat them like servants, ordering them around until marriageable age. . At that point, they would be sold off to the highest bidder like livestock.

When her parents first died, Fan Da and his wife had come to take her and Changning away, promising to raise them as their own daughters. But Fan Changyu knew exactly what kind of people they were and adamantly refused. That was why Fan Da had repeatedly tried to seize the deeds afterward.

She clearly didn't take his words seriously. "The laws are made by those high-ranking officials in the capital. Which of those lords doesn't have multiple wives and concubines, with children aplenty? Their families would never face extinction. Even if disaster struck and only an orphaned girl remained, the relatives taking her in would be influential figures who wouldn't stint on food or clothing. How would those officials know what life is like for orphaned girls in the common world? Why would they ever legislate for them?"

Xie Zheng remained silent. Before his fall from grace, he truly hadn't even heard of the plight of orphaned girls in commoner households.

Seeing his silence, Fan Changyu thought she had rebutted him too harshly. She scratched her head and awkwardly tried to make amends: "But if any officials knew about the situation of orphaned girls and were willing to propose legislation for them, that would be a good thing."

Xie Zheng, however, was considering the feasibility of orphaned girls establishing female-headed households: "The court has reduced corvée

labor and taxes for female-headed households. If orphaned girls can become household heads, they should receive the same treatment. However, if an orphaned girl marries out or takes in a live-in son-in-law, adding male members to the household, they would no longer qualify for tax exemptions. The paperwork involved would be quite complicated."

Changyu looked utterly confused: "How do you know so much about the Great Yin Law?"

Realizing he had said too much, Xie Zheng lowered his gaze and replied, "Just picked up more knowledge from traveling around."

Changyu didn't suspect anything. She pulled out a household registration document from her collar pocket: "By the way, your household registration is ready. The county officials are now arresting all refugees and beggars they see. Outsiders without household registration or travel permits get thrown in jail when entering towns. Getting replacement documents isn't easy these days - Uncle Wang had to pull some strings to get yours processed."

Hearing this, Xie Zheng's expression darkened immediately: "Officials are arresting refugees?"

Changyu nodded: "I saw it with my own eyes on my way back. They say it's because the northwest got a new Military Governor who's worried about bandits raiding homes during the New Year season."

Suddenly she looked up at Xie Zheng: "I also heard that the Wu'an Marquis died on the Chongzhou battlefield. Since you fled from Chongzhou, do you know if that's true?"

"I don't know."

Changyu sighed: "If the Wu'an Marquis really died, that would be quite a pity."

A faint, almost mocking smile appeared on the man's pale face as he asked, "Why pity?"

Chapter 12

Daylight streamed in through the door and windows, making the whole room bright. The vitality and radiance on the young woman's face became even more irrepressible. She spoke as if it were a matter of course, "Of course it's a pity. In the several hundred years of the Great Yin Dynasty, how many Wu'an Marquises have there been?"

Fan Changyu counted on her fingers for him. "He was the one who recaptured Jinzhou, the throat of the northern frontier. He also recovered the twelve commanderies of Liaodong, a conflict that had dragged on for decades and cost the lives of countless good officials and famous generals. Although the battle for Jinzhou was highly controversial, when Jinzhou was seized by the Northern Turks back then, weren't the people of the Central Plains in the city brutally massacred as well?"

"Old General Xie died on his feet to preserve his dignity, yet the Northern Turks hung his body from the city wall to expose his corpse. The civil officials condemned the Wu'an Marquis with their words and writings, denouncing him as cold-blooded and cruel, but were the soldiers and common people who died in Jinzhou sixteen years ago not innocent? On what grounds can they, with a mere flap of their lips, so lightly absolve the Northern Turks of their sins on behalf of the dead? Without the Wu'an Marquis, who knows who else could defend this land in the northwest."

Xie Zheng had heard too many self-righteous denunciations of his battle at Jinzhou. This was the first time someone had spoken up for him.

A strange feeling stirred within him, and he couldn't help but re-examine the woman before him. "You're quite daring to say that."

Fan Changyu looked at him, perplexed. "What the officials say is their business. We common folk aren't fools. While the Wu'an Marquis's methods in military and political affairs were certainly brutal, he wasn't as wicked as those scholars claimed. Should we commoners not curse the corrupt officials who fleece us of the people's blood and sweat, but instead curse the Wu'an Marquis for killing the enemy too fiercely? What on earth is wrong with that kind of thinking!"

Xie Zheng: "...Don't people in the common-folk use his name to stop children from crying at night?"

Fan Changyu said, a little embarrassed, "My dad looks too fierce when he's butchering pigs. The people in town often use my dad's name to scare children too."

Xie Zheng: "..."

He raised a hand to press his brow, speechless for a long moment. The hostility and gloom in his heart miraculously dissipated a little at that moment.

...

At lunchtime, Fan Changyu first offered a stick of incense to her parents' memorial tablets. Having heard her mention her father before, Xie Zheng glanced at the tablets enshrined on the altar table against the wall of the main hall.

After seeing the name on one clearly, he suddenly asked, "Is your uncle named Fan Daniu?"

Fan Changyu was a little surprised. "How did you know?"

Xie Zheng said, "Your father's memorial tablet."

Fan Changyu glanced at the three characters "Fan Erniu" on her father's tablet and instantly understood what he meant.

She said, "My dad's given name was Erniu, but he got lost when he was a child and found his way back to his family after he grew up. Later, the people in town gave my dad the nickname Fan Laohu, so everyone just called him by his nickname."

Xie Zheng merely gave a faint nod. His gaze swept over her mother's memorial tablet, only to see that her mother didn't even have a surname. The name on the tablet was just Lihua, which seemed like a name casually given by country folk.

He couldn't help but ask, "Were your and your sister's names chosen by someone you hired?"

This couple didn't seem like the type of people who would choose names like Changyu and Changning.

Fan Changyu brought all the dishes to the table. "No, my mother chose them."

Speaking of her mother, a hint of pride appeared in her eyes. "My mother was amazing. She could read and write, and she also knew how to blend fragrances and make powders. Other butchers would have a strong smell on them after slaughtering a pig, but our family's clothes would always be scented with the fragrances my mother blended after being washed, so they never had any odor."

A trace of surprise appeared in Xie Zheng's cool eyes. "Your maternal grandparents' family was quite wealthy?"

Being literate and knowing how to blend fragrances and make powders—either skill alone would suggest a family of some means. For both to be present in one person, she must have come from a major household with a deep heritage.

Fan Changyu shook her head. "I've never met my maternal grandparents. My mother was someone my dad met in his early years when he was working as an escort. She wasn't a young lady from a prominent family, just a maid in someone's residence."

Lihua did indeed sound like a maid's name.

If she had been a maid from a prestigious family, it wouldn't be strange for her to know such things.

Fan Changyu said, "It's a pity I'm slow. I tried to learn to read from my mother, but I'd get a headache as soon as I looked at a book. I didn't learn how to blend fragrances and make powders well either. Otherwise, I'd have another way to earn money now."

Xie Zheng recalled the scene of her beating people with a staff and said with an ambiguous tone, "Perhaps you are more talented in other areas."

Fan Changyu nodded in agreement. "I think so too. If I hadn't learned how to butcher pigs from my dad, my house and land would have probably been repossessed by now, and I'd be living on the streets with Ning Niang."

Xiao Changning was trying hard to pick up a meatball. Hearing this, her moist, grape-like eyes widened. "Ning Niang doesn't want to live on the street."

Fan Changyu helped her younger sister, placing the meatball she had been struggling with into her bowl. "We won't live on the street. In the future, we're going to buy a big mansion in the county town."

Only then was Changning reassured. She continued her battle of wits with the meatball in her bowl, chattering with Fan Changyu from time to time.

In contrast to the two sisters' lively chatter during the meal, Xie Zheng barely spoke after picking up his chopsticks, truly embodying "eat without talking, sleep without speaking."

His table manners were also very refined. Fan Changyu's were not.

Butchering pigs was physical labor. She expended a lot of energy on a daily basis, so she naturally ate more than an ordinary woman.

She directly picked up a large bowl and shoveled rice into her mouth. Changning followed her example, almost burying her entire face in her rice bowl.

The movements of the big one and the little one were surprisingly identical.

After finishing and putting down their bowls, they let out a satisfied sigh, as if it made the meal taste even more delicious.

It was the first time in his life that Xie Zheng had seen a woman eat like this. His expression was quite peculiar.

In the afternoon, Fan Changyu found Carpenter Zhao to help repair the broken main gate of her house, while she herself tucked the silver away and went to the market to buy a pig.

To deal with Fan Da for the wedding, her newly opened butcher shop had been closed for another three days. If she didn't reopen soon, the reputation she had built with the braised offal would have been for nothing.

Before she left, Xie Zheng suddenly asked her, "Your mother was literate. Does your family have paper, ink, brushes, and an inkstone?"

Fan Changyu said, "We do. You need them?"

Xie Zheng nodded. "I'd like to borrow them."

Fan Changyu went and found the Four Treasures of the Study that her mother had bought long ago. Because they had been stored for a long time, the paper had turned somewhat yellow, the inkstone had a large chip in it, and the goat-hair brush had fanned out like a broom.

When Xie Zheng saw the Four Treasures of the Study placed before him, he fell silent for a second before thanking her.

In any case, it was better than writing on cloth with charcoal.

Fan Changyu didn't ask what he needed the paper and brush for, figuring that since he was literate, he was probably just bored from being cooped up at home with his leg injury and wanted to practice calligraphy or something.

After Fan Changyu left, Xie Zheng began to grind ink and write in his room. The quality of the ink was poor; when ground, it barely dissolved evenly in the water.

He suppressed the urge to throw the cockscomb-like brush and the inkstick out the window, and patiently wrote an eight-legged essay before Carpenter Zhao finished repairing the gate.

He asked Carpenter Zhao to help take the essay to a nearby bookstore to sell. "The Spring Examination is imminent. Eight-legged essays should be selling like hotcakes in all the major bookstores. I'll have to trouble you to make a trip to a bookstore for me and see if they'll accept this kind of essay."

Carpenter Zhao was illiterate, but he could see that Xie Zheng's calligraphy was excellent. He said in surprise, "Little brother, you're a scholar too?"

Xie Zheng only said, "I studied for a few years when I was young and gained some experience traveling all over as an escort. Now that I'm injured and have no money, I thought I'd try writing an eight-legged essay to earn some silver."

With the imperial family's power waning and the northwest in turmoil, the circulation of these few essays of his would once again stir up a huge wave of condemnation against the Wei clan among the scholars of the realm. This would keep that father and son busy, and they would naturally have no time to spare for searching for him.

Some information could also be passed covertly to his old subordinates through the essays.

A Gyrfalcon appearing in a town was, after all, too conspicuous. If it were tracked down by someone with ill intentions, it would surely lead to trouble.

Hearing him say this, Carpenter Zhao's eyes couldn't help but grow hot with emotion. "You're a good child. That girl Changyu has had a hard life. For her to be able to save you when you were injured in the wilderness, it must be fate between you two. Seeing you care for her like this, her aunt and I can rest easy..."

Xie Zheng knew the old man had misunderstood his desire to earn money as him caring for the butcher girl. He wanted to explain, but he couldn't find a better explanation at the moment, so he could only remain silent.

In Carpenter Zhao's eyes, however, this was a tacit admission.

The strange feeling in his heart grew stronger. Fearing that Fan Changyu might also misunderstand, he made a point of acting even colder after she returned home. Unfortunately, his face rarely showed any extra expression on a normal day, and Fan Changyu was rather thick-skinned, so she didn't notice anything unusual about him at all.

That night.

After making the bed in the north room and putting her younger sister to sleep, Fan Changyu went to the kitchen to braise the pork for the next day's sale. Thinking that Yan Zheng was injured and would likely feel cold at night, she put the leftover red embers from the stove into a brazier and brought it to him.

She still hadn't broken the habit of walking straight into the room she had lived in for over a decade. The moment she entered, she discovered that he was once again half-undressed and applying medicine.

This time, however, Fan Changyu had no time for embarrassment, because the man's entire back was stained with blood, and his snow-white inner shirt was also spattered with it.

During the day, she had wanted to help him apply the medicine, but he had refused. She had thought his wounds hadn't split open much, but she never expected them to be this severe.

Xie Zheng's handsome brows furrowed the moment she pushed the door open. He was about to put his clothes back on when a pair of warm, strong hands pressed down on his shoulders.

The shiver that ran through him at the instant of skin-on-skin contact made his brows furrow even tighter. He subconsciously tried to push away the hand on his shoulder, but she held him fast, pinning him in place, unable to move.

Xie Zheng's breath caught. A hint of bewilderment appeared in his beautiful eyes, unsure if he was stunned by the woman's strength or by her sheer audacity. "You..."

"You what? Do you not want to live? Is asking someone to help you apply medicine so difficult?"

Seeing the split-open wounds on his back, Fan Changyu didn't give him a pleasant look. She didn't know what this man was being so stubborn about. With his wounds reopening again and again, how much silver would it cost to treat them!

As she picked up the medicine bottle on the table and sprinkled the powder onto the bloody gashes on his back, she couldn't help but mutter, "A grown man—what's with all the fuss!"

A vein throbbed violently at Xie Zheng's temple. The woman's hand on his shoulder had not moved, and half his shoulder felt as if it had been seared by a branding iron. He knitted his brows tightly. "Men and women should not touch."

Fan Changyu said, "I was the one who carried you back from the wilderness! Touch or not, we've already been intimate!"

The moment the words left her mouth, the entire room fell into silence.

Fan Changyu also realized she had misspoken. She hated studying more than anything, yet this man insisted on speaking to her in such a literary manner. She scratched her hair in frustration. "I didn't mean I've been intimate with you... Ai..."

Xie Zheng's eyelids also began to twitch. He cut her off before she could say something even more shocking. "I know what you mean."

Fan Changyu nodded quickly. "As long as you know."

Afraid he would misunderstand that she had designs on him, she gritted her teeth and told a white lie. "Don't worry, I have no designs on you. I... I'm still not over my ex-fiancé! We were childhood sweethearts, after all. He's so handsome and so smart, the only one in the entire county to pass the provincial examination. How could I just get over him like that."

After saying this, Fan Changyu's skin crawled with goosebumps.

The man before her had an inscrutable expression. He only said, "My condolences."

Fan Changyu: ?

Song Yan wasn't dead yet

Chapter 13

The next day, Fan Changyu arrived at her family's butcher shop early in the morning with fresh pork and braised meat.

The morning market was already bustling with vendors hawking their wares, and elderly women wrapped in thick coats, baskets in hand, were picking through stalls and haggling over prices.

After setting up her goods on the chopping block, Fan Changyu greeted a few butchers who had been close with her father as usual. This time, however, their responses were somewhat reluctant.

Puzzled, she was about to wonder why when an old woman shopping for groceries, likely drawn by the steaming, fragrant pork head meat on display, asked, "Is this braised pork head meat also a giveaway?"

Fan Changyu assumed the woman had heard about her previous offer of free braised offal and replied sheepishly, "Auntie, pork head meat isn't cheap, and the braising spices are expensive too. How could I give it away?"

The woman pursed her lips and turned her gaze to the braised offal nearby. "Then is this braised offal free?"

Fan Changyu said, "I gave it away for one day when my shop reopened for good luck, but now it's not free anymore. If you want to buy it, it's two coins for an ounce."

The woman's expression instantly darkened. "All the other butcher shops give theirs for free, and you're actually charging for it?"

Fan Changyu grew even more confused. "You mean all the butcher shops on this street give away braised offal with purchases?"

The woman huffed. "Why would I lie? Go see for yourself!"

"Here you go, take care!"

Just then, a deal was struck at Butcher Guo's stall across the street. His loud call drew Fan Changyu's attention, and she saw the woman who had

bought meat not only carrying pork but also holding a packet of braised offal wrapped in oiled paper.

Butcher Guo noticed Fan Changyu looking his way and deliberately turned his face away, busying himself with rearranging the meat on his stall.

A large basin sat in the corner of his chopping block. From a distance, it was hard to see what was inside, but now it was clear—it must be braised offal.

Fan Changyu's eyes widened. That shameless old man! Back when she had given away freebies, he had been so jealous he nearly stormed over to flip her stall on the spot. He had even repeatedly warned her not to give away freebies in the future. Yet now, he was using the same tactic to attract customers!

Looking around, she noticed the neighboring stalls also had basins of braised meat on their chopping blocks. No wonder the other butchers had seemed off when she greeted them earlier.

The woman pressed, "So, are you giving it away or not? If not, I'll just buy from another shop!"

Fan Changyu immediately said, "I'll give it away!"

After all, offal wasn't worth much, and the braising spices weren't just for the offal but for the pig's head meat too. She might as well keep using the offal as a giveaway to promote her braised meat!

When everyone sold pork, some buyers couldn't tell the difference in quality. But using braised offal as a giveaway was different, the color and aroma couldn't be faked!

This might actually work in her favor!

The woman had already taken a liking to Fan Changyu's braised meat. The stuff elsewhere looked dull and lacked fragrance, but hers had a rich, glossy red hue—clearly superior.

Hearing that Fan Changyu was also offering freebies, the woman beamed. "Give me five pounds of rump meat!"

Fan Changyu swiftly chopped five pounds of pork rump, weighed it, and handed it over, then sliced five ounces of braised offal as a bonus.

The woman sniffed the offal and exclaimed how delicious it smelled. Before leaving, she added, "Your giveaway is excellent, I'll tell my neighbors to come buy from you too!"

Fan Changyu smiled and agreed, promising to give the old lady more giveaways next time. The old lady happily walked away with her meat.

Others saw that she had bought fresh meat from Fan Changyu's shop and also taken a pack of braised offal. The color of the offal in Fan's shop was particularly appealing, so they couldn't help but step forward to ask the price. In the end, without exception, they all bought meat from Fan Changyu's stall.

Those who came to buy meat and vegetables noticed the crowd gathered in front of Fan's shop and instinctively assumed her goods must be better, so they squeezed in to take a look as well.

Before the morning market was even halfway over, the fresh meat and braised offal in Fan Changyu's shop had been snatched up, leaving only half a braised pork head unsold.

In contrast, the other butcher shops only managed a few sales, and those were only because Fan's meat had sold out, forcing customers to settle for second best.

Butcher Guo, seeing customers finally approaching his stall, eagerly promoted the pork on his chopping block: "Take a look—top-quality belly pork! I'll even throw in some braised offal!"

The shopper peeked at the dull, grayish offal in his basin and immediately pursed their lips, shaking their head. "The giveaways from Fan's Meat Shop—their braised offal is glossy and bright red. Did you just boil yours in water and sprinkle a bit of salt on it?"

"I'll come earlier tomorrow and buy from Fan's again!" The shopper put down the piece of pork they had been inspecting and walked away without another word.

Butcher Guo's face twisted in displeasure. He glanced at the pork in his shop, then at the braised meat in the basin, and in a fit of anger, kicked over a nearby stool, muttering vulgar curses under his breath.

The commotion naturally caught the attention of the neighboring stalls.

Fan Changyu's meat shop was directly opposite Butcher Guo's, so she saw it all clearly.

A butcher's wife from a friendly neighboring stall whispered to her, "To be honest, none of us really want to do this giveaway business. It's thankless work."

After all, when one shop started offering giveaways, business boomed. But once every butcher shop on the street began doing the same, and none stood out in taste, sales returned to how they were before, just plain pork. The only difference was that now they had to throw in a free portion of braised offal for nothing.

The butcher's wife continued, "But that Guo fellow has more schemes than a beehive has holes. A few days ago, he kept insisting you shouldn't give away freebies, yet the very next day, he started doing it himself—no shame at all. A few of us went to reason with him, but he was completely unreasonable. If anyone tried to confront him physically, he'd just flop to the ground and accuse them of assault. On top of that, he has an uncle serving as a clerk for the county magistrate. None of us can do anything about him, but we couldn't just stand by and watch him steal all the business with his giveaways, so we all started offering braised offal too."

Fan Changyu understood that this auntie was explaining so much to avoid any misunderstanding, so she said, "I get it, Auntie."

The butcher's wife, secretly pleased to see Butcher Guo suffer today, glanced in his direction and couldn't resist gloating. "Thank goodness you're back, Changyu. Let's see how much longer he can keep giving away that saltwater-boiled offal."

Butcher Guo, relying on his relative in the county government office, had always been arrogant and looked down on everyone. The vendors on this street had long been fed up with his attitude.

In the past, only Fan Changyu's father had dared to stand up to him without fear. But after the accident that took Fan's parents, Butcher Guo acted like the local tyrant of the street, barking orders and throwing his weight around every day.

Fan Changyu didn't spare Butcher Guo another glance. After selling the last half of the pork head, she began counting the copper coins in her drawer.

Today's slaughtered pig weighed just over eighty pounds. The fresh meat and braised meat together sold for over two strings and three hundred

copper coins. After deducting the one-string cost of buying the pig, the net profit was one string and three hundred coins!

Fan Changyu threaded the copper coins onto a thin string, hefting the weighty bundle in her hand, her mood lifting noticeably.

The property transfer would be completed soon, and the butcher shop's business was gradually stabilizing. Life for her and her younger sister would only get better from here!

Once she saved enough money, she would take her sister to the capital for medical treatment. She'd heard the best things in the world were in the capital, including the finest physicians.

After closing up shop, Changyu took the money to the market. After purchasing medicine for the two sickly members at home and some spices needed for braising broth, then setting aside one string for buying another pig, only a few hundred coins remained.

Changyu sighed softly. Only when managing a household does one truly understand the cost of daily necessities.

Selecting some New Year goods, she headed home. Before even entering the alley, she spotted a snow-white gyrfalcon flying high into the sky from the direction of her house, likely the same one she'd seen before.

Changyu wondered curiously: Did that gyrfalcon often hunt for food around here?

If it came frequently... then there might be a chance to catch it?

The gyrfalcon vanished from sight in an instant, but Changyu was already calculating how much money it might fetch at the market if caught.

Arriving home, she pushed open the courtyard gate and immediately noticed the half-open window in the man's room. Draped in a dark old robe, he sat at his desk with hair cascading around him, his expression serene. His slender, scabbed fingers held a brush as he concentrated on writing something.

Outside the window stood a red plum tree planted by her father for her mother years ago.

Perhaps sensing its original caretakers were gone, this winter the tree had produced only a single small bud.

Amidst branches laden with frost, that solitary splash of color still couldn't compare to even one-tenth of the beauty of the man inside.

Fine snowflakes blew through the window, some settling in his jet-black hair. The features beneath those dark locks were exquisitely refined yet chillingly aloof.

Changyu's breath caught slightly. When the man looked up, she didn't avert her gaze but continued observing him openly. "Aren't you cold with the window open?"

Xie Zheng met her eyes, noting her unwavering stare. His brows furrowed almost imperceptibly before he looked away. "The room is too dark. The window provides better light," he replied in his characteristically cool, clear voice.

Changyu made an acknowledging sound. After putting away her purchases in the main room and checking on her napping sister, she brought him a charcoal brazier.

The room felt as cold as outdoors, likely from the constantly open window. Noticing the stack of ink-covered papers on the desk, she couldn't help asking, "What are you writing?"

He'd produced so much. Had he been freezing here all morning? Didn't he feel the cold?

Xie Zheng finished the final character. Having no brush rest, he placed the ink-laden brush on the chipped edge of the inkstone. "Eight-legged essays," he answered flatly.

Changyu knew what these were. Song Yan had often scrimped to buy them, three hundred coins per volume.

Surprised, she asked, "You can write eight-legged essays?"

Xie Zheng continued to brush her off with the same excuse he had used on Carpenter Zhao: "Just some observations from traveling around. Small-town bookstores have uneven quality in their collections, and they'll take anything flashy enough to impress."

Fan Changyu choked on her words, thinking how unlucky those scholars buying Eight-legged essays must be.

The thought that Song Yan might have scrimped and saved to buy such essays in the past gave her a secret thrill.

She cleared her throat and finally remembered his injuries. "The roads are slippery in the snow. Even if the snow is swept away, there might still be thin ice. Your wounds just reopened yesterday—it's too dangerous to go out on crutches so rashly..."

Had she rambled on like this just because she was worried about him?

Xie Zheng was momentarily stunned before lowering his gaze and saying, "I asked the old man next door to bring them back for me."

Fan Changyu's expression softened slightly, but thinking of why he had written the essays, she pressed her lips together. "Since you've agreed to the sham marriage with me, I'll keep my promise to let you recover properly. The current tight finances are just because the property hasn't been transferred yet. You... don't need to do this."

The idea of a severely injured man braving the cold wind to rack his brains writing Eight-legged essays to help with household expenses weighed heavily on her conscience.

A cold gust blew into the room, stirring Xie Zheng's unbound hair. He studied the woman before him, her delicate brows furrowed, and his indifferent expression grew subtly complex.

Not wanting her to misunderstand, he said, "I was just idling away. Writing essays to pass the time—it's not what you think."

The more he said this, the more Fan Changyu became convinced of her own suspicions.

After all, who would write Eight-legged essays in freezing wind just to pass the time? Her emotions tangled into a complicated knot.

Pursing her lips, she said, "Don't worry about me being poor. I can afford to take care of you!"

With that, she left the room, leaving Xie Zheng alone at the desk. His slender fingers pressed against his temple, his gaze deep and inscrutable, as if pondering something deeply troubling.

Chapter 14

For the next several days, Fan Changyu threw herself wholeheartedly into butchering pigs, preparing braised meats, and selling her products.

The braised offal from her shop was a complete sensory delight—aromatic, flavorful, and visually appealing. Though she had always given it away as a free giveaway, no other butcher shop on the entire street could compete with her business.

Some customers, unable to buy meat from her shop on the day, would rather wait until the next day to purchase from her. For several days in a row, Fan Changyu could sell out completely even after butchering two pigs in her shop.

Such booming business naturally made all the other butchers on the street green with envy. Butcher Guo, seeing all the customers flocking to Fan Changyu's shop, grew displeased again. Shamelessly, he loudly proclaimed that offering giveaways was an unnecessary burden on butcher shops and urged everyone to stop the practice.

While the others looked down on Butcher Guo's behavior, it was undeniable that Fan Changyu had drawn away the majority of customers with her giveaways. Though they didn't openly agree, they tacitly accepted Butcher Guo's suggestion.

Fan Changyu, ever good-natured, agreed that everyone would stop offering giveaways.

It wasn't that she was easily pushed around. By now, the reputation of "Fan's Braised Meat" had already spread far and wide. She no longer needed to rely on giveaways to attract customers. The offal she painstakingly cleaned and braised was worth twenty coins per pound—why give it away when she could sell it?

She might as well do them this favor, since they were all doing business on the same street and would inevitably cross paths.

The butchers on the street eagerly waited for business to return to how it was before. However, even after stopping the giveaways, while Fan

Changyu's shop wasn't as bustling as before, it still remained the best on the entire street.

In fact, as the fame of her braised meats spread, people from the town stopped buying braised food from the street specializing in cooked dishes and made special trips to Fan Changyu's shop instead.

With so many customers coming for her braised meats, demand often outstripped supply. Fan Changyu eventually set up a large pot right outside her shop, selling the meats braised the previous night on the chopping block while simultaneously braising fresh batches in the pot.

This unplanned move unexpectedly took her braised meat business to new heights.

The aroma was simply irresistible. The braising broth bubbled vigorously in the pot, turning the cleaned pork head meat and offal into a beautiful soy-brown hue. The star anise, bay leaves, citrus peels, and other spices inside were clearly visible to all.

Not a single passerby in the market could resist approaching to inquire about the price after catching a whiff of that fragrance.

With the meats being braised right before customers' eyes and the pot filled with genuine ingredients, even the haggling became less intense compared to when she simply sold pre-cooked meats.

When she ran out of pork heads from her own butchered pigs, Fan Changyu would often buy a few more from neighboring butcher shops to avoid wasting the precious braising broth. She'd clean them on the spot and braise them immediately.

During peak business, her shop could sell seven or eight braised pork heads in a single day.

Fresh pork heads in the market sold for twenty coins per pound. After being turned into braised delicacies, the head and ears combined sold for about fifty coins per pound. A single pork head weighed around six to seven pounds, meaning each braised pork head netted her at least one hundred eighty coins in profit.

Selling seven or eight would earn her about one string and five hundred coins. Combined with the profit from fresh pork, her daily income stabilized at around two strings of coins.

As her money pouch grew steadily heavier, Fan Changyu decided to splurge one day and have new clothes made for everyone in the household.

She first went to the pawnshop to redeem the hairpin she had pawned. But the pawnbroker greeted her with an awkward smile: "That hairpin has already been sold..."

Fan Changyu immediately grew anxious: "Didn't I ask you to hold it for me?"

The shopkeeper sighed helplessly, "Well... everyone who comes to pawn something in my shop says the same thing. How can I possibly keep items for all of them? I have a family to feed too!"

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and apologized before asking, "Then do you remember who bought the hairpin?"

After some thought, the shopkeeper replied, "It was bought by a young lady on the very day you pawned it. She was dressed quite elegantly, seemed to be from the county town."

Changyu's heart sank to the depths.

Qingping County wasn't particularly large, but finding a complete stranger would still be difficult. Retrieving the hairpin seemed hopeless now.

Noticing her expression, the shopkeeper tried to promote other jewelry in his display: "How about this silver hairpin instead? The design is even prettier than yours!"

Without a word, Changyu left the pawnshop. Outside, the snowstorm raged. She sat on the steps for a while, unable to quell the ache in her chest.

Though she'd mentally prepared herself when pawning the silver hairpin that it might be lost forever, facing this reality still brought an unexpected wave of sorrow.

The hairpin her parents had given her for her coming-of-age ceremony was gone.

Wiping her eyes clumsily, Changyu trudged home with slumped shoulders.

Meanwhile, the west city alley was buzzing with unusual activity—the Song family was moving

Song Yan was the only scholar from Qingping County to pass the provincial exams this year. Even the county magistrate had invited him to dine, while local gentry and merchants vied to curry favor.

The magistrate had arranged a residence in town for Song Yan, publicly stating it was to provide better study conditions so he might pass the imperial exams and bring glory to the county.

With the new residence apparently ready, Song Yan and Mother Song had chosen today for their move.

Despite the feud between the Fan and Song families, other neighbors weren't willing to burn bridges with the family that had produced a provincial graduate. Many came out to see them off.

Approaching the alley entrance, Changyu spotted two stately blue-canopied carriages parked roadside. Further in, she saw the Song mother and son bidding farewell to neighbors at their doorstep.

Song Yan stood tall in his indigo robe, the very picture of scholarly grace as he bowed courteously to the well-wishers. His gentle features radiated bookish refinement.

Mother Song, dressed splendidly with oiled hair and golden hairpins, managed to squeeze out a few tears amid the flattery, pretending reluctance to leave.

In no mood for social niceties, Changyu pretended not to see them and skirted the crowd toward home. Then a cultured male voice called from behind, "Miss Fan, a moment please."

The crowd's expressions shifted curiously at this. Since the broken engagement, the two families had avoided contact. With Changyu already married to a live-in husband and Song Yan rumored to become the magistrate's ideal son-in-law, what business could they possibly have?

Speculations ran wild. Some curious, some eager for drama, others hoping for juicy gossip.

Turning, Changyu saw Song Yan approaching with an ornate box, stopping three paces away. Every movement exuded scholarly refinement as he spoke: "My mother and I have lived here many years, much indebted to your late father's kindness. His generosity in providing a coffin during our hardship remains forever remembered in my heart. As we move today, please accept this small token of my gratitude."

The brocade box was square, exquisitely crafted, and quite sizable—who knew what was inside?

Fan Changyu was nearly laughing in exasperation. Ever since the Song family had broken off the engagement, her Fan family had faced one hardship after another, while the Songs remained completely uninvolved. Now on moving day they brought out this brocade box in front of all the neighbors, clearly just putting on a show for the crowd.

Her expression turned mocking. "What's this?"

Song Yan replied, "A small token of regard from my mother and myself."

With a backhanded swipe, Changyu sent the box crashing to the ground. Ingots of silver tumbled out, drawing gasps from the onlookers.

None in this alley were wealthy folk; many had likely never seen a silver ingot in their lives. The sight of that gleaming white silver was an eye-opener.

Mother Song immediately shrieked, "What do you think you're doing?"

She usually worked hard to maintain her air of an official's wife, and had been basking in flattery lately. To be publicly humiliated like this by Fan Changyu was more than just "embarrassing."

Though she now wore fine silks, decades of toil had left her gaunt and shriveled, her bony frame unable to fill out the luxurious garments. Her sunken cheeks and prominent cheekbones only accentuated her sharp, unkind features.

Changyu sneered, "Scholar Song's gift is far too generous, I wouldn't dare accept it. When you came with your fortune-teller's note to break the engagement, I didn't take a single coin from your family. Yet it was my father who bought Old Scholar Song's coffin, and later paid your tuition fees. And still, some busybodies twist the truth, claiming my father used petty favors to force Scholar Song into marrying a butcher's daughter."

She gave a cold laugh. "My parents' graves are still fresh, I won't stand for such slander."

Mother Song blustered, "What outsiders say has nothing to do with us!"

Changyu glanced at the scattered ingots, her lips curling. "I never said you put them up to it. Why so defensive?"

Unable to bear the provocation, and with the neighbors watching, Mother Song flushed crimson. "What exactly are you implying?"

Changyu said, "To prevent further malicious gossip, let the neighbors bear witness today: I absolutely refuse Scholar Song's ingots. But with my parents gone, my frail younger sister, and my husband ill and injured, our family is in dire need of funds. So let's settle accounts: the money my father spent on your coffin and those years of tuition. Repaying me in full shouldn't be difficult, should it?"

Her smile was laced with sarcasm. "That way, Scholar Song and Madam Song won't have to worry about our family trying to cash in on past favors. Like last time, when Fan Da brought loan sharks to smash up our house and Auntie next door wept at your gate for help, yet your door remained shut."

Others might tiptoe around it, leaving the Songs some dignity, but Changyu had ripped off the veil. Mother Song's face was beyond "ugly", and she could feel the neighbors' silent scorn like a burning brand. Changyu might as well have pointed at her nose and called the Songs ungrateful.

Her Yan'er was destined to be a top scholar! If this vulgar butcher's daughter ruined his reputation and future, it would be the death of her!

Mother Song was trembling, about to speak, when her silent son suddenly said to the butcher woman, "If you come looking for me, I won't remain indifferent."

"Yan'er!" Mother Song rolled her eyes, nearly fainting on the spot.

Fan Changyu also frowned, thinking to herself that Song Yan must have gone mad to say such things in public.

But before she could respond, a soft voice came from beyond the crowd: "Brother-in-law, there are so many people here!"

A man's cold voice replied, "Don't wander off."

Changyu turned to see her younger sister standing on tiptoe at their doorstep, peering curiously at the commotion. The man had likely followed to ensure the child didn't get lost in the crowd. His handsome brows were furrowed as if annoyed by the trouble of watching over her.

He wore the same russet-red robes from their wedding day, his long hair simply tied back. The wide sleeves concealed most of his single crutch. His

features were sharp and cold, his complexion pale as snow.

Leaning casually against the doorframe, his posture was relaxed. It was unclear how long he'd been there or how much he'd heard of the exchange between Changyu and the Song mother and son.

When Changyu's gaze met his, his expression remained unreadable. The corners of his lips quirked slightly, though not quite into a smile.

Chapter 15

"That must be Changyu's live-in husband, right?"

"I caught a glimpse of him on their wedding day. After all this time, he looks even more handsome!"

"Now we'll get to see the showdown between the live-in husband and the former scholar fiancé!"

The neighborhood women who spotted Xie Zheng and Song Yan couldn't help whispering among themselves.

Changning also saw her elder sister and immediately tugged at Xie Zheng's sleeve, running over excitedly: "Sister!"

The two little buns on her head bounced with each step, her round face fair and delicate. Bundled in a thick padded jacket, she looked like a snowball with tiny limbs.

With thin ice covering the ground making it slippery, Fan Changyu quickly warned: "Slow down! Your brother-in-law has leg injuries. Be careful not to fall!"

The term "brother-in-law" felt slightly awkward even to Changyu herself.

She glanced at Yan Zheng's expression - his refined face remained composed, showing no particular reaction to the title, as if being addressed this way was completely natural.

Indeed, Changning frequently called him brother-in-law, though Changyu still wasn't quite accustomed to encouraging it.

Changning had already reached her sister and guiltily stuck out her tongue before wrapping her chubby little arms around Changyu's leg, glaring defiantly at the Song mother and son across from them.

She'd deliberately dragged her brother-in-law over. If these two villains dared bully her sister again, her brother-in-law could just whack their legs with his cane until they limped too!

She just hadn't shared this brilliant plan with her sister yet.

Completely unaware of her little sister's scheming, Changyu patted the girl's head and said to Xie Zheng: "Your injuries haven't healed yet. Going out is inconvenient. You shouldn't indulge Ning Niang's mischief..."

Though spoken politely, to onlookers it appeared as thoughtful concern for her husband.

Many eyes kept shifting between Song Yan and Xie Zheng.

Most privately agreed that while the live-in husband was more handsome, Song Yan's scholarly achievements made him more impressive. After all, not just anyone could pass the imperial exams.

Xie Zheng glanced at Changyu's faintly reddened eyes and simply said: "No matter."

His striking phoenix eyes narrowed slightly.

She'd been crying?

Over that ex-fiancé?

Seems she really hasn't moved on.

Pathetic.

As the north wind whipped through the hair falling across his chest, he lazily lifted his gaze to the blue-robed man behind Changyu.

Though his stare seemed casual, the intensity behind it was overwhelming.

Meeting that gaze, Song Yan felt like prey caught in a wolf's sights. His hairs stood on end instinctively. Even after looking away, his chest kept constricting with lingering dread.

Like an animal trembling after narrowly escaping a predator's jaws.

Xie Zheng wasted no words on the mother and son, cutting straight to the point: "Repay the debt."

Not just the Songs and bystanders, even Changyu was momentarily stunned.

Xie Zheng hated repeating himself. Seeing no response from the pair, impatience already tinged his handsome features. "Trying to cheat the bereaved out of their money?"

Changning pressed her lips together nervously but watched her brother-in-law's cane with barely concealed excitement.

Was he about to hit someone?

Finally processing his words, Song Yan and Mother Song were further shocked by his accusation. Mother Song nearly fainted from rage.

These Fan family members! Their tongues grew sharper by the day! Before she could even speak, they'd already branded her a swindler!

Mother Song was trembling with rage, needing the support of two women to stay upright. "When did our family ever say we wouldn't repay?"

She then called to Song Yan: "Yan'er, count out the silver for them!"

Even in her poorest days, when she had lost her husband and knelt on the streets begging for a coffin, Mother Song had never felt as humiliated as she did today.

After saying this, she immediately headed out of the alley, as if she couldn't bear to stay another moment.

Such was the nature of pride—when one had none, no amount of hardship seemed unbearable. But once one gained dignity, having it stripped away was an unbearable bitterness.

Fan Changyu hadn't expected his words to provoke Mother Song to such a state and glanced at him in surprise.

The man merely gave her a faint look.

Somehow, Changyu interpreted a hint of "You're too soft; I'm collecting the debt for you" in that glance, leaving her utterly bewildered.

When Changyu's father had provided the coffin for the Song family back then, it wasn't just the coffin. He also covered the burial clothes and funeral expenses, which came to ten taels of silver.

As for Song Yan's tuition, the village schoolmaster charged two taels a year. Song Yan had studied there for five years before passing the county-level exams. The county schoolmasters, aware of his family's poverty, had collectively waived his fees. The ten taels her father had covered were solely for the tuition.

When Song Yan handed the two silver ingots to Fan Changyu, a large, well-defined hand intercepted them on her behalf. When Song Yan looked

up, he saw the man she had taken in as a live-in son-in-law.

The man's expression was cold as he stated simply, "We're even."

Yes, from now on, they were even.

Song Yan gazed at Fan Changyu, his lips twisting bitterly.

But the man didn't give him a chance to exchange glances with Changyu. As he passed the ingots to her, he cast a sidelong glance at Song Yan and said flatly, "Let's go."

As a fellow man, Song Yan was certain there was no hostility in that look. It was pure disdain, like a mother hen guarding her chick.

Fan Changyu, being the "chick" in question, remained dazed even after entering her own home.

Once the gate closed, the man no longer concealed his contempt. "That's the kind of trash you've been pining over all this time? Even cried for him?"

Changyu, recalling her earlier lie, found herself at a loss for words and retorted weakly, "When did I cry?"

Xie Zheng detested trouble and had no patience for meddling in others' affairs. He had only stepped in because he couldn't stand watching the woman who'd saved him continue to make a fool of herself over such a man.

Hearing her evasion now, he couldn't be bothered to argue further.

Just then, their neighbor Aunt Zhao hurried over. "I heard the Songs put on a show of handing you silver before leaving. That was just for the neighbors to see, wasn't it? That mother and son really know how to make people sick! On your wedding day, he even sent over some worthless clay dolls—"

Halfway through her rant, Aunt Zhao caught sight of Xie Zheng and immediately regretted her words, clamping a hand over her mouth to swallow the rest.

Xie Zheng said nothing, only sweeping Fan Changyu with a pair of sharp, mocking phoenix eyes that clearly conveyed, "Go on, keep lying."

Changyu, stifling her frustration, stayed silent.

She hadn't expected a spur-of-the-moment lie to become a joke this man would hold over her for so long.

Only after Xie Zheng had gone inside did Aunt Zhao turn to Changyu apologetically. "This old woman really can't keep her mouth shut..."

Fan Changyu looked somewhat weary and simply said, "It's nothing."

At most, she'd just be mocked by that guy again.

She invited Aunt Zhao to warm herself by the fire pit. Once seated, Aunt Zhao couldn't help but remark, "That Song fellow pulling another stunt today—I hope it doesn't affect your marital harmony."

Fan Changyu thought to herself that it would be a miracle if she and that sharp-tongued, unforgiving man had any affection between them.

She wanted to tell the truth, but with the property dispute still unresolved, she decided to avoid complications and just said, "It won't."

Aunt Zhao suddenly asked, "Are you still sharing the north room with Ning Niang at night?"

Fan Changyu gave an affirmative hum, and Aunt Zhao's brows furrowed. "How about letting Ning Niang sleep with me tonight?"

Catching the implication, Fan Changyu nearly choked on her own saliva and hurriedly declined.

Aunt Zhao shot her a reproachful look. "You and your husband are properly wed, so what are you being so coy about?"

Fan Changyu fell back on her usual excuse: "He's injured."

Aunt Zhao widened her eyes. "Didn't you read the booklet I gave you? There are plenty of ways—"

As she continued, even Aunt Zhao grew somewhat embarrassed and sighed. "I'm just worried for you. Your husband is even more handsome than Song Yan, and he's literate too. Right now, he's injured and relies on you. If you don't build a good relationship now, what if he decides to leave once he's healed? And even if you can't keep him, you should at least have a child to rely on. Otherwise, your uncle's family will surely come to stir up trouble again."

Fan Changyu knew Aunt Zhao meant well and vaguely acknowledged her advice.

After Aunt Zhao left, she let out a dejected sigh.

The silver hairpin couldn't be redeemed, and she'd been disgusted by the Song mother and son. At least she'd recovered the twenty taels her father had lent them, and having such a sum at home was a silver lining.

But being constantly subjected to that guy's "are you blind?" looks, coupled with the lies she'd spun, left her feeling rather deflated.

Just as Fan Changyu stood up to head to the kitchen, she froze.

The booklet—the one Aunt Zhao had given her!

During the wedding chaos, she'd been too busy. That day, Aunt Zhao had handed her the booklet, and after flipping through a couple of pages in a fluster, she'd hastily closed it and stuffed it under the pillow in the bridal chamber.

So many days had passed, and she'd completely forgotten about it! She had no idea if he'd seen it in the room.

The mere thought of it made Fan Changyu feel unsettled.

She quickly dug out a new set of bedding and knocked on the door of the south room.

A cool, indifferent voice came from inside: "Come in."

Pushing the door open, she said, "With the New Year approaching, I'm washing all the bedding in the house."

Everything in this room had been arranged for the wedding not long ago and didn't need washing, so the excuse was flimsy at best.

But Xie Zheng sat at a rickety old wooden desk, a brush in hand, and didn't even glance at her as he gave a faint nod.

Seeing him absorbed in writing something, Fan Changyu exhaled quietly, relieved like a thief. But when she lifted the pillow to search for the booklet, it was already gone.

Fan Changyu was dumbstruck. She stole a glance at the man by the window, and seeing no sign he'd noticed anything amiss, she continued stripping the bed to look.

But after lifting and shaking even the mattress at the very bottom of the bed and checking underneath it, she still couldn't find that booklet. Her heart sank like ashes.

A cool, detached voice suddenly came from behind: "Need help?"

Fan Changyu's entire spine stiffened. With a wooden expression, she said, "No need. Just shaking off some dust before making the bed."

She tossed the used bedsheets and quilts into the laundry basket and expressionlessly spread out the slightly worn sheets and quilt cover.

The quilt cover had two layers—the bottom was plain cotton fabric, while the top was embroidered decorative fabric. The cotton filling went in between, and the layers had to be stitched together.

Due to nervousness, Fan Changyu pricked her fingers several times with the needle while sewing the quilt cover. She kept a straight face and didn't make a sound.

It wasn't until she left the room that Xie Zheng finally set down his brush. His gaze swept toward the booklet he had used to prop up the table leg, his handsome brows unconsciously furrowing.

This room was only separated from the main house by a single wall, so he had naturally heard everything the woman said.

Was she looking for this booklet?

Chapter 16

Fan Changyu sighed as she stepped out with a basket of dirty laundry.

He had most likely seen the item. Since he had already taken it away, she would pretend nothing had happened.

Seeing that it was still early, she went out again to the market and bought two plump pigs and a chicken.

Before this chicken became a pot of nourishing soup, it had a more important mission—she intended to use it to catch that gyrfalcon.

Though her father was a butcher, he was also an excellent hunter. She had once followed him into the mountains to hunt wild boars and catch hares, so she naturally knew how to set traps.

Fan Changyu considered setting a trap in the courtyard but worried Changning might accidentally get hurt. After much deliberation, she climbed up to the attic and onto the roof, tying the old hen there and arranging her father's trapping tools before descending, satisfied.

One pig would be slaughtered tomorrow, while the other would be butchered today to make cured meat.

As the name suggested, cured meat was made in the twelfth lunar month. Meat could be preserved longer in winter, but once the weather warmed, it would spoil. Making it into cured meat allowed it to last until the next year.

The tutors at the academy accepted tuition fees in either silver or an equivalent amount of cured meat.

Many scholars had to buy cured meat to present to their tutors during the New Year, and again in spring as tuition fees.

In the past, Mother Song would use the money she earned from embroidery and laundry to buy cured meat from Fan Changyu's father to pay Song Yan's tuition.

Now, Fan Changyu suspected there might have been an element of deliberate pity-seeking in front of her parents.

Back then, Mother Song's hands would be covered in chilblains as soon as winter arrived. The patches on her clothes outnumbered the original fabric. She often did embroidery at night, reluctant to light more than a tiny wick in the lamp oil, barely a bean-sized flame. Over time, her eyesight deteriorated, and she could hardly see anything at night.

As neighbors to this widowed mother and her son, Mother Song had said Old Man Song had spent his whole life failing the imperial exams, while Song Yan was clever from a young age, a promising seedling. She wanted to fulfill her husband's dying wish. Moved by their plight, Fan Changyu's parents had gifted cured meat to cover Song Yan's tuition.

Now, whenever Fan Changyu thought of the Song mother and son, she could only pray that heaven would open its eyes and ensure Song Yan failed the exams!

Fueled by resentment, she went to the backyard to boil water for slaughtering the pigs.

When the piercing squeals of the pigs reached the southern room, Xie Zheng's brush left an ink stain on the paper.

He crumpled the sheet and tossed it into the charcoal brazier at his feet, then leaned back, pinching the bridge of his nose.

Just as the noise was becoming unbearable, the door creaked open. A small figure clung to the doorframe, peeking in with half her face visible, and urged him, "Brother-in-law, wanna go watch the pig slaughtering?"

Her dark, grape-like eyes sparkled. "Big sister is really good at killing pigs!"

Previously, Fan Changyu had slaughtered pigs before dawn. Xie Zheng, still recovering from a knee injury sustained during his escape when he tumbled down a cliff, rarely went out and thus had never seen her in action.

Today, the pigs' cries from the backyard had gone on unusually long—two pigs wailing in unison, loud enough to lift the roof.

After a moment of thought, Xie Zheng nodded and pushed himself up with his cane. He wasn't getting up to watch the pig being slaughtered, as Changning assumed. He simply felt that if the pigs kept screaming, he might as well end them with one clean stroke and restore some peace.

Passing through the main hall led to the kitchen, which had a small door connecting to the backyard. The door was currently open, and Xie Zheng caught sight of the woman with one foot planted on the pig's back, a rope as thick as a thumb in her hand as she tied the pig, already bound at its limbs, to a hefty-looking stone bench.

Xiao Changning proudly lifted her chin toward him and declared, "My sister is amazing, isn't she?"

Xie Zheng didn't respond.

Up close, the pig's squeals grew even more piercing, and its struggles appeared fierce and violent.

Xie Zheng had seen pigs slaughtered in the camp cookhouse before, but it usually took several men to subdue a fat pig. The woman before him did not look frail in the least, but she was still only a young woman, hardly someone who could match those burly men.

He frowned slightly and was about to step forward to help when he saw the woman slap the pig's head and shout, "Behave!"

The slap was so loud that the pig's squeals instantly quieted, and its struggles noticeably weakened.

A look of unmistakable surprise flickered in Xie Zheng's previously indifferent eyes.

Knocked out?

Just like that???

How much strength did that take?

His impression of this woman suddenly swung wildly between weeping over that phoenix-man and knocking a pig unconscious with a single slap, and he could not help but frown.

After securing the pig on the stone bench, Fan Changyu turned and noticed Xie Zheng and her younger sister, who was peeking out from behind the door.

She immediately scolded, "Ning Niang, how many times have I told you? Children shouldn't watch pig slaughtering."

Changning pouted and withdrew her head behind the door, leaving only the two little buns of her hair visible.

Fan Changyu was somewhat surprised to see Xie Zheng. She was dressed in the short, practical outfit she used for slaughtering pigs, and having just wrestled with the pig, loose strands of hair hung messily across her forehead. She looked disheveled, yet there was an air of competence and vigor about her.

Busy with her task, she didn't dwell on their earlier awkwardness. After a brief moment of surprise, she said to Xie Zheng, "If you're not in a hurry to go back to your room, could you keep an eye on the fire in the stove for me?"

The water boiling in the large pot would later be used to scald the pig's hair.

Xie Zheng glanced at the makeshift stove and, uncharacteristically obliging, walked over.

Fan Changyu found the wooden basin to catch the blood and picked up the bleeding knife. With a single, precise strike, the pig was dispatched. Blood gushed out, inevitably splattering some onto her. Her gaze as she watched the blood flow was cold and sharp, like a predator eyeing its torn prey.

It took a while for the killing intent around her to fade.

When she looked up, she found the man behind the stove watching her with an inscrutable expression.

His gaze was usually detached, but now there was something deeper in his eyes, something unfathomable, like an ancient well with no visible bottom.

Fan Changyu sheathed the knife and reined in her ferocity, asking in confusion, "Did I scare you?"

Xie Zheng added a piece of firewood to the stove. His refined features flickered in the firelight as he lazily quirked a corner of his lips, as if her question amused him. "Not at all."

Fan Changyu dragged the slaughtered pig over and gave him a look. "You should go inside. The smell of scalded pig hair is pretty strong."

Xie Zheng remained seated and said, "I've smelled worse."

The stench of rotting corpses in mass graves.

This man was acting a bit strange today.

Fan Changyu simply stopped paying him any mind, pouring scalding water over the pig to soften all the bristles before starting to scrape them off.

Xie Zheng sat on a stool behind the stove watching her work, the corners of his eyes slightly lifted.

Suddenly, he found her much more agreeable when she was butchering pigs.

He asked, "Did your father teach you martial arts?"

Fan Changyu paused briefly in her scraping before continuing, "Mm. My father traveled all over as an armed escort and studied under many masters. He learned all sorts of life-saving techniques, and I picked up a few moves from him."

Xie Zheng didn't press further, simply watching her scrape the bristles with a lazy expression. Yet, his features were so striking that even sitting among the firewood, he was a sight to behold.

Before nightfall, Fan Changyu finished dividing the pork. She set aside a small piece to make braised meat for dinner, while the rest was evenly coated with coarse salt, arranged skin-side up in a clean stone vat in the yard, and covered with a bamboo sieve.

Making cured meat required salting it for seven or eight days first, then smoking it over cypress branches.

These days, salt was scarce in most places, but Qingping County produced abundant crude salt, so the local price was not too high, a little over a dozen coins for a pound.

Salt merchants with permits bought salt here and sold it elsewhere at several times the price. It was said that in some places, merchants hiked the price to over a hundred coins per pound, leaving the common folk in misery.

With the fire under the large pot still burning from boiling water earlier, Fan Changyu used it to blanch the cleaned pork, pork bones, and offal.

The pork belly was for tonight's braised meat rice, the bones for broth, while the offal and pork head meat would be sold at the butcher's stall tomorrow morning.

After blanching, she scooped the meat out with two sieves, replaced the water, and tossed in various spices and seasonings. Once boiling, she added some of the old braising broth from before, then put the meat and bones in to simmer.

As the fire brought the braising liquid to a rolling boil again, the rich aroma of meat seeped through the gaps in the lid.

Fan Changyu had only eaten a flatbread at noon and had worked hard all afternoon. Even she couldn't resist the smell, her stomach betraying her with a growl.

Changning sniffed the air, her eyes pitifully eager. "Sis, I'm hungry..."

The only one seemingly unaffected by the tantalizing scent was Xie Zheng, who sat behind the stove tending the fire with an indifferent expression.

Fan Changyu pressed a hand to her stomach, embarrassed. She stood up and headed inside. "The meat's not ready yet. I'll grab a couple of sweet potatoes to roast first."

Unbeknownst to her, the man behind the stove remained expressionless after she left, though his throat bobbed slightly.

Xie Zheng shot an impatient glance at the steaming pot. Did this thing really need to cook for so long?

Xiao Changning giggled behind her hand. "Brother-in-law, you're hungry too, right?"

Xie Zheng ignored the annoying child, closing his eyes. "No."

Fan Changyu brought two sweet potatoes and buried them in the ashes. Xie Zheng remained seated on the stool behind the stove, and since his legs were still healing, she didn't make him move. Instead, she crouched beside him, using fire tongs to cover the potatoes with embers.

The stove's opening was narrow and square, blocking her view, so she leaned slightly toward him to check if the potatoes were properly buried.

The proximity made Xie Zheng frown and lean back, but the space was too cramped. The edge of Fan Changyu's hairpiece barely brushed his jaw. She didn't notice, but Xie Zheng's expression stiffened.

She had already changed out of her butchering clothes, and there was an indescribable, delicate fragrance on her garments and in her hair, likely

the scent her mother had personally blended, as she had mentioned before.

Where her hair had brushed against him, there was a slight coolness and a tingling itch that made one want to scratch it.

Xie Zheng frowned and was about to speak when Fan Changyu had already finished burying the sweet potatoes and moved back.

Seeing him shift aside, Fan Changyu felt quite embarrassed. "Did I bump into you just now?"

The spot on his jaw where her hair had grazed still tingled.

Xie Zheng averted his gaze and simply said no.

Snow began to fall again from the sky. Fan Changyu sat on a stool playing cat's cradle with her younger sister. The firelight flickered across their faces, and their matching smiles seemed warm enough to chase away the chill of the entire winter night.

Xie Zheng watched her for a while before turning his gaze to the snowflakes drifting through the air.

When a sweet aroma mingled with the scent of meat, Fan Changyu once again squeezed right next to Xie Zheng and used the fire tongs to dig out two sweet potatoes.

The skins of the sweet potatoes had turned a charred gray, soft and piping hot to the touch.

Fan Changyu gave one to Xie Zheng while she and her sister shared the other.

Fan Changyu was bold. She snapped the sweet potato in half with one swift motion, revealing the bright golden flesh inside as thin wisps of steam still rose from the tips. Just the smell alone was enough to tell how sweet it was.

She gave half to her sister, and the two of them ate while hissing from the heat. The taste was even sweeter, though they accidentally smeared a bit of the charred skin on the corners of their mouths.

Xie Zheng peeled his sweet potato and took a bite. It was indeed much sweeter than the roasted sweet potatoes he remembered.

The highlight of the evening, of course, was the meat that had been braising for over an hour in the pot. The pork belly, already infused with the rich flavors of the braising sauce, was diced and stir-fried with diced mushrooms until the aroma of the mushrooms burst forth. Then, a ladle of the braising broth was added before the mixture was scooped over a bowl of white rice, topped with a halved braised egg.

It was the most satisfying meal Xie Zheng had eaten since his misfortune began, and he went to sleep that night in a rather good mood.

Of course, his good mood might have lasted a little longer if the Gyrfalcon hadn't suddenly started screeching desperately from the rooftop.

Chapter 17

Xie Zheng pulled on his robe with a grim expression and had just stepped out on crutches when he saw Fan Changyu descending from the attic, holding an oil lamp in one hand and a Gyr Falcon with its feathers in disarray in the other.

Spotting Xie Zheng, she looked slightly surprised. "Did I wake you?"

The dejected Gyr Falcon, having endured several slaps, let out pitiful cries the moment it saw its master, though this time it didn't dare to shriek hysterically. Its weak chirps resembled those of a chick, and the once-glossy feathers on its head were now tousled.

After a brief silence, Xie Zheng asked, "This is...?"

Changyu swung the Gyr Falcon in her hand and flashed a bright smile. "I've seen this Gyr Falcon around several times. I just bought an old hen, so I set a trap to catch it—never thought it'd actually work!"

Ordinary falcons could only snatch chicks, but this Gyr Falcon was enormous, with a wingspan of nearly a meter. Its strength was astonishing, and it had struggled so fiercely on the rooftop that it tore a hole in it. If Changyu hadn't rushed up in time after hearing the commotion, it might have escaped the trap. Only after a few slaps from her did it finally settle down.

She added, "I'll take it to the market tomorrow morning and see how much silver I can get for it."

The Gyr Falcon continued to gaze at its master with pitiful, beady eyes.

Xie Zheng couldn't bear to look at the foolish bird. Keeping a straight face, he lied through his teeth, "No one in the market buys live falcons like this. Their meat is tough and sour if slaughtered, and ordinary households can't afford to raise them. Untamed by falconers, they're too wild and prone to attacking people."

"Oh." Changyu's face fell with disappointment.

She scratched her head. "But this Gyrfalcon injured its leg in the trap, and its wing was hurt when it flapped against the rafters. If released into the wild, it probably wouldn't survive the winter."

The Gyrfalcon let out a weak, pitiful cry at just the right moment.

Xie Zheng: "...I know a bit about falconry. I could try taming it. A well-trained Gyrfalcon could fetch over a hundred taels of silver."

"Eh?" Changyu was astonished, but upon hearing that the bird could sell for dozens or even a hundred taels once tamed, she brightened considerably. Even the prospect of repairing the roof tomorrow no longer seemed like a big deal.

"Then we'll keep it at home for now!"

She immediately found a chicken coop to confine the Gyrfalcon and fetched wound medicine and bandages.

Cowering in a corner of the coop, the Gyrfalcon stared in terror with its beady eyes as Changyu lifted one of its legs to apply medicine and wrap it in bandages. It didn't dare to move a muscle.

Xie Zheng watched as the Gyrfalcon's leg was swaddled like a dumpling, his eyelid twitching twice.

After finishing, Changyu crouched beside the coop, gazing at the Gyrfalcon with the tender affection one might reserve for a hundred taels of silver. "I'll slaughter a pig tomorrow morning and give you some fresh offal to eat."

The pork had to be saved for sale, but the offal could be used freely.

The offal from today's slaughtered pig had already been turned into braised food.

Before returning to her room, Changyu reconsidered. The main hall was too cold, she and her younger sister slept on a heated kang bed and therefore they didn't need a charcoal brazier. Worried that Yan Zheng, weakened by his injuries, might suffer from the cold, she had placed a brazier in his room. It would be perfect to keep the falcon there.

After all, that was a hundred taels of silver—it absolutely couldn't freeze to death!

So Changyu turned on her heel, carrying the chicken coop and the Gyrfalcon, and knocked on Xie Zheng's door.

Without caring about the expression on the person in the room, she placed the chicken cage in a corner of his room: "It's cold at night, don't let this gyrfalcon freeze. It'll stay in your room for now."

Xie Zheng cast a sinister glance at the gyrfalcon: "...Fine."

Once the door closed, the gyrfalcon's beady eyes met its owner's narrow, gloomy phoenix eyes. Dragging its injured leg and with wings missing many feathers, it trembled in fear.

The next morning, Fan Changyu indeed slaughtered a pig and brought half a sliced pig's lung to feed the gyrfalcon.

It seemed especially cold outside today, with snow nearly piling up to the doorstep. The moment the door opened, a gust of freezing air made one shiver. Looking out through the doorway, a row of icicles hung from the eaves.

Fan Changyu's hands were red from the cold. After placing the bowl of pig's lung into the cage, she rubbed her hands together and said to the person sitting on the bed, "It's the coldest day of winter today. Bundle up when you get up later. I made maoxuewang, it'll warm you up."

Xie Zheng nodded in acknowledgment, though he didn't have much thick clothing to wear. Soon after, Fan Changyu brought over a thick coat that had belonged to her father.

Once Xie Zheng put it on, his figure looked somewhat bulky, but his tall stature still made him appear handsome. Moreover, the winter coat was truly warm, keeping the cold wind at bay.

Along with the coat, she also brought a dark blue hair ribbon. Xie Zheng had seen this ribbon before, back when Fan Changyu had angrily tied it around her own head. He frowned.

When Fan Changyu emerged from the kitchen carrying a large soup pot, she saw that he had already gotten up and washed. "You're awake? Perfect timing, let's eat."

The soup in the pot was a bright red, and the air was filled with an overpowering aroma of spice and heat.

She noticed he hadn't used the hair ribbon she'd given him but didn't comment. She had given it to him because he was fastidious. Though bathing was inconvenient in winter, he still wiped himself down with hot water every few days. He often washed his hair ribbon, and when it took

too long to dry, he'd even dry it by the fire pit. She'd thought he could use the new one as a spare.

She wasn't petty sort at all, just because she'd said she wouldn't give it to him didn't mean she actually wouldn't!

The pot was filled to the brim, and the freshly cooked soup was scalding hot. After setting it on the table, Fan Changyu quickly pinched her ears with her burned fingers. "Ouch, that's hot!"

Xiao Changning hurried over. "Ning Niang will blow on it! Blowing makes it better."

Fan Changyu, amused, held out her fingers to her little sister, who puffed her cheeks and blew several times before stopping.

When Fan Changyu looked up, she saw Xie Zheng staring at her strangely. She wiped her face, finding no soot, and asked, "Is there something on my face?"

He averted his gaze. "No."

Suspicious, Fan Changyu glanced at him twice before setting out the bowls and chopsticks. "Try the blood curd! It's best eaten fresh, but we didn't have time today."

The soup's surface was topped with a layer of Sichuan peppercorns and dried chili peppers drizzled with hot oil. Beneath lay chunks of pig's blood, along with braised pork intestines, tripe, and lungs from last night. The only thing missing was a bed of plump, crisp bean sprouts at the bottom, but none had sprouted at home.

Fan Changyu scooped a piece of blood curd into her sister's bowl. Xiao Changning gasped from the spiciness but still eyed the pot eagerly after finishing it. "More!"

Fan Changyu gave her two more pieces.

Xie Zheng was seeing this hodgepodge stew for the first time. Judging by its appearance, it didn't seem drinkable, and the Fan family didn't have the habit of using serving chopsticks.

For regular stir-fried dishes, one could pick from different sides, but with this pot of stew, it was nearly impossible to avoid mixing.

During his hesitation, Fan Changyu and her sister had already finished half their bowls of rice. Noticing he was only eating rice without touching

the dishes, Changyu asked puzzledly, "Can't you eat spicy food?"

"...That's not it."

Eventually, he set aside his dining fastidiousness and frowned as he picked up a piece of dark red cooked blood pudding.

The first sensation was numbing and spicy. There 's barely any need to chew because a light press of the lips was all it took for the blood curd to melt in the mouth. It was surprisingly delicious.

He went on to try the braised offal in the pot. First braised then stewed, the aromatic braising sauce perfectly combined with the numbing spiciness, making it impossible to resist reaching for more.

By the end of the meal, Xie Zheng had nearly forgotten his usual dining fastidiousness.

Just as Changyu had said, he soon broke into a sweat from the spiciness, completely unfazed by the freezing weather outside.

He asked, "Is this a local specialty?"

Changyu replied, "You could say that. It's a famous dish from the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion in town. That female proprietor knows so many recipes!"

Xie Zheng briefly considered introducing this dish to the military but quickly dismissed the idea. Military meals focused on filling stomachs, not such refinement. Moreover, ingredients like chili peppers and Sichuan peppercorns would be a significant expense.

After clearing the dishes, Changyu brought the gyrfalcon from his room to the fire pit. Before leaving, she reminded him, "There's half a pig's lung in the kitchen. Chop it up later to feed that gyrfalcon."

She scratched her head, somewhat embarrassed, and added, "If you have time, maybe try taming it?"

Xie Zheng's lazy glance felt like a thousand cuts: "...Fine."

The gyrfalcon in its cage shrank its neck fearfully, resembling an oversized quail.

Satisfied, Changyu pushed the cart to the shop. The heavy snow meant few pedestrians on the streets at this hour.

The butcher's street was equally deserted.

After opening the shop and clearing the snow under the eaves, Changyu discovered the brick stove she'd built outside had been smashed.

She was so angry she almost laughed. Her shop had only been selling braised meat for a few days—already enough to provoke envy and vandalism?

After the incidents with Fan Da and the gambling den, she'd built a fierce and shrewish reputation. Sometimes, a fearsome name had its advantages.

Changyu immediately threw down the broom, planted her hands on her hips, and shouted, "Which spineless coward smashed my things? Too scared to face me, so you pull this crap behind my back? Were your ancestors turtles?"

Trained in martial arts since childhood, her voice carried powerfully down the street.

The neighboring butchers stayed silent, except for Butcher Guo, who protested when her gaze landed on him: "Why're you looking at me? I didn't do it!"

Changyu hadn't actually suspected him because Butcher Guo's face showed nothing but gloating, without a trace of guilt.

The butcher's wife nearby suddenly remembered something: "Oh no, Changyu. Your shop was closed for a month before. Did you forget to pay the protection money?"

This was the first Changyu had heard of protection money. Puzzled, she asked, "What's that?"

The butcher's wife sighed, "When you open a shop for business, besides paying monthly taxes to the authorities, you also have to give some money to the gang leader who controls this street. Your shop must have been doing exceptionally well these days, and word must have reached them. I'd say they'll probably come by again soon."

Fan Changyu understood the situation. Those people had smashed the stove outside her door last night as a warning, and today they would surely come to collect protection money.

She thanked the butcher's wife, first arranging the fresh meat and braised meat she had brought on the chopping block, then placing a long

stick behind the door. As she sold the meat, she waited for the gangsters to show up.

At a quarter past seven in the morning, a group of street thugs swaggered their way toward the meat market, their arrogance on full display. People along the way quickly moved aside at the sight of them.

Hearing the commotion, Fan Changyu peeked outside from her shop.

Well, well—old acquaintances!

Chapter 18

The sun climbed high, and the icicles under the eaves dripped with melting water.

Seven or eight burly men with fierce faces shoved aside peddlers blocking their way, striding menacingly toward Fan Changyu's shop. The leader had a broad face, a short beard, and a vicious expression, though he walked with a noticeable limp.

It was none other than Boss Jin, the head enforcer of the gambling den who had repeatedly caused trouble at Fan Changyu's home.

"I'd like to see who's got the guts to run a business on this street without paying their respects—"

The moment Boss Jin spotted Fan Changyu standing with her arms crossed at the shop entrance, his voice died in his throat. The thugs behind her, who had suffered her beatings before, also paled instantly.

His uninjured leg began to ache faintly.

This husband-and-wife duo struck harder than anyone. Would his other leg end up broken here today?

The thugs instinctively took half a step back, dragging their injured legs.

Butchers from nearby shops, seeing the gang's overwhelming numbers and Fan Changyu being just a young woman, couldn't help but worry for her. Only Butcher Guo across the street wore a gloating smirk.

Boss Jin forced an ingratiating smile. "Fan... Miss Fan? Is this your shop?"

The onlookers were dumbfounded.

This... wasn't the expected outcome.

Fan Changyu casually picked up a long staff leaning against the door. The gangsters immediately recoiled in terror, their faces twisting with fear.

Boss Jin frantically waved his hands. "A misunderstanding, Miss Fan! A genuine misunderstanding! Had we known this was your shop, we'd never

dare show disrespect!"

Butcher Guo's eyes nearly popped out of his head, utterly baffled that these street thugs were so terrified of Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu fixed Boss Jin with a cold stare and pointed her staff at the smashed brick stove in front of her shop. "Your doing?"

Despite the freezing cold, sweat beaded on Boss Jin's forehead. He wiped it away roughly with his sleeve and stammered, "We were just hired hands, paid to do a job! We'll fix it! We'll fix it right away!"

He urgently signaled his underlings, who trembled at the sight of the staff in Fan Changyu's hand. Still haunted by memories of being beaten until they vomited, they scrambled to rebuild the stove.

Fan Changyu was momentarily taken aback. She had assumed they were here to extort protection money, but there seemed to be more to it.

She demanded directly, "Who sent you to cause trouble at my shop?"

"Miss Fan, that's..." Boss Jin hesitated. They'd been paid to keep their mouths shut.

Fan Changyu swung the staff, pressing it against Boss Jin's throat before he could react. His sweat froze into droplets as all professional ethics fled his mind. Stuttering, he confessed, "It... it was the owner of Wang's Braised Food on Main Street."

Fan Changyu frowned. She had never met Wang's owner, and their shops were streets apart, with no competition between them. Her braised food business had only been open for a few days—surely it couldn't have provoked such hostility.

"Lies!" she snapped. "I've no quarrel with Wang's owner. Why would he send you to wreck my shop?"

Boss Jin insisted, "It's the truth! Yesterday, Wang's employee came to us with the money himself."

Fan Changyu's frown deepened as she watched the lackeys use clay to rebuild the bricks on the stove. With more onlookers gathering, she decided not to delay her business any further and withdrew the wooden staff.

Before Boss Jin could catch his breath, Fan Changyu barked another order: "You, light the fire and dry the stove first. The rest of you, fetch

several buckets of water from the well at the street corner."

Since she was braising meat right at the shop entrance, water was naturally needed inside. However, she hadn't had time to fetch water this morning due to dealing with the smashed stove.

Having already lost half a day, doing everything herself now would be too late. Might as well put these ready-made laborers, who had delayed her time, to work.

The lackeys never expected they'd be ordered around one day. Frozen in place, they snapped to attention under Fan Changyu's sharp glance and hurried off with buckets to fetch water.

Once the hooligans left, the clueless onlookers crowding outside the Fan Family shop assumed the matter was resolved and dispersed to go about their business.

Only the neighbors, witnessing Fan Changyu bossing around these troublemakers, were so shocked their jaws nearly dropped, looking at her as if she were some freak.

Unfazed, Fan Changyu noticed Boss Jin loitering at her shop entrance, scaring away potential customers. She shooed him aside: "Go stand over there. Don't block my business. After I finish selling today's meat, you're coming with me to Wang's place. I want answers. If you feed me any lies..."

Her gaze swept over his other leg: "I'll break this one too!"

Boss Jin recalled the man's sinister expression and the ruthless strike that had crippled his leg. A sharp pain shot through his still-healing injury, turning his face pale as he hastily shook his head: "I, Jin Lao San, wouldn't dare deceive Miss Fan!"

Seeing his terror, Fan Changyu Seeing his terror, Fan Changyu kept her fierce expression but wondered inwardly—just how brutally had that man beaten them? A mere threat to break another leg had scared him this much.

The lackeys soon returned with water. Suspicious they might have tampered with it, Fan Changyu handed them a ladle to drink from their own buckets first before using the water to wash the pork for braising.

As for the cooking water, there was still yesterday's supply in her shop's water vat.

Once the large pot was set up, the aroma of braised meat began wafting down the street again.

Those who had queued unsuccessfully yesterday arrived early today and finally got their purchase.

However, most customers hesitated upon seeing Boss Jin and his crew squatting miserably by Fan Changyu's shop—their rough, scowling faces still looked intimidating despite their downtrodden state.

Noticing this, Fan Changyu, just as the first batch of braised meat was nearly sold out, bought six pig heads and three buckets of offal from a neighboring butcher. She distributed the pig heads for them to clean and had the rest wash the offal under her watch.

With them busy at work, customers no longer noticed their menacing faces.

Fan Changyu worked as both a butcher slicing braised meat and a supervisor. Anyone who tried to slack off or left something unclean was immediately jabbed with her staff. "There's still bristles on this pig's head! Rub the intestines with plant ash first, wash them clean, then scrub them thoroughly with straw from end to end!"

She was fiercer than the fiercest bully.

The gang of street thugs trembled in fear, silently regretting their terrible luck in crossing paths with this formidable woman again.

As if reading their minds, Fan Changyu scowled and said, "Wrongdoing deserves punishment, or what would become of the law?"

The group shrank like quails, nodding frantically in agreement.

Seeing their repentant attitude, Fan Changyu softened slightly during a break and asked, "Weren't you working at the gambling den? Why are you everywhere?"

At this, the thugs looked embarrassed.

Jin Lao San muttered, "We're not with the gambling den anymore."

Changyu found this strange and asked why.

A young hoodlum holding a pig's head mumbled, "We followed Third Brother to work as enforcers there just to get by. When we couldn't collect debts on time, the den wouldn't accept just Fan Da's hand as payment.

Besides, in all our years collecting, we never actually maimed anyone. Then after getting our legs broken... we got kicked out..."

Changyu frowned. "But you're still collecting protection money all over the streets?"

Jin Lao San sighed. "That money doesn't go to us. We're just collecting for others."

Seeing her confusion, he explained plainly: "We can openly extort merchants because officials turn a blind eye. With powerful backers covering for us, we're protected if trouble arises. Most of the money goes to those officials as tribute."

Changyu's face darkened as she fell silent.

Jin Lao San quickly added, "But this street never had protection fees before last month. Had we known your shop was here, we'd never have dared..."

A shadow crossed Changyu's mind. She suddenly asked, "When exactly did collections start here?"

"Last month," Jin Lao San recalled.

Her frown deepened. Her parents had died at bandits' hands last month too. Could there be a connection?

But she dismissed the thought immediately. Her father, a seasoned martial artist, had lived safely in Lin'an Town for over a decade. It made no sense for him to be targeted now.

Shaking off these thoughts, Changyu glared at Jin Lao San's group. "Strong men like you could do honest work instead of this thuggery!"

"We'll change! We swear we'll go straight!" they quivered like frightened quails.

Only then did Changyu relent. With others handling the hard labor today, she enjoyed rare leisure.

The reputation of Fan's Braised Meat had spread. Business boomed even more than yesterday. By noon, all the pre-braised meat and fresh batches had sold out, along with every last braised egg. She even sent a thug to buy another basket of eggs, most of which were sold too.

Three coins could buy two braised eggs, and such a price was truly tempting.

Fan Changyu roughly calculated today's earnings and was surprised to find it exceeded four taels of silver!

The butchers from nearby meat shops naturally envied her thriving business, but seeing how Jin Lao San and his crew bowed and scraped before her, they didn't dare utter a single jealous word.

In high spirits from her earnings, Fan Changyu even found Jin Lao San and his men much more tolerable. Since they had worked for her all morning and showed sincere remorse, she even gave each of them a braised egg.

The young ruffians, who had been ordered around all morning, were as wilted as cabbages in the field. Suddenly handed a steaming braised egg, they were clearly stunned.

Fan Changyu continued glaring at them with a fierce expression: "Eat up, then follow me to Wang's shop for a confrontation!"

Having smelled the aroma of braised meat all morning, the rascals' stomachs had long been growling with hunger. Now, they could hardly wait to devour even the eggshells.

After finishing, the group was clearly still craving more and cautiously asked, "Miss Fan... Miss Fan Da, could we come work at your shop in the future?"

Fan Changyu scowled inwardly—absolutely not! These burly men would eat her out of house and home if they all worked for her!

She mercilessly refused: "No."

The ruffians immediately fell silent, hanging their heads dejectedly as they trailed behind her toward Wang's shop. However, their naturally fierce expressions made it impossible to detect any hint of gloom.

Pedestrians along the street quickly made way for them. To any onlooker, the scene resembled a female tyrant leading her gang of thugs to pick a fight.

In a riverside tavern, a man in brocade robes personally poured tea for the person seated across from him. Amid the rising steam, the intricate embroidery on his wide sleeves blurred slightly:

“The situation in Huizhou remains unstable. With the Marquis lying low here, your trusted aides cannot easily come. But Zhao is a businessman, the Wei family’s hounds won’t sniff me out. As long as the Marquis trusts me, Zhao is willing to serve you with utter devotion.”

The window was half-open. The man opposite him had a profile as finely carved as jade, his features elegant. His slender fingers, marked by dark scabs, tapped lightly on the table in a gesture that seemed casual yet exuding an oppressive, unspoken authority.

His narrow eyes narrowed slightly as he gazed out the window, seemingly admiring the snowy scenery along the street.

The brocade-robed man, noticing his prolonged silence, followed his gaze outside and realized he wasn’t looking at the snowscape at all, but at a young girl leading a dozen ruffians down the street.

Glancing back at Xie Zheng, the brocade-robed man’s eyes flickered with amusement as he smiled. “That must be the new wife the Marquis has married, yes?”

Chapter 19

The north wind rushed in through the window, scattering the steam rising from the teacup and bringing the handsome, refined face of the man opposite into sharper focus. Those cold, phoenix eyes were so sharp they seemed unbearable to meet directly.

"You went to such lengths to see this Marquis, Young Master Zhao, just to say these things?"

The brocade-robed man knew Xie Zheng was likely referring to his earlier declaration of loyalty and devotion. Unsure whether mentioning Xie Zheng's wife had crossed a line, he hurriedly replied, "Of course, there's more."

He then presented an embroidered box. Seeing Xie Zheng made no move to open it himself, he lifted the lid to reveal its contents, wearing the practiced smile of a merchant. "I wonder if this is enough to show my sincerity?"

Xie Zheng barely glanced at it. "Gold and silver hold no value to me."

The man fell silent for a moment before suddenly rising and bowing deeply to Xie Zheng. "Zhao Xun is but a lowly merchant, unworthy of the Marquis's regard. Yet last year during the Lantern Festival, my younger sister was abducted by Wei Xuan on her first visit to the capital and met a tragic end in his tent..."

His eyes reddened, tears streaming down his face. "If I do not avenge this, I will have no face to meet my parents in the afterlife."

Only then did Xie Zheng properly look at Zhao Xun. "You managed to find me and know of my falling out with the Wei father and son. That shows some capability."

Zhao Xun hastily demurred. "The Zhao Family's business is neither large nor small, spanning several major prefectures. We have some dealings with officials, so we hear more rumors than most. Since Wei Xuan took over Huizhou, many of the Marquis's key generals have been demoted and exiled to border regions. Meanwhile, the scholars under Wei Yan in the

capital are churning out slanderous essays against you—that's how I noticed something was amiss."

"I suspected the Marquis was in trouble and had my people search discreetly for you, but to no avail. Then, just days ago, Jizhou's main city arrested a large number of refugees, with soldiers from Huizhou even bringing portraits to search among them. Through some means, I obtained one of these portraits. The figure depicted was heroic and spirited, leading me to believe they were searching for none other than the Marquis."

At this point, Zhao Xun's face brightened with joy. "Heaven must pity me! Recently, our family bookstore acquired a batch of eight-legged essays. The manager praised one as a 'golden jade chapter.' Upon reading it, I found every word a gem and assumed it was the work of some impoverished scholar, hoping to make his acquaintance. Little did I expect to find the Marquis here!"

Xie Zheng's slender fingers continued tapping rhythmically on the redwood table, the steady "thud, thud" unsettling to the core.

Zhao Xun's earnest explanation had clarified how he'd found Xie Zheng. When writing the essay, Xie Zheng had deliberately altered his handwriting. That Zhao Xun had traced him here seemed genuinely coincidental.

Xie Zheng's prolonged silence seemed to unsettle Zhao Xun, but the man held his composure, offering no further words.

He appeared capable.

Xie Zheng finally lifted his gaze slightly and spoke. "Convert the banknotes in your embroidered box into two hundred thousand dan of grain before spring arrives."

Zhao Xun was first astonished, then overjoyed by these words. Xie Zheng had dismissed gold and silver as worthless, and now, by instructing him to exchange banknotes for grain, he was offering a clear path forward.

In the court, grain requisitions usually took place in autumn, and that was also when rice merchants purchased grain, as it was the harvest season when the common people had plenty of grain, and prices were low.

Now, at the end of the twelfth lunar month, the common folk certainly had surplus grain. Buying it now at a slightly higher price than during the harvest season wasn't a big issue.

However, the northwest was never a region abundant in grain. If they purchased a full 200,000 dan before spring, and with the next autumn harvest still far away, any military conflict in the area would make it impossible for the stationed troops to requisition grain locally.

Considering this, Zhao Xun felt a chill run down his spine and quickly cupped his hands in salute. "Zhao Xun will not fail the Marquis's trust!"

Noticing Xie Zheng's plain attire, he thought to curry favor. "How about I arrange another residence for the Marquis and your lady, along with some servants for your convenience?"

Xie Zheng gave him a cool glance, the scrutiny and pressure hidden beneath his calm demeanor making Zhao Xun, already half-bowed, lower himself even further.

"Don't presume to be clever," Xie Zheng said.

Zhao Xun dared not mention the residence or servants again and spoke even more cautiously. "Then... shall I have someone escort the Marquis back?"

When they arrived, he had personally gone to the western alley to fetch Xie Zheng.

Recalling Fan Changyu leading a group of troublemakers through the streets earlier, Xie Zheng's brows furrowed slightly as he declined. "No need."

His sharp, phoenix-like eyes swept over the richly dressed merchant before him. "Focus on the task I've assigned you. Act as if you know nothing of my presence here. If word gets out..."

Zhao Xun hurriedly assured him, "Zhao came to Lin'an Town today only to meet a talented scholar from a humble background. Unfortunately, the scholar was elusive, and Zhao never saw him. As for buying grain, it's merely because Zhao noticed the rice merchants' high profits and wanted a share."

The corners of Xie Zheng's eyes lifted slightly.

This was indeed a clever man—he understood with just a hint.

"Dismissed," Xie Zheng said.

Only then did Zhao Xun bow and retreat.

Once the door closed again, Xie Zheng slowly shut his eyes amid the steam rising from the boiling water on the red clay stove. His refined features blurred in the mist, leaving only his brows and eyes, which shed their usual weariness and instead bore a heavy, bloodthirsty aura.

This Zhao Xun had appeared far too coincidentally.

But for now, it was clear he wasn't affiliated with the Wei family. Otherwise... government officials would have come instead of this man weaving deceitful words of loyalty.

The 200,000 dan of grain was his litmus test. If this man could truly be of use, securing that grain would make his next steps much easier.

If the man had ulterior motives, then beyond the 200,000 dan of grain, a greater trap awaited him and his master.

Voices sounded outside the private room: "Come on, let's go see the commotion! I heard Wang's Braised Meat across the street was jealous of Fan's Meat Shop's business and smashed their stuff. Now Fan's people are causing a scene at Wang's!"

Someone sighed. "Wang's is a century-old establishment. How could they stoop to such petty behavior?"

"To steal business, what wouldn't they do?"

Xie Zheng cut off his thoughts, opened his eyes, and stood up, his legs now as nimble as any normal person's. Only when leaving the private room did he pick up his cane again.

A dense crowd had already gathered outside Wang's Braised Meat Shop.

The shop's clerk looked at Fan Changyu, then at the fierce-looking Jin Lao San and his gang standing behind her with their arms crossed. His legs trembled, and his voice shook. "Wh-what brings you here?"

Fan Changyu frowned as she saw the shop assistant's face turn pale with fear. She hadn't come here to beat anyone up right away, she was here to reason and demand an explanation. Why was this shop assistant so terrified?

Could it be a guilty conscience?

She said, "Call your manager out. I'm here today to demand an explanation."

The assistant stammered, "The... the manager isn't in the shop."

Fan Changyu's brows knitted sharply. "He dares to send people to smash up my shop, but now he's hiding like a coward?"

Behind her, Jin Lao San and the others let out a loud, deliberate "hmp" through their noses, making the assistant's face turn ashen.

Fan Changyu glanced back at Jin Lao San, her eyelid twitching slightly. She had brought these men here for a confrontation, but it almost seemed like she was leading them to wreck the place instead.

The assistant trembled as he spoke, "We've already sent someone to inform the manager. Whatever matter you have, please... please wait until the manager arrives."

He even wobbled on unsteady legs to fetch a Grand Tutor chair for Fan Changyu to sit on and brought out a brazier for her to warm herself.

Fan Changyu swept her gaze over the expressions of the shop assistants and the onlookers, feeling that something was off. Why did it seem like she was the one acting like a female tyrant here to pick a fight?

Still, since they had brought out a chair and a brazier, and the weather was so cold, there was no reason not to sit and warm herself while waiting.

Before long, the manager of Wang's Shop arrived, dragging his portly body and sweating profusely. A businessman who always believed in harmony for prosperity, he immediately offered Fan Changyu an apologetic smile. "Miss Fan, I've already heard from my assistant about what happened at your shop. The Wang's Shop signboard has been passed down from my ancestors, and I, Wang, would never resort to such underhanded methods to bully a lone woman..."

As he spoke, he glanced at Jin Lao San and the others behind Fan Changyu. Though his tone was polite, there was a hint of disdain in his manner. "Miss Fan, are you certain it was Wang's Shop based solely on their word? Could there... be some misunderstanding?"

Fan Changyu remained unmoved in the Grand Tutor chair, merely slanting a look at Jin Lao San. "You speak."

Jin Lao San immediately said, "Your Wang's Shop has an assistant named Chun Sheng. Yesterday, he came to the tavern in the east of town with five taels of silver to hire our brothers to cause trouble at Fan's Shop. The people at the tavern can testify."

The manager's expression changed at the mention of the assistant's name, and his attitude softened slightly. He said to Fan Changyu, "That's my eldest son's usual attendant. Please wait a moment, Miss Fan. I'll summon my son to clarify."

The young master of Wang's Shop was a notorious playboy in Lin'an Town, with a house full of concubines and a habit of frequenting brothels. This time, the shop assistants had to drag him out of a brothel to bring him back.

He was still drunk when he arrived, his clothes disheveled. His father had someone force a bowl of sobering soup down his throat before he became slightly lucid.

The manager of Wang's Shop questioned him sternly in front of Fan Changyu, "You disgrace! Did you send people to smash up Fan's Shop?"

The young master's puffy eyes swept over Fan Changyu, sizing her up several times before he sneered. "Oh, so you really are quite the looker. Climbing into that old bastard Chef Li's bed to steal our business with Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, and now you have the gall to come here? You've got thicker skin than a whore."

It was common knowledge that Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion often bought famous dishes from other places to serve in their own restaurant.

That female proprietor always had her own way of doing business. Others said her methods were not worth the cost, but by combining the strengths of all, the business at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion far surpassed those of other stagnant restaurants.

After all, those who could afford to dine at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion were wealthy gentry with ample means. The town had only a few renowned eateries, and usually, one had to send servants on multiple trips to enjoy their specialties. At Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, not only could one savor their private signature dishes, but local delicacies could also be served with just a call to the waiter.

Thus, whether it was pastry vendors or those selling braised meat and cooked food, all took pride in having connections with Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion.

Upon hearing the young master of Wang's establishment speak, the onlookers' expressions varied—some shocked, some disbelieving, and others simply there for the spectacle.

Their eyes kept darting toward Fan Changyu. She was indeed beautiful, but her temperament was so fierce that people might believe she'd rob someone as a female bandit before they'd believe she'd engage in illicit affairs for business...

A collective shiver ran through the crowd. Who would dare have such audacious thoughts about her? Just seeing her slaughter pigs and chop meat would be enough to deter any improper ideas, wouldn't it?

The manager of Wang's establishment also widened his eyes and shouted, "You unfilial brat, what nonsense are you spouting?"

The young master, accustomed to bullying men and harassing women in town, didn't take Fan Changyu seriously at all. "Father, our business with Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion is already ruined. Why shouldn't I speak my mind? Are you afraid of offending that old fool Chef Li?"

His gaze leered at Fan Changyu. "You'd stoop to sleeping with such an old—"

A loud bang cut him off.

Jin Lao San and the others turned to see the heavy chopping block in front of Wang's shop overturned by Fan Changyu's kick. The force was so great it left a gaping hole in the block, sending braised meat scattering everywhere and pinning the drunken young master beneath it.

He and his gang of thugs stared at the shattered iron-pear wood, gulping and shrinking back. They realized now that when she'd dealt with them before, she'd been holding back.

If she'd used this much force then, they'd have broken several bones and still be bedridden.

The young master howled in pain, yelling at his two lackeys, "Are you two dead? Get me up now!"

The lackeys glanced at the black cleaver Fan Changyu had drawn, and the eager crowd behind her led by Jin Lao San, all ready for a fight. They didn't dare go forward, and their legs had gone so weak they wobbled like noodles as they stumbled back two steps.

The manager of Wang's shop broke out in a cold sweat at the sight. Seeing Fan Changyu with the cleaver, he trembled in fear. "Miss Fan, my son spoke out of turn. I'll discipline this unfilial wretch properly. Please don't be angry..."

Fan Changyu ignored him, stomping heavily on the chopping block. The block, which normally required two men to lift, now bore another gaping hole under her foot. The young master foamed at the mouth, his eyes rolling back.

The crowd gasped, and some timid women even covered their eyes with their sleeves, fearing Fan Changyu might bring the cleaver down on the young master's head next.

The manager pointed a shaking finger at her. "Y-you... are you trying to kill someone?!"

Fan Changyu glanced at him with a cold sneer, "How could I kill anyone? Murder lands you in prison. At most, I'd just cut out your precious son's tongue and make him chew and swallow it himself, so he won't wag it recklessly again."

The Wangji shopkeeper was nearly frightened out of his wits by her words, barely managing to stay upright with the support of his servants, his face pale as he trembled and pointed at Fan Changyu, stammering "You—" without forming a complete sentence.

The young master of Wangji, pinned under Fan Changyu's foot, finally realized his peril. His face drained of color, he wept and looked to his father, "Dad, save me..."

The Wangji shopkeeper quavered, "Call the authorities, quick—"

When the Wangji servants tried to summon the authorities, they were blocked by Jin Lao San and his group. "You think you can bully others but not face the consequences?"

Fan Changyu slapped the disgusting, pudgy face of the Wangji young master with her cleaver. "Tell me, when did I ever steal business from Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion?"

The cleaver in her hand was heavy and cold, its blade carrying the lingering metallic scent of blood from years of chopping meat. The side of the young master's face that had been struck by the blade went numb, and his entire body shook like a sieve. "W-Wangji's braised meat deal with Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion was canceled... I heard... heard it was because Chef Li recommended your family's braised meat..."

Fan Changyu scoffed. "And just for that, you slandered me?"

The women in the crowd, hearing the young master's confession, were shocked that his earlier vile accusations stemmed from something so trivial.

A woman's reputation was of utmost importance, and this was a deliberate attempt to drive someone to ruin!

They spat at him in disgust. "What a despicable creature! Seeing Fanji's braised meat selling well, he had to tarnish the girl's reputation?"

"No wonder I haven't seen Chef Li buying meat from Fanji lately. Turned out that he was avoiding suspicion because of this black-hearted schemer!"

"Wangji, with all its wealth and power, bullying a lone girl—utterly shameless!"

"Spending all his time in brothels, no wonder his mind is filled with filth!"

"Honestly, Wangji is just a big shop bullying customers. Not only has their food gotten worse, but I once even bought spoiled meat! No wonder Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion stopped buying from them!"

The Wangji shopkeeper, hearing these remarks, flushed with humiliation and stomped his feet in rage. "Ungrateful wretch! Ungrateful wretch!"

The young master of Wangji, snot bubbling as he cried, begged for mercy. "Please, spare me! I'll give you money—lots of it! I know your family needs it..."

But Fan Changyu remained silent, her eyes fierce as she raised the cleaver high and hurled it downward with force.

The onlookers gasped in shock. The Wangji shopkeeper nearly fainted from fright, while the young master screamed in terror.

Thunk!

The blade didn't strike the young master. Instead, it sliced cleanly through his hair and crown, grazing his scalp before embedding itself into the stone pavement, the steel quivering from the impact.

It took a long moment for the young master to regain his senses, his face as white as a corpse's. A foul stench rose from beneath him as a puddle of yellow liquid spread under the chopping block.

The Wangji shopkeeper, still supported by his servants, panted heavily.

Feeling the cold steel against his scalp, the young master of Wang's shop was scared out of his wits. Abandoning all pretense of dignity, he burst into tears, his face covered in snot and tears: "Don't kill me, don't kill me!"

The manager of Wang's shop had only this worthless son and nearly wept as he pleaded: "Miss Fan, my foolish son spoke out of turn and damaged your reputation. I will discipline him properly and visit your residence another day with humble gifts to apologize. The ancients said cutting hair could substitute for beheading. Since you've already shaved his head, please be magnanimous and spare him!"

Fan Changyu sheathed her blade and coldly glared at the young master of Wang's shop. "Don't let me see you again!"

She walked away with her sword, ignoring the father and son.

The young master of Wang's shop had been bullying men and harassing women for quite some time. Fan Changyu's lesson today was immensely satisfying.

The onlookers even cheered and applauded, shouting: "Well taught!"

"Thank goodness she's the daughter of Fan the Tiger. If it were anyone else suffering such bullying, they'd have nowhere to turn!"

"Exactly! There was a village girl from Liujia Village, quite pretty, who got pregnant by this young master of Wang's shop. The Wang family refused to take responsibility, and the poor girl ended up drowning herself in the river!"

"That's just the incident that came to light. Who knows how many other wicked deeds they've committed in secret! Their braised meat can't compare to Fan's anyway. Fan's uses freshly slaughtered meat daily—who knows what kind of meat they use!"

The manager of Wang's shop listened to the murmurs and pointing fingers of the crowd, his aged face nearly dragging on the ground.

The wooden plank pinning the young master was finally lifted by two servants with great effort. The grown man looked at his father, crying pitifully: "Dad..."

Instead of comfort, he received two furious kicks from the enraged manager. "You worthless wretch! Fooling around with women was bad enough, but you had to go and do this! You've shamed the Wang family name today!"

Fan Changyu paid no further attention to the commotion behind her at Wang's shop. Having vented her anger, she was about to head home when someone suddenly called out: "Miss Fan, wait!"

Turning in confusion, she saw a mustached man approaching. "Miss Fan, your skills are impressive. I'm a manager from Worthy Gathering Bank. Would you be interested in working for us?"

"A bank?" Fan Changyu frowned. "What could I do there?"

The manager smiled. "Debt collection."

Fan Changyu: "..."

Jin Lao San and the others, however, were eager: "Miss Fan, if you take up debt collecting, we'll follow you!"

Fan Changyu glared. "Weren't you all supposed to find honest work?"

Jin Lao San and the others immediately shrank back, not daring to speak further.

Fan Changyu declined the offer, but the manager wasn't deterred. Before leaving, he handed her a paper listing the benefits of working as an enforcer for Worthy Gathering Bank. "No need to decide now, Miss Fan. Take your time to consider."

Holding the paper, Fan Changyu felt conflicted. Just what kind of person had she become in the eyes of the townsfolk?

With a sigh, she turned to leave, only to spot a figure standing at the street corner ahead. Snowflakes swirled around him, his wide robes billowing in the wind. Against the backdrop of the bustling market, his cool, detached gaze rested on her with a peculiar expression.

Fan Changyu glanced at the paper in her hand with the words "debt collection" written on it and instinctively said, "I didn't go rob anyone."

When Jin Lao San and the others saw Xie Zheng, their skins instantly tightened in fear, and they chorused together, "Good day, son-in-law!"

Xie Zheng: "..."

Fan Changyu: "..."

It seemed even harder to explain now.

Chapter 20

Fan Changyu turned and snapped at Jin Lao San and his group, "What are you hollering about?"

Jin Lao San chuckled awkwardly, "Isn't this the son-in-law you took in through marriage?"

Fan Changyu choked for a moment and instinctively glanced at Xie Zheng. The man's expression remained indifferent, showing no reaction to Jin Lao San's words. Relieved, she continued, "Yes, he's the husband I took in, but why are you calling him 'son-in-law'?"

Jin Lao San and his crew lowered their heads obediently and fell silent, resembling a group of timid daughters-in-law rejected by a harsh mother-in-law.

Fan Changyu felt a vein throb at her temple and waved them off. "Today, I only brought you to confront Wang's place to seek justice. Now that justice has been served, go home and never bully men and women again."

Jin Lao San and his men mumbled their assent and left. Fan Changyu stole another glance at Xie Zheng, who stood not far away, feeling inexplicably guilty. But remembering she hadn't done anything heinous, she folded the paper in her hand, straightened her back, and walked over to ask, "What are you doing here?"

Fine snowflakes settled on Xie Zheng's ink-black hair, accentuating his cold, refined features. "The Eight-legged essays I wrote recently sold well and caught the bookstore owner's attention. He invited me for tea. When I heard you went to Wang's place, I came to check on you."

Fan Changyu exclaimed in surprise, "To earn the bookstore owner's praise, your essays must be exceptional!"

Xie Zheng hadn't expected her, seemingly unlearned, to understand such matters. He lowered his gaze to conceal his thoughts. "Having fled from Chongzhou, I know more about the war and hardships there. Even if my writing is crude, it covers topics unheard of in Lin'an Town, which is why the bookstore owner valued it. How did things go with Wang's place?"

The last sentence carried a clear intent to change the subject.

Unaware of his subtle deflection, Fan Changyu walked alongside him and recounted the incident at Wang's place. "...I didn't even hit anyone. I just kicked their chopping block and shaved their hair with my butcher knife, and they were scared out of their wits..."

Midway, she suddenly stopped and glanced at Xie Zheng before falling silent.

Xie Zheng had listened quietly as she animatedly described the events at Wang's shop. Noticing her abrupt silence, he turned his head and asked, "Why did you stop?"

He was undeniably handsome, his delicate features as if painted with ink. When he lowered his gaze slightly, the usual impatience at the corners of his eyes vanished, replaced by a fleeting illusion of cold yet gentle warmth.

Meeting his eyes, Fan Changyu suddenly felt a little embarrassed. She scratched her head and asked, "Do you think I'm too... uncouth?"

Xie Zheng's brows lifted slightly, as if surprised by the question, before he replied, "No."

Before his downfall, he might have thought so, but not anymore.

Only those with full bellies and idle minds fret over refinement and elegance. Those struggling for survival worry only about their next meal.

Judging the poor by the standards of the rich is truly asking, "Why not eat meat porridge?"

Fan Changyu curled her lips in a faint smile upon hearing this, not bothering to discern whether his words were genuine or merely perfunctory. She kicked a small pebble at her feet, as if having been alone for too long and suddenly craving conversation. Her tone was almost self-muttering, "My father never allowed me to display martial skills in front of outsiders, and my mother wouldn't even let me near the butchering. She said if a girl did such things, people would gossip. Even if Song Yan didn't mind marrying me, others would mock and scorn me behind my back."

"For over a decade, I restrained myself. Though far from being a refined lady, I had a decent reputation in town. After my parents passed away, I had no choice but to take up butchering to make ends meet, even resorting

to wielding a stick to teach a few lessons. Now, the townsfolk probably see me as some kind of she-devil."

She waved the notice from the money lender recruiting enforcers, half-jokingly adding, "If I ever quit butchering, I could always go collect debts for people!"

Xie Zheng was well aware of how crucial a woman's reputation was. Already branded as the "Star of Doom and Isolation," and now infamous for her ferocity, the townsfolk might not say it to her face, but whispers behind her back were inevitable.

This woman before him might truly be unbothered, or perhaps she was simply finding solace in hardship.

A stray snowflake landed on his lashes, melting into tiny droplets in an instant. His dark eyes settled on Fan Changyu as he spoke in a tone both lazy and earnest, "Then go collect debts."

Fan Changyu, in the midst of kicking another pebble by the roadside, nearly slipped on the icy path at his words, almost doing the splits. Fortunately, an iron-like hand yanked her arm back in time.

Her eyes widened in disbelief. "You're actually encouraging me to do such wicked deeds?"

Her arm was still held by Xie Zheng. Even through the thick winter coat, his fingers could feel how slender her arm was. It wasn't soft like a dough that invited pity or bullying. It was lean and powerful, like the forelimb of a tiger or leopard.

Paired with those round, glaring eyes, she resembled a scruffy little leopard still trying to puff itself up in defiance.

Through the coat, his palm tingled oddly.

Xie Zheng frowned, withdrawing his hand and averting his gaze. "I meant for you not to fear others' words."

Fan Changyu mulled it over for a moment before grasping his meaning, the last remnants of gloom in her heart dissipating entirely.

She quickly caught up to the man hobbling ahead on his crutch. "Your leg's still injured, let me hire an ox-cart to take you back!"

"..."

"Ah—no, I mean, your wound hasn't healed yet!"

...

The two rode an ox-cart back. Along the way, Fan Changyu stopped by the tailor's to pick up the winter clothes she'd ordered for the family's New Year celebrations and bought a packet of malt candy for Changning. They finally made it back to their home in the western part of town before nightfall.

When she went to Aunt Zhao's to fetch Changning, however, she was informed that constables from the County Government Office had come by that afternoon, summoning Fan Changyu to appear for a hearing in three days. After such a long delay, Fan Da's lawsuit was finally going to trial.

Fan Changyu hadn't thought much of it at first, but Aunt Zhao said with deep concern, "The constable who came to deliver the message works under Head Constable Wang. He let slip some troubling news. Fan Da has been frequenting the County Government Office to visit the magistrate's advisor these days. That advisor is Butcher Guo's uncle. Butcher Guo had a feud with your father years ago. Originally, since you took in a son-in-law, the property should have been awarded to you. But now, with the advisor meddling, I'm afraid at least half will have to be given to your uncle."

Fan Changyu hadn't expected these two troublemakers to join forces. She immediately frowned. "Why would Fan Da get half?"

Aunt Zhao sighed. "Those officials can decide cases however they please with just a word from their mouths. How could folks like us understand the law as well as they do? Besides, Fan Da went to the advisor. Even if you hired a lawyer, no one would dare take your case and risk offending the advisor."

Changyu's frown deepened.

Though the advisor held no official rank, he was the de facto second-in-command at the Yamen. Combined with the old grudge between Butcher Guo and her father, she was sure to get the short end of the stick when the court convened three days later.

Even if she wanted to pull strings, no one she could reach outranked the advisor. The only person with higher authority was the county magistrate himself, and hoping to reach him was nothing short of a pipe dream.

Not only did her family have no connections to the magistrate, but given that the magistrate wanted Song Yan as a son-in-law, and she was Song Yan's former fiancée, she'd be lucky if the magistrate didn't make things harder for her.

Changyu thought it over and felt a dark cloud looming over her head. She asked, "Aunt Zhao, do you know how Butcher Guo and my father became enemies?"

She only knew that Butcher Guo had a grudge against her family, but she wasn't aware of the specifics Aunt Zhao mentioned.

Aunt Zhao sighed again. "That happened over a decade ago. The shops on that street have long since changed hands, so you wouldn't have heard about it while doing business there."

"Back then, Butcher Guo was a local thug. All the merchants on that street had to pay him 'protection money,' or else hoodlums would come and cause trouble. After your father set up shop there, he refused to pay. When the thugs came to stir up trouble, they ended up getting a beating from your father instead. They confessed that Butcher Guo had sent them, so your father took him to court. The magistrate at the time was a true just official—not only did he have Butcher Guo flogged, but he also threw him in jail for over half a year. That's how the feud between your father and Butcher Guo started. Now that Guo's family has an advisor as a relative, and you're caught up in this lawsuit, they'll surely use this chance to make things difficult for you."

With such an old grudge in play, there really seemed to be no way out of this.

Changyu remained frowning all the way home.

After dinner, once Changning had gone to bed, she sat alone by the fire pit, idly poking at the ground with a charred stick.

The gyrfalcon's cage was placed near the fire pit. After a full day of smoke, its feathers had dulled a shade.

The main room was utterly silent, save for the occasional crackle of embers from the fire pit. The gyrfalcon didn't dare make a sound either, merely darting its beady eyes between the two figures seated by the fire.

When the flames spat out another spark, Xie Zheng finally spoke, watching the deep furrow between Changyu's brows in the firelight. "Don't

worry too much..."

"I'm not worried. I've already thought of a solution." Changyu tossed the stick aside, her tone firm, but her expression remained grave, showing no sign of relief.

Xie Zheng's eyes lifted slightly, the previously languid gaze cooling by three degrees: "What method?"

Going to beg her former fiancé?

That did seem to be the only feasible option available to her at the moment.

After their conversation that afternoon, Fan Changyu no longer treated him as an outsider. She clenched her fingers tightly together, her lips pressed into a nearly straight line: "If my parents knew my plans, they'd probably be disappointed in me too. I used to look down on such actions myself, but right now there's no other way..."

Xie Zheng suddenly didn't want to hear anymore. His cold phoenix eyes reflected both the firelight and her silhouette as he interrupted: "I'll help you."

Changyu looked up, puzzled: "How can you help me?"

Xie Zheng replied: "When officials judge a case, no matter how biased they are, they must base their decision on the Great Yin Law. The reason they could allocate part of your property to your uncle after you took in a husband was simply by exploiting loopholes in certain laws. We still have three days. I'll break down the relevant sections of the Great Yin Law for you in detail. When you face them in court, you won't need a lawyer; you'll be able to handle it yourself."

Changyu was both astonished by his legal knowledge and somewhat doubtful: "Will... will that really work?"

Xie Zheng shot her an icy glare, showing no mercy: "Would begging your fiancé work better?"

Changyu looked completely baffled: "Why would I beg him?"

Xie Zheng frowned: "Wasn't that the method you were thinking of?"

Changyu: "...I was planning to disguise myself as someone from a gambling den the night before the trial, stuff my uncle in a burlap sack and kidnap him."

Xie Zheng: "..."

Feeling somewhat embarrassed about confessing such plans, she added: "Head Constable Wang mentioned that if my uncle doesn't show up on trial day, the case would be invalid."

Xie Zheng: "..."

Chapter 21

The broken window was haphazardly patched with wooden planks, unable to block the howling wind outside. The flickering flames in the fire pit cast shifting shadows across the room.

After an eerie silence in the air, Xie Zheng spoke: "I overcomplicated things. Let's proceed with your method."

Fan Changyu quickly shook her head. Earlier that day, the moneylender's men had come to collect debts when he saw her. If she really went to ambush Fan Da with a burlap sack, he might genuinely think her some kind of ruthless villain.

With visible awkwardness, she said, "If there were another way, I wouldn't take this risk. If discovered, I'd face legal trouble again."

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes slightly, his dark pupils reflecting the firelight yet remaining cold. Suddenly he remarked, "If you don't fear complications, eliminating Fan Da directly would be simpler."

His tone was chillingly indifferent, as if the man who'd earlier proposed teaching her the Great Yin Law for courtroom battles wasn't him.

Changyu immediately understood his meaning of "eliminate." Goosebumps rose on her arms as she stared at him with wide almond eyes: "K...killing someone?"

Noticing her reaction, Xie Zheng's thick lashes cast faint shadows in the firelight as he averted his gaze to the blazing flames. In a tone utterly devoid of jest, he said, "I was joking."

His voice carried lazy nonchalance.

Had anyone wronged him so severely, their head would have rolled long ago.

His offer to teach her the Great Yin Law was genuinely the best solution from her perspective. Though her temperament proved more formidable than expected, it still fell short of true ruthlessness.

When Changyu's suspicious gaze swept across his handsome face, he half-raised his eyes, meeting her stare directly: "Shall I teach you the Great Yin Law now?"

Forgetting her embarrassment at being caught staring, Changyu nodded miserably, her face scrunched in distress.

She'd hated studying since childhood—words gave her headaches. Her literacy was solely due to her mother's bamboo switch forcing her to learn.

The writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone were all in the southern room. Changyu entered Xie Zheng's chamber and brightened the oil lamp's wick for better illumination.

Without any Great Yin Law texts at home, Xie Zheng recited relevant passages from memory for her to study.

This concerned protecting her family's assets, so Changyu focused intently. Yet whether from late-night fatigue or the soporific nature of legal statutes, her eyelids grew increasingly heavy as she memorized.

Xie Zheng appeared to doze in a bamboo chair nearby, yet somehow sensed whenever Changyu's head began bobbing. He'd rap his knuckles twice on the desk—"thump thump"—and her eyes would snap open.

Clutching the papers, she yawned repeatedly, tears of exhaustion forming as she forced herself to continue: "Great Yin Law, Household Decree, Childless Chapter, Article Seventeen: For heirless households, with sons establish the eldest; without sons establish an heir..."

"If they're truly heirless, how could there be 'with sons establish the eldest'?" came an icy voice beside her.

Fan Changyu trembled at the sound of his voice, like a student caught dozing during morning lessons in school. She forced herself awake and skimmed through the legal statutes he had written, then continued reciting with half-closed eyes: "For households without heirs, an heir shall be selected and established. If no heir is selected, the property shall be divided among parents and siblings, who must support any unmarried daughters. For households that take in a son-in-law, the son-in-law cannot inherit the property, which shall go to the daughter..."

Xie Zheng interjected at the right moment: "According to this statute, all the property left by your parents should rightfully go to you. But your grandparents are still alive and ailing, and your uncle Fan Da is idle and

lazy. When you go to the County Government Office in three days, if the other side cites the 'Filial Piety Book' from the Great Yin Law, at least half of your parents' property will have to be allocated to your grandparents. Since your grandparents and uncle haven't divided the family assets, that money will ultimately end up in his hands."

Changyu's drowsiness was instantly dispelled by anger. Frowning, she said reluctantly, "Then should I take my grandparents in to support them?"

Xie Zheng glanced at her. "Are you close to them?"

Changyu shook her head.

Even when her parents were alive, her family hadn't been close to her grandparents.

When her mother was giving birth to Changning, she had a difficult labor and nearly died along with the baby. The physician barely managed to save them and said it would be hard for her to conceive again.

The old couple came to congratulate them, holding the swaddled Changning, but their words were all about how her mother had failed to bear a son for her father. They suggested adopting a male heir from Fan Da's family, saying it would be a support in their old age.

Her parents ignored them, but the old couple went back and accused her mother of being jealous and unfilial, whispering in her father's ear all day to make the Fan family heirless.

Her father personally went to the old residence to settle things, and only then did they quiet down. After that, there was hardly any contact. Only during festivals would her father bring a piece of pork to the elderly couple, but he never stayed for a meal—just left the gift and went on his way.

Xie Zheng then said, "According to Article 11 of the 'Supplements to the Yin Law · Marriage Law,' if you can get neighbors to testify that Fan Da is a habitual gambler, the half meant for your grandparents can instead be managed by you."

Changyu, who was used to straightforwardness, couldn't quite grasp all these convoluted tactics. Puzzled, she asked, "How is that any different from me supporting the two elders?"

Xie Zheng paused for a moment, pressed his fingers to his brow, and patiently explained, "If you take them in, you're obligated to support them.

If you hold onto the money, it's up to you whether to give it or not."

Changyu immediately slapped the desk in excitement. "That's a great idea! It's a bit underhanded, but for Fan Da's family, it's not too much at all! How do you know so much?"

Xie Zheng glanced at the desk, which wobbled precariously from her slap, not doubting for a second that it would collapse if she hit it any harder.

His slender fingers turned the page of the book on his lap, and he lied without batting an eye: "Traveling around exposes one to many anecdotes. There was a wealthy merchant's daughter who had her inheritance seized by relatives after taking in a son-in-law. She hired a famous local lawyer, and this was the solution he proposed."

Changyu praised sincerely, "That lawyer was really clever!"

Xie Zheng didn't respond, only the faintest hint of a smile tugging at his lips.

Changyu peeked at him guiltily. "Um... since we already have a solution, can I stop memorizing now?"

Memorizing was truly a headache for her. These obscure legal statutes were even more painful than those convoluted classical texts.

Xie Zheng said calmly, "If the opposing party asks you in court which specific law you're citing, you'll be fine as long as you can answer."

Fan Changyu wanted to say he could just accompany her to court, but remembering his leg injury—which would worsen from prolonged kneeling during proceedings—she swallowed her words.

Her face scrunched up like a steamed bun as she resigned herself to continue memorizing.

Xie Zheng idly flipped through a miscellaneous book in his hands, listening as her recitation dwindled from mosquito-like buzzing to intermittent mumbling. Unable to resist, he lifted his gaze.

The next moment, her exhausted head had already drooped onto the desk, her breathing gradually evening out.

Xie Zheng: "..."

The study companion was still awake, yet the main student had fallen asleep first.

This was his first time observing her sleeping form up close. Candlelight cast long shadows from her lashes, her fair cheeks bathed in a soft glow, red lips slightly pursed—an image of tranquility completely unlike her waking self.

Yet even in sleep, she seemed troubled. Her brows were lightly furrowed, stray hairs falling across them like a wisp of fog.

Realizing he'd been staring, Xie Zheng frowned and averted his gaze. Just as he was about to wake her to return to her room, he caught her faint murmur: "Mother..."

Nasal and trembling, as if she were crying.

Frowning deeper, he looked back. Her head rested on her arm, pressing against strands of dark hair that made her face appear palm-sized in the candlelight.

He'd always thought her thin, though her vibrant energy overshadowed it. Now, seeing her half-collapsed figure, he realized she wasn't just thin—she looked fragile.

An unfamiliar, peculiar emotion flickered in his chest. Xie Zheng stared at her, his handsome features tightening further.

...

At mao hour (5-7 am), Fan Changyu awoke as usual to pitch darkness. Rising, she found both her arm and legs numb.

Memories surfaced—she must have fallen asleep at the desk. Lighting a firestarter, she barely illuminated the room.

The desk lamp had burned out. As she turned to find candles, she noticed Xie Zheng also asleep nearby, his weight pinning part of her sleeve. She had to tug hard to free it.

The movement roused him. Meeting those pitch-black, icy eyes, Changyu paused—his morning temper seemed fierce. "Did I wake you?"

His gaze held hers as the sharpness faded, though his frown remained. A red mark from sleeping on his arm marred his fair complexion.

"You fell asleep studying too?" she asked awkwardly.

A vague "Mn" was his only reply.

"I'll get candles," she said.

The firestarter wouldn't last long. But as she stood, her numb legs gave way, sending her crashing sideways.

Amidst the clatter, both tumbled to the floor with their stools, extinguishing the firestarter in the fall.

Bruised from multiple impacts, Changyu winced. Remembering she'd landed on him, she scrambled up to help. "Are you okay? Did I reopen your wounds?"

"Fine," came the strained reply.

Clearly, something was still amiss. For the next two days, he didn't even leave his bed.

Fan Changyu suspected Xie Zheng was upset with her. His demeanor toward her had noticeably cooled—he avoided speaking to her whenever possible and kept his distance.

Even when they couldn't avoid each other, he either refused to look at her or frowned in her direction.

Changyu had already apologized, but though he claimed everything was fine, his subtle withdrawal continued.

Unable to understand the reason, she hesitated to ask him about the legal texts she was memorizing, despite having questions.

Over those two days, she studied at home and during spare moments at the shop, quietly reviewing the papers until she had most of it memorized. She also gathered a few neighbors to serve as witnesses.

On the morning of the trial, considering Yan Zheng's recent odd behavior, she went to the south room and said, "Your handwriting is excellent. If you have time today, draft the divorce papers. After I transfer my parents' property, I'll just sign them when I return. Once your injuries heal, you can go wherever you wish."

He had made it clear from the start that he would leave once recovered. The only explanation Changyu could think of was that he feared she might renege—transferring the property but refusing to honor their original agreement.

Handing him the divorce papers might ease his mind.

Chapter 22

Fan Changyu left the room, but the person sitting at the desk, writing with a brush, didn't look up. Only the corners of his lips tightened slightly.

Listening to the fading footsteps, he set down the brush and leaned back in his chair, his dark eyes shadowed and unreadable.

Summoned at will, dismissed at will?

She really had the nerve—

After instructing her younger sister not to wander off while she was away, Fan Changyu bid farewell to Aunt Zhao from the neighboring house and prepared to head to the County Government Office.

Aunt Zhao, however, insisted, "Your uncle and I will go with you. That place is terrifying—I've heard that one wrong move could get you beaten with the intimidating rod. A few dozen strikes would leave your flesh torn open! If anything happens, we'll be there to help you figure something out."

It's often said that commoners shouldn't provoke officials. Since Fan Da had connections with the Record Keeper, who held a grudge against Fan Changyu's family, the elderly couple from the Zhao family had been so worried about her that they couldn't sleep.

Though Fan Changyu was skilled in martial arts, this was her first time appearing in court in over a decade. After a brief consideration, she agreed.

The three of them took an ox cart to the County Government Office. By the time they arrived, it was still early, but a crowd of onlookers had already gathered at the entrance.

Fan Changyu was familiar with the trial procedure. Once the County Magistrate took his seat, she and Fan Da would be summoned inside. The magistrate would first question Fan Da about his accusations, while the Record Keeper documented the proceedings. If there were disputes, witnesses might also be called.

Fan Changyu's witnesses were neighbors from the old Fan family residence. Most people wouldn't willingly involve themselves in such trouble, but Fan Da and his family had made plenty of enemies. After visiting a few households, several neighbors, disgusted by Fan Da's behavior, agreed to testify that he was a gambler.

Time passed slowly, and the crowd outside the Yamen grew larger. Yamen Runners had already placed the bamboo slips and the magistrate's gavel on the desk in the courtroom, but Fan Da, the plaintiff, was nowhere to be seen. Fan Changyu couldn't help but feel puzzled.

Even arriving late to court could earn someone a beating. Could Fan Da have forgotten about the trial and overslept?

Aunt Zhao glanced around and muttered under her breath, "Where is Fan Da?"

Fan Changyu had an absurd thought—had she been so exhausted from memorizing legal statutes the past few days that she'd sleepwalked last night and kidnapped Fan Da?

The sound of three drumbeats snapped her back to reality.

Three rows of Yamen Runners entered the courtroom first, lining up on either side like a flock of geese. Each held a punishment rod nearly as tall as a person, their faces stern and intimidating.

The spectators outside the courtroom gasped and murmured at the sight of them, clearly intimidated.

Fan Changyu also noticed that none of these Yamen Runners looked familiar—none were from Head Constable Wang's team. Wondering if the Record Keeper had pulled some strings, she felt a flicker of unease.

The County Magistrate, clad in his official robes, entered through a side door and took his seat behind the high desk. His eyes, narrowed by his plump face, swept over the courtroom before he raised the gavel and slammed it down.

"Court is in session!"

The Yamen Runners struck their rods against the ground in unison, chanting, "Dignity and authority—"

The sound of the rods hitting the floor nearly merged with the pounding hearts of the spectators outside.

The Record Keeper, with his thin mustache, called out, "Bring forth the plaintiff and the defendant!"

Though nervous, Fan Changyu gave Aunt Zhao and her husband a reassuring glance as the Yamen Runners escorted her into the courtroom.

But even now, Fan Da had yet to appear, leaving only her, the accused, kneeling alone before the court.

The portly magistrate, clearly encountering such a situation for the first time, exchanged glances with his advisor, both baffled by the circumstances.

The onlookers outside the court buzzed with discussion.

With the standoff unresolved, the magistrate finally addressed Fan Changyu: "Who kneels before this court?"

Fan Changyu replied, "This humble woman is Fan Changyu."

The magistrate squinted at the indictment and bellowed, "Where is the plaintiff, Fan Da Niu?"

No one answered from within or outside the court.

In the silence, the hushed murmurs of the crowd outside became all the more conspicuous.

The portly magistrate slammed his gavel heavily. "Outrageous! In all my years presiding over cases, never have I encountered a plaintiff who dares not show up in court! This is sheer lawlessness!"

The gaunt advisor, thin as a bamboo pole, cast a few glances at Fan Changyu and advised, "Your Honor, please calm your anger. Fan Da Niu is but a commoner—he wouldn't dare be late to court without reason. There must be some underlying circumstances. Perhaps we should dispatch yamen runners to his home to inquire, demonstrating Your Honor's thoroughness and fairness."

The magistrate pondered briefly. "Granted!"

Soon, yamen runners were sent to Fan Da's home to fetch him. The magistrate ordered a temporary halt to the proceedings, sparing Fan Changyu from having to kneel any longer.

With this unexpected turn, the gathered crowd didn't disperse but grew even more curious about Fan Da's absence, lingering stubbornly at the

entrance.

Fan Changyu sat on a small stool, rubbing her knees, when a minor official approached her. "Head Constable Wang requests Miss Fan's presence."

Assuming he had something to convey, Fan Changyu followed the official through a side door to the duty room behind the County Government Office.

The official, likely Head Constable Wang's trusted subordinate, kept watch at the door after she entered.

Head Constable Wang wasted no time and got straight to the point. "Your uncle... did you have him taken?"

Fan Changyu thought to herself that while she had initially considered it, she had since abandoned the idea in favor of another plan. She shook her head firmly. "How could I commit such a reckless act?"

Head Constable Wang exhaled in relief. "Good."

He had recalled Fan Changyu's earlier question about what would happen if Fan Da failed to appear in court and had sought her out privately to confirm.

Lowering his voice, he said, "Fan Da has connections with Master He. Even if you had resorted to such measures, he would have turned the tables on you, accusing you of lawlessness. You could've ended up in prison."

Fan Changyu nodded. "I understand."

The fact that the yamen had sent its own men to search for Fan Da—excluding Head Constable Wang's people—spoke volumes. There was little he could do to help in this matter.

After leaving the duty room, Fan Changyu returned to the courtroom to wait. But even after a full half-hour, the yamen runners sent to fetch Fan Da had not returned.

The magistrate grew impatient and sent someone to hurry them along. Another half-hour passed before the runners returned, carrying a stretcher covered with a white cloth.

Fan Da's wife, Madam Liu, and his elderly parents followed behind, wailing loudly.

It was clear that the figure beneath the white cloth was Fan Da.

Fan Changyu's face registered shock. Fan Da was dead?

The crowd outside the yamen buzzed with speculation, their eyes repeatedly darting toward Fan Changyu.

Fan Da had schemed to seize her family's property, and now, at this critical moment, he was dead. It was impossible not to suspect foul play.

"How could he have died on the very day of the trial?"

"Fan Da was as strong as an ox—it wouldn't be easy for an ordinary person to take his life..."

Fan Changyu felt the weight of the varied gazes upon her and pressed her lips together slightly, her heart equally filled with shock and doubt.

Who killed Fan Da?

Her mind instinctively flashed back to Yan Zheng's words a few days ago about "settling" Fan Da, but she quickly dismissed the thought.

Not only was Yan Zheng's injury worsening—he had barely left the house these past few days—but he had also painstakingly taught her all the legal statutes she might need in court. There was no way he would act against Fan Da.

Moreover, their marriage was only a sham. He had no grudge against Fan Da and no reason to kill him.

When the county magistrate heard that the plaintiff, Fan Da, was dead, he rushed out of the side room in such haste that his official hat was barely secured. His eyes, narrowed to slits by his plump face, widened in horror. He clearly hadn't expected a property dispute to escalate into a murder case. "This... what is this? Is there no law left in this land?"

A constable who had gone to search for Fan Da replied respectfully, "Your Honor, when we found Fan Da, he had already been dead for some time. His body bore multiple wounds from blades and swords."

The magistrate ordered the white cloth covering Fan Da to be lifted. One glance was enough to make the fat on his face tremble in fright. "Summon the coroner!" he cried.

Fan Da's wife, Madam Liu, collapsed beside his corpse, weeping so violently she nearly fainted. Spotting Fan Changyu, she lunged at her like a

vengeful spirit. "Was it you? Did you kill him?"

Changyu stepped back to avoid her, her voice icy. "Don't slander me, Aunt. Uncle owed piles of gambling debts—who knows which creditor he crossed? What does that have to do with me?"

Madam Liu and Fan Laopozi continued wailing, their cries giving the magistrate a headache. He ordered the yamen runners to take them away.

Before Old Fan left, he looked at Changyu hesitantly, his lips pale as if recalling something terrifying.

Since Changyu was involved in the lawsuit with Fan Da, she was unavoidably detained.

After examining the body, the coroner concluded that Fan Da had likely died that morning on his way to the County Government Office. There were eleven wounds in total, but only the fatal stab through the heart had killed him.

"The first ten cuts were vicious yet deliberately avoided vital areas," the coroner said. "The killer must be someone skilled with blades. If not for revenge, these wounds suggest... interrogation."

Changyu frowned at this.

Interrogation?

What could they have been interrogating Fan Da about?

Forcing him to repay debts?

But if the goal was repayment, why kill him?

For a moment, Changyu felt lost in a fog of confusion.

However, since Fan Da was killed on his way to the county seat, Changyu had an alibi—she had been traveling at the time, and the elderly Zhao couple and the oxcart driver could vouch for her.

Yet the magistrate's advisor wasn't ready to let her off. "Your Honor," he said, "though Miss Fan has an alibi, what if... she hired someone to kill him? I've heard she's close with that local ruffian Jin Lao San and his gang. To be safe, shouldn't we search her home?"

The sudden murder case during the New Year festivities struck the magistrate as terribly unlucky. With a life at stake, he set aside his usual

scheming and turned to Head Constable Wang, a seasoned investigator. "Take some men and search her house."

Fan Changyu stood tall and unafraid, her conscience clear. Even when faced with Head Constable Wang and the sly, weasel-like gaze of the clerk, she didn't flinch in the slightest.

The group of yamen runners arrived at the residential alley in the western part of town. The north wind howled fiercely, and one of the runners sniffed the air. "Did someone slaughter a pig? The smell of blood is so strong."

Head Constable Wang caught the scent too, but since the Fan Family lived nearby and Changyu made a living as a butcher, he didn't think much of it at first.

But when they pushed open the gate to the Fan Family's courtyard and saw the corpses strewn across the ground, even the seasoned constables from the capital, accustomed to all manner of violent deaths, paled at the sight.

The ground was littered with bodies, their blood staining the snow that had yet to be swept from the courtyard.

Head Constable Wang, who had been friends with Changyu's father, knew she had a younger sister. Not spotting a child's body in the yard, he hurried inside to check.

As he climbed the steps, he saw a man lying on his back at the entrance of the main hall, his neck torn apart by some kind of claw-like weapon. A few large feathers, the size of goose down, were scattered on the ground, and the door bore marks from sword slashes.

His heart sank. He pressed on into the inner rooms, where another corpse lay face-down in the northern chamber, a kitchen knife embedded in its back.

The blade had struck the spine dead center, yet it had sunk two-thirds of its length into the bone. The sheer force required to drive it in so deeply was unimaginable.

With a heavy heart, Head Constable Wang searched every room but found no trace of the Fan Family's youngest daughter or the live-in son-in-law. He couldn't decide whether to feel relieved or more worried.

"It seems someone came seeking vengeance against the Fan Family," he said grimly. "Quick, report back to the County Government Office!"

The sky was overcast, and thick snowflakes drifted down like goose feathers, occasionally shaking loose from the pine needles in small flurries.

Xie Zheng's chest was soaked with blood. Behind him, the startled caws of crows rose from the dense forest as chaotic footsteps crunched through the snow, tightening like a net around him. Yet he seemed oblivious, leaning against a pine tree with his bloodied sword planted three inches into the snow as he bandaged the wound on his hand with a torn strip of cloth.

A few flecks of blood dotted his pale jaw, and his lips were pressed into a thin line, his mood clearly foul.

Changning and the gyrfalcon, its feathers dulled with grime, huddled nearby. The bird still had shreds of pink flesh clinging to one talon, while Changning sobbed intermittently, her small face ghostly white from terror.

He lifted his cold gaze. "Stop crying."

Changning immediately stifled her sobs, though fat tears continued to roll down her cheeks.

"Just what kind of enemies has your Fan Family made?"

The terrified child before him couldn't possibly answer, and Xie Zheng's question seemed more like a muttered thought to himself.

By the time the chaotic footsteps finally closed in, he had finished tying the bandage with his teeth, the metallic taste of blood lingering on his tongue.

His fierce, ruthless phoenix eyes reflected the figures of masked men advancing with swords and knives through the pine forest.

Chapter 23

County Government Office.

Fan Changyu was detained in a temporary interrogation room, its doors and windows tightly shut. The tables and chairs inside seemed to exude a chilling coldness.

After sitting for a long time, the cold seeped through the thick double-layered soles of her shoes, leaving her feet nearly numb. She rubbed her hands together, blew warm air into her palms, and lightly stomped her feet, trying to ward off the chill.

Outside the interrogation room stood two on-duty Yamen Runners. Changyu had tried speaking to them through the door, but the two clearly weren't Head Constable Wang's men—they ignored her entirely.

The wait was agonizing. Finally, the door to the interrogation room creaked open, flooding the dark room with daylight. The Yamen Runner at the door said, "You're free to go."

Changyu assumed that Head Constable Wang had returned from the search and confirmed her innocence. Relieved, she stepped out of the interrogation room.

When she saw Head Constable Wang, he was frantically issuing orders to his subordinates. Only then did she notice that even the ordinary Yamen Runners serving tea were armed with blades, as if everyone in the Yamen was prepared to mobilize at any moment.

Head Constable Wang spotted Changyu and dismissed the Yamen Runners with a nod. His brows were furrowed so deeply they nearly formed the character "river." "Another report just came in," he said. "Today, aside from Fan Da's brutal death, several other households were also attacked. The blade wounds on the victims match those on Fan Da's body—likely the work of the same group. But only your home was targeted afterward. We don't know if they got any information from Fan Da. When I took my men to investigate, we found a yard full of corpses..."

At the last sentence, Changyu's mind buzzed as if her ears were ringing. She could see Head Constable Wang's lips moving but couldn't make out his words.

After a long moment, she barely managed to steady herself. "My sister —"

Her voice came out hoarse, her hands and feet icy.

Head Constable Wang quickly reassured her, "We didn't find your husband or your sister's bodies. We searched inside and out. They might have been taken by the assailants or escaped. I've already ordered the Yamen Runners to search, but the heavy snow has covered most traces. There's been no word yet."

Changyu's relief was only partial. She rushed toward the exit. "I'll look for them too."

Her parents were already gone—she couldn't let anything happen to her sister!

Though Yan Zheng was injured, he was still a trained fighter. Even in his severely wounded state, he had managed to deal with Jin Lao San and his gang. If the corpses in the courtyard were his doing, then he must have fled with Changning. But his injuries wouldn't hold out for long—she had to find them before it was too late!

—

The wind carried fine snowflakes, along with the scent of blood, far through the pine forest.

A flash of steel, and a spurt of hot blood gushed from a neck, splattering onto the frost-covered trunk of a pine. The man holding the blade collapsed stiffly into the snow. The sticky blood on the tree dripped slowly, leaving small crimson pits in the snow below.

Xie Zheng didn't even glance at the fallen man. With a flick of his wrist, he shook the blood droplets from his sword.

Within ten paces of him lay nothing but corpses.

Xiao Changning and the Gyrfalcon huddled together, their faces pale from fear or cold, too stunned even to cry.

Xie Zheng sheathed his sword and walked back, frowning at the sight before him. He bent down and tapped the back of the child's hand with his

knuckles—it was indeed as cold as ice.

He glanced at his own padded coat, already soaked through with blood, offering little warmth. His gaze then fell on the man he had just slit open nearby.

That coat didn't look dirty.

He strode over, using his sword to flick open the man's fur coat. With a kick, he sent the corpse rolling like a burlap sack, then lifted the coat with the tip of his blade, catching it in his hand.

This sword had been taken from a masked assailant. It served him well enough, so he kept it.

Xie Zheng tossed the fur coat to Xiao Changning. His bloodstained face was paler than the snow on the ground as he leaned weakly against a pine tree, his eyes half-lidded, exhaustion evident. Yet his tone remained icy: "Put it on. Stay alive until your elder sister finds you."

In the distance, footsteps closed in on the pine forest—several groups, though it was unclear whether they were allies of the masked men or another faction.

Xie Zheng had no intention of pressing forward. His strength was spent, and with a child in tow, he wouldn't get far.

Staying put to recover some energy might buy them more time.

"Zheng'er, is the osmanthus cake tasty?"

The sunlight and pine trees blurred before his eyes. For a moment, the gentle, dignified voice of a woman seemed to whisper in his ear, warm with laughter.

Xie Zheng's eyelids trembled.

Xiao Changning, seeing him covered in blood and slumped against the tree with his eyes closed, feared he was dead. With a hoarse, tearful voice, she sobbed, "Brother-in-law..."

"Quiet."

His consciousness sharpened again. Xie Zheng frowned, his limbs heavy as lead, his eyelids unbearably weighted.

This feeling was familiar. The last time he'd escaped the Martial Assassins of the Wei family, he'd collapsed unconscious in the snow just

like this.

Forcing his eyes open, he gripped the blade with his blood-soaked, bandaged hand and dragged it downward.

The sharp edges sliced deep into his palms, soaking the bandages anew. Blood dripped from his clenched fists onto the snow like scattered plum blossoms.

The pain cleared his mind somewhat.

As chaotic footsteps drew near, a glinting blade thrust straight toward the child. Xie Zheng's sword swept up in a reverse block, the clash ringing out with a sharp "clang."

Sparks flew as steel met steel.

His gaze turned fierce. As his blade slid to the hilt, he twisted his wrist and carved a vicious gash across the masked attacker's shoulder, then kicked the man back several paces.

"Hide behind the tree," he ordered coldly, the whites of his eyes now streaked with red, like a lone wolf cornered.

A dozen masked men stared at their fallen comrades, visibly shaken. After exchanging glances, they surged forward, swords aimed at Xie Zheng with lethal precision.

Xiao Changning ducked behind the tree. Though Xie Zheng had scolded her repeatedly for crying, she couldn't stop the tears from falling as she instinctively pulled out the whistle hidden beneath her collar and blew it with all her might.

Her sister had made this whistle for her long ago. Once, while playing hide-and-seek with the neighborhood children, she'd fallen into a dry well. She'd cried until her voice gave out, but no one had found her.

When her family came looking for her, she had cried herself hoarse and couldn't make a sound.

Later, her elder sister made her a whistle, telling her to blow it whenever she was in danger so the family could find her.

During the escape with her brother-in-law, she had blown it once out of fear, but it only attracted the wrong people. After being scolded harshly by her brother-in-law, she hadn't dared to use it again.

Now, in this urgent situation, Xiao Changning no longer cared about his warning.

The sharp whistle pierced through the pine forest like a fledgling bird crying blood.

A masked man noticed Changning and strode toward her with a blade in hand. Changning scrambled to her feet to run, but the oversized fur coat she had wrapped around herself—taken from one of the masked men—tripped her after just a few steps.

As the masked man raised his blade to strike, a gray falcon suddenly swooped down from nowhere, slamming straight into him. Its iron-hooked talons missed his neck but tore his face to shreds, ripping off the black cloth covering his face in the process.

From the dense woods in the distance came the faint but ferocious barking of dogs—more than one, it seemed—growing louder and more vicious. The birds nesting in that part of the forest took flight in a panic, darkening the snowy sky like a rolling storm.

Changning's eyes brightened, and she quickly puffed her cheeks, blowing the bamboo whistle several more times with all her might.

The masked man swung his sword to fend off the falcon and was about to grab Changning when a sharp whistling sound cut through the air behind him. Instinct made him jerk backward just in time to avoid the cleaver hurled straight at his skull.

The black iron blade buried itself deep into the trunk of a pine tree behind him. The impact shook the tree, sending snow piled on its branches cascading down in a flurry, momentarily obscuring vision.

In that split second, the masked man felt a sudden chill in his chest. As the blade was yanked free, blood gushed from the wound.

Though he had killed many people himself, the masked man still froze for a moment at the sight of the blood pouring from his chest.

What a ruthless strike.

This wound would drain a man's blood in the shortest time possible.

Through the falling snow, he struggled to lift his gaze, his vision settling on the black iron weapon dripping with fresh blood.

A butcher's cleaver?

His fading eyes could no longer make out the face of the person holding it.

But it was unmistakably a woman.

The masked man slumped to his knees in the snow, his head drooping weakly. The blood pooling beneath him melted the snow, the sheer volume nearly double that of the other masked men who had died here.

Fan Changyu had never killed a person with her butcher's cleaver before. In her panic, she had used the same technique as when slaughtering pigs—aiming to drain as much blood as possible.

The sheer tension and protective fury sent all the blood in her body rushing to her head. Her fingertips tingled and burned, leaving no room for any other emotion about taking a life.

The moment Changning saw her elder sister, her lips trembled as if she were about to burst into tears. But the situation was far too urgent.

Fan Changyu saw Yan Zheng, severely wounded and outmatched, his arm slashed open. Without a word to her younger sister, she yanked the cleaver from the tree trunk and hurled it at one of the masked men.

Unexpectedly, the man was pulled aside by a companion, dodging the blade—only for it to fly straight toward Xie Zheng behind him. Fan Changyu's heart leaped into her throat.

Thankfully, Xie Zheng reacted swiftly, tilting his head just in time as the heavy cleaver embedded itself into the pine tree behind him.

When he looked over, Fan Changyu's face flushed with embarrassment.

As the snow from the tree cascaded down, she had no time to think further. Repeating her earlier tactic, she closed the distance instantly, stabbing several men in quick succession using her pig-slaughtering technique, while Xie Zheng slit throats with his sword.

What scattered across the snow-covered ground alongside the frost were splashes of fresh blood.

When the last of the snow had fallen from the branches, Fan Changyu met Xie Zheng's gaze and awkwardly explained, "I was just... throwing that masked man earlier."

Xie Zheng remained silent.

More than half of the dozen masked assailants had already fallen, giving him a moment to catch his breath. Leaning on his sword, his disheveled hair hung loosely, his face as pale as snow, blood staining the corner of his lips. Though he looked so weak it seemed he might collapse at any moment, the remaining masked men hesitated, not daring to act recklessly.

The barking of dogs grew closer. Three or four hunting hounds leaped out from the dense woods, baring their fangs and snarling at the masked men.

These hounds had been borrowed by Fan Changyu from a local hunter in town. Thanks to them, she had been able to follow the scent of blood to this pine forest outside the city.

Upon hearing Changning's whistle, she had left the hounds behind and rushed ahead.

Fan Changyu shouted at the attackers, "The County Government Office's officers will be here soon!"

The masked men exchanged glances, seemingly deciding that continuing the fight against Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng would be futile, and quickly retreated.

Xie Zheng said, "Capture one alive."

Almost the moment he spoke, Fan Changyu charged forward.

These men, dressed like bandits, had killed Fan Da and broken into her home—they might very well be the same group responsible for her mother's murder.

She untied a length of rope from her waist, swiftly forming a lasso as she ran. With a powerful throw, the loop caught around the neck of the last masked man. Fan Changyu yanked back with all her strength, tightening the noose instantly.

The masked man clawed desperately at the rope strangling him as Fan Changyu dragged him backward through the snow like a sack of refuse.

Xie Zheng's expression shifted slightly at the sight.

Bracing one foot against a snow-laden pine, Fan Changyu hauled the rope with all her might, explaining, "This is a lasso used for wild horses or cattle. Once caught, it's nearly impossible to escape—the more you struggle, the tighter it gets."

Thankfully, Head Constable Wang, worried she might encounter danger during the search, had instructed the yamen runners to provide her with a constable's equipment.

A constable's standard gear consisted of just a blade and a coil of rope—the blade for self-defense, the rope for restraining criminals.

The yamen's blade didn't suit her as well as her own butcher's knife, but not wanting to refuse Head Constable Wang's kindness, she had taken the rope instead.

Xie Zheng fell silent for a moment. Despite the life-or-death situation, her words somehow eased the tension in the air.

Seeing their comrade captured, the remaining masked men exchanged brief glances before one of them suddenly hurled his sword at the trapped man.

Blood sprayed instantly as the lassoed man fell dead.

Fan Changyu cursed furiously, immediately dropping the rope and charging after them with her butcher's knife.

Xie Zheng coughed up blood, but fearing she might be outmatched, he ignored his own severe injuries and moved to follow. As he stepped forward, however, his boot struck something hard in the snow. Shifting his foot, he saw a waist badge.

The moment he recognized the insignia engraved on it, his phoenix eyes sharpened like blades.

He picked up the waist token and tucked it into his robe. When he looked at the masked men being pursued by Fan Changyu, his gaze was as indifferent as if they were already dead.

The masked men were being chased and bitten by three or four hunting dogs while simultaneously being pursued by the freakishly strong Fan Changyu. For a moment, they were utterly overwhelmed.

However, they quickly discovered Changyu's weakness. She often relied solely on brute strength and speed, lacking real combat experience where life was on the line. When they surrounded and attacked her, she couldn't defend properly and soon bore several wounds.

The burning pain from the sword cuts slowed her movements considerably. Though she was trying hard to learn how to block, this minor

improvement wasn't enough to instantly match several skilled opponents.

When she saw another masked man swing his sword straight at her wrist, Changyu panicked but couldn't dodge in time—her stance was already committed.

If her wrist was injured, at best she'd lose grip on her weapon; at worst, she might lose the entire hand.

Gritting her teeth, she prepared to fight to the death.

At the critical moment, a large, bony hand gripped hers from behind, the one holding the cleaver. Compared to the warmth of her own skin, his touch was as cold as lake ice.

With some inexplicable finesse, he guided her wrist in a twist. The blade of her butcher's cleaver flipped upward and slashed fiercely at the masked man's elbow from below. Then, with overwhelming force, the blade scraped along bone and flesh upward until it reached the tendons and cartilage beneath the armpit—before giving a sharp flick.

The masked man's sword clattered to the ground, his entire arm now a bloody, limp mess. A heart-wrenching scream tore from his throat.

Though Changyu was used to scraping bones and cutting flesh, even she shuddered at the brutality of that move. She turned her head slightly and caught only a glimpse of the man's pale jaw before he guided her hand again, blocking the killing strikes from the remaining masked men.

His movements felt more like he was teaching her how to evade attacks, yet when it came to striking, Changyu didn't hold back her raw strength at all.

With her sole weakness now gone, the masked men were quickly overpowered.

Changyu did have some talent for martial arts. While memorizing the defensive moves Xie Zheng guided her through, she still found openings to land kicks on the masked men.

One of them was sent flying by her kick, crashing into a snow-laden pine. The impact shook the tree, sending a cascade of icicles crashing down in a flurry of snow.

At the same time, the man behind her guided her hand in a fluid motion, driving the butcher's cleaver straight into another masked man's heart.

Changyu could distinctly feel the wound on his palm reopening—warm blood seeped out, wetting the back of her hand where their skin touched. Yet his palm remained cold.

Watching the chaotic flashes of swordplay before her, her chest trembled faintly, as if resonating with the fallen icicles.

"Don't lose focus." His voice, cool and slightly hoarse, brushed against her ear. Their proximity—due to the way he guided her grip—allowed her to feel the faint warmth of his breath.

Her entire ear tingled strangely.

Suppressing the urge to rub it, she forced her attention back to the fight.

By the time the bloodstained butcher's cleaver pressed against the last masked man's throat, Changyu finally had a moment to catch her breath.

She had noticed earlier that this man was likely the leader of the group—the masked man she had ensnared had been finished off by his sword.

Fan Changyu pressed her blade harder against his neck, drawing a thin line of blood, and demanded coldly, "Who are you? What grudge do you hold against my Fan Family?"

Yet the man didn't look at her. Instead, his gaze remained fixed on Xie Zheng, who stood behind her, as if struggling to recognize something. When Xie Zheng lifted his eyes to meet his stare, the man seemed to finally place him, his pupils contracting violently as a look of defeat washed over his face. Then, abruptly, he seized the butcher's knife Fan Changyu held to his throat.

Standing so close to Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu hadn't realized the man was looking at him. Startled by the sudden movement, she thought he was trying to wrest the blade from her and immediately pressed down harder to restrain him. But instead of resisting, the man gripped the knife and drove it deep into his own neck.

A spray of blood splashed across the trampled snow.

The masked man collapsed, his throat slit.

Fan Changyu stared at the scene, too stunned to speak for a long moment.

She gazed at the bloodied butcher's knife in her hand and murmured, "Why would he...?"

He'd rather take his own life than say another word—just who were these people?

Could they be enemies her father had made during his years as a caravan escort?

As she looked at the dead leader, thoughts of her parents' deaths tangled like a knot in her chest.

Xie Zheng had frowned when he saw the masked man's suicide, but his injuries had pushed him to his limit. With the danger gone and his willpower spent, the world spun violently around him.

The blood he'd been forcing back surged up, and he could no longer keep his grip on his sword.

Hearing the commotion behind her, Fan Changyu turned just in time to see him collapse into the snow, his face and lips drained of all color. Without another thought, she rushed to check his wounds.

Not only had his old injuries reopened, but he had also sustained several new ones.

The guilt weighed heavier on her heart knowing he'd nearly died again because of her family.

She didn't have any wound medicine on her, but she reasoned that these bandits might carry some. Searching the dead leader's body, she indeed found a small bottle of powder.

Unsure if it was truly a coagulant, she tested it first on the leader's still-bleeding wound. When the blood clotted, she applied it to Xie Zheng's injuries.

The moment the potent medicine touched his flesh, the searing pain—like knives and fire—jolted him back to partial consciousness, though he remained too weak to even open his eyes.

After hastily bandaging him, Fan Changyu hoisted him onto her back and set off to retrieve Changning.

Her arms bore shallow cuts from her earlier skirmish with the masked men. Though not serious, the wounds burned fiercely now as she strained under his weight.

Hoping to distract herself from the pain, she joked weakly to the man on her back, "This is the second time I've carried you out of the snow."

There was no response—he seemed to have passed out again.

Beads of sweat formed at her temples from the pain, and she whispered, "Thank you."

Thank you for saving Changning.

Without her little sister, she would have lost her last remaining family in this world—left with nowhere to go.

The blizzard raged as she carried the man on her back, leaving deep footprints in the snow.

Xiao Changning waited under the conifer tree, clutching the Gyr Falcon. Seeing Fan Changyu return with Xie Zheng on her back, she hurried forward. "Sister."

Burdened with her load, Fan Changyu couldn't embrace her younger sister. A drop of sweat trickled down her temple, stinging the scrapes on her face. She looked Changning over and asked, "Are you hurt, Ning Niang?"

Changning shook her head, her eyes reddening when she saw the unconscious figure on her sister's back. Choking back a sob, she said, "Brother-in-law got hurt protecting Ning Niang..."

The blood from his palm when he broke the move for her still stained her hand, searing like a burn. A pang of bitterness rose in Fan Changyu's chest. "Don't cry," she said. "We'll take him back to see a physician."

She always seemed calm and steady.

Yet whenever Changning heard her elder sister speak like this, her heart settled, and fear melted away.

When their parents passed, she had cried herself into a fit, gasping for breath. It was Changyu who held her by the bedside and whispered, "Don't be afraid. You still have me."

Xiao Changning watched her sister's bent back, wiping her eyes clumsily with her sleeve before clutching the Gyr Falcon and trudging through the snow after Fan Changyu.

"This is the second time I've carried you back from the snow."

"Thank you."

In his haze of delirium, Xie Zheng heard someone speaking to him. The voice was familiar, but he couldn't place it.

His eyelids were too heavy, his mind a swirling mess, unable to form a coherent thought. It felt as though he were sinking endlessly into darkness, the cold seeping into the very marrow of his bones.

Resisting the pull was exhausting. Surrendering to it brought an instant lightness.

"Zheng'er."

Someone was calling him again.

He could no longer clearly recall the gentle woman's face or voice, but in his dreams, he always knew it was her.

Why was she visiting his dreams now?

Hadn't she abandoned him?

Xie Zheng didn't want to answer her, yet his gaze was drawn forward against his will. The woman stood in the back garden of the marquis' estate, smiling as she held a child's hand, watching a martial man practice his forms in the courtyard.

"Zheng'er's father is a true hero. One day, you must become just like him."

Only when the woman turned her radiant smile toward him did Xie Zheng realize he had become that child.

Still, he remained silent, staring at her face—so vivid in the dream, yet fading into a blur upon waking.

He missed her. But she had left too soon, so soon that even her face had slipped from his memory.

The man practicing in the courtyard vanished, replaced by a coffin carried back from the battlefield in Jinzhou.

The woman, clad in mourning white, collapsed before the coffin, her wails of grief piercing the air. Maids and servants rushed to restrain her, but none could hold her back.

The scene shifted. She wore fresh robes, sitting before a bronze mirror as she traced her brows—delicate as distant mountains. Her face was exquisite, yet unmistakably sorrowful. "Why did he break his promise?" she murmured. "He said he'd return to paint my brows for me."

It sounded like the lament of a maiden whose lover had stood her up.

She noticed him and beckoned him over. Xie Zheng didn't move. Instead, a child of about four, wearing a small golden crown, dashed past him toward her. She handed the boy a plate of osmanthus cake, her voice as tender as ever. "Zheng'er, is the osmanthus cake tasty?"

Finally, he spoke, his voice laced with resentment. "No. It's not."

The woman seemed not to hear him. She lifted the child onto her lap, her gentle voice growing distant. "Zheng'er, you must grow up to be a hero like your father."

"Be good now. Go eat your osmanthus cake outside."

Then she applied her makeup, dressed in her finest clothes, leaving only her brows bare, and hung herself from the beam with a white silk ribbon.

Her general had broken his promise and not returned to paint her brows, so she went to find him.

The servant women broke down the door, wailing in grief. The child stood at the threshold, seeing only the vibrant hem of a skirt dangling in midair.

Struggling awake from this nightmare once more, Xie Zheng was drenched in cold sweat.

The numbing bitterness of medicine lingered on his tongue as his eyes focused on the patched bed curtains. A figure stood silhouetted against the light by his bedside.

Turning his head slightly, Xie Zheng saw Fan Changyu staring at him with a mix of shock and bewilderment, holding a medicine bowl in her hands. The spoon she had been holding was nowhere to be seen.

His gaze lowered to the shattered porcelain spoon on the floor.

She stammered, "Medicine never tastes good..."

Xie Zheng: "..."

His breathing, still rapid from the nightmare, gradually steadied. The lingering gloom from the dream dissipated miraculously at her words.

Frowning, he gave the woman sitting by his bed a complicated look, then forced himself upright and extended a pale, slender hand. "Give it to me."

Even in illness, his face was strikingly handsome.

Fan Changyu hesitated before realizing he meant the medicine bowl. Glancing at the bandages on his hand, she reminded him gently, "You have two deep sword cuts on this hand, and your palm is torn. The physician said you shouldn't exert it yet."

He switched hands, and only then did she pass him the bowl.

Xie Zheng downed the foul-tasting concoction in one gulp and handed the empty bowl back.

Fan Changyu recalled forcing the medicine down his throat while he was half-conscious, and his gritted-teeth roar of "It's disgusting!" So this usually silent man was actually afraid of bitterness.

She rummaged in her sleeve and pulled out a piece of candy meant for Changning. "Have some sugar. It'll help with the bitterness."

After countless doses of medicine, this was the first time she'd offered him candy. Even a fool could guess why. His expression darkened, and he closed his eyes. "No need."

But the next moment, a firm grip on his jaw forced his mouth open, and the candy was popped inside.

"You—!" He glared at her.

Fan Changyu retreated to her seat with a grin. "Sweet, isn't it? There's no shame in disliking bitterness. You're always so needlessly stubborn!"

Perhaps it was the faint winter sunlight streaming through the window behind her, but her smile seemed especially bright and warm.

—At least far warmer than the smile of that woman in his dreams, whose face he could no longer recall.

The melting sweetness of the candy gradually overpowered the medicinal bitterness, like sunlight breaking through a damp, moss-covered gloom.

Xie Zheng suddenly fell silent, turning his head away and pressing his lips together.

He hadn't eaten sweets in years—not since that woman coaxed him outside with a plate of osmanthus cake, only to hang herself with a white ribbon upon his return.

All these years, resentment and self-loathing had festered in his heart.

If only he hadn't taken that plate of osmanthus cake outside. If he'd stayed by her side, maybe she wouldn't have left.

He detested osmanthus cakes, detested sweets, and over time, those around him stopped offering them to him altogether.

Fan Changyu noticed his low spirits but couldn't discern the reason, so she simply advised, "This injury of yours is no less severe than the last one. The physician repeatedly emphasized that you must rest properly—at least until you're healed, you shouldn't be lifting heavy objects. Many in our family have died, and the authorities are investigating the case. We can't return home for now, so stay in this loft at Aunt Zhao's place to recover."

Xie Zheng had already recognized this loft in the Zhao family where he had previously recuperated when he woke up. Hearing her words, he gave a slight nod.

Fan Changyu paused, then added, "Thank you for protecting Changning."

Her voice overlapped with the one he had heard before losing consciousness, confirming it hadn't been an auditory hallucination.

At the time, she seemed to have said one more thing.

"This is the second time I've carried you back from the snow."

During his first injury, Xie Zheng had been completely unconscious. This time, though dazed, he had been vaguely aware.

He could feel how slender the back carrying him had been.

Now, as he looked at Fan Changyu again, noticing her thin shoulders and the faint glimpse of bandages beneath her sleeves, his chest tightened as if stuffed with damp cotton—stifling and moist.

When she had carried him back, she had been injured too.

He moved his pale, cracked lips and said, "You saved me first."

That was all he said, as if subconsciously unwilling to settle the debt of gratitude too clearly.

When those men had broken in, he had thought the Zhao family had been exposed, drawing assassins. But apart from trying to kill him and the child, they had nearly turned the Fan family's home upside down—clearly searching for something.

Thinking of the waist token he had picked up from the snow, Xie Zheng's eyes darkened further.

He asked, "Has the County Government Office uncovered anything?"

Fan Changyu shook her head and told him about the other families who had suffered similar tragedies that day.

Fan Da's death had nothing to do with her now, and the County Government Office had smoothly transferred all the property deeds left by her parents to her.

With more financial leeway, this was probably the only thing that brought her comfort—at least she wouldn't have to scrimp to pay for Yan Zheng's medical treatment.

Hearing that others in the county had also been targeted, Xie Zheng frowned in thought before suddenly asking, "Did those killed alongside Fan Da share any common traits?"

Fan Changyu pondered for a moment before shaking her head. "Seven households were attacked. The dead included men and women, old and young. There were no commonalities."

Xie Zheng remained silent, his brow furrowed.

Those men had targeted seven households but ultimately focused on Fan Changyu's family. Clearly, they had been searching widely for something at first, only narrowing it down after extracting information from Fan Da.

Using the Fan family's situation as a reference, he ventured a guess: "Did any of those households have members who once worked outside Lin'an Town and later returned?"

Fan Changyu felt that if this were true, it was likely revenge directed at her parents. But she couldn't understand why those people wouldn't stop even after her parents' deaths. "I'll ask Head Constable Wang later," she said.

After Fan Changyu left the loft, Xie Zheng mustered his strength to sit up. From the pile of bloodstained clothes on the bedside stool, he retrieved the waist token he had picked up from the snow.

He held it in his hand, frowning as he examined it for a while before clenching it tightly in his palm.

That waist token belonged to the Wei family's Martial Assassins.

Heaven, Earth, Mystic, and Yellow—this time, it was actually the Mystic-ranked Martial Assassins who had come.

But these men weren't here to kill him. In fact, they hadn't even noticed him hiding here. Their leader had only recognized him at the very last moment.

Yet why had that man worn such an expression upon recognizing him and immediately taken his own life?

The mystery before him grew deeper. The only way to unravel it seemed to lie in uncovering the true identities of that woman's parents.

Her martial skills were already so formidable—her father must have been no ordinary man either. It was likely he hadn't died at the hands of common bandits but rather Martial Assassins disguised as such.

Was there also more to the name without a surname on her mother's memorial tablet?

Xie Zheng pressed his fingers to his brow, considering sending word to his former subordinates to secretly investigate the origins of the woman's parents. His gaze flickered to the Gyrfalcon, its wing bandaged, lying on the floorboards as it voraciously devoured a bowl of minced pork.

The bowl of minced meat had been prepared by Fan Changyu. Since the Gyrfalcon had saved Changning, its meals had been upgraded from offal to fresh minced meat.

After rolling in the snow several times, its feathers had finally regained their white sheen. At that moment, it had just opened its beak wide to snatch up a large chunk of meat when it suddenly noticed Xie Zheng staring at it.

The Gyrfalcon's beady eyes locked onto its master's. After a tense standoff, the meat at the edge of its beak finally plopped back into the bowl with a soft thud, leaving the bird looking both foolish and innocent.

Xie Zheng coldly averted his gaze.

Never mind. The Wei family's hounds had already taken notice of this place. There was no point in relying on this stupid creature to deliver messages anymore.

If that merchant surnamed Zhao truly had come to seek refuge with him, he could use the man's shops to discreetly send out letters without anyone noticing.

With only a few days left until the New Year, he had instructed the merchant to exchange the silver notes for two hundred thousand dan of grain before the year's end. A reply would likely arrive soon.

The malt candy in his mouth had melted away, leaving only a faint sweetness on his tongue.

Only then did he glance out the window. The candy was gone, but the one who had given it to him still hadn't returned—

Fan Changyu had gone to the County Government Office to share Xie Zheng's reasoning with Head Constable Wang. However, after hearing her out, the constable merely shook his head in silence and said, "This case has already been closed."

Fan Changyu was stunned. "How can it be closed when the mastermind behind it hasn't even been found?"

Head Constable Wang replied, "Those who died in the pine forest were the culprits. They were bandits from Clear Breeze Stronghold. Bandits killing for loot during the New Year is nothing unusual."

Fan Changyu thought to herself, How could they have been bandits? They had clearly come prepared. She wanted to argue further, but when she met the constable's gaze, she swallowed all the words on the tip of her tongue.

It wasn't hard for her to guess why the County Government Office was in such a hurry to close the case.

The New Year was approaching, and with so many murders suddenly occurring, not only were the common people discontent, but the county magistrate would also have a hard time explaining things to the prefectural authorities. They needed a quick resolution.

Since the masked men had been dressed as bandits and were now dead with no way to verify their identities, pinning the crimes on them as bandits killing for loot was naturally the best excuse.

All the magistrate had to do was post a notice warning the townsfolk to be cautious when going out due to rampant bandit activity, and public sentiment would be appeased. Then, he could draft a petition requesting a bandit suppression campaign to be sent to the prefecture, neatly shifting all responsibility elsewhere.

After all, the Clear Breeze Stronghold's banditry had plagued Jizhou for years without resolution—it was already a chronic issue.

Head Constable Wang was just a minor constable. With the county magistrate pressuring him to close the case, what else could he say?

Fan Changyu felt heavy-hearted as she bid farewell to Head Constable Wang. When he escorted her to the door, he said, "Why don't you sell your pigpen and land in the countryside and go somewhere else to lay low for a while? I suspect your father might have offended someone during his earlier years as a traveling escort."

Fan Changyu knew Head Constable Wang meant well. She thanked him and said she would consider it carefully, but for a moment, she felt lost.

Leave?

She had lived in Lin'an Town for over a decade. From a rock at the eastern end of the town to a tree on the western side, she knew every inch of it.

Staying here might give her a chance to uncover the truth behind her parents' deaths, but if another assassination attempt came, she couldn't guarantee she and her younger sister would survive.

She wasn't afraid of leaving home and venturing out into the world. But her parents were buried here, and so were her and Changning's roots. The thought of leaving pained her.

By the time she stepped out of the County Government Office, her chaotic thoughts had settled. She gazed at the vast sky after the snowfall and exhaled deeply.

As long as the green hills remain, there will always be firewood to burn.

Once Yan Zheng's injuries improved, she would discuss leaving Qingshui County with him. If he wasn't afraid of more enemies seeking revenge and was willing to follow her, she'd take him along. If he had other plans, she'd write him divorce papers and give him some travel money—then they'd be even.

After returning to town, Fan Changyu went to the butcher shop to pack up some things. The best time to transfer the shop would be after the New Year. Since she planned to leave, she might as well sell the shop, along with the pigpen and farmland in the countryside.

She decided to keep the house—if she ever returned, she'd have a place to come back to. It was where she and her parents had lived for over a decade, and she couldn't bear to sell it.

As she clattered around packing things up, passersby thought the Fan Family Butcher Shop had reopened. Seeing nothing on the counter, some even poked their heads in to ask when business would resume.

Not wanting to complicate matters, Fan Changyu didn't announce her plans to transfer the shop yet. She simply said she'd reopen after the New Year.

While she was busy organizing, someone knocked at the door. Without looking up, Fan Changyu said, "We're not open today."

A hoarse voice replied, "Not even for an old man's business?"

Fan Changyu glanced up and saw it was Chef Li from the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Apologetically, she said, "Sorry, Master Li. Some things have happened at home recently, and I don't plan to open the shop until after the New Year."

Chef Li waved his hand. "Our boss wants to see you."

Chapter 24

Fan Changyu followed Chef Li to the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Upon entering, she was greeted by an imposing landscape screen, the floor paved with exquisite carved blue bricks, and the doors and windows adorned with intricate hollowed-out patterns of flowers, plants, and animals.

Since it wasn't mealtime, there were few customers in the building. At a glance, the main hall alone had over a dozen large round tables draped in fine silk, and the chairs were equally refined—not bare, but fitted with matching embroidered cushions and backrests, exuding an air of grandeur.

No wonder the townsfolk hailed the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion as the finest establishment in town.

Chef Li led Fan Changyu to an elegant private room upstairs and said, "The proprietor is inside. You may go in, lass."

After a moment's hesitation, Fan Changyu pushed the door open and found herself face-to-face with a young woman who was happily gnawing on a braised pork knuckle, sleeves rolled up.

Before the woman lay a table laden with delicacies.

Fan Changyu glanced back at the door, uncertain. "Are you the proprietor of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion?"

The woman set down the pork knuckle, swiftly wiped the grease from her face with a handkerchief, and cleared her throat. "You must be Changyu, right? Please, have a seat."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu knew she was indeed the proprietor. She thought to herself that the woman wasn't quite what she had imagined, but she seemed friendly enough.

After sitting down, Fan Changyu asked, "You know me?"

The woman smiled. "Chef Li has mentioned you. Your braised meat is exceptional."

Perhaps having heard about Fan Changyu's confrontation at Wang's shop, she studied her with a grin. "Before meeting you, I didn't expect you to be such a lovely, delicate beauty."

Unsure how to respond, Fan Changyu simply offered a faint smile.

The woman beamed. "My surname is Yu, and my given name is Qianqian. I'm a few years older than you, so I'll take the liberty of calling you Sister Changyu. As you may know, the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion has ended its braised meat dealings with Wang's shop. I've had someone buy some from your shop to try, and it's indeed better than theirs. If you're willing, I'd like to do business with you for your braised meat."

This unexpected stroke of luck would have been something Fan Changyu eagerly sought in the past. But considering her family's current situation, she hesitated before politely declining. "Thank you for your kind offer, Shopkeeper Yu, but I'm afraid I can't take on this business."

Yu Qianqian blinked. "Why not?"

Fan Changyu answered truthfully, "After the New Year, I plan to leave Linshui Town."

Yu Qianqian sighed in disappointment. "What a shame. Have you decided where to go?"

Fan Changyu hadn't settled on a destination yet and replied, "I'm still discussing it with my husband."

Yu Qianqian tapped the table with her slender fingers, looking somewhat wistful. "If your braised food disappears, the town will lose another delicacy."

There was a playful tone to her words.

Though this was Fan Changyu's first meeting with the female proprietor, she found her quite amiable. Thinking that she and her younger sister might be leaving their hometown for who knew how long, she said, "If you enjoy the braised meat, Shopkeeper Yu, I can teach you the recipe. You can have your staff prepare it."

Yu Qianqian, now the manager of a restaurant, had once worked in the kitchen herself and knew how valuable a recipe could be. She quickly declined, giving Fan Changyu a helpless look. "You silly girl, you're too honest. If you ever go to a foreign place, you've got to be more careful. Don't sell yourself out with just a few words."

Fan Changyu could sense the goodwill from the female manager and smiled. "I won't. I'm willing to share the recipe with you because you seem kind."

Yu Qianqian was amused by her response and thought for a moment. "How about this? Business is at its peak in my restaurant during the New Year period. Banquet orders are fully booked, and the demand for braised meat is high. Those gourmets have picky tastes, and lately, they've been complaining that the braised meat here isn't as good as before. The Wang family's business practices are shady—they stabbed me in the back before and are now collaborating with other restaurants under the banner of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. I absolutely refuse to go back to them. Why don't you supply the braised meat for my restaurant until the New Year? After that, I'll figure out how to fill the gap."

Fan Changyu pondered for a while. Moving to a new place would require buying a house and land, and there would be no shortage of expenses. The money from selling the pigsty, farmland, and the shop in town might not be enough. Earning a bit more now would be ideal, so she nodded in agreement.

Yu Qianqian was visibly delighted. "You're really helping me out of a tight spot. Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion used to have a yearly contract with the Wang family, buying braised food at fifty wen per pound regardless of the season. Since meat prices are higher during the New Year, I'll pay you sixty wen per pound. The restaurant sells at least ten braised pork heads a day. If your home kitchen isn't convenient, you can use the restaurant's back kitchen to prepare the meat, and I'll pay you daily."

Fan Changyu's own home had been sealed by the authorities, making it inconvenient. She nodded. "I'll prepare the meat in the restaurant's kitchen."

It was already late afternoon. Fan Changyu went to the meat market with a servant from Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion and bought ten fresh pork heads.

Her family had previously run a pork shop in that area, and most of the butchers on that street knew her. Seeing her buy so many pork heads, they couldn't help but ask, "Is Changyu's shop selling braised meat again tomorrow?"

The servant accompanying her was sharp-witted and immediately replied, "Miss Fan's braised meat is now exclusively sold at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion."

Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion was a well-known establishment in town. Even after the Wang family's fallout with the restaurant, their reputation in town had taken a hit.

Many acquaintances congratulated Fan Changyu.

With her family's pork shop closed, business had improved for the other butchers. When Fan Changyu went to buy pork heads from them, they gave her a special discount.

Fresh pork heads in the market usually cost twenty wen per pound, weighing around six to seven pounds each, but Fan Changyu paid only eighteen wen per pound.

Using the braising spices and stoves in Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's kitchen, the custom-made large pots could braise four or five pork heads at once. Two pots were enough to finish all the pork heads, and the total cost of the braising spices for a full pot was only thirty wen.

Fan Changyu did a quick calculation. Even conservatively estimated, braising these two pots of pork head meat would net her at least two taels and five mace of silver.

For a moment, she was a little stunned.

When she ran the shop herself, she had to work from dawn to dusk every day, haggling with the elderly women buying meat, which took a lot of effort. After deducting costs, she only earned about two taels of silver a day.

Now, all she needed to do was spare an hour or two to select pork head meat at the market and braise it at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion to earn the same amount. It was countless times easier than before.

Remembering that the female proprietor had offered her sixty coins per jin, she felt a bit guilty. She approached Chef Li, who was also in the kitchen preparing broth, and said, "Chef Li, could you tell the proprietor later that she can charge me fifty coins per jin for the braised meat?"

Chef Li frowned and asked, "What's the matter?"

Fan Changyu scratched her head sheepishly. "The proprietor is kind, but I feel the payment is too generous. It doesn't sit right with me."

Chef Li gave her a sidelong glance. "If the proprietor offered that price, it's because she thinks your braised meat is worth it. Why feel uneasy? Don't let her youth fool you—she has sharp judgment. Even though she's been sabotaged by Wang's this time, her past dealings with them were always profitable. Just relax."

Changyu asked curiously, "What happened between Wang's and the pavilion?"

Chef Li had nothing good to say about Wang's. "That money-grubbing old scoundrel! The proprietor planned to open another restaurant in the county town to expand the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. She ordered twelve pork heads from Wang's for good luck, and they agreed. But on opening day, Wang's didn't deliver the heads."

"The proprietor sent someone to hurry them, but Wang's hadn't even bought the heads yet! Another restaurant in town had outbid her and secured a multi-year contract for braised meat with Wang's. Missing the auspicious time for the delivery was a huge taboo. The proprietor was furious and immediately cut all ties with Wang's."

Changyu hadn't realized this was why the pavilion severed ties with Wang's. Recalling the young master of Wang's smug face, she remarked, "Wang's really lacks integrity."

Chef Li snorted. "Profit over principles—typical of petty people."

He then changed the subject. "I heard Wang's hired people to smash your shop?"

Changyu said, "Their son sent thugs, but I settled the score myself."

Chef Li suddenly laughed. "No wonder the proprietor likes you. In some ways, your temperament is just like hers."

Changyu felt embarrassed. "The proprietor is capable. How could I compare?"

Chef Li sighed. "She's had her share of hardships too. When she first came to Lin'an Town, she was heavily pregnant, alone, and worse off than you."

Changyu had often heard about the proprietor's business acumen but never about her past. Puzzled, she asked, "What about her husband?"

Chef Li shook his head. "Heard he died."

Changyu sighed in sympathy. Chef Li glanced at her again. "The pavilion's been busy lately, and the proprietor is swamped. She doesn't care about those extra ten coins per jin for the braised meat. Don't bother her with it—she's straightforward and might find such hesitation troublesome."

Since he had already put it that way, Fan Changyu naturally gave up on the idea of looking for Yu Qianqian.

After finishing the braised meat at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, it was already quite late.

Thinking that the packet of malt candy she had bought for her younger sister was almost finished, Fan Changyu, flush with the two taels and seven mace of silver she had earned that day, swaggered into the candy shop and bought two packets each of malt candy, pine nut candy, and candied orange peel.

The thought that Yan Zheng was actually afraid of bitter tastes made the corners of her lips curl up involuntarily.

He wasn't afraid of pain, yet he dreaded bitter medicine.

By the time she got home, Aunt Zhao had already started cooking.

Changning, like a sister-watching stone, clung to the doorframe, craning her neck to peer down the alley.

The moment she spotted Fan Changyu returning with several large and small packages, she immediately bounced over like a little ball to greet her: "Elder Sister is back!"

Taking the paper packages and discovering several large packets of candy inside, she lifted her sparkling round eyes and asked, "Are these all for Ning Niang?"

Faced with her younger sister's hopeful gaze, Fan Changyu felt an inexplicable twinge of guilt. "Your brother-in-law is afraid of bitter medicine—how about we give half to him?"

Before, the mere mention of the word "brother-in-law" had made her feel awkward all over, but now, as she coaxed Changning, the term didn't

feel quite so scorching on her tongue.

Changning generously agreed with an “Mhm.” She often had to take medicine herself and wrinkled her round face. “The black goo is so bitter!”

“Black goo” was her special term for medicine.

Aunt Zhao came out to pour water and overheard the sisters’ conversation. She chuckled and teased Fan Changyu, “Learning to dote on your husband now?”

Even Fan Changyu’s thick skin couldn’t withstand the teasing, and she flushed slightly in embarrassment.

Coincidentally, the medicine was ready. As Fan Changyu carried the packets of candy upstairs, she also brought the bowl of medicine with her.

The person inside wasn’t asleep. The moment she entered, his gaze landed on her, and he asked, “Why are you back so late?”

It was a perfectly ordinary question, yet it carried a strange undertone.

“Did the County Government Office turn up any new leads?” he quickly added, as if to make up for it.

The odd atmosphere finally dissipated somewhat.

Fan Changyu handed him the medicine bowl and said, “The case has already been closed.”

Xie Zheng looked up in surprise, and seeing the expression on her face, he understood most of it immediately.

Fan Changyu voiced her speculation: “It’s probably because the county magistrate was afraid of losing his official hat after so many murders during the New Year, so he rushed to pin the blame on the mountain bandits.”

Xie Zheng remained silent.

That waist token belonged to the Wei family. If the Wei family wanted to suppress this matter quickly, it wasn’t impossible for them to pressure the county magistrate through the prefectural government to close the case.

But regardless, the Wei family had already set their sights on Lin’an Town, and it was no longer safe to stay.

He looked at Fan Changyu. "If this is about revenge, they'll likely come back. What are your plans?"

Fan Changyu had originally intended to discuss leaving with him after his injuries improved, but since he had brought it up, she said, "I plan to sell off my property after the New Year and take Ning Niang somewhere else to hide for a while."

Xie Zheng, however, replied, "If you're leaving, sooner is better than later."

He knew all too well how that man operated. With so many Martial Assassins of the Xuan rank lost in a small town like Lin'an, it was bound to draw his attention.

Fan Changyu said, "The New Year is only a few days away. I've taken on a job at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion to help them prepare braised meat before the holiday. I can earn some silver these days, and selling off property and transferring documents will take time. It's just enough to wait until your injuries improve before we leave."

Since the conversation had reached this point, she couldn't help but ask about his plans: "What are your thoughts?"

Xie Zheng thought she was seeking his opinion and was about to advise her to leave as soon as possible if she intended to go. But just as the words reached his lips, he realized she was asking about his own plans—whether he would stay or leave.

Leave?

Without having time to weigh the pros and cons, he hesitated instinctively for a moment.

Fan Changyu said, "My parents probably made enemies in their earlier years outside. If you come with me, you might still be targeted by those enemies. My thought is to give you the divorce papers and leave you some money for travel expenses later. Aunt Zhao and Uncle Zhao are very kind people—I'll ask them to take care of you until your injuries heal."

Aunt Zhao and Uncle Zhao had no children. In their younger years, their son had been conscripted into the army and sent off to war, never to return. It was said he had died far from home.

Fan Changyu planned to leave them some of the farmland in the countryside so they could collect rent from tenants, ensuring the elderly

couple would have security in the future.

As for leaving Yan Zheng here as well, it was purely out of fear that he might get entangled in her family's troubles again.

Listening to her lay out all these plans for him, Xie Zheng felt an inexplicable surge of irritation, and his voice unconsciously turned colder: "I have my own plans. You don't need to worry about me."

Fan Changyu didn't know what had provoked him and gave him a puzzled look.

Xie Zheng also realized his tone had been off just now. He closed his eyes briefly, and when he opened them again, his expression had calmed. "If you're leaving, it's best to go today or tomorrow. There's no need to specially apply for a travel permit—joining a merchant convoy would be the safest bet. When passing through city gates, avoid leaving any household registration records if possible."

Even if she were the slowest to understand, Fan Changyu would have realized this was to conceal their tracks.

She asked him, "So, are you planning to come with me or stay here to recover for now?"

When she put it so bluntly, Xie Zheng was visibly taken aback. His dark eyes reflected the girl and the candlelight's glow. After a long pause, he averted his gaze and said, "I'll go with you for now."

Lin'an Town was no longer safe for him either. He was genuinely curious about what the Wei family's Martial Assassins had been digging through her home to find.

His decision was based solely on these two reasons.

Hearing the word "for now" in his reply, Fan Changyu understood his meaning—once his injuries healed, he would still leave.

She said, "Alright then. Tomorrow, I'll go to the County Government Office again to sell the shop and the pigpen in the countryside to the authorities at a discounted price."

For land transactions, selling directly to a buyer would naturally fetch a higher price—it only required transferring ownership at the government office and paying a fee for the deed.

Only those in urgent need of money would sell to the government at a discount. The authorities would then resell the properties at market price to those in need.

As for the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, she could just hand the recipe directly to the manager.

Xie Zheng suspected that the Martial Assassins had yet to find what they were looking for and asked, "Are there any belongings of your parents you need to take with you?"

Fan Changyu answered as if it were the most obvious thing in the world: "Of course there are!"

A barely perceptible flicker of something unreadable passed through Xie Zheng's eyes.

Then he heard Fan Changyu continue, "I'll take that set of butcher knives wherever I go. With those tools, I can keep butchering pigs for a living. And if we run into troublemakers on the road, they'll serve as weapons too!"

Xie Zheng: "..."

Still, his words had reminded her of something. She said, "The case has been closed at the County Government Office, but for some reason, the seal on my house's door hasn't been removed by the officials yet. Later, I'll climb over the wall to retrieve the land deed."

Xie Zheng's eyes flickered slightly as he said, "Those masked men who broke into your home that day pried up several of the blue bricks inside, as if searching for something."

Fan Changyu couldn't think of anything valuable left in her house. Frowning, she said, "Surely they weren't also looking for the land deed?"

Xie Zheng: "...Probably not."

Changyu glanced at the sky outside the window: "I'll climb over the wall to search after dark."

Climbing walls in broad daylight was too conspicuous. Her home could now be considered a haunted house—sealed off with only government personnel allowed entry. If someone reported her for trespassing, she'd be in trouble again.

Xie Zheng asked, "Did your parents never mention anything you'd need to take when fleeing for your life?"

Changyu replied, "My younger sister."

Xie Zheng: "..."

His slender fingers pressed against his temple as he suddenly lost the will to speak.

Noticing his untouched medicine bowl, Changyu urged, "The medicine will get cold if you don't drink it soon."

The decoction had indeed cooled to a drinkable temperature.

Xie Zheng drained the bowl in one go, whereupon someone immediately offered him a candied orange peel with a smile: "I've tried this—it's sweet and sour, good for masking bitterness."

Her fair hand extended toward him, fingers long and elegant—neither the boneless delicacy of pampered noblewomen nor the prominent knuckles of men. Like distinct textures of flowers and wood, hers was a unique beauty between both.

The orange-hued tangerine peel candy rested on her palm, dusted with faint sugar crystals that glowed warmly under candlelight. The phrase "a feast for the eyes" popped unbidden into Xie Zheng's mind.

Applying this phrase to Fan Changyu... He fell silent at the thought.

To dispel these strange notions, he plucked the candy from her hand and tossed it into his mouth. With a stiff expression, he muttered, "Thanks."

Assuming his awkwardness stemmed from embarrassment about hating bitter tastes, Changyu found his prickliness rather amusing.

Taking the empty bowl, she stood up: "I'll head down now and bring your meal up later."

The door curtain swayed as she left. Only then did Xie Zheng frown at his fingertips—the ones that had brushed against her palm when taking the candy.

They tingled strangely, almost numb—

Downstairs, Changyu found her younger sister feeding something to the gyrfalcon. "Here, eat..."

The bird had retreated into a corner, wings bandaged and clamped shut as it stubbornly refused to open its beak. Its beady eyes wide with terror, it resembled a helpless maiden being harassed by a ruffian.

Changyu asked, "What are you feeding it, Ning Niang?"

Caught red-handed, Changning guiltily hid her hands behind her back: "N-nothing?"

Changyu simply stared silently until her sister, who feared this expression most, obediently extended her hands and admitted in a small voice: "I gave the falcon a candy."

Candy was precious. Offering it to the bird would surely earn a scolding.

Seeing her sister's pitiful expression, Changyu couldn't bring herself to be harsh. Amused, she said, "Gyrfalcons don't eat candy. They eat meat."

Changning blinked her round grape-like eyes. "Really?"

Aunt Zhao chimed in with a laugh: "These creatures are fierce in the wild. Remember that gyrfalcon that broke the east window? Same size, but much fiercer. The one you caught is well-behaved—doesn't attack people and even protects its owner."

After a pause, she added: "Though it does eat quite a lot."

A big bowl of meat every day—if she and the old man had to raise this thing, they'd be broke in no time.

Fan Changyu looked at the gyrfalcon with growing fondness. "Maybe Yan Zheng taught it," she mused.

Originally, she had planned to keep the falcon temporarily, have Yan Zheng train it, and then sell it for money. But the bird was remarkably intelligent and had even saved Changning. Fan Changyu decided it would be better to release it once its injuries healed.

That evening, after dinner, Aunt Zhao carried a yawning Changning to her and Carpenter Zhao's room. When she returned and saw Fan Changyu still sitting by the fire pit, she couldn't help but ask, "Aren't you going upstairs to sleep?"

The Zhao family's house was similar to Fan Changyu's, with three rooms on the ground floor. The main room served as both a dining area and a place for the fire pit. The elderly couple slept in the southern room, while the northern room originally had a bed. However, after a gyrfalcon had

smashed through the window, Carpenter Zhao had temporarily stored all the lumber and the cabinets and chairs he was making for others there.

At the moment, only the attic was habitable.

Fan Changyu was still preoccupied with sneaking back to her own house over the wall and said, "Aunt Zhao, you go ahead and sleep. I'll stay by the fire a little longer."

Having lived most of her life, Aunt Zhao could easily tell that this young couple still hadn't consummated their relationship.

Back when they were staying at her place, the two had slept in separate rooms. Now, this girl was probably planning to make do by the fire pit for the night.

Aunt Zhao scowled and said, "It's the middle of the night! If you don't go back to your room to sleep and keep tending the fire pit, you'll just waste firewood!"

Fan Changyu hadn't expected Aunt Zhao to cut straight to the point just to force her upstairs.

Thinking that she could still return home by climbing onto the roof from the attic, she slowly stood up. "I'll go up and sleep now."

At the foot of the stairs, she asked, "Do you have any extra quilts?"

She still needed to make a bed on the floor for the night.

Aunt Zhao refused outright. "No!"

Fan Changyu considered coming clean about the sham marriage. "Actually, Yan Zheng and I—"

But Aunt Zhao wouldn't let her finish. "I don't care what you think, but that boy Yan Zheng seems like a fine young man to me. Look at how, when your family was in such trouble, he dragged himself along despite his injuries just to protect Changning. Now he's covered in wounds—are you disgusted by him?"

Fan Changyu couldn't defend herself. "I'm not being picky about him..."

Aunt Zhao shooed her upstairs. "Then why are you still thinking about sleeping on the floor? If I were Yan Zheng, I'd be heartbroken—risking my life to protect your sister, only to end up being treated like this by you..."

Fan Changyu felt like a wayward man being lectured by his own mother not to wrong the girl, forced to retreat to the attic in resignation.

Only after the door closed did Aunt Zhao's scolding finally stop. Taking a deep breath, Fan Changyu turned to meet Xie Zheng's calm and indifferent gaze. Realizing he must have heard everything she and Aunt Zhao had said, she felt not only embarrassed but also increasingly awkward.

She walked toward the chair. "I'll just rest my head on the table for a bit. Once Uncle and Aunt Zhao are asleep, I'll climb back home from the attic roof."

Her own attic had bedding, so she could make do there after finding what she needed and climb back before dawn.

She didn't plan to let Uncle and Aunt Zhao know about the wall-climbing—after all, it was against the law. If they found out, they'd be guilty of knowing and not reporting it.

Xie Zheng didn't say much.

Once the candle was extinguished, the room plunged into darkness. Fan Changyu rested her head on the table, closing her eyes for a short nap. Xie Zheng's breathing was light, making no sound at all.

But whether it was the night amplifying her fear or her own delayed reaction, as she thought about returning to her house—where so many had died in the courtyard, and where she herself had killed many that day—the ghastly images of their final moments slowly surfaced in her mind.

Outside, the north wind howled like ghosts wailing.

Fan Changyu shifted positions several times but couldn't get comfortable. Eventually, she sat up.

Hearing no sound from the bed, she tentatively asked, "Yan Zheng, are you asleep?"

"Not yet. What's wrong?" His voice was especially clear in the darkness.

Fan Changyu pursed her lips, trying to keep her voice steady. "When you woke up at noon, you were drenched in sweat. Did you have nightmares after killing someone?"

There was a long silence before a faint "Mm" came in response.

Changyu felt she'd found an ally and swallowed hard. "It was my first time killing someone too."

After a pause, she asked, "Are you still scared now?"

The room remained quiet for a long while. Eventually, a calm voice came from the bed: "Come here."

"You don't need to be too afraid. Just imagine you're slaughtering pigs. Do you know how to slaughter pigs? I'll teach you later. That way, even if you stop escorting caravans, you'll have a trade to fall back on..."

As she rambled on, she'd already made her way to the bedside and sat down near the headboard. Clearing her throat, she spoke with renewed confidence: "Go to sleep. Old folks say butchers carry such fierce energy that even ghosts dare not approach. With me sitting here, you won't have nightmares anymore."

Chapter 25

The night was deep, and the north wind rattled the dilapidated window shutters with a creaking sound.

Such weather always made one yearn to burrow under the covers.

Especially when those covers had already been warmed by someone else, radiating an enticing heat.

Fan Changyu tightened her arms slightly, leaning against the bedpost with her eyes closed for a brief rest, but her ears remained alert to the movements downstairs.

Once Aunt Zhao and Carpenter Zhao had gone to bed, she hurried home to fetch the land deed and then carried a quilt over to make a bed on the floor.

Since Fan Da's incident the day before, she had barely slept at all. Her body was exhausted, but her mind remained tense, not daring to relax for even a moment.

The breathing of the person beside her was always shallow. Whether it was because he had eaten tangerine peel candy, Fan Changyu could faintly catch a subtle citrus fragrance emanating from him.

Unconsciously, she recalled the moment in the pine forest when he had gripped her hand, guiding her through a move, his breath brushing against her ear as he spoke.

Her ears inexplicably grew warm, though thankfully, the darkness concealed it.

Just as Fan Changyu was about to rub her ears, the person beside her suddenly sat up without a sound. Before she could react, a slender finger, cool to the touch, pressed against her lips. His long hair cascaded down, brushing the back of her hand, sending a faint shiver of tingling coldness through her.

He was so close that the scent of tangerine peel grew even stronger.

Fan Changyu startled at first, but upon hearing the light, cat-like footsteps on the roof tiles, her ears instantly pricked up.

Xie Zheng, seeing her reaction, withdrew his index finger from her lips without a word.

The soft, warm touch of her lips lingered on his fingertip—tender, delicate, like a dewy petal at dawn.

He frowned slightly, rubbing the tingling skin of his fingertip forcefully, suppressing the strange sensation in his chest.

The footsteps on the roof were light and chaotic, suggesting more than one person. Moments later, some stopped not far away—likely above the Fan Family's roof.

Others continued forward, halting above the Zhao Family's roof. Then came the faint rustling of tiles being shifted, followed by a slender bamboo tube sliding through a gap, releasing a wisp of bluish smoke.

Covering their mouths and noses with their collars, the two exchanged a glance in the dim light filtering through the window.

The old window creaked as a shadowy figure slipped inside without a sound.

Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng stood on either side of the bed curtain, silently gesturing about how to silently eliminate the intruder once they approached the bed. But when seven or eight more figures slipped in through the window one after another, all plans went out the window.

The room was small, and the intruders would soon discover them.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips tightly together, discreetly drawing the boning knife she kept hidden on her person.

A black-clad figure swung his blade viciously toward the bed, but the dull resistance as it struck the bedding made his expression change instantly. "It's a trap!"

In the next moment, a chill pierced his abdomen as a figure darted out from behind the bed curtain, lunging headfirst toward the window with a loud crash.

Another black-clad figure, still sliding down a rope from the roof and not yet inside, was sent flying by the sudden impact, serving as a human

cushion as they both crashed into the courtyard, cracking several of the stone tiles beneath them.

The figure quickly scrambled up—revealing herself to be a woman.

Seizing the moment when the black-clad man on the ground was dazed from the fall, she swung a mighty slap at him. The man was knocked unconscious instantly, and the woman quickly snatched his sword before sprinting out of the courtyard.

All of this happened in the blink of an eye. The group of black-clad men inside the room were momentarily stunned before shouting in alarm, "After her!"

Like dumplings dropping into a pot, they leaped out the window in pursuit.

Xie Zheng, hiding on the other side of the bed curtains, hadn't expected Fan Changyu to take such a risk alone. But he soon realized she had deliberately drawn the attackers away to protect him, the elderly couple downstairs, and her younger sister. His heart grew heavy at the thought.

As the last few black-clad men prepared to jump out the window, he flicked a crystal-clear piece of tangerine peel candy from his fingertips.

The man who had just leaped out was struck in the back of the knee, throwing him off balance midair and sending him crashing to the ground.

The remaining men, startled by the commotion behind them, finally realized there was still someone else in the room. They were among the elite of the Martial Assassins, yet they had failed to detect his presence for so long. Just how formidable must his concealment skills be?

Instantly on guard, they turned and slashed at him with their blades.

A few more pieces of tangerine peel candy shot from Xie Zheng's fingers, striking the pressure points on their elbows, knees, and waists, slowing their movements for just a breath—enough time for him to seize a blade and strike.

After dispatching two of them, he pressed the stolen sword against the neck of the injured assassin, who clutched his bleeding side.

The weapon that had sliced his waist was sharp and slender—unlike a dagger—but its exact nature remained unclear. Now with a bloodied blade at his throat, the man dared not move.

Xie Zheng was about to knock him out to keep him alive for questioning and to aid Changyu outside when suddenly, the street beyond the alley erupted in blazing torchlight. The thunder of hooves shattered the night's silence, while the clatter of armor and marching footsteps wove a tightening net. The whistling of arrows sent chills down the spine.

The black-clad men chasing Fan Changyu were riddled with arrows, their bodies turned into sieves.

Xie Zheng frowned slightly, suspicion gnawing at him.

Qingping County had no stationed troops—how had these soldiers arrived so swiftly in this small town?

Seeing that Changyu was now safe, he abandoned the thought of pursuit. Instead, he forced his captive's jaw open with a grip under his chin, making him spit out the poison sac hidden between his teeth. Pressing the blade harder, Xie Zheng demanded coldly, "What did Wei Yan send you to retrieve?"

The assassin, recognizing his familiarity with the Wei family's Martial Assassins and their methods, studied his voice uncertainly. "Marquis?"

The blade pressed deeper. The torchlight streaming through the shattered window reflected off the steel, casting a sharp arc of light across Xie Zheng's face. His slightly downturned lips were icy with impatience. "Answer."

A cold wind carrying snowflakes swept in, dusting the assassin's neck—but far colder than the snow was the blade already nicking his skin.

Fear and pressure surged like a tide. The man swallowed hard, pleading, "The Marquis knows the Prime Minister's methods... Why torment this lowly one—"

The next instant, the blade plunged into the wound on his waist. The assassin let out a muffled scream of agony, curling into himself.

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze, his pale fingers covered in dark scabs twisting the knife handle, almost wrenching a chunk of flesh from the man's abdomen. His tone was indifferent and cold: "The spies in the military have tougher mouths than yours. Zhang Su, the Vice Minister of Justice, once witnessed an interrogation in the army camp. He nearly vomited his bile afterward and fell seriously ill upon returning. Would you like to try the military's methods of punishment?"

Zhang Su, the Vice Minister of Justice, was notorious throughout the court for his brutal interrogation techniques. It was said that those who fell into his hands would either die or be skinned alive, earning him the nickname "Living King of Hell."

The black-clad man couldn't suppress his screams, his forehead drenched in cold sweat. All his senses seemed concentrated on the mangled flesh in his abdomen. Whether his soaked clothes were from blood or sweat, he no longer cared. He no longer sought survival—only a swift death. Exhausted, he gasped, "A letter... The Prime Minister sent us to find a letter..."

Xie Zheng's eyes narrowed slightly. "What letter?"

The man could only shake his head, collapsing to the ground as he pleaded, "I truly don't know..."

A sword flashed across his neck, and the black-clad man fell in a pool of blood.

A letter?

Xie Zheng frowned. What kind of letter in that woman's household could make Wei Yan so fearful?

He glanced out the window at the torch-lit street. The woman stood by the roadside, seemingly explaining the situation to the soldiers. The elderly couple, probably feeling safe now but still worried about Fan Changyu, had taken the child to the courtyard gate to watch.

The soldiers were dragging away the corpses of the black-clad men. A few who weren't completely dead quickly bit into their poison sacs, ending their own lives.

The commander on horseback shouted, "Find a live one to take back!"

Xie Zheng's gaze had initially swept past the man indifferently, but upon recognizing his face, his phoenix eyes narrowed.

Zheng Wenchang?

He was a favored general under He Jingyuan, the Governor of Jizhou—and He Jingyuan was a member of the Wei Faction.

Was tonight's incident a case of friendly fire, or had He Jingyuan also been sent by Wei Yan to intercept that letter, deliberately orchestrating this ambush?

Yet, judging by the black-clad men's actions, they clearly hadn't found what they were looking for. The timely arrival of the Jizhou soldiers was indeed suspicious...

Xie Zheng suddenly realized that this seemingly insignificant butcher's family in Lin'an Town might be hiding far more than he had imagined.

The commander on horseback was directing his subordinates to quickly remove all the black-clad men's corpses when he suddenly felt an icy gaze settle on him—like a wild wolf locking onto its prey in a snowy wasteland. His spine stiffened involuntarily.

Zheng Wenchang scanned his surroundings but found no trace of that chilling stare. Noticing the empty window of the Zhao family's attic, he asked, "Is there someone still upstairs?"

Earlier, Fan Changyu had jumped out of the window to lure out most of the black-clad men, intending to protect Aunt Zhao, her husband, and her younger sister. She had prepared to die, never expecting a troop of soldiers to suddenly appear on the street. They claimed to have been dispatched after receiving a report from the county magistrate about bandit activity in Qingping County. Their scouts had noticed unusual movements at night, leading them to investigate—coincidentally saving her.

Now, faced with the commander's question, she thought of Yan Zheng, who was severely injured upstairs. Worried that any remaining black-clad men might have discovered him, she hurried toward the attic. "My husband is badly wounded and still upstairs."

Instead of sending one of his subordinates, Zheng Wenchang dismounted himself, resting a hand on the sword at his waist as he followed her upstairs. "I'll accompany you to take a look."

Fan Changyu rushed into the attic with a torch, only to find the room littered with the bodies of dead men in black. Xie Zheng also lay in a pool of blood, his clothes slashed in several places, and half of his face covered in blood, making his features nearly unrecognizable.

She hadn't expected so many assailants to remain in the room. Seeing Xie Zheng drenched in blood, her heart clenched with fear that he might be dead. She threw herself beside him to check his injuries. "Yan Zheng, how are you?"

In her panic, she reached out to feel his breath. Only when she confirmed he was still alive did she relax slightly, shouting outside, "Uncle Zhao, come take a look at Yan Zheng!"

Zheng Wenchang, who had entered the attic with two soldiers, swept his gaze over the corpses before fixing his eyes on Xie Zheng's bloodied face, as if trying to recognize something. Frowning, he asked, "Did your husband kill all these men?"

Chapter 26

Fan Changyu had already witnessed Xie Zheng killing people in the pine forest, so she wasn't particularly surprised. She nodded and said, "My husband used to be a security escort. His martial arts are quite decent."

Having grown up, she hadn't seen many security escorts, but her father's martial skills were formidable. Since Xie Zheng claimed to have worked in an Armed Escort Agency before, she naturally assumed that all escorts had decent skills—after all, they had to deal with desperate outlaws who tried to rob the shipments.

Zheng Wenchang stared at Xie Zheng with an inscrutable expression.

Carpenter Zhao had already squeezed into the attic. Seeing the room full of corpses, he let out a startled "Oh!" and felt a chill run down his spine. However, he and his wife had lived through the chaos of war in their younger years.

Back then, entire villages were left empty, and corpses littered the roadside. So he managed to stay relatively calm now. Worried about aggravating Xie Zheng's injuries, he didn't move him recklessly but instead knelt down, took his wrist, and began checking his pulse.

With only half of Xie Zheng's bloodied face visible, Zheng Wenchang suddenly said, "Turn him over and let's take a look."

Carpenter Zhao didn't understand why the military officer would make such a request, but he didn't dare disobey. Considering they were from the army, and the leader—clad in armor with a sword at his waist—had an imposing presence, his rank was likely higher than the county magistrate's. Perhaps he could help Fan Changyu uncover who these enemies were.

He immediately began lamenting, "Sir, you must help us seek justice! This poor girl lost her parents just last month. She barely managed to take in a live-in husband, and now he's been injured like this by these bandits. If we don't find out who they are, how will she survive in the future...?"

Hearing that this man was a live-in husband, Zheng Wenchang's suspicions instantly faded by more than half.

Given that man's temperament, even if he were to fall into dire straits—let alone if the emperor threw him into prison and forced him to marry a princess and become a live-in son-in-law—he would never agree to such terms.

Just then, a soldier downstairs exclaimed, "Sir, there's still a live one here!"

Before Carpenter Zhao could turn Xie Zheng over, Zheng Wenchang felt his earlier suspicions were utterly absurd and lost interest in scrutinizing the man further. Remembering his general's orders, he hurried downstairs, merely instructing two personal guards to drag the corpses from the attic down as well.

Fan Changyu, of course, had no idea how perilous the situation had just been. With soldiers downstairs keeping watch, she wasn't worried about her younger sister or Aunt Zhao's safety. She asked Carpenter Zhao, "Uncle Zhao, how is he?"

After checking the pulse, Carpenter Zhao began doubting himself—had his years as a veterinarian, unused for over a decade, dulled his medical skills? Had he misread the pulse?

The man before him was covered in blood and appeared severely injured, yet his pulse showed no signs of distress at all.

His already wrinkled forehead creased even tighter as he concentrated on checking the pulse again.

His grave expression frightened Fan Changyu, who thought Xie Zheng was beyond saving. She slumped onto a low stool, despondent. "I should have given him the divorce papers earlier and let him go somewhere else to recover. Then he wouldn't have suffered like this..."

Carpenter Zhao checked the pulse once more and found it still steady and stable. Plunged into deep self-doubt, his aged face grew even more solemn as he prepared to examine Xie Zheng's wounds.

At that moment, the man lying on the ground slowly regained consciousness.

Fan Changyu's eyes were faintly red-rimmed. Overwhelmed by the sudden relief of seeing him awake, she couldn't help but break into a wide,

delighted grin. "You're awake!"

Xie Zheng, seeing her reddened eyes and that utterly joyous smile, was momentarily stunned.

Was she nearly crying out of fear that something might happen to me?

The strange feeling in his chest grew heavier.

He lowered his gaze, coughing weakly twice, a few words escaping his bloodstained lips: "I'm fine."

Most of the blood on him belonged to those black-clad men, and the cuts on his clothes were self-inflicted to fake injuries—only shallow wounds breaking the skin.

Although Zheng Wenchang wasn't under his command, they had crossed paths a few times. If Zheng had recognized him tonight, the outcome would have been dire: either he'd be captured and handed over to Wei Yan, or he'd have to kill Zheng and his soldiers before fleeing elsewhere.

Fortunately, he had managed to evade both worst-case scenarios for now.

Despite his reassurances, Fan Changyu and Carpenter Zhao, who had seen him severely injured twice before, were still extremely worried. After helping him lie down on the bed, they fetched wound medicine to dress his injuries.

When his outer robe was removed, Fan Changyu noticed that Xie Zheng's inner garments weren't soaked in blood as before—they even looked cleaner than the outer robe. She found this odd, but before she could dwell on it, Aunt Zhao called her downstairs, saying the officers needed to take her statement.

The man lying on the bed had only wiped away a thin layer of blood from his face. Under the candlelight, the remaining stains took on an eerie beauty. He opened his eyes slightly to look at her, his voice uncharacteristically gentle: "Go ahead."

Fan Changyu thought his unusual softness must be due to his extreme weakness—he looked so frail and pitiable now.

Before leaving, she glanced back at him uneasily: "I'll be back soon."

The dead black-clad men had been dragged and laid side by side by the officers. Hearing the commotion, many neighbors had thrown on clothes

and come out to gawk at the streets filled with soldiers.

After counting the bodies, the officers confirmed that the only survivor was the one Fan Changyu had knocked unconscious with a slap earlier. Having witnessed several of the attackers biting into poison sacs hidden in their teeth to kill themselves, the officers had learned their lesson. Finding this man still alive, they first removed the poison sac from his mouth before binding him tightly and stuffing a cloth into it, making suicide impossible.

Fan Changyu answered the questions from the personal guard of the high-ranking officer honestly—mostly basic details about her household.

Once the questioning ended, the officer told her, "Wait for further notice. Once the interrogation yields results, the authorities will inform you."

After tonight's events, Fan Changyu had seen firsthand how ruthless these people were. Fearing they might return and implicate Aunt Zhao's family, she asked, "Sir, what if these men come back for revenge?"

The officer seemed about to say something impulsively but stopped himself, frowning in thought before replying, "This general will leave a few soldiers to keep watch nearby in secret. They won't withdraw until the interrogation is concluded."

Only then did Fan Changyu feel reassured, showering the officer with effusive praise.

Before leaving, the officer gave her a glance, his expression somewhat inscrutable.

After the soldiers departed, Fan Changyu fetched water from the well at the alley's entrance to wash away the blood in the courtyard and the loft, though a faint metallic scent still lingered.

She considered climbing over the wall to her own home to fetch some incense her mother had once prepared to mask the smell, but recalling the officer's warning about leaving men to monitor the area, she decided against acting rashly.

The old couple from the Zhao family were so frightened that they basically lost all desire to sleep. They rekindled the fire pit in the main hall and sat there with Changning, warming themselves by the fire while sighing from time to time.

Changning was still young and didn't understand what the adults were worrying about. With the danger gone, she carefree turned her attention back to the gyrfalcon locked in the chicken coop—which had practically become its nest by now.

Fan Changyu asked her younger sister, "Ning Niang, are you still sleepy?"

Changning shook her head and pointed at the cage holding the gyrfalcon. "Elder Sister, the falcon is very well-behaved. Can we not lock it up anymore?"

Last time, when she and her brother-in-law were at home, she had playfully opened the chicken coop door out of mischief. Later, when a group of thugs broke in, the large falcon had clawed one of the villains to death.

In her little mind, she thought that if the falcon hadn't been caged, it might have been able to injure the bad guys tonight as well.

As it turned out, the cage wasn't Fan Changyu's doing. Aunt Zhao explained, "The meat hanging over the fire pit was pecked at last night. I was afraid the falcon would steal it, so I locked it up before bed."

Fan Changyu nodded. "I'll have Yan Zheng train it again later."

Mentioning Yan Zheng inevitably reminded her of his injuries. She turned to Carpenter Zhao and asked, "Uncle Zhao, how are his wounds?"

Carpenter Zhao wanted to say that this time, they seemed to be mostly superficial injuries, but he was afraid he might have misdiagnosed them and delayed Yan Zheng's recovery. He sighed and said, "You know I used to treat livestock like pigs, cows, sheep, and horses. When it comes to treating people, it's a bit of a gamble. From what I can see, the injuries don't seem too severe, but to be safe, we should still call a proper physician tomorrow to take a look."

Fan Changyu agreed. When she went upstairs to check on Xie Zheng, she found that the blood on his face had already been wiped clean. He was lying on the bed with his eyes closed, resting.

Hearing footsteps, he opened his eyes as soon as she entered and asked, "How did it go?"

Fan Changyu replied, "These soldiers seem more reliable than the county magistrate. I heard the magistrate sent a petition to the prefecture,

and the officials there, upon learning how rampant the bandits were here, dispatched troops to suppress them. It just so happened they ran into the situation tonight."

Speaking of this, Fan Changyu was somewhat pleased. "The banditry in Jizhou has been a problem for years. It seems the authorities are finally serious about cracking down on those mountain strongholds. The officer said they'd thoroughly investigate these two assassination attempts and even sent soldiers to keep watch over us in secret. You can rest easy these next couple of days and focus on recovering—no need to rush to leave."

Xie Zheng's expression was far from pleased. "Secret surveillance?"

Fan Changyu nodded. "Yes."

Xie Zheng nearly choked on his breath. He had barely managed to conceal his identity for now, and now the Jizhou Prefecture officials were going to have people watching him right under his nose?

Still, the sudden actions of the Jizhou Prefecture were truly baffling to him.

Well, the most dangerous place was also the safest.

He said, "For the next couple of days, keep that falcon upstairs. Don't let it out. That thing is still wild and untamed—if it's not properly trained, it could easily hurt someone."

Fan Changyu exclaimed, "No wonder! Aunt Zhao just mentioned that the falcon stole meat from above the fire pit last night!"

Xie Zheng: "..."

Fan Changyu stood up. "I'll go get it right now!"

Only then did Xie Zheng give a faint "Mm" in response.

By dawn, Zheng Wenchang had already galloped back to Jizhou Prefecture.

Clutching the confession extracted from the black-clad assassin, he strode swiftly through the winding corridors. In the courtyard lined with snow pines, the armored guards recognized him and immediately stepped aside to let him pass.

Zheng Wenchang entered the study and stood respectfully below the desk. Whether from excitement or haste, his voice carried a slight pant as

he spoke: "My lord, as per your orders, this humble general stationed men early at Lin'an Town. Indeed, we captured those responsible for the multiple murders in Qingping County last night, but..."

His hand trembled slightly as he presented the confession: "Please review the confession, my lord."

The man seated at the desk had graying hair and beard, appearing already aware of the black-clad assailants' identities. He spoke calmly: "Wen Chang, you were merely apprehending mountain bandits and thieves. What is there to fear?"

Zheng Wenchang lowered his head: "This humble officer is filled with trepidation."

"Enough, leave the confession here." He Jingyuan set down his brush and looked up. Despite being a military officer, his features bore the refined elegance of a scholar. Understanding his trusted subordinate's concerns, he said: "Pretend you never read this confession. You may leave."

Zheng Wenchang clasped his fists: "As you command."

Just as he turned to leave, a voice called out again: "Were there any injuries in that household?"

After a moment's thought, Zheng Wenchang replied: "The woman had taken in a live-in husband. He was wounded by those men."

He Jingyuan merely nodded in response.

Summoning his courage, Zheng Wenchang ventured: "Does that household have connections to you, my lord?"

"Wen Chang, what did I teach you about being an official?"

This single sentence sent cold sweat breaking out on Zheng Wenchang's back: "This humble officer spoke out of turn."

"Dismissed." He Jingyuan picked up a memorial from his desk and began reading, appearing indifferent to the confession's contents.

Only after Zheng Wenchang had left the study did those aged eyes turn toward the confession. After a moment's hesitation, he finally opened it.

A sigh escaped him after reading its contents.

Rising, he opened a hidden compartment in the bookshelf and retrieved an ornate box, though he didn't open it. Speaking as if to someone unseen, he murmured: "When you entrusted this to me, you must have foreseen this day... wanting me to protect those two children for you..."

Chapter 27

Early in the morning, Fan Changyu went to the market and bought an old hen to bring back for Yan Zheng to nourish himself.

In the alley, she met a familiar face and greeted them warmly as usual, but the person seemed to avoid something, only responding with a word or two reluctantly.

Now, women who were close to the Song family outright rolled their eyes and kept their distance from her as if she were a plague. "She truly is a Star of Doom and Isolation. Her uncle went to her house a few times and ended up dead because of her. Her live-in husband has been sickly and never gets better. Thank goodness the elder sister of the Song family went to check their birthdates for compatibility. Otherwise, if Song Yan had really married her, who knows what misfortune she would have brought upon the Song family!"

Some who had previously been on good terms with the Fan family also subtly distanced themselves upon hearing this.

If before, when the Song family broke off the engagement and claimed she was fated to be a Star of Doom and Isolation, few had taken it seriously, but these past two days, her household had been plagued by misfortune. If the soldiers hadn't arrived in time last night, the elderly couple of the Zhao family might have suffered as well. Naturally, the neighbors were wary.

In the past, Fan Changyu would have retorted immediately, but last night, she had nearly implicated the Zhao family, and Yan Zheng was indeed injured.

She pressed her lips together and silently walked toward the Zhao family's house, carrying the hen she had bought.

As she passed the house of the sharp-tongued woman from earlier, no sooner had she stepped by than the woman flung a basin of rice-washing water outside. Cold droplets splashed onto Fan Changyu's embroidered shoes and skirt.

Fan Changyu stopped in her tracks and lifted her calm eyes to look at the woman.

The old woman, surnamed Kang, had been neighbors with the Song family before. After Song Yan passed the provincial examination, she had gone out of her way to curry favor with them. To please Mother Song, she often visited to chat and spew endless slander about Fan Changyu.

Perhaps because she still had this use of keeping Mother Song entertained, after the Song family moved to the county town, she was the only one in the entire alley who had been invited to dine at their new residence.

Kang Popo took great pride in this and naturally boasted to everyone about how splendid the Song family's new house was, how they even had servants at Mother Song's beck and call, and how capable Song Yan was—all while taking a jab or two at Fan Changyu.

Now, seeing Fan Changyu look her way, Kang Popo flung the remaining half-basin of rice-washing water outside again and cursed, "What awful luck first thing in the morning! I'll have to hang some dried pomelo leaves at the door later!"

Folklore said rice-washing water and pomelo leaves could ward off bad luck.

Fan Changyu's lips parted slightly, but seeing the other neighbors either silent or subtly keeping their distance, she pressed her lips even tighter and quickened her steps toward the Zhao family.

The rice-washing water had soaked her shoes and stockings, the cold dampness clinging to her ankles, seeping from flesh to bone, chilling her heart.

When Fan Changyu entered the Zhao family's courtyard, Aunt Zhao was sweeping snow. Seeing her wet skirt and shoes, she hurriedly asked, "How did this happen?"

Fan Changyu walked straight to the kitchen and said, "The snow on the road hadn't melted completely. I stepped in it and got wet."

Aunt Zhao frowned at Fan Changyu's back, knowing she wasn't telling the truth.

Distraught, Fan Changyu slaughtered the hen and stewed it in an earthenware pot. Afraid Aunt Zhao would press her further, she made an

excuse to take medicine up to Yan Zheng in the loft.

"Time for your medicine."

Her voice lacked its usual vigor, sounding somewhat subdued.

When Xie Zheng took the medicine bowl, he couldn't help but glance at her expression.

Her face showed no obvious signs, but he could still tell something was off with her mood. He asked, "What happened?"

Fan Changyu only said it was nothing: "Drink the medicine while it's hot. There's tangerine peel candy by the pillow if it's too bitter."

She sat hugging her knees on a low stool, warming herself by the charcoal brazier, her head bowed to reveal a slender neck, making it impossible to see the expression on her face.

Xie Zheng noticed the hem of her skirt and her shoes and socks seemed damp. "The snow was heavy in the latter half of the night," he remarked.

Fan Changyu vaguely hummed in agreement.

Xie Zheng frowned slightly. There had been no snow at all in the latter half of the night. She was acting very strangely today.

She remained silent, and after Xie Zheng finished the medicine and placed the bowl on the round stool by the bed, he didn't speak either.

The room was quiet for a long while before Fan Changyu suddenly said, "How about I find you an inn? I'll pay the waiter extra to take care of your daily needs."

Xie Zheng's fingers pressed slightly harder against the edge of the bed as he asked, "Why?"

Fan Changyu replied, "The authorities haven't closed the case yet. I'm afraid those people might come looking for revenge."

Xie Zheng said, "Didn't you say there are soldiers secretly guarding this area?"

After a few moments of silence, Fan Changyu looked up at him and said solemnly, "Then stay here and recover first. Leave once your injuries heal."

After she left the loft, Xie Zheng picked up a piece of tangerine peel candy, his lips pressed tightly together. The candy crumbled instantly into

powder between his fingers.

By noon, when Kang Popo from the alley came to the Song family cursing and demanding an explanation, Xie Zheng finally understood the reason for her odd behavior today.

"Fan Changyu! Come out here!" Kang Popo's voice was loud, her scolding skills second to none.

Her shouting drew a crowd of onlookers outside the Zhao family's gate.

Aunt Zhao hurried to open the door after hearing the pounding that sounded like someone kicking it. Seeing Kang Popo standing there with her grandson, looking furious, she asked, "What's going on?"

Kang Popo shoved her grandson forward and planted her hands on her hips, yelling, "Tell Fan Changyu to come out here! Her sister pushed my Tiger Head down the steps and knocked out one of his front teeth. What do you think is going on?"

Fan Changyu had been stewing chicken in the kitchen. Hearing the commotion outside, she stepped into the courtyard.

She saw Kang Popo's chubby grandson, his eyes swollen from crying, snot dripping from his nose—he'd suck it back in only for it to drip out again the next moment. His chin was swollen, and indeed, one of his front teeth was missing.

She said, "My sister has always been frail, and your grandson is several years older than her. How could she possibly push him?"

Kang Popo, hearing Fan Changyu seemingly trying to deny responsibility, spat out angrily, "You think I'm trying to cheat you? Call your Ning Niang out here and ask her yourself if she did it or not!"

Aunt Zhao, noticing the neighbors peeking out to watch the spectacle, tried to mediate, "Let's talk inside. Kids fight and stumble all the time. Arguing out here just makes us a laughingstock."

Kang Popo refused to budge. "I'm here to get justice for my grandson. Why should I care about being laughed at?"

Fan Changyu knew Kang Popo had a reputation in the alley for being shrewish and difficult. Her daughter-in-law had been driven away by her relentless bullying—to this day, Kang Popo still called her a "shameless

slut" who ran off with another man, never acknowledging how she had treated her like a beast of burden.

Later, her son got involved with a widow, but she despised the widow for having been married before and having a deceased husband, claiming she might bring bad luck to men. After all the fuss, the widow quickly broke things off with her son, who remains a bachelor to this day.

Fan Changyu had no patience to waste words with this woman and said coldly, "Whether you get to demand justice or not, I'll ask my younger sister first."

Fan Changyu called out to Changning, "Ning Niang, come out."

Xiao Changning dawdled out of the house and stood behind Fan Changyu like a little shadow.

Fan Changyu bent down and asked her, "Did you push Hutou?"

Changning pressed her lips together, gripping the hem of her clothes tightly with both hands, nodding at first but then shaking her head.

Kang Popo shrieked, "Look at this! A child this young already knows how to lie—what fine family values the Fan Family has! She nodded just now, and now she's shaking her head..."

"Shut your mouth!" Fan Changyu snapped, her voice like a blizzard instantly drowning out Kang Popo's shrill cries.

Kang Popo had thrown that basin of rice-washing water earlier in the morning, and seeing Fan Changyu remain silent, she had assumed she was easy to bully. Now, suddenly shouted at by Fan Changyu, she froze for a moment before screaming even more shrilly, "Is there no justice left in this world? Everyone, look at this! The Fan Family has such arrogance! They hurt my grandson like this and still act so righteous!"

Upstairs, Xie Zheng found the piercing screeching unbearable, his brows furrowing in irritation.

Are all common folk this noisy?

Just as his annoyance peaked, he heard the woman's cold, sharp voice: "Keep yelling, and see if I won't dunk you headfirst into a slop barrel!"

Fan Changyu's entire demeanor radiated icy fury. She had tolerated Kang Popo that morning out of guilt for the trouble her family's enemies

had caused, but now that Kang Popo was trying to push her luck, she wasn't about to indulge her.

Under Fan Changyu's glare, Kang Popo felt an inexplicable fear. She quickly glanced at the crowd of onlookers, opening her mouth as if to say more, hoping to use the spectators to pressure Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu seemed to have anticipated this tactic and said coldly, "You and that old hag from the Song Family have been gossiping about me behind my back—did you think I didn't know? My reputation is already as bad as you've made it out to be. Did you really think I'd still care what others think? If I really wanted to hit you, how many of these people do you think would step in to stop me?"

This shattered Kang Popo's last shred of defiance. She gulped, her usually unstoppable cursing mouth now seemingly stitched shut, unable to utter another word.

Only then did Fan Changyu crouch down and ask her sister, "Just now, when I asked if you pushed Hutou, why did you nod and then shake your head?"

Changning's large, round eyes, dark as grapes, were already reddening. Her chubby, delicate fingers clutched at her clothes as she said, "I did push him, but he was too heavy—I couldn't move him. He chased after me, slipped, and fell down the steps. That's how he broke his tooth."

Kang Popo immediately started wailing again, "My Hutou said it was you who pushed him—"

Fan Changyu shot her a cold glare, and Kang Popo fell silent once more.

Fan Changyu continued questioning her sister, "Ning Niang, why did you push him?"

Xiao Changning hung her head, and large teardrops instantly rolled from her eyes. "He pulled my hair, stole my pine nut candy, and splashed water on me. He said his grandma had just thrown rice-washing water on Sister this morning to ward off bad luck, and since I'm the sister of the jinx, I needed to be splashed too..."

Upon hearing this, Fan Changyu's face turned icy with fury.

Aunt Zhao's eyes reddened with anger. She had wondered why Fan Changyu's shoes and skirt hem were wet when she returned this morning

—it turned out that wretched old hag had thrown rice-washing water on her.

That rice-washing water was used for exorcising evil spirits during construction. To splash it on Fan Changyu as she passed—how malicious!

Aunt Zhao gnashed her teeth and cursed, "You filthy old crone who won't even have a coffin when you die! If you won't accumulate virtue for yourself, at least do it for your descendants! Aren't you afraid the King of Hell will hook out your tongue when you meet him?"

Kang Popo initially looked guilty, but decades of sharp-tongued habits made her lift her chin defiantly. "How am I not virtuous? Did I kill her parents? Did I kill all those people from her family who died recently? Everyone in this town knows she's a jinx—only you and that old man of yours, with no one to mourn you, would take in that cursed family. Aren't you afraid she'll bring misfortune to you one day? If you ask me, the Fan Family should've been driven out of this alley long ago. Who knows when their enemies will come looking for them again?"

"You—!" Aunt Zhao trembled with rage.

Fan Changyu wiped her sister's tears with her thumb and slowly stood up, her gaze like an icy blade. "If I'm going to bring misfortune, I'll start with you, you old hag!"

She sneered. "You want me to move out of this alley? On what grounds? Because you're a rotten-mouthed gossip? If you're so scared, why don't you move out yourself?"

Kang Popo faltered, pointing at Fan Changyu as she tried to retort, but Fan Changyu continued coldly, "And keep your grandson in check. If he dares lay a finger on my sister again, I'll cut off whichever hand he uses!"

Kang Popo's grandson met Fan Changyu's fierce glare and immediately burst into terrified sobs, snot and tears streaming down his face.

Kang Popo shielded her grandson behind her, blustering weakly, "Bullying a child—what kind of—"

Fan Changyu's lips curled in a cold smile. "Bullying? This isn't bullying."

She cast a frigid glance at the boy's arm. "I can chop through a pork knuckle with one stroke. An arm would be even easier."

The boy instinctively clutched one arm, crying and tugging at Kang Popo. "Grandma, let's go home... I want to go home..."

Seeing her grandson so frightened, Kang Popo was both furious and helpless, not daring to confront Fan Changyu directly.

Grumbling curses, she led her grandson away. As she descended the steps of the Zhao residence, her knee suddenly buckled in pain. With a shriek, she tumbled down the stairs, her chin striking the bottom step. She lay there wailing, unable to get up, her mouth full of blood.

The onlookers in the alley exchanged uneasy glances.

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned too. Instinctively, she glanced up at the Zhao family's attic—just in time to catch a fleeting glimpse of a dark blue robe hem.

After her initial shock, Aunt Zhao quickly exclaimed, "Instant karma! Everyone saw it—Changyu and I didn't even step outside. This old thief fell on her own! This is instant karma!"

Kang Popo, being elderly, lost several teeth from the fall. She sat up on the ground, wailing and pointing at Fan Changyu. "It was her! That jinx must have kicked me!"

The neighbors who had been watching the commotion hadn't seen Fan Changyu lift a finger. Seeing Kang Popo's unreasonable behavior, they couldn't help but chime in, "Enough, Kang Popo. We all saw it—Changyu didn't move an inch. You just slipped and fell on your own!"

Just as Kang Popo was about to argue further, Fan Changyu sneered, "Maybe a ghost pushed you—you've done too many wicked things!"

Older people were more prone to believing in supernatural nonsense.

This sent a shiver down Kang Popo's spine. She had indeed felt something strike the back of her knee before she fell. Recalling Fan Changyu's infamous "Star of Doom and Isolation" fate, her lips trembled as she pointed and shrieked, "It's you! You're the jinx who cursed me!"

Fan Changyu crossed her arms. "If you don't scram now, I might just 'curse' you to death."

Now genuinely terrified, Kang Popo clutched her bloody chin and fled the Zhao Family's gate with her grandson in tow.

"She brought this on herself!"

"Who in this alley hasn't been slandered by her tongue? This is truly retribution!"

The onlookers chuckled and exchanged a few remarks before shaking their heads and dispersing.

Once the courtyard gate closed again, Fan Changyu crouched to meet her sister's gaze and said earnestly, "From now on, if anyone bullies Ning Niang outside, you must tell your elder sister immediately, understand?"

Changning nodded obediently.

Aunt Zhao, recalling Kang Popo's harsh words, couldn't help but shed tears in secret for Fan Changyu.

After comforting Aunt Zhao, Fan Changyu's eyes fell on the tangerine peel candy by the gate. She made an excuse and went upstairs to the loft.

Pushing the door open, she found Xie Zheng no longer in bed but seated on a bamboo chair by the window. Though still somewhat pale, he looked much better than the previous days.

Before she could speak, his gaze swept over her coolly. "What you told me this morning—was it all because of what others said?"

Chapter 28

The window lattice was half-open, the sun hanging in the sky as nothing more than a pale, cold shadow, casting faint golden rays.

Xie Zheng's face was half-lit by the sunlight, the other half hidden in shadow, his eyes calm and unreadable.

Fan Changyu wanted to deny it, but meeting his gaze, she couldn't bring herself to speak. She hugged her knees and sat on a nearby low stool, her voice muffled: "The misfortunes of my family have indeed dragged you in twice now. You owe me nothing. Cutting ties with my family might keep you safer."

Xie Zheng asked her, "Do you believe the nonsense that ignorant old woman spouted?"

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and remained silent.

Of course, she didn't believe it. But with her parents gone, Fan Da killed, Changning and Yan Zheng nearly harmed, and if the soldiers hadn't arrived in time last night, who knew if Aunt Zhao and Carpenter Zhao would have been implicated too?

Perhaps... just as Mother Song and Kang Popo said, she truly was fated to be the Star of Doom and Isolation, bringing misfortune to those close to her.

Seeing her silence, Xie Zheng understood perfectly. His finely arched brows furrowed slightly as he asked, "You think cutting ties with me is for my own good. What about your sister? Will you cut ties with her too?"

Fan Changyu's hands, clasped over her knees, tightened, her heart a tangled mess.

Yes, she could distance herself from the elderly Zhao couple and Yan Zheng to avoid implicating them. But what about Changning?

Changning was only five years old—she was the only family the girl had left in this world.

As she remained silent, Xie Zheng spoke slowly, "What's more terrifying in this world than superstitions about fate and ghosts... is the human heart."

Fan Changyu lifted her almond-shaped eyes, looking somewhat confused.

Xie Zheng's lips curled slightly, his tone laced with mockery: "There aren't so many supernatural phenomena in this world. Even talk of national fortune is just a way to deceive the masses, let alone fate and destiny."

Fan Changyu still didn't understand: "What do you mean?"

Xie Zheng raised his gaze: "Some people, after committing evil, like to hide behind superstitions. Just as you frightened that old woman earlier, saying she fell because she was cursed. She didn't know the truth, so she half-believed it out of fear. But you and I know she fell because she was hit by a pine nut candy."

Fan Changyu lowered her eyes and after a long pause said, "Of course I know the Song family's talk of fate was just an excuse to break off the engagement. But the misfortunes that keep befalling my family are real, and that's what unsettles me."

Xie Zheng said, "Your parents made enemies early on—they didn't offend ghosts or gods. What's there to be unsettled about?"

Fan Changyu stared at him blankly, thinking how sharp-tongued this man was. Yet, the suffocating weight in her chest did ease somewhat.

She sighed, resigning herself: "I understand everything you're saying. I was just upset by those words for a moment. Once this feeling passes, I'll be fine."

Xie Zheng showed no mercy: "If someone makes you upset, teach them a lesson. Venting to me is one thing, but if you distance yourself from this old couple, see if they'll be sad or happy about it."

Fan Changyu hung her head, murmuring, "I'm sorry. I acted impulsively earlier."

Xie Zheng's long lashes cast a graceful arc at the corners of his eyes, his expression finally brightening slightly. "You're not the type to endure insults meekly. Coming back this morning after being splashed with water, instead of retaliating on the spot, you came back to sulk. How impressive."

Fan Changyu was silent for a moment before saying, "I've heard a saying: 'The law does not punish the masses.' It means when many people break the law, the authorities won't punish everyone. Now the entire town fears my 'Star of Doom and Isolation' fate, and gossips about me behind my back. I can teach one person a lesson, but can I teach the whole town?"

Xie Zheng was momentarily stunned. Her words touched a hidden corner of his heart, stirring up some long-buried memories.

Having lost both parents in childhood and living under the Wei Mansion's roof, his path to the present hadn't been smooth either.

He still remembered the taste of having his ribs broken by that man's son, his face pressed into bloody mud by brocade boots.

Through battlefield campaigns, surviving life-and-death situations, exchanging scars and axe wounds for military merits—only to be secretly scorned for tarnishing the Xie family's reputation by serving as Wei Yan's lackey.

He lifted his eyes slightly, thin lips parting with a few words: "Then have you heard another phrase—'Kill the chicken to scare the monkey'?"

"Human nature is inherently evil. If you're weak and easily bullied, no matter how kind you are, few will lend a hand. If you rise to power, even if you commit heinous acts, crowds will flock to flatter you. Isn't that what your former fiancé did?"

Listening to this, Fan Changyu fell silent again, hugging her knees as she stared at the burning coals in the iron basin without a word.

Xie Zheng's fingers, lightly tapping the bamboo chair armrest, paused. His eyes narrowed slightly, his tone carrying an unconscious sharpness: "Still not over your ex-fiancé? Does mentioning him upset you?"

Changyu looked up and glared at him, momentarily baffled before remembering how she'd previously claimed—to avoid his misunderstanding about her intentions—that she hadn't gotten over Song Yan.

Lies indeed come with consequences.

She opened her mouth, finally sighing: "I am a bit upset. He earned an official rank—the only provincial graduate from Qingping County this year. Even the magistrate fawns over him. Can't blame others for currying favor. He truly has risen in the world—what can I compare with him?"

Xie Zheng scoffed lightly: "Just a provincial graduate. In Great Yin's capital and seventeen prefectures, how many graduate yearly? What's so remarkable about your ex?"

Changyu couldn't help glancing at him: "You can say such things before me, but don't speak like this to others—you'll be laughed at."

Xie Zheng frowned: "Laughed at for what?"

Changyu found his lack of self-awareness exasperating: "You don't even have a licentiate's degree, yet you talk like this about someone who passed the provincial exams..."

She paused, then added: "I know you're saying this to cheer me up."

Feeling this sounded overly sentimental, she scratched her head: "Actually, I was just speaking casually—it doesn't truly upset me. Life is what we make it. His success is his business—what's it to me? Those who fawn over power and kick me down gain nothing from the Song family by gossiping—they're just idle chatterboxes."

Xie Zheng looked strangely at her: "Why would I cheer you up? A provincial graduate truly means nothing."

Changyu choked: "What, are you some high official yourself?"

Xie Zheng shut his mouth and said no more.

Fan Changyu found it amusing and, recalling his ability to read and write, even compose Eight-legged essays, began planning for him: "I think you're quite clever, and your handwriting is beautiful. With your injuries recurring like this, the physician said if they don't heal properly, there's an eighty percent chance of lasting complications. Escorting goods is so dangerous—why don't you study for the Imperial exam instead? You might even pass as a provincial graduate and land an official position someday!"

Xie Zheng: "...My ambitions don't lie in the officialdom."

Fan Changyu sighed: "What a shame."

She joked half-heartedly: "If you ever get the chance to become an official, and your rank surpasses that Song fellow's, I'll be counting on you to make life difficult for him!"

Xie Zheng's brows lifted almost imperceptibly as he replied, "Alright."

With this banter, the earlier tension dissipated completely.

Remembering the chicken soup she had simmering, Fan Changyu said, "I've got a pot of chicken soup on the stove—it should be ready by now. I'll go fetch you a bowl."

As she stood up, she noticed the candy packets by his bed had flattened. Wincing, she added, "I'll find you some pebbles instead. Don't use candy to hit people anymore—it's expensive! What a waste!"

After she went downstairs, Xie Zheng stared at the empty candy wrappers, frowning.

He disliked sweets, and his daily needs had always been managed by his personal guards. He truly hadn't known how costly these treats were.

Given how tight her finances were, yet she still bought them for him—was it simply because she'd misunderstood that day, thinking he feared the bitterness of medicine?

Closing his eyes, Xie Zheng felt a complicated mix of emotions.

Two days later, Zheng Wenchang arrived in the small town of Lin'an with government troops once more.

Upon hearing the news, Fan Changyu went to her doorstep to greet them.

Zheng Wenchang, seated high on his horse, announced, "The recent violent incidents in town have been investigated—they were indeed the work of mountain bandits."

Fan Changyu's heart skipped a beat at this answer. She said, "But my home was invaded twice..."

Zheng Wenchang cut her off: "The attacks on your home were linked to an armed escort your father handled years ago. Rumor has it he was transporting a Treasure Map from the former imperial family. Over a decade ago, everyone in the Armed Escort Agency was slaughtered by those seeking the map. Your father barely escaped and lived quietly after returning home. Recently, with the unrest in Chongzhou, talk of the Treasure Map resurfaced. Bandits traced your father's whereabouts and came searching for it."

This explanation did account for the strange events in Lin'an. Fan Changyu asked, "Were my parents also killed by those bandits?"

Zheng Wenchang frowned slightly, avoiding her gaze as he replied, "Naturally."

Learning the true cause of her parents' deaths weighed heavily on her. She realized now why her father had taught her martial arts yet forbade her from displaying it—he must have feared attracting these very criminals.

She said, "I've never heard my parents mention anything about a Treasure Map. Could there be some misunderstanding?"

Zheng Wenchang answered, "The claim that the map was in your father's possession was false. Days ago, rebels in Chongzhou announced they'd obtained it. The bandits won't return to this town—you can rest assured."

With that, he made a gesture, and a subordinate stepped forward holding a tray with silver ingots. His gaze toward Fan Changyu carried a hint of something imperceptibly unusual: "Lord He, the Governor of Jizhou, sympathizes with the people's plight and has specially ordered this official to deliver fifty taels of consolation silver."

Fan Changyu expressed her sincere gratitude.

The neighbors also praised, "Lord He is truly the just official of Jizhou Prefecture! Those families who suffered at the hands of the mountain bandits and lost loved ones have all received consolation silver from the authorities."

Someone asked, "Why did I hear that other families only received twenty-five taels, while Fan Er's family got fifty?"

Immediately, someone replied, "Those families only lost one person. Both Fan Er and his wife were killed, so naturally, they received more silver."

...

With the case now closed, the official seals on the Fan Family's gate were removed.

Fan Changyu thoroughly cleaned every corner of the house, especially the courtyard and rooms where blood had been spilled. She not only washed them several times with water but also sprinkled them with water boiled with pomelo leaves, believing it could ward off evil spirits and misfortune.

Only after putting everything in order did Fan Changyu bring Changning and Xie Zheng back from the neighbor's house.

She lit a stick of incense and placed it before her parents' memorial tablets, her eyes slightly reddened: "Father, Mother, may you rest in peace."

Only Xie Zheng remained frowning.

He already knew those men were Wei Family's Martial Assassins—they couldn't possibly be the mountain bandits Zheng Wenchang had spoken of, and what they were searching for was certainly not some damned Treasure Map.

Yet the authorities had gone to great lengths to fabricate a plausible lie to close the case and even distributed silver to the affected families. They had indeed put considerable effort into this.

Xie Zheng couldn't make sense of it.

If He Jingyuan also wanted to obtain that letter for Wei Yan, he should have sent troops to seal off the Fan Family's residence and conduct a thorough search.

Instead, he returned the house to Fan Changyu and went through all this trouble to settle the murder cases, almost as if he didn't want to disrupt her family's original life and wished for her to remain in this town.

What was He Jingyuan's intention?

Or was it because the letter the Wei Family's Martial Assassins were searching for was no longer in the Fan Family's possession?

Xie Zheng looked at the two memorial tablets on the altar. He Jingyuan must know the true identities of this couple—perhaps he also knew the secret of that letter?

Chapter 29

With those black-clad assassins who could come demanding her life at any moment gone, Fan Changyu no longer needed to hastily sell off her belongings and flee Lin'an Town.

She had even managed to secure a long-term deal with the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. After reopening her butcher shop, the braised meat business flourished more than ever under the pavilion's endorsement, gradually overshadowing even the Wang family's shop.

The day before New Year's Eve, as she was returning home from the shop, she spotted a rather luxurious carriage parked at the entrance of the alley. Assuming it belonged to the Song family mother and son who had returned, she entered the alley only to find a crowd gathered in front of her own house.

Fan Changyu thought something had happened at home again and pushed through the crowd. "Excuse me, excuse me..."

A neighbor asked, "Changyu, do you have some wealthy relatives?"

Puzzled, she replied, "No, I don't."

The neighbor pressed, "Could it be your husband's family? That carriage at the alley entrance looks even grander than the one the Song family used when they moved!"

Only then did Fan Changyu realize the carriage owner was here for her household.

Someone nearby chimed in, "That carriage the Song family used wasn't even theirs—they rented it from a carriage service!"

The tone had already taken on a hint of disdain toward the Song family.

Kang Popo, standing at her own doorstep with a gap-toothed grin, sneered, "Bunch of bootlickers! Just wait until Young Master Yan passes the imperial exams and becomes a top scholar—he'll have carriages to spare!"

Still confused, Fan Changyu ignored the neighbors' nosy questions and entered her house, shutting the courtyard gate behind her. Only then did she see a nobleman in embroidered robes and a jade belt seated at the square table in the main room.

When he noticed her, he nodded with a polite smile. Unsure of his identity, Fan Changyu simply mirrored his gesture.

"It's getting late, so I won't disturb Master Yan and his wife any longer," he said, rising to bow to Xie Zheng. Turning to Fan Changyu, his smile deepened slightly.

Xie Zheng sat on the other side of the table, his expression indifferent. Though dressed in plain cotton clothes, his bearing subtly overshadowed the nobleman's. "Take care. I won't see you out."

Knowing Yan Zheng's usual brusque demeanor, Fan Changyu still made a token effort to escort the guest to the gate, even though Xie Zheng remained seated.

Once she shut the gate again, blocking the prying eyes of the neighbors, she asked Xie Zheng, "Who was that?"

Xie Zheng replied, "The owner of the town's bookstore."

Fan Changyu picked up the teapot on the table to pour herself some water. "I thought the bookstore owner was a bearded old man?"

Xie Zheng said, "That's the shopkeeper. The real owner has always lived in Jizhou's main city."

When Zhao Xun had come looking for him last time, the alley's residents had all been out working and hadn't noticed. But today, with everyone home for the New Year, word had spread like wildfire, causing quite the stir.

As she poured the tea, Fan Changyu realized it was cold. She took a sip anyway, then glanced at the half-drunk cup left by the nobleman's seat. She couldn't help but remark, "You served your guest cold tea?"

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze to her, and she clearly read the unspoken "So what?" in his eyes. She was momentarily speechless.

Noticing the packet of tangerine peel candy she had bought again, Xie Zheng pushed a red-paper-wrapped bundle toward her. "I earned some silver writing eight-legged essays. Keep it."

Fan Changyu unwrapped the red paper, her almond-shaped eyes widening in astonishment—inside were four silver ingots!

Before she started selling braised meat, her butcher shop wouldn't have earned this much in an entire month!

Stunned, she blurted out, "Is writing eight-legged essays really this profitable?"

Xie Zheng took a sip from his coarse porcelain cup, his fingers—now free of dark scabs—slender and well-defined like bamboo joints. "The previous essays sold well, so the bookstore gave me a share of the profits. These forty taels also include an advance for the next batch."

Indeed, the essays he had authored had stirred up quite a storm in the capital. Though Zhao Xun was merely a merchant, he had the shrewdness to protect his family's business amidst fierce competition. While mass-printing the essays across various prefectures to sell to scholars, he had also concealed their true origin.

During the days the Fan family was in trouble, Zhao Xun's uncle had been combing through every bookstore in search of the source. Had he succeeded, the number of martial assassins sent to this small town would have at least doubled.

This silver wasn't given by Zhao Xun purely to curry favor—those essays alone were worth a fortune if sold openly.

All the bookstores under the Zhao family's name had already made a hefty profit from reprinting his essays.

To avoid raising her suspicions, Xie Zheng had deliberately asked for only forty taels. Yet even that seemed excessive to her.

Fan Changyu glanced at the gleaming silver ingots, then at Xie Zheng. "Did the bookstore owner seek you out specifically because he admired your essays?"

Xie Zheng nodded. "With the war in Chongzhou still unresolved and the court embroiled in factional strife, my firsthand account of the turmoil there—though rudimentary—stands out from what other scholars have written. That's why they sell well."

Noticing that Fan Changyu had fallen silent instead of rejoicing at the sight of the silver, he unconsciously furrowed his brows.

The next moment, she spoke. "You don't have to lie to me. I already know."

Xie Zheng's fingers tightened slightly around the cup. "Know what?"

She met his gaze. "For the bookstore owner to value you so highly, your literary talent must be exceptional. You must have studied extensively before. Were you afraid I'd resent you because my former fiancé abandoned me after passing the imperial exams? Is that why you kept pretending to be mediocre?"

Hearing this, the tension in his fingers eased slightly.

Before he could respond, Fan Changyu frowned and continued, "I'm not as petty as you think. There are countless scholars in this world—just because my ex-fiancé was heartless doesn't mean all of them are. I understand that much. You didn't need to worry about such things."

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes. "My apologies."

Fan Changyu waved it off. She had once hidden her martial skills from the neighbors too. This was his own ability—whether he told her or not didn't harm her interests, so she had no reason to mind.

Instead, she asked curiously, "If you've studied so much, why didn't you take the imperial exams? Why become an escort instead?"

Xie Zheng replied, "What I want to do cannot be achieved through scholarship."

Having spent nearly a month together, this was the first time Fan Changyu had inquired about his past. Now that the conversation had reached this point, she pressed further. "What is it you want to do?"

The wind passing through the corridor lifted a stray lock of hair by Xie Zheng's temple. He gazed at the thick layer of snow on the courtyard walls and the misty horizon, his eyes turning deep and inscrutable. "Just like how you want to continue running your father's butcher shop, there are things my father left unfinished that I wish to complete for him."

Fan Changyu pondered for a while before her eyes widened in surprise. "Don't tell me your family runs an Armed Escort Agency?"

Those who worked as escorts were often people with hard lives—who else would risk their lives for mere silver?

Considering his good education, exceptional martial skills, and experience as an escort, Fan Changyu could only conclude that he must be the young master of an Armed Escort Agency.

After a brief hesitation, Xie Zheng nodded.

Fan Changyu suddenly understood. "No wonder you've always said you'd leave once your injuries healed."

She pushed the forty taels of silver back toward him. "Keep this money for yourself. Rebuilding a Armed Escort Agency must cost a fortune! When the time comes for you to leave, I'll see if I can spare some extra silver for you."

This wasn't the first time Xie Zheng had heard her mention their eventual parting. Aside from the gruesome-looking but superficial wounds, his internal injuries had mostly healed. Zhao Xun's visit today was to inform him that two hundred thousand dan of grain had already been purchased.

Indeed, he would be leaving soon.

Hearing her speak of it again stirred an inexplicable emotion in his chest.

He pressed a hand on one of the silver ingots, stopping her from pushing it back, his tone firm. "This is for you—payment for the medicine."

Fan Changyu still refused. "When you agreed to the sham marriage, we agreed that I'd treat your injuries. How can I take your money now? That would make me untrustworthy. And you've been writing eight-legged essays despite your injuries, braving the cold wind—earning this silver couldn't have been easy..."

His grip on the ingot didn't loosen in the slightest as his dark eyes fixed on her. "Then consider it payment for candy."

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned before realizing he meant the money she had spent buying him sweets. She replied honestly, "But buying candy doesn't cost this much..."

"Then keep it for now. You can buy more later."

"Even if I keep buying until your injuries heal and you leave, it still wouldn't cost this much..."

Halfway through her sentence, Fan Changyu suddenly fell silent.

"Buy more later"—did that mean they still had a future together?

A crackling sound erupted from the fire pit as sparks flew, finally breaking the silence in the room.

His response remained unchanged. "Keep it."

Fan Changyu avoided his gaze, staring instead at the hand pressing down on the silver ingot before asking, "What kind of candy do you like?"

Hearing her question, Xie Zheng withdrew his hand. "You choose."

That night, as Fan Changyu lay in bed, she found herself staring at the canopy above, unable to sleep—something unusual for her, as she normally slept soundly.

Though she was carefree by nature, she wasn't completely oblivious.

Yan Zheng might have a temper and a sharp tongue, but he had a good heart. Otherwise, he wouldn't have risked his life to save Changning when the bandits attacked.

He was handsome, literate, and possessed exceptional martial skills.

She had always treated him as a passing guest, knowing he would eventually leave.

But today, he had given her such a large sum of silver and asked her to keep buying him candy in the future?

Fan Changyu suddenly felt a strange fluttering in her chest.

Tossing and turning like a pancake on a griddle, she only managed to drift into a fitful sleep as dawn approached.

The next day, as expected, she woke up late, with faint dark circles under her eyes.

Fortunately, the butcher shop remained closed during New Year's Eve and the first day of the lunar year, so sleeping in didn't matter.

Fan Changyu yawned as she got up to make tangyuan. Outside the alley, children were playing with firecrackers, and the entire town was immersed in the peaceful atmosphere of the New Year.

Yet in Chongzhou, just a province away, a devastating defeat had just taken place—

The capital.

The streets were adorned with festive lanterns, brimming with New Year's cheer.

An urgent military dispatch, marked for eight-hundred-li delivery, passed through Yongding Gate—but instead of being sent to the imperial palace, it was diverted to the residence of Chancellor Wei.

The courier's horse galloped swiftly through the snow-laden path, flanked by frost-covered elms and poplars.

The entrance to Wei Mansion was heavily guarded. Two stone lions, clutching treasure orbs in their claws, glared ferociously. Armored sentries stood in a goose-wing formation, while snow piled atop the walls. Even sparrows avoided perching on the withered branches here.

The courier tumbled off his horse and retrieved the dispatch from his chest, raising it high above his head. "Urgent report from Chongzhou!"

The guards at the gate paled, snatched the dispatch, and hurried inside. After passing it to a soldier within the mansion, the soldier rushed to the study, presenting it with both hands. "My lord, urgent report from Chongzhou!"

Moments later, an attendant emerged from the study to retrieve the dispatch.

The entire process was tightly controlled and efficient—this was how all reports delivered daily to Chancellor Wei's study were handled.

The attendant closed the study doors behind him, moving soundlessly as he presented the dispatch to the long-bearded elder reviewing memorials behind a redwood desk. "Chancellor, an eight-hundred-li urgent dispatch from Chongzhou."

A sinewy, gnarled hand took the dispatch. After reading it, the chancellor slammed it onto the desk. "I should have known that rebellious fool couldn't stabilize the situation in Chongzhou! How long has it been since the autumn harvest? Why hasn't any grain been collected from the entire northwest?"

The attendant dared not respond.

The elder stood—not in luxurious robes, but in plain cloth garments—and clasped his hands behind his back, gazing at the heavy snowfall outside. His phoenix eyes were narrow and sharp, his posture upright. This

was Wei Yan, the chancellor of Great Yin who had controlled the court for over a decade.

After a brief pause, he said, "Summon that rebellious fool back here. Send He Jingyuan to stabilize Chongzhou's front."

He had once wielded two most reliable blades—one was the nephew he had raised himself, the other was He Jingyuan. His own son, Wei Xuan, was nothing more than an arrogant fool with ambition but no substance.

The attendant acknowledged the order and was about to withdraw when the chancellor—who had ruled in the emperor's name for over a decade—asked, "Has Wu'an Marquis's body been found?"

The attendant shook his head. "Not yet."

Wei Yan sighed heavily. "That child carried the Wei bloodline. His temperament and methods were the most like mine... What a pity."

Having served Wei Yan for years, the attendant could somewhat discern his thoughts. Recalling how much more the chancellor had favored Wu'an Marquis over his eldest son, Wei Xuan, he ventured, "Perhaps the Marquis was merely misled by those treacherous villains. You raised him for sixteen years—though not father and son in name, you were closer than kin. The claims that you orchestrated the deaths of Crown Prince Chengde and General Xie are baseless. Where is the evidence? The Marquis never even saw proof. There must still be room for reconciliation. Why must you—"

Mid-sentence, the attendant abruptly fell silent. Meeting Wei Yan's icy, piercing gaze, he hastily slapped himself hard across the face. "This old servant spoke out of turn!"

Wei Yan, however, said, "He will find out one day. He's already grown suspicious. If we don't deal with him while he's unprepared, the Wei family will be the ones at his mercy in the future."

The attendant was stunned at first, then replied, "The Prime Minister is the pillar of the state. Even the Marquis couldn't touch you, let alone now that the Marquis is no longer with us."

Wei Yan closed his eyes and remained silent.

When he turned and sat back down behind his desk, the trace of melancholy on his face had vanished. He asked, "Has the item I sent someone to retrieve from Jizhou been brought back?"

The attendant lowered his voice. "The Martial Assassins of the Xuan unit have yet to send any word."

Wei Yan's expression sharpened abruptly. "What about He Jingyuan?"

The attendant answered, "The spy planted near He Jingyuan previously reported that He Jingyuan seems unaware of the item's existence."

Just then, another announcement came from outside the study: "My lord, the Governor of Jizhou has sent a brocade box by urgent courier."

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The attendant immediately observed Wei Yan's expression with great caution.

He said in a deep voice, "Bring it here."

Only then did the attendant go to the study door and carefully carry the brocade box to the desk.

Wei Yan's aged yet still sharp phoenix eyes scrutinized the brocade box before him. The box clearly had some years on it, with the embroidered fabric covering it already yellowed.

He unlocked it and opened the box. Upon seeing its contents, his eyes instantly darkened with gloom.

Noticing the change in his expression, the attendant hurriedly glanced at the items inside and exclaimed in shock, "Did... did He Jingyuan see this letter?"

Inside the brocade box lay a letter and a black iron token.

Wei Yan picked up the letter. The envelope appeared old, but its seal remained intact, and there was no sender's name on it. It seemed as though someone had placed its contents in a new envelope long ago.

In a low voice, he said, "He didn't dare open it."

He tore open the envelope, revealing another letter inside that had already been opened. Both the letter paper and its cover had yellowed with age, stained with dried blood that had oxidized into a pale yellow hue.

On the cover were bold, powerful characters reading: "To Meng Shuyuan, for his eyes only."

Wei Yan had held the emperor hostage to command the nobles for many years. Though criticized in court, his calligraphy was still ranked among the great masters of the era. Anyone who had seen his handwriting could recognize the characters on the envelope as his own.

Upon reading the letter inside, Wei Yan's icy expression softened slightly, though his eyes remained as sharp as an eagle's. "Why did the item I sent the Black-ranked assassin to retrieve end up in He Jingyuan's hands?"

The attendant bowed his head, sweat dripping. "This old servant will order an investigation at once."

But Wei Yan waved his hand, signaling it wasn't necessary. He noticed a memorial from Jizhou had been delivered along with the brocade box. After reading it, he tossed it onto the desk and said, "He's pleading for me to spare the two daughters of that traitor."

Having served Wei Yan for years, the attendant was adept at reading minds. A glance at He Jingyuan's memorial—which mentioned bandits attacking Qingping County, killing many innocent families, and the outlaws being executed—made the meaning behind Wei Yan's words clear.

He Jingyuan had retrieved what Wei Yan wanted and now hoped Wei Yan would cease his pursuit and spare the two girls.

The attendant's eyes flickered slightly. "General He likely acted out of old camaraderie. When you tested his loyalty by ordering him to kill those two, he complied without hesitation. It seems his loyalty to you remains steadfast—this is merely a moment of misplaced mercy."

Wei Yan sneered. "Do you think he obtained this item long ago, or is it truly as he claims in his memorial—that he mistook the Black-ranked assassin for bandits during the Qingping County operation and only then learned I was searching for this?"

The attendant weighed his words carefully. "After you ordered him to kill those two, didn't you send people to keep watch? He Jingyuan appears unaware of this item, so it must be the latter."

Wei Yan's voice turned icy. "Better to kill a thousand by mistake than let one escape. Though he didn't open the letter, the fact that he used it to plead for the traitor's daughters means he must have guessed its significance."

The attendant ventured cautiously, "Do you mean to... deal with him as you did with the Marquis?"

He made a throat-slitting gesture.

Wei Yan stared at the memorial on the desk, pondering for a long time before finally shaking his head: "It's been over sixteen years since the Battle of Jinzhou, yet just months ago, the deaths of Crown Prince Chengde and Xie Linshan suddenly resurfaced among the populace. Zheng'er's investigation into the records of that battle must have been guided by someone with ulterior motives. The mastermind hasn't even shown themselves, yet they've already forced me to break the finest blade in my hand."

At this point, Wei Yan's tone turned sharp: "Now the Chongzhou battlefield is at a stalemate—perhaps that same mastermind is pulling strings behind the scenes. If we lose He Jingyuan as another blade, we might as well hand over the entire southwest region. That traitor at least had the sense not to tell his two daughters anything about the past. Two young girls pose no threat; let them live for now."

An attendant praised: "The Prime Minister is wise."

Though inwardly, he understood that Wei Yan had spared He Jingyuan's life only because He Jingyuan, despite knowing the truth about the Battle of Jinzhou, could still be of use. As for the traitor who had betrayed him, he only left behind two daughters—what could women do about revenge? There was no need to worry about future repercussions.

But Xie Zheng was different. The murder of one's father was an unforgivable enmity.

That was why the man before him had struck first, setting a trap in the Chongzhou campaign to ensure that Great Yin's young war god, who had earned his marquis title through military exploits, would fall there.

Wei Yan ignored the attendant's flattery. With a final glance at the yellowed letter that had endured sixteen years, he tossed it into the brazier beside the desk.

The glowing silver charcoal instantly burned a large hole in the letter. As the dark brown hole expanded, the entire page was gradually consumed by flames. The weapons and bloodshed of sixteen years ago seemed to turn to ash in that fire, ensuring no one would ever know the truth of what had happened.

The firelight reflected in Wei Yan's eyes as he said gravely: "Let He Jingyuan handle the Chongzhou campaign for now. Whoever is trying to drag the Battle of Jinzhou back into the light after sixteen years won't stop."

Send the Earth-ranked Martial Assassins to keep a close watch. If there's any further movement, I want that rat stirring up trouble in the shadows brought before me!"

The attendant ventured: "Could it be Grand Tutor Li's faction..."

Wei Yan shook his head, his aged face exuding the calm of a mountain overlooking an abyss: "If that old fool had caught even a whiff of the truth about the Battle of Jinzhou, he wouldn't have waited sixteen years to bring it up again."

He continued slowly: "After Crown Prince Chengde died in battle, the Eastern Palace caught fire. Both the Crown Princess and the imperial grandson perished in the flames. The Crown Princess's face was at least half recognizable, but the imperial grandson was burned to a shriveled corpse. Let us hope that the one who died back then was truly the imperial grandson."

The attendant, understanding the implication, broke into a cold sweat and said: "Whoever died alongside the Crown Princess must have been the imperial grandson. Aside from the imperial grandson, what young boy could have been in the Eastern Palace?"

Wei Yan merely replied: "Let us hope so."

Jizhou.

It should have been New Year's Eve, but with the imperial army's defeat in Chongzhou—and Jizhou bordering Chongzhou—every official in Jizhou Prefecture ranked seventh grade or higher was summoned to the prefectural office to discuss countermeasures instead of enjoying the holiday.

A dispatch was delivered to He Jingyuan's desk. After reading it, he sighed: "The Prime Minister's eldest son seems to think the flames in Chongzhou aren't burning fiercely enough!"

Zheng Wenchang, standing below, asked: "What does the General mean by that?"

He Jingyuan handed the document bearing the seal of the Northwest Military Governor to his subordinate. As the officials in the study passed it around, murmurs of discussion arose.

Zheng Wenchang fumed, "Across the entire Great Yin dynasty, with its capital and seventeen prefectures, the northwest holds four. Chongzhou

has already rebelled, leaving only Huizhou, Jizhou, and Taizhou. Huizhou is a military garrison, and the court has long strictly prohibited garrisoned areas from stockpiling grain or farming to weaken the Military Governors' power. Now, the entire northwest has only Jizhou and Taizhou left to supply grain. Yet Wei Xuan demands that each of our two prefectures requisition a hundred thousand dan of grain within three days. Isn't this asking the impossible?"

Another official added, "I heard Taizhou couldn't meet the requisition. Yesterday, the Military Governor sent troops to forcibly seize grain—even the seeds farmers had saved were taken by the soldiers! Forget spring planting next year; if the people don't starve this harsh winter, it'll be a miracle!"

"Those soldiers under Wei Xuan's command don't treat the people as human. I heard they even beat to death several farmers who refused to hand over their grain. This hasn't spread yet, but once it does, the Wei family's infamy will grow even worse!"

He Jingyuan listened silently as the prefectural officials bickered below. Only when their arguments grew heated did he finally ask, "Why has the northwest failed to meet the grain requisition this year?"

The provisions for the hundred thousand troops at the Huizhou garrison had always been supplied by the court. However, the war in Chongzhou had disrupted the Grain Supply Line, delaying the delivery.

Had the Chongzhou conflict ended sooner, things wouldn't have come to this. But the Great Yin's God of War, the Wu'an Marquis, had already fallen there, dealing a devastating blow to the army's morale.

The newly appointed Military Governor, Wei Xuan, was an ambitious glory-seeker. To quickly consolidate control over Huizhou's hundred thousand troops, he demoted or transferred the Wu'an Marquis' most capable generals.

The men he brought with him were utterly unfamiliar with the northwest's military situation. Suffering repeated defeats, morale plummeted further, stretching the front lines and exhausting Huizhou's remaining provisions.

With Huizhou in crisis, the other three prefectures in the western region should have been able to provide emergency supplies. Even now, with only two prefectures left, it shouldn't be impossible to requisition some grain.

Zheng Wenchang, who had been as explosive as a firecracker, clasped his fists and said, "I've had it investigated. Not long ago, a merchant surnamed Zhao purchased large quantities of grain at high prices in Jizhou and Taizhou. The people only kept seeds for spring planting and coarse grains for their own consumption—everything else was sold for silver to celebrate the New Year."

He Jingyuan said, "Look into this merchant surnamed Zhao."

Zheng Wenchang acknowledged the order.

He Jingyuan continued, "Today is New Year's Eve. Let's adjourn the meeting early. Everyone should return home."

The officials, who had been grim-faced, brightened at his words but suppressed their relief, bowing properly before filing out.

Only Zheng Wenchang remained, his brow furrowed.

The hall emptied, leaving him standing alone.

He Jingyuan rose from behind his desk and, seeing him still there, asked, "Why haven't you gone home?"

Wen Chang worriedly said, "My lord, Wei Xuan has explicitly demanded that our Jizhou Prefecture produce a hundred thousand dan of grain within three days. What if we can't deliver by then?"

He Jingyuan replied, "Didn't I just instruct you to investigate that merchant surnamed Zhao?"

Zheng Wenchang fell silent. The merchant had been buying grain for some time. Even if they found him, if the grain had already been sold elsewhere, it would be too late to help.

He Jingyuan suddenly paused and looked at the young man before him, his gaze gentle yet firm. "Do you want me to follow Wei Xuan's example and send men to seize grain from the people?"

Zheng Wenchang hurriedly expressed his humility, though his face still showed hesitation: "But... how will you explain this to the Wei family?"

He Jingyuan replied, "There are always ways, but those ways don't involve holding a knife to the people's throats. Wen Chang, it doesn't matter what the court officials and scholars call our faction. What matters is that we know in our hearts that we serve as officials for the people of Great Yin."

Zheng Wenchang bowed his head in shame. "This humble official has learned much."

He Jingyuan said no more.

Outside, snowflakes as large as goose feathers were falling. As he stepped out of the study, his thoughts turned to what he had sent to the capital after learning of the defeat in Chongzhou. Wei Yan must have seen it by now.

If the transfer orders from the capital arrived before Wei Xuan made his move, then Wei Xuan would no longer be a threat.

Wei Xuan's current rush to collect grain was likely driven by fear of Wei Yan's reprimand, hence his eagerness to achieve quick results.

With no one left in the northwest, Wei Yan could only rely on him. By taking a risk to secure the lives of those two sisters, it might just work.

This was all he could do.

Hearing the distant sound of firecrackers from the streets, a complex and melancholic emotion flickered in He Jingyuan's eyes. "During the New Year, we must offer sacrifices to those who have passed. There's an old friend of mine—no one remembers to burn ghost money for him anymore. I cannot face him, Wen Chang. Come with me outside the city to burn some ghost money for my old friend."

Zheng Wenchang assented.

A carriage left the main city of Jizhou and stopped at a hillside.

The mountain wind howled as He Jingyuan personally lit incense, bowed three times toward the north, and then planted it in the earth. He then stepped aside, allowing Zheng Wenchang to burn all the ghost money there.

The wind whipped the flames, scattering the unburned ghost money everywhere. The white snow mingled with the pale ghost money, creating an inexplicably desolate scene.

As Zheng Wenchang finished the offerings and descended the slope, he saw He Jingyuan standing with his back to the hill, his expression sorrowful.

On the way back, Zheng Wenchang couldn't resist asking, "My lord, you are always so magnanimous. Why do you say you cannot face your old

friend?"

He Jingyuan sat with his eyes closed in the carriage, as if resting, and answered simply, "In these times, there are things one must do, however reluctantly."

Ling'an Town.

The melted snow on the ground was littered with waterlogged ghost money.

When the wind blew hard, many pieces of ghost money were swept into the air.

The thawed paths were difficult to traverse, muddy and slippery. Fan Changyu carried Changning as they walked along the field ridges, while Xie Zheng followed behind, expressionlessly carrying a bamboo basket filled to the brim with incense, candles, and ghost money.

It was the town's tradition to visit the graves of departed loved ones on New Year's Eve, offering incense, lighting candles, and burning ghost money.

Fan Changyu's parents were buried on a mountain outside the town, in a spot with excellent feng shui.

Being new graves, there was hardly any grass in front. Upon arriving, Fan Changyu set Changning down.

Nearly two months had passed since their parents' deaths, but Changning's eyes still welled up with tears at the sight of the two mounds. "Daddy... Mommy..."

Fan Changyu patted her little sister's head and comforted her, "Don't cry. It's the New Year—we should be happy. Only then will Daddy and Mommy in heaven feel at ease."

Xiao Changning sniffled hard, holding back her tears.

After lighting the incense and candles, Fan Changyu had Changning kowtow before the graves while she took out the ghost money from the bamboo basket and burned it in a special iron basin for ashes.

Once Changning finished kowtowing, she crouched beside Fan Changyu to help burn the ghost money. Noticing Xie Zheng standing nearby, she handed him a large stack of ghost money. "Brother-in-law, you burn some too!"

Xie Zheng hesitated for a moment before also picking up some ghost money to burn. The smell of paper ash was rather pungent, and the rising smoke made Changning's eyes water, forcing her to step aside.

Only Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng remained by the brazier.

Noticing she had divided the ghost money in her basket into four portions, Xie Zheng asked, "Who are the other two portions for?"

Fan Changyu replied, "For my maternal grandparents. My parents used to make offerings to them before. Now that they're gone too, I might as well burn some for all of them together."

Xie Zheng subtly furrowed his brows. Her mother didn't even know her original surname—how could she know her parents' birth dates for the offerings?

He grew increasingly convinced that the omission of the surname on her mother's memorial tablet was deliberate.

As for why her father's surname wasn't concealed, either the Fan surname wasn't his original one, or... he had previously used a different surname.

Though suspicions arose in his mind, he had no intention of asking about her grandfather's surname.

He could already guess the outcome—if asked, she would plead ignorance on all counts.

Seeing his silence, Fan Changyu thought he was remembering his deceased parents and generously offered, "We have extra ghost money at home. You can burn some for your parents later."

Xie Zheng's slender fingers pinched a bill of ghost money as flames licked at its edge. His features appeared somewhat detached amidst the firelight and smoke. "Does burning these things actually accomplish anything?"

This was a question Fan Changyu couldn't properly answer. After some thought, she said, "Maybe it does. The elders say that people over there need money to bribe the underworld officials, otherwise they'll suffer. Even if it's useless, it's still a form of remembrance."

Having someone burn paper money during festivals means someone in this world still remembers the departed.

Xie Zheng said nothing more, only occasionally tossing another handful of ghost money into the brazier, his lashes half-lowered, making his expression unreadable.

He added too much at once, causing unburnt stacks to produce thick smoke. Fan Changyu's eyes teared up from the fumes, and she turned her face away, eyes shut. "Don't put in so much at one time."

She reached into the bamboo basket for more ghost money but instead touched a cool, large hand.

Fan Changyu recoiled as if shocked, opening her smoke-irritated, teary almond eyes in a mix of embarrassment and awkwardness. "Sorry."

The warmth of her touch still lingered on his hand. Xie Zheng pressed his lips together slightly. He had meant to say "It's fine," but when he looked up and saw her tear-filled eyes and reddened lids, he paused momentarily.

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Fan Changyu finally managed to endure the wave of smoke. She blinked, squeezing out the tears caused by the irritation before feeling slightly better. Lifting her head, she noticed Xie Zheng staring at her with an unreadable expression. She patted the top of her head and asked, "Is there ash on my hair?"

The wind was strong, and indeed, her hair and shoulders were covered in fine ash from the ghost money.

Xie Zheng withdrew his gaze and nodded slightly.

Fan Changyu haphazardly brushed at herself, but the soot only smeared and clung stubbornly to her clothes.

Changning spotted this and toddled over, puffing out her cheeks. "Ning Niang will blow it away for you."

Fan Changyu bent down to let her younger sister help blow the ash off her hair. However, Changning was too small and didn't have enough strength to do it thoroughly. She tugged at Xie Zheng's sleeve, looking up at him. "Brother-in-law, blow it away for her."

Xie Zheng glanced at Fan Changyu. She was crouched slightly, letting her sister fuss over her hair. From his angle, he could see the pale nape of her neck and half of her delicate profile. As she spoke to her sister, a soft smile lingered on her lips.

Hearing Changning ask Xie Zheng for help, Fan Changyu straightened up. "It's mostly gone already. Let's go back—"

The last word caught in her throat.

Xie Zheng reached out, gently brushing the soot and ash from her hair. His touch was light, barely skimming the strands, yet the faint tickling sensation made Fan Changyu stiffen slightly.

It felt entirely different from when she did it herself—though she couldn't quite pinpoint how.

After flicking away the last trace of soot, Xie Zheng withdrew his hand. "Done."

Fan Changyu met his dark, inscrutable gaze and managed a stiff, "Thank you."

By the time they returned from the ancestral rites, it was nearly noon. Fan Changyu stewed a pork knuckle, sliced a plate of preserved sausage, reheated some steamed pork belly, and stir-fried a dish of dried vegetables to cut through the richness. The three of them made do with this simple lunch.

The dried vegetables were made during the harvest season by boiling and sun-drying greens—a common preservation method in their town, said to have originated from famine years when people needed to store as much food as possible.

Unlike fresh greens, the dried ones had a deep, mellow aroma. Soaked and finely chopped, then stir-fried with ginger and garlic, they were even more fragrant than meat.

By the end of the meal, half the meat dishes remained, but the plate of dried vegetables had been completely devoured.

The large bowl of minced fresh meat and offal beside the gyrfalcon's cage was also scraped clean. The bird was now preening its soot-streaked feathers with its beak, its beady eyes half-lidded as it basked by the fire pit.

After clearing the dishes, Fan Changyu brought out the red paper for Spring Festival couplets and lanterns she had bought earlier, ready to start decorating.

On New Year's Eve, pasting couplets and hanging red lanterns were essential traditions.

The writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone were all in Xie Zheng's room. Fan Changyu knocked on his door, clutching a stack of red couplet paper.

A sheet of paper was spread across the desk, and ink was already prepared in the chipped inkstone. As expected, Xie Zheng was seated at the rickety desk, writing something.

When his cool gaze flicked toward her, Fan Changyu scratched her head and asked sheepishly, "Um... do you know how to write Spring Festival couplets?"

Changning, like a little shadow, peeked out from behind the door, her eyes crinkling into crescent moons. "Brother-in-law, write the couplets!"

Xie Zheng set aside the half-written paper, clearing space on the desk, and said, "Bring it over."

Fan Changyu then squeezed into the room with the Spring Festival couplets paper and little Changning trailing behind her.

After spreading the couplets paper on the desk, Xie Zheng dipped the brush heavily into the thick ink, leaving little remaining in the inkstone. He tilted his head slightly toward Fan Changyu and said, "Grind some more ink for me."

Fan Changyu hesitated to speak but, seeing him already writing the first bold and elegant character on the paper, didn't want to interrupt. She glanced at the inkstick and began grinding it vigorously in the inkstone.

When Xie Zheng needed more ink and looked into the inkstone, he saw a thick, black pool and paused for a moment before saying, "Too much."

It wasn't just too much—she had nearly ground away half the inkstick just for one pair of couplets.

He couldn't help but glance at her hands.

Considering her strength, it made sense.

Fan Changyu said sheepishly, "I was going to ask how much to grind earlier..."

She could read and, under her mother's cane, had reluctantly learned to write, though her handwriting was barely legible. Writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone were precious, so she rarely ground ink herself. When her mother forced her to practice, it was always her mother who prepared the ink and watched her write. She truly had no idea how much was needed.

Xie Zheng seemed accustomed to such situations and said, "Grinding too much isn't a problem, but it's a waste if unused."

Fan Changyu stared at the mostly ground-down inkstick and felt a pang of regret.

Remembering that Aunt Zhao likely hadn't bought Spring Festival couplets either, she suggested, "Then let's write a pair for Aunt Zhao's

house too! We can use the leftover ink to write a few more—one for each door, for good luck!"

It was the first time Xie Zheng had heard of hanging couplets this way. His fine brows furrowed slightly, then he found it somewhat amusing, feeling an inexplicable lightness in his heart.

When they first met, he had thought her crude, but now he sensed a vibrant vitality beneath that roughness.

Like wild grass in the wilderness, untended yet growing fiercely through frozen earth and cracked rocks, enduring harsh winters and scorching summers. No matter if the sprouting shoots faced wind, frost, or rain, the roots beneath only dug deeper into the soil, continuously nourishing the shoots upward.

He glanced at the woman sitting sideways at the desk, chin propped on her hand as she watched him write. Dipping the brush into the thick ink again, he continued writing the second line of the couplet.

Snowflakes drifted in through the half-open window, the wind rustling his wide sleeves and Fan Changyu's long hair. As he finished the stroke, she leaned in to examine the couplet, and a strand of her hair brushed against the back of his hand.

His brush paused, leaving a drop of ink at the bottom of the couplet.

Fan Changyu gasped. "Did I disturb you?"

Xie Zheng averted his gaze. "No, I just dipped too much ink."

She looked regretfully at the couplet. "What a shame—the characters are so beautifully written. But it's fine, we can hang this one outside mine and Changning's room!"

Xie Zheng raised his eyes. "You like it?"

Fan Changyu nodded, studying the couplet as she read aloud, "'Ice melts as springs awaken, snow fades while grass sprouts.' The thaw brings new growth—I like the meaning."

She smiled at Xie Zheng as she spoke, "When my mother used to write Spring Festival couplets for our home, she also disliked the overly auspicious phrases commonly found in the ones sold in the market."

Xie Zheng was momentarily dazzled by her smile and didn't respond, lowering his gaze instead. He picked up the brush and with a few deft

strokes, transformed the ink blot that had ruined the entire couplet into a wild grass scene full of artistic charm.

Fan Changyu and her younger sister both let out a surprised "Huh," their eyes brimming with delight.

Fan Changyu picked up the couplet and examined it closely. "You can paint too?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Just a little."

Fan Changyu stared at the vibrant cluster of wild grass beneath the couplet. "That's more than enough."

She glanced at Xie Zheng a few more times and said, "If you sold calligraphy and paintings on the street, I bet you'd make a fortune!"

With his looks and skill, plenty of young ladies would surely flock to buy his works!

The slight upward curve of Xie Zheng's lips from her earlier praise flattened upon hearing these words.

He said, "I don't paint what doesn't suit my heart."

Fan Changyu, familiar with his stubborn temperament, wasn't surprised by his response. She watched as he continued to write the horizontal scroll.

He penned the phrase "Endure till spring's birth" with bold, vigorous strokes, as if infused with the tenacity and vitality of wild grass breaking through the soil.

Fan Changyu was already fond of the couplet, but seeing the horizontal scroll made her even more pleased.

To maintain consistency, Xie Zheng added a few strokes of wild grass to the horizontal scroll and the upper part of the couplet paper.

Fan Changyu happily placed the finished couplet on the nearby cabinet to dry.

With the ink blot gone and only enough couplet paper left for three sets, Fan Changyu decided to give one to Aunt Zhao and her family, resolving to hang this one at the front door.

For the elderly couple, Xie Zheng wrote a pair of auspicious couplets wishing them happiness and longevity.

When it came to the last set, Changning clung to the desk, standing on tiptoe and craning her neck. "Ning Niang wants to write too."

Thinking this set was just for their own home, Fan Changyu found the paper for the horizontal scroll and asked Xie Zheng to come up with a couplet. After he wrote it down, she guided her sister's hand to copy it.

Once they finished the horizontal scroll together, Fan Changyu wrote the upper line in her own clumsy handwriting.

Though the characters were a bit rough, Fan Changyu was quite satisfied.

She handed the brush back to Xie Zheng. "You write the lower line."

Xie Zheng looked at the oversized characters that nearly overflowed the paper, paused for a moment, then wrote the lower line in wild cursive to make it less jarring.

All his writing deliberately avoided his original style, ensuring no one familiar with his handwriting would recognize it.

Just as Fan Changyu was about to call it a day, Changning, who had slipped out unnoticed, returned carrying the Gyrffalcon from the coop in the main hall, her eyes sparkling. "Let's stamp Falcon's footprint too!"

Her hold was peculiar—one chubby hand cradled the Gyrffalcon's belly while the other gripped its neck, as if ready to yank it by the neck if it didn't cooperate.

Meeting the Gyrffalcon's terrified and helpless gaze, Xie Zheng felt a strange mix of emotions.

These sisters were definitely related by blood.

Fan Changyu stroked the feathers on the Gyrffalcon's head and after a moment's thought, said, "Alright!"

She brought over the inkstone, dipped one of the Gyrffalcon's claws in it, and stamped a falcon print next to the horizontal scroll Changning had written.

The shadow of being smacked on the head still lingered, so the Gyrffalcon kept its wings tucked in, not daring to move a muscle the entire time, only its beady eyes wide open, looking utterly bewildered and pitiful.

After stamping its claw prints, Fan Changyu wiped the ink off the Gyr Falcon's feet with a damp cloth before saying to Changning, "Take it back now."

Changning happily carried the Gyr Falcon back to the main hall and placed it back in the chicken coop.

Fan Changyu then went to the kitchen to fetch the leftover rice porridge from lunch. She first pasted the Spring Festival couplets—jointly completed by the three of them and the falcon—onto the doorframe of the main hall before heading out with the porridge to paste the pair bearing the words "Endure for Chun Sheng."

When the elderly couple of the Zhao Family heard that Xie Zheng had also written couplets for them, they came out to watch Fan Changyu paste the new ones up, grinning from ear to ear.

Other neighbors passing by the alley noticed and asked curiously, "Changyu, your husband can write couplets too?"

Aunt Zhao had always been unwilling to let Fan Changyu be looked down upon because of Song Yan. Hearing the question, she immediately replied, "Of course! That young man is also literate. Just look at this calligraphy—it's even better than the couplets sold on the streets!"

In such a small place, knowing a few characters was already considered a skill. Even without passing the imperial exams, just qualifying as a child scholar could elevate one's status significantly when seeking a marriage partner.

The woman nodded repeatedly. "It's no worse than the Spring Festival couplets Song Yan wrote for everyone in previous years. Changyu really knows how to pick a husband!"

She then smiled at Fan Changyu and asked, "Could your husband write a pair for me too?"

In previous years, Song Yan would set up a stall at the market during the New Year to write couplets for people, earning some extra income. When neighbors in the alley asked him to write, he never charged them, only requiring them to bring their own red paper. However, most people would still bring small gifts as tokens of appreciation.

This year, with Song Yan's family having moved away, getting someone to write couplets would cost a dozen or so coins, and buying ready-made

ones wasn't cheap either. Most households in the alley hadn't prepared their couplets yet.

Thinking of Xie Zheng's foul temper, Fan Changyu tactfully declined, "I'm sorry, Auntie, but we don't have any extra couplet paper at home."

The woman replied directly, "I still have some leftover from previous years!"

Xie Zheng appeared at the gate at some point. Seeing him, the woman smiled and asked, "Changyu's husband, do you have time to write a pair for me?"

What kind of ridiculous address was "Changyu's husband"?

Fan Changyu, fearing his sharp tongue might utter something cutting, was about to decline again on his behalf when she heard him say, "Bring the paper over."

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned, but the woman was overjoyed by Xie Zheng's response. She turned and hurried home, saying, "Wait here, I'll go get the paper right now!"

As if afraid he might change his mind the next second.

Fan Changyu assumed he had agreed mostly out of consideration for her. Once they were back in the yard, she couldn't help but say, "If you don't want to, you don't have to force yourself."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyes coolly. "When did I say I didn't want to?"

Fan Changyu: "..."

Who was it that said he wouldn't paint anything that didn't suit his fancy?

Fine, that was about painting. Writing a few characters was no big deal—she was overthinking it.

Soon, the woman returned with red paper, but she wasn't alone. Several other women and elderly ladies, also carrying red paper, followed her.

Each one greeted Fan Changyu with a cheerful smile. "We heard your husband is writing couplets for people, Changyu. Our family hasn't prepared any this year either, so we've come along shamelessly."

It was common knowledge that writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone were valuable items, so naturally, the visitors didn't come empty-handed.

Those who had made tofu at home brought a bowl of it, while those who had prepared rice crispy treats wrapped a few pieces and handed them to Changning as soon as they entered, letting her snack on them.

Fan Changyu watched as people arrived with gifts, unsure whether to refuse or accept on Xie Zheng's behalf. She could only glance at him for guidance.

He had already brought the writing brush, ink, and inkstone from the southern room to the main hall. Catching her look, he calmly said, "Please have a seat, aunties."

This was his way of agreeing. Fan Changyu then invited everyone to sit by the fire pit to warm themselves.

Xie Zheng didn't immediately start writing the Spring Festival couplets. Instead, he first asked a question or two about the desired meaning behind the couplets before putting brush to paper.

Amid the swirling snowflakes, his posture as he held the brush was composed and serene.

When an elderly woman from the end of the alley came to request a couplet, she seemed unsure how to describe what she wanted. Her words were hesitant, spoken in a thick local accent, and somewhat fragmented.

Yet, Xie Zheng showed not a trace of impatience. To better hear what the old woman was saying, he even tilted his head slightly, leaning closer.

Fan Changyu, sitting by the fire pit, was surprised by this scene. In her memory, he had always been ill-tempered and proud, so she hadn't expected this gentle and refined side of him.

After finishing the couplet, he read it aloud to the old woman and explained its meaning. She nodded repeatedly, her face crinkling into a wide smile.

Fan Changyu rested her chin on one hand, watching them, and for some reason, found herself smiling too.

Xie Zheng suddenly looked up, meeting her smiling eyes directly.

Her heart skipped a beat, and her smile stiffened. She silently turned back to the fire.

Word spread quickly after people learned Xie Zheng was helping with couplets. Soon, nearly half the alley's residents came knocking, and it

wasn't until dusk that the stream of visitors finally ceased. The snacks and treats they brought in gratitude piled high on the table.

When Xie Zheng sat down by the fire pit, Fan Changyu noticed him subtly rubbing his wrist. She teased, "Hand sore, huh?"

He simply replied, "It's fine."

She snorted inwardly—this man was nothing if not stubborn.

As night began to fall, she lit the red lanterns, intending to hang them in the yard.

In previous years, her father had always handled this task. Fan Changyu had little experience, and the bamboo pole she found was too short. Unable to reach, she called out to Changning, "Ning Niang, bring me a stool."

Changning was sitting by the door, nibbling on a piece of rice crispy treat. She broke off small bits and scattered them at her feet for the gyrfalcon to peck at.

Hearing Fan Changyu, she turned and shouted into the house, "Brother-in-law, help A-jie bring a stool to hang the lanterns."

Fan Changyu was about to scold the child for being so bossy when Xie Zheng emerged from inside.

He didn't bring a stool. Instead, he walked over and naturally took the bamboo pole from her hands. His palm brushed lightly against the back of her hand, just as it had when he taught her to counter moves in the pine forest—only this time, his crisp, cool scent carried a faint hint of tangerine peel candy.

"Done." After hanging the lantern under the eaves, he stepped back, and the aroma of tangerine peel candy faded with him.

Fan Changyu felt inexplicably flustered, managing only a stiff, "Thank you."

For dinner, there were the leftover braised pork trotters from lunch, along with the signature New Year dishes gifted by neighbors who came to write couplets. Fan Changyu selected a few dishes to reheat and set up a small pot over the fire pit. She sliced fresh meat, tofu, and winter bamboo shoots, arranged a plate of braised offal, and mixed tender pork liver with a beaten egg to cook on the spot.

This was a hotpot she had seen diners frequently order while helping with the braised meat at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion.

Curious, she had once asked what it was. Chef Li told her it was a dish created by Shopkeeper Yu. Other restaurants had similar versions, but none could match the taste of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's.

During New Year's Eve and the first day of the year, the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion was closed. Shopkeeper Yu had given her several blocks of solidified red oil broth to take home for the holiday.

Fan Changyu didn't know how the solidified red oil was made, but it contained spices like Sichuan peppercorns, bay leaves, and star anise. Once boiled in water, it turned into a bright red broth that made the meat taste even better than the Maoxuewang she had cooked last time.

The only downside was its spiciness. Changning, torn between craving it and fearing the heat, ended up with swollen lips by the end of the meal.

Fan Changyu also found the hotpot overwhelmingly spicy. Unable to bear the heat, she fetched a jar of mild wine and had already poured Xie Zheng a cup before remembering his injury.

She took the cup back and placed it in front of herself. "I forgot—you can't drink with your injuries."

Xie Zheng, recognizing the mildness of the wine by its scent, said, "This wine won't hurt."

Ignoring him, Fan Changyu poured him a cup of warm tea instead. "The physician said no alcohol until you recover."

Changning watched eagerly. "Ning Niang wants some too."

Fan Changyu poured her a cup of warm tea as well. "Children can't drink wine. Have tea like your brother-in-law."

Xie Zheng: "..."

The hotpot was so spicy yet addictive that Fan Changyu ended up drinking the mild wine like water. By the time her lips burned and she reached for another pour, she realized she had unknowingly drunk most of the jar.

She blinked in surprise. "How did I drink so much...?"

Then she reassured herself, "It's fine. This wine shouldn't be strong enough to get me drunk."

Her face was already flushed, but Xie Zheng and Changning were also red from the spiciness.

Unaware of her alcohol tolerance, Xie Zheng had assumed she could hold her liquor well, given how boldly she drank. Now, he couldn't tell if her blush was from the spice, the wine, or both.

He pushed the teapot toward her. "Drink some tea to sober up."

Her mind sluggish, Fan Changyu took a long moment to conclude that he seemed to be mocking her for being a lightweight.

Stubbornly, she poured herself another cup of wine and scowled. "My tolerance is great! My father could drink a whole jar of strong liquor, and I can handle half a jar. This mild wine is nothing!"

Xie Zheng watched as she downed the cup in one go, her almond-shaped eyes growing heavier until she slumped onto the low table, fast asleep.

Xie Zheng: "..."

The child, too, was the type to doze off after eating. Clutching the lucky red envelope her sister had given her, she had long been breathing softly in deep slumber.

On this New Year's Eve, Xie Zheng was the only one left awake.

Under the eaves, the lanterns cast a warm glow over the falling snow, while distant streets echoed with the crackling of firecrackers from some household's celebration.

Xie Zheng looked at the woman sleeping soundly on the low table, her flushed cheek glowing in the firelight. Just the sight of it made one imagine how warm and soft her skin would feel to the touch.

He watched quietly for a while before shifting his gaze. Picking up the wine jar on the table, he poured himself a cup. With one leg slightly bent and a hand resting on his knee, he lounged casually, taking a slow sip before turning his eyes to the snowy scene outside the door.

Perhaps it was the proximity to the fire pit, or perhaps the warm, soft glow of the light beneath the eaves, but at this moment, his heart was unprecedentedly calm.

Sixteen years after the Battle of Jinzhou, he finally understood once more how the New Year was meant to be celebrated.

Half a jar of wine had been sipped intermittently, yet not a trace of drunkenness showed in his eyes.

At midnight, fireworks burst in the town. He glanced at the woman across the low table, who merely murmured in her sleep at the noise before drifting off again, and softly whispered, "Happy New Year."

Chapter 32

After the fireworks, sporadic firecracker pops still echoed from distant streets and alleys, with the occasional dog bark faintly drifting through the night.

Xie Zheng lightly rapped his half-closed fist against the table where Fan Changyu lay slumped. "Wake up," he said.

Between drunkenness and drowsiness, Fan Changyu only mumbled incoherently in response, shifting her head to a more comfortable position on her arm as she sank deeper into sleep.

Seeing she wouldn't rouse, Xie Zheng hesitated briefly before standing and walking over. He lifted her up, preparing to carry her back to her room.

The movement made Fan Changyu open her eyes groggily. Her cheeks were still flushed red, leaving Xie Zheng momentarily unsure whether she was awake or still drunk.

Supporting one of her arms to prevent her from falling, he asked, "Can you make it back to your room on your own?"

Fan Changyu tilted her head to study him, her hair tousled from sleep, making her look both dazed and oddly docile. Her gaze was unfocused, as if she hadn't yet recognized who stood before her.

Xie Zheng paused, then averted his eyes with a frown. "You don't even know your drinking limits, yet you dare drink recklessly."

As he tugged at her arm to help her up, he heard her muttering something indistinct.

Unable to make out her words, Xie Zheng leaned in closer. "What?"

Fan Changyu was barely conscious, her head bobbing slightly. Just as Xie Zheng moved nearer to hear her, her head dipped once more—her lips lightly brushing his cheek before coming to rest in the crook of his neck. Her already dazed, sleepy eyes fluttered shut, completely unaware of what she'd just done.

Xie Zheng froze.

Time seemed to stand still in that moment—the wind, the snow, even the crackling of the bonfire faded into silence.

The soft crown of her head pressed against his neck, her breathing slow and shallow. She had clearly fallen back asleep.

Xie Zheng remained motionless for a long while, until a small voice piped up beside them: "A-jie?"

He turned to see Changning, seemingly just awakened, clutching her Red Envelope in one hand while rubbing her bleary eyes with the other. She stared at him and Fan Changyu in confusion.

Raising a slender finger to his lips in a "hush" gesture, Xie Zheng met her gaze, his dark eyes calm and steady in the lamplight. "Your sister's asleep. Don't wake her."

Changning nodded obediently.

Xie Zheng gestured toward the oil lamp. "Can you carry the lamp?"

Little Changning nodded even more vigorously.

Cradling the lamp carefully in both hands, she led the way while Xie Zheng followed, one arm beneath Fan Changyu's shoulders and the other under her knees, carrying her steadily.

Fan Changyu had carried him back from the wilderness twice—yet this was the first time he'd held her like this.

She was lighter than he'd imagined.

Of course. In just two short months, she'd endured the deaths of both parents, the betrayal of her childhood sweetheart, and her uncle's seizure of her family's property. And more recently, these two assassination attempts would be enough to terrify most people for a lifetime.

Outwardly, she carried on as if nothing were wrong—leaving early and returning late each day to earn money, never showing loss of appetite at meals, even laughing and playing with her little sister as usual.

Before, Xie Zheng had thought her simply thick-skinned. But now, it struck him that perhaps... it wasn't that she was unaffected. Perhaps she simply knew she couldn't afford to wallow in grief. So she worked hard, ate well, slept soundly—daring not to fall ill, daring not to let herself collapse.

Because her younger sister could only rely on her, she couldn't afford to collapse.

The path from the main hall to the northern room wasn't long, but in the interplay of darkness and lamplight, Xie Zheng felt a surge of complex emotions.

Upon reaching the northern room, Changning wasn't tall enough to place the oil lamp on the table, so she first set it on a round stool.

Xie Zheng laid the sleeping Fan Changyu on the bed, whereupon Changning quickly ran over, grabbed her sister's shoes with both hands, and tugged hard to pull them off.

The child exerted all her strength but still lacked the proper technique. Xie Zheng said, "Let me do it."

After helping remove both shoes, he was about to cover Fan Changyu with the quilt when Changning spoke up: "A-jie's padded jacket hasn't been taken off yet."

Xie Zheng's fingers paused slightly as he coaxed the child, "Your sister is asleep. Taking off her jacket might wake her. Let her sleep like this."

Only then did Changning relent.

As he covered Fan Changyu with the quilt, the child also kicked off her shoes and climbed onto the bed, tucking in the quilt corners for her sister like a little adult.

Xie Zheng waited until the child had also settled in before placing the oil lamp on a nearby wooden table. Turning back to glance at the bed, he saw Fan Changyu's face flushed with the faint redness of intoxication under the dim lamplight, her sleeping form quiet and serene.

Suddenly, he recalled that night when he taught her the Great Yin Law—how she had fallen asleep while reciting the statutes, slumped over the desk, and in her dreams, choked out the word "Mother."

That strange, unfamiliar emotion rose in his chest once more.

"Brother-in-law?"

Changning, noticing him staring, blinked and called out to him.

Xie Zheng snapped out of his thoughts and said, "What happened earlier in the other room—don't tell your sister."

Little Changning looked puzzled: "What happened?"

After a brief silence, Xie Zheng considered that she might not have seen anything upon waking and replied, "Never mind."

As he prepared to extinguish the lamp, the child asked, "Brother-in-law, won't you need the lamp to go back to your room?"

"No need."

With that, the lamp went out, plunging the room into darkness.

Xie Zheng walked calmly through the dimness and left the room, closing the door behind him.

Before returning to his own quarters, he also took the Gyrffalcon from its cage near the hearth. Once inside, he lit an oil lamp, ground ink, and finished the letter he had started earlier in the day. Then he placed it in a bamboo tube and tied it to the Gyrffalcon's leg.

The bird's wing and leg injuries had mostly healed. Having not flown out for days and with a daily bowl of fresh minced meat or offal, the falcon had grown noticeably rounder.

When Xie Zheng raised his arm for the Gyrffalcon to perch, he felt the weight on his forearm and frowned almost imperceptibly. "After delivering the letter, fly outside until nightfall before returning."

The falcon's beady eyes instinctively darted toward the large bowl of minced meat in the main hall, but sensing the sudden chill from the man behind it, it quickly flapped its wings and vanished into the dark night.

After the Gyrffalcon had flown far away, Xie Zheng didn't go inside. Instead, he stood under the eaves with his hands behind his back, watching the heavy snowflakes drift down like willow catkins for a long time.

When he had instructed Zhao Xun to purchase grain, he had anticipated that the authorities would eventually take notice.

A few days ago, when Zhao Xun came to see him, Xie Zheng had already directed him to send the grain to a designated location. The letter carried by the Gyrffalcon was meant to instruct his former subordinates to transport the supplies.

The Wei family wanted to eliminate him without shedding a single drop of blood and then take over his hundred thousand troops in Huizhou. Their

scheme was well-calculated, but since he hadn't died, the father and son's good days were now numbered.

Rumors about the Jinzhou battle sixteen years ago had suddenly surfaced several months ago. At first, he hadn't believed them. But when his dear uncle learned he was secretly investigating the Jinzhou battle, he immediately set a trap on the battlefield to take his life—undoubtedly confirming those rumors.

Before reclaiming control of the Huizhou troops, he would have to use the Wei family's own hands to uproot the spies they had planted around him.

Thinking about how he had mistaken his enemy for a father for sixteen years, Xie Zheng's lips curled into a mocking smile.

If that woman hadn't chosen to follow his father in death upon hearing the news of his demise, would he have been spared from being raised by Wei Yan's hand? Would he have avoided living sixteen years under the roof of his enemy?

He closed his eyes heavily, the lantern under the eaves casting a shadow from his high-bridged nose across his face.

For some reason, his thoughts drifted back to the two sisters of the Fan family.

For a fleeting moment, Xie Zheng actually felt a twinge of envy toward that child.

When he had suffered upheaval in his childhood, he had been about her age. But once the Xie family collapsed, there was no one left to shelter him from the storm.

That child was so fortunate—though she had lost her parents, she still had an elder sister who could shield her from the world...

When he opened his eyes again, all emotion in his gaze had settled into stillness.

He turned and went back to his room. After removing his outer robe and lying down, he immediately sensed something amiss beneath his pillow.

Sitting up, he lifted the pillow and was visibly stunned for a moment when he saw a red envelope placed underneath.

New Year money.

The character for "year" was homophonous with "evil spirits." Folklore said that New Year money could ward off misfortune and ghosts, ensuring safety and peace.

Had that woman left this for him?

Xie Zheng opened the red envelope and found several silver ingots inside.

Each weighed less than an ounce, but now, as he held them in his hand, they felt inexplicably heavy.

He couldn't remember the last time he had received New Year money. After his parents passed away, the only time he had ever received any was when his grandmother was still alive.

Wei Yan had been cold-blooded and unyielding his entire life. Not only had he never shown kindness to his nephew, but even his own son had never received a shred of paternal warmth from him. Naturally, he had never arranged for red envelopes to be prepared for them during the New Year.

Xie Zheng lay back on the bed, one arm pillowed behind his head, the other holding a silver ingot up to the candlelight as he examined it quietly. A trace of something unreadable flickered across his handsome features.

Her parents were gone—did that mean no one would give her New Year money anymore?

The next morning, when Fan Changyu woke up, her head felt heavy and swollen.

Thanks to the alcohol, she had slept in, and Changning was no longer in the room.

She slowly sat up, noticing that her clothes were still neatly on her body. She tried hard to recall the events of the previous night, but her memory after getting drunk remained a blank slate.

Still, if she had made it back to her room, she must have either walked back herself or been helped by Yan Zheng.

The mere thought of the latter made her face burn with embarrassment.

How utterly humiliating—she had gotten drunk on mild wine! If word got out, she'd be the laughingstock of the town.

Rubbing her throbbing temples, she got up and finished a quick wash when she suddenly heard Changning crying in the main room.

Fan Changyu stepped out and asked, "What's wrong?"

Changning was crouched beside the chicken coop, tears and snot streaming down her face. "Falcon's gone..."

Fan Changyu stared blankly at the empty chicken coop and said, "Perhaps the cage door wasn't closed properly last night. Once the gyrfalcon's wing healed, it must have flown away."

Changning cried even harder.

With no other choice, Fan Changyu resorted to explaining that the gyrfalcon needed to return to its falcon parents. Only then did Changning gradually stop sobbing.

Xie Zheng, who had likely heard the crying from his room, came out and saw Changning still standing tearfully by the coop. He said, "It will fly back again."

Changning raised her tear-filled eyes. "Really?"

Thinking he was just comforting the child, Fan Changyu worried that this white lie might upset Changning more when she later discovered the truth. Forgetting her own embarrassment over possibly making a fool of herself while drunk the previous night, she shot Xie Zheng a glance.

At first, Xie Zheng didn't understand her look. After Fan Changyu had coaxed Changning away, she said to him, "You don't need to lie to her like that. Changning is probably just too lonely. Come spring, I plan to raise a brood of chicks. Once she has new playmates, she'll forget about that gyrfalcon."

Xie Zheng replied, "I wasn't lying to her."

Now it was Fan Changyu's turn to look stunned.

Unable to reveal the truth about using the gyrfalcon to send messages yet, Xie Zheng lied effortlessly: "In falconry, the final stage involves releasing the bird. Only if it returns is it considered fully tamed."

Fan Changyu thought—wasn't this still uncertain? She eyed Xie Zheng suspiciously. "Are you so sure it'll come back?"

Xie Zheng nodded calmly.

Though still somewhat doubtful, Fan Changyu didn't press further, as she knew nothing about falconry.

Much of the cured meat she had smoked earlier still hung above the fire pit. Most of it was reserved for sale, with only a small portion kept for their own consumption.

In the past, when her parents were alive, her father would take a piece of meat to visit the elderly Fan couple on this day every year. Now that her parents were gone, Fan Changyu, though not close to the old couple, still felt obliged to maintain appearances as they were elders.

After breakfast, she prepared to deliver a piece of cured meat to them and return promptly. Entrusting Xie Zheng to look after Changning, she set off with the meat.

Fan Da had recently passed away, casting a somber mood over the Fan family's New Year celebrations.

When Fan Changyu arrived, only the elderly couple was home. Madam Liu had taken her two children to celebrate the New Year at her parents' house.

Having lost both sons within a year, the old couple seemed deeply affected. Fan Laopozi was bedridden, while Fan Laodie's already graying hair had turned almost entirely white. Even during the New Year, his clothes were dirty and wrinkled—whether from neglect or hardship under his daughter-in-law's management was unclear.

Seeing Fan Changyu, he invited her inside to warm herself by the fire.

But Fan Changyu only wanted to deliver the meat and leave. "Ning Niang is waiting for me at home, so I won't stay long," she said.

Fan Laodie looked at the cured meat she had brought, likely remembering how his younger son used to bring meat every New Year. His eyes reddened as he said, "Come inside and sit for a while. There are things about your father's past that I think you should know."

Fan Changyu was taken aback. What about her father's past could she not know?

Seeing Fan Laodie shuffle unsteadily into the house after speaking, Fan Changyu hesitated briefly before following him inside.

Chapter 33

The old house was even more dilapidated than Fan Changyu's home, clearly not well maintained. The interior was cluttered with items haphazardly placed together. Due to the fire pit being used during winter, the tables, chairs, and benches were covered in a layer of soot that hadn't been wiped clean.

If one didn't wipe them before sitting down, their clothes would be stained with black soot when getting up.

The furnishings in the house were all cheap earthenware pots. Both Fan Da and his son were gambling addicts, so any valuable items in the household had long been pawned for money.

The elderly couple of the Fan family lived in the west room. Fan Laodie called out at the doorway, "Old woman, Changyu is here."

Fan Laopozi, lying on the **, simply turned her back to the door, clearly unwilling to even speak to Fan Changyu.

Fan Laodie looked somewhat embarrassed and explained to Fan Changyu, "She's been like this ever since Da Niu was killed."

Fan Changyu didn't take it to heart at all, nor did she bother trying to greet her. For as long as she could remember, Fan Laopozi had never given her family a kind look.

She used the handkerchief handed by Fan Laodie to wipe the bench before sitting down by the fire pit in the main room to warm herself.

As Fan Laodie hung the cured meat she had brought over the fire pit to continue smoking, Fan Changyu noticed the uncollected bowls and chopsticks on the nearby table.

It seemed the elderly couple had cooked rice porridge for breakfast that morning. Even during the New Year, there wasn't a trace of meat on their table.

Fan Changyu frowned and asked Fan Laodie after he sat down, "Didn't you use the twenty-five taels of compensation money the government gave

after Uncle's accident?"

Twenty-five taels was no small sum. For an ordinary family living frugally without medical expenses, ten taels could cover a year's expenses.

Fan Laodie stammered, "That money needs to be saved for your cousin's marriage..."

Fan Changyu raised her eyebrows, "Don't tell me he lost it all at the gambling den again?"

Fan Laodie replied, "The money is kept by your aunt. She's worried the mourning period will delay his marriageable age, so she plans to have him married during the mourning period. They're already looking at potential brides."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu said no more.

Everyone lives their own life. The elderly couple had always prioritized Fan Da in the past, and now that their son was gone, naturally they would prioritize their grandson.

As long as the old house didn't set their sights on her family's property again, she was willing to maintain this state of mutual non-interference between the two families.

She asked, "What was it you mentioned earlier about my father?"

Fan Laodie's wrinkled face was illuminated by the firelight, making him appear even more gaunt. He sighed slowly, "Da Niu's misfortune might also be my retribution."

Fan Changyu found these words somewhat strange but remained silent, waiting for Fan Laodie to continue.

"Although your father wasn't my biological child, he was my own brother's son. That year during the famine, your real grandfather went with the villagers to raid the government granary and was beaten to death by soldiers. Your grandmother gave all the family's stored food to your father and starved to death herself. Before she died, she entrusted your father to me..."

Fan Laodie spoke of these memories with tears glistening in his cloudy old eyes: "I wanted to raise that child as my own flesh and blood, but it was a famine year. People were starving to death by the roadside, and some even set up pots to cook the corpses. The edible clay had been snatched up

too. An extra mouth in the family meant everyone had to share their meager portions with your father. Your two aunts you've never met—the elder was only thirteen, given to a wealthy landlord as a concubine in exchange for half a sack of white flour..."

His voice trembled as tears streamed down his face: "Later, that landlord moved to another province. Decades have passed, and neither my wife nor I have seen that child again, not knowing if she's alive or dead. The younger one was just eight, sold to a human trafficker for three hundred coins, and we never heard from her again. By then, only Da Niu, Er Niu, and your father were left in the family, yet we still couldn't fill our stomachs. Your father was the same age as my Er Niu, but my Er Niu was frail too. On the road fleeing the famine, he fell gravely ill. To pay for his medicine, we had no choice but to sell your father to the traffickers too..."

"Your father was sensible from a young age. When the traffickers took him, he kowtowed to me three times." At this point, Fan Laodie choked up, unable to continue: "The five hundred coins we got for selling him... I've carried that guilt my whole life. Er Niu was unlucky—despite several doses of medicine, he couldn't be saved. I thought I'd never see your father again, but sixteen years ago, he returned to this town with your mother."

"As for the two daughters we sold, he spent all those years trying to track them down. He never found the elder one, but he did locate the younger. Heard she married a military household, but later died in the war. Famine and war—human life was as cheap as grass in those times..."

Fan Changyu hadn't expected so many hidden circumstances behind her father's "disappearance." Her emotions were tangled, and it took her a moment to speak: "After my father returned, why did he take your second son's name?"

Fan Laodie explained: "When your father came back, he told me he'd made enemies while working as an armed escort. He asked if he could live in town under Er Niu's identity—how could I refuse? So we told everyone he was Er Niu, who'd gotten lost during the famine. My wife has resented your father all these years, blaming him for the sale of our two daughters. After your parents settled here, she often went to their door causing trouble, claiming she'd sacrificed her girls for your father's sake, and she squeezed plenty of favors from them. Later, when your mother fell ill after giving birth to your sister, seeing your family had no male heir, she schemed to have Da Niu's second son adopted by your father to inherit the family property."

Fan Laodie sighed heavily, his face full of shame: "She's obsessed. Even if we hadn't taken in your father during the famine, those two daughters... we likely couldn't have kept them either. One by one, the children were lost until only Da Niu remained. Her constant indulgence is what spoiled him. It's my fault too—in the early years, I couldn't provide for this big family. Later, even knowing she was wrong, whenever she wept for our daughters, I couldn't bring myself to discipline Da Niu properly..."

Fan Changyu had always disliked Fan Laopozi, finding her bitter and harsh toward her family. Hearing this history, she understood the saying "the pitiable have their hateful aspects," but her opinion of the old woman remained unchanged.

Just as Fan Laodie had said, in the end, selling off her father still couldn't save Fan Erniu. So how could Fan Laopozi be so certain that if they hadn't taken in her father back then, her two daughters and youngest son wouldn't have left her?

Her father had simply become a convenient target for Fan Laopozi to vent her resentment.

Fan Changyu said, "What's past is past. As long as you don't come to my house looking for trouble, I'll treat you the same way my father did."

Fan Laodie replied, "I'm not telling you this for that reason. Before your parents passed away, your father came to see me."

Fan Changyu looked surprised.

Fan Laodie continued with both guilt and embarrassment, "He had already arranged how to divide your family's property and shops, even writing a will stating the butcher shop could go to your uncle, while everything else would be left to you and your sister. When I asked if enemies from the past had come for him, he wouldn't say more, just asked me to look after you sisters in the future. Who would have thought my wife couldn't keep her mouth shut? After your parents died, she told Da Niu about it. Da Niu had developed a gambling addiction over the years and became increasingly unreasonable—he stole the will and burned it, trying to seize all your family's assets. This old man is useless now, completely unable to control him..."

Hearing that her parents might have prepared everything before going to their deaths, Fan Changyu felt her limbs grow cold. Her hands resting on her knees clenched into fists unconsciously, her lips pressed together

until they turned pale. "Are you saying... my father might have known he and my mother didn't have long to live?"

Fan Laodie hesitated, then nodded.

Fan Changyu felt chilled to the bone, her mind in turmoil.

If, as the authorities claimed, bandits searching for the Treasure Map had found her father and come to demand it...

Then why would her father think that by dying with her mother, the bandits wouldn't come back to kill her and Changning?

Unless... the bandits had already obtained the Treasure Map.

But later, their home was still attacked by bandits twice, clearly indicating they hadn't gotten what they wanted.

However, these later bandits obviously hadn't known about her family initially—they'd only targeted them after extracting information from Fan Da.

Fan Changyu could only think of one possibility: the bandits who killed her parents and those who later came searching for the Treasure Map weren't the same group.

The former had obtained the Treasure Map yet still killed her parents—perhaps because her parents knew some secret that required their silence?

Fan Changyu had originally thought that after the authorities suppressed the bandits, her parents' deaths would be avenged. But now she suddenly realized the true killers might still be at large.

After all, news had recently surfaced that the Treasure Map had appeared in the hands of rebels in Chongzhou, who had recruited many local bandits and outlaws. The bandits who killed her parents might very well be among them.

The entire way home, Fan Changyu was lost in thought.

As she entered the house, she heard Xie Zheng's calm voice from inside: "Wood, yao, wood, with a 'big' character underneath—combined, that makes the character 'Fan.'"

Changning whined pitifully, "I don't want to learn characters anymore! I want to learn pig-butcherer like Big Sister!"

"Your sister butchers pigs and knows how to read."

Changning sniffled, on the verge of tears.

Hearing the door open, she immediately ran out on her short legs, wrapping her arms around Fan Changyu's leg. Looking up with her face all scrunched up, she asked, "Big Sister, why do you need to read to butcher pigs?"

Fan Changyu was still preoccupied with her thoughts, only reaching out to touch the little bun on Changning's head. "Mother used to say that after learning to read and write, one would understand principles and reason, so as not to make mistakes in life."

Changning looked dazed, clearly not yet grasping the meaning of these words.

Xie Zheng lifted his eyes slightly and remarked, "I've never seen you fond of reading."

There was a hint of teasing in his tone. Normally, Fan Changyu would have bantered back, but today she only replied wearily, "I'll take it slow later."

Xie Zheng finally noticed the unusual look on her face and asked, "Why do you seem so wilted after going out?"

Fan Changyu sat by the fire pit and sighed softly. After telling him everything Fan Laodie had said, she slumped despondently. "If my parents weren't killed just because of the Treasure Map, then I have to find out the real reason they died."

Xie Zheng's expression darkened as he listened. If her father had foreseen it and even prepared for his own death, then perhaps the ones who took his life had met him beforehand?

Her speculation wasn't unfounded. However, what those people were after wasn't a Treasure Map, but a letter that Wei Yan valued above all else.

The ones who killed her parents had taken the letter. Since neither she nor her sister knew anything about their parents' past, the killers had spared them?

Having once served as Wei Yan's blade, Xie Zheng knew all too well that Wei Yan's usual approach was to eliminate every root and sprout.

The fact that they had spared the sisters might mean they had ties with her parents? Considering they had met her father before the killing, this theory seemed even more plausible.

Later, when the Martial Assassins from Wei Mansion came to her home to kill and retrieve something, and He Jingyuan, the governor of Jizhou, suddenly dispatched troops to Lin'an Town—these actions were truly worth pondering.

Most importantly, given Wei Yan's ruthless methods, it was unlike him to remain idle after losing so many Martial Assassins in Lin'an Town.

If He Jingyuan intended to protect the sisters, and Wei Yan currently had only He Jingyuan to rely on in the northwestern warfront, then some agreement between the two might explain everything.

Fan Changyu looked up and saw Xie Zheng staring at her with deep, unreadable eyes. She asked, puzzled, "What's wrong?"

Instead of answering, Xie Zheng asked, "Do you want to avenge your parents?"

Fan Changyu nodded. "Of course."

Only then did she notice that Xie Zheng was wearing the hair ribbon she had bought for him—the first time he had tied it on.

The dark blue hue accentuated the sharpness of his features, making him seem even more aloof.

Xie Zheng said, "If the official account of the case is all lies, what will you do?"

Chapter 34

Fan Changyu asked in confusion, "Why would the authorities lie?"

Xie Zheng slightly furrowed his brows. Considering she had lived in this small place since birth, the highest-ranking official she had ever seen was probably the county magistrate. He found himself unusually tolerant of her naive and simple-minded reaction at this moment.

Her parents might have taught her many principles for navigating life, but they likely never revealed the deceit and treachery of officialdom.

With rare patience, he explained to her, even giving an example: "Just like when your uncle Fan Da wanted to seize your family's property and sought out that Master He. Even in the small political arena of a county government office, there are undercurrents. Further up, in the prefectures and the imperial court, the relationships only grow more intricate—factions, colleagues, marital ties, mentor-disciple bonds... Behind every official lies a vast web of power and influence. Some cases involve the interests of high-ranking officials. What seems like an injustice against common folk might actually be a power struggle among the elite."

After pondering for a long time, Fan Changyu said, "So you mean my parents' deaths might also be tied to the interests of many high-ranking officials?"

A hint of surprise flickered in Xie Zheng's eyes—she wasn't entirely foolish after all.

He lowered his gaze. "I was merely giving an example. The authorities might have told only half-truths, or they might have lied outright. None of that matters. What matters is, if the authorities have given you a false truth, what will you do?"

This question indeed went beyond Fan Changyu's understanding. To common folk, officials were like the heavens above them. A single corrupt official was enough to make life miserable. Hearing Xie Zheng's words, she suddenly realized that not all officials were virtuous and just.

If the entire officialdom of Great Yin was a network of mutual protection, then what loomed over their heads wasn't the sky but a suffocating web.

Fan Changyu only wavered for a moment before her gaze quickly steadied. "When Fan Da colluded with Master He to scheme for my family's property, I thought about seeking help from an official higher than Master He. The highest authority in Qingping County is the magistrate, but he and Master He are in cahoots. Since I couldn't rely on the magistrate, I decided to kidnap my uncle instead."

"No matter how vast the officialdom of Great Yin is, it just means there are more officials higher up. If I knew a high-ranking official, I'd probably seek their help in my uncle's case. If Fan Da also sought out the highest official in the prefecture, and if I still had connections, I'd go to the capital to plead for justice. In the end, this chain of appeals would lead all the way to the emperor."

"The highest authority in Qingping County is the magistrate, and the highest in Great Yin is the emperor. In seeking justice, there's no difference between the two. What ultimately determines right and wrong is evidence and the ironclad law."

She looked at Xie Zheng with clear, fearless eyes. "No matter what my parents' deaths are tied to, I will investigate. That vast web of connections in Great Yin's officialdom holds no fear for me."

Her words genuinely surprised Xie Zheng.

He asked, "How will you investigate?"

Fan Changyu glanced at Changning, who was still playing in the snow in the courtyard. "I'm not afraid of danger, but Changning is still too young. If those who killed my parents take notice of us sisters again, I can't guarantee I can protect her. So before anything else, I'll send Changning to a safe place."

Xie Zheng's expression showed approval. "And then?"

Fan Changyu said, "If I were a man, perhaps I would choose to enter officialdom through the Imperial exam or military selection, personally investigating the matters connected to my parents' deaths to get to the bottom of it. But I'm just a woman. I can't enter officialdom, nor do I know any high-ranking officials. The only path left is probably that money can make the devil turn the millstone."

Xie Zheng propped his chin on one hand and remarked, "A good plan, though it sounds like it would take many years. The amount needed to make those high officials turn the millstone for you wouldn't be small."

Fan Changyu choked slightly and said, "This is the only method I can think of right now. Disguising as a man to take the Imperial exam like in operas—I neither have the brains for studying nor a brother's identity I could borrow. Unless..."

She scratched her head. "Should I sponsor a few impoverished scholars? Maybe I'll get lucky and support one with a conscience. After he passes the exams and enters officialdom, I'd have connections there. Investigating my parents' deaths would probably be much easier then?"

This time it was Xie Zheng's turn to choke. He lifted his eyelids and said sarcastically, "What if you encounter another ex-fiancé like your previous one?"

Fan Changyu noticed this person had been acting strangely lately, always bringing up Song Yan at every turn.

She said, "Can we not mention him during the New Year?"

Xie Zheng shot her a sidelong glance and pressed his lips together, as if his bad temper had flared up again.

Fan Changyu muttered, "As if I'm not unlucky enough already..."

Xie Zheng had sharp hearing and caught her muttering. The corners of his lips, which had been straight, suddenly quirked upward. He said, "You can wait a while regarding your parents' case."

Fan Changyu was puzzled. "What do you mean?"

Xie Zheng replied, "If your parents' deaths involve many things, while some in officialdom may want to bury the truth, others will want to investigate thoroughly. What you need to do now is protect yourself and your sister while waiting for those who want to uncover the truth to come to you."

Fan Changyu said, "But I know nothing about my parents' past. Even if someone comes to me, they won't find anything useful."

Xie Zheng thought to himself that as long as He Jingyuan's mouth could be pried open, the truth about her parents' deaths would surface.

But if Wei Yan found out he was still alive, even if it meant sacrificing all of Qingping County or even Jizhou, he would try to kill him again. Until the situation was settled, revealing his identity would only invite disaster.

He said, "You underestimate officialdom. Someone will come looking for you."

Fan Changyu was still confused. After wrestling with it for a while, she figured Xie Zheng was probably just trying to comfort her and didn't dwell on it further. She only said, "Lately, I've been thinking more and more that reading makes people smarter. Yan Zheng, you've read a lot, so you're very clever."

Xie Zheng had heard all kinds of flattery. When it came to compliments, no one could think of more extravagant praise than scholars, but he had never paid attention to any of it. Yet now, her straightforward and simple remark—"clever"—stirred an odd feeling in his heart.

Still, he corrected her: "It's not that reading more makes you clever. Reading helps one understand principles, broadens knowledge, teaches discretion, and prevents narrow-mindedness. That's enough for handling people and matters."

Fan Changyu nodded. "My mother used to say that too. It's a pity I was too immature back then—getting me to study was like trying to drive a New Year's pig out of its pen. Now that I want to learn, it's too late."

She truly felt the usefulness of learning now. Not to mention anything else, when Fan Da had tried to seize her family's property, Yan Zheng didn't even need to resort to underhanded tactics—he simply found a way to use the law to win the case.

If she were more knowledgeable, perhaps she could even sell pork in more creative ways.

She used to think that cucumber with sugar was just that—cucumber with sugar. But while helping with the braised meat at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, she learned that they called it "Green Dragon Resting in Snow." With such an elegant name, the price doubled.

Remembering that he had been teaching Changning to read when she returned, Fan Changyu mustered the courage to ask, "If you have time, could you teach me to read a bit? It won't take much of your time—just tell me what to study, and I'll read on my own. If I don't understand, I'll come to ask you."

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze, somewhat surprised by her request, and asked, "What books have you read before?"

Fan Changyu thought for a moment and said, "I've finished the Three Character Classic , Hundred Family Surnames , and Thousand Character Classic ."

As soon as she finished speaking, Xie Zheng's expression darkened.

Afraid he might find teaching her troublesome, she pressed on, "I've also read some of the Analects and Taixue ."

Xie Zheng's voice was icy. "You mean the Great Learning ?"

Fan Changyu was so embarrassed she wanted to disappear. She admitted honestly, "I only flipped through those two when I saw Song Yan reading them before. The text was hard to understand, and he treasured them so much that I gave them back without asking what they were about."

After her confession, she suddenly felt a chill in the air.

She glanced at Xie Zheng and found his handsome face now cold and displeased.

Fan Changyu was baffled.

Xie Zheng's words practically dripped with frost. "Since you've already 'studied' the Analects and Great Learning , you can move on to Mencius next."

Fan Changyu was utterly confused. Had she said she had studied them?

She had clearly admitted she only skimmed them without understanding a thing.

Not only that, but during lunch, she also noticed that Xie Zheng had switched back to his original hair ribbon.

Unsure what had upset him, she cleared her throat at the table and asked, "This afternoon, I plan to take some cured meat to sell in town and also bring a piece to Head Constable Wang for New Year's greetings. Is there anything you'd like me to buy?"

Only then did the man, who had been strictly observing "no talking during meals," speak up. "I've run out of paper. Writing the Spring Festival

couplets yesterday also used up the ink. Buy some paper and ink—five feet of jia xuan paper, and pine-soot Hui ink."

Fan Changyu's head spun. "What kind of paper? What kind of ink?"

Xie Zheng frowned slightly and said, "Never mind. I'll buy them myself."

Sensing his coldness and remembering his injuries weren't fully healed, she asked again, "I'll hire an ox cart for the trip this afternoon. Would you like to come along?"

Changning, hearing this, immediately started clapping her chubby hands on the table. "Changning wants to go to the market too!"

Both the big and little one stared expectantly at Xie Zheng. After a brief silence, he finally said, "Then we'll go together."

Changning was so excited about the trip that she ran circles in the yard and even chased Aunt Zhao's dog all the way to the alley entrance before stopping.

Fan Changyu hadn't decided to sell cured meat in town on a whim. In previous years, her father would also take a cart of cured meat to sell in town on this day.

Some families visiting relatives and friends, if they hadn't prepared New Year gifts in advance and the meat market wasn't open these days, would mostly buy from roadside vendors.

Upon reaching the county town, Fan Changyu expertly parked the ox cart on the street in front of the county school.

There were many students coming and going here, and quite a few families had rented houses nearby to take care of their sons studying.

When students went to pay New Year respects to their teachers, ordinary tea and wine weren't presentable enough, while expensive gifts cost too much silver. Buying a piece of cured meat as a New Year gift was just right.

As soon as Fan Changyu set up her stall, she made several sales. Xie Zheng had originally intended to go to the Bookstore, but Changning kept standing on tiptoe looking around, asking Fan Changyu eagerly, "Sister, can I go with brother-in-law to watch the flower drum performance?"

Fan Changyu said, "Your brother-in-law isn't going to watch the flower drums."

Changning then turned her hopeful eyes to Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng glanced at the less than half of the cured meat Fan Changyu had sold and said, "Let's wait until your sister finishes selling, then we'll all go together."

Fan Changyu estimated it would still take some time to sell all the cured meat she'd brought, so she said, "It'll be a while before I pack up here. If you're not in a hurry to buy paper and ink, could you take Changning around for a bit? She's just curious—once she's had a look around, she'll settle down."

Xie Zheng nodded.

Changning, having gotten Fan Changyu's permission, tugged at Xie Zheng's sleeve excitedly and walked ahead with the energy of a young calf.

Feeling the pull on his sleeve, Xie Zheng thought to himself that if this child hadn't been born weak, she might have grown up to be as fierce as her sister.

Perhaps because the county was preparing for the Lantern Festival this year, most of the county school students hadn't returned home, and the streets were lively. The twenty-some pieces of cured meat Fan Changyu had brought sold out nearly two hours earlier than she'd expected.

As she was packing up, Xie Zheng returned with Changning, who had had her fill of exploring the area.

Changning had a candied hawthorn stick in her left hand and a colorful pinwheel in her right, her face smeared with syrup.

Fan Changyu looked on helplessly and said to Xie Zheng, "You're spoiling her."

Changning grinned, her eyes crinkling. "Brother-in-law bought one for you too, sister."

Fan Changyu said, "I'm not a child, why would I eat candied hawthorn..."

Before she could finish, a candied hawthorn stick was held out in front of her.

Xie Zheng said impassively, "Your sister insisted on buying one for you too."

Fan Changyu had been about to refuse, but noticing he still had one in his hand and remembering he seemed to have a sweet tooth—and now that he wasn't taking medicine, he probably felt awkward eating sweets openly—she couldn't very well refuse. Taking it, she said, "Thank you."

Fan Changyu ate the candied hawthorn the same way Changning did, popping one whole into her mouth at a time, eyes squinting, cheeks puffed out like a hamster's.

After eating one and seeing Xie Zheng still hadn't touched his stick, Fan Changyu asked curiously, "Why aren't you eating?"

Xie Zheng's gaze moved from the candy crumbs at the corner of her mouth to the candied hawthorn in his hand. He hesitated, then took a small bite.

The sugar coating was sweet, while the hawthorn inside was slightly sour. The combination of sweet and tart when chewed was actually quite pleasant.

Changning, taking another bite of her candied hawthorn, watched this scene with a grin that showed all her teeth. She was so clever—having brother-in-law buy one for each of them meant sister couldn't scold her.

At this street corner, there weren't just vendors selling goods, but also county school students from poor families who had set up stalls to paint portraits for people.

The family of three eating candied haws on the opposite street corner was particularly eye-catching—the man extraordinarily handsome, the woman radiant with smiles, and even the child they were leading was as adorable as jade and snow.

The scholar glanced over several times, quickly sketching on his paper.

Fan Changyu had just finished her candied haws and was tidying up to take Xie Zheng to buy ink and paper when she noticed his expression suddenly turn stern. He strode toward the opposite street corner.

Changyu glanced over and saw only a scholar with a stall selling calligraphy and paintings.

Fearing trouble, she hurriedly took Changning and followed. "What are you doing?"

The scholar had just finished his last stroke when a large hand suddenly reached out and snatched the painting away.

The man who had been eating candied haws on the opposite corner moments ago now stood before him, gripping his collar with a face as cold and terrifying as white jade. "Who told you to draw this?"

The scholar, overwhelmed by the oppressive aura, stammered, "I—I merely found the sight of you, your wife, and your child so heartwarming that I couldn't resist painting it. If I've offended, please forgive me."

By then, Changyu had arrived with Changning. Seeing him poised to strike the scholar in public, she quickly pried his hand from the man's collar. "What's gotten into you?"

Xie Zheng said nothing, his gaze dropping to the painting in his hand.

Though the scholar's technique was ordinary, the figures in the painting were remarkably lifelike.

In it, Changyu squinted happily while eating candied haws, while Xie Zheng's gaze lingered on her face, as if he had been watching her every move. Changning, biting into a candied haw in front of them, turned back to look at the pair with a grin so wide her eyes nearly disappeared, her expression brimming with mischief.

Changyu let out a surprised "Huh?" when she saw the painting and asked the scholar, "Did you draw us?"

Terrified of the intimidating man beside the sweet-looking young woman, the scholar nodded hastily, showering them with flattery: "Madam and the young master are a match made in heaven, truly a perfect pair. Even your little daughter is so adorable. If you like the painting, consider it my New Year's gift to you both. May your love flourish, and may you welcome a little son next year."

Changyu nearly bit through the skewer in her mouth.

Chapter 35

Changning stood on tiptoe to get a better look at the figures in the painting, her grape-like eyes brimming with joy. Her chubby little finger pointed at the image of herself on the canvas as she exclaimed, "Ning Niang is in the picture! Ning Niang likes this!"

Before Fan Changyu could speak, Xie Zheng asked the scholar, "How much for your painting?"

The scholar was momentarily stunned before realizing this strikingly handsome yet intimidating man was inquiring about the price of his artwork. He hurriedly replied, "No charge, no charge! Consider it my gift to the young master and his wife."

Fan Changyu was still slightly embarrassed by the scholar's earlier remarks, though she did find the painting quite lovely. Seeing the scholar adamantly refusing to name a price, she thought for a moment. From the two pieces of cured meat originally intended for Head Constable Wang, she selected the smaller one and handed it to the scholar, saying, "Take this cured meat as our New Year's gift to you."

Then, with a stern expression, she pointed at Changning and clarified, "This is my younger sister."

Receiving a piece of cured meat was an unexpected delight for the scholar, who immediately showered them with blessings: "This humble one was blind not to recognize her. May the young master and his wife be blessed with twin dragon-phoenix children in the coming year, bringing perfect harmony and endless joy with children at your knees."

Fan Changyu: "..."

She considered explaining further, but there was no need to disclose their fake marriage to a stranger.

Even after leaving the scholar's stall with the painting, Fan Changyu still felt awkward, occasionally stealing glances at Xie Zheng, who walked beside her carrying the rolled-up artwork. Only when she noticed his composed expression did her discomfort ease slightly.

Returning to their earlier stall, they packed up their belongings to head to the bookstore for paper and ink. A nearby New Year goods shopkeeper, having observed Fan Changyu selling over twenty pieces of cured meat in less than an hour, grew envious of her brisk business. Waddling out with his portly frame, he called, "Young madam, a moment please!"

Turning at the sound, Fan Changyu saw the plump shopkeeper approaching with a beaming smile. "Will you be selling cured meat here again tomorrow?" he asked.

Tomorrow being the second day of the New Year, Fan Changyu would need to open her family's butcher shop and supply braised meat to Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, leaving no time to return. She shook her head. "I likely won't have time to come back in the next few days."

The shopkeeper chuckled. "Then how about this? Bring all your remaining cured meat to my shop. We'll sell it on consignment—60% for you, 40% for me. What do you think?"

Fan Changyu mused that this was exactly what Shopkeeper Yu had called "getting a wolf with empty hands"—the man wanted her to deliver the goods without any upfront payment, then take nearly half the profits.

Unlike fresh meat, cured meat could be stored in cool, ventilated areas for over a year without spoiling, making it significantly more valuable. During the New Year period, Fan Changyu priced it at 65 coins per jin, though bargaining might bring it down to around 60 coins.

At the proposed 60-40 split, even if sold at full price, she'd only earn 39 coins per jin—far less than selling it herself.

"I'm not interested in profit-sharing," Fan Changyu stated. "If you genuinely wish to purchase, let's settle the accounts clearly by weight."

The shopkeeper laughed heartily. "Young madam, you clearly don't understand business."

Fan Changyu was about to speak when Xie Zheng beside her suddenly said, "Selling on commission is acceptable."

Both Fan Changyu and the plump shopkeeper turned to look at him in unison. Fan Changyu appeared stunned, while the shopkeeper's eyes crinkled into slits as he smiled. "This young brother seems quite business-savvy, with a long-term vision—"

Before he could finish, Xie Zheng gave him a cool glance and said, "Twenty-eight split."

The shopkeeper's smile froze. "Young brother, that's quite an exorbitant demand."

Fan Changyu mentally calculated how much she'd earn from the cured meat with a twenty-eight split. At sixty-five wen per jin, she'd get fifty-two wen; at sixty wen, forty-eight wen.

But she truly hadn't intended to pursue this deal. "What's with the split? Let's just sell by weight and make it a one-time transaction. The wholesale price for cured meat on the market is around fifty wen anyway. I haven't received a single coin yet, and you expect me to deliver the meat first? I'm not comfortable with that. Let's go—we need to buy paper and ink at the bookstore first, then hurry to Head Constable Wang's house for New Year's greetings."

She tugged Changning along to leave. Seeing this, the plump shopkeeper hastily said, "Twenty-eight split it is."

He smiled somewhat helplessly. "Young lady and young brother, you play the good cop, bad cop routine well. It's only because the cured meat you're selling today has such excellent color and smoking—clearly premium goods—that I wanted to do business with you."

He then ushered the three of them into the shop. "Let's draft a contract, and you can deliver the meat later."

When Fan Changyu exchanged glances with Xie Zheng, she still looked dazed, as if surprised the deal had been struck so easily.

Xie Zheng's expression remained indifferent as he said to her, "Go sign the contract."

The shopkeeper, clearly no stranger to such barefaced deals, quickly drafted the contract with practiced ease. When he handed it to Fan Changyu for review, she scrutinized it word by word, unwilling to take any risks, then passed it to Xie Zheng. "Does this look acceptable to you?"

After Xie Zheng nodded, she boldly signed her name.

The shopkeeper handed over one tael of silver as a deposit and cheerfully saw them out.

As they walked, Fan Changyu muttered to Xie Zheng, "Tomorrow morning, I'll have to open the meat shop and deliver braised meat to Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. The cured meat will probably have to wait until the afternoon."

Xie Zheng said, "If you're too busy, I can hire a cart to deliver it for you."

Fan Changyu felt a bit embarrassed. "Should I pay you wages then?"

Xie Zheng shot her a glance, and Fan Changyu sensed—correctly—that he seemed displeased again.

Changning, carefree as ever, skipped ahead. Whenever she spotted a trinket she fancied but didn't dare ask Fan Changyu to buy, she'd gaze imploringly at Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng ended up buying her an assortment of small things. Changning clutched them in her chubby arms, barely able to hold them all.

Fan Changyu scolded her half-heartedly, "Ning Niang, if you keep wanting to buy everything you see, I won't bring you to the county market next time."

Changning hung her head, staring at her toes in chastened silence.

A cool, detached voice came from beside them. "I was the one who bought them for her."

Fan Changyu felt as though this man was deliberately opposing her. Pressing her lips together, she said, "Children don't understand restraint. If we indulge them endlessly, how can we possibly buy everything they fancy on the streets? Some principles must be taught for them to learn."

Xie Zheng fell silent, and as the three of them continued walking, even Changning could sense the strange tension between Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng.

She glanced between the two of them, then at the pile of trinkets she was holding in her arms. Suddenly, she stopped in her tracks, turned around, and shoved everything into Xie Zheng's arms. Clutching the hem of her clothes with her chubby little hands, she said, "Ning Niang doesn't want them anymore. Brother-in-law can return them."

Fan Changyu saw the tears welling up in the little girl's dark, grape-like eyes and sighed. She crouched down, patting Changning's head gently.

“Since we’ve already bought them this time, we’ll keep them. But don’t do this again in the future, understand?”

Changning nodded tearfully, then stretched out her chubby arms, asking to be held.

Fan Changyu pulled the child into her embrace and patted her back soothingly, her tone a mix of fondness and exasperation. “Why are you crying? I didn’t even scold you.”

Changning sniffled. “Elder Sister, don’t be mad at Brother-in-law. Ning Niang knows she was wrong.”

Fan Changyu glanced at Xie Zheng, who was standing to the side holding all the little trinkets, and sighed even more helplessly. “I’m not angry with him.”

Changning insisted, “You’re ignoring Brother-in-law.”

Fan Changyu couldn’t help but laugh. “When have I ignored him?”

Changning’s tears wobbled precariously in her eyes. “You’re not talking to him anymore.”

Fan Changyu thought to herself that she didn’t usually talk much to Yan Zheng anyway. But seeing her little sister on the verge of a full-blown meltdown, she coaxed, “We were just talking earlier. It’s just that we’re not talking right now.”

A single tear, as big as a bean, finally rolled down from Changning’s dark, grape-like eyes and splashed onto the ground. “Elder Sister is definitely angry.”

Fan Changyu surrendered. “What do I have to do for you to believe I’m not angry?”

Changning thought for a moment, then declared, “Hold hands! Holding hands means you’ve made up!”

Fan Changyu paused for a second before offering, “What if I talk to him the whole way back?”

Changning, stubbornly adhering to the logic of children, insisted, “Holding hands means you’ve made up.”

Fan Changyu exchanged a glance with Xie Zheng. His expression was unreadable, but she felt inexplicably awkward.

She tried to reason with the child. "Look, your brother-in-law is holding so many things, and I'm carrying things too. If we both use only one hand, wouldn't that be too heavy?"

Changning finally relented, though as she walked ahead, she kept glancing back at them.

Afraid that Changning might come up with another strange demand, Fan Changyu spoke to Xie Zheng. "Kids can be so fussy. Don't take it to heart."

Xie Zheng replied, "I don't think she's fussy. I'll probably be leaving after the New Year, so I wanted to buy her more little things."

Fan Changyu hadn't expected that his reason for spoiling Changning was because of this.

Hearing that he was leaving soon, a strange emotion rose in her chest. "I'm sorry. I misunderstood you earlier."

Xie Zheng turned his head slightly to look at her. "Why apologize?"

Fan Changyu said, "I misunderstood you and spoke harshly. Of course I should apologize."

She pressed her lips together, then asked, "You're leaving so soon? Won't you wait until your injuries are fully healed?"

Just as Xie Zheng was about to answer, a group of mounted soldiers came charging recklessly down the street, knocking over pedestrians and vendors' stalls in their path.

As the warhorses thundered toward them, Fan Changyu instinctively crouched down to shield Changning, while Xie Zheng raised his cloak to block the mud and debris kicked up by the horses' hooves.

After the group of soldiers swaggered away, many pedestrians who had been knocked over or splashed with mud on the street were cursing angrily.

Fan Changyu looked up to see Xie Zheng's cloak half-covered in mud and frowned, asking, "Are you hurt?"

Xie Zheng shook his head, but his gaze still followed the distant soldiers, his eyes harboring a dark, icy glint.

A peddler whose stall had been overturned spat fiercely in their direction and cursed, "Those damned officials! Can't even let us have

peace during the New Year!"

Fan Changyu asked, "Why have soldiers come to Qingping County again? Are they here to suppress bandits?"

The peddler replied, "Suppress bandits? These are debt-collecting demons—here to seize grain! Haven't you heard about what's happening in Taizhou? The frontlines are short on food for the war, and when the army can't requisition grain, they just rob the people. If you refuse, they beat you to death."

An older man nearby added, "Judging by the way things are going, it won't be long before they start conscripting soldiers too."

Chapter 36

In the sixteen years of the Great Yin dynasty, although there had been many wars, almost none had reached Jizhou.

Fan Changyu had only heard from the elders about the cruelty of war. After all, battles required not only grain levies but also conscription. Aunt Zhao and Uncle Zhao's son had been taken away in a conscription drive years ago and never returned.

An old man said, "Changxin Wang rebelled in Yu Chongzhou, and the court sent troops to suppress it. The battle has dragged on without resolution. I reckon the Great Yin's days are numbered—the heavens are about to change."

"With Wu'an Marquis dead, what does Wei Yan have left to stabilize the northwest?"

Another chimed in, "I don't care who becomes emperor, as long as they don't seize my grain and money or force me onto the battlefield."

Many shook their heads and sighed. "These soldiers have already started forcibly requisitioning grain from nearby villages. By the time the war ends, the officials will have wealth and power, while we commoners will be left destitute and displaced..."

Listening to this, Fan Changyu felt a heaviness in her heart and asked Xie Zheng, "If the court is fighting in Chongzhou, shouldn't they supply the military provisions? Why are they requisitioning grain from the people?"

Xie Zheng's tone carried mockery. "The grain supply line is cut. Some are just desperate."

Huizhou had once been his territory. Looking back now, Wei Yan must have begun fearing him long ago. The military provisions for his garrison had always been allocated every three months by the court, and the prefecture itself had no granaries.

As a military outpost, its geographical conditions were naturally unfavorable, lacking fertile fields for grain.

Once the supply line was severed, it was a fatal blow.

The rebellion in Chongzhou happened to be south of Huizhou, cutting off the grain route from the court to Huizhou.

As the battle lines between Chongzhou and Huizhou stretched, he had anticipated that Huizhou would eventually run out of provisions. The quickest solution, of course, was to requisition grain from the people.

After narrowly escaping assassination, he had planned to contact his old subordinates and have them secretly buy up the civilian grain reserves.

Once Zhao Xun appeared, purchasing grain became a test for him. Now that the grain was secured, Wei Xuan's failures on the Chongzhou battlefield and the inability to requisition grain from the people would surely earn him no favor from Wei Yan.

Knowing Wei Yan, he would not spare his son from punishment.

Letting Wei Xun suffer Wei Yan's wrath first was a gift to his cousin before his formal revenge.

With no one left in the northwest, Wei Yan had no choice but to hand the Chongzhou campaign to He Jingyuan. Known as a scholarly general, He Jingyuan would never stoop to the despicable act of letting his soldiers plunder civilian grain.

Moreover, given the Wei Faction's current reputation, allowing such actions would only hand ammunition to their political enemies.

With those two hundred thousand dan of grain in hand, he now had ample time to proceed with his next plan.

The sudden forced requisitioning by the soldiers was likely another foolish idea from his glory-seeking cousin, trying to achieve something before the military power officially changed hands.

Ordinary people, unaware of these intricacies, shared Fan Changyu's confusion. Some murmured, "Sixteen years ago, during the Jinzhou battle, it was that treacherous official Meng Shuyuan who delayed the grain transport, costing them the battle. Crown Prince Chengde and General Xie led a hundred thousand soldiers who starved for five days in Jinzhou. By the time they climbed the city walls, they were too weak to stand, allowing the Northern Jue to breach the gates. What's the problem with the provisions this time, that they have to scrape it off our backs?"

As for the culprit behind the Jinzhou defeat, the name Meng Shuyuan was one every subject of the Great Yin dynasty wished to see dead.

Someone immediately cursed, "That Meng Shuyuan deserved to die! General Xie held him in such high regard, entrusting him with the crucial task of escorting provisions. If he hadn't delayed the military operation, the Chengde Crown Prince wouldn't have died in Jinzhou, allowing those Wei dogs to control the court for so many years!"

"The Meng family's extinction is just retribution!"

"Let's hope the grain transport officer doesn't cause any trouble this time in Chongzhou!"

Xie Zheng had known since sixteen years ago that the fatal flaw in the Jinzhou battle's defeat was the delayed arrival of military provisions.

Back then, the responsibility for escorting the provisions fell on Meng Shuyuan, a veteran general under his father's command. His father's old subordinates had told him that while anyone in the world might betray his father, Meng Shuyuan never would.

Meng Shuyuan's delay in delivering provisions wasn't due to betrayal, but because he diverted to rescue 100,000 refugees trapped by the Northern Turks in Luocheng. In the end, he failed to save the refugees, and Jinzhou fell.

When Meng Shuyuan learned of his father's death, he knelt facing Jinzhou and drew his sword to take his own life.

The tragedy of Jinzhou concluded with Meng Shuyuan's death, yet even after more than a decade, people still reviled him when his name was mentioned.

The group of soldiers had already moved on. Xie Zheng withdrew his gaze and said to Fan Changyu, "Let's go."

But he noticed Fan Changyu seemed lost in thought, staring at the people discussing Meng Shuyuan.

He asked, "What's wrong?"

Fan Changyu, holding Changning's hand, pursed her lips and said, "Meng Shuyuan delayed the military operation to save 100,000 refugees. He wasn't as despicable as people make him out to be, was he?"

Xie Zheng's voice turned cold: "His military order was to transport provisions. Failing to deliver them to Jinzhou on time was dereliction of duty. If he had been capable enough to save the refugees without delaying the provisions, he would have deserved universal praise. But he neither saved the refugees nor delivered the provisions on time, leading to the fall of Jinzhou and the deaths of 100,000 soldiers inside the city. That is an unforgivable crime."

He looked up at Fan Changyu: "Do you sympathize with such an incompetent man?"

Fan Changyu shook her head. She didn't understand military tactics or regulations, but she felt that while Meng Shuyuan might indeed have been the main culprit in the Jinzhou battle, he didn't deserve to be vilified as a great traitor by the world—at most, he was just the incompetent man Yan Zheng spoke of.

As they passed a clothing shop, she asked Xie Zheng, "Your cloak is dirty. Should we buy a new one to change into?"

Xie Zheng had already taken off his mud-splattered cloak and had been carrying it folded over his arm the whole way.

He glanced at the colorful fabrics in the shop and said, "No need. The sun's out now, and it's not cold anymore."

Fan Changyu said, "Then how about a hair ribbon? I noticed you didn't seem to like the one we bought earlier—I haven't seen you use it much."

As soon as she finished speaking, she saw Xie Zheng staring at her with an inscrutable expression.

Fan Changyu didn't think there was anything wrong with her words. She met his gaze with wide almond eyes, their reflections mirrored in each other's pupils—one clear and bright, the other deep and shadowed.

After a moment, Xie Zheng looked away first and said, "It's not that I didn't like it."

Fan Changyu found his words as cryptic as a riddle. If he didn't dislike it, why didn't he use the hair ribbon? She said, "You've bought so many things for Ning Niang. Why don't you pick a New Year's gift for yourself? I'll buy it for you!"

Xie Zheng's lips thinned slightly: "Didn't you already give me a Red Envelope?"

Fan Changyu replied, "How can New Year money be the same as a New Year's gift?"

Xie Zheng stared at her for a moment before saying, "It makes no difference to me."

Fan Changyu took this as his way of refusing her offer to help buy New Year gifts, so she didn't press further.

She glanced at the sun. "If we accompany you to the bookstore for paper and ink first, we'll likely be late visiting Head Constable Wang's family. But if we go later, the bookstore might be closed. Here's what we'll do—you go to the bookstore alone while I take Ning Niang to pay New Year respects to Head Constable Wang first. After you finish shopping, wait for me at the bookstore. I'll drop off the gifts at the Wang residence and then bring Ning Niang to meet you."

Xie Zheng nodded in agreement.

The two parted ways at the fork in the road. Before leaving, Changning waved energetically at Xie Zheng. "Brother-in-law, be safe on your way! If A-jie and I buy something tasty, we'll get some for you too!"

Xie Zheng's brows lifted slightly as he glanced at Fan Changyu. "No need. You two enjoy yourselves."

Fan Changyu thought his words made it sound like she was deliberately sending him away so she and Changning could indulge in treats without him.

As Xie Zheng walked away under her conflicted gaze, Fan Changyu crouched down to wipe the candied hawthorn crumbs from Changning's mouth, amused yet exasperated. "You little glutton, what do you want to eat now?"

Changning pointed her plump, fair finger toward a street vendor selling brown sugar cakes.

Fan Changyu sighed and rubbed her forehead. "Let's go."

After purchasing the brown sugar cakes, Fan Changyu stopped by a nearby tavern to buy a jug of fine wine. She had originally planned to give the cured meat to Head Constable Wang but ended up gifting a portion to the scholar as well. Showing up with just one piece of cured meat would have been embarrassing.

Fortunately, Head Constable Wang was fond of drinking, so the wine would suit his tastes.

The Wang residence was located in the southern part of Qingping County. While not the most prestigious area, it was still a two-courtyard house—a property only those of considerable status could afford in such a small county.

After Fan Changyu knocked on the gate with Changning in tow, an elderly maidservant answered. Upon learning they were there to pay New Year respects to Head Constable Wang, she promptly invited them inside.

By afternoon, most of the morning visitors had already left after their meals. When Fan Changyu entered, she only saw Head Constable Wang, his wife, and Wang Laotaitai sitting on the heated kang in the east wing.

Wang Laotaitai appeared to be in her eighties. Unlike the wrinkled faces of rural elderly women, hers was plump and kindly, exuding warmth.

Wang Furen had a sturdy frame but didn't appear overly broad-shouldered. Rumor had it her father had once been a constable, and she herself knew some martial arts. Her features were gentle yet carried a dignified air.

"So this must be Changyu?" Wang Furen beamed at Fan Changyu. "What a fine girl—your build shows you're naturally fit for martial arts."

Fan Changyu smiled and greeted both Wang Furen and Wang Laotaitai.

In Qingping County, there had once been a famous courtesan known publicly as "Yu Niang" (Jade Lady). As a result, local girls whose names ended with "Yu" (Jade) were never directly called "Yu Niang." To do so would imply they were courtesans, carrying a mocking undertone.

Changning clung to Fan Changyu's sleeve, hiding behind her while peeking at Wang Furen with deer-like timidity.

Wang Furen's smile brightened at the sight of her. She grabbed a handful of candies from a lacquered tray and beckoned. "Little Ning Niang is such a sweet thing. Come here and have some treats."

Changning hesitated, looking up at Fan Changyu for permission.

Fan Changyu said, "Madam is giving you candy, go ahead and take it."

Only then did Changning trot over to receive the candy from Wang Furen. Being small, her hands couldn't hold much, so Wang Furen helped

stuff many pieces into the pockets of her clothes.

Changning said sweetly, "Thank you, Madam."

Wang Furen and Wang Laotaitai exchanged glances, grinning from ear to ear. Unable to resist, Wang Furen pinched Changning's rosy cheeks and said, "How can such a little one be so well-behaved?"

She smiled at Fan Changyu: "Did your elder sister teach you well?"

Fan Changyu smiled bashfully: "You flatter me too much."

She wasn't one for small talk and spoke very honestly. This straightforward nature made Wang Furen and Wang Laotaitai particularly fond of her. Occasionally, when Fan Changyu responded with a few words, they would burst into laughter, leaving Fan Changyu utterly bewildered as to why they found it so amusing.

Wang Furen wanted the sisters to stay for dinner and overnight, but Fan Changyu declined politely, citing that Xie Zheng was waiting for her at the bookstore.

When bidding farewell, Head Constable Wang personally saw her out. "Your parents' case has been officially closed after being taken over by the prefecture. I initially feared they might have made enemies in earlier years. Since it was bandits searching for the Treasure Map, and the map is no longer in your home, you have nothing to fear now. Settle down peacefully in town, and if you ever face difficulties, don't hesitate to come to me."

Fan Changyu thanked him and asked, "Do you know which official from the prefecture reviewed the case?"

Head Constable Wang, being just a small constable in Qingping County, had no idea. Shaking his head, he couldn't help but ask, "Why do you ask?"

Worried that her parents' deaths might involve complex conspiracies as Yan Zheng had suggested, Fan Changyu didn't want to elaborate and risk causing trouble for Head Constable Wang. She simply replied, "No reason, just curious."

To uncover the truth behind her parents' deaths, the best approach was to start with the official handling the case. The surviving bandit captured that night might have confessed something crucial to solving the mystery.

When Yan Zheng asked what she would do if the authorities lied, she had already considered secretly investigating the official in charge. Stories often depicted catching corrupt officials by their weaknesses—sneaking into their homes on dark, windy nights to strike a deal, either for money or clues.

All she needed was to identify the official, and she'd have plenty of time to dig up their secrets.

As Fan Changyu and Changning neared the gate, Wang Furen hurried after them with two red envelopes. "Take these Lucky Red Envelopes!"

One of the envelopes wasn't even properly folded, as if prepared hastily.

Unable to refuse, Fan Changyu accepted as Wang Furen pressed them into her arms.

Once outside the Wang residence, Changning eagerly opened her envelope and gasped in delight, showing Fan Changyu: "Elder Sister, it's Silver Ingots!"

Fan Changyu's envelope also contained two silver ingots.

Clutching the first red envelope she'd received since her parents' passing, Fan Changyu glanced back at the Wang house, her heart filled with mixed emotions over Head Constable Wang and Wang Furen's kindness.

Changning handed the silver ingots to Fan Changyu. "Elder Sister, you keep them."

Her pockets and small pouch were already stuffed with candies given by Wang Furen, leaving no room for the silver ingots.

Fan Changyu took them and said, "Let your elder sister keep them for you first. I'll put them in your little box when we get home."

Changning had a small box specifically for storing New Year money. However, two months ago, she had contributed it for her parents' funeral arrangements and was only now starting to save again.

Hearing Fan Changyu's words, Changning happily responded with an "Mm-hmm."

Few shops were open on this street, and peddlers passing by were even rarer. Only some children were playing around.

Perhaps news of the grain levy had already reached Qingping County, as teahouses and taverns discussing the recent Chongzhou battle inevitably brought up the Jinzhou battle from sixteen years ago.

Having heard adults talk about it so often, the children incorporated "Meng Shuyuan" into their game of catching the bad guy, where he became the one being chased and surrounded.

In such games, the leader usually played the hero, while the child often bullied and ostracized would be forced to play Meng Shuyuan. Once caught, the leader and other children would push and harass them.

Hearing the children shouting as they chased the one playing Meng Shuyuan, Changning looked up at Fan Changyu and said, "Meng Shuyuan is a great traitor."

Fan Changyu tightened her grip slightly on her younger sister's hand and said, "Changning, you mustn't play games like that, understand?"

Changning asked, "Why not?"

Fan Changyu patiently explained, "Those children are just using the game to bully the one playing Meng Shuyuan. You mustn't learn from them."

Only then did Changning nod.

Fan Changyu smoothed the fine strands of hair on her sister's forehead and said, "Mother and Father never liked seeing children play like that."

Changning immediately declared, "Ning Niang won't copy them!"

Fan Changyu smiled and ruffled her sister's round little head, but her thoughts drifted away.

She had always been tough, even as a child, known among her peers for her strength. Boys two or three years older than her had been beaten to tears and run home to complain to their parents.

Her parents always resolved things with reason. If she was in the wrong, they would punish her; if she was justified, they would argue on her behalf.

But there was one exception. Once, while playing the game of catching the bad guy with other children, one child playing Meng Shuyuan was pushed down by another who didn't know his own strength and scraped his forehead on the ground. The injured child's parents went door to door demanding an explanation.

Fan Changyu hadn't pushed anyone or joined in bullying the child playing Meng Shuyuan that time.

But when her mother heard she had participated in the game, she suddenly burst into tears, and her father was so angry he made her kneel in the courtyard all afternoon.

Fan Changyu reflected for a long time and concluded her parents must have disliked her joining in bullying the weak.

That night, when she returned to her room, her mother's eyes were still swollen. She made Fan Changyu promise never to play the game of "beating the great traitor Meng Shuyuan" again.

Fan Changyu had always felt guilty. She had never seen her mother cry so bitterly—she must have disappointed her terribly.

So when she heard her sister echo the children's words about Meng Shuyuan being a great traitor, she feared Changning might join the neighborhood kids in playing the game and decided to teach her beforehand.

By coincidence, after leaving Head Constable Wang's house, Fan Changyu—unfamiliar with the county roads—asked for directions to the bookstore and ended up taking a long detour. Passing by the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion on this side of town, she ran into Yu Qianqian.

Yu Qianqian was dressed in a large fur-lined coat with white fox fur trim, its front and cuffs embroidered with intricate golden patterns. Her straight bangs framed a face as fair as polished jade, making her look no different from an unmarried young maiden.

She seemed about to depart by carriage, with several steward-like figures standing before her, bowing and nodding as they listened to her instructions.

The moment Yu Qianqian finished speaking, she looked up and spotted Fan Changyu approaching from the street corner, leading a doll-like little girl. Her face lit up with joy. "I was just planning to return to town to find you—what luck to run into you right at the shop's doorstep!"

Fan Changyu greeted her with a cheerful "Happy New Year" before asking, "Did you need something from me, shopkeeper?"

Yu Qianqian replied, "I've got a big deal tomorrow, and I'll definitely need your help!"

The largest bookstore in the county remained open even on New Year's Day.

When Xie Zheng stepped inside, the bookstore manager, fiddling with an abacus, asked, "What would you like to purchase, young master?"

Xie Zheng let a jade ring with a hanging cord dangle from his fingertips. At the sight of it, the manager's demeanor instantly turned respectful. Bowing, he gestured with an inviting hand, "Please, young master, let us speak upstairs."

The manager led Xie Zheng to an elegant room on the upper floor. By the window stood a Huanghuali wooden table, upon which rested a slender-necked white porcelain vase holding a branch of half-blooming red plum blossoms. Against the backdrop of delicate snowflakes drifting beyond the carved wooden window, the scene carried a certain poetic charm.

"Esteemed guest, please wait here for a moment. I shall fetch the proprietor," the bookstore manager said before withdrawing. Just then, a servant entered with tea.

Wei Yan was highly skilled in the art of tea, and Xie Zheng, having been raised under his tutelage for sixteen years, had acquired some knowledge of tea appreciation.

The fragrance of this tea alone could rival the finest imperial tribute.

Lowering his gaze to the red plum blossoms in the vase, Xie Zheng tapped the tea lid lightly with his fingers.

Before long, Zhao Xun pushed the door open and entered, his charming face adorned with a practiced smile. "My apologies for not welcoming the Marquis properly upon your arrival."

"You flatter me, Young Master Zhao."

Seated in the Grand Tutor chair with an air of ease, Xie Zheng's words carried an almost domineering presence, as if he were the host rather than the guest.

Zhao Xun said, "The matters the Marquis entrusted to me have all been carried out discreetly. You need not worry—even if officials investigate, they will find nothing."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyes. "There is one more task for your men."

"What is it?"

"Expose Wei Xuan's act of allowing soldiers to seize grain in Jizhou—bring it directly to He Jingyuan's attention. In the capital, use the deaths of innocent civilians during the grain seizures to stir public outrage and denounce the Wei Faction."

The louder the public outcry, the more effective the censors' impeachment in court would be.

Hearing that this was another move against the Wei Faction, Zhao Xun hastily bowed. "I shall order my men to act at once."

But as he raised his head, he noticed a faint smile playing on Xie Zheng's lips as he regarded him.

Zhao Xun hesitated before asking, "Why does the Marquis look at me so?"

Xie Zheng took a sip of tea from the cup before him. "Qingcheng Snow Bud—plucked with only one bud and one leaf, reserved as tribute for the imperial family. I never expected to find such fine tea in a small place like Qingping County."

Zhao Xun replied, "As a businessman, I went to some expense to acquire such rare goods. Knowing the Marquis was coming, of course I had to offer it in your honor."

Xie Zheng's lips pressed into a tight line: "Even ordinary merchants couldn't have purchased two hundred thousand dan of grain so flawlessly without alerting local officials. With your family's wealth reaching such heights, and Grand Tutor Li's faction in court still available to rely on if you truly sought revenge against Wei Xun, your elaborate efforts to seek out this marquis suggest you're less interested in borrowing my hand for vengeance and more attracted to the prestige I command among the hundred thousand troops in Huizhou."

His phoenix eyes locked onto the unqualified merchant before him like a wolf confronting a hyena: "What you covet is this Marquis's military power. Since we're cooperating, I don't care for an alliance that keeps secrets."

Zhao Xun fell silent for two breaths, then suddenly burst into laughter, shedding his previous submissive demeanor as he took a seat opposite Xie Zheng. "As expected, nothing escapes the Marquis's sharp eyes."

Chapter 37

"My master also shares an irreconcilable enmity with Wei Yan."

Zhao Xun naturally had smiling eyes that gave an illusion of approachability, yet those same eyes held a distant coldness: "Approaching the Marquis was never about borrowing your influence. My master simply believes that once you learn the truth about the Jinzhou battle sixteen years ago, you too would wish to personally execute Wei Yan. The previous concealment of identity wasn't intentional—my master merely wished to reveal himself at the proper time."

Xie Zheng's gaze turned icy sharp, though a suspicion had already formed in his mind. Still, he asked, "Who is your master?"

Zhao Xun replied, "The one who miraculously survived the great fire in the Eastern Palace sixteen years ago."

A cold smirk tugged at Xie Zheng's lips. "The imperial grandson? If he still lives, shouldn't he have sought alliance with Grand Tutor Li's faction? Why wait until now to approach a defeated dog like me?"

Zhao Xun's expression turned troubled. "You've investigated the traces of the Jinzhou battle from sixteen years ago. You must know how thoroughly Wei Yan eliminates all evidence—leaving no loose ends. When the Crown Prince died and the Eastern Palace burned, even with the Ministry of Justice and the Court of Revision jointly investigating under the Late Emperor's orders, they found nothing conclusive. How much harder would it be now, when all has changed? Grand Tutor Li leads the righteous faction at court, but he wouldn't stake everything to oppose the Wei Faction for my master's sake. You're different, Marquis. General Xie died on the battlefield, his corpse hung from the city walls by the Northern Jue for three days—Wei Yan bears responsibility for that too. Don't you wish to avenge this?"

Xie Zheng's fingers clenched, a murderous aura seeping from his very bones, making the spacious chamber feel suffocating. "Tell me then—what truly happened sixteen years ago?"

Zhao Xun said, "Despite years of hiding, my master found no concrete clues about the Jinzhou battle. After the Eastern Palace fire, the investigation concluded it was caused by a night attendant knocking over a candle while asleep. But according to loyal servants who survived, assassins stormed the palace that night. The Crown Princess ordered her attendants to flee with the young heir while she remained in the chambers with the heir's childhood companion. The body found in the ruins was that companion."

"With Chengde Crown Prince's death and the Late Emperor's passing, Wei Yan has controlled the court through the young emperor for over a decade. The Jinzhou battle was undoubtedly his doing. General Xie's death alongside the Crown Prince merely served to clear Wei Yan of suspicion."

Xie Zheng's dark eyes lifted slightly, impatience tightening his brow. "I demand evidence, not conjecture."

Zhao Xun smiled faintly. "When Changxin Wang rebelled in Chongzhou, one of his strategists was my master's man. He proposed the slogan 'Purge the Court of Evil, Remove the Wei Faction' and spread rumors that Wei Yan orchestrated the Jinzhou Massacre. You know what followed—merely reviewing the case records made Wei Yan attempt your life."

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes, his gaze razor-sharp as he laughed coldly. "So I was but a piece in your scheme."

Zhao Xun stiffened. "You overestimate us, Marquis. My master only wishes to ally with you."

Seeing Xie Zheng's displeased expression, Zhao Xun quickly added, "That old traitor Wei Yan indeed revealed his flaws after the explosion. His Martial Assassins have crossed one capital and seventeen prefectures, killing over a dozen people. My master has identified some of them—they were all former retainers who served Wei Yan before retiring."

Xie Zheng asked, "I suppose you've also uncovered the identity of that Fan butcher's family?"

Zhao Xun looked ashamed. "The identity of that Fan butcher is sealed tighter than a drum. No matter how thoroughly my master investigated—whether in the Fan family's ancestral home or this town—every covert inquiry confirmed his existence. Even the government has records of his escort missions from over a decade ago. It seems someone in the authorities deliberately helped conceal his past identity."

For a moment, Xie Zheng's mind wandered to how Fan Changyu had spoken of her parents' past. A snowflake landed on the back of his hand, its melting chill snapping him back to focus.

Leaning back slightly, he draped one arm over the rosewood Grand Tutor chair's armrest. His casual posture radiated an overwhelming pressure. "Expecting this Marquis to believe your master is the imperial grandson who supposedly perished in a fire sixteen years ago, based solely on your words, is laughable."

Zhao Xun's expression changed, but before he could speak, Xie Zheng continued, "This Marquis will investigate the truth behind the Jinzhou battle sixteen years ago myself. Whether your master is the real imperial grandson or an imposter matters not. If you wish this alliance to continue, he'd best come see me in person."

Zhao Xun's face darkened, but he could only clasp his hands and say, "This Zhao will relay the Marquis's words."

As Xie Zheng stood, his eyelids drooped lazily. "And tell him to decide what he'll offer in exchange for those two hundred thousand bushels of grain."

Zhao Xun's already bowed frame bent even lower. "Understood."

When leaving, Xie Zheng placed the jade ring—originally a token of their alliance—back on the rosewood table.

His prolonged pretense with this Zhao fellow had merely been to uncover which faction he represented. The "imperial grandson" answer was unexpected indeed.

Xie Zheng wasn't worried about losing track of them. When sending Zhao to purchase grain, he'd already had his own men secretly monitor the Zhao family's intelligence outposts. Peeling back the layers from these leads, he'd soon uncover the mastermind even if they didn't show themselves.

While he did bear grudges against Wei Yan, someone daring to scheme against him before the dust had settled—simply to make him their pawn—clearly underestimated his ruthlessness.

Exiting the bookstore and finding the Fan sisters hadn't arrived yet, Xie Zheng frowned slightly and headed toward Head Constable Wang's residence.

Before long, he encountered Fan Changyu and Changning. The younger girl's cheeks bulged with candy as she skipped along, her chubby hand held by Changyu, whose face shone with bright, vibrant smiles.

Spotting Xie Zheng, her smile didn't waver. She waved from afar and called out as they approached, "We're not returning to town tonight."

Seeing her smile lifted some of the gloom from Xie Zheng's heart. "Why not?" he asked.

Fan Changyu said, "Shopkeeper Yu has opened another Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion in the county town. The son of a local official is getting married and has booked the banquet there. They need to prepare a large amount of braised meat tomorrow, and Shopkeeper Yu is worried they won't have enough time, so he asked me to go help with the preparation early tomorrow morning. Coincidentally, the county is hosting a Lantern Festival this year, so we can go see the lanterns in the evening."

Xie Zheng asked, "Should we find an inn first?"

Fan Changyu shook her head. "Shopkeeper Yu has already arranged accommodation for us. The kitchen helpers and servers at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion not only get their meals covered by the establishment, but Shopkeeper Yu also rented a nearby residential area where they can stay for free."

Xie Zheng raised an eyebrow slightly. "This shopkeeper is quite an unusual person."

Fan Changyu laughed. "Indeed, Shopkeeper Yu is very kind. All the staff at the restaurant respect him. I heard from Chef Li that other restaurant owners in the county were jealous of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's business and tried to poach the manager Shopkeeper Yu had personally promoted. They offered twice the salary, but the manager still refused to leave."

Xie Zheng simply said, "Sometimes, loyalty is indeed more valuable than money."

Fan Changyu enthusiastically shared many things about Yu Qianqian with him, but his responses were indifferent, so she eventually stopped. Noticing he wasn't carrying anything, she asked, "Weren't you going to buy paper and ink? Why did you come back empty-handed?"

A thought occurred to her, and her expression turned complicated. "Don't tell me you spent all your money buying things for Ning Niang? If you were short on funds, you should have told me..."

Xie Zheng gave a faint smile, the gloom from leaving the bookstore mostly gone. "No."

Under Fan Changyu's suspicious gaze, he explained, "The things at the county bookstore were too expensive. I'll buy them when we return to town."

Fan Changyu asked, "Then why did you stay at the bookstore for so long?"

Xie Zheng replied, "I was reading and lost track of time."

Fan Changyu asked curiously, "If you read for so long without buying anything, wouldn't the bookstore owner give you a hard time?"

Xie Zheng glanced at her. "Who told you that?"

Fan Changyu almost mentioned how Song Yan had once been treated poorly by a bookstore owner for only reading without buying, which left him in a bad mood for days. Later, he would mock that owner for being money-grubbing. But remembering how venomous Xie Zheng became whenever Song Yan was mentioned, she swallowed her words and muttered, "Just a guess."

Xie Zheng studied her for a moment, and Fan Changyu instinctively tensed, afraid he might say something cutting. Fortunately, he didn't mock her the rest of the way.

Since it was already late and they had decided to stay in the county for the night, Fan Changyu still wanted to take Xie Zheng and Changning to see the lanterns in the evening. Instead of heading straight to the accommodation arranged by Yu Qianqian, they stopped at a restaurant for a late-night snack.

On the first day of the new year, only relatively well-off families would eat out.

At the next table, a young couple seemed to have finished their meal. When the waiter came to settle the bill, he smiled at the man and said, "Sir, the total is one tael and two mace."

The man looked frail and scholarly, his expression somewhat timid and uneasy.

The woman beside him said, "He doesn't have money. I'll pay."

Her loud voice drew the attention of many diners in the restaurant.

Some people whispered among themselves, "A grown man having his meal paid for by a woman outside—how disgraceful!"

"Tsk ts, probably just a pretty boy living off someone!"

"I know that guy—he's the live-in son-in-law of the An family, a freeloader. Who knows what that An family woman sees in that spineless fool!"

The man's face burned crimson with shame, wishing he could vanish into the ground.

After the woman settled the bill, he practically fled the restaurant with his head hung low.

Xie Zheng had long finished his meal, watching the earlier commotion with detached indifference.

Across from him, Fan Changyu polished off her third bowl of rice and cleaned every last morsel from the dishes before finally setting down her chopsticks with satisfaction. "Waiter, the bill!" she called.

Fan Changyu had a hearty appetite, and since it was New Year's Eve, she'd ordered a generous spread—though without alcohol, the total wasn't outrageous.

After tallying, the waiter announced, "Eight qian of silver."

As Fan Changyu reached for her purse, Xie Zheng—who'd been sitting opposite her like a jade statue—spoke up: "I'll pay."

Both he and Fan Changyu were exceptionally striking in appearance, already drawing frequent glances in the small eatery. His words now drew even more curious looks their way.

Remembering the earlier couple's incident, Fan Changyu paused her purse retrieval when Xie Zheng offered to pay.

But as Xie Zheng reached into his robe, his expression shifted slightly.

Noticing this, Fan Changyu shot him a questioning look.

A moment later, Xie Zheng withdrew his hand and met her gaze. "You do it," he said.

Chapter 38

The waiter waiting to collect payment and the other diners in the restaurant were all stunned, clearly not expecting such a turn of events.

The men who had mocked the An family's live-in son-in-law were momentarily at a loss.

Fan Changyu was first dumbfounded, then blurted out in confusion, "Was your purse stolen on the way here?"

She then called to the waiter, "I'll pay."

During festivals, the streets were crowded, making it easy for pickpockets to strike.

After Fan Changyu's loud declaration, the roomful of people who had been staring at them returned to their meals, though some commented, "When we go to the Lantern Festival later, the streets will be packed—easier for thieves to strike. We should stay alert!"

Someone else whispered, "That man looks even prettier than a woman. Could he be another pretty boy?"

A companion retorted, "No way—he was just fighting to pay the bill!"

"After seeing the An family's son-in-law humiliated, anyone could put on an act. But with a face like that, he could definitely live off someone..."

Before Xie Zheng could react, Fan Changyu scooped up Changning with one hand and dragged him out of the restaurant with the other.

Once on the street, she caught her breath and asked Xie Zheng, "Was your purse really stolen?"

Xie Zheng's icy expression stiffened slightly before he gave a small nod.

With his skills, it was impossible for someone to pick his pocket without him noticing. The truth was, as Fan Changyu had guessed earlier, he had bought too many things for the child and hadn't realized he didn't have enough money left.

After all, in the past, he had never needed to worry about not having enough silver when buying something.

Fan Changyu recalled that he had visited the Bookstore earlier, thinking the prices there were too high, so he should have known how much money he had left. It shouldn't have come as a surprise when it was time to pay. She sighed, "It must have been stolen in the crowd earlier."

She took out her own purse, counted out two silver coins and a handful of copper coins, and handed them to Xie Zheng. "Take this money. It'll be handy if you see something you want to buy at the Lantern Festival."

Changning also generously offered, "Ning Niang's New Year money can go to Brother-in-law too!"

Her beaming smile made it seem as if they were truly a family.

An odd feeling rose in Xie Zheng's chest. He frowned and said, "No need. I won't be buying anything."

"Why are you so stubborn? Having money on you makes things easier." Thinking he was too embarrassed to take her money, Fan Changyu grabbed his hand and pressed the coins into his palm.

Her hands were always warm, and as she touched him, that warmth seemed to seep through his skin, reaching somewhere deeper.

After she withdrew her hand, Xie Zheng stared at the copper coins and silver pieces in his palm, his fingers curling slightly before he clenched his fist as if hiding something.

Dusk had fallen, and lanterns lit up the streets.

The warm yellow light outlined the sharp lines of his profile as he looked at Fan Changyu, his dark phoenix eyes growing increasingly inscrutable. "Thank you."

"What for? You already bought so much for Changning, and besides, you still have forty taels with me..." Fan Changyu brushed it off.

Xie Zheng listened quietly, only speaking after she finished. "The money for sweets is different."

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned when a burst of cheers suddenly rose from the crowd in the distance. All three of them turned their attention toward the commotion and saw a street performer breathing fire.

It was unclear how the magician managed it—holding a small burning bamboo stick in his hand, with one forceful blow, the tiny flame instantly erupted into a roaring fire. The onlookers gasped and stepped back in alarm when the flames licked too close, then burst into applause and cheers.

Changning found this utterly fascinating and immediately tugged at Fan Changyu's sleeve. "Elder Sister, Ning Niang wants to see the big fire!"

By now, night had fully fallen, and the streets were crowded. Worried that Changning might trip or get jostled, Fan Changyu picked her up and said to Xie Zheng, "The Lantern Festival seems to have started. Let's go take a look over there."

Xie Zheng glanced at the fire-breathing performers, his eyes devoid of any emotion, and said to Fan Changyu, "Let me carry her."

Fan Changyu, with her formidable strength, refused outright. "No need. Your injuries haven't fully healed yet..."

Xie Zheng replied, "Carrying a child won't be a problem."

After a pause, he added, "I noticed that other children on the street are being carried by their fathers or elder brothers."

Fan Changyu scanned the surroundings and realized that families with children at the festival—if accompanied by parents—usually had the father holding the child.

With her and Yan Zheng accompanying Changning, it was easy for others to mistake them for a family of three. Yan Zheng was tall and imposing, and with her carrying Changning, many passersby had already been casting curious glances their way. Some even pointed at Yan Zheng, unaware of the truth.

Remembering the incident at the restaurant earlier, Fan Changyu hesitated briefly before handing Changning over to Xie Zheng, cautioning, "If your arms get tired, pass her back to me."

Xie Zheng gave a calm nod.

He was a head taller than Fan Changyu, and with Changning perched on his shoulder, she could see much farther. Excitedly, she kept pointing here and there, urging them to look. Her enthusiasm was infectious.

Walking side by side with Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu held the painting the scholar had drawn for them, a rare, relaxed smile gracing her face.

Many passersby who saw them couldn't help but murmur admiringly about what a perfect couple they made.

A middle-aged couple with their young child out for the festival caught sight of Fan Changyu's group. The woman, holding her little son, immediately shoved him into her husband's arms and scolded, "Look at how considerate that young man is toward his wife! You useless lump, can't you see my arms are about to fall off?"

The man, now holding the child with both hands, winced as his ear was twisted, hastily apologizing, "Ow, ow! My mistake, my mistake!"

Fan Changyu couldn't help but chuckle, though the woman's words left her feeling slightly self-conscious.

She stole a glance at Xie Zheng, only to find him turning toward her at the same moment. Their eyes met in the flickering lantern light, and he asked, "What is it?"

Clearing her throat, Fan Changyu spotted the Lantern Tower in the distance, adorned with colorful lanterns, and quickly said, "I think there's a lantern riddle game over there. Let's go try it!"

Changning also caught sight of the dazzling array of lanterns and exclaimed, "Ning Niang wants to buy a Pig lantern!"

Fan Changyu laughed. "Alright, let's go take a look first."

Xie Zheng asked, "Is she born in the Year of the Pig?"

Before Fan Changyu could answer, Changning nodded vigorously, counting on her chubby fingers. "Elder Sister is a Tiger, and Ning Niang is a Pig."

Xie Zheng gave Fan Changyu a strange look. "You're only nine years older than your sister?"

Fan Changyu replied, "To be precise, ten years. I was born in the first month of the Year of the Tiger, while my sister was born at the end of the twelfth month of the Year of the Pig."

Her gaze softened as she looked at Changning. "After last December, Ning Niang turned six. According to local customs, we can't openly celebrate children's birthdays during the mourning period for parents to

avoid shortening their lifespans. That's why we didn't prepare any birthday gifts for Ning Niang—just made her a bowl of noodles."

She then turned to Xie Zheng. "You've had it too—it was that bowl of fat intestine noodles."

Xie Zheng: "..."

That wasn't exactly a pleasant memory.

But if her birthday is in the first month, does that mean she'll be sixteen this month?

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes slightly.

Fan Changyu suddenly asked him, "What's your zodiac sign?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer.

She guessed randomly, "You're a Dog, aren't you?"

This sounded somewhat like an insult, and passersby couldn't help but glance back at them.

Xie Zheng shot her a sharp look. Fan Changyu tried to suppress her smile but failed.

She said, "If you really are a Dog, it would suit your personality."

Her smile was utterly unrestrained and radiant.

Xie Zheng glanced at her sideways. "Meaning?"

Fan Changyu cleared her throat. "I've heard that Dogs are particularly vindictive and really good at insults."

Before she could finish, she received a chilling glare.

Fan Changyu felt inexplicably guilty. "Don't you know how sharp your own tongue is?"

Xie Zheng smirked slightly. "I haven't said much about you otherwise. Just that your taste in men is rather poor—still hung up on Song Yan after all this time..."

Fan Changyu now understood the meaning of reaping what one sows. Back then, to avoid him misunderstanding her intentions, she had spun a lie about being deeply in love with Song Yan. Now, this man seized every opportunity to mock her for it.

She couldn't help retorting, "When have I been hung up on him—"

"Pfft—"

A derisive laugh came from behind the lantern wall covered with banners and lanterns.

Fan Changyu looked up to see several young gentlemen, who had been solving lantern riddles, push aside the banners and emerge from behind the wall. Among them was Song Yan.

"Brother Song, you truly are full of surprises," said a man in apricot-yellow robes and a headpiece, pointing at Fan Changyu with a closed fan, his face wearing a frivolous smile. "The magistrate's daughter is smitten with your talents, and even your former fiancée, now married, is at odds with her husband because of you!"

Clearly, he was the one who had laughed earlier.

Fan Changyu's expression darkened instantly. She hadn't expected Song Yan and his classmates to be behind that lantern wall.

Her lips pressed tightly together. The last thing she wanted was for that Song fellow to think she still had feelings for him.

Xie Zheng had met Song Yan before and still remembered him. His cold, oppressive gaze swept over the group of dandy scholars, lingering on Song Yan a moment longer.

Song Yan wore an indigo-blue robe and, despite the cold weather, held a folding fan. When his eyes met Xie Zheng's, he instinctively looked away.

His classmates, however, remained unfazed. They were all men of rank who didn't even have to kneel in court—why should they fear the husband of a butcher's daughter?

The man in the yellow shirt immediately sneered, "Brother, don't lose your temper. Brother Song is the only one from Qingping County who passed the provincial imperial exam. It's understandable that your wife still thinks of him."

Another man beside him studied Fan Changyu for a long while before suddenly clapping his hands and laughing. "I remember now! One year, this young lady even came to the county school to deliver winter clothes to Brother Song. At the time, I asked Brother Song who she was, and he said she was his younger sister!"

"It seems this young lady is indeed deeply in love with Brother Song. No wonder that gentleman flew into a rage at the mere mention of him..."

The Lantern Festival was bustling with activity, and the group's back-and-forth drew many passersby to stop and watch. Some onlookers even pointed fingers at Fan Changyu.

"So this is the former fiancée who broke off her engagement with Scholar Song."

"She's quite a beauty, but now that she's married, why still pine for Scholar Song? Only a live-in son-in-law could tolerate such humiliation..."

"What a coincidence to run into her here. Did she know Scholar Song would attend the Lantern Festival tonight and come specifically to see him?"

Hearing this, Song Yan glanced at Fan Changyu before turning away and saying to his companions, "Let's go. These lantern riddles aren't worth solving anyway."

The whispers and Song Yan's dismissive look made Fan Changyu's blood boil with fury, her entire body trembling with disgust.

Xie Zheng glanced at her before lazily calling out to the group, "Stop."

His tone was casual, but it carried the weight of a command.

At his words, the crowd grew even more intrigued.

Song Yan and his companions halted. His classmates turned back with smug, mocking expressions.

The man in the yellow shirt teased, "What, brother? Planning to fight us? We're all scholars with official titles. Lay a finger on us, and you'll regret it for the rest of your life."

Xie Zheng's lips curled into an even colder smirk. "After a decade of studying the classics, is this all you've learned? Slandering a woman—is this how scholars behave?"

The group faltered, looking embarrassed.

"Apologize," he demanded icily.

Only the man in the yellow shirt retorted, "We never slandered anyone. We merely stated facts."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids lazily, his words dripping with scorn. "Did your imperial exam essays also consist of nothing but gossip about women? Forget the virtues of a gentleman—you've mastered the art of wagging tongues. Did you crawl out of a male brothel?"

The crowd burst into laughter.

Someone even shouted, "Well said! A bunch of so-called scholars, gossiping like fishwives! Even the male prostitutes at the brothels aren't as sharp-tongued as you!"

The man in the yellow shirt flushed crimson with rage, pointing at Xie Zheng. "You—you—"

His companion chimed in indignantly, "Such shameless, vulgar words! A disgrace to decency!"

Xie Zheng scoffed. "Decency? You're unworthy of the word. A few years of study, and you think you're above everyone else? Do you not know that when geese fly south, even phoenixes find no place to land?"

As he spoke, his indifferent gaze settled squarely on Song Yan, making it clear the remark was directed at him.

Several scholars were stunned to learn that Xie Zheng was also a scholar, their faces quickly twisting with indignation. His final remark had clearly been meant to humiliate them, yet they couldn't think of a suitable retort, leaving their expressions utterly sour.

After Xie Zheng's words, Song Yan's expression shifted unpredictably before he finally clasped his hands in apology. "My two friends spoke out of turn earlier and offended Miss Fan... Madam Fan. I apologize on their behalf to both of you."

Seeing Song Yan take the lead, the others, however unwilling, followed suit and bowed. "We were in the wrong earlier and offer our sincerest apologies."

Xie Zheng remained silent, his gaze shifting to Fan Changyu.

Changyu knew Xie Zheng was well-versed in literature, but she hadn't expected him to single-handedly outwit these scholars. After a brief moment of surprise, she coldly retorted, "When I joke with my husband, what business is it of you scholars to meddle? My husband has both looks and talent. I'm neither foolish nor blind—why would I pine for someone else?"

This drew laughter from many in the crowd.

Song Yan's face flushed red and then paled, his fingers stiffening as he clasped his hands.

Xie Zheng lazily lifted his eyes. Though he knew most of her words were just to save face, they still sounded pleasing to his ears.

After all... he didn't think they were lies either.

Having reclaimed her dignity, Changyu took Changning's hand and scoffed, "Let's go."

Xie Zheng cast a fleeting glance at the scholars still rooted in place before leisurely following after her.

Song Yan and his companions burned with humiliation.

Onlookers continued to gossip. "They say scholars are often heartless. That Song Yan broke off the engagement after passing the provincial exam, and now he even brought his friends to mock the Fan girl in public—how despicable!"

"That Fan family's live-in son-in-law seems even more talented than these scholars. I wonder if he'll take the Imperial exam. If he passes, the Fan family's fortunes will surely rise!"

Hidden in the shadows of the lanterns, Song Yan's face darkened.

His friends, desperate to salvage their pride, jeered, "A pretty-faced live-in husband—if he really had the talent for the Imperial exam, he wouldn't have had to marry into the family!"

"In my opinion, he wouldn't even pass the preliminary exams!"

Song Yan listened, his icy expression unyielding, and finally said, "Let's call it a day. We'll meet again another time."

With his dismissal, the others, too ashamed to linger after such a public disgrace, dispersed.

Xie Zheng trailed a few steps behind Changyu as they walked in silence. After a moment, he suddenly said, "Earlier... I spoke out of turn."

If he hadn't mentioned Song Yan first, those men wouldn't have overheard and mocked her from behind the lantern wall.

Changyu paused briefly before replying, "It's nothing. You already helped me. Besides, I deceived you first."

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze. "Deceived me how?"

Changyu ruffled her hair, slightly embarrassed. "Earlier, I lied and said I hadn't gotten over him because I didn't want you to think I had feelings for you."

At this, a flicker of something unreadable passed through Xie Zheng's eyes.

He said, "I thought... you were upset."

Changyu shot him a look that clearly said, "How could I be?"

They had now left the lantern-lit street behind, the surroundings growing quiet and desolate. The occasional alley they passed was dark and eerie.

Xie Zheng asked, "Is this the way to the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion?"

"No," Fan Changyu replied, then handed Changning to Xie Zheng to hold. "Cover Ning Niang's eyes later and take her somewhere far away."

Xie Zheng was silent for a moment before asking, "What are you going to do?"

Fan Changyu led him to crouch in a dark corner, pulling out the hemp bag and laundry bat she had bought when leaving the market. Baring her little canine teeth, she said, "That guy in the yellow robe has such a foul mouth—of course I have to beat him up to vent my anger!"

Chapter 39

The moon set in the frosty sky, and cold stars dotted the heavens.

A man in apricot-yellow robes left the bustling Lantern Festival street, his mood sullen as he headed toward the pleasure district.

While the festival was alive with noise and excitement, the other streets and alleys untouched by the lantern light lay like beasts lurking silently in the dark, eerie and dangerous.

Fortunately, just a street away, the pleasure district hung with red lanterns came into view, its lights casting a seductive glow once more.

As the man in yellow passed through this unavoidable route away from the festival, something suddenly descended over his head, blocking his vision. He barely had time to scream before a heavy blow struck his abdomen. The excruciating pain made him curl up instantly, the cry dying in his throat.

Then a fierce kick landed on his backside, sending him tumbling into a pitch-black alley, where a rain of blows from sticks and fists pummeled him.

The man wailed and begged, curling into a ball inside the burlap sack with his arms shielding his head, "Spare me, good sirs! Stop! I have money—take all the silver on me, just let me go!"

No one answered. Instead, several punches landed on his face through the sack.

His screams grew even more pitiful. Passersby who heard the cries from the dark alley dared not intervene for fear of trouble, only shouting from a distance, "Call the authorities! Someone's being beaten in that alley!"

Fan Changyu, not wanting to leave behind evidence, quickly stashed her laundry bat and carefully yanked the burlap sack off the man's upper body.

But she pulled too hard. The force sent the man face-first into the ground, breaking one of his front teeth. His agonized shriek was so loud it could be heard all the way to the pleasure district.

Changyu froze for a moment. Hearing hurried footsteps approaching the alley entrance, she wasted no time and sprinted toward the other end.

She had deliberately chosen this dark alley, which connected to streets on both sides, for an easy escape.

Xie Zheng was waiting at the far end with Changning. The two met without a word, moving swiftly away from the scene in perfect sync.

Only after putting two streets between them did Xie Zheng ask, "What did you do to him?"

Given the man's bloodcurdling screams, it didn't sound like a simple beating.

Changyu said, "I didn't do anything. He was just too clumsy. When I pulled the sack, he stumbled and broke his tooth on the ground."

Xie Zheng glanced at her sideways, skepticism clear in his gaze.

Changyu insisted, "...I'm not lying."

Xie Zheng asked, "Are we still dealing with the others?"

Changyu nearly rolled her eyes. "No. Beating all of them in one day would just make it obvious it was me. That one had a foul mouth, so I roughed him up first to vent. The others can wait for another chance."

Meanwhile, the man in yellow, still howling in the alley, was finally helped up by the arriving officers.

Both his eyes were blackened, one front tooth was missing, his mouth was full of blood, and two streams of crimson dripped from his nose. By the torchlight, he finally spotted his broken tooth on the ground and wailed, "My tooth! How am I supposed to enter officialdom now?!"

As the county magistrate's nephew, he barked at the constables, "What are you waiting for? Investigate! Arrest the thugs who assaulted me!"

The constable on duty today wiped the sweat from his temple and asked, "Young master, have you made any enemies recently?"

The man in the yellow robe thought carefully, wincing from the pain as he spoke, "A few days ago, that little bastard from the Wang family tried to steal a courtesan from me at the brothel. I humiliated him—it's probably him! And that son of the Liu family, who acts all high and mighty but failed

the imperial exams again—I mocked him too, so it could also be him. Oh, and the Li family..."

The constable's head spun as the man listed a string of people he had conflicts with.

Finally, the man in yellow remembered the incident at tonight's Lantern Festival and added, "Oh, tonight I also helped Brother Song mock his former fiancée."

The matter wasn't exactly honorable—after all, many had witnessed the county's top scholars being left speechless by a mere son-in-law. He cut himself off and asked, "Were Brother Song Yan and the others attacked by the assailants too?"

When the constable shook his head, the man immediately scoffed, "A butcher's daughter and her sickly son-in-law? I doubt they'd have the guts. Go investigate the families I mentioned earlier!"

As the constables set off to investigate, the man groaned and was helped to a nearby medical hall to treat his injuries.

When Fan Changyu arrived at the temporary lodgings arranged by the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, the matron was still awake.

Seeing them, she smiled and asked, "Did you enjoy the Lantern Festival?"

Changning had already fallen asleep on Xie Zheng's shoulder on the way back. Changyu, still feeling a bit guilty about the fight, replied vaguely, "It was nice. Very lively, with people everywhere."

The matron led them to a room, opening the door with a smile. "This is the only room left. Please make do for the night."

Changyu thanked her and asked for a pot of hot water to wash up. After quickly wiping Changning's hands and face, she tucked the child into bed.

She washed her own face but found little hot water left in the pot. Not wanting to trouble the matron to boil more at this late hour, she poured the used wash water into the foot basin for a quick soak.

By the time Xie Zheng finished washing his face with the remaining hot water, her feet were still in the basin. Seeing him about to pour out the wash water, she quickly said, "Just pour it in here."

Xie Zheng hesitated for a moment before carrying the basin over.

Changyu lifted her feet and rested them on the edge of the basin to make it easier for him.

Perhaps due to years without sunlight, her feet were strikingly pale, glowing like warm jade in the candlelight, with a small black mole near her ankle that stood out oddly.

Xie Zheng glanced briefly before lowering his gaze to avoid looking further.

In the capital, a woman's bare feet being seen was akin to losing her virtue. But in this border town, customs were more relaxed—women washing clothes by the river often went barefoot without a second thought.

Though her carefree nature made this gesture hardly improper, Xie Zheng still felt a faint unease.

Changyu noticed him sitting far away after pouring the water and asked, "Aren't you going to soak your feet?"

Xie Zheng replied, "You go first. I'll rinse mine with cold water outside later."

Changyu widened her eyes. "In this freezing weather? You'll catch a cold by tomorrow!"

Over the past month of living together, she had noticed that Yan Zheng was a cleanly person. Thinking he didn't want to use water she'd already used, she said: "In our family, we used to soak our feet in the same basin of water. I forgot about your cleanliness habits. Later I'll go ask the housekeeper and boil another pot of water for you in the kitchen."

Xie Zheng frowned slightly before finally saying: "No need, this water will do."

The Fan family members were all quite clean, frequently changing their shoes and socks, so the used water didn't look dirty at all.

It was just that his mind was in turmoil.

When he put his feet into the basin and saw the water marks on the rim, his mind involuntarily pictured her feet resting there moments before.

Xie Zheng's brows instantly furrowed deeper. His feet had barely touched the water when he hastily stood up to empty the basin.

Changyu sat at the table, watching with her mouth slightly agape. When he returned, she said with complicated emotions: "There's nothing wrong with having cleanliness habits. I don't think you're being disdainful. You don't need to force yourself like this..."

Xie Zheng looked into her sincere, clear eyes under the candlelight, his handsome features showing self-disgust as he simply said: "It's not what you think."

With only one bed and one quilt in the room, he placed the wooden basin back inside and headed for the door: "You should rest early."

Changyu found his behavior rather strange. "What about you?" she asked.

Surely he wouldn't sit outside all night? The housekeeper had clearly said this was the only room left.

Xie Zheng replied: "I'll go ask if I can share a room with the staff at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion."

Even after he left and the door closed behind him, Changyu still wore a slightly bewildered expression.

Why was he suddenly treating her like some kind of monster?

Had the burlap sack prank scared him that much?

Or was the foot-washing water really that traumatizing?

Chapter 40

Snowflakes drifted down beneath the eaves, dusting the steps with a thin layer of white.

Xie Zheng leaned against a pillar with his arms crossed, his eyes half-lowered in thought. The warm glow from the lantern above cast shadows of his long, delicate lashes beneath his eyelids.

He had seen many beauties before, even witnessed barefoot Western dancers performing at Wei Yan's banquets.

The details of those dancers' feet had long faded from memory, leaving only the impression of golden anklets adorned with bells that jingled with every movement—like a silent invitation.

When he caught sight of Fan Changyu's bare feet, for some reason, those golden bells flashed through his mind again.

Then came the absurdity of the thought.

Followed by a wave of self-disgust at having disrespected her.

Xie Zheng rubbed his temples irritably. Since childhood, he had lived under others' roofs, adhering to his late father's legacy by diligently studying military strategy and honing his martial skills. Wei Yan's strict discipline over him and Wei Xuan had extended to forbidding any indulgence in romantic affairs—even their attendants were exclusively male servants, with not a single maidservant in sight.

Once he joined the battlefield, his focus had been solely on combat, leaving no room for such distractions.

Wei Xuan, whether out of defiance or sheer rebelliousness, frequently visited brothels and kept mistresses, earning himself repeated punishments from Wei Yan.

Back then, Wei Xuan had mocked him for being nothing but an obedient dog, sneering, Do you even know the taste of a woman's tenderness? Xie Zheng had shared Wei Yan's disdain, convinced that such a man would never achieve greatness.

Though reluctant to admit it, Wei Yan's influence had once run deep in him. The man believed that those in power must master control over their desires—that lust was the basest of them all.

After returning from the military, Xie Zheng occasionally attended unavoidable banquets where delicate, boneless dancers earned raucous applause. He felt only contempt.

Like Wei Yan, he scorned the decadence of the capital's elite, convinced that such indulgence would only weaken a man's spine.

If he were to marry, it would be to a woman worthy of the Xie family's name—not someone fragile like his mother.

The battlefield was merciless; one day, he might meet the same fate as his father. He needed no one to die for love—only a wife strong enough to uphold the Xie family's legacy after his passing.

This was the standard by which all noble sons in the capital chose their brides.

But these past few days... what had come over him?

Images of Fan Changyu surfaced unbidden—slaughtering pigs, cutting down enemies, gritting her teeth in endurance...

She was remarkable, even more resilient than many noblewomen. Yet the simplicity of her upbringing left her ill-equipped to navigate the vipers' den... She could never be the matriarch the Xie family required.

The realization of what he was thinking stunned him.

When the matron patrolling the courtyard with a lantern spotted him under the eaves, she asked, "Young man, why aren't you resting in your room?"

Xie Zheng collected himself. "I was just about to find you. Could I share a room with the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's staff tonight?"

The matron frowned. "You're Lady Fan's husband. Why not stay with her?"

He fabricated an excuse. "She's sharing the room with her younger sister. It wouldn't be proper."

The stewardess thought to herself how young Changning was, but considering that even a little girl needed her privacy, she nodded and said,

"It was thoughtless of me. The workers here share rooms in pairs, and there are no extra rooms. However, one of the workers snores so loudly that his roommate can't sleep. If you don't mind, you can stay in his room for the night."

Xie Zheng said he didn't mind, so the stewardess led him to the worker's room.

Even before entering, the thunderous snoring could be heard from outside. Xie Zheng fell silent for a moment.

The stewardess pushed open the door, and the creaking of the hinges didn't wake the worker in the slightest. She guided Xie Zheng inside, lit the oil lamp, and pointed to an empty single bed nearby. "You can sleep here tonight."

Xie Zheng thanked her, and the stewardess left with the lamp.

He took off his outer robe, lay down with his arm as a pillow, and found himself unable to sleep. The worker's snoring from the opposite bed was like thunder, making it impossible for him to even close his eyes.

After enduring it for a quarter of an hour, Xie Zheng got up, walked to the worker's bedside, and struck the back of his neck with a swift chop. The worker was knocked unconscious, and the snoring stopped instantly.

He lay back down but still couldn't sleep.

He had never thought about a future with Fan Changyu before, but tonight, the idea of marriage inexplicably unsettled him.

He knew Fan Changyu wasn't suited to be the matriarch of the Xie family. Yet the thought of returning to the capital and marrying a well-bred noblewoman who could manage the Xie household with grace and propriety filled him with an instinctive aversion.

It was as if he had found a wild grass thriving in the wilderness—he liked it, but if he dug it up and placed it among rare and exotic flowers, others would only mock its plainness.

Wild grass is only free and resilient in its own wilderness. Once placed in an exquisite porcelain pot and meticulously tended, it ceases to be wild grass.

He raised a hand to his forehead, resting the back of it against his brow, his lips pressed tightly together in the darkness.

Before dawn the next day, Fan Changyu was already up. Changning was still asleep, so she dressed quietly, left the room, and asked the stewardess to keep an eye on Changning before heading to the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion.

The layout of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion in the county town was similar to the one in Lin'an Town, though more grandly built.

The errand boys hadn't arrived in the main hall yet, but the kitchen staff were all present.

The pig heads to be braised had already been prepared, so Fan Changyu didn't even need to light the fire herself—she only had to prepare the braising spices.

Yu Qianqian personally discussed with the chefs the order of dishes for the banquet—which to serve first, which to follow, and what the grand finale would be.

Though an outsider to such matters, Fan Changyu could tell how meticulous the planning was. Some dishes lost their flavor if left too long, while serving too many elaborate dishes in a row would overwhelm the kitchen and delay service—a disgrace for the host.

For ordinary households, late dishes might not matter, but for the elite guests who had booked the banquet, delays would shame the host, who would then hold the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion accountable. Word would spread, tarnishing the pavilion's reputation.

After finalizing the details with the chefs, Yu Qianqian noticed Fan Changyu sitting behind the stove and, without any airs, squeezed in beside her to warm herself by the fire. "It's only the second day of the new year, and I've already dragged you here to help. You must be exhausted."

Fan Changyu said, "Shopkeeper Yu, you have so much to handle. It must be exhausting."

Yu Qianqian smiled. "Making money is never easy. If we pull off this deal, Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's reputation in the county will be firmly established."

When Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion first opened in the county town, it was sabotaged by Wang's Braised Meat, and business had been lukewarm ever since. The local elites even joked about the inauspicious incident on opening day.

To elevate the pavilion's status, Yu Qianqian had gifted many novel and expensive presents to noblewomen, finally securing today's exclusive banquet.

As if remembering something, she asked Fan Changyu, "By the way, does your braised meat have a logo?"

Fan Changyu looked puzzled. "What's that?"

Yu Qianqian slapped her own forehead. "My fault—I've been too busy to mention it earlier. It's like Wang's Braised Meat—they have their own custom signboard."

Fan Changyu shook her head.

Yu Qianqian explained, "Your braised meat here competes directly with Wang's from Drunken Immortal Pavilion. Even if you don't have a logo, you should at least have some well-written characters to make it presentable."

Fan Changyu was confused. "Braised meat is just sliced and served on a plate. Does it really matter if there's a logo?"

Yu Qianqian said, "You must have noticed when you came in—some shops downstairs are rented out. Fang's tea and Li's liquor are sold there. I've reserved a spot for your braised meat too. Later, make more and display it there. Whatever you sell is yours. We need to build your reputation. Otherwise, if our pavilion serves braised meat without any branding, wouldn't we look inferior to Drunken Immortal Pavilion?"

She stood up. "I'll have someone find a scholar with good handwriting to make a temporary banner for you."

Thinking of Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu quickly said, "My husband can write. I'll ask him later."

Yu Qianqian hesitated. "How good is his handwriting?"

Fan Changyu replied, "His writing is beautiful!"

After her repeated assurances and with many tasks still at hand, Yu Qianqian said, "Then go find your husband now. If it doesn't work out, I'll send for a scholar."

The braised meat was already simmering, so all that was left was to watch the fire. Without delay, Fan Changyu agreed and went to the alley behind Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion to find Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng had been unable to sleep last night, lost in thought, and only dozed off at dawn.

But he was soon awakened by the commotion of the housekeeper calling the other workers.

The housekeeper muttered as she roused them, "This lad never seemed lazy before. How come he's still asleep at this hour?"

The worker she woke blinked in confusion. Seeing it was already light, he hurriedly dressed but yelped in pain as he moved, rubbing his neck. "I must have slept wrong—my neck hurts."

The housekeeper scolded, "That's what happens when you laze around in bed!"

Feeling guilty for oversleeping, the worker grimaced, finished dressing, and rushed to wash his face before heading to work in the pavilion.

By then, the courtyard was bustling with the sounds of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's staff moving about. Xie Zheng had no intention of going back to sleep.

After a sleepless night, the stubble on his chin had darkened. Just as he finished washing up, Fan Changyu came looking for him. Noticing the dark circles under his eyes, she asked curiously, "Did you stay up all night?"

At that moment, the housekeeper happened to pass by the courtyard. Hearing Fan Changyu's words and seeing Xie Zheng's exhausted appearance from lack of sleep, she said, "I mentioned last night that the child in the hall snores quite loudly. Young man, you must have been kept awake by it, right?"

Unsure how to respond to Fan Changyu, Xie Zheng hesitated before nodding at the housekeeper's words.

Fan Changyu immediately looked at him with sympathy.

After the housekeeper left, she said, "Get some proper rest tonight when we go home. Right now, there's something I need your help with."

Perhaps due to his lack of sleep, Xie Zheng found himself distracted by the movement of her red lips as she spoke, failing to catch her words. Instead, he recalled the brief dream he'd had during the little sleep he managed to get.

In the dream, they had parted ways as agreed, and she had married someone else, still wearing the same wedding dress from their own wedding day. Though the face of her new husband was unclear, the radiant, unrestrained smile on her face was painfully bright, as if she had married someone who truly pleased her.

He couldn't quite describe the feeling in his heart, but it was certainly unpleasant.

Now, looking at Fan Changyu again, the corners of his lips unconsciously turned downward.

Seeing that Xie Zheng hadn't responded at all and was instead staring at her with a gloomy expression, Fan Changyu waved her hand in front of his eyes. "Did you hear what I said?"

Xie Zheng snapped out of his thoughts and quickly composed himself. "Go on."

Fan Changyu eyed him suspiciously. "What were you thinking about just now?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Nothing. I just woke up and am still a bit groggy."

Having experienced grogginess from poor sleep herself, Fan Changyu didn't suspect he was lying and got to the point. "Can you help me write a few characters?"

Xie Zheng asked, "What do you need written?"

Fan Changyu explained, "Shopkeeper Yu said today's business is in competition with Drunken Immortal Pavilion, and we can't afford to fall behind. Our braised meat needs its own signboard, like Wang's Braised Meat. Shopkeeper Yu has reserved a spot for us in the main hall downstairs. There's no time to have a plaque made, so we'll have to make do with a cloth banner for now."

Xie Zheng nodded. "Do you have the ink, brush, and cloth ready?"

Fan Changyu said, "Shopkeeper Yu prepared them."

Xie Zheng replied, "Let's go then."

The Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's staff accommodations were located in the alley behind the restaurant, making it convenient for travel. Usually, groceries were delivered and swill was collected from this alley, as the back door of the restaurant opened here.

As Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng stepped out, they unfortunately ran into the swill collectors.

The collectors had been off for New Year's Eve and New Year's Day, so the restaurant had accumulated swill that needed to be cleared early in the morning.

Fortunately, it was the dead of winter, so the swill hadn't developed much of a smell after two days.

However, the alley was narrow, and when the swill cart passed by, one had to stand as close to the side as possible to avoid getting splashed with waste from the barrels.

Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng moved aside. Just as the cart was about to pass, one of its wheels hit a stone, causing the entire cart to jolt. The lid of the swill barrel on the side bounced open, and some of the contents spilled out.

Xie Zheng frowned and swiftly pulled Fan Changyu toward him.

Fan Changyu was yanked forward, her head colliding with his unyielding chest. The slop from the swill bucket splashed onto the spot where she had just been standing.

The old man pulling the swill cart turned around, apologizing repeatedly, "So sorry, so sorry! Just hit a stone back there. Didn't splash on you, did it?"

Xie Zheng glanced at Fan Changyu's skirt hem and said, "No harm done. You can move along, uncle."

Only then did the old man urge his horse onward again.

Noticing Fan Changyu had remained silent while he still gripped her wrist, Xie Zheng's heart skipped a beat. He instantly released her hand, hiding it behind his back as if his palm were about to catch fire. "You—"

But after that single word, he fell silent.

Fan Changyu hung her head low. Two drops of nosebleed landed on the thin-iced bluestone pavement, her expression utterly defeated.

She'd hit his chest too hard—hard enough to make her nose bleed.

After two beats of silence, Xie Zheng said, "My apologies."

Fan Changyu mumbled a nasal "It's fine," but the pain from her bruised nose bridge brought involuntary tears to her eyes, making her look rather pitiful.

She pulled out her handkerchief and wiped haphazardly, but the moment she finished, fresh blood trickled out again. Tilting her head back to stem the flow, she was immediately stopped by a large hand pressing the back of her skull downward.

Xie Zheng said, "Don't tilt your head back during a nosebleed."

Left with no choice, Fan Changyu pressed the handkerchief to her nostrils and lamented, "Blood first thing in the morning—guess today's my unlucky day."

Xie Zheng apologized again, to which Fan Changyu replied with some exasperation, "I was joking! How could I be unlucky? I'm blessed with fortune, raking in riches by the day!"

The bleeding seemed to have stopped, but her nose still felt terribly uncomfortable. Removing the handkerchief, she sniffled and said, "Guess it's true that fortune and misfortune come hand in hand. Dodged the disaster of being drenched in swill only to get a nosebleed from crashing into you. A nosebleed's still better than a swill bath—so really, I came out ahead!"

To reassure Xie Zheng, she even wiggled her nostrils emphatically. "See? The bleeding's already stopped—"

Her last word caught in her throat.

Xie Zheng took her handkerchief and gently dabbed beside her nose. "There's still some blood here. Since it just stopped, don't breathe too forcefully."

Even through the cloth, she could distinctly feel the pressure of his fingertips.

This man must have been extraordinarily favored by the heavens at birth—his sharp brows and starry eyes, his refined yet thoroughly masculine features. A light breeze swept past him, stirring his sleeves and the loose strands at his temples, while a withered brown leaf trembled on a branch overhead before drifting down.

Fan Changyu suddenly felt like a lobster brandishing its claws triumphantly, only to freeze stupidly, unsure how to wave them anymore.

Xie Zheng withdrew his hand. Seeing her dazed expression, he asked, "Still hurts?"

She shook her head and joked halfheartedly, "If you stayed this good-tempered all the time, you wouldn't have to worry about girls not liking you."

Xie Zheng's gaze chilled momentarily. His dark eyes narrowed at her as he pinched her handkerchief between thumb and forefinger, replying with a humorless smile, "Then I'll take that as your blessing."

Fan Changyu was baffled. She'd complimented him—why had his tone suddenly turned prickly?

They entered Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion through the back door. While Xie Zheng wrote on the triangular cloth banner Yu Qianqian had prepared, Fan Changyu, remembering he hadn't eaten breakfast, fetched steamed buns and porridge from the kitchen—the same fare the servers ate—and brought them to him.

When Fan Changyu came out, Xie Zheng's table where he was writing the banners was already surrounded by many staff members, even the accountant from the building was praising his exceptional calligraphy.

Once the ink on the banners dried, the staff helped hang them up.

Fan Changyu glanced at them. Though the words were just the ordinary "Fan's Braised Meat," his brushwork made them strikingly beautiful—bold yet elegant. The four triangular banners looked even more impressive than gilded plaques when hung.

In high spirits, Fan Changyu handed Xie Zheng a bowl of porridge and some steamed buns: "Eat something to fill your stomach first."

Yu Qianqian passed through the hall and saw the words written on the red silk banners she had the servants hastily prepare. She couldn't help but click her tongue in admiration, praising Fan Changyu for finding such a talented husband.

She also gave Fan Changyu an idea: "Sister Changyu, later you should order some custom paper bags and print these words your husband wrote on them. When people come to buy your braised meat, use these bags. Your reputation will surely surpass Wang's in no time."

Most vendors in the market used oiled paper to wrap cooked food, and Fan Changyu's shop was no exception. The oiled paper had a smooth side

for wrapping food and a rough side facing outward.

Fan Changyu had also noticed that the hotpot base sold at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion came in printed paper boxes adorned with floral and bird designs, tied with fine hemp rope in beautiful knots she had never seen before.

Yu Qianqian had specifically asked her to prepare an extra pot of braised meat to sell in the shop.

Inspired, Fan Changyu slipped out while Xie Zheng was eating his porridge and returned with a stack of oiled paper and a roll of fine hemp rope. She sliced half a pound of pork head meat and tried wrapping it in the oiled paper, securing it with a knot. It looked decent, though the paper lacked the "Fan's" branding.

Just as Xie Zheng finished his plain porridge and pickles, he noticed Fan Changyu staring at him intently: "Xie Zheng, could you write a few more characters for me?"

Xie Zheng: "..."

Before Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion opened for lunch, he had inscribed over a hundred sheets of oiled paper.

When Yu Qianqian passed by again and saw Fan Changyu's quick fix, she laughed: "Truly, when husband and wife work together, their strength can break metal." Noticing Fan Changyu's crooked knots, she even taught her how to tie them properly: "Loop the rope this way before tying, and it'll look much better."

Fan Changyu thanked her, and Yu Qianqian gave her a hearty pat on the shoulder: "No need for thanks. Today, we're standing together. If your braised meat loses to Wang's, it would shame me too."

By noon, Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion was bustling with activity as guests arrived. Over a dozen staff members handled the reception—waiters for male guests and uniformly dressed maids for female guests. Both groups carried themselves with grace, smiling warmly without being obsequious, setting the place apart from other taverns.

For female guests sensitive to the cold, the tavern even provided specially prepared warming pans—truly thoughtful service.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but remark to Xie Zheng: "Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion is the most impressive tavern I've ever seen."

Xie Zheng replied: "It's passable."

The finest taverns in the capital surpassed this by far, but for a small town, running such an establishment was still quite an achievement for the proprietress.

Fan Changyu shot him a sidelong glance: "Why is it so hard for you to utter a single word of praise?"

Xie Zheng said, "Once you've seen better, you won't praise everything you come across."

Fan Changyu: "..."

Was she just being roasted? Was that it?

She decided not to respond. However, their idle moment didn't last long before someone approached and asked, "How much for your braised meat?"

It was only today, while selling braised meat at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, that Changyu learned Yu Qianqian had set the public price at a hundred coins per pound—twice the usual market rate for braised meat.

With some trepidation, she quoted the price, only for the servant to immediately order three pounds without even haggling.

Changyu paused in surprise before swiftly slicing the meat and wrapping it up for the customer.

Yet she still felt somewhat bewildered—was doing business under the reputation of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion really this easy?

After the servant left, she whispered to Xie Zheng, "This is the first time I've sold braised meat at such a high price. My conscience feels a bit uneasy."

Xie Zheng said, "Take a look at the wine seller next to you."

The wine stall belonged to a renowned old distillery in the county, and their business was much better than theirs.

Fan Changyu watched for a while but couldn't figure out what was special about it. She asked Xie Zheng, "What about the wine seller?"

Xie Zheng glanced up at her. "Haven't you noticed that a small jar of their wine sells for nearly one tael of silver?"

Changyu nodded like a chick pecking at rice. "I saw, but wine has always been expensive."

Xie Zheng scoffed lightly. "Expensive in what way? Wine is just fermented from grains and fermentation starter. The cost might not even be as high as your meat."

Changyu thought about the price of pork versus grains and realized he had a point.

Xie Zheng continued, "Whether something is cheap or expensive depends on whether people are willing to buy it. If many are willing to pay a high price, it becomes expensive. Conversely, if everyone only offers a low price, then it's worthless."

Changyu nodded, though only half-understanding.

After selling a few more orders, she gradually began to grasp the idea.

Those dining at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion were all from well-off families who didn't lack money. Most of these wealthy households held the belief that "expensive means good," so the concept of "affordable yet high-quality" didn't apply to them.

When something edible was suddenly priced lower than what they were used to, their first reaction wouldn't be thinking they'd gotten a good deal—it would be fearing there was something wrong with it.

Thinking this way, she also understood why everything in Yu Qianqian's Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion was priced higher than in ordinary restaurants.

Part of the reason was the exceptional quality of the dishes, but another part stemmed from the psychology of competition. Yu Qianqian had positioned Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion as a place only for the elite. Spending a fortune to dine here didn't just buy delicious food—it also bought a sense of superiority, the feeling of being part of an exclusive class.

Before mealtime, Changyu's business was slow, with only a few passersby from the street stopping by to buy some braised meat for their New Year's feast.

But after the first round of banquet guests finished their meals—having likely tasted the braised meat during the feast—her stall suddenly became swarmed. A long line of maids and servants formed to buy her meat.

Overwhelmed with slicing and packaging alone, Changyu handed the packaging duties to Xie Zheng.

His striking looks, combined with the long queue outside the stall, drew the attention of many passersby, attracting even more young women and wives to line up for the braised meat.

Late-arriving guests, seeing the commotion in the main hall, couldn't help but ask, "Why are so many people buying braised meat?"

The attending waiter would smile and reply, "The earlier banquet guests tried Fan's Braised Meat during the feast and found it delicious. They wanted to buy some to take home for their families to try."

Hearing this, the guest would immediately instruct their own servant, "With so many people buying, Fan's Braised Meat must live up to its reputation. Get some for the old madam at home."

Meanwhile, guests fond of calligraphy and paintings would spot the large characters for "Fan's Braised Meat" upon entering and sigh, "Such fine brushwork wasted on a shop banner!"

Upon closer inspection, she noticed that the oil-paper packages carried by the servants queuing to buy braised meat were also labeled with the words "Fan Family Braised Meat," written in bold, vigorous strokes. This only deepened her regret. Instead of buying the braised meat, she instructed her attendant to purchase just the oil-paper wrapper used for the meat.

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned by the request, but as long as they were paying, she didn't mind.

She was beginning to understand that the pursuits of the wealthy were quite different from those of ordinary folk. Accepting the silver, she generously handed over several sheets of oil-paper to the attendant.

The Song family, having produced a provincial scholar, now held considerable prestige in Qingping County. Mother Song was particularly eager to mingle with the wives of officials and wealthy families, as if trying to reclaim the glory she had missed out on over the past decade. Naturally, she had also attended today's banquet.

Seeing the long line of servants buying braised meat, and noticing many of the wealthy ladies at the table sending their own servants to do the same, she had initially thought to join in the excitement. But when she

caught sight of the shop's banner bearing the words "Fan Family Braised Meat," her expression darkened.

Upon closer inspection, recognizing Fan Changyu bustling about in the shop, her face fell completely. "Why is she here...?"

A woman seated nearby, familiar with her, asked, "Madam Song, do you know that young woman?"

Mother Song heaved a long sigh, adopting a tone of pity. "That poor child is cursed with an ill fate. Not long ago, she brought death upon her parents, and later her uncle as well. She must have been driven out of her town by the locals and forced to make a living here in the county."

Businesspeople and officials were especially superstitious about such things. As soon as Mother Song spoke, the faces of every woman at the table turned grim.

"During the New Year festivities, does the manager of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion let just anyone set up shop here?" One woman, repelled by the idea, immediately rose from her seat.

Another official's wife sternly summoned one of the serving maids attending to their table. "Bring your manager here at once," she demanded.

The maid didn't dare delay and promptly fetched Yu Qianqian.

Though Yu Qianqian appeared young, she handled such situations with seasoned finesse. Arriving with a smile, she said, "Madam Qian, what seems to be the matter? If there's any oversight in our service, I sincerely apologize."

Yu Qianqian knew every prominent figure in Qingping County by name and was well aware of their family businesses.

Madam Qian's boldness at the table stemmed from her family's ownership of a money-lending business.

With a cold expression, Madam Qian gestured toward the Fan Family Braised Meat stall below. "We're here today for a joyous celebration. Allowing that ill-omened creature to do business in your establishment only brings us bad luck!"

The stall was crowded with people queuing for braised meat. Though Yu Qianqian guessed Madam Qian was referring to Fan Changyu, she played

dumb. "What ill-omened creature? Speaking of such things during the New Year is hardly auspicious, Madam Qian."

Madam Qian softened slightly at her response. "You don't know? They say that girl from the Fan family is cursed—she caused the deaths of her parents and then her uncle. You shouldn't let her work here, lest her misfortune rub off on you!"

Yu Qianqian gasped, covering her mouth in exaggerated shock. "Who told you such a thing?"

Madam Qian immediately pointed to Mother Song. "Madam Song here is originally from Lin'an Town. She knows all about that cursed girl's history."

Yu Qianqian said, "So it was Madam Song who said that. I heard Young Master Song and the Fan Family had been engaged for years. Only after he passed the imperial exam did they consult a diviner, who determined that the eldest Fan daughter had a cursed fate. They hastily called off the engagement—fortunately early enough, or else Scholar Song would have missed becoming the magistrate's ideal son-in-law."

The shrewd women present exchanged subtle glances at Madam Song upon hearing this.

Madam Song glared furiously. "You—!"

Yu Qianqian blinked innocently. "I don't understand fortune-telling, but the diviner in the southern city said the Fan daughter actually has a fortune that benefits her husband. Her husband writes beautifully—I heard at last night's Lantern Festival, Scholar Song was left speechless by his couplet: 'Northern geese fly south, where phoenixes tread abundantly across the land.' Such remarkable talent! If he takes the imperial exams next year, he might earn her an imperial decree of honor."

Someone couldn't suppress a quiet laugh upon hearing the couplet.

Unaware of her son's public humiliation, Madam Song recalled how he had locked himself in his study upon returning home. Now facing the scrutinizing gazes of merchant and official wives, her face burned with shame. Without a word, she hastily left with her maid.

An official's wife led the mocking laughter, and soon the entire table joined in, sneering, "Truly lacking refinement."

"How shameless to slander the girl after breaking off the engagement."

"Did you see her jade bracelet? Clearly fake. I'd rather go bare-handed than wear such trash. This scholar's mother has no sense of dignity!"

As the noblewomen moved on to other topics, Yu Qianqian smiled. "Ladies, please enjoy your meal. The pavilion is busy today—forgive any shortcomings in our service."

The women became amiable again, some even sending maids to buy braised meat downstairs after tasting it.

Fan Changyu, unaware of Yu Qianqian's intervention, had sold out of braised meat. She let Xie Zheng—exhausted from the sleepless night—return to rest while she helped in the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's kitchen.

By mid-afternoon, the banquet concluded.

Changyu counted the silver fragments and copper coins from the braised meat sales—over fifteen taels total. For the first time, she understood what "exorbitant profits" meant.

Though Yu Qianqian had said she could keep all earnings, Changyu felt the pavilion's location and clientele contributed too much. She sought Yu Qianqian to share the profits.

Yu Qianqian laughed when hearing her request. "How much did you earn today?"

"Fifteen taels and three hundred coins," Changyu answered truthfully.

Surprised, Yu Qianqian smiled. "I heard some was from tips for your husband's talent. You earned this—keep it."

Changyu insisted, "We used your premises, ingredients, and even packaging methods. If you don't take a share, I'll feel uneasy."

Yu Qianqian tapped Fan Changyu on the forehead. "You, being so honest and simple-minded, aren't really cut out for business. The reason your braised meat sold well today is ultimately because it's genuinely top-notch. Otherwise, why was there no business at first, and only after the guests finished their meals did they send servants to buy it? Sure, I came up with the idea, but it was you and your husband who actually put it into practice. How many paper wrappers did he write today? If you're going to feel sorry for anyone, it should be him."

She spoke earnestly, "Your braised meat business taking off benefits me too. There's no need to be so formal with me. Let's keep this favor for the long term—there might come a day when I need your help."

Fan Changyu finally relented but insisted on paying Yu Qianqian for the cost of the meat and ingredients.

Yu Qianqian realized she was stubborn and had no choice but to agree.

After deducting the three taels of silver for costs, the remaining twelve taels were exchanged by Fan Changyu with the accountant for silver coins, which she planned to split evenly with Xie Zheng.

The chefs and staff of the restaurant were just having their meal now. Yu Qianqian said, "Sit and eat first. I'll send someone to fetch your husband and Granny Fang."

Fan Changyu guessed that the "Granny Fang" she mentioned was the matron in charge of the back alley. Remembering that Changning was still with her, she said, "I'll go pick up my sister and call them on the way."

As soon as she stepped out of the back door of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, she saw Xie Zheng hadn't returned to their room but was standing at the alley entrance with his hands behind his back, watching something.

Fan Changyu walked over and followed his gaze to see only a squad of soldiers jogging away in the distance. Judging by their uniforms, they were from the military camp, not the local yamen runners of Qingping County.

She frowned. "Are those soldiers here to collect grain taxes?"

Xie Zheng nodded, his expression icy.

Most merchants in towns bought their grain, so the government couldn't collect grain from them and could only find ways to make them pay more money.

Grain taxes had to be collected from farmers in the countryside. Fan Changyu had already heard about farmers being beaten to death during grain collection in Taizhou, and her heart tightened with worry.

She said, "They say the high official in Jizhou Prefecture is a just and upright man. Let's hope he doesn't follow Taizhou's example and push the people to the brink for grain taxes."

Xie Zheng replied, "We'll see what Jizhou Prefecture does."

As long as Zhao Xun and those behind him weren't fools, they should have already reported Wei Xuan's grain collection in Jizhou to He Jingyuan yesterday.

When he turned back and noticed Fan Changyu's bulging pocket, he frowned slightly. "What's this?"

Fan Changyu pulled out the twelve taels of broken silver and several hundred strung copper coins, handing half to Xie Zheng. "Yours."

One tael of silver might not seem like much, but twelve taels together took up quite a bit of space.

Seeing her pull out the money like a wealthy landlord, Xie Zheng's eyelid twitched slightly. "You keep it."

Fan Changyu insisted, "No, we split it half and half. You wrote hundreds of paper wrappers."

After a pause, he said, "It's easy to lose if I carry it. You hold onto it for me."

Given his previous experience of losing money at the small eatery, Fan Changyu couldn't argue with that. She had no choice but to tuck it all back into her pocket, stuffing it full again.

The two returned to their room to fetch Changning. Before they even entered, they heard two children talking inside.

"My big sister is amazing—she can eat three bowls of rice in one meal!" It was Changning's voice.

"My mom is even more amazing. She can eat two braised pork knuckles all by herself, plus a bowl of spicy soup!" The boy seemed quite competitive.

"My sister's rice bowl is as big as a soup pot!" His tone suggested he even gestured to show the size.

"Well... then your sister is a bit more impressive." The boy seemed to concede.

Outside the house, Fan Changyu: "..."

A rice bowl as big as a soup pot—that was clearly their father's!

Chapter 41

Fan Changyu felt a twitch at her temple as she pushed the door open and entered. "Ning Niang."

"Ah... Sister." Changning, who had been full of spirit just a moment ago, immediately put on a guilty and obedient expression, her grape-like eyes darting around, not daring to meet Fan Changyu's gaze.

Xie Zheng followed her into the room, a faint curve at the corner of his lips. When his gaze landed on the boy in the satin jacket inside the room, his eyes paused slightly as he asked, "Whose child is this?"

The boy had chubby cheeks, looking no more than five or six years old. His eyes were large and round, with slightly drooping outer corners, giving him a puppy-like appearance. His clothes were embroidered with gold thread, and his small waistband was studded with gems.

Standing next to Changning, he looked honest and simple, the very image of a silly young master from a wealthy family.

Only after Xie Zheng spoke did the boy puff out his chest and declare, "All these houses belong to my family."

Fan Changyu remembered Chef Li mentioning that Yu Qianqian had a child. Since this boy claimed the houses were his family's, could he be Yu Qianqian's son?

Just as this thought crossed her mind, the voice of the stewardess called from outside the courtyard, "Young master, where have you hidden?"

The child called out, "Nanny Fang, I'm here!"

The stewardess quickly found her way over upon hearing his voice. "Young master, why did you hide here? You had me searching everywhere..."

Noticing Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng, she apologized, "The young master is still young and wandered into your quarters by mistake. Please forgive this old woman's oversight."

Fan Changyu assured her it was fine and asked, "Is this Shopkeeper Yu's child?"

The stewardess smiled and confirmed it.

From the stewardess, Fan Changyu learned the boy's name was Yu Bao'er, and everyone in the building called him Bao'er.

In Fan Changyu's experience, families with some wealth usually gave their children names that sounded cultured and refined. The fact that Yu Qianqian's child was simply named Bao'er was quite surprising to her.

But thinking of Yu Qianqian's personality, it suddenly made perfect sense.

As they walked together toward the main hall of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, Changning regained her boldness and began bickering with Yu Bao'er from time to time. Xie Zheng trailed behind, his brow furrowed as he watched Yu Bao'er's back, his expression unreadable.

Upon reaching the main hall, Yu Qianqian was both amused and exasperated to learn that Yu Bao'er had hidden in Fan Changyu's room during their game of hide-and-seek.

While checking on Yu Bao'er's studies, she noticed Changning and casually asked Fan Changyu, "Has Ning Niang started her education yet? If not, you can send her here. I've hired a private tutor for Bao'er—teaching one child is the same as teaching several. The staff here who have children all send them to study together. We don't expect them to become top scholars, but learning to read a few words is always beneficial."

Fan Changyu's admiration for Yu Qianqian grew even more. Though tempted, she hesitated. The journey from the town to the county was quite a distance, and Changning was still very young. If Changning were to study here, someone would have to accompany her back and forth daily. Moreover, she wasn't an employee of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion and had already received much kindness from Yu Qianqian. She couldn't take this generosity for granted.

"Thank you for your kindness, Shopkeeper," she replied. "She's learned a few characters from her brother-in-law, but it's not a formal education yet. She's still young and afraid of studying. Let's wait until she's a bit older."

Changning immediately chimed in, "Ning Niang can write her own name!"

She grabbed a pair of chopsticks and traced the characters in the air: "Wood, cross, wood, big—Fan!"

Yu Qianqian couldn't help but laugh, praising, "Ning Niang is truly clever."

Her gaze shifted to Fan Changyu with a teasing glint. "I forgot—you have an exceptionally talented husband at home. Ning Niang hardly needs anyone else to teach her."

Fan Changyu had originally spoken those words to politely decline Yu Qianqian's kindness. Now that she was being teased, she simply smiled without responding.

Xie Zheng glanced at her but also remained silent.

Yu Qianqian then changed the subject with Fan Changyu. "The shop outside my restaurant is available for long-term lease. If you're too busy, I can also have my restaurant staff help sell your braised meat. Other tenants either pay a year's rent upfront or give me a twenty percent share of their profits. If you're interested, I can even offer you a discount on the rent."

Fan Changyu had already witnessed how bustling the business was outside the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion today.

She said, "You're treating me far too kindly."

This remark made all the restaurant staff burst into laughter.

The accountant chimed in, "Our boss has a heart of gold—she treats all her employees well. Don't stand on ceremony, Mistress Fan."

Yu Qianqian added, "I choose friends based on first impressions. I took a liking to your personality the moment I saw you. No need to be shy—just tell me straight whether you'd like to set up shop in my Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion or not."

Fan Changyu replied, "I'd love to. There's no need to reduce the rent, but I truly can't manage the shop myself. If I borrow your staff, I'll pay them an additional wage."

Yu Qianqian laughed and asked her employees, "You all heard that, right? Anyone who wants to earn extra can step forward now and let Boss Fan get a good look at you."

Hearing herself addressed as "Boss Fan," Fan Changyu felt both embarrassed and strangely exhilarated.

Unlike the townsfolk who simply called her Changyu, this title felt like a new identity—a small boat that, though modest now, could carry her to distant shores.

After some murmuring among the staff, a particularly capable-looking woman stepped forward. "I'd like to work at the shop selling braised meat."

Fan Changyu recognized her—she had previously specialized in serving female customers, handling tasks with efficiency and a sweet tongue.

Yu Qianqian introduced her, "This girl is Fuling. She was sold into servitude as a child but saved up to buy her freedom. When I was hiring, she joined us. She's quite capable—what do you think?"

Fan Changyu nodded. "She's perfect."

Fuling, ever the smooth talker, immediately fawned, "Thank you, boss. I'll be counting on your guidance from now on, Boss Fan."

Yu Qianqian pointed at her, laughing. "See how glib she is?"

Fan Changyu couldn't help but chuckle too.

After the meal, Fan Changyu bid Yu Qianqian farewell. With the best shop in town now leased, she needed to plan for long-term braised meat supply. She had to decide whether to hire a cart or buy an ox cart outright. There was also the matter of delivering cured meat to the county school's portly manager that afternoon.

Yu Bao'er followed her mother to see Fan Changyu's party off at the restaurant entrance. While the adults talked, the children had their own conversation.

Yu Bao'er said to Changning, "Next time you come, I'll show you my study! It's full of books, clay figurines, wood carvings, and coral ornaments—so many pretty things!"

Changning tightly clutched Fan Changyu's sleeve, pursed her lips, and racked her little brain before finally coming up with something to boast about: "Come to my house, and I'll show you my sister's butcher knives—dozens of them, big and small! If we're lucky, you might even get to see her slaughter a pig! Have you ever seen a pig being slaughtered?"

Yu Bao'er shook her head, her eyes filled with envy.

Changning gestured with both hands: "My sister can knock a pig unconscious with just one slap!"

Fan Changyu: "..."

Facing the stunned gazes of Yu Qianqian and her child, she quickly cleared her throat and said, "Ning Niang, let's go."

Only then did Changning follow her out with small steps, but she held her head high, strutting like a victorious rooster.

Though Fan Changyu tried hard to keep a straight face, her ears turned red, as if she wished she could vanish into the ground.

Xie Zheng caught sight of the sisters from the corner of his eye, and a faint smile tugged at his lips.

As the three rode the ox-cart back to town, Fan Changyu couldn't stop praising Yu Qianqian's kindness.

Xie Zheng merely scoffed.

Fan Changyu frowned and asked, "Did I say something wrong?"

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze indifferently. "If someone sold you, you'd eagerly help them count the money."

Fan Changyu said unhappily, "Shopkeeper Yu is a good person. Why must you slander her?"

Xie Zheng replied mercilessly, "Don't forget, she's a merchant. You've done business with her but haven't gained much from it. Yet now you're endlessly grateful to her."

His gaze turned colder. "Her way of winning people over is something you'll never learn in a lifetime."

Fan Changyu liked Yu Qianqian very much and was displeased by Xie Zheng's words. "Why do you always assume the worst in people? Shopkeeper Yu has helped me a lot..."

Xie Zheng cut her off. "How has she helped you?"

Fan Changyu met his sharp gaze and faltered before saying, "When I first started selling braised meat, if Shopkeeper Yu hadn't given me the

opportunity, I wouldn't have been able to do business with Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion so quickly."

Xie Zheng asked, "You're not the only one selling braised meat in all of Qingping County. Why did she choose you?"

Fan Changyu said, "It was Master Li who introduced me..."

Xie Zheng stared at her silently, and her voice gradually trailed off.

After a pause, Xie Zheng said, "It's true the cook recommended you, but if what you made wasn't up to par, she wouldn't have chosen you. Merchants don't pick inferior goods out of personal favor—they only give a convenient nod when the quality is equal."

Fan Changyu clenched her intertwined hands tighter and continued, "Today, Shopkeeper Yu initially refused the money from the braised meat sale. It was only after I insisted that she accepted the cost price."

Xie Zheng asked, "How much did you earn? Probably less than what she makes from a single table."

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together. "It's not about the amount. It's the thought that counts."

Xie Zheng frowned. "I'm not saying you should take her kindness for granted. I'm just telling you that the favor she's shown you doesn't match the gratitude you feel. You can remember her kindness, but there's no need to lower yourself because of it. Besides, today was a mutual exchange—she supported you to undermine Wang's business."

Fan Changyu fell silent.

Xie Zheng knew her nature was pure and kind—when someone showed her a little kindness, she always felt compelled to repay it tenfold.

He took a few breaths to steady himself before saying, "Telling you all this isn't meant to disparage that shopkeeper. Only by seeing things clearly can you truly become her close friend in the future. If you only remember gratitude and favors, then you're no different from the honest workers under her employ."

In all her years, Fan Changyu had never been taught such things.

After her parents passed away, apart from Aunt Zhao's family who had helped her occasionally, she had shouldered everything else alone. Suddenly receiving so much kindness from Yu Qianqian was like a person

freezing to death in winter finding warmth—she instinctively moved toward that source of comfort.

After a long silence, she finally said, "Thank you."

Her voice was somewhat muffled but not dispirited.

She knew she still had a long road ahead and much to learn. Realizing things she hadn't understood before wasn't too late.

When she looked at Xie Zheng again, her eyes were filled with a thirst for knowledge: "Yan Zheng, teach me more. I want to become someone as capable as Shopkeeper Yu in the future."

Xie Zheng gave a faint smile. "Forget about business. As I've told you, her most commendable trait lies in how she utilizes people."

Fan Changyu assumed an attentive posture.

Though reluctant to continue, Xie Zheng added, "Take today, for instance—she lent you the female workers from her establishment. Naturally, you'd feel indebted to her. But she merely provided what you needed when you needed it. Setting aside all personal sentiments, you owe her nothing. You paid rent for the shop and wages for borrowing her workers. In fact, having her own staff manage the shop you rented benefits her immensely with no drawbacks."

His gaze darkened slightly. "If she wanted to check your accounts, it would be as simple as asking."

Fan Changyu said, "I believe Shopkeeper Yu isn't that kind of person."

Yet the shock made her fingertips tingle. She had initially thought Yu Qianqian was simply kind, but now she realized that behind that kindness lay sharp intelligence.

She found herself admiring this side of Yu Qianqian even more and suddenly understood how a seemingly delicate woman could single-handedly establish two large restaurants in just a few years.

Xie Zheng remarked caustically, "And that's just her way of managing subordinates. The methods she uses to deal with merchants and officials' families? You might spend a lifetime trying to learn them and still not succeed."

Though stung by his words, Fan Changyu didn't argue, considering how much he had taught her. Instead, she said, "Yan Zheng, teach me to read."

Xie Zheng looked at the person before him, who was resting her chin in her hands with a sigh—like a young lion cub encountering its first setback, pitiful yet stubborn at the core.

As he had agreed before, he responded indifferently, "Alright."

When the ox cart reached town and passed by the Bookstore, Xie Zheng bought not only paper and ink but also five books.

Fan Changyu was stunned. "So many?"

He placed four thick volumes in her hands and handed a thinner one to Changning. "The Three Character Classic for your sister. The Four Books are for you."

Flipping through them, Fan Changyu noticed he had bought The Analects and The Great Learning despite previously saying he wouldn't teach them to her. She couldn't help but grin—his sharp tongue was mostly just for show.

Holding the books happily, she declared, "I'll start studying hard tonight!"

Changning, clutching the Three Character Classic with a scrunched-up face about to protest against studying, swallowed her words dejectedly at the sight.

Upon reaching the doorstep, Fan Changyu unlocked the door. Changning insisted on being the first to enter and burst into cheers as soon as she pushed open the courtyard gate: "Falcon! Falcon's back!"

The Gyr Falcon, which had flown all day and only returned to the small courtyard at nightfall, was met not with a bowl of rewarding meat scraps but with a cold, unyielding lock on the door.

Spotting the three who had finally returned from inside a broken bamboo basket, it emerged with a few tufts of feathers sticking up.

Changning threw herself at the falcon, hugging its neck, her face flushed with excitement: "Brother-in-law didn't lie to Ning Niang! The falcon really came back!"

Fan Changyu was equally surprised. She had initially thought Yan Zheng was just humoring the child that day.

She turned to Xie Zheng: "You're that good at taming birds?"

Xie Zheng calmly deflected: "Is it possible you've just been feeding it too well?"

Fan Changyu widened her almond-shaped eyes: "...Is that really how it works?"

She then looked at the Gyr Falcon, which, despite being hugged and ruffled by Changning, fixed its beady eyes on Fan Changyu as if asking when dinner would be served.

Skeptical, Fan Changyu headed toward the main room. The Gyr Falcon pecked at the ground a few times before casually following her—and then stationed itself in front of the large bowl where its meat scraps were usually served.

Fan Changyu: "..."

Xie Zheng observed the scene, the corner of his lips curling imperceptibly as he turned away.

Resigned, Fan Changyu went to the kitchen, cut a piece of meat into scraps, and served it to the Gyr Falcon before renting a cart from the town's carriage service to deliver the cured meat ordered by the portly shopkeeper.

The shopkeeper, well-informed, smiled genially upon learning Fan Changyu had rented a stall at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion to sell braised meat: "Since this cured meat is also from your household, I plan to sell it under the Fan brand. What do you think?"

Having absorbed Xie Zheng's lessons on business intricacies, Fan Changyu's mind was sharper now. She replied, "Fine, but if you sell it at a higher price, you can't show me fake accounts."

The shopkeeper hastily assured her he wouldn't.

Since Fan Changyu's earnings were based on a share of the profits, as long as the shopkeeper didn't sell at a loss, she wouldn't lose out either, so she said no more.

On her way back, she encountered a troop of soldiers. The leader was the officer who had helped her family survive the assassination attempt.

Mounted on a tall steed, his subordinates were escorting over a dozen tightly bound men. Judging by their uniforms, the captives were also soldiers, but clearly from a different unit than the escorting troops.

Fan Changyu looked closer and recognized them as the grain-requisitioning officers she had seen with Yan Zheng at noon.

Villagers working in the fields along the official road cheered and clapped at the sight: "Jizhou has a true guardian of justice!"

"Lord He is the only official who truly understands our hardships!"

Recalling Yan Zheng's words from noon and seeing the bound grain-requisitioning officers being hauled away, Fan Changyu couldn't help but feel a quiet satisfaction.

Back home, she recounted the events to Xie Zheng. His eyes flickered briefly before he calmly turned the page of his book: "Keep studying. Tomorrow evening, I'll test you on the 'Xue Er' chapter."

Fan Changyu shrank her neck, wrinkling her face just like Changning as she reluctantly turned to her books.

She genuinely wanted to study hard, but the classical texts with their archaic language made her head spin, forcing her to grit her teeth and push through.

The window was left open, letting in gusts of cold wind that made people hunch their shoulders, preventing Fan Changyu and her sister from dozing off while reading.

Xie Zheng seemed impervious to the cold as he paced to the window, holding a scroll behind his back. His gaze darkened as he stared into the distant night, his long hair and robes fluttering in the wind.

He Jingyuan had openly captured Wei Xuan's men, clearly showing no intention of leaving Wei Xuan any face.

Given Wei Xuan's vindictive nature, before Wei Yan's transfer orders arrived, he would surely go mad and lash out at He Jingyuan again.

His men could also make their move now.

Chapter 42

The snow had just cleared, and beneath the eaves of the Jizhou Prefecture office, fine bamboo blinds hung to block the wind. Through the gaps, one could faintly glimpse a few winter plum blossoms in the courtyard, their buds just beginning to open.

The murmur of conversation drifted from the main hall, while guards stood in strict formation along the corridor steps, armored and armed, their expressions stern.

Yet at that moment, the clashing of weapons erupted outside the gates.

"Who dares trespass upon the Jizhou Prefecture office!"

Hearing the commotion outside, some of the inner courtyard guards remained at their posts to secure the meeting hall, while others rushed out with blades and halberds to reinforce their comrades.

However, the intruders were also a squad of armored soldiers armed with spears and halberds. The leading general, clad in scale armor, kicked a Jizhou soldier so hard he flew backward.

Lifting a pair of eyes brimming with malice, the general roared, "He Jingyuan, get the hell out here!"

The officials who emerged from the meeting hall at the disturbance all wore expressions of shock at the sight of him.

Only Zheng Wenchang immediately shouted, "How dare you address His Excellency by name!"

Wei Xuan sneered, utterly dismissing him, and advanced toward the meeting hall with his sword drawn. In response, Zheng Wenchang's blade slid three inches from its sheath.

As the two were about to clash, a deep, steady voice came from within the hall: "Wen Chang, stand down."

Zheng Wenchang glanced back but, though he sheathed his blade, his furious glare remained fixed on Wei Xuan.

With a smirk, Wei Xuan swung his sword directly at him. Zheng Wenchang barely dodged in time, while the surrounding civil officials scattered in panic, their cries filling the air.

"Has the Eldest Young Master come here only to harass my subordinates?" He Jingyuan, seated calmly at the head of the hall, spoke at last, his gaze resting on the man below with a hint of disappointment.

It was true that Wei Yan monopolized court affairs, but under his decade-long rule, the war-torn Great Yin Dynasty had been able to recover and thrive. Though inherently suspicious, Wei Yan was also exceptionally skilled at employing talent.

How, then, could his son be such a reckless, glory-seeking brute?

Wei Xuan, provoked by that look, flared with even greater fury. Like a snarling hyena, he pointed his sword at Zheng Wenchang. "A mere dog under your command dares bark at this general? Or is it that you, He Jingyuan, no longer hold the Wei family in any regard?"

He Jingyuan replied, "The Prime Minister showed me great kindness. I guard Jizhou by his command—how could I disregard the Wei family?"

He raised his eyes slowly. "Or... does the Eldest Young Master mean to say that I have disregarded you?"

Wei Xuan's rage flared at his words, his face twisting into a snarl. "You have some nerve! Men, seize him and throw him in prison!"

As his armored guards stepped forward, Zheng Wenchang and the other military officers drew their blades and blocked the way, the two sides now locked in a tense standoff.

He Jingyuan's voice remained composed. "I am a third-rank official of the court. If the Eldest Young Master wishes to imprison me, he must first present an imperial decree."

Wei Xuan scoffed. "With war imminent, your obstruction of military affairs alone is enough for this general to execute you first and report later!"

He Jingyuan asked, "What military affairs have I obstructed?"

Wei Xuan, incensed, flung a hand outward. "The soldiers of Huizhou are bleeding on the front lines, their supplies running low. We demanded provisions from Tai and Jizhou, yet not only did you defy orders, you even

imprisoned the officers I sent to requisition grain! He Jingyuan, are you so eager to see Huizhou fall to the rebels?"

He Jingyuan said only, "The defeat suffered by the Eldest Young Master should not be borne by the common people. If Huizhou merely defends itself now, it can hold out until the court transports grain here. The Eldest Young Master's urgency in requisitioning grain is simply because he wishes to launch another attack on Chongzhou as soon as possible. Does the Eldest Young Master not care about the lives of the people in these two prefectures?"

Wei Xuan retorted sharply, "How could it be that grain cannot be requisitioned? It's simply that those lowly peasants refuse to hand over their grain. Didn't Taizhou also claim they couldn't requisition grain before? Yet in the end, they still managed to scrape together a hundred thousand dan!"

Mention of Taizhou brought a pained expression to He Jingyuan's face. He rebuked, "Beating people to death and seizing next year's seed grain for military provisions—is this what the Eldest Young Master calls requisitioning?"

Wei Xuan sneered coldly, "Once the rebels are exterminated, the entire northwest can recuperate. A temporary hardship in exchange for long-term benefits—what's wrong with that?"

He Jingyuan asked him, "Does the Eldest Young Master know how many lives in Taizhou and Jizhou prefectures are at stake in this 'temporary hardship' of yours? When the news reaches the capital, how many scholars and officials will denounce the Prime Minister in writing?"

Wei Xuan's face twisted with fury. "Once the rebels are crushed, what do these things matter? Right now, the rebels know Huizhou's grain supply line has been cut, making it impossible to launch another attack on Chongzhou in the short term. They've let their guard down. If I mobilize troops quickly and strike them by surprise, with military achievements to my name, all dissent will be silenced!"

He Jingyuan sighed deeply. "Eldest Young Master, heed this humble official's advice. This empire belongs to the people of Great Yin. We are not yet at the end of our rope—do not push the people to this point and chill the hearts of the empire's populace."

Wei Xuan only snorted. "Womanly compassion!"

He said ruthlessly, "If you obstruct me further, this general will exercise the authority of the Military Governor and strip you of your official seal!"

He Jingyuan gazed at him steadily for a moment before reaching up to remove his official cap. "Then the Eldest Young Master may take back this humble official's seal."

The officials led by Zheng Wenchang cried out in alarm, "My lord, you must not!"

Wei Xuan, ever obstinate and unable to tolerate defiance, laughed coldly. "Court officials claim Xie Zheng is the pillar of the northwest, yet without him, isn't the northwest still standing strong? He Jingyuan, do you truly believe this general dares not strip you of your seal? You overestimate your own importance!"

He strode forward and snatched the seal of the Jizhou Governor from the desk, holding it aloft. With a challenging glare at He Jingyuan, he commanded the officials of Jizhou Prefecture, "Go requisition grain for this general immediately. If a hundred thousand dan of grain are not delivered by noon tomorrow, bring me your heads!"

The officials below exchanged uneasy glances, their faces filled with reluctance.

He Jingyuan, seated at the head, closed his eyes heavily.

When the news of renewed grain requisitions reached Lin'an Town, the townsfolk all lamented their misfortune. Fan Changyu was unaware of the reasons behind it.

Only when she went to the county to deliver meat to the plump innkeeper and the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion did she hear that Jizhou Prefecture had undergone a drastic change. The upright official surnamed He had been dismissed and placed under guard, while crowds of people from Jizhou's main city had gathered before the prefectural yamen to protest, resulting in over a hundred arrests.

Under the harsh suppression by the authorities, the people no longer dared to protest. Yet the amount of grain the government demanded from each household was truly staggering.

Farmers handed over even their seed grain, but it still wasn't enough to meet their household's military grain quota.

The solution offered by the officials was simple: if grain was insufficient, then pay with money.

But what if they had no money? Whether they borrowed or stole, it was none of the government's concern—their only task was to apply relentless pressure.

With no way out, many farmers simply turned to banditry.

The soldiers were bullies who preyed on the weak. They could swagger before unarmed commoners but avoided provoking bandits and outlaws whenever possible.

Unable to collect enough grain from the farmers or extort sufficient money, the soldiers began going door to door in the town, squeezing merchants for funds.

Each household was taxed per capita—one tael of silver per person. Fan Changyu's family had to pay three taels.

The townsfolk were outraged. In the past, even military conscription could be avoided with just two taels per person. Now this grain levy cost more than conscription itself. For impoverished families with many children, this was practically driving them to their doom.

One household in town directly bought poison, mixing it with water in front of the soldiers. Each family member drank a bowl as they declared they had neither money nor grain left. If pressed further, they would rather die and be done with it.

Now that Changyu had a means of earning money, paying three taels wasn't an issue. But many in town were like her in the past—families who couldn't scrape together that much even if they emptied their savings.

The people spontaneously gathered to kneel in protest outside the County Government Office, yet the magistrate never even showed his face.

Hearing such news repeatedly made Changyu's heart grow heavier.

That evening, holding the *Analects*, she found herself unable to focus. She turned to Xie Zheng and saw him calmly annotating the pages with a brush, seemingly undisturbed by the outside world.

Pursing her lips, she said, "This grain levy shows the authorities don't treat the people as human."

Xie Zheng's brush never paused as he replied, "The authorities wouldn't collect one tael per person for the grain levy." His voice carried a faint, icy edge.

Changyu was puzzled. "How not? Didn't the officials come demanding it door to door?"

Finishing his annotations, Xie Zheng set down his brush. "Jizhou Prefecture has 200,000 households and 800,000 people. One tael per person would amount to 800,000 taels of silver. Last autumn, grain was only seven or eight hundred copper coins per dan . Even now, with the war driving prices up, it hasn't exceeded one tael per dan . Eight hundred thousand taels could buy at least 800,000 dan of grain. The frontline only needs emergency supplies—they couldn't possibly require that much."

As he spoke, his dark eyes gleamed with a chilling coldness.

Even if Wei Xuan were as stupid as a pig, he wouldn't forcibly requisition 800,000 dan of grain from Jizhou. His rush to collect grain was merely an attempt to strike Chongzhou while it was vulnerable after the war, hoping to regain favor before Wei Yan stripped him of his military authority.

To sustain until the court's provisions arrived, 200,000 dan would suffice. They had already requisitioned 100,000 dan from Taizhou—Jizhou only needed to contribute another 100,000.

Demanding 800,000? How was that any different from outright robbery?

Pushing the people to the brink might drive them to revolt, even defecting to the Rebel King in neighboring Chongzhou.

After hearing his calculations, Changyu also found the authorities' levy method absurd, yet she remained confused. "But it was the soldiers themselves who came demanding the money. Could they really be so brazen as to overcharge on their own?"

Xie Zheng said, "The soldiers wouldn't dare. But those above them might."

Embezzlement had long been rampant in the court. Whether it was the Ministry of Works constructing roads, dredging canals, or disaster relief, funds allocated from the treasury would be skimmed layer by layer by officials, leaving only scraps to be used as intended.

Tax collection was no exception. The tax rates set by the imperial court were ironclad laws, and lower-ranking officials dared not embezzle from

them. If they wanted to line their own pockets, the only way was to impose higher commercial and grain taxes on the common people.

Fan Changyu wasn't foolish either. Hearing his words, she immediately clenched her fists. "Are you saying it's likely the county magistrate—or perhaps an even higher-ranking official—who's exploiting the people's blood and sweat?"

Xie Zheng replied, "We'd know if we checked how much military grain other counties are collecting."

Fan Changyu said, "Tomorrow, when I deliver goods to the county town, I'll see if I can run into people from other counties. If I do, I'll ask them."

If other counties weren't collecting this much, then it must be the Qingping County magistrate lining his pockets under the guise of taxation!

Xie Zheng nodded silently.

Fan Changyu was already yawning, but he picked up his brush again, as if intending to continue annotating the book.

Seeing his cold, detached profile in the candlelight, she couldn't help but say, "Don't write too late—it'll strain your eyes. You can continue tomorrow."

Xie Zheng gave an absentminded "Mm," but his brush didn't stop.

He had thought He Jingyuan could keep Wei Xuan in check, but instead, He Jingyuan was the one being controlled by Wei Xuan.

Pondering the reasons behind this, a hint of mockery flashed in his icy black eyes.

The 200,000 dan of grain Zhao Xun had purchased had already been taken over by his men. He Jingyuan's people couldn't trace its whereabouts and suspected it was his doing. That was why they deliberately allowed Wei Xuan to act this way—to force him out of hiding, wasn't it?

So much for the so-called benevolent Confucian general who loved the people as his own children.

The news of his death in battle had spread for so long, and the entire northwest had descended into chaos. At this critical juncture, he couldn't afford to let the Northern Turks seize the opportunity. He had to return.

As his brush glided across the page, forming neat and upright characters, his peripheral vision caught her shadow falling across the desk. His voice was cool and clear when he spoke: "Your birthday is this month. What would you like?"

Fan Changyu let out an "Ah," then realized what he meant. "I appreciate the thought, but my parents passed away just before the new year. I won't be celebrating my birthday this year."

Xie Zheng's brush paused slightly. "Name a wish. Consider it a gift for future birthdays."

Fan Changyu frowned. "Why does that sound so strange? Future birthday gifts can be given in the future. Why now—"

She trailed off mid-sentence, then looked at the dense annotations he had written in the book. Her smile faded. "You're leaving, aren't you?"

Chapter 43

Xie Zheng didn't answer her directly. After finishing the last annotation on the book's title page, he set down his brush and said, "I've annotated all the obscure and difficult parts in these books. You should be able to understand them on your own now."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu understood everything.

He had promised to teach her to read, but now that he couldn't fulfill that promise, he had annotated all the books for her instead.

For a moment, her heart felt strangely hollow, though she couldn't quite name the emotion.

But they weren't related by blood or obligation. Their sham marriage had been a transaction of mutual benefit, with no debts owed. Besides, he had already helped her a great deal during this time.

Suppressing the odd feeling in her chest, Fan Changyu said, "There's nothing I want. I already have everything I need. The pork shop is thriving, the braised meat has gained popularity, and there's a steady income. Come spring, I can even raise pigs in the countryside..."

As she spoke of her future plans, she realized Yan Zheng wouldn't be around to participate in the pig farming. Glancing up at him, she noticed he seemed to be listening attentively, his expression calm and gentle. A sudden wave of inexplicable sadness welled up inside her.

Perhaps it was because they had supported each other through the hardest times that his impending departure felt so unsettling.

She said, "The silver you left with me—I'll go to the bank tomorrow and exchange it for banknotes. That way, it'll be easier for you to carry when you leave."

Xie Zheng's brows furrowed slightly. "That money is yours to keep."

Fan Changyu replied, "Traveling requires a lot of expenses. Besides, you'll need funds to rebuild your Armed Escort Agency. If you don't take

any silver with you, how will you survive? And I can't accept such a large sum without reason. It wouldn't sit right with me."

Forty taels of silver was no small amount. It was one thing for him to leave it with her temporarily, but keeping it after he left was something she couldn't accept in good conscience.

Including the six taels they had split from yesterday's braised meat sale at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, he had left a total of forty-six taels with her. She planned to add another four taels to make it an even fifty, exchange it all for banknotes, and give him some copper coins for travel expenses.

This way, she wouldn't owe him anything.

Xie Zheng's lips pressed into a thin line as he looked at her. "Wasn't it for candy?"

Meeting his gaze with clear, unwavering eyes, Fan Changyu said, "If you ever come back and still want candy, I'll buy it for you then."

She smiled, her tone teasing yet earnest. "Otherwise, what if you meet a girl out there and don't have money to ask her to buy you candy?"

Xie Zheng's expression stiffened, the faint warmth in his demeanor vanishing entirely.

Fan Changyu pretended not to notice, yawning as she said, "It's late. Let's get some rest."

Even after Fan Changyu had returned to her room, Xie Zheng remained seated at the table. After a long while, he closed his eyes.

No one else would ever buy him candy but her.

He wasn't sure if he would survive this journey, so some words could never be spoken.

He Jingyuan's investigation into the missing 200,000 dan of grain had led him to Zhao Xun, who had handed the grain over to his former subordinates. Though He Jingyuan hadn't uncovered concrete evidence, the traces he found were enough to guess the truth.

Wei Xuan's reckless actions could easily have been restrained by He Jingyuan's capabilities, especially within Jizhou Prefecture. Yet he chose not to act, clearly intending to use the suffering of the common people to

force Wei Xuan into revealing himself with those two hundred thousand dan of grain.

To the Wei Faction, the hardships of the people and the infamy they bore were nothing compared to his life.

After all, back then, to eliminate him, the Wei Faction had their planted spy falsify military reports, leading the eight thousand soldiers who followed him into battle to be abandoned on the Chongzhou battlefield...

With such a mountain of corpses and sea of blood still unavenged, how could Wei Yan and his son rest easy without seeing his corpse?

He couldn't give her a promise that he would return. Though she seemed carefree, she was a woman of principle—she wouldn't involve herself with him without clarity, which was why she stubbornly refused his silver.

No debts between them, no lingering attachments.

He thought, Fine, no debts then. What's so great about a butcher's daughter anyway?

Rising to his feet, he paced toward his room. As he passed beneath the eaves, snowflakes landed on his brow, melting into a bone-chilling cold that seeped into his heart, eroding the last remnants of his pride.

His hand rested lightly on the wooden door, yet he couldn't bring himself to push it open. Lowering his head, he shut his eyes heavily, concealing the moment's wretchedness.

How could she not be great?

She was great in every way—

The courtyard was deep, snow blanketing the bamboo branches.

Zhao Xun strode briskly across the snow-covered courtyard and entered the Warm Pavilion. The room was brightly lit by candles. Beyond the arched, carved moon gate stood a pair of gilt Suanni Boshan censers, their perforated lids releasing tendrils of smoke.

Further inside, a golden gauze curtain hung halfway down before the daybed, obscuring the man seated there. Only the hem of his robe, woven with gold-threaded embroidery and extravagantly ornate, trailed onto the floor.

Not daring to look too closely, Zhao Xun bowed his head respectfully. "Master, as you instructed, Wei Xuan's forced grain requisition has been widely publicized in the capital. Now, all scholars are denouncing the Wei Faction, and Grand Tutor Li has openly challenged Wei Yan in court."

A low table sat beside the daybed, bearing a teacup. The man reached for it, his fingers long and pale—unnaturally so, as if mere skeletal bones. He chuckled softly. "Well done."

Then he asked, "What of Wu'an Marquis?"

Zhao Xun recalled his last meeting with Xie Zheng, a fine sweat breaking out at his temples. Steeling himself, he replied, "Wu'an Marquis ordered me to inform He Jingyuan of Wei Xuan's cross-border grain requisition, likely intending for He Jingyuan to stop it."

A low laugh came from behind the curtain, whether mocking or genuinely amused was unclear. "Wei Yan, that traitorous subject, actually raised a nephew who pities the suffering of the people?"

He took a sip of tea before setting the cup down. "No wonder Wei Yan fears him so. Under the guise of purchasing grain, he uncovered over a dozen of your contact points in Tai and Jizhou. Leaving clues for He Jingyuan during the handover was his way of repaying Wu'an Marquis's 'kindness.' After all... if Jizhou Prefecture doesn't continue to stir up the scandal of grain requisition, the stage we've set in the capital will have no actors."

Zhao Xun hesitated. "But if Wu'an Marquis discovers we were the ones who left a trail for He Jingyuan..."

The person behind the gauze curtain remained indifferent. "What is there to fear? It's not as if we forced Wei Xun to levy grain at saber-point. If we can make the Wei Faction lose public favor repeatedly while watching Wei Yan's two former blades perform on the same stage, why not? Besides, this could be considered helping the Wu'an Marquis. The deeper the people's resentment toward the Wei Faction grows, the more support he'll gain when he steps forward later to reclaim the northwest, won't he?"

Zhao Xun praised, "Your wisdom is unparalleled, my lord."

Then he cautiously added, "The Wu'an Marquis wishes to meet with you in person. What are your thoughts?"

Not a single word of Xie Zheng's arrogant remarks that day dared he repeat to the man before him.

After a moment of contemplation, the man behind the curtain said, "It's not yet time. Let him and Wei Yan fight it out like the snipe and the clam. Best if they both end up severely wounded."

Zhao Xun sensed his intent to merely use Xie Zheng and hesitated. "But the Wu'an Marquis is after all the sole surviving descendant of General Xie..."

The man's eyes turned icy. "A wolf cub raised by Wei Yan's own hands is no innocent. It's far safer to keep military power in one's own grasp than in another's."

Despite the freezing cold, cold sweat broke out repeatedly on Zhao Xun's back. He bowed deeply. "This subordinate understands."

That night, the lights also burned late in the He residence.

Dozens of soldiers under Wei Xuan's command surrounded the He Mansion, preventing anyone from leaving easily. Even the side gates and courtyard walls had patrolling soldiers.

In the darkness, arrows rained down like a sudden storm upon the troops at the mansion's entrance, throwing them into immediate chaos as they scrambled for cover. "Enemy attack!"

"Quick, report to the general!"

"Kill them—"

A squad of Jizhou Prefecture soldiers armed with sabers and halberds charged out from the night, catching the panicked Wei Mansion troops off guard and quickly gaining the upper hand.

Leading the Jizhou soldiers was Zheng Wenchang, who raised his saber high. "Follow me to rescue His Excellency!"

As a key general under He Jingyuan, he knew the He Mansion's layout well and soon led his men to the study.

He Jingyuan sat behind his desk, a bamboo scroll spread before him as if he were reading by candlelight. At the sight of Zheng Wenchang and his men barging in with weapons, his expression shifted slightly. "Why have you come?"

Zheng Wenchang dropped to one knee and clasped his fists. "This humble officer has come to help Your Excellency escape. Wei Xuan's actions are utterly intolerable! Your Excellency should write to the capital and inform the Prime Minister—let's see how much longer Wei Xuan can act so arrogantly!"

Hearing his intentions, He Jingyuan frowned deeply and sighed. "How foolish!"

Zheng Wenchang looked puzzled. "What does Your Excellency mean by that?"

But He Jingyuan said no more. After pacing the study for a while, he ordered, "Take your men and leave at once."

Zheng Wenchang was stunned. "And what of Your Excellency?"

He Jingyuan replied, "Wei Xuan wouldn't dare harm me. I have my reasons for acting this way. All of you should return and await orders."

Zheng Wenchang and the other officers exchanged glances, but out of respect and obedience to He Jingyuan, they clasped their fists and said, "As you command."

As they prepared to leave, He Jingyuan hesitated before adding, "If you see Wei Xuan's soldiers oppressing innocent commoners during grain levies, intervene—but avoid bloodshed."

Though puzzled, the officers merely acknowledged the order.

Only Zheng Wenchang, the last to leave, turned back at the door to ask in confusion, "Why should Your Excellency fear Wei Xuan?"

He Jingyuan stood with his hands behind his back, gazing at the plaque inscribed with "Virtue Alone Fragrant" above the desk, and sighed. "It's not that I fear him. Don't ask too much. Just do as I say."

Zheng Wenchang had no choice but to clasp his fists and withdraw, his mind filled with unanswered questions.

Yet He Jingyuan remained fixated on that plaque, unable to tear his gaze away.

His own sins mattered little. What truly weighed on him was whether the people of Great Yin would be forced to survive amidst the flames of war in the future.

When the Son of Heaven rages, corpses pile up by the millions.

The conflicts of those in power ultimately bring suffering only to the common folk.

If those two hundred thousand bushels of grain bought by that merchant surnamed Zhao were truly in his hands, this test would reveal whether he shared Wei Yan's ruthless determination—stopping at nothing to achieve his goals—or if he still held some compassion for the people of the realm.

If it was the latter, then perhaps, upon his return, it would be time to reveal what he knew about the Battle of Jinzhou sixteen years ago.

If it was the former, he would take that secret to his grave.

A man consumed by hatred, devoid of any mercy for the world, would only ignite more war once he learned the truth. And the people would suffer endlessly.

Chapter 44

The next day, Fan Changyu got up early as usual to slaughter pigs.

During these first few days after the New Year, most people in town were visiting relatives, and nearly every meal had meat in it. With bellies already greasy from rich food, folks weren't craving fresh meat as much, so sales at her shop were slow. However, the braised meat business was booming—every household preferred buying ready-made braised meat to serve guests, as it made for an impressive dish on the dining table.

Before, Changyu's shop could sell two pigs' worth of fresh meat, but these days, she only slaughtered one pig for fresh cuts.

As for the braised meat supplied to the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, she sourced the meat from elsewhere. On the street where pork was sold, pig heads and pork knuckles were almost entirely bought up by Changyu.

She was no longer just a competitor to the other butchers but had also become their biggest customer. To secure this long-term business, every butcher on the street greeted her with cheerful smiles, far more warmly than before.

If she ever ran into any difficulties at the shop, all she had to do was speak up, and a crowd would rush to help her.

Changyu suddenly understood why, after Song Yan passed the provincial exams, some people in town had gone out of their way to flatter the Song family by stepping on her.

Just as Yan Zheng had said—when she had nothing, no matter how good her nature was, people would still find fault with her.

But now, with just a slight connection to wealth and influence, the kindness she received multiplied several times over.

Everything was moving in a positive direction, except that Changyu was now stretched thin—delivering meat to the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion and the portly manager while also managing her own pork shop.

Finding a helper on such short notice wasn't easy.

During breakfast, she kept glancing at Xie Zheng, hesitating to speak.

Xie Zheng had slept poorly the night before, the dark circles under his eyes even more pronounced. Noticing her frequent looks, he set down his bowl of porridge and asked, "What's wrong?"

Only then did Changyu notice his noticeably darker eye circles and was stunned. "Did you not sleep at all last night?"

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze. "No, there were sounds of rats in the room. It took some time to deal with them."

There had indeed been rats, but he'd killed one with a single bamboo skewer and tossed it to the gyrfalcon.

At the mention of rats, Changyu immediately thought of the cured meat hanging above the fire pit and grew worried. She hurried over to check but found no signs of rodent nibbling, finally relaxing.

"Before, we never kept so much braised or cured meat at home—we mostly sold fresh cuts, so there weren't many rats. I've been careless. I'll have to get a cat soon."

Changning, who had already finished eating, went to check on the gyrfalcon in the chicken coop and burst into tears. "Falcon's gone again!"

Changyu was puzzled. "Did it fly away?"

The sisters both turned to Xie Zheng.

The man, who had secretly sent the gyrfalcon to deliver a letter in the middle of the night, paused briefly before saying, "That creature is hard to tame. Maybe it wasn't fully trained yet."

Tears broke free from Changning's eyes, slipping down her cheeks one after another like a cascade of golden beads.

Changyu sighed. "Don't cry, sweetheart. How about I get you a brood of chicks in spring?"

Changning kept sobbing. "Don't want chicks! Want Falcon!"

She wiped her eyes with her sleeve. "Falcon will come back!"

Then she looked at Xie Zheng with hopeful eyes.

This time, Xie Zheng didn't give her a definite answer. He only said, "Maybe it will."

Changning immediately pouted and cried even harder.

Fan Changyu coaxed her, "Shall we go catch another one in the wild?"

Changning shook her head, "I don't want any other, I only want Falcon."

Fan Changyu knew children could test one's patience when stubborn. She said, "The gyrfalcon has already flown away. It belongs in the wild to begin with, and even your sister can't find it now. The best I can do is catch you another one if you want, but you refuse and just keep crying. Ning Niang, tell me, what else can your sister do?"

Changning sniffled pitifully and raised her chubby arms to hug Fan Changyu. "I'm sorry, sister. Ning Niang isn't being willful, Ning Niang just misses Falcon so much."

Fan Changyu patted the child's back.

Burying her face in her sister's shoulder, Changning said in a muffled voice, "We'll raise chicks when spring comes."

Fan Changyu agreed.

Changning straightened up, her eyes red-rimmed as she declared, "When the chicks grow up, Falcon might see them and come down to eat."

Thinking she had finally comforted the child, Fan Changyu replied, "...Alright."

At least the child had stopped crying.

Fan Changyu returned to the table and sat down, finishing her remaining half-bowl of porridge with mixed feelings. Remembering the shortage of hands at her butcher shop, she scratched her head and asked Xie Zheng, "Are you going back to sleep later?"

Xie Zheng had noticed her earlier hesitation and guessed she needed help. "Just say what you need," he replied.

Summoning her courage, Fan Changyu said, "My pork shop opens today, but I still need to deliver braised meat to Shopkeeper Yu's restaurant. If you're free, could you watch the shop for half a day? I'll come back right after the delivery."

Though he'd mentioned leaving just last night, making this request felt awkward. But overwhelmed with work, she had no choice but to impose on him this once.

When Xie Zheng nodded, Fan Changyu exhaled in relief. Had he refused, even her thick skin wouldn't have spared her some embarrassment.

She'd grown slightly more socially aware—no longer immediately offering payment, as his help was a favor. Mentioning wages now would only cheapen his kindness.

Instead of transactional promises, she decided to properly express gratitude by quietly preparing more supplies for his journey. Such subtle gestures meant more than upfront bargains.

With both going out, Fan Changyu couldn't leave Changning alone. As usual, she brought the child to Aunt Zhao's next door.

Then she hailed an ox-cart at the alley entrance to transport the fresh meat to the Fan Family's butcher shop.

The meat alone was heavy enough that Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng chose to walk alongside the cart rather than ride.

Having lived here this long, it was Xie Zheng's first time seeing the morning market. Though not as bustling as the capital, its lively atmosphere surprised him.

Steam rose from breakfast stalls' cauldrons as vendors' cries mingled with the busy traffic. The hurried crowds and vibrant activity embodied both the town's vitality and the warmth of everyday life.

At the shop, Fan Changyu unloaded a basin of braised meat while Xie Zheng carried all the fresh pork inside.

Glancing at his efficiency, Fan Changyu couldn't help but think how much easier things were with an extra pair of hands.

After placing the braised meat basin aside, she began arranging fresh cuts on the butcher's block while explaining to Xie Zheng which part of the pig each piece came from and their respective prices.

The butcher's wife from the shop across the way, noticing Xie Zheng's striking appearance, teased: "Changyu, you've finally brought your husband out for everyone to see! Such a handsome young man! No wonder you've been keeping him hidden at home!"

Having grown accustomed to Yu Qianqian's teasing, Fan Changyu wasn't as easily flustered by others' jokes about her and Xie Zheng anymore. She

replied, "Auntie, you jest. He was recovering from injuries at home before. Now that he's better and I'm swamped, he's come to lend a hand."

The butcher's wife only dared make such jokes because she knew Xie Zheng was Changyu's live-in son-in-law. Being a generation older, she understood how sensitive many grooms could be about their status, and her teasing might have caused marital discord.

Hearing Changyu's earnest explanation, she quickly amended: "That was just a silly joke, young man. Don't take it to heart."

Xie Zheng responded simply, "I won't."

The butcher's wife added, "Changyu used to manage everything in this shop alone. Now that she's married, she finally has some help."

Xie Zheng silently arranged pork cuts on the block, glancing at Changyu as she hoisted a ham onto an iron hook. Despite the thick winter clothes, fine beads of sweat already dotted her forehead. He realized she must have done all this work single-handedly before.

"The ham sells for thirty-five coppers per jin. If customers bargain, never go below thirty..." Changyu explained the pricing while securing the meat. Turning back, she noticed Xie Zheng watching her and frowned. "Didn't you remember?"

Xie Zheng averted his gaze. "I did."

Skeptical, Changyu pressed, "What did I just say?"

With a faint smile, Xie Zheng recited, "Ham at thirty-five coppers, no less than thirty when bargaining."

Nodding approval, Changyu said, "Exactly right."

Just then, an elderly shopper paused at their stall, drawn by Xie Zheng's striking presence. "Young man, how much for this hind leg?" she inquired.

Changyu stayed silent, curious to observe Xie Zheng's salesmanship.

Meeting the customer's gaze calmly, Xie Zheng quoted, "Thirty-three coppers per jin."

"That's quite dear..." the woman muttered.

Xie Zheng merely raised his eyebrows slightly, adopting an unpressured take-it-or-leave-it attitude that made Changyu's eye twitch. She quickly

interjected, "You're welcome to compare prices elsewhere first. If our quality still appeals, we'll be here."

The haggling attempt foiled, the woman conceded, "You youngsters seem honest enough not to cheat an old woman. Give me two jin."

As Changyu reached for the cleaver, Xie Zheng had already selected and precisely portioned the requested amount. While Changyu wrapped the purchase, the customer kept stealing glances at Xie Zheng as she counted coins. "Are you married, young man? If not, my seventeen-year-old granddaughter is quite the catch—pretty and sweet-natured..."

Xie Zheng's expression was indifferent. "This meat shop belongs to my wife. I'm just here to lend her a hand."

The middle-aged woman immediately looked somewhat embarrassed. "Oh, I see..."

She turned to Fan Changyu. After all, having lived for decades, she knew how to smooth things over. With a smile, she said, "You young couple—the man so handsome, the woman so pretty—at first glance I thought you were siblings! Turns out it's that husband-and-wife resemblance? What a blessed match!"

Fan Changyu could only force a slight upward curve of her lips.

As soon as the woman left, Changyu couldn't help but scold Xie Zheng: "No matter what, you should greet customers with a smile when doing business. You look like someone owes you money—who'd want to buy meat from you?"

Just as she was speaking, a young girl buying groceries nearby blushed while looking at Xie Zheng and asked, "How much for these pork ribs?"

Xie Zheng's face remained completely expressionless. "Thirty-nine wen per pound."

Pork ribs were the most expensive among fresh meats.

The girl didn't dare look directly at Xie Zheng, keeping her head down as she murmured shyly, "I'll take three pounds, please chop them into small pieces."

Xie Zheng picked up the cleaver, chopped the ribs into pieces with a few swift strokes, wrapped them up, and handed them over.

Fan Changyu watched this scene dumbfounded.

For convenience in counting, a hundred coins could be strung together with thin string, making transactions easier for both parties.

When Xie Zheng handed her the one hundred and seventeen wen, Changyu was still somewhat stunned.

Then she gradually accepted this reality—while others relied on smooth talk to sell pork, this guy sold pork with his face.

Rubbing her forehead with one hand, she joked half-heartedly, "I should have had you help in the shop earlier. Our business might have been even better before the New Year."

Xie Zheng glanced at her but didn't respond.

It was still early, with few customers in the market. Other pork shops remained deserted, yet the Fan Family's stall had already made two sales.

Though other butchers were envious, Changyu often bought pig heads, pork knuckles, and occasionally offal from their shops for her braised meat business, effectively supporting their trade. Thus, no one harbored resentment.

Butcher Guo, however, had long-standing grievances with the Fan family. Changyu would never buy from his shop, making their rivalry increasingly intense.

While clearing snow in front of his stall, he aggressively flung shovelfuls onto the street, sneering sarcastically, "Selling meat indeed—why not go to the brothels instead? Might fetch better prices there!"

Clearly mocking how Xie Zheng's looks attracted customers to the Fan shop.

Changyu's face darkened instantly.

She was fiercely protective of those close to her. Xie Zheng had entered this sham marriage to help her safeguard her family assets. While others might mock his status as a live-in son-in-law behind her back, she wouldn't tolerate such vulgar remarks right before her eyes!

Moreover, his uncle had recently conspired with Fan Da to seize her property. With old grudges and new grievances combined, it was time to settle accounts!

Changyu stepped out of her shop and planted herself in the middle of the street, arms crossed as she glared at Butcher Guo. "Say that again."

Her shout drew the attention of every shopkeeper on the street and the few scattered shoppers passing by.

Butcher Guo had suffered at Fan Changyu's hands before, so he didn't dare confront her directly. Instead, he resorted to verbal provocation: "What did I say? Oh, just now on the road, a prostitute was flirting with a male prostitute. I was talking about them, so why are you, Miss Fan, so eager to claim the insult?"

The moment he finished speaking, his chin was struck hard by a long staff. The force was so strong that Butcher Guo staggered back several steps, only steadying himself after crashing into a shop counter.

Clutching his chin with one hand, he felt as though his upper and lower teeth had been jammed together, the taste of blood filling his mouth. For a long moment, he couldn't utter a word. Pointing at Fan Changyu with his other hand, he barely had time to speak before meeting her icy glare.

She only said two cold words: "Apologize."

Butcher Guo endured the sharp pain in his jaw, spat out a mouthful of bloody saliva, and then his temper flared. He snarled, "I wasn't talking about you or your pretty-boy husband! You're the one who took it personally. Why the hell should I apologize?"

Fan Changyu had no patience for his nonsense. With a thrust of her staff, Butcher Guo ducked in fright. Though the staff had no spearhead, her sheer strength drove it straight through the wooden counter door.

One couldn't help but wonder—if it had been a skull, the staff might have punched a bloody hole straight through it.

Butcher Guo trembled in fear but still blustered, "You dare touch me? My uncle is the County Magistrate's advisor! If this goes to court, you'll rot in jail!"

Fan Changyu said, "Do you believe I can twist your head off and feed it to the dogs before your precious uncle even gets here?"

When it came to sheer audacity, Butcher Guo was no match for her. His face twisted with resentment.

Fan Changyu barked again, "Apologize!"

Reluctantly, under the threat of the staff pointed at his face, Butcher Guo finally gritted his teeth and muttered in front of the crowd, "My

apologies."

Fan Changyu withdrew her staff and sneered. "They say only eunuchs love to gossip, but you're even worse than them! If you're so jealous of my butcher shop's business, why not aim higher? With your talent for twisting words, you'd make a fine chief eunuch in the palace. It's a shame to waste that silver tongue of yours!"

The onlookers burst into laughter.

Other butchers in the market stifled their grins.

"A eunuch? Ha! With Guo's bluster and no substance, he might as well be one!"

"I heard his son looks just like his cousin—probably borrowed seed!"

"Everyone's been saying his wife cheated on him. Poor woman's been slandered all this time, but turns out it wasn't her fault—he's just useless!"

"He's built like an ox, so how's that thing not working?"

"Rumor has it he was butchering a pig once, and when it struggled, he lost his grip. The pig kicked him right in the family jewels!"

Butcher Guo's face turned crimson with rage as he listened to the crowd's jeers, veins bulging in his neck. "Shut your damn mouths! I'll cut every last one of you down!"

The crowd scattered, but the whispers didn't stop.

"Look at him—he's fuming. Could it be true?"

"I always said that a grown man who gossips so much and keeps calling handsome young men male prostitutes must be one himself!"

The rumor grew wilder by the minute. The angrier Butcher Guo got at the surrounding crowd, the more elaborate the stories people spun about him became.

In the end, Butcher Guo could only glare venomously at Fan Changyu: "You just wait!"

Fan Changyu couldn't even be bothered to look at him. "That filthy mouth of yours spews the vilest things about others, but now that the tables are turned, suddenly it hurts?"

With that, she picked up her staff and returned to her butcher shop.

Butcher Guo, hearing the crowd's relentless chatter, had no mood to continue business for the day. He simply closed up shop and hid at home.

Back in her shop, Fan Changyu apologized to Xie Zheng with some remorse: "Sorry you had to get dragged into Guo's nonsense right before you leave."

Xie Zheng had seen how she'd defended him outside. "It's fine," he said, though his eyes held complex emotions.

Fan Changyu added, "He only acts so bold because his uncle's a county clerk. Once the magistrate's term ends and he's transferred, that uncle of his will be nothing!"

During the earlier scuffle, the cloth binding her sleeve had come loose.

Frowning, she untied it to rewrap it. To tighten it properly, she held one end between her teeth while clumsily trying to wind the other around her sleeve with one hand.

Though winter sleeves were narrower than summer ones, they still hindered work. Being a butcher who frequently chopped bones, she bound her sleeves at the wrists with cloth for protection.

Noticing this, Xie Zheng took the cloth strip from her hand with his long fingers. "Let me help."

It sounded more like a statement than a request, for before she could respond, his other hand had already pinched the end between her teeth. "Let go," he said.

Caught off guard, Changyu instinctively released her bite.

By the time she regained her senses, Xie Zheng had already neatly folded up her sleeve. Pressing firmly but gently at her wrist, he began winding the cloth strip methodically. The sensation against her skin was unusually vivid.

Changyu's fingertips curled slightly without her realizing.

The dark blue cloth contrasted starkly against his pale, slender fingers—bones and tendons clearly visible beneath the skin, creating an indescribably elegant sight.

Though he appeared focused, he still managed to ask, "When does your magistrate's term end?"

The strange atmosphere had made Changyu uncomfortable, but his question eased the tension. "After New Year's, it'll be three full years," she answered.

Xie Zheng said, "Then that clerk's days are numbered."

Under Great Yin's official regulations, county magistrates were reassigned every three years—typically transferred, only promoted for exceptional merit. If local citizens petitioned for them to stay, they might remain.

When Changyu asked why, he explained the regulations. Understanding dawned on her, and she laughed, "Then I've even less to fear from that Guo fellow!"

County clerks were merely magistrates' hired advisors—not even government-salaried officials.

Since he was the one advising the county magistrate, he must also be privy to many of the magistrate's secrets. Typically, when a magistrate is transferred or promoted, they either take their advisor to the new post or pay them off to prevent them from working for others in the future.

Given the current magistrate's actions in Qingping County over the years, it's impossible for the people to petition for him to stay.

So whether the magistrate is promoted or demoted, he won't remain in Qingping County. Even if Butcher Guo's uncle continues to serve as his advisor, their new post won't be in Qingping County, meaning he can no longer throw his weight around here.

After Xie Zheng finished tying the cloth strip around her sleeve for her, he looked up and saw the unrestrained, radiant smile on her face.

His gaze darkened slightly as he averted his eyes and said, "Done."

Fan Changyu flexed her wrist, her smile unwavering. "It is tighter than when I do it myself. Thanks!"

The lingering sensation of his grip around her wrist made it feel as though his hand was still there. Only after she rubbed it did that strange feeling fade somewhat.

Xie Zheng replied, "It was nothing."

Fan Changyu glanced at the sky outside and said, "I need to hurry and deliver the goods to Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. I'll leave the shop to

you."

Xie Zheng said, "Don't worry."

As she reached the door, Changyu turned back to add, "If someone comes to buy meat and we're sold out, help me take down their order if they want to reserve some."

Xie Zheng nodded in agreement.

Only then did Changyu leave with peace of mind. Once seated in the ox cart, she couldn't help but rub her wrist again, though she couldn't quite pinpoint what felt off.

The roads were slippery from the snow, and it took Changyu half an hour to reach the county town's Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. From a distance, she could already see a crowd gathered at the pavilion's entrance, with faint cries of mourning as if someone was wailing in grief. The crowd was so dense that even passing through was difficult, let alone getting the ox cart through.

Changyu had no choice but to dismount and ask a bystander on the outskirts of the crowd, "What's going on at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion?"

The middle-aged woman turned to glance at her and said, "Someone died from eating the food here. The family brought the coffin right to the entrance and is demanding justice!"

Changyu's heart skipped a beat. She had once worked at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion and knew that the ingredients procured there were of the highest quality. Shopkeeper Yu had always been meticulous about food quality—how could someone have died from eating there?

She grabbed the woman's arm and asked, "When did this happen?"

The woman, taken aback by her urgency, replied, "I heard it was yesterday at noon. The person suddenly started foaming at the mouth while eating, and though they called a physician immediately, they couldn't be saved. Early this morning, the family came to demand answers."

Two rough-looking men nearby glanced at Changyu and clicked their tongues, shaking their heads. "Charging such high prices, yet serving food that kills people—the owner of this place deserves death!"

"If the authorities don't investigate this strictly, who'd dare eat out anymore?"

"I've long heard that the female owner of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion dabbles in shady practices. Rumor has it she adds something addictive to the food—how else could she have opened two restaurants in just a few years and made such a killing? Maybe this time, she added too much, and that's why someone died!"

"Honestly, it should be a life for a life! Arrest that female owner and execute her. Just look at her face—she's clearly not the decent type! Definitely no good!"

Changyu's lips pressed into a thin line as she listened to the two rat-faced men in felt caps sneer and slander Yu Qianqian.

After retreating from the crowd, she instructed the ox cart driver to wait in a less congested area and headed toward the alley behind Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion.

Entering through the back door, Changyu found the kitchen nearly empty. The managers and the staff who usually attended to high-profile guests were all at the front, arguing with the deceased's family.

Finally spotting a waiter, Changyu quickly called out to him, "Where's Shopkeeper Yu?"

The waiter thought she was there to deliver braised meat and waved his hands dismissively. "Boss Fan, you can see the situation in the pavilion. We can't accept your braised meat today."

Fan Changyu said, "I'm not here for that. I came to see Shopkeeper Yu. What exactly happened with the person who died here yesterday?"

The waiter looked exasperated. "Who knows? Yesterday, a customer suddenly had a seizure. The shopkeeper thought it might be goat horn wind and immediately sent for a physician. The family was grateful at first, but after taking the person home, they passed away during the night. Early this morning, they brought a coffin to the restaurant's doorstep, demanding compensation for their elder's life! Isn't this just blatant extortion?"

"No matter how Shopkeeper Yu tried to reason with them, they wouldn't back down. Even offering money to settle the matter didn't work—they were clearly here to cause trouble. The shopkeeper suspects another

restaurant might be behind this. He reported it to the authorities, but no officers have come. He went to the government office himself to pull some strings, but it's been a while, and he still hasn't returned."

Though Fan Changyu hadn't read many books, she understood the saying "Tall trees catch much wind."

Yu Qianqian's banquet a few days ago had been a great success, and Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion had gained quite a reputation in the county, taking business away from many larger restaurants. It was inevitable that someone would grow envious, but using such underhanded tactics against Yu Qianqian was truly despicable.

The crowd gathered outside Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion wasn't just there because of the coffin—everyone was condemning Yu Qianqian, with not a single voice speaking up for her. Some even claimed the restaurant's dishes contained addictive substances. Fan Changyu immediately thought of those two shifty-eyed men.

Their coordinated performance was clearly meant to mislead the uninformed and stir up trouble.

If the coffin-bearers couldn't be persuaded to leave, then the instigators spreading rumors had to be dealt with first.

After a moment's thought, Fan Changyu said to the waiter, "Gather a few more people, change out of your uniforms, and come with me."

The waiter, already overwhelmed by the chaos, replied apologetically, "Sorry, Boss Fan, but we really don't have the manpower to spare today..."

Fan Changyu cut in, "There are people in that crowd deliberately slandering Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Bring some men with me, and we'll pull them out."

Hearing this, the waiter quickly rounded up a few others.

Half a quarter-hour later, Fan Changyu led seven or eight plainclothes staff from Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion out the back door and pushed back into the crowd.

After observing for a while, she noticed that most onlookers, after watching for a bit and seeing no resolution, eventually left to attend to other matters.

Only a group similar to the two felt-hat men remained at the restaurant's entrance, shouting louder than anyone else. Whenever an uninformed passerby asked what was happening, they immediately repeated the claim that the restaurant's food contained addictive substances.

Fan Changyu was certain these were the troublemakers. She signaled to the staff.

These workers treated Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion as their own home and couldn't tolerate such slander. Following Fan Changyu's instructions, they pretended to push toward the center of the crowd, forcing the instigators to the outer edges. Then, the staff behind them grabbed their shoulders and dragged them away.

These men were already guilty and nervous, so when they were grabbed, they immediately tried to shout. Fan Changyu swiftly punched them in the gut a few times, successfully making them swallow their cries before they could escape their lips.

Nearby townsfolk turned to look, and Fan Changyu snarled, "What are you staring at? Never seen debt collectors from a gambling den before?"

As she spoke, she kicked one of the felt-hatted men: "You bastard! Run all you want—you can't escape forever!"

The staff of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion were momentarily stunned to see their usually kind and approachable boss suddenly acting like a street thug, kicking people in broad daylight. But they quickly snapped out of it and rushed forward to help, grabbing the men by their collars and dragging them toward an alley. Seizing the chance to settle personal grudges, they punched and kicked while cursing loudly, "Pay your debts or we'll break your legs!"

The onlookers, hearing they were gambling debt collectors and seeing the men's shifty, unsavory appearances, hurriedly backed away, not daring to interfere.

The captives tried to yell, but their mouths were soon stuffed with filthy rags, leaving them only able to mumble as they were hauled into the courtyard behind Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Tied up like livestock, they stared in terror at Fan Changyu and the disguised staff standing before them with arms crossed.

Fan Changyu sat like a bandit king on a chair brought by her staff, idly twirling a boning knife. Suddenly, she flicked her wrist—the knife shot out, piercing straight through one man's felt hat and embedding itself in the tree trunk behind him with enough force to pin the hat there.

This was the same man who had cursed Yu Qianqian the most viciously earlier.

Fan Changyu looked up, ready to deliver a threat, but paused for a second—under that hat was a bald head!

No wonder he wore a hat!

Now exposed, the bald man's scalp felt the icy sting of the wind, sharp as a blade. Remembering how close that knife had come to his head, his face turned ghostly pale.

Fan Changyu quickly masked her brief surprise and resumed her menacing glare. "Who sent you to cause trouble at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion?"

A shifty-eyed man beside the bald one sneered, "No one sent us! People died from eating your food—can't we demand justice? You tie us up here, planning to kill us and silence everyone? This isn't a restaurant—it's a murderous den of thieves!"

Fan Changyu's temper flared at his incessant yapping—this guy was as vile as Butcher Guo!

She grabbed a wooden mallet leaning against the wall and cracked it against his forehead three times. The crisp thwacks were far more satisfying.

The man was clearly dazed from the blows.

Fan Changyu growled, "Did I say you could speak?"

The other tied-up troublemakers gulped, shuffling away from the man as subtly as they could, curling up to make themselves as small as possible.

The man wanted to keep running his mouth, but seeing the mallet in Fan Changyu's hand and feeling the splitting pain in his skull, he reluctantly shut up.

Fan Changyu scoffed. "That tongue of yours is useless anyway. Someone—drag him away and chop it up to feed the dogs!"

The staff at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion exchanged glances before two of them immediately stepped forward, dragging the bound troublemaker to the backyard.

Soon after, the sound of sharpening knives could be heard, followed by the heavy thud of a cleaver striking a chopping block and the man's agonized screams. Moments later, the screams ceased, replaced only by muffled groans.

The other troublemakers tied up in the yard turned pale with fear.

Fan Changyu nearly lost her composure on the chair. She had only been putting on a show to intimidate them, just as she'd read in storybooks. Had the staff misunderstood her intentions and actually cut out the man's tongue?

Before long, a staff member came forward carrying a plate with a small, bloodied piece of tongue on it and said to Fan Changyu, "The bastard struggled too much—we couldn't pull out his whole tongue, only managed to cut off this bit."

The sight of the gory lump nearly made the troublemakers wet themselves in terror, too frightened to look closely. Fan Changyu, who often slaughtered pigs, immediately recognized it as a small piece of pork tongue—not very fresh at that—drenched in what looked like chicken or duck blood. Placed on the plate, it was convincing enough to scare them.

She sighed in relief, thinking the staff were quite clever, and maintained her fierce expression. "Bring a dog here and feed it to the dog!" she barked.

A staff member promptly led a wolfhound over and tossed the pork tongue to it. The dog devoured it ravenously.

The troublemakers watched, retching uncontrollably, some even losing control of their bladders.

Fan Changyu figured they were scared enough to tell the truth now. Glaring, she pressed the bald one again, "Speak! Who sent you to cause trouble at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion? If you lie even once, your tongues will be cut out and fed to the dogs too!"

The bald man was retching so hard tears streamed down his face. "I'll talk! I'll talk!" he cried. "It was Master He's servant who hired us!"

Hearing this, Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned.

How was Master He, that troublemaker, involved again?

"You're lying!" she snapped.

The bald man, still bound, kowtowed frantically. "I swear, ma'am! It really was Master He's servant who came to us!"

Fan Changyu demanded, "Master He has no grudge against the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Why would he send you to do this?"

The bald man wailed, "We don't know either!"

The other troublemakers also tearfully pointed fingers at Master He.

"Let them go," a woman's voice called from the moon gate.

Fan Changyu looked up and saw Yu Qianqian. She stood from her chair. "Shopkeeper Yu, you're back?"

Yu Qianqian nodded, her eyes warm with gratitude. "Just returned. I happened to hear you interrogating these men for me. Thank you, Changyu."

Fan Changyu replied, "I didn't do much to help."

Yu Qianqian smiled. "This was more than enough. Release them."

She signaled the staff to untie the troublemakers.

The man Fan Changyu had ordered taken away earlier was brought back out—his tongue intact, though his mouth had been gagged. Clearly, the earlier screams had been faked by some method Yu Qianqian had arranged.

Puzzled, Fan Changyu asked, "Aren't you taking them to the magistrate's court to confront Master He?"

Yu Qianqian only shook her head, her expression weary. After the ruffians had been taken away by the establishment's staff, she finally spoke: "As you just found out, these men were sent by Master He."

Fan Changyu frowned. "Did a rival restaurant seeking to compete with Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion bribe Master He to undermine your business?"

Yu Qianqian gave a bitter smile. "It's worse than that."

Fan Changyu had thought that was the worst possible scenario. Hearing Yu Qianqian say it was even worse left her at a loss. "What exactly is

happening?"

Yu Qianqian's neatly combed bangs were now disheveled from constant rubbing. She closed her eyes. "Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion can't be saved. It's my fault—I was too aggressive. If only I hadn't rushed to open a restaurant in the county town last year..."

In Fan Changyu's memory, Yu Qianqian had always been confident and in control, rarely showing such helplessness. "Though our friendship isn't particularly deep, I remember all the times you've helped me. I don't know what difficulties Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion is facing, but if you need it, my family has some connections with Head Constable Wang at the County Government Office. I could ask him for a favor to see if we can help."

Yu Qianqian shook her head. "It's no use."

She squeezed Fan Changyu's hand and forced a smile. "I appreciate your kindness. I've spent the entire afternoon exhausting all my connections. If there were a way, I wouldn't just wait for disaster. Don't go to Head Constable Wang—it would only cause trouble for him."

Fan Changyu could feel Yu Qianqian's exhaustion. Even she hadn't expected Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion to face such a crisis overnight. "I still can't understand what trouble the pavilion has gotten into. The old man who ate here yesterday—I heard from the staff that he had a goat horn wind seizure, which caused the foaming at the mouth. How can that be blamed on the food? Even if it goes to court, physicians can testify."

Yu Qianqian asked, "Do you know who Master He works for?"

Fan Changyu uttered two words: "The magistrate?"

Yu Qianqian nodded wearily. "The highest official in Qingping County wants to seize my family's assets. Right and wrong in court are whatever he says. What commoner would dare oppose an official?"

Fan Changyu said, "Then appeal to Jizhou Prefecture. The magistrate may be the highest authority in Qingping County, but outside it, what power does he have?"

Yu Qianqian shook her head again, her expression pained. "After hearing rumors from noble households that the magistrate was behind this, I sent a guard by carriage to Jizhou Prefecture. Just as I returned, someone delivered something..."

Her voice trembled. "It was my guard's severed finger. The officials and bandits are working together—all roads to Jizhou Prefecture are blocked by outlaws."

Fan Changyu finally understood what it meant for someone to "cover the sky with one hand." What Yu Qianqian was experiencing was even more hopeless than when Fan Da had tried to seize her family's property.

The authorities had already spread rumors that Yu Qianqian's restaurant had tampered with its food. Coinciding with an old man's death after dining at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, they could easily claim her food was to blame. After confiscating all her assets, they might even arrest her.

In the blink of an eye, Fan Changyu recalled what Xie Zheng had mentioned earlier about the military grain requisition in Jizhou Prefecture. She said, "With just you alone, you'd certainly be outmatched. But if all the people of Qingping County rise against the magistrate, then whether the authorities blockade the roads or send Yamen Runners to suppress us, it won't matter anymore!"

Yu Qianqian asked, "How so?"

Fan Changyu explained, "Jizhou Prefecture is collecting military grain, and our county is demanding one dan of grain per person. Those who can't pay in grain must pay in silver. With over a hundred thousand people in Qingping County, that means the county alone could forcibly extract a hundred thousand dan of grain. Jizhou wouldn't push the common folk to the brink—clearly, the magistrate is using this as an opportunity to amass wealth!"

Upon hearing this, Yu Qianqian's expression changed drastically.

She murmured, "The magistrate isn't just amassing wealth. At this critical moment of his transfer, he's suddenly extorted so much silver from the people and set his sights on my Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Even if he can hide it temporarily, it won't last forever—he'll eventually be exposed. Even after his transfer, he won't escape punishment. Perhaps... the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion is just the chicken slaughtered to warn the monkeys! His real targets are all the wealthy merchants of Qingping County!"

She turned to Fan Changyu, her face grim. "Chongzhou borders Jizhou. The magistrate must be planning to defect to the Rebel King!"

Chapter 45

Fan Changyu couldn't immediately grasp the key point and asked, "Why do you say that?"

Yu Qianqian analyzed for her: "If the county magistrate is extorting the people's blood and sweat because his superiors want to embezzle, then the magistrate wouldn't need to collude with bandits to block the roads to Jizhou Prefecture. Even if things escalated, his superiors could easily suppress it."

"As for using the old man's death to pressure me, it's simply because they've targeted the financial resources of Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. Among the wealthy merchants in this town, my foundation is the shallowest, making me an easy target. The usual bribes I give officials might get me help with ordinary difficulties, but in such serious matters, they wouldn't dare get involved. Once Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion falls, the magistrate can then extort money from other wealthy merchants one by one. If those merchants don't want to end up bankrupt and imprisoned like me, they'll have no choice but to pay up."

Fan Changyu suddenly understood the stakes and slammed the table, saying, "Then we must quickly unite with the other wealthy merchants in Qingping County!"

But Yu Qianqian shook her head: "This matter requires careful planning. I'm just a merchant and have no idea how much grain each household is supposed to contribute under the Grain Requisition Order issued by the prefecture. If you hadn't mentioned that the magistrate might be embezzling by collecting so much grain, I wouldn't have thought this deeply. After all, while bullying a merchant like me might not draw much attention from the court, oppressing the entire population of Qingping County without protection from above would surely lead to disaster once exposed. The magistrate must understand this. After much thought, the only possibility is that he intends to defect to the Rebel King."

She paused here and looked at Fan Changyu: "Only officials know how much grain the military requires. Sister Changyu, how did you know the magistrate was collecting extra military provisions?"

After repeating Xie Zheng's reasoning, Fan Changyu added, "The magistrate blocking the roads to Jizhou Prefecture is surely because he's guilty!"

Yu Qianqian pondered briefly and said, "With the blocked roads, we can almost certainly conclude the magistrate intends to rebel. But unless he admits it and claims it's just bandits robbing travelers, we have no evidence to prove his collusion with them or to convince the people. The only thing that could expose the magistrate is the Grain Requisition Order. Simply saying this year's levy is higher than before isn't enough—Jizhou authorities wouldn't push the people to this extent, so it can't serve as proof against the magistrate. Besides, with Huizhou's recent defeat and grain supply lines disrupted, no one can guess what the officials are thinking."

When Fan Changyu heard Xie Zheng's analysis, she found it very convincing. Now, listening to Yu Qianqian, she suddenly felt Yu Qianqian's points also made sense.

As she carefully considered both Xie Zheng's and Yu Qianqian's words, a strange feeling arose in her heart.

Yu Qianqian said only officials knew how much grain the military required, yet Yan Zheng had spoken as if he knew exactly how much the government intended to collect.

Moreover, Yu Qianqian worried Jizhou officials might disregard the people's welfare for the sake of war, while Yan Zheng was absolutely certain Jizhou wouldn't dare push the people so far.

Was it because Yu Qianqian, with years of business experience, considered things more thoroughly, while Yan Zheng, lacking her experience, held unrealistic expectations of the government?

Yet based on the facts before them, Yan Zheng seemed correct—the grain requisition demanded by Jizhou wasn't as excessive as what the magistrate was collecting.

She frowned in deep thought, her brows nearly knitting together in frustration.

Yu Qianqian noticed and, assuming she was troubled about the matter of accusing the county magistrate, comforted her: "Don't worry about it for me, Changyu. I'll figure out a way to handle the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion situation myself."

Given how the county magistrate was using the old man who died of goat horn wind to smear the pavilion's reputation, it was clear he intended to throw Yu Qianqian into jail.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and said, "That Master He is the magistrate's lackey. He's the one who hired people to frame you. I suspect he probably knows the real amount of military provisions Jizhou Prefecture is demanding. Why don't we start with him?"

Yu Qianqian looked puzzled. "How?"

Fan Changyu replied, "Knock him out with a stick, stuff him in a burlap sack, drag him back here, and interrogate him. What do you think?"

Yu Qianqian stared at the seemingly sweet and innocent girl before her, hardly believing such words had come from her mouth.

Then she recalled how Fan Changyu had just used similar methods to deal with the ruffians harassing her earlier, and her initial shock faded slightly.

After careful consideration, she nodded. "Fine, let's try it as a last resort."

She looked at Fan Changyu. "But don't get involved yourself. I'll hire someone to do it. Right now, the magistrate's main targets for extortion are the wealthy merchants of Qingping County. If this gets exposed and traced back to you, your husband and your sister will be dragged into it too."

Fan Changyu opened her mouth to argue but swallowed her words at Yu Qianqian's reasoning.

She truly feared nothing when acting alone, but once Changning was involved, she couldn't afford to be reckless.

If anything happened to her, Changning would have no one left in this world.

And Yan Zheng—Yan Zheng was about to leave soon. She couldn't let him get tangled in a legal mess because of her either.

In the end, Fan Changyu could only say, "Then, is there anything else I can do to help?"

Yu Qianqian smiled at her. "You've already given me so much advice—isn't that help enough? And stop calling me 'manager' all the time. It

sounds too formal. I may be six or seven years older than you, but don't make me sound ancient. Just call me Qianqian."

Fan Changyu could clearly sense that Yu Qianqian was treating her with more familiarity than before. She didn't dwell on the formality either and immediately said, "Qianqian."

Yu Qianqian grinned, her eyes curving like crescents. "I heard you brought a cartload of braised meat. There's no way I can sell it here today, and it'd be a shame if it spoiled before you could sell it all. Here's what we'll do—take it to the Drunken Carp Restaurant. I'm on good terms with the owner, and they happen to have a banquet today. Your braised meat will come in handy."

She called over one of the pavilion's attendants to escort Fan Changyu to the restaurant and settled the payment for the meat. "I'll pay you first on behalf of the restaurant owner and collect from him later."

Fan Changyu refused. "Focus on resolving the pavilion's troubles first. You can pay me after the restaurant owner settles with you."

Yu Qianqian pressed the money pouch into her hand. "Take it. If the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion still can't be saved, I might have to bring Bao'er to your place for a few meals. Can't owe you money beforehand."

Since she put it that way, Fan Changyu had no choice but to accept.

After delivering the braised meat to the Drunken Carp Restaurant, Fan Changyu had the cart driver take the pavilion's attendant back. Then, after some deliberation, she decided to pay a visit to Head Constable Wang's home.

It wasn't to ask Head Constable Wang to help Yu Qianqian. Fan Changyu knew Head Constable Wang was an upright man. If the county magistrate had him lead the constables under him to commit some heinous act, and Head Constable Wang, unaware of the magistrate's rebellious intentions, unwittingly became the magistrate's blade, he would likely spend the rest of his life in remorse.

What's more, if he were branded a rebel, the consequences would be even worse.

Fan Changyu knocked on Head Constable Wang's door. The same old woman answered, but she didn't seem as pleased to see Changyu as before, her face full of worry. "Ah, it's the Fan family's daughter-in-law."

"Is Head Constable Wang home?" Fan Changyu asked.

"He is," the woman replied.

She led her inside. Both Head Constable Wang and his wife were in the main room. Whether it was her imagination or not, Changyu felt there was a certain weariness about Head Constable Wang, not as heroic as before.

Wang Furen, however, smiled and invited her to sit. "Changyu, what brings you here? Are you in some trouble?"

Changyu shook her head. "No, I came to ask Uncle Wang about some matters at the County Government Office."

Wang Furen's face immediately showed hesitation. "Your Uncle Wang... I'm afraid he can't help you. He's no longer working at the County Government Office."

Changyu gasped in surprise. "When did this happen?"

Wang Furen sighed. "On the second day of the month, your uncle went to the office as usual, only to be told he needn't come anymore. They said it was because he handled the Treasure Map murder case poorly. All the lads who worked under him were replaced too. The County Magistrate has been quiet all this time, and now, just before his transfer, he pulls this stunt."

Changyu's eyelids twitched at this. Clearly, the magistrate knew Head Constable Wang's character and was afraid he might interfere, so he removed him in advance.

She asked, "Uncle Wang, do you know where the current Yamen Runners in the office are from?"

Head Constable Wang shook his head. "I didn't inquire, but I heard they specifically sought out men with good martial skills."

Changyu pressed her lips together. "Those men might be bandits."

This left both Head Constable Wang and his wife stunned.

Wang Furen was the first to react, forcing a laugh. "Child, what nonsense are you saying?"

Changyu's expression was grave. "Auntie, I'm not speaking nonsense. The magistrate has colluded with bandits to block the roads. He's also been extorting the people's blood and sweat under the guise of collecting

military provisions. Now he's targeting all the wealthy merchants in Qingping County. He clearly intends to take this wealth and defect to the Rebel King."

Her words left the room so silent you could hear a pin drop.

Head Constable Wang was too shocked to respond for a long time, murmuring, "This... how can this be?"

Changyu then recounted Yu Qianqian's ordeal. "He's no longer just pressuring the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion's shopkeeper for money—he wants all of the pavilion's wealth. And by blocking the roads, he's cut off the route from the county to Jizhou Prefecture."

Head Constable Wang was already somewhat convinced, but the news was simply too shocking. He still tried to reassure himself. "Blocking the roads might just be to stop Shopkeeper Yu from going to Jizhou Prefecture to report him?"

Seeing this, Changyu deeply felt that Yu Qianqian's concerns were justified. Without solid evidence, relying only on scattered clues and suspicions, most people—even if they harbored doubts—wouldn't dare take sides without seeing irrefutable proof.

She recalled what Yu Qianqian had said about the Grain Requisition Order and asked, "Uncle Wang, have you seen the Grain Requisition Order sent from Jizhou Prefecture to Qingping County? If the magistrate's requisition amount differs from the order, that would be solid evidence."

Head Constable Wang shook his head. "How would I have seen that? The magistrate and Master He review it first, then directly order us constables to collect the grain. But all documents are stored in the county government office's archive. I have some acquaintance with the record keeper who manages the documents—he should have access to the requisition order."

Fan Changyu's heart pounded, her palms sweating unconsciously. "Can we go see that record keeper?"

Having worked cases for years, Head Constable Wang remained cautious. "We can't alert the enemy. If I visit Clerk Liu right after being dismissed, and the magistrate truly has rebellious intentions, word would reach him the moment I step into Clerk Liu's house."

Wang Furen suddenly spoke up. "We haven't paid New Year's greetings to the Liu family yet this year. That gives us a reason. It's almost noon—old

man, you stay home. I'll take Changyu with some gifts to the Lius'. The magistrate won't suspect anything."

Head Constable Wang nodded. "That could work."

Wang Furen selected a few holiday gifts and took Fan Changyu to Clerk Liu's home.

Upon hearing their purpose, Clerk Liu was startled. "Jizhou Prefecture did send a military grain requisition document, but I've never seen it. The magistrate has kept the order himself."

The magistrate refusing to let Clerk Liu file the document further confirmed his rebellious intentions.

Fan Changyu and Wang Furen left the Liu residence, both weighed down with worry as they walked back.

Without the requisition document, their only hope now lay with Master He.

Wang Furen said sorrowfully, "That damned magistrate defected to the Rebel King with money and grain. What will the farmers whose seed stocks were seized live on?"

Changyu glanced at the sun, wondering if Yu Qianqian's group had captured Master He yet.

As this thought surfaced, another idea suddenly flashed through her mind.

She turned to Wang Furen. "Auntie, what if we just kidnap the magistrate?"

Wang Furen's eyes were still reddened. Staring at this seemingly sweet girl, she opened her mouth but remained speechless for a long moment.

Chapter 46

Lin'an Town.

Xie Zheng finished selling pork and frowned as he wiped his hands clean with a handkerchief.

Only then did he lift his gaze to glance at the sun, realizing it was nearly noon. His already furrowed brows deepened.

Lin'an Town wasn't far from the county seat—why had she been gone so long?

Xie Zheng closed up the shop. Passing through the market, he spotted a foreign merchant's stall displaying various animal pelts and leather goods. His eyes settled on a pair of vambraces.

Noticing his interest, the merchant called out, "Looking to buy vambraces, young master? These are made of deerskin—truly fine work. Though for you... they might be a bit small. I've got some made of roe deer hide here. Care to take a look?"

As he spoke, he picked up a much larger pair and offered them to Xie Zheng.

But Xie Zheng didn't take them. Instead, he picked up the deerskin vambraces, examining them before lightly gripping them in his palm, as if measuring their size from memory. After a moment, he said to the merchant, "These will do."

He paid and was about to leave when he overheard a group of men in a nearby tea house sighing heavily.

"Poor souls from Majia Village—dozens of lives lost! Those damned officials are truly heartless!"

"Let's just hope that scholar escaped. Maybe he can expose the atrocities those dogs have committed!"

Xie Zheng paused, glancing toward them. Seeing his interest, the merchant sighed and said, "It's about the massacre in Majia Village. A scholar from the village couldn't stand the government's brutal grain levy

and planned to lead the villagers to kneel before the Jizhou Prefecture Office, begging to leave some seeds for the farmers. The whole village set out last night, trying to avoid detection, but this morning, they were found slaughtered on the main road. The scholar's nowhere to be seen—either captured or escaped.”

A cold glint flashed in Xie Zheng's eyes. “Did the officials kill them?”

The merchant replied, “That's what everyone suspects. They were just poor farmers—what bandit would target them? It's not like they'd block the road just to kill dozens of peasants for sport.”

“Strangely enough, right after the massacre, all roads to Jizhou Prefecture were blocked by bandits. What a coincidence, eh? Clearly, they're afraid someone might report this to the prefecture. Farmers from the neighboring villages have already armed themselves, saying they'll join the Rebel King in Chongzhou.”

The merchant shook his head. As a foreigner, he traveled the land only to trade pelts, but as a commoner, he couldn't help but lament such a tragedy.

Xie Zheng's brows tightened. As someone in power, he sensed something amiss.

The Majia Village massacre seemed deliberately orchestrated to incite rebellion among Qingping County's people.

If that scholar survived and escaped, he would surely expose the slaughter to Jizhou Prefecture—or even the capital.

The government's ruthless grain levy had left the people with no way to survive. When they knelt before the county magistrate, pleading for mercy, they were ignored. Turning to the prefecture, they were slaughtered on the way. Anyone hearing of such a tragedy would wish to tear those officials limb from limb.

Such atrocities fueled public outrage, and inciting rebellion in Qingping County would undoubtedly strike a blow to the imperial court's military efforts.

Recalling the similar tragedies reported during the grain levy in Taizhou, Xie Zheng's gaze turned even colder.

Every atrocity tied to the grain levy seemed to have someone deliberately fanning the flames behind the scenes.

The only ones who benefited were undoubtedly the rebels in Chongzhou

Jizhou Prefecture.

Wei Xuan sat in the main seat, watching impatiently as his subordinates tallied the provisions collected from various counties.

Soon, a personal guard reported, "General, the grain from Qingping County has not yet arrived."

Wei Xuan, already in a foul mood, grew even angrier. He kicked over the low table in front of him and roared, "How dare a mere county magistrate defy my military orders?"

Drawing his sword, he stood up. "Men! Mobilize the troops! We're going to Qingping County to collect the grain ourselves!"

Just then, a scout rushed in urgently. "Report—urgent dispatch from Yanzhou, eight hundred li away!"

Wei Xuan's expression darkened. Yanzhou was nothing more than a barren, mountainous backwater near Mount Yan—the very place where he had exiled Xie Zheng's former subordinates. What urgent news could there possibly be?

When he unfolded the letter and saw the familiar handwriting, his blood ran cold.

The personal guard didn't understand why his general's face had suddenly twisted in fury—until Wei Xuan abruptly drew his sword and hacked the overturned table in half, his eyes blazing with rage. "He's not dead! He deliberately waited until now to reveal himself, just to humiliate me after my defeat!"

A trusted aide picked up the discarded letter from the floor. Upon seeing the bold, unrestrained script and the signature—"Xie Jiuhang"—he too was horrified.

The Great Yin's Wu'an Marquis, surnamed Xie, given name Zheng, courtesy name Jiuhang.

This courtesy name had been bestowed by his teacher, Grand Tutor Tao, who said the character "Zheng" (meaning "to conquer") carried too much aggression and feared he might act recklessly in pursuit of victory. Thus, he gave him the courtesy name "Jiuhang" ("nine measures") to temper his

nature—while others needed only to think twice, Xie Zheng was to weigh matters nine times before acting.

All these years, Xie Zheng had indeed lived up to Grand Tutor Tao's expectations, never acting rashly on the battlefield. Though he had risen to fame at a young age, his prudence rivaled that of seasoned veterans.

The personal guard, being Wei Xuan's confidant, naturally knew about the Wei father and son's scheme against Wu'an Marquis during the Chongzhou campaign.

He immediately advised, "Wu'an Marquis has been lying low all this time, surely biding his strength to avenge that day. In this letter, he orders you to retreat to Huizhou and guard the northwestern gateway against foreign enemies—this could very well be a trap! The northwest is no longer safe. The Prime Minister's transfer orders will arrive soon—returning to the capital is your best course of action!"

Wei Xuan grabbed the guard by the collar and snarled, "You think I'm afraid of him?"

The guard knew Wei Xuan despised being compared unfavorably to Wu'an Marquis, but now was not the time to worry about provoking him. He pleaded earnestly, "General, don't let pride cloud your judgment! The northwest is already in chaos. The remaining seventy thousand soldiers in Huizhou were all trained by Wu'an Marquis himself. They obeyed your orders only because they believed Wu'an Marquis had died at the hands of the Chongzhou rebels and sought vengeance for him. Now that he's alive, we're nothing but fish on his chopping block if we stay here!"

Wei Xuan knew the guard spoke the truth—but the more he understood, the more infuriated he became. He had been overshadowed by this man since childhood. Xie Zheng was a thorn in his eye, one he could never pluck out.

Yet in the end, Wei Xuan had no choice but to swallow his pride. With two thousand personal guards in tow, he stormed out of Jizhou Prefecture in a rage.

When He Jingyuan heard of this in his residence, he sighed—half in relief, half in shame.

Relieved that the famed "Slaughter General" was ruthless only toward foreign enemies, yet still held compassion for the people of Great Yin.

He felt ashamed that as a local official, he had allowed Wei Xuan to push the people of Jizhou to such dire straits.

Zheng Wenchang asked for his instructions: "Sir, what should we do with the military provisions that were collected?"

He Jingyuan replied, "Return the grain seeds to the farmers. Spring has arrived, and we must not delay next year's planting."

Zheng Wenchang acknowledged the order.

He Jingyuan then asked, "I heard one county did not submit any provisions. Do you know which one it was?"

Zheng Wenchang answered, "Qingping County."

Hearing the name again, He Jingyuan's expression darkened. "County Magistrate Cui Shoude is a coward. How dare he refuse to submit provisions? There must be something unusual about this. Take some men and investigate."

Just as Zheng Wenchang was about to clasp his fists in acknowledgment, a guard hurried in and reported, "Sir, trouble! A scholar is beating the drum outside the government office to proclaim his grievances, composing poems denouncing the authorities for forcibly seizing military provisions and slaughtering the farmers in the fields. The whole city is in an uproar!"

Both He Jingyuan and Zheng Wenchang were startled.

Zheng Wenchang quickly clasped his fists and said, "After receiving your orders, I have been keeping an eye on the soldiers under Wei Xuan who were collecting provisions. I did not find any evidence of them killing people or seizing grain by force."

He Jingyuan simply instructed the guard, "Bring the man here. I want to question him."

The guard obeyed and left.

In Qingping County.

Fan Changyu's suggestion of kidnapping the county magistrate was, unsurprisingly, vetoed by Wang Furen. She sighed helplessly, "The yamen runners in the County Government Office number around a hundred in total. How could we possibly kidnap the magistrate?"

Afraid of alarming Wang Furen, Fan Changyu lowered her head and stayed silent, though she thought to herself, No matter how many there are, they can't follow the magistrate every hour of the day. He must have moments when he's alone.

Before Wang Furen could say more, a commotion erupted from the street ahead.

A group of fierce soldiers marched past, escorting a line of people bound with ropes. Fan Changyu recognized their clothing and gasped, "Those are the staff from Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion!"

Wang Furen's heart skipped a beat. "Is the magistrate acting so quickly?"

Fan Changyu didn't see Yu Qianqian among the captives and quickly pushed through the crowd to get a closer look.

The onlookers murmured among themselves, "Why have all the cooks and staff from Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion been arrested?"

"I heard someone died after eating their food. The family carried a coffin to the pavilion's entrance to protest. The authorities sealed the place and took everyone in for questioning to investigate."

Fan Changyu stood on tiptoe to scan the procession and finally spotted Yu Qianqian, her hands bound, walking in the middle. Yu Qianqian also saw her and subtly shook her head, signaling her not to approach. She silently mouthed two words.

From her lips, Fan Changyu discerned the words "Bao'er."

Fan Changyu scrutinized the escorting soldiers but saw no child among them. She realized Yu Bao'er must have been hidden somewhere by Yu Qianqian, and the silent message was a plea to look after the child.

Wang Furen had caught up and, fearing Fan Changyu might act rashly, tightly gripped her hand, whispering in her ear, "No matter how close you are to that manager, don't approach now. If the soldiers notice you, you might bring trouble upon yourself."

Fan Changyu understood and forced herself to stay still.

Only after the soldiers had passed did Wang Furen look at Fan Changyu and say, "If you need maps of the County Government Office or the magistrate's residence, I can get them for you."

Fan Changyu knew that given the situation in the Wang household, Wang Furen's willingness to offer such words was already a rare gesture. She expressed her thanks, saying she would retrieve it when needed, then hurried toward the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion.

Yu Qianqian had been arrested at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, and Yu Bao'er might very well be hidden somewhere inside by her.

Upon reaching the main street, Fan Changyu spotted the grand entrance of the pavilion already sealed with an official notice from afar. She circled to the back alley and saw that even the courtyards where the pavilion's servants lived had been sealed off. Glancing at the rear wall of the pavilion, she was about to climb over when a hand suddenly reached out from the side, pulling her into a narrow, dark alley between two outer walls.

Fan Changyu reflexively grabbed the person's collar, ready to throw them to the ground with a forceful twist of her arm. But the moment she caught the scent of bitter medicine and tangerine peel candy on them, her grip loosened abruptly.

"Yan Zheng?" she called out.

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes, signaling her to stay silent, his phoenix-like gaze coldly sweeping the alley's entrance. Fan Changyu instinctively tensed as well.

The sound of approaching footsteps grew louder—a squad of soldiers had taken position outside the pavilion's rear gate. "By the county magistrate's order, until the murder case at the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion is resolved, the premises shall remain sealed. To prevent the destruction of evidence, guard this building strictly!"

Fan Changyu whispered, "Yu Bao'er wasn't taken by the soldiers. I'm afraid Yu Qianqian hid him somewhere inside."

They stood so close that each other's breaths were audible. To avoid detection, she kept her voice extremely low.

Xie Zheng felt as if an insect were crawling in his ear. Frowning, he straightened and stepped back slightly. "I arrived a quarter-hour before you. I've already entered and taken him away."

Relieved, Fan Changyu finally asked, "Weren't you at the butcher shop? Why did you come to the county town?"

Xie Zheng's gaze turned frosty. "After selling the pork, I noticed you hadn't returned for a long time, so I came to check."

"I'm fine," Fan Changyu said. "But Shopkeeper Yu is in trouble."

After explaining her and Yu Qianqian's suspicions, she added, "I plan to kidnap the county magistrate to save Shopkeeper Yu. You take Yu Bao'er and Ning Niang to hide somewhere. If I'm caught, please look after Ning Niang for me."

Xie Zheng frowned at her. "Who gave you such a foolish idea?"

Baffled by his retort, Fan Changyu thought for a moment and assumed he was angry at her for risking herself and then burdening him with the children. "It was my own idea. I only mentioned the possibility of being caught—of course, I'd strike when the magistrate has few guards around. How could I actually get caught...?"

Xie Zheng scoffed. "Many farmers in the countryside have already rebelled, ready to storm the County Government Office before joining the Rebel King. Do you think the magistrate, if he were the mastermind, would put himself in such danger?"

Fan Changyu understood his implication—kidnapping the magistrate wouldn't save Yu Qianqian.

After a moment of fruitless thought, she raised her clear, guileless eyes to Xie Zheng. "Then what should we do? Who is the mastermind? Would kidnapping them work?"

Hearing she still clung to the kidnapping plan, Xie Zheng nearly laughed in exasperation.

"Kidnapping anyone would be useless," he said. "This is someone's scheme to sow discord, incite the people of Qingping County to rebel, and then lure Jizhou's garrison troops to suppress the riot. That way, the rumors of the court's grain levies driving the people to revolt would be confirmed."

Qingping County had not delivered the levied grain to Jizhou Prefecture. Given Wei Xuan's temperament, he would surely march on Qingping County immediately. Once his forces clashed with the rebels, there was every possibility Wei Xuan would order his men to massacre the entire county.

Chapter 47

Xie Zheng turned to Fan Changyu: "You know that Constable Wang. Go find him quickly and have him bring the Yamen Runners to guard the city gates. We must not let the rioters enter the city."

Fan Changyu was puzzled: "If the rioters enter, they'll likely only cause trouble for the magistrate and those Yamen Runners. Why should we help the magistrate stop them?"

Xie Zheng's expression turned icy in a way that was hard to describe: "They've staked their lives on this rebellion—do you really think they're only after justice? What they want now is power and wealth! Every household in this city is richer than those peasants, and that alone makes them objects of bitter hatred. One more step, and they could become a rampaging rebel army that kills, burns, and loots without mercy. If you don't want to see this county plundered, do as I say."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu felt a momentary heaviness in her heart at the complexity of human nature. Pressing her lips together, she said, "Constable Wang has already been dismissed by the magistrate. His orders carry no weight in the Yamen now."

Xie Zheng frowned but still insisted, "Just go and deliver the message. Tell him the magistrate has been sidelined and to first lead the Yamen Runners to set up defenses at the city gates. If they encounter the rioters, focus on placating them—promise that the government will return all the levied grain and won't hold them accountable for their crimes."

"But what if the government doesn't return the grain?"

"First, stabilize the rioters. I'll figure out the rest." His calm gaze was inexplicably convincing.

Fan Changyu thought for a moment but still had reservations: "Didn't you say they've rebelled because they're after wealth and status? Will this really work to calm them?"

Xie Zheng glanced at her: "The rioters are fighting desperately because they have no way back. Promise not to punish them and return their grain

—if they can go back to their old farming lives, those with ambition will keep inciting them, but those who were just forced into this and only want to farm in peace will start hesitating."

Fan Changyu finally understood—he wanted the rioters to turn on each other first.

For a moment, the Yan Zheng before her felt unfamiliar, as if she had never truly known him.

Xie Zheng noticed her gaze and asked, "What's wrong?"

Fan Changyu shook her head and asked, "How do we get out?"

The soldiers were still guarding the back alley of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. If they left through the alley entrance, they would surely be spotted by the soldiers outside. If they knocked out the soldiers and fled, the unconscious soldiers would soon be discovered, still exposing their tracks.

Unfortunately, the other end of the alley was sealed off—it was extremely narrow, meant only for draining rainwater between the eaves of two buildings, barely wide enough for one person. Perpetually damp and sunless, the walls were covered in slippery moss, and one misstep could send them tumbling.

Xie Zheng glanced at the high wall sealing the alley and said to Fan Changyu, "Step on my shoulders and climb over."

Fan Changyu sized up their heights and nodded. "Alright. Once I'm up, I'll find a ladder for you."

As Xie Zheng crouched by the base of the wall, she braced one hand against it and stepped onto his broad shoulder.

Their combined height finally allowed Fan Changyu to reach the top of the wall. She pushed herself up with her arms and flipped over. When she scanned the courtyard, she spotted a man writing at a desk in front of a room with wide-open windows. Suddenly, he sharply looked up in their direction.

With lightning speed, Fan Changyu grabbed a loose tile from the wall and hurled it straight at his pressure point.

The man looked stunned, unable to utter a word before collapsing face-first onto the writing desk.

Only after striking him did Fan Changyu belatedly realize the man looked somewhat familiar, though she couldn't immediately recall where she had seen him before.

Xie Zheng, hearing the commotion from inside, asked, "Someone's on the other side of the wall?"

Fan Changyu nodded with a quiet "Mm," then said, "I've already knocked him out. There's a bamboo ladder in this courtyard—wait a moment, I'll fetch it."

With that, she leapt down from the wall, agile as a cat.

The bamboo ladder was just the right length to reach the top of the wall. After climbing up, she passed it over to the other side so Xie Zheng could also make his way into the courtyard.

He stepped inside and glanced at the man Changyu had knocked unconscious, a flicker of surprise crossing his eyes. "It's the bookstore owner."

How had the Zhao Family's residence ended up right next to the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion?

This small suspicion made him take another glance at the unfinished letter on the desk. The brushstroke Zhao Xun had left when he collapsed had smeared much of the ink, but the general content was still legible.

Xie Zheng's gaze abruptly turned cold. Whether intentionally or not, as he turned to leave, his sleeve knocked over the inkstone, spilling thick ink across the desk and staining the unfinished letter, along with Zhao Xun's sleeve and half his face.

Already feeling guilty upon learning this was the bookstore owner, Fan Changyu nearly panicked when she saw Xie Zheng topple the inkstone. Stuttering, she said, "I—I hit your employer, and now you've ruined his inkstone... Will he hold a grudge against you?"

She remembered Xie Zheng had been writing Eight-legged essays at the bookstore—hadn't there been a deposit in that forty taels last time?

Xie Zheng was momentarily taken aback, not expecting her to worry about that. The coldness in his expression eased slightly as he replied, "It's fine. He may not remember you, nor will he know I was here."

Changyu thought it over—she had barely recognized him herself. As a wealthy merchant, he must meet countless people daily and likely wouldn't remember her either. Relieved, she exhaled deeply.

The Zhao residence was a two-courtyard house, yet there were hardly any servants in sight. Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng easily slipped out through a side gate.

Changyu mused that all this trouble was because both the front and back alleys of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion were guarded by officers. Unable to hold back, she said, "Shopkeeper Yu and the other workers have already been thrown into prison by that corrupt official. Why are they still watching the pavilion? Could it really just be to find Yu Bao'er?"

Xie Zheng's expression darkened. "It's possible."

Changyu's face twisted with anger. "Those corrupt officials are downright vicious!"

Were they really making an example out of a child?

Xie Zheng didn't respond, only saying, "I've temporarily left the child with the old man who drives your cart."

Changyu had rented the old man's oxcart for a month to deliver goods, so he was at least somewhat trustworthy.

Still, having an old man care for a young noble boy would easily raise suspicions. "I'll take Bao'er with me when I go to Head Constable Wang's place," she said.

Xie Zheng nodded. As they parted ways, he looked at her as if he wanted to say something, but in the end, he remained silent.

Noticing his hesitation, Changyu asked, puzzled, "What's wrong?"

The overcast sky made Xie Zheng's eyes appear darker than usual as he said, "If the rioters enter the city, just focus on protecting yourself."

After a pause, he added, "Don't trust anyone lightly."

Fan Changyu's heart skipped a beat as she looked up at him. "Are you leaving?"

His sudden words felt particularly ominous.

Xie Zheng choked slightly, his expression turning unpleasant. "Though I'm not exactly someone trustworthy either, for now you can still believe in me."

After he left, Changyu stood dazed for a moment before fetching Yu Bao'er from the old coachman and heading to Head Constable Wang's house.

Upon hearing about the rioters, Head Constable Wang was equally shocked. After pacing back and forth several times in the room, he said to Wang Furen, "Bring me my constable uniform."

While Wang Furen went to the inner room to fetch the clothes, Head Constable Wang looked at Fan Changyu and remarked, "Your husband, with such insight and sharpness, must be no ordinary man..."

Changyu replied, "His family used to run an Armed Escort Agency. He's probably seen more of the world than most."

Head Constable Wang muttered "No wonder," and after changing into his uniform, immediately went out to gather his former subordinates.

Wang Furen saw him off at the door, her face filled with worry.

Changyu didn't know what Xie Zheng's next plan was, but sending a dismissed constable like Head Constable Wang out for such tasks carried risks.

Yet once rioters entered the city to loot, with no way back, their ambition and greed would surge like beasts tasting blood—unstoppable unless crushed before they could act.

After some thought, she said to Wang Furen, "Earlier you mentioned having maps of the County Government Office and the magistrate's residence?"

Wang Furen hesitated before nodding. "Yes, but child, what are you planning?"

Changyu explained, "From what my husband implied, the magistrate has likely been sidelined in this grain levy mess. What if we rescue him? At the very least, we should reinstate Uncle Wang's position as constable to make his tasks easier."

No matter who was secretly in control now, to ordinary citizens and yamen runners, the magistrate remained the highest authority in Qingping

County.

Wang Furen didn't know if the girl was naturally bold or something else. While her own heart still raced with fear, this girl was contemplating even bolder actions. Thinking of her husband going to stop the rioters, she steadied herself and said, "That's too dangerous. I'll go with you."

Changyu pondered and said, "There's a less risky approach, but I'll still need your help, Auntie."

Wang Furen's expression shifted—

Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion.

A carriage pulled into the back alley of the pavilion, stopping not far from the entrance, yet no one emerged. The guards at the back door eyed the carriage warily.

Two of them exchanged glances and moved to investigate when suddenly a dark figure darted from the other end of the alley, swinging a club at the remaining guards' heads. They collapsed unconscious on the spot.

Having changed into boy's clothes at Head Constable Wang's house and smeared her face with soot to obscure her features, Fan Changyu kicked open the seal on the pavilion's back door and rushed inside.

The two guards who had been approaching the carriage shouted, "An accomplice is breaking into Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion to destroy evidence!"

They chased after her, only to find Changyu waiting for them just inside the door.

As soon as the men entered, she hurled a club and knocked one unconscious. The soldier behind drew his sword to strike Fan Changyu, but she dodged sideways and kicked him into the slop barrel in the backyard. The barrel was deep, and the soldier folded inside, struggling for a long time without resurfacing.

Fan Changyu entered the house briefly, then emerged swiftly, clutching something wrapped in a cloak as she hurried out of the yard.

The soldier screamed hysterically, "The thief escaped! The thief escaped!"

The commotion had already alerted the guards at the main gate of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. A group of men dressed as constables but clearly not real ones split into two groups, chasing from both ends of the alley. They only caught a glimpse of a small man holding what seemed like a child, hastily boarding a carriage waiting at the alley's entrance.

Before the soldiers could catch up, the carriage sped away.

Snowflakes drifted down as the driver, clad in coarse cloth and a bamboo hat obscuring his face, cracked the whip with the skill of a trained fighter. Soldiers attempting to block the front were met with another whip—over ten feet long—that lashed out, leaving bloody gashes. With a sweep, the surrounding soldiers collapsed by the roadside, howling in pain.

The officer in charge shouted, "It must be an accomplice from the pavilion escaping with that brat! Call for reinforcements!"

A whistling arrow shot into the gray sky, and soon, the County Government Office dispatched another squad of soldiers.

The people in the carriage were none other than Fan Changyu and Wang Furen.

Wang Furen, familiar with every street and alley in the county, quickly lost the pursuing soldiers with a few turns. Before jumping off, Fan Changyu said, "Auntie, please lead them on a chase for half an hour, then shake them off and escape on your own."

Wang Furen lifted her hat slightly and asked, "Half an hour—will you have enough time?"

Fan Changyu replied, "My husband must have gone to the County Government Office. I'll head to the magistrate's residence. With all the soldiers mobilized to capture Shopkeeper Yu's son, we'll surely find the magistrate."

There was no Yu Bao'er in the carriage. What she had wrapped in the cloak and carried out of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion was merely a small quilt.

Wang Furen only urged, "Be careful!"

Fan Changyu nodded, "You too, Auntie."

As the carriage slowed, Fan Changyu slipped out unnoticed and wound through several alleys toward the magistrate's residence.

When she arrived, she spotted Mother Song there as well.

Hiding in the shadows, she saw Mother Song standing at the magistrate's gate with a young maid, laden with packages, her face plastered with an ingratiating smile. "Young Master Yan is leaving for the capital exams and misses the young lady dearly. So, he asked me to bring these trinkets for her..."

The steward at the gate replied, "Scholar Song is most thoughtful."

He ordered a servant to collect the hairpins and jewelry Mother Song had reluctantly purchased but made no move to invite her inside.

Mother Song's smile was stiff from days of rejection. Unwilling to let her silver go to waste without winning the magistrate's favor, she added, "The madam admired my shoe patterns the other day. I've come today to share tea with her and deliver those patterns."

The steward merely said, "Madam has caught a chill and hasn't recovered yet. If Mother Song has anything to deliver to Madam, you may entrust it to this old servant."

Mother Song had initially thought the county magistrate's family status was somewhat beneath them. Once Song Yan passed the imperial examinations with high honors, the daughter of a mere county magistrate might not be worthy of her son. However, given that they still needed the magistrate's support in this county, she maintained cordial relations with the magistrate's wife.

Previously, when the magistrate's wife was eager to settle the marriage between their children, Mother Song had secretly calculated her moves. She dangled the sweet prospects of being the wife of a provincial graduate and later a metropolitan graduate before the magistrate's wife and daughter, but never actually agreed to the betrothal.

When the magistrate's wife pressed her too hard, Mother Song would weep and bring up Song Yan's recent broken engagement, saying he was a filial son who had borne the reputation of being heartless by breaking off with the butcher's Fan family for her sake. Now the Fan family was going around telling everyone how the Song family had wronged them. She claimed that if Song Yan got engaged again so soon, it would only provoke more resentment from the Fan girl, who might spread malicious rumors that could harm Song Yan's official career. Since their families would eventually become in-laws anyway, why rush things?

This speech successfully intimidated the magistrate's wife, who had always been warm toward Mother Song during their tea gatherings and theater outings.

During the New Year, when Song Yan caused a scandal with the Fan family at the Lantern Festival, Mother Song felt utterly humiliated.

Fearing the magistrate's wife might look down on her son, though she had originally intended to keep her options open, Mother Song suddenly worried—what if her son failed the metropolitan examinations and couldn't become an official in the capital? In all of Qingping County, marrying into the magistrate's family would still be the most prestigious option. Thus, on the second day of the New Year, she brought gifts to the magistrate's residence to pay her respects.

To her surprise, she was turned away at the door.

Mother Song returned home that day seething with anger, nearly spitting blood in frustration. Afraid of disturbing her son's studies, she didn't dare tell Song Yan about the incident. Secretly, however, she resolved to mend relations with the magistrate's family and had been sending gifts to their home these past few days.

When she couldn't get through to the magistrate's wife, she tried currying favor with the magistrate's daughter instead. Yet despite her persistent gift-giving, she still couldn't even set foot inside the magistrate's residence.

Mother Song felt as if her face had been ripped off and trampled underfoot. By the time she left, she couldn't even force a smile, her expression dark with fury. Only after turning the street corner did she dare spit viciously on the ground: "Who do they think they are? Just the daughter of a county magistrate—as if my Yan'er is begging to marry her! They have the gall to accept my gifts but won't even invite me in for a cup of tea?"

Fan Changyu stood with her back turned at a street stall, pretending to browse goods while clearly overhearing Mother Song's words. She cast a sidelong glance at the retreating figure. Though she had long stopped caring about the Song family, seeing Mother Song's true colors only reinforced her belief that evil would be repaid with evil.

She thought to herself that the magistrate's family must have finally seen through the mother and son's true nature, hence their cold shoulder.

Changyu circled to the back wall of the magistrate's residence, climbed a tree leaning against it, and vaulted over into the compound.

Head Constable Wang, having served as a constable for over a decade under multiple magistrates, knew the layout of the estate well. After studying the map provided by Wang Furen, Changyu had a rough idea of the residence's arrangement—this should be the kitchen.

Moving silently along the wall, she slipped past a moon gate and spotted the steward entering. Quickly, she ducked behind a corner.

The steward, carrying the items given by Mother Song, pleaded with a guard-like man: "Sir, these are all gifts from our future son-in-law to the young lady. Please be lenient and let me deliver them to her."

The steward of the County Magistrate's household had to beg a guard?

This was clearly abnormal. Fan Changyu pricked up her ears to listen.

The guard only sneered coldly: "Throw them into the side room with the previous items. If even a whisper of this leaks out, none of you will keep your heads!"

The steward was clearly frightened, meekly falling silent without another word.

Fan Changyu suddenly realized that the group controlling the County Magistrate's residence was anything but ordinary. She made her breathing even more subtle and prolonged.

She noticed that the snow in the courtyard of the entire County Magistrate's residence hadn't been cleared. It was unclear whether the magistrate's family had been taken control of, leading to the servants slacking off, or if someone had ordered the snow not to be cleared.

After all, with snow on the ground, no matter how lightly someone walked through the courtyard, their footsteps would inevitably make a sound.

As Fan Changyu was deep in thought, she suddenly heard footsteps approaching from behind.

Turning around, she locked eyes with a young maid carrying a tray.

The maid was about to scream when Changyu swiftly closed the distance and knocked her unconscious with a chop to the neck. Catching the tray with one hand and supporting the maid with the other, she glanced around

before using her foot to push open the door of a nearby room and carried the maid inside.

Moments later, Fan Changyu emerged openly, dressed in maid's attire and carrying the tray.

As she turned the corner, the guard under the eaves glanced at her. Keeping her head down, Changyu passed by and headed in the direction the steward had gone.

Having studied the map beforehand and possessing a good sense of direction, she quickly located the steward's quarters based on the residence's layout.

When she pushed the door open, the steward was sitting in a chair, lost in sorrow. Spotting Fan Changyu, he nearly died of fright, tumbling to the ground. Grimacing in pain while trying to maintain his dignity as the senior steward, he scowled and demanded, "Which household's maid are you? How dare you!"

Fan Changyu reasoned that since the County Magistrate was under surveillance, the order to dismiss Head Constable Wang couldn't have come from him. The magistrate was probably counting on Wang to save his life right now.

So she said, "I'm with Head Constable Wang."

The anger on the steward's face froze, and he nearly wept with joy. "Head Constable Wang is as shrewd as ever, seeing at a glance that something was amiss in the County Government Office these days..."

Seeing that he was about to launch into a lengthy lament, Changyu frowned and cut him off, asking only what she wanted to know: "What's going on here?"

The steward tearfully replied, "A few days ago, wasn't there a Grain Requisition Order from Jizhou Prefecture? A squad of soldiers bearing Jizhou military insignia came to oversee the requisition. When our master heard they were demanding one dan of grain per person, he pleaded that this would drive the common folk to ruin. But the officials from above pressured him with the Grain Requisition Order, insisting he comply."

"My lord had no choice but to order the requisition of grain, but the soldiers sent to collect it ended up killing farmers in the countryside. Fearing that the matter might escalate to Lord He in Jizhou Prefecture and

cost him his official position, my lord decided to go to Jizhou Prefecture in advance to plead guilty. However, he was detained by those soldiers who came from Jizhou. They claimed to be under the command of Wei Xuan, the Military Governor of the Northwest, and said everything must be done according to their orders. Now, even Lord He has been dismissed by the Military Governor. They accused my lord of obstructing the grain requisition and have placed him under house arrest in the residence. Even his wife and daughter are not allowed to leave or receive visitors."

Fan Changyu frowned even more deeply. She had heard of Wei Xuan's name before—it was his indulgence that led to the tragic grain requisition incident in Taizhou.

She wasn't sure in her heart. If Wei Xuan was truly so cruel and tyrannical as to forcibly requisition grain this way, what if—after Head Constable Wang temporarily calmed the rioters at the city gates—Wei Xuan turned around and led his troops to slaughter those commoners?

Fan Changyu thought for a moment and said, "How about we kidnap that high-ranking official sent by Wei Xuan and have the magistrate return the requisitioned military provisions to the people?"

If they captured the leader, he wouldn't be able to order the killing of civilians.

The steward's lips trembled, barely registering the latter half of her words—just the first part nearly scared the soul out of him. "K-Kidnap? There are over a dozen soldiers in this residence, each highly skilled in martial arts. The County Government Office is also filled with their men. How could we possibly kidnap anyone?"

Fan Changyu said, "If we can't fight them, can't we use knockout drugs or something?"

The steward couldn't help but scrutinize Fan Changyu, wondering if she was truly sent by Head Constable Wang to help.

Kidnapping a military officer from Jizhou Prefecture—what kind of crime would that be? If those men sought revenge later, all the heads in this residence combined wouldn't be enough to pay for it!

He waved his hands frantically. "No, no! How would my master explain this to those officers afterward?"

Fan Changyu knew the plan was a bit ruthless, but this magistrate had served in Qingping County for three years without committing any major evils—yet he hadn't done much good for the people either. Right now, this was the only way. It might screw over the magistrate, but why not use him?

She said, "People in Majia Village were beaten to death by soldiers. The troops have already provoked the surrounding villagers into rebellion. Thousands of rioters are gathering to storm the County Government Office. Do you think your master will be the scapegoat pushed out to die? And as the magistrate's steward, do you think those rioters won't hold a grudge against you too?"

The steward's lips trembled again. After weighing the situation, he said, "There's no knockout drug in the residence. Besides, those men are extremely cautious—they make the servants taste anything before they eat or drink."

Now Fan Changyu was at a loss.

Seeing this, the steward said reluctantly, "But we do have croton beans in the residence. The main kitchen is currently preparing white fungus and lotus seed soup."

A short while later, Fan Changyu carried a tray while a servant boy followed with a wooden bucket, heading to the front courtyard.

On Fan Changyu's tray was a white porcelain jar. Inside, a large snow pear had been sliced open at the top, hollowed out, and filled with white fungus and lotus seed soup before being resealed with the cut-off pear lid, then gently simmered.

Through the jar, one could smell not only the fragrance of the white fungus but also the fresh sweetness of the pear.

Fan Changyu could only marvel—wealthy households really came up with such novel ways to eat.

The servant boy's wooden bucket contained only ordinary white fungus and lotus seed soup.

Of course, all of it had been laced with croton beans.

The steward beamed at the guard under the eaves. "The weather is bitterly cold. The magistrate's wife, out of consideration for you officers, had the kitchen prepare some white fungus and lotus seed soup for you."

The guard, with a faint scar near the corner of his eye, snorted through his nostrils, maintaining an air of superiority—though it was clear he was rather pleased.

The steward seemed long accustomed to his cold demeanor. He had the servant boy scoop a bowl of the soup and drink it first to prove it was safe. Only then did the guard say, "Fine, leave it here."

Pointing at the tray in Fan Changyu's hands, the steward added, "This was specially prepared for the officer inside."

The guard glanced at Fan Changyu. With her head slightly bowed, she did indeed appear to be a gentle and delicate beauty at first glance. The guard's smile grew colder as he said, "Just hand it over to me."

The steward fawned, "That esteemed guest has come from afar, and Qingping County is but a small place with little to offer. Let this girl serve him."

The insistence on sending Fan Changyu in wasn't without reason. While croton beans could cause diarrhea, they couldn't incapacitate an entire courtyard of people in a short time. If Fan Changyu entered to deliver the soup, she could get close to the officer in charge. If she could subdue him, the rest would be much easier to handle.

The guard's mocking expression didn't fade. Seeming to recall something, he gave Fan Changyu another glance and said, "I'll go ask the master."

After knocking and entering, he addressed the young man who was propping his elbow on a chessboard, playing against himself. "Young Master, the household insists on sending a beautiful maid to serve you soup."

The one who had ambushed the Jizhou garrison troops and impersonated tax collectors to seize control of Qingping County for days was none other than Sui Yuanqing, son of the Rebel King of Chongzhou, the Prince of Changxin.

The Prince of Changxin had two sons. The elder, frail since childhood, left the title of heir to the younger. In earlier years, the prince had bided his time, and Sui Yuanqing was known only as a wastrel. But when the prince rebelled, Sui Yuanqing began to distinguish himself on the battlefields of Chongzhou, his ruthless tactics earning him the moniker "Little Wu'an Marquis."

Hearing his subordinate's report, Sui Yuanqing also sneered, tossing the chess piece back into its box. "Wei Xuan's reputation for cruelty and lust is well-known. It's unlikely his subordinates would be paragons of virtue. Fine, let her in. What tricks could a mere county magistrate possibly pull?"

As the guard turned to leave, Sui Yuanqing asked, "Have the scouts reported back? Has Wei Xuan arrived with his men?"

"Not yet," the guard replied.

Sui Yuanqing frowned involuntarily. Given Wei Xuan's explosive temper, wouldn't he have charged here with his troops the moment he learned Qingping County hadn't delivered the grain? Could something have happened in Jizhou?

The mob from Qingping County was nearly at the city gates. If that fool Wei Xuan didn't show, this whole performance would be for nothing. Tapping the table with his long fingers, he said, "First, transport the money and grain seized from Qingping's merchants and commoners out of the city. Station a thousand men at the slope outside the city. If Wei Xuan doesn't come, we'll 'help' him deal with the mob."

The guard was puzzled. "But those rioters intend to join Chongzhou. Why kill them?"

Sui Yuanqing scoffed. "No need to slaughter them all—just enough to shatter any remaining faith in the court. If we don't strike them down, how many will vent their rage and actually join our cause? Only when pushed to the brink will they truly embrace rebellion."

The scholar they deliberately allowed to escape would carry news to Jizhou: imperial troops had forcibly seized grain, leaving the people no choice but to seek justice at Jizhou Prefecture, only to be massacred. No matter how the Wei Faction tried to explain, the world would believe the scholar's account—especially since the Wei Faction's infamy was long-standing. Behind the scholar's tearful accusations lay the lives of tens of thousands in Qingping County. Facts grounded in reality always evoked greater empathy and credibility.

The guard quickly praised, "The Young Master is wise."

Ignoring the flattery, Sui Yuanqing asked, "Has that brat been caught yet?"

The guard tensed up and said, "Half a quarter ago, someone broke into the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion, injured our men, and seemed to have fled with a child in their arms. I've already dispatched troops to pursue them. We should have news soon."

Sui Yuanqing merely said, "Don't harm the child. After all, it's my elder brother's flesh and blood."

The guard ventured another question, "And the woman in the prison cell..."

Sui Yuanqing lifted his cold, piercing eyes. "My elder brother's concubine. How to deal with her is his decision once we bring her back. Let her suffer in the cell for a couple of days first, but make sure no one humiliates her."

The guard acknowledged the order.

After the guard withdrew, a maid entered carrying a tray.

Hearing the light yet steady footsteps, Sui Yuanqing's lips curled into a cold smirk.

When he raised his eyes to look at the maid, though he had expected the county magistrate to send someone decent to curry favor with him, he was still surprised to see such a striking beauty in this backwater place.

Especially her eyes—they weren't dazzling like stars nor lively like a deer's. The first impression they gave was actually one of beauty and honesty, the kind that made you worry she'd be bullied if taken back to the manor as a maid.

Fan Changyu, perhaps accustomed to Xie Zheng's sharp glances, didn't feel the slightest fear when scrutinized by this unfamiliar man. She simply held the tray steady and approached.

As she placed the soup bowl on the table and reached to retrieve the tray with one hand, the man remarked with a faint smile, "Quite bold, aren't you?"

Fan Changyu thought he had discovered the Croton beans in the soup. Her palms grew clammy with sweat as she inwardly noted that this man, though not as handsome as Yan Zheng, was clearly just as sharp and hard to fool.

Remembering the old saying "strike first to gain the upper hand," she suddenly swung the tray as if to smash it over his head. His eyes turned icy in an instant, and he raised an arm to block.

But the tray swing was a feint. She immediately kicked him in the abdomen. Sui Yuanqing's face twisted in shock and pain as he doubled over, while Fan Changyu struck the back of his neck with her other hand.

A normal person would have been knocked unconscious by such a blow, but Sui Yuanqing still had the strength to overturn the table to block her. Clutching his neck, he staggered to his feet and bolted toward the door with surprising speed.

Fan Changyu hadn't expected his neck to be so tough. The guards outside, hearing the commotion of the overturned table, rushed toward the room. "General?" they called.

Having already considered that she might not be able to subdue him up close, Fan Changyu swiftly pulled out a thin rope she had pre-knotted into a noose and looped it around Sui Yuanqing's neck.

The thick winter clothing had concealed the rope hidden in her sleeve.

As the guards burst through the door, they saw Fan Changyu tightening the noose around their young master's neck with a fierce yank. Sui Yuanqing, one arm wedged against his throat, gripped the rope and struggled against her, his face flushed red—whether from lack of air or fury, it was hard to tell.

Sui Yuanqing possessed astonishing arm strength. Normally, a single tug from him should have sent the audacious woman flying toward him like a rag doll. Yet she only stumbled briefly before steadying herself and matching his force, pulling back with the strength of an ox.

Sui Yuanqing's neck was no match for the strength of her two hands. As she dragged him over like a dead dog, hoisted him up, and pressed the sharp knife against his throat, half of his handsome face was contorted from suffocation, while the other half burned with fury, wishing he could slice the person behind him into a thousand pieces.

He snarled viciously, "You'd better not fall into my hands, or I'll skin you alive and hang your corpse on the city gate!"

Fan Changyu, currently holding him hostage under the county magistrate's name, wasn't the least bit intimidated. She jabbed the sharp

boning knife into his thigh, drawing a shallow wound: "Then let's see if you skin me faster, or I stab you faster."

Though the stab wasn't deep, it still drew blood. Yet Sui Yuanqing didn't make a single sound.

The guards outside, however, were terrified—both worried for him and shocked that Sui Yuanqing had been captured by a woman.

The guard who had entered earlier was his personal guard, named Mu Shi. He immediately shouted at Fan Changyu, "Don't harm my general!"

Fan Changyu said, "Do as I say, and I won't hurt him."

Mu Shi and the others looked to Sui Yuanqing for confirmation. Gritting his teeth, Sui Yuanqing forced out, "Do as she says."

Then, in a voice only she could hear, he threatened, "I'll remember you."

How had he ever thought this woman was meek at first glance?

Fan Changyu wondered why he only held a grudge against her and not the county magistrate. After all, she was technically acting on the magistrate's behalf!

After a moment's thought, she pressed the boning knife deeper into his flesh and called out to the guards outside, "Release the county magistrate now!"

Mu Shi shot a glare at the steward, looking as if he wanted to tear him apart on the spot.

The steward trembled so violently he nearly fainted.

Soon after, the county magistrate, who had been imprisoned for days, finally stepped out of the room. The moment he saw the scene in the courtyard, he almost passed out on the spot.

He'd rather stay locked up for another year than face this situation the moment he was freed!

A faint smile curled Sui Yuanqing's lips as he asked, "My men have released the magistrate. Will you let me go now?"

As if to reassure her he wouldn't retaliate immediately, he suddenly adopted the demeanor of a refined nobleman: "Don't worry. Even if I were to capture you, I'd wait until you've fully escaped before doing so. I won't act now."

Just then, a soldier rushed in through the main gate: "Report—rioters have gathered outside the county gates! The prisoners from the County Government Office have all been freed, and they've seized the military provisions meant for conscription, transporting them to the county gates to return them to the rioters!"

Sui Yuanqing's face twisted with rage. He smiled coldly at Fan Changyu. "Whoever planned this was quite thorough."

Fan Changyu ignored him. The chaos at the County Government Office was likely Yan Zheng's doing.

Right now, the man in her grasp was a hot potato. If she killed him, she'd be guilty of murdering a high-ranking official, and she'd probably have to spend the rest of her life hiding in a bandit den with Changning.

But if she let him go, she'd never have peace again.

She turned to the county magistrate. "Magistrate, the villagers of Qingping County have rebelled over the military grain levy. You must give them an answer to quell their anger."

As she spoke, her gaze flicked meaningfully toward the man she held hostage.

The county magistrate turned pale upon hearing that the rioters had reached the city gates. If they entered the city, they would surely kill a few corrupt officials, and as the magistrate of Qingping County, he would undoubtedly be the first to be sacrificed as a scapegoat.

If he died, the higher-ups would demand an explanation and pin all the blame on him—after all, his governance had been mediocre at best, and the dead were the easiest to hold accountable.

When Fan Changyu gave him that meaningful look, the magistrate, though cowardly in the face of superiors, was shrewd enough to survive in officialdom. He instantly grasped her implication.

After considering its feasibility, his heart swelled with joy.

Indeed, he dared not act against these people, but the rioters needed someone to answer for their grievances. Why not just push this group out and let them bear the brunt of the rioters' wrath?

The magistrate, his belly protruding like a woman eight months pregnant, jiggled his chubby cheeks and avoided looking at Sui Yuanqing

as he said, "The grain levy was ordered by you generals. Given the circumstances, I must trouble you to go to the city gates and explain yourselves to the people."

How the rioters dealt with them would be their own affair.

Sui Yuanqing merely sneered. "Fine, let's go to the gates and give them an explanation."

Mu Shi, meeting his gaze, understood and suppressed his visible anger.

They had a thousand soldiers lying in ambush on the slopes outside the city. At the signal of a single whistling arrow, their forces would descend and slaughter the entire Qingping County without hesitation!

Outside Qingping County, a contingent of troops bearing the Jizhou flag marched in a winding column along the official road. Leading them was the veteran general He Jingyuan, clad in heavy armor that overshadowed his usual scholarly demeanor, leaving only stern authority on his face.

Yet age had taken its toll—his hair and beard were streaked with white, and the exhaustion from sleepless nights left him looking weary.

Zheng Wenchang, riding half a step behind him, said, "Perhaps that scholar exaggerated. How could a mere magistrate of Qingping County dare to exploit the grain levy to oppress the people? I could have led the troops to investigate for you. Why trouble yourself to come personally?"

He Jingyuan shook his head, his gaze aged yet commanding. "Qingping County has salt lakes. For such an incident to occur during the grain levy suggests deeper complexities."

No sooner had he spoken than a scout galloped toward them from ahead. "Report—a hidden force of Chongzhou troops has been spotted in the forests ten li ahead on the slopes!"

Even Zheng Wenchang broke into a cold sweat at the scout's warning.

Chapter 48

In the dense woods on the outskirts of Qingping County, several scouts trampled over the withered grass still dusted with remnants of snow as they hurried toward the army concealed among the pine trees.

"General! A troop of imperial soldiers is heading toward Qingping County!"

The young officer from Chongzhou, who had been left behind on standby, brightened at the news. "Are they flying the Wei banner?"

The scout replied, "No Wei banner in sight. It's the Jizhou flag."

The officer's expression became momentarily inscrutable. He asked again, "Who leads them?"

"An old general and a young officer."

The officer muttered, "Could it be Wei Xuan and He Jingyuan coming together?"

His subordinate asked, "General, should we still ambush the rebels surrounding Qingping County?"

The officer shook his head. "With Jizhou's troops arriving, let our men continue inciting the rebels. It'd be best if they storm the county town. That way, no matter who Jizhou has sent, their army will have no choice but to engage the rebels."

Once the rebellious villagers entered the town, the higher the civilian casualties, the more charges could be pinned on the Wei Faction.

Their prince's original plan was to seize the military provisions collected by Qingping County. Given Wei Xuan's temperament, he would surely fly into a rage and personally lead troops to requisition the grain. Meeting the enraged rebels at their peak would be like igniting two firecrackers—conflict was inevitable.

The news of the imperial court forcibly requisitioning grain and driving a county to rebellion, followed by the army slaughtering unarmed villagers, would undoubtedly cause an uproar.

The situation at the city gates was far from optimistic.

Qingping County was a small town where defense had never been prioritized. Even the rammed-earth walls were absurdly low, with nothing but a bare gate tower—no barbicans, watchtowers, or bastion walls to speak of.

Head Constable Wang, having received advance notice, had led his yamen runners to shut the gates and hastily set up a few bows at the lookout ports above the gates. But the defenses still looked pitifully sparse, with not even enough men to line the walls properly.

It was absurd enough to have constables guarding the city gates.

But Qingping County had no garrison troops, and apart from bandits, it had never experienced war in decades.

Below the gate tower, the gathered farmers formed a dark, seething mass, each wielding hoes and rakes. Their once-honest faces were now twisted with fury, as if they longed to tear the constables on the walls apart with their bare teeth.

Even the seasoned Head Constable Wang felt a chill in his heart at the sight. If these thousands of farmers truly stormed the town, what could this flimsy gate tower possibly hold back?

For now, Head Constable Wang could only hope that Jizhou had caught wind of the unrest and would send troops swiftly.

Remembering Fan Changyu's words, he leaned out from the lookout port and pleaded with the crowd below: "Fellow villagers, what are you doing? Don't act rashly and commit a crime that could wipe out nine generations of your family!"

Most of the farmers who had come this far still feared the bows on the walls and dared not press forward. Though they outnumbered the defenders, no one wanted to be the first to die.

Everyone knew the severity of rebellion. Understanding it in their hearts was one thing, but hearing such warnings from others was another.

Most of them had spent their lives tied to the land, never even leaving Qingping County. To them, the highest authority was the emperor, and the highest official in their world was the county magistrate.

Offending the county magistrate would earn you a beating and imprisonment; offending the emperor would send all your relatives within the nine degrees of kinship to the execution block.

Even on ordinary days, the sight of these constables filled people with fear. Now, hearing Head Constable Wang's words, they couldn't help but feel apprehensive.

Seeing this, the leader of the group glared fiercely and shouted at Head Constable Wang on the city wall: "When you officials strut around with your power, we farmers are just lowly peasants you order about. Now that we're driven to desperation, suddenly we're 'fellow villagers'? Pah! I won't accept being called 'fellow villager' by a county magistrate's lackey like you! Execution of nine generations? We've already lost our seed grain—we don't need the emperor to execute us, we'll starve to death first! Since we're doomed either way, we might as well storm the city, take what we need, and join the Rebel King in Chongzhou—at least that way we have a chance to live!"

The hesitant farmers grew resolute upon hearing his words, shouting: "The government won't give us a way out! We'll make our own way!"

The leader raised his farming tool high: "Bring out the damned magistrate to die!"

The farmers behind him echoed: "Bring out the damned magistrate to die!"

Seeing the situation spiraling out of control, Head Constable Wang hurriedly said, "Fellow villagers, calm down. The seed grain... will be returned to you. Everyone should go home, and the government won't pursue this rebellion."

The leader sneered: "See, everyone? When we didn't rebel, these officials treated our lives as worthless, beating people to death to seize our grain. Now that we've rebelled, they're suddenly willing to return it! All the suffering we've endured over the years—it's only because we were easy to bully!"

His words stoked the farmers' fury even further.

Seizing the moment, the leader pressed on: "We can't back down! If we retreat, these officials will just strut around again! The rich in the city—aren't they all arrogant snobs? Whenever we came to the market, they looked at us like we were filth! Storm the city! Kill the damned officials,

take their gold and silver, and pay them back for all the humiliation we've suffered!"

He exchanged glances with a few men behind him, who took the cue and began shouting:

"That's right! We're not born lowly—we just didn't have the luck to be born in the city!"

"Don't be fooled by this magistrate's lackey! If he tricks us into going home, we'll end up like the Ma Village massacre!"

"We've come this far—why retreat now? I'd rather die a happy man! I hear the women in the city are so tender you could squeeze water from their skin, white as dough! Any unmarried brothers here—don't you want to be a 'one-night groom' to those rich young ladies?"

With the Ma Village massacre fresh in their minds, no one dared retreat. The temptations of the city only inflamed their passions further. The farmers panted heavily in the mud, their eyes burning with rage as they roared: "Storm the city!"

Head Constable Wang had only learned the reason for the farmers' rebellion upon arriving at the city gates. First, the county officials sent to collect grain had acted with brutal tyranny, treating the farmers as less than human. Second, the people of Ma Village, who had tried to take their grievances to Jizhou Prefecture, had been massacred along the way.

He no longer even held the position of Constable, and his earlier promise to return the grain seeds to these people had lacked conviction. Now, seeing the rebellious farmers with their savage, beast-like expressions, he could only plead earnestly, "Fellow villagers, don't be foolish, don't be foolish! How big is Qingping County? If you rebel here, do you really think you can escape to Chongzhou alive? Even if you manage to flee, what about your wives, children, and elderly mothers?"

The loudest agitators were all those from the countryside who had neither elders above nor children below.

Head Constable Wang's words struck the rioting farmers, and their expressions shifted in various ways.

Some, who had only joined the riot out of sheer desperation, shouted, "Does your promise to return the grain seeds still stand?"

Head Constable Wang wasn't actually sure whether the authorities would return the seeds. After a moment's hesitation, he gritted his teeth and said, "Of course it does!"

Those with relatives in Majia Village snarled, "Hand over the corrupt officials and soldiers who slaughtered the entire village, or this isn't over!"

Head Constable Wang quickly replied, "The massacre in Majia Village will be thoroughly investigated, and justice will be served for our fellow villagers."

The ringleaders, seeing their rebellion being divided by Head Constable Wang's words, exchanged glances among themselves.

The previously loudest agitators continued to stir the crowd: "Thoroughly investigated? It's still up to you corrupt officials to decide how! What if you turn around and blame it on bandits? What could we do then?"

This was indeed a possibility, and the crowd, which had begun to settle, grew restless again.

"That's right! Hand over those damned soldiers now!"

The mob surged toward the city gates.

Head Constable Wang shouted, "Stop right there! Anyone who takes another step will be shot!"

The constables beside him drew their bows to full tension, but their hands trembled slightly as they nocked the arrows.

The crowd below cursed even louder: "This Wang is the County Government Office's Constable—the ones who killed the villagers of Majia Village might well be his own men! How could he possibly hand them over?"

The rebellious farmers, further inflamed by these provocations, glared at Head Constable Wang with even greater hatred.

Just as Head Constable Wang was at his wits' end, a commotion arose behind him. The newly appointed Yamen Runners, their faces dark with malice, pushed past them and sneered, "A bunch of dismissed good-for-nothings still dare to wear these uniforms?"

Head Constable Wang and the constables below flushed with humiliation.

One of the ringleaders below, spotting the newly arrived Yamen Runners, flashed a triumphant look and bellowed, "When have these corrupt officials ever treated our lives as human lives? So what if they shoot? If they kill me, don't forget to avenge me, brothers!"

With that, he charged forward. The "Yamen Runners" on the city wall, who had seized the bows, loosed a volley of arrows at the crowd below.

The loudest agitators remained unscathed, while an ordinary farmer who had been incited to step forward was struck dead by an arrow.

With the first death, the uproar below the wall grew even louder.

Someone who recognized the fallen man wailed, "Erdan!"

The instigators pressed on: "See? These government lackeys never intended to leave us a way out! Charge in and fight them to the death!"

The man cradling the dead farmer—likely his brother—howled in grief and rage, "I'll fight you corrupt bastards to the death!"

Consumed by rage and devoid of reason, the farmers were about to recklessly storm the city gate tower when suddenly—a loud "thud" echoed, and blood sprayed beneath the tower.

The farmers stared at the Yamen Runner who had fallen to his death below the tower, exchanging bewildered glances. They halted their advance and looked up again.

A man wearing a Blue Devil mask stood atop the tower, his voice icy as he declared, "Whoever fired the arrows—take your grievances to them."

The mask, commonly seen during the New Year's Lantern Festival, now exuded an indescribable eeriness on his face.

The leader of the rioters felt an inexplicable unease and shouted, "Who are you?"

Xie Zheng replied, "The one who kills corrupt officials."

The real and fake Yamen Runners on the tower finally snapped out of their daze. Head Constable Wang and his men were utterly confused by the situation, while the impostors drew their swords and charged at Xie Zheng.

Without even lifting a hand, Xie Zheng stood atop the tower, his wide sleeves billowing in the cold wind. As he sidestepped the slashing blades,

he grabbed the collars of the impostors and hurled them off the tower—another body crashed to the ground.

While Head Constable Wang stood dumbfounded, Xie Zheng seized the moment to toss another fake Yamen Runner over the edge and turned to him, saying, "The magistrate has been detained. These are all impostors. Order your men to act freely."

Head Constable Wang quickly regained his composure. Though he didn't recognize the man in the Blue Devil mask, recalling the recent oddities at the County Government Office, he grasped the situation. He immediately commanded his team, "Arrest these impostors!"

The bewildered constables, seeing their leader charge ahead, wasted no time and drew their blades to confront the fake Yamen Runners.

The farmers below craned their necks, watching the spectacle in confusion. One muttered, "Why are the officials fighting among themselves?"

Another answered, "Looks like Head Constable Wang's men are attacking the constables who fired the arrows."

"The magistrate's lot may be no good, but Head Constable Wang's decent. When my ox wandered into the next village and that scoundrel Chen tried to keep it, it was Head Constable Wang who got it back for me."

The instigator, seeing the situation spiral out of control, fanned the flames: "Since when does Head Constable Wang outrank the magistrate? These lackeys would kill their own to save their skins—our lives mean nothing to them! If we want justice, we must break through the gates and kill the magistrate!"

Many farmers hesitated, unsure whether to press forward or wait for an official resolution.

Soon, all the fake Yamen Runners on the tower had been thrown off by Xie Zheng and his men. The farmers, who had never killed before, stared at the corpses strewn before the city gates, their courage wavering.

Xie Zheng stood with his hands behind his back atop the tower and announced, "Those willing to take their grain and leave—today's matter ends here. The authorities will not pursue it further. For the stubborn: Jizhou's army is already on its way to Qingping County. If you breach these gates today and shed even a single drop of blood, there will be no turning

back. Choose now—spend the rest of your lives farming with your families, or drag them all to their doom."

At the mention of Jizhou's army, the farmers, lifelong tillers of the soil, trembled with fear.

The combination of kindness and severity proved effective. After all, compared to the stability of returning to normal life, the choice to loot the city and then have one's entire family executed by the soldiers was something even a fool wouldn't make.

The troublemakers spoke up with a challenge: "Empty words mean nothing. Where's the grain?"

Head Constable Wang was about to chime in when suddenly a voice came from inside the city tower: "The grain is here!"

To everyone's surprise, the staff of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion were carrying grain up to the city tower.

Under the current circumstances, opening the city gates was absolutely out of the question. Instead, some of the grain was lowered down in baskets from the tower.

Several farmers stepped forward to untie the burlap sacks and inspect the contents. Their faces broke into wide grins, though they couldn't help wiping their eyes with their sleeves. "It's grain—it really is our grain!"

Upon hearing that the grain had been returned, most of the farmers who had joined the riot felt their hearts settle back into place.

Head Constable Wang approached Xie Zheng and whispered, "Sir, thank you for resolving Qingping County's crisis. But returning the requisitioned military grain to the farmers like this... the military officials in Jizhou... the County Government Office won't be able to account for this!"

Xie Zheng replied, "That's for the county magistrate to handle."

The order to abolish the grain requisition had already been sent to Jizhou Prefecture along with his military command for Wei Xuan to return and defend Huizhou. Jizhou would no longer be requisitioning grain, but there was no need to explain all this to a constable who was completely unaware.

Head Constable Wang, who had been at his wit's end, felt a sudden resolve upon hearing Xie Zheng's words.

Indeed, placating these rebellious individuals and preventing them from entering the county town was already the best he could do.

At his age, he could only shoulder so much responsibility. For anything beyond that, the county magistrate would have to take charge.

He said, "Your quick thinking, sir, using the Jizhou army to intimidate these rebels, has spared the townspeople from disaster."

Xie Zheng remained silent. His mention of the Jizhou army wasn't just to scare the rebellious farmers below the tower. With such a major incident occurring in Qingping County, it was impossible for Jizhou Prefecture not to have heard any rumors.

As long as it wasn't Wei Xuan leading the troops, the army wouldn't engage in battle with these manipulated farmers.

The troublemakers, seeing the rebellious farmers being placated and realizing their hopes for wealth and status were slipping away, scowled and pressed on: "What about the dozens of lives lost in Majia Village?"

Head Constable Wang looked to Xie Zheng for help.

The blue devil mask concealed Xie Zheng's entire face, making it impossible to discern his expression. He simply said, "Buy time."

Head Constable Wang was momentarily stunned but quickly understood. The massacre at Majia Village couldn't be investigated immediately, nor could they provide an on-the-spot resolution for these people.

They would have to wait until the Jizhou troops arrived to stabilize the situation before addressing it.

Wiping the sweat from his temples, he did his best to placate the troublemakers below the tower.

Meanwhile, Xie Zheng's gaze subtly settled on the few individuals who kept provoking the crowd.

They weren't seeking justice—they were trying to incite hatred among the farmers, to escalate the situation as much as possible.

But what benefit would they gain from a larger conflict?

The genuine farmers, who toiled under the sun and knew little beyond their fields, were inarticulate and easily led by these agitators. Stirred by hatred, these simple men were driven to commit atrocities, and once they

did, they would have no escape. The fact that these troublemakers acted so boldly suggested their backing was worth pondering.

While the troublemakers, seizing on the authorities' inability to immediately account for the massacre in Majia Village, continued to stir up trouble and reignited the hatred between the farmers and the officials, Xie Zheng was about to quietly deal with those instigators. Suddenly, a voice rang out from the city tower: "The Magistrate has arrived—"

The crowd below the tower fell silent, their faces filled with hostility as they glared upward.

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes, assuming the mastermind behind the scenes had forced the magistrate to make an appearance. But when he glanced over, he saw the magistrate, his wealthy belly protruding, strutting ahead with an air of arrogance, followed by a group of servants restraining bound soldiers.

Fan Changyu, dressed in ill-fitting maid's clothing, was also escorting someone, pressing a boning knife against the captive's throat. Her sleeves were too short, exposing half of her pale wrist.

The person she held had several shallow cuts on his neck, clearly from resisting along the way.

Xie Zheng's gaze fell on the captive's face. At first, he froze—then, beneath his blue devil mask, his expression turned utterly bewildered.

Chapter 49

Fan Changyu had all her attention focused on the man she was escorting. He was too cunning—during the journey, he had deliberately tried to distract her by talking, and once nearly tripped her to snatch the knife from her hand.

After that, Changyu became wary. She ignored everything he said, and if he provoked her too much, she would make a small cut on him as a warning.

Now that they had reached the city gate, Changyu only had time to glance briefly at the situation before her. For a moment, she didn't recognize that the one who had captured the blue devil mask was Xie Zheng.

Head Constable Wang, seeing them dragging a string of bound prisoners like dumplings on a skewer, was utterly bewildered. He asked the county magistrate, "My lord, this is...?"

The magistrate, though inwardly fearful at the sight of the rebellious commoners glaring at him, thought of how Qingping County could now be defended. There was finally someone to bear the people's hatred, and when the time came, he could take credit for quelling the unrest in Qingping County before the Jizhou Prefecture officials. A promotion might even be within reach. His plump body immediately stopped trembling.

Adopting the inscrutable demeanor of an official, he said, "The generals from Jizhou Prefecture were overseeing the grain levy, but the people's grievances have grown too loud. Someone had to answer for it. That's why I, despite overstepping my authority... ordered these soldiers to be bound."

As he spoke, he glanced at Fan Changyu, confirming that she wouldn't reveal he had actually been the one imprisoned. His expression grew even more smug.

The magistrate's household servants wore varied expressions, but they were used to being his lackeys. If the magistrate called white black, they would blindly agree—why would they expose him now?

Fan Changyu's face showed not the slightest hint of strangeness. To the magistrate's men, she seemed like an obedient, unambitious child who knew her place.

Those like Head Constable Wang, who had no idea what was really happening, completely treated Fan Changyu as part of the background, focusing all their attention on the magistrate. Though still somewhat doubtful, with the evidence before his eyes, he had to admit the magistrate had shown some courage in daring to bind these soldiers. He praised, "My lord, your righteousness is commendable."

The magistrate thought to himself that Head Constable Wang had led the defense of the city gates, and it was his men who had captured the leading general. When rewards were distributed by Jizhou Prefecture, Wang would surely be credited with the greatest merit. If he wanted to claim that credit for himself, he'd have to flatter Wang first. So he added, "The rioters haven't breached the city yet, all thanks to Head Constable Wang's foresight in guarding this place. I only pretended to dismiss you to lull the vigilance of these Jizhou soldiers. You truly lived up to my expectations."

Head Constable Wang, feeling guilty, hurriedly said, "Wang Chuanxian is ashamed..."

He was about to say it had been Fan Changyu's idea when he looked up and saw her frantically winking at him.

Fan Changyu would be thrilled if the magistrate took all the credit.

She wasn't stupid. The leader she had captured was an official from Jizhou Prefecture. If he died, that bastard General Wei Xuan up above would surely hold a grudge against her once he heard her name.

She was just a common girl. Being thrust into the limelight might earn her some gold and silver, making her famous throughout Qingping County, but the cost—being marked for death by an official far more powerful than the magistrate—wasn't worth it. Who knew if she'd even live long enough to spend the rewards?

Moreover, if the guy in her hands was pushed out to let the people vent their anger and somehow didn't die, he would definitely hold a grudge against her. Although she had already somewhat unkindly hinted that she was working for the magistrate, the magistrate's cowardly and timid demeanor made it hard to believe he was the mastermind behind all this.

Now that the magistrate, eager to claim credit, was spinning a convincing tale and successfully diverting the hatred, she was inwardly delighted.

Head Constable Wang, however, was utterly confused. Seeing Fan Changyu signal him to stay silent, he swallowed the second half of his words.

Just then, the crowd below the city gate, seeing the magistrate arrive and immediately putting on his usual bureaucratic airs, grew increasingly resentful. Many began shouting curses: "Corrupt official! How will you pay for the dozen lives lost in Majia Village? With the lives of your entire family?"

The magistrate had never heard such vulgar language in his life. His mind was already filled with visions of climbing the ranks, so the sudden insults made his mustache quiver with rage. "How dare you insolent peasants curse an imperial official!"

The crowd, which Head Constable Wang and Xie Zheng had painstakingly calmed with a mix of authority and persuasion, erupted again at the magistrate's words.

Troublemakers in the crowd seized the moment to fan the flames: "Everyone saw it—this corrupt official still doesn't see us as human and has no intention of giving us justice!"

"If we let them trick us into going home now, tomorrow it'll be the Yamen Runners with their clubs beating us to death!"

"Kill the magistrate! Demand justice!"

The farmers below the gate roared, raising their farming tools. The small gate tower trembled under the waves of fury, like a lone boat on the sea, one surge away from splintering into pieces.

Seeing the situation escalate, the magistrate panicked and hastily ordered his servants to bring Sui Yuanqing and his men forward. "I'm just a minor magistrate—how could I decide on grain levies? The grain collection was entirely overseen by officials from Jizhou Prefecture! I knew nothing about what happened in Majia Village. If you want justice, I can only defy convention and hand these men over to you!"

He then commanded his subordinates, "Open the gates! Send them out!"

Xie Zheng's gaze had been fixed on Sui Yuanqing the entire time. Noticing the cold smirk on Sui Yuanqing's lips and the troublemakers in the crowd frequently glancing his way, he spoke coldly, "This man cannot be released."

Head Constable Wang quickly added, "Sir, you mustn't open the gates! If the rebels outside flood in, the city's residents will suffer!"

Hearing Xie Zheng's voice, Fan Changyu finally realized the masked man was him and looked up in surprise.

Sui Yuanqing frowned at the sound of his voice, sizing up the man standing nearby.

As the magistrate and Head Constable Wang argued, a sharp whistling sound cut through the air—several hidden arrows shot from the crowd, aimed straight at the magistrate and Fan Changyu on the gate tower.

At the same time, Eagle Claw Hooks flew from below, latching onto the rammed-earth battlements. A group of Martial Assassins, disguised as farmers, swiftly scaled the ropes, stepping on heads as they surged toward the tower.

Head Constable Wang drew his sword in alarm and shouted, "Protect the magistrate!"

Fan Changyu saw the sleeve arrow flying toward her face and instinctively dodged to the side. However, the man she was restraining suddenly lunged forward onto the Boning knife in her hand. Avoiding his neck—the vital spot—he dragged his shoulder heavily across the blade, leaving a deep gash, while the ropes binding him were severed.

By the time Changyu realized what had happened, the man—now bleeding profusely from another wound on his shoulder—flashed her a vicious, twisted grin.

Her instincts screamed danger. She reflexively leaped back, but Sui Yuanqing was faster. Free from his restraints, he snatched a Yamen Runner's saber and slashed at her.

The killing techniques honed on the battlefield were ruthless and lightning-fast.

Changyu's Boning knife was too short to match his long blade. When she blocked with it, the sheer force numbed her palm.

Xie Zheng intercepted the sleeve arrow aimed at Changyu, but as Yuan Qing broke free and turned the tables, his expression darkened. Just as he moved to assist, the Martial Assassins scaling the city wall with Eagle claw hooks seemed to read his intent. While continuing to fire hidden arrows at Changyu, they diverted forces to stall him.

Between shielding Changyu from the arrows and fending off these relentless attackers, Xie Zheng was stretched thin.

The Yamen Runners were no match for the assassins. Head Constable Wang's men fell one after another. The magistrate's guards, who had been restraining the prisoners, had never seen such carnage. Terrified out of their wits, they fled down the city wall, leaving themselves wide open—some were cut down before they could even think of fighting back.

For a moment, Yuan Qing's forces gained the upper hand.

Changyu was forced into retreat by Yuan Qing's relentless blade. Outmatched by his longer weapon, she couldn't disperse the impact—each clash split her palm further, blood beading from the cracks.

Gritting her teeth against the pain, she knew her earlier success in capturing him at the magistrate's residence had only been due to catching him off guard.

Now, every strike he aimed was lethal, ruthless to the extreme. Though skilled, she lacked real combat experience, and his underhanded tactics—coupled with her inferior weapon—left her completely suppressed.

She wanted to grab a saber, but Yuan Qing's relentless attacks left no opening. All she could do was barely parry with her Boning knife.

Seizing a fleeting chance, she hurled the knife like a projectile. Yuan Qing had to dodge, and Changyu immediately ducked to snatch a fallen Yamen Runner's blade.

But Yuan Qing's saber seemed to have eyes—it sliced toward her fingers in the next instant. To save her hands, she abandoned the weapon and rolled aside, narrowly avoiding the second slash aimed at her head.

Yuan Qing's lips curled into a smirk, his gaze alight with the amusement of a cat toying with prey. "You stabbed me so many times. It's only fair I return the favor—then skin you and hang you from the city gates."

Changyu spat fiercely. "If I'd brought my butcher's knife today, I'd show you how we bleed New Year's pigs!"

Realizing she was insulting him, Yuan Qing's expression darkened. The playful cruelty vanished as he advanced, blade raised. "You're asking for death!"

Fan Changyu was just as reckless, mimicking his earlier move by not dodging but instead charging straight toward the blade.

Xie Zheng, witnessing this from afar, narrowed his phoenix-like eyes coldly. In one swift motion, he seized a blade from a Martial Assassin and hurled it fiercely toward Sui Yuanqing.

The assassin let out a piercing scream—his wrist bone had been snapped by Xie Zheng during the disarming.

As the cold steel closed in, Sui Yuanqing's pupils contracted. Forced to defend himself, he had no choice but to redirect his strike to block the incoming blade.

The two blades collided with a sharp metallic clang, and the ring-pommeled sword in Sui Yuanqing's hand shattered into two pieces.

The sheer force behind the throw made him look up in astonishment at the man wearing the blue devil mask.

Earlier, when he had heard this man speak, the voice had struck him as vaguely familiar. Moreover, he had only ever encountered such raw strength from one opponent on the battlefield. Could this man be...?

The moment the thought crossed his mind, his distraction cost him dearly—a brutal elbow strike smashed into his jaw, sending him sprawling backward. For a long moment, his entire lower face went numb, his teeth rattled as if loosened, and the metallic tang of blood filled his mouth. The impact likely reverberated to his cheekbone, as his ears rang so loudly he could barely hear anything around him.

Suddenly, he wasn't so sure the masked man was the Wu'an Marquis anymore. If even an unknown young woman in Qingping County possessed such monstrous strength, who knew what other hidden talents lurked here...

Fan Changyu held a grudge. Earlier, this man had bullied her without a proper weapon, forcing her to fend off his greatsword with nothing but a dagger-sized boning knife, leaving her utterly defenseless. After smashing her elbow into his jaw, she immediately snatched up a fallen ring-pommeled sword from the ground and swung at him again.

With only a broken blade left in hand, Sui Yuanqing's eyes flashed with hatred, but in the end, he chose to retreat rather than face her onslaught.

Now it was Fan Changyu's turn to press the attack without pause. Sui Yuanqing dodged and retreated continuously, leaving deep, finger-width gouges in the city walls on either side as her blade carved through stone.

Mu Shi and several Martial Assassins, noticing their young master being chased down and hacked at, quickly broke away to assist him.

From the distant official road came the chaotic thunder of hooves. Looking up, they saw the Jizhou flag flapping violently in the cold wind.

The commoners gathered below the city gate had long lost track of the situation when the fighting broke out on the battlements. Those seemingly ordinary farmers in short coarse robes were all shockingly skilled fighters—none of them recognizable. With the chaos escalating and the instigators gone, the remaining crowd dared not act rashly.

Now, seeing the Jizhou Prefecture troops approaching, they weren't just worried about clashing—they feared the soldiers might mistake them for allies of those formidable "farmers" on the walls. They hastily cleared a path.

Seizing the moment while several Martial Assassins surrounded Fan Changyu, Mu Shi helped Sui Yuanqing up. Glancing at the approaching Jizhou soldiers, he urged, "Young Master, as long as the green hills remain, there'll never be a shortage of firewood. Let's retreat for now!"

Sui Yuanqing glared venomously at Fan Changyu. Seeing that the dozen or so Martial Assassins could no longer hold back the blue-masked man, he suddenly drew Mu Shi's saber and lunged toward the county magistrate.

The magistrate shrieked in terror. Head Constable Wang, already slashed multiple times, threw himself forward to shield the official.

Fan Changyu couldn't just watch Head Constable Wang die before her eyes. With Yan Zheng still entangled by swarms of Martial Assassins, she swung her greatsword to intercept Sui Yuanqing's killing strike.

Unexpectedly, Sui Yuanqing fainted, abruptly abandoning his blade. His hand coiled around Fan Changyu's sword-wielding wrist like a vine. With some inexplicable maneuver, Changyu felt her entire arm go numb instantly, her broadsword clattering to the ground.

"I've changed my mind. It'd be a waste to skin you and hang your hide on the city walls. Come back with me and be my concubine instead."

With one hand gripping the rope secured by the Eagle Claw Hook and the other clutching Fan Changyu, Sui Yuanqing laughed wildly as he leaped from the collapsed section of the parapet.

Changyu was yanked off balance, tumbling down before she could steady herself. Instinctively, she cried out, "Yan Zheng!"

At the critical moment, another large, sinewy hand shot out from the battlement, seizing Changyu's arm in a death grip.

Even behind the Blue Devil Mask, Xie Zheng's aura was terrifyingly cold and vicious. His long-handled blade slashed toward Sui Yuanqing's hand gripping Changyu with such ruthless force that no one doubted the limb would be severed in the next instant.

Sui Yuanqing had no choice but to release Changyu, gritting his teeth. Yet the razor-sharp blade still sliced off a lock of hair at his temple and left a shallow cut on his face.

When he raised his eyes to meet the savage glare beneath the Blue Devil Mask, his heart lurched in shock.

With her other hand now held firmly by Xie Zheng, Changyu had leverage. Without hesitation, she kicked straight at Sui Yuanqing's face, barking orders at Xie Zheng, "Quick! Cut the rope! Let this bastard fall to his death!"

The Eagle Claw Hook anchoring the rope to the battlement snapped instantly. However, Sui Yuanqing managed to cushion his fall by kicking off the wall mid-descent, and his personal guards hauled on the rope to break his landing. He touched down unscathed—save for a black boot print marring half his handsome face.

Changyu couldn't hide her disappointment. Even as Xie Zheng hauled her back up, she muttered resentfully, "Why didn't he just die from the fall..."

The next moment, she was abruptly engulfed in a broad, solid chest—so tightly that she felt as if clamped between iron plates. Her grumbling ceased abruptly.

Chapter 50

Strange movements arose below the city walls as the sound of approaching hoofbeats drew near, the north wind howling and whipping the tattered banners still clinging to the battlements.

The embrace was brief—as if Xie Zheng had only pulled Fan Changyu into his arms to dissipate the force with which he'd yanked her up.

Before Changyu could even process what had happened, Xie Zheng had already released her, leaving behind an icy command: "Stay on the walls. Don't come down."

Having said this, he himself gripped his long-handled blade, seized a rope tied with an eagle claw hook, and slid down the city wall like a swooping hawk.

Changyu scrambled to her feet, leaning over the parapet to watch as he charged straight after Sui Yuanqing.

Among the rebelling peasants were many of Sui Yuanqing's hidden scouts, dressed in the same coarse clothing as ordinary farmers. They darted through the crowd, sowing chaos. Thousands of people stood packed together, the constant jostling making movement nearly impossible, hindering Xie Zheng's advance.

From atop the wall, Changyu had a clear view of Sui Yuanqing's movements. She pointed in one direction and shouted to Xie Zheng, "That bastard's fleeing southwest!"

Hearing her, Xie Zheng vaulted over the shoulders of the tightly packed peasants, leaping toward the southwest in pursuit of Yuan Qing.

The Martial Assassins hidden among the peasants swarmed to intercept him. Xie Zheng forced several back with a single slash of his blade, but some, relying on their patched peasant garb, pretended to be ordinary farmers, shouting, "The man in the blue devil mask is killing people!"

"I wasn't part of the group that stormed the walls! Why's he swinging his blade at me?"

Unaware peasants, seeing Xie Zheng attacking those in short robes, assumed he was slaughtering common folk. Enraged, they grabbed whatever weapons they could and rushed to block him.

Against a group of Martial Assassins, Xie Zheng could fight ruthlessly—but against deceived peasants, he had to hold back. Trapped, he could only watch helplessly as Sui Yuanqing was escorted to the edge of the crowd by his personal guards.

The two men locked eyes across the throng, and Yuan Qing flashed Xie Zheng a taunting grin.

Behind the blue devil mask, Xie Zheng's gaze was glacial.

From the wall, Changyu watched Sui Yuanqing escape using such underhanded tactics and angrily punched the parapet in frustration.

The already crumbling wall crumbled further under her fist, sending chunks of debris raining down.

Changyu froze, staring at the crumbling wall, then at her own hand. She glanced at Head Constable Wang and the county magistrate, who were gaping at her in shock, and promptly took several steps back, putting as much distance between herself and the wall as possible.

She absolutely could not be held responsible for repairs!

Meanwhile, He Jingyuan had led his troops to block the only official road outside Qingping County's gates. Seeing the chaos among the peasants surrounding the city, he frowned in confusion.

Spotting soldiers in Jizhou uniforms mixed in with the crowd, his aged eyelids drooped slightly. "Why are Jizhou Prefecture troops here?"

He ordered a nearby personal guard, "Signal the Jizhou soldiers in the crowd to come here."

Amid the deafening clamor of battle, verbal commands were useless—advances and retreats were directed by signal flags.

The guard quickly retrieved two small flags and signaled to the Jizhou soldiers now at the crowd's periphery. They saw the command but didn't approach—instead, they swiftly fled in the opposite direction.

The guard turned to He Jingyuan. "General, what do we—?"

He Jingyuan said in a deep voice, "They're not soldiers from our Jizhou Prefecture. They might be from that unmarked army Wen Chang went to suppress. Capture them!"

A young officer quickly led several dozen men to pursue Sui Yuanqing and his fleeing group.

Meanwhile, the Martial Assassins hidden among the crowd pushed farmers forward to block the pursuing soldiers while shouting, "The soldiers are killing people!"

"The officials don't care about our lives at all!"

"This corrupt court—we might as well rebel!"

Some Martial Assassins took advantage of the chaos to stab several soldiers chasing Sui Yuanqing. The remaining soldiers, thinking their comrades had been killed by rebelling peasants, angrily began cutting down the civilians blocking their way.

Seeing the soldiers killing indiscriminately, some terrified farmers shrank back into the crowd while others, enraged, raised their hoes and rakes to fight back.

He Jingyuan frowned deeply at the escalating chaos.

Another officer under his command watched with gritted teeth and stepped forward, saying, "Lord He, let me lead a thousand troops to suppress the rioters and support Commandant Hu!"

As He Jingyuan pondered, a black-clad man suddenly emerged from the crowd. Tall and wielding a Yanyue blade, his face hidden behind a blue devil mask, he spoke in a rough voice: "The one fleeing in Jizhou military uniform is Sui Yuanqing, second son of Prince Changxin. His men are disguised as rebels, stirring up trouble among the crowd."

He Jingyuan thought this explained everything. Studying the young man before him, he couldn't help asking, "Might I know who you are, brave warrior?"

Xie Zheng replied coldly, "Just a commoner, unworthy of naming myself before Your Lordship." As he spoke, his gaze shifted to the young officer who had spoken earlier. "I'll borrow your horse and bow."

The officer felt his collar yanked violently, and before he knew it, he was pulled off his horse. Stumbling several steps to regain balance, he looked

up to see the man already galloping away on his steed.

Indignant, the officer shouted, "How dare you—" but stopped mid-sentence when his eyes met He Jingyuan's, hanging his head in shame. The stranger had dismounted him within five paces, and he hadn't even been able to resist—clear proof of his inferior skills.

He Jingyuan didn't reprimand him, instead watching Xie Zheng's retreating figure with a complicated expression before ordering his troops: "Sound the horns and form ranks."

With the rebels in complete disarray, restoring order was the only way to minimize casualties.

The mournful sound of buffalo horns echoed as shield-bearing soldiers formed the front lines, rhythmically striking their thick shields with swords while thousands of troops shouted in unison—a deafening display that successfully intimidated all the rebels present.

The farmers still held their tools defensively against the armed soldiers, but fear showed on their faces as they instinctively shrank back.

He Jingyuan addressed them: "I am He Jingyuan, Governor of Jizhou. You are all people under my jurisdiction. Why rebel?"

Hearing it was him leading the troops, though still clutching their tools, the crowd erupted in hushed discussion. Their expressions softened, and some even began quietly sobbing.

Soon someone dropped their tools and knelt, crying bitterly, "Lord He, you must deliver justice for us!"

As the front rows knelt, others gradually followed suit, dropping their tools and kneeling until the field was filled with weeping voices: "We had no other choice!"

Even those who were still unwilling had to accept that the tide had turned. These farmers, who only knew how to wield hoes, stood no chance against well-trained soldiers. Rebellion was a crime punishable by the extermination of one's entire clan. It was better to obediently admit their mistakes now and beg for mercy, hoping the authorities would let the matter slide since the blame couldn't be pinned on everyone.

For a moment, the area beneath the city tower was filled with the cries of the common folk—some genuinely lamenting their hardships, others feigning distress to avoid punishment.

But regardless, the riot had been quelled.

The county magistrate collapsed onto the tower floor, gasping for breath. The thought of nearly losing his life to a blade made his plump face tremble uncontrollably. He said to Head Constable Wang, "Head Constable Wang, you saved my life. I'll reward you handsomely later."

Head Constable Wang, covered in countless wounds and smeared with blood, pushed aside the body of a fallen Martial Assassin. Wiping the blood from the face of a young constable with his sleeve, he grinned through reddened eyes and said, "Just doing my duty, my lord. If you wish to reward anyone, give more compensation to the families of these young men."

He looked at the dead young constable. "This is Xiao Wu, the youngest constable in the Yamen. He was the most filial—his eighty-year-old blind mother relied on him. Every month when he got his pay, he'd buy a piece of meat from the butcher to make porridge for her. The one next to him is Li Da. His wife is pregnant, due in two months. With the family's breadwinner gone, I don't know how they'll survive..."

His voice choked up as if stuffed with cotton, and he could no longer speak. He simply covered his eyes with his bloodstained hands.

Fan Changyu stared at the fallen constables, her lips pressed tightly together.

She glanced down from the tower but saw no sign of Xie Zheng, Sui Yuanqing, or their group.

Sui Yuanqing and his personal guards had already fled in the planned direction when He Jingyuan sent pursuers after them.

Martial Assassins held back the pursuing soldiers while Mu Shi protected Sui Yuanqing. Mu Shi fired a whistling arrow into the sky, but the thousand men they had stationed at the hillside failed to come to their aid.

As the pursuers grew in number and their Martial Assassins were mostly dead or wounded, unable to hold off the soldiers any longer, Mu Shi was about to fire a second whistling arrow when Sui Yuanqing stopped him. "No need."

With a cold smirk, he suppressed his fury. "The one leading the troops is He Jingyuan, not Wei Xuan. After all, he's a renowned general of Great Yin.

I suspect he's already discovered our thousand men lying in ambush at the hillside."

Realizing the gravity of the situation, Mu Shi's heart sank. "This subordinate will fight to the death to escort the Young Master back to Chongzhou."

Sui Yuanqing merely chuckled indifferently, even slowing his pace. The cavalry behind them closed in, firing arrows as they urged their horses forward.

Dodging an arrow, Sui Yuanqing snatched one midair. As a warhorse galloped past, he grabbed its reins and swung himself onto the saddle.

The mounted soldier panicked, slashing backward with his blade, but Sui Yuanqing leaned away and drove the arrowhead into the man's throat.

The soldier died instantly, and Sui Yuanqing shoved the corpse off the horse.

Mu Shi also seized another soldier's horse and caught up. Sui Yuanqing grinned roguishly. "If we want to return to Chongzhou, four legs are faster than two."

Now mounted, they paid no heed to the Jizhou soldiers behind them.

"Whoosh!"

A white-feathered arrow whistled through the air, grazing Sui Yuanqing's ear before embedding itself deep into the frozen ground several zhang ahead, its white fletching still trembling.

Everyone was startled—had that arrow been aimed at Sui Yuanqing, the tip would have pierced through his back and the shaft would have emerged from his chest.

Sui Yuanqing stared at the arrow that had landed nearby, his usual arrogance fading from his expression as he turned to examine the archer.

The official road had been churned into mud, and remnants of thin snow still clung to the treetops in the forests on either side. At the end of the road stood a man wearing a Blue Devil mask, his long-handled Yanyue blade planted casually in the ground while he held a large bow in hand.

He had already nocked another arrow but made no deliberate effort to aim. The eyes behind the mask were cold and indifferent.

With just one glance, Sui Yuanqing's face twisted in fury.

"Split up and run!" he bellowed.

His personal guards, though confused, immediately scattered on their stolen warhorses.

Xie Zheng's lips curled into a cold smirk as he released the bowstring. By the time the arrow was in flight, he had already nocked a second one.

His movements were astonishingly swift, arrows raining down like meteors. In mere moments, over a dozen arrows had been loosed, and Sui Yuanqing's guards all tumbled from their saddles.

Seeing his men fall one after another, Sui Yuanqing had no time to worry about the archer behind him. Gritting his teeth, he spurred his horse forward, pressing himself as low as possible against its back.

Xie Zheng's quiver was empty by the time he gave chase. As he passed a fallen cavalryman, he reached back and snatched the man's quiver, plucking an arrow with one hand before tossing the quiver aside.

Only Mu Shi remained among Sui Yuanqing's guards, still riding close behind. Glancing back, Mu Shi's eyes widened in horror. "Young Master, watch out!" he roared.

Sui Yuanqing turned at the warning and froze in shock. The man in the Blue Devil mask had fanned nearly ten arrows across his bow, releasing them all at once like a swarm of locusts hurtling toward him.

Terror gripped Sui Yuanqing—he had never witnessed such extraordinary archery in his life. Who was this masked man?

Forced to twist in his saddle, he raised his sword to desperately deflect the incoming arrows. But then his horse screamed as its legs were struck, collapsing and sending Sui Yuanqing flying. He rolled several times before finally skidding to a stop.

The sound of hooves drew near, yet the masked man didn't rush forward. Instead, he reined in his horse, advancing at a leisurely pace, exuding an air of indifference.

Sui Yuanqing's face darkened. This cat-and-mouse game—wasn't this exactly what he had done to that little maid from the magistrate's residence on the city wall earlier?

What connection did this masked man have with that maid?

When he had seized her, hadn't she been calling out a name?

Mu Shi, fearing Xie Zheng would harm Sui Yuanqing, charged forward on horseback, his spear leveled. "Don't you dare touch my general!"

Xie Zheng caught the spear mid-thrust, twisting and wrenching it upward with such force that Mu Shi was flung from his saddle. His palms, clenched too tightly around the shaft, were nearly skinned raw from the violent tug. Pain forced him to let go.

Now armed with Mu Shi's own weapon, Xie Zheng sat calmly astride his horse, the silver spearpoint resting against Sui Yuanqing's throat. His voice carried a faint mockery.

"Changxin Wang's heir, Sui Yuanqing?"

Sui Yuanqing clenched his teeth so hard that a faint taste of blood filled his mouth. The veins on his temples bulged, but after a moment, he suppressed the humiliation and burst into laughter. "Indeed, it is this heir."

Below the official road roared the raging waters of the Nu River, which, even in the depths of winter, never froze due to the swift current.

Sui Yuanqing stole a discreet glance downward, his entire body appearing utterly relaxed under the tip of Xie Zheng's spear. "And who might you be? If you're here to take this heir's life, surely you wouldn't dare withhold your name."

Xie Zheng remained silent. If Sui Yuanqing had been captured by military forces, they wouldn't kill him now. Taking him to the battlefield in Chongzhou to negotiate terms with Changxin Wang would be far more advantageous.

Sui Yuanqing's deliberate question was an attempt to fish for information.

Seeing that Xie Zheng wasn't biting, Sui Yuanqing suddenly smirked and asked, "Who's that little maid on the city tower to you? Her skin was so fair, and her lips tasted sweet."

Xie Zheng's gaze turned icy in an instant. Sui Yuanqing had been waiting for this moment of distraction. With a swift motion, he knocked aside the spear at his throat and dove headfirst toward the river.

Xie Zheng reacted with lightning speed, sweeping his spear toward Sui Yuanqing and striking his flank. Sui Yuanqing grunted in pain, and the next

moment, his entire body vanished into the churning river, leaving only a spreading stain of crimson on the water's surface.

Chapter 51

When the Jizhou Prefecture soldiers who had their horses stolen caught up, they saw a man wearing a blue devil mask standing by the official road, holding a long spear as he gazed at the churning river below.

Mu Shi had injured his leg when he fell from his horse and was now lying amidst the gravel by the roadside, weeping and shouting toward the river: "Young Master!"

The Jizhou soldiers, unsure of the situation, raised their weapons warily at the masked man. Suddenly, he turned around, giving them a cold glance before saying, "The fugitive escaped into the river. He won't swim far with his waist injury. You can search downstream."

With that, he mounted his horse and rode off, leaving the soldiers too intimidated to stop him.

Only one sharp-eyed soldier recognized the warhorse Xie Zheng was riding and whispered, "That's Captain Xu's horse."

Captain Xu was the young officer whose horse Xie Zheng had earlier seized.

The soldiers exchanged uneasy glances, none daring to speak up. After a moment, their leader ordered them to restrain the injured Mu Shi, sending some downstream to search for Sui Yuanqing while others escorted Mu Shi back for questioning.

At the gates of Qingping County, the rebellious villagers had been subdued.

When He Jingyuan led his troops into the city, the county magistrate, smearing blood on his face, rushed forward wailing: "Lord He, thank heavens you've arrived! Had you not come, this humble official would have had to throw his bones upon the city walls to stop the rebels!"

Seated on horseback, He Jingyuan observed the blood-covered magistrate. Though he hadn't held a favorable impression of him before, his expression softened slightly. "Magistrate Liu, the safety of Qingping's people owes much to your efforts."

Magistrate Liu, sensing a potential promotion, wept even more dramatically: "In my three years here, my achievements have been modest. Just as my transfer neared, the military's grain requisition incited rebellion. In desperation, I ordered the county constables to bar the gates and detained the grain-collecting officers to quell the unrest—until your reinforcements arrived. I beg your forgiveness for any impropriety."

He Jingyuan, already aware from the masked man's account that the unrest had been instigated by Changxin Wang's heir, grew suspicious upon hearing about the grain officers. "Explain the grain requisition in detail," he demanded.

Magistrate Liu recounted how days earlier, officers had arrived demanding one shi of grain per person.

He Jingyuan exclaimed, "Preposterous! Jizhou Prefecture would never issue such an order!"

Sweating profusely, the magistrate stammered, "They claimed it was Military Governor Wei's decree. How could I refuse? They even confined me! When I learned the peasants were rebelling, I feared disaster and had my men arrest them."

Eager to claim credit, Magistrate Liu omitted Head Constable Wang and Fan Changyu's roles, summarizing events vaguely.

He Jingyuan fell silent, his grim expression unsettling the magistrate.

From the magistrate's account, He Jingyuan pieced together the truth: Changxin Wang's heir had ambushed the grain officers, forged a requisition order, and likely orchestrated the Ma Village massacre—all to incite rebellion in Qingping County.

However, the magistrate of Qingping County still had no idea about the true identities of those soldiers. How did the masked man recognize Sui Yuanqing then?

Could it be that the masked man already knew Sui Yuanqing?

He Jingyuan's gaze grew increasingly complex as he recalled his earlier suspicions.

He asked the magistrate, "Earlier, I noticed a man in black wearing a blue devil mask on the city wall, fighting fiercely against the enemy. Do you know who he was?"

After waiting for so long only to be asked this question, Magistrate Liu grew uneasy and shook his head. "This... I don't know either. Perhaps he was a righteous man from the city."

Just then, the soldiers who had been pursuing Sui Yuanqing and his group returned to the city.

The leader of the soldiers dismounted as soon as he entered the gate and cupped his fists toward He Jingyuan. "Sir, the leader of the bandits escaped by fleeing into the river. I've already sent men to search downstream, but first, I've brought back this captive to report to you."

He Jingyuan glanced at the tightly bound Mu Shi and asked, "Did you see a man wearing a blue devil mask?"

The subordinate cupped his fists and bowed his head. "This man was captured by that very warrior. When we arrived, he told us the bandit leader had fled into the river and then headed downstream himself. It seemed he was also searching for the bandit leader."

The young officer whose horse had been taken couldn't help but mutter, "Then where's my damn horse?"

He Jingyuan shot him a look, and he immediately shut his mouth.

He Jingyuan turned to Mu Shi. "Lock him up first and keep a close watch on him. Make sure he doesn't take his own life."

The subordinate acknowledged the order.

He Jingyuan then pointed at the young officer who had just spoken. "Lieutenant Xu, take a squad and search along the river as well. Try to capture the bandit alive if possible."

The young officer quickly straightened his expression and cupped his fists. "Understood!"

After escorting Head Constable Wang to the physician, Fan Changyu noticed that it was almost dark and Xie Zheng still hadn't returned. Worry crept into her heart, so after informing Head Constable Wang, she prepared to leave the city to search for Xie Zheng.

By now, the city gates were guarded by soldiers from Jizhou Prefecture, clad in armor and armed to the teeth, an imposing sight that kept ordinary citizens at a distance.

Fearing that accomplices of the bandits might still be hiding in the city, entry and exit had become extremely strict. Some villagers who usually came to trade were temporarily detained.

After a brief hesitation, Fan Changyu decided to approach the guards to explain her situation and ask if they had seen Yan Zheng during the pursuit. After all, Yan Zheng had been wearing a blue devil mask—he should have been easy to recognize.

Just as she was about to step forward, the sound of unhurried hoofbeats came from outside the gate. The soldiers guarding the entrance peered out and saw a chestnut horse returning alone.

At the same time, a large hand suddenly grabbed Fan Changyu's wrist from the side, pulling her back several steps.

The soldiers who had gathered around the gate looked outside but saw no rider. Puzzled, one of them said, "Lieutenant Xu's horse came back by itself?"

A few steps away, Fan Changyu was startled—then overjoyed—to see the man in dark robes standing before her, the blue devil mask now removed. As he led her away, she was so preoccupied with her chatter that she didn't even notice he was still holding her hand. "Why were you gone so long? The soldiers already came back with their captives. I thought something had happened to you..."

Xie Zheng listened to her rambling, his grip on her wrist unwavering. "I was chasing the bandit leader. He fled far."

Fan Changyu immediately realized he must have been pursuing that cunning officer. "Did you catch him?"

Xie Zheng shook his head.

He had searched over ten miles along the river but hadn't caught sight of Sui Yuanqing. The man had escaped into the river wearing that suit of armor, with a wound on his waist from Xie Zheng's spear. Even if he were an excellent swimmer, his chances of survival were slim.

If Sui Yuanqing truly managed to escape death, it could only be said that fate wasn't ready to claim him yet.

Hearing that Sui Yuanqing hadn't been caught, Fan Changyu was also disappointed but quickly added, "They say turtles live for a thousand years

and tortoises for ten thousand. If that little bastard didn't die, it must be because he's just like them."

Noticing that Fan Changyu never had a kind word to say about Sui Yuanqing, Xie Zheng's eyes darkened as he recalled the taunting words Sui Yuanqing had thrown at him before diving into the river. He asked, "Do you have a grudge against him?"

Fan Changyu replied, "There wasn't one at first. After you told me the magistrate was being controlled, I wanted to drag him out and reinstate Head Constable Wang to his position so he could do his job more easily. Who knew that little bastard was staying at the magistrate's residence? I had no choice but to go after him, and that's how the grudge started."

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze, concealing the emotions in his eyes. "His martial skills are decent. How did you capture him?"

At this, Fan Changyu looked a little embarrassed, feeling her method wasn't entirely honorable. But being straightforward by nature, she recounted truthfully, "There were too many of them, and I was afraid I couldn't take them all. I originally planned to drug them, but the magistrate's residence didn't have any sedatives. So I disguised myself as a maid and served that little bastard a bowl of silver ear soup laced with croton beans."

She was still wearing the maid's outfit, her fair wrist partially exposed where Xie Zheng held it.

Xie Zheng looked down at her, thinking of how she had worn this same outfit to serve Sui Yuanqing the soup. Unconsciously, his grip tightened.

The pain in her hand finally reminded Fan Changyu that he was still holding her wrist. She patted his hand and hissed, "Ease up a bit. That bastard bullied me on the city wall when I didn't have a proper weapon—he swung a ring-pommeled saber at me while I only had a boning knife. Later, when he dragged me off the wall, he injured this wrist too. It still hurts."

Xie Zheng released her hand and noticed a ring of bruised fingerprints on her pale wrist—clearly not from him—and a split in the webbing between her thumb and forefinger, the dried blood still visible.

A flash of fury crossed his eyes.

Seeing his silence, Fan Changyu realized her earlier words might have sounded like complaining, which felt overly sentimental. She quickly added, "But I got my revenge. I stabbed him several times, and before he ran off, I even kicked him in the face!"

Xie Zheng remained silent as she spoke, his gaze cold and heavy.

Fan Changyu noticed he had been unusually quiet the whole way and guessed he might be frustrated about failing to catch that bastard. She tried to comfort him with a few more words.

Before returning to town, Fan Changyu first went to reassure Head Constable Wang, so he wouldn't worry about Yan Zheng not coming back.

Upon learning they planned to return to town, Head Constable Wang said, "It's already dark, and the snow is heavy. After today's events, bandits will surely take advantage of the chaos. Traveling in the dark isn't safe. I have spare rooms at home—you two can stay here for the night and leave tomorrow."

Fan Changyu considered it. Both she and Yan Zheng were exhausted after the day's events, so she thanked him and agreed.

Yu Bao'er, seeing Fan Changyu arrive, toddled over and asked, "Auntie Changyu, when is my mother coming to get me?"

Fan Changyu then remembered Yu Qianqian's situation and looked up at Xie Zheng: "Is Shopkeeper Yu still in jail now?"

Xie Zheng leaned against the moon gate with his arms crossed, shaking his head faintly. His idle gaze lingered on Yu Bao'er, carrying a trace of complexity before he averted his eyes and said, "The murder case at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion hasn't been closed yet. It's unclear how the authorities will handle it. Since she entrusted this little one to you, just take care of him until the case is resolved."

Fan Changyu thought that Yu Qianqian had always treated her well, so helping to look after Yu Bao'er for a while was the least she could do.

She and Yu Qianqian had previously speculated that the county magistrate wanted to seize Yu Qianqian's property to pledge allegiance to the Rebel King, but now it seemed that wasn't the case.

If the authorities handled the case fairly and cleared Yu Qianqian's name, then all would be well.

But if the magistrate had any ulterior motives, she now had evidence of his corruption and wouldn't let him bully Yu Qianqian.

Fan Changyu patted Yu Bao'er on the back of the head and said, "Your mother has run into a little trouble. Once she sorts it out, she'll come get you. For now, come with me to town and play with Ning Niang for a few days, alright?"

In the past, when Yu Qianqian was busy with the shop, she would leave Yu Bao'er with the maids at home. Sometimes, he wouldn't see his mother for days.

Though young, he was already quite composed. Hearing this, he nodded obediently and asked curiously, "Aunt Changyu, do you know how to butcher pigs?"

Fan Changyu thought for a moment and said, "Maybe."

The day's events had left the entire county in turmoil. It was uncertain whether the market would even open in the next few days. It would probably take some time before things returned to normal.

Yu Bao'er completely ignored the word "maybe." Satisfied with Fan Changyu's answer, he happily let the maid take him to wash up and sleep.

From the moment Fan Changyu arrived at Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion early in the morning to deliver meat to Yu Qianqian until now, she hadn't even had a sip of water.

Wang Furen knew she must be starving and had the maids prepare a meal.

Fan Changyu hadn't even thought about hunger all afternoon, but the moment she smelled the food, she realized she was famished.

She had been doing physical labor all day and was completely empty. She wolfed down three bowls of rice and was about to reach for a fourth when Xie Zheng pressed down on her spoon.

He said, "Don't overeat after starving for so long. It'll hurt your stomach."

Grudgingly, Fan Changyu set down her chopsticks.

After the meal, Xie Zheng went out for a while. Head Constable Wang often got injured while working cases, so his home was stocked with wound medicine.

Xie Zheng asked Wang Furen for some bruise ointment and a bottle of тpавma medicine.

When he returned to the room, Fan Changyu had just finished washing up.

He saw her wringing out a cloth in the basin and frowned. "Has no one ever told you to keep wounds away from water?"

Fan Changyu glanced at the cuts on her hand and said dismissively, "These little scratches? No big deal."

Then she noticed the medicine in Xie Zheng's hand and exclaimed, "Oh, you went to get medicine for me?"

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes slightly and said flatly, "Wang Furen gave it to me."

Fan Changyu didn't doubt him. "Auntie is so thoughtful, noticing even these small injuries."

Xie Zheng didn't respond. Leaning against the doorframe, he asked, "Are you going to apply it or not?"

Fan Changyu thought to herself that this man's temper was so unpredictable. But remembering how he had saved her several times on the city wall, she decided not to argue. Tilting her head up, she said, "Of course I'll apply it. This is medicine Auntie gave me—it's the thought that counts."

Upon hearing the words "feelings," Xie Zheng glanced up at her briefly before averting his gaze again.

Fan Changyu first sprinkled тpавma medicine on her palm. Seeing her struggle to tie the gauze with one end clenched between her teeth, Xie Zheng stepped forward to help her wrap and secure it.

However, when it came to applying the ointment to her wrist, Fan Changyu realized she had made a foolish mistake.

She should have applied the ointment to her wrist first. The salve was oily and needed to be gently spread and massaged into the skin. Now, with both hands wrapped in gauze, she could only scoop a little with her fingertips and slowly rub it in with her fingers, which was quite troublesome.

Moreover, the oily salve was extremely slippery, making it difficult to work into the skin with just her fingertips.

Fan Changyu haphazardly rubbed it in and was about to close the ointment box when her wrist was suddenly intercepted by a large hand.

Xie Zheng's calloused palm spread the still-wet salve over her wrist, his tone far from polite: "Do you always do everything so carelessly?"

Fan Changyu, once again on the receiving end of his sharp words, couldn't help retorting, "It's not like my hands are free right now!"

Xie Zheng seemed momentarily taken aback. After that, he focused solely on massaging the ointment into her wrist without saying another word.

Her pale skin took on a warm, jade-like hue under the candlelight, while the ring of blue fingerprints around her wrist stood out starkly, looking almost shocking.

Suddenly, Xie Zheng recalled the provocative smirk Sui Yuanqing had thrown his way after breaking through the crowd earlier.

An inexplicable anger surged in his chest, and his lips pressed into a tight line.

His palm was separated from her wrist by a layer of ointment. While the salve was still wet, the rubbing felt slippery, but as it absorbed into her skin, the sensation of his fingers kneading her wrist became unmistakable.

Perhaps from prolonged contact, his palm grew scorching hot, like a branding iron.

Fan Changyu frowned, about to say it was enough, but he withdrew his hand before she could speak.

The words on her lips had to be swallowed back.

Xie Zheng put away the ointment box and went to wash his hands at the nearby washstand.

Fan Changyu looked down at her reddened wrist, feeling it burn and itch intensely. She scrunched her face, resisting the urge to rub it against her clothes.

She thought to herself that if she had known the ointment would make her whole hand numb and itchy, she wouldn't have bothered applying it.

She might as well have waited to use medicinal wine when she got home.

Xie Zheng turned and saw her conflicted expression. "What's wrong?" he asked.

Fan Changyu shook her wrist. "The medicine's taking effect. It feels strange."

Outside, the night watchman's clappers sounded—it was already midnight, and the entire Wang household was silent.

Without needing further explanation from Fan Changyu, Xie Zheng went to check the wardrobe but found no extra bedding.

Fan Changyu, still seated at the table, noticed this as well.

At this hour, it was hardly appropriate to wake Wang Furen just to ask for a quilt to sleep on the floor.

After a moment, Xie Zheng turned back and said, "I'm not tired yet. You should rest."

Fan Changyu thought to herself that this was nonsense—he hadn't slept well for several nights in a row, and this morning, he had barely managed to help her sell pork.

Besides, in the dead of winter, spending the night without a charcoal brazier was practically freezing. Did he plan to sit in the room all night?

Glancing at the single thick quilt left on the bed, Fan Changyu offered, "How about... we share the bed for tonight?"

Xie Zheng's heart skipped a beat. When he turned to her with a frown, Fan Changyu misunderstood his hesitation and quickly raised her gauze-wrapped hands in assurance. "Don't worry, I won't have any improper thoughts about you!"

Chapter 52

The room was pitch-black after the lamp was extinguished. Fan Changyu lay in bed, pressed almost against the wall. She squinted, glancing at the person lying on the edge.

Yes, Xie Zheng was practically sleeping on the bed frame.

She closed her eyes, too lazy to care whether he was comfortable or not. She had already declared multiple times that she had no improper thoughts about him and had left him plenty of space. Yet, after getting into bed, he remained silent, still choosing to sleep on the very edge.

This look of utter avoidance—wasn't it a clear sign he was afraid she'd covet his handsome face?

Fan Changyu turned over to face the wall, thinking to herself that with his foul temper, she wouldn't want him even if he were as beautiful as a celestial being!

The "celestial being" Xie Zheng was feigning sleep with his eyes closed. When the person on the inside suddenly turned over, the corner of the quilt he was barely holding onto was instantly pulled away completely.

The night's chill seeped through his thin lapels and drilled under his skin. Xie Zheng opened his eyes and looked inward. Fan Changyu's form made a small mound under the thick quilt, with most of the blanket spread across the middle of the bed.

To get under the covers, he would have to shift inward a little, but that would inevitably startle Fan Changyu.

Her breathing was shallow; she was clearly not yet asleep.

Xie Zheng retracted his gaze and closed his eyes again.

One year, while leading his troops beyond the frontier, he had been caught in an avalanche and survived after being buried in snow for three days. He paid this bit of cold no mind.

There were at least three feet between them, but perhaps because the thing they were lying on was a bed, he felt a constant sense of unease.

Even siblings of the opposite sex were not supposed to share a room after a certain age, let alone an unrelated man and woman.

In this world, only a husband and wife could share a bed like this.

And the one sleeping soundly beside his couch at this moment was this very woman.

These chaotic thoughts churned in Xie Zheng's mind, chasing away any hint of sleep. When he heard Fan Changyu's breathing become long and steady, a wave of inexplicable frustration rose in him. He simply sat up, leaning against the headboard to ponder the current situation.

After sleeping for a while, Fan Changyu shifted to lie on her back.

Hearing the movement, Xie Zheng's gaze swept over coolly.

She truly had a most deceptive face. Looking at it while she slept, it appeared gentle and harmless in every way.

Yet, when she was up to no good, she wore the same honest and simple expression.

Sui Yuanqing... he must have been deceived by this very appearance, right?

At the thought of this person, Xie Zheng's eyes turned a few shades colder and deeper.

He couldn't quite describe the feeling. It was as if a wildflower in a field that he thought only he had taken a fancy to was now being coveted by someone else.

A spot over his heart felt as if it had been singed by a candle flame. It didn't hurt, but it burned with an unsettling heat.

He stared unblinkingly at the sleeping Fan Changyu, his eyes hidden in the dark of the night, their expression growing ever more inscrutable.

Perhaps sensing his gaze in her sleep, Fan Changyu mumbled in discontent, "Don't want it..."

Xie Zheng didn't hear clearly. He frowned and asked, "What?"

Fan Changyu replied with a mumble, not a single syllable clear. Xie Zheng had no choice but to lean his ear closer to listen.

The chill from his body made Fan Changyu instinctively shy away even in her sleep. As she turned, her lips brushed lightly against his ear. Xie Zheng's entire body stiffened.

Someone was too close. A strange presence enveloped her. After all she had been through, Fan Changyu was still somewhat vigilant. Her eyelashes trembled as she was about to wake. Xie Zheng's cool fingers pressed a point on the side of her neck. Before her eyelids could open, she sank back into a deep sleep.

Xie Zheng got up. Without even lighting a candle, he used the faint glow from the snow outside reflecting into the room to go to the table and pour himself two cups of cold tea, which he drank down.

After finishing the tea, he did not go back to the bed. He simply sat at the table, his brows knitted, his dark eyes staring unblinkingly at the raised curve on the bed, as if deep in thought.

The faint cry of an eagle seemed to come from the night sky.

He lifted his gaze and slipped out of the room almost silently. He vaulted over the wall of the Wang family's courtyard and walked to a more distant street before putting his knuckles to his lips and letting out a sharp whistle.

If a Gyr Falcon delivering a message couldn't find its recipient, it would circle and cry out in the air. Only upon hearing a whistle would it follow the sound and dive down.

In a few moments, a pure white Gyr Falcon swooped in from the night. Xie Zheng extended his right arm, and the Gyr Falcon's iron-hook-like talons gripped his forearm firmly. It flapped its wings to steady itself before folding them.

Xie Zheng took the letter from the Gyr Falcon's leg. After reading it by the moonlight, the paper in his fingertips turned to dust.

The Jizhou Prefecture yamen was also still lit this night.

When Zheng Wenchang came out of the main prison and presented the interrogated confession to He Jingyuan, he bowed his head and said, "It is indeed as you said, my lord. It was Changxin Wang's men who intercepted ours, disguised themselves as grain requisition officers, and went to Qingping County to collect grain. The dozens of lives in Majia Village were also the work of the rebels. This subordinate suspects that the incident in

Taizhou, where people were beaten to death during grain requisition, is likely also connected to the Chongzhou rebels."

He Jingyuan stood with his hands behind his back, gazing at the row of warm yellow lanterns under the eaves and the heavily falling snow. He answered with a non-sequitur, "Wen Chang, tell me, those two hundred thousand shi of grain, after passing through the hands of Merchant Zhao, where do you think they were sent?"

Zheng Wenchang didn't know why his superior and teacher had suddenly asked about the grain again. He answered truthfully, "This subordinate initially guessed it was for a merchant's profit, but during the grain requisitions in both Taizhou and Jizhou, we saw no sign of that merchant selling the two hundred thousand shi of grain at a high price. Based on the current situation, it does seem like the rebels are stirring up trouble. This subordinate believes that if we raid that Merchant Zhao, we will surely uncover several rebel strongholds."

He Jingyuan shook his head. "You are underestimating the enemy. Tomorrow, just you wait and see how many of the Zhao family's businesses you can still find in the entire Jizhou Prefecture."

Zheng Wenchang lowered his head in shame. "If this subordinate had noticed earlier and raided Merchant Zhao's home, such a major incident in Qingping County would not have happened."

He Jingyuan said, "It's not your fault. The rebels were able to exploit this opening, and I bear some responsibility. If I hadn't fallen for the rebels' trap, single-mindedly trying to force out the person who bought the grain and allowing Wei Xuan to forcibly collect it, the rebels wouldn't have been able to stir up such a storm in Jizhou, no matter how many spies they planted."

Zheng Wenchang didn't understand his meaning. Puzzled, he said, "My lord, how can you take all the blame upon yourself? As this subordinate sees it, the grain purchase was a trap set by the rebels from the very beginning. Wei Xuan is arrogant and eager for glory. He relied on his position as the Military Governor of the Northwest to seize your official seal. That was not something you could control."

He Jingyuan let out a long sigh and said nothing more.

This student of his was good in every way, except he was too upright and rigid. He believed whatever he saw.

There were many things he ultimately couldn't explain too clearly.

If that Merchant Zhao hadn't deliberately left a trail, leading him to guess that the two hundred thousand shi of grain were bought by the Wu'an Marquis, how could he have mistakenly believed that the Wu'an Marquis bought the grain just to trip up Wei Xuan?

In the struggles between those in power, it was always the common people at the bottom who suffered.

He had allowed Wei Xuan to requisition the grain because he wanted the Wu'an Marquis to see what the common people were paying for his personal vendetta. He also wanted to know if the Wu'an Marquis was the kind of person who would resort to any means to achieve his goals.

It was precisely this relinquishment of power that gave the rebels an opportunity.

With the people pushed to this point, the Wu'an Marquis had no choice but to "appear," having his old subordinates from Yanzhou send a military transfer order to move Wei Xuan away and stop the grain requisition.

He had operated from behind the scenes. Regardless of his motives, he had ultimately become a pusher in the rebels' plan.

Today, on his way to Qingzhou, when he saw the person in the blue devil mask who had turned the tide, a question suddenly occurred to He Jingyuan.

What if he had guessed wrong from the start? What if the Wu'an Marquis had never intended to use the people of Taizhou and Jizhou as bargaining chips to bring down Wei Xuan? Then why did he requisition those two hundred thousand shi of grain?

His long-closed eyes suddenly snapped open. "Jinzhou!" he said.

Zheng Wenchang was baffled. "My lord, what about Jinzhou?"

He Jingyuan strode quickly back to his desk, took out a map of the Northwest and spread it open. He pointed at Jinzhou, his expression uncharacteristically grave. "Changxin Wang has rebelled in Chongzhou, causing internal strife in the Northwest, and the Wu'an Marquis has died in battle. What does this mean for the Northern Turks beyond the pass?"

Zheng Wenchang thought through the implications, and a sudden shock of realisation struck him. He said, "This is the best opportunity to attack

the Great Yin."

He Jingyuan paced back and forth before the desk with his hands clasped behind him. "Jinzhou is the gateway to the Great Yin, with Huizhou and Yanzhou behind it, forming a triangle that secures the Great Yin's entrance. But its grain supplies must be allocated by the imperial court. With Chongzhou in rebellion, the grain supply line is cut off. Huizhou has no grain, so where would Jinzhou get any? I have been a fool! Those two hundred thousand shi of grain that were bought—they weren't to frame Wei Xuan at all. They were a precautionary measure for Jinzhou!"

Hearing He Jingyuan's words, Zheng Wenchang was also greatly shocked. Connecting this with his earlier words, he finally understood the key point. "You mean, those two hundred thousand shi of grain were bought by the Marquis? The Marquis, after being defeated on the Chongzhou battlefield, had already foreseen the danger Jinzhou would face in the future?"

He Jingyuan nodded slowly.

Zheng Wenchang said, "The Marquis's foresight is beyond our reach. Now that the rebels' treacherous plot has been foiled, Huizhou is secure, and Jinzhou has grain, this should be a joyous occasion. Why are you still frowning, my lord?"

He Jingyuan sighed. "If external threats and internal troubles pile up together, how can this situation be resolved?"

This question plunged Zheng Wenchang into a dilemma as well.

There were some things He Jingyuan didn't say.

Wei Yan's faction would surely not let the Wu'an Marquis live. Last time, they were able to tamper with things on the Chongzhou battlefield. This time, if the Northern Turks and the Chongzhou rebels attacked the Wu'an Marquis from both front and rear, and the imperial court deliberately withheld military provisions, he truly feared a repeat of the Jinzhou Massacre from seventeen years ago.

He Jingyuan stood with his hands behind his back for a long while before saying to Zheng Wenchang, "Continue to lock down Qingping County and strive to root out all the rebels' spies. The canal waterways are at a low level in winter, which is also a good time to clear out the silt. Wen Chang, once the matter in Qingping County is resolved, you will take men to dredge the waterway from Jizhou to Chongzhou."

If they could travel by water, any amount of goods could be transported.

Zheng Wenchang's heart leaped. He accepted the order and withdrew.

Only He Jingyuan was left in the study. The door to the side room was then pushed open, and an old man with a crane's white hair and chicken-like skin walked out. "Tell me, if that fellow surnamed Wei finds out you've been feigning compliance like this, how many days do you think you have left to live?"

He Jingyuan simply said, "In my position, I plan for its governance; in my office, I fulfill its duties. As long as I, He, have a clear conscience before the people of this world, it is enough."

The old man shook his head and chuckled. "The next time this old man comes looking for you for wine and chess, I can only hope you're still alive."

He Jingyuan said, "I will await Your Excellency, the Grand Tutor's, presence at any time. May I ask where the Grand Tutor plans to go next?"

The old man was dressed in ragged clothes, his white hair held up messily by a wooden pin. A wine gourd hung from his waist. He stretched and said, "That little brat Changxin Wang keeps sending people to my grass hut to disturb my peace every few days. It's terribly annoying. This old man will first wander around for a bit."

He Jingyuan lowered his eyelids and said, "I had thought the Grand Tutor came out of seclusion upon hearing that the Marquis had died on the battlefield."

The old man scoffed. "This old man doesn't have much ability, but in this lifetime, I've only taught this one disciple. The person in this world who can take his life has yet to be born. Otherwise, he would have to gain a junior martial brother."

He Jingyuan listened to the old man's words with a smile, saying nothing.

Grand Tutor Tao had retired from office and lived in seclusion for many years. After Changxin Wang rebelled, he had sent people to find him many times, saying he wanted to invite him to be an advisor, but in reality, he wanted him to teach his two sons.

The old man's last sentence meant that if he were to take another disciple, it would only be one whose aptitude surpassed the Wu'an

Marquis's.

It seemed that Changxin Wang's two sons had not caught his eye.

He Jingyuan asked, feigning ignorance, "After the battle of Chongzhou, the heir of Changxin Wang has been known as the 'Little Wu'an Marquis.' Did the Grand Tutor not take a fancy to him either?"

Grand Tutor Tao's expression soured. "When that brat was ten, a chess manual I taught him somehow ended up in the hands of Changxin Wang's youngest son. What do you think Changxin Wang is planning?"

He Jingyuan's expression grew somber. The Little Wu'an Marquis... was Changxin Wang raising his youngest son in the mold of the Wu'an Marquis?

Qingping County.

Fan Changyu woke up at the first crow of the rooster.

The sky was just beginning to lighten. She groggily turned over and rolled to the other side, only to be jolted awake by the startling cold of the bed.

Fan Changyu sat up, her hair a mess from sleep. She remembered clearly that she had shared the bed with Yan Zheng last night. She looked towards the table and, as expected, saw Yan Zheng sleeping there, propping his head up with his hand.

Judging by the temperature on this side of the bed, he probably hadn't slept on it all night.

Fan Changyu couldn't quite describe the feeling in her heart. Was it perhaps the annoyance of having her good intentions spurned?

Then she wondered why she was angry. He was being so proper; she should be happy and think of him as a gentleman.

While she was still wrestling with her thoughts, the person dozing with his head in his hand also woke at the sound of the rooster. His eyes met Fan Changyu's. He paused for a moment before saying calmly, "You're awake?"

Fan Changyu nodded, scratching her hair. "If I'd known, we would have just gone back to town last night. I made you stay up all night again."

Xie Zheng said, "I got up during the night. Seeing that it was almost dawn, I didn't go back to sleep."

Fan Changyu gave a vague hum in response, not wanting to argue with him too much on the matter.

It was just a simple matter of catching up on sleep. He could do as he pleased. It wasn't her who had been freezing and sleepless all night, anyway.

After having breakfast at Head Constable Wang's house, Fan Changyu took Yu Bao'er and returned to town with Xie Zheng.

Changning had slept with Aunt Zhao last night. She almost burst into tears upon seeing Fan Changyu return, but when she saw Yu Bao'er, she was afraid of losing face and managed to hold her tears back.

With the two children together, they had company and were so boisterous they nearly tore the roof down. The only thing that gave Fan Changyu some comfort was that Yu Bao'er no longer mentioned looking for her mother, and Changning seemed to have forgotten about the Gyrfalcon.

Qingping County was still under lockdown to catch the remaining rebel accomplices. However, Head Constable Wang sent someone to her house with a secret reward of fifty taels of silver from the county magistrate.

That day at the magistrate's residence, she had claimed to be one of Head Constable Wang's people. It seemed the magistrate, after taking the credit, was giving her this benefit to win her over.

Fan Changyu deeply understood the principle of getting rich quietly. Fame was useless to her and would only attract trouble; it was not as practical as real gold and silver.

After seeing the official off, Fan Changyu went smilingly into the room to hide the silver. Bumping into Xie Zheng, she said generously, "Half for you?"

It was one thing for this guy to want to draw a clear line between them, but he was the one who came up with the idea to save Qingping County, and he had saved her on the city wall. The accounts still had to be settled clearly.

Xie Zheng just felt that in the two days since they returned, Fan Changyu had become much more distant towards him.

When she saw him, she would still smile and greet him as before, but one could clearly feel that it was different from before.

He suppressed the inexplicable displeasure in his heart and asked, "Does the government know my identity?"

Fan Changyu shook her head. "I didn't tell anyone who you are. The magistrate wants to take all the credit and didn't even mention Head Constable Wang's name, so I doubt he'd bring you up on his own."

She herself was unwilling to be exposed, afraid of being marked by that group of people. Since Yan Zheng had even worn a mask when he appeared on the city wall, Fan Changyu guessed he definitely didn't want to reveal his identity either.

After all, offending those officials would only bring them endless trouble.

Xie Zheng then said, "This reward money is all yours. Why should you split it with me?"

Fan Changyu said, "Wasn't it your idea?"

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes. "The reward money the magistrate gave you wasn't because you defended the city gate. It was because you saved him from his predicament and tied up the rebel. It has little to do with me."

Fan Changyu couldn't win the argument against him. After taking the silver back to her room, she came out a moment later holding a pile of things. "You said before that you were leaving, but you only stayed these extra few days because the county was sealed. I've been gradually preparing some things for you. Take these two sets of clothes to change into on the road. These shoes are double-stitched and durable. Oh, and I also exchanged fifty taels for silver notes for you. It'll be more convenient for you to carry..."

She chattered on like an old mother sending her wandering son on a long journey. "I've also written the divorce papers. All that's left is for you to press your fingerprint."

A letter of repudiation only required one party's signature, but a divorce was different from a repudiation. It was an amicable end to the marriage, so both parties had to sign and press their fingerprints.

The stuffiness that had been stuck in Xie Zheng's chest these past few days grew even more uncomfortable when he heard her talk about these things.

He leaned against the doorframe with his arms crossed, watching her for a moment. Then he suddenly smiled and said caustically, "I'm so grateful you've been this thoughtful for me."

Fan Changyu didn't bicker with him, only saying, "Being out on the road isn't like being at home. It's best to be as prepared as possible. If you run into any trouble out there, there won't be anyone to help you..."

An inexplicable emotion churned in his chest, and the caustic smile on Xie Zheng's face could no longer hold. He looked away at the accumulated snow on the courtyard wall and suddenly asked, "What about you? What are your plans for the future?"

Fan Changyu found it amusing. "Didn't you ask that before? As long as Qingping County can remain peaceful, I'm planning to set up the pigsty..."

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes half-lifted. "I mean, are you planning to marry someone, or continue to have a man marry into your family?"

This question stumped Fan Changyu. She put the pile of things on the table, walked to the steps by the door and sat down. She looked at the pear tree in the courtyard, which had lost all its leaves, and thought for a while before saying, "I'll definitely get married. As for whether I'll marry out or have a man marry in, we'll see when the time comes."

Xie Zheng fiddled with a small pebble, tossing it nonchalantly at the pear tree, startling away a few sparrows perched on it. "What kind do you like? If no one marries you in the future, and no one marries into your family, I can look around for you."

Hearing him mock her, Fan Changyu couldn't help but get annoyed. "Definitely not someone with a foul temper like you! With a mouth as nasty as yours, you should be worrying about whether you can find a wife yourself!"

Xie Zheng sat down, one leg bent, a mocking smile playing on his lips. "I wouldn't marry someone like you either. I need to marry a gentle, virtuous wife who knows how to manage a household."

The last pebble in his hand was thrown particularly far, flying over the courtyard wall and landing somewhere unknown.

Fan Changyu glanced at his exquisite profile, then lowered her eyes and tugged at the corner of her lips. She said frankly, "I like someone gentle and refined. Preferably someone who has read many books, is learned,

humble, good-tempered, and loves to smile. My mother used to say when she was alive that my personality is too boisterous, and I need someone more gentle to keep me in check for the days to last."

A trace of inexplicable bitterness rose in her heart. Fan Changyu thought it was probably because she was reminded of her mother.

She said, "We've been through thick and thin for so long, after all. You're about to leave, so don't curse me to be unwanted in the future. I'll wish you to marry a gentle and virtuous wife, and you can wish me to find a gentle and refined husband!"

Xie Zheng said, "Alright."

His smile was truly beautiful.

When he stood up, he even kindly offered a hand to Fan Changyu. Having sat for a long time, her leg was a bit numb. Seeing the hand he offered, she didn't think much and placed her hand on it.

The change happened in that instant. Fan Changyu was pulled by a tremendous force, stumbling into his embrace. The grip on her uninjured wrist was so strong it felt as if it would snap her wrist in two.

He seized her jaw, lowered his head, and almost brutally sealed her lips with his.

Chapter 53

Fan Changyu was stunned.

She only snapped back to her senses when a sharp pain came from her lips. Humiliated and angry, her other hand instinctively swung toward his face, but as if he had anticipated it, he easily intercepted her hand, pulling her more forcefully toward him. His hard chest and a pair of iron-like arms bound her tightly.

Fan Changyu had never been treated like this before. She struggled with brute force, but he neutralized her efforts with skillful leverage.

In her fury, she put all her strength into her teeth. As she bit down, Xie Zheng hissed softly. When they separated, there was blood on his lip. He frowned. "You—"

Before he could finish, Fan Changyu had already slammed her head forward, her forehead hitting his nose squarely. A dull ache spread from the bridge of his nose, forcing him to release one hand to cover it. In the next instant, Fan Changyu's free hand landed a vicious punch on the corner of his eye.

Though in pain, Xie Zheng did not let go of her other hand. He yanked her backward, twisted her arms behind her back, and pinned her against the wall, pressing his body against her. His tone was somewhat cold. "Are you that aggrieved?"

Fan Changyu wanted to bite him to death. Her previously injured wrist made it impossible for her to break free from his hold for the moment.

She cursed, "What madness has gotten into you? If you're looking for a woman, the brothels are full of them willing to do business with you. What kind of person do you take me for?"

Xie Zheng's head snapped up, his dark eyes deep and gloomy. "Is that what you think of me?"

Pinned and unable to move, Fan Changyu was so humiliated and furious that sparks nearly flew from her eyes. "What do you think you were just doing? Taking advantage of my predicament!"

Xie Zheng was probably so incensed that he let out a low laugh. "Taking advantage of your predicament? If I truly wanted to take advantage of you, I wouldn't have waited until now."

He released her and took a step back, the curve of his lips cold. "You just can't let go of that ex-fiancé of yours, can you? Any man you find in the future has to be similar to him? Have you learned nothing at all?"

Having just been taken advantage of by him, hearing his sarcastic, lecturing tone now made her heart burn with rage. Before she knew it, she had swung another punch at his face. "Whether I can let go or not, what does it have to do with you?"

Xie Zheng neither dodged nor evaded, taking the full force of her powerful punch. The corner of his lip split open, and the flush that spread across half his face was unexpectedly bewitching against his jade-like features.

After landing the punch, Fan Changyu herself was taken aback. She knew exactly how much force she had put into it.

Why... why didn't he dodge?

Xie Zheng pressed his tongue against the cut on his lip, tasting a faint metallic flavor. He turned his head to look at Fan Changyu and asked, "Aren't you going to continue?"

Fan Changyu couldn't describe the feeling in her heart at that moment. Her knuckles still ached faintly; his face must be in a worse state.

But he had done such a thing to her, and she couldn't bring herself to apologize. She pressed her lips together tightly and turned to go back into the house.

But unexpectedly, the man who was a step away closed the distance like a phantom. Fan Changyu only saw his alarmingly dark eyes before he cupped the back of her head and kissed her again.

A jolt of alarm passed through her. Having lost the initiative, she found herself constrained at every turn. In the struggle, she was pressed against the wall. He seized both her hands and held them above her head, using his superior size to pin her down. As he lowered his head, his breath, unlike its usual light scent, fanned across her face. The kiss was even more savage and rough than the last.

Fan Changyu bit him hard in a fit of rage, but he quickly clamped down on her jaw. Using some unknown trick, he prevented her from biting down again. Yet he had no intention of retreating. Instead, he used the opportunity to force her teeth apart, sweeping his tongue inside her mouth several times.

When it was over, Fan Changyu was panting unevenly. Her mind, momentarily starved of oxygen, forgot to punch him again. She could only stare at him in disbelief.

Xie Zheng released her, wiped the blood from his lips with his forefinger, and said, "Now, this is taking advantage of your predicament."

The fury of being offended and violated shot straight to Fan Changyu's head. The moment Xie Zheng released his hold on her and stepped back, she drew the boning knife she always carried and pressed it to his neck. "Who do you think you are, that you can humiliate me as you please?"

Xie Zheng leaned casually against a wooden pillar. Even with a knife at his throat, his expression remained unchanged. Only when he heard her words did he raise his eyes, his expression uncharacteristically serious. "Instead of having poor judgment and finding another ingrate in the future, you might as well be with me."

The moment these words were spoken, not only Fan Changyu but Xie Zheng himself was slightly stunned. This was immediately followed by the numbing pleasure of reason being forcibly shattered.

That's right. Instead of her marrying someone else in the future, wouldn't it be better to keep her by his side?

Having made the opening, the words that followed seemed to come more easily. He fell silent for a moment, then said slowly, "I have a very powerful enemy out there. I might die at his hands, or he might die and I might live. If you're willing, wait for me for two years. If I die, someone will come to deliver a message to you. It won't be too late for you to remarry then."

Fan Changyu stared at him coldly. "You keep calling Song Yan an ingrate, but how are you any better than him? You take liberties with me, and then you tell me you have feelings for me?"

She sheathed her knife. The anger of being violated temporarily overshadowed all other emotions. She raised her sleeve and wiped her lips

forcefully. "I hit you, so we can consider it even. The things are on the table. As soon as the city gates are unsealed, you should leave."

Xie Zheng watched her retreating back as she returned to the house, unable to even muster a cold, sharp curve on his lips.

So, he had been rejected?

A man who had only ever suffered one defeat in his life, on the battlefields of Chongzhou, had now tasted defeat in another arena.

He didn't take the things from the table in the main hall. He stood leaning against a porch pillar for a while before leaving the Fan family's courtyard.

Because of the recent siege by the rebels of Qingping County, and the current martial law imposed by the authorities, the streets of Lin'an Town were desolate. There were almost no farmers from the countryside coming to the market.

Xie Zheng wandered aimlessly to the pine forest by the river outside of town. The ground was covered in a foot of snow. The river, fed by the undulating terrain, flowed swiftly. The thin layer of ice that had just formed on its surface the previous night had already shattered, and only the tinkling sound of a mountain spring could be heard.

He lay down on a gentle slope in the snow, pillowing one arm behind his head, and stared blankly at the distant, faint outline of Lin'an Town.

He hadn't panicked when he was plotted against and on the brink of death on the Chongzhou battlefield. He hadn't felt fear when he luckily escaped with his life, pursued by martial assassins for over a hundred li. After falling off a cliff and being carried by the river to Jizhou, he had woken up on the riverbank, endured his many sword wounds, high fever, and the cold to search for a village, only to collapse in a field and be picked up by that woman.

Back then, all he had been plotting was how to stabilize the situation in the northwest and then, step by step, exact his revenge on the Wei family.

When did he start to become reluctant to leave?

That small house was always bustling with noise, full of the warmth of life. He had seen too many spines bent by hardship, but that woman, even if the sky were to fall, would straighten her slender back to bear it.

Perhaps... it had just been too long since anyone had been so purely good to him?

The tangerine peel candy when he drank his medicine, the red envelope for the New Year... A mocking smile crept onto Xie Zheng's lips. For a moment, the phrase "wagging his tail for pity" came to mind.

She was probably just too kind-hearted. Even if it hadn't been him she saved that day, but anyone else, she would have cared for them just as diligently, buying candy, preparing a New Year red envelope...

She was good to him because he was pitiful, not because she had any romantic feelings for him.

His words, "be with me," had truly become a joke.

A man who had been proud for half his life was not quite willing to admit to this joke of a failure.

In the sky, a gyrfalcon circled, crying out as if searching for someone.

This time, Xie Zheng did not whistle for a long while. He turned his head slightly and saw, near the riverbank where most of the snow had melted, a tender green sprout had broken through the snow. It stood, emerald green, amidst the vast whiteness.

Ice melts, spring streams flow; snow thaws, grass sprouts grow.

This was the New Year couplet he had written for her.

He watched it for a while, then lowered his gaze and sat up halfway. He plucked the sprout, tossed it into the rushing current, and silently watched as the river swept it away.

If his heart was in turmoil, he just had to pluck it out.

The gyrfalcon circling in the sky finally spotted him. As it swooped down, Xie Zheng did not raise his hand to receive it. The gyrfalcon landed and stood for a moment. Seeing that Xie Zheng did not retrieve the message, it tilted its head to look at him, then walked closer and gently pecked the back of his hand with its beak.

Xie Zheng raised his hand and smoothed the feathers on the gyrfalcon's head, his gaze still fixed on the distant current. After a long while, he finally took the paper from its leg.

He scanned it quickly. The paper turned to dust in his fingertips. He took one last look at the distant Lin'an Town and said, "Let's go. It's time to go back."

Jizhou.

An urgent report from Jinzhou was delivered to the Jizhou Prefecture yamen. All the officials who read it were greatly alarmed.

"The Northern Turks have really attacked Jinzhou!"

"Thankfully, the Wu'an Marquis did not perish in Chongzhou. With the Wu'an Marquis guarding Jinzhou, the Northern Turk barbarians will probably be terrified at the mere mention of his name!"

Seated at the head of the council hall, He Jingyuan's face was as grim as water. Before he could say a word, another guard reported from outside the hall, "Lucheng is in peril! Changxin Wang's general, Guo Xinhou, is leading fifty thousand troops to besiege Lucheng!"

At these words, the officials in the hall erupted into an even greater uproar.

How long had it been since the Changxin Wang's heir, with a group of martial assassins disguised as farmers, had instigated the people of Qingping County to rebel?

If the rebellion in Qingping County had not been suppressed and the common people had truly revolted, Lucheng, being the first line of military defense bordering Chongzhou, would have been caught between two fires, with Qingping County right behind it.

An official cursed, "This is clearly a premeditated plot by the rebels! With Jinzhou in peril, the Wu'an Marquis's heavy troops stationed in Huizhou will surely be transferred to Jinzhou, leaving him with no strength to deal with the rebels! The rebels are trying to use this opportunity to swallow up the northwest!"

A military official said, "The urgent matter at hand is that the rebels are already at the gates of Lucheng. We must figure out how to defend Jizhou."

If Lucheng fell, Jizhou would lose its shield.

Amidst the clamor, He Jingyuan said, "Guo Xinhou is a veteran general, skilled in the art of war. I will personally go to Lucheng to oversee the defense."

"Your Excellency, you absolutely must not! Lucheng is perilous right now. The rebels have fifty thousand troops pressing down, while Lucheng has only twenty thousand. If any harm should befall you, we would be guilty beyond redemption!"

Amidst a chorus of "you must nots," He Jingyuan raised his hand, signaling the officials to say no more. He said, "Is it perilous for me to go, but not for the soldiers defending Lucheng? If I go, the rebels will be wary of me, and Lucheng will actually be less perilous. This will also give you all enough time to conscript more soldiers from the populace."

As soon as the meeting concluded, cavalymen with conscription orders galloped toward the various prefectures and counties.

Lin'an Town.

Fan Changyu had been stewing in anger all afternoon because of Xie Zheng's insolence.

She opened the book on the table, hoping to distract herself, but when she saw the densely packed annotations in small characters, a lump of frustration lodged in her chest, unable to go up or down.

All the annotations in this book were written by him during those nights he stayed up late.

As her anger slowly subsided, the thought of him saying he might die at his enemy's hands left a sour taste in her mouth.

Had he been saying he had to leave all this time because he was burdened by a great feud?

She walked out of her room. Passing through the main hall, she saw that the pile of things she had prepared for him was still on the table. The divorce papers were there too. Both copies only had her name on them; he hadn't signed or stamped them. Her feelings grew even more complicated.

Changning and Yu Bao'er had gone out to play with the other children in the alley and hadn't returned yet.

Fan Changyu walked to the door of the south room. After a moment's hesitation, she knocked.

There was no answer from within.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together, knocked twice more, and called out, "Yan Zheng, are you there?"

She was met with silence again.

Thinking that she had spoken harshly in her anger and that Yan Zheng might have left without a word, Fan Changyu pushed the door open forcefully. When she saw that none of his personal belongings had been taken, her heart finally settled back into place.

So he had probably just gone out to clear his head?

Fan Changyu closed the door and was about to return to her room when she heard a clamor of crying and shouting, mixed with the curses of soldiers, from outside the alley.

"Sir! Sir! He's my only son! Please have pity on us, mother and son..."

"The rebels are about to attack Jizhou! If the young men don't go to the battlefield, are we to wait for the rebels to come and slaughter everyone in Jizhou?"

Fan Changyu's heart skipped a beat. She opened the courtyard gate to look out and saw armored soldiers with sharp weapons barging into houses one by one to seize the men.

The one sitting on the ground, wailing for all she was worth, was Kang Popo.

She clung to her son and wouldn't let go, but she was no match for the strength of several able-bodied soldiers. Her son was dragged away by them.

Kang Popo howled, "My son, don't be afraid! I'll go to the Song family and find Scholar Song. I'll have him plead with the county magistrate to let you come back."

The moment Fan Changyu saw that these soldiers were wearing the uniforms of the Jizhou Prefecture army, she knew that pleading with the county magistrate would be useless, unless the magistrate was willing to humble himself and cozy up to the officer in charge of conscription, offering some benefits.

She immediately began to worry about Yan Zheng.

Once conscripted, they could only return home when the war was over. More likely, they would die on the battlefield, perhaps without even a place for their bones to be buried.

The children playing outside saw the commotion and no longer dared to be mischievous, each running back to their own homes.

Changning led Yu Bao'er to their gate, and they both hid behind Fan Changyu, peeking out with only half their heads, timidly watching the soldiers who had stormed into the alley.

Changning looked up at Fan Changyu nervously and asked, "Big Sister, Yanzi's big brother was taken by those soldiers. Will they take Brother-in-law too?"

Fan Changyu had no answer. This was also the first time she had witnessed a conscription.

She had heard from Aunt Zhao that one could pay silver to avoid conscription, but this time it didn't seem to be an option.

She herded the two children into the courtyard, saying, "You two go inside first."

She had just closed the courtyard gate when the platoon leader from the alley arrived at her gate with the soldiers.

According to the dynasty's laws, the populace was organized into squads of five households and platoons of ten. Taxes and conscription were carried out based on these units of ten neighboring households. If anyone harbored a fugitive, all ten households would be held jointly responsible.

The platoon leader looked embarrassed as he reported Fan Changyu's household situation truthfully to the soldier: "This is the head of this household. Her surname is Fan, name is Changyu. She has a live-in husband."

The soldier was surprised to hear he was a live-in husband. Seeing only Fan Changyu outside and the courtyard gate shut tight, his expression soured. He barked, "Where is your husband?"

Fan Changyu's lips tightened. If she said at this moment that she and Yan Zheng were already divorced, but Yan Zheng hadn't yet put his fingerprint on the divorce papers in the house, she would undoubtedly be pushing the other nine households into a fiery pit.

But if she let Yan Zheng be taken away, it would be an undeserved disaster for him.

After careful consideration, Fan Changyu answered truthfully, "He is not at home."

The soldier seemed accustomed to this excuse. With a hostile expression, he raised his foot to kick the door. The soldier next to him, holding a register, was apparently literate. He had already found Fan Changyu's entry in the Lin'an Town roster and quickly stopped his companion. "Wait."

He looked at the roster again, then at Fan Changyu. "Fan Changyu, is that right?"

Fan Changyu replied, neither servile nor overbearing, "That is I."

The literate soldier said to his companion, "Her husband is already on the conscription list. He must have been among the batch we rounded up on the road just now."

Fan Changyu's heart pounded wildly. She asked quickly, "My husband has already been taken away? Sir, are you sure you're not mistaken?"

The literate soldier glanced at the roster and said, "Isn't your husband named Yan Zheng?"

Hearing that name, Fan Changyu's last shred of hope vanished.

She said in a hoarse voice, "That is my husband."

The platoon leader led the soldiers to knock on the next door. Fan Changyu sank to the ground by her courtyard gate, her hands and feet cold.

With Yan Zheng's skills, the soldiers couldn't have stopped him if he wanted to leave.

He had read so many books and was well-versed in the law. He must have willingly let the soldiers take him away because he was afraid of implicating the other nine neighboring households, right?

Fan Changyu thought of the pile of things she had prepared on the table in the house, and their recent unhappy parting. A heavy, suffocating feeling grew in her chest, a mix of guilt and something else.

She sat numbly for a moment, then, as if remembering something, she raised her head and asked the soldier who was knocking on the next door, "Sir, where is my husband now? Can I see him one more time? He was taken away while he was out, and I want to give him some things."

The soldier glanced at Fan Changyu and said, "The batch rounded up on the road has already been escorted to the county town. They're about to head to Lucheng with the main army. If you hurry now, there's no telling if you'll be able to catch up."

Upon hearing this, Fan Changyu said her thanks, entrusted Changning and Yu Bao'er to a neighbor, rushed into the house to grab the bundle of things from the table, stuffed two more bags of tangerine peel candy inside, and hurried off toward the county town.

Finding the ox-cart too slow, she borrowed a horse from someone. But when she reached the county town gate, she was still a step too late. The first batch of conscripts from the county had already left for Lucheng with the garrison.

Except for those on the conscription list, unauthorized people were still not allowed to enter or leave Qingping County easily.

The snow was falling heavily. Fan Changyu stood at the city gate, holding the large bundle and leading the horse, gazing at the official road that stretched into the distance beyond the gate's archway.

Her chest felt terribly tight. She led the horse and walked back without a word.

On the way, someone bumped into her, and the contents of her bundle scattered all over the ground. Fan Changyu silently picked them up one by one. When she got to the two bags of tangerine peel candy, she picked one up and put it in her mouth.

It's a good thing I didn't catch up, she thought. These two bags of candy I bought are too sour, not as sweet as the previous ones.

Even if I had given them to Yan Zheng, he probably wouldn't have liked them.

After gathering her things, as Fan Changyu hung the bundle on the saddle, she rested her head against it for a long while.

How did it end like this?

She was angry with him, but he had been conscripted and taken away without even a single word of farewell. She couldn't help but feel that she owed him.

On her way back to town, she happened upon the second batch of soldiers escorting newly conscripted men to the county town.

Family members followed, weeping and wailing, while the conscripts, their own eyes red, repeatedly told their families to stop following.

Fan Changyu noticed that the elderly Carpenter Zhao was also in the crowd.

She couldn't help but call out, "Uncle Zhao, why are you going to Lucheng too?"

Carpenter Zhao's old face was wrinkled with bitterness. "I blame this old man for choosing the wrong trade. A veterinarian in my youth, a carpenter in my old age. Those military sirs said that in the army, I can treat warhorses and also build siege equipment."

The soldiers brandished their whips, urging the crowd to move faster.

Fearing that Uncle Zhao, at his age, would die of exhaustion just from the journey, Fan Changyu hesitated for a moment before saying, "Uncle Zhao, take this horse!"

When the soldier saw Fan Changyu approaching, he was about to shoo her away, but upon hearing she was giving a horse, he immediately turned a blind eye.

A horse was a valuable asset. It could carry a person or goods, and if they were attacked, riding a horse could mean a faster escape and a chance to save one's life.

Carpenter Zhao refused. "This horse is so valuable, how could I?"

Fan Changyu handed the horse's reins to Carpenter Zhao. "Please take it. The things in the bundle are for Yan Zheng. I didn't catch up to him. Uncle Zhao, if you see Yan Zheng in Lucheng, please help me give these things to him."

Hearing this, Carpenter Zhao no longer refused. He felt sorry for the young couple and said, "Don't you worry. As long as this old bag of bones is still alive, I will definitely deliver the things to him for you."

Fan Changyu watched Carpenter Zhao walk away before heading back to town on foot. She took out some silver to pay for the horse.

When she went to Aunt Zhao's house to pick up Changning and Yu Bao'er, Aunt Zhao, upon hearing that Fan Changyu had bought a horse for

Carpenter Zhao, wept as she expressed her gratitude.

If a conscript brought his own horse, it was considered the soldier's private property. In the military camp, they would most likely be assigned to the cavalry.

Even if their physique was weaker and they couldn't join the cavalry, they wouldn't be treated poorly.

After comforting Aunt Zhao for a while, Fan Changyu took Changning and Yu Bao'er home. The two children, perhaps because someone was missing from the house, were no longer boisterous. Enveloped in this silence, Fan Changyu felt more and more that the house had become strangely cold and empty.

How strange. It wasn't as if Yan Zheng was a talkative person.

Why was it that now that he was gone, everything suddenly felt different?

Fan Changyu went to the south room to tidy up. She found that the desk he had used was very neat, requiring almost no cleaning from her.

On the corner of the desk lay a pair of leather vambraces, alongside tools like files, with a sheet of paper tucked beneath them.

Judging by the size, they didn't seem to belong to Yan Zheng.

Fan Changyu picked up the paper and saw only eight words written on it: "Happy birthday, everlasting joy and no sorrow."

Memories of Yan Zheng asking about her birthday flooded her mind, and suddenly the vambraces in her hands felt as heavy as a thousand pounds.

She lowered her gaze to examine them closely and noticed that one appeared to have been meticulously refitted—when fastened around her wrist, the leather fit perfectly.

As she tried to unbuckle the vambraces, whether due to her trembling hands or the lingering ache in her knuckles from punching Yan Zheng earlier, she struggled several times without success.

Giving up, she leaned back in the chair, staring blankly at the vambraces on her hands, feeling an inexplicable emptiness in her chest.

Chapter 54

Due to the conscription, the already declining Lin'an Town saw its market become even less lively than before.

The New Year had passed, and apart from weddings and funerals, almost no households were slaughtering pigs, leaving Fan Changyu with a sudden abundance of free time.

The meat market was also sluggish, with many butcher shops temporarily closing. Since Qingping County wasn't far from Lu City, many people were anxious. Some well-informed wealthy merchants had even begun selling their properties and fleeing south.

For the past two days, Fan Changyu had been at home taking care of the two children. Though she hadn't read much, she was familiar with texts like the Three Character Classic and Thousand Character Classic and had planned to teach Changning and Yu Bao'er how to read.

Unexpectedly, despite his young age, Yu Bao'er already recognized quite a few characters. When he gripped a charcoal stick and wrote on the ground, his characters looked surprisingly well-formed.

Changning usually outperformed Yu Bao'er in everything else, and when they played together, Yu Bao'er always listened to her. But now, discovering that this seemingly slow-witted kid was better at reading and writing than her, Changning grew indignant. She stopped thinking about play and pestered Fan Changyu to teach her instead.

Yu Bao'er was eager to help: "If you want to learn, I can teach you."

Changning tugged at Fan Changyu's sleeve and snorted. "I won't learn from you! My sister will teach me. Once she's taught me all the words she knows, my brother-in-law will teach me too, and then I'll be even better than you!"

Fan Changyu was flipping through the Three Character Classic to teach Changning the day's characters when she suddenly froze at the mention of Yan Zheng.

So many days had passed—had the conscripts reached Lu City yet? Tens of thousands had been drafted this time, and Carpenter Zhao had gone as a veterinarian and carpenter. If Yan Zheng was assigned to the infantry, Carpenter Zhao's chances of running into him would be slim.

If he was selected for the cavalry, though, Carpenter Zhao might have a better chance of finding news of him.

Noticing Fan Changyu's prolonged silence, Changning gently shook her sleeve. "Sister, what's wrong?"

Fan Changyu collected herself. "It's nothing. Come, let's learn these five characters today..."

Writing brushes, ink, paper, and inkstones were expensive, so Fan Changyu didn't let the children waste them. Instead, she had them practice writing with charcoal on a clean stone slab.

While Changning focused on her writing, Fan Changyu slowly opened the Four Books with Yan Zheng's detailed annotations. She started with the Analects. Since Yan Zheng had already taught her two sections and the text was thoroughly annotated, she didn't find it too difficult.

At noon, someone knocked on the Fan family's gate.

Fan Changyu went to answer and, seeing it was Yu Qianqian, warmly invited her inside.

Yu Qianqian wore a dark cloak. Though she smiled, she looked weary. "Changyu, I'm in a hurry today, so I won't come in. I'm here to take Bao'er back."

Hearing his mother's voice, Yu Bao'er had already run out from the courtyard, hugging Yu Qianqian's leg and looking up joyfully. "Mama!"

Yu Qianqian patted the child's head and said to Fan Changyu, "Thank you so much for looking after Bao'er all this time."

Fan Changyu quickly brushed it off.

Not seeing Xie Zheng, Yu Qianqian asked, "Was your husband conscripted to Lu City the other day?"

Fan Changyu confirmed it and again invited Yu Qianqian inside, but she politely declined once more.

She looked at Fan Changyu and hesitated slightly before saying, "Sister Changyu, to be honest with you, all the wealthy merchants in Qingping County are already making arrangements to move their assets south. I've also sold off my two Overflowing Fragrance Pavilions at a discount and have secured passage through the city gates. At dusk, my family and I will leave for Jiangnan. It's still uncertain whether Lucheng can hold out. Sister Changyu, come with me to Jiangnan. If you're worried about your husband, you can return to Qingping County after the war is over."

Fan Changyu finally understood why Yu Qianqian seemed in such a hurry. After a moment's hesitation, she politely declined, "Thank you for your kindness, but there are still many matters at home I haven't settled. If I leave abruptly and the government issues any new tax or grain requisition orders, the nine households in this alley who are connected to me will suffer."

Neighboring households were not allowed to relocate freely. Even if they wanted to move, they had to go through the cumbersome process of obtaining relocation documents from the authorities.

After the murders in her home, she had planned to take Changning elsewhere to lay low, but dealing with property and paperwork had delayed her for days. By the time the authorities closed the case, the documents still hadn't been processed. When she decided not to live in hiding anymore, the matter was temporarily shelved.

Yu Qianqian knew how difficult it was for ordinary families to obtain such documents, especially with the city still under lockdown. Merchants like her had to bribe officials heavily to get the necessary paperwork under the pretext of trade missions.

She squeezed Fan Changyu's hand tightly and said, "I'm just a merchant. I can't take others with me, but if you're willing to come, meet me at the city gate at dusk today."

Fan Changyu nodded, "I understand your kindness."

But she truly couldn't leave now. Aside from the complicated relocation process, Carpenter Zhao had already been conscripted, leaving only Aunt Zhao behind. She couldn't abandon Aunt Zhao, who was like a grandmother to her and Changning.

Seeing that she couldn't persuade Fan Changyu, Yu Qianqian didn't press further. She turned to Yu Bao'er and said, "Bao'er, say goodbye to

Aunt Changyu and Sister Changning."

Yu Bao'er knew Yu Qianqian had come to pick him up but didn't expect they would be leaving Qingping County altogether. He looked at Fan Changyu and said, "Goodbye, Aunt Changyu."

Then he glanced at Changning, who was clutching Fan Changyu's skirt, and added, "I'll teach you to read later."

Changning retorted defiantly, "I'll definitely know more characters than you!"

The children's bickering made Fan Changyu and Yu Qianqian laugh, easing the sadness of parting.

Fan Changyu held Changning's hand as she escorted Yu Qianqian and her son to the carriage outside the alley.

Just as Yu Bao'er was about to board, he suddenly ran back, took off a jade pendant hanging around his neck, and handed it to Changning. "This is for you."

Fan Changyu quickly protested, "This is too valuable," turning to Yu Qianqian.

Yu Qianqian smiled gently and said, "Let Ning Niang keep it. This child is too lonely. Whenever he has to part with a playmate, he can't bear it and gives them his favorite things. It's his way of expressing his feelings."

Only after Fan Changyu nodded did Changning accept the pendant.

She tugged at her clothes and said to Yu Bao'er, "But I don't have anything to give you."

Yu Bao'er pointed to a grasshopper woven from straw hanging on her small pouch and said, "I want this one."

Changning had been raised by Fan Changyu for the most part and was often quite simple-hearted. She had never seen jade before and didn't know how valuable it was, though it did look pretty with its white, translucent glow.

But she also really liked the straw grasshopper. After a brief moment of hesitation, Changning decided that Yu Bao'er seemed to genuinely adore the little grasshopper, so she untied it and handed it to him.

She said, "This was woven for me by Uncle Zhao before he was taken away. Uncle Zhao has gone to the army now, and no one will make grasshoppers for me anymore. You must take good care of it. If you ever don't want it anymore, bring it back to me, and we can trade it for your little pendant."

Yu Bao'er replied, "I'll keep it safe."

Still too small to climb into the carriage by himself, Yu Qianqian lifted him up. As she did, her wide sleeves slipped down slightly, revealing the pair of broad jade bracelets on her wrists, which also slid a little lower.

Fan Changyu noticed what looked like rope marks on Yu Qianqian's wrists.

Guessing they were left from her time in prison, Fan Changyu frowned, her heart aching for Yu Qianqian.

When Yu Qianqian turned back to bid farewell, she noticed Fan Changyu staring at her wrists. Her smile faltered for a moment before she instinctively covered the marks with her sleeve and continued, "Then we'll be off."

Unaware of the moment, Fan Changyu simply smiled and said, "Have a safe journey."

Only after Yu Qianqian had boarded the carriage did the driver urge the horses forward.

As Fan Changyu walked home with Changning, she noticed the girl kept her head down, occasionally kicking small pebbles with the tips of her shoes, clearly in low spirits.

When Fan Changyu crouched down, she saw Changning's eyes were red.

"Missing Bao'er?" Fan Changyu asked.

Changning nodded, then shook her head, her voice thick with sadness. "Sunsun is gone, Brother-in-law is gone, Uncle Zhao is gone too... Ning Niang misses them..."

Fan Changyu pulled her sister into a hug, gently patting her back, feeling a pang of melancholy herself.

She said, "Once the war is over, they'll come back."

Hundreds of miles away, in Lu City.

He Jingyuan had just arrived at the city gates with the newly recruited soldiers when he encountered a contingent from Yanzhou. The leader, spotting him from afar, grinned and clasped his hands in greeting, his fox-like eyes brimming with cunning. "Lord He."

Seeing the man dressed in white robes, as handsome as an actor on stage, He Jingyuan couldn't help but frown.

The Lu City general who had come to greet He Jingyuan explained, "This is Gongsun, a strategist under the Wu'an Marquis. He arrived in Lu City not long ago, claiming Yanzhou's defenses are weak and requesting reinforcements from us."

He Jingyuan's expression darkened instantly. "The rebels have 50,000 troops surrounding Lu City. How can we spare any forces for Yanzhou?"

The Lu City general broke into a cold sweat. "They say this Gongsun is a genius, but I have no idea what he's scheming. I already used the siege as an excuse, but Gongsun insisted he only wants a thousand men from your newly recruited soldiers."

At this, He Jingyuan's face also twisted in confusion.

In that brief moment, Gongsun Yin, clad in his ethereal white robes, sauntered over to He Jingyuan with effortless grace. "I've come to ask for your assistance, Lord He."

Though Gongsun Yin served Xie Zheng and held no official military rank, his reputation as a master schemer ensured no one dared underestimate him.

Although He Jingyuan served as the Governor of Jizhou, while administrative affairs were directly reported to the imperial court, military matters had to follow Xie Zheng's orders.

Thus, when Gongsun Yin arrived before him, he dismounted and carefully said, "Yanzhou is in trouble, and Jizhou should naturally lend aid. But as you can see, Gongsun, the current situation in Jizhou..."

Gongsun Yin smiled. "I have come under the Marquis's orders to relieve the siege of Lucheng."

He Jingyuan grew even more puzzled when he heard no mention of borrowing troops. "What do you mean by that?"

Gongsun Yin replied, "The incident where Wei Xuan beat people to death while requisitioning grain in Taizhou has caused quite an uproar, and there's no doubt that the rebels have been fanning the flames. However, Jizhou has salt lakes, which is why the rebels chose to besiege it. If Jizhou proves difficult to conquer, the rebels might very well turn their attention to Taizhou. The Marquis's plan is for Yanzhou to feign weakness, sending me to Jizhou to request reinforcements. If the rebels see that Jizhou can still spare troops for Yanzhou, they will inevitably suspect Jizhou's true military strength and hesitate to act rashly in the short term."

He Jingyuan asked, "Would Changxin Wang be so easily fooled by this ruse? What if he turns to attack Taizhou instead?"

Gongsun Yin's smile remained unchanged. "The Marquis has already sent another envoy to Taizhou to borrow troops."

He Jingyuan fell silent for a moment, pondering the scheme in his mind.

Both Taizhou and Jizhou had been embroiled in scandals over grain requisition, leading to widespread discontent among the people. Yet the rebels had chosen to attack Jizhou, undoubtedly drawn by its salt lakes.

By sending envoys from Yanzhou to request aid from both Taizhou and Jizhou, the Wu'an Marquis was essentially signaling to the rebels that Yanzhou was currently the most vulnerable target, while Jizhou and Taizhou still had troops to spare—implying that these two provinces were far stronger militarily than Yanzhou.

Under normal circumstances, Changxin Wang might have suspected a trick. But with Jinzhou, north of Yanzhou, currently engaged in battle against the Northern Turks, it was entirely possible that Yanzhou's defenses were indeed weak.

In the end, He Jingyuan summoned his deputy. "Allocate whatever troops Gongsun requests."

Gongsun Yin bowed deeply. "I am deeply grateful, Lord He."

He Jingyuan said, "If this relieves the siege of Lucheng and preserves Jizhou, it is I who should thank you and the Marquis."

After exchanging a few more polite words, Gongsun Yin took his leave.

Half an hour later, Gongsun Yin, clad in pristine white robes, returned to the camp where his Yanzhou troops were stationed, leading the thousand newly borrowed soldiers.

The moment he entered the tent, his barely contained glee spilled over. Eyeing the man reclining on the couch, whose face and the corners of his eyes were still bruised, he smirked and teased, "Well, well—who in this world could have beaten you up like this?"

Chapter 55

The bruise at the corner of Xie Zheng's eye had faded considerably. Leaning against the couch with slightly lowered eyelids, he seemed lost in thought, not even noticing Gongsun Yin's entrance into the tent. Only after Gongsun Yin's teasing remark did he lift his gaze: "If you're so idle, go supervise the battle in Jinzhou."

Gongsun Yin found himself a seat, pouring a cup of hot tea as he replied, "Idle? When Xue Luan delivered your letter, I immediately led the Yanzhou troops hundreds of miles to Lucheng. After working like an ox or horse, this is all the thanks I get? How heartless!"

Xie Zheng's mood was foul, and his words grew sharper: "Naming that foolish creature so pretentiously—you've got no shame. Since you're already an ox or horse, I suppose you won't need a carriage for the return trip to Yanzhou. Walk back."

Gongsun Yin choked. Though everyone said he had a silver tongue, he'd never gained the upper hand against Xie Zheng.

Unable to resist, he shot back, "So irritable? If you dislike Xue Luan so much, give her to me!"

As he spoke, his fox-like eyes darted toward the gyrfalcon in the corner of the tent. For some reason, the bird had taken a liking to a bamboo basket—originally meant for dirty laundry—as its nest.

Xie Zheng raised his eyes coolly. "Didn't you realize it's your naming sense I despise?"

Gongsun Yin, incensed, flicked his sleeve and made to leave. "Xie Jiuhan, don't push your luck!"

Xie Zheng let him storm off. But at the tent entrance, Gongsun Yin suddenly turned back and sat down again. "Almost fell for your trick, letting you provoke me into leaving. To injure you and put you in such a foul mood..." His fox eyes narrowed. "I heard Changxin Wang's heir visited Qingping County recently. On the Chongzhou battlefield, you fell for his

tactics and lost. The troops hail him as peerless in valor—did he give you that bruise?"

Xie Zheng scoffed. "You overestimate him."

Gongsun Yin immediately knew it couldn't have been Sui Yuanqing. Frowning, he ventured, "It couldn't be some romantic entanglement... a woman did this?"

The moment he said it, he burst out laughing. "Impossible. Not only does Xie Jiuhan lack any romantic fortune, but no woman could pack such a punch."

Xie Zheng's expression stiffened. "Is this why you came?"

Seeing his displeasure, Gongsun Yin grew serious. "Naturally, there's serious business. When the Yanzhou troops met Merchant Zhao for grain transport, they left no traces. Instead, Zhao left clues for Jizhou officials, allowing He Jingyuan to trace it back to Yanzhou."

"I ordered raids on the Zhao Family's covert bases but deliberately leaked information, letting them relocate in advance. That's how we uncovered their deeper hideouts. The investigation revealed... quite intriguing findings."

He smiled mysteriously, continuing only when Xie Zheng looked over. "The Zhao Family also has ties to Changxin Wang."

Xie Zheng remained impassive. "When Zhao Xun met me, he repeatedly hinted he serves the imperial grandson who perished in the fire over a decade ago. With Changxin Wang rebelling, it's no surprise his backers would deal with the prince."

When Gongsun Yin heard the words "imperial grandson," his expression changed slightly. He asked Xie Zheng, "What does the Marquis think?"

He addressed him as "Marquis" rather than "you," indicating he was asking not as a friend but as an adviser seeking his stance on the matter.

Xie Zheng replied, "After the Battle of Chongzhou, Wei Yan and I are now irreconcilable."

Gongsun Yin pondered for a moment before saying, "Changxin Wang is no saint either. If the imperial grandson truly still lives, it's unclear what deal he struck with Changxin Wang."

Xie Zheng sat with one leg slightly bent, his long hair tied up and his dark brows sharp as blades. His tone was casual yet icy: "If the imperial grandson had dealings with Changxin Wang, yet Changxin Wang rebelled without invoking his name, then either this so-called imperial grandson was merely a smokescreen created by Changxin Wang, or... Changxin Wang is too ambitious, unwilling to submit to anyone even after gaining momentum."

Hearing this speculation, Gongsun Yin was startled. "Even if Changxin Wang refuses to serve under another, rebelling under the imperial grandson's banner would lend him legitimacy. Once the realm is secured, with his grip on power, whether the imperial grandson ascends the throne would be entirely up to him. In that case, the imperial grandson affair truly seems like Changxin Wang's scheme."

He furrowed his brows. "Yet Wei Yan has also been investigating the imperial grandson, arresting many on mere rumors these days. Even you... reopening the Jinzhou case from back then has made him want you dead. If the imperial grandson's survival were false, why would Wei Yan panic?"

Xie Zheng reflected on Zhao Xun's words that day. Zhao Xun had hinted he was aligned with the imperial grandson, yet knew nothing of the hidden truths behind the Jinzhou Massacre seventeen years ago. Even his account of how the imperial grandson survived the East Palace fire was entirely his own claim, with no evidence to support it.

It was precisely because he found this suspicious that Xie Zheng had demanded Zhao Xun's backer meet him personally. But with the Zhao Family's properties being seized one after another by the authorities, the matter had stalled.

He asked, "Before the authorities raided the Zhao Family's bases in Qingping County, did your men discover anything?"

Gongsun Yin replied, "Those bases in Qingping County were temporary—shops and taverns bought by the Zhao Family less than two months prior. There was pitifully little to uncover."

Xie Zheng's fingers, which had been tapping the table, paused. "When the Zhao Family's businesses were seized, I had only been in Qingping County for a month. Clearly, those bases weren't set up for me."

Gongsun Yin also felt the situation growing more perplexing. "You mean, in the month before your misfortune, something must have happened in

Qingping County to prompt the Zhao Family to establish so many bases there?"

The events in Qingping County a month before his misfortune...

Xie Zheng's gaze sharpened. The only thing that came to mind was the deaths of the Fan family couple.

Wei Yan had sent men to kill the couple and repeatedly dispatched Martial Assassins to the Fan Family in search of something. Such movements wouldn't have gone unnoticed by those monitoring Wei Yan.

So... were the Zhao Family's bases established for the Fan Family?

Zhao Xun hadn't found him by chance after reading his Eight-legged essay and paying a visit out of admiration. Instead, the Zhao Family had been watching the Fan Family all along, which led them to discover his whereabouts.

Something was on the verge of becoming clear.

Xie Zheng said slowly, "It seems Wei Yan has also been outmaneuvered by Changxin Wang."

Gongsun Yin was astute enough to instantly grasp the implication behind Xie Zheng's words: "Are you saying that Changxin Wang deliberately leaked rumors about the imperial grandson and the Battle of Jinzhou from back then, to make Wei Yan panic and reveal his hand?"

Xie Zheng voiced his speculation: "The imperial grandson might truly exist, or he might just be a decoy. But Changxin Wang must know something about what happened back then. Lacking concrete evidence, he deliberately spread these rumors to make Wei Yan think he hadn't cleaned up all loose ends. When Wei Yan goes back to eliminate the remaining threats, he'll expose the evidence himself."

Even Gongsun Yin was momentarily stunned, his brows furrowing tightly. "If there never was an imperial grandson to begin with, then that Zhao fellow buying two hundred thousand dan of grain for you—was it all just to provoke Wei Xuan into requisitioning grain, inciting the people of Qingping County to rebel and attack Lucheng from within and without?"

He stood up and paced back and forth in the military tent. "Just as the Northern Turks began attacking Jinzhou, those two hundred thousand dan of grain would make it nearly impossible for them to take the city. If Jinzhou were to fall, the northwestern gateway would be wide open,

allowing the Northern Turks to march straight down. Changxin Wang himself wouldn't fare well either. Those two hundred thousand dan of grain serve three purposes at once!"

"Wei Yan wants you dead. Changxin Wang guards the Chongzhou Grain Supply Line. You hold off the Northern Turks while his army continues southward. By the time you're at your limit, you'll either starve to death in Jinzhou like your father and the Chengde Crown Prince did back then, or be forced to ally with Changxin Wang and surrender your military power."

When Gongsun Yin sat down again, his expression was grim. "What an intricately calculated and utterly ruthless plan!"

Xie Zheng, however, seemed oddly indifferent, as if the deadly predicament didn't weigh on him. "I thought you'd advise me to ally with Changxin Wang."

Gongsun Yin's expression darkened. "Don't lump me in with those useless fools. Leaving aside the fact that you're Wei Yan's own nephew, just the sheer military power you command would make Changxin Wang wary of accepting your surrender. No one in this world can sleep soundly with a sword hanging over their head."

He was the sharpest blade in the world, unmatched in its edge.

Wei Yan, forced by circumstances, had inadvertently forged him. Yet at the slightest hint of trouble, he sought to break him.

Even a man as powerful as Wei Yan feared him to this extent—how could Changxin Wang dare wield such a blade?

If Xie Zheng rebelled, it was unclear who between him and Changxin Wang would prevail. Changxin Wang was far too shrewd to keep such a dangerous liability by his side.

Still, Xie Zheng's words planted an idea in Gongsun Yin's mind. His fox-like eyes narrowed. "Does the Marquis desire the empire?"

Xie Zheng scoffed. "I want the truth about the Battle of Jinzhou seventeen years ago."

This made Gongsun Yin laugh. "Now that's the Xie Jiuhan I know."

Gongsun Yin straightened his robes and prepared to leave. At the tent's entrance, he couldn't resist turning back. "I'm still rather curious—who was it that hit you?"

Aside from this injury, there were no others on his body. The fact that only his face had been beaten to such a state was truly baffling.

When Xie Zheng's icy gaze swept over him, Gongsun Yin hastily lifted the tent flap and left.

Xie Zheng closed his eyes. The emotions he had deliberately suppressed inexplicably surged back because of Gongsun Yin's words.

Perhaps because he had tasted few defeats in his life, aside from the bitterness, an inexplicable sense of unwillingness also arose.

Not to mention the noble ladies in the capital, even a princess—if he wished, he could marry any of them. Yet that woman alone treated him with such disdain, as if he were nothing more than a roadside weed.

A suffocating tightness filled his chest, mingled with irritation.

Just then, the tent flap was lifted. Xie Zheng raised his eyes impatiently to see Gongsun Yin returning, carrying a large bundle that looked vaguely familiar.

Meeting Xie Zheng's unfriendly gaze, Gongsun Yin shrugged. "A lieutenant from the Jizhou military camp sent this. Said a carpenter cured his rheumatism with a few medicinal plasters, so he owed the man a favor. The carpenter asked him to help find his niece's husband—apparently, the man's name is Yan Zheng. Coincidentally, among the thousand men I requisitioned from He Jingyuan, you're the only one using the alias Yan Zheng. I figured this must be for you."

His fox-like eyes couldn't resist a teasing glint. "Niece's husband? You got married?"

Xie Zheng froze momentarily at the sight of the bundle, then pressed his lips together, his expression turning cold. "Take it to the back tent."

Gongsun Yin's eyes widened comically, his usual sly demeanor replaced by stunned disbelief. "Wait—you actually got married?"

Xie Zheng remained silent, his lips pressed tightly together.

Married—but only in pretense.

Gongsun Yin frowned, then suddenly seemed to realize something, staring at Xie Zheng in shock. "Don't tell me you're planning to abandon her after taking advantage?"

His gaze drifted to the wounds on Xie Zheng's face, and his suspicions grew stronger. "Are those injuries from the girl's family after you wronged her?"

Xie Zheng's expression darkened. "Shut up."

He was the one who'd been cast aside like worthless trash.

Gongsun Yin, however, took Fan Changyu's side, shaking his head in dismay. "Jiuheng, Jiuheng... I never thought you'd be this kind of man..."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids impatiently. "Do you want to walk out on your own, or should I have someone throw you out?"

Gongsun Yin frowned, his tone turning serious. "Jiuheng, even if her status is too low to be your official wife, she stood by you when you were at your lowest. At least bring her back and give her the position of a concubine. How can you be so heartless..."

After a long silence, Xie Zheng finally said, "She didn't want me."

Gongsun Yin's expression instantly twisted into something indescribably strange.

Chapter 56

After Gongsun Yin left, Xie Zheng acted as if he hadn't seen the large bundle, picking up a military manual from the table to read.

When his personal guard entered with tea, he said coldly, "Take that to the back tent."

The guard paused for a moment before realizing he meant the bundle Gongsun Yin had brought. He carried it to the rear tent.

Though the bundle was no longer in sight, Xie Zheng's brow remained furrowed. His fingers flipped rapidly through the pages, yet he couldn't suppress the restlessness in his heart.

Soon after, he tossed aside the military manual. The guard at the entrance, hearing the noise, was about to enter and ask if he needed anything. But just as he lifted the tent flap slightly, he saw Xie Zheng rise and head toward the back tent himself.

The guard quickly withdrew his hand and resumed his post, standing rigidly without glancing around.

Xie Zheng's current status in the Yanzhou Army was known only to Gongsun Yin and a few trusted aides. His tent was that of an ordinary officer, divided into a front section for meetings and a rear section for rest.

The bundle the guard had taken to the back tent was placed on a small table beside the bed.

Xie Zheng gazed at it for a while before untying the knot.

Inside were two sets of new clothes and a pair of shoes—all items Fan Changyu had packed for him that day.

When he spotted the two additional packets of tangerine peel candy, the tight line of his lips softened slightly. The suffocating weight in his chest suddenly felt as though it had been submerged in warm water, and the inexplicable agitation subsided.

Xie Zheng's fingers brushed over the new clothes as he picked them up to store in the chest. But as he lifted them, the banknotes and the divorce

papers tucked between the garments fell out.

The sight of the stark, bold characters spelling "divorce papers" instantly froze the faint curve of his lips.

She truly was... determined to sever all ties with him!

A cold smirk curled Xie Zheng's thin lips. His innate pride made him want to call someone in immediately and have the bundle thrown far away.

Closing his eyes, he took a few steadying breaths. In the end, he simply gathered the items from the bundle and locked them all in the chest.

He sat beside it, staring blankly at the chest at his feet, his expression unreadable.

If he threw them away now, he would only dwell on them.

Better to keep them—until the day they no longer stirred even a ripple in his heart. Then, it would be time to discard them.

He had been raised by Wei Yan. If anything, the most valuable lesson Wei Yan had taught him was to face his desires head-on—and to master them.

His feelings for her were real, but that was all there was to it.

Meanwhile, after leaving the Yanzhou camp, Gongsun Yin couldn't shake the nagging curiosity clawing at him. He wandered over to the new recruits' camp in Jizhou.

Xie Zheng was tight-lipped. No matter how much Gongsun Yin pestered him, he couldn't pry much about the marriage. But Gongsun Yin reasoned that if the girl had gone to the trouble of sending her uncle to deliver things to Xie Zheng, she couldn't be entirely indifferent. So why did Xie Zheng insist she didn't want him?

Baffled, Gongsun Yin sought out the officer in charge of craftsmen in Jizhou. It didn't take long to track down Carpenter Zhao.

There was only one carpenter who knew medicine and had treated a captain's rheumatism with a few plasters—easy to find.

The newly recruited soldiers were still in training and not yet deployed for combat. The craftsmen conscripted from civilian life were assigned to work on fortifications and equipment.

Before he could be assigned to tend to the warhorses, Carpenter Zhao was first sent to the carpentry tent.

When the soldier overseeing the craftsmen led Gongsun Yin to Carpenter Zhao, the old carpenter was busy planing a piece of wood with his plane.

The soldier called out, "Carpenter Zhao, are you here? Someone's looking for you!"

Carpenter Zhao set down his plane and raised his aged eyes to look outside. "This old man is here," he replied.

The soldier beckoned to him, and Carpenter Zhao, after briefly excusing himself from the supervising foreman, stepped out.

As craftsmen, they weren't issued standard military uniforms, so Carpenter Zhao still wore his own drab, gray clothing. His back was slightly hunched, and he appeared lean and wiry.

The soldier addressed him with some courtesy: "This lord is here to see you."

Though Carpenter Zhao hadn't been in the camp long, he had already learned the ways of survival. To those clad in armor, he addressed them as "General"; to ordinary soldiers, he called them "Master Soldier"; and to those without armor but with an air of distinction, regardless of their actual rank, he simply referred to them as "Lord."

Now, upon seeing Gongsun Yin, Carpenter Zhao hastily bowed and greeted, "This old man pays his respects to the Lord."

Gongsun Yin gestured for him to rise, his smile as warm as a spring breeze. "No need for such formalities, Elder. I've heard you have a nephew-in-law named Yan Zheng?"

During his time in the army, Carpenter Zhao had been inquiring about Yan Zheng's whereabouts. But with tens of thousands of conscripted soldiers, it was impossible to find him quickly. By sheer coincidence, he had treated a commandant who, being a man of his word, told Carpenter Zhao to seek him out if he ever needed help. Worried that mentioning a mere neighbor might not be taken seriously, Carpenter Zhao lied and claimed he was searching for his nephew-in-law, asking the commandant to help inquire.

True to his word, the commandant took the matter to heart. Upon discovering that Yan Zheng was among the thousand men loaned to Yanzhou, he immediately informed Carpenter Zhao. Like most craftsmen, Carpenter Zhao was kept under watch to prevent desertion and wasn't allowed to move freely around the camp. So, he entrusted the commandant to deliver the bundle prepared by Fan Changyu to Xie Zheng.

After delivering the items, the commandant sent word back to Carpenter Zhao, who finally felt at ease, believing he had fulfilled his duty to Fan Changyu.

Now, suddenly confronted by a finely dressed young lord, Carpenter Zhao couldn't fathom the reason. He wondered if he was about to be punished for falsely claiming Yan Zheng as his nephew-in-law.

His lips trembled slightly before he finally nodded, his heart pounding with unease.

Seeing he had found the right person, Gongsun Yin's fox-like eyes crinkled into a smile. He even boldly requested a tent from the soldier and invited Carpenter Zhao inside for a brief chat.

Carpenter Zhao had never encountered such a situation before and sat in the tent as if on pins and needles.

Gongsun Yin, ever polite and amiable, even poured tea for him. "I heard you cured Commandant Hu's rheumatism, Elder. With such medical skills, why didn't you become an Army Doctor instead of joining the craftsmen's camp?"

Carpenter Zhao, somewhat embarrassed, replied, "This old man's knowledge is shallow. I used to treat livestock—how could I dare to be an Army Doctor?"

Learning he was a veterinarian, Gongsun Yin chuckled. "So Commandant Hu was your first human patient?"

Carpenter Zhao answered truthfully, "Not exactly. I was a veterinarian for over a decade before switching to carpentry. The first person I treated was my nephew-in-law. At the time, he was severely injured, and none of the town's medical halls would take him in. That's when I took the risk and treated him with medicine."

Gongsun Yin was taken aback at first, then burst into laughter. Under Carpenter Zhao's puzzled gaze, he coughed several times before barely

suppressing his mirth and said, "Meeting you in his desperate straits was truly his good fortune."

Carpenter Zhao quickly denied this. "My niece carried him back from the wilderness. If she hadn't picked him up, he would have either died from his injuries or frozen to death in the snow."

Gongsun Yin thought to himself that a beauty saving a hero would make for a fine tale. Suppressing his curiosity, he asked, "So later he married your niece?"

Carpenter Zhao gave him a closer look at this persistent questioning, wondering why an official would be so interested in Yan Zheng's marital affairs.

Realizing he'd been too obvious, Gongsun Yin hastily made up an excuse: "Your nephew-in-law has caught our general's attention. The general always investigates thoroughly those he intends to promote, hence sending me to inquire."

Though not well-educated, Carpenter Zhao had decades of life experience. The war hadn't even started, yet Yan Zheng had already attracted a general's notice. He thought this boded ill—could it be that Yan Zheng's striking looks had caught some general's eye, wanting him as a son-in-law?

What would become of Changyu then? Could she endure another situation like with Song Yan?

His mind racing, Carpenter Zhao replied, "To answer Your Honor, the boy later married into my niece's family."

Gongsun Yin, who had been drinking tea, spat it out in shock. Normally eloquent, he now stumbled over his words: "Married... into her family?"

Even the emperor wouldn't dare suggest Xie Zheng marrying into some commoner's household—what kind of joke was this?

Carpenter Zhao, seeing his reaction, grew more convinced of his suspicions.

He hurriedly explained, "That boy Yan Zheng was carried back from the snow by my niece, barely alive. Later, bedridden with injuries, it was my niece who tended to him without complaint, earning money through butchering to buy his medicine... Over time, affection naturally grew."

Having just wiped tea from his mouth, Gongsun Yin's expression turned peculiar: "Your niece... is a butcher?"

He'd been wondering what ordinary woman could carry Xie Zheng so easily.

Not wanting Fan Changyu to be looked down upon, Carpenter Zhao said, "The girl's had a hard life. Her family ran a butcher shop in town—a decent living—until bandits killed her parents, leaving just her and a five-year-old sister. She had to take up butchering to survive."

He glanced surreptitiously at Gongsun Yin, secretly pleased by the official's complicated expression.

His purpose in sharing this was clear: to emphasize Fan Changyu's profound kindness to Yan Zheng. Pressuring Xie Zheng to marry some general's daughter would be unconscionable.

And even if Xie Zheng agreed, it would reveal poor character—abandoning the wife who saved his life. Any official considering such a match should think twice.

Unbeknownst to him, Gongsun Yin was now imagining a brawny, thick-necked woman with a cleaver and a face full of hardened flesh.

He sucked in a sharp breath, recalling Xie Zheng's words, "She didn't want to be with me," and quickly rubbed his arms.

No wonder that guy kept his distance from women—was this his preference after all?

Holding onto his last shred of hope, Gongsun Yin asked with mixed emotions, "So Yan Zheng married into your niece's family to repay a debt of gratitude?"

Carpenter Zhao immediately bristled, "What debt of gratitude? That young couple is deeply in love! When the local ruffians in town had no choice but to cause trouble at my niece's place, it was her husband who drove them off. He's literate and well-educated. Seeing my niece working from dawn till dusk slaughtering pigs to earn money for his treatment, even before his injuries had fully healed, he begged me to help him find work writing Eight-legged essays at the bookstore in town. During the New Year, he even wrote Spring Festival couplets for all the neighbors in the alley! When my niece was too busy at the butcher's shop, he went to help sell pork once he recovered a bit..."

As Carpenter Zhao rambled on about the couple's loving daily life, Gongsun Yin pictured Xie Zheng selling pork and couldn't help but shudder again, goosebumps rising on his arms.

Just what had that guy been through during his time in exile?

Marrying into a butcher woman's family?

Hiss—utterly horrifying.

Knowing Xie Zheng as he did, Gongsun Yin was certain that if Xie Zheng didn't want to do something, not even the Jade Emperor himself could force him. So Xie Zheng must have willingly married into the family.

It was precisely this realization that made Gongsun Yin find the whole situation even more absurd.

Could it be that Xie Zheng genuinely liked brawny, fierce women?

Gongsun Yin mused that if the noble ladies of the capital ever found out about this, they'd probably cry their hearts out...

Noticing the official's ever-changing expression, Carpenter Zhao, fearing they still had some designs on Xie Zheng, added, "Once this war is over and my nephew-in-law returns home, their child might already be running around."

Gongsun Yin's expression could only be described as horrified. "Your... your niece is pregnant?"

Carpenter Zhao stammered, "Well, it's hard to say. In our village, there have been cases where a wife discovered she was pregnant soon after her husband left for military service."

But inwardly, he thought that even if noble families could tolerate their future son-in-law having concubines or maids, they'd never accept him fathering illegitimate children before the wedding.

Gongsun Yin, who was always the epitome of refinement in public, truly lost his composure this time. His mind was in turmoil.

Xie Zheng, who had always looked down on everyone, had actually fallen for a butcher's daughter?

Unable to resist, Gongsun Yin pinched his own thigh hard, the pain twisting his mouth. Confirming this wasn't a dream, his expression grew

even more shattered. After exchanging a few polite words with Carpenter Zhao, he left, his face a picture of existential doubt.

Watching his stunned and bewildered retreating figure, Carpenter Zhao sipped his tea with great satisfaction.

At least he'd managed to fend off some unwanted romantic advances for the young couple.

As Gongsun Yin left the military tent, he happened to run into the Jizhou army's Commandant Hu, who had come again to ask Carpenter Zhao for medicinal ointment.

Recognizing Gongsun Yin, the man respectfully clasped his fists in greeting. "Master Gongsun."

Still dazed, Gongsun Yin nodded and asked, "That carpenter who used to be a veterinarian—he's the one who cured your rheumatism?"

Commandant Hu was a straightforward man, unbothered by Carpenter Zhao's past as a veterinarian. With his rheumatism gone and feeling much better these past few days, he grinned and nodded. "That's right. Did you need him for something, Master Gongsun?"

So he hadn't mistaken the man.

The nephew-in-law Carpenter Zhao spoke of was undoubtedly Xie Zheng.

Gongsun Yin said, "Just asking casually."

After returning to the Yanzhou camp with a look of utter bewilderment, he summoned his personal guard and muttered some instructions before adding with a complicated expression, "Don't disturb that woman. Just keep an eye on her movements."

Once the guard had left to carry out his orders, Gongsun Yin stared at Xie Zheng's tent for a while. Recalling Xie Zheng's lost and distracted demeanor earlier in the tent, he shuddered violently and muttered, "That guy... has it been too long since he last saw a woman?"

Xie Zheng, who had been in a foul mood after patrolling the camp on horseback, happened to hear the latter half of his remark. Holding the reins of his black steed, its nostrils still puffing white breath, he stood not far away and said coldly, "Too long since you've seen a woman? Should I have someone throw you into the Red Pavilion tonight?"

In the past, Gongsun Yin would never have dared to respond. But after meeting Carpenter Zhao today, he had been subjected to too many shocks. Now, meeting Xie Zheng's icy gaze, he actually considered it for a moment before saying, "Jiuheng, neither of us has ever been to a brothel. Why don't we go take a look?"

His main intention was to confirm whether Xie Zheng's judgment had somehow gone awry.

Xie Zheng paused as he coiled his whip, and when he looked up again, all traces of his usual nonchalance were gone. "If you were one of my officers, a hundred lashes with the military rod would be lenient."

Gongsun Yin knew he had misspoken, but if he meekly accepted the punishment now, their friendship would be over. He shrugged and laughed, "But I'm not."

Xie Zheng handed his warhorse to a personal guard and walked past him toward his tent, leaving only a parting remark: "Don't violate my military regulations."

Gongsun Yin clicked his tongue as he watched Xie Zheng's retreating figure. "To think you'd actually show interest in someone... I'm even more curious now about who that butcher's daughter really is."

Lin'an Town.

Under the night sky, thick snow had piled up once more on the eaves and treetops. The entire town was silent, not even a dog's bark to be heard.

"Bandits are coming!"

"They're killing people—run!"

Panicked shouts from those fleeing the county town shattered the deathly stillness of the snowy night. The townspeople, startled from their sleep, hastily wrapped themselves in clothes, grabbed their children, and rushed outside.

But as soon as they opened their doors, a gleaming blade was thrust into their chests.

A man, his eyes wide with terror, was kicked aside by the bandits outside. Inside, a woman clutched her child and hid in a corner, only for

the child to be torn from her arms by the intruders. With a cruel laugh, they dragged her by the hair toward the bed...

Soon, the entire town of Lin'an was engulfed in flames. The cries of children and the bandits' savage shouts were horrifying and piercing.

Amid the firelight, a man sat astride a tall horse, coldly watching the bandits slaughter and plunder. He glanced down at the magistrate of Qingping County, whom he held like a dead dog, and lazily asked, "Where does that woman live?"

Magistrate Liu had fled with his entire family the moment he learned the bandits were attacking Qingping County, taking advantage of the conscription that had stripped the town of its able-bodied men. He had assumed the bandits would be content with slaughtering the county's civilians.

But after his carriage had traveled over a dozen miles, this man had still caught up on horseback.

Now covered in blood and jostled on horseback for the entire journey, Magistrate Liu was utterly terrified. He could only beg, "I don't know, I truly don't know..."

Chapter 57

The scorching wind, thick with the stench of burning, melted the snowflakes that had yet to fall in the night.

A barefoot child wailed as it fled from a home engulfed in roaring flames, only to be cut down by bandits after a few steps in the snow. The spattered blood stained the hooves of Sui Yuanqing's horse.

He toyed with a gleaming dagger in his hand, looking down at Magistrate Liu with disdain. "Wasn't it your scheme to kidnap me and quell the people's anger? The lives I lost in Qingping County that day—tonight, I'll reclaim them a hundredfold, a thousandfold."

He tapped the dagger against Magistrate Liu's cheek and sneered, "You don't know the identity of the man in the blue devil mask, and you don't know the maid from your household who kidnapped me either?"

The blade suddenly slashed downward, opening a gash on Magistrate Liu's body, eliciting a pig-like squeal from the man.

Sui Yuanqing said leisurely, "Do you know now?"

Magistrate Liu, greedy for credit, had claimed after suppressing the Qingping County uprising that he and his subordinates had orchestrated Sui Yuanqing's capture. Only now did he realize the gravity of his mistake.

His plump face trembled as he wept, snot and tears mingling. "I truly don't know where that woman lives! She wasn't a maid from my household! I only know her name is Fan Changyu, the daughter of a butcher from Lin'an Town. I beg you, Your—"

A scar-faced man rode up from among the bandits. Sui Yuanqing's expression shifted, and just as Magistrate Liu was about to utter "Your Highness," he slit the man's throat and tossed his body from the horse.

The scar-faced man, hearing Sui Yuanqing was searching for a woman, frowned. "Fifth Brother, didn't you say you captured this spineless magistrate to find the one who wounded you? Why ask about some maid from his household?"

Sui Yuanqing smirked. "That maid is the one who wounded me."

The scar-faced man's expression relaxed slightly, though a veiled threat lingered in his tone. "Given Thirteen Sister's temper, if you have any romantic entanglements outside, she won't let them live."

Sui Yuanqing's smile didn't reach his eyes. "You jest, Elder Brother. That woman nearly sent me to a watery grave. This debt must be repaid, no matter what."

The scar-faced man glanced at the dead magistrate on the ground. "The brothers have already looted the magistrate's residence clean. We didn't see any maid skilled in martial arts. You chased her for miles on horseback and still couldn't find her. Can she vanish into thin air?"

He turned to Sui Yuanqing. "We've ransacked Qingping County. Jizhou Prefecture will surely send troops to hunt us down soon. We must return to Clear Breeze Stronghold quickly."

The implication was clear—he didn't want Sui Yuanqing to keep searching for the woman.

Sui Yuanqing tugged the reins, steadying his restless horse, a faint smile on his lips. "As you say, Elder Brother."

Seeing that Sui Yuanqing had indeed given up the hunt for the woman who wounded him, the scar-faced man nodded in satisfaction and barked, "After we finish looting this town, we return to Clear Breeze Stronghold!"

Sui Yuanqing, a long spear strapped to his saddle, urged his horse forward at a leisurely pace. A ragged townsman darted out from a dark alley, and without hesitation, Sui Yuanqing painted the ground red with a flick of his spear.

The scar-faced man, witnessing this, seemed finally at ease and rode off to inspect elsewhere.

But Sui Yuanqing, spear in hand, leaned slightly forward on his horse and asked the half-dead man at his feet, "Fan Changyu—where does she live?"

The name rolled off his tongue, and a predatory smile curled at his lips, laced with a hint of destruction.

Having found the woman, it was likely they could also locate the man wearing the blue devil mask.

The man on the ground was bleeding profusely from his chest. His survival instinct made him tremble as he weakly pointed in a direction: "West... west of the city..."

Sui Yuanqing spurred his horse forward, riding through the flickering firelight and swirling snow toward the western part of the city.

The wound on his side, not yet fully healed, throbbed with a dull pain from the jostling ride, but it did nothing to dampen his delight.

Lin'an Town was far less prosperous than Qingping County. Having already plundered Qingping County once, the bandits, now accustomed to richer spoils, had little interest in the meager pickings there. They mostly targeted wealthy households, as robbing the poor was often more trouble than it was worth.

Most of the time, they couldn't find any silver unless they threatened those hiding inside with blades, forcing them to dig out their carefully hidden savings from every nook and cranny.

As Sui Yuanqing rode into the alley where Fan Changyu's family lived, he saw numerous bodies strewn about—some elderly, some children. He held a freshly captured man in his grip.

Suspecting that his prey might have already been taken by someone else, he narrowed his eyes. His tone remained lazy but turned icy: "Which house belongs to Fan Changyu?"

The bloodied man in his grasp shivered and pointed to the second house at the end of the alley.

Sui Yuanqing tossed the man aside. Thinking he had been spared, the man scrambled to flee, only to be impaled through the chest by a blade the moment he stood up. He collapsed stiffly, adding another corpse to the ground.

Glancing at the blood staining the blade he had picked up, Sui Yuanqing wrinkled his nose in disgust and wiped his hands with a handkerchief before stepping through the gates of the Fan family home.

The house had clearly been ransacked. The courtyard was in disarray, and the door to the main room stood wide open, showing no signs of anyone hiding inside.

Yet Sui Yuanqing showed no intention of leaving. He raised his torch and entered the house.

Inside, drawers and cabinets had been flung open, pots and jars shattered across the floor. Bedding and sheets had been torn off and thrown aside—evidence of someone searching desperately for hidden silver.

He was about to leave when he noticed a door behind the kitchen. Hesitating briefly, he still strode forward with the torch.

Opening the door revealed the Fan family's backyard: a pigpen, a well covered by a heavy stone slab, and a stone bench used for butchering pigs.

Sui Yuanqing scanned the area and was about to turn away when his gaze landed on the slab covering the dry well. He paused.

The torchlight clearly illuminated the thick layer of snow atop the slab, but beneath the well's rim, where the slab shielded the ground, there was also a thick blanket of snow.

Clearly, the slab had been placed there recently.

Why cover the well?

Naturally, because something was hidden inside.

The slab looked to weigh over a hundred pounds. To anyone else, it would seem like an abandoned well, and they would have walked away.

But Sui Yuanqing chuckled softly, his eyes curving into crescents, as if pleased.

Step by step, he approached the well with the torch in hand. The crisp crunch of snow underfoot, mingling with distant wails, seemed to tread on someone's nerves.

As he reached to lift the slab, a murderous intent surged from behind.

Sui Yuanqing dodged just in time as a boning knife grazed past his ear and embedded itself into the courtyard wall nearby.

Before Sui Yuanqing could even look up to see where the boning knife had come from, the figure hiding on the rooftop leaped down with the agility of a panther, the bleeding knife in hand once again aimed straight for his vital points.

Sui Yuanqing dodged by instinct, but his opponent wielded two blades—one slashing while the other swept horizontally—giving him no chance to catch his breath.

Fan Changyu was truly intent on killing this time. Hidden in that dry well were Changning, Aunt Zhao, and several neighbors from nearby households. If she failed, they would surely die.

Her strikes were swift and fierce. In her left hand was a cleaver, in her right a bleeding knife that could slash like a blade or thrust like a sword. There was hardly any technique to it—just sheer speed, forcing him into a defensive stance with no opportunity to counterattack.

Several times, Sui Yuanqing tried to draw his sword, only to be forced back by Fan Changyu's relentless assault. He retreated step by step, evading her pressing blade.

Finally, he resorted to using the torch in his hand as a weapon. Swinging it with a whooshing sound, the flame trailed behind like an orange silk ribbon. Yet Fan Changyu's onslaught didn't let up, leaving him utterly unable to retaliate.

Sui Yuanqing dared not clash the torch directly against her butcher knife, so he could only deflect by striking the flat of her blade or dodging its edge.

This made his defense all the more strenuous. Worse still, his opponent seemed tireless—her strikes not only relentless but also undiminished in strength despite the prolonged fight. The force of her blows split the skin of his palm, and his grip on the torch grew numb with each impact.

Sui Yuanqing cursed inwardly—what kind of freak was this woman?

In the flickering light, Fan Changyu's eyes were cold and sharp, like a tiger or leopard tearing into an intruder, filled with a deadly ferocity that bore no resemblance to the naive honesty of their first meeting.

When she fought with such intensity, there was an inexplicable allure in the arch of her brows and the corners of her eyes.

Sui Yuanqing stared at this beautiful yet fierce face and froze for a split second. In that instant, the torch in his hand was sliced clean in half, and the bleeding knife plunged deep into his shoulder. Had she twisted it with more force, half his arm might have flown off.

The searing pain snapped him back to reality. Before Fan Changyu could sever his tendons, he shouted, "If you kill me, neither you nor those in the well will leave here alive."

Fan Changyu's blade hesitated.

Sui Yuanqing seized the chance to negotiate. "Let me go, and I'll spare you and the people in the well."

Fan Changyu scoffed coldly, "Why should I believe you?"

Just then, bandits outside noticed Sui Yuanqing's horse left in the alley and called out, "Fifth Leader, are you in there?"

Blood soaked half of Sui Yuanqing's robe from his wound, yet he managed a leisurely smirk. "Believe it or not, the choice is yours."

The decision had to be made in an instant. Before the bandits outside could enter, Fan Changyu withdrew the bleeding knife from Sui Yuanqing's shoulder and pressed a small boning knife against the gap between his ribs on the left side.

A thrust there would pierce his heart.

Fan Changyu whispered, "I told you before—I'd show you how a New Year's pig is bled. If you try anything, this knife will send you to the underworld before me."

Keeping the blade pressed against him, she yanked him up. As she kicked aside the heavy stone slab covering the well, the bandits searching the Fan family's courtyard heard the noise and rushed toward the backyard.

Several torches illuminated the cramped space. The group arrived just in time to see Sui Yuanqing pinning a woman against the wall, a discarded door plank lying on the ground—apparently the source of the earlier commotion.

Little did they know, beneath that door panel lay the very bleeding knife that had gouged a gaping hole in Sui Yuanqing's shoulder.

Sui Yuanqing, his injury still unhealed, wore a heavy cloak draped over his shoulders. At this moment, the woman's figure was completely concealed within its folds.

The bandits who caught sight of this exchanged knowing smirks.

One of them remarked, "We've interrupted the Fifth Leader's fun."

Sui Yuanqing merely chuckled and scolded, "Then why aren't you scrambling out of here?"

As he casually wrapped an arm around Fan Changyu's waist, she pressed her boning knife forward slightly, the blade grazing his chest just enough to break the skin. The cold steel against his flesh made Sui Yuanqing restrain himself—his hand hovered loosely over her clothes, appearing from a distance as though he were embracing her.

Yet, in a hushed voice, he teased, "If you're taking me hostage, how else am I supposed to get you out and cover for whoever's hiding in that well?"

Fan Changyu remained silent, though the knife didn't advance further.

She leaned against him as if shy, her face mostly hidden by the cloak, but in truth, her cold eyes held the blade steady against his vital point.

Sui Yuanqing glanced down at the only visible part of her—her fair ear, glowing faintly in the firelight. A sharp, gnawing itch surged in his gums, and he couldn't help but imagine biting down on that earlobe, hard enough to draw blood and leave his mark.

Just the thought inexplicably lifted his mood.

Twice now, he'd been bested by this woman—each time worse than the last.

Surprisingly, he didn't feel anger. Accustomed to women who obeyed him, this was a strangely refreshing experience.

It was like taming a wild horse—he relished the slow process of breaking her in.

Yet, the memory of her calling out to the man in the blue devil mask when he'd pulled her from the falling building flashed before his eyes, intensifying that maddening itch. He bent his head slightly, whispering close to her ear, "Why isn't that masked man coming to your rescue now?"

Fan Changyu's boning knife pressed forward without hesitation.

Feeling the chill at his chest, Sui Yuanqing straightened with a faint smirk.

To outsiders, it looked like he'd whispered something flirtatious to the woman in his arms. The bandits' lecherous gazes kept darting beneath his cloak, but Fan Changyu's figure was entirely concealed. They only noted that she seemed taller than most women—nothing else stood out.

Sui Yuanqing said, "Let's go. The boss must be waiting."

Under the cloak's cover, Fan Changyu kept the knife at his back as they moved, her mind racing.

After this spectacle, hardly any bandits paid attention to the well in the courtyard.

The dry well, originally used as a cellar, had a rope ladder inside. Once the bandits left, those hiding within could climb out.

Her plan was simple: hold this man hostage, wait until Aunt Zhao and Changning had escaped, then force him to lead her somewhere secluded. Dealing with him alone wouldn't be a problem.

But... after the Jizhou authorities had quelled the rebellion, they'd identified him as a rebel from Chongzhou. How had he ended up colluding with these bandits?

The official notices hadn't named Sui Yuanqing's identity—Fan Changyu only knew he was a rebel, unaware he was the heir of Changxin Wang.

As she pondered this, a sudden shout came from the alley outside: "The boss is here!"

Fan Changyu subtly glanced at the bandit leader mentioned by the mountain bandits, only to see his expression darken as he lashed his whip directly toward her.

Changyu knew she absolutely couldn't block that whip. The moment Scarface Man struck, she simply twisted the boning knife in her hand to the side.

She didn't drive it deeper, but she widened the wound further.

Sui Yuanqing, subjected to her silent threat, smiled even more broadly. When the whip was about to land on her, he caught it barehanded.

The whip recoiled onto the back of his hand, instantly raising a swollen welt. Yet, as if he felt no pain, he lifted his gaze to Scarface Man on horseback and asked, "What's the meaning of this, elder brother?"

Scarface Man bellowed, "You want to take this woman back to Clear Breeze Stronghold?"

Yuan Qing replied nonchalantly, "It's rare for me to find someone who suits my tastes."

Scarface Man threw a knife at Yuan Qing's feet and snapped, "If you still intend to marry Thirteen Sister, kill this woman."

Chapter 58

Fan Changyu noticed the obvious discord between Sui Yuanqing and the bandit leader. It seemed Sui Yuanqing was even betrothed to someone, which made her inwardly curse his cunning.

If the bandit leader ordered him to kill her and he refused, the leader might take matters into his own hands—then her act of holding him hostage would be exposed.

For a moment, sweat dampened the palm gripping her boning knife, but she forced herself to remain calm.

The worst outcome was being discovered for kidnapping him. As long as she silenced him with a blade before he could reveal the people hidden in the dry well, Changning and the others would remain safe.

Alone and with nothing to lose, she might even seize a horse and escape.

Sui Yuanqing stood close enough to sense Changyu's tension—her entire body was coiled like a predator ready to pounce and tear its prey apart.

If she truly decided to strike, he would be the first to meet his end.

He didn't provoke her now, merely chuckling lightly. "Big Brother, are you asking me to remain chaste for Thirteen Sister, devoted to her alone for life?"

They were all bandits—who didn't know the fickle nature of men?

Scarface Man roared, "She's my only sister! I don't care what happens later, but before you're even wed, you dare bring another woman back to the stronghold? What do you take Clear Breeze Stronghold for?"

Sui Yuanqing frowned, his tone deceptively sincere. "When I joined Clear Breeze Stronghold and became sworn brothers with you, it wasn't through a woman's connections. I, Qin Yuan, am a rogue at heart—utterly unworthy of Thirteen Sister. Why not find her a better match? From now on, I'll treat her as my own sister. If anyone dares harm her, I'll be the first to strike."

Scarface Man gritted his teeth. "You really look down on my sister that much?"

Sui Yuanqing lowered his gaze. "It's my nature—too wayward to be a good match for her. Today, you can force me to kill this woman. But what about tomorrow? Will you make me kill every woman I fancy? Over time, it'll only strain our bond. Better to lay things bare now."

Though furious, Scarface Man knew Sui Yuanqing had a point.

It was precisely his roguish charm that had captivated Thirteen Sister. But if this was his nature, could he be forced forever?

Still, resentment for his sister burned in his chest. "Thirteen Sister saved you from the river—never mind the debt of life. You've already been intimate with her! If you won't marry her, what becomes of her?"

Sui Yuanqing lifted his eyes. "To make me wed her, you'd resort to such conventional arguments?"

Scarface Man's expression darkened—he knew his reasoning was flimsy.

In the martial world, men and women paid little heed to trivialities. If word spread that he'd used his sister's life-saving intimacy to force a marriage, it would invite ridicule.

In the end, he didn't press further. With a grim face, he turned his horse and barked, "Back to Clear Breeze Stronghold!"

The underlings noisily followed, though a few lingered to flatter Sui Yuanqing. "Fifth Leader truly is a man of honor! Some said you only won the First Leader's favor through Thirteen Sister, but clearly, he values your skills—that's why he wanted to marry her to you. When Black Dragon Stronghold attacked, it was all thanks to Fifth Leader's strategy..."

Sui Yuanqing had a knife pressed against the wound under his ribs by Fan Changyu, so he wasn't in the mood to listen to these underlings flatter him. He interrupted them, saying, "Stop talking nonsense, lest it harm the bond between me and Big Brother. He treats me like a blood brother—he was just protective of his sister because of Thirteen Sister's matter. Let's head back to the stronghold."

The men, having been reprimanded, looked embarrassed and didn't dare to say anything more to deliberately please him.

Fan Changyu remained silent. From their conversation, she had already figured out why Sui Yuanqing was mixed up with these bandits.

So after he was injured by Yan Zheng that day and fled into the river, he was rescued by the people of Clear Breeze Stronghold.

She noticed that among the flattering underlings, one had quietly moved forward. She guessed that person must be from the leader of Clear Breeze Stronghold, and Sui Yuanqing knew it, which was why he deliberately said those things?

Fan Changyu thought to herself, This guy really has more schemes than a lotus root has holes.

With a knife pressed against his chest, Sui Yuanqing acted as if nothing was wrong and led Fan Changyu to the horse. Only then did he lower his head slightly and ask in a hushed voice, “With your knife pressed against me like this, how am I supposed to mount the horse?”

Whether he mounted first or Fan Changyu did, she wouldn’t be able to continue holding him hostage.

The underlings assumed Sui Yuanqing was flirting and stole a few longing glances, not daring to act out of line. They muttered a couple of crude jokes and laughed as they walked ahead.

One of them said, “This time we really pulled off a big job. We can rest easy for a while after returning to the stronghold. Last time, the boss took us to ambush that escort and search for some damned treasure map, but it turned out to be fake...”

Fan Changyu had been focusing solely on dealing with Sui Yuanqing, but when she suddenly heard this, her blood nearly boiled over.

Ambushing escorts, a treasure map...

When the authorities closed the case, hadn’t they said her parents were killed by bandits because of a treasure map?

What a coincidence—were her parents also murdered by this very group?

She could barely suppress the killing intent surging through her.

Sui Yuanqing, noticing her silence and the sudden spike in her murderous aura, immediately grew wary, thinking Fan Changyu intended to kill him right there and escape alone on horseback.

He said, "Killing me here isn't a wise choice unless you want to face hundreds of men alone."

Fan Changyu tightened her grip on the knife handle, knowing this wasn't the time for rash actions. She could avenge her parents later—right now, the priority was to lead these bandits away, as Changning and Aunt Zhao were still in the dry well.

After a brief consideration, she said, "Take off your sword and give it to me. You mount first, then pull me up."

Thinking he had persuaded her, Sui Yuanqing smirked and complied.

The moment he turned to grab the saddle, Fan Changyu suddenly struck at the back of his neck with a knifehand strike. Sui Yuanqing, having learned from last time and now prepared, dodged sideways as her palm sliced through the air. With lightning speed, he intercepted her wrist and twisted hard. Fan Changyu let out a muffled groan as her entire arm went limp—she knew it must be dislocated.

Sui Yuanqing watched the cold sweat bead on her forehead and said leisurely, "I won't fall for the same trick twice..."

Fan Changyu's round almond eyes glared at him fiercely, filled with unyielding determination.

As Sui Yuanqing pulled her dislocated arm toward him, attempting to seize her other hand, Fan Changyu abruptly kicked him hard between the legs.

This time, it was Sui Yuanqing's turn to let out a muffled groan. He doubled over in pain, gritting his teeth as he spat, "You—"

He clearly hadn't expected Fan Changyu to resort to such an underhanded trick.

Changyu didn't care about fighting fair. As he hunched over, she drove her elbow sharply into the back of his neck—twice. Sui Yuanqing's vision swam with darkness, and he staggered before finally collapsing.

The commotion drew the attention of the bandits walking ahead.

Torches in hand, they turned and froze at the sight of Fan Changyu hauling the unconscious Sui Yuanqing like a dead dog.

Without hesitation, Changyu hoisted him onto the horse.

She would have preferred to finish him off right then with a knife, but Sui Yuanqing's earlier words held some truth—even at her peak, she might not have been able to take on this gang of bandits. Now, with one arm dislocated, the odds were even worse. Keeping him alive meant she could use him as a hostage if needed.

Everything happened in an instant. The bandits finally snapped out of their shock and shouted, "That woman's kidnapped the Fifth Leader!"

They brandished torches and blades, rushing to intercept her, but Changyu was already on horseback. Digging her heels into the horse's sides, she charged out of the alley. The bandits scrambled to avoid being trampled—some dodged, others were slammed into walls—but none managed to stop her.

The noise made Scarface Man, riding at the front, glance back. Through the flickering torchlight, he saw a powerful horse burst from the alley, carrying two figures. The one gripping the reins was unmistakably a woman.

She spotted him too. After a brief pause, she swiftly turned the horse and galloped in the opposite direction down the street.

The bandits who had chased her out of the alley yelled, "The Fifth Leader's on that woman's horse!"

Scarface Man recalled how the woman had clung to Sui Yuanqing earlier, her demeanor anything but that of a respectable woman. Realizing something was amiss, he spurred his horse after her. "Stop her!"

Fan Changyu led the pursuit for over ten miles beyond Lin'an Town. Some of the bandits were skilled archers, loosing arrows at her the entire way. Changyu shifted the unconscious Sui Yuanqing behind her, using him as a human shield. The archers hesitated, and their arrows no longer threatened her.

But her horse, burdened with two riders, couldn't outpace the mounted bandits. The longer the chase went on, the closer they got. The thunder of hooves behind her matched the frantic rhythm of her heartbeat.

Changyu estimated that Aunt Zhao and the others had already escaped Lin'an Town with Changning. If she could keep the horse running straight at the upcoming mountain bend, drawing the bandits after her, she could leap off and evade them—at least temporarily.

She glanced back at the man serving as her shield, then thought of the chaos in Qingping County and the innocent lives lost tonight. Her hand moved to the boning knife at her waist.

But before she could strike, the jolting ride roused Sui Yuanqing. His eyes snapped open to the glint of steel, and instinct drove him to seize her wrist with a crushing grip.

With the previous lesson of making him lose an arm, Fan Changyu reacted extremely quickly this time. Using his momentum, she leaned back sharply, driving her elbow hard into the wound on his chest.

Sui Yuanqing gasped in pain and released his grip on her wrist. As Fan Changyu twisted to stab again, he had no time to dodge, so he kicked at the back of her knee where it braced against the stirrup.

Losing her balance, Fan Changyu nearly toppled from the horse, and her blade veered off course, stabbing the horse's flank instead.

Just as she fell, the horse let out a pained whinny and bolted wildly.

Having barely dodged the knife, Sui Yuanqing now nearly got thrown off. At this speed, a fall would leave him either dead or missing limbs. Cursing under his breath, he had no choice but to grip the reins tightly to steady himself.

The ground was blanketed in a foot of snow. Fan Changyu rolled several times upon landing to disperse the impact, avoiding further injury—except for her dislocated arm, which had been jolted during the tumble, sending waves of agony through her. One of her shoes had also been torn off by the stirrup when she fell.

Ignoring the cold and the pain, she scrambled up, snatched the shoe, and hurled it toward the riverbank by the roadside before plunging into the dense, snow-laden forest on the other side.

Soon, the thunderous sound of hooves approached but didn't pause, chasing straight after the runaway horse.

Snow continued to fall heavily. Fan Changyu exhaled slowly.

She had thrown the shoe toward the river to mislead the bandits into thinking she had fled across the water.

Now, she trudged deeper into the pine forest. Snow was the worst for hiding—every step left tracks. Fortunately, it was night, and without

torches, the footprints would be hard to spot.

Still, Fan Changyu broke off a pine branch and swept away her trail. With the snowfall this heavy, the marks would soon be buried.

After erasing the tracks near the forest's edge, she discarded the branch and relied on the North Star to guide her forward.

With one foot bare, clad only in a felt sock, she staggered through the snow. The sock quickly soaked through, the biting cold creeping up from her sole until her entire leg grew numb. Her lips turned pale, and she shivered uncontrollably.

But Fan Changyu dared not stop for even a moment.

Changning was waiting for her—

A scouting party reached the borders of Qingping County and froze at the sight of the entire town engulfed in flames.

The well-trained scouts dismounted, preparing to gather intel, when they spotted a group of over a dozen elderly, women, and children supporting each other as they hobbled along the rugged path...

.....

Lucheng.

At dawn, a swift messenger horse raced toward the Yanzhou military camp.

"The entire Qingping County was slaughtered?"

Inside the central military tent, Gongsun Yin's usually composed and gentle face darkened with rare severity.

The scout who had rushed back overnight bowed his head. "By the time we arrived at Qingping County on your orders, it was already a city of the dead. While investigating, we stumbled upon a few surviving families by chance."

Gongsun Yin pressed urgently, "Where are they now?"

The scout replied, "I returned first to report. The rest of the unit escorted the survivors to Jizhou Prefecture."

Gongsun Yin paced the tent, hands clasped behind his back. "Was that butcher's daughter, Fan, among them?"

The scout reported, "No, but her younger sister was there. The dozen or so survivors said it was the butcher's daughter who hid them in the cellar of her home and entrusted them to care for her younger sister. After the bandits discovered the people hiding in the cellar, the butcher's daughter somehow lured them away. When the survivors emerged, they couldn't find her body, so they assumed the bandits had taken her back to their stronghold."

Gongsun Yin had never met Fan Changyu, but upon hearing his subordinate recount how she had been captured by the bandits to protect the others, he couldn't help but admire her courage and righteousness—qualities that rivaled any man's.

He dismissed the scout and summoned his personal guard. "Where is the Marquis now?"

The guard saluted and replied, "The Marquis went to survey the river valley terrain early this morning."

Gongsun Yin knew exactly why Xie Zheng had suddenly gone to inspect the valley. While Jinzhou and Huizhou relied on Chongzhou for their grain supply lines, Jizhou had an alternative water route for transporting grain. However, with the drop in river levels during winter, shipping had been suspended. Come spring, this route would reopen.

If Jizhou were also lost, Changxin Wang would truly have them by the throat.

To hold Jizhou, the barrier of Lucheng must not fall.

He and Xie Zheng had discussed it—the most effective way to counter Changxin Wang's fifty-thousand-strong army was to leverage the spring floods after the thaw.

Gongsun Yin ordered, "Send someone to find the Marquis immediately!"

No sooner had he spoken than a voice called from outside the tent, "Marquis."

Gongsun Yin, already overwhelmed, hurried out to greet him.

Dawn had just broken. The man approaching the tent wore black armor, his shoulder guards and cloak dusted with fine snow and morning frost. His sharp, handsome features carried a chilling aura, forbidding any direct gaze.

Gongsun Yin cut straight to the point. "Qingping County seems to have been targeted in a revenge attack—the entire town was slaughtered."

Xie Zheng paused while removing his cloak. "When did this happen?"

Gongsun Yin said, "The scout just brought the news. It appears to be the work of bandits. That butcher's daughter from Lin'an Town, surnamed Fan, was also captured by them. Something feels off—the whereabouts of Changxin Wang's heir remain unknown. Could this be his retaliation?"

Xie Zheng grabbed a sword from the rack and strode out. "Prepare horses. Assemble a hundred light cavalry and follow me to Qingping County!"

By dawn, Fan Changyu had finally reached the main road, having long since shaken off the bandits.

She had walked barefoot through the snow for half the night, utterly exhausted. Whether it was due to catching a cold or not, her head throbbed incessantly.

In her heart, she cursed Sui Yuanqing a thousand times, vowing to take his wretched life the next time they met.

Jizhou Prefecture lay south of Qingping County. After leaving the county, Aunt Zhao and the others would surely report to the authorities in Jizhou Prefecture. If she headed there as well, she would eventually reunite with them.

Hearing the sound of wheels in the distance, Fan Changyu reasoned that bandits either ambushed in groups or rode horses—they wouldn't operate with just a single carriage. So she didn't bother hiding.

As the carriage drew near, she glanced at it. Though not ornate, its wheels were larger than those of ordinary carriages, allowing it to move steadily through the snow. The shafts looked sturdy, and the canopy was made of a thick fabric she had never seen before.

Fan Changyu guessed this must belong to a wealthy household. After a brief look, she lowered her head and continued on her way.

The coachman noticed Fan Changyu was missing a shoe and remarked to the person inside the carriage, "That young lady truly fears no cold—walking barefoot in such heavy snow."

A pale, slender hand lifted the thick carriage curtain. Light-colored eyes reflected the snowy mountain scenery along the official road and the barefoot woman walking upon it. "She must have met with some mishap. Ask where she lives—we can give her a ride."

Since the master had spoken, the coachman dared not refuse. Stopping the carriage, he called out to Fan Changyu, "Young lady, where is your home? My master pities your hardship traveling in this snow and offers you a ride."

Fan Changyu knew her current condition was far from ideal. Her dislocated wrist, left untreated, had swollen badly, and her bare foot was so numb from cold and pain it had lost all sensation.

She didn't refuse out of pride. "I need to go to the Jizhou Prefecture office."

To report to the authorities.

The coachman said, "That's along our way. Come aboard."

After thanking them, Fan Changyu boarded the carriage.

When the curtain lifted, warmth rushed out to greet her.

On the seat inside, a young man reading a book wore a plain violet robe without any embroidery, yet it exuded an air of "great simplicity"—the essence of sophistication.

At first glance, Fan Changyu thought he truly looked the part of a scholar.

Unlike Song Yan's self-proclaimed nobility or Yan Zheng's casual irreverence, his brows and eyes carried a gentle serenity, like a sudden ray of warm sunlight breaking through the icy wilderness—unexpectedly comforting.

Noticing Fan Changyu staring blankly at him, the young man showed neither impatience nor mockery. He merely gave her a polite nod. Seeing her collar and hair damp with melted snow, he pushed the charcoal brazier toward her and handed her a cloak of unknown material, soft to the touch.

"Young lady, your shoes and socks are soaked. Warm yourself."

Fan Changyu was acutely aware of her disheveled state. Though the carriage interior appeared simple, there was an indescribable refinement

to it. She sat as close to the door as possible and shook her head. "Thank you, sir, but I'm not cold."

The frost and snow on her head and lashes had melted in the warmth, forming tiny droplets that clung to her like morning dew on a young leopard emerging from the forest at dawn.

Stripped of its ferocity, she instead appeared somewhat lost and pitiable.

Assuming she was uncomfortable with his presence, the young man closed his book and smiled kindly. "It's rather stuffy sitting in here for too long. I'll step outside for some air."

With that, he lifted the curtain and joined the coachman outside.

Fan Changyu stared blankly at the swaying heavy curtain for a moment.

The brazier's warmth gradually restored feeling to her frozen limbs. She still didn't take the cloak, folding it neatly and placing it on the seat.

She only used the brazier to dry her snow-dampened clothes.

The deerskin vambraces on her wrists grew uncomfortably hot from the heat, warming her entire arms through the fabric.

With one wrist dislocated, removing the vambrace would be troublesome—she wouldn't be able to fasten it again afterward—so she endured the heat.

When the vambraces became too hot, she lifted a hand to press against her cheek.

Remembering Yan Zheng's parting words, her chest inexplicably tightened.

Just as her clothes were nearly dry and she was about to invite the young man back inside, the carriage came to an abrupt halt.

Fan Changyu heard the muffled groan of the coachman outside and the sound of something heavy hitting the ground. In an instant, she tightened her grip on the boning knife hidden close to her body.

The sound of hoofbeats approached from outside the carriage, followed by a laughing remark: "We couldn't find the woman who injured the Fifth Leader, but we've managed to catch a big fish along the way."

The young man was clearly encountering such a situation for the first time. Though his voice carried a hint of panic, his words remained

composed: "Honorable heroes, please spare my servant's life. You may take all the valuables in the carriage. If that's not enough, I can write a letter home to fetch more silver."

The bandits blocking the road burst into laughter at his cooperation. "Good lad, you know what's what!"

Several bandits immediately stepped forward to lift the carriage curtain and inspect its contents. Fan Changyu, fearing recognition, had no choice but to shake out the cloak lying on the seat and drape it over herself. She could only hope that in the darkness of the previous night, with her face hidden beneath Sui Yuanqing's cloak, they wouldn't remember her exact appearance.

Before the curtain could be lifted, however, Fan Changyu first heard the sound of a blade piercing flesh.

Outside, the young man's voice rose in furious protest: "You... why did you kill him?"

The bandits laughed heartily. "You're the only one worth keeping for ransom, brother. Why should we bother hauling a servant around? Now, if there were women in that carriage, we'd gladly take them back to the stronghold."

When one bandit used his knife to flip open the carriage curtain, the figure inside kicked him flying over ten feet away. The remaining bandits were stunned by the sudden turn of events, momentarily frozen.

Cloaked, Fan Changyu lunged to the carriage shaft, swiftly cutting the harness ropes with her blade. With a leap onto the shaft, she landed atop the horse, gripping the reins tightly. As she urged the horse past the young man, she hauled him up by the waist.

"It's the woman who wounded the Fifth Leader! After her!" The bandits, now recovered, surged forward like hyenas.

The young man, clearly inexperienced on horseback, nearly tumbled off. "Grab onto my clothes!" Fan Changyu barked.

True to his propriety, even in mortal danger, he didn't overstep. He clung desperately to the fabric at her waist, yet still teetered precariously several times. Unable to spare the focus to secure him, Fan Changyu finally yanked him by the collar and laid him across the saddle in front of

her. Now he wouldn't fall—though the jolting threatened to turn his stomach inside out.

The pursuing bandits closed in relentlessly, while ahead, another group blocked the fork in the road. Their leader was none other than Scarface Man. The two groups collided, both momentarily bewildered.

Fan Changyu noticed the newcomers were bloodied and disheveled, as if fresh from a brutal fight. She couldn't guess whom they'd clashed with but instinctively veered onto the only clear path.

The original pursuers caught up, spotting the other group. "Big Boss, what brings you here?"

Scarface Man spat bitterly, "Clear Breeze Stronghold has been razed by imperial troops!"

The first group gaped. "What do we do now?"

"Capture that woman!" Scarface Man roared. "The troops are hunting the one who wounded Fifth Brother last night!"

As the two groups merged into a single relentless chase, Fan Changyu cursed inwardly. It wasn't as if she'd dug up their ancestors' graves—why were they chasing her like their lives depended on it?

The road stretched onward, ending at a desolate ferry crossing. In the bitter cold, only a single small boat waited—with no boatman in sight.

Fan Changyu dismounted and, using her uninjured hand, hauled the young man onto the only boat at the ferry. However, she didn't know how to pole the boat. After pushing off from the shore with the bamboo pole to send the boat a few meters into the water, she couldn't make it advance any further.

When the bandits caught up, they didn't care how icy the winter river was and plunged into the water like dumplings in a pot.

Fan Changyu tried to fend them off with the bamboo pole, but there were simply too many bandits, and some still managed to find gaps to grab onto the boat's sides.

Xie Zheng had destroyed Clear Breeze Stronghold but hadn't found Fan Changyu there. After interrogating a few bandits and learning that she had never been captured the previous night, he led his cavalry to hunt down the fleeing outlaws.

Chasing them all the way to the ferry, he spotted a woman's figure on the river from afar, which looked strikingly familiar. As he drew closer, he confirmed it was indeed Fan Changyu! Before the burning anxiety in his chest could settle, he noticed her desperately shielding a defenseless scholar on the boat. Xie Zheng's lips pressed into a tight line.

His personal guard caught up and, seeing Xie Zheng halt his horse, glanced at the man and woman besieged by bandits at the riverbank. "Marquis, it seems the bandits are trying to seize the boat."

Xie Zheng's voice was icy. "Fetch my bow."

His gaze, cold enough to freeze shards of ice, remained fixed on the young man sheltered behind Fan Changyu.

Chapter 59

The weather today was truly unfavorable, with fine snow falling continuously, and the river's edges covered in a layer of broken thin ice.

Fan Changyu had just used a bamboo pole to sweep away the bandits clinging to the ship's side when the young man behind her suddenly let out a cry. Turning around, she saw a bandit gripping one of his legs, dragging him forcefully toward the water.

More bandits were climbing onto the stern. With no time to spare, Changyu gritted her teeth, kicked the bandit at the stern into the water, and thrust the bamboo pole backward. The bandit holding the young man's ankle was shoved into the river before he could even take a breath, icy water flooding his mouth and nose, leaving him half-drowned.

The young man scrambled up, his leg and foot soaked, the biting cold turning his lips pale. Still, he remembered to thank her: "Thank you, miss —"

His expression suddenly changed as he shouted, "Watch out!"

Instinctively, Changyu swung the bamboo pole behind her to block. A scar-faced man leaped from the water, wielding a broadsword that came slashing down at her. The pole in her hands was cleanly severed in two.

Seeing the blade nearly upon her, dodging was impossible. Changyu leaned back to avoid a fatal strike while thrusting the sharp end of the broken pole forward. Though she intended to take at least one enemy down with her, the makeshift spear did pierce the scar-faced man—yet the blade meant for her left shoulder never landed.

A sharp whistling sound tore through the air as an arrow, carrying immense force, grazed past her temple. The gust of wind it left behind stung her cheeks.

"Clang—"

A metallic screech rang out as the arrow struck the scar-faced man's broadsword, sparks flying. The arrowhead shattered from the impact, and the steel blade cracked apart like broken ice.

More arrows followed, raining down on the bandits clinging to the ship's sides.

Everyone froze in shock.

The scar-faced man reacted swiftly, drawing a dagger to cut off the bamboo lodged in his body before diving into the water, no longer willing to stay exposed as a target.

Changyu looked toward the source of the arrows and saw a squad of cavalry with large bows charging forward. The soldiers on horseback wore identical heavy armor, making it impossible to tell who had fired the arrow that shattered the scar-faced man's blade.

Assuming the Jizhou Prefecture authorities had learned of the massacre in Qingping County and sent troops to suppress the bandits, she breathed a sigh of relief.

Most of the bandits were mere rabble, barely capable of wielding their weapons. Against mounted archers, they could only flee in panic.

Arrows fell like locusts upon the water. The bandits, clustered tightly together, soon filled the river with cries of agony, the surface tinged red with blood.

Unable to reach the shore and with the freezing water unbearable, a group of skilled swimmers among the bandits began pushing Changyu's boat toward the river's center.

When she realized the wooden boat was drifting farther from the dock, Changyu knew trouble was brewing.

Once out of the archers' range, she would be left alone to fend off these desperate bandits—a far more daunting task.

Moreover, the river's current was swift at its center. Without needing to row, the boat was swiftly carried downstream.

The soldiers on the shore had clearly noticed this as well and ceased firing arrows. Some of the troops who could swim removed their heavy armor and dove into the river.

The bandits who had pushed the wooden boat away from the ferry now surfaced from the water, intent on retaking the vessel. Fan Changyu had no time to worry about the young man. Grabbing him by the collar, she

muttered, "Forgive me!" before hurling him with all her strength toward the soldiers entering the water.

The young man paled in shock, barely managing to cry out, "Miss—!" before his body arced through the air and plunged into the river. Clearly unable to swim, he flailed desperately in the icy water, screaming for help. The soldiers swimming toward him struggled to avoid his flailing arms before finally seizing him by the nape and dragging him back to shore.

Xie Zheng watched from the bank, his lips pressed into a tight line. He nocked another arrow on his great bow. His personal guard wanted to point out that the boat had drifted too far—it was well beyond the range of any arrow—but in the next instant, a volley of white-feathered arrows exploded from his bowstring. One by one, corpses floated to the surface near the distant boat.

The landlubber cavalrymen on the shore stared in stunned silence before erupting into cheers. Yet Xie Zheng's expression remained icy.

The boat had reached the center of the river, carried downstream by the current. The arrows could no longer reach the bandits hiding beneath it.

The rescued young man lay on the ground, his face blue from the cold, soaked and coughing up water. As soon as he caught his breath, his first words to the surrounding soldiers were, "Quick, save the young woman on that boat!"

Xie Zheng shot him a cold glance before yanking his reins and galloping down the riverside highway. His guards, realizing he intended to pursue the boat by land, swiftly mounted their horses and followed.

—

Fan Changyu stood on the boat, gripping a broken bamboo pole, and thrust the last bandit attempting to climb aboard back into the water. The river surface grew still, as though all the bandits hiding beneath the boat had perished. Not daring to let her guard down, she cautiously scanned the water. Only the rippling current remained. Satisfied, she moved to the bow to pick up an oar and began rowing toward the shore.

She had only taken a few strokes when a sudden splash erupted from below. A bandit surfaced, startling her. Reacting instinctively, she swung the oar to strike. But the bandit was already dead—Scarface Man had used the distraction to leap up alongside the boat, slashing at Changyu's neck

with a dagger. She dodged, but the blade still grazed her arm, leaving a long gash.

Gritting her teeth against the pain, Changyu reversed her grip on the oar and rammed its handle into Scarface Man's abdomen—right where the bamboo pole had wounded him earlier. Though he had managed to board the boat, the blow to his injury sent him staggering back. He collapsed onto the deck, veins bulging at his temples from the agony.

Changyu drew her boning knife and lunged. Scarface Man's pupils contracted as he rolled aside, barely avoiding the strike. He retreated to the stern, panting, and attempted to negotiate: "Heroine, neither of us wants to die in this river, food for the fishes. Rather than fighting to mutual ruin, why not call a truce for now? Any grievances can be settled another day. What do you say?"

Changyu appeared to consider this seriously before sheathing her knife. "Fine."

Scarface Man exhaled in relief but remained at the stern, not daring to lower his guard for even a moment.

After navigating through the turbulent stretch, the river calmed, and the boat slowed down. The pursuing cavalry could now be seen on the shore.

Xie Zheng led the charge at the forefront. The elevated official road gave him a clear view of the distance from the riverside to the boat in the middle of the river. He whipped his warhorse twice, urging it forward with such speed that it left his personal guards far behind. Only after passing the boat on the river did he abandon his steed, swiftly removing his armor as he hurried toward the water's edge before diving in bare-chested.

The boat was drifting downstream with the current. To intercept it, he had to swim diagonally toward the center, requiring him to run ahead before making the crossing.

On the boat, Scarface Man only noticed the pursuing cavalry and grew visibly anxious. Fan Changyu, ever considerate, suggested, "How about I give you the oar, and you row yourself?"

Scarface Man hesitated but nodded.

Fan Changyu grabbed the oar from the bow and threw it toward him—along with the boning knife. At the same time, she lunged at him with the two-foot-long bamboo pole she had sharpened earlier.

Under this triple assault, Scarface Man had no time to dodge. He barely managed to evade the knife aimed at his throat and blocked the sharp bamboo pole with his hand. The oar struck him square in the face, nearly breaking his nose and sending blood gushing out.

What he didn't expect was that the bamboo pole was also a feint.

Fan Changyu had endured excruciating pain to grip the pole with her dislocated arm. She had tried to reset the joint earlier, but with no medical knowledge and suffering such an injury for the first time, she couldn't be sure of the exact alignment. Though she could now move her left arm, every motion sent searing pain through her bones, leaving her with little strength.

As Scarface Man blocked the pole, Fan Changyu grabbed his hair with her right hand and shoved his head underwater. Her eyes burned with ruthless determination.

Scarface Man thrashed desperately, but the hand pressing his skull down was unnaturally strong, preventing him from resurfacing.

Icy river water flooded his mouth and nose, threatening to choke his lungs.

Only when his struggles weakened did Fan Changyu yank him up briefly by the hair. Gasping and coughing, his former bravado gone, he begged, "Spare me, warrior! I'll serve you for life—"

Fan Changyu's thoughts flashed to the mourning hall draped in white and her parents' bodies in their coffins. Her gaze turned icy as she plunged him back into the water. After a moment, she hauled him up again, hatred lacing her voice. "Did you ambush a retired escort for a treasure map?"

Thinking she sought wealth, he babbled, "That map was fake! The real one is already in Changxin Wang's hands! But I've run Clear Breeze Stronghold for years—I have other hideouts! All my silver's stashed elsewhere! Let me live, and I'll give you everything—"

"You think a monster like you deserves to live?" Fan Changyu spat coldly. "How many died in Qingping County last night? Answer me—did you kill that escort?"

Recognizing her vengeful tone, Scarface Man hastily denied, "It wasn't me! It was Third Brother!"

The enemy was right before her eyes, and Fan Changyu's blood surged with fury. Her grip on Scarface Man's hair was so tight that her knuckles turned white: "Was it your stronghold's third-in-command who killed them?"

Scarface Man hurriedly replied, "Yes, yes, yes."

Fan Changyu roared, "Birds of a feather flock together! I'll kill you first, then go back and slaughter your third-in-command to avenge my parents!"

Scarface Man shouted, "You're Ma Taiyuan's daughter? Ma Taiyuan was a eunuch—how could he have descendants?"

Fan Changyu froze: "Who is Ma Taiyuan?"

Scarface Man said, "The chief escort of the Four Seas Armed Escort Agency. He was the one responsible for transporting the treasure map back then. A little inquiry would tell you his name."

He paused, then added, "Could it be that you've sought revenge on the wrong people?"

The authorities had clearly told her that her father was the one who escorted the treasure map back then—how did it become Ma Taiyuan?

Countless doubts swirled in Fan Changyu's mind as she demanded, "Last November, at Tiger Fork in Qingping County, a couple surnamed Fan was killed—wasn't it your Clear Breeze Stronghold's doing?"

Scarface Man cried out in protest: "The only job we pulled in Qingping County was last night's. Before that, we never came to Qingping County to kill anyone."

Suspecting he was lying to save his own skin, Fan Changyu shoved him back into the river: "Tell me the truth!"

Scarface Man thrashed about, half-dead already. When he was hauled up again, his face was purple, his eyes stinging from the icy water. He gasped, "I swear I'm telling the truth! Last November, our stronghold was locked in a feud with Black Dragon Stronghold—we didn't go out raiding. If you don't believe me, ask around!"

Now Fan Changyu was truly bewildered. Did that mean the group of black-clad men who had repeatedly attacked her home weren't bandits after all?

Having fought these bandits firsthand, Fan Changyu recalled the skills of those black-clad men. Though she hated to admit it, their martial prowess was extraordinary—nothing like ordinary bandits.

Then what really caused her parents' deaths?

The cold and the emotional turmoil made Fan Changyu's head throb with pain.

Her grip on Scarface Man loosened slightly. Seizing the chance, he reached back, grabbed her arms, and yanked her into the river.

The dislocated left arm sent searing pain through her at the slightest touch. Caught off guard, Fan Changyu was truly dragged into the water by Scarface Man, choking on a mouthful of river water.

After enduring Fan Changyu's humiliation for so long, Scarface Man didn't immediately try to kill her. Instead, with a vicious grin, he pressed her head underwater, letting her struggle until she was nearly spent before pulling her up—only to repeat the torment.

"You bitch! Where's all that strength from earlier when you were dunking me? Why aren't you fighting back now?"

His face was alight with vengeful glee.

Fan Changyu had no strength left. Starved for oxygen, she instinctively gasped for breath even underwater, bubbles streaming from her nose and mouth as the cold water flooded her lungs, the pain excruciating.

Her eyes burned. She knew she might die here.

But what about Changning?

Changning...

In the last second before losing consciousness, Fan Changyu seemed to hear the "crack" of something dislocating. Then the hand gripping her hair suddenly let go, and something warm and soft pressed against her lips. To someone about to die in the icy river, that warmth felt like the world's final comfort.

Her eyes closed heavily at last.

After Xie Zheng shared a breath with Fan Changyu, he quickly carried her to the surface. The corpse of Scarface Man floated nearby, his head

twisted halfway around, his neck bent at an unnatural angle. Even in death, his wide eyes remained frozen in terror.

The personal guards who arrived saw Xie Zheng had personally dived into the water to rescue her and hurriedly waded in to assist.

Xie Zheng had already carried Changyu to the shallows. Without a word, he strode toward the shore with her in his arms, his face darker than ever before. Water dripped from his tensed arms, veins bulging beneath his skin, the sheer ferocity around him suffocating.

A personal guard holding dry clothes stepped forward, about to call out, but instinctively fell silent. Remembering Xie Zheng never allowed women near him, the guard offered, "Marquis, let me carry the young lady."

But Xie Zheng ignored the guard's outstretched hands entirely. Instead, he wrapped his cloak around Changyu's drenched form and continued walking with her in his arms.

The guards stood frozen, still processing what had happened, when his icy, ruthless voice cut through the air:

"Take the bandit leader's corpse back. Whip it."

Even these hardened soldiers, who had cut down men like melons on the battlefield, felt a chill crawl down their spines at his command.

Chapter 60

After coming ashore, Xie Zheng set Fan Changyu down for the moment. As his fingers pressed against her wrist to check her pulse, his gaze lingered briefly on the pair of deerskin bracers wrapped around her sleeves.

His eyes then traveled downward to her left hand, swollen beyond recognition. His already tightly pressed lips thinned even further into a straight line.

She hadn't suffered such severe injuries even when pursued by the Wei Mansion's martial assassins, yet now, after encountering mere mountain bandits, she was in such a pitiful state.

He reached out to remove the vambrace from that hand before focusing on taking her pulse. But the pulse beneath his fingertips was alarmingly weak, and the body in his arms was as cold as ice—hardly resembling a living person.

The scent of blood filled Xie Zheng's senses, making his brow furrow deeply.

She shouldn't be like this.

In his memory, she had always been warm, no matter the circumstances.

But now, this icy body seemed to be telling him that her life was slipping away bit by bit.

An inexplicable turmoil churned in his chest, and a sudden sense of panic left him restless, his violent impulses urging him to kill.

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze to Fan Changyu's tightly shut eyes. She was completely drenched, her hands and face tinged blue and purple from prolonged exposure to the cold. The wet clothes clung to her, and the cloak wrapped around her did little to provide warmth.

She was too cold—she needed warmth, and quickly.

Xie Zheng swept a glance over his personal guards and ordered in a deep voice, "Leave my clothes here, then retreat ten paces away and turn your backs."

The guards exchanged uncertain looks, but after realizing what Xie Zheng intended to do, though startled, they quickly complied.

Once they had withdrawn, Xie Zheng studied Fan Changyu's discolored complexion. His fingers paused slightly as they reached her collar. Untying her hair ribbon, he used it to blindfold himself before carefully peeling off her soaked garments. Then, feeling his way, he wrapped her in the dry clothes he had removed before entering the water earlier.

With his vision obscured, the sensation at his fingertips became all the more pronounced. By the time he had securely bundled Fan Changyu up, fine beads of sweat had formed at the tip of his nose. He pulled off the blindfold in silence.

Wordlessly, he took hold of Changyu's left arm. Even before changing her clothes, he had noticed it was dislocated. Upon further examination, he realized the bone had been set incorrectly.

Even injured like this, she had still protected that scholar—was she truly unafraid of dying at the hands of those bandits?

He couldn't quite name the emotion stirring in his chest.

For a fleeting moment, he thought bitterly—what did it matter to him if she died?

Yet when he reset the bone with a firm push and release, his movements were deliberately gentle.

Xie Zheng's expression darkened. Once the bone was back in place, he called for a guard to fetch a wooden splint to temporarily immobilize her hand.

The guards had never seen him treat a woman like this before, leaving them uncertain of his intentions. After Xie Zheng had temporarily tended to all of Changyu's injuries, one guard ventured, "Marquis, shall we proceed to Jizhou Prefecture now?"

Xie Zheng glanced at Fan Changyu, whose complexion remained pallid and discolored. Finally, he lifted her into his arms and strode toward his warhorse. "First, we'll find a household to take shelter."

All his clothes were now wrapped around Fan Changyu. The river wind cut like a knife against his bare torso, his damp fringe dripping water down his forehead. Yet he didn't so much as shiver. His muscles were taut

and well-defined, lean but far from frail—every inch of him brimming with strength.

The personal guards watched in astonishment as their Marquis, bare-chested, carried the tightly wrapped woman onto his horse. Without time to process their shock, they quickly mounted their own steeds and followed.

The horse's gait was rough, but Xie Zheng carefully avoided Fan Changyu's dislocated arm, cradling her protectively against his chest. Feeling the weight of her against him, his grip on the reins tightened.

He glanced down at Changyu's lifeless profile and said coldly, "You'd better stay alive. Who do you think will take care of that little burden of yours otherwise?"

Only the howling wind answered him. Pressing his lips together, he tightened his hold around her.

The hundred light cavalymen following Xie Zheng were all seasoned scouts. They quickly located a lone dwelling in the wilderness—home to an elderly blind woman living by herself.

Not wanting to disturb her, Xie Zheng took only a few personal guards with him. Knowing common folk feared soldiers, they posed as traveling merchants, offering the old woman a few taels of silver in exchange for the use of a bedroom and kitchen.

Some guards set to boiling water in the kitchen, while others inquired about nearby physicians before rushing off to fetch one.

Initially suspicious of the group of men carrying an unconscious woman, the old woman relaxed upon hearing their activities—human traffickers wouldn't go to such lengths for their victims.

She fetched some of her daughter-in-law's clothes and brought them to the room. "What happened to this poor lady? Did she fall into the water?" she asked.

Three braziers burned in the small room, making Xie Zheng sweat even bare-chested, yet Changyu remained icy cold beneath the blankets.

Without a bathtub in the house, Xie Zheng couldn't immerse her in hot water to warm her quickly. Instead, he used steaming cloths to massage her frozen limbs.

After rewetting a cooled cloth in the hot water basin and wrapping it around her hands, he answered, "We encountered river bandits. She jumped into the water to escape and caught a chill."

"What a tragedy..." The old woman sighed with pity at the mention of bandits.

She handed over the clothes. "These belonged to my daughter-in-law. Change your wife into them later."

Xie Zheng thanked her.

"You must be soaked too, escaping the river in this cold," she added. "I'll find some of my son's clothes for you."

After she left, Xie Zheng sat silently by Changyu's side on the crude wooden bed. Gradually, the bluish pallor faded from her face, replaced by a feverish flush.

He pressed a hand to her forehead—burning hot, as expected. Frowning, he replaced the hand compress with a fresh hot cloth for her forehead.

By the time the guards returned with the physician, Changyu's face was flushed crimson.

Half-dead from the rough horseback ride, the physician barely had time to catch his breath before being shoved into the room to take her pulse.

Though he might have complained under other circumstances, facing a group of armed soldiers left him no choice but to focus on surviving the house call.

Upon entering the room and realizing the patient was a woman, the physician was startled but dared not ask further. As he took her pulse, his already wrinkled brow furrowed even deeper. "This is an invasion of pathogenic cold," he said. "How could it have been left this long before calling a physician? Someone with a weaker constitution might not have survived."

No sooner had he spoken than he felt a cold, heavy gaze settle upon him.

The physician looked at the strikingly handsome man standing bare-chested in the midst of winter and felt his heart race under that stare. He hurriedly added, "But it's not hopeless. Medicine alone won't suffice—she needs Gua sha to stimulate blood flow and unblock the meridians. Dispelling the cold first will make the medicine twice as effective."

Xie Zheng had heard of using Gua sha to treat cold ailments. It was a common folk remedy among soldiers, painful but sometimes more effective than medicine.

His gaze fell on Fan Changyu, whose lips were cracked from fever. After a moment of silence, he said, "Understood."

The physician was taken to the kitchen to prepare the medicine, while Xie Zheng had his personal guard bring another basin of warm water.

Apart from the blind elderly woman, everyone here was male, and Gua sha required visual assessment of the skin's reaction. It fell to him.

Xie Zheng dipped a copper coin into the warm water, watching Fan Changyu's flushed face. "You'll probably accuse me of taking advantage when you wake up," he murmured.

There was no response.

Gua sha was performed on the back, but Fan Changyu's left arm was immobilized with a splint, making it impossible for her to lie prone.

He casually threw on a robe belonging to the old woman's son and approached the bed, lifting Fan Changyu to sit upright with her back against him. Turning his face aside, he reached to untie the sash at her waist.

As the sash loosened, the oversized robe slid down her arms.

Xie Zheng retrieved the copper coin from the basin and gathered her disheveled hair over her shoulders. Though he had resolved to remain detached, the sight of her smooth, evenly toned back made his breath hitch slightly.

Unlike the rugged musculature of a man or the boneless softness of the dancers he'd seen at victory banquets, her taut muscles formed a slender waistline—delicate yet strong, exuding a resilient beauty.

Her skin, once blue from the cold, had regained a pale hue.

Earlier, fearing she might freeze, Xie Zheng had removed even her soaked undergarments when changing her clothes. Now, with her head lolling weakly, her pale, vulnerable neck was exposed, save for the cascade of dark hair spilling over one shoulder.

The inner garment half-concealing the curve of her waist was also his...

This realization sent something exploding in Xie Zheng's mind, the copper coin in his fingers suddenly scalding.

He frowned sharply, averting his gaze for a few steady breaths before forcing his focus back onto the coin. He began scraping it down her snow-white back.

The first stroke left only a faint redness. By the second, the marks darkened noticeably. He continued until the skin turned a deep crimson before moving to the next area.

Fan Changyu, heavily afflicted by the cold, remained unconscious throughout, entirely reliant on Xie Zheng's supporting hand to stay upright.

By the end, her back was a sight—covered in purplish-red Gua sha marks, yet carrying a strangely brutal beauty.

Xie Zheng's fingertips burned intensely, fine beads of sweat forming on his forehead and the bridge of his nose. After tossing the copper coins into the water basin, he hastily grabbed a piece of clothing to wrap Fan Changyu in, bundled her into the blankets, then fled through the door.

The biting wind and light snow against his face finally cooled the heat within him.

When his personal guard arrived with the freshly brewed medicine, he found Xie Zheng leaning against a wooden pillar beneath the eaves, arms crossed, seemingly staring blankly at the door—so lost in thought that he hadn't even noticed the approaching footsteps.

The guard cleared his throat softly. "Marquis... Master, the medicine is ready."

Xie Zheng snapped out of his daze and glanced at him, reaching out to take the bowl.

Just as the guard was about to tactfully withdraw, he heard his usually stern and unyielding master ask, "Among common folk, this would mean having to marry the girl, wouldn't it?"

The guard froze for a moment before realizing Xie Zheng was referring to himself and the woman inside.

Wouldn't you have to take responsibility for her no matter where you are? the guard thought. Seeing his master acting so out of character—

clearly not indifferent to the woman—why was he even asking such a question?

He could only answer truthfully. "Of course, you would."

Before Xie Zheng could say more, a scout stationed a few miles away hurried into the courtyard to report, "Master, Jizhou Prefecture's troops are searching along the riverbank."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids slightly. "Are they also looking for the Clear Breeze Stronghold's bandit leader?"

The scout glanced at him and replied cautiously, "It seems they're searching for the young lady inside. That scholar we fished out of the river earlier is Grand Tutor Li's grandson. Right now, he's helping the Jizhou troops look for her."

A cold smirk tugged at Xie Zheng's lips. He was aware that Grand Tutor Li had sent his grandson, Li Huaian, to Jizhou.

Wei Xuan's reckless grain requisition had caused such a disaster, handing Grand Tutor Li—who had always been at odds with the Wei Faction—a perfect weapon. Previously, the entire northwest had been under Wei Yan's control, but after this incident, Grand Tutor Li's faction had nearly come to blows with Wei Yan in court. Now, they had finally sent one of their own—ostensibly to assist with the northwest's military affairs, but in truth, it was all about seizing power.

With Li Huaian in Jizhou, Grand Tutor Li's faction now had eyes in the northwest, a region long dominated by Wei Yan.

What he hadn't expected was that this man was also entangled with Fan Changyu.

Was it a coincidence, or had Grand Tutor Li's faction also caught wind of something and was now probing into the Fan Family's secrets?

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze to the steaming medicine in his hands, his tone casual but laced with frost. "Guard the mountain pass. Don't let anyone through."

Once the scout had left to carry out his orders, Xie Zheng carried the medicine bowl back into the room.

Inside, Fan Changyu lay quietly beneath the blankets, the feverish flush on her cheeks not yet faded, giving her face some color.

Xie Zheng sat by the bed and watched her for a while before remarking, "I told you before—your judgment is terrible."

Having undergone gua sha and warmed up, Changyu was now deeply asleep and couldn't respond.

Feeding her medicine became an ordeal. Forcing her mouth open, he poured it in, only for most of it to spill out. Displeased, he wiped her face with a nearby piece of clothing—whose it was, he didn't know—but still patiently fed her the remaining medicine bit by bit.

The fire in the brazier crackled softly, its glow flickering across his sharply defined profile. Using his thumb, he wiped away the last traces of medicine from Changyu's lips, staring down at her in silence for a long moment before suddenly saying, "Fan Changyu, I'll marry you."

"If you don't say anything, I'll take it as your agreement."

Chapter 61

Fan Changyu slept restlessly, her fever spiking again during the night.

She was trapped in a nightmare, her vision filled with a vast expanse of white snowfields as heavy snowflakes fell in thick clusters.

Clad in thin garments and barefoot, she ran desperately across the snow, her feet nearly numb from the cold, yet she dared not stop.

At first, Fan Changyu didn't know what she was chasing—until she spotted a couple walking hand in hand through the distant snow. Then she understood why she was in such a hurry.

It's Father and Mother!

She ran even harder, her chest aching with a sour, swelling pain as hot tears welled up in her eyes. "Father! Mother!" she called out.

The two figures ahead weren't moving quickly, yet no matter how hard she tried, she couldn't catch up. Frustration and despair nearly brought her to tears.

Finally, the woman in the snow turned around, her face as gentle as Changyu remembered. "Be good, Changyu," she said softly. "Go back."

Fan Changyu didn't understand why she felt so heartbroken. As tears streamed down her face, her chest throbbed with pain. "Where are you going?" she asked helplessly.

The woman didn't answer, only turned back to continue walking alongside the man.

Changyu stood frozen, feeling as though she had forgotten something. Her chest tightened painfully, and breathing became agonizing, as if she were drowning.

When Xie Zheng returned with a basin of warm water to cool her fever, he found her trapped in the nightmare—her body convulsing uncontrollably, drenched in sweat that soaked her hair and underclothes. Her pale face was flushed an unnatural red from the high fever, her murmurs incoherent, and her eyes damp with tears.

"Nightmare?"

This was the first time Xie Zheng had seen her in such a disheveled, vulnerable state. His chest tightened as if stuffed with damp cotton—soft yet suffocating. He shook her gently. "Wake up."

But Fan Changyu was too deeply ensnared by the nightmare, showing no signs of waking.

Seeing her thrash dangerously close to injuring her left arm again, he carefully avoided the wound and pressed a hand against her shoulder to still her movements. Coldly, he ordered the personal guard outside, "Fetch the physician!"

Earlier, after the physician had examined her and her condition seemed stable, Xie Zheng had sent him back with the guards, as the old woman's home had no spare room for him to stay.

Who could have predicted Fan Changyu would suddenly convulse in the night?

What kind of nightmare was this?

Xie Zheng frowned unconsciously. Noticing blood seeping from her tightly clenched lips, he reached to pry her jaw open but accidentally had his knuckles bitten instead.

He tried to pull free, but her teeth only clamped down harder, instantly breaking skin and leaving a ring of bloody teeth marks.

With only a slight furrow of his brow, Xie Zheng let her keep biting his index finger.

Feeling her entire body tremble in his arms, the sight of her frail, curled-up frame stirred long-buried memories. He had never comforted anyone in his life, yet now, after a hesitant pause, he softened his voice. "It's just a nightmare. There's nothing to fear."

In his childhood, the woman's blood-stained skirt hanging from the beam had been his own relentless nightmare. Every time he woke up convulsing, he was either alone in endless darkness or met with Wei Yan standing coldly by his bed, staring at him like a dead dog.

Wei Xuan would lead the children of the Wei clan to mock him, imitating his convulsions during nightmares for their amusement.

Later, he was no longer afraid of nightmares.

Having crawled out from mountains of corpses and seas of blood, the blood on his blade was thicker than the vengeful spirits in his dreams.

At this moment, Fan Changyu's trembling figure seemed to overlap with the memory of his younger self.

Xie Zheng's eyes darkened. While waiting for the physician, he let Changyu bite down on his knuckle, half-holding her as he stiffly patted her back in slow, soothing motions.

The words he repeated most often were: "Don't be afraid."

Don't be afraid—nightmares always end.

By the time the personal guard hauled the physician from his bed, flung him onto a horse, and galloped back, Changyu had already calmed down, though she had exhausted herself and fallen into a deep sleep once more.

Xie Zheng sat casually on a wooden chair in the room, his left index finger bearing a row of bloody bite marks. His gaze was distant, his lashes half-lowered, strands of hair falling over his eyes as if lost in thought.

Only when the trembling physician was carried through the door did Xie Zheng's lazy yet oppressive glance sweep over him. "She had a nightmare," he said flatly.

The physician, dragged from his bed in the dead of night like a sleepwalker, had expected some dire emergency—only to find it was just a nightmare!

Indignation clogged his throat, yet he dared not voice a single complaint. Under the man's piercing gaze, cold sweat broke out down his back, and he resigned himself to checking the unconscious woman's pulse with trembling hands.

To his surprise, her pulse, which had been weak that afternoon, was now much steadier.

Stealing a glance at the strikingly handsome yet grim-faced man beside her, the physician didn't dare say the woman was perfectly fine. After much deliberation, he prescribed a sedative. "Your wife must have suffered a fright. This calming draught will help her sleep more soundly."

The personal guard looked to Xie Zheng, who gave a slight nod, before escorting the physician to the kitchen to prepare the medicine.

Once the sedative was ready, Xie Zheng pried open Changyu's jaw again and fed it to her spoon by spoon.

Only then did the two rows of bloody bite marks on his left index finger begin to throb faintly.

He glanced at them after finishing the task but said nothing.

The guard hesitantly offered травма medicine. "Marquis, should you tend to your wound?"

Xie Zheng dismissed the minor injury with a wave. "It's nothing."

As the guard retreated with the bowl, he stole another glance at the unconscious Fan Changyu, his mind reeling.

Though her looks were pleasing, she was hardly a peerless beauty—so why had the Marquis taken such an interest in her?

Then he recalled how she had single-handedly lifted a grown man and hurled him across the room, and a shiver ran down his spine.

That arm strength... was probably on par with their Marquis's, wasn't it?

After taking the sedative, Changyu indeed slept deeply for the rest of the night without fever returning.

Xie Zheng dozed lightly by the bedside for two hours. At the first light of dawn, a soft knock sounded at the door.

He checked on Changyu, noting her deep slumber, then took the cloak from the stool and left the room without a sound.

The personal guard outside the house lowered his voice hastily upon seeing him emerge: "Marquis, we've located Sui Yuanqing's whereabouts—he was indeed hiding in Clear Breeze Stronghold! When the stronghold was raided, he escaped with some of its members through a rear mountain path during the chaos. Now our men have driven them to Pineshade Mountain."

Xie Zheng's eyes gleamed with icy resolve: "Block all mountain exits and release the hounds. Let's see how long he can hide."

The guard couldn't conceal his excitement as he clasped his fists: "I'll see to it immediately!"

A cold wind swept by. Xie Zheng watched a frost-laden withered leaf drift to his feet and suddenly remarked, "The wind blows from the

southwest today."

Before the guard could grasp his meaning, Xie Zheng continued: "Create heavy smoke upwind. Bring the bandit leader's corpse along too—flog it posthumously."

After a startled pause, the guard's face lit up with greater delight: "As you command, my lord!"

Flogging the Clear Breeze Stronghold chief's corpse at Pineshade Mountain's base would surely terrify the remaining bandits hiding above. After the smoke had choked them thoroughly, releasing the hounds would guarantee flushing out the remnants. With all exits guarded, it would be like catching turtles in a jar—

Another heavy snow day, yet Pineshade Mountain was shrouded in thick smoke. Massive piles of burning pine and cypress branches sent billowing clouds drifting deep into the forest with the wind, while hounds weaved through the dense woods, their barks rising and falling like wolves chasing prey.

The bandits scattered in panic, only to be ambushed by waiting soldiers whenever they appeared on mountain paths. Yet when the smoke cleared and the troops tallied their captives, neither Sui Yuanqing nor the female bandit from Clear Breeze Stronghold was among them.

The young officer pressed his blade against a bandit's throat: "Where are Qin Yuan and that Yan woman?"

The bandit pleaded: "I don't know! When the smoke came, we all scattered running from the dogs in the woods."

Seeing no answers forthcoming, the officer sent search parties uphill—only to find two soldiers with slit throats, stripped of their armor.

"Damn it!" the officer swore darkly. "After them—down the mountain now!"

At a mountain foot where a stream gurgled, two figures in soldiers' garb who had galloped dozens of miles along the official road finally reined in. They tumbled from their horses to the riverbank and, ignoring the snow, knelt to gulp the icy water greedily.

One—a woman by her high-pitched sobs—suddenly broke into wrenching tears by the bank. The man beside her, having drunk his fill, lay gasping in the snow without offering comfort. When recovered, he

removed his armor and hurled it into the river before striding toward the warhorses.

Seeing him prepare to leave alone, the weeping woman's cries hitched in alarm. She scrambled after him: "Brother Qin! Where are you going?"

These were Sui Yuanqing (now "Qin Yuan") and Yan Thirteen Sister—having killed two soldiers for their uniforms to escape Pineshade Mountain. As Sui Yuanqing mounted, the woman desperately clutched his arm.

He looked down at her tearful face. Tall for a woman, with plain features and the windburned cheeks of mountain girls, she'd have been fit only for menial work in Changxin Prince Manor.

He thought he had fallen for women who were skilled in martial arts and wild at heart, but now it seemed that wasn't the case.

The only one who truly made his heart itch was that woman.

He had a pair of mesmerizing peach-blossom eyes, especially charming when he smiled.

Now, as he curled his lips, he slowly pried Thirteen Sister's fingers from his arm: "The world is vast, and I have my own path. Farewell."

His smile was cold, yet still captivating.

Thirteen Sister froze. When she came to her senses, she clutched Sui Yuanqing desperately, her nails digging into his flesh through his clothes as she shrieked hysterically, "What do you mean? You're leaving me behind?"

Sui Yuanqing raised a brow slightly, as if her question was foolish, and smirked. "Why not?"

Her nails were too sharp, stinging his arm.

Frowning, he lost all patience, yanked her hand away, and mounted his horse in one swift motion.

Thirteen Sister cried bitterly, "Qin Yuan, you heartless bastard! My brother distracted the officers so we could escape! How can you betray him like this?"

Sui Yuanqing scoffed. "Escaping the authorities is a matter of skill. Or do you think those people on Yansong Mountain died for nothing?"

Thirteen Sister wailed, "Have you forgotten I saved you from the riverbank? You can't do this to me—"

Sui Yuanqing suddenly grinned, even leaning down from his horse to meet her gaze. "You saved me, but didn't I also get you out of Yansong Mountain? Why can't I do this to you?"

With that, he straightened, tugged the reins, and rode off without another glance.

Thirteen Sister screamed curses after him, "Qin Yuan, may you die a wretched death!"

Sui Yuanqing ignored her cries, galloping away before finally pulling out the painting he had later retrieved from the Fan Family.

The painting depicted what seemed like a family of three—a strikingly handsome man, a woman with a lively, sweet smile, and a mischievous little girl who looked just like her.

The wound on his shoulder, stabbed by Fan Changyu, still ached, but Sui Yuanqing's mood suddenly brightened.

From the moment he found this painting, he had guessed that the masked man who wounded him was Xie Zheng.

As for the woman in the painting and her connection to him...

Could she be his secret lover?

And the child—their daughter?

Sui Yuanqing studied the painting again. The woman appeared to be a young maiden, but if she had a child that age, she'd have to be at least twenty.

Then he recalled his elder brother's runaway concubine, who had borne a son yet still looked like a girl, and slowly accepted the possibility.

No wonder that woman had guarded the dry well so fiercely. Xie Zheng must have left Qingping County due to the war, and knowing she couldn't escape with a child, she hid the girl inside.

The thought that she had already borne Xie Zheng a daughter darkened Sui Yuanqing's expression. He tucked the painting back into his robes, spurred his horse, and rode on.

No matter what, this trip to Qingping County wasn't entirely fruitless.

At the very least, he had discovered the Wu'an Marquis's weakness.

Chapter 62

Fan Changyu woke up feeling sore all over.

Her gaze fell upon the patched bed curtains. Propping herself up on her right arm, she took in the modest room—low walls of packed earth, gaps sealed with wooden planks, and a single square table with two stools, both worn and riddled with wormholes.

She remembered being held underwater by the mountain bandit leader before losing consciousness. Had someone saved her?

Fan Changyu glanced down at her clothes—they weren't her own. Her wounds had been bandaged, and her dislocated wrist had been reset.

Gripping the aged bedpost, she tried to stand, but the moment she put weight on her back, a sharp pain made her grimace.

She wondered—her waist hadn't been injured, so why did it hurt so much? Had she knocked it somewhere during the fight without realizing it?

After so many twists of fate, her instincts drove her to search for her Boning knife, her means of self-defense. Only when she spotted the knife and the pair of Deerskin bracers Yan Zheng had given her on the low stool by the bed did she finally exhale in relief.

Her fingers brushed over the smooth, supple leather of the vambraces as she lowered her gaze, preparing to fasten one to her right wrist. But then, hurried footsteps sounded outside.

Her expression shifted instantly. Pressing against the wall, she moved to the door and peered through the half-finger-wide crack in the weathered wooden panel.

Outside appeared to be a small farmyard. Two armored soldiers with swords stood beneath the eaves, and another strode briskly into the courtyard.

Fan Changyu relaxed slightly. It seemed she had been rescued by the soldiers who had chased the wooden boat ashore that day.

But why was she still here?

“Is... the master here? The troops from Jizhou Prefecture are closing in—we can’t hold them off much longer...” The soldier who had just entered spoke in a hushed voice.

Fan Changyu’s relief vanished. Weren’t they soldiers from Jizhou Prefecture? Why were they blocking their own people?

One of the soldiers guarding the courtyard replied, “Word came back from Yansong Mountain. The master went to question them. Take some men and hold the pass. Once he returns, I’ll report to him.”

The messenger nodded and quickly departed.

Fan Changyu leaned against the door, her entire body tense.

She had no idea who this “master” they spoke of was.

But dressed as military men, operating within Jizhou, yet seemingly at odds with the local authorities... Could they be bandits in disguise?

The realization sent a chill down her spine.

Just then, the two soldiers outside began chatting. One said, “We can’t stay here long. If we run into Jizhou’s forces, the master’s identity will be exposed. Once he returns, whether that woman inside is awake or not, we’ll have to move.”

The other clicked his tongue. “Seems the master’s taken a peculiar interest in her. Last night, when she had a Nightmare and started convulsing, he was afraid she’d bite her tongue—so he stuck his own finger in her mouth! His index finger’s got a bloody ring of teeth marks now.”

Fan Changyu still remembered the nightmare she’d had. Hearing that she had bitten their so-called master, she frowned.

She wanted to eavesdrop further, but suddenly, the tapping of a bamboo cane against the ground reached her ears. Peering through the crack again, she saw a white-haired, blind old woman approaching from under the eaves.

The soldier outside asked, “What brings you here, elder?”

The old woman held a stack of clothes in her arms and smiled kindly. “Your young mistress’s clothes from when she fell in the water yesterday—I’ve dried them and brought them for her.”

The soldier hesitated for a moment, seemingly reluctant to enter due to propriety between men and women, and stepped aside saying, "You may go in."

While the old woman was tapping her wooden cane to find her way and shuffling through the door, Fan Changyu had already silently and swiftly retreated to the bedside. She kicked off her shoes and lay back on the bed, pretending to still be asleep.

Once inside, the old woman groped her way to the bed, set down the clothes, and tucked the blanket around Fan Changyu. She then felt Changyu's forehead and murmured to herself, "Good girl, at least the fever's gone. How terrible that you and your husband encountered bandits on the boat and suffered so much. But thankfully, you have such a caring husband..."

After rambling on for a while, she fumbled her way to the brazier to add a couple more logs before finally closing the door behind her.

The soldier outside had glanced into the room when the old woman entered. Seeing the lump under the covers, he assumed Changyu was still asleep and averted his gaze to resume his post.

The moment the door closed, Changyu's eyes snapped open.

After hearing the old woman's words, she became even more certain that these people were not real soldiers. If the authorities had rescued her, why would they claim she had encountered bandits on a boat? And why pretend to be her husband?

As for the "master" mentioned by the two lackeys outside, Changyu instinctively thought of Sui Yuanqing.

That man had always been part of the Rebel King's faction. After being wounded by Yan Zheng, he had fled into the river and was rescued by the Clear Breeze Stronghold. Now, leading this group of bandits disguised as soldiers, he was surely up to no good!

The Jizhou Prefecture soldiers were nearby. She had to find a way to break out and report this.

Uncertain how many bandits were outside, Changyu dared not act rashly. After some thought, she smoothed out her vambrace and tucked it into her chest like armor, then strapped the boning knife to her leg,

covering it with her skirt. Only then did she get out of bed and kick over a stool, pretending the noise was from a fall.

As expected, the men outside immediately pushed open the door. Inside, Changyu was leaning weakly against the table, one hand propping her up as if she might collapse at any moment. Pale-faced, she said, "I need to use the latrine."

One of the soldiers blurted out, "There's a chamber pot in the corner—"

His companion elbowed him sharply, reminding him that this was a woman—and one their Marquis fancied—making his remark far too crude. He promptly shut his mouth.

Changyu feigned distress and urgency. "Sir, my stomach hurts terribly."

This couldn't be resolved indoors. The two soldiers didn't stop to wonder why Changyu had suddenly developed stomach pains upon waking. Since she was someone their Marquis favored, they didn't dare touch her and instead called the old woman to help her to the latrine.

The latrine was behind the house. As the old woman supported her, Changyu took the opportunity to scout the area and count the bandits. To her surprise, she found only the two at the door.

This made things much easier.

On their way back, passing under the eaves, Changyu suddenly punched the soldier on the right without warning. The man was stunned, staring blankly at her with blood streaming from his nose before collapsing unconscious.

The soldier on the left froze, but before he could react, Changyu—separated from him by the old woman—grabbed the bamboo cane from the old woman's hand and swung it hard at his neck. The cane snapped in two, and the soldier crumpled to the ground.

The old woman stood bewildered, her face full of fear. "What's happening?"

Fan Changyu didn't know when "Sui Yuanqing" and the other bandits would return. Though she had acted swiftly, her palms were still slick with sweat. She crouched halfway in front of the old woman and said, "These people are bad men. The one who brought me here isn't my husband either. Granny, quickly climb onto my back. I'll take you away."

The old woman was terrified and hesitated as she climbed onto Fan Changyu's back. "Young lady, how can you carry an old bag of bones like me with one arm dislocated?"

The old woman was very thin, so carrying her with one arm wasn't a problem for Fan Changyu. After stepping outside, she quickly surveyed the terrain and said, "Just hold tight to my shoulders."

The snow on the path hadn't melted, and with the sky no longer snowing, it would be difficult to cover their tracks in the snow.

To avoid being captured again, they had to find officials from Jizhou Prefecture before the bandits caught up with them.

Fan Changyu recalled the earlier conversation among the soldiers about guarding the mountain pass, so she guessed the Jizhou Prefecture soldiers must be stationed there.

She asked the old woman, "Granny, which path leads to the mountain pass the fastest?"

Fortunately, though the old woman was blind, she was very familiar with the roads near her home. "Follow this path west to the fork in the road, then take the middle path."

Once Fan Changyu had her bearings, she practically jogged with the old woman on her back.

The scout had come to report on the bandit suppression at Yansong Mountain. To avoid complications, Xie Zheng had taken his men outside the old woman's courtyard to discuss the matter.

When he returned and saw the two personal guards stationed in the courtyard knocked unconscious, his expression darkened. Pushing open the door and finding the room empty, he thought Fan Changyu had been abducted by someone, his eyes instantly turning icy.

One of the personal guards who had accompanied Xie Zheng outside noticed there was no blood on the ground. He crouched to check the breathing of his two comrades and hurriedly reported, "Marquis, they're still alive!"

As he spoke, he pressed hard on the philtrum of one of his unconscious companions.

The guard who had been knocked out by Fan Changyu with a bamboo pole groggily came to. Seeing Xie Zheng standing before him with a stormy expression, he immediately knelt in terror. "Marquis, this subordinate deserves death!"

Xie Zheng examined the broken bamboo pole on the steps, his gaze frosty.

No one had ever dared to abduct someone right under his nose.

The main routes here had been sealed off by his men. To avoid disturbing the old woman, he had only brought three personal guards.

Who could have slipped past the cavalry at the mountain pass and infiltrated this place?

Suppressing a flicker of anger at the affront, he asked, "Who took her?"

The guard answered miserably, "It was the young lady who knocked us out."

Xie Zheng was momentarily stunned. His handsome brows furrowed, and his expression turned peculiar. "Why would she knock you out?"

The guard said, "This subordinate doesn't know. The young lady woke up and said she had a stomachache. Seeing how weak she was, I let the old woman help her to the outhouse. But when she returned, she suddenly punched Anzi unconscious, then snatched the bamboo pole from the old woman and knocked me out too."

The personal guard who had accompanied Xie Zheng outside inspected the rooms and came out to report, "The old woman is missing too."

After a brief consideration, Xie Zheng realized Fan Changyu must have misunderstood something, mistaking them for villains, which was why she had fled with the old woman.

He asked, "What happened in the courtyard while I was away?"

The personal guard who had been knocked unconscious by Fan Changyu thought for a moment and said, "The scouts at the mountain pass reported that the Jizhou Prefecture soldiers were attempting to search this mountain again. But you were away at the time, Marquis, so I took the liberty of ordering them to continue guarding and not allow the Jizhou Prefecture soldiers to enter."

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes and murmured, "So that's what happened."

She must have woken up then, noticed the people in the courtyard wearing military uniforms but not aligned with the Jizhou Prefecture troops, and mistaken them for bandits.

Just then, another scout galloped up the path on horseback, dismounted, and knelt on one knee with a fist salute. "Marquis, the girl you rescued yesterday is carrying an old woman down the mountain. Should we stop her?"

Xie Zheng raised his gaze to the snow-covered mountains and remained silent.

To eliminate the remnants of the bandits who had fled to Yansong Mountain, he had dispatched most of the hundred light cavalry he brought with him there.

He had rushed back thinking she was in danger, but now that she was safe, with urgent battles on the frontlines and Li Huaian—the eyes of the Qingliu faction—now in Jizhou, he truly shouldn't linger any longer.

"Withdraw the troops guarding the mountain pass and return to Lucheng," he ordered.

The scout acknowledged the command, mounted his horse, and rode off to relay the message.

After a brief rest, several personal guards in the courtyard went to a nearby pine grove to retrieve their warhorses.

As Xie Zheng mounted his horse, he glanced in the direction of the descending path, a lingering sense of unwillingness tightening his chest. He affixed the half-face human skin mask he had prepared before leading the troops and said to the guards, "Go ahead first. I'll catch up shortly."

With that, he tugged the reins and galloped down the mountain path, leaving the guards exchanging bewildered looks.

Fan Changyu, carrying the old woman on her back, suddenly heard the sound of chaotic hoofbeats ascending the mountain. Unsure whether they belonged to bandits disguised as soldiers or genuine Jizhou Prefecture troops, she weighed her options and temporarily hid with the old woman in a pine grove by the path.

To ensure safety, Fan Changyu said to the old woman, "Grandmother, stay hidden here and don't make a sound. I'll go check. If they really are government troops, I'll come back for you."

The old woman clutched Fan Changyu's hand, repeatedly urging her to be careful.

Fan Changyu retreated from the grove while using a branch to erase her footprints. Just as she reached the main path to check if there were still soldiers at the mountain pass, the sound of hoofbeats suddenly echoed behind her again.

This time, the hoofbeats were singular—only one rider—but approaching astonishingly fast.

Fan Changyu was about to dive back into the pine grove when the rider came into view.

Afraid that leading this person into the grove might accidentally expose the old woman, and considering there was only one opponent, she gritted her teeth and decided to keep running forward, believing she might overpower him if she fought with all her strength.

The winding mountain road was rugged, offering a clear view of the foothills from the halfway point.

When Fan Changyu spotted a troop of soldiers bearing the Jizhou flag ascending from the foothills, she was overjoyed. Running and shouting, she cried, "Help!"

The Jizhou soldiers at the foothills heard her and looked up. Soon, someone responded, "Don't be afraid, miss! I'll bring help right away!"

Only then did Fan Changyu notice, among the mass of soldiers, a young man in a pale blue Confucian robe—the same kind-hearted youth who had given her a ride that day.

This distant exchange of glances struck Xie Zheng, who was galloping toward her on horseback, as particularly jarring.

He wore a scarred human skin mask over his face and covered one eye, making it difficult even for those familiar with him to recognize his identity.

Only a few zhang away from Fan Changyu now, he viciously spurred his warhorse forward. As the horse charged, he reached out to grab her and haul her onto the saddle.

Changyu reacted swiftly, dodging his grasp before abandoning the main road entirely. Instead, she slid straight down the steep slope beside the winding mountain highway.

The lower section of the mountain road lay just beneath this slope—no matter what, descending this way would be faster than circling around on horseback.

Yet she never expected the fake officer chasing her would also abandon his horse and follow her down the slope.

Chapter 63

Fan Changyu turned her head at the sound, a sharp flicker of alarm went through her.

To her misfortune, her clothes had snagged on a branch jutting from the steep slope. With a forceful tug, she managed to tear free, but the sudden movement caused the deerskin bracers tucked in her robe to slip out and tumble down, only stopping when caught by a snow-laden thicket.

Her heart inexplicably clenched when the vambraces fell.

They were Yan Zheng's gift for her sixteenth birthday.

Without hesitation, she rushed to retrieve them, unaware of the hidden pit beneath the snow and pine needles. Her foot plunged through empty air, sending her plummeting downward.

With her left arm injured and her right hand clutching the recovered bracers, she had no strength to climb. Fortunately, her collar suddenly tightened as someone hauled her up like a scruffed cat.

Dead branches and gravel tumbled into the dark abyss below, their echoes swallowed by the depths.

A shiver of fear ran through her as she twisted to see the one-eyed man who'd caught up. His posture was upright, but a vicious scar ran from his left eye across his nose to the right side of his face—terrifying to behold.

Pursing her lips, she met his gaze like a cornered leopard, eyes blazing with defiance.

Effortlessly holding her by the collar with one hand, his aura icy, his gaze lingered on the vambraces still clutched in her hand. "Willing to die for this?" he mocked, his voice unnaturally low and hoarse, as if his throat had been injured.

She thought bitterly that she hadn't known about the pit, but only snapped, "None of your business!"

Her right hand now free, she stuffed the bracers into her robe, preparing to defend herself.

Noticing this, his eyes darkened. "That important to you?" he asked abruptly.

Wondering why he cared, she retorted, "Obviously!"

Distracting him, she suddenly grabbed the wrist holding her collar, twisting to plant her feet against the pit wall to climb.

Better to seize control than leave her life in another's hands.

But anticipating her move, he leaned back, yanking her clear of the pit.

Crashing onto him, she was dazed by the impact with his hard armor. Before she could rise, he flipped her onto her back, pinning her down.

The complete domination made her hair stand on end. "Get off!" she snarled.

One hand pinned her wrist, the other pressed her shoulder, carefully avoiding her injured left arm. Barely a foot apart, he studied her as she glared back, chest heaving with rage and exertion.

The bracers stuffed in her robe accentuated the rise and fall, adding an unintended, provocative edge to the struggle.

But the man restraining her seemed completely devoid of ulterior motives. His gaze fixed on Fan Changyu, his uninjured eye strikingly beautiful with pitch-black pupils that revealed no bottom, instinctively giving off a dangerous aura: "Who's that pretty boy down the mountain to you?"

Fan Changyu, burning with rage, refused to answer and kept struggling, only to be pressed down harder. Turning her head, she noticed the hand pinning her wrist bore a fresh ring of teeth marks on the index finger.

Memories surfaced of the two fake officers' conversation outside the old woman's house earlier. Could this be the "master" they mentioned? Not that bastard she'd stabbed full of holes?

So was it this man who saved her?

Her struggles weakened slightly as she couldn't help studying him, finding his dark eyes strangely familiar. She couldn't resist demanding: "Who are you?"

The man's voice was hoarse: "Answer my question first."

Calculating how soon the officers would arrive, Fan Changyu stalled by turning her head away, avoiding his gaze: "I don't know him."

The man scoffed: "Don't know him? Yet you risked your life protecting him on the river?"

Fan Changyu found this man utterly bizarre: "I was being chased by bandits when I came across his carriage. He kindly gave me a ride. When the bandits caught up, I helped him escape."

The pressure on her lessened slightly as the man glanced at the vambrace peeking from her collar, asking casually: "Who gave you this treasure you hold so dear?"

Fan Changyu cursed her injuries and hunger-weakened state—otherwise how could this bastard overpower her? Hoping the officers would hurry, she coldly parried: "Someone very important."

Thinking of Yan Zheng, her heart ached inexplicably.

The man seemed momentarily stunned by her answer. Noticing the redness around her eyes, he asked: "How important?"

Fan Changyu snapped: "None of your damn business!"

Snow cascaded from the pine tree as Xie Zheng rolled with her, one hand pressing firmly against her back—almost like seizing a chance to embrace her.

Seizing the perfect escape opportunity, Fan Changyu headbutted his chin hard. As he recoiled in pain, she scrambled up and kicked out.

Xie Zheng dodged nimbly—her powerful kick struck a thick pine instead, dislodging more snow.

Knowing she'd lost her advantage, Fan Changyu didn't press the attack. Using the snow as cover, she sprinted toward the official road below.

Their exchanges had revealed his martial prowess. Injured and exhausted, charging blindly would only invite humiliation.

She had to survive—had to return to Changning! No reckless heroics here!

Xie Zheng sat up in the snow, nursing his throbbing chin. More snow showered down as he tasted blood from biting his tongue during the impact.

Glancing toward Fan Changyu's fleeing figure, hearing approaching hoofbeats, he ultimately let her go.

With urgent battles in Jinzhou, the commander appearing in Jizhou would hand Li Huaian and his faction damning evidence if recognized.

Though he had turned against Wei Yan, he had still done much for him in the past. The Li faction could never win him over; they only wished to see him and Wei Yan destroy each other.

And yet... knowing that she did not utterly despise him was enough.

At the very least, she still cherished the things he had given her, calling him someone very important.

The personal guard, uneasy about Xie Zheng coming alone, had ridden out to find him. Following the tracks along the winding mountain road, he found Xie Zheng sitting alone beneath a snow-laden pine, his solitary figure resembling a lone wolf. Eventually, the guard spoke up: "Marquis, the troops from Jizhou Prefecture will arrive soon. Let us go."

Xie Zheng gave a faint "Mm" in response. He walked back to the road, mounted his horse, and cast one last glance at the winding path obscured by the pine forest before spurring his horse away.

Fan Changyu raced all the way to the main road, finally encountering the troops who had been ascending from the foot of the mountain. Seeing the Jizhou flag fluttering in the wind and the hundred or so soldiers, she confirmed they were indeed government troops and finally allowed herself to relax.

Li Huaian and a few soldiers approached her. "Miss, are you alright?"

Fan Changyu nodded, panting heavily, and pointed toward the steep slope behind her. "There's a group of men dressed as soldiers who claimed to be merchants staying with a blind old woman. They're highly suspicious—likely bandits in disguise. Please hurry after them, don't let them escape."

Zheng Wenchang, leading the troops, immediately dispatched a large contingent to pursue them, leaving only a dozen or so soldiers behind to protect Li Huaian.

Seeing how out of breath Fan Changyu was, Li Huaian fetched a water flask from his horse and handed it to her. "Here, have some water."

Perhaps worried she might mind, he added, "This is a spare flask. It hasn't been used."

Fan Changyu took it with thanks and gulped down several mouthfuls before catching her breath.

Li Huaian bowed slightly toward her. "My name is Li Huaian. I must thank you for saving my life yesterday."

Fan Changyu replied, "It was your kindness in giving me a ride first."

Li Huaian insisted, "A mere ride cannot compare to the debt of saving a life. May I ask your name, so I may properly repay you in the future?"

Fan Changyu had no choice but to answer, "Lin'an, Fan Changyu."

A flicker of surprise crossed Li Huaian's gentle eyes. "The entire Qingping County was massacred, and Lin'an Town nearby suffered the same fate, with only a few elderly, women, and children surviving. Were you the one who lured away the bandits to protect those families?"

Fan Changyu had been worried about Changning and the others, but hearing that the neighbors hiding in the dry well had escaped, her face lit up with relief. "Yes, that was me. How did you know about this?"

Li Huaian said, "I am ashamed to admit it. With the rebels running rampant, after Lord He Jingyuan of Jizhou personally went to guard the pass at Lucheng, I was appointed by the court to temporarily oversee Jizhou in his stead. Unfortunately, I had just arrived in Jizhou yesterday when I encountered the bandits. Thanks to your protection, I was rescued and later heard about the incident in Qingping County."

Fan Changyu finally understood—this man was also an official, and a high-ranking one at that, like Lord He of Jizhou. No wonder he could appear here alongside the Jizhou troops.

Her tone grew noticeably more distant as she asked, "May I ask, sir, if my younger sister and the neighbors are safe now?"

Hearing her sudden shift in address, Li Huaian remained as warm as ever. "They have been temporarily housed at the courier station in Jizhou Prefecture. They are safe for now."

After answering her, he smiled warmly and said, "Miss Fan, there's no need to be so formal. We're not in court; you don't have to address me as 'Your Honor.'"

Fan Changyu nodded, but the next time she spoke, she still called him "Your Honor." Li Huaian chuckled and shook his head, ultimately deciding not to correct her again.

They rested briefly where they were. Half an hour later, Zheng Wenchang returned with the soldiers from their search. He had found numerous footprints but hadn't caught sight of the bandits. Instead, he discovered the elderly woman Fan Changyu had hidden near the pine forest.

Questioning the old woman yielded the same answers Fan Changyu had given earlier. The woman, fearing damage to Fan Changyu's reputation, made no mention of the man among the bandits who had falsely claimed to be her husband and shared a room with her.

Though the bandits remained at large, at least Fan Changyu had been found. Zheng Wenchang left some men to continue searching the area while he escorted Li Huaian back to the main city of Jizhou.

It was only on the way back that Fan Changyu learned the truth about the magistrate of Qingping County. When the bandits stormed the city, the magistrate and his family had fled in panic without even attempting to organize the yamen runners to resist. After Song Yan left for the capital to take the imperial exams, Mother Song had moved in with the magistrate's family, claiming her own home was too lonely. That night, when the bandits attacked, she fled with them.

No one expected the bandits to chase them over ten miles to slaughter the magistrate's family. Mother Song ultimately met a tragic end under their blades.

The most heartbreaking fate was that of Head Constable Wang and his wife. Wang had rallied his yamen runners, intending to block the bandits at the city gates as they had done with the rioters outside the walls before. But the bandits struck first, breaching the gates. Outnumbered, the constable and his wife fell at the city entrance.

Hearing all this, Fan Changyu felt a heavy weight in her chest the entire journey.

Upon reaching the main city of Jizhou, she went to the courier station to find Changning, only to learn that someone had set fire to the station and kidnapped her in the chaos.

Endless wilderness stretched before them as six or seven riders emerged from the rugged mountain path. The sound of a babbling brook accompanied their brief stop to rest, their horses drinking from the stream after the long ride.

A five- or six-year-old girl was lifted off the horse by a handsome yet sinister-looking young man, still quietly sobbing.

Sui Yuanqing hadn't expected the child to cry so much—she hadn't stopped the entire journey. But with a child's fragile spine, he didn't dare knock her unconscious, fearing he might accidentally break it. After all, losing the girl would render the sacrifice of his last remaining forces in Jizhou pointless.

Holding the sniffling child like a kitten, he impatiently threatened, "If you keep crying, I'll throw you into the river."

Changning, terrified, pursed her lips, and her quiet sobs erupted into loud wails. Sui Yuanqing's face darkened instantly.

Just then, a guard handed him a flask of fresh water. Without hesitation, he tossed the child toward him. "Do whatever it takes to make her stop crying."

The incessant crying grated on his nerves, and the pain from his wounds on his waist and shoulder only fueled his irritation. If not for the child's usefulness, her delicate neck would have been snapped long ago.

The guard holding Changning looked miserable. Killing was one thing, but comforting a child? That was beyond him. Still, under Sui Yuanqing's orders, he forced a stiff smile and tried to soothe her. But Changning, seeing his unnatural grin, only cried harder, nearly choking on her tears.

The guard noticed Sui Yuanqing's icy glare and broke out in a cold sweat, redoubling his efforts to comfort Changning.

But gradually, he realized something was seriously wrong with Changning. She didn't seem to be crying anymore—she was genuinely struggling to breathe, her mouth gaping wide, her face and neck flushed red, yet still gasping for air.

Fearing the child might come to harm under his watch, the guard hurriedly called out to Sui Yuanqing, "Young Master, this child seems to have wheezing disease."

Sui Yuanqing glanced at the child, who looked as if she might suffocate at any moment, and his expression darkened further.

He had gone to such lengths to snatch this child away. If she died on the road now, all he'd gain was Xie Zheng's hatred—no benefit at all.

"Check if she has any medicine on her," he ordered.

He had a half-sister who suffered from wheezing disease—she coughed every few steps, gasped for breath constantly, and rarely dared to leave her room, always carrying medicine with her.

After searching, the guard replied nervously, "N-none."

"Put her on the ground," Sui Yuanqing commanded.

Once Changning was laid flat, it took a while before her breathing gradually steadied.

Now aware of her condition, Sui Yuanqing refrained from frightening her further. He took a water flask from the guard and handed it to her. "Thirsty?"

Changning was clearly terrified of him. She nodded, then shook her head, her face streaked with tears, looking utterly pitiful.

Sui Yuanqing hauled her upright and pressed the flask to her lips. "Drink."

Still frightened but too exhausted from the attack to cry again, Changning took small sips. The water soothed her parched, aching throat from all the crying.

Sui Yuanqing screwed the cap back on and stood, heading toward the horses. "Keep moving. Just make sure she doesn't die on the way."

When the guard lifted Changning onto the horse, her eyes were still brimming with tears, her lips pressed tightly shut. Though young, she was clever—she had gathered from their conversations that these villains had mistaken her for someone else's daughter. If she revealed the truth now, they'd surely kill her, and she'd never see her sister again.

The thought of her sister made fresh tears well up. She fished out the bamboo whistle hanging around her neck and blew into it sporadically.

Three days later, in Lu City.

Gongsun Yin received a letter from Yanzhou. After reading it, his fan slipped from his hand in shock. "Since when did Xie Jiuhang have a daughter?" he muttered in disbelief.

But then again, the man had kept a lover hidden all this time—who was to say he didn't also have a secret child? With a strange expression, he took the letter and went to find Xie Zheng. When he entered the tent, however, Xie Zheng was nowhere in sight.

He knelt on a cushion to wait. As he did, he noticed, for the first time ever, a small dish of tangerine peel candy placed on the low table.

Since when did Xie Zheng's personal guards become so careless? he wondered. The man despises sweets—leaving candy here is just asking for punishment.

Out of boredom, he tried one and found the sweet-and-sour flavor surprisingly pleasant.

After eating three pieces, he magnanimously pocketed the rest to spare the guard from Xie Zheng's wrath when he returned.

A short while later, Xie Zheng strode in, his armor dusted with snow. Spotting Gongsun Yin, he merely asked, "What brings you here?"

Gongsun Yin scrutinized him with a peculiar look. "Business, of course."

Xie Zheng ignored his probing gaze, removed his cloak, and handed it to the personal guard behind him. As he sat down, he noticed the entire plate of tangerine peel candy was empty. His expression darkened instantly as he shot a glance at Gongsun Yin. "You ate them?"

Chapter 64

Gongsun Yin thought to himself that Xie Zheng actually knew there were candies in the dish, but he didn't consider eating a few pieces to be a big deal. He replied frankly, "Yes, what about it?"

Xie Zheng's face turned icy as he ordered his men, "Throw him out!"

The two personal guards exchanged glances, took one look at Xie Zheng's expression, and ultimately had no choice but to haul Gongsun Yin toward the exit.

Gongsun Yin was stunned. By the time he regained his senses, he was already being dragged to the tent entrance. Furious, he shouted, "Xie Jiuhan! Are you serious? I only ate a few of your candies!"

During his struggle, the candies he had tucked in his pocket spilled onto the ground.

When Gongsun Yin met Xie Zheng's gaze, he felt the man's expression grow even colder.

Seeing the usually arrogant man crouch down to pick up the scattered tangerine peel candies one by one, Gongsun Yin froze in surprise.

Straightening his expression, he shook off the guards' grip and commanded, "You two, leave first. I have important matters to discuss with the Marquis."

The guards had never truly intended to throw Gongsun Yin out in the first place. With his words and Xie Zheng remaining silent, they promptly withdrew.

Gongsun Yin walked back to the low table and frowned. "Did that Fan girl give these to you?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer.

Gongsun Yin knew it must be true. Unable to hold back, he said, "They're just a few tangerine peel candies. I'll pay you back, alright?"

Xie Zheng placed the retrieved candies back into the porcelain dish, the hard sweets clinking unevenly against the surface. He lifted his dark, frigid eyes to Gongsun Yin—like sunless rocks buried deep in the ocean for millennia. Just meeting his gaze sent an inexplicable chill down one's spine.

Gongsun Yin rubbed the goosebumps on his arms and finally shut his mouth.

Xie Zheng asked, "What did you come for?"

At this, Gongsun Yin's expression instantly turned strange. He looked at Xie Zheng. "Do you have a daughter?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer, only scoffed.

Gongsun Yin understood it must be a baseless rumor. He took out the letter from Jizhou and handed it over. "Changxin Wang sent this. He says your daughter is in his hands. If you don't want her used as a sacrifice, trade Jizhou for her."

Xie Zheng didn't take the letter, clearly not even bothering to read it. He sneered, "Has Sui Tuo gone mad knowing he'll never sit on that throne in this lifetime?"

Gongsun Yin also found the matter bizarre. Logically, if Changxin Wang dared to send such a letter, he must have been confident in his leverage. Yet, as things stood, the letter seemed utterly ridiculous.

He said, "Could he have mistaken some rumor and thought you had a daughter lost among the common folk?"

As he spoke, Gongsun Yin rummaged in his sleeve and pulled out a bamboo whistle, placing it on the table with a laugh. "Oh, right. This whistle came with the letter—supposedly a keepsake from your daughter."

When Xie Zheng's indifferent gaze swept over the whistle, it suddenly paused.

He recognized this whistle.

When he was severely injured at the Fan Family's residence, Wei Yan's martial assassins had ransacked the place for something, killing everyone in their path. As he fled with that child, she had been blowing this whistle the entire way.

Hadn't she and her sister both escaped safely? Why would this whistle end up in Changxin Wang's hands?

Xie Zheng picked up the whistle and examined it closely before coldly ordering, "Investigate. Find out what happened to the Fan child who was sent to Jizhou Prefecture."

Upon hearing it was related to the Fan Family, Gongsun Yin quickly grasped the situation and asked, "Could the one who fell into Changxin Wang's hands be that Miss Fan's younger sister?"

Xie Zheng pressed his lips together in silence, tacitly confirming it.

Gongsun Yin hadn't expected such a misunderstanding either. His folding fan snapped open and shut in his hand before he finally looked up at Xie Zheng. "If it really is her sister, what do you plan to do?"

Jizhou

Though early spring had arrived, winter in the northern regions always lingered longer than in the south. A thin layer of unmelted snow still clung to the red plum blossoms in the courtyard, while icicles hanging from the eaves glistened under the sunlight, slowly dripping water.

Fan Changyu stood beneath the eaves, staring blankly at two sparrows hopping and pecking at food on the courtyard wall. Her back was straight, but faint shadows under her eyes betrayed her exhaustion.

She had barely slept since the day the courier station caught fire and Changning went missing.

Her sister had been abducted, yet she didn't even know who the enemy was.

During the fire at the station, Aunt Zhao had carried Changning out, only to be stabbed and collapse in pain, helplessly watching as masked men snatched Changning away.

Fortunately, the wound wasn't fatal, and Aunt Zhao had survived.

After investigating, the authorities speculated it was an act of revenge, reasoning that since the kidnappers had taken Changning rather than killing her on the spot, they must intend to use her as leverage.

But three days had passed, and the abductors seemed to have vanished without a trace, sending no demands.

Fan Changyu couldn't think of any enemies she might have made. The only possible retaliation could have come from Clear Breeze Stronghold.

However, the remnants of the stronghold had already been eradicated by the authorities. Even if a few stragglers remained, they wouldn't dare cause such a commotion in the heart of Jizhou.

At first, she had suspected the strangely behaving soldiers who rescued her were bandits in disguise. But later, Li Huaian told her that Lu City, fearing Jizhou's weakened defenses after troop withdrawals, had sent a light cavalry unit to assist.

If bandits hadn't taken Changning, Fan Changyu recalled the Clear Breeze Stronghold leader's words—that it wasn't her father who had escorted the treasure map back then, but a eunuch named Ma Taiyuan. This led her to suspect the still-mysterious enemies of her parents.

Over the past two days, she had inquired about the Four Seas Armed Escort Agency and Ma Taiyuan, confirming the bandit leader hadn't lied.

The only remaining lead was the official records of the interrogations of those black-clad men. With no other options left, Fan Changyu had come to seek Li Huaian's help in accessing the files on her parents' deaths and the two attacks on her family.

After a servant announced her arrival, she had waited in the front hall for the time it took to drink a cup of tea. The weight of her worries made sitting still unbearable, so she stepped out to the corridor for air.

A clerk hurried over from the other end of the walkway and, upon seeing Fan Changyu, said politely, "The magistrate is in the Literary Archives. Please follow me, Miss."

Fan Changyu thanked him and strode after him, paying no attention to the elegant scenery of the estate.

The Literary Archives were heated by an underfloor system, and warmth enveloped her as soon as she stepped inside, banishing the lingering chill of early spring.

Li Huaian sat at a desk in his crimson official robes, reviewing documents with a brush in hand. Compared to the gentle and amiable demeanor Fan Changyu remembered from their first meeting, the authority of his position now lent him an air of detachment and solemnity.

The clerk bowed respectfully. "Magistrate, Miss Fan is here."

Li Huaian finally looked up from the pile of documents, setting down his brush as he said, "Apologies for keeping Miss Fan waiting. All the records of Jizhou Prefecture are stored in the Archive. It took some time to arrange for the subordinates to prepare them. We may proceed now."

As a member of the Li faction, temporarily filling in for He Jingyuan's position in Jizhou, it would not reflect well on him to be seen investigating the Archive's records upon arrival—let alone bringing an outsider along. It was necessary to dismiss any unrelated personnel for discretion.

Fan Changyu replied, "I've troubled you, sir."

Li Huaian smiled at her, once again resembling the gentle and earnest scholar he appeared to be. "If not for Miss Fan, I might have lost my life to the mountain bandits. Accessing these records is well within my authority. Please don't stand on ceremony."

As they were about to leave, he glanced at Fan Changyu's attire and instructed a clerk to fetch a cloak. "Any records borrowed from the Archive must be officially logged. Since you'll be accompanying me inside, it's best to wear this cloak to avoid drawing attention."

Understanding that he was bending the rules to help her—and not wishing to cause him trouble—Fan Changyu donned the cloak, pulling the hood over her head until only her chin and faintly rosy lips remained visible.

Li Huaian's gaze lingered for a fleeting moment longer than necessary.

On their way out, Fan Changyu encountered no one—likely cleared away by Li Huaian's orders.

Upon reaching their destination, they were met by a stern contingent of armored guards stationed outside the gates. Only after Li Huaian presented his token were they permitted entry.

Following him into the towering, somber structure, Fan Changyu noticed black cloth draped over all the windows and doors. The dim glow of a single lamp barely illuminated the endless rows of shelves crammed with bamboo scrolls and documents.

Li Huaian carried a candleholder ahead, searching through the labeled shelves before retrieving a scroll. "From last December—found it."

He handed it to Fan Changyu, who quickly began scanning its contents. Li Huaian moved closer to provide better lighting but maintained a

respectful half-step distance, ensuring she felt no discomfort.

After swiftly reviewing the scroll, Fan Changyu's expression darkened. "This record states my parents were indeed killed by mountain bandits for the Treasure Map."

Li Huaian's eyes flickered, though he refrained from suggesting the records had been tampered with. The only one in Jizhou with the power to alter official documents so brazenly would be the governor, who had personally gone to guard Lucheng.

He offered gently, "Perhaps the bandit leader lied to save his own life."

Fan Changyu remained silent. She had already verified the bandit leader's claims before daring to approach Li Huaian.

Had the authorities deliberately recorded it this way, or was it a hasty conclusion to close the case? Finding no clues about her parents' enemies in the official records, her heart grew heavier. After leaving the Archive, she bid Li Huaian farewell and returned to her temporary lodgings.

Aunt Zhao, still injured, required constant care. In Fan Changyu's absence, the few surviving neighbors from the post station fire took turns looking after her.

The remaining survivors of Qingping County—mostly the elderly, weak, and women—had been relocated to the main city by Jizhou authorities, who provided monthly provisions.

Unbeknownst to Fan Changyu, news of her Archive visit had already been rushed by courier to Lucheng that very day.

The night was cold and the dew heavy. He Jingyuan finished reading the letter sent from Jizhou under the lamplight, murmuring to himself after a long silence, "I've already given him the item. Those two children know nothing. Given the current situation, he shouldn't make a move against them now."

His aged eyelids were heavy with wrinkles, and as a certain possibility crossed his mind, his once refined face hardened slightly. "Could it be that Grand Tutor Li deliberately set this up to obtain what the Fan Family holds?"

After some deliberation, he finally picked up his brush and swiftly wrote a letter. Sealing it, he called for his personal guard outside the tent. "Deliver this letter to Jizhou at full speed and hand it to Wen Chang."

Zheng Wenchang was his prized disciple. Though He Jingyuan was not currently in Jizhou, Zheng Wenchang, who commanded the troops there, could act on his behalf. It was Zheng Wenchang who had informed him that Li Huaian had taken Fan Changyu to review the archives.

The guard took the letter and hurried away.

Gazing into the deep night, He Jingyuan sighed heavily. "The world isn't yet in chaos, yet the people already suffer so. If true disorder comes, how many more will perish?"

In the camp of the Yanzhou forces stationed outside Lucheng, the central military tent was also brightly lit.

The scouts had confirmed the news: the little girl missing from the relay station was undoubtedly Changning.

Gongsun Yin pointed to the locations of Yanzhou and Chongzhou on the map and said, "I suspect deception here. Not only is Changxin Wang's proposal to exchange a mere child for Yanzhou utterly absurd, but Yanzhou lies north of Chongzhou. The Northern Turks are currently attacking Jinzhou, and beyond Jinzhou, only Huizhou and Yanzhou stand in their way. You deliberately weakened Yanzhou's defenses to lure him away from Jizhou and attack Yanzhou instead, relieving the siege on Jizhou, yet he didn't take the bait. Why would he demand territory now? Even if Jinzhou, Huizhou, and Yanzhou all fell into his hands, he'd still need to divert forces to fend off the Northern Turks. Why would he let you shield him from foreign invaders while he marches south?"

Xie Zheng sat in an armchair, his cold gaze sweeping over the two locations Gongsun Yin had indicated before he suddenly chuckled. "They're turning our own stratagem against us."

Gongsun Yin paused, then understood. Looking back at the map, realization dawned. "Changxin Wang saw through our feigned weakness in Yanzhou as a ploy to protect Jizhou. Now he pretends to target Yanzhou, but his real aim is to draw us away and continue attacking Jizhou?"

Unable to contain his excitement, he turned to Xie Zheng. "If we let Changxin Wang believe we've fallen for his ruse and rush back to defend Yanzhou, we can deploy our original tactic when the rebels attack Jizhou!"

Xie Zheng finished his thought. "The challenge lies in convincing Changxin Wang that we're truly returning to Yanzhou."

Gongsun Yin nodded. "Exactly. Though Jinzhou is guarded by several of your brave generals, the troops stationed in Huizhou must not be moved as a precaution. Without a significant military maneuver, it's hard to lure Changxin Wang into the trap."

Xie Zheng studied Yanzhou on the map for a moment before saying, "I'll go to Yanzhou myself."

Gongsun Yin was startled—he intended to use himself as bait.

Concerned, Gongsun Yin asked, "What if Changxin Wang decides your life is worth more than Jizhou and truly turns to seize Yanzhou?"

Xie Zheng raised his eyes. "Didn't you say Changxin Wang still counts on me to hold off foreign enemies so he can march south unimpeded?"

Gongsun Yin wanted to say more, but Xie Zheng merely smiled, his careless expression carrying an air of arrogance: "If he truly dares to come for my life, I'll take his head on the battlefield—then the unrest in the northwest will be thoroughly quelled."

Gongsun Yin thought this man was utterly reckless, but then he suddenly realized something, his gaze turning complicated.

During the Battle of Chongzhou, Xie Zheng had fallen into a trap and nearly died on the battlefield. The rumors of his death had spread for so long that morale had long since wavered. The Xie Family Army had been handed over to that incompetent fool Wei Xuan, who then squandered it in countless defeats, further crushing their fighting spirit.

Now that he had returned, he needed to win an absolutely decisive victory to restore the Xie Family Army's morale, which had been utterly ruined under Wei Xuan's command.

Gongsun Yin even suspected that Wei Yan, unable to find Xie Zheng's corpse and fearing his resurgence, had deliberately sent Wei Xuan to take over Huizhou and systematically dismantle the Xie Family Army.

Building an elite army took at least three to five years—but destroying one only required a few defeats.

Though Xie Zheng acted for the greater good, whether he also intended to help his beloved retrieve her sister in the process was something Gongsun Yin didn't ask at this moment. Instead, he said, "Marquis, if you intend to use this strategy, you must either bring He Jingyuan under your command or... eliminate him. After all, the current military forces in

Lucheng are all under his control. To create a trap capable of swallowing Changxin Wang's fifty-thousand-strong army, we must mobilize all of Lucheng's forces."

A hint of deeper meaning flickered in Xie Zheng's half-lidded eyes. "After being in Lucheng for so long, it's indeed time I met him."

The secret hidden behind the Fan couple—despite his men investigating for so long, they had found nothing. Aside from Wei Yan, only He Jingyuan likely knew the truth.

Chapter 65

Since receiving the letter from Jizhou's main city informing him that the youngest daughter of the Fan Family had been inexplicably abducted and Fan Changyu had gone to review the case files, He Jingyuan had been unable to sleep a wink. He was currently reading military texts in his tent when his personal guard outside suddenly entered to announce that Gongsun Yin was requesting an audience.

He Jingyuan had no idea what schemes Wu'an Marquis's chief advisor was up to, but after a brief hesitation, he still had the guard invite him in.

When the tent flap was lifted, however, more than just Gongsun Yin entered.

He Jingyuan's gaze landed on the man behind him, dressed in a black arrow-sleeved long robe embroidered with swirling cloud patterns. After a moment of surprise, he quickly rose to his feet. "Marquis?"

Xie Zheng lifted the corner of his lips. "Lord He, it's been a while."

Compared to the seasoned generals who had fought countless battles, he was far too young. With his striking looks, many in the military had once doubted him, believing he had merely been born into the right family—the sole heir of the Xie lineage, with Wei Yan as his uncle—which had allowed him to rise swiftly through the ranks.

But after reclaiming Jinzhou and recovering the twelve prefectures of Liaodong—achievements unmatched since the previous dynasty—all such doubts had finally been silenced.

Outsiders marveled at his innate genius, but as a fellow military man, He Jingyuan knew full well that any single one of Xie Zheng's military exploits would have been enough for an ordinary general to boast about for a lifetime.

And behind such glory was inevitably paid in blood and countless brushes with death.

Though He Jingyuan was at least two decades older than Xie Zheng, he held genuine respect for the youngest Martial Marquis in the history of

Great Yin.

He gestured for Xie Zheng to take the seat of honor. "What brings the Marquis to Lucheng so suddenly?"

Xie Zheng did not decline. If he didn't sit there, no one else in the tent would dare to sit either.

He lounged casually in the chair, accepting a cup of tea personally offered by He Jingyuan. When their eyes met, He Jingyuan's posture lowered slightly, a trace of guilt in his gaze over the earlier grain requisition incident.

Xie Zheng's lips twitched, but he chose not to press the matter now. Instead, he said, "Sui Tuo has surrounded Jizhou with fifty thousand troops, aiming to sever the waterborne grain supply lines come spring. While the frontlines remain stable for now, I came personally to inspect the rear supply lines."

He Jingyuan clasped his fists solemnly. "Rest assured, Marquis. As long as I draw breath, I will not let those bandits take Jizhou."

Xie Zheng tapped the armrest of the Grand Tutor chair lightly, his dark eyes carrying a smile yet exuding an unspoken authority. "My visit isn't due to any lack of trust in you, Lord He. Whether Jizhou holds depends entirely on Lucheng. But with only twenty thousand troops currently stationed here, if Changxin Wang launches an assault, resistance will be difficult. The newly conscripted soldiers are said to number fifty thousand, but in reality, there are only thirty thousand—all untested farmers. If it comes to the point where even personal guards must be thrown onto the city walls to hold the line, Lucheng's advantage will still be slim. After surveying the terrain around the city with Gongsun, I've devised a plan to annihilate all fifty thousand of Changxin Wang's troops surrounding Lucheng."

He Jingyuan hadn't slept well since Lucheng was besieged. Hearing Xie Zheng speak of a strategy to break the enemy, he couldn't hide his astonishment. "What is the Marquis's plan?"

Xie Zheng looked at Gongsun Yin, who answered on his behalf: "The Witch River flows from west to east, passing through Jizhou, but its source lies in the Yanshan Mountains. When the snow and ice on Yanshan melt in early spring, the water flows into the Witch River. We can send troops to build a dam upstream to temporarily block the river's flow. The riverbed near Lucheng will remain shallow, allowing Lord He to lure Changxin

Wang's forces into crossing it. Then, by detonating the dam upstream, we can flood Changxin Wang's fifty-thousand-strong army."

Upon hearing this plan, He Jingyuan couldn't help but clap in admiration: "Brilliant! However, building a dam is no small task—it would require mobilizing thousands of soldiers. How can we keep it hidden from Changxin Wang's scouts?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Changxin Wang recently sent me a letter of challenge, intending to seize Yanzhou. I will borrow twenty thousand troops from Jizhou and, on the way back, station most of them upstream to construct the dam. Meanwhile, Lord He can dispatch more men to intercept enemy scouts. This way, we can deceive them completely."

He Jingyuan was puzzled. "Earlier, Gongsun mentioned weakening Yanzhou's defenses to lure Changxin Wang into attacking. If he falls for it, shouldn't he strike Yanzhou directly, catching us off guard?"

Gongsun Yin smiled knowingly. "Lord He is correct. Changxin Wang is playing a counter-strategy—pretending to fall for our trap by targeting Yanzhou, while his true goal remains attacking Jizhou to seize the salt lakes and control the waterways."

As an experienced veteran, He Jingyuan quickly grasped their earlier suggestion of leading troops back to reinforce Yanzhou as another layer of deception—making Changxin Wang believe they were truly defending Yanzhou.

After a moment of contemplation, he asked, "But what if Changxin Wang also realizes this is a ruse?"

Xie Zheng said firmly, "He won't."

He Jingyuan looked confused.

Gongsun Yin, barely suppressing a laugh, explained, "The Marquis's only daughter is in Changxin Wang's hands. On the surface, borrowing troops to return to Yanzhou is also to rescue her."

Xie Zheng's icy gaze swept over Gongsun Yin, who immediately straightened up with a serious expression.

He Jingyuan, however, was momentarily bewildered before composing himself and clasping his hands. "I was unaware the Marquis had a daughter. It must be difficult for her to suffer in the hands of those rebels."

Gongsun Yin, who had barely held back his laughter, nearly lost his composure again at He Jingyuan's words.

Xie Zheng's expression darkened, but he clarified, "It's my sister-in-law. The rebels mistook her identity."

He Jingyuan, who had just reluctantly accepted that Xie Zheng had a daughter, now learned that the captive wasn't his daughter but his sister-in-law. The sudden revelation of a Marchioness—despite his mental preparation—still shocked him.

If it had only been a daughter, perhaps born to a woman by his side, it wouldn't have been a big deal. But the existence of a Marchioness was no trivial matter. Countless noble families in the capital had been vying to marry into his household. Even after rumors of his fallout with Wei Yan spread, the imperial family—long suppressed by Wei Yan—had considered marrying a princess to him to use his influence against Wei Yan.

How had such a coveted position been claimed without anyone noticing?

Not only He Jingyuan but even Gongsun Yin was stunned.

He had assumed Xie Zheng's feelings for that butcher's daughter, surnamed Fan, were merely gratitude for saving his life, mixed with some affection over time. Who would have thought he regarded her as his wife?

For a moment, Gongsun Yin even wondered if Xie Zheng had been cursed.

Though the Xie family now had only him as the sole male heir, it was still a centuries-old aristocratic clan. If he were to marry, it would stir up a storm in the entire capital, as it would mean a complete reshuffling of power among the nobility.

The matriarch of the Xie family could only be one of the most outstanding noble ladies from prestigious families in the capital. Marrying a country bumpkin would make the entire capital laugh at them, wouldn't it?

Gongsun Yin's brows furrowed tightly. Knowing the man he had befriended for over a decade was not one to act impulsively, he wanted to question him further. However, with He Jingyuan present, he restrained himself.

Xie Zheng watched as both He Jingyuan and Gongsun Yin lost their composure, his eyes unreadable. He simply asked, "What does Lord He

think of this plan?"

He Jingyuan snapped back to reality, suppressing the shock in his heart, and hurriedly replied, "The plan is brilliant! All troops in Lucheng are at the Marquis's disposal!"

As he spoke, he raised both hands above his head, presenting the Jizhou Tiger Tally.

There could be no more sincere a pledge of loyalty.

Xie Zheng took the Tiger Tally, seemingly indifferent to the iron token that could mobilize all of Jizhou's forces. Twirling it between his fingers, he lowered his gaze and said, "There is one more matter I'd like to consult Lord He about."

His use of the word "consult" was rather intriguing. He Jingyuan vaguely guessed what he wanted to ask. Ever since Xie Zheng had stopped Wei Xuan from requisitioning grain, He Jingyuan had resolved to reveal everything he knew. Now, he merely said, "The Marquis may ask whatever he wishes. If this humble official knows the answer, I will hold nothing back."

At this assurance, Xie Zheng's lips curved slightly. "In Lin'an Town of Qingping County, there was a butcher family surnamed Fan. Why did Wei Yan want that couple dead? And what was he searching for in their home all those times he sent men there?"

Hearing Xie Zheng ask so much about the Fan family, Gongsun Yin instinctively frowned. Could it be that his interest in the Fan girl was related to Wei Yan?

He Jingyuan's expression turned complicated, wondering how much Xie Zheng already knew about the past. "Before this official answers, might the Marquis tell me why he is investigating the Fan family's background?"

Xie Zheng said, "My wife's parents died unjustly. I must look into it for her."

At these words, He Jingyuan abruptly looked up, his face a picture of shock.

Xie Zheng assumed he, like Gongsun Yin, was surprised by his acknowledgment of Fan Changyu's status. Displeased, his expression cooled. "Can Lord He answer me now?"

He Jingyuan's fingers trembled faintly. Lowering his aged eyelids, he remained silent for a long moment before sighing. "The deceased Fan butcher was once a subordinate of the Prime Minister. Later, he betrayed his master and fled, living under an assumed name. But the Prime Minister eventually tracked him down and took his life. As for what the Prime Minister was searching for, I truly do not know."

Wei Yan had once shown him kindness and mentorship. Though their political views now diverged, He Jingyuan still addressed him respectfully as "Prime Minister."

Xie Zheng's gaze sharpened abruptly, though his lips still held a faint smile. "If I'm not mistaken, it was Lord He who took that item, wasn't it?"

He Jingyuan said bitterly, "It was indeed this official who took it, but I truly do not know what it was."

Xie Zheng's patience waned. "Does Lord He expect me to believe that?"

He Jingyuan replied, "Whether the Marquis believes it or not, every word I've spoken is the truth."

Xie Zheng sneered, "You don't even know what Wei Yan is looking for. How can you help him find it?"

He Jingyuan gave a self-deprecating smile. "My actions in Jizhou over the years have long displeased the Chancellor. When he ordered me to kill the Fan family couple, it was merely to test my loyalty—he never instructed me to search for anything. That item was given to me by the couple before their deaths, with the instruction to hand it over to the Chancellor when demanded, and never to open it myself."

Xie Zheng sensed something unusual in his words and asked, "Were you acquainted with the Fan family couple?"

He Jingyuan's eyes betrayed a deep weariness. "They were old friends of mine."

Gongsun Yin, unaware of the Fan family's affairs, couldn't help but interject, "So, Lord He, to prove your loyalty to Wei Yan, you killed your former friends?"

He Jingyuan remained silent, tacitly admitting it.

Gongsun Yin, observing his sorrowful demeanor, remarked ambiguously, "Loyalty and righteousness have always been hard to reconcile. One can

hardly blame Lord He."

Detecting the sarcasm in his tone, He Jingyuan replied, "If I hadn't done it, the Chancellor would have sent someone else. By killing the couple myself, I could at least honor their final wish—to spare their two children. Had another been sent, the entire family would have been eradicated."

Gongsun Yin fell silent. They all knew too well the ruthlessness of Wei Yan's methods.

After a pause, he asked, "Wei Yan never ordered you to retrieve that item. Weren't you afraid he'd suspect you when you handed it over later?"

He Jingyuan answered, "Of course I was. But since the Marquis has married the Fan family's daughter, he must know the sisters are completely unaware of their parents' affairs. My old friends are gone, and I carry this guilt. All I ask is to protect the last remnants of their bloodline. At the time, Wei Xuan had been defeated, rumors of the Marquis's death were spreading, and the northwest was in chaos. The Chancellor had no choice but to rely on me, so he turned a blind eye."

Xie Zheng tapped the armrest of his chair lightly, remaining silent. What He Jingyuan said aligned closely with his own earlier speculations.

Gongsun Yin pressed further, "Lord He, did you truly never look at what the Fan family couple gave you?"

He Jingyuan smiled bitterly. "Master Gongsun, you jest. Had I looked, would the Chancellor have spared me?"

Gongsun Yin shrugged at Xie Zheng.

Despite all these questions, while many mysteries seemed resolved, none of the truly crucial ones had been answered.

Xie Zheng suddenly lifted his gaze. "When Fan Erniu served under Wei Yan, what name did he go by, and what was his position?"

Cold sweat dripped from He Jingyuan's temple. "Marquis, I beg your forgiveness, but I cannot disclose that now."

When Xie Zheng wasn't smiling, his phoenix eyes exuded an especially intimidating pressure. He scrutinized He Jingyuan and asked, "Why not?"

He Jingyuan's mouth tasted bitter. He knew all too well what the truth behind the Fan family meant to Xie Zheng. If Xie Zheng had merely stumbled upon the Fan family while investigating the old Jizhou case, with

no personal ties to them, He Jingyuan might have hoped for mercy—that with the couple dead and the past settled, he would leave the orphaned sisters alone.

But Xie Zheng had called Fan Changyu his wife, and the younger Fan sister had been mistakenly kidnapped by rebels who thought she was his daughter. He Jingyuan dared not imagine what would happen to the two sisters if the truth came out now.

He would tell Xie Zheng the true identity of the Fan family couple—but not yet. At the very least, he had to wait until both sisters were safe.

Chapter 66

The distant sound of night watchmen striking the wooden clappers to announce the hour drifted through the darkness, its sharp report piercing the silence of the grand tent. The candle flame on the high table flickered violently.

Under Xie Zheng's cold gaze, He Jingyuan spoke with difficulty, "Marquis, you may consider He Jingyuan a coward for now. If I survive after resolving the siege of Lucheng, I will surely confess everything to you."

Hearing this, Gongsun Yin couldn't help but glance at Xie Zheng, though neither showed any reaction.

He Jingyuan had even handed over the Tiger Tally for troop deployment in Jizhou, demonstrating his loyalty. Yet he still guarded the secret of the Fan family couple's identity, merely to protect himself—fearing Xie Zheng might eliminate him after securing military power. Such petty concerns were ultimately harmless.

After a brief silence in the tent, Xie Zheng finally curled his lips slightly and said, "Lord He, you may set your heart at ease. Xie comes from military stock and cannot promise much, but I never break my word. Moreover, you've served in Jizhou for over a decade, earning both the people's trust and the soldiers' respect. This Marquis wouldn't dare act rashly against you, now would I?"

Cold sweat trickled down He Jingyuan's temples as he hastily bowed his head. "You jest, Marquis. Who could surpass your prestige in the army?"

Xie Zheng tapped the armrest of his chair twice, his dark eyes scrutinizing the respectful scholar-general before him. As if weighing his options, he finally conceded, "Very well. This Marquis will await your answer after Lucheng's siege is lifted."

He Jingyuan felt the oppressive gaze lift from him, and his breathing eased. Bowing even deeper, he clasped his fists and said, "Many thanks for your mercy, Marquis."

Xie Zheng stood, the hem of his robe—embroidered with the Cloud Sea Pattern—falling gracefully, its fabric shimmering in the candlelight. He remarked coolly, "Tomorrow, Lord He will assign twenty thousand new recruits and include skilled hydraulic engineers among them. After the spring equinox, the rains will come. If we don't reinforce the embankments along the Witch River before the Spring Flood arrives, this strategy will be useless."

He Jingyuan quickly replied, "This official will summon the officers tonight to arrange it."

Once outside the tent, Gongsun Yin murmured to Xie Zheng, "You actually allowed his bargaining."

Xie Zheng tossed him the Jizhou Tiger Tally and asked sidelong, "What else?"

Gongsun Yin caught the tally with both hands and said, "He's entrenched in Jizhou for years. Since we need the Jizhou army to encircle Changxin Wang's fifty thousand troops, we can't easily move against him. Losing a commander before battle would damage morale. Still... he dared to gamble that you'd spare him for the sake of the Fan family, even after surrendering the Tiger Tally."

Xie Zheng replied, "Had he not handed over the tally, would I have dared march north?"

Gongsun Yin chuckled. "This Lord He sees clearly. His caution isn't unfounded—you wouldn't act before the battle, but fearing his influence over Jizhou's troops, whether you'd let him 'die honorably' during the fight is another matter."

Xie Zheng remained silent, tacitly agreeing. As they walked on, he added, "Regarding Chongzhou, draft a reply in my stead. Negotiate other terms with that old fox Sui Tuo."

Gongsun Yin understood his meaning—exchanging Yanzhou for the Fan family's youngest daughter was impossible. He replied, asking Changxin Wang to propose other conditions, making it seem they genuinely cared about the child's life. This way, borrowing troops from Jizhou to reinforce Yanzhou wouldn't raise suspicions.

Moreover, once Changxin Wang realized how important the child was to them, he would be even more cautious about harming her—

Several days later, Changxin Prince Manor, Chongzhou.

A man's pale, skeletal fingers tossed the letter into the brazier beside the desk. The paper quickly turned to ash in the glowing embers.

Despite the lingering chill of early spring, even indoors, the man still wore a heavy cloak draped over his shoulders. His sickly, bloodless lips curled slightly, like a child who had won a game—his smile wicked and pleased. "He actually borrowed twenty thousand troops from Jizhou."

The man who had delivered the letter frowned in confusion. "The child the young master abducted isn't Wu'an Marquis's daughter at all. Your Highness, could this be a trap?"

Sui Yuanhuai lifted his dark, spine-chilling eyes. "Isn't she his woman's sister? When Qingping County was massacred, he rushed back recklessly to save people. If he doesn't rescue that child, what do you think his woman will do when she finds out?"

The man standing below in embroidered robes was Zhao Xun.

He had wanted to say that someone of Wu'an Marquis's status could have any woman he wanted. But recalling the woman who had tried to escape several times, only to be caught by the man before him, he swallowed his words and instead said, "Your Highness is wise."

Sui Yuanhuai mused with amusement, "Even if it is a trap, what does it matter to us?"

Zhao Xun's heart jolted in alarm. He realized Sui Yuanhuai intended to watch the tigers fight from a safe distance and quickly bowed. "Your Highness is brilliant."

Sui Yuanhuai watched him, his lips quirking in an inscrutable smile. Under that gaze, Zhao Xun felt as if needles were pricking his back. Trembling, he asked, "Why does Your Highness look at this subordinate so?"

Sui Yuanhuai chuckled. "I heard you taught that little bastard how to write?"

Zhao Xun's knees buckled, and he dropped to the floor. "Your Highness, spare me! How could this lowly one dare teach the young master? The young master kept crying to see... Consort Yu. I only told him that if he studied and learned his characters well, Your Highness might be pleased enough to let him see her."

Sui Yuanhuai smirked. "How generous of you to make decisions on my behalf."

At these words, Zhao Xun's face turned deathly pale. He pressed his forehead to the cold floor. "This subordinate deserves death. Please punish me, Your Highness."

Just then, a middle-aged woman entered with refreshments. Seeing Zhao Xun kneeling, her expression shifted strangely.

Sui Yuanhuai propped his chin lazily on one hand and drawled, "Get up. Aunt Lan is watching."

Zhao Xun didn't dare move. The woman carrying the tray also paled. After setting the refreshments on the table, she took a step back and knelt. "Your Highness, if Xun'er has done wrong, punish him as you see fit. Do not humiliate this servant."

Sui Yuanhuai smiled and personally helped the woman up. "Aunt Lan, what are you doing? Without you, where would I be today? Rise, quickly."

His hands, perpetually cold from prolonged illness, sent a shiver through her when she accidentally brushed against them.

Noticing her fleeting unease, Sui Yuanhuai's smile deepened. He glanced at Zhao Xun, still kneeling. "A-Xun, get up too. You and Aunt Lan are my closest people. No need to kneel so often."

Zhao Xun glanced at the middle-aged woman and only rose to his feet, his back drenched in cold sweat, after receiving her slight nod. He said respectfully, "It is my duty to serve Your Highness with loyalty."

Sui Yuanhuai smiled without responding. With disinterest, he cast a glance at the scrolls on the desk and remarked idly, "Later, have that little bastard brought to me. I want to see how his studies are coming along."

Zhao Xun bowed his head in assent.

After Zhao Xun and the middle-aged woman had left, Sui Yuanhuai mused aloud as if to himself, "Are they still loyal to me?"

From the shadows of the empty study emerged a figure: "The Zhao mother and son harbor no disloyalty toward Your Highness."

Sui Yuanhuai merely smiled. "Keep watching them."

The shadow retreated back into the darkness, as if no one had ever been there.

Sui Yuanhuai seemed weary, his handsome features tinged with exhaustion as he propped his head on one hand, gazing absently at the scenery outside the study window.

His body was in terrible condition, sustained all these years by medicinal brews.

Sixteen years... no, another year had passed—seventeen years now—since the fire in the Eastern Palace had scorched most of his face and nearly half his body. It was precisely this that had allowed him to swap identities with the eldest son of the Prince of Changxin and escape with his life.

The one who had truly perished in the Eastern Palace that day was the eldest son of the Prince of Changxin.

It had been a meticulously planned golden cicada shedding its shell.

With the Crown Prince dead, his mother knew it would soon be their turn. She orchestrated the Eastern Palace fire herself.

Under the pretense of overwhelming grief, she invited many noblewomen from the capital to visit with their children, ostensibly to keep her company and lift her spirits.

The Changxin Prince Manor was the refuge she had chosen for him. When a palace maid accidentally overturned a teacup, staining the eldest son of the Prince of Changxin's robes, his mother ordered the attendants to take the boy to change clothes. The garments he removed were ultimately worn by Sui Yuanhuai, while the Prince of Changxin's wife and son perished in the flames.

His face had been burned beyond recognition, and with the Prince of Changxin's wife dead, the manor's servants couldn't identify him. They identified him as the manor's eldest son solely by his clothing and personal effects, taking him back with them.

From then on, he was no longer the imperial grandson but Sui Yuanhuai, the half-burned legitimate eldest son of the Prince of Changxin.

Aunt Lan, once his mother's trusted confidante, had also escaped the fire. She later married a wealthy merchant and secretly supported him. After giving birth to Zhao Xun, she poisoned the merchant, allowing Zhao

Xun to inherit the family fortune. Once Zhao Xun was capable of standing on his own, she returned to Sui Yuanhuai's side to care for him.

To make himself presentable again, the dead skin from his burns had been gradually replaced over the years.

In the early days, his face was so disfigured that none of the servants dared to look directly at him. Later, enduring excruciating pain, he had the burned skin replaced, only to find the servants growing even more fearful of him.

At this thought, Sui Yuanhuai smirked mockingly.

Yet his mother's choice of the Changxin Prince Manor as his escape route had been carefully considered.

A disfigured cripple could never become the manor's heir. No matter whom the Prince of Changxin remarried, any new wife would treat such a harmless legitimate eldest son with kindness to bolster her own reputation.

Even more fortunately, after the tragic death of the Prince of Changxin's wife, her family feared his ghastly appearance would provoke the Prince's disgust. Worried that a new wife might secretly mistreat him, they arranged for the Prince of Changxin to marry the deceased wife's younger sister as his second wife.

The younger sister of the Princess of Changxin indeed treated her sister's child as her own, doting on him. After giving birth to Sui Yuanqing, she always taught him to be close to this "elder brother" of his.

But stolen affection—could it truly be called familial love?

When that mother and son eventually learned the truth, they would likely wish they could tear him apart with their teeth.

All these years, he had only maintained a facade of harmony with them.

The fingers that had been propped against his temple suddenly pressed hard against his temples.

Back then, to deceive everyone, he had burned most of his face. Now, even after replacing the scarred skin, his head often throbbed as if splitting apart. At this moment, the pain struck abruptly, intensifying the malice in his heart. He wished he could torment a few people just to ease his own bitterness.

Just then, the door was pushed open, and a little figure appeared in the doorway, holding a stack of practiced calligraphy sheets. His puppy-dog eyes held a trace of fear, yet he still lifted those clear, bright eyes to look at him, pursed his lips, and called out, "Father."

Chapter 67

Sui Yuanhuai studied the child who had suddenly barged in. The boy bore no resemblance to him, yet the moment Aunt Lan laid eyes on the child, she'd claimed he was the spitting image of Yuan Huai in his youth.

Yuan Huai couldn't recall his own childhood appearance—his only memories were the searing pain after the fire and the scars that had left his face unrecognizable.

Resting his chin on one hand, he sneered at the timid child standing by the door. "Father? Who gave you permission to call me that?"

Yu Bao'er tightened his grip on the calligraphy sheets, clearly at a loss. His wide, innocent eyes—black and white like polished stones—stared at the man draped in a heavy cloak, seated imposingly above him. Unsure what else to call him, Bao'er simply pressed his lips together and stayed silent, looking pitifully obedient.

He had traveled south with his mother, only for their caravan to be intercepted by a troop of black-armored guards.

That day was his first encounter with this man. Snow fell thick as cotton floss as the man, sickly and pale, leaned against the carriage surrounded by guards. His unnaturally pallid fingers, weakened by prolonged illness, held back the carriage curtain as he fixed Bao'er and his mother with a gaze so dark it bordered on cruel—tinged with the vicious satisfaction of impending vengeance.

Bao'er feared him. His mother seemed even more terrified, trembling as she held him close.

From that day on, he never saw his mother again.

Brought here, he wasn't punished. Instead, servants attended to his daily needs. But whenever he asked about his mother, they avoided the subject. Only one kind-hearted nanny dared whisper snippets about her.

She told him this man was his father. If he behaved well and pleased him, he might be allowed to see his mother again.

Since arriving, Bao'er had been nothing but obedient. Yet no one ever mentioned reuniting him with his mother. Two days ago, he finally broke down—refusing to eat, crying in protest.

In the end, a stranger came and told him that if he studied hard, learned his characters, and excelled in his lessons, he might get to see his mother.

So he obeyed. Today, for the first time since his arrival, he was led out of his courtyard.

Yuan Huai watched Bao'er's timid demeanor with disdain, his gaze flickering to the calligraphy sheets clutched in the boy's hands. "I heard someone's teaching you to write. Bring them here."

Even seated, the man exuded an oppressive gloom that made others shrink back.

Bao'er was afraid too, but he still took small, determined steps forward.

The only feature he truly shared with Yu Qianqian was his eyes—round and dark, with slightly downturned corners that made him look gentle, harmless, and inexplicably pitiable.

As Bao'er approached, Yuan Huai's expression faltered. For a fleeting moment, it was as if he saw her—the woman who, even heavily pregnant, had never stopped plotting her escape.

Fragile enough that he could crush her with a finger, yet no matter how he punished her, she never learned. Given the slightest chance, she'd run without hesitation.

Like a captive deer, forever dreaming of returning to the wild.

Only when Bao'er thrust the calligraphy sheets in front of him did Yuan Huai snap out of it. His face darkened inexplicably as his pale, bony fingers flipped through the pages, making Bao'er nervously clutch the hem of his robe.

A moment later, he scattered the stack of practice sheets Yu Bao'er had written as if they were scrap paper, sneering coldly, "What kind of nonsense is this? The characters are as limp as boneless—rewrite them."

Yu Bao'er looked at the sheets she had carefully written in hopes of seeing her mother, her eyes reddening slightly, but she remained silent.

Soon, a servant entered with bated breath, quietly setting up a small desk with writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone. The entire process was

nearly soundless.

Everyone serving in the courtyard knew Sui Yuanhuai was unpredictable in his moods. They entered to serve with their lives hanging by a thread, not daring to slacken even the slightest bit.

Yu Bao'er watched all this, still somewhat at a loss. Seated behind the desk, Sui Yuanhuai lifted his eyelids slightly to glance at her and said coldly, "Practice here."

Yu Bao'er mustered her courage to ask, "If I write well, can I see my mother?"

Sui Yuanhuai's smile grew even more mocking. "Who taught you to say such things to me?"

Tears welled up in Yu Bao'er's eyes, but she stubbornly refused to let them fall. "No one taught me. I just miss my mother."

Sui Yuanhuai picked up a bamboo scroll from the table, his voice icy. "Go practice your writing. Cry again, and you'll never see her again in this lifetime."

When Yu Bao'er obediently went to the low desk to practice, her small body turned slightly away from him. Struggling to hold the brush thicker than her fingers, her tears plopped onto the paper, leaving tiny watermarks. Afraid he would notice, she didn't dare wipe her tears or let out a sob, only slowing her breath to cry silently.

She thought she was hiding it well, but the man seated in the high position saw every little movement. His eyes half-lowered, shadowed with darkness.

He disliked this child—not only because that woman had been ungrateful, but also because the child's existence posed a serious threat to his position.

Compared to a sickly invalid who couldn't even practice martial arts, a healthy, young, and easily controlled child was clearly the better choice.

The closer the Zhao mother and son grew to this child, the more wary he became.

Back then, to survive, he had endured the agony of fire, leaving him with lifelong ailments.

Later, to appear presentable, he had suffered countless inhuman tortures, slowly replacing the burned skin on his body. The pain of flaying was a torment only the dead should know, yet he had endured it while alive.

Having struggled so hard to survive, anyone who dared stand in his way would die!

With these thoughts, his expression grew even more twisted. The hand gripping the bamboo scroll clenched so tightly his pale knuckles seemed on the verge of snapping.

A maid entered to serve tea and, caught off guard by his expression, let out a short scream. The tea spilled, the cup shattering on the ground. The maid's face drained of color as she prostrated herself on the floor, trembling as she begged, "Young Master... Young Master, spare me..."

Sui Yuanhuai loathed it when servants looked at him with horror, as if he were a ghost. His thin lips curled as he uttered blood-chilling words: "Drag her out and beat her to death!"

Someone entered almost immediately. The maid barely had time to scream before her mouth was gagged and she was taken away. The entire process was swift and silent, like a shadow puppet show.

Yu Bao'er sat at the low desk, staring blankly at the scene. A drop of ink fell from her brush, staining the nearly finished practice sheet.

The person seated behind the desk watched his pale little face with a cold gaze before suddenly speaking maliciously, "If you don't behave, your mother will end up just like her."

Yu Bao'er was clearly terrified. That day, after finishing his calligraphy practice in Sui Yuanhuai's study, he fell ill for several days, crying out for his mother even in his nightmares.

Lan Shi, who had fled the Eastern Palace years ago and married a wealthy merchant to develop external forces for Sui Yuanhuai, had not been by his side during the worst of his burn injuries. Seeing Yu Bao'er, she felt as if she were looking at the little imperial grandson she had once cared for, and her heart ached with pity. She pleaded with Sui Yuanhuai to let Yu Bao'er see his mother, only to be met with a sneer: "A mere maid beaten to death scared him into illness? Aunt Lan, have you forgotten? When I was his age, I had just survived the Eastern Palace fire."

Lan Shi, seeing the cold, mocking glint in Sui Yuanhuai's dark eyes, dared not plead further for Yu Bao'er.

Three days later, Yu Bao'er slowly recovered, but his temperament became withdrawn. He spoke little and barely interacted with anyone, his only unwavering routine being calligraphy practice.

Fearing the child might be permanently traumatized, Lan Shi ordered servants to find a few clever children to be his playmates. Yet Yu Bao'er ignored them all, focusing solely on his own tasks.

Zhao Xun, who had been tasked with monitoring Yu Qianqian's every move in Qingping County, knew of her and her son's ties to the Fan Family. Boldly, he suggested to Lan Shi, "What if we bring the Fan Family's youngest daughter here? Perhaps she could get Yu Bao'er to speak?"

Lan Shi hesitated visibly. "That child is now publicly known as the daughter of Wu'an Marquis and is under strict surveillance by the Prince's household. How could we bring her here as a playmate for the young master?"

Zhao Xun replied, "The heir apparent is close to His Highness and fond of the young master as well. Without trying, Mother, how can we know the heir apparent would refuse?"

After a moment of silent exchange with her son, Lan Shi said, "Xun'er, even if it's for the young master's good, we must first seek His Highness's permission."

Zhao Xun abruptly lowered his head. "I was only worried for the young master's well-being and acted in haste."

Lan Shi admonished, "The entire Zhao Family's future now rests in your hands. Your decisions determine our survival. Do not act recklessly."

Zhao Xun bowed respectfully. "I will remember your teachings, Mother."

When Lan Shi next sought an audience with Sui Yuanhuai, she found him, usually with little appetite, surprisingly enjoying a meal. The attendant beside him tasted each dish before he took a bite.

A glance at the peculiar dishes on the table told Lan Shi they were likely prepared by Consort Yu. That woman, soft as dough in appearance, was stubborn beyond measure. Lan Shi had tried to discipline her before but failed to soften her temper.

Her sudden overtures to Sui Yuanhuai now were likely due to learning of Yu Bao'er's illness, hoping to see her child through this gesture.

As for how news had reached Consort Yu, whose courtyard was tightly guarded—it was clear Sui Yuanhuai had allowed it.

Lan Shi frowned. Even now, she couldn't fathom Sui Yuanhuai's true feelings toward Consort Yu. Back when his health had deteriorated, she had selected several concubines for him, fearing the worst.

Sui Yuanhuai understood her intentions. Though disgusted, he had no choice but to select one to bear his heir.

Lan Shi sometimes thought that it was probably from that time onward Sui Yuanhuai no longer trusted her completely.

But if given another chance, she would still do the same. She was the Crown Princess's confidante. If the imperial grandson was on the brink of death, she had to ensure he left behind a bloodline to continue the cause of vengeance—it was the only way to honor the Crown Princess's spirit in the afterlife.

Back then, among the maidservants selected for intimacy, Sui Yuanhuai had bypassed all the glamorous and alluring ones, choosing instead Consort Yu, who was timid as a rabbit and obedient.

But perhaps frightened by his unpredictable temper, and already naturally timid, Consort Yu became listless after serving him and later fell gravely ill. The household whispered behind her back that she had been terrified into such a state by Sui Yuanhuai.

He punished those who spread rumors and even intended to dispose of Consort Yu as well. But when the physician examined her pulse, he detected a pregnancy.

That was how Consort Yu managed to keep her life. However, after recovering from her illness, her temperament seemed to change entirely. Outwardly docile, she harbored many schemes in secret. She seized every opportunity to flee, and even when caught, no matter how furious Sui Yuanhuai became, she focused solely on ensuring her own comfort to the greatest extent possible.

When morning sickness struck hard, she would tinker in the small kitchen to prepare her own meals. Even when confined, she ate and drank

well, taking care of her health without the slightest neglect. And the moment she spotted another chance, she would vanish like a rabbit again.

Years ago, when Consort Yu successfully escaped while seven months pregnant, she had coaxed Sui Yuanhuai into staying at a manor for a while to relax. She personally cooked but laced the food with drugs. After drugging everyone at the manor, she gathered her jewelry, took her trusted maid and a guard, and fled.

When Sui Yuanhuai awoke, he nearly destroyed the entire manor, cursing her as nothing but a lowly servant. Yet he mobilized nearly all his forces to search for her. The search lasted five or six years before he finally found her in a small place like Lin'an Town.

Lan Shi had assumed that, given his temperament, he would eliminate the mother and keep the child after capturing Consort Yu and her son. But instead, he merely separated and confined them, neither mistreating nor questioning them. Apart from the occasional sarcastic remark, he seemed indifferent. Lan Shi couldn't quite grasp his intentions.

As Sui Yuanhuai dined, he noticed Lan Shi standing nearby, hesitating for a long while. He asked, "Aunt Lan, do you have something to discuss with me?"

Lan Shi wasn't sure if bringing up Yu Bao'er now was wise, but she steeled herself and said, "The young master's condition still shows no improvement. I heard from Xun'er that while in Qingping County, Consort Yu was close with the Fan Family. I dare to suggest... since the youngest daughter of the Fan Family is currently in the residence, perhaps... we could let her be the young master's companion temporarily, to see if his condition improves."

Sui Yuanhuai didn't believe Changning would live long enough to return anyway. Perhaps because the meal had been to his liking, he was in a relatively good mood and didn't wish to grant that woman's wish—to see her son—so soon. Resting his chin on his hand, he pondered briefly before suddenly smiling. "Aunt Lan already has a plan. Go find Qingdi, then."

As she stepped out of the room, Lan Shi still couldn't quite believe it. Today, Sui Yuanhuai seemed far more agreeable than usual.

Sui Yuanqing brought Changning back to the Changxin Prince Manor, casually handing her over to the servants with only a brief instruction to ensure the child didn't starve or freeze to death. Lan Shi, using Sui

Yuanhuai's name as pretext, claimed she wanted to find a playmate for Yu Bao'er. Without further questions, Sui Yuanqing granted her request.

Led by a maidservant to fetch Changning, Lan Shi opened the door to the woodshed and found a little girl curled up in a pile of straw. She appeared unwashed for days, her hair in messy tufts, her face smudged with dirt, and her cheeks reddened from the cold. Yet her eyes were strikingly bright—clear and alert like a deer's, watching them warily.

Having come from the palace, Lan Shi had seen countless beauties in her lifetime. But the sight of this child gave her pause—this little girl would grow into a rare beauty.

Jizhou.

Fan Changyu kicked open the door of the dungeon, sending the guard sprawling. With a single swing of her black iron cleaver, sparks flew as the lock on the cell door clattered to the ground.

Panting heavily, the soldiers behind her called out, "Miss, don't rush ahead—there are many bandits up there—" Their words trailed off as they took in the scene of groaning bandits strewn across the ground.

Ignoring the belated arrival of the soldiers, Fan Changyu stepped into the dimly lit dungeon. She lifted the drowsy children, still groggy from the drugged fumes, checking each one while calling Changning's name.

Recently, Jizhou had seen a sudden surge in child abductions and kidnappings. The authorities claimed a group of traffickers was taking advantage of the chaos to snatch children. Fearing Changning might have been taken, Fan Changyu clung to hope, following the soldiers as they raided trafficking dens day after day.

Though she hadn't found Changning, her reputation for wielding a butcher's knife with unmatched ferocity had spread far and wide. Every time a den trafficking children or women was dismantled, her bravery in battle earned her the highest honors. Yet, since she wasn't an official, the government could only reward her with hefty sums of silver.

As the stack of banknotes in her pocket grew thicker, Fan Changyu's anxiety deepened—Changning was still missing. Interrogations revealed some children had already been sold to different prefectures. She noted down every girl matching Changning's description. Leaving half the silver with Aunt Zhao, she packed the other half along with several butcher knives, determined to traverse multiple prefectures in search of her sister.

To aid her search, the officials suggested commissioning a portrait of Changning. Only then did Fan Changyu recall the New Year's painting done by a scholar, which she had framed and hung in their room. But when she returned home to retrieve it, turning the house upside down yielded nothing.

Previously preoccupied, she hadn't given the painting a second thought. Now its disappearance sent a jolt of alarm through her. It wasn't the work of a master—who would steal it? Moreover, after the massacre by Clear Breeze Stronghold, Lin'an Town was practically deserted. Thieves seeking loot would target wealthy households, not the impoverished homes in the western district.

After much deliberation, Fan Changyu realized the only person who could have taken the painting was that bastard she had ambushed that night—the one who had likely returned to block the escape route from the dry well!

The painting depicted herself, Changning, and Yan Zheng, making it easy for outsiders to mistake them for a family.

After the people of Clear Breeze Stronghold were all captured, only that bastard and a female bandit managed to escape. Could it be that they had abducted Changning based on that painting, seeking revenge against her?

Fan Changyu considered that Jizhou was no longer a safe haven for that bastard. Since he was originally a soldier from Chongzhou, he might have fled back there.

With a direction to search for them, she bought a horse that very day and set off for Chongzhou, asking for directions along the way.

Chapter 68

On the day Fan Changyu set out, Zheng Wenchang hurriedly wrote another letter to He Jingyuan.

Previously, when He Jingyuan learned that Changning had been captured, he replied, instructing Zheng Wenchang to find a way to keep Fan Changyu steady.

Zheng Wenchang still didn't know who had actually abducted the child. To give Fan Changyu some explanation, he lied, claiming it might have been the work of traffickers in Jizhou City who kidnapped women and children.

He had assumed Fan Changyu would patiently wait for news of the authorities raiding the traffickers' dens. Unexpectedly, the young woman grabbed her butcher's knife and personally followed the soldiers into the dens to search for the child.

What was originally planned to take one or two months to completely eradicate was absurdly shortened to just half a month, leaving Zheng Wenchang with a rather peculiar feeling.

The authorities always offered rewards to those who helped capture wanted criminals. Fan Changyu received such a substantial bounty, coupled with her previous heroic feat of defending over a dozen neighbors against the Clear Breeze Stronghold, that she had gained a small reputation in the underworld—now known as the Butcher Beauty.

Among the scattered bandits still lingering in Jizhou City, a saying had spread: if you encounter a beautiful woman carrying a butcher's knife on the road, don't entertain any foolish ideas. Just let her pass peacefully, or else... she might just dismantle your entire hideout.

Some women traveling long distances would invariably buy a butcher's knife as a talisman, carrying it with them along the way. Surprisingly, it proved quite effective—so much so that blacksmiths and blade shops couldn't keep up with the sudden surge in demand.

By the time He Jingyuan received the letter, it was his turn to feel that peculiar unease.

Before Xie Zheng led twenty thousand new recruits away, he had specifically instructed He Jingyuan to keep an eye on Fan Changyu, who was far away in Jizhou Prefecture. The situation had developed in a way He Jingyuan had never anticipated.

He had originally hoped the two Fan sisters would live ordinary lives, free from the shadows of their parents' past. But now, it seemed that was no longer possible.

His personal guard stood outside the tent, hearing only a deep sigh from within.

The sun hung high, and tender buds had sprouted along the greenery flanking the official road.

Fan Changyu chewed on dry rations atop her horse, too preoccupied to appreciate the spring scenery. She found it strange—throughout her journey, she hadn't encountered any refugees. Had they all fled in the past few months?

The dry food was a bit hard to swallow. When she reached for her water flask, she found it nearly empty.

Glancing at the shallow stream running parallel to the road, she dismounted to refill it. The water was so shallow that unless she positioned the flask between the scattered rocks, she could only scoop up half a flask's worth.

After drinking a few sips of the crisp, cool water and refilling the flask, she was about to continue her journey when a disheveled man stumbled toward her from a fork in the road. Spotting her from afar, he cried out, "Miss, save me!"

Assuming he had encountered bandits, Fan Changyu hung the flask back on her horse and immediately drew her bone-cleaver. As the man approached, she subtly angled the blade toward him, successfully stopping him three paces away.

Traveling alone, Fan Changyu didn't dare let her guard down. During her raids on traffickers' dens with the authorities, she had learned that many abducted young women were deceived by seemingly helpless

children or elderly people, lured into secluded spots, and dragged away in burlap sacks.

She studied the man and asked, "Did you run into bandits?"

The man shook his head, his face—tanned and ruddy from years of labor—dripping with sweat. Panting heavily with his hands on his thighs, he said, "The imperial soldiers are heartless, trying to round up honest folks like us to build dams..."

The chaotic sound of hoofbeats drew closer, and the man grew visibly panicked and fearful. He pleaded with Fan Changyu, "I'll hide in the woods. Please don't tell them where I went. I've got elders above and children below—if I'm taken, I'll likely die under those soldiers' whips. What will become of my family then?"

His desperation was such that he seemed on the verge of kowtowing to her. After speaking, he dove headfirst into the bushes by the roadside.

Fan Changyu processed the man's words, realizing why the stream was still so shallow despite it being spring—they must have dammed the water upstream. She hadn't seen any refugees along the way either; had they all been seized for dam construction?

She wasn't in a hurry to leave. Watching her horse graze on the fresh grass by the road, she absently scratched its neck.

When the disorderly hoofbeats finally arrived, there were over a dozen armored soldiers. Since this was a fork in the road, their leader reined in his horse and asked Fan Changyu, "Did you see a man pass by?"

Given how few people she'd encountered on this road, claiming she hadn't seen anyone would seem suspicious.

Fan Changyu nodded. "I did."

She showed no fear in the face of the soldiers. With several blades visibly strapped to her saddle and dressed in practical riding attire, they took her for a wandering martial artist and didn't suspect anything. The leader only asked, "Which way did he go?"

Fan Changyu pointed to the side path. "That way."

The leader glanced at her but didn't immediately order all his men to chase in the direction she'd indicated. Instead, he sent two riders down the road she had come from while leading the rest down the side path.

Fan Changyu watched expressionlessly as the soldiers galloped away, thinking to herself, This isn't how it's supposed to go in the stories...

Once the soldiers were completely out of sight, she called toward the bushes where the man was hiding, "Come out. They're gone."

The man crawled out, disheveled, and effusively thanked her. "My whole family owes you their lives."

Fan Changyu waved it off. "It was nothing. By the way, I pointed them toward that path, but two riders still went down this main road. Maybe you should hide in the bushes a while longer. When the soldiers don't find anyone ahead, they'll likely double back. Wait until they've passed before heading down this road."

The man thanked her repeatedly but didn't leave. Instead, he eyed the large bundle on her saddle with embarrassment, licking his dry lips. "Miss... do you have any food? I've been hiding from the soldiers for days and haven't eaten."

Fan Changyu's bundle contained plenty of provisions. She studied him for a moment before saying, "I'll get you some."

Unfastening the bundle's knot required both hands. She tucked her cleaver into the leather sheath on her saddle and reached to undo the bundle.

Her dislocated arm had mostly healed, though lifting heavy objects still strained it occasionally. To aid its recovery, she'd avoided strenuous tasks with that arm lately.

The man's honest expression turned ferocious the moment Fan Changyu turned to fetch food, his hidden dagger thrusting straight toward her back.

But there was a metallic "clang" as the blade seemed to hit an iron plate, unable to advance even slightly. The man froze in obvious surprise.

Changyu paused while untying her bundle, turning her head coldly to meet his gaze: "Lying to me?"

The man's expression darkened as he withdrew the dagger and slashed at Changyu's throat. She responded with a powerful kick to his abdomen, sending him flying over ten feet away.

Perhaps his internal organs had ruptured from the impact—the man could no longer hold his dagger, writhing on the ground in agony while

clutching his stomach.

Before deciding to travel alone, Changyu had taken precautions. She'd commissioned an ironsmith to forge two extremely sturdy iron plates—one worn in front, one behind—precisely to guard against unexpected dangers on the road.

Grabbing her butcher knife, she approached intending to tie up the man and leave him for the pursuing soldiers while making her escape beforehand.

Otherwise, having nearly let a wanted criminal escape while deceiving the pursuing officers, she might well be charged as an accomplice.

Unexpectedly, hoofbeats soon approached again. When the officer in charge spotted Changyu and the man, his expression turned grim, his cavalry immediately training crossbows on her.

Changyu quickly explained: "Sir, I was deceived by this man earlier! He claimed to be a civilian conscripted for dike repairs with elderly parents and family. He begged me to conceal him, then tried to kill me—I subdued him."

The officer coldly assessed her before ordering his troops: "Bind them both. Take them away."

Desperate, Changyu pleaded: "Sir, I'm truly innocent! I admit deceiving you earlier was wrong, but I've captured this criminal—can't this offset my offense?"

The officer snorted: "This is a scout from Chongzhou's army. For all we know, you're a spy staging this act because you couldn't extract him."

Stunned by the severity of the accusation, Changyu protested: "Sir, I have household registration documents! I'm from Jizhou, truly not a spy!"

She produced her papers but, forbidden from approaching, had to toss them to the officer.

After examining them, he demanded: "If you're from Jizhou, why travel toward the northwestern border during war?"

This road led to both Chongzhou and Yanzhou. Fearful of being implicated, she dared not mention Chongzhou again: "I'm seeking family in Yanzhou."

With refugees everywhere during war, few bothered obtaining travel permits anymore.

Unconvinced, the officer retorted: "How do I know you didn't murder someone for these documents?" Wheeling his horse, he barked: "Take them away!"

Changyu: "..."

Could her luck get any worse?

Facing a row of crossbows, she reluctantly surrendered her knife and let them bind her hands for the march to camp.

While she knew troops were stationed in Lucheng, she hadn't realized tens of thousands were encamped halfway from Jizhou, constructing a massive dam.

After reaching camp, Changyu was temporarily imprisoned. Her horse, bundle, butcher knife—even the two iron plates—were confiscated during a thorough search by female guards.

The guards provided her with nothing but water and the dry rations from her own bundle every day. Being forcibly detained and having to pay for her own prison meals only added to Fan Changyu's frustration.

Two days later, she was finally taken out of the cell. Although it was confirmed she wasn't a spy, she wasn't released. Instead, she was grouped with other ragged civilians, each given a hoe and a basket. The guards ordered them to dig for earth and stones, working in pairs. If they failed to fill ten baskets by noon, they wouldn't get lunch.

It was then that Fan Changyu learned these people were all refugees passing through the area, forcibly detained here. Apparently, the guards feared they might leak information about the river embankment construction. But keeping them locked up meant having to feed them, so the guards put them to work digging earth and stones.

Most refugees were willing to do the manual labor just to get a full meal.

Fan Changyu was held back for the same reason—the guards worried she might pass through Chongzhou on her way to Yanzhou and reveal something.

She didn't understand why building an embankment had to be so secretive. Worried about Changning's safety, she thought that now that she

was out, she could use the digging work to scout the terrain and plan an escape.

Being new, she found most teams already formed. The majority were men, and when it came to securing a meal, no one cared about chivalry. Even the sturdy women, seeing how tall but slender Changyu was, doubted her strength and refused to pair with her.

Changyu figured filling ten baskets alone by noon wouldn't be too hard. But the guards, noticing she and a frail old man were left without partners, assigned them as a team, likely assuming a "delicate woman" and a "feeble old man" couldn't match the others. They were told five baskets would suffice.

Carrying her basket and hoe, Changyu followed the group up the mountain. The old man, struggling even with his own hoe, panted the whole way, cursing the guards nonstop—though in such refined language, full of classical allusions, that neither the laborers nor the guards could understand him.

Changyu had Yan Zheng's annotated Four Books in her bundle and occasionally read them in her spare time, so she grasped some of it. But the more obscure references left her just as lost.

Seeing the old man nearly out of breath, she thought of Carpenter Zhao, who'd joined the army at the same age, and felt a pang of sympathy. Using her hoe like a blade, she cut a thick branch from a tree, trimmed the twigs and sharp end, and handed it to the old man as a cane. Reaching for his hoe, she said, "Let me carry that for you."

Sweat dripping into his eyes, the old man refused, stubbornly insisting, "This old man can manage on his own."

A nearby woman remarked, "Girl, don't bother with him. He's a strange one!"

Changyu could tell the old man was all bark and no bite, so she just smiled and let it go.

When it came to digging, Changyu's strength made quick work of filling five baskets, earning her a second glance from the tallying guards.

Transporting the earth and stones wasn't their job—mules or pairs of guards carried them on shoulder poles.

Having finished her morning quota, Fan Changyu didn't want to openly rest while others were still digging. She pretended to work while chatting with the old man: "Old sir, you're clearly a scholar. How did you end up here too?"

The old man fumed: "When I heard Jizhou had lent twenty thousand troops to Yanzhou, I guessed they must be building a dam upstream on Witch River. I merely wanted to inspect the dam's progress, but those soldiers arrested me as a spy! Fools, absolute fools!"

Changyu said, "Old sir, some spectacles aren't worth watching. Things like war and dam construction—best stay away in future."

Misunderstood as merely a curious onlooker, the old man bristled with anger and refused to speak to Changyu until lunch.

Having leisurely dug eight baskets of earth that morning, Changyu was unexpectedly praised by the guards and given an extra bun. She offered it to the old man, but he snorted disdainfully, so she kept it for herself.

Being stronger than most, her appetite was larger too. Learning that more digging meant more food, she dug twelve baskets that afternoon and earned two extra buns.

The old man continued his refined cursing—alternating between damning the guards and some "wretched boy."

Changyu, munching her bun between sips of porridge, asked curiously: "Is that your son?"

The old man shot her a sidelong glance. "You could say half a son."

"Oh," Changyu nodded. "Your son-in-law then."

The old man's beard quivered with indignation. "My student! You ignorant little chit!"

Perhaps accustomed to Yan Zheng's sharp tongue, Changyu didn't take offense at the gruff but kindhearted elder. Instead, she respected his learning. Boldly, she asked, "You were a teacher? I've studied the Analects myself—might I ask you some questions?"

The old man looked surprised. "Self-taught?"

Changyu's expression dimmed briefly before she smiled. "My late husband was a scholar. He... didn't have time to finish teaching me the Four Books before he left. He annotated them for me to study alone."

Perhaps moved by the thought of such young widowhood, the old man uncharacteristically softened. "My condolences for your loss."

Changyu blinked, then hurried to clarify: "He's not dead! He was conscripted."

The old man's mustache bristled. "Then why phrase it like he'd died?!"

Changyu: "..."

Yanzhou.

The distant Yanshan Mountains rose like a dragon's spine against the night sky, their snow-capped peaks faintly visible as pale smudges.

Thousands of military tents sprawled at the mountain's base, interspersed with tripod-mounted braziers where firewood crackled, illuminating the camp.

Inside the central command tent, Xie Zheng studied the military deployments of Yanzhou and Chongzhou on the map. Pointing to a location, he addressed his subordinate generals: "Chongzhou has besieged Lucheng with fifty thousand troops. Their remaining fifty thousand remain formidable. I'll personally lead the decoy operation while you set the ambush at First Line Gorge—"

He suddenly sneezed into his hand.

The assembled generals blinked in surprise.

Though Yanshan's snows had melted, nights remained bitterly cold. Xie Zheng had already switched to lightweight spring attire that accentuated his broad shoulders and narrow waist—the very image of the dashing military officers so admired by noble ladies in the capital.

He frowned and continued with his arrangements. During a brief pause, his personal guard entered to refill his tea and thoughtfully brought him a thick coat.

Xie Zheng looked at the guard holding the garment with an icy expression. The guard steeled himself and said softly, "The night is cold and damp, Marquis. Be careful not to catch a chill."

Xie Zheng: "...Get out."

Chapter 69

Fan Changyu had been digging earth and rocks in the camp for three days. Since the soldiers strictly monitored them during excavation, they couldn't wander freely. The only terrain she could survey was the path from their detention barracks to the mountain.

One soldier was assigned to watch every ten people, and the collective punishment system was enforced. If one person escaped, the other nine—whether aware or not—would be punished if they didn't report it. So not only were soldiers watching, but the laborers also kept an eye on each other. Escaping was no easy task.

Apart from that, the soldiers maintained strict discipline. They didn't withhold food or harass the women in the barracks.

However, some single men among the refugees often leered at the women, whistling and making crude remarks.

Fortunately, the men's and women's barracks were separate. The only time the two groups interacted was during morning assembly for excavation and mealtimes.

Women who had husbands, fathers, or brothers among the refugees were rarely bothered. But those alone—whether young girls or married women—became targets of the men's vulgar teasing.

Some even lured solitary women into joining their excavation teams, promising lighter work and more food—though not without groping and harassment.

Fan Changyu, with her striking looks, had drawn attention since her arrival, though she remained oblivious.

At first, no one wanted to team up with her. The men planned to let her struggle, hoping she'd eventually rely on them for food.

But Fan Changyu was an oddity. Instead of depending on them, she became the fiercest competitor for rations.

For the first two days, she dutifully dug earth and rocks, consistently earning two extra steamed buns per meal. Then she noticed a burly man receiving a chicken leg. Suddenly, her plain bun and porridge seemed lacking. She asked why he got special treatment.

The woman beside her bunk explained, "That man's incredibly strong. Besides digging, he carries his own loads. A sergeant admires him and wants him to enlist, but he stays to feed his wife and child."

Fan Changyu bit her bun. "So if we do extra work, like hauling, we get meat?"

The woman nodded. "Those baskets weigh nearly 300 pounds when full. Even soldiers carry them in pairs. He's the only one here who can manage alone."

Later, as Fan Changyu returned to Old Man with her porridge bowl, she suddenly said after his lecture on The Analects, "How about we eat meat tomorrow?"

Old Man scowled, snorting through his nose. "I teach you the wisdom of Confucius and Mencius, and all you think about is filling your belly?"

Fan Changyu scratched her head, somewhat embarrassed, and said, "I did listen. You said, 'Be strict with yourself and lenient with others, and you will keep resentment at bay.' Always reflect on your own faults rather than blaming others—did I remember it right?"

After speaking, she couldn't help but ask, "Don't you feel like eating meat at all?"

The old man's throat bobbed with difficulty as he closed his eyes and scolded, "Vulgar."

Fan Changyu wasn't upset by the reprimand. That afternoon, she worked with renewed vigor digging earth and stones. Previously, she had only worked enough to earn two extra steamed buns, slacking off afterward. But now, motivated by the prospect of meat, she dug fifteen baskets in a single afternoon and even told the soldiers she would carry them herself.

The soldier overseeing them thought she had lost her mind. Pointing at the basket filled with rocks, he said, "Do you know how heavy this is? One basket could crush your legs!"

Only then did the old man realize what Fan Changyu had meant when she asked if he wanted meat at noon. Worried that something might happen to the young woman, he strode over with a stern face and snapped, "Nonsense! Aren't two steamed buns and a bowl of porridge enough for you? If not, you can have my share too."

Ignoring the old man, Fan Changyu asked the soldier, "If I carry all fifteen baskets down the mountain, can I get a chicken leg tonight?"

The commotion caught the attention of the officer in charge of all the laborers. Hearing Fan Changyu's question, he scoffed, thinking she was daydreaming. "Forget fifteen baskets—if you can carry just one down to the foot of the mountain, I'll reward you with a whole chicken!"

Fan Changyu blinked in surprise. Was this for real?

With such a tempting offer, the other laborers, who had been bent over digging stones, stopped working and turned to watch, leaning on their hoes and murmuring among themselves.

The woman who had spoken to Fan Changyu at noon looked worried, probably regretting that her words had led the girl to such recklessness.

The old man's wrinkled brow furrowed into a deep frown as he glared at Fan Changyu. "Girl, don't be foolish!"

The officer hadn't actually expected Fan Changyu to attempt it. Seeing her hesitate, he assumed she was scared and taunted, "Well? Still going to try?"

Fan Changyu reassured the old man, "Don't worry about me, sir."

She set down her hoe and walked over to the officer. "I'll do it. Just make sure you keep your word."

Lifting three hundred pounds with one hand was still a bit strenuous for her, but carrying it on her back? That was no trouble at all.

Everyone watched, some frowning, others amused, as the tall but slender girl planted her feet firmly on the flat dirt, slung the basket straps over her shoulders, and gripped them tightly. Her shoes sank slightly into the ground as she hoisted the nearly three-hundred-pound load onto her back.

Gasps rippled through the crowd. The idlers who had been leaning on their hoes with smirks now gaped in disbelief, relieved they hadn't made

any crude remarks when she first arrived—otherwise, they might have ended up with more than just a beating.

The officer was dumbfounded. He had heard from his subordinates that there was a woman who worked diligently, earning extra steamed buns at every meal.

But digging stones only required skill and endurance—anyone could do it. Carrying such a heavy load, however? Even in the entire military camp, only a few generals could manage that.

Fan Changyu barely used the crutch for support, gripping only the straps of the shoulder baskets with both hands as she steadily descended the mountain step by step. It didn't look easy, but she didn't seem particularly strained either.

Even after Fan Changyu had walked far away, the entire quarry remained eerily silent.

The Old Man watched her retreating figure thoughtfully, stroking the few grizzled wisps of his goatee as he muttered under his breath, "With such innate talent, if she were a man, she would surely achieve greatness..."

When the soldiers distributed the evening meal, Fan Changyu indeed received a whole roasted chicken. Carrying her bowl of porridge, she found a quiet spot to squat down with the Old Man. She tore off a large drumstick and offered it to him, but he didn't take it. Instead, he looked at her with a complicated expression and asked, "How did the scouting go?"

Fan Changyu raised her head to meet his gaze. "How did you know I was scouting?"

The Old Man's wrinkled eyelids drooped, but his aged eyes remained sharp. "Every time we went up the mountain to quarry stone these past days, you've been quietly observing the terrain and troop deployments here, asking all sorts of questions whenever you saw someone. You watched others eat meat the past two days—why couldn't you resist showing off today? It's obvious you've already mapped out the nearby terrain and defenses and wanted to check the troop arrangements elsewhere."

Their voices were hushed, and with no one nearby, Fan Changyu, realizing the Old Man had seen through her plan, said, "Don't worry, Old Man. I won't sneak off and cause trouble for you all. Carrying stones to the

dam was also to see how the repairs are coming along and how much longer we'll be trapped here. The dam looks nearly finished—we should be released soon."

If they were to be stuck here for a year or more, she wouldn't be able to endure it.

The Old Man snorted. "Using such a foolish method to check the dam's progress. Let me tell you, that dam must be completed before the first heavy rain of spring."

Fan Changyu was puzzled. "Why?"

The Old Man shot her a sidelong glance. "First, you haven't paid me any tuition fee. Second, you haven't kowtowed or served me tea to become my disciple. If you're just going to parrot rigid questions from the Four Books, fine, but why should I teach you these things?"

Fan Changyu simply said, "Oh," and took the question at face value, dropping the subject. She began gnawing on the greasy drumstick she had offered the Old Man, which he had refused.

Seeing this, the Old Man glared in outrage. "You dim-witted piglet! That's the extent of your wisdom!"

Fan Changyu was baffled by his scolding but didn't want to argue with a white-haired, thin-tempered old man. Pressing her lips together, she shifted a step away and continued eating the drumstick in silence, making it clear she took offense at his words.

This only infuriated the Old Man further. His chest heaved as he barked, "No tea—can't you even kowtow without it?"

Finally, Fan Changyu realized the Old Man's earlier words had been an invitation for her to become his disciple.

She knew her own limitations well. After a moment of hesitation, she tactfully declined. "I'm really not cut out for studying. But my mother used to say it's never wrong to read more, so I've dabbled in those books half-heartedly. I'd feel bad making you teach me for nothing. The soldiers took my belongings, but if they return them when we're released, I'll pay you the tuition fee properly."

The main issue was that if she became his disciple, she would have to take care of this old man indefinitely. Fan Changyu had listened to him rant about his former student for so long that she guessed he had once hoped

that student would support him in old age, only to be betrayed. That was why he now wanted to find someone new to rely on.

But she still had to find her sister and couldn't afford to delay here for too long, let alone care for this old man permanently.

The old man realized his offer to take her as a disciple had been rejected. He glanced at Fan Changyu, his stubborn temper flaring up, and sneered, "Do you know how many people would pay a fortune just for me to take them as my disciple, and yet I refuse?"

Fan Changyu, who had just finished gnawing on the chicken leg, held the bone in shock and asked, "Being a teacher is that profitable?"

The old man: "..."

His wrinkled face flushed red with anger. He closed his eyes and roared, "Enough! Truly, you can't carve rotten wood!"

Fan Changyu thought of the similarly destitute Zhao family couple and realized the old man was so furious simply because she refused to become his disciple. She couldn't help but pity this eccentric old man—his temper was terrible, he had no children, and finding someone to care for him in his old age must be incredibly difficult.

Inappropriately, she suddenly thought of Yan Zheng and felt his foul temper was strikingly similar to this odd old man's.

If Yan Zheng ended up alone for life because his mouth was too sharp, wouldn't he turn out just like this old man in his later years?

Fan Changyu shook off the bizarre thought and glanced at the grumpy old man, who was now sulking and refusing to speak to her. She tore off half of the roast chicken, placed it in his bowl of steamed buns, sighed, and took the remaining half back to the women's barracks.

That night, spring thunder cracked, and torrential rain poured down.

Puddles formed on the ground, growing deeper. Fan Changyu watched the blinding flashes of lightning seeping through the cracks in the doors and windows, listening to the deafening thunder outside and the chaotic cries of children in the barracks. An uneasy feeling settled in her chest.

She sat up, and as soon as her feet touched the ground, she realized she was stepping into water—the floor of the barracks had already flooded.

Recalling the old man's claim that the dam would definitely be repaired before the spring floods, Fan Changyu thought back to what she had seen that afternoon while carrying earth and stones to the dam site. It seemed to align with his words.

She hoped the soldiers would release them tomorrow at the latest, but beneath the roar of the storm and thunder, there seemed to be other faint noises outside.

Hesitating for a moment, she decided to throw on her clothes and check the door.

To prevent escape, they weren't held in tents but in the mud-walled tiled houses abandoned by fleeing locals, now commandeered by the soldiers.

At night, the main door was always locked.

Fan Changyu waded through the water to the door and, under the flashes of lightning, noticed the soldiers who were supposed to be guarding outside were nowhere to be seen. From the nearby building where the male refugees were held, it sounded like someone inside was using a hard object to smash the lock.

She quickly realized something must have happened at the military camp, and this stormy night was their perfect chance to escape.

There were no hard objects in the room except for the beds. After a moment's thought, Fan Changyu took two steps back, charged forward, and kicked the wooden door with all her might. It collapsed outward instantly.

Ignoring the stunned women inside, she dashed out into the pouring rain, heading straight for the barracks where their belongings were stored.

Soon, others snapped out of their daze and rushed out as well.

The men in the barracks saw this and stopped smashing the locks. Moments later, the gate along with its frame was knocked down. The burly man couldn't stop his momentum in time and tumbled into the rain-soaked ground. After scrambling up, he went to the opposite barracks to find his wife and children.

In an instant, the camp holding the displaced people descended into chaos, with everyone calling out names to find their relatives.

Fan Changyu, being alone, quickly found her bundle. Struggling against the tide of people, she squeezed out of the barracks where the belongings were stored and saw the Old Man stumbling out of the barracks where he had been confined.

His soaked clothes clung to his emaciated frame.

Changyu initially thought of leaving him behind, but recalling that despite his eccentric temper, he had earnestly taught her the Four Books. There was a saying among the common folk: "A teacher for a day is a father for life." Since he had instructed her, he could be considered half a teacher.

Gritting her teeth, Changyu finally dashed into the rain with her bundle and said to the Old Man, "I'll carry you to escape."

Before the Old Man could respond, Changyu had already slung him onto her back. Drenched like a long-necked pheasant, he still managed to sound defiant: "This old man can walk on his own! No need for you to carry me!"

Knowing his stubborn nature, Changyu didn't argue with him now. Having memorized the camp's layout in recent days, she swiftly carried the Old Man to the main road.

Occasional flashes of lightning illuminated the path, water droplets weighing down her eyelids. Yet, she saw the ground littered with the corpses of soldiers, the rainwater tinged faintly with the color of rouge.

In the distance, amid the pouring rain, tents were burning, as if two forces were locked in battle.

The Old Man's expression darkened. "Disaster," he muttered. "The rebels must have discovered the dam built here to block the water."

Changyu squinted through the downpour to find the way and asked, "Did the rebels kill these soldiers?"

The Old Man replied, "Ever since the dam was built, any scouts the rebels sent to investigate this area never returned. That must have tipped them off, so they sent a detachment to launch a surprise attack—likely to cover their scouts and let them bring back the news!"

Changyu was puzzled. "What does this have to do with the dam?"

The Old Man's face turned grim. "Have you ever seen a dam built in just ten days or half a month? This dam was hastily constructed to temporarily

block the water. The rebels have besieged Lukou with fifty thousand troops. Once the dam releases the stored water downstream, Lukou can crush the rebel army without losing a single soldier. If the rebels knew in advance that the upstream waters could drown their entire force, do you think they'd fall into the trap and be lured into the valley?"

Only then did Changyu understand why the soldiers had detained them.

But in this situation, survival was paramount. To avoid detection, she murmured an apology and stripped the outer armor from two dead Jizhou soldiers, dressing herself and the Old Man in them.

Ahead, she spotted a horse nuzzling a fallen general with its nose.

Changyu hurried over to take the horse, thinking that since her own horse had been confiscated by the soldiers and never found, this one could serve as compensation from the camp.

As she turned to leave, the hem of her garment was seized by the bloodied man on the ground. Recognizing the Jizhou soldier's uniform she wore, he choked on blood and rasped out, "Three scouts escaped via Lukou Road... hurry... chase them..."

With those words, he breathed his last.

Despite having witnessed numerous life-and-death situations, Fan Changyu still felt goosebumps rise on her skin in this rainy night.

The old man stood silently in the rain with his hands behind his back. Fan Changyu led her horse over and hesitated for a moment before asking, "Will you still come with me?"

The old man looked at her through the curtain of rain and sighed deeply. "If you were a man, I would have you cross Witch Ridge and ambush those three rebel scouts at the crucial pass on Lukou Road leading into Lucheng. Their lives determine the survival of not just Lucheng but the entire Jizhou. But though you possess martial skills, you're still just a woman. The rise and fall of nations is no responsibility of women. Go flee for your life. I'll take this news back to the military camp."

Fan Changyu said, "Then we part ways here."

She mounted her horse and spurred it fiercely toward the distant official road. Rainwater streamed down her cheeks from her jaw, and the lightning splitting the sky illuminated the struggle in her eyes.

She wanted to find Changning and live their simple, peaceful lives as before.

Matters like war should be the concern of high-ranking officials. The responsibility for the survival of cities and territories could never fall on a common woman like her.

Yet the tragedies in Qingping County and Lin'an Town remained fresh in her memory. Even bandit raids had turned those places into ghost towns. If the troops sent from the camp failed to intercept the scouts, if the plan to flood the Chongzhou army failed, what fate awaited the people of Lucheng when the city fell?

Fan Changyu cracked her whip fiercely, and the warhorse galloped madly through the heavy rain. The rain and cold wind lashed her face with stinging pain.

In that instant, many faces flashed through her mind—the deceased Head Constable Wang and his wife, the neighbors from the western alleys, Carpenter Zhao and Yan Zheng still in Lucheng...

She had already killed many people, but the bloodshed in Qingping County and Lin'an Town still made her shudder when she recalled it.

Perhaps... if she gave chase, she could still stop those three scouts from delivering their message?

Fan Changyu took two deep breaths, then finally pulled the reins to halt her horse. Leaving her baggage behind, she took only a few butcher knives from it, fastened her vambraces, and like a leopard hunting in the heavy rain, abandoned her steed and raced toward Witch Ridge.

Lucheng.

Unlike the torrential rains upstream in Jizhou, only a light drizzle fell through Lucheng's night sky.

He Jingyuan stood on the city wall, gazing at the faint outlines of distant mountains. "How far have we lured the rebels?" he asked.

A deputy nearby answered, "Scouts report the rebels have reached the river mouth but remain cautious, refusing to advance further."

After a moment's thought, He Jingyuan said, "Raise my Commander's Flag. Continue baiting them."

Orders were immediately relayed. The city gates opened a crack to release a scout galloping to deliver the message.

He Jingyuan glanced toward the upper reaches of Witch River. Though his expression revealed nothing, his hand gripping the battlement had clenched into a fist.

If this plan failed, Lucheng would be left with only thirty thousand troops for defense—over ten thousand of them raw recruits recently conscripted who couldn't even perform a complete spear routine.

The wilderness of Yanzhou was also graced with a gentle rain.

Xie Zheng reined in his horse atop a low slope, his expression cold as he surveyed the battle below. Torchlights intertwined, only occasionally revealing whether the banners whipping in the wind and rain bore the insignia of Yanzhou or Chongzhou.

The raindrops formed by the drizzle slid down his chin, yet he remained utterly focused, watching the banners of Yanzhou advance segment by segment through the firelight without even a flicker of his eyelashes.

Gongsun Yin shielded himself from the slanting drizzle with a feather fan and asked, "If you don't go down, the Chongzhou army won't enter First Line Gorge."

Xie Zheng remarked, "We've set up an ambush at First Line Gorge, so the Sui family must have laid traps elsewhere as well. Let's wait for them to cast their bait first."

Gongsun Yin's fox-like eyes lifted slightly. "You mean to take their bait and then lure them into First Line Gorge?"

Xie Zheng neither confirmed nor denied.

As Gongsun Yin pondered over the bait Xie Zheng mentioned, his eyes narrowed. Just as he was about to speak, a minor ** erupted in the battlefield below.

A young general charged out from the Chongzhou army—mounted on a white steed, wielding a silver spear, his handsome features tinged with a roguish air. Cradling a terrified little girl who wept uncontrollably amid the battlefield carnage, he arrogantly shouted at the chaotic Yanzhou Army ahead, "Where is Wu'an Marquis? Come forth and meet your death!"

Frowning at the figure standing before the Chongzhou army in the firelight, Gongsun Yin remarked, "He bears some resemblance to your former self."

Xie Zheng cast a cool glance his way with phoenix eyes. "When did your eyesight go bad?"

Before Gongsun Yin could react, Xie Zheng had already lifted the halberd planted in the ground, spurred his horse down the gentle slope. The black cloak billowed high behind him in the drizzle, like a powerful dark cloud.

Chapter 70

The scent of blood, damp earth, and the acrid burn of pine resin torches filled the rain-soaked air.

Sui Yuanqing charged through the ranks of the Yanzhou Army with Changning in tow, his long spear sweeping soldiers aside with the momentum of his horse. Changning's face was splattered with blood, her cries hoarse from screaming.

Sui Yuanqing's own face was streaked with blood, yet he grinned wildly, even teasing Changning in the midst of battle: "Kid, if your old man doesn't have the guts to come save you, you might as well stay at my Changxin Prince Manor. My nephew seems to like you—you'd make a decent little maid for him..."

With a thrust of his spear, he knocked another Yanzhou general from his horse. Just as he moved to finish the man, a halberd suddenly slashed in from the side, deflecting his spear before sweeping horizontally toward him. Sui Yuanqing barely managed to block with the shaft of his weapon, but the force still sent him and his horse stumbling back two steps before he regained his footing.

He raised his eyes to meet the halberd's owner, lips curling in a taunting smirk. "I thought the esteemed Marquis was too noble to show himself."

The drizzle had now turned into a downpour. Xie Zheng stood motionless in the rain, lightning fracturing the black sky behind him. His soaked cloak dripped water down his horse's flanks, the halberd slung across his back, its blade still slick with blood. His cold phoenix eyes fixed on Sui Yuanqing, offering no reply.

Noticing the blood on the halberd's edge, Sui Yuanqing glanced down at his own arm—sure enough, a gash had been opened. The rainwater soaking his clothes seeped into the wound, sending sharp pain radiating through him.

His brow furrowed. Damn, he's fast.

Xie Zheng sneered. "Taking a child onto the battlefield—how bold of you, Sui Shizi ."

Sui Yuanqing's expression darkened at the jab, but he wasted no time engaging further. Wheeling his horse around, he spurred it back toward his own lines with Changning in tow.

Dazed by the night's carnage and the darkness, Changning hadn't recognized Xie Zheng until she heard his voice. As Sui Yuanqing galloped away with her, she suddenly burst into loud sobs. "Brother-in-law—!"

Perched precariously on the saddle in front of Sui Yuanqing, she twisted her small body to look back, her swollen eyes still streaming tears.

Sui Yuanqing shoved the nearly-falling child back into place, his expression turning oddly strained. "What did you just call him?"

Now that Xie Zheng was here, Changning found her courage. Glaring at her captor with puffy eyes, she spat, "My brother-in-law will make you pay!"

Sui Yuanqing looked as if he'd seen a ghost. "So you're not even his daughter?"

The moment Xie Zheng heard Changning's cries, he urged his horse forward in pursuit. His lieutenant, scrambling up from the ground, called out, "Marquis, it could be a trap!"

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes at Sui Yuanqing's retreating figure, then signaled only a few personal guards to follow. "Hold your position here. Do not pursue."

With that, he dug his heels into his horse's flanks and gave chase.

The lieutenant opened his mouth to protest, but Xie Zheng was already gone, his black cloak slicing through the cold wind like a blade.

Arrows whistled past Sui Yuanqing's scalp in the darkness, forcing him to duck low to evade the relentless white-feathered shafts. Memories of being hunted down in Qingping County resurfaced, filling him with bitter humiliation.

Changning was pressed tightly against the horse's back by him. Knowing that someone had come to rescue her, she mustered all her strength to resist Sui Yuanqing, either pulling his hair or biting the hand that held the reins.

A sharp pain shot through the back of his hand, and Sui Yuanqing hissed lightly. With his other hand, he pinched Changning's cheeks between his thumb and forefinger, forcing her to release her bite, then coldly threatened, "If you don't know what's good for you, I'll throw you off this horse right now and let the hooves trample you to death!"

Changning's cheeks ached from his grip, and tears welled up uncontrollably in her eyes.

Seeing her subdued, Sui Yuanqing withdrew his hand. As he and the Chongzhou cavalry zigzagged to evade the arrows behind them, he weighed in his mind whether this little girl in his grasp—who wasn't even Xie Zheng's daughter—was truly worth the immense risk he was taking to save her.

Their original plan had been to use the child as bait to lure Xie Zheng into an ambush. Even if they couldn't kill him, they'd at least make him suffer.

But the bait hadn't been as heavy as he'd anticipated, yet Xie Zheng had still taken it. A sense of foreboding suddenly gripped Sui Yuanqing.

Where had his calculations gone wrong?

From what he knew of Xie Zheng, the man shouldn't be one to act on impulse.

His father's rebellion hadn't been a spur-of-the-moment decision. The seeds of resentment toward the imperial family had been sown years ago when the Grand Princess Consort died in the Eastern Palace.

His father believed the fire that had claimed the Grand Princess Consort and her son was the emperor's warning to him. To protect himself, he had spent the past decade biding his time.

To deal with Wei Yan, they first had to break the sharp blade in his hand. From the moment Xie Zheng rose to fame, his father had groomed Sui Yuanqing to be the one to defeat him.

Military strategy emphasized knowing both oneself and the enemy. Everything Xie Zheng had learned, Sui Yuanqing had studied in turn. Every battle Xie Zheng had won, his father's strategists had analyzed with him repeatedly, searching for weaknesses and devising counter-tactics.

Having spent years replicating everything Xie Zheng had done, Sui Yuanqing sometimes felt as if he had become Xie Zheng's shadow.

Apart from Xie Zheng himself, no one in this world should understand him better than Sui Yuanqing.

If it had been the child of that woman, Xie Zheng's pride might have driven him to take such a risk.

But merely her sister? For men like them, it simply wasn't worth gambling the lives of thousands of soldiers.

Could it be... that he had overestimated Xie Zheng after all?

Lost in thought, Sui Yuanqing was jolted back to reality when his horse took an arrow to the foreleg. The steed whinnied in pain and, driven by momentum, began to collapse forward. His expression darkened as he swiftly grabbed Changning with one hand and used his spear to vault onto another cavalryman's horse, narrowly avoiding being thrown to the ground with his mount.

Xie Zheng had already caught up. He reined his horse to a halt in the middle of the road, blocking Sui Yuanqing and his personal guards. With one hand lightly holding the reins and the other tilting his halberd at an angle, he regarded Sui Yuanqing with an amused glint in his eyes and remarked casually, "It seems the Young Prince of Sui didn't learn his lesson last time. How forgetful."

A thunderclap boomed overhead, and the flash of lightning carved out the sharp contours of Xie Zheng's face, the cold darkness of night stretching behind him.

Though he stood alone against over a dozen Chongzhou riders, the sheer pressure he exuded left the cavalymen struggling to breathe.

Sui Yuanqing was also provoked by these words, nearly unable to suppress the anger in his eyes, but he quickly regained his composure and smirked, "They say the Marquis's horsemanship and archery are extraordinary. For Sui to experience it twice is indeed an honor, isn't it?"

The personal guards who had followed Xie Zheng finally caught up, blocking Sui Yuanqing's retreat path.

Sui Yuanqing showed no panic. He tilted his head slightly and asked Xie Zheng with a smile, "Sui had thought the Marquis was not the type to treat soldiers' lives as trivial. Yet, to save this child, the Marquis is willing to spare no expense."

As he spoke, he stroked Changning's rain-soaked hair, as if petting a small animal.

This was a blatant attempt to sow discord, aiming to stir discontent among Xie Zheng's troops.

Xie Zheng only countered, "Is this spring rain heavy?"

The downpour intensified, large raindrops hammering the ground, carving small pits in the mud under the firelight.

At first, Sui Yuanqing didn't understand why Xie Zheng suddenly mentioned the rain. When realization struck, his expression darkened abruptly. The thought that the fifty thousand troops besieging Lu City might perish in this spring flood made a vein bulge at his temple, his eyes simmering with restrained fury. He raised his spear and pointed it at Xie Zheng, "You knew this was a trap all along? Borrowing twenty thousand troops from Jizhou was also a lie?"

Xie Zheng neither confirmed nor denied.

Sui Yuanqing glared at him, teeth clenched, then suddenly burst into laughter. "Fine! If the battle for Lu City is lost, so be it. Capturing you would bring far greater satisfaction than taking Lu City and marching straight to Jizhou!"

He lifted Changning from the saddle and sneered, "The Marquis's schemes are unmatched. Sui admits defeat. In that case, there's no need to spare this child's life."

With that, he tossed Changning into the air and thrust his spear upward.

Changning let out a short, terrified scream. Xie Zheng's eyes turned icy as he deflected Sui Yuanqing's weapon with his halberd, then leaped from his horse to catch Changning. Seizing the moment, Sui Yuanqing angled his spear beneath Xie Zheng's armor, stabbing into his side.

Without the armor's protection, the spear tip pierced flesh, likely hitting bone—Sui Yuanqing felt the resistance clearly.

Everything happened in an instant. Xie Zheng, still holding Changning with one arm, spotted a personal guard approaching and hurled the child toward him. With his other hand, he pressed down on the spear shaft, using its black-gold tip to pry open his own chest armor. Once back on his horse, he swung the halberd at Sui Yuanqing.

Sui Yuanqing, startled, pushed off the saddle with one hand, vaulting into the air to evade the strike. But he hadn't anticipated Xie Zheng using the halberd to pole-vault into a mid-air kick aimed squarely at his chest.

The impact shattered ribs. Excruciating pain exploded in his chest, and the metallic taste of blood filled his throat.

Instinctively, he tried to rise, but the halberd's blade was already at his throat.

The rain was too heavy, the pain too blinding—he couldn't make out Xie Zheng's expression at that moment.

But Sui Yuanqing knew with absolute clarity: he had lost, utterly and completely.

With his capture, the Chongzhou cavalry dared not act recklessly. Soon, Yanzhou riders arrived to bind Sui Yuanqing.

Xie Zheng looked down at him and ordered, "Take him back."

Sui Yuanqing's personal guards watched helplessly as he was led away, too afraid to intervene. One of them, unnoticed by Xie Zheng's men, mounted a horse and raced back to deliver the news.

Xie Zheng commanded several guards, "Head for First Line Gorge at once."

Initially, there was concern about luring Prince Changxin's army into the canyon, but capturing Sui Yuanqing alive proved to be even more effective than using himself as bait.

The group rode back on horseback, with Xie Zheng sitting upright in the saddle, though his lips were faintly pale. Blood continuously seeped from his sleeve onto the hand gripping his halberd, trickling down his wrist and dripping from the blade.

The maroon inner robe successfully concealed the color of the blood, and the heavy rain masked the scent, so his personal guards had yet to notice his condition.

Changning sat on the horse of one of the guards, initially stunned by fear. Once she regained her composure, she couldn't hold back her sobs, incoherently calling out for "Elder Sister" and "Brother-in-law" in turns.

Xie Zheng glanced at her and, remembering they would pass through the battlefield littered with corpses on the way back, ordered his personal

guard, "Cover her eyes."

Chapter 71

Dozens of riders scattered across the wilderness, their horses' hooves splashing through muddy waters as the Chongzhou Army closed in behind them.

To lure the enemy deep into the gorge, Xie Zheng had deliberately ordered his personal cavalry to feign retreat, baiting the Chongzhou forces into underestimating them.

Sui Yuanqing, bound tightly and slung over a cavalryman's horse, had lost count of how many ribs were broken. His entire chest ached from the crushing pressure. He knew full well that the pursuing Chongzhou troops would never return alive—yet with him captured and the Yanzhou Army pretending to flee, there was no way he could turn the tide.

Suppressing the searing pain in his chest, he let out a cold laugh. "The Marquis took my Gilded Phoenix Wing Spear straight through the lungs and still managed to ride this long. Truly admirable."

His spear had pierced through the gap in Xie Zheng's armor beneath the arm, but Xie Zheng had remained so composed that even the cavalryman who caught Changning assumed it was only a minor wound—let alone the others.

At Sui Yuanqing's words, the men couldn't help but glance at Xie Zheng.

His aim was to shake their morale. If Xie Zheng fell, leaderless and disorganized, tonight's battle might still be overturned.

Thunder rumbled. Xie Zheng's soaked cloak clung to his armor, draping over his horse's back. He tilted his head slightly, posture unwavering, his profile as cold and flawless as jade under the stark lightning. His phoenix eyes lifted lazily as he drawled, "Seems the tip of Young Master Sui's spear was made of wax. Next time you take the field, remember to use iron."

The mockery in his tone was unmistakable.

The cavalrymen burst into derisive laughter. Sui Yuanqing's expression darkened. "Let's see how long the Marquis lasts."

Xie Zheng cast him a cold glance before addressing the rider carrying him. "Young Master Sui seems lively. Let him walk for a while."

Sui Yuanqing's face paled instantly. He knew this was far from a simple "walk."

The cavalymen cheered as expected. Bound and helpless, he was thrown into the rain-soaked mud, filthy water splashing over him, some stinging his eyes. Before he could rise, the riders whooped and cracked their whips, urging their horses into a gallop.

Dragged through the mire by the rope, Sui Yuanqing's back burned raw despite his armor. His fractured ribs shifted further, agony searing through him. Gritting his teeth, he glared into the black downpour, sweat and rain mingling on his brow, the taste of blood thick in his mouth.

Xie Zheng led the charge at the front. Under the lightning's glow, he glanced down at his inner robe, now darkened with blood. His lips pressed into a pale line as he cracked the whip, urging his horse onward toward First Line Gorge.

His condition was far from ideal. Though Sui Yuanqing's spear hadn't pierced his organs, it had struck bone, leaving a sizable wound. The relentless rain prevented clotting, and blood loss left him faint.

But with the Chongzhou Army hot on their heels, stopping now was not an option.

Ahead, the mouth of First Line Gorge loomed like the gaping maw of a slumbering beast. The Chongzhou forces, sensing an ambush, slowed their advance.

As Xie Zheng listened to the scout's report, his eyelids grew heavy. Suddenly, he toppled from his horse. Several riders yanked their reins and rushed to his side. "Marquis!"

Sui Yuanqing, dragged half-dead behind the galloping horse, was in too much pain to muster even a single taunt.

The unusual activity was quickly detected by the scouts of the Chongzhou army, who swiftly carried the news back.

The Chongzhou general leading the pursuit was now in a dilemma. If he stopped at First Line Gorge and failed to bring back Sui Yuanqing, he would undoubtedly face the wrath of Changxin Wang upon his return.

Yet if he pursued into First Line Gorge and fell into an ambush, resulting in the annihilation of his entire force, not even several heads would suffice to atone for such a failure.

The scout's report was the final straw. Coupled with the testimony of Sui Yuanqing's personal guard who had returned to deliver the message—confirming that Xie Zheng had indeed been wounded by Sui Yuanqing—the Chongzhou general leading the troops quickly made his decision.

With the prospect of rescuing Sui Yuanqing and capturing the illustrious Wu'an Marquis as an unparalleled achievement before him, he ordered the cavalry to lead the way and commanded the army to advance at full speed.

It was only then that Xie Zheng's personal guards noticed he was truly injured—a wound that grazed his right ribs, deepening toward the left, a sight that was nothing short of horrifying.

The rain was too heavy. Despite pouring two bottles of trauma medicine over the wound and hastily bandaging it with torn fabric from a battle robe, blood continued to seep out.

A cavalryman who had been keeping watch on the movements of the Chongzhou army rode back and reported, "The Chongzhou cavalry is heading this way in full force."

For a moment, the several dozen cavalymen were thrown into panic. But Xie Zheng, who had been resting briefly in the rain to tend to his wound, suddenly opened his eyes. As if unharmed, he donned his outer armor, mounted his horse, and declared, "Now we can lure the rebels completely into First Line Gorge. Proceed into the gorge as planned!"

The stunned guards exchanged bewildered glances, unable to tell whether Xie Zheng had truly fallen earlier or if it had all been a ruse to deceive the Chongzhou rebels. Recovering quickly, they mounted their horses and followed.

With the need to move at full speed, they no longer had the leisure to toy with Sui Yuanqing.

As Sui Yuanqing was placed on horseback, he suddenly understood the purpose behind Xie Zheng's earlier fall—it had been deliberate!

Injured as he was, not only would the Chongzhou general leading the troops seize this rare opportunity, but even Sui Yuanqing himself would have done the same if he were in command.

Jostled on the horse, Sui Yuanqing hung upside down until the whites of his eyes turned bloodshot. When he lifted his gaze to the rapidly receding cliffs, they too seemed tinged with a faint crimson hue.

Staring at Xie Zheng, who still rode ahead at full speed, Sui Yuanqing suddenly wondered—did Xie Zheng not feel pain?

He didn't believe Xie Zheng's injuries were any lighter than his own. Yet while he himself felt as though he had died several times over from the agony, Xie Zheng had shown no sign of distress except for the deliberate fall to bait the enemy.

As he pondered, the cavalry rounded a bend and fired a whistling arrow into the sky.

In an instant, the entire gorge echoed with the thunderous roar of boulders crashing down. The Chongzhou cavalry, mere moments away from catching up, found themselves in chaos on the narrow mountain path as falling rocks rained upon them.

Attempting to retreat, they were blocked by their own infantry, who had just entered the gorge, leaving no room to escape. In the end, more infantry were trampled to death by panicked horses than were crushed by the rocks.

Even the deafening thunderclaps could not drown out the screams in the gorge. As lightning split the sky, Sui Yuanqing lay over his horse, watching the carnage among the Chongzhou troops in the distance. He shut his eyes heavily, fists clenched so tightly that his nails dug into his palms, drawing blood between his fingers.

This was a debt he would repay.

The Chongzhou cavalry, having trampled many infantrymen in their panic within the gorge, were quickly brought under control by their commanders who rode forward to restore order. The cavalry were commanded not to retreat but to charge forward en masse to reduce the chances of being crushed by the boulders rolling down from the mountains.

Meanwhile, the infantry who had not yet fully entered the gorge hastily turned back to retreat.

However, when the Chongzhou cavalry reached the gorge's exit, they were met with rows of archers already poised with drawn bows.

From the rear of the infantry formation, which had not fully entered the gorge, a detachment of the Yanzhou Army suddenly attacked, throwing the rear ranks into disarray. The soldiers who had barely escaped the gorge alive were still shaken when they saw chaos erupting outside, and their morale plummeted, leading to a near-rout.

The Chongzhou commander leading the troops knew that the battle had already gone disastrously wrong and that he could not escape blame. His only thought now was to preserve as much of his forces as possible and retreat. But with the Yanzhou infantry blocking their path, he devised a plan—ordering his soldiers to shout, "The Wu'an Marquis is dead!"—to sow confusion among the Yanzhou troops.

The tactic worked. The Yanzhou Army, which had been pressing their advantage fiercely, began to falter at the cries of "The Wu'an Marquis is dead!"

On the mountain, Xie Zheng, upon hearing the scout's report, ignored his injuries and struggled to rise, leaning on his halberd. The Army Doctor hesitated, not daring to stop him, but Gongsun Yin pushed him back down, saying, "That brat from the Sui family stabbed you with a viciously cunning spear thrust. Had it been even slightly off, it would have pierced your organs. Have some regard for your life—what could you even do in this state if you went down the mountain?"

They had taken shelter in a cave found by Xie Zheng's personal guards. Though it kept them out of the rain, the cold wind howling through carried dampness that left everyone shivering.

The forest was soaked from the rain, and the soldiers below had been unable to find dry firewood.

Xie Zheng had removed his armor, wearing only an inner robe with his chest exposed. A fierce spear wound ran diagonally from his right chest to his left, leaving a deep gash. The Army Doctor had applied crushed medicinal herbs but had yet to bandage it.

His expression was cold and stern as he said, "Shi Yue is a seasoned general under Changxin Wang, with countless battles to his name. We must not underestimate him. If he regains his morale and counterattacks, our ten thousand troops below the mountain will be in grave danger."

The Chongzhou infantry still numbered twenty thousand below the mountain. If the enemy realized their predicament, their own ambushing

force of ten thousand would be surrounded and annihilated.

Gongsun Yin glanced at the discarded armor piled nearby and said, "I have a plan. Find a personal guard who resembles you in build, dress him in your armor, and have him ride down the mountain to steady morale. In the darkness, who could tell if it's really you? Shi Yue is cautious—he already fell for your earlier trap and charged recklessly into the gorge, learning his lesson. If he sees you appearing below, he won't dare prolong the battle."

The deputy general standing nearby quickly agreed that the plan was feasible.

After weighing the risks, Xie Zheng finally nodded in approval.

As the Army Doctor continued bandaging his wound, Gongsun Yin turned his gaze to Changning, who was wrapped in a dry cloak and sleeping soundly against the cave wall. The child had delicate features, and even with his hair still tousled from being wiped dry after the rain, he looked endearing, like a ruffled chick.

But his face was unusually red. Gongsun Yin reached out to touch him and realized Changning wasn't just asleep—he had fallen ill from being drenched in the rain all night.

Hurriedly, he told the Army Doctor, "After you finish with him, take a look at this child too."

Xie Zheng turned his head and noticed the faint flush on Changning's face. He said to the Army Doctor who was wrapping bandages, "Go check on the child."

The Army Doctor had no choice but to let Xie Zheng press down on the already wrapped gauze himself while he went to take Changning's pulse.

Gongsun Yin had initially intended to help Xie Zheng, but he saw him lower his head and use his teeth to grip one end of the gauze, swiftly tying a knot—clearly no stranger to doing this before.

He was eager to inquire about Fan Changyu. Originally, he had assumed a woman who could butcher pigs would likely be broad-shouldered and stout. After Xie Zheng returned from rescuing someone in Qingping County, Gongsun Yin had privately asked the personal guard if he had seen the girl.

The guard's answer left Gongsun Yin puzzled: She's very pretty, and she can lift a grown man with one hand and throw him several yards away.

Gongsun Yin couldn't picture what kind of woman that might be.

For a while, he suspected Xie Zheng's personal guard might share the same taste in women as Xie Zheng himself, which was why he found such a girl attractive.

But tonight, upon seeing Changning and learning she was Fan Changyu's younger sister, Gongsun Yin began to doubt his earlier assumption. If the younger sister was this delicate and pretty, the elder sister probably wasn't bad-looking either.

So was it true, then, what the guard had said about the pig-butcherer girl being quite beautiful?

His curiosity about Fan Changyu's appearance grew even stronger.

The Army Doctor's medicine chest was stocked with wound medicine and remedies for colds. After taking Changning's pulse, worried that such a young child might not endure the illness, he went to ask the personal guard to find a way to start a fire and brew some medicine.

With only Xie Zheng and Gongsun Yin left in the cave, Gongsun Yin cleared his throat and said, "You rescued this child unharmed, but if you go see her sister covered in injuries like this, that girl will probably shed quite a few tears of heartache!"

Xie Zheng gazed at the rain outside and didn't respond.

Not wanting to seem too obvious, Gongsun Yin continued probing indirectly, "What do you plan to do with the child?"

Xie Zheng glanced at Changning, who now had a damp cloth on her forehead. "Her sister is in Jizhou. Once she recovers from her cold, I'll send her back to Jizhou."

Gongsun Yin asked, "Aren't you going with her?"

Xie Zheng suddenly turned to look at him. Realizing his ulterior motive had been exposed, Gongsun Yin quickly straightened up and fanned himself while staring at the rain outside the cave. "Ah, this rain is really heavy. If everything went smoothly at the dam, those fifty thousand Chongzhou troops besieging Lucheng should all be drowned by now."

Xie Zheng withdrew his gaze and ignored him, though his brows furrowed slightly—clearly also concerned about the battle situation in Lucheng.

Chapter 72

Upstream of Jizhou.

The dam had been blown apart, its murky yellow waters spilling over the riverbed, surging downstream with the force of the torrential rain.

The downpour was like a waterfall. The camp after the night's fierce battle held only corpses and an oppressive silence.

The surviving soldiers were clearing the battlefield in the rain. An old man stood with the general responsible for building the floodgate dam, both gazing at the roaring floodwaters and the recruits who had fallen in battle that night, their faces heavy with unspoken grief.

After a long silence, the general finally asked the old man, "Grand Tutor, do you think releasing these floodwaters downstream will still serve any purpose?"

The one who had been trapped in this camp with Fan Changyu these past days was none other than Grand Tutor Tao, who had resigned from office and retired many years ago.

Raindrops slid down his wrinkled eyelids as he clasped his hands behind his back and looked skyward. "We can only do our best and leave the rest to fate."

Suddenly, the soldiers clearing the battlefield stopped their work, murmuring as they looked in one direction. Grand Tutor Tao and the camp's commanding general turned to see a woman riding slowly through the dark curtain of rain.

In the flashes of lightning, as she drew nearer, everyone could see several riders following behind her, all wearing Jizhou military uniforms, with heads washed clean of blood by the storm hanging from their saddles.

The woman was Fan Changyu.

Grand Tutor Tao seemed to guess what had happened. He raised his aged eyes to meet hers, his gaze showing three parts surprise, three parts

admiration, and four parts self-satisfaction at having recognized her potential.

The riders reached them. The soldiers dismounted and knelt in the rain to report, unable to suppress their joy: "General, when we went to pursue the three fleeing scouts, we found this young lady had already intercepted and killed them all! We brought back their heads."

The general overseeing the dam construction was first startled, then overjoyed. He stepped forward through the rain and cupped his hands respectfully toward Fan Changyu. "By preventing these rebels from reporting back, you've saved countless soldiers and civilians in Lucheng from disaster. On behalf of Lucheng's people and troops, I thank you, honored warrior."

Fan Changyu held the reins of a chestnut warhorse taken from the scouts. "You honor me too much, General. I was merely fulfilling the dying request of that officer from the mining camp."

Raindrops fell from the general's eyelids as he sighed heavily. "That was General Andingbei."

Andingbei? Fan Changyu thought. Now that's a name befitting a great general.

The soldiers who had died this rainy night—whether generals or common troops—could perhaps rest in peace knowing their desperate struggle hadn't been in vain.

Her main reason for returning was to retrieve her pack. When she'd crossed Witch Ridge to intercept the three scouts, she'd left her belongings on her horse. Upon returning, her steed wasn't where she'd left it at the mountain's base. Thinking the old horse knew its way home, she'd followed the cavalry pursuing the scouts back to camp.

After brief pleasantries, Fan Changyu stated her purpose. But the night had been too chaotic, and no one had noticed if a horse had returned on its own.

The camp commander arranged a separate tent for Fan Changyu to rest in while ordering his men to search for her belongings. Having traversed mountains and valleys through the stormy night, Fan Changyu was bruised in many places, her clothes thoroughly soaked. She needed to clean up, so she gratefully accepted the offer.

The military camp had no suitable clothes for her, so the commanding officer ordered a new set of soldier's attire to be brought to her. The smallest size fit Fan Changyu perfectly.

Once she had tidied up, she couldn't wait to personally search for her belongings in the camp's stables. Even when Grand Tutor Tao came looking for her, he found her already gone.

That night, the rain poured down in torrents. Despite the victory report being sent back, the entire army had no time to rest—clearing the battlefield, searching for the wounded, digging mass graves to bury the fallen soldiers...

Even the stables were bustling with activity. Some warhorses had been slashed, others had stepped on sharp objects during battle. The camp's veterinarians were as busy as the army doctors, not even having time to take a sip of water.

Fan Changyu was asking a soldier where General An's warhorse was kept when she heard a familiar, aged voice: "There's a wooden wedge stuck in this horse's hoof. Fetch me a pair of pliers."

Peering over, Changyu was overjoyed and quickly called out, "Uncle Zhao!"

Carpenter Zhao was tending to an injured warhorse. Startled by Fan Changyu's voice, he thought he must have misheard. Squinting his aged eyes, he looked outside and was both surprised and delighted to see it was indeed her. But noticing she was dressed in a soldier's uniform, his expression instantly darkened.

He instructed the soldier helping him lift the horse's leg, "Go get the pliers."

Once the soldier left, he motioned for Fan Changyu to come assist him. The young soldier who had escorted her to the stables was about to refuse, but Changyu quickly explained that she and Carpenter Zhao were from the same hometown and eagerly stepped forward to help.

Uncle Zhao was nearly frantic with worry. Under the guise of having her assist, he lowered his voice and asked, "Why are you in the military camp? If anyone finds out you're a girl, it'll mean your head!"

After changing into dry clothes, Fan Changyu had taken down her hair to dry it before tying it up again.

This was a military camp. Wearing a soldier's uniform, it wouldn't do to style her hair like a woman's, so she simply tied it up haphazardly. She wasn't deliberately disguising herself as a man, but with her naturally heroic bearing, at a glance, she did resemble a delicate-featured young man.

Seeing Uncle Zhao's misunderstanding, Fan Changyu quickly summarized everything that had happened to her recently.

Relieved to learn she hadn't disguised herself as a man to join the army, Uncle Zhao finally relaxed. But hearing about the bandits' massacre in Qingping County and that his wife had been injured, his heart ached, and he repeatedly wiped his tears with his sleeve.

After treating the horse's injured hoof, the two found a quiet spot to talk.

Fan Changyu asked, "Uncle Zhao, were you also conscripted to build the dam?"

Carpenter Zhao sighed. "Originally, I was in Lu City crafting defensive equipment. Later, when Yan Province requested 20,000 troops, even an old bone like me was sent along. After days of marching, when the army stopped here, I learned it was for dam construction. Along the way, warhorses would fall ill, and the mules hauling stones would often get pebbles stuck in their hooves, needing treatment. That's mainly why I'm here—to tend to the livestock."

Fan Changyu had been confined to digging and transporting earth and stones, never venturing into the heart of the camp, while Carpenter Zhao hadn't visited the outer camps either, so they hadn't crossed paths until now. Both sighed at the circumstances.

Remembering Yan Zheng, Fan Changyu asked another question: "Uncle Zhao, since you've been in the camp, have you heard any news about Yan Zheng?"

When this topic came up, Carpenter Zhao hesitated for a moment before glancing at Fan Changyu and saying, "He was among the first batch of soldiers loaned to Yanzhou. I had someone deliver the items you entrusted me with to him. I initially thought he was also here repairing the dam, but after asking around for days, it seems he's been transferred to Yanzhou."

Yanzhou bordered the frontlines and was engaged in battles with the Northern Turks, making it, in some ways, even more perilous than Lucheng.

After a brief silence, Fan Changyu said, "With his skills, he should be able to carve out a good future for himself."

Unaware that the package contained divorce papers, Carpenter Zhao chuckled, "If he makes something of himself, you'll be able to enjoy the benefits too, girl."

Fan Changyu decided not to hide the truth any longer and pursed her lips before saying, "Uncle Zhao, we've actually already divorced."

Carpenter Zhao had been holding a coarse clay bowl of hot water to ward off the cold, but at these words, he nearly dropped it. Raising his wrinkled eyes, he asked, "What happened?"

Fan Changyu answered truthfully, "The marriage was never real to begin with. It was just to deal with Fan Da and protect the family property."

Carpenter Zhao set down the bowl and remained silent for a long while, digesting the news. Finally, he sighed deeply and said, "Changyu, girl, from what I've seen, that lad Yan Zheng didn't seem indifferent toward you. Young couples are often impulsive and prone to taking wrong turns. If you ever meet again in the future, clear things up properly. Don't leave behind a mess of regrets when you're old."

Fan Changyu thought of the day Yan Zheng left—she hadn't even exchanged a proper word with him. A pang of regret stirred in her heart, and she lowered her eyes, murmuring an agreement.

Outside the tent, soldiers led over an injured warhorse, shouting for Carpenter Zhao to come quickly.

Having retrieved her own bundle, Fan Changyu had nothing else to do, so she went to assist Carpenter Zhao, acting as his helper.

Grand Tutor Tao waited and waited at the military tent but saw no sign of Fan Changyu returning. When he came looking for her himself, he found her in the stables, unbothered by the filth, helping an old veterinarian lift a horse's leg. The enthusiasm she showed here was a stark contrast to the aloofness she displayed toward him—it was like night and day.

Grand Tutor Tao's expression darkened immediately. Not only had this girl refused to formally acknowledge him as her teacher, but now she was turning her attention to learning from some old veterinarian? Was her judgment really that poor?

He stood outside the stables and coughed several times, but the noise of the stables and the thunder drowned out his attempts.

As one veterinarian was extracting an arrowhead from a warhorse's leg, the horse suddenly panicked. Not only did it kick the vet, but it also bolted wildly through the stables, knocking over a wooden pillar and causing the entire stable roof to collapse. In an instant, all the warhorses spooked and stampeded outward, with the soldiers unable to stop them.

Fan Changyu reacted swiftly, dragging Carpenter Zhao out of the way of the collapsing roof. But when she looked up, she saw the old man standing dumbfounded at the entrance, with horses charging straight toward him. Without a second thought, she rushed over and hauled him to safety.

After setting him down, Fan Changyu wiped the rain from her face and asked Grand Tutor Tao, "What brings you here, sir?"

Carpenter Zhao asked, "Who is this?"

Fan Changyu replied, "This is the elder I mentioned earlier—the one I met while being forced to quarry stones here."

Grand Tutor Tao had practically been carried over in Fan Changyu's frantic dash. His stomach churned, and his head spun from the ordeal. Struggling to maintain his dignity, he busied himself straightening his robes, refusing to acknowledge her.

The startled warhorses were all calmed down by the soldiers in charge of the steeds, and a nearby military tent was cleared to temporarily treat the injured.

Fan Changyu intended to help Carpenter Zhao and Grand Tutor Tao take shelter from the rain, but when she touched Carpenter Zhao's arm, he let out a pained "Aiyo!"

Fan Changyu quickly asked, "Did I hurt you when I pulled you earlier?"

Carpenter Zhao waved his hand. "These old bones aren't what they used to be. The joints get injured at the slightest touch."

Changyu realized she must have pulled too hard in her urgency, straining the old man's joints. Feeling guilty, she found him a chair to sit on as soon as they entered the tent.

The army veterinarian who had been kicked by a horse was rescued by soldiers and was now lying in the tent having his bones set, wailing loudly

and pitifully. Seeing it would take a while before he could be bandaged, Changyu fetched a basin of hot water, wrung out a cloth, and applied it to Carpenter Zhao's arm to ease the pain.

Grand Tutor Tao had been standing in the tent for quite some time, watching Changyu bustle about taking care of Carpenter Zhao while he was completely ignored, receiving none of the same attention. His displeasure was evident as the corners of his mustache drooped downward.

He walked over and sat in the chair opposite Carpenter Zhao, letting out an exaggerated "Aiyo!"—even louder than the veterinarian who had been kicked by the horse.

Changyu, busy as a spinning top, turned her head at the sound and asked, "What's wrong with you?"

Grand Tutor Tao closed his eyes and said, "This old man has a headache."

Changyu replied, "It must be from getting caught in the rain—you've caught a chill."

She then turned to the Army Doctor and asked him to check Grand Tutor Tao's pulse and prescribe some medicine.

The personal guard who had accompanied Grand Tutor Tao knew his true identity and dared not let anything happen to him. He quickly suggested taking him back to the main tent to have the Army Doctor examine him properly, but Grand Tutor Tao stubbornly refused to leave.

When the Army Doctor finally checked his pulse, he realized the obstinate old man was already running a fever and hurriedly sent a subordinate to fetch a packet of medicine for colds to be brewed.

With not enough hands to brew the medicine, Changyu volunteered to prepare the decoctions for both Carpenter Zhao and Grand Tutor Tao.

Since Grand Tutor Tao adamantly refused to return to the private tent assigned to him by the commander and insisted on staying in the infirmary tent, the soldiers, seeing that both he and Carpenter Zhao were elderly, arranged their beds side by side.

Carpenter Zhao was amiable by nature, but Grand Tutor Tao, suffering from fever and headache, grew increasingly irritable. Even when Carpenter Zhao tried to strike up a conversation, he ignored him.

Only when Changyu went to brew the medicine did Grand Tutor Tao, enduring his headache, declare, "This old man's medicine must be brewed first!"

Changyu found the old man as childish as a kid, competing over such trivial matters, and sighed, "Both pots are brewing at the same time. There's no 'first' or 'second.'"

Only then did Grand Tutor Tao fall silent.

Carpenter Zhao, completely unaware of Grand Tutor Tao's inexplicable hostility toward him, chatted amiably: "For Changyu to encounter a teacher even in the army is her good fortune, and it's also your kindness to form this bond with her."

Grand Tutor Tao felt somewhat mollified by these words and asked, "What are you to that girl?"

Carpenter Zhao said, "We've been neighbors for over a decade. I watched that girl grow up—she's like my own granddaughter."

Suddenly, Grand Tutor Tao felt this seemingly good-natured old man was subtly boasting about his close relationship with the girl. Thinking of his own failed attempts to take her as a disciple, he sulked and fell silent again.

Zhao the Carpenter sighed again as he spoke: "What a fine girl, but alas, fate has been unkind to her. Not only has she lost both parents, but she also divorced her live-in husband. Now her younger sister has been abducted and no one knows where she is..."

Grand Tutor Tao had initially only noticed Fan Changyu's exceptional resilience, but after hearing Zhao recount her misfortunes, he couldn't help feeling more sympathetic toward her. Even his resentment over her refusal to become his disciple lessened somewhat. He said, "I have a student in the army who's like a son to me. He holds an official position. If that girl can't find a good match in the future, I'll have that rascal find her a steady and ambitious young man from among his subordinates."

Hearing that the old man was willing to take charge of Fan Changyu's marital prospects, Zhao became even more convinced he was her benefactor. After expressing his gratitude, the two found themselves getting along remarkably well.

Free from prejudice now, Grand Tutor Tao found this illiterate veterinarian surprisingly insightful. Listening to his tales from decades as a vet and carpenter, he discovered unexpected rustic charm in them.

When Fan Changyu returned with the decoction, she was baffled to find the two men chatting like old friends who'd met too late in life.

Little did she know they'd already arranged a "steady and ambitious young man" as her future husband—

The next afternoon, news of the victorious battle at Lucheng arrived at the camp. The Yanzhou Army's ambush against the Chongzhou forces at First Line Gorge had also been overwhelmingly successful, even capturing the heir of Prince Changxin alive. Morale soared throughout the army, with jubilant celebrations everywhere.

However, spring rains had triggered mudslides, trapping the remaining Yanzhou troops on the mountain. Upon learning of Lucheng's defeat and realizing the Yanzhou reinforcements were a ruse, Prince Changxin—apparently driven to desperation—made a risky move by leading his remaining Chongzhou troops to besiege First Line Gorge, vowing to trap both the Yanzhou Army and Marquis Wu'an on the mountain until they perished.

Upon receiving this intelligence from scouts, the camp's commanding general urgently summoned all subordinate generals to discuss rescue strategies.

The twenty thousand soldiers sent to repair the dam were all recruits with virtually no combat experience. During the previous night's surprise attack by Chongzhou forces, they'd been thrown into such disarray that three enemy scouts had escaped.

If they rashly attempted to rescue those at First Line Gorge, the rain-soaked, mudslide-ravaged terrain would pose extreme hazards. One wrong move could lead them straight into a Chongzhou trap, potentially resulting in total annihilation.

As everyone struggled for solutions, Grand Tutor Tao—his cold slightly improved—dragged his ailing body into the central military tent and proposed a "relieve the besieged by attacking the base" strategy.

He said, "The twenty thousand troops stationed at the river mouth should march on Chongzhou as the main force. Merely besieging it would force Prince Changxin to turn back and defend his stronghold. After all,

without Chongzhou, even if he slaughters every last Yanzhou soldier on that mountain, it would be meaningless."

The commander exclaimed joyfully, "Brilliant strategy! I'll order the camp to move out immediately!"

Grand Tutor Tao, still suffering from his cold, coughed hoarsely before adding, "The trapped Yanzhou troops likely have dwindling provisions. We must send separate units with supplies."

The Yanzhou-Chongzhou conflict had been mobile warfare, with neither side carrying much materiel. Only the mudslides following their victory had allowed Chongzhou to regain the initiative.

The frantic commander, enlightened by Grand Tutor Tao's suggestion, quickly agreed: "The Grand Tutor speaks wisely! But a large supply convoy might alert Chongzhou scouts. Let's dispatch a thousand troops with provisions as emergency relief."

Orders for troop deployment and supply transport were promptly issued, and the army began preparing to break camp.

Carpenter Zhao had to follow the army to besiege Chongzhou. Fan Changyu initially wanted to go along, but as a young woman currently settled here—having already made contributions—and with some surviving refugees also temporarily left in her care, staying with the army for too long would violate military regulations.

She had ambushed and killed those three scouts, but the commander could only reward her with money and couldn't grant her an official military position.

She could have set out on her own, but Fan Changyu was now hesitating. Changxin Wang had led troops to the mountains to encircle the Wu'an Marquis, so Chongzhou's gates were undoubtedly tightly shut. Even if she went, she wouldn't be able to enter the city to find Changning.

Moreover, Carpenter Zhao mentioned that Yan Zheng seemed to be among the thousand soldiers borrowed by the Yanzhou Army. After a brutal battle and a subsequent mudslide triggered by heavy rain in the mountains, it was unclear whether Yan Zheng was alive or dead.

Should she go to First Line Gorge first to look for Yan Zheng?

When Tao Taifu returned and saw Fan Changyu standing outside the tent lost in thought, he asked, "Girl, this old man is about to accompany the

army to deliver provisions to the Yanzhou troops in the mountains. Would you like to come with me?"

Only in the past two days had Fan Changyu learned that this eccentric old man was surnamed Tao. Due to his genuine talents, he had apparently become an advisor in the army, and even the commander treated him with great respect.

Staring at Tao Taifu's wrinkled face, she thought carefully and finally nodded.

It wouldn't hurt to see Yan Zheng one more time. If he had died there, she would bury him and erect a tombstone for him.

He seemed to have no other family. At the very least, they had known each other and been nominal husband and wife for a few months. During future festivals, when she burned ghost money, she could burn some for him too.

If he was still alive, they probably wouldn't end up completely estranged.

The supply convoy set off first. Carpenter Zhao came to see them off, but to Fan Changyu's bewilderment, he actually exchanged more words with the old man than with her.

To avoid Chongzhou's scouts, the supply convoy had to take a detour through the mountains. Even so, they encountered several patrols. Fortunately, the army had archers who pursued the scouts for miles, ensuring the news of their march didn't reach the Chongzhou forces too quickly.

Fan Changyu had gained some fame among the new recruits for crossing Witch Ridge and killing three Chongzhou scouts. Sometimes, when pursuing scouts, she was even invited to join.

She wasn't skilled with a bow. When learning from the archers, her strength was so great she could snap a bowstring, but her aim was terrible—worse than throwing rocks from the ground.

Afraid of wasting weapons, she simply gave up. But after seeing the archers shoot wild rabbits for meals along the way, she grew envious and praised their skills.

The more seasoned soldiers laughed and said, "Miss Fan, you've never seen our Marquis shoot. His archery is truly unmatched. Within a hundred

paces, forget rabbits—he can hit willow leaves.”

Fan Changyu had heard the legend of shooting through a willow leaf at a hundred paces, but hitting a willow leaf at that distance was unheard of. How could anyone shoot something so slender from so far away?

Shocked as she was, the image of the formidable Wu'an Marquis grew even more impressive in her mind.

After traveling day and night for a day and a half, they finally arrived at the entrance of First Line Gorge. Changxin Wang had likely already heard about the twenty-thousand-strong army heading to besiege Chongzhou, so the troops stationed at the mountain's base had withdrawn somewhat. Their numbers didn't seem large, but they were still more than the thousand-strong supply convoy could handle.

To transport the provisions up the mountain, the only feasible plan now is to coordinate from within and without, catching the Chongzhou army off guard and forcing an opening to slip through.

However, their forces are weak, and it remains uncertain whether they can hold out long enough for those on the mountain to notice them and join in the coordinated attack.

Grand Tutor Tao and the young general leading the troops were at their wits' end when they encountered reinforcements from Yanzhou. Combining their forces, they now had two to three thousand soldiers and launched a massive assault up a strategic path at the mountain's base that was guarded by Chongzhou troops.

The commotion quickly drew the attention of the remaining Yanzhou forces on the mountain, who immediately coordinated with the reinforcements to attack the Chongzhou troops from both sides. Soon, they breached an entry point into the mountain, and all the provisions and wound medicine were swiftly transported uphill.

However, the supply-carrying reinforcements did not follow up the mountain. Once the remaining forces had moved all the supplies, and as Chongzhou troops from other positions rushed over, they retreated into the dense forest, playing a game of cat and mouse with the enemy. Their goal was to provide external support when the Yanzhou forces on the mountain later launched their descent.

Fan Changyu had initially been observing the battle alongside Grand Tutor Tao, but seeing how slow the supply transport was, she grew

impatient and couldn't resist joining in. After hauling bags of grain up the mountain, she realized the exit had been sealed off again, leaving her and the other supply carriers stranded on the mountain.

Changyu wasn't too disheartened, though. She had come here intending to find Yan Zheng, and now she could gather information on the mountain.

The trapped Yanzhou soldiers had gone without food for two days. It was early spring, and the mountain yielded few edible wild greens. They had survived on thin broth made from the scant game they managed to hunt, barely tasting any meat.

Now that they had rice, the soldiers immediately set to work building fires and cooking meals.

Conditions in the wounded soldier camp were even grimmer. Many soldiers, drenched by rain, had developed high fevers, but the Army Doctor's limited medical supplies were insufficient. Others, injured in the chaos of battle or mudslides, had no hemostatic agents—only strips of torn undergarments wrapped around their wounds as they lay in various states of agony in the medical tents.

With the arrival of medicine, the Army Doctor urgently began preparing decoctions for the wounded.

Changyu, heartbroken by the soldiers' suffering—fathers, sons, husbands, their fates uncertain—volunteered to help brew the medicine, drawing on her past experience caring for Changning and Yan Zheng.

The Army Doctor prioritized Xie Zheng's treatment once medicine became available. Since the mudslide two days prior, which trapped them on the mountain and allowed the resurgent Chongzhou troops to block their escape, Xie Zheng had barely slept, constantly strategizing with Gongsun Yin on defense tactics.

His injuries were severe, but with supplies scarce, he had forgone treatment for two days, insisting the medicine go to more critically wounded soldiers instead.

Changning, fortunately, had responded well to the earlier dose of medicine—her fever broke quickly. However, with no proper food, she had visibly withered. The game caught by the personal guards, boiled without salt or seasoning, reeked so strongly of blood that she vomited at the smell and couldn't eat. Xie Zheng had meat roasted with grass juice to mask the odor, which she managed to stomach in small amounts.

Knowing Xie Zheng was injured and unable to care for Changning properly—and with officers frequently visiting his quarters for meetings—Gongsun Yin took the child to his own lodges and assigned personal guards to look after her.

At this moment, the Army Doctor went to persuade Xie Zheng to change his bandages. Knowing that the soldiers currently had sufficient food and medical supplies, the dizziness from excessive blood loss and exhaustion from two sleepless days overwhelmed Xie Zheng all at once. He felt that if he closed his eyes, he would fall into a deep sleep immediately. Pressing his temples with his hand, his eyes bloodshot, he said, "This Marquis can still hold on. Give the medicine to the soldiers below first. The wounded soldiers' tent is too crowded—some can be moved to the main tent."

There weren't enough military tents on the mountain either. Many soldiers had to cut branches on the spot to hastily build makeshift shelters from the rain.

The Army Doctor, worried about Xie Zheng's condition, quickly said, "Marquis, there's enough wound medicine. Your health is what matters most..."

Xie Zheng suddenly lifted his gaze to look at the Army Doctor. Struck by that cold, weary stare, the physician lowered his head, all his words of persuasion stuck in his throat.

He knew that despite his lord's fearsome reputation, Xie Zheng deeply cared for his soldiers. With a sigh, he left the tent, thinking he should ask Gongsun to persuade him later.

Upon hearing this, Gongsun Yin simply instructed that the already bandaged wounded soldiers be transferred to the main tent.

The Army Doctor, confused, complied. Only then did he realize Gongsun Yin's intention—once Xie Zheng saw the wounded soldiers, he would believe there was enough medicine.

Xie Zheng was utterly exhausted. After the Army Doctor left, he propped himself up, intending to massage his throbbing temples, but succumbed to fatigue and fell asleep. He only woke again when he heard the commotion of the wounded soldiers being moved into the main tent.

The personal guards set up several makeshift military beds made of branches in the main tent and urged Xie Zheng to rest on one of the empty ones.

Noticing that his presence in the commander's seat made the wounded soldiers keep glancing his way, Xie Zheng nodded in agreement.

His chest wound made wearing armor painful, so he only wore a thin inner robe.

Most of the wounded soldiers brought into the tent were low-ranking privates who had rarely seen Xie Zheng up close. Bewildered at being transferred here, they noticed his lack of armor and his injuries, mistaking him for another wounded soldier sent to recover.

Since Xie Zheng had lent the main tent for the wounded to recuperate, he didn't want them lying there nervously under his gaze. He ordered his personal guards not to reveal his identity, then lay down in his clothes to catch up on sleep.

Worried he might catch cold but not daring to cover him with his thick brocade cloak, the guards deliberated before finally draping a tattered private's uniform over him.

Fan Changyu, having finished brewing the medicine, learned that a group of wounded soldiers had been relocated. She came to deliver the medicine, handing out bowls one by one from the beds near the entrance. The soldiers, realizing she was a woman, grew shy and thanked her softly.

One of Xie Zheng's personal guards glanced outside and, upon spotting Fan Changyu, widened his eyes in shock.

If he wasn't mistaken, wasn't this the woman their Marquis had personally gone to rescue from the bandit den in Qingping County not long ago?

Why was she here, dressed in a Jizhou soldier's uniform?

The guard immediately imagined a heart-wrenching tale of a wife traveling thousands of miles to find her husband. He glanced at the sleeping Xie Zheng, then back at Fan Changyu still distributing medicine, hesitating whether to wake his lord.

Before he could decide, Fan Changyu had already approached with a bowl of medicine in hand.

Xie Zheng found the light too bright and was sleeping with his face turned inward, most of his features hidden in shadow. Fan Changyu didn't recognize him at first, only noticing that half his clothes were soaked with blood, and the bandages wrapped around his body were stained red in

large patches. It didn't look like a fresh dressing, and he seemed to have passed out.

Frowning, she quickly called outside the tent, "Army Doctor! This man's wounds seem to have reopened. He needs to be rebandaged."

Almost the moment he heard her voice, Xie Zheng abruptly opened his eyes.

Fan Changyu had been about to help adjust the position of this severely injured man, moving to the other side of the bed, when she unexpectedly met Xie Zheng's gaze. She froze visibly, staring for a long moment before hesitantly saying, "Yan Zheng?"

The moment the name left her lips, seeing him covered in blood, Fan Changyu's nose suddenly stung.

So he really had almost died here.

Xie Zheng looked at her without speaking, his brows instinctively furrowed. To others, it might seem unreadable, but those who knew him well could tell he was stunned.

The personal guard, after careful consideration, silently took a few steps back.

The other wounded soldiers, assuming Fan Changyu had traveled a great distance to find her husband, cast envious glances their way.

Xie Zheng studied Fan Changyu for a long time, as if confirming she had truly come here, before finally asking in a hoarse voice, "Why are you here? What are you doing here?"

He hadn't slept for two nights, and his throat was rough.

Fan Changyu hadn't expected to see Xie Zheng again under such circumstances. Staring at the bloodstains on him, her eyes inexplicably burned as she said, "I came to find you."

It was the truth. When she learned he was also in this Yanzhou Army, she had feared something might happen to him and followed along to deliver supplies.

At her words, Xie Zheng's pupils contracted almost imperceptibly. His heart felt as if it had been suddenly hooked tight—sharp pain followed by a dense, creeping itch, as though something was trying to take root and

sprout within that mass of flesh and blood. His dark eyes remained fixed on Fan Changyu as he repeated, "Find me?"

Fan Changyu had already begun unwrapping his bandages. Seeing the gruesome wound stretching across most of his chest, mingled with herbal paste and darkened blood, her eyes reddened further. Ignoring his question, she pressed her lips together to suppress the ache in her chest and asked, "How did you get hurt like this?"

It looked even worse than the injuries he'd had when she first found him.

This was the first time Xie Zheng had seen such an expression in her eyes—like the first rays of dawn breaking through misty, rain-soaked forests: warm, tender, radiant, and full of pity.

The hook in his chest tightened further, pain and itch intertwining, as if the wound itself was urging new growth. His fingers twitched, an unconscious urge to reach for something, but he averted his gaze and said, "The wound looks worse than it is. It's not that serious—didn't hit any vital organs. A few days of rest and it'll heal."

Fan Changyu naturally didn't believe him. Looking at his pale, blood-streaked face, she suddenly felt an overwhelming sadness and said, "Don't stay in the army. Come back with me. I'll raise pigs to support you."

Gongsun Yin and the Army Doctor had just arrived outside the tent and were about to lift the flap when they heard this, freezing in unison.

Chapter 73

The Army Doctor had interacted with Fan Changyu before and knew she was looking for someone. Hearing her sudden outburst, he broke into a cold sweat for her, thinking that since the Wu'an Marquis was also inside the tent, if he heard Fan Changyu urging the soldiers to desert, who knew how he would punish her.

He was about to rush in to interrupt when Gongsun Yin stopped him. Wearing an enigmatic smile, Gongsun shook his head at him, made a silencing gesture, and then tilted his head to listen carefully to the commotion inside the tent.

The Army Doctor's heart was in his throat. He thought the woman had merely misspoken out of ignorance of military regulations, but why was even the strategist acting like he was enjoying the spectacle?

Standing outside the tent in trepidation, he feared the next moment would bring Xie Zheng's order to drag her out for a military rod punishment. But from inside, only the clamor of the wounded soldiers could be heard. One of them said, "Brother, if I were you, having a girl travel thousands of miles to find me, I'd die here with no regrets!"

"Who knows how many lifetimes of good karma you've accumulated. After this war, the rest of us just hope to return home in one piece, and even then, finding a wife might be impossible at our age. But you? The girl came straight to you!"

Others tried to console Fan Changyu: "Sister, we know you're worried about your man, but you shouldn't say such things in the military camp. Desertion is punishable by death! Don't worry, though. Surviving such severe injuries means he's bound for good fortune."

Of course, Fan Changyu knew she couldn't let Yan Zheng desert. Seeing the gruesome wounds on his body and knowing he had been conscripted to spare her family and nine other households, her heart ached with pain and guilt. In her desperation, those words had slipped out.

As she helped Xie Zheng clean the days-old medicinal residue from his wounds, the mingled stench of blood and medicine had formed a foul odor.

The new flesh intertwined with the rotting flesh, and reapplying medicine would likely require scraping off the decayed layer.

A tear the size of a bean fell straight from her eye without even tracing her eyelid. Only then did Fan Changyu realize she was crying.

She raised her hand to wipe her eyes clumsily, trying to steady herself, but her voice still came out hoarse when she spoke: "I didn't mean for him to desert, I..."

She looked at Xie Zheng, another tear falling, and finally managed three raspy words: "I'm sorry."

If not for the sham marriage to her, he wouldn't have been on the conscription list.

If not for sparing her and the neighboring families, he wouldn't have obediently gone with the officers.

Seeing him wounded like this on the battlefield filled Fan Changyu with sorrow.

Xie Zheng was still reeling from her words about taking him back. Raising his eyes to see the tears in hers, his pale, cracked lips pressed together slightly as he said, "Don't cry."

He knew why Fan Changyu was apologizing and understood the guilt weighing on her heart. He wanted to tell her everything, but the timing and setting were all wrong. In the end, he couldn't bring himself to speak.

This was the first time he had seen Fan Changyu cry. His chest felt as though something were twisting inside it, yet also as if he were soaking in warm spring water—an odd and unfamiliar sensation.

He wanted to wipe her tears and hold her, but perhaps the tension that had been coiled in his mind these past days had finally loosened. The exhaustion and damage to his body surged forth with doubled intensity, his limbs feeling as heavy as lead. Even half-propping himself up to sit was a struggle.

Fan Changyu noticed he wanted to move and pressed him back down by his shoulders, her eyes red as she said, "Don't move. Wait for the physician to treat your wound."

She then turned and urgently called outside the tent, "Where's the Army Doctor? Has the Army Doctor arrived yet?"

Xie Zheng looked at her profile, his gaze settling on the hand she had placed beside the bed. Hesitantly, he reached out to lightly grasp it and said again, "Don't cry."

Suppressing the sting in her eyes, Fan Changyu glanced down at his hand weakly holding hers and firmly clasped back, pressing her warm palm tightly against his large, calloused one. His palm felt slightly cool from weakness, but under her tight grip, it seemed to gradually warm.

From the time they met until now, this was the first time they had held hands.

As if an unspoken understanding had been reached in this simple gesture, Fan Changyu met his eyes with clear determination and said, "I'm not crying. Don't be afraid. We brought plenty of wound medicine up the mountain. The Army Doctor will definitely heal you."

When Fan Changyu called out again, the Army Doctor hurriedly looked at Gongsun Yin. Gongsun Yin, seemingly disappointed at not hearing what he had hoped for, finally led the Army Doctor into the tent.

The Army Doctor felt uneasy, thinking to himself that this strategist was truly a wolf in sheep's clothing—how could he be disappointed that the Marquis hadn't punished the woman?

Gongsun Yin, always dressed in white robes and carrying a fan, was easily recognizable. The moment he entered, the wounded soldiers visibly tensed.

With a warm smile, Gongsun Yin said, "Rest easy, brave soldiers. I've come only to check on your injuries and ensure there's enough wound medicine."

Yet his gaze subtly drifted toward Fan Changyu.

Hearing the commotion, Fan Changyu turned toward the entrance. This was her first time seeing Gongsun Yin, and though she could tell he was an official, Xie Zheng's injuries took priority. She ignored him and immediately addressed the Army Doctor, urging, "Doctor, please examine him quickly!"

As she lifted her head, Gongsun Yin got a clear look at her face. His fox-like eyes arched slightly in surprise.

The woman wasn't unattractive, but at first glance, she seemed plain and unassuming—like an overlooked noble daughter from a powerful

family, one who had lost her mother early and been bullied by her sisters, never winning her father's favor.

Unlike the delicate, pitiable type that evoked sympathy, she instead reminded one of a docile stray puppy—just looking at her inexplicably softened hearts. No one would believe she was the type to wield a butcher's knife.

Recalling the rumors he'd heard about her, Gongsun Yin found it all rather strange. His eyes fell on her slender arms, and his brows furrowed further. With such delicate limbs, could she really lift a grown man and throw him several yards away?

Had the personal guard been exaggerating?

Gongsun Yin glanced toward the guard now huddled in the corner. The guard met his gaze, clearly confused by the unspoken question, his expression utterly blank.

Resigned, Gongsun Yin looked away, knowing no answers would come from the guard's foolish expression.

The Army Doctor had already moved toward Fan Changyu with his medicine chest. From the moment he entered, he had cautiously glanced toward the main seat, relieved not to see Xie Zheng there. No wonder the Marquis hadn't erupted in anger, he thought.

Now setting down his chest and rolling up his sleeves to check the pulse, he froze the instant he recognized the figure lying on the army cot. His legs nearly gave way, his mind turning to mush as shock and bewilderment overtook him.

Marquis... why is the Marquis here?

Could it be that the woman's words just now were directed at the Marquis?

The Army Doctor sucked in several sharp breaths.

Seeing the Army Doctor frozen in place with a horrified expression, Fan Changyu quickly urged him again, "Army Doctor?"

The Army Doctor snapped out of it and glanced at Fan Changyu, swallowing hard before meeting Xie Zheng's gaze. As he sat on the makeshift wooden stool to take the pulse, his hands trembled so badly he could barely steady them, and his legs shook uncontrollably.

Had he heard too much that he shouldn't have? Would the Marquis silence him afterward?

Noticing the Army Doctor trembling all over, Fan Changyu worried he might misdiagnose Xie Zheng and asked with concern, "Army Doctor, are you alright?"

In just this short time, sweat had already beaded on the Army Doctor's forehead like rolling pearls. He wiped it away roughly with his sleeve and, under Xie Zheng's gaze, forced a strained smile. "I'm fine... fine..."

Once he finally finished taking the pulse, Fan Changyu immediately asked about Xie Zheng's condition. The Army Doctor wiped his sweat and said, "Mar—"

The moment the word left his mouth, he caught a warning glance from the Marquis's personal guard and hastily corrected himself, "This young man is truly remarkable. The injury came within a hair's breadth of his organs—extremely dangerous. But his constitution is strong, which is why he's lasted this long. Still, he must take medicine promptly and rest properly. Due to severe blood loss, he'll likely experience frequent dizziness in the coming days. It's best... best to supplement his diet with meat for nourishment."

When it came time to clean the necrotic flesh from Xie Zheng's wound and reapply medicine, Fan Changyu saw the Army Doctor's hands still shaking and feared he might accidentally hurt Xie Zheng. She offered to do it herself.

The Army Doctor's trembling was purely from fright, and he was trying hard to steady himself. He absolutely dared not let Xie Zheng suffer any harm, but he also didn't trust Fan Changyu, a complete novice, to handle the task.

At this moment, Xie Zheng spoke up, "Let my wife do it."

The Army Doctor's mind was instantly thrown into turmoil—this woman was their never-before-seen Marchioness!

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned by the term but said nothing.

Even as the Army Doctor sat on a low stool nearby, directing Fan Changyu on how to scrape away the necrotic flesh, his mustache still quivered uncontrollably.

Gongsun Yin was clearly just as surprised. Under the pretense of caring for the wounded soldiers, he shamelessly stayed behind, enduring several sharp glares from Xie Zheng without budging. His gaze kept darting between Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng.

Fan Changyu held a dagger over the flame to sterilize it, her full attention fixed on the necrotic flesh on Xie Zheng's chest, completely oblivious to the others around her.

A personal guard handed Xie Zheng a clean cloth to bite down on, but he refused.

Fan Changyu gripped the dagger, her other hand lightly pressing against his chest as she asked, "Are you afraid?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Just do it."

Suddenly, Fan Changyu felt her eyes sting. Suppressing all emotions in that moment, she focused entirely on scraping away the necrotic flesh from his chest. Her hand was steady, her lips pressed tightly together.

Xie Zheng never took his eyes off her, as though the wound on his chest and even his own life were of no consequence.

Sweat beaded on both their foreheads, yet neither made a sound.

When Fan Changyu noticed her palms were damp, she wiped her hands and the dagger's handle hastily with a cloth before resuming the task.

Xie Zheng's muscles were taut as stone, veins bulging from his arms to his temples. Sweat dripped from his eyelids, yet he didn't even blink.

The entire tent was eerily silent, not a word spoken.

Gongsun Yin stood to the side with his fan in hand, the teasing in his eyes and the smile at his lips both fading away.

It was a strange feeling. Just moments ago, he had thought that while this woman and Xie Zheng were a match in appearance, considering their family backgrounds, it was uncertain whether this union would bring her fortune or misfortune.

But now, he suddenly felt that in this world, there was probably no one else besides this woman to whom Xie Zheng would willingly entrust his life.

If he could even give his life for her, how could he ever let her suffer the slightest grievance in the murky waters of the capital in the future?

As for whether she was worthy of Xie Zheng—since she could make him willingly go to such lengths, who else had the right to judge her merits or worthiness?

He tapped the fan lightly against his palm twice, and a faint smile curved his lips once more.

As the last piece of decayed flesh was scraped from Xie Zheng's chest, Fan Changyu's back was almost entirely drenched in sweat. She turned to the Army Doctor and said, "Done."

The Army Doctor hastily sprinkled a bottle of ґpавma medicine over the wound and applied the herbal paste he had prepared in the meantime. He instructed Xie Zheng to stay in bed as much as possible in the coming days and avoid lifting heavy objects until the wound fully healed.

Fan Changyu remained silent, standing to the side the entire time.

Having seen enough of the spectacle, Gongsun Yin finally spoke a few comforting words to the wounded soldiers at a leisurely pace when Xie Zheng shot him another cold glare. Then, with a meaningful glance that promised to keep his secret, he gracefully rose and followed the Army Doctor out.

With everyone gone, the personal guard, afraid that Fan Changyu might notice something amiss, felt too awkward to linger inside and also stepped outside.

Only then did Fan Changyu ask Xie Zheng softly, "Does it hurt?"

Xie Zheng shook his head. "No."

Changyu's eyes were still faintly red. The medicine she had brewed earlier had anti-inflammatory properties, and Xie Zheng's injury could benefit from it as well.

She brought over a bowl and fed it to him spoon by spoon. Seeing him so weakened, she said sorrowfully, "You should have signed those divorce papers sooner."

Xie Zheng choked on the medicine, coughing violently as if his lungs would tear apart.

Chapter 74

Fan Changyu quickly set down her bowl and patted his back: "Why are you choking?"

This pat turned out to be a mistake—Xie Zheng immediately leaned over the bedside and spat out a mouthful of dark red blood.

Fan Changyu was terrified. She looked at her hand, then at Xie Zheng, before turning her head and shouting outside the tent: "Army Doctor! Call the Army Doctor, someone's coughing up blood!"

The personal guard stationed outside heard the commotion, lifted the tent flap, and upon seeing the blood on the ground, immediately ran to catch up with the Army Doctor who had just left the tent not long ago.

The other wounded soldiers in the tent began murmuring among themselves—some said Xie Zheng was experiencing a final rally before death, while others told Fan Changyu not to worry too much and to wait for the Army Doctor's assessment.

Fan Changyu hastily wiped the blood from Xie Zheng's mouth with a handkerchief, gripping his hand tightly as she muttered, "It's okay, it's okay..."

It was unclear whether she was saying this to comfort Xie Zheng or herself.

Xie Zheng had been carrying a clot of stagnant blood in his chest for days. This coughing fit had finally expelled it, instantly relieving the suffocating pressure in his chest and making his breathing much smoother. However, the violent coughing must have reopened his wounds, as faint traces of blood began seeping through the bandages.

He glanced at Fan Changyu's hand tightly clutching his. His originally pale lips had gained a touch of color from the coughing, but this only made his face appear even more ashen, evoking an inexplicable sense of heartache.

Lowering his eyes weakly, he asked, "You want to divorce me?"

Fan Changyu's eyes welled up with tears: "No, no more divorcing!"

Her voice even carried a sob: "You were only conscripted because you married into my family. If we had talked properly that day and you'd signed the divorce papers, the officers wouldn't have taken you away, and you wouldn't have been hurt like this. Don't be afraid—I won't abandon you in this state. On my way here, I'd already decided... if you died here, I'd take care of your remains. You have no family left, so I'd make offerings to you during festivals..."

As she spoke, her genuine fear that this person might die here caused large teardrops to fall onto the quilt, leaving small wet marks.

A hand pressed against her back, forcefully pulling her into an embrace that smelled of blood and medicinal herbs.

Afraid of aggravating his injuries, Fan Changyu pressed against his shoulders to push him away, but Xie Zheng only tightened his arms around her, pressing her firmly against his chest. He rested his chin on her trembling shoulder—still shaking from her crying—and said hoarsely, "Don't move."

Not daring to struggle further for fear of worsening his condition, Fan Changyu remained still. Yet an indescribable emotion filled her chest, making it feel tight, and tears continued to spill uncontrollably, soaking into the fabric on his shoulder.

Xie Zheng said, "Don't cry. I'm glad you came to find me."

After a pause, he added, "About that day... I'm sorry."

Fan Changyu knew what he was referring to. She pressed her lips together, about to respond, when the tent flap was suddenly thrown open. The personal guard rushed in with the Army Doctor, and Gongsun Yin, worried something might have happened to Xie Zheng, had also come to check. Upon seeing the scene before them, they all froze in place with varying expressions.

Hearing the noise, Fan Changyu turned her head and noticed the other wounded soldiers staring unblinkingly at them. Her face flushed red, and she hurriedly pushed Xie Zheng back onto the bed—perhaps a bit too forcefully, as he let out a muffled groan. Fan Changyu awkwardly withdrew her hands: "Did I hurt you?"

Xie Zheng, his face still pale, said it was nothing.

The injured veteran inside the tent smiled and helped them out of the awkward situation: "The young couple just went through a life-and-death separation, they're still shaken by it!"

The other wounded soldiers also laughed good-naturedly.

The Army Doctor stepped forward to ask about Xie Zheng's coughing up blood, then took his pulse again. Not daring to be overconfident, he simply said it was due to physical weakness—his vitality severely depleted and in need of nourishment.

"Physical weakness, huh..." Gongsun Yin teased Xie Zheng with a glance, stroking his chin as he said, "Have the cookhouse camp prepare some meat dishes for the injured soldiers, let them all nourish themselves properly."

The wounded soldiers in the tent all expressed their profuse thanks.

Gongsun Yin continued, "Those with severe injuries and those with minor ones should be separated into different tents for care, which will also make it easier for the army doctors to prepare medicine."

As he spoke, he pointed at Xie Zheng: "Coincidentally, the soldiers set up several new tents this afternoon for the Jizhou troops coming down the mountain. They're not far from here—this man can be moved to one of the new tents."

Xie Zheng shot him a cold glare, to which Gongsun Yin responded with a mischievous grin.

Since Xie Zheng was injured, several personal guards disguised as ordinary soldiers carried him along with his bed to the newly erected tent.

Fan Changyu followed and was surprised to find that although the tent contained many military beds, no one else was currently staying there.

Gongsun Yin explained that more severely injured soldiers would be gradually assigned to this tent later.

When Fan Changyu went to the cookhouse camp to help fetch meals for the wounded soldier camp, Gongsun Yin finally sat down on a military bed opposite Xie Zheng and asked with raised eyebrows, "Should I arrange a separate tent for that girl, or let her stay here with you?"

Xie Zheng had just drunk a bowl of medicine and was still suffering from the bitter taste. He sat up, poured himself a cup of water to drink, then

held the cup and lowered his eyes in thought for a moment before saying, "Arrange another place for her."

Gongsun Yin smiled. "Fine, I nearly forgot—there's also a little kid at my place. Now that her sister is here, it would be good for the two sisters to stay together."

Remembering the scene he'd witnessed when lifting the tent flap earlier, he couldn't resist teasing: "That gunshot wound of yours was worth it—the girl even cried for you. There's no way she doesn't have feelings..."

At this point, his voice suddenly paused as he looked at Xie Zheng: "Even Sui Yuanqing thought to capture her sister to threaten you once he learned of her connection to you. If Wei Yan also hears rumors... you know his methods."

Xie Zheng's fingers gripping the earthen cup suddenly tightened. "Seal all information about today's events. Not a word is to spread."

Gongsun Yin said, "Only the Army Doctor and a few of your personal guards know. Those guards were personally promoted by you—they're tight-lipped. I've already warned the Army Doctor and have had people secretly watching him these past two days. There shouldn't be any problems. But the wounded soldiers in the tent all know that girl came looking for you. If they were to learn your true identity, it might be troublesome..."

Xie Zheng said, "Then keep it concealed for now."

Gongsun Yin asked further, "What about Miss Fan?"

Xie Zheng half-lifted his eyelids. "I'll find an opportunity to explain everything to her."

Gongsun Yin nodded. "As long as you have a plan."

After he left, Xie Zheng lay back with his arms behind his head, staring blankly at the tent ceiling for a long time.

He wasn't sure whether Fan Changyu would still choose to be with him after learning everything.

She might have accepted Yan Zheng who had nothing, but she might not choose Xie Zheng who bore a sea of blood feuds.

Much of her current kindness toward him stemmed from guilt—believing he'd been forced to join the army to avoid causing trouble for her and the

neighbors.

When she found out he was originally planning to return to the army as well, this sense of guilt should have vanished without a trace.

He knew how much she cared for her sister, but because of him, her sister had fallen into the hands of villains and nearly lost her life.

Whether she would resent him, he wasn't sure. But one thing was certain—if she chose to stay with him, she would likely face such dangers again in the future.

Given her temperament, for the sake of her sister's safety and peace, she would probably draw a clear line between them. She preferred tranquility, just as she had once said—to find a humble, dependable scholar as a husband and live a simple, ordinary life.

The kindness she showed him now felt like something he had stolen.

A thief would always be exposed one day.

He understood the consequences, but when he recalled the way she had looked at him while crying, the words she had spoken, his heart ached uncontrollably.

He had never wanted something so desperately, yet feared losing it so much.

For a moment, Xie Zheng even wished he really was just Yan Zheng.

In the end, he could only manage a self-mocking smile.

Fan Changyu returned with food to find Xie Zheng with one hand over his eyes, as if asleep.

But as she approached, he lowered his arm and looked at her.

Fan Changyu smiled at him. "You're awake? The cookhouse camp caught some wild chickens and made soup for the injured soldiers. Drink it while it's hot."

Holding a large bowl in one hand, she reached out with the other to help him up. Xie Zheng's face was unnaturally pale from blood loss, with dark circles under his eyes from days without sleep. Yet his features were so striking that even in this state, he exuded a fragile, weary beauty.

After sitting up against the pillow, Xie Zheng reached for the bowl to drink on his own, but Fan Changyu, just as she had done when feeding him

medicine earlier, scooped up a spoonful and brought it to his lips.

Xie Zheng hesitated briefly before opening his mouth to drink, then subtly frowned.

—It was scalding.

But Fan Changyu seemed completely unaware of this. After all, she had never fed anyone soup or medicine before. When her parents passed away, Changning was already five and didn't need help with meals or medicine.

The previous medicine had cooled considerably, but this soup had just been brought from the cookhouse camp in a wooden bowl, making it hard for her to gauge the temperature.

When the second spoonful reached his lips, Xie Zheng's mouth twitched as if he wanted to say something, but he drank it anyway before reaching for the bowl. "Let me do it myself."

Seeing his sickly pallor, Fan Changyu felt a pang of pity and refused to hand it over. She stirred the soup with the wooden spoon, scooped another portion, and insisted, "You're badly injured. Just rest—I'll feed you."

Xie Zheng stared at the steaming spoonful before him and resigned himself to drinking it.

By the time he finished the bowl, his tongue was numb from the heat.

Fan Changyu, however, looked at the empty bowl with an odd sense of accomplishment.

She was taking such good care of him!

When Xie Zheng reached for a cup of cold tea, she hurried to pour it for him, handing it over with a puzzled look. "You just drank a whole bowl of soup—are you still thirsty?"

Xie Zheng made up an excuse. "The taste was a bit strong. Just washing it down."

There was a little broth left in the bowl. Fan Changyu took a sip and realized the soup had no salt at all—it was so bland it was almost unpalatable.

She frowned and said, "Probably the cookhouse camp was too busy and forgot to add salt. Why didn't you tell me earlier?"

Xie Zheng fell silent for a moment, his expression turning grave. "There is no salt."

Fan Changyu froze, then immediately understood his meaning. Their army had originally planned to fight one battle and leave immediately. They hadn't prepared any provisions, let alone salt.

The reinforcements from Jizhou had only brought food and medicinal herbs.

Here, survival itself was a luxury—who cared whether the food tasted good or not?

Before coming up the mountain, Old Tao had already told her about the dire situation here. First Line Gorge was close to Chongzhou. After Changxin Wang's defeat at Lucheng, he had staked everything on besieging First Line Gorge, aiming to push the Yanzhou Army on the mountain to desperation by cutting off their food supply.

Days of heavy rain had flooded Changxin Wang's fifty thousand troops, but it had also left many soldiers on the mountain soaked and ill.

Changxin Wang knew Tang Peiyi's siege of Chongzhou was just a feint, so he had only withdrawn half his troops as a precaution. Even so, twenty thousand Chongzhou soldiers remained at the mountain's base. If their army descended now, even with the aid of the two or three thousand scattered reinforcements, it would be like throwing an egg against a rock.

Fan Changyu didn't know what would happen once their food ran out. She looked at Xie Zheng earnestly and said, "Don't worry. I've heard Wu'an Marquis is exceptionally strategic. He's won so many battles—he won't just let the rebels trap him here. Even if we exhaust our food and the rebels attack, as long as I have strength left, I'll carry you to safety."

Xie Zheng's heart churned with mixed emotions. He looked at her and asked, "If it comes to that, just save yourself. Why bother with me?"

Fan Changyu replied matter-of-factly, "I told you I'd take care of you from now on."

The words struck some hidden chord in Xie Zheng. He stared at her for a long moment before suddenly saying, "Fan Changyu, you don't need to go this far out of guilt."

"I joined the army not because I feared you or your neighbors would face trouble, but because the power I seek lies here. My injuries were earned

on the battlefield for military merit—they have nothing to do with you. What exactly are you feeling guilty for?"

His expression was almost cold in that instant.

Fan Changyu didn't understand why he'd suddenly become this unfamiliar version of himself. She asked, "You didn't want me to come find you?"

Xie Zheng's dark eyes were icy as he suppressed that foolish hope. "If it's just guilt, you shouldn't have come here. You owe me nothing."

Fan Changyu began to grasp his meaning. Pressing her lips together, she said, "Back in that army tent earlier, I didn't finish speaking. Before coming to find you, I'd already considered both possibilities—whether you were alive or dead. When you left, I'd beaten you so badly and said such harsh words... then I never saw you again. Every time I thought about it, it hurt, and yes, I did feel guilty."

She paused, raising her eyes to look at Xie Zheng with a hint of confusion. "But coming to find you wasn't just because of guilt. You don't know—I almost died too. Qingping County and Lin'an Town were both massacred. That rebel who pretended to be a grain-collecting officer before was hiding among the bandits, seeking revenge on me. There were too many of them, and I couldn't fight them all. So I hid Changning and Aunt Zhao away. That bastard dislocated my arm, and the bandit leader nearly drowned me in the water. Later, Changning was kidnapped. On my way to find her, I met Uncle Zhao, who said you had come here. I was afraid you'd die here, so I thought, no matter what, I should come see. If you were dead, I'd bury you. If not, I'd talk to you properly—tell you Changning is missing, that I can't find her, but I'll keep looking..."

She rambled on, recounting everything she had endured after he left. Her vision inexplicably blurred, and when she blinked, a large teardrop rolled down her cheek.

How strange. She had rarely cried since childhood.

Unable to see the expression on the face before her, the next moment she was pulled into a fierce embrace—tighter than before, so tight it almost hurt her bones.

He pressed the back of her head, making her lean against his shoulder, his grip so forceful his fingertips turned white. He seemed to want to say

something, his throat moving slightly, but in the end, he remained silent, closing his eyes heavily. Everything was conveyed in that wordless hug.

The mingled scents of blood and medicine were far from pleasant, yet in that moment, the embrace only deepened the ache in Fan Changyu's eyes. Her chest swelled with an unfamiliar emotion, something akin to grievance.

After her parents' deaths, she had endured many hardships, but she had never complained to anyone or shed a single tear in front of others.

Only today, nestled in his arms, did she finally allow herself to weep freely against his shoulder.

Outside the tent, Gongsun Yin led Changning to the spot. Hearing the sounds inside, he hesitated, torn between entering and leaving, his face twisted in discomfort.

Chapter 75

Changning recognized Fan Changyu's crying and was about to rush in on her short little legs when Gongsun Yin grabbed her by the collar.

She looked up in confusion to see Gongsun Yin putting a finger to his lips in a "shhh" gesture.

Gongsun Yin led her a few steps away before squatting down to her level. "Let your sister and brother-in-law talk for a while," he said.

Changning nodded obediently. The baby fat on her face had diminished considerably, making her eyes appear even larger. She spoke very little around unfamiliar people, and Gongsun Yin clearly still fell into the "unfamiliar" category.

Remembering Xie Zheng's plans, Gongsun Yin asked her, "Little one, do you remember how your brother-in-law rescued you?"

Changning's small face paled at the memory of that rainy night's violent struggle. It had been pitch black, and she'd been too terrified to think clearly. After struggling to recall, she answered, "Bad men wanted to hurt Ning Niang... brother-in-law fought the bad men..."

Gongsun Yin sighed softly. For such a young child to be dragged onto a battlefield and not be scared witless showed remarkable fortitude—how could she possibly remember the details? He patted Changning's head and said, "Don't be afraid, it's all over now. The bad men have been caught by your brother-in-law."

Only then did Changning's expression relax slightly. She nodded vigorously with an "Mm," then looked up again, nervously clutching her clothes as she asked Gongsun Yin, "Will my brother-in-law die?"

Gongsun Yin chuckled. "Little one, do you know the saying 'the wicked live a thousand years'?"

Changning shook her head.

Hiding a smile behind his fan, Gongsun Yin explained, "Your brother-in-law is exactly that kind of wicked man in others' eyes. His life is tough—he

won't die so easily."

Reassured that Xie Zheng wouldn't die, Changning turned to gaze longingly at the tent flap.

Seizing the opportunity, Gongsun Yin asked, "Your sister and brother-in-law get along well, don't they?"

After thinking, Changning nodded.

Showing no shame at pumping a child for information, Gongsun Yin pressed on: "How well?"

Changning opened her clear, innocent eyes wide. "After Mama and Papa were gone, Ning Niang would cry in front of sister when hurt. But sister only cries in front of brother-in-law."

This gave Gongsun Yin pause.

Changning began counting on her fingers: "When troublemakers came to our house, brother-in-law broke their legs and chased them away. When sister earned money selling pork, she bought brother-in-law new clothes and hair ribbons. When brother-in-law took bitter medicine, sister bought him candy..."

Gongsun Yin's expression turned peculiar. So what that old man in Lu City had told him was true—Xie Jiuhan really had become a live-in son-in-law and was living off his wife's earnings!

He wanted to ask more when suddenly, despite the thick tent flap, he felt an icy chill down his back.

Gongsun Yin decisively told Changning, "Child, you wait here for your sister. I have matters to attend to and must take my leave."

With that, he stood to depart.

Inside the tent.

After venting her accumulated emotions through this bout of crying, Fan Changyu straightened up and wiped her eyes. "I think I heard Changning's voice."

Xie Zheng had long since noticed the commotion outside. He withdrew his cold gaze from the tent entrance and said, "She's outside. I didn't get to tell you earlier—while you were at the cookhouse camp, I had someone bring her to the army."

Fan Changyu was taken aback. Without asking further questions, she quickly lifted the tent flap to look outside. Sure enough, she spotted Changning squatting obediently not far away, cupping her cheeks in her hands as she gazed in their direction, along with Gongsun Yin who had just taken a few furtive steps away, clearly guilty as a thief caught in the act.

"Changning!" Fan Changyu exclaimed in delight.

Changning's eyes instantly sparkled when she saw Fan Changyu. She rushed over and threw herself into her sister's arms, clinging tightly to Changyu's waist as she called out in a muffled voice, "Elder Sister..."

The moment those words escaped her lips, the tears welling up in her large eyes could no longer be held back, falling in big droplets.

"How did you get here?" Fan Changyu asked her, though her gaze involuntarily drifted toward Gongsun Yin, who was attempting to sneak away a few steps away.

Having been spotted, Gongsun Yin could no longer pretend to leave nonchalantly. He retracted his half-extended foot and, with a flick of his fan, resumed his usual debonair demeanor. "This child accidentally fell into enemy hands. After being rescued, she was temporarily sheltered in the military camp. Upon learning she was your brother-in-law's sister-in-law, I brought her here."

Fan Changyu quickly expressed her gratitude before squatting down to wipe Changning's tears. Seeing how much thinner her sister's cheeks had become, her heart ached. "I'm sorry I couldn't find you sooner. You've suffered so much."

Changning shook her head, burying her face in her sister's shoulder as she sobbed so hard she hiccuped.

Fan Changyu held Changning and invited Gongsun Yin to come inside the tent for a while. Gongsun Yin, realizing Xie Zheng already knew he was outside, figured it would be inappropriate to leave now. So, under the pretense of visiting the patient, he followed them in.

Once inside, Changning saw Xie Zheng half-lying on the military cot, his chest wrapped in blood-stained bandages. Her lips quivered as she called out, "Brother-in-law."

Then, wiping her tears, she said to Fan Changyu, "Brother-in-law got hurt saving me from the bad guys."

Fan Changyu turned to Xie Zheng, clearly puzzled. "You were injured saving Changning?"

Xie Zheng hadn't prepared to tell Fan Changyu everything at this moment. His lips pressed together slightly, unsure how to respond.

Even the usually silver-tongued Gongsun Yin found this lie difficult to spin and was beginning to feel a headache coming on. Then Changning, still sniffing, spoke up: "The bad guys thought I was some important official's daughter and took me away. They put me on a horse to kill people. It was so dark, raining hard, and the thunder was loud. I was so scared. Then I heard Brother-in-law's voice and called out to him. When Brother-in-law came to save me, the bad guy threw me into the air. Brother-in-law got stabbed trying to catch me, and there was so much blood..."

Recounting these events clearly still terrified her. Her little face turned pale, and she clutched Fan Changyu's clothes tightly, as if clinging to something solid to fend off the fear that night had instilled in her.

Fan Changyu had initially suspected Sui Yuanqing had abducted Changning, likely to seek private revenge against her. She never imagined Changning had endured so much. Just hearing about it made her wish she could tear the "bad guy" Changning mentioned into pieces.

She patted her sister's back soothingly. "Don't be afraid, Changning. It's all over now."

Yet she couldn't help but wonder why Changning had suddenly been mistaken for some high-ranking official's daughter.

Seeing Fan Changyu, Changning felt reassured. But then she remembered how Yu Bao'er had clung to her clothes, refusing to let go when she was being taken away. The servants had dragged him along, tearing off several of his fingernails in the process. Her eyes reddened again at the memory. "Bao'er was there too. Elder Sister, can we save Bao'er and his mother?"

Fan Changyu was confused. "You mean Shopkeeper Yu and Bao'er?"

Changning nodded.

Fan Changyu asked, "Didn't Shopkeeper Yu and Bao'er go to Jiangnan? Where did you see them?"

Changning sobbed in reply, "Bao'er and his mother were locked up there by those bad people, just like Ning Niang."

Gongsun Yin didn't know who Yu Qianqian and her son were, looking puzzled. But Xie Zheng, who knew Changning had been in Sui Yuanqing's hands during her captivity, grew thoughtful.

Was that female shopkeeper connected to Changxin Prince Manor?

Being straightforward, Fan Changyu asked in confusion, "Could Shopkeeper Yu and Bao'er have been mistakenly taken as relatives of some high-ranking official too?"

She turned to Gongsun Yin, "Sir, may I ask how my sister was mistaken for a high official's daughter and taken away?"

Gongsun Yin glanced at Xie Zheng before giving an evasive answer: "After the disaster in Qingping County, the Jizhou Prefecture temporarily housed refugees in government post stations, which normally only accommodate visiting imperial officials. The rebels must have received incorrect information, leading to your sister's mistaken capture."

While this explanation sounded plausible, Fan Changyu still felt something was amiss when recalling the missing painting from her home.

Gongsun Yin tactfully suggested, "The military camp is full of rough men unsuited for childcare. We've arranged quarters next door for Miss Fan to settle with your younger sister."

Having just found her sister, Fan Changyu naturally had many questions. She glanced at Xie Zheng lying on the bed and said, "Rest well then. I'll take Ning Niang to clean up."

After her fever broke, Changning had been left with Gongsun Yin. The mountain conditions were harsh, and the personal guards were all rough men who knew nothing about childcare. They could barely coax her to eat meals. While Changning could wash her own face, her hair had become a complete bird's nest without proper care.

As soon as Fan Changyu left, Xie Zheng told Gongsun Yin, "Send a message via gyrfalcon to Yanzhou to investigate the Yu mother and son detained at Changxin Prince Manor."

Gongsun Yin asked in confusion, "Are they important?"

Xie Zheng replied, "When I first saw that child, I noticed some resemblance to the one currently sitting on the throne."

Gongsun Yin was startled, then frowned, "You suspect imperial lineage?"

The current emperor was the Late Emperor's youngest son, ascending at just eight years old. His mother had been a lowly palace maid without any influential relatives.

He became emperor solely because Wei Yan chose him as a puppet ruler. But now the young puppet had grown up, supported by Grand Tutor Li's faction, inevitably wanting to overthrow Wei Yan and reclaim imperial power to restore governance.

However, it was obvious that even if the emperor used Grand Tutor Li's influence to topple Wei Yan, the Li faction would simply become the next Wei Faction in court.

The imperial authority of Great Yin had long been hollowed out by powerful families. Though the imperial exam system was implemented, commoners held negligible positions in court.

Moreover, the current emperor lacked regal bearing—cowardly before powerful ministers yet tyrannical toward palace servants, unfit for governance.

Xie Zheng said, "That merchant Zhao claimed to work for the deceased imperial grandson from the Eastern Palace. But in Qingping County, I discovered he owned a residence near the Yu shopkeeper's home. If the imperial grandson truly exists, investigating through the Yu mother and son might reveal something."

Gongsun Yin immediately responded, "I'll send the message right away."

If that mother and son surnamed Yu were the Crown Prince's people, trapped in Changxin Prince Manor, perhaps Changxin Wang had captured them to threaten the Crown Prince?

He was almost out of the tent when he turned back to look at Xie Zheng: "Jiuheng, if the Crown Prince is truly still alive, you... would you support the bloodline of Chengde Crown Prince?"

The one on the dragon throne, upon learning of Xie Zheng's falling out with Wei Yan, had considered marrying off a princess to win Xie Zheng over. However, since Xie Zheng was still in the northwest, the capital couldn't make too big a show of it.

But the thoughts of an emperor have always been hard to guess.

Though the one on the dragon throne had long hinted to Xie Zheng that after overthrowing Wei Yan, Wei Yan's position would be his, who could say

whether Xie Zheng would become the next target for elimination when the time came?

Moreover, by the emperor's side, Grand Tutor Li had long been firmly entrenched as the top advisor.

In terms of legitimacy, the bloodline of Chengde Crown Prince was more entitled to sit on that dragon throne than anyone else in the current royal family.

Taking a step back, just based on the Battle of Jinzhou years ago, Xie Zheng and the Crown Prince shared a common enemy, making them natural allies.

The tent fell silent for a long time before Xie Zheng's cold, deep voice finally sounded: "How do you think the emperor treats Wei Yan?"

With just that one sentence, Gongsun Yin realized the crux of the matter. Wei Yan had supported the one on the dragon throne, initially intending him to be a puppet emperor. But at some point, Wei Yan had indeed become the emperor's greatest backer.

If Xie Zheng supported the Crown Prince, the merit he could gain would be no less than Wei Yan's past favors to the emperor.

But Xie Zheng already held military power. If the Crown Prince ascended the throne, what more could he reward him with?

When rewards run dry, suspicion and wariness would only grow day by day.

Gongsun Yin put himself in Xie Zheng's shoes and suddenly frowned: "I've realized something. In your current situation, no matter who sits on the dragon throne, they'll go all out to win you over before securing power. But once everything's settled, you'll be among the first to be discarded like a bow after the birds are gone."

Xie Zheng remained silent.

Gongsun Yin walked back dejectedly and sat opposite Xie Zheng, throwing caution to the wind: "Just give me a straight answer—what exactly are you thinking? If you haven't planned an escape route for yourself, I might as well find another patron now to avoid being dragged down by you later."

Dusk had deepened. Xie Zheng gazed at the flickering lamp in the tent: "With the chaos in the northwest, nine out of ten households are empty, and good men lie buried in the yellow sand. Great Yin hasn't yet reached the point of needing to rebuild the nation. Fighting the Northern Turks is one thing, but waging war against our own people for selfish desires..."

He scoffed coldly: "It would be a betrayal of those soldiers who should have died beyond the frontier."

Clearly, he held Changxin Wang's actions in utter contempt.

Gongsun Yin raised an eyebrow: "You want to be a loyal minister?"

Xie Zheng glanced up indifferently: "Don't you think someone like me should be called a powerful minister instead?"

Gongsun Yin choked, then said, "Powerful or not, you should think about how to break the current siege first!"

Xie Zheng asked, "How long will the provisions we brought up the mountain last?"

Gongsun Yin replied, "Eating to fullness, half a month. Stretching it with wild vegetables in porridge, maybe a month."

After a moment's thought, Xie Zheng said, "We still have Sui Yuanqing in our hands. The mountain terrain is complex. Changxin Wang is besieging without attacking, hoping to starve us out. If they run out of provisions too, they won't be able to hold out."

Gongsun Yin was startled: "You're thinking of targeting Changxin Wang's supply lines?"

Chapter 76

After Fan Changyu took Changning to the tent Gongsun Yin had assigned to the two sisters, she first fetched some water to help Changning wash up.

While tying Changning's hair into small buns, she asked, "Ning Niang, do you still remember how you were captured?"

Changning counted on her fingers, recalling carefully. "Big Sis hid us in the cellar. Later, Aunt Zhao fled with me. We ran into some soldiers on the road, and after a long journey, they took us to an inn. Aunt Zhao said it was Jizhou City and that we were safe."

Fan Changyu realized the inn Changning mentioned was the post station where the Jizhou authorities had temporarily housed them. She quickly asked, "What happened after that?"

The memory of being taken from the post station still frightened Changning, and her eyes reddened again. "Later, a fire suddenly broke out at the inn. A bad man slashed Aunt Zhao with a knife, then tied me up, gagged me, and put me in a chest to carry me away..."

At this point, she couldn't hold back her tears. "Big Sis, Aunt Zhao bled so much. Did Aunt Zhao die too?"

Fan Changyu gently patted her back, coaxing, "Aunt Zhao is fine. She's still in Jizhou right now. You'll be able to see her when you go back."

Only then did Changning stop crying.

Fan Changyu asked her, "Did those villains put you in a chest and take you out of the city in a carriage?"

Changning nodded, then added, "When they let me out, there were mountains everywhere. They threw away the chest and the carriage and took me away on horseback. We arrived at a very large residence, and they locked me in a dark room. It was several days before a very fierce old nanny took me out. That nanny told me to play with Bao'er."

Fan Changyu was a little confused. "Wasn't Bao'er locked up just like you?"

Changning thought for a moment and said, "He was locked up, but those fierce nannies and maids were all trying to coax him to play. They called him Young Master, but Bao'er ignored them. Bao'er said a bad man had locked up his mother, and he had to be obedient to see her again."

The more Fan Changyu heard, the more bewildered she became. The way Changning described being "locked up" sounded more like house arrest.

And the servants called Bao'er "Young Master." Could it be that Yu Qianqian's husband was someone from that residence?

Even if Fan Changyu wasn't the sharpest, she knew this matter was tied to the rebels and was likely not simple.

Changning, however, looked up and asked Fan Changyu, "Big Sis, once Brother-in-law's injuries are healed, can we go rescue Bao'er and Aunt Yu together?"

Fan Changyu said, "Once we get down the mountain, Big Sis will go to Chongzhou to ask around for news."

This made Changning happy again.

Fan Changyu noticed something tied around her neck with a red string and asked, "What's this?"

Changning pulled it out. It was an exquisite little pig jade pendant. She said, "Bao'er gave it to me before I left. The one he gave me last time is at home. He said he always carries the grasshopper I wove for him, so he's giving me this little pig pendant and told me to always wear it too."

The previous jade pendant had been a bit large, and it was shaped like a jade lock. It was fine for Yu Bao'er to wear it over his clothes, but on Changning, it looked somewhat out of place.

To avoid attracting envious eyes and fearing that Changning might damage the jade lock while playing with the neighborhood children, Fan Changyu had told Changning to leave it at home.

She picked up the little pig pendant and examined it closely. Even without any knowledge of jade, she could clearly feel that its texture was warmer and smoother than the previous jade lock. It was likely quite valuable. The character "Bao" was even carved on the bottom of the pendant, as if it had been custom-made.

Fan Changyu guessed it was a gift Yu Qianqian had prepared for Yu Bao'er in the past. As for why it was carved into a little pig, seeing as Yu Bao'er was around the same age as Changning, perhaps he was also born in the year of the pig?

She felt that this pendant might hold even more significance for Yu Bao'er than the last one.

The two children, having met a familiar face in a foreign land, probably saw each other as their only playmate.

Fan Changyu helped Changning tuck the pendant back inside her collar. "Then you wear it properly and don't lose it. When we rescue Bao'er and his mother, you can return this pendant to him. This gift is too valuable, and Bao'er is still young. We can't accept it, understand?"

Changning nodded. "Just like last time, if Aunt Yu agrees to let him give it to me, then I can accept it, right?"

Fan Changyu smiled and stroked her head. "Right."

Changning hadn't slept well for days. That night, staying by Fan Changyu's side, she started yawning after just a short conversation.

After coaxing Changning to sleep, Fan Changyu remembered that when she saw Yan Zheng during the day, some of the bloodstains on him hadn't been washed off. She fetched a basin of water and went to his tent.

He had always been a man who liked to be clean. If he weren't so badly injured, he would never have tolerated the smell of medicinal herb residue and blood on his body.

When Fan Changyu arrived, a light was indeed still on inside Xie Zheng's tent.

Unsure if any new wounded soldiers had been moved here after she left, she called out from the entrance, "Yan Zheng, are you asleep?"

"Not yet," a deep voice came from within.

Fan Changyu entered with the basin of water. As she lifted the tent flap, she saw Xie Zheng, bare-chested, re-wrapping gauze around his waist, layer by layer. On the table beside him were two empty bottles of *травма* medicine.

Cold sweat beaded on his forehead. The pain had likely put him in a foul mood, as his expression was somewhat cold when he looked toward the

entrance. Only when he saw it was Fan Changyu did his gaze soften. "Why have you come over?"

Fan Changyu said, "I brought you a basin of water to wash up."

She noticed that the bandages he had removed were once again stained with a large patch of fresh blood. Thinking of their earlier embrace, she looked ashamed. "Was it because I pressed on your wound earlier?"

Xie Zheng had already tied the knot on the gauze and was putting on his robe. "No."

Although he denied it, Fan Changyu still felt guilty. Remembering he had been injured while saving Changning made her feel even more remorseful. Seeing him about to tie his robe shut, she said, "Don't put it on yet. Let me help you wipe down."

Xie Zheng's brow furrowed instinctively. "You'll help me?"

Fan Changyu just felt that this wasn't the first time she had done something like this. When she had just found him, she had held him down to apply medicine directly. There was nothing to be shy about. She nodded generously. "Your wound can't get wet, and you can't reach your own back. If you feel awkward, I can go find a young soldier outside to help you."

Xie Zheng had already untied the sash again. "You can do it."

The ink-black robe fell open, casting a deep shadow in the candlelight. His firm and well-proportioned muscles had the luster of warm jade. The gauze wrapped diagonally from his shoulder to his ribs, set against his cool eyes, gave him an air that was both fragile and unyielding.

Fan Changyu wrung out a cloth and began to gently wipe his face.

Sitting on the edge of the bed, Xie Zheng seemed not to have expected her to start with his face and was slightly taken aback for a moment.

Fan Changyu's movements were very light. She patiently wiped the bloodstains and dirt from his face, smiling as she said, "When I found you, you were much dirtier than this. Your face was so caked with blood I couldn't even see what you looked like."

Xie Zheng didn't speak, merely watching Fan Changyu's every move in silence.

Her features were exquisite. In the candlelight, her whole person seemed to be covered in a soft glow. Just looking at her seemed to calm all

the restlessness in his heart.

After cleaning his face, Fan Changyu wrung out the cloth again and began to wipe his upper body. The cloth paused as it neared the bandaged area. She raised her hand and gently touched the scar that ran across his entire chest through the gauze, whispering, "It must have hurt a lot, right?"

Xie Zheng still only replied, "It didn't hurt."

Fan Changyu fell silent. When she looked up a moment later, her eyes were faintly red.

Xie Zheng raised a hand to tuck a stray strand of hair behind her ear. He looked at her for a while, then suddenly lowered his head and placed a kiss on her eyelid.

It was so light that Fan Changyu felt as if she had been brushed by a feather.

She blinked, a little unaccustomed to it, and stared blankly at Xie Zheng. She was clearly not used to this sudden intimacy, but she didn't reject it either.

When she was in a daze, her eyes were clear and innocent, with a hint of an honest, easily-bullied look.

Xie Zheng's voice was deep in the quiet of the military tent. "What are you staring at me for?"

Fan Changyu was silent for a moment, then said something astonishing. "Did you kiss me?"

The tent flap wasn't completely closed. The mountain wind gusted in, making the candle flame flicker and distorting their cast shadows into a chaotic mess.

Xie Zheng looked at her and gave a soft "Mhm," but the depths of his eyes were startlingly intense.

Another long silence followed.

Until Fan Changyu suddenly straightened up, quickly pecked him on the forehead, and said, "We're even."

Then she picked up the water basin and left the tent.

Xie Zheng stared at her retreating back, unable to snap out of it for a long time.

He had clearly kissed her in a much more forward way before, yet feeling the lingering warmth on his forehead, he couldn't suppress the joy welling up in his heart. The corners of his mouth curled up into a slight smile.

Fan Changyu didn't sleep well that night. For as long as she had known Yan Zheng, she had almost always seen him as family or a friend. That was why she had been so angry when he had taken liberties with her last time.

It wasn't just because of his rudeness, but also because she had always trusted him, and he had betrayed that trust.

But after everything that had happened, that bit of anger had long since dissipated. She only hoped that everyone she cherished would be well.

When she learned his fate on the mountain was unknown, her subconscious urge was to find him.

As for what to do after finding him, she thought they would live as they had before. She could afford to feed one more mouth in her household.

But what happened tonight had thrown her into confusion. He had kissed her again, but she wasn't angry. She had just competitively pecked him on the forehead!

Fan Changyu tossed and turned in bed irritably. Realizing she had pulled the blanket off Changning, she quickly turned back and tucked Changning in again.

She didn't finally drift into a light sleep until the fourth watch.

When dawn broke, Fan Changyu got up with dark circles under her eyes. After helping Changning wash up, she went to the cookhouse camp to get food for the wounded soldiers. She heard the cooks complaining that they hadn't caught any game in the past two days and couldn't make special meals for the wounded soldier camp.

Fan Changyu remembered the Army Doctor saying that Xie Zheng's body needed proper nourishment. How could he recover without eating meat?

She decided that after breakfast, she would join the soldiers in charge of hunting and venture deeper into the woods to see if she could hunt

anything good.

As for delivering Xie Zheng's medicine and breakfast, she was afraid it would be even more awkward to see him after last night's events, so she entrusted the task to other soldiers.

Gongsun Yin went to find Xie Zheng early in the morning to report on official business and found him in an unusually foul mood. After some probing, he learned that Fan Changyu hadn't been to see Xie Zheng all morning. Finding this very strange, he wandered off to find Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu had already prepared her things to go into the mountains and was about to take Changning to Xie Zheng for him to look after. As soon as Gongsun Yin arrived, she asked him to take Changning over.

Gongsun Yin was very surprised to learn that Fan Changyu was going hunting. Worried that something might happen to a young woman like her, he secretly sent two more personal guards to follow her.

As he led Changning to find Xie Zheng, he noticed the two buns on her head were lopsided and crooked, an ugly and jarring sight.

He couldn't help but ask, "Little girl, did your big sis not comb your hair this morning?"

Changning touched her buns and said, "She did! She even re-tied my buns!"

Gongsun Yin was speechless.

How was it possible for her hair to look even uglier after being combed than before?

He endured it all the way, but in the end, he couldn't resist taking down Changning's buns and re-tying them himself.

Facing the confusion of the other personal guards, the personal guard who had been with Xie Zheng the longest explained in a low voice, "Sometimes Gongsun just can't stand things that aren't neat. Like that child's hair being tied one high and one low—it would make Gongsun uncomfortable all day."

Chapter 77

After a spring rain, the vegetation on the mountains grew even more lush.

The soldiers had been hunting frequently in recent days and were quite familiar with the nearby woods. They had set traps and made some animal snares, but perhaps because they had been hunting in the same area for several consecutive days, even after checking several pre-set traps, they had little to show for it.

Along the way, Fan Changyu didn't even spot a single rabbit.

The young officer leading the group said, "If we want to bag something worthwhile, we'll probably have to split up and search deeper into the forest."

After a moment's thought, he divided the hundred or so men into small teams of ten. A few were left behind to continue hunting in the previously searched areas, while the rest followed him deeper into the mountains.

Fan Changyu was grouped with the two personal guards secretly sent by Gongsun Yin, assigned to hunt in the outer perimeter. It was clear they had been instructed to keep her from venturing deeper into the woods, where she might encounter danger.

Changyu had suggested swapping with soldiers heading into the old forest, but the young officer issued a military order. Knowing she was still disguised as a common soldier from Jizhou and that this was a military operation, she didn't press further.

The group wandered through the woods but only managed to bag a few pheasants. They raided a nest and collected quite a few wild eggs, which one soldier had to carry in his bundled-up shirt.

Having experience hunting in the mountains with her father, Changyu remained vigilant, scanning the surroundings. The rain-soaked ground was soft, making it easy to spot tracks.

She noticed signs of a large animal climbing the slope and disturbing the pine needles at the edge of the deeper woods. "These look like wild boar tracks," she told the team. "If we follow them, we might find a boar's den."

The personal guards hesitated at the prospect of entering the dense forest. "But Miss Fan," one said, "Captain Yang ordered us to stay in the outer perimeter and await further instructions..."

Changyu thought for a moment. "How about this—you wait here, and I'll go in alone to check. Since I'm not part of your army, Captain Yang's orders don't apply to me. That way, you won't be disobeying orders."

The two guards inwardly groaned. Captain Yang had specifically told them not to let Changyu venture into the dense woods for fear of her coming to harm. If they allowed her to go in alone, they'd be courting disaster.

One guard quickly countered, "Then why don't you wait here, Miss Fan, and we'll take a few men to search for the boar's den?"

Military scouts were meticulous, and following tracks wouldn't pose much risk.

Their repeated objections made Changyu feel like she was holding them back. She looked at the guard and said, "I've hunted in the mountains with my father many times—I know what I'm doing. You don't need to treat me with extra caution just because I'm a woman. If I were going to be a burden, I wouldn't have come with you in the first place."

Truthfully, Changyu was starting to regret her decision. These men were being overly cautious, and she wished she had just acted on her own.

The two guards couldn't argue. Along the way, they had noticed that Changyu was no delicate lady—she hadn't even broken a sweat after walking so far, clearly trained in martial arts. After some hesitation, they followed her into the dense woods.

Ancient trees towered overhead, and the morning mist lingered after the rain. The two guards repeatedly called out to the others to stay close.

As Changyu followed the tracks, she periodically marked the trees along the path with her butcher's knife.

When she noticed the claw marks on a pine tree, she suddenly halted, crouching down to examine them. Frowning, she said, "It doesn't seem like a wild boar..."

No sooner had she spoken than an earth-shattering roar erupted from ahead.

A massive black bear stood not far away, its mouth holding half of a bloodied bird wing as it glared at them with a savage glint in its eyes, clearly guarding its meal.

The personal guards and soldiers felt their hearts tighten with fear. One of the guards grabbed Fan Changyu's sleeve and pulled her back, urging, "Miss Fan, run! It's a black bear!"

Changyu had experience hunting wild boars and bulls with her father, but she had never hunted a black bear before.

While the guards were panicking, she merely frowned, calculating whether it was worth the effort. Killing this bear would take considerable work. She had never tasted bear meat and wasn't sure if the entire animal was edible. If they only took the paws, it wouldn't be worth the trouble.

As she was being pulled back, she hesitated for a moment before turning to two of the guards and saying, "Maybe we should kill it. It's not easy to find prey like this."

The guards and soldiers stared at her in disbelief, unable to tell if she was terrified out of her wits or simply fearless out of ignorance.

Among wild beasts, bears and tigers were notoriously the hardest to hunt. With only ten men armed with swords and ordinary bows—no crossbows or spears—how could they possibly take down a bear?

Their retreat seemed to provoke the bear. With a sudden shake of its head, it flung aside the crane in its jaws and charged straight at them.

Everyone scattered in panic, making it harder for the bear to chase any single target.

The more agile ones climbed trees like monkeys, but the bear simply rammed its body against the trunk, toppling a tree as thick as a bowl. A soldier clinging to it screamed as he crashed to the ground.

To prevent the soldier from being mauled, Changyu knew the bear's nimble limbs made it hard to lasso like a boar. Still, she unhooked the long rope from her waist and flung it around the bear's neck.

Bracing one foot against an ancient tree, she wrapped the rope around her hands and pulled with all her might.

The bear, caught by the neck, was yanked backward before it could strike, slamming onto the ground with a thunderous crash.

The terrified soldiers gasped in astonishment, never expecting Miss Fan to possess such strength. Recovering quickly, they rushed to help pull the rope.

The two personal guards, more experienced in combat, seized the chance to stab at the bear with their weapons.

The bear thrashed wildly, its massive paws flailing, forcing the guards to keep their distance. They managed only two shallow wounds on its back—hardly life-threatening for the thick-skinned beast. Instead, the pain enraged it further, and its claws snapped the rope.

Changyu and the soldiers, who had been straining with all their might, stumbled backward.

Freed from the choking restraint, the bear turned its fury on the two guards. Outmatched, they could only dodge desperately under its swiping paws, shouting at Changyu, "Get Miss Fan out of here!"

But Changyu couldn't abandon them. She hefted her heavy cleaver and hurled it at the bear, embedding it in its back. The wound wasn't deep enough to kill, but it succeeded in drawing the bear's full attention.

With a furious roar, the beast turned and lunged straight at her.

Fan Changyu had the soldiers scatter while she herself lured the black bear toward the bamboo grove. During the retreat, her butcher knife slashed across the bear's chest, though the wound wasn't deep.

Enraged by the pain, the bear rampaged through the underbrush, smashing everything in its path. Once Changyu reached the edge of the bamboo grove, she swiftly chopped down a thick bamboo stalk, sharpening one end into a crude spear. Instead of retreating further, she charged straight at the bear with the spear in hand.

The bamboo spear's length gave her an advantage. From a distance of about ten feet, aided by her running momentum, she drove it straight through the wound she had made earlier, piercing the bear's heart. The beast roared in agony and snapped the spear with a swipe of its paw.

Changyu planted a foot against a nearby bamboo stalk, using it to propel herself upward as she drove her butcher knife deep into the bear's chest wound. Foul-smelling blood splattered all over her, even splashing across her face.

She didn't so much as blink, her ferocity making her seem like a leopard locked in a life-or-death struggle with the bear.

Only after the bear collapsed with a thunderous crash did Changyu shake the blood off her knife, muttering almost to herself, "Hunting a bear really is tougher."

Years ago, her father had hunted bears to supplement their family's income, but back then, she hadn't realized just how dangerous it was.

The personal guards and soldiers finally caught up, staring in shock at the dead bear and Changyu, whose clothes were now stained with blood. They swallowed hard, their expressions a mix of disbelief and bewilderment, as if they were dreaming.

This seemingly gentle and harmless girl had single-handedly taken down a bear?

If word of this got back to the army, no one would believe it. Just what kind of monster was she?

The two personal guards who had accompanied Xie Zheng to Qingping County had seen Changyu toss men overboard with one hand on the boat. Their expressions were slightly more controlled, but they suddenly exchanged a glance: If this girl ever fought their Marquis, who would win?

Changyu wiped the blood from her face with her sleeve, the killing intent in her eyes fading as she reverted to her usual harmless demeanor. She asked, "Should we just take the bear paws, or bring the whole thing back?"

The soldiers hesitated, but one of the personal guards spoke up, "Supplies on the mountain are already scarce. Might as well take the whole bear."

Everyone agreed, quickly fashioning a makeshift sled from bamboo and vines to haul the carcass.

The soldiers and guards took turns pulling the sled, sparing Changyu from further exertion.

However, the heavy load slowed their return. Along the way, they encountered a young officer who had successfully hunted a wild boar. When he learned that Changyu had taken down a bear, his jaw nearly hit the ground.

The group continued their journey with mixed emotions—joyful yet uneasy. Just as they emerged from the forest, the sound of a horn calling for reinforcements echoed from the foot of the mountain.

The young officer cursed, “Damn it! The rebels are attacking the mountain!”

He quickly assigned a dozen men to continue transporting the game while the rest followed him to reinforce the main mountain pass.

Unsurprisingly, Changyu was once again tasked with hauling the game. She didn’t mind—until her keen nose caught the scent of roasting meat.

She asked the guards and soldiers, “Do you smell that?”

The men, who hadn’t had a proper meal in ages, swallowed hard. After days of thin gruel and bland vegetables on the mountain, even the thought of salt made their mouths water—let alone the rich aroma of meat.

The personal guard questioned a soldier who had run up the mountain to deliver a message and then reported, “The rebels are attacking the mountain while roasting meat at the base to entice us to surrender, aiming to demoralize our troops.”

Fan Changyu thought this tactic was too underhanded and wondered if Old Tao and the reinforcements from Yanzhou and Ji Provinces could come up with any countermeasures below.

Noticing her concern, the personal guard said, “The men of Yanzhou have backbone. Even if we were left with only roots and tree bark, let alone the fact that we still have provisions on the mountain, we wouldn’t be swayed by such crude tactics from the rebels!”

They were at the boundary between the camp and the forest, where the view was unobstructed. Looking down, they could even make out the number of tents set up by the rebels at the foot of the mountain.

Fan Changyu observed that the rebel tents outnumbered those on the mountain by at least two to one and frowned. “The rebels have more men, and they’ve blocked all the roads.”

But the personal guard countered, “Miss, don’t just look at the arrangement of the rebel tents. The rebels withdrew half their forces, so they should have fewer tents. But they didn’t strike camp—first, to confuse us in case of a night attack from the mountain, and second, to intimidate our new recruits into thinking their numbers are overwhelming.”

On her way here, Fan Changyu had heard Old Tao talk about warfare, but without concrete examples, she had only grasped bits and pieces.

Now, hearing even a lowly soldier in the Yanzhou Army speak so knowledgeably, she couldn't help but praise, "You know so much!"

Realizing he might have said too much, the personal guard quickly added, "After spending so long in the army, you pick up a thing or two."

Curious, Fan Changyu asked, "Then how do you estimate their actual numbers?"

"By the cooking smoke," the guard replied. "Tents can be faked, but the smoke from cooking fires can't. The number of stoves needed depends on how many people are eating, so you can estimate their numbers from that."

Fan Changyu glanced at the thick smoke rising from below and then at the sparse wisps behind the mountain. Drawing her butcher's knife, she widened her honest almond-shaped eyes and earnestly suggested, "There are fewer people over there. Should we launch a surprise attack?"

Chapter 78

In the distance, beacon fires blazed across the sky, yet the central military tent on the mountain remained eerily silent.

Gongsun Yin strode briskly into the tent, unable to conceal his excitement: "By having the soldiers at the mountain's base scrape tree bark and dig up roots to feign a food shortage on the mountain, the rebels have truly taken the bait! Believing we've been cut off from supplies for days, they deliberately slaughtered pigs and sheep to roast meat extravagantly, aiming to demoralize our troops!"

Xie Zheng's injuries were severe, his face still pale. Draped loosely in an outer robe, he reclined against the headboard, the white bandages wrapped around his shoulder faintly visible beneath. His slender fingers held a terrain map, his refined features carrying a hint of languidness as he lifted his gaze to ask, "Has the message been sent to the reinforcements below the mountain?"

Gongsun Yin replied, "It was sent by gyrfalcon yesterday."

Xie Zheng tossed aside the map and said, "Create some commotion to tie down the rebel forces, allowing the reinforcements below to burn their provisions."

He seemed about to rise, but the movement sent a sharp pain through his chest wound. A frosty expression crossed Xie Zheng's handsome features as he asked, "How has Sui Yuanqing been recently?"

Gongsun Yin answered, "Exposed to wind and rain all day, surviving on a single bowl of thin gruel to keep him alive. Yesterday, he seemed to have developed a fever, but I judged he wouldn't die, so I didn't send the Army Doctor to see him."

A cold breeze intermittently lifted the tent flap, allowing thin daylight to slant across Xie Zheng's face. The corner of his lips curled coldly as he said, "Take Sui Yuanqing to the front lines. If the rebels are roasting meat, you should do the same."

Gongsun Yin immediately grasped his meaning and chuckled wryly, "The flames roasting Sui Yuanqing will likely burn straight into Changxin Wang's heart. With such bait, we needn't worry about the rebels not taking the hook."

This was a stratagem to lure the enemy away from their base—making the rebels believe they were short on supplies to draw them into a trap, then using Sui Yuanqing as leverage to tie down most of the rebel forces. Meanwhile, the Yan and Ji reinforcements waiting below could seize the opportunity to strike directly at the enemy's heart and burn their provisions.

Once the rebels also ran out of supplies, no matter how many troops they had stationed above and below, another day or two of attrition would reverse the roles of attacker and defender.

As Gongsun Yin left the tent to take Sui Yuanqing to the front lines, a personal guard suddenly came running back, his face distraught: "Gongsun, something terrible has happened! Miss Fan has gone to launch a surprise attack on the enemy camp at the rear mountain!"

Gongsun Yin's expression changed drastically. He quickly glanced back toward the tent, ensuring it was far enough that Xie Zheng wouldn't have heard, before snapping, "Wasn't she out hunting? How did she end up at the enemy camp?"

The guard explained, "On our way back from hunting, we heard the urgent horn signals from the mountain's base. As soon as Miss Fan learned the rear mountain was lightly guarded, she charged straight there."

Gongsun Yin paced back and forth a few steps before quickly devising a response: "The Marquis is still severely injured—don't let him know about this yet. Take a hundred light cavalry and pursue her immediately. You must ensure her safety."

The guard didn't dare delay for even a moment and rushed off to muster the troops.

Gongsun Yin rubbed his temples and muttered worriedly, "At this critical juncture, let nothing go wrong..."

Rear Mountain.

Fan Changyu, along with the remaining personal guard and eight soldiers, lay concealed on a mound covered by shrubs, each wearing a

makeshift hat woven from branches and vines.

After staring at the narrow winding path leading down the mountain for a while, Fan Changyu couldn't help voicing her confusion: "Are there really no guards here?"

The personal guard answered, "They're all hidden in the woods."

Fan Changyu let out an "Oh" and was pondering whether they needed permission from the guards at the mountain pass to approach the enemy camp when she spotted a patrol of allied soldiers coming down the winding mountain path. Their uniforms were stained with fresh blood, and as they walked, they kept glancing around, their bows still drawn with arrows—an odd sight.

Fan Changyu stared at the mountain path for a long time but couldn't figure out where they had come from. She whispered to the personal guard beside her, "Is this a shift change?"

The guard also seemed puzzled. Covering his mouth with his hand, he let out a few sharp bird calls. In an instant, a hail of arrows rained down toward the bushes where they were hiding.

The guard's expression changed drastically. He tried to pull Fan Changyu to cover, but she was faster, rolling to the side and taking shelter behind a large tree. Some of the soldiers, panicking, tried to stand and run, only to be turned into human pincushions by the arrows.

Fan Changyu watched as the men who had just been hunting with her moments ago now lay lifeless on the ground, blood pooling beneath them, their eyes still wide open in death. Her lips pressed into a tight line, and a bitter taste rose in her throat. Her gaze, sharp as a leopard's, locked onto the archers.

Even if she were slow-witted, she could tell something was off about these men.

The bloodstained uniforms they wore were likely stripped from the bodies of Yanzhou Army soldiers.

After the volley of arrows, the group advanced with swords drawn, as if to confirm whether everyone was dead.

The personal guard hiding behind a tree opposite Fan Changyu signaled with his lips for her to escape at the first opportunity. Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and didn't respond.

When the rebels disguised as Yanzhou soldiers were just a few steps away, the guard roared and charged out. The surviving soldiers, their hands trembling as they gripped their swords, also let out battle cries to steel themselves before rushing forward.

Fan Changyu noticed one who looked barely more than a boy about to charge as well. She grabbed him by the collar. The boy kicked and struggled, shouting, "You're a woman—run for your life! A man of Yanzhou would rather die dragging an enemy down with him!"

Fan Changyu shot him a glance. "You—go back and report."

With a powerful throw, she sent him flying far away.

Several rebels spotted her and advanced with their blades raised. Seeing this, Fan Changyu drew her bleeding knife and cleaver, scraping the blades together with a grating metallic screech. Without hesitation, she charged straight at them, a knife in each hand.

The personal guard, skilled in combat, managed to fend off the rebels attacking him. Worried about Fan Changyu, he glanced back—only to see her cutting down one enemy after another. Though she avoided fatal strikes, the rebels she struck couldn't get back up.

Alone, wielding two butcher knives, she spun through the crowd like a whirlwind. What had been a rebel pursuit now looked more like her hunting them down.

The guard stared in a daze, marveling inwardly—their Marquis certainly didn't fall for ordinary women.

The boy Fan Changyu had tossed out of the fray was also stunned. Shaking himself out of it, he scrambled to his feet and raced back to deliver the message: The rebels had a two-pronged plan—loudly taunting at the front while sneaking in a surprise attack from the rear!

Not far into their escape, they encountered another personal guard who had gone back to report. The young man was nearly overcome with joy upon seeing him bring reinforcements, pointing behind him and shouting, "Quick! Quick! The rebels disguised as our men have come up the mountain!"

Remembering Gongsun Yin's instructions, the personal guard immediately led a hundred light cavalry to assist.

With the reinforcements, the rebels disguised as Yanzhou Army soldiers were swiftly subdued.

After scouting the rear mountain outposts, the scout returned with a grim shake of his head. "Our men were all shot dead by a hail of arrows."

The personal guard who had fought alongside Fan Changyu was so enraged that he punched the captured rebel leader twice in the face.

The leader spat out a mouthful of blood and laughed. "At least my brothers took down so many of you before they came up here—worth it!"

The personal guard responded with another brutal punch to his nose.

Interrogation quickly revealed how they had infiltrated the mountain.

The rebels had stripped the uniforms from dead Yanzhou soldiers on the battlefield, disguised themselves as the scattered reinforcements from the foothills, and deceived the mountain defenders into lowering their guard. Once close, they had unleashed a volley of arrows.

Their goal in coming up the mountain was to rescue Sui Yuanqing while chaos reigned at the front.

Both personal guards suggested taking the captured rebels back to camp for the strategist and Wu'an Marquis to decide their fate.

Fan Changyu glanced again at the smoke rising from the foothills and said, "Since they've all come up here, there shouldn't be anyone left down there, right?"

The personal guard who had gone for reinforcements, fearing Fan Changyu hadn't given up her reckless idea, said, "Miss Fan, the rebels have a large force, and their deployment in the foothills is complex. It's not advisable—"

"Wait a moment."

Fan Changyu abruptly cut him off, dragging one of the bound rebel soldiers away.

She threw him behind a tree and pointed downhill. "How many of you are left down there? Where are they hiding?"

The soldier sneered. "I'm no coward who fears death—"

Before he could finish, a fierce punch smashed into his nose.

The soldier screamed as blood gushed from his nostrils.

Fan Changyu glared. "Talk or not?"

"Only a thousand men remain at this pass, waiting at the foot of the mountain for extraction."

She dragged him back. The other prisoners, having heard only the screams and not the conversation, saw their comrade's face covered in blood and shuddered in fear.

Fan Changyu hauled another soldier away to repeat the questioning.

This method was something she'd learned from Head Constable Wang—he'd said the County Government Office interrogated prisoners separately to prevent collusion, making it easier to distinguish truth from lies.

After questioning three or four and receiving the same answer, she turned to the two personal guards. "Only a thousand remain below, all stationed at the mountain's base."

The guards exchanged glances. One said, "Miss Fan, wait here a moment. Let me bring more men."

While that guard went for additional reinforcements, Fan Changyu and the other guard led the hundred or so light cavalry trained by Xie Zheng down the mountain, stealthily observing the movements of the thousand rebels below.

The mountain path was steep, so the cavalry dismounted. But as cavalymen, their physical prowess far surpassed that of infantry—taking on two opponents each was no challenge. This was why the personal guard had allowed Fan Changyu to descend.

They had originally planned to wait for the personal guard to bring more reinforcements before taking action. But in the distance, a scout galloped in on a swift horse and seemed to say something to the rebel leader. Suddenly, the thousand rebels stationed at the foot of the mountain turned and followed the scout away.

Fan Changyu asked, "Why are they leaving?"

The personal guard didn't know the reason either and only said, "Perhaps something happened at the front."

Fan Changyu understood the principle of calling for backup in a fight. She immediately said, "Then we need to find a way to delay this group."

Otherwise, what if the front can't hold out?"

The personal guard was still hesitant, but Fan Changyu had already made up her mind and dashed toward the rebel tents set up at the mountain pass.

Afraid that Fan Changyu might get hurt, the personal guard had no choice but to follow, and the rest of the soldiers rushed out in a swarm.

Fan Changyu barged into the rebel tents, ignoring everything else, and rummaged around frantically for salt.

Once she found where the rebels stored their food and salt, she hoisted two bags of salt onto her shoulders and ran.

Seeing this, the other soldiers followed suit, grabbing sacks of grain.

The rebels, who had just left, turned back when they saw the Yanzhou Army descending the mountain to loot their supplies, intending to surround Fan Changyu and her group.

This was only a small rebel outpost, so the stockpile of food wasn't large. The hundred or so soldiers who had come didn't even manage to carry a full bag each.

The personal guard, having fought alongside Xie Zheng for years, immediately urged everyone to flee when he saw the rebels turning back. They also set fire to the empty tents.

Worried that Fan Changyu might struggle carrying two bags of salt, he took one from her and carried it himself.

Fan Changyu acted like a bandit raiding a village. With her hands now free, she remembered that Changning and Yan Zheng had no blankets to sleep under at night, so she snatched two cloaks hanging in the tents and ran off with them.

Passing by the rebels' cooking area, she spotted a whole roasted lamb—meant to taunt the Yanzhou Army on the mountain—still hanging over the fire. She draped the cloaks over the salt bags, freeing her hands to grab the spit holding the lamb.

The rebels who had turned back to chase them were stunned to see her sprinting away with a bag of salt on one shoulder and the roasted lamb held high in her other hand.

The rebel leader on horseback drew his bow and aimed an arrow at Fan Changyu.

The pursuing scout shouted, "General! The Yanzhou Army and Jizhou Army below are trying to burn our grain stores! Don't delay the battle!"

The rebel leader cursed, "The Yanzhou bandits from the mountain are stealing our food! Can't you see they've already set our camp on fire?"

The arrow he loosed fell short due to the distance. When the personal guard yelled a warning, Fan Changyu blocked it with the bag of salt on her shoulder.

Furious, the rebels finally closed in on Fan Changyu's group as they fled with the supplies—only for the personal guard who had gone for reinforcements to return with the Yanzhou Army from the mountain.

The Yanzhou Army rained arrows down, forcing the rebels to halt outside their range. In the end, the thousand-strong rebel army could only watch helplessly as Fan Changyu and the others carried the food and salt back up the mountain.

Panting heavily, Fan Changyu only noticed the thick smoke rising in the distance when she reached the mountainside.

She gasped, "Are the rebels burning the mountain over there?"

But the personal guard, recognizing the direction of the smoke, was overjoyed. He dropped his bag of salt and collapsed onto the ground, laughing. "With all this rain, the mountain foliage is soaked—they can't burn it. That's our men setting the rebels' supplies on fire!"

Fan Changyu led them to seize the grain, inadvertently delaying the thousand troops at the foot of the mountain, which indirectly aided their allies who were setting fire to the enemy's provisions.

He looked at Fan Changyu with admiration in his eyes. "Miss Fan, you've accomplished a great deed this time!"

However, secrets are hard to keep. When Gongsun Yin suddenly dispatched a large number of troops to the back mountain, Xie Zheng grew alert. "Has something happened at the back mountain?" he asked.

Gongsun Yin stiffened slightly before replying, "Rebels disguised as our men tried to sneak up the mountain, but they've all been captured. The reinforcements are just a precaution."

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes. "Has she not returned from hunting yet?"

Realizing he could no longer conceal the truth, Gongsun Yin sighed and admitted, "Miss Fan is at the back mountain."

Xie Zheng's expression turned icy. "Reckless! If you knew it was dangerous, why did you let her stay there?"

He struggled to rise, but Gongsun Yin quickly stepped forward to restrain him. "I've already sent Xie Qi and Xiao Wu after her, along with a hundred light cavalry. They'll bring Miss Fan back soon—"

Just as Xie Zheng was about to push his hand away, a personal guard rushed into the tent, unable to hide his excitement. "Marquis, Miss Fan has returned!"

Xie Zheng's expression softened slightly, and Gongsun Yin also breathed a sigh of relief. However, when Fan Changyu entered the tent moments later—one hand holding a red velvet cloak and the other carrying a roasted lamb—both men suddenly fell into stunned silence.

That cloak bore the insignia of Chongzhou.

Where had it come from?

Chapter 79

Fan Changyu returned to the camp. The other spoils of war would naturally be tallied by the junior officers managing the military supplies. She first took the warm cloak and roasted lamb to find Yan Zheng.

Upon entering the tent, she was surprised to find Gongsun Yin there as well. "Gongsun has come to visit the wounded again?" she asked.

Hearing the other soldiers in the camp address this handsome and refined man as "Gongsun," she assumed he must be an advisor or official like Old Tao and followed suit.

Gongsun Yin answered stiffly, "Yes."

Fan Changyu said, "Perfect timing—I brought back a whole roasted lamb. We can all share it later."

With that, she walked straight toward Xie Zheng. The fruitful gains from today's excursion had long overshadowed the awkwardness from last night. As she shook out the cloak and draped it over Xie Zheng, she smiled and said, "I found something to keep you warm at night."

Not seeing Changning, she held up the remaining cloak and asked in confusion, "Where's Ning Niang?"

Xie Zheng noticed the unmistakable Chongzhou emblem on the cloak and frowned. He was about to ask where it came from, but Fan Changyu's question forced him to answer first: "She was tired, so I had someone take her back to rest."

Gongsun Yin eyed the roasted lamb in Fan Changyu's hands and asked uncertainly, "Miss Fan, did you hunt a lamb and roast it yourself?"

Fan Changyu widened her innocent eyes and said, "I took it from the rebels at the foot of the mountain."

Gongsun Yin nearly choked on his own saliva, while Xie Zheng's expression darkened abruptly. His gaze locked onto Fan Changyu as he asked in a displeased tone, "You went down the mountain?"

Fan Changyu nodded. "Yes."

Xie Zheng snapped sternly, "Reckless! It's dangerous down there!"

Understanding that Xie Zheng was worried about her safety, Fan Changyu wasn't angered by his harsh tone. She simply explained, "I wanted to see if I could help. The rebels are all gathered at the front of the mountain, so the rear must be less guarded. We have enough food up here, but we're short on salt. It wouldn't hurt to grab some."

Xie Zheng's brows remained tightly knit. Knowing that Fan Changyu had truly descended the mountain and even clashed with the rebels, his heart was in his throat. Though she stood unharmed before him now, he couldn't shake the lingering fear, and his tone grew even sterner: "The rear mountain's terrain is steep and unsuitable for troop movement. The rebels wouldn't choose to attack from there unless absolutely desperate. Today, the army planned to burn the rebels' provisions. Raiding their supplies recklessly could alert them and jeopardize the entire operation. You're not bound by military regulations, but if you cause a major mishap, countless soldiers' lives could be lost. Don't act so rashly in the future."

Hearing these harsh words, Fan Changyu's smile slowly faded. She stared at Xie Zheng for a moment before setting down the roasted lamb and walking out without a word.

Gongsun Yin watched the tent flap fall back into place, then turned to Xie Zheng. "She returned safely—why lecture her so harshly? Do you really see her as one of your soldiers?"

Xie Zheng closed his eyes heavily. "War is no game."

Gongsun Yin sighed, recognizing that his concern had clouded his judgment.

Xie Zheng then ordered in a low voice, "Summon Xie Qi and Xie Wu."

Xie Qi and Xie Wu were the two personal guards Gongsun Yin had assigned to protect Fan Changyu, both seasoned veterans who had fought alongside Xie Zheng for years.

Within moments, Xie Qi and Xie Wu—who had been handing over the seized provisions to the supply officer—hurried over.

The two men had initially looked somewhat pleased, but upon seeing Xie Zheng's frosty expression, they realized their mistake and quickly composed themselves, kneeling with bowed heads. "We acknowledge our fault," they said.

Xie Zheng's chest tightened at the thought of Fan Changyu's angry departure, and the pain from his wound only worsened his mood. His long, dark lashes cast a sharp shadow as he nearly laughed in frustration. "Acknowledge your fault? Then why did you follow her reckless actions? I tasked you with protecting her, not escorting her into a den of rebels! What do you take military regulations for?"

Xie Wu, the personal guard who had stayed with Fan Changyu to fight at the rear mountain, hesitated before speaking. "Marquis, please calm your anger. We only intended for Madam to survey the mountain. Fearing we couldn't dissuade her, we informed Gongsun. Unexpectedly, we encountered rebels disguised as our men sneaking up the mountain. I planned to escort Madam to safety, but she proved herself a heroine, slaying the enemy with such valor that she captured all the rebels who had ascended. After interrogating a few rebel foot soldiers and learning their defensive layout, she decided to retaliate, catching them off guard to avenge our fallen brothers. However, before Xie Qi could return with reinforcements, the rebels below began retreating. Worried something had gone wrong at the front, Madam acted swiftly to seize their camp and stall them."

He paused before continuing, "Madam led us to seize five sacks of coarse salt and sixty-two sacks of grain without a single casualty. I failed in my duty and accept punishment, but I beg you not to blame Madam."

Hearing these details, Xie Zheng fell silent, his thick lashes veiling his emotions.

Gongsun Yin interjected, "Miss Fan acted with quick judgment, not recklessness. Her actions were more beneficial than harmful. Your concern clouds your judgment, Marquis. Now that you know the full story, don't let her heart grow cold."

Xie Zheng half-closed his eyes before finally speaking, "Dismissed." The order was clearly for the two guards.

After they left, Gongsun Yin regarded Xie Zheng. "Though Sui Yuanqing was rescued by the rebels, his presence at the front drew Changxin Wang's forces, allowing the reinforcements from Yan and Ji to burn their supplies. Without provisions, the rebels won't last long. Miss Fan unwittingly helped complete your grand plan. Since you've already driven her away with harsh words, you'd best think of how to make amends."

Xie Zheng pressed his lips together, silent, but self-reproach flickered across his brow.

Gongsun Yin shook his head and left the tent, deciding to mediate. He inquired about Fan Changyu's whereabouts from nearby sentries and learned she had gone to the cookhouse camp. Strolling over, he found the place bustling with activity, a crowd of soldiers gathered in a boisterous circle.

Drawing closer, he saw Fan Changyu slaughtering a pig.

The wild boar, brought back from the hunt, had been bound but not yet killed. After days of overcast skies, the sun finally emerged, casting a soft glow. Amid the crowd, Fan Changyu, sleeves rolled up, seemed to radiate a golden halo, every strand of her hair shimmering in the light.

Gongsun Yin was just thinking how serene and lovely Fan Changyu looked at this moment when, in the next instant, he saw her raise her knife and bring it down with a swift motion. The wild boar, tied up securely, let out a piercing scream as blood gushed from its neck.

Gongsun Yin paled slightly and quickly averted his gaze, silently musing that this young lady was probably only someone Xie Zheng could handle.

The soldiers watching from the sidelines cheered loudly.

"Miss Fan's pig-slaughtering technique is superb! One strike and it's done!"

"Look at this big basin of pig blood—we can make another dish for the troops today!"

Fan Changyu sheathed her knife, pleased by the praise, which she took as affirmation of her butchering skills. She smiled faintly.

Looking up, she noticed Gongsun Yin standing in the crowd, seemingly there specifically to see her. After exchanging a few words with the head cook, she pushed through the crowd and approached him. "Were you looking for me, sir?"

Not wanting to appear too obvious, Gongsun Yin cleared his throat and said, "I came to the cookhouse camp to take a look and happened to run into you slaughtering a pig."

He paused briefly before revealing his true purpose for coming. "Don't take your husband's words to heart. He may have a sharp tongue, but his

heart is soft. He's just worried you might run into danger if you go down the mountain. The battlefield is perilous—just look at his injuries. Every battle is a fight for survival. It's fortunate you returned safely this time, but if something had happened to you, given how badly he's wounded, he wouldn't have been able to save you even if he wanted to."

Fan Changyu sat down on a stone stool and said, "I'm not angry with him. Hearing what he said made me realize I might have done more harm than good with my good intentions. Like you said, it was sheer luck I came back unscathed this time. If I hadn't, and other soldiers had died because of me, I'd truly be a sinner. Those soldiers have wives, children, and elderly parents waiting for them at home. Just thinking about it weighs heavily on my heart."

Gongsun Yin was genuinely surprised to hear such words from Fan Changyu. "Though you are a woman, Miss Fan, your temperament is no less than a man's. What you've said touches on the rare qualities of a true general."

Seeing her look somewhat puzzled, he explained, "A general's every decision determines the lives of the soldiers under their command. But there isn't a single battle that can be fought without shedding blood or losing lives. A general's tactics can only sacrifice the few to save the many. Victory and defeat are commonplace in war. If a general loses a battle but lacks the fortitude to endure, they'll likely never achieve anything significant in this life."

Fan Changyu suddenly felt that those who became generals were not only formidable in martial skill but also admirable in their mental resilience.

She looked at Gongsun Yin and said, "Thank you for enlightening me, sir."

Gongsun Yin, knowing Xie Zheng's stubborn pride, doubted he would humble himself to console her. "Your husband was afraid you'd resent him, so he asked me to check on you."

Fan Changyu picked up a small stick and poked at the dirt on the ground, muttering, "I don't resent him. He's suffered such severe injuries—he must have experienced life and death on the battlefield. He told me those things because he was afraid I'd cause trouble and get others killed. I... I feel ashamed."

Gongsun Yin raised an eyebrow in surprise and said truthfully, "He was just worried about you."

Fan Changyu's hand stilled briefly, but she kept her head lowered and said nothing.

Unsure what the young woman was thinking, Gongsun Yin said, "I've delivered the message, Miss Fan. I have some other matters to attend to, so I'll take my leave now."

He was about to leave when he overheard loud discussions from the cookhouse camp: "What a shame we hunted such a black bear up in the mountains. If we were down below with all the seasonings ready, I could whip up a Full Bear Banquet!"

Gongsun Yin paused mid-step and turned toward them, asking, "You hunted a bear?"

Hearing his voice, the soldiers from the cookhouse camp turned to look. Seeing his striking figure in white robes, they immediately recognized his identity and quickly made way for him, calling out respectfully, "Military Advisor."

Gongsun Yin observed the massive black bear and thought it would have taken a fierce warrior to bring it down. He praised, "After today's great victory over the Chongzhou rebels, this bear is truly an auspicious sign. Which general hunted it?"

A nearby cookhouse soldier eagerly replied, "Miss Fan took it down!"

Gongsun Yin: ???

Chapter 80

The sun shone brightly as Gongsun Yin stared at Fan Changyu a few steps away, suddenly wondering if his ears were playing tricks on him.

He asked again in disbelief, "Who hunted it?"

The cookhouse camp soldiers chuckled and replied, "It was Miss Fan!"

Gongsun Yin looked at the massive bear, then at Fan Changyu's slender arms and legs, clearly struggling to imagine how she could have taken down such a beast.

Previously, when he heard Fan Changyu had descended the mountain, raided the enemy camp, and seized provisions, he assumed she had merely accompanied Xie Wu and others on the risky mission, perhaps offering strategic advice to guide their plundering.

Her pig-slaughtering skills, having been mentally prepared by prior information from Carpenter Zhao, and with many cookhouse soldiers holding down the wild boar, only made him think she was different from ordinary women.

But now, being told she had hunted a bear, Gongsun Yin felt his previous understanding waver. He asked, "How did Miss Fan hunt it?"

One soldier who had accompanied Fan Changyu on the morning hunt eagerly jumped in: "We found large predator tracks in the forest, thinking it was a wild boar. Following the trail to find its den, we stumbled upon a bear's lair instead! You've all seen how huge this bear was—it even had a bloodied bird in its jaws when we first saw it. Those savage black eyes stared straight at us, scaring us into a cold sweat!"

The soldier was quite the storyteller, vividly describing the encounter until even the gathered cookhouse troops gasped in fearful suspense, their hearts trembling with tension.

Gongsun Yin subtly rubbed the goosebumps rising on his arms.

The soldier continued, "None of us had ever faced such a beast before! Armed only with ordinary swords and bows, we knew our weapons

wouldn't even pierce its hide. We scattered in panic. Seeing us flee, the bear charged in fury. One brother climbed a tree to escape, but the bear's tremendous strength toppled the trunk—thick as a rice bowl—in just two strikes. We all thought that brother was done for, but then Miss Fan untied the rope from her waist, swiftly fashioned a noose, and lassoed the bear's neck!"

The crowd held their breath like strangled chickens.

The soldier mimicked Fan Changyu's movements: "Miss Fan braced one foot against a large tree, yanked the rope with all her might, and—bam!—flipped the bear right onto its back!"

The cookhouse soldiers erupted in astonished gasps.

"How strong must her arms be?" someone newly arrived and skeptical interjected, "Really? Who could have that kind of strength? Especially a woman."

The storyteller snapped, "We who were there saw it with our own eyes! How could it be false?"

Another chimed in, "Miss Fan isn't some ordinary woman! Today I followed her to raid the rebel camp—you should've seen her heft two sacks of salt, each weighing nearly a hundred jin, onto her shoulders! And still have hands free to grab cloaks and even drive off the rebels' goats from the mountain!"

Some had witnessed the heroic sight of a small soldier carrying a sack of salt while holding up a whole roasted lamb, unaware that it was Fan Changyu. The gathered soldiers gasped in awe, their voices filled with admiration and astonishment.

A soldier from the Jizhou army who had once transported provisions up the mountain with Fan Changyu said, "Carrying a hundred pounds of salt is nothing! Back when they were building the dam upstream in Jizhou and needed to excavate earth and stones, Miss Fan carried a basket of rocks weighing nearly three hundred pounds all the way from the mountain to the dam site! That night, the news spread like wildfire through our camp. The officer in charge of the excavation even rewarded Miss Fan with a roasted chicken!"

The crowd's gasps grew even louder. Gongsun Yin gripped his fan but remained silent, his expression visibly stunned.

Fan Changyu, unused to the attention, felt awkward. She wanted to say something but couldn't find the right words for the occasion, so she simply stood there, looking honest and unassuming.

The Jizhou soldier, feeling that boasting about Changyu's feats also brought honor to their army, continued, "The battle where we flooded the rebel stronghold in Lucheng might have seemed like a sure victory with the advantage of terrain and timing, but it was perilous! We had tens of thousands stationed upstream at Witch River, building the dam. The slightest misstep could have alerted the rebel scouts, so we had to keep a constant watch, intercepting and killing every scout we found. But on the eve of the battle, the rebels sent a cavalry unit to raid our camp, covering the escape of their scouts! If that news had reached the rebel army, our entire plan to flood them would have been ruined! Three scouts got away, but it was Miss Fan—just a woman—who single-handedly crossed Witch Ridge in the pouring rain and killed all three!"

Such a military feat was no small achievement, no matter where it happened.

The soldiers gathered around the cookhouse camp now regarded Fan Changyu with nothing but reverence.

Changyu, faced with their awestruck gazes, could only nod earnestly and humbly, though inwardly, she was utterly bewildered.

The soldier who had mentioned her bear-hunting exploits was also stunned by her accomplishments. Stumbling over his words, he finished his story: "That black bear—Miss Fan speared it through the heart and lungs with a bamboo pole, then finished it off with the same knife she used to slaughter pigs earlier. It died on the spot."

When Fan Changyu left the cookhouse camp with Gongsun Yin, the once-elegant and refined Gongsun seemed to have aged into a disheveled old man. He walked with his hands behind his back, glancing back at her every few steps as if his entire worldview had been shattered.

After what felt like the hundredth glance, Changyu finally couldn't hold back. "Gongsun, are you alright?"

Gongsun Yin shook his head numbly. "I'm fine."

Changyu frowned, genuinely concerned. "You don't look fine."

Gongsun admitted, "A little."

He stared at her as if she were some kind of monster, utterly baffled. "So, if you can handle all that, why is your husband so worried about you going down the mountain?"

Before hearing about Changyu's exploits, he had understood Xie Zheng's concern.

Now? He didn't get it at all!

Changyu parted her lips. "He—"

Gongsun raised a hand to stop her, clearly still reeling from the shock. "Miss Fan, I think I need some time alone to process this."

Changyu gave an "Oh" and walked away. After a while, she glanced back at Gongsun Yin, now sitting on a low slope, staring blankly into the distance as if questioning his entire existence. Scratching her head in frustration, she sighed.

It seemed she had caused quite a bit of trouble for Gongsun?

Fan Changyu strolled back to her temporary lodging. Although she understood the reasoning behind Xie Zheng's earlier lecture, she couldn't help feeling somewhat downcast. At least for now, she didn't want to go see him, so she went to check on Changning instead.

Changning had already woken from her nap. Xie Wu had brought over some portioned roasted lamb chops, and Changning was sitting on a small stool at the entrance of the tent, gnawing on a chop. However, she wasn't paying much attention to her food—her big, grape-like eyes were fixed on Xie Wu as he recounted her elder sister's exploits from earlier that day.

From a distance, Fan Changyu spotted Changning. Since everyone in the camp was wearing military uniforms and Xie Wu had his back to her, she didn't recognize him at first, simply calling out, "Ning Niang."

The moment Changning heard Fan Changyu's voice, her eyes lit up as she turned excitedly toward her. "Sister's back!"

Xie Wu also greeted her with a smile. "Miss Fan."

Fan Changyu nodded. "Ah, it's Brother Xiao Wu. What brings you here?"

She had only just gotten somewhat familiar with Xie Wu and Xie Qi that day but didn't know their surnames, only that one was called Xiao Wu and the other A'Qi—apparently brothers.

Xie Wu explained, "The brothers reheated the lamb and portioned out some chops to bring to you, Miss Fan. If not for you, we wouldn't have had such a treat today."

Fan Changyu thanked him, and Xie Wu excused himself, saying he had other matters to attend to.

After he left, Fan Changyu patted Changning's head and asked with a smile, "What were you talking about with that big brother just now? You look so happy."

Changning couldn't contain her excitement, waving her lamb chop around. "He said you're amazing! You killed a big black bear all by yourself! And you went to the bad guys' place and took their food and roasted lamb!"

She looked up, her bright eyes filled with admiration. "I wish I could tell Bao'er all this! He shivers when he talks about the bad man who locked him up. If he knew, he wouldn't be so scared anymore. Sister will go save him and Aunt Yu, right?"

Fan Changyu was also worried about Yu Qianqian's situation and reassured Changning, "Yes, once we leave the mountains, we'll go rescue them."

Changning happily took another bite of her lamb chop and followed Fan Changyu into the tent, chattering away. "After we save Bao'er and Auntie, they can reopen their restaurant. Sister can build a pigpen and open a pork shop, and Ning Niang will learn how to butcher pigs from you! We'll make lots and lots of money!"

Fan Changyu couldn't help but laugh at the child's innocent dreams, curling her lips. "Sounds good."

Changning counted on her fingers but then frowned in confusion. "But what will Brother-in-law do?"

The innocent question caught Fan Changyu off guard, leaving her momentarily dazed. But Changning had already come up with what she thought was the perfect arrangement and declared cheerfully, "Brother-in-law can raise pigs in the countryside pigpen!"

Outside the tent, Xie Wu, who had returned, suddenly erupted into a fit of violent coughing.

Fan Changyu lifted the tent flap and saw Xie Wu standing stiffly at the entrance, looking extremely uncomfortable. Puzzled, she asked, "Brother Xiao Wu, is there something else?"

Xie Wu, recalling the murderous glare Xie Zheng had given him when he reported that Fan Changyu had returned but hadn't gone to see him, hurriedly said, "Brother Yan is seriously injured and has no one to look after him. When I went to deliver medicine for the Army Doctor earlier, I found out he's been lying there all day—he couldn't even get someone to boil water for him when he wanted a drink..."

He couldn't keep making things up and awkwardly stopped mid-sentence.

Fan Changyu thought to herself that Gongsun had just visited the wounded not long ago. But then she reconsidered—after all, Gongsun was an official, while Yan Zheng was just a lowly soldier. How could he dare trouble Gongsun to fetch him tea and water?

Having seen Yan Zheng's injuries herself, she suddenly felt a pang of discomfort. "Thank you, little brother. I'll go over shortly," she said.

Xie Wu then left, visibly uneasy.

Changning also looked at Fan Changyu with wide eyes. "Elder Sister, does Brother-in-law not even have anyone to pour him water? He's so pitiful."

Considering that another fierce battle had taken place that day and the wounded tents would surely be receiving more casualties, Fan Changyu decided it wouldn't be appropriate to bring Changning along. "Stay in the tent and don't wander off. I'll go check on him," she instructed.

Changning nodded obediently. "Ning Niang will be good. Ning Niang won't go anywhere."

Only then did Fan Changyu head to Xie Zheng's tent. Just as Xie Wu had said, the place was eerily quiet—not a single person celebrating the victory, nor any new wounded being brought in.

When she lifted the tent flap and entered, she saw Xie Zheng leaning against the headboard, his face pale, his eyes closed as if in light sleep. The daylight streaming in through the open flap fell upon his lashes, dark as crow feathers, giving him an unexpectedly childlike vulnerability.

Perhaps sensing the light, the moment the flap was lifted, Xie Zheng opened his eyes and looked over. That fleeting trace of childlike fragility vanished instantly, replaced by a cold, sharp, and gloomy gaze. Only when he saw it was Fan Changyu did he pause slightly. After a moment, he lowered his eyes and said, "I thought... you didn't want to see me anymore."

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and didn't respond. After entering the tent, she went straight to the table and picked up the teapot—it was indeed empty.

She turned on her heel, teapot in hand, about to leave when she suddenly heard a voice from behind: "Wait."

Chapter 81

Fan Changyu turned her head to look at Xie Zheng, whose face was half-hidden in the shadows.

Backlit as he was, she couldn't make out his expression at this moment, but his voice was noticeably deeper than usual. "I spoke harshly to you earlier. My apologies."

Having been proud all his life, it was rare for him to lower his head voluntarily.

Fan Changyu still didn't respond and simply lifted the tent flap to step outside.

Xie Zheng watched the swaying fabric of the tent entrance, his lips gradually tightening.

A short while later, Fan Changyu returned carrying a water kettle, steam rising from its spout—clearly freshly boiled.

Ignoring the momentary surprise on Xie Zheng's face, she picked up a wooden cup from the table, poured water into it, and handed it to him. "Want some?"

Xie Zheng took the cup. The freshly boiled water was scalding, so he didn't bring it to his lips, merely holding it in his hand as he offered a belated thanks. "I appreciate the cloak you found for me."

Fan Changyu glanced at the red velvet cloak draped over his front but still didn't engage, only asking, "Have you changed your bandages?"

Most of Xie Zheng's face was obscured by the steam rising from the cup, his long lashes like delicate fans. After a brief hesitation, he shook his head. His pallid complexion, cold as frost, resembled a wintry moon hanging over a frost-laden forest—lonely and detached, his features etched with a world-weary aloofness, as if resigned to withering away here.

Fan Changyu supposed this was the advantage of having a striking appearance. Seeing him like this, she inexplicably felt a pang of pity.

Assuming the army doctors were too overwhelmed with the influx of wounded to tend to him, she wordlessly stood and went to fetch medicine.

After today's fierce battle, the mountain had indeed gained many more injured. The few army doctors accompanying the troops were rushing about the camp. The one assigned to Xie Zheng had originally intended to change his bandages on schedule but had been dismissed with Xie Zheng's insistence to "see to the other soldiers first."

The doctors were well aware of Xie Zheng's temperament, and since his bandages had only been changed the night before, they didn't press further. Now, seeing Fan Changyu approach, they inwardly sighed in relief and promptly handed her the herbs for dressing his wounds and the decoction to be brewed.

Returning with several packets of medicine, Fan Changyu looked at Xie Zheng, who was propped against the headboard, and said stiffly, "Take off your clothes."

Xie Zheng glanced at the medicine in her hands but asked no questions, obediently removing his thin robe.

Compared to when Fan Changyu had first found him, he was noticeably more solid now, his abdominal muscles well-defined and sculpted. Yet the scars—some deep, some shallow—were just as glaring.

Her expression stern, Fan Changyu carefully unwound the bandages that slanted from his shoulder to his ribs, her movements deliberately gentle.

The innermost layer of gauze was stained with herbal juices and blood, the smell far from pleasant. When she saw the wound—slightly improved from before but still gruesome—her heart churned with mixed emotions, and she averted her gaze.

She was about to apply the herbs when a hand closed over hers. The warmth against her skin sent a jolt through her, her entire arm prickling as if her blood were flowing backward. Frowning, she turned to Xie Zheng.

His eyes seemed to hold a multitude of emotions, yet none were clear. He only said calmly, "The wound is unsightly. I'll do it myself."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu pressed her lips together, applied a bit more force, and pressed the herbs onto his injury. Xie Zheng looked at his now-empty hand, lowered his gaze, and seemed lost in thought.

After applying the medicine, Fan Changyu silently wrapped the clean gauze around his wound layer by layer before finally murmuring, "I wasn't afraid of that wound of yours."

Xie Zheng was momentarily stunned by her words, but before he could respond, Fan Changyu added, "Push aside the hair on your left shoulder."

Having been bedridden for days, his tied-up hair had long since become disheveled, with many loose strands falling down. To wrap the gauze over his shoulder, she needed to brush aside the stray hair, but her hands were full.

Xie Zheng did as she asked, though a few strands still remained.

As she wound the gauze around, Fan Changyu continued her earlier thought: "I was afraid you would die."

Xie Zheng's long lashes lifted slightly, his cold, star-like eyes showing a trace of bewilderment.

The girl before him whispered, "Such a severe wound, nearly piercing your organs... it must have been excruciating at the time..."

Xie Zheng stared unblinkingly at her delicate features, feeling as though a tree with inward-curving thorns had taken root in his chest. Each inch its roots grew deeper into his heart brought a dull, aching pain, while the branches stretching upward filled him with a tender warmth, causing the tree to grow even more wildly.

He said, "I won't die."

How could he bear to die before marrying her?

Fan Changyu seemed naturally incapable of lying. Her clear almond eyes met those of this man who remained strikingly handsome and fierce even in his weakened state as she stated, "All men must die."

Xie Zheng smiled and said, "I know."

His genuine smile was breathtakingly beautiful. Unsure why he suddenly smiled, Fan Changyu was momentarily dazzled before frowning and continuing to wrap the bandage.

Xie Zheng asked, "Not angry with me anymore?"

Her hands paused slightly. "I wasn't really angry to begin with. I'm not part of the military camp and don't understand the rules. What you said

wasn't wrong."

Though her words sounded reasonable, Fan Changyu felt slightly embarrassed recalling her earlier behavior.

She had indeed been angry, though she didn't understand why.

After descending the mountain to seize salt—solving the most pressing issue for those above—she had casually taken two cloaks, thinking of Yan Zheng and Changning.

But returning full of joy, she was met with harsh scolding instead. She knew Yan Zheng's words were justified, yet couldn't suppress the ache in her heart, that inexplicable feeling resembling grievance.

Wrong was wrong—why feel aggrieved?

Fan Changyu felt she was becoming strange, almost unlike herself, which was why she had hurried away.

In the past, she wouldn't have taken Yan Zheng's words so personally—after all, his disdain for her wasn't new.

Now his words could hurt her.

Fan Changyu didn't know what had changed. She seemed to have become worse—acknowledging mistakes and correcting them was the right way.

Hearing her words, Xie Zheng also paused slightly before saying, "My earlier words were too harsh. Your trip to the back mountain wasn't reckless—on the contrary, you uncovered the rebels' scheme. Your merits far outweigh any fault."

Fan Changyu only offered a shy smile, lacking the casual closeness they once shared, even showing a polite distance usually reserved for outsiders.

After bandaging his wounds, she stepped back and sat on a round stool, lowering her eyes as she said, "Someone will bring you medicine tonight. Remember to take it. Tomorrow, I'll ask Xiao Wu to come help change your bandages and clean you up. Rest well, and if you need anything, just tell Xiao Wu. I heard you two were in the same unit before, so it's good to have someone familiar looking after you."

Xie Zheng finally sensed something amiss, his handsome brows furrowing. "What do you mean?"

Fan Changyu casually made up an excuse: "More injured soldiers have been brought down from the mountain, and the army doctors are overwhelmed. I'm going to help out and won't have time to come here anymore. I've told Ning Niang to stay in her tent these past couple of days and not go outside."

Xie Zheng didn't say another word until Fan Changyu left.

Fan Changyu felt uneasy too. She wandered off alone to a quiet slope and sat there in a daze for a while.

She knew that with Yan Zheng's proud nature, he wouldn't lower himself to ask her to keep tending to him. Even if he misunderstood that she might be repelled by his injuries, he wouldn't press further.

But her heart was in turmoil right now. Fan Changyu didn't understand what was happening to her. The only solution she could think of was to stay far away from Yan Zheng for the time being.

Gongsun Yin spent the entire afternoon coming to terms with the fact that the girl Xie Zheng had taken a liking to was just as much of an oddball as he was. When he went to discuss the upcoming battle plans with Xie Zheng, to avoid walking into a storm, he first asked Xie Wu, who had been standing guard in the shadows. Learning that Fan Changyu had visited Xie Zheng and even changed his bandages, Gongsun Yin thought that should have smoothed things over.

But the moment he stepped into the tent and saw Xie Zheng's expression, he nearly turned right back around.

That deathly glare was anything but smoothed over—it was like someone had combed his fur backward with glue!

The chill in his gaze could freeze icicles!

Gongsun Yin cleared his throat and asked, "I heard Miss Fan came by?"

The moment Xie Zheng's cold, heavy gaze turned on him, Gongsun Yin instantly regretted not wearing thicker clothes tonight. The spring chill was bone-piercing.

Rubbing his arms, he asked, "Did you two argue again? Wait, I ran all the way to the cookhouse camp to sing your praises. Xie Jiuhang, you're a grown man—can't you just swallow your pride and coax her properly?"

Xie Zheng leaned back in his armchair, unfinished documents still spread across the desk before him, his expression dark with self-loathing. "I apologized."

Gongsun Yin said, "With girls, you've got to humble yourself and sweet-talk them. You can't just scowl your way through an apology—"

Xie Zheng's glare cut him off.

After a long pause, Xie Zheng said, "I apologized properly. She said she wasn't angry, but then she said she wouldn't be coming back."

Gongsun Yin declared without hesitation, "That's obviously her still being angry!"

Seeing Xie Zheng still looking somewhat confused, Gongsun Yin couldn't help but say, "Women are always like this—they say one thing but mean another! When she says she's not angry, she's actually furious! She even said she won't be coming for the next few days—didn't you catch that?"

This was the first time Xie Zheng had ever liked a girl, and he had no idea how a woman's mind worked. He asked, "How do I make her stop being angry?"

Gongsun Yin pondered for a moment and said, "Actually, Miss Fan has every reason to be angry. With her exceptional martial skills, before coming here, when rebel scouts discovered the construction of the dam upstream in Jizhou, she had the courage to cross Witch Ridge alone on a rainy night to intercept them. This morning, she went hunting and single-handedly brought back a bear. Such bravery is rare even among your top generals. According to Xiao Wu, Miss Fan decided to pursue the rebels only after assessing their strength—showing both wisdom and courage. Not to mention, this act earned her solid military merits. Yet you scolded her harshly without a second thought. How could she not be angry?"

Fan Changyu had previously glossed over her experiences in Jizhou to avoid worrying Xie Zheng, so he was unaware of her exploits.

Hearing about them now, especially her solo bear hunt, he couldn't help but feel astonished, though he grew even more silent.

Seeing this, Gongsun Yin sighed. "Miss Fan is no ordinary woman. I know your words that day came from concern and good intentions, but don't mistake a swan for a sparrow. Though I haven't interacted with her

much, I can tell she has a very kind heart. Right now, the best course is for you to show some vulnerability."

Xie Zheng's handsome brows furrowed slightly in confusion. "Show vulnerability?"

The next day, Fan Changyu indeed went to help the Army Doctor, as she had told Xie Zheng the day before.

Her feats of seizing salt and killing a bear had already spread throughout the camp overnight.

As soon as she entered the wounded soldiers' tent, many greeted her enthusiastically. Upon realizing she was a strikingly beautiful young woman, their surprise only grew.

The Army Doctor, aware of Fan Changyu's status, didn't dare let her bandage wounds and instead assigned her to brew medicine.

One wounded soldier remarked, "What a shame Miss Fan wasn't born a man! With her martial prowess, she could've earned herself a generalship through military merits!"

Though there had been female generals in the dynasty, they all came from military families. Ordinary women, no matter how skilled, couldn't even enlist, let alone fight for merits.

Another soldier joked, "Whoever has the fortune to marry Miss Fan won't just have ancestors smiling in their graves—their graves would be on fire!"

Someone promptly elbowed him and whispered, "Watch your words! Miss Fan is already married!"

The uninformed asked eagerly, "Miss Fan is married?"

Xie Qi, who had ostensibly come to help but was actually there to protect Fan Changyu covertly, entered carrying a freshly brewed pot of medicine. Hearing the lively discussion about her, he couldn't help but feel indignant on behalf of his master. "Miss Fan traveled thousands of miles to these mountains just to find her husband."

A wounded soldier immediately asked, "Who is Miss Fan's husband? Did she find him?"

Xie Qi proudly lifted his chin, about to answer, but a soldier who'd heard rumors cut in first: "She found him, but they say he's barely clinging to

life, just hanging by a thread."

Xie Qi: "..."

The crowd first sighed in sympathy, then broke into animated chatter. A few even subtly adjusted their hair when Fan Changyu walked in, their hopeful gazes seemingly willing her "barely alive" husband to stop struggling and pass on sooner.

After leaving the wounded soldiers' tent, Xie Qi couldn't resist rushing to report this to Xie Zheng.

On the other end, Fan Changyu had just started brewing the medicine sent by the Army Doctor when Xie Wu came rushing to find her: "Miss Fan! It's terrible! Your husband suddenly coughed up blood! You must come back quickly!"

Fan Changyu's heart skipped a beat as she hurriedly asked, "How did he cough up blood?"

Xie Wu didn't dare meet her eyes, his face twisted in distress as he said, "I don't know either! When I went in to deliver the medicine, I found him coughing so violently that the bedding was covered in blood!"

Fan Changyu thought to herself that such severe coughing was absolutely alarming. She immediately called for the Army Doctor who had previously examined Xie Zheng to accompany her back for a look.

The young soldier helping her brew the medicine was the same lad she had thrown out of the encirclement earlier.

Watching Fan Changyu and the Army Doctor hurry away, the boy sighed and muttered, "Is Sister Fan's husband really going to die?"

Chapter 82

Inside the tent, Xie Zheng frowned at the chicken blood staining his clothes and cloak. "Isn't this too much blood?"

Gongsun Yin, while directing Xie Qi to take the freshly slaughtered pheasant to the cookhouse camp for soup, replied, "Haven't you seen the wounded soldiers in the camp? Some are missing arms or legs, all covered in blood. Miss Fan has seen plenty while helping there. If we don't make it convincing, how will we fool her?"

As he spoke, he spotted a stray feather from the pheasant's struggle still clinging to the edge of the cloak and quickly plucked it off.

Noticing that despite Xie Zheng's pale complexion and the faint dark circles under his eyes, there was no sign of fever, he couldn't help but add, "You spent all last night in the cold wind and washed your hair with cold water. How come you're not even slightly feverish?"

Xie Zheng: "..."

Gongsun Yin resignedly said, "Fine, fine. This should be enough for the self-inflicted injury ploy."

Xie Wu's voice came from outside the tent, "He's inside!"

Gongsun Yin quickly stepped back and sat on a nearby stool, adopting a sorrowful expression.

Fan Changyu hurried in with the Army Doctor and immediately spotted Xie Zheng lying weakly on the bed, his clothes stained with a glaring patch of blood.

Her heart clenched as she rushed forward, "Yan Zheng!"

Xie Zheng's eyes were tightly shut, his lips chapped, his face as pale as snow, with disheveled hair scattered across his forehead and faint dark circles under his eyes, looking utterly haggard and disheveled.

Changyu felt as if a hand had gripped her heart, the dark bloodstains on the cloak stinging her eyes with unshed tears.

How could someone who was fine just yesterday suddenly end up like this?

Holding onto her remaining composure, she stepped aside and urged the Army Doctor, "Please, check his pulse quickly!"

The Army Doctor, also alarmed by the scene, quickly took Xie Zheng's wrist to feel his pulse. Sensing the steady beat beneath his fingers, the physician's expression flickered with surprise, but when he looked up, Gongsun Yin gave him a meaningful glance.

The physician quickly cleared his throat and put on a grave face, continuing to examine the pulse while Changyu's heart pounded anxiously.

After a long moment, the Army Doctor finally withdrew his hand and said, "Miss Fan, your husband's condition is extremely critical!"

Changyu pleaded, "Army Doctor, please save him!"

The physician stroked his goatee hesitantly, "Coughing up blood like this suggests that his previous injuries have left significant internal bleeding in his lungs. He needs nourishing yin and moistening the lungs, and due to excessive blood loss and liver fire, he also requires nourishing blood and stopping bleeding. I'll prescribe some medicine for him to take, but someone must watch over him at all times to prevent him from choking on blood while unconscious."

Changyu, now filled with dread, quickly assured, "I won't leave his side for a moment."

As the Army Doctor left to prepare the medicine, Changyu gazed at Xie Zheng lying amidst the bloodstains, her nose tingling with unshed tears, guilt inevitably washing over her.

Yan Zheng was still recovering from serious injuries—why had she been so stubborn yesterday, saying she wouldn't come back? If anything happened to him, she might regret it for the rest of her life.

Seeing Changyu's expression, Gongsun Yin knew their self-inflicted injury ploy had succeeded. He comforted her at just the right moment, "Miss Fan, don't worry too much. Young Master Yan is sure to pull through."

As Fan Changyu entered the tent, all her attention had been focused on Xie Zheng. Only then did she notice Gongsun Yin was also present. "Gongsun is here too?" she asked.

Gongsun Yin lied without batting an eye: "Young Master Yan suddenly coughed up blood, and Xiao Wu panicked. I happened to be inspecting the camp nearby, so I told him to fetch the Army Doctor while I watched over Young Master Yan temporarily."

Changyu thanked Gongsun on Xie Zheng's behalf. Gongsun smiled and said, "We're all brave warriors of Great Yin fighting on the battlefield. Only by preserving our lives can we continue protecting our nation's rivers and mountains. No thanks needed. Now that Miss Fan is here to watch over him, I'll take my leave."

After seeing Gongsun off, Changyu pulled up a small stool and sat by Xie Zheng's bedside, murmuring gloomily, "You must get better."

Perhaps because she was too close, Changyu suddenly sniffed hard at the bloody scent from the cloak.

Having slaughtered pigs frequently, she was sensitive to the smell of pig's blood. After days of living by the sword, she was also familiar with the scent of human blood. But the blood on these beddings not only smelled strongly of blood—why was there also a faint feathery odor?

As she leaned in for a closer sniff, Xie Zheng, who had been "unconscious for hours," suddenly fluttered his long lashes and weakly opened his eyes.

Changyu instantly forgot everything else in her joy. "Yan Zheng, you're awake?" she exclaimed.

Xie Zheng gazed at her for a moment before replying hoarsely, "You came." His voice was broken and raspy, as though his throat had been injured from excessive coughing.

Those simple words made Changyu's heart ache again. She tucked the blankets around him and said, "The Army Doctor said your coughing blood is from internal injuries that need careful recuperation. I'll stay here from now on, so you can focus on recovering."

Xie Zheng's pale lips were stained with blood, making him appear even more fragile. He spoke slowly, "I heard about what happened in Jizhou."

Unsure what he meant, Changyu remained silent as he continued with difficulty, "After all you've been through, you're no longer just an ordinary woman from Lin'an Town who only knew how to slaughter pigs and sell meat. It was wrong of me to blame you so harshly after your return."

Hearing him apologize again for yesterday's harsh words only made Changyu feel more ashamed. She lowered her eyes and muttered, "The lesson you gave me was right. The soldiers and I escaping unscathed from the mountain was just luck. If Brother Aqi hadn't brought reinforcements in time, we might all have been trampled to death under the rebels' horses."

Gathering her courage, she finally looked up to meet Xie Zheng's gaze. "It was narrow-minded of me to get angry at you after being scolded. I'll change."

Filled with remorse, she noticed blood still staining Xie Zheng's lips and went out to fetch hot water to clean him.

Xie Zheng watched her departing figure with a slight frown.

How had this turned into her being narrow-minded?

When Xie Wu brought the prepared medicine, it was Changyu who took it and fed Xie Zheng spoon by spoon.

The thick cloak retrieved from the rebel camp had served as Xie Zheng's bedding, now stained with blood. Knowing he valued cleanliness, Changyu returned to her quarters to fetch the cloak she and Changning used at night, covering Xie Zheng with it temporarily while she prepared to wash both the bloodied cloak and Xie Zheng's bloodstained clothes.

Xie Wu, fearing Changyu might notice something amiss while washing them, hurriedly took the task upon himself.

By evening, Fan Changyu wanted to stay by Xie Zheng's side but was also worried about leaving Changning alone in their tent. Noticing there were extra army cots available in Xie Zheng's tent, she decided to bring Changning over to sleep there with her.

As she remade the beds, she wondered aloud, "The other infirmary tents are packed with wounded soldiers. Why are there so many empty beds here?"

The army doctors were doing everything to avoid Xie Zheng—how could they dare send other wounded soldiers to his tent?

On the mountain, both lamp oil and candles were precious. At night, nearly every tent relied on braziers for light.

The flames licked at the darkness, casting a warm golden glow over half of Xie Zheng's face. His refined features, as if painted with ink, stood out sharply against the firelight. Tilting his head slightly, he watched Fan Changyu make the beds and answered with a perfectly straight face, "Not sure. Maybe the army doctors have their own arrangements."

Unfamiliar with military camp logistics, Fan Changyu didn't dwell on it. Once the beds were ready, she settled the drowsy Changning in and said to Xie Zheng, "If you need water or have to get up at night, just call for me."

At the mention of "getting up at night," Xie Zheng's ears burned, and he stared at her in surprise.

Meeting his gaze, Fan Changyu suddenly understood and flushed as well. Turning away, she muttered, "What are you thinking? If you call, I'll go find a patrolling soldier to help you."

For convenience, Fan Changyu and Changning's cot was placed right next to Xie Zheng's, barely three feet apart.

Exhausted from the past days, Fan Changyu fell asleep almost as soon as her head touched the pillow.

Only after listening to the steady breathing of both sisters did Xie Zheng turn his head toward their side. The brazier still held a smoldering log, its faint flickering light rippling over Fan Changyu's face, lending her serene features an indescribable radiance.

A surge of emotion sprouted in his chest, fierce and relentless, like ten thousand ants gnawing at his heart. He stared for a long time at Fan Changyu's slightly pursed lips, pressed from her side-sleeping posture. The darkness in his eyes grew thicker than the night itself. Yet, in the end, he did nothing. Turning away, he shut his eyes heavily and lay still.

The next day, a new batch of wounded soldiers was assigned to the tent—some with injured arms, others with hurt legs, but none so incapacitated that they couldn't assist each other.

Fan Changyu took on the task of brewing medicine for them, which also made it easier to care for Xie Zheng during the day. At night, she and Changning returned to their own tent, leaving Xie Zheng in the care of the new arrivals.

These wounded soldiers were surprisingly amiable and quiet, unlike the ones Fan Changyu had tended to before. She chalked it up to individual

differences and thought little of it.

Unbeknownst to her, these men were Xie Zheng's personal guards who had been injured. The night before, after hearing Fan Changyu's question, he had instructed Gongsun Yin to transfer them here.

Half a month passed in the blink of an eye.

During her spare moments, Fan Changyu pulled out books from her bundle to study. With Yan Zheng nearby as a ready-made tutor, she could ask him directly whenever she didn't understand something.

Noticing she was reading Mencius, Xie Zheng asked, "Finished The Analects?"

Fan Changyu nodded honestly. "Yes."

When memories of her protecting Li Huaian during the mountain bandit attack surfaced, Xie Zheng raised his slender phoenix eyes slightly and asked, "Did you learn this from reading books yourself?"

Fan Changyu replied, "The articles inside are profound. Even with annotations, many parts remained unclear. When I was working on the dam upstream in Jizhou, I met an old gentleman. Stern-faced but kind-hearted, he taught me until I understood."

Speaking of Old Tao, Fan Changyu's expression grew more respectful. "You wouldn't believe it, but that old man was quite an extraordinary figure. He later became a military advisor. It's just that he's advanced in years with no children, and his only student abandoned him. Quite pitiful really. When we were quarrying stones together in the mountains, he'd curse that student of his every day!"

Hearing it wasn't Li Huaian who taught her, Xie Zheng felt relieved. Yet learning about Changyu being mistaken for a spy and forced to quarry stones for the dam construction gave him mixed feelings.

The strategy had been his idea, but the workforce building the dam came from He Jingyuan's side. At that time, he'd been stationed in Yanzhou and truly hadn't known Fan Changyu was detained there.

He only commented on her earlier words: "If his student disrespects his teacher, now that he's in a position of influence, he should teach that student a lesson."

Fan Changyu glanced at Xie Zheng disapprovingly. "Old Mr. Tao might have a sharp tongue, but his heart is magnanimous."

When Xie Zheng heard the old man's surname was Tao, his fingers paused slightly on the book page. "What's his name?"

Fan Changyu said, "I don't know. He only said his surname was Tao."

There were countless Taos in the world. Xie Zheng considered the old man constantly cursing his ingrate student - this bore no resemblance to Grand Tutor Tao at all. If his teacher had emerged from seclusion after all these years, he would have come to him first.

Suppressing these thoughts, he said, "Since he helped you, we can arrange some advancement for him in the future."

The moment these words left his mouth, Fan Changyu stared at him strangely.

Realizing his slip, before he could remedy it, Fan Changyu frowned and said, "Old Mr. Tao is already an advisor under General Tang's command. What could you possibly do for him? You're not a general. Don't say such careless things - how improper it would be if Old Mr. Tao heard."

Xie Zheng choked momentarily before responding, "I meant in the future."

Fan Changyu looked somewhat exasperated. "Are you so certain you'll become a general?"

Xie Zheng's expression shifted slightly as he lifted his eyes from the scroll. "What if I attain a position higher than general?"

Fan Changyu looked puzzled. "What's higher than a general?"

Xie Zheng said casually, "Becoming a marquis or chancellor."

Abandoning her book, Fan Changyu asked him, "Does your wound still hurt?"

Having been meticulously cared for these past days, Xie Zheng wasn't sure why she suddenly asked this. He measured his words: "It's bearable, though any exertion causes sharp pain."

In truth, it was nearly healed - unless he used excessive force, the pain was minimal.

Fan Changyu handed him the cooled medicine bowl. "Take your medicine first. Focus on recovering before dreaming about titles and positions."

Xie Zheng: "..."

Two days later, Xie Zheng's injury still showed no "improvement." Gongsun Yin, dark circles under his eyes from being overwhelmed by military affairs and memorials from the capital, arrived with murderous intent to visit the "patient."

Having not seen him for some time, Fan Changyu was startled by Gongsun's haggard appearance. "Master Gongsun, what happened to you?"

Gongsun Yin reined in his murderous aura, forcing out a refined smile. "Trivial matters have kept me rather busy."

Fan Changyu said, "You should still take care of your health, Gongsun."

Gongsun Yin smiled and agreed before asking, "How is your husband's injury?"

After a moment's thought, Fan Changyu replied, "The Army Doctor said his internal injuries are quite severe and will take time to heal. His wounds still pain him."

Maintaining his smile—though it looked more like gritted teeth—Gongsun Yin said, "Is that so? I'll go check on him."

Just as Fan Changyu left to prepare medicine, Gongsun Yin entered the tent and dismissed the personal guards who had been lying low for over half a month, their wounds already scabbed over but still bandaged to feign illness. He glared at Xie Zheng, who was napping with a book over his face, grinding his molars audibly before snatching the book away and roaring, "If your injuries don't 'heal' soon, I'll drop dead from exhaustion under that mountain of paperwork!"

The more he thought about how enthusiastically he had contributed to this plan, the more he regretted it.

This bastard was truly resting while he toiled like a donkey at a millstone.

No—even a donkey had it easier!

What sin had he committed to dig such a pit for himself?

With the book no longer shielding his eyes, the harsh daylight made Xie Zheng frown. When he lazily opened his eyes, his face—now fully restored from days of good food and rest—was strikingly handsome, enough to make Gongsun Yin's eyes burn with envy. He nearly strangled him on the spot.

Once upon a time, he had been the dashing, ethereal one! But ever since Xie Jiuhan holed up here pretending to be injured—lest Fan Changyu notice—he hadn't lifted a brush, at most sending one of his equally "injured" guards to relay orders and boss Gongsun Yin around.

Now, every time Gongsun Yin closed his eyes, he saw the towering pile of unfinished documents on his desk, threatening to be the death of him!

Xie Zheng sat up, ignoring Gongsun Yin's outburst. He glanced at the crumpled book, his weary gaze already tinged with displeasure. "Hand it over."

Curious, Gongsun Yin checked the cover and saw the words Mencius . He found it odd. "You studied the Four Books early on—why bring this to the mountains?"

Suspicious, he added, "You treasure it so much—is it some indecent book in disguise?"

Flipping through it, he noticed detailed annotations for every line. Though the handwriting was altered, Gongsun Yin recognized Xie Zheng's style instantly.

Before he could examine further, Xie Zheng snatched it back.

Gongsun Yin's indignation flared anew. "I've been mimicking your handwriting to process documents until my hand nearly fell off, and you had the leisure to annotate an entire Mencius ?"

Xie Zheng offered no explanation, only saying, "The Seven Sages' rare edition from my library—take it when we return."

Gongsun Yin immediately stopped wailing. Flicking open his fan, dark circles under his eyes, he grinned and fanned himself obsequiously. "Assisting the Marquis is but a strategist's duty."

Xie Zheng, long familiar with his temperament, showed no surprise at the swift change. He got down to business. "Chongzhou is besieged by Tang Zhaoyi's twenty thousand Jizhou troops, cutting off their supply lines.

The rebels below the mountain have been attacking for days, exhausted and starving. It's time to wipe them out."

While the Yanzhou Army atop the mountain had been recuperating, the Chongzhou forces below had resorted to digging up roots and stripping bark for food since two days prior.

After the burning of the provisions, the Chongzhou Army faced three choices: first, to return to Chongzhou; second, to eliminate the Yanzhou Army on the mountain; or third, to retreat without fighting to preserve their strength.

The first option, returning to Chongzhou, was fraught with peril. Twenty thousand Jizhou troops were stationed outside Chongzhou's walls, and the rebels at the foot of the mountain would have to shed layers of skin just to enter the city. Even if they fought their way back, they would still face certain death once the main forces of Yanzhou and Jizhou encircled Chongzhou.

Changxin Wang, ever the shrewd strategist, had withdrawn only half his troops that day, likely anticipating the current predicament. The remaining half of the Chongzhou Army at the mountain's base was the lifeline he had left for Chongzhou.

With Jizhou firmly secured and He Jingyuan mobilizing a large force toward Chongzhou, if Chongzhou fell, the Chongzhou Army at the foot of First Line Gorge could still break out, find a stable city to regroup, and rise again.

Commanding that army was Shi Yue, Changxin Wang's trusted general.

Back then, to burn the Chongzhou Army's provisions, Xie Zheng had deliberately used Sui Yuanqing as bait to tie down most of the rebel forces. In the end, Shi Yue had sacrificed countless lives to push through the mountain pass. Though he rescued Sui Yuanqing, the heavy losses, compounded by the destruction of their provisions, were a devastating blow.

Shi Yue had assumed the Yanzhou Army on the mountain, deprived of their hostage Sui Yuanqing and trapped for days, would have lost their will to fight. Enraged by the loss of their provisions, he ordered relentless assaults for half a month. Yet the treacherous terrain of First Line Gorge cost him even more troops.

Meanwhile, the elusive cavalry reinforcements from Yanzhou and Jizhou roamed the foothills, appearing and vanishing like ghosts. Whenever they encountered the Chongzhou Army, they fought if they could win and fled if they couldn't. The infantry, with their two legs, could never catch up to the four-legged cavalry, leaving the Chongzhou commanders fuming.

Now, with provisions depleted below and the Yanzhou Army's defenses still ironclad above, Shi Yue realized he could not trap Wu'an Marquis on the mountain and achieve a legendary victory. He quickly adjusted his strategy, secretly withdrawing part of his forces under cover of night.

With the failed assaults, preserving their strength was now the priority.

The mountain suddenly buzzed with the tension of impending battle. Fan Changyu heard all sorts of discussions about the coming fight in both the wounded soldier camp and the cookhouse camp.

Troops were constantly being deployed to various mountain passes. Stepping out of the tent, one could see military banners fluttering across the camp, with waves of soldiers surging toward their assigned positions.

Every wounded soldier who could still wield a blade was ordered back to their unit—including Xie Zheng.

Just by observing the preparations, Fan Changyu knew this battle would be perilous. But Yan Zheng's wounds still throbbed with pain at the slightest exertion. How could he even hold a weapon? Going to the front lines would be suicide.

The thought of the bloody hole in Yan Zheng's body filled her with unbearable anxiety.

Chapter 83

Before the grand army set out, an order was given for the cookhouse camp to light the fires and prepare a meal, allowing the officers and soldiers to eat their fill.

Fan Changyu went to help slaughter the pigs. An old veteran from the cookhouse camp, still recounting her deeds, said to a new soldier transferred from elsewhere to help, "Miss Fan has the courage of Mulan!"

The new soldier, who was illiterate, scratched his head and asked, "Who's Mulan?"

The old veteran shot the newcomer a disdainful look. "You don't even know Hua Mulan? A great hero from the Northern and Southern Dynasties. Her father had no sons, and when he was old, he was conscripted by the court. Fearing her father would die on the battlefield, she disguised herself as a man and took his place in the army for eleven years, earning great military honors!"

The new soldier was astonished. "How could a woman blend into an army camp for eleven years without anyone finding out?"

This question clearly stumped the old veteran. He said impatiently, "That's how it's written in the plays. She just had the skill. In the end, she was even personally ennobled by the emperor!"

The speaker was casual, but the listener's heart was stirred.

From the moment Fan Changyu learned the grand army was to move out, her anxious heart had not been able to rest.

Now, hearing the old veteran's story of Hua Mulan, her hand, wiping the blood from the pig-slaughtering knife, paused. A bold idea faintly emerged in her mind.

She had previously noticed that Xiao Wu seemed quite close to Yan Zheng, and upon asking, she learned they had once been in the same squad. She knew Yan Zheng had a bad temper and worried he would offend people, leaving him without support on the battlefield. She had asked about the others in their squad, intending to help Yan Zheng manage

his relationships with his comrades-in-arms, only to be told that everyone else had died, leaving just him and Xiao Wu.

This time, the entire army was being deployed, and he and Xiao Wu would have to be assigned to other battalions.

Reorganized into a new unit with no acquaintances, it would be even harder to find someone to watch his back on the battlefield.

With Yan Zheng's injuries, this campaign would likely be a one-way trip. If she went to fight this battle in his place, and Yan Zheng helped her by staying behind with Changning in the logistical train with the cookhouse camp, perhaps his life could be preserved to the greatest extent possible.

If she took his place on the battlefield, he wouldn't be considered a deserter. Besides, apart from Xiao Wu, no one in the new battalion knew Yan Zheng. Xiao Wu would surely keep the secret. Her taking his place on the battlefield would go completely unnoticed by others. When she returned, she would simply switch back with Yan Zheng.

Once this thought took root in her mind, it was impossible to suppress.

On this journey, she had lost too many relatives and friends. Just the thought of Yan Zheng being hacked to death on the battlefield made her chest feel as if it were being squeezed by something.

After leaving the cookhouse camp, Fan Changyu went straight to the wounded soldier camp.

The Army Doctor was not there. The half-grown boy was brewing medicine for the soldiers whose injuries were so severe they still couldn't get out of bed.

The boy was named Wu Sanjin. It was said that his mother had given birth to him while fleeing a famine. The adults were all skin and bones on the road, so what nutrition could there be for a child? He weighed only three jin at birth. His parents thought he wouldn't survive, but unexpectedly, he grew up healthy. So his parents named him Sanjin.

After he joined the army, he was assigned to the logistics corps because of his small stature.

Seeing Fan Changyu now, Wu Sanjin immediately greeted her warmly, "Sister Changyu, are you looking for Doctor Han? Doctor Han went out."

Doctor Han was the Army Doctor who had treated Xie Zheng.

Fan Changyu said, "I'm here to see you."

Wu Sanjin, holding a palm-leaf fan for stoking the fire, looked puzzled. "Me?"

When Fan Changyu was feeling guilty, her expression became all the more righteous and stern. She asked, "Do you know where the knockout powder is kept?"

Wu Sanjin had been doing odd jobs in the wounded soldier camp for days and knew exactly where the medicines were stored. He said, "I know. Sister Changyu, what do you need knockout powder for?"

Fan Changyu continued with a righteous face, "I want to hunt a few wild boars for the victory feast when the army returns triumphant. Mixing the knockout powder into coarse bran to make a trap will make them easier to hunt."

Wu Sanjin had no reason to doubt her and quickly went into the tent to retrieve a packet of powder, handing it to Fan Changyu. "This is enough to hunt ten wild boars."

Fan Changyu thanked him, tucked the powder into her robes, and left.

Inside the main tent, the personal guards who had been feigning illness for days had all donned their armor.

Xie Wu was reporting the frontline situation to Xie Zheng. "Our vanguard has intercepted the rebels. We're just waiting for the main force to encircle them. However, a scout reported that the rebels secretly withdrew some of their troops last night. Sui Yuanqing was among them."

Xie Zheng's eyes darkened. "Order Chen Liang to take a thousand elite cavalry in pursuit."

Xie Wu cupped his fist. "This subordinate will go relay the order now."

Xie Qi, who was standing guard outside the door, suddenly announced, "The lady is here!"

The expressions of Xie Zheng and all the personal guards in the tent changed slightly.

Fan Changyu entered the tent carrying a tureen of soup, only to find that all the "wounded soldiers" inside were neatly dressed, as if ready to return to their battalions at any moment.

After greeting Fan Changyu stiffly, they took their respective belongings and departed.

Xie Wu glanced at Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng, then also stood up. "I'll go back and get ready too."

Soon, only Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng were left in the tent. Fan Changyu placed the soup in her hands on the table and asked him, "Are your things ready?"

Xie Zheng found it amusing. "Besides a weapon, what else is there to prepare for the battlefield?"

Fan Changyu picked up the tattered set of armor hanging by his bed. Seeing its dilapidated state, she frowned. "How can you wear your armor when it's so torn? Let me mend it for you."

This set of common soldier's armor had been procured by Xie Wu earlier. The other wounded soldiers in the camp all kept their armor hanging by their bedsides. If they didn't have a set of armor by their bed, it would inevitably make Fan Changyu suspicious.

Xie Zheng had been pondering the battle situation. His gaze unintentionally fell upon Fan Changyu, and watching her thread the needle, he became lost in the sight.

The last time he had gone to war, he hadn't even had a proper farewell with Fan Changyu. This time, setting out on an expedition, he suddenly experienced the taste of heart-wrenching tenderness.

Neither of them spoke. Fan Changyu kept her eyes lowered, concentrating on mending the tattered armor. A stray lock of hair fell down, brushing against her fair cheek. Her small, lustrous white ear was partly visible amidst her dark hair. At this moment, her expression was gentle and serene.

Of course, if one looked at the stitches, they were neither very gentle nor very serene.

Unfortunately, Xie Zheng didn't see that. His gaze lingered for a long time on her earlobe, half-hidden by her dark hair. A savage beast seemed to be rampaging in his chest. As if possessed, he raised his hand to tuck the stray lock of hair behind her ear. When his fingertip touched her small, lustrous white ear, Fan Changyu looked up at him.

The wicked thought in his heart suddenly became irrepressible. The fingertip that should have moved away instead applied a bit of force, curling around to the back of her head.

He lowered his head and kissed her, gentle and not so gentle.

One hand plunged forcefully into Fan Changyu's hair. Because she didn't refuse him, when they parted, a vein stood out on his temple. His breath was scorching, and his eyes were tinged with red, like a savage wolf that longed to devour her whole but was forced to stop by the circumstances.

"Wait for me to come back," his clear, melodious voice was hoarse.

Fan Changyu's lips were a little numb and sore from his bite. She wanted to slap him but held back. She negotiated with him in all sincerity, "Yan Zheng, let me go to the battlefield for you?"

Xie Zheng's handsome brows furrowed almost immediately. "What nonsense are you talking?"

Fan Changyu said, "Your injuries haven't healed. What if you can't even swing your saber on the battlefield?"

Recalling the lie he had told earlier, Xie Zheng said with a slightly unnatural expression, "I'm a swordsman in the infantry formation. I'm only responsible for cleaning up the remnants of the enemy scattered by the vanguard. It's not dangerous."

Seeing his resolute attitude, Fan Changyu seemed somewhat disappointed. "Then be careful in all things."

She then asked, "Which battalion of swordsmen are you in, and which general do you follow?"

Xie Zheng hadn't expected that after just a few days in the army, Fan Changyu would have become familiar with the military's organization. He knew he shouldn't keep deceiving her, but with the arrow already on the bowstring, he had no choice but to spin another lie. "Under General Li Lian of the Left Guard Army's Third Battalion."

Fan Changyu secretly committed it to memory, then went to the table and brought over the tureen of chicken soup. "I caught a wild pheasant and secretly stewed this for you. Drink it and then go back to your battalion with Brother Xiao Wu."

Xie Zheng, suspecting nothing, drank the chicken soup in a few gulps.

Fan Changyu watched him, her expression somewhat complicated. She said, "While I'm gone, I'll have to trouble you to look after Changning for me."

The whole world began to spin. Xie Zheng finally realized something was wrong, and his face changed. "You..."

But his body had already gone limp in an instant. He had just taken a step when he collapsed. Fan Changyu caught him, whispering to the unconscious man, "I don't want you to die."

Fearing someone might check the roster of wounded soldiers and discover Xie Zheng's identity, Fan Changyu carried him on her back to the tent she shared with Changning first.

When Changning saw Xie Zheng on Fan Changyu's back, her face turned pale. "Elder Sister, is Brother-in-law going to die again?"

Fan Changyu choked slightly. "No, he's just temporarily fallen asleep. He should wake up in about half a shichen. Ning Niang, be a good girl and watch over your brother-in-law in the tent. If you run into danger and your brother-in-law isn't awake yet, use this needle to poke him awake."

Of the knockout powder Wu Sanjin had given her, she had used a dose sufficient to knock out a wild boar.

Mainly, Yan Zheng's willpower was stronger than that of an ordinary person, and she was afraid a normal dose wouldn't be enough to knock him out.

After handing Changning a needle, Fan Changyu untied the dagger from her calf and gave it to her. "Just in case, you take this dagger too. Remember, if you encounter danger, the first thing you do is poke your brother-in-law awake. Use the needle, not the dagger. Once he's awake, he can protect you."

Changning, clutching the embroidery needle in one hand and the dagger in the other, nodded vigorously, but couldn't help asking, "What about Elder Sister?"

Fan Changyu said, "Elder Sister is going to fight the bad guys who took Ning Niang and Bao'er. I'll be back after I've beaten them."

Changning grabbed a corner of Fan Changyu's clothes, her black grape-like eyes glistening with worry. "Then Elder Sister must be careful."

Fan Changyu patted her head. "Don't worry, Elder Sister is going to get revenge for you!"

After giving Changning her instructions, she took out her pig-slaughtering knife and bone-chopping cleaver, tucked them into her waist, and left the tent, heading for the Left Guard Army's camp. As luck would have it, she ran into Xie Wu on the way.

When Xie Wu saw her wearing the uniform of a Yanzhou soldier, a terrible guess had already formed in his mind. He stammered, "Miss... Miss Fan."

Fan Changyu asked in confusion, "Brother Xiao Wu hasn't returned to the battalion yet?"

Xie Wu said stiffly, "I... I was going to look for Big Brother Yan."

Fan Changyu glanced around, then grabbed Xie Wu and whispered, "Brother Xiao Wu knows as well that my husband's serious injuries haven't healed. For him to go to the battlefield is undoubtedly suicide. I will go on this expedition in my husband's place. Brother Xiao Wu, just pretend you don't know about this. When I return from this battle, I will switch back with my husband. No one will know."

How could no one know! Xie Wu thought.

Although the battle plan had been laid out long ago and the various armies were deploying down the mountain in an orderly fashion, it would be inexcusable if the Marquis never showed his face from beginning to end!

Yet, at this moment, he didn't dare take it upon himself to inform Fan Changyu of Xie Zheng's true identity. He could only try to persuade her, "Miss Fan, don't be foolish. This is a major taboo in the army, punishable by beheading!"

Fan Changyu looked at Xie Wu. Her roundish almond eyes were sincere and resolute, yet they also held a hint of the chill of a hunting leopard. She said, "I'm sorry, Brother Xiao Wu. I just don't want my husband to die a pointless death on the battlefield. If he weren't injured, I wouldn't resort to this. As it is, sending him to the battlefield, he'd be less effective at killing enemies than I would. This action won't bring any loss to the grand army. As for the punishment for violating military orders, I will bear it all myself when I return. My husband was drugged and knocked out by me. To avoid implicating you, Brother Xiao Wu, I might as well knock you out here too."

Seeing Fan Changyu already raising her hand, Xie Wu quickly said, "I'll keep Miss Fan's secret! We'll go kill the enemy together. At least we'll have each other's backs on the battlefield."

Fan Changyu didn't understand why he had changed his mind so quickly, but since he had said so, she lowered her hand. "Then let's return to the battalion."

Xie Wu let out a huge sigh of relief. If they had really come to blows, he would definitely be no match for this young woman.

For now, the only plan was to first send a message to the other personal guards to find Xie Zheng, while he himself followed Fan Changyu in order to protect her.

Xie Wu let out a few sharp whistles. Fan Changyu suddenly turned to look at him. "What are you whistling for?"

Xie Wu broke out in a cold sweat from the scare. Just then, a goshawk flew across the sky. He pointed at it and forced a smile. "I heard an old soldier in the camp say that falconers use this kind of whistle to give hawks instructions. I was seeing if it was true."

Fan Changyu asked, "Does it work on hawks that haven't been trained?"

Xie Wu pointed at the hawk in the sky and said stiffly, "I tried. It seems it doesn't."

Fan Changyu was greatly disappointed. She had been thinking that if it worked, she would learn how to do it later and catch another falcon for Changning.

The central army had already set out. Fan Changyu followed the banners and found the Left Guard Army's Third Battalion. When she and Xie Wu stood at the back of the formation, the squad leaders were counting the number of soldiers under their command.

The fully armored colonel stood at the front of the formation, looking majestic and imposing.

When the squad leader at the very back of the line counted Fan Changyu and Xie Wu, he shouted, "Which squad are you from? Why are you standing in my line?"

Xie Wu was not the least bit intimidated and replied loudly, "We were scattered from the infantry battalion and reassigned here."

He did this specifically to draw the Third Battalion's colonel, Li Lian, over.

Sure enough, Li Lian, seeing the commotion at the rear of the formation from his position at the front, strode over with his head held high and barked, "The army is about to move out, what's all the shouting about?"

The squad leader said, "General, there are two extra men in the line. They say they were reassigned from elsewhere."

Li Lian had also been in the personal guard unit in his early years. Later, when he became capable of holding his own, he was sent down to the Left Guard Army by Xie Zheng. He naturally recognized Xie Wu.

Those in the personal guard unit who were granted the surname Xie had all been martial assassins in the past, without names or surnames. They were also the group most loyal to Xie Zheng.

When Xie Wu shot Li Lian a look, Li Lian didn't ask any more questions about why he and another unfamiliar soldier had appeared in his ranks. Assuming he was on some secret mission, he just cursed the squad leader, "I lost so many men defending the mountain a few days ago! It took me great effort to get some men assigned over, and now you're complaining that I have too many people in my ranks, is that it?"

The squad leader, having been scolded, immediately fell silent.

The other soldiers, who had been craning their necks to size up Fan Changyu and Xie Wu, also quickly stood properly and dared not look around anymore.

It was a good thing that the soldiers Fan Changyu had interacted with before were all from the cookhouse and wounded soldier camps. People from other battalions had only heard her name but had never seen her.

At this moment, wearing tattered battle armor and standing in the ranks with her head lowered, the soldiers only thought this new kid was like a skinny monkey, and no one paid her much attention.

Li Lian clasped his hands behind his back and returned to the front of the formation. Seeing this, Xie Wu grew anxious. He was just about to give Li Lian a hint to find a way to kick him and Fan Changyu out of the line—after all, he couldn't really let Fan Changyu go onto the battlefield—when a commotion broke out in the military formation up ahead. A scout on a fast horse returned to report, "Shi Yue has led his men to tear an opening in

the vanguard and is about to flee south! By order of the military strategist, the Left Guard Army is to immediately advance to support the vanguard!"

The Commandant of the Left Guard Army roared, "First three battalions of the Left Guard Army, full speed ahead!"

The military formation, which had been standing in neat ranks, immediately broke into a run, five men abreast, rushing towards the battlefield.

Xie Zheng's personal guard unit often used whistle sounds as secret signals to convey simple messages.

That kind of sharp and urgent whistle meant that Xie Zheng might be in danger.

The personal guards who heard Xie Wu's whistle instantly rushed to find Xie Zheng. Discovering he wasn't in the wounded soldier tent where he had been staying, they searched the surrounding area for clues and soon found the tent belonging to Fan Changyu and her sister.

Changning had been clutching the embroidery needle, guarding Xie Zheng's side. When she heard the rapid footsteps approaching the tent, she quickly poked Xie Zheng with the needle.

The unconscious man's eyes flew open almost instantly. The personal guard who lifted the tent flap was overjoyed to see Xie Zheng. He paid no mind to Changning's presence and called out, "Marquis!"

Xie Zheng's face was terrifyingly grim. He got up to walk out of the tent, but the knockout powder's effects hadn't worn off yet, and his body was completely drained of strength. He managed to steady himself by grabbing a bedpost in time.

A personal guard hurried over to support him. "Marquis, what's wrong with you?"

Xie Zheng spotted the dagger Changning had placed by the bed. He picked it up without hesitation and sliced it forcefully across his palm. Blood dripped from the tip of the dagger to the ground. Changning was so frightened she let out a short, low cry, her little face turning white.

The sharp pain clearly lessened the effects of the drug on Xie Zheng, but his expression grew even darker. He asked the personal guard, "Where are General Li Lian's troops of the Left Guard Army now?"

The personal guard replied, "Somehow, a fierce general has joined Shi Yue's ranks. He possesses superhuman strength and is unstoppable. Shi Yue is using this general to clear a path, and they have forcefully torn through our vanguard. The military strategist has ordered the Left Guard Army to plug the gap torn in the vanguard."

Xie Zheng could not sit still for another moment. He strode out of the tent and commanded coldly, "Bring me my battle armor! And assemble five hundred elite cavalry!"

The vanguard he had dispatched was one of the fiercest under his command. If even the vanguard couldn't stop Shi Yue, this battle was likely not looking optimistic.

Soon, a personal guard came forward, holding his set of heavy, black-scaled armor, and helped him put it on. Changning dazedly followed him out of the tent. Seeing Xie Zheng's icy expression, the "Brother-in-law" on the tip of her tongue was swallowed back down.

She had never seen her brother-in-law with such a frightening expression, as if he were about to swallow someone whole. He didn't seem like the brother-in-law in her memory at all.

And these people called her brother-in-law "Marquis." What was a Marquis?

A personal guard led Xie Zheng's warhorse over. He fastened his black cloak and gave a cold order to the personal guard beside him, "Send a message to Gongsun Yin. Tell him to tighten the pocket at the rear. There's no need to divert troops to the vanguard."

As he swung himself onto the horse, he glanced at Changning, who was standing like a little cabbage at the tent entrance, and said to Xie Qi, "Watch her."

Xie Qi cupped his fist in acknowledgment. Xie Zheng had already spurred his horse and galloped away, with a dozen personal guards instantly following him.

Tears welled up in Changning's eyes. She wanted to cry but didn't dare. Why had her brother-in-law become so fierce after waking up?

Xie Qi had no experience with children. He clumsily tried to soothe her. Changning, probably having determined that he was not someone who would be fierce with her, suddenly burst out crying, "I want Elder Sister—"

Xie Qi hadn't seen Fan Changyu and was also very puzzled. He asked her, "Then where did your elder sister go?"

Changning sobbed, "Elder Sister said she went to fight the bad guys."

Xie Qi's heart skipped a beat. He continued to ask, "How did the Marquis... I mean, your brother-in-law, get here?"

Changning hiccupped. "Elder Sister carried him back."

Xie Qi choked. He suddenly understood why his Marquis had that man-eating expression after waking up.

He looked at Changning and decided it was best to take the child away from this place of trouble first. He said, "Don't cry. How about I take you to see some wild pheasants?"

Changning continued to sob, scared. She kept muttering that she wanted her elder sister. Xie Qi listed all the wild animals he could think of on the mountain, from wild boars to wild oxen. When he mentioned seeing a falcon, Changning's sobs finally paused. She opened her big, tear-filled eyes and asked, "Falcon?"

Seeing a chance, Xie Qi quickly said, "A white-headed Gyrffalcon. When it spreads its wings, it's this big. Want to go see it?"

Changning looked at the size he was gesturing and nodded. "Yes."

To receive messages in the fastest time possible, the Gyrffalcon had been cared for by the personal guards in shifts these past few days. No matter day or night, whenever the Gyrffalcon returned with a letter, the guard on duty would present it to Xie Zheng.

It happened to be Xie Qi's turn on duty these two days. He figured that if he took the child over, he could watch both the person and the falcon at the same time, which would save him some trouble.

Fan Changyu didn't know where the battlefield for the two armies was located. She only felt that along the way, the mountainous terrain and green trees gave way to barren land where not a blade of grass grew, trampled flat. From a great distance, she could hear the deafening sounds of slaughter, like ocean tides, wave after wave.

The wind blowing over the mountain ridge carried with it the stench of blood.

This was Fan Changyu's first time truly participating in a large-scale battle. She herself didn't feel afraid, but her heart inexplicably quickened its pace, and a layer of goosebumps rose on her arms, which were tightly wrapped in vambraces.

She and Xiao Wu were positioned in the middle-rear of the formation and couldn't see the state of the battlefield ahead. They only heard some general or other shout himself hoarse, "Cavalry formation, charge!"

Then another wave of battle cries erupted, so loud it made one's eardrums ache. Tremors came from the mountain pass ahead, and the entire earth seemed to tremble along with it.

Fan Changyu noticed that Xiao Wu seemed even more nervous than she was. He said to her, "Miss Fan, once we're on the battlefield, stay close to me and don't take any risks!"

Fan Changyu responded with an affirmative, but the infantry formation ahead erupted into a deafening roar, instantly drowning out her voice. Everyone was drawing their swords and charging forward.

At this point, military commands were completely inaudible. It was almost a case of seeing what those in front were doing and following suit.

Fan Changyu's heartbeat pounded like a drum, her blood surging with tension to the point where she couldn't even feel the exhaustion from the long march. She followed the army as it poured into the battlefield like a flood.

The ground was littered with corpses—they were practically stepping over bodies as they charged forward. When they clashed with the rebel soldiers who had fought to the point of bloodlust, the roars that erupted served only to bolster their courage.

A soldier running ahead of Fan Changyu was impaled clean through by a rebel wielding a spear. The squad leader of that soldier—the same one who had previously questioned Fan Changyu and Xie Wu's identities—let out a furious roar, his face twisted in rage as he swung his ring-pommeled sword down at the rebel's face, sending blood spraying everywhere.

The remaining three soldiers in the squad, their eyes bloodshot, charged forward with their leader. When one was knocked down, the others worked together to rescue him.

At this moment, Fan Changyu suddenly understood Gongsun Yin's words from the day they seized the provisions more deeply.

Not only did generals consider the lives of their soldiers their responsibility, but even squad leaders and platoon leaders fought with everything they had to protect their men.

Facing living, breathing people, Fan Changyu still couldn't bring herself to strike fatal blows as if cutting melons or chopping vegetables. She aimed to avoid vital areas, ensuring only that her opponents lost their ability to fight.

When that squad leader nearly had his head taken off, Fan Changyu deflected the fatal strike for him. He glanced back at her but said nothing, his face covered in blood as he continued battling the rebels.

A rebel general on horseback charged into their midst, his spear stabbing and slashing with the momentum of his horse, killing many Yanzhou soldiers.

Even those not immediately killed were knocked down, only to be swarmed by Chongzhou soldiers who finished them off. The Yanzhou infantry was clearly at a disadvantage.

Xie Wu, being a seasoned soldier, grew furious at the sight. Seeing that Fan Changyu's martial skills were solid and none of the surrounding soldiers could harm her, he seized the moment when the rebel general charged past. Grabbing the saddle, he used the momentum to flip onto the horse, his long blade slashing downward.

The rebel on horseback hastily raised his spear to block, but Xie Wu had already landed firmly on the horse's back. The rebel's long weapon became a liability in close quarters, allowing Xie Wu to slit his throat with a dagger and shove him off the horse.

"You there—your life is forfeit!" Another rebel general, witnessing this, charged forward, his pair of spiked hammers whirling through the air with terrifying force. As he advanced, countless soldiers were sent flying under the crushing blows—clearly, this man possessed monstrous strength.

Xie Wu's fighting style emphasized agility, so he dared not engage directly. He quickly abandoned the horse and dodged away. Li Lian, seeing the rebel general slaughtering their soldiers with such brutality, moved to intercept him.

But when his lance clashed with the rebel's weapon, both man and horse were forced back several steps. The impact sent a sharp pain through Li Lian's hands, nearly making him lose his grip on his weapon. His expression instantly darkened.

The rebel general laughed heartily. "Pathetic! Your arms are as weak as noodles!"

From afar, an unknown general spotted Li Lian engaging the rebel commander and shouted, "General Li, be careful! That brute has immense strength—even the Commandant was struck from his horse by him!"

Hearing this, Li Lian was horrified. As the rebel commander charged toward him with his hammers, Li Lian barely managed to exchange a few blows. He realized this man possessed monstrous strength—the pair of spiked hammers were not only heavy but also unnaturally agile in his hands. A single hit would mean certain death or severe injury.

When the rebel launched another fierce attack, Li Lian swiftly raised his lance to block, but he was no match for the other's freakish strength. The spiked hammer struck him, sending him coughing up blood. Fortunately, most of the force had been deflected, sparing him from instant death.

"Not a single worthy opponent among you!" the rebel commander roared arrogantly. As he raised his hammer for a second strike, a rope suddenly flew out of nowhere, looping tightly around his neck. A powerful yank followed, but the rebel dug his feet into the stirrups, dropped one hammer, and gripped the rope with one hand, engaging in a tug-of-war to avoid being dragged off his horse.

He glanced sideways toward the source of the rope and was stunned to see a scrawny Yan Army soldier holding the other end.

Seizing the opportunity, Li Lian thrust his lance forward. The rebel blocked with his remaining spiked hammer, nearly knocking the weapon from Li Lian's grasp. Realizing he stood no chance, Li Lian swiftly retreated.

The rebel commander, a mountain of a man astride his horse, glared murderously at Fan Changyu, his face twisted with malice. He gripped the rope with both hands and yanked hard, trying to drag the frail-looking Yan soldier toward him.

Caught off guard, Fan Changyu stumbled but quickly planted her feet firmly into the ground, as if rooted to the earth. No matter how hard the

rebel pulled, she refused to budge.

Refusing to believe it, the rebel strained with all his might, his muscles bulging. Meanwhile, a rebel soldier seized the chance to thrust a spear at Fan Changyu. She timed it perfectly—releasing the rope and kicking the attacker away.

With the rope suddenly slack, the rebel commander lost his balance and toppled backward off his horse.

Quick-eyed Yan soldiers immediately lunged with their spears. Despite his bulk, the rebel was surprisingly agile—he rolled aside, grabbed a knife to sever the rope around his neck, then seized a soldier's spear. Lifting both man and weapon, he swung them like a flail, forcing the surrounding Yan troops back before hurling the soldier into a densely packed group, sending them sprawling.

The Yan forces suffered heavy losses, and the soldiers' initial fearless fervor visibly waned, replaced by hesitation.

The rebel commander retrieved his fallen spiked hammers, casually crushing Yan soldiers underfoot like ants as he strode straight toward Fan Changyu. Grinning savagely, he taunted, "You scrawny rat, you've got some strength in those arms. Let's see how many of my hammer strikes you can take!"

Xie Wu, having just beheaded a rebel soldier, screamed hysterically at Fan Changyu, "Run!"

Fan Changyu wanted to flee, but as she watched the rebel commander swing his hammers with brutal efficiency—shattering skulls, splattering brains, and sending Yan soldiers flying like ragdolls—she found her feet rooted to the spot. Xie Wu, determined to cover her, charged recklessly at the rebel commander, leaving her no choice but to stand her ground.

She discarded the ring-pommeled sword she had picked up earlier, drawing the black iron cleaver and bleeding knife from her waist. With a sharp scrape of the two blades—one long, one short—against each other, she charged toward the rebel general, her gaze as cold as the white lightning flashing through the storm.

Xie Wu, relying on his agility, managed to slash the rebel general once but was violently slammed to the ground, instantly losing sensation in half his body. As the spiked hammer descended toward his face, he braced for

the impact that would splatter his brains, instinctively closing his eyes. Yet the fatal blow never came—only the grating screech of metal colliding.

Xie Wu cracked his eyes open to see Fan Changyu half-kneeling on the ground, her two black iron butcher knives crossed to block the rebel general's hammer. Her teeth were clenched tight, and one knee had sunk into the dirt.

Xie Wu's eyes burned with emotion. Through gritted teeth, Changyu spat out a single word: "Go!"

Without hesitation, Xie Wu rolled away from the hammer's range, hurling a dagger at the rebel general as he retreated. The general, forced to deflect the dagger with his other hammer, gave Changyu the opening she needed.

Seizing the moment, she twisted her cleavers upward, pressing the blades down onto the back of the general's hand and slicing a deep, bone-exposing wound. As the general roared in pain and swung his hammer horizontally, Changyu leaped back to evade the blow.

The rebel general glanced at his bleeding hand, his face contorted with rage. "You're dead!" he bellowed, disregarding his injury as his hammer strikes grew even more vicious, aimed solely at taking Changyu's life.

His spiked hammer was solid, weighing over eight hundred jin. When Changyu had intercepted the earlier blow to save Xie Wu, the impact had nearly torn her palms apart. Her butcher knives were too short and too light to match the hammer's force.

Now, she avoided direct clashes, dodging whenever possible. The few times she had no choice but to block, the hammer's force sent shocks through her arms, blood from her torn palms staining the knife handles. In another unavoidable clash, the bleeding knife was knocked from her grip.

The rebel general grinned savagely at the sight. "I'll pound you into paste!"

Changyu kicked up a fallen broadsword to replace the lost knife, but the hammer's next strike shattered it in two.

The Left Guard Colonel, wounded by the rebel general's hammer and unable to remount, had been dragged to safety by his personal guards. Watching Changyu trade blows with the enemy, he remarked in surprise, "Which unit is that soldier from?"

His guards shook their heads, clueless.

After a closer look, the colonel said, "With the right weapon, he might stand a chance against that rebel. Someone, give him my Horse-Cutting Sword!"

As a guard hurried to fetch the long, ornate polearm, Xie Wu—frantic—rushed over and shouted, "Colonel Yan Yi of the Left Guard, where are you?"

Recognizing him as Xie Zheng's personal guard, the colonel quickly responded despite his injuries, "At your service."

Xie Wu, eyes bloodshot, pointed toward Changyu. "Send troops to save Madam, now!"

The colonel froze. "Madam?"

Xie Wu could no longer afford to hesitate and blurted out, "The one fighting that rebel general is the Marquis's wife!"

The Left Guard Army captain instantly felt as though he had several heads to spare for the chopping block, but his injuries were so severe he could barely lift a weapon. He could only order a few junior officers to lead troops in reinforcement.

Xie Wu borrowed a horse from him and galloped back to support Fan Changyu. The Left Guard Army captain thrust a Horse-Cutting Sword into his hands: "Might come in handy!"

Xie Wu didn't have time to think. Wielding the Horse-Cutting Sword, he hacked his way through rebel soldiers toward Changyu.

Meanwhile, Changyu had picked up several broadswords, only for them to meet the same fate—shattered. When another hammer swing came her way, she failed to dodge in time. The spiked hammer scraped off her helmet, revealing her hair still tied up but unmistakably that of a woman.

The rebel general seemed stunned that the opponent who'd exchanged so many blows with him was a woman. Even in such disarray, her features remained striking. He roared with laughter: "A woman? Take her alive! Every soldier in Chongzhou can be a groom tonight!"

The Chongzhou troops erupted in raucous cheers, their battle fervor intensifying.

The rebel general no longer seemed intent on killing Changyu, focusing instead on capturing her alive. His hammer strikes lost their previous lethality but became more persistent.

Changyu's face was icy as she snatched a spear from a Chongzhou soldier to use as a weapon. With the longer reach, her attacks turned razor-sharp, her movements expansive and forceful, actually forcing the rebel general back several steps. But when he mustered his strength, the spear in her hands snapped clean in two.

The rebel general threw back his head and laughed mockingly.

A bloody scratch marred Changyu's face. She discarded the broken spear, her gaze fixed fiercely on the spiked hammer in the rebel general's right hand—his right arm bore a deep gash she'd inflicted, bone visible beneath. Disarming his right side would be easier.

Suddenly, a voice shouted from behind: "Catch!"

Changyu turned to see a long-handled Horse-Cutting Sword flying toward her.

She reached out to grab it, but the rebel general swung his hammer at her. If she continued reaching for the sword, his spiked hammer would crush her hand.

Instead, she feinted toward the sword while driving her foot hard into the rebel's armpit as he swung. The general howled in pain. Changyu's hand, which had pretended to catch the sword, now wrenched the spiked hammer from his grip. Without pause, she swung it viciously at him.

The rebel general hastily raised his own hammer to block. The two massive spiked hammers collided with a deafening metallic clang that left nearby soldiers momentarily deafened.

The spikes on one hammer flattened upon impact. The rebel general staggered back, nearly losing his grip on his weapon.

His jowls quivered as realization dawned—with a weapon matching his own, this woman might very well defeat him.

Changyu showed no signs of stopping. Her second hammer blow split the rebel general's palms open. Baring her teeth in a grin that mirrored his earlier mockery, she taunted: "Let me show you how to pound meat paste!"

With bloodied hands gripping the hammer's shaft, she delivered a crushing blow. The rebel general instinctively blocked with his own hammer, but the force sent both man and weapon flying backward.

One hammer embedded itself deep into his abdomen—truly hammered into flesh.

He struggled to sit up, but only managed to spit out a mouthful of blood before collapsing with wide, lifeless eyes.

The vast battlefield seemed to fall into sudden silence.

The rebel soldiers who had been leering at Fan Changyu moments ago now scattered like frightened ghosts, their faces pale as they fled in panic.

Even their own allies looked at Fan Changyu with trepidation.

The soldiers gathered at a distance, too afraid to approach her.

Several severely wounded generals lay slumped on a distant slope, swallowing hard.

One of them said, "Truly worthy of being our Marquis's wife."

Another whispered, "Using the same tiger-tooth meteor hammer, how did Madam send that mountain of a man flying?"

The question left them all in stunned silence.

Was their lady even more monstrously strong than the rebel's prized champion?

After confirming the rebel commander's death, Xie Wu rushed to Fan Changyu's side. "Miss Fan, are you alright?"

Fan Changyu looked at him, her vision tinged red as if through a bloody veil. Waves of nausea washed over her—the world spun violently yet refused to let her faint.

Bracing her hands on her knees, she dry-heaved before managing to say, "I'm... fine."

Xie Wu quickly retrieved a waterskin from his horse and handed it to her. "Rinse your mouth, Miss Fan. It's common for new soldiers to have nightmares for weeks after their first battle."

After rinsing and drinking some water, the nausea subsided slightly.

She'd never witnessed such large-scale carnage before—it felt like her blades had been stabbing at something less than human.

But on the battlefield, you either killed or were killed.

As unrest still rippled through the remaining enemy troops, Xie Wu picked up a blade and approached the dead rebel commander.

Fan Changyu asked, "What are you doing?"

Xie Wu answered, "Taking his head to intimidate the remaining soldiers into surrendering."

Glancing at her butcher's knife lying nearby—the weapon that had been knocked from her grasp multiple times amid taunts—she said, "Let me."

Xie Wu, already poised to strike, stepped aside at her words.

Though she'd killed before, decapitation was new to her.

The black iron cleaver sliced cleanly through flesh and bone with a single stroke.

Since death had already claimed him, no blood sprayed from the severed neck.

Xie Wu lifted the head high and bellowed toward the remaining rebels, "Your general is dead! Lay down your arms and surrender, and your lives will be spared!"

The distant rebels exchanged glances before gradually lowering their weapons.

Then thunderous hoofbeats approached, forcing the exhausted Yanzhou Army to remain alert despite their fatigue.

A scout scrambled up the slope to identify the approaching banners before shouting down, "Allies!"

From generals to foot soldiers, everyone exhaled in relief.

Were it not for the sea of corpses and blood surrounding her, Fan Changyu would have collapsed to the ground then and there.

She was exhausted beyond anything she'd ever known—too spent to lift even a finger.

As the hoofbeats drew nearer, the setting sun bled across the sky like an open wound, while geese cried mournfully overhead.

Fan Changyu looked toward the allied forces approaching in a cloud of yellow dust. They seemed to have just emerged from a fierce battle, with fresh blood staining their horses' legs, armor, and weapons. Even the wind blowing from their direction carried the scent of blood.

Her gaze swept over the general charging ahead on a sleek black steed. At first, it was just a casual glance, but then she suddenly snapped her attention back, narrowing her eyes. She pulled Xie Wu over and asked, "That general of yours wearing the Bright Light Armor with qilin shoulder ornaments, charging ahead on that tall horse—why does he look somewhat like my husband?"

Xie Wu stared at Fan Changyu, opening and closing his mouth, but not daring to utter a single word.

Chapter 84

As the sun sank in the west, the tattered banners slanted across the battlefield were dyed a bloody crimson tinged with a faint golden glow by the setting sun. The corpses littering the ground created a scene of boundless desolation.

The approaching unit of Iron Cavalry was like a steel blade, thrusting hard into this war-torn land. The rebel soldiers who had just laid down their arms and surrendered grew even more alarmed, huddling together like a flock of lambs to the slaughter.

As they drew nearer, Fan Changyu got a clearer look at the man charging at the very front, all alone. His face was like cold jade, and his eyes, like stars clustered in a fire, were fixed on her like a wolf hunting on the steppes. He whipped his horse viciously and charged toward her.

Seeing this, Fan Changyu's heart jolted. She murmured to Xie Wu, "Now that he's closer, how come he looks even more like him?"

Xie Wu was on the verge of tears. Seeing Xie Zheng's murderous, ferocious expression, he reacted instinctively, "Miss Fan, run!"

Fan Changyu's helmet had long since fallen off. The small topknot on her head was on the verge of coming undone after her life-or-death struggle with the rebel general, and her messy hair flew about, making her stand out among the grimy soldiers.

She thought Xie Wu's panic was because her disguise as a man to fight on the battlefield in Yan Zheng's place had been exposed. Her heart sank. With no time to ponder why the general on horseback looked so much like Yan Zheng, she bolted and ran toward the densest part of the crowd, hoping to hide.

Alas, two legs were no match for four. The large black horse, a head taller than a man, seemed to kick up a gale as it galloped. Before Fan Changyu could even pick up a helmet from the ground to put on, she was hoisted onto the horse by her waist.

She was slung head-down over the front of the saddle, the air knocked out of her. The warhorse immediately galloped back the way it came, and for a moment, all she could see was the surrounding scenery flashing past.

Someone in the Iron Cavalry shouted, "The rebel commander Shi Yue has been slain by the Marquis at the gorge! Here is his head as proof! The army returns in triumph!"

The exhausted Yanzhou Army instantly erupted in a tsunami of cheers.

Snatched onto the horse, Fan Changyu instinctively struggled a couple of times. But she had spent too much energy killing enemies earlier, and a wave of fatigue was now washing over her. Her limbs were sore and weak, and the hand pressing on her back and waist was like an iron clamp, preventing her from thrashing about.

As she struggled, she caught a whiff of a clean, bitter medicinal scent mixed with the thick smell of blood on the man. Fan Changyu's struggles weakened. She tried hard to turn her head to look at the man on horseback, whose handsome face seemed to be covered in a layer of frost, and called out uncertainly, "Yan Zheng?"

Xie Zheng glanced down at her without a word. His eyes fixed forward, he suddenly kicked the horse's belly even harder and yelled, "Giddy-up!"

Although the voice was cold, deep, and filled with rage, Fan Changyu could still recognize it as Yan Zheng's.

She suddenly stopped struggling, hanging on the horse like a dazed goose. Her eyes, reflecting the setting sun and the mountain forest, were filled with nothing but confusion and bewilderment.

Yan Zheng wasn't a common soldier; he was a general.

Why did he lie to her?

Xie Zheng's warhorse had already left his retinue of personal guards far behind. On either side of the official road, green mountains and flowing streams kept them company.

Noticing Fan Changyu's strange quietness, Xie Zheng reined in his horse to slow it down. He reached out to pull her upright, but he didn't expect her to suddenly attack. She twisted her elbow to evade his large hand and sprang up like a leopard, pinning him down on the horse's back. Her roundish almond eyes blazed with anger as she stared at him and snapped, "You lied to me!"

The coldness on Xie Zheng's face faltered slightly. "I can explain," he said.

The sky was growing darker. Fan Changyu looked at the man she had pinned to the horse by his collar. After the anger came a sense of grievance she couldn't quite name.

She had seen how gravely he was wounded and feared he would die on the battlefield, so she had devised a plan to take his place in secret. But it seemed he had been lying to her from the very beginning.

If his injuries were truly that severe, how could he have lifted her onto the horse with one hand?

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together, anger and that sense of grievance intertwining in her heart. She demanded, "Are you going to explain why you're a general, or are you going to explain why you lied about your injuries never healing?"

The web of her thumb, which had split open, was bleeding again from the force she was exerting. Xie Zheng felt the warm, sticky sensation and his expression changed before he could answer her question. "You're injured?"

As he spoke, he grabbed the hand she was using to hold his collar, intending to get up and look at her wound, but Fan Changyu forcefully pushed him back down.

Xie Zheng's face grew colder. His heart was still pounding, whether from the frantic ride or from some lingering fear, he didn't know. He suppressed a sliver of anger in his eyes and said, "I can explain everything you mentioned. Let me take you back to have your wound looked at first."

Fan Changyu's anger had not subsided. She spat out a few hard words, "None of your business."

With no one holding the reins, the warhorse had already stopped after trotting for a short distance. After releasing her hold on Xie Zheng, she was about to jump off the horse, but the man behind her suddenly grabbed her waist and pressed her tightly into his embrace.

After she had flipped up, she had been sitting facing him. Now, her waist was squeezed so tightly it felt like it would break, and her jaw was gripped forcefully by one of his hands, the bones aching faintly. His eyes were tinged with a bloody aura as he spoke, almost viciously, "None of your

business? Then you shouldn't have drugged me to go onto the battlefield! Do you have any idea what a battlefield is? It's a place where human lives are worthless! Have you completely forgotten what I told you when you went down the mountain to seize grain?"

He seemed angrier than he had ever been. The veins on his temples bulged, and his gaze was so fierce it was as if he wanted to eat her alive. Yet the hand gripping her waist was so tight its knuckles had turned white, as if desperately protecting his most precious treasure that he had almost lost.

Fan Changyu was already angry and aggrieved by his deception. Now, being yelled at by him, her eyes inexplicably stung. She fought back the stinging sensation, gritted her teeth, and snapped, "I was just afraid you would die on the battlefield!"

"Even if I had died there, you shouldn't have gone!"

As soon as he roared these words, Xie Zheng looked at Fan Changyu, whose eyes were welling with tears she stubbornly refused to let fall. His heart felt as if it had been seared by a red-hot iron, the beating muscle clenching in pain. Both of their breaths were trembling.

His face remained taut, but when he lowered his eyes, his voice softened. "If I had died, you should have taken your sister and left the army camp. Find a new place to settle down, open a pork stall, or build a pigsty to raise pigs. Live a good life. In the future, marry a refined and handsome scholar you like, have children..."

When the tear Fan Changyu had been holding back so desperately splashed onto his hand, he watched as large teardrops fell from her eyes, the girl crying without a sound. The blood-red in his eyes deepened, and he suddenly cupped her jaw and kissed her fiercely.

Boom—

A clap of thunder exploded in the sky. A bright flash of lightning split the dark night curtain. After half a month of clear skies, a sudden spring downpour had finally arrived this night.

Fat drops of rain hammered down. Fan Changyu pushed him hard several times but couldn't shove him away. Rainwater slid down her eyelids, making it impossible to tell if the streaks on her face were from rain or tears. She jabbed her elbow into his body several times and heard a muffled grunt, but the hand cupping the back of her head didn't loosen in

the slightest. Instead, he kissed her even more ferociously, as if his life depended on it.

Lightning flashed across the mountain terrain. After a moment of brightness, the world plunged back into boundless darkness.

When it came to being crazy, Fan Changyu was no match for him.

Her chest was a tangle of unknown and unfamiliar emotions; she couldn't even cry properly.

When it ended, he rested his forehead against hers. His hand, covered in dried blood, gently stroked her rain-soaked hair. His voice was very soft, his eyes pitch-black. "As long as I'm alive, you can forget about having children for anyone else in this lifetime."

Fan Changyu had cried her fill, venting all the terrible emotions in her heart with that good cry. When she lifted her eyes to look at Xie Zheng, she threw a punch without holding back.

She didn't pull her punch. Xie Zheng was knocked right off the horse's back.

Without a single glance back at him, Fan Changyu yanked the reins and shouted, "Giddy-up!"

The warhorse galloped off, kicking up a spray of muddy water.

Xie Zheng lay on his back in the rain, one hand covering the left eye Fan Changyu had hit. He sucked in a sharp breath of cold air. After a long moment, he finally lowered his hand and, looking up at the rainy night sky, let out a hearty laugh.

Fan Changyu galloped her horse all the way. On the road, she wiped her lips with the back of her hand, but they hurt at the touch. They were definitely swollen.

The cool rain hit her face, yet her cheeks felt faintly hot. Fan Changyu scrubbed her lips harder a couple of times, as if trying to wipe something away.

Up ahead on the official road, she ran into the group of personal guards who had come looking for Xie Zheng, Xie Wu among them.

When he saw Fan Changyu, he quickly urged his horse forward and called out, "Miss Fan."

Seeing Fan Changyu on Xie Zheng's mount, he looked behind her but saw no sign of Xie Zheng. He asked, "Where is the Marquis?"

Fan Changyu had thought Xie Zheng was just a general. Hearing Xie Wu call him Marquis, she first froze, then said with a stern face, "He fell to his death!"

With that, she ignored the expressions on the personal guards' faces and rode straight on.

Xie Wu quickly ordered a few men, "You escort Madam back. The rest of you, follow me to find the Marquis!"

The dozen or so personal guards split into two groups. One group followed Fan Changyu from a careful distance, while the other went to find Xie Zheng in a hurry.

When they saw Xie Zheng on the official road, Xie Wu and his men quickly dismounted and went to greet him. "Marquis!"

The pine-resin torches burned steadily even in the rainy night. When the personal guards saw the bruise on the corner of Xie Zheng's eye, they were all stunned.

Madam hit the Marquis?

Xie Wu, remembering that he had also helped deceive Fan Changyu, and then recalling the miserable sight of the rebel general being bludgeoned to death by her hammers, swallowed with great difficulty.

When they got back, would Madam beat him up too?

Xie Zheng didn't notice his foolish thoughts. He asked, "Where is she?"

This "she" could only be Fan Changyu.

Xie Wu quickly came to his senses and replied, "Xie Jiu and the others are escorting Madam back."

Xie Zheng asked no more questions. He mounted a warhorse that Xie Wu led over and said, "Back to camp."

Chapter 85

Gongsun Yin was responsible for commanding the central army's rear guard during this campaign. Midway through the battle, he suddenly saw a cavalry unit charge in, breaking through Chongzhou's infantry formation and assisting him in completing the encirclement at the rear.

When the two forces joined, Gongsun Yin spotted an elderly man standing composedly in the heavy rain, dressed in plain clothes and holding an umbrella. Surprise and delight simultaneously appeared on his face as he hurried forward with a cupped-hand salute: "The Marquis had mentioned earlier that there was a mastermind among the reinforcements from the mountain. I never expected it to be Grand Tutor Tao here!"

His personal guard quickly followed, holding an umbrella for him. Rainwater cascaded from the ribs of the umbrella as a cold wind lifted the hem of his robe, giving him an air of effortless grace reminiscent of Wu Daozi's flowing brushstrokes.

Grand Tutor Tao said, "I happened to be traveling through this area and thought I'd stop by."

He examined the young man before him with an appreciative gaze: "I've long heard that the Gongsun family of Hejian produced a worthy talent. That boy must have some skill to have persuaded you to join his ranks."

Gongsun Yin nodded and said, "The Marquis cares deeply for the world and shows compassion for all people. I admire his integrity and willingly serve under him."

After speaking, he guided Grand Tutor Tao toward the carriage: "Shi Yue has an exceptionally strong general under his command who tore through our vanguard and helped Shi Yue escape. The Marquis has gone in pursuit and should be on his way back soon. Grand Tutor, please accompany me up the mountain first for some ginger tea to ward off the chill."

It was already evening, and after this major battle, the soldiers needed rest. With ready-made camps and defensive walls already established on the mountain, staying there for now was the best strategy.

After expressing his gratitude, Grand Tutor Tao boarded the carriage with Gongsun Yin. Raindrops pattered against the canopy like scattered beans as the carriage swayed along the mountain path. Grand Tutor Tao's voice was unhurried amidst the rain: "I must trouble you, young friend Gongsun, to help me find someone."

Gongsun Yin, who was pouring tea for the grand tutor, smiled warmly and said, "Please go ahead, Grand Tutor."

Grand Tutor Tao said, "Among the Jizhou troops who escorted provisions up the mountain half a month ago, there was a young girl—my half-disciple. She rashly came up the mountain that day and must have endured considerable hardship since."

Gongsun Yin's hand paused mid-pour. He thought to himself that among the recent reinforcements delivering supplies, Fan Changyu was the only woman. Could Grand Tutor Tao be referring to her? Or was there another woman disguised as a man on the mountain now?

He slid a cup of tea toward Grand Tutor Tao and asked, "Might I ask the name of your esteemed disciple?"

Grand Tutor Tao replied, "Her surname is Fan, named Changyu. A sincere and honest child."

Gongsun Yin suddenly felt as though the tea he had just sipped had turned into century-old vinegar, so sour it nearly locked his jaw. After a long pause, he managed to say, "I heard you have rather high standards when accepting disciples?"

Being the astute man he was, Grand Tutor Tao immediately sensed that Gongsun Yin must have met Fan Changyu. Not wanting to admit that he had offered to take her as a disciple only to be refused, he cleared his throat and stroked his goatee, saying, "That girl has excellent foundations—a once-in-a-century prodigy in martial arts. It's just that her wisdom is somewhat lacking, which is why I say she's only half a disciple."

Hearing this, Gongsun Yin's envy dissipated, and he smiled. "I've met your disciple, esteemed elder."

As soon as Fan Changyu returned to the military camp, she went looking for Changning. Unable to find her, she inquired and learned that Changning had been taken away by Xie Qi.

She immediately went to look for her and entered the tent, only to find Changning asleep on Xie Qi's military cot. Beside the bed was a bamboo basket of unknown purpose, filled with some dry grass, where the Gyr Falcon was perched, dozing. At the sound of footsteps, it instantly opened its round, beady eyes.

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned at the sight of the Gyr Falcon, unable to tell whether the large falcon had been tamed by Xie Zheng or if it had originally belonged to him.

Xie Qi, unsure whether the Marquis's identity had been exposed, tentatively called out, "Miss Fan."

Fan Changyu glanced at him but said nothing, simply picking up Changning and carrying her back.

The presence of the falcon here meant he was also aware of Xie Zheng's identity. She had been completely deceived by them all this time.

Seeing Fan Changyu's expression, Xie Qi knew she must have figured everything out. Half guilty and half ashamed, he didn't dare stop her as she left.

Changning, feeling herself being moved, drowsily opened her eyes and, upon seeing Fan Changyu, murmured "Big sister" before nestling into her shoulder and falling back asleep.

Fan Changyu carried Changning with one arm, freeing the other to hold an umbrella. Xie Qi quickly stepped forward, saying, "Miss Fan, let me hold the umbrella for you."

Fan Changyu studied the young man's stiff, ingratiating smile for a moment before relenting. With Xie Zheng above him, deceiving her hadn't been his own choice.

The rain pattered softly against the umbrella. Though the weather was uncooperative, every tent in the victorious camp was lit. Unable to celebrate outdoors, the soldiers feasted on wine and meat inside.

Through the curtain of rain, the sounds seemed both distant and clear.

Ever quick-witted, Xie Qi cautiously said, "Miss Fan, I understand you must be upset with the Marquis for hiding his identity, but he had no choice. The Marquis is constantly surrounded by wolves. After Changning was kidnapped by rebels, he feared you might also come to harm, hence this last resort."

Fan Changyu paused slightly and asked, "Was Changning's kidnapping related to him too?"

Xie Qi hesitated, unsure how to respond, but Fan Changyu already had her answer from his momentary silence, her heart growing even more unsettled.

Their tent was just ahead. At the entrance, Fan Changyu turned and said, "Thank you for escorting us, Brother Xie Qi. It's untidy inside, so I won't invite you in."

Xie Qi hurriedly replied, "You flatter me, Miss Fan. This is my duty."

Fan Changyu said no more. Entering the tent, she didn't light a lamp, placing Changning on the bed in the dark and covering her with a blanket. She then sat curled up beside the bed, staring blankly into the pitch-black night.

There was only one Marquis in the entire northwest—so Yan Zheng was the Wu'an Marquis who struck fear into the hearts of the Northern Turks?

Before, she had thought Yan Zheng was vivid and real—bad-tempered, sharp-tongued, picky about food, yet kind-hearted. He called her foolish but always helped her, and he rarely broke his promises.

He had read many books and understood much, the smartest person she had ever met.

Perhaps the time she had spent with Yan Zheng was the hardest period after her parents' death, which was why she often thought of him after he left.

Sometimes she would braise pork intestines, imagining how he would frown while picking them up with his chopsticks if he were still here, and couldn't help feeling amused. Other times, while flipping through books he had annotated, she would hunch over only to immediately straighten her posture upon remembering his remark about how even reading sage texts couldn't make her sit properly. And sometimes, when buying pine nut candy for Changning at the sweets shop, the shopkeeper would ask why she no longer purchased tangerine peel candy. Though there was no one left at home who ate it, she would still instinctively buy some...

When facing difficulties, she would think how nice it would be if Yan Zheng were still here—he was so clever, he would surely help her find a solution.

The person she had traveled over mountains and rivers to find, the one she had braved life and death on the battlefield to protect—that person simply didn't exist.

She couldn't continue seeing Wu'an Marquis as Yan Zheng.

Behind that title lay illustrious military achievements, the admiration of countless people, and for her, an unbridgeable distance.

Her rain-soaked hair hadn't been fully dried yet, and droplets fell from the ends, dampening a small patch of the dry clothes she had just changed into. The wet fabric clung to her skin, bringing a chill that only made Fan Changyu feel more awake.

As soon as Xie Zheng returned to camp in the heavy rain, a personal guard stepped forward to take his horse. "Marquis, Gongsun sent word asking you to see him upon your return. He mentioned there's an important guest."

The soaked cloak was uncomfortable. Xie Zheng removed it and tossed it to the guard. "I'll change into dry clothes first."

Striding into the central military tent, he found hot water for bathing and fresh clothes already prepared by his personal guards.

After a quick wash, Xie Zheng roughly dried himself with a towel and pulled on an arrow-sleeved long robe from beside the bed. "How was she after returning?" he asked.

Xie Qi, who was attending inside, carefully replied, "The lady still seemed rather upset. I tried to console her, but she barely spoke."

Xie Zheng frowned slightly as he fastened his belt. "I'll go see her."

Fan Changyu was still sitting in the tent, lost in thought, when footsteps splashing through the rain approached outside—more than one person, it seemed.

Moments later, the footsteps stopped at the tent entrance. Xie Qi's voice came through: "Miss Fan, the cookhouse camp has prepared ginger soup. I've brought you a bowl."

Her mind was in turmoil. "My constitution is strong. I don't need it. Give it to the other soldiers," she said.

But the person outside didn't leave. Instead, the tent flap was lifted as someone entered directly.

When Changyu looked up, she met Xie Zheng's beautiful yet willful eyes.

He carried the ginger soup inside, followed by Xie Qi carefully shielding a candleholder with one hand. Xie Qi gave her an awkward smile, placed the candleholder on the table, and retreated.

The warm glow of the candle seemed to dispel the cold gloom filling the tent.

Changning, always a heavy sleeper, was bundled in a crimson cloak with only her chubby little face visible. Sensing the light, she turned away from it, smacked her lips a few times, and her breathing grew deep again.

Changyu looked at Xie Zheng. He had always looked good even in simple cloth garments, but now, dressed in an embroidered brocade robe, his noble bearing was unmistakable—though the bruise near his eye was rather conspicuous.

She had completely calmed down by now and had carefully weighed the pros and cons. Knowing he was after all a Marquis, and that the punch she'd thrown in her anger and distress had been inappropriate, she pursed her lips and said, "I'm sorry for hitting you like this."

Xie Zheng raised his eyebrows slightly in surprise. "Compared to the last time you hit me, this should count as light."

Fan Changyu naturally knew he was referring to when he was forcibly conscripted and taken away. She repeated, "I'm sorry."

Xie Zheng had only been half-joking when he said that. Hearing her apology, his brows furrowed. "Why keep apologizing to me? That time I really was a bastard."

His dark eyes locked onto her, the casual expression masking something like a vicious dog that had retracted its fangs. "I've read many books of sages and understand propriety and shame. But with you, sometimes I just can't control wanting to do bastardly things."

There was even a hint of self-loathing in his words.

Fan Changyu instinctively glared at him fiercely. After two beats of silence, she softened her tone. "Yan... Marquis, let's talk."

Hearing her change in how she addressed him, Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids, his gaze deepening. "Alright. Drink the ginger soup first."

He handed her the bowl.

Fan Changyu took it and downed it in one go. The bowl of ginger soup indeed warmed her entire stomach.

Only then did Xie Zheng speak. "Deceiving you wasn't my intention originally. I was being hunted and ended up in Qingping County, where you happened to save me. Telling you my true identity would have brought disaster, so I kept hiding it."

Fan Changyu said, "I don't blame the Marquis for hiding it back then."

Her sudden display of being extremely reasonable inexplicably made Xie Zheng feel uneasy.

Chapter 86

The tent flap wasn't fastened properly, letting in a cold gust that made the lone candle on the table flicker precariously, casting shifting shadows across the interior.

Xie Zheng tapped his fingers restlessly against the table, his handsome face carved into alternating light and shadow by the wavering candlelight, his eyes growing increasingly inscrutable. "Are you blaming me for keeping this from you?" he asked.

Fan Changyu was about to respond when the candle suddenly went out, plunging the entire tent into darkness.

Her intended words became: "Let me relight the candle first."

As she rose, a hand caught her wrist—not too tight, but firm enough that she couldn't easily break free.

Xie Zheng's deep voice sounded in the darkness: "I once told you about a formidable enemy of mine. The last time I nearly died by his hand was because of a traitor in the army. If I'd rashly involved you and your sister, he might have targeted you. The more people who knew, the greater the danger. That's why, when you mistook me for an ordinary soldier in the mountains, I went along with it."

He paused briefly before continuing, "There's something else I must apologize for. When your sister was kidnapped by the rebels, it was because they mistook her for a member of my family."

Fan Changyu had already guessed from Xie Qi's earlier remarks that Changning's kidnapping was related to Xie Zheng, but hearing it confirmed still stunned her momentarily.

Outside, the light from tripod braziers with makeshift rain covers cast enough illumination to vaguely discern shapes within the tent.

Reading her expression clearly, Xie Zheng said, "You know the man who took Changning—he was the rebel who impersonated grain-collecting officers and incited the rioters to besiege the city. He's Sui Yuanqing, heir to the Prince of Changxin."

This revelation truly shocked Fan Changyu—that scoundrel was actually a rebel prince!

Her wide almond eyes resembled amber as they turned toward Xie Zheng, whose gaze darkened slightly in response.

She asked, "Was the wound on your chest from rescuing Changning? Did he do that?"

Xie Zheng frowned slightly, reluctant to admit he'd been injured by Sui Yuanqing and had been bedridden for days. Releasing her wrist, he said, "I captured him alive."

Initially, after hearing Xie Qi's account, Fan Changyu had blamed herself for Changning's ordeal, thinking it resulted from her close association with Xie Zheng. Now understanding the full sequence of events left her with even more complicated feelings.

If not for protecting Qingping County—if she hadn't crossed that scoundrel—he wouldn't have come seeking revenge at her home. Had he not come, he wouldn't have seen that portrait. Without seeing the portrait, he wouldn't have recognized Yan Zheng, nor kidnapped Changning to threaten him.

But there were no what-ifs. Even given another chance, she'd probably still choose to protect Qingping County by apprehending the rebel—though this time she'd make sure to finish him off cleanly with one stroke.

After a moment's silence to collect herself, Fan Changyu said, "Changning's kidnapping wasn't entirely your fault—I share the blame too. And after you risked your life to save her, you owe me no apologies. As for deceiving me in the mountains..."

She paused briefly before continuing, "You were looking out for us sisters. I can't fault you for that."

Her uncharacteristic calmness only deepened the restlessness between Xie Zheng's brows. He could vaguely guess what she was about to say next, and merely the thought of it made the dark turmoil in his chest nearly unbearable.

He pressed a hand to his forehead, forcing down the agitation. "When you said we should talk, were you planning to bring up parting ways again?"

Fan Changyu was momentarily taken aback. In her mind, they hadn't discussed it that many times. Besides, his sham marriage had been agreed upon beforehand.

She answered honestly, "We were never actually together, so it wouldn't count as parting ways."

The moment the words left her lips, she felt the air around him turn sharply hostile. Her heart inexplicably skipped a beat.

Xie Zheng slowly lifted his gaze. "Never together?" he asked.

Meeting his intense stare, Changyu's eyes remained gentle but firm. "If you're referring to our time in Qingping County, that was based on our prior agreement when you entered a sham marriage with me. Moreover, you used a false name—Yan Zheng doesn't even exist in this world. That marriage certificate holds no weight, so it doesn't count as being together."

Xie Zheng didn't look at her again. When he lowered his eyes, his dark lashes resembled the folded wings of a crow. "Then why did you come looking for me? Why ask me to go back with you? And why take it upon yourself to fight in my stead?"

The smile that curled his lips was icy.

Changyu watched him, her gaze softening gradually. Yet behind that gentleness, there seemed to be something far stronger supporting her. "Because back then, you were Yan Zheng," she said.

A rare trace of confusion flickered in Xie Zheng's usually cold and arrogant eyes. His voice was hoarse. "But wasn't that still me?"

Changyu replied, "The person hasn't changed, but everything you represent has. When you were Yan Zheng, you were just yourself. But as the Wu'an Marquis, you're more than just you—you're the great hero admired by all, the only son of General Xie. The kind of woman worthy of the Marquis should be gentle, virtuous, and skilled in household management, just as you once described. I'm not well-educated; I only know a few characters. I haven't even finished reading the Four Books, let alone mastered music, chess, calligraphy, or painting. Naturally, I'm not fit to be your official wife. But my parents raised me with care, and I won't demean myself by becoming someone's concubine."

Xie Zheng's dark eyes bore into her. "How do you know I wouldn't be willing to marry you as my wife?"

Changyu was stunned by his words.

Was he joking? The illustrious Wu'an Marquis marrying a butcher's daughter—wouldn't that make the entire world laugh?

Flustered, she said, "Don't talk nonsense..."

Xie Zheng cut her off coldly. "You think this is nonsense?"

Changyu frowned. "At most, lower-ranking families might marry their daughters off to impoverished scholars. But have you ever seen a princess of the court wed a poor scholar? Even the least fortunate princess marries the top scholar. I didn't know your identity before, but now that I do, how can I take those past words seriously?"

She still had some self-awareness.

Hearing her compare herself to a princess made a vein throb at Xie Zheng's temple. His laughter was laced with anger. "Who a princess marries is decided by the emperor. Who this Marquis marries is decided by this Marquis himself."

He looked down at Changyu. "What does it matter if I'm the Wu'an Marquis? It's not like I've grown three heads and six arms to devour you whole. Why would that frighten you so much?"

Fan Changyu was somewhat unsettled by his words. After a long pause, she said, "Let me tell you a story. When I was little, there was a Tofu girl in our town. Although she was widowed young, she was hardworking and managed to make a decent living by herself at her tofu stall. Plus, she was quite beautiful, so many widowers sent matchmakers to propose, but she didn't fancy any of them. Later, a young master from a wealthy family in the county visited Lin'an Town with friends and saw her. He became utterly infatuated, returning every few days to buy tofu from her. Over time, they grew close. The young master wasn't some frivolous playboy—he always treated her with respect and even told his family he wanted to marry her."

Xie Zheng could probably guess how this story would end and said coldly, "Don't compare me to others."

Fan Changyu didn't respond to that and simply continued, "The wealthy family would never agree to their son marrying a widow. The old madam and the matriarch were so furious they fell ill. They locked the young master up and even hired thugs to smash the Tofu girl's stall. During that

time, the whole town was buzzing with gossip about her. Everyone thought she and the young master were done for, but then he went on a hunger strike to force his family's hand. In the end, they reluctantly agreed to the marriage—but only as a concubine. The Tofu girl, already remarried and now entering a wealthy household, didn't expect to be the main wife. She just wanted the young master to treat her well. On the wedding day, even though it was just a concubine's ceremony, the pomp and fanfare rivaled that of a proper wedding."

"People in town said the Tofu girl was lucky to live a life of comfort. In the years that followed, whenever she returned to town, she was dressed in fine clothes, but she grew thinner with each passing year. The only constant was that some still envied her, while others whispered vile gossip behind her back—calling her vulgar and shallow, not a proper woman, saying she'd flirted around after her husband's death and seduced the young master to marry into wealth. By the third year, she was driven out of the wealthy household. Luckily, she had been a commoner—if she'd been of servile status, the family would've sold her off."

Xie Zheng's expression turned icy. "That man simply changed his mind."

Fan Changyu said, "I used to think the same. But my mother told me that people from different paths, even if they come together for a time, will inevitably part ways. It's like someone choosing a rough stone among gold and jewels—the world pities him for it, while the chosen stone is both envied and deemed unworthy. But no one realizes that the one who chose the stone can always pick gold again, while the stone has no choice left. That's what happened to the Tofu girl. When the young master loved her, she was better than any noble lady. When he stopped loving her, she was no different from any tavern girl or tea seller."

Xie Zheng said coldly, "That man lacked resolve. If I decide what I want, I'll cling to it even in the grave."

As he spoke, his dark eyes fixed unwaveringly on Fan Changyu. Beneath that calm gaze lay a fierceness that made one's heart tremble.

Fan Changyu's heart skipped a beat unconsciously, but recalling the words her mother had once told her, her gaze grew firm and clear again: "My mother also said that what led them to this point wasn't just those things. A person can never escape their past. The fact that the Tofu Girl was once a widow would follow her for life. Disliked by the mistress of the house, she would face all kinds of scrutiny and disdain within the

household. The rules and etiquette of a wealthy family weren't something she could learn overnight. Oppressed by her mother-in-law, mocked by sisters-in-law, even servants could look down on her. The pervasive inferiority caused by those voices and status differences eroded the Tofu Girl every moment."

"The only thing she could rely on was the young master's kindness toward her, but everyone said she wasn't good enough. Hearing such words once or twice might not shake one's resolve, but after years of such whispers in her ears, it was inevitable that she'd be influenced subtly. The flaws she once overlooked suddenly became glaringly obvious. The young master was born into wealth—while he was beginning his studies, the Tofu Girl might have been helping her mother with chores at home; while he was toasting with friends, she was probably bent over making tofu."

"The young master lived for romance; the Tofu Girl lived for survival. The young master didn't think it was a big deal for the Tofu Girl to prepare simple meals—after all, his household was full of servants. The Tofu Girl couldn't appreciate the young master's refined taste for poetry and painting. They were never the same kind of people—how could they truly understand each other's thoughts? What they believed to be their most precious offerings meant nothing to the other. Small conflicts accumulated over time, until one day they looked back and found an insurmountable chasm between them."

At this point, Fan Changyu finally raised her eyes to meet Xie Zheng's gaze: "The Marquis is an Unrivaled Hero. Only the daughters of nobles and high officials are worthy matches for you. If you married a butcher like me, the whole world would laugh at you."

Xie Zheng listened as she spun this story to gently reject him, and when she suggested he marry some noble's daughter instead, he laughed in cold anger: "Who cares what the world thinks about whom I marry?"

Fan Changyu remained silent for a long while before speaking again: "I thought... after all I've said, you would understand what I mean."

Her fingers tightened unconsciously, her chest feeling strangely heavy and uncomfortable. For a fleeting moment, she even thought—if only he were just Yan Zheng.

Across the table, the two gazed at each other through the thin veil of night, until Xie Zheng broke the silence: "Did you think everything I told you before was also a lie?"

Fan Changyu froze, not yet grasping his meaning, when he continued: "I told you long ago—there's no one left in my family. Only me remains."

His expression was even somewhat cold as he spoke, as if he were extremely reluctant to mention anything about his family.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and replied: "I never thought those words were lies."

Xie Zheng smiled, his expression inscrutable—both defiant and seemingly wounded, yet ultimately suppressed by his pride. "The story you mentioned doesn't fit us. The Xie family still has a few collateral branches. If you marry into our household, they'd be the ones scrambling to curry your favor. There won't be any fools like in your story who'd mock or trouble you. If you can't even be bothered to listen to their flattery, you don't have to see them at all. After we quell the rebels and I take Wei Yan's head, I'll request to be stationed at the western frontier. You'll come with me to the fief. We won't return to the capital for at least a decade. The noblewomen you'd need to interact with there could be counted on one hand. Avoiding them this way, you'd hardly ever cross paths with them in this lifetime."

"You fear the world's ridicule, thinking I have other choices. Then I'll ask His Majesty to bestow the marriage. As long as I don't plot rebellion in this lifetime, I'll have no choice but to remain devoted to you alone. No one in this world would dare oppose this union."

"As for your concerns about shared interests—when I'm free, I either practice martial arts or study. You have remarkable talent in martial arts and often pore over books. It seems our interests align well enough; there's no unbridgeable gap."

Here, he finally paused. His clear, striking eyes reflected the young woman's image as he said slowly, "Fan Changyu, if I were to marry you, would you be willing to marry me?"

Perhaps from the moment he realized his feelings, he had been planning for this future. Now, asking this question, he felt neither untimely nor presumptuous—only waiting in this silence for the answer that would settle everything.

Chapter 87

Fan Changyu hadn't expected Xie Zheng to say such words. It was impossible not to be moved deep down, yet she clearly realized that once she nodded in agreement, her future life might no longer be hers to decide.

Just as he, as the Wu'an Marquis, had to shoulder those responsibilities and bear those missions, becoming his Marchioness would mean carrying the burdens behind the title of First-rank titled woman.

What he needed was a wife who could walk shoulder-to-shoulder with him, not someone who required constant accommodation to move forward together.

A sparrow adorned with Phoenix feathers still wouldn't become a Phoenix. Only by undergoing Nirvana oneself could one grow genuine Phoenix plumes.

The sound of rain outside the tent seemed to lessen. Water accumulated on the tent roof dripped into puddles at the edges with audible "plinks," unusually distinct in the silence.

Changyu clenched her hands resting on her knees and finally looked up at Xie Zheng.

With just one glance, Xie Zheng understood the answer she meant to give. Whether it was his innate pride acting up or his unwillingness to hear her rejection spoken aloud, he suddenly said, "No need to give me your answer."

At that moment, Xie Qi's voice came from outside: "Marquis, Gongsun is urging you to come."

Xie Zheng bid farewell and left by lifting the tent flap.

After his departure, Changyu stared blankly at the gently swaying tent entrance for a long while.

Xie Qi had kept his distance after Xie Zheng entered the tent. When he came to deliver the message and found the lights inside extinguished, his

heart skipped a beat, fearing he might have interrupted something important.

But Xie Zheng emerged almost immediately, his expression unreadable yet clearly displeased. Realizing his assumption might be wrong, Xie Qi dared not ask questions, following silently behind with bated breath.

Unexpectedly, Xie Zheng suddenly stopped and asked, "I recall you have a younger sister?"

Xie Qi didn't understand why his lord would ask this. His expression darkened as he answered, "Yes."

Orphaned young, he and his sister had been sold to human traffickers. To maximize profits, traffickers typically sold pretty girls to brothels and boys to the palace.

Some noble families training Martial Assassins also selected children from traffickers. He had been bought by Wei Yan. Among ten children of similar age, only one would become a Martial Assassin—the unlucky ones died, while survivors became household slaves.

During the final chaotic fight, he had been stabbed multiple times, beyond saving. He should have been wrapped in a straw mat and left for wild wolves, but he desperately wanted to live. Despite his untreated wounds, he clung to life until the next day.

At that time, the Marquis was still a youth, already working for Wei Yan but only getting what Wei Xuan rejected—from objects to servants.

Wei Xuan chose the victorious Martial Assassin as his personal attendant. The Marquis walked through the dark dungeon, passing over those with minor injuries who could become Wei Mansion slaves, and instead selected him.

The steward warned he might not survive—enduring such severe injuries overnight was rare.

The Marquis said, "He's fought so hard to live. What a waste if he died."

So he was taken out, treated by physicians, and upon recovery became the Marquis's personal attendant, given the name Xie Qi.

From that moment, his loyalty belonged solely to Xie Zheng. Later, he even killed Wei Xuan's Martial Assassin-turned-attendant for Xie Zheng.

As for his sister, by the time he found her, she had already become a well-known courtesan in a small-town brothel.

Given his current status, he didn't dare openly acknowledge her, fearing she might be endangered—he'd seen too many cases where family members were kidnapped as leverage.

He secretly provided her with money and pressured the madam to let her buy her freedom. Now she runs an embroidery shop.

Xie Zheng asked, "When your sister got married, there was a wealthy admirer. Why did she still marry a blacksmith?"

This happened after Xie Qi's sister gained her freedom. When Xie Qi learned of her marriage, he couldn't openly attend the wedding, only requesting leave from Xie Zheng to secretly observe the ceremony.

The wealthy admirer was present that day. Xie Qi and several close comrades like Xie Wu kept watch from the shadows, ready to drag him into an alley for a beating if he caused trouble.

Unexpectedly, the man simply drank himself into a stupor at the banquet.

They'd discussed this incident upon returning, and Xie Zheng must have heard about it. His sudden mention of it now puzzled Xie Qi, who simply replied, "As her brother, I see no issue with her marrying a blacksmith."

Xie Zheng paused and glanced sideways. "Why?"

Xie Qi answered, "My sister doesn't know I'm alive or that I've found her. If the blacksmith mistreats her, she can support herself with the embroidery shop and divorce him easily. The neighbors would help if needed. Had she married that wealthy man, she'd be alone against his entire clan. With their power, seeking justice would be impossible."

This was another Tofu girl story—except this Tofu girl didn't choose the noble suitor.

Xie Zheng looked thoughtful but said nothing more, proceeding toward the central military tent.

The personal guards at the entrance spotted him and called out, "Marquis!"

As Xie Zheng approached, they lifted the tent flap. Inside, the brightly lit space revealed an elderly man seated below the head position. Xie Zheng's

expression shifted slightly in surprise as he greeted, "Teacher."

Grand Tutor Tao observed his prized student, stroking his beard. "I heard you pursued the enemy. Any success?"

He noticed the bruise near Xie Zheng's eye, assuming it was a battlefield injury, though the angle seemed unusually precise.

If a fist could reach his face, a blade might have cost him the eye. In that light, it was fortunate.

Gongsun Yin also spotted the bruise—the first time he'd seen Xie Zheng return from battle with such an injury. Strangely, it reminded him of the bruise he'd seen on Xie Zheng's face back in Lucheng.

The resemblance grew more striking the longer he looked, leaving Gongsun Yin with an odd expression.

Could Fan Changyu have struck him again?

But he'd just returned from battle—that shouldn't be possible...

Ignoring their scrutiny, Xie Zheng took his seat at the head of the tent with composed dignity. "Shi Yue's head has been taken."

Grand Tutor Tao nodded approvingly, then asked with satisfaction, "Shi Yue had a formidable general under him—reportedly his brother, Shi Hu. Exceptionally large and inhumanly strong. I witnessed him fighting Jizhou troops below the mountains—a tough opponent. Did you kill them both single-handedly?"

Xie Zheng immediately frowned. "I led five hundred cavalymen, taking a shortcut over the mountains to pursue them. We only intercepted and killed Shi Yue, but didn't encounter his brother."

Gongsun Yin expressed surprise: "Vanguard Ge Daqing is one of the Marquis's top fierce generals. Even he was severely wounded by Shi Hu. Since the Marquis didn't engage Shi Hu personally, who else in our army could have subdued that bandit?"

The vanguard and Left Guard Battalion suffered heavy casualties in this battle. Nearly all the officers were too severely wounded to leave their beds, and the Army Doctor had to go from one to another to dress their wounds.

Xie Zheng asked: "Didn't the battle report mention how many enemies the Left Guard Battalion killed? How many enemy officers were slain?"

Gongsun Yin picked up the battle report beside him and handed it over, saying: "Neither the vanguard nor the Left Guard Battalion mentioned killing Shi Hu. But Shi Hu is indeed dead, so the Grand Tutor and I assumed it was you who killed him."

Xie Zheng said: "Shi Hu did not die by my hand."

Xie Wu, who had just entered with tea, hesitated before speaking up: "Shi Hu was killed by Madam."

At these words, all three men in the tent turned to look at Xie Wu.

Gongsun Yin, unaware that Fan Changyu had secretly joined the battle, was both shocked and puzzled: "She was on the mountain. How did she kill Shi Hu?"

Xie Wu stole a glance at Xie Zheng and chose his words carefully: "Madam didn't know the Marquis's identity at first. Fearing something might happen to him in battle, she drugged the Marquis and infiltrated the Left Guard Battalion. I couldn't stop her, and fearing for her safety, I followed. The officers of the Left Guard Battalion fought Shi Hu but were all defeated, and morale collapsed. When Madam confronted Shi Hu, she had no suitable weapon. After several fierce exchanges, she wrested the spiked hammer from Shi Hu's hands and killed him with three blows."

Xie Wu had wanted to tell Xie Zheng about this feat on the road, fearing his anger at Changyu for going to battle without permission, but hadn't found the right moment.

Gongsun Yin was so astonished by Fan Changyu's achievement that he was speechless for a long time, even forgetting to laugh at the rare embarrassment of Xie Zheng being drugged.

After a long pause, he murmured: "Hunting a black bear could be attributed to the bear's lack of intelligence despite its brute strength. But Shi Hu... he had more than just brute strength. Vanguard Ge Daqing had the courage to hunt tigers and bears, with years of battlefield experience, yet still couldn't defeat him. And Miss Fan managed to take his weapon and kill him with three hammer blows?"

Gongsun Yin drew a sharp breath and looked at Xie Zheng: "In all the world, I thought only the Marquis possessed such valor."

Xie Zheng leaned back in his chair, frowning in silence, lost in thought.

When Grand Tutor Tao heard Xie Wu say that Madam had killed Shi Hu, he began to wonder, thinking to himself that this rascal really didn't remember his teacher at all—getting married was such a big event, yet he hadn't been informed.

Then hearing Xie Wu mention that Madam didn't know Xie Zheng's identity and went to battle in his stead only confused him further. Now, hearing Gongsun Yin refer to the woman as "Miss Fan," he thought: Could it really be such a coincidence? Is it Fan Changyu?

He raised his aged eyes to Xie Zheng: "When did you get married? You didn't even send word to this old man."

Gongsun Yin, who had deliberately kept Grand Tutor Tao in the dark about Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng's relationship, watched the two with amusement despite his surprise, waiting for Xie Zheng to explain the whole story himself.

But Xie Zheng said: "It's a long story. I was in dire straits at the time, and the wedding was very simple. When we hold a proper ceremony later, I'll definitely invite you to be our witness."

Grand Tutor Tao was well aware that Xie Zheng's marriage could potentially lead to a reshuffling of the major factions in court. Recalling Xie Wu's mention of the woman who had killed Shi Hu, he narrowed his eyes slightly and asked, "Is she from a military family?"

Xie Zheng paused briefly before replying, "No."

Grand Tutor Tao then said, "She must be a good girl regardless. Treat her well."

Xie Zheng thought of Fan Changyu's words rejecting him, his heart heavy, and simply responded with an affirmative.

Grand Tutor Tao shifted the conversation to the current situation: "With Shi Yue dead, Changxin Wang has lost a right arm. The Chongzhou army at the foot of the mountain has either perished, fled, or been captured and reorganized into our ranks. You can now march south directly to besiege Chongzhou and join forces with He Jingyuan's troops to attack the city together. But will the court allow you to end this war so quickly?"

The stalemate in Chongzhou had persisted precisely because of the infighting in the court.

Initially, Wei Yan had schemed to have Xie Zheng die on the Chongzhou battlefield. Now, the delayed military pay and provisions from the court for several months clearly indicated that someone didn't want the war to end quickly.

Weapons, provisions, and military pay—all required silver. As long as the war dragged on at the frontlines, those in the court had the perfect excuse to demand funds from the Ministry of Revenue.

As for how much of those allocated funds actually reached their intended purpose, that depended on whether the corrupt officials skimming off each layer still had any conscience left.

Both the Ministry of War and the Ministry of Revenue were under Wei Yan's control. Even if the emperor ordered an audit, the records would only show that the funds, provisions, and weapons had all been delivered to Xie Zheng's hands. If the rebels still weren't quashed despite sufficient supplies, it would be Xie Zheng's incompetence to blame.

Xie Zheng mocked, "Wei Yan is trying to cover up the mess Wei Xuan caused in the northwest. Right now, he probably wants me to hand over the military merits of crushing the Chongzhou rebels."

Grand Tutor Tao lowered his eyelids slightly. "In my opinion, this isn't necessarily a bad thing."

Gongsun Yin asked, puzzled, "Why do you say that, Grand Tutor?"

Grand Tutor Tao countered, "Who else in Great Yin has been enfeoffed as a marquis before the age of twenty? The moon wanes when full; water overflows when brimming. With your Marquis's achievements in suppressing the rebels, what else could the emperor reward him with upon his return to the capital? Right now, the Wei Faction is at its zenith. The emperor naturally hopes for him and Wei Yan to fight to the death. Once Wei Yan falls, who's next?"

Gongsun Yin said, "I understand what you're saying, Grand Tutor. But even if the Marquis wishes to retreat now, he's already entangled in the capital's power struggles—there's no stepping back."

Grand Tutor Tao chuckled. "Ah, youth—"

Gongsun Yin sensed there was more to his words. "I'd like to hear your insight, Grand Tutor."

Grand Tutor Tao said, "Retreat to what extent? Just enough so that after Wei Yan's downfall, the emperor's next target isn't your Marquis."

Gongsun Yin immediately grasped his meaning. "You mean, let the Li family and Wei Yan fight first?"

He thought of Li Huaian, grandson of Grand Tutor Li, who was currently temporarily replacing He Jingyuan in Jizhou, and was struck by the realization. He looked up at Grand Tutor Tao.

Grand Tutor Tao knew what he was thinking. "Even without your Marquis, Wei Yan still controls the Ministry of War and He Jingyuan. Grand Tutor Li has no military power, which is why he hasn't dared to confront Wei Yan head-on all these years."

The Li family's presence in the northwest clearly signaled their intent to seize military authority.

All Xie Zheng needed to do was toss out the fat prize of the military merits for suppressing the rebels, and both the Li and Wei factions would pounce on it like hyenas fighting over carrion.

Wei Yan was forced to fight because he had been pushed to the brink. If he didn't fight, these powers would fall into others' hands and become weapons against him.

Xie Zheng could withhold the military merits, but winning this battle while Wei Yan cut off all military supplies would surely leave him severely weakened. Exchanging this for a meager official reward from the emperor and putting himself in the spotlight was hardly worth it.

The Li family wanted military power, yet after arriving in the northwest, they remained inactive—as if they had calculated that Xie Zheng, after weighing the pros and cons, would relinquish the military merits.

For Wei Yan to seize these merits, he could only rely on He Jingyuan. But now, Li Huaian was managing Jizhou on He Jingyuan's behalf, with full access to all accounts and records. If he found even a minor fault, given the young emperor's current reliance on the Li family, wresting power from He Jingyuan wouldn't be difficult.

Xie Zheng, who had remained silent until now, suddenly spoke: "If that's the case, Changxin Wang's rebellion seems tailor-made to deliver military power to the Li family."

At these words, both Gongsun Yin and Grand Tutor Tao were startled.

Grand Tutor Tao said, "The Li family couldn't have schemed to manipulate Changxin Wang to such an extent."

Gongsun Yin added, "I heard Changxin Wang's consort also perished in the fire at the Eastern Palace back then, and his eldest son was burned beyond recognition. After years of biding his time, his hatred for the court is undoubtedly genuine."

But Xie Zheng's eyes darkened slightly. The Crown Prince's heir had ties to Changxin Prince Manor, Yu Qianqian's son bore some resemblance to the late emperor, and Chengde Crown Prince had also resembled the late emperor in his time. Moreover, when Changning was captured by Sui Yuanqing, she had seen Yu Bao'er at Changxin Prince Manor.

Something was becoming clear. He turned to Gongsun Yin: "After we descend the mountain, send word back to the capital to secretly investigate the Eastern Palace fire from back then."

Gongsun Yin was puzzled. "Why suddenly investigate the Eastern Palace fire now?"

Xie Zheng gave a faint smile. "I suspect the Crown Prince's heir is at Changxin Prince Manor."

This statement shocked Gongsun Yin and Grand Tutor Tao even more. But for now, it was merely speculation—evidence was needed to confirm it.

Outside the tent, the night watch sounded, marking the passing of midnight. Xie Zheng dismissed Grand Tutor Tao and Gongsun Yin to rest.

But Grand Tutor Tao lingered. Gongsun Yin assumed the teacher and student had private matters to discuss and yawned his way back to his quarters.

The bond between Xie Zheng and Grand Tutor Tao ran deep—a single glance conveyed unspoken understanding. Xie Zheng asked, "Did you have something to ask me, Teacher?"

Grand Tutor Tao said, "With Gongsun present earlier, I couldn't pry into personal matters. This marriage of yours—is it a proper wife or a concubine?"

Xie Zheng replied, "A wife."

Grand Tutor Tao was momentarily taken aback, then said, "You're already twenty-one. Most men your age have children old enough to run

around, yet you've remained alone. It's good you can marry as you wish now, but you seem troubled. Why is that?"

Xie Zheng's long delay in marrying stemmed from his identity as a Xie—yet raised by Wei Yan.

Though the Xie family was a centuries-old clan, the larger the family, the more idle hands it bred. By his father's generation, the Xie family had already declined. Their branch alone had his father upholding the family's legacy, while the collateral branches had no capable successors.

Great families feared nothing more than having no heir. Thus, when his father died in battle and his mother followed in death, he was taken away by Wei Yan—and none of the collateral relatives dared speak up.

In a way, Xie Zheng being taken away by Wei Yan was a good thing. Had he stayed with the Xie family, he would likely have been raised into mediocrity.

Though Wei Yan treated him harshly, for the sake of his father's prestige and old subordinates in the military, he spared no effort in grooming Xie Zheng, turning him into the sharpest blade in all of Great Yin.

When ordinary young men reached marriageable age, female elders in their families would typically arrange matches with suitable young ladies. But Xie Zheng was raised in the Wei household. Since Wei Yan did not take the initiative to arrange a marriage for him, the Xie family dared not overstep Wei Yan and directly propose matches for him.

They did, however, entertain foolish schemes—attempting to push some cousin or distant relative's daughter toward him. This self-degrading behavior not only earned Xie Zheng prolonged mockery from Wei Xuan but also Wei Yan's disdain for the Xie clan.

Later, when Xie Zheng joined the military, the matter of marriage was further delayed.

By the time he had achieved merit and distinction, his marriage had become a matter of alliance between two families, rather than simply taking a wife.

The Qingliu faction dared not marry their daughters to him, while those aligned with Wei Yan were wary of him gaining influence through his wife's family, making him harder to control. Naturally, subordinates dared not

offend Wei Yan, and neutral officials were even less willing to wade into such muddy waters.

The higher his status rose, the more complicated his marital prospects became.

Xie Zheng confided in Grand Tutor Tao about his relationship with Fan Changyu: "She saved me when I was in dire straits. I had no choice but to conceal my identity from her. Now that she knows everything, she is wary of my status and has no desire to marry into a noble family."

Grand Tutor Tao listened and praised, "She sounds like a sensible woman."

Xie Zheng knelt before Grand Tutor Tao, bowing deeply. "I have a request to make of my teacher."

Grand Tutor Tao narrowed his eyes. "Does it concern that woman?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Yes."

Grand Tutor Tao said, "If she refuses to marry you, what can an old man like me do?"

Xie Zheng raised his head. "I implore you, Teacher, to take her as your adopted daughter."

Grand Tutor Tao instantly grasped his meaning. "You want to give her a respectable family background? To silence the gossips?"

Xie Zheng remained silent, tacitly acknowledging it.

Grand Tutor Tao shifted the topic. "And what if the girl still refuses and only wishes to live an ordinary life?"

The young man kneeling on the ground pressed his lips tightly together before finally answering, "I will pave every path for her. If she is willing to walk it with me, I will not let her stumble. If she still refuses... then let fate end here."

Grand Tutor Tao sighed. "Rise. It just so happens this old man has no children of his own. Taking in an adopted daughter would give me something to look forward to in my later years. But you must also do me a favor."

Xie Zheng said, "Please speak, Teacher."

Grand Tutor Tao, still thinking of Fan Changyu, said, "Do you have any promising young men under your command? On my journey, I met a divorced young woman and promised an elder of hers to find her a good husband."

He paused before adding, "He must be honest and broad-minded—the girl has been divorced, so the young man must not mind that. She is sincere at heart; if she ends up with someone cunning, she'll be taken advantage of. His military rank need not be too high—she isn't versed in the ways of noblewomen."

Xie Zheng found these traits somewhat familiar, but since Grand Tutor Tao mentioned the woman was divorced and that he had promised her elder to find her a husband—Fan Changyu had no elders who knew Grand Tutor Tao—he dismissed the thought and agreed without further suspicion.

Chapter 88

The long-separated teacher and student talked by candlelight late into the night. When Xie Zheng insisted on personally seeing Grand Tutor Tao back to his quarters, the old man waved him off: "Enough of this formality between us. You should rest too—this old man can find his own way back."

Xie Zheng then instructed Xie Qi to escort Tao Taifu instead. After a pause, he added, "If she knew I asked you to adopt her as your goddaughter, she might refuse out of pride. Tomorrow when we break camp, I'll arrange for her to ride down the mountain in your carriage. She respects learned scholars greatly—if you could guide her in some reading during the journey and persuade her to accept you as her godfather..."

Tao Taifu raised his aged eyelids at such meticulous planning and asked, "Is she worth all this trouble?"

Standing at the tent entrance where candlelight cast his handsome profile into shadow, Xie Zheng answered firmly, "She is."

With a chuckle, Tao Taifu conceded, "Very well, as you wish." Then inquired, "What's the girl's name and birth details? Since I'm adopting her, this old man should give her a courtesy name."

"Her surname is Fan, named Changyu. Sixteen this year, born around the first month of Qingli Year Two," Xie Zheng replied, though he didn't know Changyu's exact birthday—she'd declined to share it when asked in Qingping County.

Tao Taifu's expression underwent remarkable contortions. So this was why Gongsun Yin had claimed to recognize Fan Changyu yet refused to elaborate—the trap had been set here all along!

Noticing his teacher's odd reaction, Xie Zheng frowned. "Is something wrong?"

Tao Taifu regarded him with complex emotions. "The girl I met on the road was also named Fan Changyu."

Xie Zheng recalled Changyu mentioning an eccentric but erudite old man she'd encountered during dam construction—one who constantly

berated his students. His eyelids twitched violently.

Silence engulfed the command tent as teacher and student stared wordlessly at each other.

After a long pause, Xie Zheng ventured, "Teacher...were you detained by Jizhou's dam construction troops?"

The involuntary labor memories being distinctly unpleasant, Tao Taifu's mustache quivered with indignation as he counterattacked: "That girl told me her divorced husband had been a live-in son-in-law." Peering at Xie Zheng, he demanded, "Did you become her concubine-spouse during your exile?"

After a measured silence, Xie Zheng slowly affirmed, "Mn."

Tao Taifu shot his disciple an astonished look—he knew exactly how prideful this student was! When Xie Wu mentioned Fan Changyu killing Shi Hu, he'd instinctively suspected this connection. But how could Xie Zheng, of all people, agree to matrilocal marriage? Moreover, Shi Hu had been a formidable general who defeated all vanguard and left-flank commanders—how could a martial novice like Fan Changyu achieve such a feat?

Furthermore, Xie Zheng's description painted an intelligent, perceptive girl, whereas Tao Taifu remembered Fan Changyu as a stubbornly simple-minded lass. These discrepancies had convinced him they were different people sharing a surname—who could have imagined such cosmic coincidence!

Observing his usually brilliant disciple's uncharacteristic despondency, Tao Taifu cleared his throat while stroking his goatee. "In that case, we'll abandon plans to find her another suitor."

Xie Zheng glanced at Grand Tutor Tao, who clearly read a hint of "Do you really think I'd go looking for someone else?" in that look.

Xie Zheng said, "The matter of taking her as an adopted daughter will still require your assistance, Teacher."

Grand Tutor Tao shook his head with a sigh. "You might not believe it, but when I met that girl on the road, I thought she was promising material. Though she lacks a bit in cleverness, her temperament is generous and her will is firm. With some polishing, she could become something remarkable. I had intended to take her as my disciple, but she repeatedly refused."

Xie Zheng recalled how Fan Changyu had recently told him with a sympathetic expression that the eccentric old man was lonely and likely wanted to take her as a disciple so she could care for him in his old age. She was too preoccupied with finding Changning to spare the energy for a temperamental old man, hence her polite refusal—which had left the eccentric old man sulking for quite a while.

Now, hearing Grand Tutor Tao explain the reason, Xie Zheng felt a peculiar sensation in his heart.

Seeing his silence, Grand Tutor Tao added, "She wouldn't even agree to become my disciple back then. Now, asking her to recognize me as a foster father—this old man can't guarantee she'll agree."

Xie Zheng replied, "Do what we can, and leave the rest to fate."

Grand Tutor Tao sighed. "You two—just a pair of stubborn mules brought together!"

Xie Zheng remained silent.

After Grand Tutor Tao left, he stood alone with his hands behind his back, gazing absentmindedly at the dark night outside the tent.

The rain had stopped. In the distance, the orderly rows of military tents under the glow of campfires looked like small, dark mounds.

Xie Wu hesitantly approached and said, "Marquis, it's already the third watch of the night. You should rest."

Xie Zheng's thoughts were in turmoil, and he felt no trace of sleepiness. He ordered, "Go and reprimand the Left Guard Camp. The matter of her killing Shi Hu—keep it suppressed for now."

Xie Wu understood this was to protect Fan Changyu. If she didn't plan to stay in the army, spreading this news would only bring her trouble.

He immediately clasped his fists and said, "Understood."

After Xie Wu withdrew, Xie Zheng ordered someone to bring his warhorse. Without any attendants, he rode alone aimlessly around the camp. Unconsciously, he arrived outside Fan Changyu's tent. Sitting atop his horse, he quietly watched for a while before tugging the reins. His jet-black steed, its coat smooth as satin, turned and trotted into the deeper darkness of the night.

Inside the tent, Fan Changyu lay on the bed fully clothed, equally unable to sleep.

When the sound of hooves approached outside, she instinctively held her breath. The hoofbeats were light, as if deliberately slowed to avoid disturbing anyone.

After a long pause, the faint sound of hooves resumed, clearly moving away.

Who else would wander by her tent in the middle of the night just to check on her?

Realizing this, Fan Changyu felt a pang of complicated emotions. The events of the past few months flashed through her mind, making her even more unsettled.

Tossing and turning in an attempt to ease her restlessness, she nearly woke Changning. Rubbing her temples, she sat up and decided to go out for a walk as well.

She rose quietly, strapping a boning knife to her belt. As she stepped out of the tent, she noticed an unfamiliar soldier stationed near her quarters—seemingly on guard duty, though this area had never been patrolled at night before.

Fan Changyu's eyes met his. The soldier stared back dumbly, his gaze a mix of panic and admiration. After a moment, as if remembering his duty, he guiltily averted his eyes.

Fan Changyu guessed this was likely Xie Zheng's doing, and her emotions grew even more unsettled.

Familiar with the camp, she walked silently toward the outer perimeter of the encampment.

The personal guard had indeed been sent to protect Fan Changyu and her sister. Initially, Xie Wu and Xie Qi had been responsible for this task, but Fan Changyu had already grown familiar with them. If they were assigned to guard her, she would recognize them at a glance. Afraid she might be annoyed, Xie Zheng had instead dispatched a personal guard she hadn't met before.

By the latter half of the night, the moon emerged from the dissipating clouds.

The mountain ridges in the darkness seemed dusted with silver, making the surroundings visible even without torches.

Fan Changyu stepped on the rain-softened earth, following the sound of flowing water toward the riverbank.

The wilderness was vast, filled with the alternating chirps of grass insects and croaks of frogs. The post-rain air was indescribably fresh, and taking a deep breath eased some of the heaviness in her heart.

If not for the drenched grass, she would have liked to spread her arms and lie down, sinking into the soft greenery, letting the peace of the night calm the restless thoughts in her mind.

A rustling sound came from the grass nearby. Fan Changyu paused, looking closely—only to see a pitch-black warhorse tied to a shrub. Further ahead by the riverbank, faint splashing sounds could be heard.

Recognizing the warhorse, Fan Changyu was startled and turned to leave, but the person by the river had already noticed her.

"Who's there?"

The cold, deep voice was followed by several stones hurtling toward her like meteors. Fan Changyu quickly rolled aside, barely avoiding the projectiles that could have pierced straight through flesh.

As she pushed herself up from the ground, a sudden chill pressed against her neck—the man who had been by the river moments ago now stood before her, water dripping from his body, a steel blade pointed at her throat.

"It's you."

Only after recognizing her did the sharpness in Xie Zheng's eyes fade. He sheathed his blade, scrutinized her briefly, then extended a hand to help her up, frowning as he asked, "Are you hurt?"

Fan Changyu shook her head, refusing his hand as she sat up on her own. Yet inwardly, she marveled at his speed.

She had seen him kill before, but this was the first time she had witnessed his beast-like alertness.

Though the blade had been withdrawn, the skin on her neck still prickled with lingering tension. The sensation of having her life in another's hands, even for just a moment, had left her heart pounding.

Xie Zheng said, "I thought you were an enemy scout."

Dressed in a common soldier's uniform, her hair tied in a simple knot for convenience, she could easily be mistaken for someone else in the dark from a distance.

Fan Changyu thought that if she truly had been an enemy scout, even if she had dodged the stones, she wouldn't have escaped his blade.

Awkwardly, she explained her presence: "I couldn't sleep, so I came out for a walk to clear my mind. I happened to see your horse and assumed you were by the river, so I intended to leave."

Xie Zheng wore only military trousers, having just emerged from the river, water still dripping from his body. Unconcerned about the wet grass, he sat down directly. A few strands of his soaked hair had escaped his tied-up crown, clinging messily to his face and neck, lending him a youthful air.

Hearing Fan Changyu's words, he glanced up at her, seemingly surprised. "You couldn't sleep either?"

His collarbones appeared even more pronounced due to the way he sat with his arms propped behind him. Under the moonlight, his skin took on a pale, frosty hue. Water droplets from his damp hair fell onto his collarbones, tracing a path down his firm muscles before disappearing below his narrow waist...

Fan Changyu suddenly felt her face grow warm and quickly averted her gaze. Afraid he might misunderstand, she said, "I killed a lot of people today. It's weighing on my mind."

The word "also" in his statement made it clear he couldn't sleep either—hence his presence here.

As for why he couldn't sleep, the reason was obvious.

While his words had indeed unsettled her and robbed her of sleep, she had already given him a clear rejection. Admitting now that his words kept her awake would feel... strange.

Though the battlefield scenes were certainly another reason for her restlessness.

Xie Zheng recalled that time in Lin'an Town when she'd been so frightened after killing someone that she crept to his bedside at night. His gaze softened slightly.

He'd long known from Xie Wu that on the battlefield, she couldn't bring herself to deliver fatal blows to common soldiers—only striking non-lethal areas to disable them.

Despite such reverence for life, she'd still fought on the battlefield for him.

How could she dare?

His chest burned as if scalded, a voice in his mind screaming to pull her into his arms. His fingers dug deep into the muddy grass beneath him, yet he didn't dare overstep.

It felt like insects were burrowing through his veins, his bones trembling with restraint until he finally suppressed the roaring impulse in his chest. Forcing composure, he lowered his eyes and said, "After my first battle, I had nightmares all night too."

"The second time I fought, I killed even more than before. That night I didn't sleep—just trained at the drill grounds until exhausted. When I collapsed, I fell asleep instantly. No nightmares."

A cold sneer touched his lips as he recounted these old memories, unaware of the aura of violence rising around him.

Like a stray dog covered in wounds, instinctively baring its teeth at approaching footsteps, as if ferocity could prevent further harm.

Then a warm hand rested on his soaking hair, its heat penetrating the cold wet strands.

Xie Zheng raised his phoenix eyes—the silver moon reflected in them, along with Fan Changyu's sun-bright features.

Pressing her lips together, she gently patted his head as if comforting a child. "It's all in the past now," she said.

Chapter 89

The moonlight was soft, and the stream murmured.

Xie Zheng tilted his head slightly, watching Fan Changyu without a word for a long moment.

Fan Changyu met his gaze, freezing for an instant. Then, as if realizing the intimacy of her action, she awkwardly withdrew her hand and placed it on her lap.

The atmosphere between them grew a little delicate. Just as she was about to say she should leave, Xie Zheng suddenly spoke. "If you're still feeling down, I can spar a few rounds with you."

To just leave now, after she had subconsciously patted his head to comfort him, would be strange no matter how she looked at it.

Fan Changyu recalled his phantom-like speed from before and found that she did indeed have the urge to test her skills against his, so she nodded.

She had only brought a boning knife. Xie Zheng put his top back on but didn't even grab a weapon, preparing to fight bare-handed.

Feeling slighted, Fan Changyu pursed her lips and said, "You should at least grab a dagger."

Xie Zheng placed one hand behind his back and simply said to her, "Come."

This posture, as if giving her a one-hand advantage, made Fan Changyu's lips press together even more tightly. Without another word, her gaze instantly became as sharp as a hunting leopard, and she shot forward like an arrow released from its bow.

She used one hand to try and control Xie Zheng's single arm while her boning knife slashed straight for his neck. But upon closing in, she found Xie Zheng was as slippery as a fish. She wanted to grab his hand, but he always managed to evade her a step ahead, unhurried and with ease. As he sidestepped her dagger, a gust from his palm swept toward her face. Fan

Changyu quickly dodged, but his hand hooked her elbow and pulled it down and back. Her entire center of gravity was thrown off, and she nearly tumbled backward.

Xie Zheng changed the downward pull to a tug on her arm, preparing to pull her up, but a sudden coolness touched his neck.

He asked with a smile, "What's this? Repaying kindness with enmity?"

Fan Changyu pressed the boning knife against the side of his neck and said, "All's fair in war."

The smile on Xie Zheng's face brightened. He looked at her and said, "You have a point."

Fan Changyu gazed into his smiling dark eyes, then withdrew the knife and pursed her lips. "My skills are inferior to yours."

Noticing her dejection, Xie Zheng said, "Close-quarters combat relies on speed. You're used to heavy-handed weapons. When you switch to a lighter blade, you can't use your wide, sweeping moves. If I, after more than a decade of hard training, couldn't even beat you in the speed of drawing a knife, that would be what's truly unreasonable."

Fan Changyu thought of the move he had used to take her down and asked, "That move where you hooked my elbow and pulled down, what was that?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer. Instead, he once again hooked her elbow and pulled it down and back. Fan Changyu's body instantly tensed, but this time, her feet didn't move an inch.

Xie Zheng asked her, "Understand now?"

Fan Changyu recalled the moment she had almost fallen. His palm strike had forced her to dodge, so her body had been turned to the side, not standing firmly in place.

She frowned. "The key wasn't the pulling move?"

Xie Zheng nodded in approval. "Sometimes you don't need to use brute force. Go with the momentum, use their strength against them. A small force can deflect a great one."

Fan Changyu tightened her grip on the boning knife and said to him, "Again!"

The brief, restrained exchange had only just warmed up Fan Changyu's joints. Her strength was in fierce attacks, so she stopped trying to counter Xie Zheng's moves with finesse and simply went on the offensive. Each slash of her knife was sharper than the last. Though it was only a boning knife a little over three inches long, she somehow managed to swing it fast enough to leave afterimages.

Xie Zheng was somewhat surprised to see her play to her strengths, using offense as defense. A flicker of astonishment crossed his eyes. So she had been holding back earlier, merely probing his style of martial arts.

This realization brought a hint of a smile to his eyes, but he didn't go easy on her in his moves.

Only through this kind of real, practical sparring could Fan Changyu learn the fastest and improve her martial arts.

Having learned her lesson, Fan Changyu no longer tried to grab Xie Zheng's free hand. Her knife hand was for attacking, and her fisted hand was also for attacking. She struck again and again, trying to force Xie Zheng into a defensive position so he wouldn't have a chance to counterattack.

But this exchange lasted only a little longer than the previous one. After a few rounds, Xie Zheng once again circled behind her like a phantom. Following the momentum of her knife strike, he used the force to push her shoulder and back. Fan Changyu was sent flying a good distance, half-falling into the grassy field.

In a way, Fan Changyu was a martial arts fanatic.

She lifted her head, a small flame seeming to burn in her eyes as she shouted, "Again!"

Xie Zheng stood not far away, the night wind making his robes flutter. Against his cold, jade-like face, he had an air of immortal grace.

Like a little calf, Fan Changyu raised her knife and charged at him again.

In less than a moment, Xie Zheng smoothly deflected her knife-wielding arm, and she stumbled and plunged into the bushes once more.

The black horse grazing nearby, perhaps annoyed that she had crushed a patch of fresh grass, even nudged her with its head.

Fan Changyu clutched her boning knife and climbed up, spitting out the grass she had accidentally gotten in her mouth. She glared at Xie Zheng and roared, "Again!"

...

After being thrown for the umpteenth time, Fan Changyu's clothes, stained with grass juice and mud, were a complete mess. Her face was grimy, and a few blades of grass were stuck in her hair.

She lay flat on her back, gasping for air as she stared at the sky. Every muscle in her body ached so much that she didn't want to move a single finger, yet she felt utterly and thoroughly exhilarated.

Her mind was also empty, free of all distracting thoughts. She could truly fall asleep the moment she closed her eyes.

Xie Zheng took a water flask from his horse and handed it to her. "Have some water."

Fan Changyu had sweated a lot and was indeed terribly thirsty. She sat up. Perhaps from being thrown so many times, her head was a little dizzy. She took the flask and guzzled it down like an ox.

When she finished, she handed it back to Xie Zheng. He glanced at it, then tilted his head back and took several large gulps himself.

Fan Changyu stared blankly, her brain finally processing what had happened. That was Xie Zheng's water flask. She had drunk from it, and now he was drinking from it. What did this count as?

Before the embarrassment could fully set in, she remembered him kissing her on horseback on the way back. Fan Changyu subconsciously wiped her lips a few times with the back of her hand, and suddenly felt that sharing a water flask was no big deal.

The back of her hand was also covered in grassy mud, so this wipe only succeeded in smearing it onto her lips.

After drinking, Xie Zheng screwed the cap back on. Noticing her strange behavior, he asked, "What's wrong?"

Fan Changyu said awkwardly, "There's dirt on my face. I'm going to wash up."

With that, she got up and walked toward the river.

Xie Zheng's voice came from behind her. "You're covered in mud. Do you want to wash your clothes too?"

Fan Changyu thought he was being fresh with her and immediately turned to glare at him. But seeing Xie Zheng's dead-serious expression, it didn't seem like he was deliberately teasing her, and she couldn't help but frown.

Xie Zheng saw that she had misunderstood. "The army breaks camp tomorrow. We'll be heading to Chongzhou to join the Jizhou army and annihilate the rebels. I'm afraid there won't be a change of clothes on the road."

As he spoke, he took off his own outer robe and hung it on a nearby tree branch. "You can borrow my outer robe for now."

He then turned and walked into the woods, perhaps to deliberately give her some privacy.

After watching him walk away, Fan Changyu's gaze fell on the robe hanging from the branch.

Her hair was also full of grassy mud. After a moment's hesitation, she finally went over, took the outer robe, and hid behind a large boulder by the riverbank. She placed the robe on the rock, undid her hair, and shed her mud-caked soldier's uniform, immersing her entire body in the icy water.

Although it was late spring, the river water at night was still bone-chillingly cold. Fortunately, Fan Changyu had a strong constitution and wasn't afraid of the cold. After washing off the mud, she began to scrub her long hair.

The crackling sound of burning firewood came from the riverbank. She peeked out from behind the boulder and saw Xie Zheng sitting with his back to her in front of a fire. It was clear that when he went into the woods, it was to find firewood.

Fan Changyu stared at him for a while and saw that he never once turned his head. After washing her hair, she shivered as she stood up, wrung out her hair, and picked up the robe draped over the boulder to wrap around herself.

Only when she was tying the sash did Fan Changyu notice a problem. The robe was far too big for her. Even with the sash tied, the collar gaped

wide open.

She frowned, then decisively wrung out her own clean under-bodice as much as she could, put it on, and then wrapped the outer robe over it.

Once all this was done, she walked out from behind the boulder and knelt by the river to wash her uniform, which was caked with grass juice and mud.

Xie Zheng must have heard the noise. He turned to look at her and asked, "Aren't you going to dry your hair first?"

Fan Changyu wanted to finish washing her clothes first and then dry them by the fire. "I'm not cold," she said.

Footsteps approached from behind. Just as they reached her, she looked up to see Xie Zheng walk right past her and step into the river, his upper body bare.

Fan Changyu frowned and asked, "Are you going to bathe?"

Xie Zheng glanced at her. "I was swimming here before you came over."

With that, his entire body dove into the water like a silver fish. In a moment, he had swum several dozen feet downriver.

From the looks of it, he intended to continue swimming in the river?

Fan Changyu figured that with her washing clothes on the bank and him swimming in the middle of the river, they wouldn't be bothering each other, so she lowered her head and continued to wash her clothes.

The water in front of her suddenly rippled. Fan Changyu looked up to see Xie Zheng emerge from the water holding a fish. The splash he made soaked her. Water dripped from his dark hair and his fine-boned jaw. Like a young boy, he laughed heartily. "We have fish to eat!"

The fish in his hand was also struggling fiercely, flapping its tail and splattering fishy-smelling water droplets all over Fan Changyu's face.

Fan Changyu had no choice but to turn her face away and block with her sleeve, saying with a mix of helplessness and exasperation, "Get that fish away from me!"

But because of this arm-raising motion, the wide collar of her robe, which she had just gathered, fell open again. Fan Changyu almost instantly felt a chill.

The man in front of her also fell silent at once, staring at her dumbly. The fish escaped from his hand and splashed back into the water, drenching his face, but he didn't seem to react.

Fan Changyu realized something was wrong and looked down. She saw the outer robe's collar gaping open. Her under-bodice was wet, clinging to her body and outlining its round curves, even faintly revealing a bean-like protrusion.

Her face instantly turned red enough to steam. Without thinking, she kicked out and cursed, "You damn pervert!"

Kicked squarely in the face, Xie Zheng was sent back into the river. Caught completely off guard, he choked on a mouthful of water and couldn't get up for a long time.

Fan Changyu was mortified and furious. At first, she thought he was faking it, but when he didn't surface after a good while, she finally realized something was wrong. She called out to the water, "Yan Zheng?"

She still habitually called him Yan Zheng.

There wasn't a single ripple on the water's surface. Afraid she had knocked him unconscious with her kick, and with a life at stake, Fan Changyu couldn't care about anything else. She tossed his outer robe onto the bank and jumped into the water to save him.

A moment later, she hauled the choking man out, threw him onto the bank, and pressed hard on his chest a few times. Seeing Xie Zheng turn his head and spit out a mouthful of water as he slowly came to, she finally sat down beside him, exhausted.

She was tired, her breathing heavy, but it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say her face was expressionless.

What in the hell had happened today?

When Xie Zheng opened his eyes, he saw Fan Changyu sitting beside him, wearing only her long trousers and under-bodice. Her long, wet hair was loose, and the skin not covered by her dark hair and bodice was as white as frost and snow in the moonlight. The expression on her face was hard to read—was it cold indifference, or had she simply given up after too many blows?

But her entire being seemed to pluck at his heartstrings. He was stunned at first, then a rush of heat surged into his nose.

Realizing what it was, Xie Zheng quickly raised a hand to cover his nose, his ears turning completely red. He hastily averted his gaze, more flustered than he had ever been in his life. "S-sorry..."

Fan Changyu was so irritated she wanted to hit someone. "Shut up!" she snapped.

She picked up the outer robe she had dropped on the ground and wrapped it around herself. With no outlet for her pent-up frustration, she continued to warn him fiercely, "You didn't see anything!"

With that, she walked a good distance away and sat down to question her life choices.

Xie Zheng looked at her back, wrapped in his robe, then at the clothes by the river that were still not finished. He splashed some cold water on his face to force back the heat, then finished washing her clothes. He set them up on branches a short distance from the fire to dry, then went back into the river and caught two more fish. After gutting and cleaning them, he skewered them on branches and stuck them by the fire.

When the fish was cooked, he took one over to Fan Changyu, choosing his words carefully. "Have something to eat."

Wrapped in his outer robe, Fan Changyu seemed not to have recovered from the successive blows. She just stared at him with wide almond eyes and threatened him again, "You are not to speak of tonight's events to anyone!"

Chapter 90

Xie Zheng gave a faint smile and countered, "Who could I tell?"

Fan Changyu thought about it and realized he had a point. After being kicked into the river by her and still struggling to get up, he must have felt quite humiliated.

She shot him a fierce glare and said, "Just don't tell anyone, no matter what."

After Xie Zheng repeatedly assured her, he handed her the fish. "Here, eat."

She stared at the golden-brown, fragrant fish in his hand and stubbornly declared, "I'm not hungry"—only for her stomach to betray her with a loud growl.

The heat that had just receded from Changyu's face flared up again.

Suppressing the urge to smirk, Xie Zheng offered her an out. "I grilled too much. I can't finish it all."

If she kept being stubborn now, she'd only embarrass herself further. Resentfully, Changyu reached out and took the fish, resigning herself. "And you can't tell anyone about this either."

Xie Zheng held back a laugh and agreed, "Alright."

Out in the wild, without any seasonings, most roasted game smelled enticing but tasted bland or even fishy. Yet the fish Xie Zheng had prepared was not only free of any unpleasant taste but carried a faint tangy and spicy flavor.

After a couple of bites, Changyu asked in confusion, "Did you bring seasonings?"

Xie Zheng picked up the leftover wild berries by the fire and showed them to her. "Some of these are sour, others are pungent."

Changyu muttered under her breath, "Did you taste each one before picking them?"

Xie Zheng, with his sharp hearing, merely curled his lips in amusement before lowering his gaze again to pick bones from his fish. "I enlisted at thirteen, starting as a mere foot soldier in the Vanguard Battalion. Eight years have passed since then. Just like when you came to these mountains, the army didn't always have food. At our hungriest, roots and tree bark were delicacies. Of course, I've tasted wild berries too. The edible ones—I remembered their flavors. The poisonous ones—after watching comrades die from them, I naturally avoided them."

Listening to his past, Changyu found the fish tasteless in her mouth. She looked up at him in a daze.

When she first learned he was the Wu'an Marquis, he had seemed so distant, as if they were from two separate worlds that should never have crossed.

Only now did she realize that behind that title lay not just glory, but hardships few had endured.

She knew firsthand the brutality of war.

Enlisting at thirteen—younger even than Wu Sanjin—he had clawed his way up through the years. The bitterness he must have endured was something only he truly understood.

A complex emotion settled over her heart. Changyu lowered her head and silently picked at the fish bones.

A deboned fish, wrapped in a clean wild banana leaf, was handed to her. Xie Zheng took the one she was holding and said, "Eat this one instead."

Changyu held the neatly sliced banana leaf but hesitated to eat.

Xie Zheng paused in his task and glanced up. "What's wrong?"

Changyu said, "Yan Zheng—I'd rather call you Yan Zheng. Don't be so good to me. You're a noble Marquis, the Unrivaled Hero in the hearts of Great Yin's people. The one worthy of standing beside you should be a refined lady from a prestigious family. I'm just a crude border-town girl who hasn't even finished reading the Four Books. I'm not good enough for you."

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes and continued deboning the fish, a faint smile playing on his lips. "But out of all the women in the world, you're the only one I love."

Fan Changyu froze. This was the first time Xie Zheng had ever expressed his feelings to her so directly. Her heart pounded uncontrollably for a few beats before an endless bitterness welled up inside her.

She said, "Don't like me. With your unparalleled military achievements and being enfeoffed as a marquis at a young age, you should marry a wife of equal social standing—live a bright, illustrious life admired by thousands."

Xie Zheng handed her the fish he'd picked clean of bones and replied, "I reached this position through military merit, not people's admiration. Besides, in this world, there are those who respect me and those who despise me. They respect me because I drove back the Northern Barbarians and reclaimed lost territory. They fear me because I've killed countless enemies. Having spent half my life on battlefields to earn this reputation, if I still had to worry about public opinion when choosing a wife, wouldn't that make me the most pathetic Martial Marquis?"

He fixed his gaze on Fan Changyu. "Before meeting you, I did intend to marry a strong-willed girl from an aristocratic family—live together respectfully till old age. If I died in battle, she could raise our children comfortably with the family fortune."

"After meeting you, I stopped thinking about dying on the battlefield. How could I possibly die?"

With a laugh, he lay back, resting his head on his arms as he gazed at the star-studded sky. "After the war ends, I'll request to govern Liaoxi. As long as I keep the barbarians from moving south, the capital's intrigues won't concern me anymore. Then I'll ask the young emperor to grant our marriage—carry you home in a grand procession with gongs and drums, letting the whole world know you've married me."

The youthful vigor and joy on his face made Changyu's chest feel stuffed with damp cotton, the moisture welling up in her eyes.

"You've never seen the sunrise over Mount Yan or the hunting grounds of Huizhou. I'll take you to see them all. Liaoxi is vast—you'll never feel stifled there."

"But you keep rejecting me, afraid our statuses don't match. Yet back when I had nothing, you weren't afraid to be with me." Still staring at the sky, he smiled self-deprecatingly. "We bring nothing into this world and

take nothing when we leave—just shackled by empty reputations. What you see as barriers between us are actually meaningless."

"You say I could meet better women, but how do you know you're not the best one for me?"

Changyu opened her mouth but found her throat too painfully dry to speak. Covering her face with her hands, she felt tears escape.

Xie Zheng sat up to wipe her tears. "I didn't say these things to make you cry—just to tell you I love you, not for any other reason but because you're Fan Changyu. Having lost both parents young, with no elders or sisters at home, I didn't initially understand your concerns. After asking others, I came to grasp the implications."

"Regardless of whether you fear gossip or the future, I should handle these matters properly first. I asked my teacher to adopt you—that would be Old Mr. Tao who once taught you reading and wanted to take you as his disciple. He's a renowned scholar who served as Grand Tutor. Even without my request, he's very fond of you. From now on, he'll be your family. Even if you don't marry me, no one would dare slight you with that status."

When saying the last sentence, Xie Zheng lowered his eyes, hiding their redness.

If that day ever came, it would likely be after his death.

Even dead, he'd want her to live well.

He couldn't bear to part with her.

The only sun he had ever embraced in this life.

But he loathed becoming someone like his mother, so he wished for her happiness.

As long as she continued to shine her light and warmth upon the world, he wouldn't feel the cold even in hell.

Fan Changyu bit her lip hard, but couldn't suppress a sob. Large teardrops fell uncontrollably: "I'm not as good as you think..."

Xie Zheng gently wiped away the tears rolling down her cheeks, saying softly, "You're the kindest and bravest girl I've ever met in my life. Do you think just anyone has the courage to go to battle?"

When he pulled Fan Changyu into his embrace, she buried her face in his shoulder, still unable to stop her quiet sobs.

After her parents' death, she had trudged forward alone with her younger sister. Suddenly, someone had burst into her life, treasuring her at every turn. After initial wariness and defensiveness, she had finally let down her guard. What spread through her then wasn't just joy, but also a bittersweet ache.

Xie Zheng patted her back gently. "I'll help you avenge your parents too."

At the mention of her parents' death, Fan Changyu straightened up, roughly wiping her eyes with her sleeve. "I'll avenge my parents myself."

Remembering how her search through the Jizhou Prefecture archives had yielded no clues, she suddenly looked at Xie Zheng. "Do you know who killed my parents?"

Xie Zheng nodded slowly.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together. "Who?"

Xie Zheng uttered two words: "Wei Yan."

Fan Changyu froze momentarily, recalling the well-known relationship between him and Wei Yan. "Your uncle?"

Xie Zheng's expression turned cold. "He doesn't deserve that title." Worried his expression might frighten her, he added, "Remember the powerful enemy I once told you about? That's him."

But Fan Changyu looked visibly confused. "Wei Yan is the current prime minister. My father was just a bodyguard. Why would Wei Yan want him dead?"

Xie Zheng studied her for a moment before revealing the truth. "Your father once worked for Wei Yan."

Fan Changyu's eyes widened in shock. Then she remembered what Old Fan had told her when Fan Da died—that her father wasn't originally Fan Erniu, but had been sold as a child. He'd returned over a decade later, continuing to live under that name in Lin'an Town. This made her realize Xie Zheng's words were likely true.

Wei Yan had committed many evil deeds. Had her father been involved in them too?

Her heart clenched painfully at the thought.

Noticing her distraction, Xie Zheng seemed to guess her thoughts. "He Jingyuan, the governor of Jizhou, also worked for Wei Yan but never oppressed the people. That he called your father an old friend suggests they were like-minded."

He Jingyuan was considered the righteous official of all Jizhou. With Xie Zheng's words, Fan Changyu immediately felt somewhat relieved.

"When did you start investigating my parents' case?" she asked.

"After leaving Qingping County," Xie Zheng replied.

The memory of their separation then still brought a pang of guilt to Fan Changyu's heart. Recalling how she'd kicked him in frustration by the river earlier only deepened her remorse. "I won't hit you anymore, and you shouldn't kiss me so casually either."

Xie Zheng paused briefly in tending the fire. "Just don't hit so hard next time."

Fan Changyu blinked in surprise before understanding his implication. The firelight made her flushed face even redder as she glared at him. "I'm being serious here!"

Xie Zheng slightly lifted his phoenix-like eyes, the naturally upturned corners exuding a disdainful yet alluring charm. "I'm being serious too. When can I kiss you without getting hit?"

Fan Changyu couldn't hold back and swung the empty banana leaf (that once held grilled fish) at him.

Xie Zheng tilted his head to dodge the leaf, chuckling softly.

Changyu sat hugging her knees by the fire, pouting in annoyance, refusing to speak to him again.

Chapter 91

The morning light filtered through the military tent, casting a soft glow inside.

Changning blinked sleepily awake. When she had fallen asleep the night before, Fan Changyu hadn't returned yet. Now, seeing her elder sister lying soundly beside her, she rubbed her eyes with her chubby little hands and, confirming it was indeed Changyu, broke into a delighted grin.

Too well-behaved to wake Changyu, she carefully draped her own red velvet cloak over her sister before crawling to the foot of the bed on all fours, slipping into her shoes, and climbing down.

She dressed herself in her outer clothes too.

In the past, she had needed Changyu's help with winter clothes because the sleeves always bunched up inside. But after being kidnapped by those villains, she had learned to dress herself—though she still couldn't do her hair.

Changning tugged at the little bun atop her head and fetched the small wooden basin from the corner of the tent for washing her face.

After getting dressed in the morning, one had to wash their face.

She was about to leave the tent when she suddenly sniffed the air and turned toward the source of the aroma—a package wrapped in banana leaves on the table.

Standing on a small stool, Changning fumbled with the banana leaves, struggling for a while before undoing the palm leaves tied around them. Inside, she found a grilled fish with all the fins neatly removed. Her eyes sparkled at the sight, but her sister had taught her that cold meat shouldn't be eaten directly—it would give her a stomachache.

After a moment's thought, she rewrapped the banana leaves with the palm leaves, carefully placed the bundle in the wooden basin, and then carried it out of the tent with quick, pattering steps.

She needed to fetch water to wash her face—and heat up the fish so she could eat it with her sister!

Changning didn't know where to get hot water, but Xie Qi had been very kind to her yesterday, coaxing her and even taking her to see the falcon. So, instinctively, she toddled off on her short legs to find Xie Qi.

Today, the army was preparing to march, and the cookhouse camp had already started preparing rice porridge and steamed buns early in the morning.

Some of the troops stationed at the foot of the mountain had already withdrawn, leaving those on the mountain to depart last. The soldiers were taking their time packing up.

When Changning arrived, wooden basin in hand, Xie Qi was dismantling tents with the other personal guards. Spotting the little figure squeezing through the crowd, he wiped his hands on his waist and led her to an open area, crouching down to ask, "Here to see the Gyrfalcon again?"

Changning's eyes brightened even more. She nodded, then immediately shook her head, thrusting the wooden basin toward him.

Xie Qi saw the banana-leaf-wrapped bundle inside. When he opened it and found the fish, the satisfaction of looking after the child yesterday resurfaced. He patted Changning's head with an exceptionally gentle smile. "You eat it. I've already eaten."

Realizing he hadn't understood, Changning grew anxious and pushed the basin toward him more insistently. "Cold," she said.

Xie Qi felt the fish through the banana leaves and finally grasped her intention. Taking the basin, he asked, "You want me to heat this up for you?"

Changning nodded eagerly, then pointed at the basin. "Ning Niang needs to wash face."

Feeling a mix of amusement and chagrin at the misunderstanding, Xie Qi handed the fish to a nearby comrade to take to the cookhouse camp for reheating. Then, from a freshly filled kettle of hot water, he poured some into the basin for Changning to wash her face.

He had taken care of his younger sister before and had experience with children. Originally intending to help Changning wash her face, he instead watched as she rolled up her sleeves high, revealing two chubby arms like

sections of lotus root. She pressed her hands into the basin, splashed water onto her round, plump cheeks, and only after her entire face was wet did she wring out the small cloth Changyu had cut from old clothes to use as a face towel, cupping it in both hands to wipe her face.

She scrubbed so hard her cheeks turned slightly red, and the fine baby hairs at her forehead, now damp, clustered along her hairline like a fuzzy patch.

Several personal guards nearby who were tidying up the camp stopped their work, unable to hide their envy. "If I could have such an adorable daughter in this lifetime, I'd die happy!" one exclaimed.

Another guard tried bargaining with Xie Qi, "Brother Seven, you were on duty yesterday. Today's your rest day. I'll take good care of the little girl and the Gyr Falcon, I promise!"

Xie Qi laughed and scolded, "Get lost!"

Only after Changning finished washing did Xie Qi ask her, "Where's your elder sister?"

Changning replied, "Sister hasn't woken up yet."

Xie Qi had originally planned to bring breakfast to the sisters early that morning, but at dawn, the Marquis had returned covered in morning dew and instructed him to go later. Xie Qi didn't think much of it, assuming the Marquis was being considerate of his wife. After all, according to Xie Wu, Miss Fan had fought fiercely on the battlefield—it was only natural she'd want to sleep in after such exhaustion.

He had Changning sit on a small wooden stump nearby, undid her half-fallen pigtails, and re-tied her hair. Having once cared for his sister, he had to admit his hair-tying skills weren't bad. After securing the pigtails, he even picked two orange wildflowers and tucked them into her hair.

Changning was so delighted she crouched by the basin, turning her head left and right to admire her reflection for a long time before finally allowing Xie Qi to pour out the water.

By the time the cookhouse camp had heated the fish and sent over two bowls of porridge and two steamed buns, Xie Qi noticed Changning couldn't carry everything alone, so he helped her by carrying the items back to their tent.

Just then, Changyu, awakened by the camp's morning horn, realized Changning was missing. After a hasty cleanup, she was about to go search when she saw Changning skipping back with Xie Qi.

Spotting her sister, Changning dashed over, hugged Changyu around the waist, and looked up proudly. "Sister, look at Ning Niang's hair!"

Changyu noticed the two little flowers in her pigtails and pinched her nose. "Where did you run off to so early? Who tied your pretty pigtails? Was it Gongsun?"

Changning beamed. "No, it was Uncle Seven! Ning Niang washed her own face, and Uncle Seven heated the fish I brought."

Xie Qi, standing nearby, quickly greeted, "Miss Fan."

Changyu, seeing him holding the basin in one hand and the banana leaf-wrapped fish in the other, said politely, "Thank you for your trouble, Brother Seven."

Xie Qi simply replied it was his duty.

Changyu invited him to stay for breakfast, but he repeatedly declined, saying he'd already eaten. So she told Changning to go inside and eat first.

Sitting on the stool, Changning sniffed the enticing aroma of the grilled fish but stubbornly waited for Changyu, refusing to start. Swinging her legs, she asked, "Sister, where did the fish come from?"

Changyu casually splashed cold water on her face to wash up. "Couldn't sleep last night, so I went to the river and caught some."

Changning then dropped a bombshell: "Did Brother-in-Law grill it?"

Fan Changyu froze mid-wipe, while Xie Qi standing nearby instantly widened his eyes.

The Marquis had gone out last night and only returned this morning. Had Miss Fan also gone out last night? Connecting this with the Marquis's instructions this morning, Xie Qi suddenly felt extremely awkward, not daring to look at Fan Changyu and pretending to be a wooden post with downcast eyes.

Fan Changyu asked Changning, "Why do you think your brother-in-law grilled it?"

Changning answered truthfully, "Before A-jie found Ning Niang, brother-in-law grilled fish for her, and it smelled exactly like this."

Without any guilt about deceiving a child, Fan Changyu said, "I grilled it."

Remembering Xie Zheng's words from last night, her discomfort grew stronger. She took a forceful bite of the steamed bun in her hand.

...

After breakfast, the troops stationed on the mountain began their descent.

Fan Changyu packed up her and her sister's belongings and helped Xie Qi and others dismantle the military tents. When it was time to descend, she was assigned to a carriage.

Inside sat an elderly man with completely white hair and beard, dressed in simple cloth garments. Every deep wrinkle on his face seemed filled with the wisdom and insight bestowed by time.

A chessboard was set before him as if he were playing against himself. Noticing the carriage curtain being lifted, his aged eyes swept over and he smiled, "Girl, we meet again."

Though Fan Changyu already knew the old man's identity from Xie Zheng last night, she instinctively addressed him, "Old Mr. Tao."

Changning, seeing his completely white hair and beard yet remarkably spirited demeanor—so unlike the frailty of ordinary elderly, more resembling sages from paintings or statues in Confucian temples—pointed at him in amazement and exclaimed, "Immortal grandpa!"

Her grape-like eyes widened round.

Grand Tutor Tao was amused by this childish remark. "The elder sister is simple, but the younger one has a sweet tongue."

He beckoned to Changning, "Come here, little one, let grandpa take a look."

Changning looked up at Fan Changyu. Around strangers, no matter how friendly they seemed, she always waited for Fan Changyu's permission before approaching.

Fan Changyu patted her head with a smile, "Go ahead."

Only after being helped onto the carriage did Changning approach Grand Tutor Tao.

Examining her features, his initially kindly expression suddenly grew more solemn. After studying Fan Changyu's features as well, he stroked his beard and said, "This little one is blessed. Your elder sister protects your first half of life, paving the way for great nobility in your latter half."

Changning didn't quite understand his words, but she puffed out her chest and declared, "Ning Niang loves A-jie most!"

Fan Changyu had always worried about Changning's health—her occasional breathlessness and wheezing disease that hadn't shown much improvement despite years of medication. Hearing Grand Tutor Tao's words lifted her spirits, and she asked, "Does Old Mr. Tao practice physiognomy too?"

The old man replied simply, "At my age, one reads many miscellaneous books and picks up bits of everything."

Fan Changyu said, "My sister was born frail with wheezing disease. I only hope she can stay healthy."

After some thought, Grand Tutor Tao said, "A future destiny too noble can be hard to bear, naturally weakening the body. With you anchoring her fortune, it's nothing serious."

This mystical talk left Fan Changyu even more confused. She scratched her head, wanting to ask more but unsure where to begin.

Grand Tutor Tao noticed her hesitation and rephrased, "Just keep her by your side until she comes of age."

This version Fan Changyu understood. She nodded, "Naturally."

The carriage had already descended the mountain with the army. Though the road was uneven and the compartment rocked violently, not a single chess piece on Grand Tutor Tao's board had shifted.

He turned to Fan Changyu, "Girl, how about a game of chess with this old man?"

Changyu replied awkwardly, "I don't know how."

The mountain wind rushed through the carriage window, billowing Grand Tutor Tao's wide sleeves as he stroked his beard. "I'll teach you myself. Watch a game or two—how could you not learn?"

With the elder having spoken thus, Changyu had no choice but to agree.

As she gathered the pieces, she realized they seemed magnetically adhered to the board—no wonder none had fallen despite the carriage's violent rocking.

"In chess, black moves first. The entire game depends on 'qi'—the life force. Black and white battle to capture each other's 'qi'..."

Grand Tutor Tao's voice was aged yet resonant. His bony fingers placed pieces while explaining, but Changyu only half-understood, scratching her head and making moves through guesswork.

After several games, the old man's face turned green: "You were practically taught by my own hands—how can your play be this terrible?"

Changyu hung her head obediently under the scolding.

Having vented his frustration, Grand Tutor Tao sighed, "Never mind. Even the legendary Yuchi Jingde was a terrible chess player, yet he became a renowned general. Battle formations and chess can't be compared."

He then glanced sideways at Changyu, "Girl, I heard you killed the rebel general Shi Hu—a man famed for his valor across three armies. Though you're a woman, such remarkable skills shouldn't be wasted. Wouldn't you like to achieve glory?"

Changyu asked, "Are you asking if I wish to remain in the military?"

Grand Tutor Tao nodded, "Let me be blunt—someone petitioned me to adopt you as my goddaughter. Taking in a daughter means little to me, but learning my skills..."

He chuckled dryly, "That would be quite another matter!"

Studying Changyu, he asked, "Girl, would you be willing to become my disciple and learn to be a warrior who can face ten thousand foes?"

Chapter 92

Amid the rumbling of the carriage wheels, Fan Changyu remained silent for a long while before asking, "If I stay in the army, I'll have to kill many, many people from now on, won't I?"

She lifted her eyes, the light from outside the window reflecting the mountains and rivers in her gaze, now tinged with a quiet solemnity. "Old Master, the truth is, I don't like killing at all."

"Yesterday on the battlefield, I saw so many faces filled with panic and fear—they were cut down like pumpkins in a field. Changxin Wang has rebelled, and in this war so far, the ones dying the most are the common soldiers at the bottom. They didn't join the battlefield willingly, but deserters are executed on the spot, and their wives, children, and parents are still in Chongzhou City, so they have no way out."

"I know the rebels deserve to die, but when I see those bewildered, terrified faces on the battlefield, I can't bring myself to strike."

"They are also people of Great Yin. If not for this war, they'd be ordinary civilians—tending crops in the fields or peddling goods in the streets to earn a little extra for their families."

"Looking at them, I'm reminded of those conscripted from the common folk in Jizhou Prefecture during the siege of Lu City. They probably died the same way, like ants trampled on the battlefield."

Grand Tutor Tao regarded her with some surprise and said, "Your thoughts are not wrong. Those in power, driven by ambition, act without benevolence, treating the people as mere straw dogs. But when an unrighteous army already exists, if we do not stop it, won't we allow it to bring about even greater calamity?"

Seeing Fan Changyu's confusion, he asked, "Child, tell me—why did you cross Witch Ridge in the rain that night to ambush those three scouts?"

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together. "You said if they delivered their message, the entire population of Lu City would suffer."

Grand Tutor Tao nodded. "You killed those three scouts because you believed their lives would determine the fate of Lu City's people. But isn't this war against the rebels also for the sake of the people? Changxin Wang's rebellion has displaced countless civilians around Chongzhou. If we allow him to grow stronger, how many more will suffer when he marches south?"

"You ambushed the scouts to save the people of Lu City. The imperial army fights Changxin Wang to save the people of the realm."

"Even if the current court is riddled with corruption, the answer lies in reform, in opposing the corrupt officials—not in inciting war and plunging the people into misery. Between hardship and utter ruin, which is worse? Do you understand, child?"

As she listened, Fan Changyu felt the weight in her chest grow heavier.

Grand Tutor Tao continued, "Changxin Wang's army is the blade he wields to march south. If we hesitate to break that blade, more innocent lives will be lost beneath it."

"Since ancient times, no war has been fought without bloodshed or death."

"Beneath the yellow sands of the battlefield lie countless loyal bones, as well as those unjustly forced into battle, as you described. But it is precisely because every dynasty has had such loyal souls who rise to oppose unrighteous armies that a fractured realm can be restored to peace."

"The strategies of war are not meant for killing, but to end conflicts with as little bloodshed as possible."

Fan Changyu rose from the carriage seat and knelt, bowing solemnly to Grand Tutor Tao. "Changyu thanks you for your guidance."

The old tutor chuckled. "Still calling me just 'Master,' are you, child?"

Fan Changyu knelt on the ground and kowtowed three times, then picked up the wooden teacup beside her and offered it to Grand Tutor Tao: "Teacher."

Grand Tutor Tao accepted the teacup, the wrinkles at the corners of his eyes deepening with a smile. "You, girl, suit my fancy. I'd be willing to take you as my adopted daughter. From now on, call me 'Father.'"

Fan Changyu called out again, "Father."

This time, Grand Tutor Tao's face nearly blossomed into a flower from joy. After taking a sip of tea, he set the cup down and said, "Since you're now my daughter, I'll give you a courtesy name. You were born in the Year of the Tiger. 'Changyu' is a dignified and gentle name, already tempering some of your sharpness. But having only the courage of a tiger won't serve you well if you ever go to the battlefield. How about the courtesy name 'Shanjun'?"

Fan Changyu asked in confusion, "Does it mean 'gentleman of the mountains'?"

Grand Tutor Tao stroked his beard and chuckled. "Taken literally, it could mean that. But 'Shanjun' also refers to the fierce tiger of the mountains."

Since ancient times, only men were given courtesy names by their elders. Some women didn't even have their own names until marriage, referred to only by their surname and birth order before then, such as "Third Sister" or "Fourth Sister."

Grand Tutor Tao's thoughtful gesture moved Fan Changyu deeply. She said earnestly, "Thank you, Father, for the courtesy name."

Changning blinked her large, grape-like eyes. "Ning Niang wants one too!"

Grand Tutor Tao shook his head with a laugh. "You're still too young, little one. Wait a few more years."

Changning pouted unhappily and stuck out her pinky finger. "Then let's pinky promise! No cheating Ning Niang!"

Grand Tutor Tao, unusually cheerful, hooked his aged finger with hers and smiled. "Very well. This old man owes you a courtesy name, little girl."

With the pinky promise sealed, Changning was satisfied. She kicked off her shoes and climbed onto the carriage seat, pressing her face against the window to look outside. Spotting a Gyr Falcon swooping low, she pointed excitedly and cried, "It's the falcon!"

Fan Changyu held her steady with one hand, afraid she might fall.

Grand Tutor Tao said to Fan Changyu, "I suppose you've already guessed who my student is. Shall I inform him of your decision to remain in the

army?"

Fan Changyu replied, "Father, I wish to stay with the Jizhou army."

Grand Tutor Tao lifted his wrinkled eyelids and looked at her. "Avoiding him to prevent gossip?"

Fan Changyu said, "That's part of it. Ordinary soldiers earn their merits through blood and steel on the battlefield. I want to walk this path alone and see how far I can go."

If she served under Xie Zheng, no matter how impartial he might be, he would likely shield her from true danger.

Having chosen this path, Fan Changyu wanted to temper herself through the trials ahead.

Grand Tutor Tao laughed. "I knew I wasn't wrong about you. It so happens that you distinguished yourself in the battle of flooding Lucheng. The general who led the troops to build the dam was Tang Peiyi, the defender of Lucheng—a man of loyalty and righteousness. Serving under him won't be a waste of your talents."

Fan Changyu felt a mix of emotions. "Thank you, Father."

Grand Tutor Tao smiled. "What's there to thank me for? Your ambition gladdens my heart."

The carriage continued winding along the mountain path.

Fan Changyu gazed out the window. After the sudden rain, the sky was clear and boundless.

An eagle soared across the heavens, its cry sharp and far-reaching.

Two days later, Xie Zheng learned that Fan Changyu had enlisted—but under the banner of the Jizhou army.

The main army was only half a day's march away from reaching Chongzhou when news arrived from the troops sent to pursue Sui Yuanqing—he had fled back to Kangcheng, the hometown of Changxin Wang's consort. With only five thousand cavalry, capturing Kangcheng was hopeless.

The only solution now was to split the forces.

The Jizhou army led by He Jingyuan had already reached the gates of Chongzhou, trapping the rebels inside. The fall of Chongzhou was only a

matter of time.

The court was still withholding military provisions and funds. Since He Jingyuan was Wei Yan's man, as long as Xie Zheng relinquished command, the court would release the supplies. As for who would ultimately claim the military merit after Chongzhou's capture, that would be a battle between the Li family and Wei Yan.

And once Xie Zheng stepped back, besieging Kangcheng would be the perfect retreat to avoid being sidelined.

After repeated discussions with Gongsun Yin and his strategists, Xie Zheng ultimately decided to attack Kangcheng.

The Yanzhou Army diverted toward Kangcheng, while the Jizhou reinforcements continued toward Chongzhou.

Xie Zheng had been swamped with military and political affairs these past two days, only able to hear daily reports from his personal guards about Fan Changyu's activities. Learning that she had spent most of the journey in Grand Tutor Tao's carriage—either learning chess or reading books, often provoking the old man to huff and puff—Xie Zheng's lips curled slightly at the thought of his mentor's temper.

But on the day the two armies parted ways, while Xie Zheng was still discussing siege tactics for Kangcheng with Gongsun Yin, Xie Wu rushed in frantically: "Marquis! Trouble! The Lady and Grand Tutor Tao have gone with the Jizhou Army!"

Xie Zheng lifted his cold eyes from the map, frowning. "What happened?"

Xie Wu handed him a letter. "Grand Tutor Tao asked me to deliver this to you."

Xie Zheng took it with slender fingers, and upon reading it, his face instantly frosted over, a hint of fury flashing in his eyes. "Prepare my horse!" he ordered icily.

Gongsun Yin, seeing his expression darken, asked, "What does the letter say?"

But by the time the guards brought the warhorse, Xie Zheng had already mounted and galloped away. Left with no choice, Gongsun Yin picked up the discarded letter from the ground and read it himself. After a moment,

he let out a soft hiss. "This old man and young woman—are they trying to drive him to madness?"

Then, stroking his chin, he mused, "But... if even Grand Tutor Tao knows that Chongzhou's victory will spark a fight between Wei Yan and the Li family, yet still agreed to let the girl join the Jizhou Army, perhaps it's not such a bad thing?"

If the Li family truly overthrew He Jingyuan, they had no capable military leader to take charge. They would never dare let Jizhou's military power fall back into Xie Zheng's hands. At that point, they would need someone competent to stabilize Jizhou's forces.

Fan Changyu had the courage to kill Shi Hu, and with Grand Tutor Tao's guidance in strategy, she might just make a name for herself in Jizhou.

Fan Changyu sat in the carriage with Changning in her arms, her right eyelid twitching incessantly. She glanced out the window and rubbed her temples.

Grand Tutor Tao, who had been feigning sleep, suddenly opened his eyes. "You've been restless since noon. Regretting not telling him?"

Fan Changyu replied, "My foster father has already explained everything in the letter."

Grand Tutor Tao chuckled dryly. "You've got that brat's temper figured out. If you'd told him face-to-face, he'd have tied you up and dragged you along."

Fan Changyu lowered her head, staring at her toes in awkward silence.

The carriage, which had been moving smoothly, suddenly came to an abrupt halt. Fan Changyu, sitting inside, felt herself lurch forward. If she hadn't quickly shielded Changning, the girl would have bumped her forehead against the carriage wall.

Outside, the sound of warhorses neighing filled the air.

Grand Tutor Tao wasn't so fortunate—he happened to hit the back of his head against the carriage wall. Cursing, he muttered, "It must be that damned brat!"

No sooner had he spoken than the carriage curtain was yanked open, revealing Xie Zheng's icy, handsome face at the doorway. His pitch-black

eyes held not a trace of emotion as he stared at Fan Changyu and said, "Will you come out yourself, or shall I carry you out?"

Grand Tutor Tao, clutching the back of his head, scolded, "You rebellious disciple! Are you trying to kill your own teacher?"

Xie Zheng's dark eyes shifted to him, and the grand tutor's blustering demeanor instantly faltered. He averted his gaze guiltily.

Xie Zheng said, "This student begged his teacher to adopt the woman he loves as a foster daughter. Yet the teacher sneaks away with her without a word. Shouldn't you give me an explanation?"

Grand Tutor Tao grumbled, "Didn't I leave you a letter?"

He just hadn't expected the letter—which he thought Xie Zheng would only see that evening—to have fallen into his hands so soon, allowing him to catch up.

Fan Changyu, who had been silent until now, suddenly looked up at Xie Zheng and said, "I'll go with you."

She placed Changning back in the carriage and said to Grand Tutor Tao, "Please watch over Ning Niang for me, Father."

Changning, frightened by Xie Zheng's expression, clung to Fan Changyu's sleeve and refused to let go, whispering, "Elder Sister."

Fan Changyu patted her head reassuringly. "Don't be afraid. I'll be back soon."

With that, she handed the girl to Grand Tutor Tao. Just as she lifted the carriage curtain and was about to jump down, a large hand hauled her straight onto a horse.

The moment her back pressed against his chest, Fan Changyu could feel him breathing like a beast suppressing towering rage.

He spurred the horse forward, swiftly leaving the Jizhou Army's contingent behind. Realizing they were heading toward the rendezvous point with the Yanzhou Army, Fan Changyu calmly said, "I must join the army in Jizhou."

He wasn't wearing armor, and she could clearly feel every muscle in his body tense instantly.

With a vicious tug on the reins, he brought the warhorse to a rearing halt. He dragged her off the horse and pinned her against a thick tree by the roadside, one so wide it would take a person's full embrace to encircle it.

His grip was brutal, and the fury in his eyes was so intense that blood vessels stood out, making his entire gaze appear red. Yet his voice was deceptively light, even carrying a hint of laughter as he asked, "Do I disgust you so much that you'd rather join the army in Jizhou just to stay far away from me?"

Chapter 93

The mountain wind rustled the leaves in the treetops. The man before her lowered his head slightly, his gaze fixed on her. They were barely half a foot apart, so close that the sound of each other's breathing was clearly audible as they spoke.

Fan Changyu looked at the man, whose eyes and brows exuded a vicious aura, and instinctively sensed danger. The force with which he gripped her shoulder was immense. She tried to struggle, but not only did she fail to break free, he gripped her even tighter, making her bones ache faintly.

She frowned. "What nonsense are you talking about?"

Xie Zheng asked her in a frigid voice, "Aren't you heading to Jizhou to join the army?"

Fan Changyu said, "I am going to join the army, but it's not what you think."

Xie Zheng was so furious he laughed. "Not what you think? Then why were you afraid of me finding out, leaving without a single word?"

Fan Changyu looked at his fierce, bloodshot eyes, and a sliver of guilt rose in her heart. Leaving without saying goodbye was indeed a lapse in judgment on her part, but there were some things she truly didn't know how to bring up to his face.

She pressed her lips together slightly and said, "I'm sorry."

Looking at this girl who was always so honest she couldn't even tell a lie, Xie Zheng, for a fleeting moment, had the urge to strangle her. The hand gripping her shoulder was trembling. His face somewhat contorted, he pulled her into his embrace, not wanting her to see the even more savage and terrifying look in his eyes.

He practically ground out through his teeth, "Fan Changyu, you should have stabbed me twice before you left, wounded me so badly I couldn't get out of bed."

Black rage churned in his chest. The deep-seated terror that felt as if he were the only person left in the world drilled out from the cracks in his bones, seeping into his flesh and blood bit by bit, causing the arms holding her to spasm uncontrollably.

What pride, what fortitude—it all shattered like thin ice under the sun.

Why was she so unwilling to be with him?

Why did everyone abandon him?

That woman back then, and now her too.

He was resolving all the obstacles she thought stood between them.

But she still didn't want him!

He had carved out his entire heart for her, and she had cast it aside with disdain!

For an instant, Xie Zheng felt as if he were no longer himself, because he couldn't control his own body. He saw himself lower his head and, through her clothes, bite down viciously on Fan Changyu's shoulder.

Fan Changyu cried out with a muffled grunt of pain, but his teeth only clenched tighter. A bloody tint spread through his phoenix eyes, and his arms locked around the person in his embrace, not loosening in the slightest no matter how she struggled, like a wild wolf biting into its dying prey.

Fan Changyu cursed through the pain, "Are you insane?"

The man biting her finally let go. His lips were stained with blood, yet his face was somewhat pale. He lowered his eyes to look at her and murmured, "Fan Changyu, why can't you just love me?"

The words were less a question and more a plea.

A light breeze stirred the messy strands of hair falling across his forehead.

In that moment, the expression on his face was one of unprecedented vulnerability.

The anger on Fan Changyu's face froze. The Xie Zheng in her memory had always been proud. When had he ever looked so humbled, as if brought down to the dust? Her heart softened, and she sighed. "How could I not love you?"

She raised a hand to stroke his hair, her gaze gentle yet firm. "If I didn't love you, I wouldn't have come looking for you. I wouldn't be so afraid you'd die that I'd go to the battlefield in your place."

As her hand rested on the crown of his head, the vicious aura around him dissipated by more than half. He stared at her blankly for a moment, then the corners of his lips curved in a self-deprecating smile. "The person you love is the Yan Zheng you imagined."

Fan Changyu hadn't expected him to suddenly get stuck on this point. She said, "When you were Yan Zheng, I loved you. Now that you're Xie Zheng, I love you too."

"When you had nothing, I would have slaughtered pigs to support you. Now that you're far more capable than I am, I'm also learning to become stronger, which is why I'm going to join the army."

Xie Zheng was completely stunned. His dark eyes stared at her blankly. His raven-like eyelashes were dark and curled, looking fluffy in the sunlight. His coolly refined and exquisite face actually revealed a hint of docility.

He was like a child who had never been given candy and, upon suddenly receiving a piece one day, reacted not with joy, but with stunned bewilderment.

After a long moment, he looked at her appraisingly and said, "Are you just trying to placate me?"

Fan Changyu was exasperated, but seeing him like this, she couldn't help but feel a pang of heartache.

She had always thought he was a child of fortune who could have anything he wanted. But at this moment, she suddenly felt that what he possessed was pitifully little.

That was why losing anything felt like it was being brutally stripped from his flesh and blood, enough to make him lose half his life.

She said, "I'm not placating you. I'm just telling you that I love you too, regardless of whether you're Yan Zheng or Xie Zheng."

"I rejected you before because I felt we wouldn't have a good outcome together. When you were Yan Zheng, all we had to worry about was daily necessities. But you could earn silver by copying books and writing eight-legged essays, and I could earn money by slaughtering and selling pork.

Whatever difficulties we encountered, we could support each other and overcome them."

"But now that you're the Wu'an Marquis, I don't know how to help you with any difficulty you face. I don't understand what you're busy with or what you're worried about. My mother said that for a husband and wife to last a lifetime, they must be considerate and supportive of each other. Most of those who become resentful couples have already worn away their past affection before they can finish a lifetime of accommodation."

"I wanted to make a clean break, but then you told me we would watch the sunrise at Yan Mountain and go hunting in Huizhou together. You were afraid I'd be bullied, so you asked Old Mr. Tao to accept me as his goddaughter. I'm not made of stone. I feel sad and reluctant to part, too."

"I don't know if I'll regret choosing this path in the future, but at least for now, I'm willing to take the gamble."

She looked at him with a serious expression. "I will become the same kind of person as you and stand with you, open and proud."

The sun was high in the sky, yet not a single ray of light reflected in Xie Zheng's pitch-black eyes. They only mirrored Fan Changyu's silhouette, like a pool of thick ink about to swallow her whole.

He pulled her forcefully into his arms, his voice deep and hoarse. "No matter what status you have when you're with me, it is always open and proud."

Fan Changyu said, "What I'm seeking is the confidence to walk alongside you forever. This confidence doesn't lie in the depth of your feelings for me, but in myself. A falcon is powerful, but it can't carry another falcon on its back to fly, can it?"

Xie Zheng understood the meaning behind her words, but it was precisely because he understood that his thin lips pressed together even more tightly. He straightened up and said, "The battlefield is not a game. The slightest mistake can cost you your life. Even with the courage to take on ten thousand men, accidents can still happen. I will not let you put yourself in danger."

The battlefield could bring military honors, but buried beneath the yellow sand were mountains of white bones.

Fan Changyu looked at him and said, "I'm afraid of dying too. I can't bear to leave Ning Niang, and I can't bear to leave you. But if I don't walk this path myself, someone else might force me into a dangerous situation in the future. I still remember the two assassination attempts at our home in Lin'an Town. I never knew my enemy was such a person of immense power and influence. Even you nearly lost your life at his hands."

"Rather than being carefully protected like a porcelain vase, only to shatter to pieces the moment I'm dropped, I'd rather forge a body of bronze and iron. I told you, I want to walk side by side with you. He is my enemy too. For the sake of avenging my parents, this is what I should do. I love you, but I can't rely on you for the rest of my life. Otherwise, that wouldn't be me anymore."

Xie Zheng couldn't refute her words and finally made a concession. "Isn't it fine to just stay in the Yanzhou Army?"

Fan Changyu said, "That would be no different from being on the mountain before."

The two looked at each other, one with phoenix eyes filled with restrained silence, the other with apricot eyes clear and bright.

Finally, Xie Zheng relented. "Fine. You can go to Jizhou to join the army, but you must take Xie Wu and Xie Qi with you."

Fan Changyu knew this was the greatest concession he could make. She nodded, then added, "Take me back. Otherwise, Old Mr. Tao and Ning Niang will get anxious from waiting."

She still wasn't used to calling Tao Taifu her godfather. She turned to walk toward the big black horse that was grazing, but he grabbed her hand.

She glanced at him, a little puzzled. "Yan Zheng?"

Dappled sunlight filtered through the gaps in the leafy canopy, scattering mottled light and shadows across the young man's hair and his jade-like face.

His pitch-black pupils locked onto her. He didn't say a word, yet it seemed he was silently asking her for something.

Fan Changyu didn't understand what he meant and asked again, "What's wrong?"

He said slowly, "You said you love me."

Fan Changyu first froze, then met his gaze. Thinking of what he had done to her in the past, she suddenly understood what his words meant.

He had done this sort of thing to her many times, but for her, it was still the first time.

It was different from the time he was sick, when she had naively kissed his forehead after he had kissed her eyelids.

Back then, she hadn't thought much of it, feeling it was similar to planting a smack on Changning's face. This time, because she understood the meaning, she hadn't even done anything yet, but just being watched by him made her heart pound, as if a small deer was trapped in her chest.

She had never seen how other people kissed, but every time Xie Zheng kissed her, he would just press down on her.

So, the question of whether to close her eyes or not was not within Fan Changyu's consideration.

She was considered tall among women, but Xie Zheng was still a good half-head taller than her.

Her face tense, she stood on her tiptoes and quickly brushed her lips against his beautifully shaped ones.

Unlike the swollen and painful sensation left on her lips every time Xie Zheng finished kissing her, Fan Changyu was surprised to find that his lips were quite soft.

Then why did her mouth hurt so much before?

Could it be because he bit her?

The moment this thought popped up, Fan Changyu felt that a gentleman's revenge was an opportunity not to be missed. The teeth marks on her shoulder still ached, so she unceremoniously bit his lip as well.

The force wasn't heavy, but she clearly felt the person before her hitch his breath.

Fan Changyu knew when to stop and quickly pulled back. "Alright, let's go back..."

Xie Zheng seemed not to have recovered either. There was a moment of stunned blankness on his face, his long, dark lashes trembling slightly. He

already had a handsome, ascetic appearance. Due to his long years on the battlefield and his high position, his superior's bearing usually only made people feel an unapproachable majesty.

This rare expression of his, with less of its sharp dominance, made the stunning quality of his features all the more intense. Fan Changyu's heart throbbed wildly a few times.

How could a man be this good-looking?

Xie Zheng raised a hand to touch his lower lip where Fan Changyu had bitten it, then glanced at her again. His eyes were unreadable, and it was impossible to know what he was thinking. He put his fingers to his lips and blew a whistle. The big black horse grazing in the distance quickly galloped back.

After swinging himself onto the horse's back, he extended a hand to Fan Changyu. She took it, and with a gentle tug, he pulled her up onto the horse.

Fan Changyu asked curiously, "Can that whistle summon a Gyrfalcon and also command a horse?"

As she spoke, she looked at the index finger he had just used to whistle and noticed a scar ringing it, left by some unknown injury. It looked like a bite mark, but even more gruesome.

The man behind her replied, "Different lengths and pitches of the whistle carry different commands."

For the rest of the journey, the two didn't speak much. When Fan Changyu occasionally asked him a question or two, his answers were very simple, as if his mind was wandering.

It wasn't until the rear of the Jizhou army came into view on the gentle slope ahead that Xie Zheng suddenly reined in the horse.

Fan Changyu thought he was afraid of being too conspicuous by escorting her directly back to the army formation and was about to dismount, but he grabbed her arm.

She turned back in confusion, only to find his dark eyes locked on her once more. He was clearly very close to her, able to kiss her with just a slight dip of his head, yet he didn't press down another inch.

His intention couldn't be more obvious.

Fan Changyu faltered slightly. As she leaned in to kiss him, she was still thinking, why is it that when this person wants someone to kiss him, he has the wretched temper of someone who wants it but refuses to say it, and who would immediately turn hostile if you didn't?

Chapter 94

Grand Tutor Tao prided himself on knowing his stubborn disciple well, but after Fan Changyu was taken away by him, he suddenly felt uncertain. He frequently glanced out the carriage window and eventually stepped out to pace around the carriage, occasionally looking in the direction where Xie Zheng had led Fan Changyu away.

A young officer approached to ask, "Grand Tutor, the army has been resting here for quite some time. Should we... continue the journey?"

Grand Tutor Tao clasped his hands behind his back, gazing into the distance. "Let's wait a little longer," he said.

The officer saluted and withdrew.

Changning poked her head out of the carriage window, resting her chin on the sill. "Grandfather, when will my sister be back?" she asked.

Grand Tutor Tao's heart was unsettled, and he didn't bother correcting her address. "She should be back soon," he replied.

He reasoned that even if Xie Zheng had been provoked enough to take Changyu away on the spot, there was still the younger sister here. Surely, he wouldn't leave her behind?

This thought eased his mind slightly.

Suddenly, Changning, still leaning on the windowsill, cried out joyfully, "Sister!"

Grand Tutor Tao snapped out of his thoughts and looked in the direction of her gaze. There, the young man who had left with a stormy expression now appeared calm as he led his horse, escorting his newly adopted daughter back.

Watching this scene, an odd thought crossed Grand Tutor Tao's mind: "There's always someone who can tame another."

After dismounting from the gentle slope, Fan Changyu walked side by side with Xie Zheng. Her lips still felt numb and sore. She touched them lightly—they were probably swollen.

Fan Changyu decided she needed to learn her lesson: she couldn't keep biting him every time. This time, her attempt had backfired spectacularly. When he bit back, it was far worse—for a moment, she thought he might actually devour her.

His breathing had been ragged as he held her, panting heavily for a long time. Near the bite mark on her shoulder, he had nipped her a few more times.

It wasn't exactly a bite—it didn't break the skin or hurt much, but it left several red marks.

When she met Grand Tutor Tao, Fan Changyu pressed her lips together tightly, afraid he might notice the swelling. "Father," she greeted.

Before Grand Tutor Tao could examine her closely, Changning bounded out of the carriage like an agile little rabbit, arms outstretched. "Sister, hold me!" she demanded.

Fan Changyu picked her up, chuckling helplessly. "Ning Niang, are you a sticky rice cake? I've never seen anyone as clingy as you."

Changning pouted but didn't reply, clinging tightly to her sister's neck. Only when she caught Xie Zheng's gaze from the corner of her eye did she obediently murmur, "Brother-in-law."

Ever since she had pricked Xie Zheng awake with a needle and seen his terrifying, ghost-like expression, Changning had been afraid of him.

Xie Zheng acknowledged her greeting with a slight nod before turning his attention back to Grand Tutor Tao.

Though his gaze was calm now, Grand Tutor Tao inexplicably felt a pang of unease under his scrutiny.

"I entrust her to you, Teacher," Xie Zheng said.

Grand Tutor Tao understood this was a request to protect Fan Changyu. He straightened his expression. "This old man finally has an adopted daughter to cherish. Of course, I'll guard her like a treasure—no need for you to remind me."

Once Fan Changyu and Changning were back in the carriage, the army prepared to move again.

Xie Zheng remained on horseback by the roadside, the wind rustling through the forest billowing his robes around his tall, straight figure. Fan

Changyu lifted the carriage curtain to look at him. "I'm leaving now," she said.

Xie Zheng nodded. "Be careful on the road," he added.

Changning squeezed her head out from the corner of the carriage window, clinging to the edge as she said, "Ning Niang is leaving too."

With her elder sister by her side, she wasn't as afraid of her brother-in-law anymore, even waving her chubby little hand in farewell.

Xie Zheng had little experience dealing with children and wasn't sure how to coax them, so he simply said, "Listen to your elder sister."

Changning proudly declared, "Ning Niang is the most obedient."

A sharp cry echoed from the sky as the Gyr Falcon that had been searching for Xie Zheng swooped down. He raised his arm, and the bird landed steadily on his forearm.

Changning's eyes immediately lit up. "Falcon-falcon!"

Under Fan Changyu's astonished gaze, Xie Zheng extended the Gyr Falcon toward the carriage window and said, "Take the Gyr Falcon with you. It delivers messages faster."

Fan Changyu asked, "What about you?"

Xie Zheng replied, "If you send it to deliver a message to me, it can find me. But if I send it to you, it might not locate you as easily."

Before Fan Changyu could respond, Changning already chimed in, "Ning Niang will raise little chickens to feed the falcon!"

Grand Tutor Tao, standing nearby, remarked, "Girl, this lad is rarely so generous—don't hold back on his account. All these years, he's never shown such filial piety to this old man, yet now he's willing to part with his treasures..."

He couldn't help feeling a bit sour, silently grumbling that the old saying was indeed true—boys forget their mothers once they take a wife. His status as a half-father figure wasn't faring much better.

But then it occurred to him that this half-daughter-in-law was also his own adopted daughter. Having a clever girl protected by a cunning boy with eight hundred tricks up his sleeve wasn't such a bad thing. His bitterness faded, replaced by a strange sense of relief.

In the end, the Gyrfalcon was carried into the carriage by Changning. As the carriage slowly advanced through the infantry formation, Xie Zheng turned to Xie Wu and Xie Qi, who were mounted behind him, and said, "Go. Protect her well."

Xie Wu and Xie Qi clasped their fists and spurred their horses to follow the army.

Xie Zheng and the remaining personal guards stood at the mouth of the official road until the tail end of the Jizhou army disappeared from sight. Only then did he tug the reins, turning his horse around. "Back to camp."

Yanzhou Military Camp.

When Gongsun Yin learned that Xie Zheng had personally pursued Fan Changyu yet failed to bring her back, he gleefully approached, fan in hand, ready to offer a few perfunctory words of consolation.

To his surprise, upon entering the camp, he found the heavyweights of Yanzhou and their advisors packed into the command tent. Xie Zheng, clad in a black arrow-sleeved long robe, sat at the head of the table, with maps of Kangcheng and its defensive layouts spread before him. He was deep in discussion with his generals, a far cry from the dejected figure Gongsun Yin had imagined.

Spotting him, Xie Zheng raised a hand and tossed the map over. "Perfect timing. You'll guide them on the siege tactics for the western gate."

Gongsun Yin barely caught the flung map and scanned the newly marked areas, clicking his tongue. "I thought we were just wearing Kangcheng down, waiting for He Jingyuan to take Chongzhou before making a move?"

After all, the siege of Kangcheng was merely a show for the imperial court after conceding the military merits of Chongzhou. If they took Kangcheng with overwhelming force, they'd still have to divert troops to reinforce Chongzhou, risking entanglement in Wei Yan and the Li family's power struggle again.

Xie Zheng's sharp phoenix eyes lifted slightly, a faint smile playing at his lips. "Who said I was planning to take Kangcheng outright?"

Gongsun Yin scrutinized the marked areas on the map again, puzzled. "Isn't this a blitzkrieg assault?"

Xie Zheng said, "Once we've pulled out all the claws and fangs of the rebels in Kangcheng, letting them linger on their last breath will only be a matter of time."

Gongsun Yin pondered this. The words weren't wrong, but hadn't their initial strategy been to encircle the city without attacking, wearing down the rebels' patience before launching an assault? Why the sudden change in tactics?

The discussions and deployments continued late into the night. As the generals and advisors in the central military tent gradually dispersed, Gongsun Yin gulped down a cup of tea to soothe his throat before asking, "Did you fail to bring her back and now want to vent your frustration through battle?"

The tent was brightly lit by tall candles, the cold gleam reflecting off the dark iron vambraces at Xie Zheng's sleeves. Holding a bamboo scroll, he replied, "Three days. I want Kangcheng stripped of any ability to send out troops, forced into a desperate defense."

He looked up at Gongsun Yin. "After three days, you'll lead the troops to besiege Kangcheng. Wait for news of victory from Chongzhou before breaching the city gates."

Gongsun Yin mulled over his words, then suddenly paled. "You're planning to dump this mess on me?"

Xie Zheng glanced at him. "I'll leave the Kangcheng rebels barely clinging to life before I go. If you still can't hold the city afterward, there's no need for you to serve under me in the future."

Gongsun Yin could easily guess why he had rushed back to handle these matters. Considering how he had raced nonstop to intercept someone, only to return empty-handed, Gongsun Yin suddenly felt less aggrieved about being left behind in Kangcheng.

Fanning himself, he offered a few words of consolation, fearing Xie Zheng might be blinded by impulse: "Alright, alright. In three days, you're planning to go to Chongzhou for Miss Fan, aren't you? Don't blame her for being harsh. I actually think her joining the Jizhou army isn't a bad thing. Although He Jingyuan handed the Tiger Tally over to you, if Li Huaian truly uncovers something in Jizhou Prefecture and brings down He Jingyuan, that tally will eventually be reclaimed by the court. If Miss Fan can become

a general in Jizhou by then, with Grand Tutor Tao's support, at least the military power there won't fall into others' hands."

Xie Zheng responded coldly, "A true man's ambition is to achieve glory for his wife and descendants. This marquis is not so incompetent as to rely on a woman to secure military power. If I want Jizhou, I don't have to return the tally at all. Whether it's the Li Faction or the Wei Faction, what can their courtly schemes do against steel and blood? At worst, it just means more killing."

As he spoke, his expression was icy, his eyes devoid of any warmth. Even Gongsun Yin, who prided himself on understanding Xie Zheng well, felt a chill run down his spine.

"But if we kill them all, the Great Yin court will become an empty shell. Decrees and policies must be implemented layer by layer—someone has to carry them out, or the common people will only suffer greater chaos." He idly twisted the white jade qilin ring on his finger. "Dynastic reforms have taken decades in past eras. After all, you must first cultivate replacements for those positions before making a move."

He then scoffed lightly. "Let the young emperor worry about such matters. This marquis won't trouble himself with them."

Gongsun Yin thought to himself, Thank heavens he has no interest in the throne. With Wei Yan ahead and this wolf behind him, the young emperor would live in constant fear—if he didn't die young from sheer terror, it would only be by divine mercy.

Puzzled, he asked, "So you plan to bring Miss Fan back in three days?"

Given Xie Zheng's temperament, if he truly intended to retrieve her, he wouldn't have returned empty-handed after chasing after her today.

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze to the bamboo scroll in his hand and said, "Her aspirations lie within this. I can protect her, but I shouldn't stand in her way."

Gongsun Yin shuddered, shaking off goosebumps, and replied, "Then let's hope Miss Fan appreciates your sentiments."

Xie Zheng suddenly remarked, "I've heard many young ladies admire you."

Gongsun Yin straightened his posture slightly, his fan-waving becoming even more dashing: "Not many, not many. Just enough to fill a carriage

with fruits whenever I step out."

Without looking up from the scroll, Xie Zheng continued, "Has any lady ever been so inspired by your extraordinary talents or your reputation as a sage of Hejian that she resolved to study diligently and become a renowned scholar herself?"

Gongsun Yin opened his mouth, at a loss for words, when Xie Zheng added, "She said she wants to walk the path I've taken and become someone like me."

Gongsun Yin froze for a moment before finally realizing the roundabout point Xie Zheng had been making.

No wonder he'd been acting this way since returning!

Gongsun Yin's face twisted with envy as he rose abruptly, flicking his sleeves. "I take my leave!"

Chapter 95

After a day's march, they reached the territory of Chongzhou.

Fan Changyu was heading to the military camp and couldn't keep bringing Changning along indefinitely.

Previously, while searching for Changning in Jizhou, she had assisted the local authorities in dismantling several mountain bandit dens that trafficked women and children. For this, she received a substantial reward. With the money, she rented a small courtyard in a nearby town and settled Changning there, hiring a simple and honest peasant woman to take care of her daily needs in exchange for wages.

As an extra precaution, she left Xie Qi behind, taking only Xie Wu with her to the military camp.

This was common among soldiers stationed outside the frontier for long periods. Most of them had families in the border towns and could reunite with them when not on duty.

Once everything was arranged, Fan Changyu was formally enlisted into the Jizhou army through Grand Tutor Tao's recommendation. Her previous feats—intercepting and killing three enemy scouts—were solid military merits in the eyes of the Jizhou army. Later, she had also slain the rebel general Shi Hu at First Line Gorge, making it easy for her to secure a rank.

However, on the way to the camp, Grand Tutor Tao suddenly asked her, "Girl, would you rather have a group of subordinates who obey you but aren't close to you, or would you prefer to personally train a few reliable people of your own?"

Fan Changyu had witnessed the brutality of the battlefield. If not for those who were truly close, who would risk their lives to protect you?

The generals in the army had risen through the ranks—from squad leaders to platoon leaders—precisely because they had earned the trust of their soldiers and shared life-and-death bonds with them. It was this bond that made their troops charge fearlessly into battle alongside them.

Even when military power shifted, the rank-and-file soldiers were more inclined to stand with the generals they followed rather than obey the distant imperial authority.

Fan Changyu wasn't particularly clever, but she wasn't foolish either. She quickly weighed the pros and cons and answered, "On the battlefield, I need people I can trust with my back."

Her implication was clear—she chose the latter.

Grand Tutor Tao stroked his beard and smiled. "That aligns with my thoughts. You're new to the army and unfamiliar with its workings. If you're hastily given a high-ranking position without reliable subordinates, you'd only be a target of envy with an empty title. It's better to keep a low profile, take things step by step, and build a solid foundation."

With these words, Fan Changyu realized that at best, she might start as a squad leader in the army.

Under the military system of Great Yin, five soldiers formed a squad, ten a platoon, five platoons a company, ten companies a battalion, and five battalions a regiment. A regiment had a minimum of 500 soldiers, though the upper limit was flexible.

Multiple regiments combined formed an army.

The military hierarchy was complex—some positions held both rank and real authority, some had rank but no power, and others had authority without official rank.

For example, the leader of a battalion, who commanded a hundred soldiers and was called a centurion, technically held no official rank but wielded considerable practical power.

On the battlefield, a hundred soldiers could accomplish much. Historically, many renowned generals had earned their fame as centurions by achieving remarkable feats in battle.

Fan Changyu was assigned to Tang Peiyi's forces. After the previous defeat where the rebels flooded the area outside Lucheng, Tang Peiyi's newly recruited army of 20,000 had suffered nearly 3,000 casualties during the rebels' surprise attack on a rainy night. Another 1,000 had been dispatched with Grand Tutor Tao to deliver supplies to First Line Gorge, while Tang Peiyi led the remaining troops to besiege Chongzhou.

Grand Tutor Tao led a thousand men who, after joining forces with reinforcements from Yanzhou at First Line Gorge and gaining experience through multiple engagements with the rebels under the guidance of Yanzhou veterans, had rapidly matured. The few hundred survivors who returned were now all battle-hardened soldiers.

Tang Peiyi intended to disperse these men and reassign them among new recruits to train the fresh troops.

After besieging Lucheng, he had clashed once with Prince Changxin's forces but suffered heavy losses. It wasn't until He Jingyuan arrived with reinforcements from Jizhou that he dared to relax.

With only ten thousand or so raw recruits left under his command, he couldn't afford to keep them idle. Now that the main forces from Jizhou were holding the line, he wanted to train his new troops as quickly as possible.

When Grand Tutor Tao approached him to recommend Fan Changyu for enlistment, Tang Peiyi agreed without hesitation.

If not for Fan Changyu intercepting and killing those three scouts, Lucheng would have fallen, and he would have had to accept execution.

He said, "That young woman actually managed to kill Shi Hu—such ferocity is rare even among men! To have such talent under my command is truly my good fortune."

But Grand Tutor Tao replied, "Jade must be polished to become a gem. Let her temper herself further first."

When Fan Changyu was assigned to the ranks, she discovered she hadn't started as a common soldier or even a squad leader—she was directly appointed as a Squad Leader, commanding forty-nine men. Xie Wu, to her surprise, was assigned to her unit.

The soldiers under her command, realizing their Squad Leader was a delicate-looking young woman, began whispering among themselves.

"What's a woman doing in the army?"

Fan Changyu's immediate superior, Guo Baihu, was a burly, bearded brute—tall and imposing like an iron tower. The officers leading the new recruits had all been transferred from Jizhou's regular army.

When he learned one of his Squad Leaders was a woman, he nearly choked on his anger. Right in front of the troops, he sneered, "Some general's precious daughter must be here to chase glory again. Why not just make her a captain and surround her with layers of bodyguards? Throwing her into my unit—if she so much as scrapes her knee, my decades of service will be for nothing!"

His words were meant to put Fan Changyu in her place. A thin-skinned person, publicly humiliated like this, would likely quit on the spot.

This was exactly the outcome Guo Baihu hoped for. After all, whether it was a general's daughter or some high official's son sent to "gain experience," none of them wanted to deal with such burdens.

You couldn't discipline them, couldn't scold them, and on the battlefield, you'd have to risk your life protecting them.

If they got hurt, there'd be hell to pay—let alone the fact that battlefields were unpredictable, and death was commonplace. If anything happened to them, the higher-ups would demand heads, and the entire unit would suffer.

So when noble sons were sent to the army for "training," the generals had an unspoken rule: give them an empty title, set up a tent for them, and assign bodyguards to protect the little treasures.

No need for merit—just avoid mistakes.

Once their "training" was done, they'd be credited with a few insignificant achievements and sent back unharmed. That was the ideal outcome.

As for the daughters of military families who came for experience, most did know martial arts and had passion in their hearts—but they were too naive. Killing a few people was nothing compared to the hellish reality of war.

These daughters of military families, often the treasured pearls of their generals, were never allowed to face any real danger on the battlefield. More often than not, the number of enemies they killed paled in comparison to the common soldiers who died protecting them.

Thus, during actual battles, the high-ranking generals seldom permitted these young women from military families to participate in combat.

As for those useless young masters, they were even less worth mentioning.

The only descendants of military families who truly earned the respect of the common soldiers were those who rose through the ranks step by step, relying on genuine military achievements.

The army did not conscript female soldiers, which was why Guo Baihu naturally assumed Fan Changyu had enlisted through connections. Being a martial artist himself, he could tell from her steady breathing that she was trained. This only fueled his anger further, as he suspected she was trying to emulate those descendants of military families who started from the bottom.

He couldn't care less about others' lofty ambitions, but if those ambitions might get him and his men killed needlessly on the battlefield, he despised them.

Unaware of these underlying sentiments, Fan Changyu remained composed even as Guo Baihu openly challenged her. There was no trace of embarrassment on her face as she stood there confidently.

She had no reason to be upset over others' misunderstandings.

Xie Wu spoke up for her: "Squad Leader Fan fought at First Line Gorge. She killed Shi Hu and earned her place in the ranks through real military merit."

At this, murmurs erupted among the troops.

Since enlisting, they had all heard of Shi Hu's fearsome reputation—a monster who delighted in devouring raw flesh and drinking human blood, whose spiked hammers had claimed no fewer than eight hundred lives.

Could this slender young woman before them, clad in the uniform of Jizhou's soldiers, really have killed Shi Hu?

Guo Baihu scrutinized Fan Changyu anew, as if gauging whether she truly possessed the courage to slay Shi Hu.

Someone who had seen Fan Changyu carrying rocks during the dam construction immediately shouted, "I know Squad Leader Fan! When she was working on the dam upstream in Jizhou, she carried stones weighing over three hundred jin down the mountain without breaking a sweat!"

With such concrete evidence, the soldiers' gazes toward Fan Changyu grew even more reverent.

Xie Wu wanted to mention her bear-hunting exploits, but since he hadn't witnessed it himself, it might sound like boasting. Seeing the troops' newfound respect for Fan Changyu, he swallowed his words.

Guo Baihu asked Fan Changyu, "What weapon are you skilled with?"

After a moment's thought, she replied, "A butcher's knife."

A few soldiers couldn't suppress their muffled laughter.

Guo Baihu's expression darkened. "You go into battle with a butcher's knife?" he barked.

Fan Changyu nodded honestly.

Another wave of stifled laughter rippled through the crowd.

Guo Baihu was now thoroughly incensed. Convinced she couldn't possibly have killed Shi Hu, he assumed someone had fabricated the achievement to bolster her reputation—a common enough practice.

He no longer cared about sparing her dignity. "Fine!" he roared, clenching his fists like sandbags, his brutish aura flaring. "Let's see what your butcher's knife can do! Come on!"

The soldiers, never expecting such excitement on the first day of reorganization, erupted in cheers and shouts of encouragement.

The commotion drew the attention of the generals on the platform.

Tang Peiyi asked, "What's going on over there?"

Fan Changyu's formation was positioned at the very rear of the drill ground. From the high platform, one could only see a dense block of shadowy figures standing in neat squares, making it impossible to discern what was happening at the back.

A personal guard immediately responded, "This subordinate will go and check."

No sooner had he left than another guard arrived to report, "General, a visit from Young Master Li!"

Tang Peiyi asked, "Which Young Master Li?"

The guard wiped his sweat and replied, "Grandson of Grand Tutor Li—Young Master Li Huaian!"

Tang Peiyi immediately glanced at Grand Tutor Tao. Grand Tutor Li had assumed his position two years after Tao's resignation. Though he led the Qingliu faction, half the court officials were his disciples, making him a figure who seemed poised to rival Wei Yan.

He remarked, "After the Wu'an Marquis went to Kangcheng to suppress the remnants of the rebels, the court's military provisions were delivered by water. Li Huaian also serves as the Army Supervisor and has come to verify the provisions. He should be seeking Lord He, yet he's come to me instead—likely for the Grand Tutor's sake. Will you see him, Grand Tutor?"

Grand Tutor Tao merely smiled. "Since this young man knows I'm here, avoiding him today won't help tomorrow. Let's meet him. I'd like to see what kind of child that old man Li has raised."

Tang Peiyi then instructed the guard, "Bring him over."

In moments, Li Huaian, dressed in a pale blue scholar's robe, was escorted over by the guards.

Like Gongsun Yin, he was a scholar, but his features were plainer in comparison. Yet, he resembled a cup of mild tea—subtle at first but growing more refined with time. His uniquely upright and gentle demeanor made him seem like the most refined disciple at a sage's side.

His eyes immediately landed on the silver-haired Grand Tutor Tao. With a respectful bow, he greeted warmly, "This one pays respects to the Grand Tutor."

His gaze then shifted to Tang Peiyi beside him, and he added, "And to the General."

Given Grand Tutor Tao's seniority and former rank, it was natural for him to address Li Huaian first. Smiling at the young man before him, he said, "You resemble your grandfather in his youth. At first glance, this old man almost thought he had somehow grown younger over the years."

It was unclear whether this was mere jest or carried deeper meaning.

Li Huaian simply smiled faintly and replied, "Grandfather's health has declined in recent years. He cannot match the Grand Tutor's vigor."

Grand Tutor Tao stroked his beard and chuckled. "This old man enjoys leisure. With so many beautiful mountains and rivers yet unseen, and no burdens on my shoulders, of course I'm more carefree than your grandfather."

Li Huaian said, "It is only because the Grand Tutor knew when to step back. Grandfather often says that if he could possess even half of your wisdom, he would be content in this life."

Grand Tutor Tao's smile remained, the deep wrinkles on his face creasing further as he joked, "That old man grows less content with age. With disciples filling half the court, is his knowledge still not enough?"

Li Huaian maintained his polite smile, his tone still gentle. "Half the court's officials still pale in comparison to pillars of the state like the Wu'an Marquis."

Tang Peiyi was a rough man, but having risen to his position, he was no fool. The more he listened to their exchange, the stranger it seemed. Just as he was considering whether to interject and steer the conversation elsewhere, the guard he had sent out earlier came running back, panting heavily.

The guard saluted and reported, "General, it's a hundred-household officer and his female squad engaged in a martial contest!"

Li Huaian looked surprised. "General Tang has women serving under his command?"

Fan Changyu had been recommended to join the army by Grand Tutor Tao. Tang Peiyi was unsure whether to temporarily conceal this fact when he heard thunderous cheers erupt from the rear of the military formation.

Li Huaian glanced in that direction, seemingly intrigued. "Can we observe the martial arts competition in the army?"

There was no rule prohibiting spectators, and Tang Peiyi couldn't fabricate one on the spot. He could only grit his teeth and say, "Yes."

The deafening cheers erupted when Fan Changyu executed a perfect shoulder throw, sending Guo Baihu flying.

Guo Baihu had challenged her bare-handed, and she couldn't exactly bully him—after all, the last person who'd fought her one-handed while she wielded a boning knife was Xie Zheng.

The fall was solid. Guo Baihu clutched his waist, grimacing as he staggered to his feet. Glaring at Fan Changyu standing nearby, he growled, "I'm better with a blade than fists. Dare to pick up a weapon and fight me again?"

Changyu agreed readily. "Sure."

Soon, a weapon rack was brought forward.

Guo Baihu selected a Yanyue blade. Changyu was also most skilled with long-handled sabers, but considering the crowd, she didn't want to embarrass Guo Baihu too badly.

After some thought, she picked up two massive iron hammers.

The hammers had short handles and, unlike blades, wouldn't leave gashes with a single slash. If she held back her strength, she could exchange a few more moves with him.

Unbeknownst to her, her slender frame—smaller than most men's—paired with her gentle, harmless expression while wielding two heavy hammers created an utterly bizarre sight.

Guo Baihu swung his blade with a fierce whoosh, bellowing as he charged. Changyu didn't engage at first, dodging instead.

Seeing her nimble movements despite the hammers, Guo Baihu's confidence wavered. Frustrated, he barked, "Stop dodging! Take my strike!"

Changyu obliged. When the blade came crashing down toward her face, the watching soldiers gasped in horror.

Xie Wu, though confident in her skills, kept a close eye on every move. If danger arose, he'd intervene immediately.

Guo Baihu realized too late that his strike was unstoppable, and Changyu wasn't even attempting to block. Cold sweat drenched his back—whether she was the general's daughter or not, her presence here meant powerful backing. Killing her accidentally would be the end of him.

A deafening clang rang out, stinging eardrums.

The descending blade was caught between the two hammers, halted mid-air.

Guo Baihu's hands trembled violently from the impact, his palms numb and aching. Sweat poured down his forehead.

Those nearby saw how Changyu had trapped the blade with the hammers, but those farther back doubted such a strike could be stopped so easily. Murmurs spread.

"Is Guo Baihu going easy on her because she's pretty?"

"Losing face for a beauty's favor? I'd do the same!"

Then, Changyu released the hammers.

Sandwiched in between, the blade of Guo Baihu's broadsword shattered like ice, tinkling as the fragments scattered across the ground.

Silence fell instantly both inside and outside the training grounds.

Even the soldier who had earlier suspected Guo Baihu of going easy on her swallowed hard with difficulty.

To shatter a descending broadsword with a single hammer strike—what kind of monstrous strength did that require?

Amid the pin-drop silence outside the training field, applause suddenly rang out. Fan Changyu turned her head to see Grand Tutor Tao, Tang Peiyi, and a group of officers approaching, with Li Huaian among them.

As the commanding general and with this being the training grounds, it was Tang Peiyi's place to speak. He praised, "An impressive display! A reward is in order!"

The soldiers cheered for Fan Changyu, who had previously observed military salutes during her time in the army. She clasped her fists in imitation and said, "This humble officer thanks the general!"

Li Huaian, recognizing her, seemed genuinely surprised. "I wondered which of General Tang's female officers could be so formidable. So it's Miss Fan."

Fan Changyu had no idea why he was in Chongzhou but remembered he was an official. She saluted him properly, addressing him, "Lord Li."

Not only Grand Tutor Tao but even Tang Peiyi looked puzzled. "You two know each other?"

Li Huaian smiled gracefully. "Miss Fan once saved my life."

Fan Changyu quickly replied, "It was nothing more than a small favor."

Xie Wu, who had been among the hundred cavalrymen Xie Zheng brought back to Qingping County, clearly remembered Fan Changyu protecting Li Huaian. Watching Li Huaian's subtly ambiguous attitude toward her now, he suddenly frowned deeply.

Li Huaian wasn't at all surprised by Fan Changyu's reserved politeness. Ever since she learned his identity and sought his help in investigating the records of her parents' deaths, she had addressed him respectfully as "Lord Li" without fail.

He said, "What a fortunate coincidence this journey has been. When you left alone for Chongzhou, saying you were searching for your younger sister, you left an Aunt Zhao at the Jizhou Prefecture office. When I set out for Chongzhou, the old woman, worried about you, begged me to bring her here to find you."

Half stunned, half delighted, Fan Changyu exclaimed, "Aunt Zhao?"

Li Huaian nodded with a smile. "She's currently staying where I'm lodged."

The military had just finished reorganizing the rosters that day, and no drills were scheduled, so soldiers could request leave for the afternoon.

After the reorganization concluded, Fan Changyu requested half a day's leave to bring Aunt Zhao back to the courtyard she had rented.

Xie Wu naturally took leave to accompany her.

As the two boarded the Li family's carriage, Li Huaian looked at Xie Wu, his expression still warm and amiable, and asked without malice, "Might I ask who this young man is?"

Fan Changyu was starting from the bottom ranks in the army, and as a woman in the military, she already faced enough scrutiny. Revealing her connection to Xie Zheng would only make things harder for her. Though Xie Wu wanted this smiling fox to back off, he knew better than to cause trouble for Fan Changyu. Stiffly, he replied, "I'm my squad leader's personal attendant!"

Hearing this, Li Huaian chuckled lightly, his demeanor still nothing but gentle and harmless. To Fan Changyu, he said, "Congratulations, Miss Fan. With your martial prowess, you're bound to achieve great things in the army."

Fan Changyu replied, "I only hope for peace in the world."

When they finally met Aunt Zhao, the old woman took one look at Fan Changyu in her military uniform and, upon learning she had joined the army, burst into tears, hugging her tightly.

Xie Wu followed them the entire way. Wherever Li Huaian was, he was there too. Li Huaian noticed the young man's inexplicable hostility toward him but still responded with nothing more than a polite smile.

Fan Changyu took Aunt Zhao back to the small courtyard she had rented. Since it was quite a distance and the surrounding towns had been devastated by war, making it impossible to borrow a carriage, Li Huaian offered to have his coachman take them part of the way.

On the way back, Xie Wu sat outside with the coachman while Fan Changyu and Aunt Zhao chatted inside the carriage, catching up on what had happened during their time apart.

Xie Wu kept his ears perked the entire time, afraid to miss even a single word about that Li fellow.

When they arrived at the small courtyard, Changning, who hadn't seen Aunt Zhao in a long time, let out a loud cry and threw herself into Aunt Zhao's arms, sobbing uncontrollably.

Aunt Zhao, recalling the terror of Changning's disappearance, couldn't help but cry as well.

Fan Changyu was busy comforting the young and the old, while Xie Wu exchanged a glance with Xie Qi. Seizing the chance while preparing dinner in the kitchen, he quickly told Xie Qi about their encounter with Li Huaian that day. "Tonight, you write a letter and have the Gyrfalcon deliver it to the Marquis," he said.

Kneading the dough in the basin with extra force, he added indignantly, "That pretty boy has designs on our lady!"

Chapter 96

Kang City, inside the central military tent.

A scout hurried in from outside, kneeling on one knee with a fist salute: "Marquis, the rebels in Kang City still stubbornly defend the gates and refuse to come out!"

The man seated at the head wore dark robes instead of armor, his figure tall and slender. His long, pale fingers held a military manual, his phoenix eyes calm and unruffled, as if he had anticipated this situation. He simply said, "Continue the siege until the rebels can no longer even fill the gaps on the city walls with heads."

The scout quickly accepted the order and left.

Xie Zheng tossed aside the military manual and called for his personal guard: "Bring me my armor."

Gongsun Yin, standing nearby, asked, "Are you going to challenge them to battle?"

Xie Zheng replied, "The remaining forces in Kang City are no longer a threat, but Sui Yuanqing remains a hidden danger. With morale crumbling inside the city, if I challenge him, he won't dare refuse."

Gongsun Yin understood the stakes. Sui Yuanqing was the only capable fighter left in Kang City, and Xie Zheng intended to eliminate him before leaving.

Challenging Sui Yuanqing after two days of siege was like placing him on a burning pyre. If he accepted, it would play right into Xie Zheng's hands, allowing him to remove this major threat on the battlefield. If he refused, the already low morale within the city would plummet further.

Below the city walls of Kang City, the Yanzhou Army, which had been fiercely attacking, suddenly halted. Before the defenders on the walls could catch their breath in relief, they saw the Yanzhou Army's formation shift.

The black ant-like ranks split apart, creating a narrow path wide enough for two men. Through the swirling dust and sand, a single rider on a black horse slowly advanced from the rear to the front of the formation. The qilin-shaped shoulder guards gleamed solemnly and fiercely under the scorching sun, while a dark cloak trailed behind him over the horse's back. In one hand, he held a black-shafted halberd adorned with golden dragon patterns.

The sight of this black-armored warrior on his steed alone sent shivers down the spines of the defenders on the walls, their legs trembling uncontrollably. When they recognized the dark iron halberd with its dragon-patterned blade, their faces paled further in terror.

"The Black Golden Dragon Halberd—it's the Wu'an Marquis!"

"If the Wu'an Marquis has come personally, Kang City will surely fall today!"

Ordinary generals would never dare wield weapons bearing dragon motifs. That black-and-gold dragon halberd had been forged by hundreds of craftsmen under imperial decree, bestowed upon the Wu'an Marquis after he reclaimed Jinzhou and avenged the humiliation of ceding territory seventeen years prior, greatly pleasing the emperor.

When he was enfeoffed as the Wu'an Marquis, the emperor declared, "With a Martial Marquis like this, our Great Yin shall be at peace."

In today's court, any proud and ambitious military officer aspired to surpass the Wu'an Marquis. Yet, his long list of battle achievements remained an insurmountable peak none could ever hope to reach in their lifetimes.

Below the city walls, two rows of war drums were set up on chariots. As the deep, resonant drumbeats echoed across the open battlefield, the defenders on the walls broke out in goosebumps, their hands shaking so badly they could barely grip their swords.

The archers stationed at the battlements trembled like chicken claws, their arrows losing all accuracy. Amid the drumbeats, the young general on horseback lifted his head to gaze at the city walls. His strikingly handsome, jade-carved features were framed by cold, indifferent phoenix eyes as he raised his halberd and pointed it at the walls, shouting arrogantly, "Sui Yuanqing! Come out and face your death!"

The messenger on the walls scrambled away in panic to deliver the news.

Though Kang City had only been under siege for a few days, the lord's residence was already shrouded in gloom.

It was common knowledge that the one besieging Kang City was the Wu'an Marquis. Not only were the low-ranking soldiers terrified, even the servants in the city lord's manor knew it was only a matter of time before the city fell.

But fear aside, no one dared discuss the war. Over the past few days, several servants who rashly claimed Kang City wouldn't hold for long had been beaten to death with clubs in the manor.

The messenger who had rushed back from the city gates hurried through the deep courtyards and was finally led to Sui Yuanqing.

Kneeling on one knee, his voice trembling, he said, "Young Master, the Wu'an Marquis is challenging you to battle at the city gates, demanding you come out and fight."

As summer approached, the sunlight was scorching. Half of the bamboo curtain by the study window was rolled up, letting in a blaze of light at the entrance, while the inner part remained untouched by the sun, casting a gloomy shadow.

Sui Yuanqing sat on the floor with disheveled hair and bare feet. The low table in front of him was cluttered with books, brushes, and ink.

After falling into Xie Zheng's hands and suffering greatly, he had been rescued and spent many days recuperating. Though his physical wounds had healed, he had grown much thinner, and the gloom between his brows had deepened. Hearing the messenger, he replied darkly, "No. Just keep defending the gates."

The messenger hesitated. "Young Master, the morale of our soldiers is collapsing. If this continues, Kang City might fall without a fight. You once defeated the Wu'an Marquis on the Chongzhou battlefield. If you go out to fight, it could at least rally the troops' spirits."

Sui Yuanqing sneered. "If I truly go out to fight, I'll be falling right into Xie Zheng's trap. He abandoned Chongzhou to come here and capture me— isn't it because he's desperate to escape the court's factional struggles?"

As long as Chongzhou remains unbroken, he won't dare step through Kang City's gates."

The messenger had no choice but to withdraw.

Once alone in the study, Sui Yuanqing suddenly let out a furious roar, sweeping the books and scrolls off the low table. The inkstone filled with ink crashed to the floor, spilling black ink across the wooden boards.

Sui Yuanqing braced his hands against the table, the veins on his slender hands bulging. His pale jaw was clenched tightly, his teeth gritted.

Once upon a time, surpassing Xie Zheng had been his obsession. After all, for so many years, he had lived in Xie Zheng's shadow, studying what he studied, practicing the techniques he mastered.

When they first clashed on the Chongzhou battlefield, he thought he had won—that Xie Zheng was now his defeated foe.

Only now did he realize how naive he had been.

He even had a premonition—that he might die by Xie Zheng's hand.

This feeling was like a fog settling over his heart, making him grow gloomier by the day. Lately, he had shut himself in his study.

He needed to stay calm. As long as he found Xie Zheng's weakness and the reason for his sudden attack, he could still find a way to counter him.

Sui Yuanqing closed his eyes heavily.

Footsteps approached hesitantly from outside.

When Sui Yuanqing lifted his gaze, the young girl startled, nearly dropping the plate of pastries in her hands.

Trembling, she set the plate of exquisitely made snacks on the low table and stammered, "It's me, cousin."

A pampered girl from the inner chambers, her face was no larger than a palm, her skin smooth as fine jade. Her almond-shaped eyes glistened with tears, timid and delicate—like pear blossoms battered by rain.

Sui Yuanqing narrowed his eyes. This was a beauty entirely unlike the wildcat he had encountered—that one had a fierce temper, clawing, scratching, biting.

The woman before him resembled a delicate flower trembling as it bloomed in the rain, just waiting to be plucked.

She was too fragile, as if anyone could do anything to her, and she would be utterly powerless to resist. Even if she did resist, it would likely only be with those tearful eyes silently weeping at her tormentor.

When Sui Yuanqing raised his hand to grip her chin, she trembled all over, flustered as she picked up an exquisitely crafted pastry from the tray to offer him. "Mother said... that Cousin has been exhausting himself to defend Kang City these past days, so the kitchen prepared some pastries and asked me to bring them over."

Sui Yuanqing didn't open his mouth. Gazing at that delicate, beautiful face, he asked indifferently, "Why are you trembling so much, Cousin? What are you afraid of?"

The woman shook her head in panic.

Sui Yuanqing released her chin, took the pastry she had tried to feed him, and examined it. Suddenly, he smiled and instead brought it to her lips. "I don't care for sweets. You should have it, Cousin."

Her face instantly paled, and she shook her head frantically. "I... I don't like them either."

Holding the pastry, Sui Yuanqing lowered his head, his smile still lingering but his expression darkening as he asked softly, "Why?"

The woman's nerves finally gave way, and she broke down in tears. "Cousin, you must flee! Father heard that the Wu'an Marquis himself is challenging us at the city gates. Fearing our family would be executed if the city falls, he had the kitchen prepare these poisoned pastries to kill you. He planned to cut off your head and surrender it at the gates."

Sui Yuanqing grinned, his smile widening. "Is that so?"

With that, he strode straight to the sword rack, took his blade, and walked out.

The Yan army was attacking the city, and the main forces were concentrated at the four main gates. Only a few hundred household guards remained at the city lord's residence.

The woman thought Sui Yuanqing had taken his sword to escape the estate. Weak-limbed, she stumbled out of the study, her mind in turmoil as

she wondered how to report back. But then, she heard a chorus of agonized wails from the front hall.

Her heart lurched. The delicate shawl draped over her arm fell to the ground, but she didn't stop to pick it up. Lifting her skirts, she rushed toward the source of the cries. When she entered the hall and saw the room filled with corpses, she nearly fainted on the spot.

The sight of her parents lying in pools of blood made her legs give out, and she collapsed to the floor. Overwhelmed by grief and terror, she couldn't even cry—only tears streamed down her face like broken beads. It took her a long moment to regain her voice, and she let out a heart-wrenching scream: "Father! Mother!"

She looked at Sui Yuanqing, standing in the center of the hall with his sword dripping thick blood, as if he were a demon. Her voice was choked with sobs. "Why... why did you kill my parents? With your skills, you could have escaped! You could have just left the estate..."

Sui Yuanqing watched coldly as the fragile woman wept herself nearly breathless, his lips curling slightly.

This cousin of his—he couldn't tell if she had been raised to be this naive or if she was simply foolish.

Or perhaps the Liu family knew all too well that nobles only married women groomed by prestigious families to be matriarchs, while a beauty taken as a concubine ought to be gentle, submissive, and simple-minded. That was why they had raised their daughter to be this weak and easily bullied.

In a way, this woman had been a discarded pawn of her family long ago.

Pitifully, she was still weeping like this for parents who had been ready to give her away as a plaything at any moment.

He crouched down before her, touching her face with his bloodstained hand as he countered, "They were all ready to offer my head in surrender. Why shouldn't I kill them?"

Liu Wan'er's snow-white cheeks bore the bloody imprint of his fingers. Her lips parted, but no words came out. Her long lashes fluttered as tears streamed down her face, making her appear even more fragile and pitiful.

She was breathtakingly beautiful—the kind of beauty that would soften any man's heart.

Yet, for some reason, Sui Yuanqing suddenly recalled the cold, ruthless look in Fan Changyu's eyes when she had stabbed him with a blade.

In the past, he had always favored beauties like Liu Wan'er—docile, delicate, clinging to him like vines that would wither without a tree to support them.

But after seeing so many of these identical beauties, their faces blurred together in his memory. They all had the same temperament, the same fragility. Whether one more or one less lingered by his side, he likely wouldn't even remember.

Among the nobility, the only thing worth competing over was which of these beauties was the most stunning. But beauty was fleeting. In just three to five years, fresh-faced girls, tender as spring onions, would catch the eyes of the powerful again.

Who still remembered what the beauty they had once fought over looked like?

It was no different from the courtesans in brothels—once one grew old, another would take her place.

After encountering so many identical beauties, it was the wildcat that knew only how to wound that lingered in his thoughts.

Sui Yuanqing withdrew his hand, looking down at the woman collapsed on the floor, her body trembling with sobs. "You're a good girl," he said. "You told me the truth. I won't kill you."

He sheathed his sword and stood, walking to the door before pausing. Without turning back, he added, "From now on, you are no longer the daughter of the Liu family. Hide among the common folk and live well."

Liu Wan'er stared blankly at Sui Yuanqing's retreating figure, then at her parents' lifeless bodies, their eyes still wide open. In all her sixteen years, she had never faced such upheaval. Now, beyond weeping, her mind was filled only with fear and confusion about the unknown.

She didn't even think of how he had just slain her parents—instinctively, she scrambled to her feet, clinging to the doorframe as she staggered after him, sobbing, "Cousin..."

The midday sun blazed fiercely. Sui Yuanqing hadn't left his study in so long that when he passed through the moon gate, he stopped, squinting at the bright orb in the sky.

The glare momentarily robbed his vision of color, plunging the world into darkness.

He smiled lazily, as if calmly accepting his fate.

There was another way to live in this world—by embracing death.

The Yanzhou Army had been taunting below the city gates for hours, yet Sui Yuanqing never appeared. Instead, they were met with a truce banner hung from the battlements.

The soldiers below only jeered louder, while the defenders atop the walls looked haggard, their expressions almost numb. After enduring the daily torment of siege, they now wished the Yanzhou Army would just take Kangcheng swiftly and be done with it.

When Xie Zheng and Gongsun Yin returned to camp, the latter fumed, fanning himself furiously. "That coward Sui Yuanqing! He dared challenge you so arrogantly at First Line Gorge, and now he hides behind his walls like a dog with its tail between its legs! The shame of it!"

Xie Zheng said, "He didn't take the bait to engage in battle, which means he understands that I'm stalling him here while waiting for Chongzhou to fall first. But after today, the rebel morale in Kang City is completely shattered. If there are any dissenters in their ranks, internal strife will keep them occupied for a while. They won't dare to launch another offensive anytime soon."

Gongsun Yin suppressed his anger and said, "Alright, alright. You're planning to go to Chongzhou now, aren't you?"

He clicked his tongue twice. "We agreed on three days, but you can't even wait two and a half?"

Xie Zheng replied calmly, "This Marquis has some private matters to attend to. Since Sui Yuanqing knows I'm here, he won't act rashly. After I leave, have someone impersonate me in the tent."

Gongsun Yin couldn't help but be suspicious. "Going to see her is already a private matter. What other private matters do you have?"

Xie Zheng said, "I had a weapon custom-made for her."

He had long heard from Xie Wu about how Fan Changyu was nearly overpowered by Shi Hu during their last encounter due to lacking a proper weapon. Almost immediately after descending the mountain, he had

ordered a blacksmith to forge a weapon for her, intending it as a surprise. Little did he expect she'd have her own plans to join the army and head to the Chongzhou battlefield.

By his calculations, the weapon should be ready by now. He planned to retrieve it and deliver it to her personally.

Remembering his last humiliating experience, Gongsun Yin cut him off at the mere mention of the topic. "Enough, enough! Just go already!"

Just then, a personal guard entered the tent holding a rolled-up letter. "Marquis, the Gyrfalcon has returned with a message."

The Gyrfalcon had been taken by Fan Changyu, so its sudden return likely meant news from her. Xie Zheng took the letter and scanned it quickly. His previously composed expression darkened instantly. He tossed the letter into the brazier used for burning important documents and said coldly, "Prepare my horse!"

Gongsun Yin's curiosity was instantly piqued. "What happened?"

But Xie Zheng didn't answer. He simply lifted the tent flap and strode out.

Noticing the letter in the brazier hadn't completely burned and had been blown out by the wind, Gongsun Yin couldn't resist picking it up to look. Though most of the letter had been charred, the words at the end remained clearly visible: "Li Huaian has improper intentions toward your wife."

Gongsun Yin burst out laughing, unable to suppress his schadenfreude. "Xie Jiuhan, oh Xie Jiuhan! Your karma has come for you far too quickly!"

Meanwhile, far away in Chongzhou, Fan Changyu had just finished running over ten miles around the mountains with the training troops. The exhausted soldiers collapsed like overcooked noodles. When someone spotted a river ahead, the sweat-drenched soldiers scrambled up, clamoring to wash off in the water.

The weather was growing increasingly hot, and Fan Changyu had worked up quite a sweat too. But as a woman, joining them in the river wasn't an option. She stood in the shade of a tree, drinking some water instead.

Initially, she had thought Grand Tutor Tao securing her the rank of squad leader was rather ostentatious. But after being assigned her own

tent—something only squad leaders and above were entitled to—she realized his thoughtful consideration.

When she went to thank him, Grand Tutor Tao explained, "If I'd made you a squad leader of ten, with Xie Wu gone, you'd only have eight to manage—something you could do blindfolded. Once you've learned one plus one equals two, relearning it would be a waste of time. That's why I started you as a squad leader."

She needed to learn how to manage an increasing number of people—dozens now, but soon hundreds, thousands, even tens of thousands.

With so many under her command, she couldn't personally oversee each one, so she had to promote those who could serve her purposes.

This involved something even more complex—winning people's loyalty.

Xie Zheng had once said that Fan Changyu wasn't good at this. She was used to being straightforward, and suddenly having to consider so many twists and turns was indeed a challenge for her.

But on the battlefield, the low-ranking soldiers first sought survival before they could pursue prospects, wealth, and other worldly things.

Compared to that, the hearts of the people here weren't all that complicated.

Fan Changyu now resembled a toddler just learning to walk, stumbling along this path.

Her earlier duel with Guo Baihu had turned out to be a blessing in disguise, as it had earned her some authority in the army. At least among the hundred men under Guo Baihu's command, no one dared to look down on her anymore.

The squad leaders and platoon leaders under her also held her in high regard.

Xie Wu had told her that among these people, some might become her trusted aides in the future, or perhaps none would be suitable.

She had to figure out for herself who could be used and how; for those who couldn't, since they were already under her command, how should she handle them...

Nowadays, Fan Changyu spent her days following drills, squeezing in time to study military texts under Grand Tutor Tao. At night, when she lay

down to sleep, she either pondered the parts of the texts she didn't understand or mulled over the art of employing people.

But perhaps because she was too exhausted, she often fell into a deep sleep within moments.

During this rare moment of leisure, Fan Changyu stared at the few men under her who hadn't gone to the riverbank, once again contemplating the selection of trusted aides when she suddenly sneezed several times in a row without warning.

Xie Wu, who was standing guard beside her, quickly asked, "Squad leader, have you caught a chill?"

Fan Changyu waved her hand. "The old saying goes, 'One sneeze means someone's thinking of you, two means they're cursing you, three means they're talking about you.' Maybe Ning Niang is missing me."

No sooner had she spoken than she sneezed again.

Fan Changyu froze for a moment.

Xie Wu, recalling the letter he had Xie Qi send back, suddenly felt a pang of guilt.

Chapter 97

The battle between the imperial court's army and the rebels of Chongzhou had been raging for nearly a year.

All military equipment, including armor and weapons, was issued by the Armory Bureau. However, damaged weapons and armor during wartime couldn't simply be sent back to the capital for repairs. Thus, stationed troops often requisitioned nearby weapon workshops in the prefectures.

In addition to repairing damaged weapons, the blacksmiths in these workshops could also forge new arms for the army.

Although He Jingyuan held military authority over Jizhou, Xie Zheng could mobilize the entire northwestern forces, including He Jingyuan's Jizhou troops.

Initially, only the Xie Family Army from Huizhou had engaged the Chongzhou rebels. Later, when the Northern Turks attacked Jinzhou, the Xie Family Army moved north to reinforce the defense. It was then that Changxin Wang attempted to seize Jizhou by advancing south, dragging the Jizhou army into the conflict.

Before He Jingyuan led the remaining Jizhou forces to Chongzhou to join Tang Zhaoyi, the only Jizhou troops that had set foot in Chongzhou territory were the ten thousand or so new recruits under Tang Zhaoyi's command.

Tang Zhaoyi was a cautious man. While besieging Chongzhou, he couldn't be certain whether Xie Zheng, after dealing with the rebels at First Line Gorge, would head to Chongzhou to assist in crushing the rebellion. Thus, he dared not rashly take over the weapon workshops near Chongzhou.

Even now, those workshops were still managed by the remaining Huizhou forces under Xie Zheng's command. Therefore, when Xie Zheng went to retrieve the weapon forged for Fan Changyu, he had no need to conceal his identity.

The young officer stationed there hurried out to greet him upon hearing the announcement: "Greetings, Marquis."

Xie Zheng handed the reins of his warhorse to the soldier who stepped forward and strode straight into the camp, asking, "How is the Horse-Cutting Sword coming along?"

The young officer quickened his pace to keep up with Xie Zheng and replied, "One more tempering, and it will be ready."

Upon entering the forging workshop, a wave of heat struck them, as if stepping into a steamer.

Rows of furnaces stretched deep into the workshop, seemingly endless at a glance.

Shirtless blacksmiths stood at their stations, swinging hammers in rhythmic succession against the iron on their anvils. Their muscles bulged with power, and the clanging of metal mixed with deep, forceful chants, stirring a sense of awe in those who heard it.

The furnaces blazed fiercely, each manned by an assistant tasked with operating the bellows. They too were bare-chested, drenched in sweat.

The young officer led Xie Zheng to the furnace designated for forging long-handled weapons. Beside it stood a temporary rack holding a Horse-Cutting Sword—a blade three chi long with a five-chi handle.

The gleaming blade and dark iron shaft bore faint layered patterns under the firelight, a testament to the countless folds and hammer strikes it had endured.

The young officer said, "The blade is made of hundred-fold steel."

Xie Zheng's gaze swept over it briefly. He lifted the hilt, testing its weight with a swift flourish. The blade sang like a tiger's roar, its wind forcing the young officer to step back.

Examining the cold, sharp edge, Xie Zheng asked, "If the blade is already sharpened, why temper it again?"

The young officer couldn't answer, but the old blacksmith responsible for forging the weapon, hammering away at a new piece without looking up, rasped, "Ancestral rules dictate that a weapon destined for the battlefield must be tempered once more after its first bloodletting before it can be deemed complete."

Perhaps from years spent by the furnace, the old blacksmith's voice was as rough and grating as a cracked gong, almost jarring to the ear.

These are all folk rumors. Weapons that have tasted blood on the battlefield carry heavy malice. Since ancient times, few military generals have met peaceful ends, hence the belief that overly bloodthirsty weapons bring misfortune to their owners. Therefore, when forging weapons, after the blade is first sharpened and bloodied, it must be returned to the furnace for another round of tempering—said to subdue the weapon's spirit.

Fearing Xie Zheng's displeasure, the young officer hurriedly explained, "This old master shares the same lineage as Yun Yazi, who once forged the Marquis' halberd. If not for the fact that this Horse-Cutting Sword is also being forged with dark iron, I doubt I could have persuaded him to come out of seclusion."

Dark iron was precious, and ordinary blacksmiths dared not casually use such valuable material to forge weapons. Even renowned master smiths rarely had access to such fine materials—most were commissioned by nobility or royalty at great expense.

From the day he first stepped onto the battlefield, Xie Zheng had ceased to believe in superstitions.

But this Horse-Cutting Sword was being forged for Fan Changyu. Even knowing it was mere superstition, he still sought peace of mind.

He asked, "What kind of blood?"

The old smith lifted his aged eyes, illuminated by the furnace flames. One eye was clearly blind, but the other gleamed with the sharpness of a hawk as he met Xie Zheng's gaze fearlessly. "A weapon of slaughter is meant to kill—human blood is best for quenching. Here, we usually use black dog's blood."

The young officer quickly added, "My lord, men have already been sent to fetch black dog's blood."

But Xie Zheng said, "No need for the trouble."

His expression indifferent, he stared at the gleaming blade, then gripped the collar of his robe and tore it off with a sharp tug, revealing his powerfully built torso.

The young officer caught the discarded robe in both hands, realizing his intent, and paled in alarm. "My lord, you mustn't! Your body is worth ten thousand gold—"

Xie Zheng ignored him. Gripping the Horse-Cutting Sword, he spun it in a flourish before slashing it across his own back. The razor-sharp edge instantly carved a deep wound into his muscular flesh.

As the blade completed its arc, blood dripped from its edge in a crimson trail.

The old smith gave Xie Zheng a startled glance before bellowing in his grating voice, "Stoke the flames!"

The men working the bellows frantically pumped, and the furnace roared to life, the heat searing enough to blister skin.

The bloodied sword was returned to the blazing furnace, while the young officer hastily summoned attendants to tend to Xie Zheng's wound.

Once the blade glowed red-hot again, the old smith took up his hammer, meticulously reshaping the metal with precise strikes. When plunged into water, the blade hissed violently, sending up a plume of white steam.

After it cooled completely, the old smith examined the sword closely. The blade now matched the hilt's dark iron hue, its layered forging patterns shimmering with gold and crimson, while the newly tempered edge gleamed like frost. Overcome, he nearly wept.

"It's done... it's done..." he murmured.

The surrounding craftsmen erupted in cheers, crowding around to admire the second weapon ever forged from dark iron.

The old smith polished the edge once more with his tools, wiping away the residue with a cloth. The retempered blade now shone with a deadly brilliance, its sharpness palpable even to the naked eye.

And the swirling gold-and-crimson patterns along the blade exuded an eerie, otherworldly allure.

The old blacksmith reverently presented the Horse-Cutting Sword to Xie Zheng, his voice trembling with emotion: "May the Marquis find a worthy master for this blade. All my life's learning is forged within it. If this weapon and its wielder can one day make their name known across the land, this old man's craft shall not be inferior to that of Yunyazi!"

Xie Zheng replied simply: "Naturally."

The moment he saw this long-handled Horse-Cutting Sword, he knew it was perfect for Fan Changyu.

Equally deadly whether slashing or chopping, the weapon excelled both for cavalry charges and infantry combat.

Xie Zheng ordered the great blade encased in its scabbard. No sooner had he left the camp than a personal guard came galloping from Kangcheng's direction: "My Lord, a letter from Grand Tutor Tao!"

Xie Zheng's brows knitted. Xie Qi had just sent word via gyrfalcon—why would Tao Taifu be writing now? Had something gone wrong in Chongzhou?

Accepting the missive, he read it through before tucking it away. His gaze fell upon the guard: "You'll accompany me to Chongzhou."

The guard hastily assented.

Grand Tutor Tao's letter revealed that Li Huaian had remained with the army since arriving in Chongzhou. The Grand Tutor suspected Li had uncovered some incriminating evidence against He Jingyuan from Jizhou Prefecture's archives, while also confirming the imperial grandson's likely presence in Chongzhou—hence his prolonged military stay.

The dying sunlight fractured in Xie Zheng's eyes as his expression grew colder. Swinging onto his saddle, he jerked the reins sharply and barked: "Hyah!"—

When Grand Tutor Tao sought out He Jingyuan, the latter reacted with mingled surprise and resignation: "After flooding the rebels attacking Lucheng, General Tang dared besiege Chongzhou with fewer than twenty thousand raw recruits. I should have guessed the Grand Tutor was advising him."

Tao Taifu stated: "The northwest has suffered chaos too long. Now that the Li and Wei factions have exhausted their court intrigues, it's time to restore peace to the people."

He Jingyuan sighed: "How our Great Yin's subjects have suffered."

The Grand Tutor pressed: "If you truly care for the people's welfare, was a single act of patronage enough to bind you to Wei Yan's service all these years?"

He Jingyuan smiled bitterly: "The year Chengde Crown Prince and General Xie fell at Jinzhou, our border defenses collapsed completely—Great Yin teetered on the brink. It was the Chancellor who became the empire's backbone. Whatever his faults, the Marquis could only march north to retake Jinzhou because of the strength accumulated during those years of recovery. In that time, the Chancellor accomplished much for Great Yin. Had I not met him, Jingyuan would have been just another frozen corpse by the roadside decades ago. How could I forget such a debt?"

Tao Taifu countered: "That old man of the Li clan postures as righteous, yet his ambition rivals Wei Yan's. At least Wei's faction, having gorged themselves on state coffers, still perform some service for the people. Should Wei fall and the Li faction take over, those starving jackals would first sate their greed before tossing scraps to the populace—by then the treasury would be drained dry."

His gaze sharpened on He Jingyuan: "Though I disagree with Wei Yan's policies, I despise even more how the Li faction starved disaster victims by withholding relief grain—just to manufacture charges against Wei. You know well how the Li patriarch and Wei Yan now compete for credit over Chongzhou. With Li Huaian's arrival, he must have obtained some leverage against you. Wei Yan likely won't protect you now. But remembering how you buried my wife and child years past, I'd spare your life. Will you tell me what evidence Li Huaian has uncovered?"

He Jingyuan listened as Grand Tutor Tao spoke of the burial kindness from years past, and memories flooded his mind, leaving him with an inevitable sense of melancholy.

The reason Grand Tutor Tao had taken a liking to him was not only due to his incorruptible governance and fatherly care for the people but also because, during the chaos of war in earlier years, when the Grand Tutor's wife and child had perished tragically, He Jingyuan had helped erect their graves.

Over twenty years had passed since the deaths of his wife and child, yet Grand Tutor Tao had remained alone all this time. Compared to other scholars who had passed the imperial examinations in the same year, he appeared more than a decade older.

After Xie Zheng completed his studies, the Grand Tutor felt that his lifelong knowledge had finally found a successor, so he resigned from office

and retreated into seclusion—until now, when he had emerged once more.

With Grand Tutor Tao as his assurance, He Jingyuan suddenly recalled the promise he had made to Xie Zheng that day. Rising to his feet, he bowed solemnly and said, "I, He Jingyuan, have clung to life until now only because the burden on my shoulders has yet to be lifted. If that day truly comes, my life is of little consequence. I only beg the Grand Tutor to protect the lives of a pair of sisters in my stead."

Grand Tutor Tao found this answer somewhat peculiar and asked, "Who are they?"

He Jingyuan replied, "They are the daughters of an old friend of mine."

The elderly tutor's brow instinctively furrowed, and then he heard He Jingyuan continue, "That old friend... I believe the Grand Tutor knows of him."

Chapter 98

After returning from He Jingyuan's, Tao Taifu went straight to look for Fan Changyu. Only when he arrived at her camp was he told that she had gone home.

The new recruits did not have to fight yet. The commanders had one day of rest every half-month, so the soldiers under them also got this day off. Those like Fan Changyu, who had their own residence near the garrison, could go home for a day.

Tao Taifu clasped his hands behind his back and glanced at the sky, murmuring, "Fate truly toys with people. How did everything get tangled up together like this?"

By the time Xie Zheng, following the address mentioned in Xie Qi's letter, found the small courtyard Fan Changyu had rented, the sun was nearing dusk.

The courtyard was somewhat secluded, with a stone slab path leading to its gate. From within the courtyard walls, a pomegranate tree extended its branches and leaves. The red blossoms had all fallen, and pomegranate fruits the size of a fingernail dotted the calyxes.

The courtyard gate was open. A matron in her fifties sat on the threshold with a basin of green vegetables, slowly snapping them. A young woman, changed back into her dress, sat on a low stool, helping the matron with the vegetables.

Inside the courtyard, a wiry old man was crafting some sort of utensil, while a young man beside him was engrossed in helping plane wood.

Xie Zheng, leading his horse, paused and watched quietly for a long time.

Perhaps it was the afterglow of the setting sun casting a layer of warm, dusky light over everything, but the scene before him unexpectedly gave him the illusion of home.

The treacherous undercurrents of the imperial court seemed to fade away, leaving only a piece of tranquility in his heart.

The sound of footsteps came from the other end of the path, along with the cheerful sound of a child humming an out-of-tune nursery rhyme.

Xie Zheng turned his head to see Changning skipping at the front, the two tufts of hair on her head bobbing along. Xie Qi followed behind, herding a mother duck and a group of ducklings, saying with some exasperation, "My little ancestor, please walk slower. Be careful not to fall..."

The Gyr Falcon also waddled along. If a duckling fell behind and Xie Qi couldn't manage, the Gyr Falcon would go over and peck it, scaring the little yellow fluff ball into squawking and scurrying forward.

When Xie Qi looked up and saw Xie Zheng standing by the path holding a horse, he was startled and quickly called out, "Mar... Master."

Changning also cried out in surprise, "Brother-in-law?"

Fan Changyu, sitting at the courtyard gate, heard the commotion and looked out. Seeing the man and horse standing in the sunset, she was first taken aback, then wiped her hands on her clothes and stood up. She wanted to go forward to help Xie Zheng with his horse but hesitated and remained where she was.

It was Aunt Zhao who beamed upon seeing Yan Zheng and urged Fan Changyu, "Quick, quick, Xiao Yan has come to find you. Why aren't you going to greet him?"

Fan Changyu was simply unprepared for Xie Zheng to appear in Chongzhou so soon.

Wasn't he supposed to be leading troops to attack Kangcheng?

Why had he suddenly come here?

With a head full of questions, Fan Changyu walked forward. Just as she was about to offer to take the horse, Xie Wu, who had been helping Carpenter Zhao plane wood in the courtyard, had already rushed over and snatched the task.

He grinned and said, "The cowshed is empty. I'll go tie the horse in the cowshed first."

This courtyard had originally belonged to a farming household, so it came with a pigpen and a cowshed.

After Aunt Zhao arrived, besides planting some vegetables nearby, she also raised a brood of chickens and ducks. Every day, Changning would beg Xie Qi to take her along to herd the ducks to the river for a swim before bringing them back.

As a craftsman and veterinarian conscripted into the army, Carpenter Zhao didn't need to drill with the main forces, so his schedule was even more flexible than Fan Changyu's. Fan Changyu had gone to find him right after bringing Aunt Zhao back.

Carpenter Zhao had never expected to see his wife again in a foreign land. When he was taken by the conscription, he had already prepared himself to die away from home. Now that the old couple could be together, he mostly came back to the small courtyard.

He was not one to sit idle. Seeing that the tables and chairs in the courtyard were old, he began to build all sorts of furniture and utensils.

The initially bleak and dilapidated courtyard slowly began to fill with the warmth of a home.

Fan Changyu looked at the man she had been separated from for only a few days and asked very honestly, "Weren't you going to Kangcheng? Why are you here?"

The orange-red sunset fell on her cheeks, making her face seem as if it were rouged. Xie Zheng stared at her for a moment before saying, "The mountain would not come to me, so I had to go to the mountain."

These past few days, Fan Changyu had been forced to study by Tao Taifu, listening to him drone on about the great truths with his classical phrases. Her learning had indeed improved, and she understood his words. The sunset made her face flush an even deeper red.

Aunt Zhao had already stood up with the snapped vegetables, saying happily, "Xiao Yan, quick, come sit inside."

She was delighted to see Xie Zheng. Since ancient times, few men had returned alive from war. The Old Man was fine, and Changyu's husband was also fine. Aunt Zhao felt this was a joyous occasion of the highest order. She turned and ordered Carpenter Zhao, "Old Man, quick, go slaughter that old speckled hen in the chicken coop."

Xie Qi, who had just herded the flock of ducks back into their pen, said, "Aunt, let me do it."

With that, he grabbed an old hen from the coop next to the duck pen and headed for the kitchen.

Aunt Zhao, still unaware of Xie Zheng's identity, was afraid he might misunderstand. She said, "That was Xiao Qi just now, and the one who took your horse earlier was Xiao Wu. They are both soldiers under Changyu. You don't know, Changyu is so capable now, she's become an officer in the army! She's in charge of dozens of men."

Fan Changyu hadn't told Aunt Zhao and her husband Xie Zheng's true identity. For one, she was afraid of frightening the two elders. For another, their previous engagement was no longer valid, and fearing some unforeseen change, she thought it best to wait until everything was settled before saying anything.

Who would have thought Aunt Zhao would praise her for being a mere squad leader right in front of Xie Zheng? She quickly interrupted, "Aunt, what are we eating tonight?"

Aunt Zhao was indeed distracted. She began to ponder the welcome feast for the evening, muttering, "We have chicken, but it's a pity there's only one mother duck. She still has to lead those ducklings, so we can't kill her. Let's stew a pork rib soup as well..."

Perhaps to give the "long-separated" couple more time alone, when Aunt Zhao went to the kitchen, she had Carpenter Zhao help with the fire and also coaxed Changning into the kitchen.

Xie Wu did not return for a long time after tying up the horse, leaving only Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng in the courtyard.

She said, a little awkwardly, "I haven't told Aunt Zhao and the others your identity yet."

"It's fine," Xie Zheng said.

He then asked her, "How are things in the army?"

Though they had been fine when they parted, Fan Changyu now felt awkward all over. She drew circles on the ground with the tip of her foot and said, "Godfather secured a position as a squad leader for me. Everything is fine for now."

Xie Zheng gave a faint "en."

Fan Changyu couldn't find anything else to say. Seeing the man-high, long wooden box he was leaning on, she asked, "What is this?"

"For you," Xie Zheng said.

"For me?" Fan Changyu glanced at him curiously. When she took it, she found it was quite heavy.

Opening it, she saw a Horse-Cutting Sword with a blade that was black with crimson-gold forging patterns, leaving only the cutting edge gleaming like snow. It looked brand new.

Fan Changyu picked up the long sword and weighed it, feeling that its weight was just right for wielding. She gently brushed her fingertip over the edge and it broke her skin, causing a tiny bead of blood to well up.

She said with some surprise, "What a sharp blade!"

Lifting her head to look at Xie Zheng, she asked, "Did you have this specially forged?"

Xie Zheng was noncommittal. He raised his eyelids, his tone lazy yet tinged with a smile, "I'm waiting for you to quickly achieve merits and establish yourself."

Fan Changyu understood the meaning behind his words, and her face burned even hotter. She tightened her grip on the sword's hilt but still raised her eyes to look at him resolutely. "I will."

Xie Zheng was slightly taken aback by her gaze. His eyes deepened a few shades as he asked, "Want to break in the new blade?"

Fan Changyu thought he wanted to spar with her and said happily, "Alright."

With that, she had already assumed a fighting stance.

But Xie Zheng said, "Let's go outside."

Fan Changyu assumed he found the courtyard too small and feared they wouldn't have room to move freely. She readily agreed, "Then let's go to the riverbank. It's open there."

She called out towards the kitchen that she would be back later, then carried her newly acquired sword and walked out with Xie Zheng.

At this hour, the world was already shrouded in twilight. There was no one on the riverbank.

Xie Zheng casually picked up a wooden stick to use as a weapon. Fan Changyu, who used to wield two pig-slaughtering knives, had a wide-open, aggressive fighting style. Now, with a long-handled Horse-Cutting Sword that suited her, she was able to bring her strengths to their fullest potential.

Under the moonlight, the clash of their weapons was so fast that only afterimages could be seen. The sounds of iron and wood colliding rang out, one a clear clang, the other a dull thud.

Compared to short blades, Fan Changyu's use of the long-handled sword allowed for more fluid movements. But because she had few opportunities to use a long-handled sword in actual combat, and her opponent was Xie Zheng, she still showed a degree of inexperience.

For some reason, however, Xie Zheng didn't seem to be using his full strength tonight. He seldom matched her brute force, mostly using skill and finesse. Fan Changyu, accustomed to heavy offense and light defense, felt she couldn't unleash her raw power against his evasive maneuvers. Her sword strikes grew hasty, revealing an opening.

After one of her slashes, Xie Zheng slipped through her defense. The wooden stick flicked the Horse-Cutting Sword from her hand. She stepped on a loose stone and staggered back a step, her back hitting a pier post. Just as she was about to reach for her sword, the wooden stick in Xie Zheng's hand was already pointing at her heart, a mere half-inch away.

Fan Changyu was secretly alarmed. She had broken out in a sweat from the fight, her breathing was heavy, and her chest heaved, her lapels almost brushing against the stick Xie Zheng pointed at her.

In the darkness, she couldn't see Xie Zheng's expression, only hearing him say, "You lost."

His voice, for some reason, was a little hoarse.

Fan Changyu replayed their exchange in her mind. She pursed her lips, wanting to move, but found that Xie Zheng had no intention of withdrawing his stick. She said, unconvinced, "Again!"

But the man before her only stared at her fixedly.

Fan Changyu met his gaze and was startled by the darkness in his eyes. She subconsciously wanted to look away but felt as if she were bewitched, and could only stare at him, transfixed.

When he lowered his head to kiss her, her breath hitched slightly. Listening to the gurgling of the river, her long lashes trembled, and she slowly closed her eyes.

Compared to before, his kiss this time was gentler, but exceptionally clingy.

Fan Changyu felt she was about to run out of air and went to push him, but he caught her hands and pinned them above her head. His other hand held her jaw, kissing her very, very deeply.

Perhaps because they had just been sparring, his whole body was burning hot. His breath felt like fire, and the thin summer clothes could not block the scorching heat of his body.

The heat intensified his scent. It wasn't incense or sweat, but a unique scent that belonged only to him. It was very pleasant.

It was probably the lack of oxygen. Unlike before, when a kiss only left her lips and tongue numb, Fan Changyu now felt her limbs go weak, unable to stand properly.

The man before her seemed to be in a worse state. He buried his head in the crook of her neck, his breathing as heavy as a beast on the verge of frenzy. The breaths he exhaled on the side of her neck were almost scalding.

Fan Changyu instinctively sensed danger. She turned her head as far to the side as she could, thought hard, and suggested, "How about we fight again?"

The man before her suddenly bit down hatefully on a small patch of her neck, sucking on it as if in retaliation.

The subtle yet distinct pain made Fan Changyu suck in a sharp breath, not daring to speak again.

She knew little about matters between men and women, but she felt that after hearing her soft gasp, his body seemed to tense even more, and beads of sweat faintly appeared at his temples.

Fan Changyu sensed his intense discomfort and patted his back soothingly.

He released her neck and simply stared at her from half a foot away. His pupils were darker than the night, and a soft note flowed through his

husky voice. "Fan Changyu, when can I marry you?"

He was truly handsome. Sweat-dampened strands of hair fell messily across his forehead. Within his deep-set phoenix eyes was a domineering air mixed with a subtle hint of compromise and grievance. His lips were pressed into a tight line, making one want to kiss him.

Fan Changyu's heart softened. She reached out to touch his face and said very seriously, "When I've saved up enough of a 'dowry' for myself, I'll marry you."

The dowry she wanted was naturally not money, but the confidence to walk side-by-side with him, something she had told him before.

Xie Zheng stared at her. "Fine, I'll wait for you. In this life, I will marry no one but you, and you cannot marry anyone else either."

Fan Changyu found this amusing. "In all my life, you're the only one I've ever liked. If I don't marry you, who would I marry?"

This statement left Xie Zheng stunned for a good while.

Having said that, Fan Changyu felt a little embarrassed. She averted her gaze and said, "Aunt Zhao has probably finished cooking. Let's go back."

But Xie Zheng suddenly asked, "What about that ex-fiancé of yours?"

So much had happened since Fan Changyu left Qingping County that she had almost forgotten about Song Yan. Hearing Xie Zheng bring him up now, she looked at him in disbelief. "You think I would like him?"

Xie Zheng forced out two stiff words: "Back then."

Fan Changyu never expected him to suddenly bring up old scores. She knew that in the past, he had held Song Yan in absolute contempt.

She said with some exasperation, "Whether you believe it or not, not even back then."

She scratched her head, a little embarrassed. "Actually... I wasn't very familiar with him. In the past, it was mostly our parents who interacted. He was completely absorbed in his scholarly books since he was a child. When I was little, I ran wild with all the kids in the alley, and when I grew up, my mother kept me cooped up. I rarely saw him, and even when we did meet, we barely exchanged a few words. I always felt he was quite arrogant and didn't seem to want to marry a butcher's daughter. I even privately told him to call off the engagement."

Xie Zheng abruptly interjected, "You gave him a pair of clay dolls."

Fan Changyu was utterly dumbfounded. For the first time, she felt this man's memory was far too good.

She stammered, "No, I was less than eight years old then. I didn't give him the clay dolls out of any romantic feelings. It was just that his father had just passed away, and I gave them to him because I felt sorry for him."

Xie Zheng's lips pressed together, and he said nothing.

Fan Changyu ran a hand through her hair and asked, "Have you never given a girl something out of courtesy or something?"

He replied with two chilly words: "Never."

Fan Changyu truly didn't know how to handle the current situation. It was as if she were a seasoned heartbreaker who had met a girl she fancied, only for the other party to suddenly mind her past.

She sighed. "If you mind..."

He cut her off. "I don't."

Fan Changyu: "..."

What else could be said?

She and the man before her stared at each other, wide-eyed.

Finally, Xie Zheng lowered his long, thick, dark lashes and said, "Let's go back."

The silhouette of him turning to leave looked ethereal yet lonely under the moonlight.

As Fan Changyu shouldered her Horse-Cutting Sword and chased after him, she was still completely bewildered. She had no idea how she had suddenly become a heartless woman who had broken someone's heart.

Along the way, Fan Changyu tried to talk to Xie Zheng again, but he mostly replied with just one or two words.

Fan Changyu could see that he didn't want to talk to her for the time being, so she simply shut her mouth and didn't say another word to him all the way home.

During the meal, Aunt Zhao probably also sensed the strange atmosphere between the two.

After dinner, Xie Wu and Xie Qi scrambled to clear the dishes. Xie Zheng sat in the courtyard, making small talk with Uncle Zhao, so Fan Changyu went to get the bedding for a floor pallet.

There were only three rooms in the courtyard. Usually, Aunt Zhao and Changning shared one, Xie Qi had one to himself, and the other was left for Fan Changyu.

Whenever Fan Changyu came back, Carpenter Zhao and Xie Wu would usually come back too. At those times, Changning would typically sleep with Fan Changyu, the old Zhao couple would take a room, and Xie Wu would squeeze into Xie Qi's room.

With the situation tonight, someone would inevitably have to sleep on the floor.

As she was carrying the bedding, intending to return to her room, Aunt Zhao blocked the doorway, her expression somewhat serious. "Changyu, Auntie has something to say to you."

Fan Changyu thought it was something important, so she temporarily put down the bedding. After Aunt Zhao closed the door and sat down inside, she said, "Please speak."

Aunt Zhao looked at her and sighed. "Changyu, Auntie knows you're successful now, but there's a saying that one should not abandon the wife who shared their hardships. When you were going through such difficult times, it was Xiao Yan who supported you. Later, he was even taken away by the conscription. This bond is something no one else can compare to. Xiao Yan is good-looking and well-built, too. No matter what, Auntie hopes you two will live well together. Don't be like those heartless men who turn their backs on people once they become rich and powerful."

Fan Changyu couldn't defend herself and could only say through gritted teeth, "We're fine."

Aunt Zhao's face was stern. "He was perfectly fine when he first arrived. How come he looked like that after you two went out for a while? You must have had a fight. Don't try to fool me. I'm an experienced person. I can tell just from a single look between you two."

She thought for a moment and asked, "Xiao Wu is always by your side. If Yan Zheng minds this, how about Auntie acts as a matchmaker and finds a wife for Xiao Wu?"

Fan Changyu quickly said, "It's not about that. Auntie, please don't worry. It's really not a big deal. I'll find a chance to talk it over with him."

Aunt Zhao was skeptical. She glanced at the bedding Fan Changyu had taken out, stuffed it all back into the cabinet, and then shut the cabinet door. "Then you two will sleep in the same room tonight and talk things out properly. I'll take Ning Niang."

Fan Changyu made a last-ditch effort. "One blanket isn't enough."

Aunt Zhao glared. "How is it not enough? It's already summer. Sharing a corner of the blanket is fine. Are you taking out so much bedding because you plan to kick him out of bed and make him sleep on the floor?"

When she was shooed back into the room, Fan Changyu felt even more aggrieved.

She wasn't the one throwing a tantrum!

Before long, Xie Zheng also entered the room. It was obvious Aunt Zhao had persuaded him to come in.

Fan Changyu sat on the edge of the bed. Their eyes met, and she squeezed out a dry sentence, "Shall we rest?"

Xie Zheng took off his outer robe and lay down on the outer side of the bed, wearing only his middle garments.

Fan Changyu saw the large space he had left for her. Their relationship was already this stiff; she couldn't bring herself to say something like asking him to sleep alone.

She blew out the lamp, fumbled her way around his feet to the inner side in the dark, and lay down along the inner edge of the bed, leaving a large empty space in the middle.

No one spoke in the darkness. After a long while, Fan Changyu finally sighed. "How can you be so unreasonable? When I gave things to people in my childhood, I had no idea what the Song family would turn out to be like, nor did I know I would meet you. You can be upset with me over things happening now, but if you mind things from the past, what do you want me to do?"

The person lying on the outer side didn't move. A low voice sounded in the darkness. "I lost both my parents when I was four."

Hearing him say this so suddenly, Fan Changyu thought he was trying to get a gift from her too, since she had mentioned giving Song Yan the clay dolls after his father passed away.

She said helplessly, "Uncle Zhao actually made that pair of clay dolls for me to play with, just like those grasshopper toys Changning plays with. How about I make a pair of dolls for you with my own hands?"

When she asked the last few words, she reached out, took his hand, and shook it gently.

It felt like a feather was gently brushing against his heart.

He was silent for a long time before answering with a single "Alright."

He didn't mind; he was jealous.

He was jealous that in the years before he met her, he had walked alone, while another child, because of the pain of losing a father, had received her pity, had something she had given, had been able to grow up with her, and had seen every year of her past that he could never see. He had even had an engagement with her.

Just thinking about these things made an indescribable malice spread in his heart.

But he didn't dare tell Fan Changyu this. He was afraid she would think he was a madman.

Receiving his reply, Fan Changyu felt she had finally placated him. She said to him, "Then it's a deal."

As she prepared to withdraw her hand, he held it firmly, giving her no room to pull away.

Fan Changyu looked at the person beside her in surprise, only to see his eyes were closed, as if he were already asleep.

She felt both helpless and amused, her heart melting into a soft puddle. She lay there flat on her back, holding his hand, and fell asleep.

After Fan Changyu's breathing became steady, the person feigning sleep suddenly opened his eyes. He turned his head slightly, gazing at her unblinkingly in the darkness.

Chapter 99

In the courtyard, just a wall away, Aunt Zhao was crouched beneath the window ledge. Hearing no sounds of argument or any other commotion from inside, she was starting to feel a bit puzzled.

Xie Wu and Xie Qi, who had just stepped out, saw this scene, silently retracted their feet, and even closed the door to their room.

Carpenter Zhao stood under the eaves and coughed twice to get Aunt Zhao's attention before he, too, went inside.

Aunt Zhao glanced back at the main house, which was still utterly silent, then tiptoed back to her room. As she shut the door, she shot Carpenter Zhao a glare. "You think I was eavesdropping? I was just worried about that young couple. They seemed a bit off, and I was afraid they'd fight."

Carpenter Zhao didn't know what was going on with Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng either. He only said, "When Changyu was taken away to repair the dam, she found me and told me that she and that boy Yan Zheng had already divorced."

This news startled Aunt Zhao. "What nonsense are you talking about!" she blurted out.

Forgetting to lower her voice in her agitation, she quickly glanced outside before sitting on the edge of the bed. "When Yan Zheng was conscripted, Changyu was so dejected for days. She even prepared so many things for him, packing them in bags big and small. How does that look like they've divorced? Besides, when I went to persuade them, didn't they end up sleeping in the same room?"

Carpenter Zhao then relayed what Fan Changyu had told him.

Aunt Zhao was first shocked to hear that their marriage had initially been a sham. But on second thought, considering Yan Zheng was literate, educated, and handsome, his willingness to marry into the family did seem to fit Carpenter Zhao's explanation.

She sat worriedly on the bed for a while, then said, "Even if it wasn't a love match when they married before the new year, they properly bowed to

the heavens and earth. How are they not husband and wife? A single man and a single woman under the same roof day after day, not to mention they're both exceptionally good-looking—how could they not develop feelings for each other? Look, back when Yan Zheng was so injured he couldn't even get out of bed, Changyu was afraid his medicine would be too bitter. Even when her own life was so hard, she still bought him candy! You can't fake that kind of bond forged through hardship!"

Carpenter Zhao glanced at Changning, who was listening with her ears pricked up, and sighed. "Alright, alright. The two of them have probably made up. Ning Niang is still here, let's not talk about this."

Changning blinked her big, bright black eyes.

Aunt Zhao helped her take the silk flower off her topknot and pinched her chubby little face with a smile. "Our Ning Niang is a lucky one. Your big sister is on duty in the army now, in charge of a whole group of people. In the future, Ning Niang's husband won't dare to bully her."

Changning grinned, revealing a mouthful of small white teeth. After a moment's thought, she held up her thumb and added, "Brother-in-law is amazing, Little Uncle Qi is amazing, and Falcon is amazing too! No one will bully Ning Niang!"

Aunt Zhao was amused by her. "What a clever little imp."

After coaxing Changning to sleep, Aunt Zhao lay in bed, but another matter came to mind.

According to the Old Man, that young couple probably hadn't even consummated their marriage yet?

On one hand, Aunt Zhao hoped the two of them would live a good life together. On the other, thinking about Fan Changyu's position in the army, she knew that if she were to get pregnant, it would be extremely troublesome. This thought made her worry endlessly, and she tossed and turned all night, unable to sleep. Several times, she even felt the urge to get up and eavesdrop on the house next door.

The next day, Fan Changyu had just woken up when Aunt Zhao pulled her into a secluded corner.

She had slept well, but for some reason, Aunt Zhao's eyes, which already had bags under them, were now frighteningly dark and bruised-looking.

Fan Changyu asked in confusion, "Auntie, did you not sleep at all last night?"

Aunt Zhao glanced around before lowering her voice. "Changyu, ah, your mother passed away early, and you don't have any elders to guide you, so there are some things no one has taught you. I see you as my own child, so I'll be direct. You're in the army now. If you were to have a child, it would be inconvenient. Do you want me to find a physician to prescribe you a contraceptive decoction?"

Fan Changyu hadn't expected Aunt Zhao to be worried about this. Her face instantly flushed red to the roots of her neck. She shook her head. "There's no need."

Hearing this answer, Aunt Zhao was momentarily unsure whether to be relieved or to continue worrying about the young couple.

While she was still conflicted, Fan Changyu had already gone to the courtyard to draw water and wash her face.

Now that it was summer, the well water was still a bit chilly in the morning.

Seeing her wash her face with cold water, Aunt Zhao couldn't help but nag, saying she was afraid the cold would accumulate in her body and telling her to get hot water from the kitchen.

Fan Changyu had a strong constitution and didn't take Aunt Zhao's words to heart. But when Changning put her hands in the basin, looking like she was about to join her in using the cold water, Fan Changyu wouldn't allow it. She made Changning take her hands out and obediently go to the kitchen for hot water.

After washing Changning's face, Fan Changyu yawned and tied Changning's hair into topknots by feel.

The child, who used to accept whatever hairstyle she gave her, now looked at her reflection in the basin of water and mumbled aggrievedly, "I want Little Uncle Qi to do it."

Fan Changyu glanced at the frizzy topknots she had tied and felt a pang of guilt.

The child was growing up and now knew the difference between pretty and ugly. She wasn't as easy to fool as before.

“Alright then,” she said. “Go find your Little Uncle Qi to do it.”

Changning took the comb herself and trotted over the threshold on her short legs to find Xie Qi. She checked each room but couldn’t find him. Hearing faint voices from the main house, she pattered over. But the moment she pushed the door open, she let out a terrified wail and burst into tears.

Inside the room, Xie Zheng stood with his back to the door, his upper body bare. Blood-stained white cloths were scattered at his feet. A knife wound, scarlet and gruesome, stretched across most of his back. Xie Qi was applying medicine to it.

The moment he heard Changning’s cry, Xie Qi knew things had gone wrong. The master had specifically waited until the mistress was out before having him come in to help with the medicine. Now, it seemed the secret was out.

Sure enough, although Xie Zheng had managed to wrap a thin robe around himself in time, Fan Changyu, drawn by Changning’s cries, had already arrived at the door.

When she saw the circle of bloody white cloths on the floor, Fan Changyu’s expression changed. She lifted her gaze and looked straight at Xie Zheng. “You’re injured?”

Xie Zheng tied the sash of his robe. “A small injury,” he replied.

Fan Changyu’s brows furrowed tightly. Looking at the pile of cloths on the floor, she knew the wound on his body was likely not small. No wonder when he sparred with her last night, he had almost entirely avoided heavy attacks, relying on clever techniques instead.

She crouched down, patting Changning’s shoulder and comforting her for a moment. Then she said to Xie Qi, “Brother Xie Qi, please take my sister out first. She was frightened once before and is a bit afraid of blood.”

Xie Qi coaxed Changning and led her out of the room.

Fan Changyu closed the door. When she turned around, her face was still expressionless. She just looked at Xie Zheng and said, “Let me see the wound on your back.”

Xie Zheng’s handsome brows knitted slightly. He hadn’t expected Fan Changyu to stumble upon this. He answered evasively, “The medicine has

already been applied.”

Fan Changyu stared at him, enunciating each word. “I said, let me see.”

The two of them were at a standstill for a moment. When Xie Zheng still didn’t move, Fan Changyu stepped forward and went to untie his sash herself.

When he caught her hand, she was afraid of tearing open the wound on his back and didn’t dare to struggle forcefully, but her expression was extremely unpleasant.

Her pair of apricot eyes were cold and sharp, her tone uncharacteristically forceful. “Either take off your clothes, or you leave right now and never appear before me again.”

Xie Zheng’s hand, gripping her wrist, did not let go. His long, narrow phoenix eyes were half-lowered, his long lashes casting a beautiful arc. In the morning light filtering through the window screen, his jawline looked somewhat pale. He asked with a lazy smile, “Your tone... it’s as if you’re forcing an innocent man into prostitution.”

Fan Changyu’s lips tightened into a thin line. “I am forcing you.”

Xie Zheng met her gaze. It was the first time he had ever seen Fan Changyu look so forceful. Her apricot eyes had lost their usual clear, harmless quality; her gaze was sharp and aggressive.

It was as if a lazy cat had suddenly transformed into a tiger or leopard that could easily tear its prey to shreds.

And yet, that very gaze seemed to have hooks that snagged right onto Xie Zheng’s heartstrings.

His Adam’s apple bobbed. He lowered his lashes, suppressing the impulse to seize her jaw and kiss her deeply. He obediently untied his sash again. As he slightly raised his eyes, the inky black of his pupils lightened in the dawn, making them look exceptionally beautiful. His profile was even coated in a layer of soft light.

The long fingers pulling at the sash had faint, small scars. The body hidden beneath the robe was not as elegantly handsome as his face suggested, but rather lean, powerful, and solid, even exuding a sense of pressure.

It wasn't the first time Fan Changyu had seen Xie Zheng bare-chested, but before, he had either been lying down injured or seen vaguely in the moonlight. Never had she seen him so clearly.

When her eyes met Xie Zheng's intensely aggressive gaze, the imposing aura she had built up instantly deflated. She couldn't help but press her lips together, shifting her line of sight from his firm waist and abdomen to circle behind him and look at the wound on his back.

Upon seeing the long, diagonal wound amidst a crisscross of old scars, Fan Changyu's voice was hoarse for a long moment before she asked, "How did you get this?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer, only saying, "It doesn't hurt."

Fan Changyu glared at him, her eyes red. "I asked how you got it."

He still wouldn't speak. Fan Changyu stared at him and voiced her suspicion. "Was it that bastard surnamed Sui who hurt you?"

She could have said anything else, but the mistaken assumption that he had been injured by Sui Yuanqing finally made Xie Zheng speak. "I cut it myself."

Seeing the look she gave him, as if he were a madman, he couldn't quite explain what he was thinking at that moment. He only locked his dark eyes on her. "To draw blood as an offering for your knife."

Fan Changyu truly did curse him. "Madman!"

But the redness in her eyes only deepened. She pushed him down to sit, picked up the half-used medicine bottle on the table, and began to apply it for him. Forcing her voice to remain steady, she said coldly, "If there's a next time, I won't care if you die from the pain! And I don't want that stupid knife anymore!"

The trauma medicine was potent, stinging like salt and fire when sprinkled on the wound. Listening to Fan Changyu's scolding, Xie Zheng rested his hands on the arms of the chair but couldn't stop a smile from spreading across his lips.

His dark, obsessive, and abnormal thoughts hadn't made her afraid or disgusted; they had only earned him her pity.

He was scarred and mottled like moss in a dark alley, damp, cold, and sticky, yet his sun was still willing to shine on him.

The gloomy haze that had been weighing on his heart seemed to dissipate in an instant.

Fan Changyu finished applying the medicine and was re-bandaging him. Seeing that he still had the mind to smile, she didn't spare him with her words. "Did the pain make you stupid?"

Taking advantage of the way her arms had to reach around his back to wrap the gauze, Xie Zheng raised his hands and hugged her, resting his chin in the crook of her shoulder. His tone carried a trace of laziness. "I was thinking of the doll you're going to give me, and it made my heart happy."

Fan Changyu tied the knot and shot him a glare.

As for what kind of doll to give Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu had actually been pondering it for quite some time.

She had originally planned to just mold a pair of clay figurines, but when she thought of how much he was looking forward to it, and how easily clay dolls could break, she saw Carpenter Zhao doing woodwork and decided it would be better to carve him a pair of wooden puppets.

Carpenter Zhao could not only build all sorts of furniture and tools, but the carvings on the chests and cabinets he made were also incredibly lifelike.

However, Fan Changyu had no foundation in woodworking and couldn't carve a finished product in a short time. The good thing was that she had used a knife for years, so her hand was extremely steady.

She only had one day of leave from the army. She had returned yesterday afternoon and had to go back this afternoon, leaving her with only half a day to learn woodcarving from Carpenter Zhao.

As Fan Changyu sat in her room practicing with a pile of scrap wood left over from Carpenter Zhao's furniture making, Xie Zheng frowned at the stack of white paper on the table. His knuckles tapped lightly on the desk as he asked, somewhat uncertainly, "You want me to help you copy a book?"

Fan Changyu didn't even look up. "Last time, my adoptive father tested me on the Zhuangzi. I misquoted a line, so he punished me by making me copy that chapter ten times."

Xie Zheng's fingertips fiddled with the new sheets of paper. Discovering that only the top sheet had a few lines written on it, he slowly raised his eyes to look at Fan Changyu. "So you haven't even finished copying it once?"

Even before their eyes met, Fan Changyu felt a wave of guilt. She kept her head down, whittling the wood, and tried to make her voice sound firm. "I've already memorized it. It's just that my adoptive father said my handwriting is ugly and that I have to copy it neatly ten times. That's why it's taking so long."

Xie Zheng held the top sheet of paper with one hand, studied it for a moment, and said, "Your handwriting is, indeed, a bit ugly."

Fan Changyu said, annoyed, "Are you going to help me or not?"

Xie Zheng said, "My handwriting is different from yours. It would be difficult to imitate your script."

Fan Changyu understood his underlying meaning—he couldn't write that ugly.

Her hand tightened on the knife handle. After taking a deep breath, she said as if accepting reality, "Forget it, I'll copy it myself. This woodcarving won't be done anytime soon anyway. I'll just practice slowly when I have time."

She put down the piece of wood and the boning knife and reached out as if to take the stack of paper from in front of Xie Zheng, but a few well-defined fingers pressed down on the edge of the paper.

Fan Changyu looked up and, not surprisingly, saw Xie Zheng's dark, handsome face.

He pressed his temple, looking as if he was at his wit's end with her. "Fine. Your handwriting won't improve in a day or two. I'll copy it for you."

Her scheme successful, Fan Changyu's eyes narrowed and the corners of her mouth curled up. She smiled like a cat that had stolen the cream, picked up her boning knife, and continued to practice her carving, hugging the piece of wood.

Xie Zheng dipped his brush in thick ink and glanced at the person sitting cross-legged across from him, engrossed in her carving. Sunlight shone through the screen window, seeming to cast a halo on her hair. On the

paper before him, the few columns of characters were... a stark contrast to their owner's appearance.

He gave a helpless tug at the corner of his lips and began to write on the paper, imitating her script, a gentleness in his eyes that he himself was unaware of.

Chapter 100

In the afternoon, as soon as Fan Changyu returned to the military camp, she was summoned by Grand Tutor Tao.

She thought it was to check the books he had assigned her to copy, so she brought the stack of papers Xie Zheng had helped her transcribe. However, she found another person present in Grand Tutor Tao's tent.

The man appeared to be nearly forty, with refined and upright features. He wasn't wearing armor, looking more like a civil official.

Fan Changyu didn't recognize him, so she simply greeted Grand Tutor Tao, "Foster Father."

The middle-aged man had been observing her intently since she entered the tent, his gaze kind yet heavy, mixed with an indescribable sense of relief and concern.

Changyu found it rather odd, but since the man harbored no ill intent, she allowed him to continue his scrutiny.

Grand Tutor Tao glanced at her and said, "You're here."

He didn't seem inclined to introduce her to the other man, merely stating, "This is a general in the army. He heard you killed Shi Hu and was curious to see your martial skills."

Changyu hadn't expected the scholarly-robed man to be a general. She quickly clasped her fists in salute. "Greetings, General."

The man was none other than He Jingyuan. Seeing traces of an old acquaintance in Fan Changyu, his heart swirled with complex emotions. He asked, "You know martial arts?"

Changyu replied, "A little."

Though he already had his suspicions, He Jingyuan pressed, "Who taught you?"

Changyu answered, "My father."

He Jingyuan then asked, "Would you spar with this old man?"

Changyu looked to Grand Tutor Tao for guidance.

The grand tutor stroked his beard and said, “This general is also skilled in saber techniques. Let him offer you some pointers.”

Changyu clasped her fists again. “I would be honored to learn from you, General.”

The tent was too cramped for a proper match, so they moved outside to the training grounds, each wielding a long-handled saber.

Changyu initiated the attack first, her blade swift and overwhelming. He Jingyuan initially focused solely on defense, retreating step by step to study her techniques.

Only when he was nearly backed against the tent did he suddenly switch from defense to offense, employing the very moves Changyu had used earlier.

Compared to Changyu’s relentless aggression, his saber techniques were far more composed—capable of both offense and defense, perfectly balanced in rhythm.

Just as Changyu was about to shift her attack, He Jingyuan seized a flaw in her defense, his blade stopping just short of her neck.

Her own saber hadn’t even had the chance to strike. Startled, she realized that while she lacked real combat experience, her sole pastime had been practicing the saber techniques her father taught her. She had believed she knew every move inside out.

Yet facing this general, she felt as though he understood the techniques even better than she did, anticipating every countermove with ease.

Noticing her dazed expression, He Jingyuan withdrew his blade and asked, “Do you know where the flaw in your last move was?”

Changyu bowed respectfully. “Please enlighten me, General.”

He Jingyuan said, “You’ve practiced this set of techniques so rigidly that your strikes have become inflexible. You must complete one move before starting the next. But the battlefield is ever-changing. If one strike fails, you must adapt immediately—how can you afford to lose composure just because your opponent counters you?”

His words pinpointed the flaw in Changyu’s technique. When she used her butcher’s cleaver, she often caught opponents off guard.

But with the long-handled saber, she could easily overpower those less skilled than her. However, against masters like He Jingyuan or Xie Zheng, who were well-versed in all kinds of weaponry, she found herself severely constrained.

Fan Changyu felt a surge of respect and gratitude, saying sincerely, "Thank you, General!"

Seeing that she understood, He Jingyuan's eyes held not only complexity but also a faint trace of relief. He said, "Let me teach you a few more moves."

The two continued their practice in the open space outside the military tent. With each move Fan Changyu executed, He Jingyuan pointed out its flaws and taught her how to counter them.

It wasn't until a soldier resembling a personal guard came looking for him that He Jingyuan stopped, instructing Fan Changyu to return and reflect on what she had learned that day.

After bidding farewell to Grand Tutor Tao, Fan Changyu headed back, her mind filled with sword techniques.

Grand Tutor Tao noticed that even after Fan Changyu had gone far, He Jingyuan was still staring absently in the direction she had left. He remarked, "I always thought that child was honest and resilient, maintaining her kindness no matter the circumstances—a promising seedling. When you later told me she was that old man's descendant, it all made sense. Her wisdom in simplicity mirrors her grandfather's."

He Jingyuan bowed solemnly to Grand Tutor Tao. "The orphan of an old friend—I entrust her to you, Grand Tutor."

Grand Tutor Tao sighed. "One boy, one girl—both are dear to me. But the past is gone. When those events occurred, neither girl had even been born. What does it have to do with them? No matter what, I will protect them."

He Jingyuan bowed deeply once more.

Grand Tutor Tao said, "As for Jiuheng, let's keep it from him for now."

He Jingyuan worried, "I fear paper cannot wrap fire forever."

Grand Tutor Tao patted his shoulder. "Jingyuan, Jingyuan, you still don't fully understand your Prime Minister. Do you truly believe it took him over

a decade to discover that Meng Shuyuan's daughter and son-in-law were hiding in Qingping County under your protection?"

He Jingyuan froze.

Grand Tutor Tao clasped his hands behind his back, gazing at the distant mountains meeting the sky. "Perhaps the past wasn't as you thought. Both of us know Meng Shuyuan's character—he would never have acted so recklessly. Yet after Jinzhou fell, he took his own life in his tent, and his trusted generals perished in subsequent battles, leaving no way to uncover the truth. But if Wei Yan orchestrated it all, and Meng Shuyuan's descendants held evidence of his schemes, he would rather kill a thousand innocents than let one escape. How could he allow them to flee to the borderlands and live in hiding for over a decade?"

He Jingyuan smiled bitterly. "When Brother Qilin brought Meng's only daughter to me, he told me the Prime Minister had ordered him to kill her. Unable to do it, he faked their deaths by falling off a cliff. If, as you say, the Prime Minister intended to spare them from the start, why did he later order me to kill my former comrades and repeatedly send Martial Assassins to the Fan Family to retrieve that item?"

Had any veteran been present, they would have recognized the "Qilin" He Jingyuan mentioned as Wei Qilin, a retainer of the Wei Mansion.

Wei Qilin had not originally borne the Wei surname, nor did he have a proper name. He was merely a servant bought by the Wei Family and trained as a Martial Assassin. His natural strength and martial talent led to his promotion as a family retainer.

Wei Yan had initially held no military power whatsoever. It was only through the battlefield achievements of He Jingyuan and Wei Qilin that he gradually gained influence.

Later, when Wei Yan married his sister to Xie Linshan, the ties between the Wei and Xie families grew even closer. Wei Qilin even served under Xie Linshan's command and won the admiration of Meng Shuyuan, an old general in Xie's ranks. Since Old General Meng had only one daughter, Wei Qilin married into the Meng family.

This Wei Qilin was none other than the later Fan Erniu.

What He Jingyuan had always feared was that Wei Qilin had become the blade—the one who pushed Old General Meng to delay the grain shipment.

Yet regarding the events of Jinzhou back then, Wei Qilin had told him very little. Over the past decade, apart from that one time Wei Qilin sought him out for help, the two had not met again, all to avoid arousing Wei Yan's suspicions.

He let out a heavy sigh. "If I had opened and read those things he gave me back then, I wouldn't be so uncertain now."

But if he had read them at the time, unless he openly rebelled against Wei Yan, he wouldn't have been able to protect Fan Changyu and her sister either.

Grand Tutor Tao comforted him, "Nothing is settled yet. Let's wait and see. The reason I emerged from seclusion was my worry that someone might use the Battle of Jinzhou to manipulate Jiuh*eng as a weapon. Linshan's death remains an insurmountable wound in that boy's heart. I fear he might fall into someone's trap."

He Jingyuan considered himself well-versed in the current situation, yet his mind was still clouded with doubts. He said, "I may be slow-witted, but when rumors questioning the Battle of Jinzhou spread among the people, the accusations pointed directly at the Chancellor. Are you suggesting, Grand Tutor, that someone is trying to pit the Marquis against the Chancellor in a fight where both sides lose?"

Grand Tutor Tao replied, "I was never close to Wei Yan. Over the years, whether among the common folk or in court, he has faced nothing but condemnation. Perhaps, after sitting in that position for so long, he truly lost his way. But as you said, looking back a dozen years, he was once diligent in serving Great Yin's imperial court. Back then, when he wanted me to take Jiuh*eng as my student, he even went through a scholar from Nanshan Academy, using Linshan's name to persuade me indirectly. It seemed he feared I would refuse the boy due to my disagreements with him."

Grand Tutor Tao himself had studied at Nanshan Academy.

He Jingyuan had not expected Wei Yan to go to such lengths for Xie Zheng's sake. He had once been a trusted subordinate of Wei Yan and had occasionally witnessed Wei Yan's interactions with Xie Zheng. Wei Yan had always been stern and unyielding toward his nephew.

Even when Xie Zheng achieved great military feats and received commendations, Wei Yan would first reprimand him before offering half-

hearted praise.

The entire Chancellor's estate knew that Wei Yan disliked his nephew Xie Zheng. Yet behind the scenes, he had gone to great lengths to secure Grand Tutor Tao as Xie Zheng's teacher—a privilege even Wei Xuan, Wei Yan's own son, had likely never enjoyed.

For a moment, He Jingyuan was even more perplexed.

He said, "But it's also true that the Chancellor sought to kill the Marquis on the Chongzhou battlefield."

Grand Tutor Tao narrowed his aged yet piercing eyes. "The Jinzhou case was undoubtedly linked to Wei Yan. But there may be some hidden circumstances that led to his erratic behavior. I will go to the capital to see him in person. Until I return, do not tell Jiuh*eng about the Meng family."

He paused, then added, "The Li family has uncovered quite a bit and may make their move soon. My daughter has been tempered enough—let her go to the battlefield and earn some military merits. If the Li family disrupts things and that brat learns of this prematurely, at least she'll have capable people by her side. Then I won't have to worry for her."

(Note: Jiuh eng is Xie Zheng's courtesy name, but since it wasn't explicitly defined in the glossary, it's retained in pinyin for consistency.)

He Jingyuan felt as if the tangled mess of thoughts in his mind had finally found a loose end and quickly agreed—

The capital.

After the morning court session, civil and military officials gradually filed out of the Golden Luan Hall, clustering on either side behind Wei Yan and Grand Tutor Li, respectively.

As Wei Yan descended the white marble steps, he happened to cross paths with Grand Tutor Li, who was coming down the opposite side separated by dragon-carved railings.

Both were seasoned old foxes who had weathered the treacherous tides of officialdom for years. At this encounter, one exuded stern authority, while the other appeared amiable and approachable.

After a brief moment of eye contact, Grand Tutor Li was the first to cup his hands in greeting. "Chancellor Wei."

He was gaunt, with white hair and beard, appearing much older than Wei Yan. Yet, his affability lacked the effortless ease of Grand Tutor Tao, making him seem approachable at first glance but difficult to truly get close to.

Wei Yan merely raised his hand slightly in return. "Grand Tutor Li."

Having held the reins of imperial power for over a decade, his imposing presence was no less than that of an emperor.

Grand Tutor Li chuckled. "On the northwestern front, the rebels are now pinned down separately by the Wu'an Marquis and General He, leaving them no room to fight back. His Majesty is greatly pleased. Victory reports should soon arrive in the capital. I, Li, offer my early congratulations to the Chancellor."

Wei Yan's expression remained unreadable. "A matter of national importance—shared joy."

With that, their exchange reached its conclusion.

Regardless of the current political climate or the public outcry against Wei Yan, he was undeniably the foremost figure in Great Yin's court. Without hesitation, he strode past Grand Tutor Li, his crimson official robes billowing in the wind as he descended the next stretch of white marble steps with composed dignity. No one dared utter a word of dissent.

Only after Wei Yan had gone far did the officials behind Grand Tutor Li dare to voice their indignation. "Wei Yan is far too arrogant! The Great Yin imperial family still bears the surname Qi!"

Grand Tutor Li cast a calm glance at the speaker. "Shouyi, mind your words!"

His tone was neither loud nor angry, yet it frightened the official into a deep bow, stammering, "This humble official spoke out of turn..."

Grand Tutor Li said nothing more and departed with the other officials. Only then did the chastened official dare to glance fearfully back at the Golden Luan Hall, wiping cold sweat from his brow with his sleeve.

Three generations of the Li family had entered officialdom. Aside from Grand Tutor Li, the pillar of resistance against Wei Yan, and Li Huaian, who had gone to the northwest, Grand Tutor Li had several other sons serving in the court. However, the only one remaining in the capital now was his eldest son—also Li Huaian's father.

Once father and son were seated in their carriage home, Li Yuanting spoke up. "Father, the Wu'an Marquis bypassed Chongzhou and instead laid siege to Kangcheng. It seems he saw through our plan to claim credit for the Chongzhou campaign and deliberately stayed out of it. Yet, during today's court session, His Majesty still praised the Marquis highly, even hinting at betrothing the Eldest Princess to him. Wei Yan hasn't fallen yet, but His Majesty is already wary of our Li family."

Grand Tutor Li closed his eyes and asked, "How is the Empress?"

Li Yuanting replied with difficulty, "Her Majesty... still hasn't conceived."

Grand Tutor Li had been the young emperor's tutor. Back then, to bolster the Li family against Wei Yan, the emperor had elevated a Li daughter, not yet thirteen, to Empress.

Yet years had passed, and the Empress remained childless.

Grand Tutor Li asked, "What did the imperial physicians say?"

Li Yuanting answered, "They couldn't identify the ailment."

Grand Tutor Li opened his eyes and said with an ambiguous tone, "His Majesty has indeed grown up."

Li Yuanting looked puzzled and asked, "Father, what do you mean by that?"

Grand Tutor Li gazed at his eldest son and inquired, "Do you remember how Wei Yan chose His Majesty, who had no maternal clan to rely on, among all the imperial princes to inherit the throne back then?"

After pondering for a moment, Li Yuanting suddenly looked startled. "Did His Majesty deliberately prevent the empress from conceiving?"

Wei Yan had selected the current emperor to ascend the throne precisely because he lacked external relatives. The young emperor, to secure his position, had no choice but to obey Wei Yan in everything.

Thus, Wei Yan almost naturally monopolized imperial power.

Seeking protection, the young emperor had feigned obedience before Grand Tutor Li for over a decade, but now he was gradually revealing his claws.

Under years of support, the Li family had risen to prominence in the court. The young emperor feared that once the Wei Faction fell, the Li

family would become the next Wei Faction, so he dared not let the empress conceive.

After all, he had yet to reclaim his full authority. If Empress Li were to become pregnant, any future intention to eliminate the Li family might prompt them to strike first, following Wei Yan's example by supporting a young prince to the throne.

Grand Tutor Li remained silent, tacitly acknowledging his son's words.

Li Yuanting's face darkened with indignation. "No wonder His Majesty wants to marry the eldest princess to Wu'an Marquis. After Wei Yan's downfall, he intends to use Wu'an Marquis to restrain our Li family! They say the bow is put away once the birds are gone. While Wei Yan still controls the court, His Majesty already treats our family this way. Once Wei Yan is removed, will our Li family even have a place to stand?"

Grand Tutor Li merely said, "Enough. The hearts of emperors have always been inscrutable."

Li Yuanting pressed urgently, "Father, we must think of a way. The way His Majesty treats Wei Yan today may well be how he treats our Li family tomorrow."

Grand Tutor Li spoke leisurely, "In this realm, isn't there another who is most qualified to inherit the throne?"

Li Yuanting shuddered. "You mean... the imperial grandson?"

Grand Tutor Li did not pursue the topic further and instead asked, "What has Huai'an discovered in Jizhou?"

Li Yuanting, realizing the implications of their earlier conversation, felt cold sweat drench his back. He replied, "Wei Yan has indeed maintained capable men under him all these years to secure his position as chancellor. He Jingyuan served in Jizhou for over a decade without a hint of corruption. After months of investigation, Huai'an only found a suspicious case involving a butcher's family whom Wei Yan sent numerous Martial Assassins to kill last year."

Grand Tutor Li raised an eyebrow. "Weren't those Martial Assassins sent to kill Wu'an Marquis?"

Li Yuanting explained, "Huai'an checked Jizhou Prefecture's military deployment records. When Wei Yan dispatched the Martial Assassins, He Jingyuan also sent troops to assist. It seemed like one wanted to kill while

the other wanted to save. Yet when Wei Xuan caused trouble by requisitioning grain in the northwest, He Jingyuan urgently sent something back to Wei Yan, who showed no sign of reproach."

Glancing at his father's expression, he continued, "The butcher and his wife were recorded in the case files as killed by bandits, but the captured bandits all denied harming the family. Delving deeper, Huai'an found the butcher had returned to Qingping County seventeen years ago with a woman of unknown origin. Back then, all his business dealings were conducted under the name of an escort."

Grand Tutor Li said, "Throughout the entire Jizhou Prefecture, only He Jingyuan has the authority to forge household registries and other official documents."

He turned to his eldest son. "Are you saying He Jingyuan is helping that butcher hide something? And has been sheltering the butcher's family all along?"

Li Yuanting nodded. "Exactly so."

Grand Tutor Li fell silent for a long while.

Seventeen years—that number was far too sensitive.

How many significant events had occurred seventeen years ago?

Meng Shuyuan, a veteran general under Xie Linshan, had disregarded military orders to rescue 100,000 besieged border town civilians while transporting provisions. This delay in battle strategy led to the deaths of Chengde Crown Prince and Xie Linshan at Jinzhou, after which Meng committed suicide to atone, bearing eternal infamy.

That same year, the Eastern Palace caught fire, killing both the Crown Princess and the imperial grandson.

Grand Tutor Li spoke slowly, "What do you think He Jingyuan gave to Wei Yan?"

Li Yuanting was startled. "Unfortunately, He Jingyuan is meticulous in his work. Huai'an couldn't uncover anything else."

Grand Tutor Li replied, "If we can't find it, let those who can investigate instead."

Li Yuanting hesitated. "You mean... report it to His Majesty?"

Grand Tutor Li answered, "As Censorate Official Zhao once rightly said, this Great Yin Empire still bears the surname Qi."

The Censorate Official Zhao he referred to was the outspoken censor who had angrily spoken up after Wei Yan left earlier.

Li Yuanting realized he had guessed his father's intentions correctly.

The carriage had stopped, and Li Yuanting personally assisted Grand Tutor Li in alighting. With numerous servants and guards at the doorstep, the two refrained from further discussion of state affairs. Only after entering the residence did Li Yuanting continue, "Using His Majesty's hand, we can eliminate He Jingyuan and sever one of Wei Yan's limbs. But since you intend to support the one in Chongzhou, if His Majesty arranges a marriage between the Grand Princess and Wu'an Marquis, securing Wu'an Marquis as an ally, the situation could turn extremely unfavorable for us."

Grand Tutor Li lifted his eyelids slightly. "Didn't Huai'an mention a woman by Wu'an Marquis's side?"

Li Yuanting quickly responded, "Indeed, the butcher's daughter. When Huai'an first went to Jizhou and encountered bandits, it was Wu'an Marquis's personal cavalry disguised as Jizhou Prefecture soldiers who rescued her. Now, the woman is in the Jizhou army and has even been adopted as a foster daughter by Grand Tutor Tao. It seems Wu'an Marquis holds her in high regard."

Grand Tutor Li paused mid-step. "That old fox Tao Yi?"

His eyelids drooped slightly, his pupils appearing faint with age. After a moment, he said, "Find a way to let the Grand Princess hear of this."

Li Yuanting acknowledged the order.

He understood well—being adopted as Grand Tutor Tao's foster daughter elevated the woman's status significantly. Clearly, Wu'an Marquis had no intention of keeping her merely as a concubine.

The proud and haughty Grand Princess would never tolerate such a thing.

The Emperor sought to win over Wu'an Marquis through marriage, but whether this would forge an alliance or enmity remained uncertain.

A few days later, a memorial impeaching He Jingyuan for falsifying records and harboring criminals was presented to the Emperor.

He Jingyuan was Wei Yan's man, currently leading troops to suppress rebels in Chongzhou. Punishing him now would put the Emperor in a difficult position, so he handed the memorial to the court officials for deliberation on how to proceed.

The officials were at a loss—the accusers were Grand Tutor Li's faction, the accused Wei Yan's. Not one of them dared meddle in such a deadly factional struggle.

During that morning court session, only the Wei Faction and Li Faction argued fiercely.

In the end, the Emperor postponed the matter, citing ongoing military campaigns.

After the court session, Wei Yan and Grand Tutor Li crossed paths once more at the end of the white marble steps.

Grand Tutor Li still wore his usual smile as he cupped his hands and said, "Old men like me can no longer control our disciples—their minds are too set in their ways. I hope the Prime Minister won't take today's morning court affairs to heart."

The one who had impeached He Jingyuan was none other than Grand Tutor Li's disciple.

Wei Yan did not even return the courtesy this time. His hawk-like eyes swept over with an imposing air that commanded respect without anger: "Grand Tutor Li is getting old. Perhaps you could learn from Grand Tutor Tao. Back then, Grand Tutor Tao retired at the height of his career, and now not only the officials in the court but even His Majesty remembers him fondly, doesn't he?"

The smile on Grand Tutor Li's face faded slightly.

Only then did Wei Yan raise his hand slightly in a perfunctory gesture and say, "I shall take my leave first."

After Wei Yan had gone far, Grand Tutor Li's expression darkened as well.

Once inside the sedan, Wei Yan kept his eyes closed, his face stern and solemn.

Grand Tutor Li's move was an attempt to force the Emperor to investigate He Jingyuan.

Due to the war in Chongzhou, the Emperor had temporarily set the matter aside. But once the battle in Chongzhou was over, even without the Li family's prompting, the Emperor would bring it back to the agenda.

Seventeen years had passed, and the young Emperor was gradually gaining strength, seeking to wrest power from his hands.

Once He Jingyuan's act of forging an identity for that traitor was exposed, the Jinzhou Massacre from back then would inevitably be brought up. Meng Shuyuan was already a condemned criminal, and if his trusted aide shielded the offspring of a criminal, the Jinzhou case, which he had long sought to suppress, would likely face a retrial.

After a long silence, he opened his hawk-like eyes and said slowly, "He Jingyuan must not be spared."

Outside the sedan, a shadow swiftly darted away.

Chapter 101

Fan Changyu spent three full days thoroughly mastering the techniques He Jingyuan had taught her.

Yet without anyone to spar with, she couldn't gauge how much she had improved.

Counting the days, she would be able to return home the day after tomorrow. She planned to exchange a few good moves with Xie Zheng then.

The last time she returned to camp, Xie Zheng had mentioned he was in Chongzhou on official business. From the sound of it, he would be staying there for a while.

So, aside from training with the main army, Fan Changyu also squeezed in time to practice her carving.

After ruining countless pieces of wood, she finally managed to carve a rough but recognizable little figurine.

Unexpectedly, when training ended that day, Guo Baihu announced, "Starting today, the camp is sealed. No one is permitted to leave, and daily training hours will be doubled."

The soldiers below murmured among themselves, while Fan Changyu and another squad leader exchanged bewildered glances.

"What's all this noise?"

Guo Baihu's deep roar silenced the hushed discussions as his fierce gaze swept over them.

In a gruff voice, he barked, "The two squad leaders stay. The rest of you, return to your barracks and await orders!"

The soldiers dispersed in small groups, their whispers spreading once more.

Fan Changyu and the other squad leader remained, waiting for Guo Baihu's instructions.

He looked at them and said, "Your chance to earn glory has come. The main force is short on numbers, so we'll be deployed to the right flank behind the vanguard to support the main army's advance. Many soldiers serve for a decade and only get to clean up the battlefield at the rear. This time, we've lucked out. Fortune favors the bold—I've never been a coward in my life, so don't you dare lead a bunch of spineless soldiers and embarrass me!"

Only after Fan Changyu and the other squad leader repeatedly promised to intensify training did Guo Baihu dismiss them.

The war in Chongzhou had been at a stalemate for a long time. Fan Changyu hadn't expected the two armies to engage in a major clash so soon. As she walked back, lost in thought, Guo Baihu suddenly called her back. Half his face was hidden behind a thick beard as he rasped, "I know you've got connections higher up. You're skilled too. But if you're in danger on the battlefield, no one in my unit will risk their life to save you. If you want to pull strings and get transferred elsewhere, now's your chance."

Fan Changyu merely glanced at him and walked away without a word.

When she returned to the barracks, the soldiers huddled together, still discussing the implications of Guo Baihu's words.

Seeing Fan Changyu, one of them asked, "Squad Leader Fan, are we going to war?"

To maintain an air of authority, Fan Changyu usually spoke little in front of others and rarely showed expression.

Strangely enough, this tactic worked well. She hardly ever lost her temper, yet the soldiers beneath her seemed to fear her.

Of course, it might have something to do with the fact that on her first day leading them, she had shattered Guo Baihu's broadsword with a pair of iron hammers.

After she responded with a stern "Mm," the soldiers fell silent for a long moment, their faces a mix of unease about the unknown and sorrow at the thought that they might never see their parents, wives, or children again.

Fan Changyu knew that even soldiers feared war. After all, before donning their uniforms, they had been nothing more than laborers scraping by or hardworking farmers.

She didn't offer any inspiring words, simply saying, "In the coming days, everyone should practice their sword and spear techniques diligently. We may not seek wealth and honor, but we must have the skills to protect ourselves if we want to survive the battlefield and return home to see our wives, children, and elderly mothers."

After a pause, she added, "I managed to survive First Line Gorge with just a butcher's knife because the rebels I killed were fewer than the pigs I'd slaughtered before."

She thought hard for a moment before finally recalling the phrase, declaring with all seriousness: "Practice makes perfect—that applies everywhere. You're afraid of the battlefield, but the lowly soldiers in the rebel army are too. When everyone's afraid, it comes down to who can swing their blade or thrust their spear faster when fear strikes."

The soldiers burst into laughter, and the previously tense atmosphere dissipated considerably.

With their training directly tied to their survival, and Fan Changyu's "practice makes perfect" remark fresh in their minds, the several dozen men under her command trained with exceptional diligence.

Xie Wu even generously taught them several lethal combat techniques for one-strike kills.

On the eve of their departure, one of the soldiers sought out Fan Changyu and handed over all the military pay he'd earned since enlisting, asking her to keep it safe.

He said, "Squad leader, my mother only has me as her son. I'm from Huangping County in Jizhou. If I die, please take this silver to her."

After saying this, he ran off. Fan Changyu stared at the few pieces of broken silver in her palm for a long time before finally putting them away.

She used to fear the battlefield too, but when she thought of her parents' great vengeance, of Yu Qianqian trapped in Chongzhou City, and of Xie Zheng, her fear faded.

Military merit was the best path she could think of to achieve everything she needed to do on her own.

But now, she had another conviction—she wanted to lead every soldier under her command off the battlefield alive.

With a few hours left before their march, Fan Changyu lay awake, unable to sleep. She reached under her pillow and pulled out the half-carved wooden figurine she was working on.

The figurine already had hair carved out. She turned the blade and slowly carved out the eyes.

Since it was a round-headed, chubby doll, she made the eyes larger.

Recalling Xie Zheng's appearance in her mind, she angled the outer corners of the eyes upward as she finished, instantly giving the silly-looking doll an arrogant, nose-in-the-air demeanor.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but smile. She poked the doll's chubby cheeks and murmured, "Looks just like him."

Where was he now, she wondered?

The moon reached its zenith, startling crows in the forest.

Zhao Xun was forced to his knees, surrounded by corpses—all his guards.

His face was deathly pale, his forehead drenched in cold sweat. His pupils reflected the blood dripping from the sword tip of the man illuminated by torchlight. Trembling, he stammered, "M-Marquis..."

Xie Zheng flicked the sticky blood from his blade and glanced sideways. "Even a cunning rabbit only has three burrows. Young Master Zhao has so many hideouts, you've truly made this Marquis search hard for you."

A breeze rustled through the treetops, carrying his voice through the flickering torchlight—cool and faintly indifferent.

Several days earlier, after Fan Changyu returned to camp, Xie Zheng had gone to see Grand Tutor Tao. He had intended to discuss matters concerning the imperial grandson and the Li family, but Grand Tutor Tao mentioned urgent business in the capital and asked him to thoroughly investigate the connection between the imperial eldest grandson and Prince of Changxin before his return.

Xie Zheng agreed and had initially intended to seek out He Jingyuan to obtain answers regarding Fan Changyu's origins.

However, He Jingyuan happened to be personally overseeing the inventory of military provisions and equipment delivered by the court alongside Li Huaian. Since Xie Zheng was ostensibly stationed in

Kangcheng at the time, appearing abruptly in Chongzhou would only give the Li faction grounds to accuse him of abandoning his post. Thus, he proceeded directly to investigate the matter concerning the imperial eldest grandson.

The person most directly connected to the imperial eldest grandson was Zhao Xun, so Xie Zheng naturally began his inquiries with him.

Since the Zhao family was involved in business, their information network was extensive. Before Chongzhou was besieged, Zhao Xun had already left the city.

The Zhao family's business interests were vast, with numerous strongholds, and it took Xie Zheng some effort to finally corner him.

When Zhao Xun saw Xie Zheng arrive in person, he knew things had taken a dire turn. Struggling to maintain composure, he replied, "My lord jests. If there is any way this humble Zhao can be of service to you, I would gladly lay down my life..."

Xie Zheng regarded him with a faint, mocking smile. "When Young Master Zhao sought me out in Qingping County at the beginning of the year, you said the same thing."

Zhao Xun's face stiffened.

Xie Zheng rested his bloodstained sword on Zhao Xun's shoulder. Swallowing hard, Zhao Xun rasped, "My lord, please calm your anger. This lowly one's wretched life is also in another's hands. Many things... are beyond my control."

Xie Zheng applied slight pressure, lowering the blade. Zhao Xun dared not utter another word, sweat beading on his forehead like pearls, his body rigid as iron.

The bloodied sword slid across the fabric of Zhao Xun's robe, leaving behind a stark crimson streak.

Though the blade never touched his skin, Zhao Xun could already feel its icy edge and the sticky warmth of blood soaking into the cloth. The metallic scent assaulted his senses, draining all color from his face. His entire body trembled violently, as if shaken by a sieve.

Xie Zheng sheathed his sword and handed it to a personal guard behind him, casually remarking, "Don't mind me—just borrowing Young Master Zhao's robe to wipe off the blood."

Zhao Xun collapsed, utterly defeated. "Please, my lord... spare me."

A thin smile played on Xie Zheng's lips. "When I was in dire straits, Young Master Zhao procured two hundred thousand dan of grain for me. By that measure, we are old acquaintances. I'll ask you a few questions. Answer truthfully, and I won't make things difficult for you."

Mentioning the grain purchase only made Zhao Xun turn even paler.

Back then, he had bought the grain because he saw that Wei Yan intended to destroy Xie Zheng, while Grand Tutor Li merely watched from the sidelines, waiting for the conflict to escalate so he could impeach Wei Yan. Zhao Xun had acted preemptively to stockpile provisions for Jinzhou.

But he had deliberately left traces for He Jingyuan to discover, ensuring He Jingyuan knew Xie Zheng was behind the purchase. His original plan had been to pit Xie Zheng and He Jingyuan against each other—one having turned against Wei Yan, the other still loyal. Yet He Jingyuan had taken no action, leading to Wei Xuan's forced grain requisition, Sui Yuanqing's impersonation of requisition officers to incite violence, and the ensuing chaos.

Zhao Xun kowtowed heavily, his forehead pressed to the ground, voice quivering. "My lord, please quell your anger. At the time, I did advise His Highness, but my voice carried no weight—I couldn't sway his decisions. What happened... was never my intention."

Xie Zheng asked coldly, "You claim to serve the imperial eldest grandson. How can I be sure the one pulling your strings is truly him?"

Zhao Xun's eyes flickered with a hint of struggle before he finally answered, "My mother was the chief maid serving the Crown Princess. Later, when she reached the age, she was released from the palace—ostensibly to marry my father, but in truth, she was managing the Crown Princess's external assets in secret."

Xie Zheng had long ordered the investigation of the records concerning the East Palace fire years ago and knew that the Crown Princess did indeed have a chief maid who was released from the palace at the age of twenty-five.

The defeat at Jinzhou and the East Palace fire occurred one after the other. With the death of Chengde Crown Prince, the Crown Princess and the imperial grandson also met tragic fates. Anyone with eyes could see these two events were undoubtedly connected.

Behind the East Palace fire might lie the truth of the disastrous defeat at Jinzhou.

One of Xie Zheng's hands, clasped behind his back, unconsciously tightened, his voice cold and deep. "Didn't the Crown Princess and the imperial grandson both perish in the East Palace fire?"

Zhao Xun replied, "The East Palace fire was set by the Crown Princess herself, to secure a slim chance of survival for the imperial grandson."

Xie Zheng's brow furrowed sharply. "Who wanted the imperial grandson dead?"

Zhao Xun gave a bitter smile. "I truly don't know. My mother only received a letter written by the Crown Princess before her death, detailing the imperial grandson's whereabouts—after the fire. But the letter made no mention of who sought to harm the East Palace."

Xie Zheng's gaze turned icy, his expression mocking. "So, Young Master Zhao has spun a tale to deceive this Marquis?"

Zhao Xun hurriedly said, "I wouldn't dare. If the Marquis doubts me, there are the Crown Princess's handwritten letter and tokens as proof."

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes were dark and unreadable in the firelight as he asked, "The imperial grandson is now the eldest son of Prince Changxin?"

Having extracted so much information, coupled with Zhao Xun's close ties to Changxin Prince Manor and Changning's earlier mention of Yu Bao'er and her son being held there, everything pointed to one clear answer. Xie Zheng's final question was posed with absolute certainty.

Zhao Xun dared not conceal the truth and nodded.

Xie Zheng narrowed his long, narrow eyes.

Everything fell into place. Prince Changxin could only rebel under the banner of removing Wei Yan and purging the court of corrupt officials, never daring to invoke the imperial grandson's legitimacy—because Prince Changxin had no idea his own son had been switched.

The imperial grandson, too, dared not reveal himself.

After all, if Prince Changxin could outright rebel, discovering his son had been supplanted all these years would likely leave no room for the imperial grandson's survival.

Xie Zheng asked, "Was Sui Yuanqing's appearance in Qingping County at the beginning of the year also the imperial grandson's doing?"

Sweat dripped from Zhao Xun's eyelids as he answered, "Yes."

Through Zhao Xun, the imperial grandson learned of Xie Zheng's presence in Qingping County and orchestrated Sui Yuanqing's visit, intending to use Xie Zheng's hand to eliminate him.

At that time, Chongzhou had yet to show signs of defeat. If Prince Changxin could seize Jizhou while the Xie Family Army was tied down by the Northern Jue and press southward, even storming the capital to force the emperor's abdication was not impossible.

But Prince Changxin had named Sui Yuanqing as his heir. Even if they conquered the realm, Sui Yuanqing would inherit the throne.

Thus, the imperial grandson needed Sui Yuanqing dead.

Now that Prince Changxin was clearly losing, the imperial grandson realized storming the capital to reclaim the throne was no longer viable and had begun courting the Li family's favor.

Xie Zheng sneered coldly, "So this is the legacy of Chengde Crown Prince's bloodline?"

Zhao Xun gave a bitter smile. "When His Highness was young, in order to replace the eldest son of Prince Changxin, half his face was severely burned, leaving him with chronic illnesses. Over the years, his temper has grown increasingly erratic. Though I am merely a merchant reeking of copper, I still understand right from wrong. I have long secretly admired a peerless hero like the Marquis. I also know that if His Highness were to ascend the throne one day, the people would surely suffer."

He seemed to struggle internally before finally voicing his risky thoughts: "His Highness already has an heir. The Marquis must have seen the female proprietor of the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion in Qingping County—she was His Highness's concubine who fled. Her child is the imperial great-grandson. The state of the world today is clear: imperial authority wanes, factional strife persists, and the people endure hardship. The Marquis surpasses even Wei Yan of old. If the Marquis were willing to follow Wei Yan's example and support the imperial great-grandson's ascension, this humble one would gladly serve as the Marquis's most loyal hound!"

Xie Zheng showed not the slightest flicker of interest in his proposal. The faint upward curve of his lips carried a hint of mockery as he said, "You would betray your master to serve me. How can I be sure you won't turn and serve another just as easily?"

From ancient times to the present, turncoats have always been despised.

Zhao Xun, well aware of this, laid all his cards on the table: "I only seek a path to survival for myself and my mother. Ever since the imperial great-grandson was found, His Highness has grown increasingly paranoid. He even sent Shadow Guards to monitor us, fearing we might switch allegiance to support the great-grandson. His suspicions grow by the day, and I fear he may one day move against us."

After a pause, he added, "From the moment I first saw the Marquis, I recognized you as a towering figure of integrity. That is why I dare speak such bold words before you."

Xie Zheng ignored his flattery, his dark lashes half-lowered as he pondered the current situation.

The pine-resin torches crackled, their sound unusually distinct in the wind-swept night.

Xie Zheng asked, "Where are the imperial great-grandson and his mother now?"

Zhao Xun answered with difficulty, "They remain in Chongzhou City, along with my mother."

Effectively held as hostages to ensure his loyalty while carrying out tasks elsewhere.

Hearing this, Xie Zheng frowned slightly.

The imperial eldest grandson was now collaborating with the Li faction. To help them secure military merits in Chongzhou, He Jingyuan would first need to be removed.

The capital and Chongzhou were separated by thousands of miles. The impeachment accusations against He Jingyuan at court had not yet reached Xie Zheng's ears.

He asked, "What leverage do you have against He Jingyuan?"

Fan Changyu had spent the entire night carving wooden dolls and finally completed both the heads and bodies.

They were ugly at first glance, but after staring at them long enough, they seemed oddly endearing.

She was quite satisfied with her first creations.

While washing up, Xie Wu somehow procured a breastplate mirror for her to wear inside her uniform.

After glancing at its size, Fan Changyu decided it would be safer to continue wearing the two steel plates she had brought from Jizhou when setting out to find Changning.

When Xie Wu learned she intended to strap steel plates to both front and back, he was utterly dumbfounded.

Fan Changyu assumed his shock stemmed from never having seen someone as death-fearing as herself. But adhering to the principle that survival came first, she resolutely strapped them on anyway.

Generals wore breastplate mirrors because their armor already protected other vital areas—the heart was merely the last line of defense.

The soldier's uniform she was wearing probably couldn't even block a single strike—when it came down to it, she'd have to rely on steel plates to save her life.

That palm-sized heart protector, which Xie Wu found inconvenient and thought hindered his agility, Fan Changyu secretly gave to the soldier who had entrusted her with his silver for safekeeping.

When the soldier took the heart protector, he looked at Fan Changyu with teary eyes as if she were his savior, making her feel extremely awkward.

When Guo Baihu was counting the troops, he noticed Fan Changyu hadn't left. His expression was complicated—whether it was fear of trouble or something else, it was hard to tell.

He roared, "On the battlefield, killing one is breaking even, killing two is profit! Those who come back alive, I'll throw you a victory feast!"

Fan Changyu joined the surrounding soldiers in shouting "Yes!" at the top of their lungs.

Fear, valor, and concern—all seemed to be vented in that single shout.

Unlike the last time she went into battle, this time Fan Changyu and her comrades weren't positioned so far back, nor were they reinforcements arriving midway. They could clearly see the formations of both armies before the clash.

The dark masses resembled two ant colonies facing off. From such a distance, all they could see were the red tassels tied to the rebels' raised halberds, forming a continuous crimson line.

When the horns sounded from both sides, the vanguard troops of each army charged forward with roars, colliding almost instantly as if a dull thud had echoed across the field.

Fan Changyu thought the bravest soldiers in the army must be those in the Vanguard Battalion.

After all, those at the back followed the ones in front, while those at the front charged straight into the enemy's blades and spears.

To her surprise and relief, the few dozen soldiers under her command stuck close to her without fail. Wherever she fought, they immediately rushed to her side.

Fan Changyu couldn't tell whether they were trying to protect her or seeking her protection.

But their formation was undoubtedly like a sharp awl—with Fan Changyu as the tip, there was no place she couldn't pierce through. Xie Wu stayed close, never more than three steps behind her.

The Horse-Cutting Sword in Fan Changyu's hands became a blur as she advanced. At first, she could still see the Vanguard Battalion, but soon, her vision was filled with nothing but enemies.

Remembering their role was to support the vanguard, she grew anxious when she lost sight of them. While continuing to push forward, she asked Xie Wu, "Do you see the Vanguard Battalion's banner?"

The vanguard was supposed to break through the rebel ranks, while they were meant to squeeze through the gaps the vanguard created, allowing the infantry behind to widen the breach and divide the enemy forces.

If they got cut off anywhere and were surrounded by rebels, they'd be the ones getting slaughtered—a near-certain death.

Xie Wu, his face covered in blood, slashed horizontally at an oncoming rebel and said in frustration, "The Vanguard Battalion's already scattered—now we are the vanguard!"

Fan Changyu let out a confused "Huh?" Using the reach of her Horse-Cutting Sword, she forced back an attacking soldier and glanced behind her. Only then did she realize the troops following her had grown from a few dozen to a massive crowd.

Guo Baihu wasn't far behind, leaning on his longsword and panting heavily. He cursed, "You idiot, charging ahead like you're rushing to your grave—you turned my right flank into the damn vanguard!"

Xie Wu ignored Guo Baihu, wiped the blood from his face, and said to Fan Changyu, "I'll go retrieve the vanguard flag. The soldiers behind can't see the banner and don't know which direction to charge."

On the battlefield, the worst mistake is to break formation and let the enemy divide and conquer.

Fan Changyu kicked one man flying and shouted, "Where's the flag?"

Xie Wu, skilled in qinggong, leaped several steps forward by stepping on the rebels' heads and pointed in a direction for Fan Changyu. Changyu then advanced like a sharp blade, cutting through the enemy ranks toward that spot.

The commanders observing from the heights watched with grim expressions as the vanguard's goose formation was scattered, seemingly foreseeing defeat in this first battle. Unexpectedly, a new spearhead suddenly emerged from the right flank protecting the vanguard's charge—sharp as a bee's stinger—piercing relentlessly toward the rebel army's core.

At first, the commanders exchanged bewildered glances. But when this newly formed spearhead joined forces with the scattered remnants of the vanguard, hoisted the vanguard's banner, and drove the rebels into retreat, their expressions turned peculiar.

One commander remarked, "I've heard of rearguards turning into vanguards, but this is the first time I've seen a right flank take on the vanguard's role. To stabilize the offensive and defensive situation without even needing to reform the formation—the commander must be a seasoned veteran, sharp enough to grasp the entire battlefield."

Another added, "That right flank was hastily assembled from General Tang's new recruits. Truly, his command is full of talent."

Tang Peiyi forced a stiff smile in response, his eyes fixed intently on the battlefield below, straining to identify the commander. But the distance was too great—he nearly went cross-eyed without catching a clear glimpse. He racked his brain but couldn't recall having such a capable officer under his command.

Only He Jingyuan remained silent, gazing down at the battlefield.

Chapter 102

The wind howled across the heavens, swirling with yellow sand.

The Chongzhou army, their formation shattered by the relentless charge of the Jizhou troops, was thrown into chaos on the battlefield. Junior officers struggled to maintain order, but the pursuing Jizhou forces pressed too closely, widening the breaches in their ranks until they were fragmented and surrounded.

In war, momentum is everything. Once morale crumbled, the Chongzhou soldiers were swiftly beaten back by the ferocious assault of the Jizhou army.

The frontline Jizhou soldiers, bloodlust in their eyes, fought with increasing ferocity.

Among the Chongzhou ranks, from generals to foot soldiers, fear crept onto their faces. Even the shouts of charging officers lacked their usual conviction.

Some soldiers even began to flee the battlefield in disarray.

The Chongzhou commander, enraged, drew his sword and executed several retreating soldiers, bellowing hoarsely, "Those who retreat—show no mercy!"

But his voice was drowned out by the deafening clash of steel and the roar of battle, rendering his command futile.

Just as the commander prepared to lead a charge himself, the thunder of war drums erupted from the walls of Chongzhou city behind him.

The towering walls of Chongzhou, with their Bastion Walls extending like wings into the mountains, amplified the sound of dozens of drums beating in unison. The waves of sound, trapped on three sides, surged through the only opening like a tidal wave.

The terrain acted like a funnel, sending the drumbeats echoing across the battlefield, shaking the hearts of all who heard them.

Fan Changyu, leading the right flank in the thick of battle, instinctively turned toward the city gates at the sound of the drums.

The massive gates, which could withstand a battering ram for half a day without yielding, now creaked open slowly, parting the smoke and banners strewn across the ground.

Dust billowed as spears and halberds advanced in unison. The defenders inside, faces twisted with fury, charged out with weapons raised, roaring like a flood unleashed from a broken dam.

After two vanguard units surged forward to stabilize the front lines, an elderly general with half-black, half-white hair and clad in Golden Mountain Pattern Armor rode forth on a prized steed. Drawing his sword, he bellowed, "Charge—!"

More Chongzhou defenders poured from the gates behind him, howling as they stormed onto the battlefield.

From the rebel ranks, someone shouted, "The Prince himself has taken the field! Victory for Chongzhou!"

Like a stone cast into still waters, the cry rippled through the battlefield.

With reinforcements arriving and the Prince of Changxin leading the charge, the demoralized Chongzhou forces, who had been on the verge of collapse, suddenly found their fighting spirit renewed.

Earlier in the battle, Fan Changyu had seized a horse, planting the vanguard's banner into the stirrup and steadying the flagpole with her foot to keep it upright.

After hours of relentless combat, her mount was exhausted. Though her strikes with the Horse-Cutting Sword remained fierce, she was only human—her arms ached with fatigue, her hands trembling uncontrollably during brief pauses.

Not from fear, but from muscles pushed beyond their limits, spasming from sheer exhaustion.

From horseback, her vantage point gave her a clearer view of the battlefield. As she assessed the disparity in numbers between the two sides, she realized with grim certainty: if the rebels encircled them now, none of them would make it back alive.

She forcefully pressed her foot into the stirrup, tugging the reins to turn in another direction. Sweat-drenched strands of hair clung to her face, sticky with dust and grime. Her eyes blazed with the ferocity of a tiger or leopard as she shouted, "Cut through the middle of this entangled Chongzhou army! Don't let them trap us here!"

The vanguard's banners flapped fiercely behind her. Though clad in the tattered armor of a common soldier, no one could mistake her for one.

The Jizhou soldiers behind her immediately followed her lead, executing a swift turn like a coiling dragon's tail, keeping close behind without hesitation.

The rebels, having been battered by the imperial vanguard that had torn through their formations, now saw their chance to retaliate. With reinforcements arriving, they threw themselves into blocking the retreat with reckless abandon.

Their commanding general even abandoned rear defenses, deploying all forces to flank from both sides, determined to trap and annihilate the imperial vanguard that had breached their lines.

He Jingyuan and his subordinate generals stood atop a vantage point, observing the battlefield below.

Tang Peiyi, furious, struck the pine tree beside him and clasped his fists in salute. "General, I request permission to lead troops to relieve the right flank!"

After a moment of contemplation, He Jingyuan replied, "Sui Tuo once earned his title through military merit. Though aged, his Lion-Head Spear remains formidable. I will lead three thousand men to confront him personally. General Tang, take two thousand and reinforce the right flank."

Tang Peiyi's worry instantly turned to relief. "Understood, General!" he responded eagerly.

Before Fan Changyu, figures blurred in and out of focus. She swung her blade with near-numb determination, the hot, bitter liquid dripping from her eyelids into her eyes—whether sweat or blood, she couldn't tell.

Her jaw clenched tightly. As her blade sliced through the rebel soldiers blocking her path, she could no longer distinguish whose expression was more savage—theirs or her own.

There was a time when she couldn't bring herself to strike down rebel soldiers on the battlefield.

But now, those following her were comrades who had entrusted their lives to her. If she hesitated, the next blade might fall upon those who had followed her without hesitation.

As an outsider, she could pity the lowest-ranking soldiers on both sides. But now, she was part of the fray—just as she had once raised her blade against mountain bandits to protect her neighbors, defending her brothers-in-arms had become her duty.

Fan Changyu fought like a frenzied leopard. Every swing of her Horse-Cutting Sword sent sprays of blood into the air.

The rebels soon recognized her as a formidable foe. When their soldiers were forced to charge toward her warhorse, hesitation and fear flickered across their faces, allowing her unit to retreat slowly, though with great difficulty.

But soon, another unit of soldiers wielding Hook Scythe Spears advanced. Their weapons were different—long spears with crescent-shaped scythes attached, capable of both thrusting and slashing from a distance.

Xie Wu's face paled at the sight of them. "Watch out!" he shouted to Fan Changyu.

The rebel soldiers worked in tandem—one group stood upright, thrusting their spears toward Fan Changyu on horseback, while another knelt, sweeping their Hook Scythe Spears toward the legs of her steed.

Even though Xie Wu and the others behind her did their best to fend off the enemy soldiers, Fan Changyu's warhorse had its legs slashed and collapsed with a whinny.

As Fan Changyu was thrown off, countless rebels swarmed toward her like hyenas drawn to the scent of blood, thrusting their spears at her.

Using the banner on horseback to brace herself, she vaulted into the air, kicking a circle of rebels in their breastplates before landing steadily.

Her hands were slick with blood, making it impossible to grip the black iron hilt of her Horse-Cutting Sword. The banner was about ten feet long, its pole tipped with a spearhead, so she rolled the flag tightly around the pole and wielded it as a weapon.

Any soldier who got within five paces of her was swept away by the banner.

By then, Xie Wu had fought his way to her. As the spearhead of the vanguard, Fan Changyu was like the lead goose in flight—undoubtedly the most exhausted.

Her stamina was nearly spent. Xie Wu snatched the banner from her hands, his once-delicate face now smeared with blood, making it impossible to tell whose it was—his or the enemy's.

Gasping for breath, he said, "Squad leader, I'll lead the retreat!"

The banner unfurled in his grasp, fluttering in the wind once more, guiding the Jizhou troops to rally behind them.

Fan Changyu, drained of strength, leaned on her Horse-Cutting Sword, panting. A rebel tried to ambush her from behind, but Guo Baihu roared and swung his blade, nearly cleaving the man in two.

Fan Changyu glanced back. Half of Guo Baihu's face was hidden beneath his thick beard, only his bloodshot eyes gleaming with ferocity. "I said I wouldn't give a damn about you once we hit the battlefield, but you didn't shame me! Even if I die here today, this fight was worth it!"

Without warning, Fan Changyu swung her Horse-Cutting Sword at him, startling Guo Baihu into a cold sweat.

The next moment, a spray of blood drenched half his shoulder.

He stiffened, turning to see the rebel who had silently crept up behind him, sword raised—only to be cut down by Fan Changyu before he could strike.

His thick beard twitched, and he refocused, shouting at Fan Changyu, "We're even!"

Fan Changyu didn't respond. Her hands were still slick with blood, making the sword hilt slippery, and her fingers were so weak she could barely grip the blade.

Her lips were dry and cracked, and she had no energy left for words.

She tore a strip of cloth from her battle robe and wrapped it tightly around her hand before gripping the sword hilt again.

Xie Wu, holding the banner, was a moving target. Countless blades and spears struck at him—he dodged the fatal blows, but the accumulation of lesser wounds left half his battle robe soaked in blood.

When a rebel officer charged on horseback, spear aimed at Xie Wu's life, Xie Wu had just swung the banner to drive back the surrounding soldiers—he had no time to block or evade.

Fan Changyu lunged forward, just as she had once saved him from Shi Hu's warhammer at First Line Gorge, using her Horse-Cutting Sword to parry the officer's thrust.

The prolonged battle had left Xie Wu dizzy. He had to stay close to Fan Changyu—in this army, if she bore the brunt of the fighting, then he was the second most exhausted.

Not only did he have to look out for himself, but he also had to constantly monitor the situation around Fan Changyu.

Seeing Fan Changyu block that spear thrust for him, he instinctively called out, "Squad leader..."

Fan Changyu shoved him backward into the ranks of the advancing Jizhou troops and snapped, "Get behind me!"

In the same breath, the blade of her Horse-Cutting Sword clashed violently with the spear tip of the young general on horseback, sending sparks flying.

The force of Fan Changyu's strike sent the young general reeling backward, throwing his attack off by half a beat. Before he could even process the shock of her immense strength, Fan Changyu had already crouched low and slashed at the legs of his horse.

The Horse-Cutting Sword's blade was slender and razor-sharp, and combined with Fan Changyu's formidable strength, the warhorse's front legs were severed cleanly. As the beast collapsed forward in a gush of blood, the young general was flung from its back by the momentum.

Fan Changyu swept her blade sideways once more, and the young general's head tumbled to the ground with a dull thud.

Guo Baihu, who had been gripping his Crescent Blade and preparing to rush to her aid, gulped and muttered to Xie Wu, "Sweet mother of mercy, how is she this strong?"

But Xie Wu didn't even respond. Though worried for Fan Changyu's safety, he couldn't easily move to her side while carrying the flag—a living target. Instead, he shoved the banner into Guo Baihu's hands and said, "The flag is yours now."

Without waiting for a reply, he snatched up a long saber and charged forward, joining Fan Changyu in clearing a path for the army.

Butcher Guo glanced down at the bloodstained banner in his hands—who knew how many lives had been lost beneath it—and cursed loudly, "Do I look like the kind of man who hides in the back holding a damn flag?"

He promptly passed the banner to a soldier behind him and barked, "You lot, protect the vanguard flag and stay close!"

With that, he swung his broadsword and cut down a rebel soldier, then hurried after Fan Changyu and Xie Wu, hacking his way forward while growling, "I'm the damn Baihu here! You little brats think you can charge ahead of me?"

The soldiers behind him were momentarily bewildered, but the wounded officers among them understood that the flag was a crucial beacon in the chaotic battlefield—it couldn't be lost. They quickly ordered a hundred or so men to form a protective circle around it.

The rest maintained their wedge formation on the outer edges, clinging tightly to the bloody path Fan Changyu and the others had carved out. Like ants huddling together in a fire, they slowly pushed their way through the rebel encirclement.

Chapter 103

When the banners of the reinforcements led by Tang Peiyi finally came into view, Fan Changyu and the exhausted soldiers behind her felt a renewed hope of breaking through.

Many of the foot soldiers grew excited, fighting the enemy with even greater ferocity.

Guo Baihu also roared in exhilaration, "Damn it, I almost thought my life would end here!"

Tang Peiyi spotted the vanguard flag of Fan Changyu's unit and led his reinforcements toward them. Seeing their encirclement was futile, the rebel commander raised his signal flag and galloped away, swiftly issuing orders through flag signals.

The rebels pursuing Fan Changyu and her men loosened their grip, allowing them to quickly merge with Tang Peiyi's reinforcements.

Tang Peiyi, still mounted, looked at Fan Changyu with surprise. "So it was you who adapted to the battlefield, leading the right flank as the vanguard into the enemy formation?"

Changyu was in a wretched state—her helmet long lost, her small topknot barely holding, her face smeared with blood and dust. Only her piercing black eyes remained fierce, like a tiger descending the mountain.

Exhausted, she leaned on her Horse-Cutting Sword to stay upright. She was about to clasp her fists in response when Tang Peiyi, noticing her group's fatigue, waved his hand to dismiss the formality. "The right flank has performed exceptionally. Once this battle is over, I will personally commend you before Lord He!"

The weary soldiers behind Changyu perked up at his words, their faces lighting up with joy.

But then, chaos erupted on the frontlines. Through the throngs of figures, Changyu and her men couldn't discern what was happening. Tang Peiyi, however, turned his head sharply, his expression hardening. "The rebels are trying to encircle General He! Follow me to reinforce him!"

With Tang Peiyi's troops clearing the way, Changyu and the right flank finally had a moment to catch their breath.

Tang Peiyi led his cavalry to break through the rebels encircling He Jingyuan's five thousand troops, swiftly tearing open a gap. Changyu then led the right flank through the breach, cutting down rebel foot soldiers on either side to widen the opening, ensuring the trapped Jizhou troops could retreat if needed.

With Tang Peiyi and He Jingyuan drawing the rebels' main forces, Changyu's unit only had to deal with scattered foot soldiers, making their task far easier than before.

But suddenly, Tang Peiyi's cavalry formation inexplicably collapsed, allowing rebel forces to penetrate their ranks.

Changyu and the others strained to see what was happening at the center of the battlefield, but the shifting figures obscured their view.

Guo Baihu cursed, "What the hell is going on up front?"

Then, a rebel voice roared, "He Jingyuan is dead!"

The cry spread like wildfire, electrifying the rebels.

Among the Jizhou troops—whether Tang Peiyi's cavalry or Changyu's right flank—shock and fear flickered across their faces. He Jingyuan was the commanding general of this campaign against Chongzhou. If he was dead, how could the battle continue?

Changyu pressed her cracked lips together, glanced toward the chaotic battlefield ahead, and turned to the surviving soldiers under her command. "Stay here and protect Baihu. You don't need to follow me!"

With that, she charged straight toward the heart of the battlefield.

Xie Zheng had once told her—He Jingyuan was an old friend of her parents.

She had been in Chongzhou for so long, staying dutifully in the military camp without using Grand Tutor Tao or Xie Zheng's influence to directly approach He Jingyuan and ask about her parents. She wanted to rely on herself to rise through the ranks, earn the right to meet He Jingyuan, and then inquire about her parents' affairs.

She intended to avenge her parents with her own abilities. In this matter, Fan Changyu was unwilling to overly depend on Grand Tutor Tao

and Xie Zheng.

Who would have thought that in this first major battle, she was unharmed, but He Jingyuan, the commander, had died?

No matter what, she wanted to fight her way to the front to see for herself.

Without hesitation, Xie Wu followed her forward. Some loyal soldiers, seeing this, also picked up their weapons to join, but they were stopped by Guo Baihu, who had just beheaded a rebel. Furious, his beard almost bristling, he cursed, "What, do you all think your heads are too securely attached to your necks?"

One of the soldiers burst into tears, sobbing, "General He is dead. Squad leader Fan must be fighting her way in to find him. I want to go in and retrieve General He's body too."

He Jingyuan was renowned for his love of the people and his soldiers, treating them like his own children. Both the military and civilians of Jizhou held him in high esteem.

Hearing the sudden news of his death on the battlefield, the soldiers below were thrown into disarray.

Guo Baihu slapped the crying soldier across the face and roared, "Playing the hero isn't your job! Don't you know your own limits? Hold this gap for me!"

Fan Changyu fought her way forward. To get a better view of the battlefield ahead, she even seized a horse from a rebel.

She didn't recognize He Jingyuan, but seeing Tang Peiyi locked in combat with a Chongzhou general, she urged her horse toward them.

Tang Peiyi turned and spotted Fan Changyu, shouting urgently, "Quick, save General He and get him back to camp!"

Hearing Tang Peiyi's shout, Fan Changyu felt a wave of relief.

He Jingyuan wasn't dead!

The earlier news must have been spread by the rebels to demoralize their troops.

She scanned the area and spotted a Jizhou general who had fallen from his horse, struggling against rebel soldiers. She cut her way through,

shouting at the top of her lungs, "General He, is that you?"

The old general looked up. Even with his beard stained red from coughing up blood and his face smeared with grime, Fan Changyu recognized him instantly—he was the general who had once instructed her in swordsmanship.

Her heart pounded. Countless thoughts flashed through her mind, but the dangers of the battlefield forced her to push them aside for now. Swinging her Horse-Cutting Sword, she carved a path through the enemy and reached the old general, extending a hand. "General, let me get you out of here!"

After cutting down another rebel soldier, He Jingyuan leaned heavily on his long sword to steady himself. His weary, aged eyes studied Fan Changyu, a faint trace of approval in his gaze. "It's you... cough cough ..."

He covered his mouth, coughing violently. Despite his efforts to hide it, blood seeped through his fingers.

Fan Changyu realized He Jingyuan's condition was dire. Her gaze dropped to the broken arrow embedded in his chest armor, the surrounding metal already soaked red with blood.

As more rebel generals closed in like hyenas, and He Jingyuan, severely wounded, could barely lift his sword, she didn't hesitate. With a battle cry, she leaped from her horse and charged forward, blade raised.

When Xie Wu arrived, Fan Changyu shouted at him, "Quick, take General He and go!"

He Jingyuan recognized Xie Wu and naturally understood that his presence on the battlefield was likely on Xie Zheng's orders to protect Fan Changyu.

Perhaps sensing his impending doom, He Jingyuan thought of the tangled grievances between the Xie and Fan families of their fathers' generation. Watching Fan Changyu, who was fighting several young Jizhou officers to cover his retreat, he felt a bitter taste in his mouth.

Xie Wu helped He Jingyuan onto a horse while Fan Changyu fought a retreat, struggling not to be trapped in the rebels' encirclement.

Meanwhile, Tang Peiyi was ultimately no match for Changxin Wang. With a sweep of his staff, Changxin Wang knocked Tang off his horse. Tang

rolled on the ground to evade the opportunistic stabs from the enemy soldiers below.

Seeing He Jingyuan being rescued, Changxin Wang spurred his horse forward in pursuit, bellowing, "Where do you think you're going, you Wei family dog!"

He thrust his Lion-Head Spear forward. Xie Wu raised his weapon to block, but the sheer force of Changxin Wang's strike forced him to one knee, his kneecap sinking into the yellow earth. The back of his blade pressed against his shoulder, and even through his armor, blood began to seep from the wound.

Xie Wu clenched his teeth so hard that the metallic tang of blood filled his mouth. His fingers, white-knuckled around the hilt, couldn't lift the Lion-Head Spear pressing down on his blade even a fraction.

Changxin Wang exerted more force, and Xie Wu coughed up blood but still refused to let go, his eyes fixed fiercely on the prince.

Changxin Wang laughed heartily. "What a fine lad! Even a mere foot soldier has such skill. Truly a waste in Jizhou. Why not serve under me?"

Xie Wu spat fiercely in response.

Changxin Wang's expression darkened. "Ungrateful wretch!" he roared.

He raised his Lion-Head Spear to strike Xie Wu down, but He Jingyuan, barely holding on atop his horse, mustered the strength to block the blow with his own spear.

He Jingyuan was not only wounded by arrows but also severely injured internally. The slightest exertion sent him into a coughing fit, his organs feeling as though they were tearing apart.

After blocking that single spear thrust, he slumped over his horse, coughing uncontrollably, and urged Xie Wu, "Don't worry about me! Run!"

Changxin Wang sneered. "What's the hurry? None of you will escape today!"

He swung his Lion-Head Spear in a wide arc, aiming for Xie Wu again, but a black iron longsword suddenly intercepted his weapon.

The clash sent a numbing shock through Changxin Wang's hand, and he turned in surprise to see the newcomer.

The figure wore the tattered uniform of a Jizhou foot soldier, face smeared with blood and dirt. Though slight of build for a man, the way he stood gripping the longsword exuded an air of holding the pass against ten thousand.

Changxin Wang mused, "How strange. Today, the foot soldiers of Jizhou seem to grow more formidable by the minute."

Fan Changyu growled, "To slay a traitorous subject like you, foot soldiers like us are enough!"

Her voice was hoarse, resembling a young man's, which for the moment didn't arouse Changxin Wang's suspicion.

Changxin Wang scoffed. "Arrogant brat! Take this!"

He spurred his horse forward, launching a rapid series of spear thrusts. Fan Changyu blocked and dodged, but aside from Xie Zheng and He Jingyuan, this was her first time facing such a skilled commander. His attacks were swift and unpredictable, leaving her struggling to keep up.

Seeing Fan Changyu at a disadvantage, Xie Wu knew the ruthless Prince of Changxin would show no mercy. His anxiety burned like fire. When Tang Peiyi finally fought his way through the minor soldiers, Xie Wu immediately instructed him to protect He Jingyuan and retreat while he rushed to assist Fan Changyu.

Tang Peiyi, torn between concern for Fan Changyu and worry over He Jingyuan's injuries, escorted He Jingyuan back to the Jizhou army lines. Noticing He Jingyuan's pale lips, he couldn't help but curse, "That damned Prince of Changxin, ambushing during combat—what kind of tactic is that? If not for this arrow wound, you might have bested him!"

He Jingyuan's expression darkened as he recalled the arrow strike.

Being hit by stray arrows wasn't uncommon on the battlefield, but he had an inkling of who truly loosed that shot—intending for him to die beneath the Prince of Changxin's blade.

Was the Prime Minister so desperate to silence him, fearing he might reveal the truth about the Fan couple?

And was Wei Qilin truly innocent in that grain transport mishap years ago?

Suddenly gripping Tang Peiyi's arm with difficulty, he rasped, "Go... bring that child out."

Tang Peiyi froze momentarily before realizing He Jingyuan likely meant Fan Changyu. Unwilling to let such a promising talent perish under the prince's hand, he quickly replied, "I'll go aid her at once! My lord, return to camp for treatment!"

Fan Changyu and Xie Wu fought side by side, yet the Prince of Changxin's onslaught remained overwhelming.

Her swordsmanship had improved, but compared to a seasoned veteran like the prince—who had decades of battlefield experience—she was still too green. Exhaustion further dulled her attacks.

Noticing her martial style, the prince suddenly asked while sizing her up, "What is He Jingyuan to you?"

Panting as she leaned on her Horse-Cutting Sword, Fan Changyu shouted, "He is my Jizhou army commander!"

The prince sneered. "This blade technique was jointly created by the two tiger generals of the Wei clan—He Jingyuan and his sworn brother. That brother died years ago, leaving only He Jingyuan who still practices it. How could a mere foot soldier inherit his true teachings?"

Fan Changyu stiffened at these words.

Her father had taught her this technique, and He Jingyuan had recognized it instantly during their training.

Could her father have been He Jingyuan's sworn brother?

Before she could process this, the prince's spear tip twisted as he charged toward her on horseback: "Once I capture you, I'll negotiate terms with He Jingyuan while he still clings to life!"

Fan Changyu wasn't foolish enough to block the mounted strike head-on. Heeding Xie Wu's warning, she dodged aside.

Just then, Tang Peiyi returned on horseback to assist them. Seizing the moment while Tang Peiyi engaged the prince, Fan Changyu used her sword's reach to slash at the horse's hind legs.

The steed collapsed sideways, but the prince vaulted clear using his spear, landing steadily with a fierce glare.

Tang Peiyi's charge failed, and as he wheeled his horse around with a roar—"Die, traitor!"—the prince mimicked Fan Changyu's earlier move, spinning to stab Tang Peiyi's mount.

The panicked horse bolted wildly across the battlefield, forcing Tang Peiyi to leap off and tumble repeatedly before stopping.

By now, Fan Changyu and Xie Wu were utterly spent, their bodies littered with wounds. Xie Wu had sustained internal injuries earlier while parrying the prince's blows and was barely holding on.

Fan Changyu understood that even if she and Tang Peiyi joined forces now, they were no match for Changxin Wang.

She was utterly exhausted, barely able to swing her Horse-Cutting Sword anymore. Dragging this out would only result in Changxin Wang overpowering them first.

Her gaze fell upon a young Chongzhou officer riding to aid Changxin Wang. Suddenly, she lunged toward him.

The officer noticed Fan Changyu's intent and hastily raised his spear to thrust, but she grabbed the shaft and yanked him off his horse. With one hand gripping the saddle, she vaulted onto the galloping steed. Seizing the moment while Changxin Wang was occupied with Tang Peiyi, she swung her blade sideways in a sweeping slash.

Changxin Wang narrowly dodged and attempted to pursue, but two legs were no match for four. Tang Peiyi, catching Fan Changyu's signal, swiftly retreated as well.

By the time other Chongzhou reinforcements arrived, Changxin Wang had commandeered a horse and gave chase.

Fan Changyu lay flat against the horse's back, avoiding combat and leading Changxin Wang on a wild pursuit. She panted harder than the galloping steed beneath her, trying to buy time to recover her strength.

Changxin Wang seemed to realize her plan. He drew the great bow from his horse's back, nocked a white-feathered arrow, and loosed it at Fan Changyu.

Feeling the arrow whistle past her scalp, she had the chilling thought that today might be her last. She pressed herself even lower against the horse.

When his arrows missed their mark, Changxin Wang aimed for her mount instead.

The horse screamed as an arrow struck its leg, sending it crashing to the ground. Fan Changyu tumbled, her Horse-Cutting Sword clattering aside. Gasping for breath, she seemed utterly spent.

Changxin Wang pressed his Lion-Head Spear against her throat, then frowned deeply upon noticing her lack of an Adam's apple. "A woman?"

Fan Changyu, her face drained, remained silent.

He drove the spearhead beneath her breastplate at the ribs, intending to hoist her onto his horse. But as he grabbed her collar to sling her over the saddle, Fan Changyu struck—drawing the Boning knife hidden beneath her vambrace and plunging it deep into Changxin Wang's unarmored armpit.

Her years as a butcher served her well—she knew exactly where bone, sinew, and cartilage lay. The blade sank to the hilt without resistance.

"You—" Changxin Wang stared at his sleeve, now soaked in blood, then at Fan Changyu, speechless.

Clenching his jaw against the blood rising in his throat, he drew a dagger and slashed at her neck. Still pinned by his spear, Fan Changyu had no room to dodge. She caught the blade with her bare hand, gripping it tightly to halt its descent toward her throat.

It was a desperate gamble—whether Changxin Wang would succumb to the knife in his ribs first or she would falter from pain and exhaustion.

Her vision blurred from agony and blood loss, sweat streaming down her temples. Just as her grip began to fail, Changxin Wang shuddered violently, the blood he'd held back now gushing from his mouth.

A white-feathered arrow had pierced his heart, its triangular tip even punching through his mountain-pattern armor, the bloody point protruding from his chest.

When Prince Changxin toppled from his horse, Fan Changyu was still impaled on his Lion-Head Spear through her breastplate. With both hands severely cut and burning with pain, she couldn't free herself in time and was dragged down with him.

Yet in that moment of falling, she spotted a figure standing with a bow atop a distant horse.

The man bore a hideous scar running from his nose bridge across his left cheek. His right eye was covered, as if the scar extended upward to that eye.

Fan Changyu recognized him—he was the one who had saved her when she nearly drowned in an icy lake at the hands of mountain bandits.

As she fell, the man had already spurred his horse toward her. Amidst the chaotic battlefield where slaughter raged everywhere, everything around her seemed to freeze—only the dust kicked up by his galloping horse remained in motion.

A blade sliced through her breastplate, the Lion-Head Spear clattered to the ground, and she was swiftly hauled onto the horse's back.

When her back pressed against the man's chest, Fan Changyu gasped his name: "Yan Zheng?"

But she didn't hear his reply. The familiar scent of him made the tension in her mind dissolve, and she fainted from exhaustion and blood loss.

So she never knew how tightly he held her—his arms trembling faintly—

Fan Changyu woke two days later.

It wasn't due to severe injuries, but sheer exhaustion.

Peeling her eyes open and realizing she was in her own military tent, she sighed in relief. Just as she tried to sit up, she winced—her entire body ached, and her hands were wrapped into thick bundles.

Drawing a shallow breath, she recalled the person she'd seen before passing out, now uncertain whether it had been real or a hallucination.

Out of habit, she called out: "Xiao Wu?"

Hearing no response, she remembered Xie Wu had also been struck by Prince Changxin in battle, coughing up blood—he was likely still recovering in the infirmary tent.

Using her bandaged hands like clumsy mitts, she tried to prop herself up slowly when the tent flap suddenly lifted.

Xie Wu entered, carrying a steaming bowl of medicine. "Squad leader called for me? I was just outside preparing your medicine."

Fan Changyu hurriedly asked, "How are your injuries?"

Xie Wu replied, "Just minor wounds. Mostly healed now."

His voice was the same, but his entire demeanor seemed subdued, making Fan Changyu feel oddly unsettled.

She studied him in surprise, noticing he seemed taller.

Puzzled, she asked, "Xiao Wu, how old are you this year?"

Xie Wu answered, "Seventeen."

Fan Changyu nodded in sudden understanding. "No wonder you look taller—still growing, then."

She stretched out her mitten-like hands to take the medicine bowl, but Xie Wu hesitated. "Your hands are injured. Should I feed you?"

Fan Changyu gave him an even stranger look.

Xie Wu lowered his eyes. "The Army Doctor said both your hands suffered tendon damage. Without proper care, you might struggle to wield weapons in the future."

Fan Changyu glanced at her heavily bandaged hands. "So it's that serious."

Her tone betrayed no concern as she asked instead, "What about our squad's casualties?"

Xie Wu answered, "Thirteen dead, seventeen severely wounded. The rest have minor injuries."

As if aware that Fan Changyu had just joined the army and might not yet understand the casualty rates in each campaign, he added, "It's common for the vanguard forces to be completely wiped out. Suffering only half casualties is already fortunate. Squad leader, you needn't blame yourself too much."

Though he said so, Changyu's heart still grew heavy. She said, "When the army's compensation funds come through, send my share of the reward along to their families."

Xie Wu glanced at Fan Changyu and said, "Squad leader, you killed Changxin Wang (Prince of Changxin) and claimed the first merit in this battle. The reward will be at least a thousand taels of silver."

Fan Changyu froze. "I killed him?"

Xie Wu nodded.

Fan Changyu tried to recall the events before she lost consciousness. She remembered stabbing Changxin Wang, but it was Xie Zheng who finished him off with an arrow before he breathed his last.

Frowning, she asked Xie Wu, "He... didn't come to the army? I remember seeing him on the battlefield. He was the one who shot Changxin Wang and saved me."

Xie Wu's eyes darkened unexpectedly, deep and still like the abyss untouched by sunlight for millennia. "The Grand Tutor was ambushed on his way to the capital and disappeared. The Marquis, concerned for the Grand Tutor's safety, went to investigate those who abducted him. He was never in Chongzhou."

Fan Changyu's expression changed instantly at his words. "Foster Father!"

Overcome with agitation, she tried to stand but collapsed back onto the bed from the soreness in her muscles. Xie Wu swiftly reached out to steady her but withdrew his hand the moment he noticed the bite mark on his index finger.

Too preoccupied to notice Xie Wu's momentary unease, Fan Changyu muttered to herself, "Why would Foster Father suddenly go to the capital when everything was fine?"

Thinking of Changxin Wang's death, she insisted, "I only stabbed him under the armpit. The arrow in his body wasn't mine—someone helped me, a one-eyed Scarface Man..."

She had wanted to say that person was likely Xie Zheng.

But Xie Wu cut her off. "When General Tang and I arrived, Squad leader, you were lying on the ground beside your horse, gripping a broken arrow in your hand. There's no doubt you killed Changxin Wang. Could it be that after the battle, you've been haunted by a Nightmare?"

Hearing this, Fan Changyu looked momentarily lost.

Could it be that she had been so disoriented she misremembered? Had she stabbed Changxin Wang with the arrow herself, while her subconscious tricked her into believing someone had saved her?

Still lost in thought, a gruff voice called from outside the tent, "Is Squad Leader Fan here?"

Xie Wu lifted the tent flap and replied, "Yes. What business do you have with our squad leader?"

The man answered, "General He has summoned Squad Leader Fan."

Chapter 104

Fan Changyu heard this exchange clearly from inside the tent. Regarding her parents, she was indeed full of questions she wanted to ask He Jingyuan. She immediately said, "Please ask the brother outside to wait a moment. I'll come over as soon as I change into some presentable clothes."

As she looked for a clean robe, she suddenly remembered another problem. The day she came off the battlefield, her military uniform was already too filthy to look at. Who had changed her out of it while she was unconscious?

Besides, with her hands bandaged up like this, she couldn't put on the robe by herself even if she had it.

Just as Fan Changyu was frowning, another voice came from outside the tent. "Changyu, is it convenient for Auntie to come in?"

Recognizing Aunt Zhao's voice, Fan Changyu was both surprised and delighted. "Auntie, please come in," she said quickly.

After lifting the curtain and entering, Aunt Zhao picked up the set of robes and began to help Fan Changyu into them. "I heard a general has summoned you. Xiao Wu asked me to come over and help you change."

Fan Changyu said, "Xiao Wu is certainly thoughtful."

She then asked, "Auntie, when did you arrive at the camp?"

Aunt Zhao sighed. "Xiao Wu brought me here two days ago. You child, you nearly scared me to death. That uniform was drenched in blood. It's a good thing you didn't suffer any major injuries. If something had happened to you, what would Ning Niang do?"

It seemed Aunt Zhao had been the one to change her clothes while she was unconscious.

But Fan Changyu remembered that Xie Wu's injuries on the battlefield were no lighter than her own. How could he have run back home to get Aunt Zhao that same day?

A faint confusion appeared in Fan Changyu's eyes. "Xiao Wu isn't injured?"

After putting the outer robe on Fan Changyu, Aunt Zhao was helping her tie the waist sash. "That, I wouldn't know. But for the two days you were unconscious, Xiao Wu stayed guard in your tent. I was afraid he'd exhaust himself and told him to go rest, but I couldn't shoo him away."

Speaking of this, Aunt Zhao looked up with a somewhat peculiar expression and said to Fan Changyu, "He went through life and death with you on the battlefield. Changyu, ah, could it be that Xiao Wu has other ideas?"

She seemed to get a headache all of a sudden. "Xiao Wu is a good boy, but you already have Yan Zheng. Why don't I find Xiao Wu a wife later?"

Fan Changyu knew that both Xie Wu and Xie Qi were Xie Zheng's men. Their loyalty to her was simply because they were following Xie Zheng's orders. "Auntie, don't let your imagination run wild," she said helplessly. "It's not what you think."

However, Aunt Zhao's comment that Xie Wu had been watching over her for the past two days still struck Fan Changyu as a little strange.

After changing her clothes, she left the tent to see He Jingyuan.

Xie Wu was now considered her personal guard, so he went with her to the central military tent, but he could only wait outside and was not allowed to enter.

After the messenger who led Fan Changyu over conferred with the guard at the entrance of the central military tent, the guard went inside to report something before allowing Fan Changyu to enter alone.

Lifting the tent flap, Fan Changyu was met with a thick smell of medicine. Remembering the etiquette she had learned in the army these past few days, she knew not to look directly at a superior officer. She lowered her gaze slightly and cupped her fist. "This humble general, Fan Changyu, pays her respects to Lord He."

He Jingyuan had been an official in Jizhou for many years. Whether it was the common people below or the generals under his command, they were all more accustomed to privately calling him "Lord He."

In truth, he was a bit too scholarly and gentle. He was less like a military general and more like a civil official.

From the direction of the bed came a voice that was clearly lacking in vigor. "There is no need for formalities... cough, cough, cough..."

Seeing the man on the bed start coughing violently before he could finish his sentence, Fan Changyu hesitated for a moment before stepping forward. She used her bandaged, ball-like hands to pat his back and asked, "My lord, should I summon the Army Doctor?"

It was only by standing closer that she dared to discreetly observe the old general on the bed.

He seemed to have lost a lot of weight, his cheeks were sunken, and his complexion was very poor. Where there had once been only a few silver strands in his black hair, it was now half-black and half-white, making him look much more weathered all of a sudden.

Fan Changyu suddenly realized his condition was very poor.

He Jingyuan coughed for a long while before he managed to suppress the tickle in his throat.

As he lay back against the pillow, he had to take several gasping breaths to recover.

However, because of his violent coughing just now, the arrow wound on his chest had started to seep blood again, staining a fingernail-sized patch of his snow-white inner shirt red.

He waved his hand weakly and said, "It injured my lungs. The coughing has been rather severe these past two days."

Noticing that both of Fan Changyu's hands were bandaged, he asked, "How are your injuries?"

Fan Changyu replied, "On my body, only these two hands can be considered major injuries."

He Jingyuan actually laughed at her words, but his laughter turned into a low cough again. Fortunately, it wasn't as severe as before.

He said with gratification, "The younger generation is truly formidable. Changxin Wang is a renowned figure in the Great Yin. Trading this injury on your hands for Changxin Wang's life is more than worth it."

What appeared in Fan Changyu's mind, however, was the image of the Scarface Man shooting Changxin Wang with an arrow, then spurring his horse to rush over and grab her.

She remembered the strength with which he had pulled her onto the horse, and she remembered that familiar scent.

If not for that final arrow from him, even if Changxin Wang would have eventually died from the organ she had pierced with her saber, she likely would have been too exhausted to hold onto Changxin Wang's sword and would have died under its blade.

But Xiao Wu had said Xie Zheng wasn't in Chongzhou at all.

Fan Changyu felt that either her consciousness had truly been muddled and she had misremembered, or Xiao Wu had lied to her.

And the only person who could make Xiao Wu lie to her was Xie Zheng.

The moment she figured this out, Fan Changyu's heart practically leaped. She wished she could go back to her camp immediately and interrogate Xiao Wu about Xie Zheng's whereabouts.

She suppressed the thought for now, only because He Jingyuan was still present.

Since Xie Zheng's current identity was not to be exposed, Fan Changyu didn't rashly mention that he had disguised himself to save her on the battlefield. She only replied humbly, "You praise me too much, my lord. This humble general was just lucky to have stabbed Changxin Wang."

The gratification in He Jingyuan's eyes deepened. "You are a good child. With such a down-to-earth nature, you will be able to go much further on your future path."

Fan Changyu said reservedly, "Thank you for your praise, my lord."

He Jingyuan noticed her restraint. He pointed to a small square stool by the bed and said with effort, "Sit. There are some things it is time to tell you."

Fan Changyu had just sat down on the stool when she heard He Jingyuan's words. Her fingertips subconsciously clenched, only to grasp nothing. It was then she remembered her hands were wrapped in gauze like two balls.

She unconsciously straightened her back and asked, "Is it about my parents?"

He Jingyuan showed surprise on his face, as if he hadn't expected Fan Changyu to already know of his relationship with her parents. Then, he

slowly nodded. "I heard from Wen Chang that you checked the archives of Jizhou Prefecture, wanting to find out who truly harmed your parents..."

He let out a soft sigh. "When your parents entrusted you and your sister to me, it was because they didn't want you to be tainted by the karma of the previous generation. They only wished for you to live out your lives in peace. A pity that the ways of the world are so unpredictable."

Fan Changyu thought of the simple, warm days when her parents were alive, their sudden deaths, and the several assassination attempts she had encountered in Qingping County. Her heart sank. "My parents... what exactly were their identities?"

He Jingyuan looked at her, as if seeing the shadow of an old friend through her. His tone was full of world-weariness. "Your father was once a family general of the Wei Mansion. Because of his outstanding abilities, he was granted the surname Wei and was called Qi Lin. After the Prime Minister married his younger sister to General Xie Linshan, your father went to serve under General Xie. Later, he married into the family of Old General Meng, who also served under General Xie."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu's pupils couldn't help but shrink. "Meng Shuyuan?"

This was the main culprit behind the Jinzhou tragedy, a name known to even three-year-olds in the Great Yin.

He Jingyuan understood her state of mind at that moment and sighed. "Old General Meng was the general whom General Xie relied on the most. Your father marrying his only daughter was a joyous occasion that brought the Xie and Wei families even closer. It's just a pity that Jizhou was later besieged, and Old General Meng's mistake in escorting the provisions led to that irreparable disaster."

Learning that her own maternal grandfather was the prime culprit who had caused a hundred thousand soldiers in Jizhou to starve to death, led to the deaths of Chengde Crown Prince and General Xie Linshan at the city gates, and forced the imperial court to cede territory for a truce, Fan Changyu felt as if she had been plunged into an ice cellar.

In that instant, only one thought filled her mind—her entire family were sinners of the Great Yin.

She was a sinner in Xie Zheng's eyes as well.

Xie Zheng hated her maternal grandfather so much. What would he do when he found out she was a descendant of the Meng family?

Fan Changyu's mind was in turmoil. She subconsciously avoided this question and asked, "So Wei Yan wanted to kill my parents to avenge General Xie?"

But He Jingyuan shook his head. "After Jizhou fell that year, your maternal grandfather committed suicide to atone for his crime. Whether there were hidden circumstances behind the delay of military opportunity is still unknown to this day. But the Prime Minister did indeed order your father to kill your mother back then. Your father couldn't bring himself to do it, so he faked their deaths and escaped with your mother, begging me to help them forge new identities and hide their tracks.

"But after more than a decade, the Prime Minister suddenly issued a kill order for them again, this time to retrieve something."

Fan Changyu looked up at him in surprise.

He Jingyuan suddenly found it difficult to say the next words. He looked at Fan Changyu and said arduously, "When the Prime Minister ordered me to kill your parents, they seemed to have long anticipated that day. They only begged me to spare you and your sister's lives. They also gave me a box and told me not to open it, but to give it to the Prime Minister when he asked for it. After explaining all this, they committed suicide in front of me."

Fan Changyu's hands and feet turned ice-cold. She had never imagined that so many heavy secrets were hidden behind the cause of her parents' death, which she had been trying so hard to uncover.

He Jingyuan said, "The several assassination attempts on your family were the Prime Minister's men searching for that box."

Receiving so much explosive information at once, Fan Changyu felt a dull ache in her head as she struggled to sort through her thoughts.

What the world knew now was that her maternal grandfather's mistake in transporting provisions had led to the disastrous defeat in the battle of Jizhou. But her father had once been Wei Yan's man and had been ordered by Wei Yan to kill her mother, only to later betray Wei Yan and escape with her mother by faking their deaths.

And her parents had something in their possession that made Wei Yan hunt them down to retrieve it even after more than a decade.

So, her maternal grandfather's mistake in transporting provisions back then was likely related to Wei Yan?

But Wei Yan was merely a court official. At that time, not only was the Chengde Crown Prince trapped in Jizhou, but so was his brother-in-law, General Xie. What was he plotting by orchestrating all this?

But when she thought about how Xie Zheng had said Wei Yan was his enemy, how he had almost died at Wei Yan's hands, and how Wei Yan now wielded immense power, even to the point of completely sidelining the imperial family, Fan Changyu felt her guess was correct.

If Wei Yan didn't have a guilty conscience, why would he try to kill Xie Zheng?

It seemed her maternal grandfather's mistake with the provisions really did have something to do with Wei Yan.

After a long while, Fan Changyu finally asked He Jingyuan, "Back in Lin'an Town, my family was attacked, but troops arrived in time to help. Was it you, my lord, who ordered people to protect my family?"

He Jingyuan nodded.

Fan Changyu knew very well that the only clue now was likely in the box her parents had left behind. After some deliberation, she asked He Jingyuan, "My lord, have you seen what's inside the box my parents left?"

A bitter and mocking look appeared on He Jingyuan's face. "If I had looked, forget the Prime Minister sparing you and your sister's lives, even I, He, would likely not have escaped death."

Fan Changyu was silent for a moment, then voiced her speculation. "My maternal grandfather's delay in transporting provisions was due to Wei Yan's interference, wasn't it?"

He Jingyuan sighed. "The great crime of Jizhou's defeat was all pinned on your maternal grandfather after the fact. When I discussed it with Grand Tutor Tao, we also felt that a man as cautious as Old General Meng couldn't possibly have been unaware of the situation in Jizhou at the time, and wouldn't have been foolish enough to risk delaying military opportunity to save those hundred thousand trapped disaster victims. But

how the Prime Minister's leverage fell into your father's hands is worth pondering."

Fan Changyu understood his underlying meaning—

Her maternal grandfather couldn't have done something so foolish. So, it was likely her father who had acted as Wei Yan's pawn, which was why her father possessed something that Wei Yan would kill them to take back even after more than a decade.

This conclusion brought Fan Changyu little comfort.

Her grandfather was no longer the main culprit, but because her father had been a pawn for someone else, he had been wrongly blamed and reviled for so many years. Just thinking about it made Fan Changyu's chest tighten, making it hard to breathe.

In her memory, her father had always been taciturn and not good with words. He rarely even smiled. Even when he was in the pork business, he wasn't very good at haggling. Only when he was with her mother did the expressions on his face become lively and rich.

He always did many things silently, clumsily trying to please her mother. Just because her mother was afraid of the cold and genuine mink coats were unavailable on the market, he went into the mountains alone for four or five days and hunted a pile of silver minks to make a cloak for her.

And her mother? Although she was usually the gentlest person, speaking in a soft, quiet voice, it was a different story if you angered her.

As a child, Fan Changyu had been disciplined by her mother with a broom. When her mother got angry, even her father didn't dare to intervene.

It was precisely because of this that Fan Changyu felt that with her mother's temperament, it was impossible for her to have chosen to live in seclusion with her father after learning that he had harmed her own father.

She suddenly asked He Jingyuan, "My lord, when my mother passed away, did she know the secret of that box?"

He Jingyuan recalled the scene of the couple committing suicide one after another in the snow that day. A trace of sorrow still lingered in his heart. He nodded and said, "Your mother was very composed. I believe she knew."

Fan Changyu then said with conviction, "If my father had harmed my maternal grandfather, my mother would never have forgiven him. There must be another hidden story behind what happened back then."

He Jingyuan was somewhat surprised. He wanted to speak but couldn't stop the tickle in his throat. He coughed for a long while before saying, "Grand Tutor Tao also raised doubts. Unfortunately, seventeen years have passed. Apart from these speculations, we have no concrete evidence. Even if we wanted to investigate, there's nowhere to start. That's why Grand Tutor Tao decided to make a trip to the capital to see the Prime Minister in person. Unfortunately, there has been no news from him since."

He looked at Fan Changyu and said earnestly, "I have heard a thing or two about the matter between you and the Marquis. I had thought about taking these things to my grave, letting them be buried with me. Let the affairs of the previous generation... return to dust with their deaths."

"But I was also afraid... that if the truth ever came out, the feud of a murdered father is not something anyone can easily let go of. Rather than wait until things are irreversible, it is better to inform you of all this beforehand and let you two decide."

A hundred flavors mixed in Fan Changyu's heart. She knelt before He Jingyuan's bed and kowtowed solemnly to him. "Thank you, Lord He."

He Jingyuan covered his mouth with his hand and coughed for a long time before saying breathlessly, "If you don't hate me, then call me Uncle. Your father and I were once sworn brothers. The saber technique you use was created by him and me together."

Fan Changyu looked at this man who seemed to be in his twilight years. A faint sting filled her eyes as she called out, "Uncle."

He Jingyuan seemed to have waited for this day for many years. The wrinkles on his face spread as he smiled broadly and answered, "Aie."

Coming out of the central military tent, Fan Changyu felt that even her breathing was heavy.

She didn't see Xie Wu outside the tent. After looking around and not finding him, she asked a personal guard standing outside, "Excuse me, have you seen the young brother who came with me?"

The personal guard said, "You mean that tall lad? He went that way a quarter of an hour ago."

Fan Changyu couldn't help but frown. Xie Wu had been by her side for some time, but he had never been so discourteous.

Suddenly, as if she had thought of something, she quickly lifted her feet and chased in the direction the personal guard had pointed.

But she hadn't run more than a few steps when she saw Xie Wu walking towards her.

It was the real Xie Wu.

He wasn't as tall as the one she had seen when she first woke up. When he walked, his steps were somewhat unsteady, probably due to the injuries on his body. Upon seeing her, he called out, "Squad Leader."

He didn't dare to look Fan Changyu directly in the eye. He scratched the back of his head with an embarrassed smile and took the initiative to explain why he had left early. "I... I've been drinking a lot of water with my medicine these past two days. I just went to find the latrine..."

But Fan Changyu didn't listen to his fabricated excuses. She ripped off the gauze wrapped around her hand and grabbed him by the collar. "Where is he?"

Since the real Xie Wu had been brought over, he must have been gone for a while.

Fan Changyu's grip was surprisingly strong. The wounds from catching Changxin Wang's blade with her bare hands began to seep blood again, but her eyes were terrifyingly cold.

It was the first time Xie Wu had seen Fan Changyu like this. He was utterly terrified and also afraid that her hand injuries would worsen. He quickly said, "The Master has left the camp."

Fan Changyu let go of Xie Wu and went after Xie Zheng again.

She had been careless. Her mind was muddled when she woke up, and she had been distracted by too much information. She had clearly sensed something was off at the time, but she still hadn't realized that the "Xiao Wu" was Xie Zheng in disguise.

Why did he come to the battlefield to save her but not let her know? Why did he even have to pretend to be someone else to stay by her side?

Her intuition told Fan Changyu that Xie Zheng must have already found out something about the events of seventeen years ago before he came,

which was why he chose to do this.

She didn't know what use it would be to chase after him now, or what she could say to him, but a voice in her heart was telling her that she had to go after him.

At the very least, she had to apologize to him on behalf of her deceased elders.

And tell him that even if he ended this relationship because of his father's feud, she would keep investigating.

He might not understand why she firmly believed her father had never betrayed her mother or grandfather just because of her mother's attitude towards her father, but she would find out.

She would also kill Wei Yan to avenge her parents.

He had once extended his hand to her, but she hadn't dared to walk with him because of the many obstacles in their path. He had silently paved the way for her.

So now that he wanted to stop, she would walk forward with determination until she could present the truth to him and let him know that those things were not an obstacle between them either.

Fan Changyu chased all the way to the entrance of the main camp but didn't see Xie Zheng. She asked the sentries on duty if anyone had left the camp. After learning that a one-eyed man with a scarred face mask had just left on horseback not long ago, she quickly borrowed a horse and continued the chase.

It was a good thing she was now considered a figure of some renown in the Jizhou army. Not only did the guards at the camp entrance not stop her, they even treated her with great respect.

The wounds on her hands were deep. When Fan Changyu swung herself up onto the saddle, her face turned pale with pain. She ignored the fresh blood that was once again staining the gauze red, cracked the whip hard, and shouted, "Giddy-up!"

The warhorse galloped off. Fan Changyu rode for four or five li before she spotted a figure on horseback on a gentle slope in the distance.

Afraid of bringing trouble to Xie Zheng, she didn't dare to call out his real name, only shouting loudly, "Yan Zheng!"

The person on horseback seemed to glance back at her. She spurred her horse harder, and within a few breaths, she was finally close enough to see the other person's face clearly.

Even with one eye covered by a patch and a scarred face mask on his face, Fan Changyu recognized him at a single glance.

The warhorse slowed its pace, carrying her steadily forward.

Fan Changyu held the reins, her eyes meeting Xie Zheng's from a distance of several zhang. Her eyes suddenly stung, and she said in a hoarse voice, "You came to see me, but you didn't even want me to know?"

Xie Zheng sat erect on his horse, looking at Fan Changyu without speaking.

His dark phoenix eyes were as still as an ancient well. His back was straight and upright, like a rock on a cliff that had been weathered by wind and sun for years yet still stood tall and imposing, carrying a cold austerity and magnificence honed by time.

A lump formed in Fan Changyu's throat. "What Lord He told me today... you already knew, didn't you?"

Xie Zheng finally uttered a single, heavy word: "Yes."

After interrogating Zhao Xun, he had a rough idea, but he hadn't been certain.

After hearing He Jingyuan's conversation with her today, it was all settled.

—It was the worst possible outcome, one he had anticipated after interrogating Zhao Xun and learning of Grand Tutor Tao's disappearance.

Fan Changyu's eyes were red as she looked at him, her voice choked with sobs. "I'm sorry."

She added, "My maternal grandfather would not have betrayed General Xie, and my father would not have done anything to wrong my mother. Whether you believe it or not, what happened back then is definitely not what you think..."

A sorrow and fear she had never known before overwhelmed her, making her explanation come out in a jumbled mess. She tried hard to steady her voice, but by the end, it was choked nearly to silence.

"Fan Changyu," Xie Zheng suddenly called her name.

Changyu lifted her tear-filled eyes in a daze to meet his gaze.

Xie Zheng's dark eyes showed no emotion whatsoever as he said, "Let it be. From now on, I'll only regard you as a junior fellow disciple."

He would never love another girl like this in his lifetime. But his father's death had been a mountain weighing on his heart all these years, a nightmare that haunted his entire childhood and youth.

The murder of his father—he simply couldn't let it go so lightly.

If there had truly been some hidden truth about what happened back then, Wei Yan wouldn't have been in such a hurry to kill He Jingyuan or detain Grand Tutor Tao.

But even if he learned that her father had most likely been Wei Yan's lackey, he still couldn't bring himself to harm her in the slightest.

Uprooting someone planted in your heart, roots and all, truly hurt like hell.

Then stay far away.

He would give her connections and military merits.

Never seeing each other again in this life would be for the best.

Hearing his words, Changyu stared at him in disbelief, her breath trembling, large teardrops falling uncontrollably. "It's really not like that..." she murmured.

Xie Zheng met her gaze, his hand gripping the reins so tightly it turned white.

He had always hated seeing her cry.

She was like poison to him—when she cried, it made him want to kill.

He wanted to hold her.

To coax her, tell her not to cry.

But with the metallic taste of blood from biting his molars and the whites of his visible eye tinged red, he ultimately couldn't say a word.

In his life, before being haunted by endless nightmares, he had briefly known familial love.

He couldn't remember the face of the man who died in battle at Jinzhou, gutted and hung on the city walls, but he still recalled him teaching martial arts in the garden. He remembered the corpse full of holes brought back in a coffin.

Before hanging herself, that woman had washed the body—sixty-seven arrow wounds alone, countless sword and knife injuries.

They said when the Northern Turks gutted him, only weeds and roots came out.

That woman had cried herself unconscious countless times holding that corpse. When conscious, she only repeated to him: take revenge.

With no reinforcements or supplies coming, his father had died in Jinzhou in that brutal way when he was just a child.

All these years, he had never forgotten—to take revenge.

Xie Zheng stared fixedly at Changyu, watching her cry as if his own chest were being torn open, waves of pain lancing through him.

Even if she stabbed him multiple times, he could still hold her tight without letting go.

But her father had helped Wei Yan kill his!

Xie Zheng's jaw clenched tightly as his bloodshot eyes remained locked on Changyu. "Don't cry," he said softly, voice barely audible.

He seemed to want to comfort her, but only made the redness in his eyes deepen. "When I uncovered this truth, it took me days before I dared come see you."

He removed his blindfold and mask, as if wanting to take one last good look at her before leaving. "I also wish your father wasn't the mastermind behind it all, but I couldn't find any evidence proving his innocence. On the contrary, He Jingyuan nearly got silenced on the battlefield just like I did back then. The Old Man was detained when he went to the capital, and your father held evidence that could threaten Wei Yan..."

His dark eyes were filled with broken fragments as he gazed at Fan Changyu: "Tell me, how can I believe your father wasn't the mastermind?"

Fan Changyu's tears fell even harder.

She wanted to explain further but found herself at a loss for words. Her parents had been deeply in love, but that wasn't proof enough to convince Xie Zheng of her father's innocence.

Xie Zheng's gaze fell on her hand, where the bandage was stained red with blood. "I just bandaged this—how did it get like this again?" he said.

His tone was scolding, yet he lowered his eyes just as before, unwrapping the bandage to apply medicine. He tore strips from his own robe to wrap around her hand, calmly instructing, "Don't get it wet or lift anything heavy until it heals..."

"Xie Zheng."

The person before him called his name with a sob, a clear teardrop landing on his hand.

Her entire body trembled.

Xie Zheng's hand stiffened slightly. Silently, he tied the bandage securely before suddenly cupping the back of her head and kissing her fiercely.

More violent than any kiss before, his lips and tongue ravaged hers with a desperate, almost mad intensity.

Fan Changyu even tasted blood—and the salt of tears.

But just as abruptly, he pulled away.

Forehead pressed to hers, he let her see all the love, hatred, and unwillingness in his eyes.

"Fan Changyu," he said, "the man who died in Jinzhou, who was gutted and left exposed—that was my father. I can choose not to hate, but I can't allow myself to keep loving the daughter of Wei Qilin. This is the best path I can choose for you."

Cradling her face in both hands, he gently wiped away her tears even as his words remained resolute: "If I kill Wei Yan and survive, I'll never leave the northern frontier again. I won't see you for the rest of my life. When you marry someday, don't let me know."

He laughed at himself, but his eyes were dark, devoid of any light. "I know what kind of person I am. If I ever regret today's decision, I'd drag you into my coffin and bury us together—even if it kills me."

Looking at her, he added in an almost inaudible whisper, "I'd do it."

Whether he was saying it to Fan Changyu or himself was unclear.

Fan Changyu stood frozen, only her tears continuing to fall silently.

Perhaps afraid of frightening her, Xie Zheng gently stroked her cheek with his thumb before murmuring softly, "I'm leaving."

With that, he withdrew his hand and spurred his horse away.

As if staying even a moment longer would make him change his mind.

Only when Xie Zheng had ridden far into the distance did Fan Changyu snap out of her daze. "Stop right there!" she shouted.

Against all odds, the distant figure actually reined in his horse at her command.

Seeing this only made the bitterness in her chest swell even more.

Taking a deep breath, she declared, "I'll uncover the truth of what happened back then. I'll clear my grandfather's name after seventeen years of slander—and give your father, and all the innocent soldiers who died in Jinzhou, the justice they deserve."

Without waiting for Xie Zheng's response, she turned her horse around and galloped back the way she came, cracking her whip fiercely.

Chapter 105

The sun hid behind the clouds as the wind rustled the reeds on either side of the gentle slope. Their pale yellow tassels drooped low while the figure of a young girl in riding attire grew smaller and smaller amidst the undulating sea of reeds across the mountain wilderness, eventually becoming nothing more than a tiny russet speck.

Xie Zheng remained astride his horse, the strands of hair at his forehead swaying gently in the breeze. Beneath those loose strands lay eyes so bloodshot they seemed veined with crimson spiderwebs.

That distant russet speck finally vanished into the depths of his blood-streaked pupils.

Yet his face betrayed no emotion whatsoever. When he tugged the reins to turn his horse around, he even uttered a casual "Hyah!" as if it meant nothing. The warhorse began trotting in the opposite direction.

But the hand gripping the reins bulged with veins, and upon closer inspection, the reins themselves were stained a faint rouge hue—clearly, his palm had long been pierced by his own fingernails.

Fan Changyu whipped her horse into a frenzied gallop, not stopping until there was no trace of anyone behind or ahead of her.

The weather was neither cold nor hot, the wind so quiet that only the fine down from the reed tassels danced lightly in the air.

Seated atop her horse, she lifted her gaze to the vast, boundless sky and took deep, heaving breaths. Her chest felt as if filled with lead, so heavy she could barely breathe.

Never had she felt so helpless—not even when her parents had passed away.

Her grandfather was a man reviled by the world for seventeen years as a criminal. If this injustice could not be cleared, he might remain condemned for eternity.

The father she had once revered most turned out to be Wei Yan's man—even his marriage to her mother might have been part of a scheme.

Chengde Crown Prince, General Xie, and the tens of thousands of soldiers had all perished miserably in Jinzhou after the city fell, with reinforcements and provisions never arriving.

The weight of these countless lives pressed down on Fan Changyu until her mind grew hazy.

Of course, she believed her father could never have committed such folly. But without concrete evidence, her blind faith was meaningless.

Faced with such an eternal, monumental crime, how could she not tremble with fear?

Even with her head raised, tears spilled uncontrollably from the corners of her eyes, trailing down her cheeks before falling onto the desolate wilderness.

She knew she shouldn't blame Xie Zheng for not believing her, but the sorrow was unbearable.

Fan Changyu raised a hand to clumsily wipe her face, only to let out a choked sob in the end.

Her warhorse seemed to understand her anguish in that moment and did not move forward. Horse and rider stood motionless amidst the undulating reeds, with only her hoarse weeping left in the silence.

By the time Fan Changyu returned to the military camp, the only trace of her tears was a faint redness beneath her eyelids.

Xie Wu waited anxiously at the camp's main gate. Spotting Fan Changyu's return, he hesitated briefly before stepping forward as he always had to take her horse, cautiously calling out, "Squad Leader."

Fan Changyu dismounted and walked toward the camp as if nothing were amiss. Only once they were far from the sentry post did she ask, "Did he leave you behind?"

Her voice was slightly hoarse, but otherwise, nothing seemed out of the ordinary.

Xie Wu immediately guessed that she must have caught up with Xie Zheng. "When the Marquis ordered me and A-Qi to follow you to Chongzhou, we were never meant to return."

Fan Changyu paused mid-step. Xie Wu explained, "To the Marquis, once something—or someone—is given away, it's never taken back."

He looked at Fan Changyu with some embarrassment and said, "If the squad leader doesn't want to keep Xie Qi and me either, we'll have no choice but to rejoin the army as foot soldiers."

Fan Changyu lowered her eyes, and no one could tell what she was thinking at that moment. After a long pause, she finally said, "Then you two can stay."

After a brief hesitation, she added, "As long as I have wealth and status, you won't be left out."

Xie Wu quickly clasped his hands in salute. "Fighting alongside the squad leader on the battlefield to protect the people is our aspiration."

Fan Changyu patted his shoulder but said nothing more.

The bandages on her hands were thinner now, allowing her to move them slightly.

Xie Wu's words completely dispelled any thought she had of sending him and Xie Qi away.

So far, she hadn't found any personal guards in the army who could match Xie Wu and Xie Qi. Having served under Xie Zheng for years, they were well-versed in military affairs. Driving them away and training new personal guards would be a lengthy and troublesome process.

With so many urgent matters at hand and a pressing need for capable people, Fan Changyu didn't want to create unnecessary trouble for herself just to prove a point.

Besides, with Xie Qi keeping an eye on Changning, she felt more at ease.

When she returned to her quarters, Fan Changyu found not only Guo Baihu waiting but also several unfamiliar hundred-household officers who had brought gifts.

Looking at the table piled with pastries, wine, tonics, and the warm smiles on their faces, she finally realized they had come to visit her.

Yet among them were some leaning on crutches or with arms in slings, which puzzled her.

She didn't recall having any close ties with these people, and some seemed even more severely injured than her. Had they really come all this way just to see her?

Noticing her strange expression as she silently surveyed the crowd, Guo Baihu—still technically her superior and the most familiar with her in the room—spoke up first: "You returned from the battlefield and were unconscious for two days and nights. Everyone was very worried. When we heard you'd woken up today, we decided to come together to check on you."

Fan Changyu replied politely, "Changyu thanks all of you for your concern."

The group quickly waved off her formality, saying she was being too polite.

Fan Changyu thought to herself that apart from Guo Baihu, most of these people had probably met her no more than three times before today. How could they claim such familiarity?

Outwardly, she still invited them to sit. "All of you are injured. Please don't stand on ceremony—have a seat."

They smiled warmly but had little to say once seated.

Since there weren't enough stools in her tent, Xie Wu had to borrow a few from neighboring tents.

The atmosphere in the tent felt oddly strained. Everyone seemed uncomfortable yet was trying hard to appear friendly with her.

Only Guo Baihu showed genuine interest in a jar of wine someone had brought for Fan Changyu. He said bluntly, "Squad Leader Fan, since everyone's here, why not open this jar of wine?"

In the military, camaraderie was forged not only on the battlefield but also over drinks. A shared jar of wine could turn strangers into confidants in no time.

Seeing Butcher Guo still with his head wrapped in white bandages, Fan Changyu hesitated. "But everyone here is injured..."

The group of soldiers, likely sensing the awkward atmosphere, all chimed in that it was nothing. One of them said, "Back when we held

victory feasts, weren't we all covered in wounds? If we really had to avoid certain foods, we wouldn't be able to drink or eat meat at all!"

This drew hearty laughter from the rest.

Some sharper individuals noticed Fan Changyu's injured hand and remembered she was a woman. They said, "The brothers can fool around all they want, but let's not drag Squad Leader Fan into it. Her injuries must be serious—best not to urge her to drink."

The quicker-witted ones immediately caught on and added, "Right, right! We brothers are just craving a drink, joking around out of habit. Squad Leader Fan shouldn't take it seriously."

The baihu who had brought the wine to Fan Changyu seized the moment: "You bastards! This is the fine Dukang wine I've been saving for ages. So thirsty for alcohol you'd even pester Squad Leader Fan for it?"

Even someone as socially inexperienced as Fan Changyu could tell they were flattering her.

After brief consideration, she understood the reason.

The battle beneath Chongzhou's walls had made her famous. Everyone in the army probably knew she was due for a promotion. During the past two days while she was unconscious, no one could visit to curry favor. Now that she'd just woken up and was summoned by He Jingyuan, anyone could see she had gained his favor.

This promotion might not be just one or two ranks up.

For lower-ranking officers like Guo Baihu, if they didn't establish connections with her before the official rewards were announced, they might not even get a chance to speak with her later.

The words Grand Tutor Tao had asked her in the carriage when she first joined the army still echoed in her ears.

Did she want an empty title with no capable subordinates, or to start from the bottom and cultivate her own reliable team?

After being appointed squad leader, she'd focused entirely on selecting capable people from her few dozen subordinates. Only now did she truly grasp the meaning behind Grand Tutor Tao's words.

The truly useful people would come from here, after her promotion.

Suddenly, she understood why Guo Baihu had suggested she treat everyone to drinks.

Fan Changyu turned to Xie Wu. "Go fetch drinking bowls. I'll pour for these gentlemen myself!"

Xie Wu was momentarily stunned, then quickly grasped her intention. He hurried out and returned with a stack of bowls, arranging them on the table.

Some still tried to decline, but Fan Changyu said, "Getting drunk together isn't possible, but let this serve to satisfy your craving."

With things put this way, no one wanted to spoil the mood.

Her palm injury made bending difficult, so Xie Wu helped remove the red cloth sealing the wine jar. She then personally filled each bowl.

When all the baihu had their bowls raised, Fan Changyu lifted hers and addressed them solemnly: "Changyu is new to the army. I thank you all for your care these days, and hope to share more jars of wine with you in the future!"

Regardless of how much sincerity was in her words, she threw her head back and drained the bowl in one go.

Today she toasts those in this tent; tomorrow, others will be toasting her.

The baihu raised their bowls in response: "Squad Leader Fan flatters us! We too hope to drink with you again!"

They likewise drank their bowls dry.

When setting down their bowls, the baihu were visibly more cheerful and relaxed than when they'd arrived.

This shared drink represented, for them, an unspoken declaration of allegiance and alliance.

Military merits on the battlefield aren't easily earned, especially for those who've already reached the position of Baihu. Common soldiers who've served for a decade and reached this rank without meeting influential patrons or possessing extraordinary talent have basically hit their ceiling.

They took the initiative to show goodwill to Fan Changyu because they understood that her recent promotion through military achievements left

her short of capable subordinates. If she could promote them even slightly, they'd consider themselves fortunate to have met their benefactor.

It was clear now that Fan Changyu had accepted their gesture.

After finishing their drinks and some casual conversation, the group gradually dispersed.

Guo Baihu was the last to leave. When the barracks were empty, Fan Changyu stood and gave him a solemn salute: "Thank you for your guidance earlier, Lord Guo."

Guo Baihu, being straightforward, didn't mince words: "Enough with the 'Lord' this and that—it grates on my ears. That wasn't guidance anyway. Even if you hadn't drunk with those roughnecks today, they'd still be willing to seek your favor when you're short on people."

He glanced at Fan Changyu: "But they're all old foxes from the barracks. Even if they seem to obey you on the surface, they might not truly respect you. Refusing to share a drink with them would be seen as looking down on them. That's the unwritten rule of the military camp."

Fan Changyu replied, "I'll remember that."

She added earnestly, "If I encounter anything else I don't understand, I'll come straight to you, Guo Baihu. I hope you won't find it troublesome."

This was already a subtle attempt at forming an alliance.

Guo Baihu responded candidly, "Right now, my rank's still higher than yours, so I won't stand on ceremony. When you get promoted, as long as you need me, I'll follow you. I misjudged you at first, thinking you were just another one of those here for easy military honors. After all these years of fighting, I've never had such a satisfying battle. I thought being a Baihu was as far as I'd go, but now I'm thinking of earning myself a general's title!"

After Guo Baihu left, Xie Wu said to Fan Changyu, "Congratulations, Squad leader!"

With her promotion, she now had a group of people she could truly call her own.

Fan Changyu, however, rubbed her temples wearily and said, "This skill of speaking differently to different people isn't something just anyone can master."

Xie Wu simply smiled: "The squad leader has figured out how to build connections in the military camp."

Fan Changyu lifted her gaze to him: "What I said to you when I returned to camp wasn't just politeness. You and Xiao Qi will both be assigned as my personal guards."

Without waiting for his response, she instructed, "I have a headache. You may leave now."

Xie Wu glanced at her and eventually withdrew.

Sitting alone, Fan Changyu lost herself in thought for a while. She could vaguely see that what lay ahead for her would be even more complex.

But to uncover the truth of what happened back then, she needed to move closer to the center of power.

Her peripheral vision caught the Horse-Cutting Sword on the weapon rack, and Xie Wu's words—"Once the Marquis gives something, he never takes it back"—flashed through her mind, stirring a tumult of emotions.

If she hadn't noticed and chased after him that day, he might have truly left without a word.

Did Xie Wu say that because he was afraid she'd return everything he'd given her?

The bitterness she'd managed to suppress on the way back began to spread through her heart once more.

Fan Changyu didn't want to wallow in those terrible emotions any longer. Her head was indeed throbbing from absorbing too much explosive information, so she decided to take a short nap.

When she accidentally touched the broken silver under her pillow, she remembered the soldier in her squad who had given her all his pay before the expedition. Instantly, her drowsiness vanished.

Earlier when she woke up, Xie Zheng, disguised as Xiao Wu, had told her that thirteen men from their squad had died in battle, with seventeen severely wounded.

She had intended to visit the men she led then, but unfortunately, He Jingyuan sent someone to summon her, delaying her plans due to the subsequent events.

Fan Changyu directly called for Xie Wu and, bringing along the pastries and tonics sent by the hundred-household officers, went to the lower barracks.

The soldiers weren't as well-informed as Guo Baihu and the others, but they knew that once the official rewards were announced, Fan Changyu would likely be promoted to general.

It wasn't that they didn't want to curry favor, but Fan Changyu had been unconscious for the past two days. Today, after waking up, she was immediately called away by He Jingyuan. By the time she returned, the hundred-household officers had already rushed to fawn over her, leaving no opportunity for the ordinary soldiers.

Thus, when they saw Fan Changyu arrive, they were all quite surprised, stammering, "Squad... Squad leader."

These large military tents had communal bedding, with each tent housing twenty-five men. It was cramped, but given wartime conditions, there wasn't much choice.

A few beds were empty—clearly those of the fallen soldiers.

There were no tables in the tent; the only place to put things was on the military beds. The items Fan Changyu brought were placed on one of the empty beds.

Fan Changyu asked, "Whose bed was this?"

A soldier nearby with a bandaged arm and head instantly reddened his eyes, grinning as he replied, "Squad leader, it was Ge Mazi's. My fellow villager. He... he was probably trampled to pieces on the battlefield. I searched for two days but couldn't find his body."

By the end, the soldier wiped his eyes with his good arm, his voice trembling with sobs.

Fan Changyu asked, "Who does he have left in his family?"

The soldier answered, "His old mother and younger sister."

Fan Changyu said, "Once the official rewards and compensation are issued, a portion of my reward will be set aside and sent to his family."

She looked at the other soldiers in the tent and promised, "The same goes for all of you here. In the future, if anyone dies, their parents, siblings—they become our parents and siblings. We'll take care of them together."

These words brought tears to many soldiers' eyes, and they roared hoarsely, "Yes!"

Perhaps the heart-protecting mirror she had given him had played a role, but the soldier who had entrusted her with his pay before the expedition had indeed returned alive, suffering only minor injuries.

Fan Changyu returned the broken silver to him, saying, "You don't have to worry about your parents going unsupported anymore."

The soldier took the silver, grinning sheepishly with reddened eyes as he agreed. He then tried to return the heart-protecting mirror to Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu said, "Keep it. I have no use for it."

The soldier thanked her again and, under the envious gazes of his comrades, carefully stored the mirror like a treasure.

One bolder soldier asked eagerly, "Squad leader, after you're promoted, can we still follow you?"

Fan Changyu replied, "Of course you'll stay with me."

Though they had won this battle against the Chongzhou army, it had been a narrow victory.

He Jingyuan was struck by a stray arrow, and rumors spread by the rebels in Chongzhou falsely claimed he had died in battle, severely shaking the morale of the Jizhou Army. The losses were devastating.

If not for the fortunate slaying of Changxin Wang, which turned the tide against the Chongzhou rebels, the outcome of that day would have been uncertain.

Her ability to stab Changxin Wang when he was off guard was largely due to his contempt upon discovering she was a woman—he hadn't taken her seriously at all.

After the rebels retreated in disarray and barricaded themselves inside the city, they had kept their gates tightly shut for the past two days. It was said that Changxin Wang's eldest son had temporarily taken control within the city.

He Jingyuan did not press the advantage and order an immediate assault for two reasons: first, his injuries were truly severe, and second, while the Jizhou Army's situation was slightly better than that of the rebels in

Chongzhou, they were still in dire straits, having suffered heavy casualties. Both sides needed time to recuperate.

Under these circumstances, troops were in short supply. Even if Fan Changyu were promoted, she wouldn't be given a separate unit. More likely, she would take over the duties of a higher-ranking officer within their current army.

With Fan Changyu's firm reassurance, the soldiers visibly relaxed, as if following her into battle no longer seemed so terrifying.

Fan Changyu's heart was a tumult of emotions. She meticulously inquired about the condition of every wounded soldier under her command and solemnly committed the names of each fallen comrade to memory.

Stepping out of the barracks, she exhaled slowly, her gaze fixed on the distant horizon, growing ever more resolute.

The more she understood the brutality of war and the hardships of low-ranking soldiers, the less she could tolerate the idea that the Battle of Jinzhou seventeen years ago had been a conspiracy.

Even now, Crown Prince Chengde and General Xie's reputations remained highly praised among the people.

The tragic deaths of this heir apparent and a pillar of the state were deeply mourned, but the soldiers who had perished unjustly on the battlefield that year also had families waiting for their return.

The truth should not be buried beneath the schemes and machinations of those in power—

Kang City.

Dark clouds loomed over the city, heralding a storm.

A cold wind whipped the banners atop the battlements, making the solitary walls appear even more fragile beneath the rolling thunderheads.

Fine droplets of rain stung her face, the chill deepening.

The deputy general, peering through the crenellations at the vast, ominous ranks of the Yanzhou Xie Family Army below—their presence as formidable as the storm itself—began to tremble. "Y-Young Master... news from Chongzhou says the prince has fallen. The city will likely fall soon. If Wu'an Marquis is mobilizing his forces to attack now, he undoubtedly means to take Kang City..."

"If he attacks, we defend."

The voice beside him was flat, devoid of inflection. A pale jawline, exposed to the cold wind and drizzle, carried an almost frost-like detachment.

It was impossible to tell whether the speaker had resigned himself to fate or was brimming with confidence.

Compared to the last time, Sui Yuanqing seemed even thinner, the shadows beneath his eyes darker, the whites of his eyes streaked with red veins.

The deputy knew that attacking during a storm put the aggressors at a disadvantage, but with Wu'an Marquis commanding the opposing forces, he couldn't shake his unease.

Wu'an Marquis was infamous for his unorthodox tactics—he never followed conventional military strategies. Rumors even claimed that if one compiled all the tactics he had employed in battle, they could fill an entirely new military manual.

Cautiously, the deputy peered through the crenellations again, only to see that the Yanzhou Army below hadn't even brought siege ladders.

The iron-black army stretched out beyond the range of the city wall's archers, with crossbowmen leading the charge. These crossbows required extraordinary strength to draw—ordinary men couldn't manage it. The crossbowmen had to lie on the ground, using the force of their waists and legs to cock the weapons while their assistants loaded three arrows into the grooves. When fired in unison, the bolts flew toward the battlements like a sudden storm of shooting stars.

The defenders at the city wall's crenellations didn't even have time to react before being pierced through—arrows and all.

Though it couldn't compare to the devastating power of a ballista that could pierce through city walls, within this range, its striking force far surpassed ordinary arrows.

The deputy general's face turned pale with fright. He pulled at Sui Yuanqing, nearly scrambling for cover atop the battlements, and cried in panic, "Young Master, this is bad! The Wu'an Marquis intends to launch a full-scale assault!"

Below the city walls, positioned behind the crossbow formations and ahead of the cavalry, stood a war chariot.

Gongsun Yin, emulating the ancients, held a feathered fan. His white robes billowed wildly in the battlefield's fierce winds, giving him an almost divine appearance.

He glanced at the thick, dark storm clouds gathering across half the sky, then at the man beside him—whose very presence, from man to horse, exuded a chilling, murderous aura—and asked in bewilderment, "A heavy rain is coming. If we're to take Kang City, there's no need to rush these one or two days. Why insist on pressing forward and launching the attack now?"

Xie Zheng's Ferghana Black-Hoofed warhorse stomped restlessly beneath him. Gripping his halberd in one hand, Xie Zheng's palm was wrapped in a thin layer of gauze. Raindrops traced faint, glistening trails along the dark iron blade.

His cold gaze fixed on the distant battlements of Kang City, dozens of zhang away. The ferocious Canthus Beast Head adorning his shoulder armor only deepened the ruthless intensity in his brow. "Before the storm arrives," he said, "Kang City will already be ours."

Gongsun Yin couldn't help but study him again. He had always known this man was arrogant, but he hadn't expected such sheer audacity.

Recalling Xie Zheng's behavior since returning from Chongzhou—outwardly unchanged, yet subtly unsettling in every action—Gongsun Yin suddenly frowned. "It almost feels," he mused, "like you're fighting this war just to vent."

Chapter 106

The man who had been staring indifferently ahead suddenly cast a cold sidelong glance at him.

Just then, a chilly wind swept by. Gongsun Yin couldn't tell whether it was the wind or that icy gaze that sent a shiver down his spine.

Quickly shifting his gaze to the distant city tower, he fanned himself twice with his feathered fan and changed the subject: "The rebels on the tower have had their morale crushed by our crossbowmen. It's time to storm the city!"

Xie Zheng also withdrew his gaze, turning it once more toward the Kang City tower, which seemed dwarfed beneath the looming storm clouds. His thin lips parted to utter two words: "Storm it."

The messenger at his side, having received the order, ascended the temporary platform erected within the military formation and bellowed, "Storm the city—"

The sprawling army stretched across the plains outside Kang City's gates, far beyond the reach of mere shouts. Over a hundred flag officers, stationed at the front, caught the command and immediately raised their signal flags. Spurring their horses along the narrow paths left open for movement within the formation, they galloped toward the orderly ranks arrayed behind, shouting, "Storm the city—"

In an instant, beneath the walls of Kang City, the iron-clad army surged forward like an unstoppable tide. Within the dark mass of soldiers, crimson signal flags twisted like dragons through the black waves of war. The roar of battle shook the heavens, making the heavy storm clouds above seem to sag even lower. The distant city tower appeared as nothing more than a fragile boat, easily capsized by the first wave of this oncoming black tide.

The defenders atop the tower, already demoralized by the earlier hail of arrows, now paled at the sight of the Yanzhou Army charging toward them like wolves.

Even as the Yanzhou Army entered the range of the city's archers, not a single defender managed to loose an arrow in time.

Only one thought filled their minds: We're finished.

This battle was already lost before it had even begun!

Sui Yuanqing, enraged, drew his sword and cut down the nearest archer, snarling, "What are you waiting for? Shoot!"

The defenders on the tower, trembling, fumbled to nock their arrows and draw their bows—but their hands shook so violently they could barely pull the strings. A few feeble shots barely made it past the walls before dropping harmlessly to the ground.

The deputy general, though seasoned in battle, still felt his soul quake at the sight of the Yanzhou Army advancing like an unstoppable flood.

The rear of the formation seemed to merge with the storm clouds pressing down from above, as if the entire city of Kang were being swallowed by darkness.

Even he, a veteran, felt his legs weaken—how could the common soldiers possibly muster any will to fight?

Pushing past the archers trembling at the battlements, he sought out Sui Yuanqing and pleaded in panic, "My lord, Kang City is lost! Let me cover your retreat—as long as there's life, there's hope!"

Sui Yuanqing turned his dark, sunken eyes toward the deputy, staring at him as if he were already dead. "Retreat? To where?"

The deputy's mustache twitched, his gaze flickering as he avoided Sui Yuanqing's eyes. Of course he knew—aside from Chongzhou, Kang City was the Sui family's last stronghold.

His offer to cover Sui Yuanqing's retreat was a lie; in truth, he simply didn't want to throw his life away in a hopeless battle.

Whether Sui Yuanqing saw through him or not, he suddenly pressed the bloodied sword against the deputy's throat.

The cold sword blade, still dripping with thick blood, pressed against the deputy general's neck, instantly raising goosebumps all over his skin. Fear flashed in his eyes.

Since Sui Yuanqing had taken over Kang City, the deputy had served under him for some time and knew his unpredictable temper—when he went mad, he would kill anyone.

His reaction clearly amused Sui Yuanqing, who smiled faintly, his voice deceptively gentle yet sinister: "General Ma, if you dare spread such demoralizing words again, this heir will surely take your head."

The deputy was well aware of Sui Yuanqing's strength. Even if he couldn't hold Kang City, taking his life before the city fell would be effortless. He immediately pledged his loyalty: "This general would rather die on these city walls! I only worry for the heir's safety!"

His words sounded noble, but Sui Yuanqing had no interest in discerning their sincerity. With a mocking glance, he said, "General Ma's loyalty is commendable. Go and command the troops to defend the city."

Having narrowly escaped death, the deputy exhaled in relief and hurried away with a salute.

When Sui Yuanqing turned back to survey the battlefield below, even the faint smirk faded from his face. His hands, gripping the stone bricks of the battlement, tensed with bulging veins, and his jaw clenched tightly.

Launching an attack before a thunderstorm, with such overwhelming force—throughout history, only Xie Zheng would dare such a move.

Anyone who had read military strategy knew that large-scale siege battles should never be fought in heavy rain. Strong winds and downpours drastically reduced the range and lethality of arrows.

Yet Xie Zheng defied convention—and succeeded.

Arrows were limited by the storm winds, so he used crossbows with greater range and power than ordinary bows.

Dark clouds loomed over the city, and the Yanzhou Army's formation spread like a black tide. With nature's fury on their side, the sheer visual impact alone shattered the morale of Kang City's defenders.

The highest strategy in warfare had always been psychological warfare.

Before this battle, he had never imagined someone could wield psychological tactics so simply, directly, and brilliantly.

He had always resented Xie Zheng, believing him merely older, riding on his father Xie Linshan's military prestige, and benefiting from battlefield

luck to earn his merits.

Had it been him, he would have done no worse than Xie Zheng.

But after several confrontations, the sense of fate and defeat within him grew stronger.

He would never become Xie Zheng in this lifetime.

He had studied military strategy to reach where he was, but Xie Zheng was the kind who could rewrite strategy itself.

Nothing was more envy-inducing—or more disheartening—than talent that surpassed even the utmost effort.

The Yanzhou Army had reached the city walls, ladders scaling the ramparts. The panicked defenders fired arrows and hurled boulders, only for them to be deflected by the steel round shields of the climbing soldiers.

At the gates, dozens of soldiers chanted in unison as they rammed a battering ram against the doors. Defenders above lifted logs and stones to drop below, but the Yanzhou Army locked their shields together, forming a massive, half-arc iron shell to protect the ramming team.

The stones and boulders thrown from the walls bounced off the shields and rolled harmlessly to the ground. The Yanzhou Army below suffered almost no casualties.

Sui Yuanqing watched everything unfold with the detachment of an outsider. Stripped of all jealousy, resentment, and unwillingness, he could almost admire the perfection of this siege.

A general on horseback ought to die on the battlefield. If it were in such a grand battle, Sui Yuanqing even felt a strange sense of relief and liberation.

With a thunderous crash, the city gates were finally breached. The deputy general, his face smeared with blood, pushed past the panicked defenders scrambling along the walls and knelt before Sui Yuanqing. "Young Master, the gates are broken! Kangcheng can't hold any longer!"

The drizzle thickened slightly. Sui Yuanqing tilted his head slightly, giving the man a lazy smile before uttering just two words: "Get lost."

The deputy general didn't understand, but Sui Yuanqing had already taken his weapon from his personal guard. Amid the chaotic defenders

scattering like headless flies, he strode leisurely and unhurriedly down the city wall, moving against the tide.

Watching his retreating figure, the deputy general sighed inwardly—was this man truly mad?

Once the gates fell, the defenders inside fled in terror.

The fine drizzle gradually turned into heavier raindrops, sparsely falling from the dark clouds overhead.

Xie Zheng rode into the city with a dozen personal guards and encountered Sui Yuanqing in the barbican.

Sui Yuanqing stood alone, his horse's hooves resting atop the corpses of a dozen Yanzhou soldiers. His spear dripped with fresh blood as he taunted Xie Zheng with a challenge: "Xie whelp, dare you come and meet your death?"

The guards beside Xie Zheng bristled with anger, urging their horses forward, but Xie Zheng halted them with a sweep of his halberd.

"Fall back," he said coolly.

The dozen guards exchanged glances before retreating several paces.

Seeing this, the bloodlust and excitement in Sui Yuanqing's eyes flared. Gripping his spear, he dug his heels into his horse's sides and charged at Xie Zheng with a roar.

His attack, fueled by the momentum of his steed, was nearly unstoppable.

Yet Xie Zheng remained motionless atop his horse, his Dawan black-hoofed warhorse—a veteran of countless battles—showing no fear.

Only when Sui Yuanqing's blade was inches away did Xie Zheng raise his halberd to block.

A grating metallic screech rang out as the crescent blade of the halberd locked firmly onto Sui Yuanqing's spearhead. The collision of immense force sent both man and horse stumbling half a step back.

Sui Yuanqing gritted his teeth, his face contorted with effort.

Before he could wrench his weapon free, the shaft of the halberd struck him hard across the abdomen.

In an instant, Sui Yuanqing felt as though his organs had been shattered. He was flung from his horse, blood spraying from his mouth.

When he hit the ground, his vision blurred and doubled, darkness creeping at the edges. Only the cold sting of raindrops on his face remained clear.

The "Sui" banner on the city walls was toppled as Yanzhou soldiers swarmed the battlements, its pole hacked apart. The wind carried the fallen standard beneath Xie Zheng's horse.

Without hesitation, the horse trampled over it. The halberd's dark gold dragon-engraved blade pressed against Sui Yuanqing's throat.

Xie Zheng held the halberd one-handed, looking down from his saddle with the indifference of one regarding an insect. "Young Master Sui, were all these years of martial training spent on your tongue?"

Sui Yuanqing ignored the mockery. His mouth filled with blood, he stared up at the blurred, mountainous figure before him and laughed in exhilaration. "Kill me. Make it quick."

Xie Zheng gave him a cold look but withdrew his halberd, ordering the personal guards behind him, "Tie him up and take him back."

The guards moved forward to drag Sui Yuanqing away. He rasped, "Xie Zheng! If I must die, I'd rather it be by your blade! Those executioners aren't worthy of severing this head of mine!"

The rain grew heavier, soaking the city bricks on the ground with bean-sized droplets.

Xie Zheng had already ridden his horse forward a few steps but turned back at these words, his voice icy. "There's someone you might want to see, Sui Yuanqing. After that, you might not be so eager to die."

Sui Yuanqing was swiftly bound and taken away by the guards.

Gongsun Yin arrived late, shielding himself from the increasingly heavy rain with a feathered fan. He clicked his tongue. "So, as soon as this storm hit, Kangcheng fell just like that?"

Xie Zheng ignored him, urging his horse further into the city while instructing his subordinate generals, "Once the army enters the city, no harm is to come to the civilians."

The generals clasped their fists in acknowledgment.

...

The thunderclouds gathered over Kangcheng eventually unleashed a torrential downpour that lasted a full day and night without pause.

Inside the room, bright candles burned high. Xie Zheng sat bare-chested, his well-defined muscles stark under the dim candlelight. A long, diagonal wound stretched across his back—partially scabbed at the ends but split open in the middle, the dark scabs mingling with raw, crimson flesh in a gruesome sight.

He didn't even bother applying medicine, simply wrapping clean white cloth tightly around the injury. Though fine beads of sweat dotted his temples from the pain, his expression remained unflinching.

Discarded clothes lay haphazardly on a low table nearby, among which a crudely carved wooden figurine with haughtily upturned eyes stood out conspicuously.

The door was abruptly pushed open as Gongsun Yin barged in excitedly to report, "I took that Zhao fellow to see Sui Yuanqing. You wouldn't believe—" His words cut off abruptly as he caught sight of Xie Zheng's mangled back, his brow furrowing. "When did you get such a severe injury?"

Xie Zheng's expression was frigid as he finished tying the bandage and donned his outer robe. "When capturing Zhao Xun."

Gongsun Yin looked astonished. "The Zhao Family could afford guards that formidable?"

Xie Zheng swiftly changed the subject. "What about Sui Yuanqing?"

Gongsun Yin's earlier excitement had vanished. "He no longer wants to die—just to fight his way back to Chongzhou, behead his fake elder brother, and save his mother." Then, his attention returned to Xie Zheng's wound. Glancing at the low table and finding no medicine bottles, his frown deepened. "Your back is split open like that, and you're not treating it?" Suspicion crept into his voice. "I've felt something was off since your return. Did you have another quarrel with Miss Fan?"

Xie Zheng's voice turned icy as he issued a dismissal. "If there's nothing else, leave."

Gongsun Yin paused, realizing he'd guessed correctly. It was rare to see Xie Zheng's expression so grim, and he surmised the conflict must have

been serious. Any urge to tease vanished.

Years of friendship had taught him this man's temperament. Now wasn't the time to pry. As he retreated, his gaze flicked to the figurine on the table.

Xie Zheng's room would never house such an ugly trinket—it must have been brought back from Chongzhou.

Only after walking far from the room did Gongsun Yin summon a guard and mutter, "Go to Chongzhou..."

Chapter 107

After Gongsun Yin left, Xie Zheng sat silently before the low table.

His hair was still damp from the bath, wet strands clinging to his forehead. The tall bridge of his nose cast a shadow in the candlelight, his thin lips pressed together, giving him a stubborn, wild air.

His long fingers picked up the ugly yet endearing doll, studying it for a long while before gently stroking it with his thumb.

Beneath the low table lay a large bundle, retrieved by his personal guard from Yanzhou.

He untied the knot—inside were two sets of clothes, unworn double-stitched short boots, and a packet of tangerine peel candy.

It was the same bundle Fan Changyu had entrusted to Carpenter Zhao to deliver to him.

The rainy weather had left everything inside slightly damp.

Xie Zheng unwrapped the oil-paper packet of tangerine peel candy—some of the candies had melted, sticking together.

As if he didn't notice, he picked one up and placed it in his mouth. Instead of letting it dissolve slowly, he crushed it between his teeth and swallowed.

One after another, he chewed and swallowed each piece.

Only the sweetness, sourness, and bitterness of the tangerine peel candy spread across his tongue.

By the end, there was almost no sweetness left—just sour and bitter.

Chongzhou

The night rain poured down, the faint glow of a single lamp warding off the damp chill outside the tent.

Fan Changyu sat cross-legged on the military cot, staring blankly at the empty chest beside her.

She had already taken out all the clothes inside and piled them on the bed, but she still couldn't find the roughly carved wooden doll.

Though she was the only one living in this tent, she occasionally called in squad leaders and platoon leaders for discussions. She always kept her personal belongings neatly stored.

Her spare clothes were kept in the chest, and the doll—she would take it out to carve whenever she had time, then put it back in the chest with her clothes.

When she had hastily grabbed a change of clothes earlier to meet He Jingyuan, she hadn't noticed.

Now, in the quiet of the night, she wanted to take the doll out and refine the carving—but it was gone.

Footsteps approached outside the tent, followed by the sound of an oil-paper umbrella being shaken. Moments later, Aunt Zhao pushed aside the tent flap with her elbow, one hand holding the dripping umbrella and the other carrying a bowl of medicine.

"This rain is downright frightening!" she muttered.

Leaning the umbrella against the tent wall, she walked toward Fan Changyu with the medicine bowl. Seeing the clothes strewn all over, she asked, "Why'd you take all these out?"

Remembering that Aunt Zhao had been tending to her during her two days unconscious, Fan Changyu quickly asked, "Auntie, when you were tidying my things, did you see a wooden doll in the chest?"

Aunt Zhao shook her head. "Didn't see any wooden doll."

Noticing her despondent expression, she added, "What's wrong?"

Fan Changyu only shook her head, her almond-shaped eyes reflecting confusion and a hint of bitterness in the candlelight.

How could the doll just disappear?

Xie Wu, though her personal guard, would never overstep and touch her private belongings.

During the two days she was unconscious, the only other person who had entered this tent was Xie Zheng, disguised as Xie Wu.

Did he take the doll?

Aunt Zhao said, "Drink this medicine while it's hot. I still need to go back and brew some more for your Uncle Zhao."

Fan Changyu's hand injury hadn't healed yet, so she had been staying at the military camp these days to take care of her daily needs. During the day when she had free time, she would help the army doctors brew medicine or wash the clothes of severely wounded soldiers.

The battle had caused significant casualties in the army. Even Carpenter Zhao, originally a veterinarian, was called upon to bandage and treat the wounded soldiers.

At first, he was apprehensive, fearing his medical skills weren't good enough and might harm the soldiers. But when he realized that the newly recruited army doctors for treating the wounded didn't even understand pharmacology as well as he did, he felt somewhat uneasy.

Upon inquiry, he learned they were mostly rural folk healers, some even just herb gatherers who recognized medicinal plants. Carpenter Zhao couldn't help but feel a bit nervous.

Yet he understood it was unavoidable. With thousands of wounded soldiers and only a few army doctors accompanying the troops—many injuries requiring timely treatment—how could the doctors manage alone?

They had no choice but to recruit anyone within a hundred-mile radius with even the slightest knowledge of medicine to treat the wounded.

Regardless of their medical skills, having some treatment was better than none.

Drawing from his experience treating Xie Zheng's severe injuries, Carpenter Zhao successfully saved many wounded soldiers and was exceptionally promoted to a full-fledged Army Doctor.

The army always treated doctors with respect, so Carpenter Zhao no longer had to do carpentry or veterinary work and even got his own separate tent.

Fan Changyu snapped out of her thoughts. Two days ago, when she was unconscious, Aunt Zhao had no choice but to stay by her side at night. Now that she was awake, she didn't need Aunt Zhao to take care of her all the time. Taking the medicine bowl, she said, "It's pouring rain, and the camp is pitch black—it won't be easy to walk. I'll have Xiao Wu escort you. Once you're done, rest at Uncle Zhao's place instead of coming back here."

Her tent was quite a distance from the wounded soldiers' tents, and it would be exhausting for the elderly woman to go back and forth.

Fan Changyu understood Aunt Zhao's desire to do something for the wounded soldiers.

Aunt Zhao and her husband had lost their son on the battlefield years ago. When she came to the camp and saw the soldiers in the wounded soldier camp, perhaps reminded of her own fallen son, she even cried, treating the wounded soldiers like her own children, bustling about without a moment's rest.

Maybe she wanted to make up for the regret of not being able to do anything when their son died in battle.

Aunt Zhao still seemed worried. "But will you be alright alone at night?"

Fan Changyu held the bowl and said, "My hand only suffered flesh and tendon injuries—the bones are fine. It's nothing serious."

Aunt Zhao hesitated before saying, "Alright then. If anything happens, have Xiao Wu come get me."

Fan Changyu agreed and called for Xie Wu to escort Aunt Zhao to Carpenter Zhao's tent.

Once the tent flap closed again, shutting out the rain and the endless darkness, Fan Changyu finally settled into silence.

Holding the medicine bowl, she lowered her head as if something wet fell into the dark, bitter liquid, causing ripples.

She drank it all in one go, ignoring how the bitterness made her stomach cramp. After placing the bowl on the low stool by the bed, she stuffed the clothes back into the chest, shook out the thin quilt, wrapped herself in it, and buried her head to sleep.

The battle report announcing the killing of Changxin Wang was sent to the capital, and it took half a month before the imperial envoy arrived in Chongzhou with the imperial decree of official rewards.

When the imperial envoy entered the camp, Fan Changyu was the only one below the rank of captain included in the welcoming party.

The arrival of an imperial decree was akin to the emperor's personal presence, requiring all civil and military officials to don their official robes.

He Jingyuan, still severely wounded, forced himself into the heavy armor to lead his subordinate generals in welcoming the imperial envoy at the camp entrance. His face was gaunt, cheekbones protruding and cheeks hollowed, even tinged with a sickly gray hue, evoking deep sympathy among his subordinates.

Fan Changyu's heart grew heavy. He Jingyuan's injuries weren't just from arrows—during the confrontation with Prince Changxin, he had taken a Lion-Head Spear strike meant for Tang Peiyi, damaging his internal organs, which was why his condition showed no improvement.

When He Jingyuan wrote his memorial to the capital, he had already stated his grave injuries and likely inability to continue as the main commander for the attack on Chongzhou. No one knew what this imperial decree would bring.

Standing at the back, Fan Changyu saw a large group approaching the camp. The leader wore an official robe she had never seen before—neither civilian nor military—his wrinkled face pale and beardless, exuding an indescribable strangeness.

Upon seeing He Jingyuan, the man raised his eyelids arrogantly and declared in a high-pitched, shrill voice, "Governor of Jizhou, He Jingyuan, receive the decree—"

Only then did Fan Changyu realize this must be one of those legendary eunuchs serving the emperor.

He Jingyuan knelt with the others. Afraid of causing trouble through impropriety, Fan Changyu dared not scrutinize the eunuch further and kept her eyes fixed on the ground before her.

"The Emperor, by the Mandate of Heaven, decrees: The rebels of Chongzhou have ravaged our lands and oppressed our people. Governor He Jingyuan of Jizhou has upheld the realm and slain the rebels, bringing Us great comfort. Now learning of his grave injuries, We hereby confer upon him the title of General of Huaihua, reward him with a thousand taels of gold, and temporarily transfer his military authority to General of Manifest Might Tang Peiyi, permitting his return to Jizhou to recuperate."

The moment the words fell, the expressions of those kneeling at the camp entrance shifted dramatically.

This decree granted He Jingyuan a higher but hollow military title while stripping him of his actual command.

Tang Peiyi knelt slightly behind He Jingyuan to his left. Having been promoted by He Jingyuan himself, he held deep respect for his superior. Hearing the decree, he grew visibly agitated, wanting to speak but restrained by the unfinished proclamation, left to kneel in anxious silence.

The eunuch continued, "General of Manifest Might Tang Peiyi, for his merit in constructing dams to intercept the rebels and training the right flank army to achieve remarkable victories in the Chongzhou campaign, demonstrating great military talent, is hereby conferred the title of General of the Cloud Banner and rewarded with five hundred taels of gold."

"His subordinate generals have also shown exceptional bravery: Wang Daqing, for slaying the rebel vanguard, is conferred the title of Mobile Cavalry General and rewarded with a hundred taels of gold; Gou Siyou, for slaying a rebel captain, is conferred the title of Resolute Captain..."

The decree dragged on, nearly rewarding every general kneeling at the camp entrance. Only then did Fan Changyu understand she had been summoned to receive honors as well.

The battle reports detailing these merits had all been written by He Jingyuan and submitted to the emperor. He likely anticipated who would be rewarded, hence gathering them in advance.

Yet Fan Changyu's name remained unmentioned.

Her knees had nearly gone numb when the eunuch finally intoned, "Right Flank Army Captain Fan Changyu..."

Startled, she instinctively looked up—only to meet the eunuch's gaze already upon her.

His eyes seemed to smile, yet sent an inexplicable chill down her spine. The indescribable discomfort made her quickly lower her head again.

The eunuch continued reading the imperial decree: "For slaying the Prince of Changxin and achieving extraordinary merit, Fan Changyu is hereby appointed Swift Cavalry Commandant and awarded three hundred taels of gold. So decreed!"

Fan Changyu didn't yet know how high-ranking the position of Swift Cavalry Commandant was, but hearing that the reward was three times greater than what a military officer named Wang Daqing under Tang

Peiyi's command had received, she privately surmised that this official position must be quite significant.

After finishing the imperial decree, the eunuch dropped his haughty expression and smiled at He Jingyuan, saying, "Lord He, receive the decree."

His peripheral glance also swept briefly toward Fan Changyu.

Even while ill, He Jingyuan's voice remained firm: "He Jingyuan receives the decree!"

The eunuch handed the decree to He Jingyuan, his face wearing an ostensibly warm yet subtly unsettling smile. "Congratulations, my lord. My sincerest congratulations."

He Jingyuan looked at the decree in his hands, his eyes revealing a trace of weariness as he smiled and said, "It is His Majesty's mercy."

Tang Peiyi immediately clenched his fists in indignation. "My lord, this humble general is unworthy of assuming command. I beg you to continue leading the troops!"

He Jingyuan rebuked him sharply: "Enough nonsense! Do you wish to defy the imperial decree?"

Tang Peiyi wanted to say more, but seeing the eunuch watching with an amused smile, he ultimately restrained himself.

He Jingyuan then addressed the decree-bearing eunuch: "Your Excellency has traveled far and endured hardships. A modest tent has been prepared in the camp. If you do not disdain it, please rest and recuperate."

The eunuch chuckled. "No hardship at all. It is you, Lord He, who toils tirelessly on the frontlines as a pillar of the state who endures true hardship. But whether it's you, a minister, or us servants of His Majesty, we all receive the emperor's stipend and must share his burdens, isn't that so?"

He Jingyuan understood the eunuch's implied meaning but showed nothing on his face, merely saying, "Your Excellency speaks wisely."

The eunuch's smile deepened as he looked at He Jingyuan. "It's good that Lord He understands."

After subordinates led the decree-bearing eunuch and his entourage away, Tang Peiyi could no longer contain himself. "My lord, how could His Majesty simply strip you of your military authority?" he protested on He Jingyuan's behalf.

Half in frustration and half in anger, he lowered his head. "I don't have the capability to take your place! I can't handle the mess in Chongzhou either!"

He Jingyuan only said, "Foolish!"

"My lord..."

Tang Peiyi wanted to continue, but He Jingyuan cut him off. "If this military authority doesn't fall to you, the court will send someone else. Between the two, I'd much prefer you take command of the Jizhou army."

As he spoke, he patted Tang Peiyi's shoulder.

Tang Peiyi, a man of eight chi stature, actually reddened around the eyes. "If not for you saving me that day..."

He Jingyuan suddenly sighed. "Peiyi, I truly have grown old."

Looking at He Jingyuan's noticeably grayer temples and gaunt figure after just half a month, Tang Peiyi's eyes stung, and he could no longer bring himself to voice any further refusal.

Fan Changyu also found the scene deeply affecting.

Since ancient times, it seemed the fate of military generals was always to be discarded once their usefulness ended.

Preoccupied with these thoughts, she felt no joy at all about her military appointment and reward.

When He Jingyuan dismissed everyone, she found herself inexplicably rooted to the spot.

Seeing her, He Jingyuan didn't seem surprised. "Walk with your uncle," he said.

Changyu gave an affirmative sound and fell half a step behind He Jingyuan's side.

Due to his injuries, He Jingyuan walked slowly. Even clad in armor, his inherent scholarly gentleness remained undiminished.

After walking a distance in quiet surroundings, he spoke slowly, "I didn't hide from you the fact that I killed Changxin Wang. Now the entire court knows about you. From now on, you must be vigilant on your own, for who knows how many eyes are watching you from the shadows."

Fan Changyu replied, "Changyu understands."

He Jingyuan sighed, "The Prime Minister can no longer tolerate me. Who knows when he might strike against you and your sister next? Hiding won't help. By making everyone aware of you, the Prime Minister will think twice before acting."

He paused, then continued, "Grand Tutor Li's faction has already uncovered your parents' past. He wants to overthrow Wei Yan and will spare no effort to protect you now. Li Huaian remains in the army as a military supervisor. Though he is humble, courteous, and virtuous, he is still a member of the Li family. Do not trust him lightly."

Fan Changyu could sense the elder's deep concern and felt grateful. She said earnestly, "Changyu will remember all of this."

Only then did He Jingyuan give her a slight nod, his eyes reflecting the kindness and pity of an elder for a younger generation. "Choosing this path has been hard on you."

Thinking of her parents' deaths, her grandfather's seventeen years of infamy, and the day she parted with Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu's dark almond eyes were calm yet flickered with an unyielding flame. She said firmly, "It's not hard."

Chapter 108

By the time Fan Changyu returned, news of her appointment as Swift Cavalry Commandant had already spread throughout the camp.

Everyone who saw her offered congratulations: "Congratulations, Commandant Fan!"

Fan Changyu responded to these familiar and unfamiliar faces with only slight nods.

Though she had mentally prepared herself, when the day actually arrived, she still found it hard to adjust.

With her promotion came a new military tent, and the number of well-wishers far exceeded those who had come when she was merely a centurion. Most were generals or officers of higher rank.

Fan Changyu dared not be negligent, but the finesse required in social etiquette wasn't something one could master overnight. She struggled to handle it smoothly. Fortunately, the war wasn't over yet, and banquets were inappropriate in the military camp, so she didn't have to host a feast for these visitors.

Faced with the chorus of congratulations, she imitated the gestures of promoted generals she'd heard about from storytellers, clasp her fists and replying to each well-wisher with a "Same to you."

It was only then that she realized the camp wasn't lacking in flatterers.

Several unfamiliar military officers nearly hailed her as a reincarnated war deity.

"Back when the dam was being built in Jizhou, I'd already heard of Commandant Fan's reputation! Even as a commoner, she cared for the realm, intercepting three scouts on a rainy night, ensuring the rebels were lured into the river valley so the flood strategy could succeed!"

"And that battle at First Line Gorge where she beheaded Shi Hu—truly spectacular! Armed with just two butcher knives, she took his head! Now

she's accomplished another extraordinary feat, saving Lord He and slaying the Prince of Changxin!"

The crowd marveled and praised, "Heroes emerge from humble origins—how true the saying is!"

Fan Changyu modestly replied, "You overpraise me. My success against the Prince of Changxin was merely luck."

A military officer immediately interjected, "Commandant Fan, don't be so modest! Even luck isn't something just anyone can claim!"

As others chimed in, an officer with thin mustaches on either side of his mouth expressed regret: "Logically, slaying the Prince of Changxin should be the foremost merit. After the vanguard was scattered, it was the commandant who led the right flank into the heart of the rebel formation. How could the court only grant a fifth-rank position and a mere three hundred taels of silver?"

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned, realizing for the first time that Swift Cavalry Commandant was a fifth-rank position.

She recalled Xie Zheng—disguised as Xie Wu—telling her that killing the Prince of Changxin would bring a thousand taels in reward.

Yet she'd only received three hundred.

Since the reward was specified in the imperial decree, no official would dare embezzle it. The reduction must have been the emperor's own decision.

For now, Fan Changyu couldn't fathom the reason.

But this officer's words implied that Tang Peiyi had taken credit for her achievements.

With so many present—many of them strangers—such remarks could easily lead to gossip.

Lord He's warning echoed in her mind, and Fan Changyu grew wary. She promptly said, "The tactics and battle formations for attacking Chongzhou were the brainchild of Lord He and General Tang. They deserve the greatest credit. As a mere squad leader promoted five ranks at once, I'm already overwhelmed by His Majesty's boundless grace. Moreover, my experience in the army is still shallow. I'm uneasy about assuming this commandant role and will rely on everyone's guidance in the future."

In the military camp, the officer in charge of fifty men held no official rank. To be precise, they should be called squad leaders, but since there were both primary and deputy squad leaders, those under their command habitually referred to the primary one as "squad leader" and the deputy as "deputy squad leader."

Fan Changyu's words left no room for criticism. The other officers had already broken into a cold sweat when that person made that ambiguous remark.

They had only come to offer congratulations because they would be serving under Fan Changyu from now on.

If those words reached Tang Peiyi's ears and displeased him, and their immediate superior lost the general's favor, what hope would they, the subordinates, have?

So when they heard Fan Changyu's humble yet flattering words about He and Tang, everyone in the room breathed a sigh of relief and quickly chimed in, "The Commandant speaks wisely! Both generals have made great contributions, but the Commandant's position is well-deserved!"

With that, the matter was settled.

Just as Fan Changyu was about to see her guests out, an unexpected visitor arrived outside the tent.

"The Commandant's tent is quite lively."

That voice, as gentle as a spring breeze in March, was unmistakable.

Fan Changyu turned to see the attendant lift the tent flap, and in walked a man in a pale blue scholar's robe, smiling—none other than Li Huaian.

The officers in the tent immediately stiffened. Fan Changyu wondered if he had come to congratulate her on her promotion, but she maintained proper decorum, clasping her fists and saying, "Lord Li."

Li Huaian raised his delicate brows slightly. His eyebrows were naturally light, with a slight curve at the ends, giving him an air of gentleness and harmlessness. Even this gesture, which might seem frivolous on others, looked pleasing on him.

He smiled faintly and said, "Commandant Fan is still so formal with me."

Then he took a brocade box from his attendant behind him and said, "Upon hearing of the Commandant's official rewards from His Majesty, I

prepared a modest gift for you."

Xie Wu, standing guard at the entrance like a door god, widened his eyes at the sight. If his gaze could turn tangible, he would have burned two holes through the back of Li Huaian's head.

Though the Marquis and the Commandant were currently separated, Gongsun had even sent Xie Shisan to Chongzhou to gather information. After returning, the Marquis had immediately taken action against the rebels in Kangcheng—clearly, he still cared for the Commandant.

As for the Commandant, there was no need to say more. He had caught her staring blankly at the Black Steel Modao more than once.

And now, Li Huaian was here to offer some kind of goodwill?

Taking advantage of the situation?

Xie Wu's heart pounded as he stared at Fan Changyu, silently praying she wouldn't accept the gift.

Fan Changyu frowned and said to Li Huaian, "I appreciate Lord Li's kindness, but private exchanges are forbidden in the military. I cannot accept this gift."

The centurions who had visited her earlier had come under the pretense of checking on her health, bringing only inexpensive pastries and wine—hardly a private exchange.

The officers who came to congratulate her today weren't foolish enough to bring gifts directly to the camp, so they had all arrived empty-handed. Thus, refusing was not difficult.

Li Huaian chuckled and said, "The Commandant misunderstands. This box merely contains a few military strategy books I annotated in my spare time."

With that, he opened the box, revealing only a few slightly worn volumes—nothing else.

He tapped the bottom of the brocade box subtly with his fingertips, his smile unwavering: "Huaian's humble gift is indeed meager, and I fear the Commandant may find it laughable. I only hope you won't disdain it."

Having said this much, and with the contents being merely a few books, Fan Changyu truly couldn't find any further excuse to refuse.

Moreover, Li Huaian's discreet gesture seemed to be hinting at her to accept the box first.

After some thought, Changyu considered that if it were merely a simple gift, he wouldn't have chosen to present it amidst a crowd of military officers congratulating her.

Her gaze swept indifferently over the mustached officer who had earlier tried to provoke discord between her and Tang Peiyi. Recalling He Jingyuan's words that Grand Tutor Li's faction currently meant her no harm, she hesitated briefly before accepting the brocade box from Li Huaian, saying, "Then Changyu will graciously accept."

Li Huaian's expression seemed to relax slightly as he smiled. "Huaian's understanding of military strategy is shallow. I only hope these annotated military texts may be of some assistance to the Commandant."

Changyu could only respond with another polite remark: "You are too modest, my lord."

Finally seeing off all the well-wishers, Changyu slumped into a chair, feeling a throbbing ache in her temples.

Whoever said the military was full of rough, unrefined men clearly hadn't met these officers who had clawed their way up from foot soldiers. Not a single one was foolish.

That officer who deliberately set traps to drive a wedge between her and Tang Peiyi would certainly need watching in the future. Such overt threats were easy to deal with; it was the hidden ones that worried her.

Li Huaian's behavior was also inexplicably peculiar.

After everyone had left, Changyu examined the box carefully. There were no hidden compartments, and the military texts contained no concealed notes—the annotations were just that, annotations.

With no leads whatsoever, she sighed and asked Xie Wu, "Xiao Wu, what do you think Li Huaian meant by hinting that I should accept these military texts?"

Since this was a serious matter, Xie Wu suppressed his personal biases and analyzed: "With the military authority in Jizhou changing hands, the officers below, though loyal to Old General He, must now seek favor with their new superiors. Just as those centurions came to show goodwill to the

Commandant earlier, accepting their overtures would be a form of alignment and alliance."

He paused here, glancing at Changyu before continuing, "Li Huaian... is likely also trying to win you over."

Changyu understood. "By accepting these military texts, I'm now aligned with the Li family?"

Xie Wu nodded, then added, "But he deliberately presented the gift publicly, clearly wanting someone specific to know."

Changyu pondered this carefully. The only one who wanted her dead was Wei Yan, but whether or not she accepted Grand Tutor Li's protection, Wei Yan wouldn't relent.

So the only person in the camp who could have prompted Li Huaian to go to such lengths was likely the imperial eunuch who had arrived that day to deliver the edict.

But the eunuch served the emperor.

Did the emperor mean her harm?

But why would the emperor wish her ill? At present, He Jingyuan hadn't yet been interrogated, meaning her true origins hadn't been revealed to the court. Even if the emperor resented her because of her grandfather, why would he confer an official title upon her?

Though it seemed the rank had been somewhat suppressed.

Fan Changyu grew increasingly frustrated as she tried to make sense of things, grabbing a handful of her hair in agitation.

In the past, Grand Tutor Tao had taught her how to analyze situations, but now he was missing without a trace, and He Jingyuan was about to be transferred back to Jizhou. From now on, no matter what happened, she would have to figure things out and make decisions on her own.

At this thought, her gaze fell on the three hundred taels of gold laid out on a red silk tray on the table.

Each gold ingot weighed ten taels, and there were thirty ingots in total, gleaming brilliantly and catching the eye.

After some consideration, she instructed Xie Wu, "Take thirteen ingots and send them, along with the official compensation, to the families of the

thirteen fallen soldiers. Take two more ingots to buy tonics for the severely wounded soldiers. Then, find me a few capable advisors—pay them whatever silver you deem appropriate."

Xie Wu nodded. "As a fifth-rank commandant, it's only fitting for you to have advisors. But... isn't the amount for the fallen soldiers a bit excessive?"

Ten taels of gold converted to a hundred taels of silver. Combined with the five taels of official compensation, that made a hundred and five taels.

Fan Changyu said, "This is what I promised them."

The group of captains led by Guo Baihu might serve him in the future, but they could never become her personal guards.

She still had too few people around her who were both capable and loyal.

She wanted to select two from the soldiers she had trained to serve as her personal guards.

Xie Wu was momentarily stunned by her answer but ultimately said nothing more.

As he was about to leave, Fan Changyu called him back. "Take these military books and distribute them among the soldiers as well."

Xie Wu froze.

Fan Changyu said, "Reading more about military strategy will only benefit them."

Once he confirmed that she meant for him to handle the books, Xie Wu was nearly ecstatic. His grin threatened to split his face, but he quickly reined it in, afraid Fan Changyu might notice. He picked up the brocade box and said, "Understood! I'll take care of it right away!"

After Xie Wu left, Fan Changyu stared blankly at the Horse-Cutting Sword resting on the weapon rack for a while before pulling out the books Xie Zheng had annotated for her and slowly flipping through them.

Reading could make a person wiser. She needed to read more.

Whether it was coincidence or intention, Li Huaian's act of gifting her annotated books—from their first encounter on the mountain path to later helping her investigate the case of her parents' murder, which

conveniently revealed issues with her origins, and then tracing the clues to uncover how He Jingyuan had forged documents for her parents—was all just too "coincidental."

The Imperial Palace.

Amidst the jade towers and jeweled pavilions, a striking woman in begonia-red palace robes strode swiftly forward, followed by sixteen maids with twin buns, their heads bowed as they hurried to keep up.

The elderly eunuch guarding the doors of the Imperial Study spotted her from afar, his wrinkled face already forcing an ingratiating smile as he stepped forward. "What wind brings Her Highness the Princess here today —"

The woman, radiant as a lotus yet icy in demeanor, flicked her sleeve and shoved the blocking eunuch aside, glaring as she snapped, "Out of my way!"

The eunuch yelped as he fell to the ground. Seeing that he couldn't stop her and fearing the emperor's wrath later, he clung to one of her legs, his shrill voice pleading, "Your Highness, you mustn't go in! His Majesty is weary and has just retired—"

Before he could finish, the princess had already pushed open the doors of the Imperial Study.

The heavy scent of ambergris filled the room, causing the princess's meticulously painted face to twist slightly in disgust.

The old eunuch trembled as he prostrated himself at the doorway. "Your Majesty, please calm your anger! This worthless servant deserves death for failing to stop Her Highness the Princess—"

"Enough. Leave us." A young man's voice came from within.

The eunuch retreated as if granted amnesty, bowing deeply and closing the study doors behind him.

The princess stood fearless before the Dragon Desk, her cold gaze fixed on the figure in bright yellow imperial robes who massaged his temples with visible exhaustion. "You've arranged my marriage to Wu'an Marquis?"

The emperor looked down at the radiant beauty standing below the jade steps. His lips curved into a boyish smile devoid of guile, yet his eyes

gleamed like a venomous snake flicking its tongue in shadows. "I've found my royal sister an Unrivaled Hero for a husband. Are you displeased?"

"Wu'an Marquis met a commoner girl during his exile and pledged himself to her!" the princess snapped. "Does Your Majesty intend to make me the villain who tears lovers apart?"

The emperor waved a hand. "You worry too much, royal sister. How could some vulgar peasant compare to the pearl of our Great Yin dynasty? The marquis has already severed ties with her."

The princess's delicate brows knitted together. "Impossible. To marry that girl as his principal wife, he even begged the retired Grand Tutor Tao to adopt her as foster daughter. How could he simply abandon her?"

The emperor chuckled. "Then royal sister truly doesn't understand men. Between overwhelming power and the most beautiful woman in the realm, could some peasant girl possibly hold greater sway in his heart?"

"I refuse to tolerate such impurities," the princess said, her expression growing colder.

The emperor replied casually, "Rest assured, royal sister. After your marriage, you'll never lay eyes on that peasant girl again."

The princess paled. "You killed her? Aren't you afraid Wu'an Marquis will resent you?"

The emperor's smile deepened. "What's strange about a general dying in battle? Any resentment Wu'an Marquis bears should be directed at the rebels, no?"

In his youth, he'd been reduced to a puppet by Wei Yan and feigned stupidity to avoid suspicion. Later, to win over Grand Tutor Li, he'd pretended to be docile and easily controlled. Only in recent years had he begun baring his fangs.

Hearing his words, the princess stared in horrified silence, as if stunned by his depravity.

The emperor gazed at the woman before him, his expression as guileless and obedient as the timid young ruler he'd once pretended to be. Yet his eyes brimmed with unchecked ambition and desire.

Running his fingers over the gilded dragon head adorning his throne armrest, he mused with boundless anticipation, "Once Wei Yan falls,

imperial power will return to me. With Wu'an Marquis at my side, what have I to fear from that old fool Li?"

Tilting his head, he added cheerfully, "Given the Li family's embezzlement over the years, exterminating their entire lineage would be justified."

The princess had never felt more estranged from the meek, kind-hearted younger brother she'd known. Goosebumps rose along her arms beneath the thin gauze sleeves. "And Wu'an Marquis? With his military power, how can you trust him?"

The emperor seemed about to respond, but his smile deepened as he looked at the princess standing below him. Abruptly changing course, he said, "Naturally I trust him—after all, royal sister will be keeping watch over him for me."

"In this world, you're the one person I trust completely, royal sister."

The chill creeping through her limbs slowly climbed up her spine.

The grand princess forced a composed smile. "It is my honor that Your Majesty places such trust in me."

Delighted by her change in attitude, the emperor said, "I knew my elder sister would stand by my side. You may return and await your grand wedding."

The grand princess responded with a "Yes," curtsied, then turned and swept out of the study in her resplendent palace robes, her back straight and her expression as haughty as when she had entered, followed closely by sixteen palace maids.

No one knew the sheer fabric on her back was soaked with cold sweat, hidden only by her dark hair.

Upon returning to her palace, the grand princess shut the doors and angrily smashed porcelain until the floor was littered with shards.

Exhausted, she finally sat on a nearby couch, resting her forehead on one hand, her snow-white brow furrowed in obvious distress.

A senior maid carefully offered a cup of floral tea, advising, "Your Highness, please don't harm your health with anger..."

The grand princess took the cup but, recalling the emperor's words, couldn't suppress her rage and hurled it away. The shattering porcelain

startled the nearby maids.

"What does he think he is? Born of a lowly palace maid, without any maternal relatives, and now he wants to drag me into this mess!"

Her beautiful face was twisted with fury.

She was the Late Emperor's most beloved daughter, though not his first—those before her had died young, leaving her the grand princess. Her mother was of noble birth, making her and the emperor half-siblings.

The emperor had likely grown close to her over the years to curry favor with her maternal family.

The senior maid, unaware of the conversation inside the study, assumed her mistress was still angry about the marriage arrangement. After some hesitation, she ventured, "Your Highness, that Gongsun Yin has refused to take office or even step foot in the capital just to avoid you. Why cling to him? The Wu'an Marquis is a peerless match—a decorated general, ennobled before he even turned twenty..."

"Silence!" The grand princess's face turned icy, her nails digging into the wooden armrest so hard they nearly snapped.

The maid froze in shock.

Realizing her overreaction, the grand princess lowered her lashes like a fan to hide her momentary loss of control and scoffed, "Do you think the Wu'an Marquis will meet a good end?"

The maid paled, sensing political implications. "The imperial decree has been issued, and the envoy has left the capital. What can be done now?"

After a moment of silent contemplation, the grand princess suddenly said, "Prepare ink for me."

Kang City.

A troop of soldiers halted by the riverbank, where bound bandits crouched like dumplings under the watch of a dozen armored guards.

The lush summer grass had grown coarse, and the warhorses nosed through it for tender shoots.

When Gongsun Yin received the letter brought back by his personal guard from Chongzhou, his brows furrowed deeply.

He asked, "Miss Fan killed the Prince of Changxin, and the court only made her a Swift Cavalry Commandant?"

Xie Shisan nodded. "Absolutely. A eunuch from the Office of Ceremonial Affairs personally delivered the decree."

Gongsun Yin muttered, "Is the Prince of Changxin's head worth so little?"

He waved his hand to signal Xie Shisan to withdraw first, then glanced at the person standing bare-chested by the riverbank, allowing their personal guard to pour water down their entire back to clean the wound. Walking over, he deliberately raised his voice and said, "Miss Fan truly is a heroine among women. After slaying Changxin Wang, she was appointed as a fifth-rank Swift Cavalry Commandant."

The water trickling down Xie Zheng's back carried a faint tinge of rouge.

Upon hearing Gongsun Yin's words, he merely lifted his half-lowered eyelids slightly but remained silent, his expression indifferent and devoid of interest.

Over the past half-month, he had been relentlessly suppressing bandits, destroying every bandit stronghold around Kang City. The wounds on his back would nearly heal, only to split open again.

Yet he never once applied medicine.

When his personal guard once again poured water from a canteen over the bleeding wounds on his back, Xie Zheng seemed to deem it sufficient. Raising a hand, he signaled for the guard to withdraw, then donned his outer robe directly over the damp skin.

Gongsun Yin frowned deeply at the sight. "If you keep treating your injuries like this, they'll be the death of you sooner or later."

Xie Zheng appeared too weary to even respond. Adjusting his collar, he turned to leave. "The bandit threat around Kang City has been eliminated. I have matters to attend to in Huizhou—I leave this place to you."

Gongsun Yin studied his sickly pale complexion under the sunlight, biting back the urge to curse at him. Instead, he said, "I heard Li Huaian annotated several military treatises as a congratulatory gift for Miss Fan. Given that my relationship with Miss Fan is, at the very least, better than his, and since I'll be escorting Sui Yuanqing to Chongzhou anyway, I won't stay in Kang City. I might as well bring her a gift too."

Xie Zheng paused mid-step, uttering a terse "As you wish" before continuing without looking back.

Watching his retreating figure as he mounted his horse, Gongsun Yin finally exploded in anger. "Xie Jiuhan! You've got nerve! If you're really so determined to let go, why don't you toss that hideous doll in your room into the brazier and burn it when you get back?"

The warhorse kicked up dust as it galloped away, its rider offering no further response.

The armored guards left behind stood stunned for a moment before rallying and following with their captured bandits in tow.

Only Gongsun Yin remained, still cursing under his breath.

Xie Zheng traveled with only two personal guards, riding day and night until he reached the Xie family estate in Huizhou.

His father had settled in Huizhou while garrisoning the northwest, making the Huizhou estate, in a sense, the ancestral home.

The Xie residence in the capital had been purchased only when his father married, and every plant and decoration within its walls had been arranged according to that woman's preferences.

The family retainers stationed at the Huizhou estate were startled when Xie Zheng returned in the dead of night.

Though called retainers, they were effectively servants—men who had followed his father into battle, only to lose an arm or a leg, rendering them unfit for the battlefield for the rest of their lives.

The Xie family would support them until their dying day.

Without disturbing too many, Xie Zheng went straight to the ancestral hall, kneeling before the tablets all night.

Only at dawn the next day did the hall's doors open again.

A middle-aged man with a limp and a missing arm hobbled inside, his face rugged yet composed. Gazing at the figure kneeling as straight as an ancient pine on the prayer mat, he said gently, "I heard the Marquis returned last night. Why didn't you send word?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Uncle Zhong, I've come to request punishment."

A flicker of surprise passed through the crippled man's eyes before he steadied himself. "How much punishment?"

The Xie family had ancestral rules: any male descendant who committed a grave offense must come to the ancestral hall to request punishment.

In seventeen years, Xie Zheng had sought punishment only once—when he recaptured Jinzhou and repaid blood with blood, eye for eye, ordering the slaughter of all Northern Turks in the city, just as they had once massacred the people of Great Yin.

The Xie Clan had always been known for producing benevolent generals. Yet after the massacre of the city, the world only remembered his reputation as a slaughtering commander, forgetting entirely the Xie tradition of merciful leadership.

For a military leader to fail in restraining his own brutality was a grave transgression.

The only time Xie Zheng ever requested punishment, he asked for the severest penalty in the Xie Clan's ancestral code—one hundred and eight lashes.

Today, kneeling before the ancestral tablets of the Xie Clan, he again answered: "One hundred and eight lashes."

This number caused a strange light to reappear in the middle-aged man's eyes as he asked, "What offense has the Marquis committed?"

Xie Zheng gazed at the central tablet in the ancestral hall—Xie Linshan's memorial plaque—and replied, "Uncle Zhong will know in time."

Xie Zhong, having once been a battlefield veteran himself, was acutely sensitive to the scent of blood. The dark stain spreading across Xie Zheng's robe from reopened wounds was particularly conspicuous.

Hesitantly, he said, "The Marquis seems to bear serious injuries."

Xie Zheng merely responded, "It's nothing."

Xie Zhong then retrieved the python-skin whip hanging on the wall. After silently observing Xie Zheng for two breaths, he asked, "Shall we begin?"

Xie Zheng gave a quiet "Mm" of assent.

"Bright is our ancestor, whose legacy flows through history,

Teaching sons and grandsons, all founded on righteousness."

The solemn recitation of ancestral precepts was accompanied by the first heavy lash across Xie Zheng's back.

His body shuddered violently. His back tensed like forged steel, both hands clenched into fists at his sides to prevent himself from pitching forward. The whip had already torn through his robe, leaving behind a livid welt that threatened to split the swollen flesh beneath.

The Xie family's tradition dictated that punishment be administered while reciting ancestral teachings—so the punished might understand their transgression and engrave these principles into their bones.

"Ponder these words, extend their wisdom,

Hearken, all descendants, to our instruction."

Crack!

Another brutal lash fell, overlapping with the countless-times-reopened wound on his back. Flecks of blood and flesh sprayed out. Xie Zheng's lips blanched with pain, sweat beading like pearls at his temples, veins bulging in his clenched fists—yet not a single groan escaped him.

With each recitation of ancestral precepts came another lash until Xie Zheng's entire back became a crosshatch of bleeding welts. Sweat dripped from his eyelids, yet his eyes remained wide open, fixed unblinkingly on Xie Linshan's memorial plaque above the altar.

By the ninety-eighth stroke, blood had thoroughly saturated his robes, pooling on the stone floor beneath him. He could no longer maintain his kneeling position, collapsing forward as shadows crowded his vision, obscuring the ancestral tablets.

Xie Zhong's arms ached from exertion, the python-skin whip now slick with blood. As this generation's appointed disciplinarian of the Xie Clan, no matter how his heart rebelled, he could not show leniency during punishment.

Only this once, he said, "Marquis, let this suffice."

Xie Zheng lay prone on the ground, the wooden figurine hidden in his robes tumbling out. His palms were bloody from resisting pain, and when he retrieved the figurine, the palm-sized carving became smeared with crimson. Slowly blinking, he asked, "How many remain?"

Xie Zhong answered, "Ten strokes."

Supporting himself with one hand on the ground, the other clutching the figurine, Xie Zheng gradually rose back to his knees. Straightening his ravaged back once more, he said, "Continue."

Though pity flashed in Xie Zhong's eyes, he still loudly recited the ancestral teachings and brought the whip down with full force.

Blood sprayed across the stone tiles beneath them, blooming like grotesque flowers.

Ten lashes—not too many, not too few. By the time they were done, Xie Zheng was drenched in blood, his fingertips nearly embedded in the wooden post from gripping it too tightly. His head hung low, his eyelids too heavy to lift.

Xie Zhong, fearing his injuries might be too severe and lead to complications, hurried out of the ancestral hall to summon a physician.

Kneeling on the ground, Xie Zheng gasped for breath, his back so numb with pain he could barely feel it.

After a long while, when he finally caught his breath, he forced his leaden eyelids open and bowed his head before Xie Linshan's memorial tablet. His voice was hoarse as he whispered, "This unfilial son begs forgiveness."

There was someone rooted in his heart. He had carved out his entire heart, yet still couldn't bear to let go.

At first, endless battles and slaughter could numb his mind, but later, even the agony of his wounds reopening couldn't suppress his longing to see her.

Even when the pain wracked his body with spasms, he couldn't wake from it.

Or perhaps he had always been awake.

He simply wanted to see her.

So badly it ached in his bones.

After enduring these one hundred and eight lashes, he could finally go to her.

Chapter 109

On the day He Jingyuan returned to Jizhou, Fan Changyu, Tang Peiyi, and a group of subordinate generals personally saw him off.

He Jingyuan's injuries had not yet healed, so he couldn't ride a horse. Waiting outside the camp was a green-canopied carriage.

Before He Jingyuan boarded, Tang Peiyi clasped his fists solemnly and said, "Sir, once you return to Jizhou, rest well. Peiyi will surely conquer Chongzhou and capture Sui Yuanhuai alive, living up to your high expectations!"

He Jingyuan nodded at him, patted his shoulder with satisfaction, but when his gaze swept over Fan Changyu and the subordinate generals who had once followed him, a trace of weariness flickered in his eyes.

Those gathered today were all his own people, so he spoke without much restraint. "Peiyi, this niece of mine—please look after her in the future."

Tang Peiyi quickly replied, "Though Captain Fan is a woman, she is a fierce general admired by all in the army. It was Captain Fan who intercepted and killed those three scouts, ensuring our plans weren't compromised. Had Lucheng fallen, this humble general would have been guilty beyond redemption. In the future, it will be I who relies on Captain Fan."

His promotion to commander was partly due to the military achievements of the right-wing army, so his words weren't entirely empty flattery.

He Jingyuan said, "This girl can be stubborn at times. When it comes to court matters, guide her a little."

Tang Peiyi didn't say more this time and simply agreed.

He Jingyuan then turned to Fan Changyu. Her heart was a tangle of emotions as she called out, "Uncle."

He Jingyuan said, "Serve well under General Tang and make your mark."

His eyes still held the weight of too many things from seventeen years ago, but those words could not be spoken openly.

Fan Changyu nodded firmly.

A general standing beside her, his chin shadowed with faint stubble, looked valiant but now had reddened eyes. "Sir."

He Jingyuan only smiled at him. "I've kept you by my side all these years, and your temper has mellowed. Wen Chang, follow General Tang and carve out a future for yourself on the battlefield."

This man was Zheng Wenchang, who had recently been transferred from Jizhou.

When the rebels had sought to take Jizhou and attacked Lucheng, its gateway, He Jingyuan had personally gone to oversee the defense, leaving Zheng Wenchang to manage affairs in Jizhou—in another sense, acting as his eyes to monitor Li Huaian.

Now that Li Huaian had found what he was looking for and remained in the Chongzhou battlefield, and He Jingyuan was being recalled to Jizhou, he had Zheng Wenchang transferred over, fearing Fan Changyu would lack support in the army.

In the past, both Tang Peiyi and Zheng Wenchang had been his subordinates, but Tang Peiyi was merely a junior officer, not as close as Zheng Wenchang, his student.

Now that Tang Peiyi held great authority, Zheng Wenchang would have to tread carefully.

After their farewells, He Jingyuan boarded the carriage back to Jizhou.

As Fan Changyu returned to camp, she glanced at the vast sky, a sense of melancholy rising in her heart.

On this path, it seemed those close to her were gradually leaving, but she had no choice but to press on.

Just the night before, He Jingyuan had summoned her privately.

He told her to stay patient, first accumulating military merits on the battlefield. Once the rebels were crushed and she returned to the capital to receive the emperor's personal commendation, the matter of him forging her parents' identities would be re-examined.

Once Wei Yan was implicated, with the emperor and the Li family presiding over the trial, the truth of what happened seventeen years ago could no longer be hidden.

He also told her that Zheng Wenchang was his man, and if she encountered any difficulties, she could seek help from him.

Fan Changyu was deeply moved by He Jingyuan's thoughtful arrangements.

Since the death of her parents, apart from Aunt Zhao's family, she had never received such care from an elder.

Now, as a high-ranking officer, she could participate in discussions within the central military tent. However, having read little of military strategy, she mostly listened as Tang Peiyi and the others debated over the sand table, sometimes so heatedly that it seemed they might come to blows.

At first, Fan Changyu was utterly lost, but now she could follow their discussions. Still, the strategy for attacking Chongzhou remained undecided.

One thing was certain, though—when they returned to the battlefield, she would lead the vanguard.

A cavalry unit of two hundred men was assigned to her. Though small in number, it was enough to serve as the spearhead of the vanguard.

The leader of this cavalry unit turned out to be someone Fan Changyu had met before.

During the dam construction, when she had been forced to dig earth and stones, there was an exceptionally strong man among the detained civilians who always got a chicken leg with his meals.

Now, he was the leader of this cavalry unit.

When he saw Fan Changyu, he showed little surprise, likely having known beforehand that he would be placed under her command.

Only one of his subordinates gaped at her and exclaimed, "Good heavens! Isn't this the lady who kicked down the women's barracks door the day the rebels attacked the dam?"

Clearly, this soldier had also been among the refugees that day.

To ensure cohesion on the battlefield, Fan Changyu now had to find time to train with the cavalry in addition to drilling the infantry.

Fortunately, the cavalymen seemed to hold her in high regard—whether because of her feat in slaying the Prince of Changxin or the tales of her digging earth and stones.

Fan Changyu was also busy studying current affairs and the broader political landscape with the advisors Xie Wu had found for her, leaving her no time to worry about what her subordinates gossiped about in their free time.

By the time the rumor that she could kick down a city gate with one foot had spread throughout the army, Fan Changyu was completely baffled.

She asked Xie Wu, “When did I ever kick down a city gate?”

Xie Wu replied, “They say it was when the rebels attacked the Jizhou troops building the dam.”

Fan Changyu was stunned and corrected him, “I didn’t kick down a city gate—it was the door of the women’s barracks.”

Xie Wu chuckled and said, “Let the rumor spread. It does you no harm, Commander. It might even intimidate the rebels when we face them on the battlefield.”

Having recently studied many military texts—and after reducing several advisors to half their hair—Fan Changyu had finally grasped the gist of the Thirty-Six Stratagems.

Unfortunately, despite offering several times their original pay, none of the advisors were willing to stay and continue teaching her.

Now understanding that Xie Wu was referring to a psychological tactic, she sighed and remarked, “So, the so-called art of war is really about who has the blacker heart?”

Xie Wu smiled sheepishly. “If cunning can save lives, then it’s worth it.”

Fan Changyu nodded and said, “Alright. Then find me a few more advisors.”

Xie Wu’s smile froze on his face.

One should never underestimate those scholars who refuse official posts and instead serve as honored guests in noble households—they have an

uncanny network for information.

He had gone to great lengths to find a few truly capable advisors for Fan Changyu. Upon hearing they would serve under a newly promoted female general, they had some reservations, but after learning of Fan Changyu's military achievements, they were willing to offer their services.

Unfortunately, after less than half a day of teaching, they were all left with headaches and ready to resign.

Fan Changyu hadn't even finished reading *The Art of War*—how could they teach her?

As for court politics, she was still completely clueless about the officials in the imperial court. Explaining who belonged to the Wei Faction, who was aligned with the Li faction, and who were neutral, loyal ministers was exhausting.

The advisors could only lament their bleak prospects. A general with only brute courage and no wisdom? Forget a prosperous official career—if she didn't die confused on the battlefield, it would only be by the grace of heaven.

They were forced at swordpoint to gloomily teach Fan Changyu through *The Art of War*, eating half a bowl less at every meal, visibly losing weight from sheer distress.

Half guilty and half remorseful, Fan Changyu feared these elderly gentlemen teaching her military strategy might actually die of depression under her watch. In the end, she agreed to let them go.

After returning, the advisors drowned their sorrows in wine and vented their grievances—they'd rather starve than serve as Fan Changyu's advisors. And so, this reputation spread among scholars.

Now, whenever someone tried to recruit advisors for Fan Changyu, the scholars would grab their bags and flee before the offer was even fully explained.

Xie Wu cautiously said, "Commandant, if we keep searching, I fear we won't have enough silver..."

Fan Changyu understood Xie Wu's implication—even offering several times the usual pay wouldn't attract anyone now. She sighed deeply and said, "My foster father is so formidable, and he even wanted to take me as

his disciple at first. Could it be that his eyesight has failed him in his old age?"

Xie Wu replied, "The Commandant possesses great wisdom. Grand Tutor Tao must have recognized this in you."

Fan Changyu knew the phrase great wisdom often appears as foolishness —was this implying she looked particularly stupid?

For a moment, she couldn't tell if Xie Wu was comforting her or twisting the knife further. Helpless, she said, "Alright, you may leave."

She then wrote a letter home, instructing Xie Qi to hire a private tutor for Changning.

With the war in Chongzhou, private schools had long ceased operation, but children from wealthy families could still hire tutors for lessons.

Fan Changyu decided that Changning must not follow in her footsteps—she had to ensure her sister studied properly from a young age.

A carrier pigeon flapped its wings and landed atop the pigeon coop. Inside the wooden cage, faint movements could be seen as the other birds peeked curiously through the entrance hole.

The servant tending to the coop noticed the newly returned white pigeon and hurried forward to retrieve the letter from its tube. After releasing the bird back into the coop, he rushed toward the military tent.

"Young Master, a letter has arrived from Chongzhou City."

The man writing at the desk paused and set down his brush, extending a hand as slender and pale as bamboo to accept the rolled-up letter from the servant.

Unlike the delicate, boneless fingers of a woman, this hand bore the sinewy strength of a man's, though without the pronounced knuckles of a martial artist hardened by years of training. Only the faint calluses from long hours of writing marked his fingers.

Li Huaian unfolded the letter and read it, but his handsome brows remained slightly furrowed. He murmured, "Wei Yan is far too cunning—he shouldn't have taken the bait so easily."

The letter had been sent by Sui Yuanhuai, trapped within Chongzhou's walls.

When the Li family investigated He Jingyuan, Wei Yan, fearing the emperor would interrogate him and expose himself, attempted to assassinate He Jingyuan but failed.

Now, He Jingyuan was not only protected by his own Martial Assassins but also secretly guarded by the Li family's Martial Assassins, making it impossible for Wei Yan to strike again.

Sui Yuanhuai proposed a feigned collaboration with Wei Yan—Wei Yan would help him retain control of Chongzhou, and in return, he would assist Wei Yan in stabilizing the military power in Jizhou.

After all, if Chongzhou fell, Sui Yuanhuai, the "son of a rebel," would face execution, and the military authority of both Jizhou and Chongzhou would fall into the hands of the Li family—a scenario extremely unfavorable to Wei Yan.

At this moment, cooperation between the two sides seemed the best option.

However, Wei Yan's immediate agreement after being approached by Sui Yuanhuai made Li Huaian hesitate.

Luring Wei Yan into collaborating with Chongzhou was part of their joint scheme with Sui Yuanhuai to swiftly overthrow him.

Originally, he and his grandfather had planned to use the events of seventeen years ago as leverage, but after extensive investigation, the only lead—the letter—had dead-ended with Wei Yan. Even if brought to court, Wei Yan had countless ways to exonerate himself.

Thus, they devised another plan, leveraging the military authority of Chongzhou and Jizhou as a trap.

Once Wei Yan agreed to collaborate with Sui Yuanhuai, the evidence they obtained would be irrefutable.

Even without uncovering the truth from seventeen years ago, they could still use this to bring Wei Yan down.

Yet, the plan's smooth execution made Li Huaian suspect that Wei Yan had already seen through their scheme and was merely playing along, turning their own strategy against them.

Chapter 110

The pavilion built by the water welcomed breezes from all directions. Lush bamboo shadows filtered through the half-rolled fine reed blinds, casting patterns on the floor tiles inside, while scattered sunlight danced upon the draping robes of the man engaged in a game of Go. The hidden patterns on the brocade shimmered with flowing light.

The cicadas' chirping grew restless. Across the lotus-covered lake, a brilliantly colored koi occasionally leaped up, catching a blooming petal before plunging back into the water, stirring ripples across the surface.

Xie Zheng's long fingers, marked with dark scabs, lifted a black Go piece and placed it on the board, instantly surrounding and cutting off his opponent's white pieces.

Xie Zhong held a white piece, scanning the board for a long while but finding no viable move left. He finally chuckled in defeat. "The Marquis's skills have improved again. This subordinate is no match."

The man seated across from him had left his hair unbound. Due to unhealed whip marks and reopened sword wounds, he wore only a thin inner garment beneath a loosely draped outer robe. His strikingly handsome face still bore traces of illness-induced pallor. A tickle rose in his throat, and he covered his mouth with a light cough before speaking: "Practice makes perfect."

With his repeatedly reopened sword wounds and the one hundred and eight lashes, Xie Zheng had been confined to bed for three full days before he could rise.

When the physician came to treat his injuries, he shook his head repeatedly, exclaiming that there wasn't a single patch of unblemished flesh left on Xie Zheng's back. An ordinary man would have died from the pain alone.

But Xie Zheng, perhaps tempered by years of warfare, possessed a battlefield-forged willpower. Though weakened, no amount of pain could render him unconscious.

Even as the physician used tweezers to painstakingly extract shreds of cloth embedded deep in his wounds, he remained fully awake—not uttering a single sound throughout. By the time the wounds were cleaned, the cold sweat from enduring the pain had soaked through the bedding beneath him.

Before leaving, the physician said these injuries would likely require ten to fifteen days of bed rest before he could rise. Yet Xie Zheng had managed to stand on his own after just three days of recovery.

Xie Zhong assumed his urgency to return stemmed from the message Gongsun Yin had sent on the first day of his recuperation—that palace eunuchs bearing official rewards and an imperial decree had arrived in Kangcheng. Gongsun Yin had claimed Xie Zheng was inspecting the borders, so the eunuchs waited in Kangcheng.

He said, "Border inspections take at least a month, sometimes several. With Gongsun temporarily managing the palace envoys, the Marquis need not hurry back before fully recovering."

Xie Zheng tossed the black piece back into its container, his phoenix eyes half-lidded with disinterest. "This Marquis hardly cares for the little emperor's decrees."

Xie Zhong pondered before asking, "Is it due to the changing situation in Chongzhou?"

"With Changxin Wang dead, breaching Chongzhou is only a matter of time. But He Jingyuan's sudden severe injury led the court to replace the commander mid-campaign. The morale in Jizhou's army has collapsed—likely no better than the rebels inside Chongzhou's walls." Xie Zheng's tone turned contemplative. "Who knows whether this was truly the little emperor's doing or Wei Yan's scheme."

He then countered, "Uncle Zhong, after He Jingyuan steps down, who among Wei Yan's faction could take over Jizhou's military power?"

Xie Zhong considered carefully before shaking his head. "Likely no one. His son Wei Xuan has courage but no strategy. Currently, the military authority over Jizhou and Chongzhou is prime territory for the Li and Wei factions to fight over. Wei Yan wouldn't be reckless enough to send the impulsive, easily provoked Wei Xuan to the Chongzhou front. The emperor promoted Tang Peiyi as commander. Though Tang Peiyi was promoted by

He Jingyuan, he's a true loyalist. With Jizhou's forces in Tang Peiyi's hands, the emperor must feel assured."

Xie Zheng said, "If Chongzhou falls, the military power of both Jizhou and Chongzhou will either fall into the hands of the Li faction or return to the young emperor. If Wei Yan wants to keep this piece of fat from being snatched away by others, he can only let the battle in Chongzhou remain deadlocked, slowly wearing down both sides. The Li family still has Li Huaian serving as the Army Supervisor in Chongzhou—sooner or later, they'll find a way to pin the blame on the Li faction."

Xie Zhong was startled. "Does the Marquis mean that Wei Yan might repeat what he did to you and He Jingyuan—deliberately creating flaws on the battlefield to frame the Li faction or Tang Peiyi, gradually reclaiming control over Jizhou's military power?"

Xie Zheng shook his head. "Wei Yan won't use the same trick a third time. Besides, if we can deduce Wei Yan's strategy, the strategists nurtured by the Li family aren't fools either—they wouldn't fail to see through it. Sui Yuanhuai is the imperial grandson who survived the fire in the Eastern Palace, and now he's allied with Grand Tutor Li's faction. Chongzhou is already in the Li family's grasp. To eliminate any future threats, they might even set a trap, deliberately luring Wei Yan into it."

At this point, Xie Zheng paused, his gaze turning colder by the second. "To ensure Wei Yan is thoroughly condemned, we must provoke the fury of both the officials and the common people. Tell me, Uncle Zhong—what could enrage the entire nation?"

After a moment of contemplation, Xie Zhong gasped in horror. "It could only be Wei Yan colluding with rebels and slaughtering loyal subjects. For this to escalate, the death toll must be high enough..."

He dared not continue, only muttering, "Grand Tutor Li surely wouldn't be so reckless..."

Xie Zheng said, "If they were merely fighting to the death in court, I wouldn't mind surrendering Jizhou and Chongzhou to them. But if they intend to sacrifice the lives of thousands of soldiers to fabricate a historic case for seizing power, I'd rather take the military authority into my own hands."

"After all... sooner or later, we'll have to tear into each other anyway."

Hearing this, Xie Zhong showed a faint trace of relief. "The Marquis upholds righteousness and does not disgrace the Xie family's integrity. If the General knew of this in the afterlife, he would be proud of you."

Xie Zheng did not respond. He leaned back slightly, his dark hair spilling over his shoulders as he gazed at the scenery beyond the pavilion amidst the dense shade of bamboo. "If only you had left the capital later back then, Uncle Zhong, and taken me back to Huizhou after my mother's passing."

Had he not spent over a decade recognizing a thief as his father, perhaps his heart would have suffered less.

Xie Zhong sighed at the memory. "After the General's death, the Madam was overwhelmed with grief, and her temperament changed drastically. We had originally intended to guard the Xie family's legacy in the capital after the General's passing. But the Madam, in her sorrow, often blamed us for failing to protect the General. Every time she saw us, she would weep so bitterly it nearly made her ill. The maidservants by her side eventually advised us to leave the capital."

He lowered his head, bitterness in his voice. "For the sake of the Madam's health, we returned to Huizhou. Yet not long after, we heard she had taken her own life to follow the General, and the Marquis was taken in by Wei Yan to be raised. As mere servants, we had no right to question our masters' decisions, so we remained at the Xie family estate in Huizhou."

Xie Zheng's back stiffened slightly. He asked, "Was it my mother... who sent you back to Huizhou?"

Xie Zhong hurriedly said, "Don't blame Madam. She was grieving and didn't know I had lost an arm and broken a leg at the time, so I couldn't follow the general to the Jinzhou battlefield. That's why she resented me for failing to protect him. I truly feel guilty too. Afraid that my presence in the capital would only bring her more sorrow, I chose to leave on my own."

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes as if deep in thought, remaining silent for a long while.

Outside the waterside pavilion, along the bamboo-lined path, a servant hurried over and stopped at the entrance. Bowing, he presented a letter and said, "Marquis, a letter from Gongsun."

Xie Zhong limped out of the pavilion, took the letter, and handed it to Xie Zheng. After reading it, a sudden surge of fury flashed in Xie Zheng's cold,

phoenix-like eyes.

Extreme rage choked his chest, forcing him to cover his mouth and cough softly. His voice, though quiet, was icy: "Prepare the carriage. We're returning to Kangcheng."

After days of anxious waiting, the eunuch sent to Kangcheng to deliver the imperial decree finally received news of Xie Zheng's return. Immediately, he led a grand procession to announce the decree and bestow the official rewards.

Standing outside the magistrate's residence where Xie Zheng was temporarily staying, the eunuch proclaimed loudly, "The imperial decree has arrived—"

The guards at the gate glanced at him before going inside to report. However, the expected scene of flustered yet delighted reception never materialized.

Gongsun Yin was famously good-natured, always ready with pleasant words to appease others, whether sincere or not. But those around Xie Zheng took after their master—none of them even bothered to put on a show.

The eunuch waited outside the gate for the time it took three incense sticks to burn before someone finally emerged. It wasn't Xie Zheng but a man in armor—likely just a personal guard.

The guard showed no fear as he addressed the eunuch: "The Marquis suffered minor injuries while suppressing bandits recently and is unable to come to the gate to receive you, Your Excellency. Please proceed to the front hall."

The eunuch's expression darkened instantly.

A young eunuch beside him, unaccustomed to such disrespect outside the palace, immediately pointed at the guard and snapped, "You—"

The decree-bearing eunuch raised a hand to stop him. This was Kangcheng, not the palace, and he knew better than to provoke trouble. With a forced smile, he said, "The Marquis's safety is paramount. This humble servant will announce the decree in the front hall. Please lead the way, young general."

The guard spared no further glance for the eunuch. "Follow me, Your Excellency."

The eunuch and his entourage entered the residence and headed for the front hall.

Outside, the sun was scorching, but the hall's design—crafted with ingenious skill—brought an immediate chill upon entry. The sudden shift from heat to cold sent an inexplicable shiver down the eunuch's spine.

Looking up at the raised seat, he saw a young man in a dark robe embroidered with gold and crimson threads lounging casually against the backrest. His face was like cold jade, his eyes a frozen pond.

Without his battle armor, he looked every bit the noble scion of a centuries-old aristocratic family.

Steeling himself, the eunuch announced loudly, "Wu'an Marquis, receive the decree—"

The man seated above remained unmoved. Even the adjutants flanking the steps stood rigid, their gazes fixed straight ahead.

The eunuch's unease grew, but he dared not offend Xie Zheng now. Forcing a smile, he said, "Marquis, please accept the decree. These are His Majesty's official rewards. Once you receive it, this old servant can return and report the completion of my task."

Xie Zheng half-raised his phoenix-like eyes and finally spoke slowly, "If you don't read this imperial decree, Eunuch, you can still claim the edict was never proclaimed upon returning to the capital. But if you read it and I refuse to accept it, do you know what that would mean?"

The decree-proclaiming eunuch was terrified by Xie Zheng's audacious words. Pointing at him, he exclaimed in shock and anger, "Defying an imperial decree? Wu... Wu'an Marquis, do you also intend to rebel?"

No sooner had these words left his mouth than armored soldiers, who had silently gathered outside the doors, surged in, surrounding the eunuch and his entourage.

Seeing this display, the eunuch's legs turned to jelly. His powdered face turned deathly pale as he blustered weakly, "Do you truly mean to rebel?"

Xie Zheng drew the sword from his lieutenant's side and descended step by step from the high platform. His black robes trailed over the steps, as if weighed down by an oppressive aura of bloodlust and malice.

The eunuch's legs gave way completely, and he collapsed to the ground.

Xie Zheng stopped three paces away from him. With the cold tip of his sword, he lightly tapped the eunuch's face, his phoenix eyes half-lidded as he spoke in an uncharacteristically patient tone, laced with indolence:

"The Xie family has served as loyal subjects of Great Yin for a hundred years. My father died a tragic death on the battlefield of Jinzhou seventeen years ago, earning a reputation of heroic martyrdom. I have no wish to tarnish his name, so for now, I'm still willing to play the part of a dutiful subject. Take a message back to that little emperor."

"If he's grown tired of sitting on that throne, this Marquis wouldn't mind finding someone to take his place."

"Seventeen years ago, Wei Yan could place him on the dragon throne. Today, this Marquis can just as easily pull him down."

The eunuch's mind reeled with shock. Pointing a trembling finger at Xie Zheng, he stammered in outrage, "You... the Xie family! Traitorous subjects!"

"Ah—"

In the next instant, the eunuch's screams echoed throughout the city lord's residence.

Xie Zheng had cleanly sliced off one of his ears.

Clutching the side of his head with one hand, the eunuch wailed incessantly as blood streamed through his fingers, quickly soaking a large portion of his sleeve. Seeing the bloody ear lying on the ground, he howled in pain, nearly fainting from the agony.

The young eunuch supporting him trembled like a leaf, his eyes fixed unblinkingly on the severed ear, unaware that he had wet himself in fear.

Xie Zheng tossed the sword to his personal guard who had followed him. Straightening lazily, he looked with disgust at the room full of wailing figures and uttered coldly, "Scram back and deliver my message."

Only then did the eunuch, supported by his attendants, scramble frantically toward the door.

Watching the retreating figures of the eunuch's party, the personal guard turned to Xie Zheng with concern. "Marquis, aren't you worried about how His Majesty might—"

Xie Zheng's gaze followed the eunuch's awkward figure, his eyes indifferent yet icy. "This Marquis does indeed intend to depose the emperor."

Chapter 111

Gongsun Yin heard about the imperial edict-bearing eunuch hastily fleeing Kang City and hurried to find Xie Zheng. Upon entering the study, he immediately said:

"That eunuch is the adopted son of Wang Xi, the Chief Steward of the Imperial Presence. He came here on the emperor's orders. By cutting off one of his ears, you've essentially slapped the emperor in the face. Are you truly prepared to sever ties with the court?"

Xie Zheng sat behind the desk, his left arm resting on the armrest of the yellow pearwood Grand Tutor chair. A military deployment map of Great Yin lay spread across the desk. His lips curled into a faint smile as he gazed at the map, but his eyes were icy. "That young emperor is still playing the fool under Wei Yan's thumb, and he already treats the lives of his generals on the battlefield as expendable. Do you really think he'll be any kinder once he truly holds power?"

Gongsun Yin was momentarily speechless. After a brief silence, he admitted frankly, "The emperor has been stripped of his authority for years, first by Wei Yan, then by Grand Tutor Li. In terms of endurance and temperament, he stands out among past emperors. But precisely because he's endured for over a decade, his hunger for imperial power must have reached its peak. There's likely little benevolence left in him—only an unyielding determination to reclaim his authority by any means."

Xie Zheng raised a brow. "Your judgment of people remains as sharp as ever."

With that, he tossed a thick stack of documents at him.

Gongsun Yin caught them with both hands. "What is this?"

Xie Zheng replied simply, "You'll understand once you read it."

Gongsun Yin opened the documents and scrutinized them, his frown deepening until anger was plain on his face. "Is all of this true?"

Xie Zheng answered, "Zhao Xun gave me this evidence to persuade me to support the imperial great-grandson."

Gongsun Yin flipped through the stack, his jaw tightening in fury. "The drought two years ago, the floods in Jiangnan last spring—how many died? The factional strife between Li and Wei was bad enough, but the inspectors sent by Grand Tutor Li concealed the true extent of the disaster just to let more people die so they could incriminate Wei Yan—and this was the emperor's doing? Back then, the Chengde Crown Prince gave his life in Jinzhou for the sake of thousands of soldiers and civilians. Now, the man sitting on the throne is willing to sacrifice hundreds of thousands of disaster victims to fuel his own ambitions?"

Two years prior, severe droughts in Guanzhong and floods in Jiangnan had nearly emptied the national treasury in relief funds. The silver passed through Wei Yan's subordinates, but the Li faction had at least sent inspectors along. Yet in the end, over half the victims still perished from starvation and disease.

The entire realm was outraged. The scholars led by Grand Tutor Li had publicly denounced the Wei Faction in court.

It was then that Wei Yan, pressured by the entire court and the people, suffered his first defeat against Grand Tutor Li. He sacrificed several of his own high-ranking officials to take the blame before the matter was settled.

But Wei Yan's reputation among the people was already as vile as that of Meng Shuyuan, the reviled traitor after the Jinzhou Massacre.

Xie Zheng's expression was frigid. "That old man from the Li family is no less ambitious than Wei Yan. But as a scholar, he fears the condemnation of the people more. The young emperor wants to use him to overthrow Wei Yan, but he's also wary that one day the emperor's blade might turn against the Li family. So while the emperor was powerless, he left himself a way out."

"The inspectors he sent to oversee disaster relief wrote eleven urgent reports to the capital. The courier stations in every prefecture have records of fast horses dispatched to the capital, but the palace has no record of receiving any disaster reports."

At this point, Gongsun Yin understood everything.

Deliberately concealing disaster reports, resulting in over half of the victims perishing, is a grave crime no matter when it is revisited.

The emperor wanted to firmly pin this blame on Grand Tutor Li, but the old fox had his subordinates deliver urgent reports to the capital. As for

why these reports never reached the palace—should the truth come to light later—the emperor and his minister would each tell their own version, leaving it to public judgment.

Gongsun Yin couldn't help but ask, "How did Zhao Xun obtain those urgent reports Grand Tutor Li's people sent to the palace?"

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze slightly: "Who do you think has been taking the fall for the young emperor in the palace?"

After a moment's thought, Gongsun Yin uttered a name: "Wang Xi?"

Xie Zheng remained silent, tacitly confirming.

Gongsun Yin quickly grasped the intricate web of interests. With imperial power in decline, no eunuch in the palace would stake everything on a single path.

That Wang Xi, having served as Chief Eunuch for years without offending Wei Yan while still enjoying the young emperor's trust, was clearly a man of remarkable cunning.

Using disaster relief to fabricate a major case as the first step to topple Wei Yan—the emperor wanted Grand Tutor Li to take the blame, while Grand Tutor Li sought to implicate the emperor. The urgent reports sent to the palace couldn't reach the young emperor, so Wang Xi had to intercept them all himself.

As long as the emperor and Grand Tutor Li remained united against external threats without exposing each other's secrets, he was safe.

When the emperor and Grand Tutor Li eventually clashed, he could side with the winner—a move with no downside.

If the young emperor won, he could destroy those eleven disaster reports, ensuring the blame fell squarely on Grand Tutor Li.

If Grand Tutor Li won, he could produce those reports and testify himself, providing irrefutable evidence of the young emperor's lack of virtue.

Even if Wei Yan ultimately prevailed, he could quickly present this evidence to restore Wei Yan's reputation by exposing how the young emperor and Grand Tutor Li had conspired against him.

After his initial anger subsided, Gongsun Yin felt a pang of sorrow. He sighed, "The waters of Great Yin's court have long been too murky to see

through."

The Wei Faction might be a pack of corrupt officials, but an emperor and Grand Tutor who would sacrifice hundreds of thousands of disaster victims to incite public outrage against Wei Yan were no better.

Turning to Xie Zheng, he said, "With the one on the throne so devoid of virtue, now scheming even in military affairs—I know you cannot pledge loyalty to such a ruler. But even if we cooperate with Zhao Xun to support the imperial great-grandson, who's to say in ten or twenty years he won't become just like this young emperor?"

Xie Zheng simply said, "I won't become another Wei Yan."

Gongsun Yin replied, "I know your aspirations differ from Wei Yan's. But even if you retreat to the northwest and withdraw from court affairs, as long as you retain military power, whoever sits on that throne will always covet it when they come of age."

This time Xie Zheng remained silent for a long while.

After standing quietly for a moment, Gongsun Yin sighed, "Enough—that's a worry for decades hence. For now..."

"If the new emperor proves benevolent and cares for the people, I would gladly return military power and live as a free man. The Xie family wasn't born to command armies. As long as someone continues guarding Great Yin's lands, I have no qualms about relinquishing authority."

Gongsun Yin's words were interrupted. Glancing sideways, he could only see the razor-sharp profile of the man seated in the Grand Tutor chair—handsome yet unyielding as forged steel.

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze slightly. "If he turns out like that little emperor, I can kick him off the dragon throne just as easily as I put him there, and choose a new one."

Gongsun Yin was momentarily stunned by these words before chuckling softly. "Indeed, that sounds more like you."

He abruptly changed the subject. "In her letter to me, the Grand Princess mentioned the little emperor intends to move against Miss Fan. It would be extremely dangerous for her to remain in Chongzhou. Should I send more men to protect her?"

Another wave of itchiness rose in his throat. Xie Zheng pressed his lips together to suppress the urge to cough. "Unnecessary."

Gongsun Yin's expression turned peculiar again.

He had assumed Xie Zheng's urgent return was due to receiving his letter, but apparently not?

Recalling Xie Shisan's latest report, he said with deliberate provocation, "Well, He Jingyuan may have left Chongzhou, but he sent his prized disciple there instead. That Zheng... Zheng something-wen. I hear he's not only handsome but also accomplished in both civil and martial arts. Most importantly, he led troops to rescue Miss Fan when Wei Yan's Martial Assassins pursued her in Lin'an Town. One might say he owes her a life debt now."

The thick wolf-hair brush handle snapped cleanly in Xie Zheng's grip, though his face remained impassive. "Leave."

Dissatisfied with this reaction, Gongsun Yin fanned the flames further. "Imagine them fighting side by side on the battlefield—countless life-and-death situations ahead. What's that phrase? Oh yes, 'proximity breeds affection'!"

Xie Zheng suddenly looked up at him. Gongsun Yin instinctively took a large step back.

But Xie Zheng showed no anger, only saying, "After three years away from the capital, the Grand Princess still knows your whereabouts. Is her network truly that formidable, or have you been deliberately revealing your location to someone?"

All traces of mockery vanished from Gongsun Yin's face as he regarded Xie Zheng with surprise. "Using that against me? You must be genuinely furious."

After Gongsun Yin left, Xie Zheng discarded the broken brush.

Tiny, sharp wood splinters had embedded in his fingertips. He removed them expressionlessly. The knife wounds and whip marks on his back still ached dully, yet the sharp, uncontrollable pain in his chest when hearing she might grow close to another—and the sudden urge to destroy everything—had been equally vivid.

He found he couldn't wait another moment.

When they parted, he'd known full well that a woman like her would find good men in this life even without him.

But when that moment truly arrived, he realized with startling clarity how his blood seemed to flow backward. In that instant, his mind screamed with nothing but boundless jealousy and murderous intent—yet his entire being remained eerily calm.

Within seconds, he'd even devised ways to make any man she favored disappear without a trace.

Coming to his senses brought only intense self-loathing, his palms slick with cold sweat.

He knew his sickness was worsening. He refused to become the kind of man he despised most.

Xie Zheng leaned back limply into the Grand Tutor chair, an arm draped over his eyes, shadowing most of his face. The dark archer's sleeves accentuated the sickly pallor of his jaw as an aura of gloom enveloped him.

Before Gongsun Yin arrived, the personal guard who had been instructed to prepare the troops entered the room, knelt on one knee with a fist salute, and reported, "Marquis, the carriages and horses for escorting Sui Yuanqing are ready. The army can depart at any time."

Xie Zheng responded somberly, "Let's go."

By the time Gongsun Yin belatedly received the news and rushed to the city wall to watch the departing army, he was so furious he nearly jumped three feet in the air. He fumed, "No wonder that scoundrel Xie Jiuhang said no additional troops were needed—he's already taken the whole army there! What's the point of sending more?"

Chongzhou.

After the death of Changxin Wang (Prince of Changxin), the Jizhou army clashed twice more with the rebels inside Chongzhou city, both times in small-scale skirmishes. Though these were only minor victories, they still managed to boost morale somewhat.

After Fan Changyu attended another strategy meeting in the central military tent, she received new orders—her vanguard unit would soon engage in a large-scale battle.

Whether it was Tang Peiyi deliberately arranging it due to He Jingyuan's earlier instructions or not, the officer assigned to support and coordinate with the vanguard happened to be Zheng Wenchang.

Chapter 112

Emerging from the central military tent, a young officer congratulated Fan Changyu: "The previous battles have already severely dampened the rebels' morale. With the death of Prince Changxin and the fall of Kang City, the rebel heir Sui Yuanqing was captured by the Marquis. There's no one left in Chongzhou capable of putting up a fight. If you breach the city gates tomorrow and claim this first merit, we'll be left even further behind in your dust."

Though seemingly flattering, there was an undercurrent of sourness in his words.

Fan Changyu's standing in the army was still shallow. Having earned her superiors' favor through several remarkable feats, many officers, while not voicing it openly, secretly harbored some envy.

Fan Changyu simply replied, "It's all due to the battle strategies devised day and night by General Tang and Lord Li. We merely charge into battle with courage—how can we speak of first merit? You flatter me too much, General."

By invoking Tang Peiyi and Li Huaian's authority, the young officer dared not say more, offering only an awkward smile of agreement.

Li Huaian emerged from the tent shortly after, having likely overheard part of their conversation. With a smile, he said, "All you generals have fought valiantly. His Majesty and General Tang have seen and taken note of your efforts. The peace of Great Yin still relies on your service."

The phrase "seen and taken note of" visibly altered the young officer's expression, fearing his earlier remarks might have offended Li Huaian. He clasped his fists repeatedly in agreement.

Fan Changyu also saluted with a composed demeanor, neither submissive nor arrogant.

Li Huaian glanced at her but said nothing further, only adding, "With the decisive battle imminent, all generals should rest and conserve their strength. Tomorrow, we must take Chongzhou without fail."

Fan Changyu saluted again with the others and prepared to return to her tent.

After walking some distance, she noticed Li Huaian following her at a measured pace, as if merely strolling coincidentally in the same direction.

During the strategy meeting in the central tent, personal guards were not permitted inside. While other generals had come alone, Fan Changyu had not brought Xiao Wu to wait outside, leaving her unaccompanied now.

Being straightforward by nature, she frowned slightly before stopping abruptly and turning to ask directly, "My lord, do you have orders for this subordinate?"

Li Huaian, caught off guard by her sudden question, paused momentarily before shaking his head with a wry smile. "First 'my lord,' then 'this subordinate'—you grow more distant with each meeting."

Fan Changyu replied, "Propriety must be observed."

Li Huaian's expression sobered, and he suddenly asked, "Do you address the Marquis the same way in his presence?"

Fan Changyu remained silent.

Realizing his lapse, Li Huaian frowned more deeply, perhaps annoyed at himself—usually so composed—for such a remark. "My words were improper. Miss Fan, please do not take offense..."

At this, Fan Changyu lifted her head, her gaze steady and calm. "The Marquis is of noble standing. This subordinate naturally cannot neglect propriety either."

This time, Li Huaian's pause lasted longer.

Fan Changyu said, "If my lord has no further instructions, this subordinate will take her leave."

Li Huaian stopped her. "You resent me over Lord He's matter, don't you?"

Fan Changyu replied, "This subordinate wouldn't dare."

Li Huaian studied her for a long moment. He stood where the shadow of a tent fell, half his robes fluttering gently in the moonlight while his features remained obscured in darkness. Without his usual mask of refined amiability, he seemed more genuine.

He said, "The secret guarded by Miss Fan's parents might be the key to overthrowing Wei Yan. Wei Yan has been usurping imperial power for years. Only by eradicating the Wei Faction can we restore clarity to Great Yin's court. While Lord He chose loyalty and kept it hidden, Huaian cannot. If Miss Fan resents this, Huaian has no other choice."

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and replied, "You overstate the matter, my lord. You act with impartial justice, and this humble general has no right to comment. But you used me to uncover Lord He's faults, causing my benefactor to fall into this predicament, yet still expect me to harbor no resentment? Truly, my lord makes it difficult for me."

Li Huaian seemed surprised by her words. "So you already knew," he said.

Fan Changyu remained silent.

The night wind stirred his wide Confucian robes, outlining his bamboo-like figure. His voice carried a sigh-like softness: "Wei Yan's Martial Assassins all perished in Miss Fan's home. When I was ordered to investigate this in Jizhou, our 'chance encounter' on the mountain path was staged. But today, my desire to sincerely befriend Miss Fan is genuine. No matter how Wei Yan moves against you, the Li family will ensure your safety."

Fan Changyu simply said, "For the Li family's great kindness, this general shall repay in due time."

Though she spoke of repayment, the Li family's protection surely served their own purpose against Wei Yan.

To Li Huaian's ears, her words sounded both shameful and somewhat laughable.

Seeing her so distantly and politely drawing boundaries with the Li family, Li Huaian couldn't quite name the feeling in his chest—only that it sat uncomfortably.

As if struck by a thought, he suddenly added, "Miss Fan should also be wary of that eunuch from the palace."

Fan Changyu asked, "Does His Majesty mean to act against me?"

Li Huaian explained, "The matter of Lord He sheltering your parents for seventeen years hasn't yet reached His Majesty. But an imperial decree has been issued for the Marquis's marriage to the princess. Given rumors

that the Marquis once shared hardship as your husband, the princess might take offense..."

He left the rest unsaid, but the implication was clear.

Fan Changyu abruptly asked, "If I weren't a serving military officer but just a common woman—would I already be dead?"

Li Huaian's silence seemed confirmation.

In a voice thick with disbelief, she murmured, "Does royal birth grant license to treat common lives as ants?"

At this news, beyond the ache of Xie Zheng's betrothal, came a sudden fog obscuring her path forward.

To common folk, the emperor was the very sky above.

Fan Changyu had once pinned hopes on vindicating her grandfather—that through military merit, she might plead his case before the golden halls as in operas, where wrongs were righted and justice served.

Yet reality diverged sharply from those tales. Where operas portrayed impartial judges and emperors, real rulers had private designs. That distant throne's occupant, ignorant of her grievances, would see her dead merely for potentially troubling a royal wedding.

Noting her pallor, Li Huaian wished to offer comfort. But words that risked heads couldn't yet be spoken. He pledged instead: "For seventeen years Old General Meng has borne infamy. If Wei Yan wrought this, the Li family will see justice done for him."

He didn't elaborate much about her father, seemingly also tacitly acknowledging that her father was Wei Yan's man, who had once helped Wei Yan frame her maternal grandfather.

Fan Changyu only numbly expressed her thanks before saying she was tired and needed to return to camp to rest.

Li Huaian watched her retreating figure for a long time, lost in thought, then murmured to himself as if speaking to no one, "What a fool I was—why did I have to tell her about the emperor's marriage decree at this moment?"

Perhaps... it was simply because he couldn't stand her polite yet distant attitude toward him.

But after telling her, seeing the sudden surge of sorrow in her eyes, he didn't feel any better either.

In the end, Li Huaian laughed at himself mockingly—

After returning, Fan Changyu had never felt so exhausted before. Her entire body felt heavy, as if all the fatigue of the past month had accumulated at this very moment.

Lying down on the military cot in her clothes, even breathing felt laborious. A suffocating sensation enveloped her, making her feel as though she had sunk into a swamp, dragging her limbs down with an inescapable weight.

She turned her head and glanced at the deerskin bracers tied to her sleeve. After untying them, she hesitated to throw them away, ultimately placing them on the low stool by the bed where clothes were kept. Suppressing the dull ache in her chest from the effort of breathing, she exhaled deeply before covering her eyes with one hand and falling asleep.

There was a tough battle to fight tomorrow—she needed proper rest.

But the shaky breaths in the darkness betrayed her emotions. The moisture that slipped from the corners of her eyes into her hairline gathered until it soaked the pillow.

When he had left that day, his words had been so clear and so final. The emperor's marriage decree meant he could gain more power to deal with Wei Yan by marrying the princess. For him, it was a good thing—he likely wouldn't refuse.

She had already seen everything so clearly, yet she couldn't control the sorrow in her heart at this moment.

Fan Changyu kept her hand over her eyes, silently telling herself that she was only allowed to grieve for this one night. After tonight, that man's affairs would have nothing to do with her anymore.

The emperor was no good ruler in her eyes, but the common people shouldn't have to endure more war because of it. She would fight tomorrow's battle well.

Besides, it was precisely because she had become a military official in the court that the emperor dared not openly move against her. She needed to be wary of the eunuch the emperor had placed in the army and climb higher.

The advisors she had hired had explained the current power balance in the court. The emperor wanted so badly to eliminate Wei Yan, yet all state affairs still had to go through him—because Wei Yan held too much power.

Those who could be easily erased were simply those who didn't hold enough power.

Even now, Fan Changyu still didn't like fighting for so-called power. But if it meant protecting her own life and those around her, she would fight tooth and nail for it—

The next day, when Fan Changyu woke up, her eyes were predictably swollen.

Xie Wu was taken aback at the sight of her. "Commander, you..."

Without blinking, Fan Changyu lied smoothly, "There were too many mosquitoes last night. Got bitten near the eye."

Xie Wu opened his mouth, then closed it again, only nodding in agreement. "Yeah, the mosquitoes are terrible."

Fan Changyu no longer wore the deerskin bracers Xie Zheng had given her before. With one hand, she fastened the iron vambrace that matched her armor and said, "Select a few from the dozens of men I personally trained and assign them to Changning's side under Xiao Qi's command. Have them escort Changning and Aunt Zhao back to Jizhou."

Xie Wu keenly sensed something amiss: "Commander, are you worried Miss Changning might be in danger?"

Fan Changyu didn't hide it from Xie Wu but didn't elaborate either, simply stating, "Better safe than sorry."

Both Wei Yan and the emperor viewed her as a thorn in their side.

Fan Changyu wasn't afraid of them coming after her, but she feared they might resort to underhanded tactics against Changning.

Once she was on the battlefield, she would be stretched too thin. For now, Jizhou was still He Jingyuan's territory, so sending Changning and Aunt Zhao back there would be relatively safer for them.

Taking her words to heart, Xie Wu didn't hesitate and immediately went to make arrangements.

Returning to the battlefield, this time as the vanguard commander, Fan Changyu felt little fear but a heavy weight on her shoulders.

So many lives were entrusted to her. She wanted not only to win this battle but also to ensure that even the nameless foot soldiers could return home alive.

Tens of thousands of troops had Chongzhou City surrounded on all sides.

Fan Changyu was responsible for attacking the eastern gate. The cavalry and infantry under her command had trained and fought in minor skirmishes during this time, their coordination now seamless.

But as she led the vanguard toward the eastern gate, entering the rebels' archery range, the Chongzhou soldiers on the battlements appeared panicked. Only a few attempted to shoot arrows, and even they struggled to draw their bows.

Behind these soldiers, several taller men brandished whips, lashing at them. Some soldiers even knelt, seemingly begging for mercy.

From her galloping warhorse, Fan Changyu gazed at the battlements, a trace of confusion flickering in her eyes.

The archers behind her, now within range, heard their officer shout, "Loose arrows!"

A hail of arrows rained down on the rebel soldiers atop the walls, eliciting cries of agony. A chaotic scramble ensued among the Chongzhou-clad soldiers along the narrow parapet walkway, with none even thinking to use the battlements for cover.

Someone on the wall wailed desperately, "Don't shoot! We're just civilians from the city—"

The next moment, the pleading man was beheaded by a vicious Chongzhou soldier behind him.

But the Chongzhou soldiers overseeing these civilians seemed few in number. More and more people on the walls, despite the pressure from the soldiers, cried out that they weren't Chongzhou troops but merely civilians forcibly conscripted.

Fan Changyu sharply pulled the reins, her horse rearing up with a whinny. She raised a hand to halt the archers and shouted, "Aim for the Chongzhou soldiers at the back!"

Xie Wu, riding beside her as both bodyguard and signal officer, immediately relayed the order through flag signals.

Amid the deafening clamor of battle, verbal commands were hard to hear, but flag signals were unmistakable.

The archers ceased their volleys and instead took careful aim at the sturdier soldiers on the walls.

With most of the battlements manned by untrained civilians, Fan Changyu and her elite troops crossed the perilous archery range with little difficulty.

Upon reaching the base of the city wall, as the siege ladders were set against the battlements, the true Chongzhou soldiers seemed to panic, frantically whipping the civilians to force them to lift stones and hurl them downward.

Fan Changyu pressed close to the wall, dodging falling rocks and logs as she shouted upward, "People of Chongzhou on the walls, listen! You were forced into this. The court will not punish you once the city falls. The rebels are doomed. If you aid the imperial army in battle, you will be rewarded based on your merits after the city is taken!"

The civilians forced onto the walls had been driven there at swordpoint. They dared not resist the Chongzhou soldiers, partly out of ingrained fear of authority and partly because, with the imperial army at their gates, they feared being executed as rebels alongside them.

After Fan Changyu's words, though most remained timid, a few brave souls roared and seized weapons from the rebel soldiers, turning them against their oppressors.

As chaos erupted atop the walls, the Jizhou troops below found it easier to scale the ladders and attack.

Once Fan Changyu climbed up, she cut down several Chongzhou soldiers like vegetables. Seeing how few defenders remained at the rear of the wall, she realized something was terribly wrong. Scanning the area, she spotted a fully armored officer attempting to flee. Fan Changyu hacked through the soldiers blocking her path and, before she could reach him, hurled her eight-foot black iron blade at him.

The officer was struck in the leg, howling in pain. When he tried to push the heavy blade off his wounded limb, the movement only worsened his

agony.

By then, Fan Changyu had caught up. She planted a foot on his injured leg and picked up the Horse-Cutting Sword with one hand, demanding, "Where is the eldest son of the Prince of Changxin?"

The officer wailed, "My leg... my leg..."

Fan Changyu eased the pressure slightly and barked, "Speak!"

With Chongzhou's fall imminent, the officer abandoned all pretense and confessed, "The young master left through the city gates last night."

Fan Changyu's expression darkened. Pressing the sword's tip to his throat, she snapped, "You're lying!"

The officer begged, "Madam, whether I'm lying or not, you can see how few soldiers remain in the city. That can't be faked!"

It was true. The eastern gate, Chongzhou's main entrance, was barely manned by a mix of soldiers and civilians in uniform—clearly something was amiss.

Fan Changyu's face twisted in frustration. "All four gates were heavily guarded. How could the rebels have escaped the city?"

The officer pleaded, "The main rebel force withdrew through the western gate last night. Where the western gate guards went, I truly don't know!"

Realizing she'd get no more useful information from the rebel officer, Fan Changyu had him bound and immediately sent scouts to report to Tang Peiyi.

The rebels' silent escape through the western gate last night was no small matter.

Beyond each of the four gates, well out of range of the wall's arrows and catapults, five thousand imperial troops were stationed.

For the Prince of Changxin's eldest son to slip away with his army, he'd have needed wings or the ability to tunnel underground.

Fan Changyu's mind raced like tangled threads. She left Xie Wu in charge at the gate, strictly ordering the Jizhou troops entering the city not to harass civilians. Seizing a Chongzhou soldier to act as a guide, she led a contingent to storm the Changxin Prince Manor.

Upon arrival, they found only servants remaining in the manor. After interrogating several, all claimed Sui Yuanhuai had fled the previous night.

Fan Changyu couldn't find Yu Qianqian and Yu Bao'er. After interrogating some servants, she learned that several months ago, Sui Yuanhuai had indeed brought back a mother and child. The woman's surname was Yu, but they didn't know her full name. They only knew she was Sui Yuanhuai's concubine, and the child was born after she had fled.

Hearing this result, Fan Changyu remained silent for a long while.

After collecting herself, she ordered her soldiers to detain the people from Changxin Prince Manor and sat alone in the room, lost in thought.

She had been slow to realize. Ever since Changning mentioned encountering Yu Bao'er at Changxin Prince Manor, she should have guessed that Yu Qianqian's identity wasn't simple.

Though she hadn't known Yu Qianqian for long, it was clear she was a woman of strong will. If she had fled before, she likely hadn't willingly become Sui Yuanhuai's concubine.

The current problem was that both she and Yu Bao'er had been captured by Sui Yuanhuai, and the servants in the manor all knew he had a son.

Fan Changyu worried that if Sui Yuanhuai were eventually captured, Yu Bao'er would also be implicated.

Rebellion was a crime punishable by the extermination of one's entire clan.

A knock at the door interrupted her thoughts.

"Commandant, General Tang has led the army into the city and urgently summons you for a meeting," came Xie Wu's voice.

Fan Changyu replied, "Understood. I'll go immediately."

When Fan Changyu arrived at the meeting hall, the atmosphere was predictably tense.

Tang Peiyi sat at the head with a grim expression, while the officers below kept their heads bowed. Fan Changyu also lowered her head and took her place at the back of the line.

However, her late arrival had caught Tang Peiyi's attention. He addressed her directly, "Commandant Fan, I heard you went to search

Changxin Prince Manor after the city fell. Did you find anything?"

Fan Changyu stepped forward and saluted. "Reporting to the General, only about a hundred servants remained in the manor. They all claimed that the eldest son of Changxin Wang had left the city last night. I have ordered the manor sealed and all the servants temporarily detained."

This news did little to improve Tang Peiyi's mood. He waved his hand dismissively, signaling for her to step back.

As soon as Fan Changyu returned to her place, Tang Peiyi overturned the table before him. The teacups and the low table crashed to the ground, shattering porcelain flying everywhere. Everyone in the room was startled, holding their breath even more.

Everyone knew how absurd this was.

The rebel army, numbering tens of thousands, had openly abandoned the city after being besieged. The battle report to be sent to the capital would be difficult to write.

If the Emperor were angered, it was uncertain whether Tang Peiyi, the newly appointed commander of the Jizhou army, could keep his head.

Li Huaian entered the hall and, seeing the scene, calmly said, "General Tang, there's no need for anger. We've already uncovered the full story of how the rebels escaped through the west gate last night."

Tang Peiyi finally looked up. "What happened?"

Li Huaian replied, "Commandant Lu Dayi, who was stationed at the west gate, was an old acquaintance of one of Changxin Wang's advisors. They had been secretly in contact all along. The military achievements Lu Dayi claimed in previous battles were all due to the advisor leaking the rebels' troop deployments. Last night, after you finalized the plan to attack the city today, the advisor wrote a letter of surrender and, along with a map of Chongzhou's defenses, tied it to an arrow and shot it outside Lu Dayi's camp. This was his pledge of allegiance, promising to open the city gate at midnight to help Lu Dayi take Chongzhou without a fight and claim the first merit."

Tang Peiyi was so furious his eyes nearly turned red, shouting sharply, "That fool actually believed it?"

Li Huaian nodded slowly with a heavy expression. "Lu Dayi, eager to claim the first merit, feared the movement of troops would alert the scouts,

so he withdrew the scouts near the west gate. At night, he led the guards outside the west gate to secretly enter the city with that advisor, only to be ambushed by rebel arrows in the dark alleys. The rebels then seized the opportunity to escape the city."

"Lu Dayi had an advisor by his side who, upon seeing that letter last night, urged him not to take such a risk. Lu Dayi thought the advisor was cowardly and feared he might ruin his plans, so he had the man tied up and left in his tent. It was only when I led men to investigate the west gate that we discovered him."

Tang Peiyi took the letter of surrender written by the advisor to Lu Dayi, handed over by Li Huaian, and cursed loudly: "Lu Dayi deserved to die! That incompetent fool who ruins everything! Who could possibly shoulder such a colossal disaster for him?"

Li Huaian lifted his amber-colored eyes and said ambiguously, "Lu Dayi was recommended by the Prime Minister."

Hearing this, Tang Peiyi slammed the armrest of the Grand Tutor chair with even greater force. The sturdy chair instantly shattered into splinters. "That Wei Yan harbors treacherous ambitions! Lord He entrusted the military power of Jizhou to me, yet Lu Dayi was so eager to claim merit—was he trying to seize back Jizhou's military power for Wei Yan?"

Furious, he turned back to the table, grinding his teeth. "Even if I have to risk my life, Wei Yan won't escape unscathed!"

Li Huaian lowered his eyes and said, "The immediate priority is to locate the rebels' next hideout."

Tang Peiyi blurted out almost without thinking: "Lucheng! If the rebels head further north, they'll run straight into the Xie Family Army under Wu'an Marquis—that would be suicide. Changxin Wang's consort's hometown, Kangcheng, has already been taken by Wu'an Marquis. The rebels can only move south now. Between Taizhou and Jizhou, Taizhou's troops haven't mobilized, but Jizhou's forces have all been dispatched to Chongzhou. If they breach Lucheng, the gateway to Jizhou, the rebels can march south unimpeded!"

His teeth chattered uncontrollably: "Dispatch troops to Lucheng immediately."

Li Huaian shook his head. "The rebels set out at midnight last night. Even at full speed, our main forces likely won't catch up. We must first

send scouts to deliver the message, then dispatch cavalry for support."

Tang Peiyi, frantic with urgency, quickly agreed: "Yes, yes, we'll follow your suggestion, Nephew."

Zheng Wenchang, a native of Jizhou and personally trained by He Jingyuan, immediately stepped forward: "General, I request permission to lead the cavalry back to Lucheng for reinforcements!"

Fan Changyu knew He Jingyuan's injuries likely rendered him unfit for battle. Moreover, since she had sent Xie Qi to escort Changning and the others back to Jizhou earlier that morning, she feared they might encounter the rebel army on the road. She also stepped forward: "I too am willing to reinforce Jizhou."

Tang Peiyi glanced at the two of them, aware of their exceptional martial skills and their deep respect for He Jingyuan, and immediately ordered: "You two will lead three thousand cavalry to Lucheng!"

At that moment, a shrill voice came from outside: "Wait—"

The eunuch who had earlier delivered the imperial edict, supported by a younger eunuch, slowly crossed the threshold and entered.

Li Huaian's brow twitched at the sight of him.

Tang Peiyi, already overwhelmed, couldn't muster a pleasant expression. "What instructions does the Eunuch have for us?"

The edict-bearing eunuch's heavily powdered face creased into a stiff smile. "When His Majesty sent me to console the troops of Jizhou, he also bestowed upon me the title of Army Supervisor. Surely, General Tang can heed my words here?"

This was a blatant assertion of authority—the Army Supervisor held oversight power in the military. Tang Peiyi had no choice but to grit his teeth: "Of course, Eunuch. But the military situation is urgent, and I truly..."

"It's precisely because of the urgent military situation that I've made this special trip," the eunuch interrupted Tang Peiyi.

When his gaze swept over Fan Changyu, she felt as if she'd been brushed by a serpent's tail—that cold, slimy sensation was both nauseating and terrifying.

Recalling Li Huaian's words to her the night before, Fan Changyu wondered if this damned eunuch was setting some kind of trap for her now.

Sure enough, the eunuch drawled in the next moment: "General Tang, your tens of thousands of troops have besieged Chongzhou City for days. Capturing the rebels should have been as easy as catching turtles in a jar, yet it's come to this. Sending three thousand cavalry to Lucheng—who knows if they'll even catch up with the rebels? And even if they do, can three thousand men really defeat nearly twenty thousand rebel troops?"

His wrinkled eyelids drooped lazily as he spoke with detached leisure: "This frontline situation must be reported to His Majesty immediately, so the Ministry of War can deploy troops to prepare defenses south of Jizhou."

Hearing the eunuch's implication that Jizhou couldn't be held, Tang Peiyi could barely contain his anger. He replied coldly: "If the Eunuch wishes to return to the capital and report to His Majesty, by all means do so. This general will lead my subordinate generals to reinforce Lucheng at all costs."

The eunuch smiled as if hearing a joke: "General Tang's loyalty to the throne is commendable. I'll put in a good word for you before His Majesty. But if I travel back alone and encounter rebels, I'm afraid this message won't reach the Emperor."

Then he revealed his true purpose: "General Tang, assign two thousand of your cavalry to escort me back to the capital to deliver my report."

Tang Peiyi's eyes nearly bulged from their sockets: "Two thousand? If I give you two thousand men, what will I have left to reinforce Lucheng?"

The eunuch raised his eyelids lazily: "General Tang, you're deceiving yourself by pretending Jizhou hasn't fallen yet. Tell me—if Jizhou is lost, what can your three thousand cavalry accomplish in Lucheng? Give me two thousand, and I'll take the Taizhou detour back to the capital. At least the message will get through first."

Tang Peiyi roared: "Go back and report if you wish—no one's stopping you! But you won't get two thousand of my cavalry!"

The eunuch snorted, his smile vanishing: "Tang Peiyi, are you defying an imperial decree?"

Blinded by rage, Tang Peiyi couldn't even bother with diplomatic language for this powdered fop: "Today I defy it! You rootless coward—keep your palace intrigues in the capital! Bring that nonsense here, and I'll kill you today, then report you died at rebel hands! What can you do about it?"

His bandit-like ferocity actually cowed the eunuch.

Li Huaian chose this moment to intervene: "General Tang, don't act rashly."

Tang Peiyi shoved Li Huaian aside and barked at Fan Changyu and Zheng Wenchang: "You two—march your troops to Lucheng immediately!"

Knowing the current crisis was beyond their capabilities, Fan Changyu realized holding Lucheng would absolve Tang Peiyi of blame and spare Jizhou's civilians from war. She and Zheng Wenchang immediately clasped fists and departed.

Behind them, the eunuch still shouted: "Tang Peiyi! How dare you treat an imperial envoy this way—"

Tang Peiyi glanced back at the eunuch and ordered his men, "Tie him up! Throw him into the corpse pile—let him see how many have died in this battle!"

His eyes burned with fury as he glared at the eunuch, jaw clenched. "The letter will be sent back to the capital, but you, sir, shall remain here with my fallen soldiers!"

With that, he roared, "Army, march out!"

After Tang Peiyi left the hall, Li Huaian watched the trussed-up eunuch being dragged away, his expression unreadable. Catching up to Tang Peiyi, he said, "General Tang, why must you go this far?"

The towering man's eyes reddened once more from the day's events. "Nephew, look at us—risking our lives for peace, while those around His Majesty play with words."

He grinned bitterly. "Don't mistake me for despising scholars. Since ancient times, pretty words have always come from their mouths. Whether they have integrity or not, I wouldn't know. But the bones on the battlefield, drenched in blood—will posterity even remember their names?"

"That castrated fool thinks Jizhou is surely lost. But I know Lord He—he'll hold out until reinforcements arrive, even with his last breath."

"And those two lads leading the cavalry vanguard—they're fearless. Every moment they buy us increases our chances."

Li Huaian thought of the grand scheme his grandfather and the imperial heir had devised to topple Wei Yan, and a wave of guilt surged within him. "Even if Jizhou falls, it may not be so dire. We can always retake it."

Tang Peiyi fixed him with a stern gaze. "How can war be treated so lightly? Remember how many years and how much Great Yin blood it took to reclaim Jinzhou after it fell to foreign invaders?"

Just then, a personal guard hurried over and saluted. "General, the army has set out. Your warhorse is ready!"

Tang Peiyi turned to Li Huaian. "I entrust Chongzhou to you, nephew."

As Li Huaian watched his broad-backed figure stride away, his emotions churned violently.

Barring unforeseen circumstances, Sui Yuanhuai had already taken Jizhou by now.

He wasn't worried about the civilians there—he knew Sui Yuanhuai was the imperial heir and wouldn't slaughter innocents.

This was all a performance. A battle they should have won effortlessly had gone awry because Wei Yan's men bungled things, allowing the rebels to escape grain-starved Chongzhou and seize Jizhou.

Not only would the court rage, but the entire realm would be incensed. Wei Yan would become the target of universal condemnation.

Soon, Jizhou would be retaken, the "rebels" brought to justice, and a full confession extracted—revealing that their escape from Chongzhou wasn't due to Wei Yan's men overreaching for merit, but a covert deal: Wei Yan helped them break through Chongzhou's blockade, and in return, they prolonged the conflict to delay the recall of his military authority.

As for Lu Dayi's death? Naturally, Wei Yan had silenced him.

To make this play convincing enough, they had to keep pawns like Tang Peiyi in the dark. Only with enough deaths could the scandal reach the necessary magnitude.

Perhaps influenced by Tang Peiyi's words, Li Huaian suddenly felt profoundly unsettled.

A question gnawed at him: Was orchestrating this scheme to overthrow Wei Yan right—or wrong?

Once he had believed that as long as Wei Yan controlled the court politics of Great Yin, the dynasty would have no future until he was removed.

To eliminate this treacherous minister, what did political maneuvers in court matter? Over the years, their Li family had risen in power, sacrificing countless lives to oppose Wei Yan. So why did he now feel guilt over the deaths of those soldiers?

Their deaths would topple Wei Yan and bring a better life to the people.

Sacrificing the few for the greater good—was that truly wrong?

Li Huaian closed his eyes, unwilling to dwell on it further.

A carriage traveled along the winding mountain road, while a snow-white Gyrfalcon circled high in the sky.

When the carriage passed by the river at the mountain's base, it came to a stop. A young man went to fetch water but misstepped, tumbling onto his back.

The other young men guarding the carriage burst into laughter.

Grimacing, the youth scrambled to his feet and noticed traces of smoke hidden beneath the weeds. He muttered, "Why would there be a cooking pit here by the riverbank?"

Spotting more areas where weeds had been deliberately arranged to conceal something, he kicked them aside one by one, revealing numerous cooking pits. Scratching his head, he said, "Strange. So many pits—how many people must have cooked here?"

A small head peeked out from the carriage. Changning, cradling a fluffy yellow duckling, asked excitedly, "Are we cooking now?"

The young man was one of the personal guards Fan Changyu had sent to protect Changning and Aunt Zhao—the same one who had entrusted his money to her before his first battle. His name was Qin Yong.

Glancing at the sun, he chuckled. "At least we won't have to dig pits here."

Xie Qi, seated on the carriage shaft some distance from the riverbank, hadn't seen the pits yet. But when Qin Yong mentioned their abundance, his instincts sharpened. He jumped down and asked, "How many are there?"

Qin Yong counted them. "Just here, there are seven or eight, all covered with weeds."

Having served as a scout in the army, Xie Qi was more attuned to environmental clues. He walked along the river valley and, after finding cooking pits extending for over a mile on both sides, declared with certainty, "An army of at least ten thousand passed through here."

The other guards tensed. Hesitantly, one asked, "The rebels are trapped in Chongzhou, and General Tang is leading the Jizhou army to crush them. Where would another large force come from now?"

Xie Qi didn't answer. Instead, he tested the warmth of the ashes in one pit and murmured, "The embers are cold. It's nearly noon now—armies don't cook at night, so it must have been this morning."

Qin Yong, the guard who had fetched water, asked, "Could it be the Marquis, leading troops from Kangcheng to Chongzhou?"

Xie Qi stood up. "Taking this route from Kangcheng to Chongzhou would be a detour."

His expression darkened. Returning to the carriage, he swiftly wrote something on paper, rolled it into a small scroll, and whistled sharply at the Gyrfalcon soaring above. The bird swooped down.

After slipping the note into the metal tube fastened to its leg, Xie Qi stroked its feathers and said, "Go find our master."

With a powerful flap of its wings, the Gyrfalcon ascended back into the sky.

Qin Yong watched the scene with immense envy. The white Gyrfalcon that had been following them in the sky was exceptionally fierce, and none of them dared approach it except for this brother called Xie Qi.

He asked, "Did you send the Gyrfalcon to find the Commandant?"

Before Xie Qi could respond, Changning pouted and asked, "Uncle Xie Qi, where did you send the falcon?"

Xie Qi reassured Changning, "The Gyrfalcon will return after delivering a message."

Qin Yong grew even more excited, his admiration for Fan Changyu soaring to new heights: "It really went to find the Commandant? I never imagined the Commandant would raise such a formidable bird of prey."

Xie Qi, recalling how Xie Wu had mentioned Fan Changyu's special attention to this young soldier on the battlefield—even giving him a breastplate—couldn't help but coolly reply, "The Gyrfalcon went to deliver a message to our Commandant's husband."

The young men all perked up their ears.

Qin Yong stammered, "The... the Commandant is married?"

Xie Qi lifted his eyelids and said, "Of course."

A nearby soldier curiously asked, "What kind of person is the Commandant's husband? Is he also in our army?"

Another soldier eagerly interjected, "He is! I heard from the brothers who went to reinforce First Line Gorge that the Commandant joined the army to search for her husband after he was conscripted."

The others clamored, "Really? Is that true?"

Xie Qi nodded coolly yet proudly, as if basking in reflected glory. "How could it be false?"

The other soldiers then pressed the one who seemed to know more details about Fan Changyu's husband.

That soldier said, "I heard the Commandant's husband was badly injured in the battle at First Line Gorge and is now half-paralyzed."

The soldiers sighed in sympathy, privately lamenting Fan Changyu's tragic fate.

Xie Qi, who had just taken a sip of water from his canteen, nearly choked to death.

Even Aunt Zhao inside the carriage couldn't help but scold, "What nonsense are you spouting!"

Qin Yong and the others didn't know who this elderly woman was to Fan Changyu, but seeing how respectfully Xie Qi treated her, they all ducked their heads and accepted the reprimand.

Though young, Changning understood that the "husband" they were talking about was her brother-in-law. She clung to the carriage window and looked up at Aunt Zhao, asking, "Auntie, what does 'half-paralyzed' mean?"

Aunt Zhao spat twice before explaining, "It means he's a cripple."

Changning immediately defended Xie Zheng: "My brother-in-law is not a cripple!"

The soldier who had spoken earlier scratched the back of his head awkwardly. "I... I just heard it from others in the army."

Aunt Zhao, unaware of the subsequent events between Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng, worried that with Fan Changyu's rising rank, people around her might start having ulterior motives. She liked Xie Qi precisely because he was honest, capable, and free of such scheming.

To prevent Xie Zheng from being cast aside as a discarded spouse, she deliberately spoke up in front of everyone: "Changyu's husband is a fine-looking man, well-educated, and skilled in martial arts."

Qin Yong, being simple-minded, figured that if the Commandant was so capable, her husband must be impressive too, as Aunt Zhao described. He blurted out, "Then the Commandant's husband must be a captain or general too?"

Aunt Zhao didn't know Xie Zheng's military rank, but recalling that when he last visited, he hadn't even held a position as high as Fan Changyu's squad leader, she didn't dare exaggerate. Lowering her eyes, she focused on amusing Changning and didn't answer.

Qin Yong was still unaware that he had misspoken. Seeing that Aunt Zhao ignored him, he exchanged puzzled glances with his companions.

It was Xie Qi who finally spoke up, "When you meet the Commandant's husband in the future, you'll know who he is."

With that, the topic was temporarily set aside.

They took a brief rest where they were, lighting a fire to cook. Xie Qi gazed at the horizon where the gyrfalcon had flown away, his expression

still tense.

He had written down everything he had witnessed on the road and sent the gyrfalcon to find Xie Zheng.

The gyrfalcon recognized the Xie Family Army flag. If Xie Zheng's troops were passing through this area, they could only have traveled a few dozen miles in half a day. The gyrfalcon would quickly return with a reply from Xie Zheng.

If it wasn't Xie Zheng, sending the gyrfalcon to deliver the message would still ensure the military intelligence reached him promptly.

The black-armored troops flowed like molten iron through the endless green mountains, the "Xie" banner with its gray wolf emblem stretched taut by the mountain winds, flapping fiercely.

A clear, piercing cry echoed from the sky. The personal guard riding close to the carriage in the middle of the formation looked up and respectfully reported to the person inside, "Marquis, it's the gyrfalcon."

The man inside, who had been resting with his eyes closed, lifted his cold, sharp phoenix eyes.

He had left the gyrfalcon by her side. She wouldn't use it to send him messages—only Xie Qi or Xie Wu would.

Had something happened to her?

A tickle rose in his throat. He pressed his lips together, suppressing a cough, then lifted the thick brocade curtain of the carriage.

The gyrfalcon spotted him, circling low before swooping down, its iron-like talons gripping the edge of the carriage firmly as it raised the leg carrying the message tube.

Xie Zheng retrieved the letter inside. After reading it, his eyes turned icy as he issued a cold command, "Change course. Full speed to Lu City."

The guard outside the carriage glanced at the sky and hesitated, "Marquis, if we head to Lu City now, we likely won't arrive before nightfall."

From inside the carriage came only an unyielding, frigid voice, "Bring me my warhorse. The cavalry will ride ahead with me."

The sun sank in the west, the dying light as red as blood.

The fields outside Lu City's gates were bathed in a brilliant golden-red hue.

At some point, Fan Changyu had grown to dislike sunsets. The color was too vivid, always reminding her of blood on the battlefield.

Like now.

Riding back to Lu City with three thousand cavalry without pause, the sight of blood staining the earth that same dazzling shade made her heart sink.

Lu City hadn't been breached, but the corpses piled beneath the gates were so thick they nearly reached the height of the walls.

Earlier that day, while attacking Chongzhou City, she had seen ordinary civilians forced onto the walls at swordpoint by the rebels. Yet here at Lu City, she saw civilians willingly climbing the walls to defend it.

He Jingyuan stood at the center of Lu City's battlements in full armor, like an unshakable mountain, pressing down on the besiegers and keeping them at bay.

Just seeing his figure from afar made Fan Changyu's eyes grow hot with tears.

Against all odds, with Lu City's forces stretched thin, he had actually led its civilians in holding the gates until now.

Zheng Wenchang let out a hoarse battle cry, leading the cavalry to pierce through the rebel ranks from behind. Fan Changyu followed closely.

Whether it was because the rebels were exhausted from their prolonged siege or because their cavalry truly had divine aid, they fought their way to the front of the enemy formation. The rebels, lacking capable commanders beyond sheer numbers, ultimately chose not to engage and retreated for the time being.

They made it into the city.

The defenders on the city wall cheered with tears of joy. Fan Changyu followed Zheng Wenchang to the city wall to find He Jingyuan.

The deputy general looked at the elderly man whose stern eyes were fixed ahead and said excitedly, "Sir, we've defended Lu City!"

The old man did not respond, his expression unchanged.

Startled, the deputy reached out to touch him, only to find the elder's body already stiff—yet he still stood unyielding, leaning on his sword.

The deputy general let out a grief-stricken cry, "My lord!"

Fan Changyu and the others who had just ascended the city tower felt their hearts suddenly turn cold upon hearing this wail.

Chapter 113

At the front, Zheng Wenchang visibly staggered before pushing past the bewildered soldiers flanking the city wall steps and charging even faster toward the battlements.

Fan Changyu was a step behind. When she reached the top, she saw soldiers kneeling in grief-stricken sobs and civilians wiping away tears. Whether from overwhelming sorrow or exhaustion after the battle, for a moment, the world seemed to spin around her. A wave of desolation and uncertainty surged within her.

Though she had imagined the fall of Lu City on the way here, witnessing the old general's lifeless body still gripping his sword on the battlefield unleashed a tidal wave of grief that choked her breath.

"My lord?"

Zheng Wenchang's throat tightened as he rasped out the words to the stiffened figure. The towering man's eyes were bloodshot, his voice breaking into sobs the moment he spoke.

After closing the deceased elder's eyes—still wide with unyielding fury in death—he dropped to his knees, kowtowing heavily until his forehead split open, tears and snot streaming down his face. He repeated only one phrase: "This student came too late... I returned too late..."

The deputy general, his own eyes red, couldn't bear the sight. He steadied Zheng Wenchang and said, "Wen Chang, don't do this. The lord was already gravely wounded and overworked. When he heard of the rebels' sudden attack on Lu City, he rushed here despite his failing health, holding out until your reinforcements arrived. He must have died in peace. Now, with the enemy at our gates, don't waste yourself. Crushing the rebels is what he would have wanted!"

Zheng Wenchang lifted his bloodshot eyes to the sea of rebel troops below the walls and muttered, "Yes... the rebels. They deserve death!"

His clenched fists creaked as he stood and barked an order: "All troops, heed my command! Follow me out to battle—we take Sui Yuanhuai's head

and avenge our lord!"

The deputy urgently countered, "Wen Chang, don't act rashly! Twenty thousand rebels surround us. Charging out now is suicide!"

Fan Changyu's cavalry, originally three thousand strong, had dwindled to two thousand after the brutal fight to break into the city.

Two thousand against twenty thousand? Defending the walls was feasible, but opening the gates meant certain death.

Veins bulged on Zheng Wenchang's hands as he glared at the eight-horse war chariot shielded at the heart of the rebel forces below. His jaw clenched. "Then I'll go alone—I'll bring back Sui Yuanhuai's head myself!"

With that, he grabbed his spear and stormed toward the stairs like a maddened bull, the deputy's grasp slipping from his arm.

As he passed Fan Changyu, the silent woman struck like lightning—a brutal chop to his nape sent him crumpling into darkness.

"Wen Chang!"

The deputy caught him, relieved to find him merely unconscious. Recognizing Fan Changyu as the sole female officer in the northwest army, he bowed gratefully. "Thank you, Commander Fan, for your aid."

"Take General Zheng below," she said. "Let him rest."

The deputy signaled soldiers to carry Zheng Wenchang away, then called for a stretcher to bear He Jingyuan's body with care.

The elderly man closed his eyes, his face still dignified, yet with a trace of serenity between his brows.

As the soldiers carried He Jingyuan's body away, Fan Changyu quietly observed the departed elder for a moment and softly called out, "Uncle."

Then she made a promise: "I will defend Lucheng and not allow a single inch of Jizhou to fall to the rebels."

The first words were spoken as the daughter of an old friend, addressing this noble and virtuous elder. The latter was a pledge made in her capacity as a subordinate.

The deputy general watched with mixed emotions and could only say, "Captain Fan, please accept my condolences."

He Jingyuan's body had already been carried away by the soldiers. Fan Changyu nodded silently and was about to turn back to assess the situation below the city walls when a scout, who had been monitoring the rebels' movements, rushed to report to the deputy general: "General, the rebels are preparing to attack the city again!"

The deputy general paled in shock and hurried to the battlements to look down.

Below the city, the rebels had reorganized their formation, which had been scattered by Fan Changyu's cavalry. Once again, they advanced with shield formations and archers at the forefront, covering the rebels carrying ladders as they approached the city walls.

The deputy general, frantic, issued orders: "Archers, quickly! Fill every battlement—two men per group, rotating!"

Turning to Fan Changyu, he said, "Captain Fan, how many of your cavalry are skilled archers? Deploy them immediately to man the battlements!"

Fan Changyu promptly instructed Xie Wu: "Bring all archers still fit for battle up to the city walls."

Most cavalymen were already elite among ordinary soldiers, and archers required considerable arm strength to draw longbows. Thus, soldiers skilled in mounted archery were even rarer.

Of the three thousand cavalry Fan Changyu had brought back, five hundred were originally archers. Many had been lost in the battle to enter the city, leaving just over three hundred still combat-ready. Xie Wu led them all up to man the battlements of Lucheng's walls.

The civilians who had been assisting in the city's defense voluntarily went below the inner walls to help transport weapons, stones, and logs.

Fan Changyu had fought in several siege battles before, but this was her first time defending a city.

Unlike the relentless charge forward in an offensive siege, the sight of rebels swarming like a tide below the walls was far more visually overwhelming. The vastness of the enemy formation was fully visible, creating immense psychological pressure and easily instilling fear.

The deputy general, clearly experienced, shouted encouragement to the troops as the rebels' shield-and-archer formation entered firing range:

"During the rebels' last attack, we held the walls with fewer than a thousand men. Now we have thousands of elite reinforcements—close your eyes if you must, but drive these rebels back!"

As soon as the enemy formation entered range, he roared, "Loose arrows!"

Instantly, arrows rained down like meteors from the walls. Each battlement was manned by two archers—one firing while the other nocked an arrow behind him. When the first archer stepped back, the second immediately took his place to shoot, ensuring a continuous barrage.

Fan Changyu and the deputy general peered down from the battlements and saw rebels falling in the enemy ranks. But their numbers were vast—as those in front fell, those behind trampled over the corpses and continued their charge.

Through sheer numbers, they eventually managed to raise their ladders against the walls once more.

After the previous city defense battle, the guards on the city walls reacted swiftly this time. While the archers fired their arrows, other soldiers and civilians began hurling stones and logs, lifting barrels of oil to pour down. Another torch was thrown, and soon the ladders and the rebel soldiers climbing them were engulfed in flames. The soldiers screamed as they tried to extinguish the fire on their bodies, but their clothes, soaked in oil, inevitably turned them into human torches before they plummeted from the ladders.

When Fan Changyu first stepped onto the battlefield, the sight of corpses had made her nauseous. Now, witnessing this hellish scene, she still felt disgusted, though she no longer retched or vomited.

She could even calmly analyze the battle situation with the deputy general: "General He, I notice our oil reserves are running low. Should we conserve it? Some ladders can be destroyed with stones and logs—let's use those instead."

The military supplies in Lu City had been transported to Chongzhou along with the defending troops after the initial siege was lifted. After all, no one had expected the rebels, already cornered like desperate beasts, to break through the encirclement of tens of thousands of troops and counterattack Lu City.

Deputy General He sighed. "I initially thought the same as you, Captain Fan. But Lord He insisted we mustn't let the rebels know our supplies are dwindling. If we repel their assaults several times, even if they use human wave tactics, they'll eventually tire. If they realize our supplies are running out, they'll only attack more fiercely."

Fan Changyu fell silent at his words.

Deputy General He's reasoning was sound. In this defensive battle, they were the weaker side, already short on manpower. If their supplies ran out, the rebels' morale would soar, and capturing Lu City would become effortless.

With the help of the two thousand cavalry that had entered the city and the civilians, Lu City managed to hold off another wave of the rebel attack.

As the rebels retreated like beaten dogs, sounding their gongs to withdraw, the soldiers and civilians on the walls cheered in triumph.

But the quartermaster, after taking stock of the meager remaining supplies on the walls, approached Deputy General He with a grim expression. "General, we're nearly out of arrows, and only a few barrels of oil are left."

Deputy General He glanced at the rebels below, who seemed to be regrouping once more, and asked Fan Changyu, "Captain Fan, how much longer until General Tang's forces arrive?"

Fan Changyu replied, "Lu City and Chongzhou are over a hundred li apart. Even if General Tang's troops march at full speed without any baggage, we'll still need to hold out for at least two more hours."

Deputy General He turned his gaze back to the smoke-filled battlefield below and said simply, "Then we'll hold for two more hours."

Xie Wu, standing behind Fan Changyu, showed a flicker of unease but remained silent.

On the walls, only the low-ranking soldiers celebrated this brief victory. The officers above seemed to understand that arrows, oil, stones, and logs were nearly exhausted—Lu City could not be held.

Every face bore the weight of the situation, yet no one spoke of it. They continued their duties methodically.

It was less a preparation for the next defensive battle and more an acceptance of a heroic death.

In such moments, even grief seemed superfluous.

Fan Changyu observed the faces around her—some heavy with dread, others radiant with fleeting joy. After a brief silence, she suddenly said to Deputy General He, "I have an idea that might help Lu City hold out longer."

Deputy General He quickly asked, "What is it?"

Fan Changyu said, "This subordinate will lead a dozen men out of the city to challenge the rebel generals to single combat. Deputy General He, take this opportunity to reinforce the city gates."

Upon hearing that she intended to trade her life for a few more hours of defense, Deputy General He immediately objected, "Absolutely not!"

Fan Changyu replied, "This is the only method I can think of right now to buy us more time."

She looked at Deputy General He and continued, "The rebels fled here overnight—their military supplies and provisions must be insufficient. If they breach the city, the civilians will suffer. Lord He defended Lu City with his life—how can we let it fall through our hands simply because we fear death? The city still needs you to oversee the situation, Deputy General He. Therefore, I request to lead this charge."

Deputy General He hesitated, conflicted.

Xie Wu urgently interjected, "If the Commandant insists on going into battle, this subordinate is willing to go in your stead."

For the first time, Fan Changyu spoke harshly to Xie Wu: "You're not qualified."

Deputy General He said with difficulty, "Commandant Fan..."

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together, then clasped her fists and declared, "Deputy General He, this subordinate, Meng Changyu, is a descendant of General Meng Shuyuan of Changshan. Deceiving the emperor is already a grave crime. If I cannot uncover the truth of the Jinzhou Massacre in this lifetime to clear my ancestors' name, then at least let me do one good deed for the people—to uphold the Meng family's honor. I beg you to grant me this!"

Deputy General He was deeply shaken. After a moment of internal struggle, he finally shut his eyes in resignation and said, "Permission granted."

Fan Changyu bowed gratefully. "Thank you, General."

With that, she turned to descend the city wall.

Xie Wu hurried after her. "This subordinate will accompany the Commandant to issue the challenge outside the city."

Fan Changyu stopped in a secluded spot and spoke with unexpected calmness, "Xiao Wu, thank you for your support all these years in the army. I know you and Xiao Qi stayed by my side on his orders. But now that he's about to marry a princess, keeping you here would weigh on my conscience."

Xie Wu, who had been by Fan Changyu's side all this time, was unaware that the emperor had sent an envoy to arrange the marriage. Hearing this, he felt both bewildered and alarmed by what Fan Changyu was about to do. He pressed urgently, "Commandant, there must be some misunderstanding—who told you His Lordship is marrying a princess?"

Fan Changyu ignored the question and said instead, "I don't blame him. The Jinzhou Massacre shocked the world—no one could forgive that. I've always believed my father and grandfather were innocent, but that's just my own belief. If I die defending Lu City today, consider it atonement for their sins. There's just one thing I'd like to ask of you, Xiao Wu. If I fall and Lu City holds, evade the palace and Wei Yan's spies, and find a good family to adopt Ning Niang."

She paused, then added after a long moment, "She's the only one I can't let go of now."

There was still one other person in her heart she couldn't forget, but their fate had long since run its course.

Xie Wu's eyes reddened. "Commandant..."

Fan Changyu clasped her fists toward him. "I leave it to you."

Before Xie Wu could say more, Fan Changyu turned and strode toward the assembled troops below the barbican.

The dozen men were all locals of Jizhou, their faces solemn with resolve.

Fan Changyu scanned each of them and said, "We go out there. If we can hold out long enough for reinforcements to arrive, our comrades, brothers, and fellow townspeople won't have to die. Our names may be remembered by future generations, and our families will receive imperial compensation—enough to live comfortably for the rest of their lives."

"If we can't hold the city and it falls, we'll just be another corpse among the countless bones beneath the yellow sand. Our wives, children, and elders at home may be displaced by the flames of war, or they may die beneath the rebels' blades."

With that, she mounted her horse and shouted boldly to the soldiers guarding the city gate, "Open the gates!"

The heavy city gates slowly creaked open with a sound like rolling cartwheels. As Fan Changyu rode out from the city, saber in hand, the distant mass of rebel soldiers visibly froze in shock.

Sixteen elite troops followed her out of the city, forming a V-shaped formation behind Fan Changyu like a pair of wings sprouting from her back.

The last remnants of the setting sun cast a crimson glow as the Jizhou flag atop the city walls flapped fiercely in the wind. In the deathly silence of the battlefield, Fan Changyu's voice tore through the gale, reaching every ear: "Meng Changyu, daughter of Meng Shuyuan, stands here today. Does any rebel general dare come forth and fight?"

Chapter 114

The battlefield was eerily silent, save for the howling wind.

Several dozen yards away, the rebel soldiers, still reorganizing their formations, paused briefly. Several young officers on horseback glanced back with varying expressions, awaiting orders from the central army.

Fan Changyu sat tall on her horse, her gaze steady and her grip firm on the long blade, showing no trace of fear.

For some unknown reason, no response came from the enemy camp in the distance.

Fan Changyu frowned. After Shi Yue and Shi Hu had died at First Line Gorge and Changxin Wang was executed in Chongzhou, the rebel forces had lost many of their top generals. Now, Sui Yuanhuai had almost no capable commanders left under him.

Her desperate strategy was meant to buy time.

If Sui Yuanhuai saw through her plan and refused to lose any more of his remaining officers, ordering a full assault instead, she and the dozen or so soldiers behind her wouldn't last long.

After a brief consideration, Fan Changyu devised a plan. Pointing her blade forward, she shouted, "Listen well, you rebels! Changxin Wang has already fallen to my blade, and Sui Yuanqing was captured in Kangcheng. The man you follow is nothing but a coward who can't even lift a sword—let alone name a single brave warrior to fight for him! What makes you think he can lead you to the capital and grant you riches? If you abandon this doomed cause now, all will be forgiven!"

Her words caused a visible stir among the rebel ranks.

Deputy General He and the others on the city walls, realizing Fan Changyu's intent, joined in the taunting: "Sui Yuanhuai is a coward! He fled like a stray dog from Chongzhou to Lucheng, with no one left to fight for him. He's just using you as cannon fodder to clear his escape route south!"

"The Sui family's fate is sealed! At least Sui Yuanqing was a fierce warrior—who doesn't know Sui Yuanhuai is just a sickly man clinging to life? Following him is suicide!"

The unrest among the rebels grew louder.

A scout hurried back to report the situation to the rear formation. Trembling, he relayed the news, only for a cold scoff to come from the carriage surrounded by elite guards: "Meng Changyu?"

The voice inside was icy, like a chilling wind through a dark forest, sending shivers down one's spine.

He chuckled lowly. "What a masterful attempt at sowing discord and demoralizing the troops. Sui Ping, take some men and capture that Meng remnant alive."

The burly general outside the carriage immediately clasped his fists. "At your command!"

But the strategist, who had rushed over upon hearing the news, protested, "Young Master, no! You mustn't!"

He laid out the risks: "That female general is clearly baiting us. Right now, General Sui Ping is the only capable commander left in our army. If anything happens to him, even if we take Lucheng, how will we defend against Tang Peiyi and Wu'an Marquis when they arrive? We should focus on storming the city—pile up corpses if we must, but take the walls first!"

A pale, slender hand adorned with a white jade ring lifted the carriage curtain. The lack of sunlight from years of illness made the veins and tendons starkly visible beneath the skin.

A nearby scout caught a glimpse and shuddered, quickly lowering his head.

Rumors had long circulated in the army—the young master was plagued by chronic illness, his temperament cruel and unpredictable, and those who served him closely often met sudden, violent ends.

The carriage curtain was fully drawn back, revealing Sui Yuanhuai with a cloak draped over his shoulders. His pallid face bore obvious signs of illness, yet a faint smile played at the corners of his lips, exuding an air of gloomy malevolence.

He spoke unhurriedly, "The military advisor has toiled hard, but after suffering consecutive defeats, the army's morale must be restored. That female general killed my father—this vengeance unavenged, I would be ashamed to face him in the afterlife."

The military advisor still hesitated, "But—"

Sui Yuanhuai raised a hand to silence him. Though his eyelids lifted slightly, revealing the gaze of a man long afflicted by illness, the advisor felt an inexplicable pressure the moment their eyes met. He quickly averted his gaze, silently reassessing the rumors that the eldest son was merely a useless invalid sustained by medicine.

Noting the advisor's reaction, Sui Yuanhuai's lips curled slightly. "The army will set out at midnight. Even if Tang Peiyi notices something amiss after attacking Pochong City and gives chase, it will take him at least half a day to reach us. The Wu'an Marquis is entrenched in Kang City and won't arrive in time to aid them. What fear is there of a mere woman? Let's not give those imperial lapdogs on the city walls a reason to laugh."

The advisor had only wanted to capture Lu City swiftly to avoid complications, but Sui Yuanhuai's words eased his concerns. With a bow, he retreated.

Watching the advisor leave, Sui Yuanhuai tapped the carriage window with his knuckles before instructing his personal guards, "Go and assist. Ensure the Meng woman is taken alive—kill everyone else."

Half the elite fighters surrounding the carriage vanished instantly.

Lan Shi, Zhao Xun's mother, cautiously glanced at Sui Yuanhuai and ventured, "Does Your Highness intend to use the Meng woman to expose Wei Yan's role in the Jinzhou Massacre?"

Sui Yuanhuai regarded her with a half-lidded, mocking gaze, remaining silent.

Lan Shi grew uneasy. Since Yu Bao'er's return, Sui Yuanhuai's wariness toward her and her son had deepened. She understood his suspicions—she had never harbored disloyalty all these years. But for those of imperial blood, once doubt took root, it festered like a thorn.

With no further word from Zhao Xun, she feared Sui Yuanhuai's trust in them had dwindled further.

A pang of sorrow struck her—after all, she had watched him grow up. She lowered her head. "This old servant spoke out of turn."

Suddenly, Sui Yuanhuai's hostility melted away, replaced by a gentle demeanor as he poured tea for her. "Aunt Lan, you've grown distant from me. Wei Yan is cunning. Even if the Meng woman accuses him, she wasn't born seventeen years ago, and the sole evidence has already returned to his hands. He has countless ways to refute it. I'm merely puzzled—why would you think I'd use her to topple Wei Yan?"

In this gentler state, he bore a striking resemblance to the late Chengde Crown Prince.

Lan Shi's sadness faded. "Then why does Your Highness order her capture alive?"

Sui Yuanhuai smirked. "That usurping fool sought to win over the Wu'an Marquis by arranging a marriage, yet the Marquis sliced off the eunuch messenger's ear in defiance. Though the palace suppressed the news, walls have ears. Tell me, Aunt Lan—for whom did the Wu'an Marquis refuse the imperial marriage to the princess?"

Understanding dawned on her. "Your Highness means to use the woman to control the Wu'an Marquis?"

She hesitated and said, "But... since she is a descendant of Meng Shuyuan, even if Meng Shuyuan was manipulated back then, her biological father was Wei Yan's man. It's likely she is also implicated in the Jinzhou case. With such a blood feud between them, would the Wu'an Marquis still care about her life or death?"

Sui Yuanhuai merely smiled. "The stage is set. Now we just watch the play."

Lan Shi pondered the meaning behind his words, but Sui Yuanhuai said no more.

Since Zhao Xun's disappearance, he had indeed grown more wary of this mother and son pair. This joint scheme with the Li family to frame Wei Yan was also kept hidden from Lan Shi.

After the fire in the Eastern Palace, he had stopped trusting anyone completely.

At that moment, a commotion arose from a carriage behind them. Sui Yuanhuai frowned impatiently. "What's going on?"

Before the Shadow Guard outside the carriage could investigate, a servant hurried over to report, "Master, the young master has fallen ill."

A flash of disgust crossed Sui Yuanhuai's eyes as he replied coldly, "If he's ill, summon the Army Doctor. What's all the noise for?"

The servant answered in a hushed voice, "It's... Consort Yu insists on seeing you, Master."

Sui Yuanhuai twisted the ring on his finger without a word. The messenger kept his head slightly bowed, but in those brief moments, he felt as though needles were pricking his back, cold sweat trickling down.

Lan Shi also found it odd. That Consort Yu had always avoided His Highness at all costs—why would she suddenly seek an audience today?

She glanced at Sui Yuanhuai, considering that with the armies about to clash, His Highness likely had no time to spare for the woman. So she replied on his behalf, "The siege is imminent, and the Eldest Young Master is occupied with pressing matters. I'll accompany you to check on the young master."

Yet the moment she finished speaking, Sui Yuanhuai said, "I'll go see him myself."

The usual cold smirk played on his lips, but there was an added glint of unspoken amusement in his eyes, as though he were in a good mood.

Lan Shi frowned. His Highness's behavior regarding Consort Yu was far too erratic.

Sui Yuanhuai stepped down from the carriage with the support of his most trusted Shadow Guard and strode unhurriedly toward the rear carriage.

By the time he reached it, a servant had already lifted the curtain. Stepping onto the coachman's back to board, he saw the woman sitting as close to the corner as possible. The coldness in his smile deepened.

His gaze swept over Yu Bao'er, who lay with eyes tightly shut against her lap, his small body trembling slightly. With a mocking tone, he asked, "Wasn't it said that this little beast was ill?"

Yu Qianqian met his eyes calmly. "Bao'er isn't ill. I wanted to see you."

The curve of Sui Yuanhuai's lips stiffened for an instant. He raised his gaze, reassessing the woman before him.

She wanted to see him? That was nothing short of a joke.

She never sought him out unless she needed something.

A shadow of malice flickered in his eyes as he sneered, "Need a favor?"

Yu Bao'er could no longer pretend to sleep, clutching Yu Qianqian's sleeve tightly.

Yu Qianqian gave his little hand a reassuring squeeze and held Sui Yuanhuai's gaze steadily.

The short bangs that once framed her forehead had grown out over the past months, now swept up to reveal a smooth, unblemished brow. Her face seemed even more radiant, dignified yet gentle.

She said, "The female general leading the charge was once an acquaintance of mine. Why must women suffer for the conflicts of men? Spare her life."

She was unaware that Sui Yuanhuai had already issued orders to capture Fan Changyu alive. In the entire northwest, there was only one renowned female general. When Yu Qianqian heard the female challenger identify herself as Meng Changyu, she immediately guessed it was Fan Changyu.

Sui Yuanhuai commanded an army of twenty thousand. How could the remaining two thousand battered soldiers in Lu City possibly withstand such a force?

Unable to save more people, she only hoped to secure a favor from Sui Yuanhuai—to ensure Fan Changyu's survival at all costs.

Upon hearing this, Sui Yuanhuai let out two cold laughs. "You can hardly protect yourself, yet you're sympathizing with stray cats and dogs outside?"

Yu Qianqian pressed her full lips together and said, "That's why I'm begging you."

His pale, icy fingers suddenly gripped her chin without warning. Forced to look up, Yu Qianqian met Sui Yuanhuai's dark eyes and instantly felt as though she were ensnared by a venomous serpent—damp, cold, and suffocating. Her body stiffened.

Standing barely half a foot away, Sui Yuanhuai looked down at her with disdain. "Is this how you beg?"

Years of consuming medicine had left him with a bitter herbal scent. Being this close, Yu Qianqian inhaled nothing but that odor.

The cool touch of his fingers on her chin remained vivid.

Her delicate brows furrowed slightly as she gazed at the pale, brooding man before her. "How do you want me to beg?"

Sui Yuanhuai seemed taken aback by her calm retort. For a moment, his eyes flashed with a feral hatred. Ignoring Yu Bao'er's presence in the carriage, he abruptly bent down and kissed her roughly.

A sharp pain shot through her lips. Coming to her senses, Yu Qianqian hurriedly covered Yu Bao'er's eyes with her hand.

Fortunately, he soon pulled away. Wiping her lips, she saw blood—unsurprisingly—and winced at the sting.

Noticing the blood on her lips, the darkness in Sui Yuanhuai's eyes lessened slightly. Half-lowering his gaze, he sneered, as if using mockery to mask some hidden emotion, and tossed out, "Come to my room tonight."

Even after he lifted the carriage curtain and left, Yu Qianqian remained silent.

Yu Bao'er's large, dark eyes fixed on his frail yet resilient mother. "Mama..." he whispered, clutching her sleeve tightly, his lips pressed into a thin line.

He didn't want her to go to that man alone.

Yu Qianqian pulled the child into her arms, gently patting his back. "Don't be afraid. It's nothing. If it means saving your Aunt Changyu, what does this matter?"

Yu Bao'er stayed silent.

Watching the fluttering carriage curtain, Yu Qianqian spoke softly, "Ning Niang is even younger than you. She's already lost her parents. If she loses her elder sister too, what will become of her?"

A flicker of emotion finally surfaced in Yu Bao'er's dark eyes.

Yu Qianqian stroked his head. "Just endure a little longer."

After several rounds of taunts on the battlefield, Fan Changyu finally saw a narrow path open in the distant enemy formation.

A burly general charged forward on horseback, brandishing a double-edged axe. "Enough of your arrogance! Let me deal with you!"

Accompanying him were over a dozen others, uniformly dressed yet unlike any military officers. At first glance, Fan Changyu's right eyelid twitched uncontrollably.

An indescribable discomfort coiled around her.

The fully armored general roared and spurred his horse toward her. Shaking off her thoughts, Fan Changyu urged her own steed forward to meet him.

The clash of the Horse-Cutting Sword against the double-edged axe sent sparks flying as both riders passed each other by several yards before wheeling their horses around for another strike.

In mere moments, Fan Changyu had already exchanged several blows with the enemy commander. The man had decent arm strength, but his moves were too rigid. If she truly wanted to kill him, she could have unhorsed him in under three strikes.

But her current goal was to buy time, so Changyu deliberately held back. The two of them traded blows, circling each other across the open battlefield for nearly half a lap without a clear victor.

After roughly a quarter of an hour, the dozen or so men watching from the opposing side realized she was stalling and charged forward in unison.

Changyu's heart sank. She quickly knocked the enemy commander off his horse with the flat of her blade.

The approaching riders numbered exactly sixteen.

The sixteen elite soldiers behind Changyu assumed this would be a one-on-one fight and urged their horses forward.

But what followed was nearly a one-sided slaughter.

The sixteen opponents moved like phantoms. The Jizhou soldiers wielding spears and swords couldn't even get close before their heads were lopped off by ruthless, precise strikes.

They were like executioners honed through years of practice—every swing of their blades was meant only to kill.

Using the reach advantage of her Horse-Cutting Sword, Changyu managed to save one soldier who was close to her. But in the next instant, the enemy's blade twisted, slicing a long gash down her arm.

She quickly forced the attacker back with her sword, creating a safe distance.

Her heart pounded violently, her palms slick with cold sweat, making it hard to grip the hilt firmly.

Never before had death felt so close. These men weren't ordinary fighters who knew fear or hesitation.

They were like killing machines—untiring, unfeeling.

All around her, her comrades fell one after another. Changyu once managed to land a strike on an enemy, nearly severing his entire arm, yet the man didn't even cry out. Instead, he rolled along the length of her blade and slashed her across the waist.

Bracing herself on her sword with one hand, Changyu pressed the other against the bleeding wound on her abdomen, gritting her teeth as she faced the dozen men encircling her just a few yards away.

She had figured out their fighting style. Against the other soldiers, they aimed only for fatal blows.

But that last attacker had a clear chance to kill her—yet he deliberately struck her waist instead.

Suddenly, she understood. They wanted to capture her alive.

A bead of sweat dripped from her brow. Changyu unwound the cloth binding from her hand and tightly wrapped it around her abdomen to stem the bleeding.

The enemies seemed to think she was at her limit and didn't press the attack just yet.

Up on the city wall, Xie Wu's eyes burned with fury. He roared hoarsely, "Those aren't soldiers—they're trained Martial Assassins! Open the gates! Let me out to help the Commandant!"

Deputy General He watched in horror as the sixteen elite soldiers were cut down in moments. But opening the gates now would only invite the enemy to storm the city.

Grimacing in anguish, he said, "We can't open the gates. Commandant Fan and those sixteen brave souls went out for the sake of Lu City's people. If we open the gates now, what will become of the hundreds of thousands of civilians inside?"

Xie Wu stared down at Changyu, surrounded and outnumbered, then recalled her earlier instructions to him. He slammed a fist against the battlement in frustration.

Finally, as if reaching a decision, he suddenly looked up and barked, "Bring me a rope!"

At the base of the city wall, Fan Changyu bandaged the wound on her abdomen and then pulled out a pair of deerskin bracers from her armor, fastening them onto her wrists.

She had originally intended to discard these vambraces, but when breaking camp to rush to Lu City, she had inexplicably tucked them into her robes.

Now, they proved to be of great help.

As she tightened her grip on the Horse-Cutting Sword once more, a Martial Assassin from the opposing side closed in like a ghost, his blade aiming for her waist. Fan Changyu swung her sword in a wide arc, forcing him back while slicing a wound across his abdomen.

The assassin landed and glanced at his injury, exchanging a look with his comrades before they suddenly launched a coordinated assault, all charging at Fan Changyu.

From atop the city wall, the defenders screamed in fury, "You sons of bitches! A dozen men ganging up on a woman—only the Sui family's lackeys would stoop so low!"

There were faint murmurs among the rebel ranks, but in the heat of battle, there was no room for distraction. The dozen or so Martial Assassins ignored the curses raining down from above, their killing techniques shifting fluidly.

Fan Changyu couldn't tell whether the wetness on her face was blood or sweat. Her entire focus was locked onto the approaching blades.

Their martial arts were unlike any general she had faced on the battlefield before—vicious, cunning, unpredictable.

Fortunately, she had survived several assassination attempts with Xie Zheng in the past. Later, during their sparring sessions, she had been stunned by the eerie swiftness of his techniques and had learned a few moves from him.

With that foundation, and the fact that her attackers were deliberately trying to keep her alive, she managed to hold her own against the dozen for several more minutes.

Slash, hack, slice, flick, cleave—her Horse-Cutting Sword became a blur of motion.

The prolonged exertion left her arms burning with fatigue, blood soaking through her sleeves, yet she dared not stop.

Time seemed to slow—so much so that she could see every slight movement of the assassins' arms, every shift of their blades. Her sword deflected each attack with precision. Even where her eyes couldn't see, the disturbance in the air and the whistle of steel slicing through wind became vividly clear.

Back when she first trained in martial arts, her father had told her that once one mastered the basics, techniques had to move faster than the eye could follow.

But at higher levels, it was about returning to simplicity—no matter how fast the moves, true mastery meant being able to see every strike clearly.

She had always been stuck at that threshold, never fully grasping what her father meant about the eyes surpassing the blade. Yet now, in this moment, she broke through that bottleneck.

Blades that should have been impossible to evade were dodged again and again. She even countered, cutting down three of the assassins.

The remaining assassins were also wounded.

They were the most elite Martial Assassins under Sui Yuanhuai's command, warriors who had never been outmatched even against Wei Yan's top-ranked assassins. Yet today, sixteen against one, they were being held at bay by a single woman.

The lead assassin's gaze sharpened as he reassessed Fan Changyu. His next strikes became noticeably fiercer.

She barely managed to parry a few moves before exhaustion overwhelmed her defenses. A blade slashed across her back.

Blood seeped from the corner of her tightly pressed lips. She could see every attack clearly, but her injuries and drained strength made her reactions sluggish.

The final strike clashed against the tip of her Horse-Cutting Sword, its force partially deflected before slicing into her right arm.

With a sharp "clang," the descending blade was intercepted by Xie Wu, who had slid down from the city wall using a rope.

Knowing it was a death mission, nearly ten soldiers still volunteered to follow Xie Wu, descending by rope to lend their aid.

Fan Changyu was utterly exhausted, leaning on her long blade just to stay upright.

Seeing her so grievously wounded, Xie Wu's eyes reddened with urgency: "Commander, get out of here!"

Seven or eight soldiers followed Xie Wu, risking their lives to hold off the Martial Assassins, while the rest supported Fan Changyu, helping her retreat. "Commandant, there are ropes by the city tower. We'll take you back! Deputy General He said you've already bought the army over half an hour—that's enough. The rest of us will stake our lives defending the walls of Lu City... uh—"

The soldier supporting Changyu suddenly fell silent.

A long blade had pierced straight through his chest.

He stared at the bloodied tip protruding from his body, collapsing as he repeated the same words: "Commandant... go..."

Behind them, Xie Wu was the only one holding back the dozen Martial Assassins. Outnumbered, he was stabbed multiple times before collapsing in a pool of blood, kneeling with his back to Changyu, never to rise again.

Changyu could barely lift her sword anymore. At the sight, a crimson tide seemed to surge in her eyes, and a tiger-like roar of grief tore from her throat. Swinging her blade, she cleanly severed the head of the nearest Martial Assassin.

Another assassin, who had tried to kill the soldier still supporting her, was nearly bisected at the waist by her strike. Even as he collapsed, his

body twitched violently, entrails and blood spilling onto the ground.

Such brutal dismemberment sent chills down the spines of even these battle-hardened assassins.

Changyu's blade dripped blood as she slowly raised her head. The whites of her eyes were entirely bloodshot, a terrifying crimson, her disheveled hair making her look like a demon clawing its way out of hell.

The assassins hesitated, too afraid to advance.

From the enemy ranks behind them, a voice suddenly shouted, "By the lord's command—storm the gates!"

The soldiers who had been resting and observing the battle now surged toward the city gates once more. Bolstered by their reinforcements, the assassins shaken by Changyu steadied themselves, preparing to strike again—when the ground beneath them trembled.

Fine grains of sand quivered as if a colossal beast were tearing through mountains and valleys, splitting the earth itself.

"Woo—"

At the first blast of the horn, the Jizhou troops on the walls were too stunned to react.

"Woo woo—"

When the piercing horn sounded again, the defenders erupted in ecstatic cries: "Reinforcements are here!"

The Chongzhou troops below the walls instinctively turned to look. In the distance, dust clouds billowed, but the thunderous gallop of approaching horses grew louder by the second.

Moments later, a scarlet banner—the Banner of Xie—emerged above the swirling dust.

"The Wu'an Marquis! The Wu'an Marquis has brought the Xie Family Army!"

The Jizhou troops on the walls were electrified. Deputy General He stammered in excitement, "Quick—open the gates! All troops inside, follow me out to slaughter the enemy!"

But the Chongzhou forces below faltered the moment they saw the Xie banner. Their once-orderly formation dissolved into chaos.

The soldier Changyu had saved knelt on the ground, weeping with joy, shouting at her, "Commandant! The Wu'an Marquis himself has come! We're saved!"

Changyu seemed not to hear. She had long since exhausted her strength; her limbs were numb and unresponsive. Leaning on her Horse-Cutting Sword, she slowly knelt before Xie Wu.

To her, both Xie Wu and Xie Qi were almost like family.

As she gazed at the bloodied young man before her, riddled with blades, her throat burned with unspeakable pain. Tears mingled with the blood on her face, and she couldn't even choke out the name "Xiao Wu."

The surviving soldiers, after the initial elation of having narrowly escaped death, looked at the devastated battlefield and their fallen comrades, their expressions turning sorrowful.

Although the Chongzhou army numbered twenty thousand, several rounds of siege warfare had already worn down their morale. Seeing Xie Zheng personally leading troops to their aid, and with no commanding general of prestige left in their ranks, they were instantly terrified out of their wits. The Xie Family Army and Jizhou forces quickly captured them through coordinated attacks from within and without. Only a small contingent of elite troops managed to cover Sui Yuanhuai's escape in the chaos, pursued by capable officers under Xie Zheng's command.

When Xie Zheng entered the city with a group of light cavalry, Deputy General He led all the notable officers within the city to greet him.

Upon seeing Xie Zheng, the deputy general was nearly moved to tears: "Thank the Marquis for arriving in time! Had Lu City fallen, this humble general would have had no face to show the elders and fellow villagers of Lu City, nor would I have dared to face Lord He in the afterlife!"

Xie Zheng, still recovering from his injuries, wore only light armor. Having ridden hard all the way and then fought in battle, the whip wounds on his back had reopened, soaking his clothes with blood. But he was always one to endure pain, and aside from an unusual pallor, not a trace of discomfort showed on his face.

Only at Deputy General He's words did a ripple of emotion appear in his eyes: "Old General He... has passed?"

The deputy general wiped his tears and said, "He passed standing on the city walls."

It was rare for military men to meet a peaceful end.

After a moment of silence, Xie Zheng asked, "Has the memorial hall been set up? I wish to pay my respects to the old general."

Deputy General He looked ashamed. "We haven't had time yet. The rebels came too fiercely, and we simply couldn't attend to Lord He's funeral arrangements. If not for Commandant Fan and Colonel Zheng bringing three thousand cavalry to our aid, and Commandant Fan single-handedly holding off the rebel generals to buy time, Lu City might not have held until the Marquis arrived with reinforcements."

Xie Zheng suddenly looked up sharply: "The Swift Cavalry Commandant is here?"

Swift Cavalry Commandant was Fan Changyu's official title.

Deputy General He, puzzled by his strong reaction, answered, "Yes, yes. But Commandant Fan fought fiercely against over a dozen rebel generals and was severely wounded. She's currently with the Army Doctor—"

Before he could finish, the figure before him moved abruptly. His collar was seized as Xie Zheng, his expression icy and uncharacteristically agitated, demanded, "Where is the Army Doctor?"

Still shaken, Deputy General He pointed in a direction. His collar was suddenly released, and he could breathe again.

Before he could process what had happened, Xie Zheng was already striding away.

"What's gotten into the Marquis?" he wondered aloud. Then it struck him—before leaving the city, Fan Changyu had mentioned being a descendant of General Meng Shuyuan of Changshan. His heart skipped a beat.

Everyone knew that Grand General Xie Linshan and the Chengde Crown Prince had perished in Jinzhou due to Meng Shuyuan's delay in delivering provisions. Was the Marquis rushing to find Commandant Fan because he already knew her identity and sought to avenge his father?

Cold sweat broke out on Deputy General He's back. He hurried after Xie Zheng: "Marquis, please don't act rashly! Whatever Meng Shuyuan did,

Commandant Fan is a loyal patriot who has served the country with utmost devotion!"

Fan Changyu lay in the infirmary, staring blankly at the ceiling.

Her eyes, still bloodshot from earlier, hadn't fully cleared yet, and everything looked slightly blurred, as if through a thin mist.

The Army Doctor said it would take several days of rest to recover.

Her wounds had already been dressed by the medics, the worst being the gash on her abdomen.

Having stayed awake all night and fought in two battles from dawn till now, Fan Changyu was utterly exhausted, yet sleep still eluded her.

The deaths of He Jingyuan and the severe injuries to Xie Wu had dealt her heavy blows.

When she came down from the battlefield and saw Xie Wu with several knives embedded in his body, she thought he was already dead. The sight of him covered in blood made her afraid to even touch him.

Xie Wu and Xie Qi had followed her through thick and thin in the military camp for so long that she had long regarded these two young men as her own younger brothers.

If Xie Wu were to die, it would be no different from losing another family member to her.

Fortunately, the soldiers carrying Xie Wu noticed he still had a faint breath and quickly called the Army Doctor to treat his wounds on the spot.

Although he had been brought back now, the Army Doctor said his injuries were too severe—whether he would survive depended on how tough his fate was.

That word, "fate," weighed heavily on Fan Changyu's heart.

When the door opened, she thought it was the medic returning to urge her to take her medicine. Still staring blankly at the ceiling, she replied hoarsely, "Ahui, I can't eat anything. Don't worry about me—go tend to the other soldiers."

Ahui was the medic's name.

She truly couldn't stomach anything now. Not only medicine, but even a sip of water made her stomach convulse violently until she vomited up

nothing but bile.

After she spoke, there was a long silence at the door, with no sound of footsteps leaving.

Fan Changyu seemed to sense something. Her expression shifted slightly as she turned her gaze toward the doorway.

Despite imagining this reunion many times, the moment she saw that tall figure, her heart clenched as if gripped by a large hand, aching dully.

Her vision was still blurry, but she could tell he had grown much thinner, as if he had been ill.

His frame, wrapped in black armor, was noticeably gaunter, and even his lips lacked color. He didn't look much better than she did, a patient fresh from the battlefield—only the sharpness in his brows and eyes was more pronounced than before.

Had he not been well since they parted?

Their eyes met, but neither spoke.

Fan Changyu wanted to exchange a few polite words, but remembering what he had said during their farewell and the emperor's decree of marriage between him and the princess, her heart ached with bitterness and an indescribable heaviness, making it even harder to speak.

"Marquis! Marquis! Please wait for this subordinate!"

In that moment, Deputy General He had hurriedly caught up. Seeing one lying on the bed and the other standing at the door, both silent, he found it strange but also breathed a sigh of relief.

Then it occurred to him—could it be that Fan Changyu didn't realize the man before her was the Wu'an Marquis?

Noticing Xie Zheng hadn't lashed out, he grew bolder and quickly signaled to Fan Changyu: "The Marquis cares deeply for his subordinates and has come personally to inspect the soldiers' injuries. Colonel Fan, why don't you greet the Marquis?"

So that's why, Fan Changyu thought. No wonder she had run into him here.

Suppressing all her emotions, she forced herself to sit up, curving her lips slightly as she clasped her fists in salute, her tone distant. "This

humble officer, Fan Changyu, greets the Marquis."

He had said he would only regard her as a fellow disciple from now on.

In truth, if not for Grand Tutor Tao's connection, he probably wouldn't want anything to do with her anymore.

Now, with the truth still unclear and him already betrothed, Fan Changyu could no longer bring herself to ask him to believe in her grandfather and father.

Perhaps it was best to act as if they had never known each other, sparing both of them the awkwardness.

She thought this was the most prudent approach, but what followed her words was a dead silence.

You could hear a pin drop.

The person standing at the door watched her quietly for a long moment before chuckling, "What did you just call me?"

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Fan Changyu's heartstrings inexplicably trembled slightly at that soft chuckle.

But she concealed it perfectly, her face showing no trace of emotion as she maintained her respectful posture and calmly replied, "Marquis."

After she spoke, another long silence ensued.

Xie Zheng's smile remained at his lips, yet even a blind man could have sensed the sudden chill in the air around him.

The atmosphere in the room seemed to grow thin.

Deputy General He noticed the subtle tension between them and thought something was amiss. He wanted to help Fan Changyu, opening his mouth to speak, but couldn't find the right words to persuade Xie Zheng to leave.

Fortunately, hurried footsteps suddenly sounded from outside the courtyard.

It was one of Xie Zheng's personal guards. As soon as he entered the courtyard, he clasped his fists and reported, "Marquis, the rebel Sui Yuanhuai has been executed! The concubine and only son who fled with him have also been captured!"

Fan Changyu's bloodshot pupils contracted slightly, and her clasped hands tightened.

Yu Qianqian and Yu Bao'er had been captured?

Traitorous subjects were to be executed along with their entire clans!

Her mind was in turmoil, and she instinctively looked toward Xie Zheng.

For some reason, Xie Zheng frowned upon hearing the news, though no other emotion showed on his face. Capturing the remnants of the rebels was of utmost importance. He gave Fan Changyu one last glance, his gaze lingering on her blood-red eyes and the bandaged wound for a few extra moments.

His tightly pressed lips moved slightly, but in the end, he said nothing and turned to leave.

Deputy General He watched Xie Zheng's retreating figure, eager to follow, but the Marquis's earlier uncharacteristic questioning had been so unusual that he couldn't help asking Fan Changyu, "Are you and the Marquis acquainted?"

Given the current situation, Fan Changyu didn't want others to misunderstand any connection between her and Xie Zheng. She simply replied, "I dare not presume such an honor. I was merely fortunate enough to earn Grand Tutor Tao's favor and was taken in as his adopted daughter."

Deputy General He nodded. "I see."

Yet he still found it strange. But considering the enmity between their families, he didn't dare speculate further or press Fan Changyu with more questions. He only advised her to rest and recover before hurrying after Xie Zheng.

Fan Changyu stopped him to ask, "General He, what will happen to the rebel's family?"

In Lu City at present, aside from Xie Zheng, Deputy General He held the most authority.

She guessed he would know how Yu Qianqian and Yu Bao'er would be dealt with.

Deputy General He answered, "They will be executed immediately."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu's heart sank even further.

She knew the rebels deserved death—countless soldiers had died on the battlefield because of them, and the people of the entire northwest had been displaced.

But Yu Qianqian and her son had done no wrong. Yu Qianqian hadn't willingly followed the rebel either. They didn't deserve such a fate.

She pressed her lips together and asked, "Is there no other possibility?"

Deputy General He gave her a strange look. "How can we not root out the remnants of the rebels? As for the childless concubines from Changxin Prince Manor, they can be exiled or sold. Why do you ask, Commandant Fan?"

Fan Changyu deflected, "I haven't been in the army long and am unfamiliar with these laws. I was just curious."

After Deputy General He left, Fan Changyu lay back on the bed, lost in thought for a long while.

How could she save Yu Qianqian and Bao'er?

After leaving the courtyard, Xie Zheng asked, "How were her eyes injured?"

The personal guard following him had only just arrived in Lu City and didn't know what had happened to Fan Changyu. He hurriedly replied, "This subordinate will investigate at once."

The evening wind swayed the lanterns hanging under the eaves, casting chaotic shadows from the cluster of asparagus ferns planted by the low wall.

Xie Zhengting's pale face gained no warmth from the lamplight as he ordered in a low voice, "Find the best physician to treat her injuries. Search for Xie Wu—see if he's still alive."

He could well imagine that all her wounds had been sustained on the battlefield.

But for her to be injured so gravely—just how brutal had the battle been?

Had he not received Xie Qi's letter and rushed here, would she have died in this place?

After the personal guard accepted the order and withdrew, Xie Zheng stood alone in the corridor with hands clasped behind his back. Suddenly, he slammed his fist violently against the stone wall, shattering the hard bricks and sending debris scattering to the ground.

His hand was scraped, beads of crimson blood welling up.

The other accompanying guards were startled by this sudden outburst, but none dared speak.

When Deputy General He arrived, the coroner had already completed the autopsy.

Peering at the corpse covered by a white cloth with only the head exposed, he asked the coroner, "Are you certain this is Sui Yuanhuai?"

The coroner replied respectfully, "General, Sui Yuanhuai's face was disfigured in the fire at the Eastern Palace during his childhood. It's said he never left the prince's manor all these years, relying on medicine to sustain his frail health. His appearance was so horrifically ugly that even the manor's servants rarely saw him."

"This humble one observed old burn scars on the body. The fingers are slender and callus-free, indicating a life of privilege. The darkened tongue coating and bitter medicinal smell suggest long-term drug use. Thus, I conclude without doubt that this is Sui Yuanhuai."

Deputy General He studied the severely burned face but found no clues. Turning to the grim-faced man seated in the Grand Tutor chair, he asked, "Marquis, what do you think?"

An aura of gloom surrounded Xie Zheng. Raising his eyes, he merely said, "With the rebel remnants executed, all should rejoice."

This implied his agreement that the corpse was indeed Sui Yuanhuai's.

With Xie Zheng's nod, Deputy General He breathed a sigh of relief.

Thus, the rebels who had plagued the northwest for so long were finally eradicated.

He cautiously inquired, "What of Sui Yuanhuai's concubine and only son..."

"Escort them to the capital to await imperial judgment."

Noticing Xie Zheng's visibly foul mood, Deputy General He ventured, "The Marquis doesn't seem pleased?"

Xie Zheng countered coldly, "With General Tang's tens of thousands of troops surrounding Chongzhou City, how did the rebel forces reach Lucheng?"

When Fan Changyu and Zheng Wenchang arrived with reinforcements, they had explained how the rebels evaded Chongzhou's siege. After hearing this, Xie Zheng gave a cold laugh and ordered, "Bring him in."

Dragged in by two personal guards was one of Sui Yuanhuai's advisors. Though bound tightly, he kowtowed desperately upon seeing Xie Zheng, pleading, "Marquis, this lowly one was truly forced to remain at Changxin Prince Manor! I only sought livelihood when I became an advisor there."

After Changxin Wang rebelled, I wanted to flee, but those who tried to leave were silenced. That's why I dared not escape."

A guard beside Xie Zheng barked, "How did Sui Yuanhuai's rebels escape Chongzhou? Speak truthfully!"

The advisor hurriedly answered, "It was Wei Yan colluding with Sui Yuanhuai! I once overheard Sui Yuanhuai and his strategist plotting—Wei Yan's agents in the army secretly helped them leave the city!"

Lu Dayi was precisely the man Wei Yan had recommended to join the army.

All evidence seemed to point to Wei Yan colluding with the rebels.

Deputy General He had never expected that the brutal battle in Lu City, which had nearly wiped out their entire force, was actually a political scheme. His eyes reddened with fury as he roared, "Bastards! Lord He was exhausted to death in those scoundrels' conspiracy!"

He dropped to his knees before Xie Zheng. "I beg the Marquis, when you return to the capital, to seek justice for Lord He and the soldiers who died in Lu City!"

Half of Xie Zheng's face was shrouded in the shadow of candlelight as he replied, "This blood debt—I will settle it."

Hearing Xie Zheng's words, Deputy General He thought of He Jingyuan's wrongful death and couldn't help wiping his tears with his sleeve.

Xie Zheng only said, "General, please restrain your grief."

His gaze fell upon the corpse covered with a white cloth, his eyes icy and piercing.

The dead man was not Sui Yuanhuai.

But from this moment on, there would no longer be a "Sui Yuanhuai" in this world.

Though the truth of Jinzhou seventeen years ago remained shrouded in mystery, the bloodshed in Lu City was enough to completely topple the Wei Faction.

Yet precisely because the evidence was too perfect—and because he knew Sui Yuanhuai's true identity—he grew even more suspicious of the truth behind this massacre.

Sui Yuanhuai, like himself, bore a grudge against Wei Yan. How could he have collaborated with Wei Yan?

This might very well be another massacre, identical in nature to the Jinzhou Massacre seventeen years ago.

Only this time, the mastermind knew full well that Xie Zheng also harbored a deep hatred for Wei Yan, and thus deliberately placed the evidence in his hands—making him the blade that would sever Wei Yan's head!

Xie Zheng's fingers tightened, snapping the wooden armrest of the Grand Tutor chair clean in half.

What he despised most in this life was precisely this kind of "scheme"—one that used the lives of countless soldiers as bargaining chips in political struggles!

The army led by Tang Peiyi did not arrive until dusk.

Upon entering the city and learning that though Lu City had been held, He Jingyuan had perished, Tang Peiyi—a man of towering stature—let out a guttural sob of grief. He knelt before the newly erected mourning hall and lamented, "This general is incompetent! I have failed Lord He and betrayed his trust!"

Deputy General He and the other officers who had once served under He Jingyuan all urged Tang Peiyi to restrain his sorrow.

"General Tang, do not blame yourself. This was not your fault. It was Wei Yan who colluded with the rebels—his crimes deserve death!" Deputy General He, though overcome with grief, spoke indignantly, recounting the confession of Sui Yuanhuai's advisor to the gathered men.

Battle-hardened generals valued courage above all else. Hearing that so many of their brothers had fallen in two grueling battles today—all due to the schemes of traitors—they cursed vehemently, swearing to bring Wei Yan to justice.

Li Huaian had followed the army to Lu City. Amid the clamor of curses, he silently gazed at He Jingyuan's coffin in the center of the mourning hall, his eyes turbulent with complex emotions.

Everything was proceeding according to the plan to overthrow Wei Yan—yet suddenly, his chest felt unbearably heavy.

The man lying in that coffin was a good official, a respectable elder.

But he had died in the grand scheme to topple Wei Yan.

Had he and his family chosen the wrong path after all?

A general clapped him heavily on the shoulder. Li Huaian turned to see the man's grief-stricken, reddened eyes. "Lord Li, you must petition His Majesty to seek justice for Lord He and the soldiers who died in Lu City."

Li Huaian met those sincere, sorrowful eyes and, after a long pause, managed to say, "It is my duty. Of course I will."

Did he feel guilty?

Yes.

But neither he nor the Li family had any way back now.

Outside the mourning hall, a commotion arose—the clamor of weeping and cursing gradually quieted.

Li Huaian looked up to see Xie Zheng stepping in from the outside, the thick night clinging to his figure. The cold moonlight cast upon his face, as if frosting it with a layer of chilling silver.

His arrival silenced everyone involuntarily.

Li Huaian had merely glanced over instinctively, only to meet Xie Zheng's gaze directly.

The cold ferocity in those eyes sent an indescribable chill down his spine in an instant.

It was as if he had already become prey marked for death in the eyes of a wild wolf.

Forcing himself to steady his nerves, he frowned and looked again, trying to discern something more, but Xie Zheng had already walked past him.

An attendant offered lit incense sticks. Xie Zheng took them, bowed three times before He Jingyuan's memorial tablet, and after inserting them into the incense burner, he lifted his gaze briefly to the tablet before leaving without a word.

His arrival was abrupt, and his departure just as sudden, yet no one dared to comment.

With the cries and curses against Wei Yan interrupted, the hall full of battle-hardened men saw no further weeping. Deputy General He arranged shifts for the vigil and dismissed the other generals who had rushed back from their arduous journeys to rest.

Walking alone to his temporary quarters, Li Huaian recalled the look in Xie Zheng's eyes when they had met, his brow furrowing unconsciously.

Did he already know something?

As he reached a small path ahead, he noticed someone seemingly waiting for him in the waterside pavilion. Slightly taken aback, he promptly clasped his hands and bowed respectfully. "Marquis."

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The night was cool as water, with shimmering ripples reflecting off the red-lacquered pillars of the waterside pavilion.

The figure standing inside the pavilion had his back turned, hands clasped behind him, his dark robes blending seamlessly with the thick night.

"Lord Li, have you decided how to word the memorial to the capital?"

A deep voice carried from the pavilion, laced with the chill of the night breeze.

Li Huaian replied respectfully, "Naturally, I shall report the truth to His Majesty."

As the Army Supervisor—the emperor's eyes in the northwest—he was duty-bound to relay all frontline military developments to the capital without delay.

Xie Zheng turned around, his phoenix eyes sharp and piercing. "As the Army Supervisor stationed in Chongzhou, Lord Li, are you not also accountable for the rebels slipping out of the city under cover of night?"

Li Huaian remained in his bow, his wide sleeves swaying in the lakeside wind, maintaining the dignified composure of a noble scholar.

He nodded. "Indeed, this official failed in his supervisory duties. I shall truthfully report to His Majesty and request punishment."

The wind by the lake was strong, and the two men stood a zhang apart, their hair and robes fluttering in the night breeze.

Xie Zheng, half a head taller, looked down at the man before him, who remained in his deferential posture.

He remained silent for a long while.

With his stern demeanor concealed beneath that coldly refined face, no trace of emotion escaped him, leaving others unable to guess his thoughts.

Yet the pressure Li Huaian felt did not lessen in the slightest.

He couldn't help but discreetly study the young man standing a zhang away.

Ennobled as a marquis before the age of twenty—one could say he was heaven's favored son.

Before the Battle of Chongzhou, Xie Zheng had never known defeat, nor had he ever tempered his edge. Everyone knew he was the sharpest blade in Great Yin.

But now, he no longer flaunted his brilliance. Instead, he resembled a weathered cliffside rock, enduring wind and sun yet still standing unyielding.

Xie Zheng asked, "Lord Li, as a man of great learning, you must have heard of 'Fighting South of the City'?"

Though they were of the same generation, Li Huaian inexplicably felt the same tension he would before his grandfather.

Suppressing the turmoil in his heart, he met Xie Zheng's gaze calmly. "What does the Marquis wish to say?"

Xie Zheng replied, "I would like to gift Lord Li two lines from 'Fighting South of the City': 'Soldiers perish in the wilds, generals' efforts come to naught. Thus we know war is a tool of slaughter, used only when the sage has no choice.'"

His tone was icy, each word striking heavily upon Li Huaian's heart.

Though he had suspected as much, hearing it spoken aloud still made Li Huaian's pupils contract sharply.

He truly knew everything!

Guilt and the terror of his family bearing eternal infamy now that the truth was uncovered tore at him, drenching his back in cold sweat in an instant.

Xie Zheng stepped out of the pavilion, pausing slightly as he passed Li Huaian. "I hope Lord Li will reflect deeply upon this poem."

Even after Xie Zheng had walked far away, Li Huaian remained motionless where he stood.

From the moment his grandfather had conspired with the imperial grandson to overthrow Wei Yan, he had known many would die.

But compared to toppling the Wei Faction and purging the corrupt court, what did the deaths of a few soldiers in this remote northwestern frontier matter?

When had any great reform ever been bloodless?

Minor reforms prioritize the people, with law as secondary. Major reforms prioritize the law, with people as secondary.

To truly overthrow Wei Yan, a great upheaval was necessary to breathe new life into Great Yin's decayed bureaucracy.

If people were secondary, then sacrifices were inevitable.

Yet after Xie Zheng uttered those words about "the sage using force only as a last resort," Li Huaian found himself unable to muster even the courage to argue that it was for the sake of upholding the empire.

From Chongzhou to Lucheng, he had followed the army's march, witnessing firsthand the brutality of war—mountains of corpses and rivers of blood.

To overthrow Wei Yan, they had personally orchestrated a living hell.

Covering his face with his hands, Li Huaian suddenly let out a sorrowful, bitter laugh.

He thought—they had been wrong.

Xie Zheng had just returned to his temporary residence when Xie Shiyi hurried in with a report: "Master, we've secretly arranged for Zhao Xun to examine Sui Yuanhuai's corpse. As you predicted, the dead man isn't Sui Yuanhuai but a body double raised by his side since childhood."

Lan Shi, who had once served the Crown Princess, was meticulous in her planning. After the fire in the Eastern Palace, she had prepared a body double for Sui Yuanhuai as a precaution.

Not only did the double resemble Sui Yuanhuai in stature, but to avoid detection by the prince's household, even his scars had been meticulously recreated—burn marks painstakingly branded onto his skin to match Sui Yuanhuai's own.

Sui Yuanhuai had endured excruciating pain to gradually replace his burned skin, preparing for the day he might reclaim the throne, while the double remained permanently scarred.

After all, those serving in Sui Yuanhuai's courtyard were all Lan Shi's people, and with Sui Yuanhuai's notorious reputation for cruelty, other servants in Changxin Prince Manor dared not approach his quarters.

He rarely appeared in public, and even when meeting the Princess of Changxin, he wore a mask.

Thus, for years, almost no one in the entire manor had seen Sui Yuanhuai's true face.

It seemed Lan Shi had prepared the double from the beginning for this very moment—to execute the golden cicada shedding its shell and escape Changxin Prince Manor.

Xie Zheng removed his dark outer robe and handed it to the personal guard at the door without a word.

Xie Shiyi cautiously added, "Zhao Xun also inspected the captured mother and son. He confirmed they aren't Sui Yuanhuai's concubine and only child either."

Seating himself behind the desk, Xie Zheng poured himself a cup of tea. "I know."

The woman by Sui Yuanhuai's side was Yu Qianqian. When the pair was captured, he had gone to see them immediately—they weren't Yu Qianqian and her child.

Previously unaware that Sui Yuanhuai's attack on Lucheng was a ruse, Xie Zheng now realized Sui Yuanhuai had long prepared for this escape.

Even the doubles for Yu Qianqian and her son had been arranged from the start.

Had Xie Zheng not arrived in time, Lucheng would have fallen. Though Tang Peiyi's reinforcements would eventually retake the city from the ragtag defenders, countless lives would have been lost in the interim.

Sui Yuanhuai would never restrain his forces—he wanted Lucheng to become a wasteland of suffering after its fall.

Only then could the censors wield each tragedy as a blade in their denunciations, pinning Wei Yan to these atrocities that would outrage both heaven and mankind.

Understanding this, Xie Zheng's expression grew even colder.

Misinterpreting his displeasure as frustration over Sui Yuanhuai's escape, Xie Shiyi said, "Xie Yi and the others are scouring the city inch by inch. They should find them soon."

But Xie Zheng ordered, "Recall them first."

Perplexed, Xie Shiyi asked, "Marquis, why?"

Xie Zheng's dark eyes reflected the shadows of the two candle flames on the bronze stand: "Sui Yuanhuai has long been connected with the Li family. Since Zhao Xun hasn't returned yet, if he's cautious enough, he won't seek refuge with the Zhao Family after escaping. His only option is to seek shelter with the Li family first. If he doesn't show himself voluntarily, searching would be futile."

Upon hearing this, Xie Shiyi immediately realized the situation was more complicated than it seemed. He asked, "Marquis, does that mean we can only wait now?"

Xie Zheng countered with another question instead of answering: "Is the Princess of Changxin also dead?"

Xie Shiyi nodded: "She was found in the tent along with the decoy corpse of Sui Yuanhuai. Both died by suicide."

"Suicide"—naturally, to avoid being captured alive and interrogated.

The generals pursuing the deserters could confirm the corpse was Sui Yuanhuai not only because of the luxurious attire and burn marks but also because the Princess of Changxin lay dead beside him.

That Sui Yuanhuai had brought the Princess of Changxin with him even after fleeing Chongzhou showed he had planned for every contingency.

Xie Zheng said, "Pass this news to Sui Yuanqing."

Xie Shiyi, the youngest among Xie Zheng's personal guards and less composed than Xie Wu and the others, scratched his head and asked, "Marquis, Sui Yuanqing is now just a prisoner. Even with this grudge of matricide, what use is telling him if we can't find Sui Yuanhuai?"

Xie Zheng only replied, "Just do as I say."

His words to Li Huaian earlier tonight had been deliberate.

Li Huaian didn't know how much Xie Zheng had uncovered, only that their plan had been exposed. He would surely try to contact Sui Yuanhuai

to discuss countermeasures.

All they needed was to keep a close watch on Li Huaian and wait for him to reveal Sui Yuanhuai's hiding place.

Just as Xie Shiyi was about to leave, he suddenly remembered another urgent matter and hesitated before speaking: "Marquis, about Miss Fan... I've also gathered the details..."

Moonlight filtered through the gauze window into the chamber, casting a silvery frost across the floor.

On the bed, the young woman's dark hair spilled across the pillow as she lay on her side, deep in slumber.

In the armchair by the window, a figure who had sat silently for an unknown length of time cast a slender shadow in the moonlight before the bed.

Xie Zheng held the bloodstained gauze Fan Changyu had discarded, quietly observing the slight figure beneath the thin quilt.

She had grown much thinner, her body covered in countless wounds large and small.

Curled on her side, she resembled a leopard ever-vigilant even in sleep.

Xie Shiyi's words echoed in his ears: "When the rebel army pressed against the city walls, Miss Fan feared Lu City wouldn't hold. She volunteered to challenge the rebel generals alone to buy time. It's said she claimed to be Meng Changyu, descendant of General Meng Shuyuan of Changshan, willing to die to uphold her ancestor's honor."

"The sixteen rebel fighters she faced wielded exceptionally ruthless techniques, unlike ordinary soldiers. Outnumbered, Miss Fan fought one against sixteen and nearly lost her life..."

Each word weighed heavily on Xie Zheng's heart, making it hard to breathe.

A sharp, lingering pain spread through his chest, and his throat itched. Afraid of disturbing her, he covered his mouth and suppressed a cough.

The thought that she had truly gone out intending to die—that had he arrived a moment later, she would have been nothing but a cold corpse beneath the city walls—suddenly unleashed a fury and dread that roared through his very bones.

The bloodied gauze she had discarded during her dressing changes in the laundry basket now seemed unbearably glaring.

When he first saw her during the day, her wounds had already been bandaged, showing no obvious signs of injury. It was only after hearing from Xie Shiyi that she had fought against more than ten Martial Assassins under Sui Yuanhuai's command that he realized what she had endured.

Those Martial Assassins by Sui Yuanhuai's side were originally left to the Crown Princess by the late Chengde Crown Prince. After the Crown Princess perished in the flames of the Eastern Palace, the Shadow Guards pledged their allegiance to Sui Yuanhuai—each one a peerless master, with few surviving encounters against them.

Xie Zheng felt his teeth ache with a dull throb, as if insects were gnawing at his veins. The veins at his temples bulged, and even the pain from his reopened whip wounds on his back faded into insignificance.

The realization that she had nearly died was like the nightmares that had haunted him throughout his youth, now awakened and gripping him once more.

Nothing else mattered—as long as she was alive.

In the darkness, Xie Zheng pressed a hand to his throbbing temple, his pale face appearing cold yet indescribably striking under the moonlight. His dark eyes remained fixed on the sleeping Fan Changyu.

Perhaps sensing his overly oppressive gaze even in her dreams, the woman curled slightly in discomfort.

Xie Zheng gently tucked a stray lock of hair behind her ear, his fingertips lingering near her cheek—as if yearning to touch her yet restraining himself with great effort. In a whisper, he said, "In this world, no one has the right to take your life."

Chapter 117

Fan Changyu had not slept well for two days and a night. After traveling all day and fighting on the battlefield until utterly exhausted, her slumber was more akin to a semi-conscious collapse than actual rest.

When she woke again, it was already the afternoon of the next day. Beyond the bleeding gashes, the soreness in her muscles had also peaked, making even the slightest movement excruciating. Changyu nearly couldn't get out of bed on her own.

The medic, Ah Hui, came to change her bandages. Changyu mentioned that her back ached strangely.

Ah Hui examined the bruises and dark purplish marks covering her body, her heart aching as she said, "Commander, your injuries aren't just from blades and axes—your entire back is bruised. Let me apply some medicine for swelling and trauma to help ease the pain."

Fan Changyu thanked her.

During the battle, she had been forced off her horse by the Martial Assassins, tumbling several times across the ground while dodging spears and halberds aimed at her. The bruises and impact wounds hadn't been obvious yesterday, but now that the swelling had set in, the sight was truly alarming.

To make it easier for Ah Hui to treat her, Changyu removed her outer robe and sat on a round stool, leaning forward over the table.

The knife wound on her abdomen wasn't deep—it hadn't reached her internal organs—but the gash was long, stretching almost to her waist. Fortunately, the arm she had injured was on the same side. When lying flat became unbearable due to the bruises on her back, she could sleep on her uninjured side instead.

Ah Hui gently swept Changyu's dark hair forward, then scooped out some medicinal oil with her fingers and began massaging the bruised areas on her back. As she worked, her eyes reddened.

Changyu's warm, fair complexion had lost some of its usual color due to her injuries, making the bruises and wounds stand out even more starkly.

When a tear fell onto Changyu's back, she turned in surprise, looking at the young girl whose eyes were as red as a rabbit's. "What's wrong?" she asked.

Ah Hui wiped her eyes clumsily with her sleeve, sniffing. "Commander, it must hurt terribly, doesn't it?"

Realizing the girl was distressed on her behalf, Changyu paused for a moment before smiling faintly. "It's not that bad, really."

She leaned back over the table, the curve of her lips gradually fading into something lonely.

How could it not hurt?

Back when she trained in martial arts with her father, she would sometimes get hurt. Too proud to admit it, she would stubbornly insist she was fine—until her mother pulled her aside to tend to her wounds. Only then would she grimace and cry out in pain while her mother gently scolded her. It all felt like it had happened just yesterday.

But now, she no longer had her parents. There was no one left in this world whom she could freely cry out to when she was hurt.

Ah Hui silently finished applying the oil to the bruises on her back, then suddenly made a small sound of surprise. "Commander, you're hurt here too."

She rubbed a spot near the base of Changyu's neck with her oil-slicked fingers. "It's red."

Changyu didn't pay it much mind. "Probably scraped by a rock when I fell off my horse."

Ah Hui studied the two small, fingernail-sized red marks more closely. Unlike the other bruises on Changyu's body—dark blue or purple—these were still fresh.

Ah Hui had just turned fifteen this year. Since her father was an Army Doctor, she had grown up learning medicine by osmosis. Because Changyu was a woman, she had been specifically assigned to tend to her wounds.

Once, she had seen similar red marks on the neck of a courtesan who had come for treatment. When the woman noticed Ah Hui staring, she had

covered her mouth with a silk handkerchief and giggled knowingly.

Her mother saw it and scolded her with a cold face, later telling her that such women were not proper and that she should avoid too much contact with them.

Ahui asked her mother why the woman had red marks on her neck—was she sick? Her mother only scolded her more harshly, saying a young lady ought to know shame.

To this day, Ahui still didn't know what those marks were, but privately, she guessed they couldn't be anything good.

Yet now, the commandant had similar red marks on the back of her neck...

Ahui racked her brains but couldn't figure it out, only concluding that the marks on the commandant must have been from the battlefield—different from those on the courtesan—

Fan Changyu knew nothing of this. At noon, Ahui brought her a bowl of lean meat porridge.

The Army Doctor had said that since she hadn't eaten for a long time, her body was too weak for rich nourishment. She must avoid overeating and instead have small, frequent meals.

At first, Fan Changyu hadn't felt particularly hungry, but after finishing the bowl of porridge, she still didn't feel full at all. Holding the empty bowl, she looked at Ahui with puppy-dog eyes. Ahui couldn't bear that pleading gaze, her eyebrows twisting in conflict. "Father said the commandant can only have one bowl of porridge for lunch..."

Fan Changyu didn't want to trouble the young girl further. After handing back the empty bowl, she asked about Xie Wu: "How is my brother doing?"

Ahui replied, "He hasn't woken yet, but this morning when I fed him medicine, he swallowed instinctively. Father said that as long as he can eat, his life is out of danger."

This was probably the best news Fan Changyu had heard in the past two days. She steadied herself against the bedpost and stood up. "I'll go see him."

Ahui hurried over to support her. "Commandant, you're still badly injured yourself! Father said you need to rest in bed for a few more days."

Fan Changyu only said, "I'm tough. It's fine."

Fan Changyu was tall for a woman, standing at least half a head taller than Ahui.

When helping her up, Ahui only had to tilt her head slightly to see the elegant line of her jaw. The afternoon sunlight fell on her pale, wounded profile, making even the fine down on her face clearly visible.

Ahui's cheeks flushed as she blurted out, "Commandant isn't tough at all! Commandant is the most beautiful woman Ahui has ever seen."

She had once seen a type of orchid in the city lord's garden—its leaves sharp as swords, rigid and unyielding, like a towering iron tree. Yet the flowers it bore were pure white as snow, blooming in clusters at the very center of those stacked sword-like leaves, breathtakingly beautiful.

The servants in the manor had tried to pick them, but the flowers were shielded by the sharp leaves, making it nearly impossible.

When she first saw Fan Changyu, covered in wounds—so badly hurt that Ahui trembled while bandaging her—yet still comforting her in return, Ahui had thought of those sword-leaved orchids.

She mused that only an Unrivaled Hero from the storybooks could ever be worthy of a woman like the commandant—

Xie Wu remained unconscious. After visiting him, Fan Changyu personally asked the Army Doctor about his condition. The physician said that given the severity of his injuries, it was a miracle he had survived at all. His left arm had taken a deep slash—though the limb was still attached, the bones inside were shattered. Even if he recovered, that arm would never be functional again.

Looking at the young man lying on the sickbed, Fan Changyu felt a pang of sorrow, remembering how he had risked his life to lead others in rescuing her that day.

But despite suffering multiple wounds, he had still clung to life—that alone was a blessing.

Fan Changyu's eyes reddened slightly as she murmured, "As long as he's alive, that's enough."

She was worried that the Army Doctor might be short-handed and Xie Wu wouldn't receive proper care, so she wanted to assign two soldiers to

assist. However, Ahui mentioned that someone had already come to watch over Xie Wu last night. The person looked unfamiliar, so she asked a few questions and was told they were Xie Wu's sworn brother from the army.

Fan Changyu immediately thought of Xie Zheng.

Since he had come to Lucheng, his personal guards must have followed.

The one who came to watch over Xie Wu last night was likely one of his former comrades.

Only after confirming Xie Wu's safety did Fan Changyu have the peace of mind to reflect on yesterday's events.

She hadn't expected to see Xie Zheng in Lucheng at all.

After the Li family and Wei Yan began vying for control of the military forces in Chongzhou and Jizhou, he had left for Kangcheng under the pretext of hunting down remnants of the rebels and never returned.

The journey from Kangcheng to Lucheng was even longer than coming from Chongzhou. For him to arrive in such a short time, his troops must have already been on the move.

Had he received advance notice, or was it mere coincidence that his army happened to be near Lucheng?

Fan Changyu was full of questions. And... what did that cold smirk and aggressive retort mean when she addressed him as "Marquis"?

The way he had looked at her before leaving made her feel even more unsettled.

She forcibly stopped herself from dwelling on Xie Zheng.

With Xie Wu out of danger, the priority now was rescuing Yu Qianqian.

The Army Doctor and Ahui kept a close watch on Fan Changyu. She excused herself to pay respects to He Jingyuan, and only then did the Army Doctor reluctantly allow her to leave the courtyard where the wounded officers were recuperating. Concerned about her injuries, he even sent Ahui to accompany her.

The mourning hall was draped in white. The large black character "奠" (condolence) on the dark coffin weighed heavily on the heart.

Suppressing the pain in her abdomen, Fan Changyu knelt and kowtowed three times before offering incense to He Jingyuan.

Madam He personally helped her up, her face etched with grief but still kind. "You must be Changyu. My husband often spoke of you."

She had only received the news this morning and rushed from Jizhou with her children, still covered in dust from the journey. Dressed in mourning attire with white fabric and black embroidery, her exhaustion was evident, and strands of silver peeked from her temples. Yet Fan Changyu felt an immediate kinship with her.

In a hoarse voice, she said, "Auntie."

Madam He responded with a sorrowful smile, then comforted her, "Good child, don't cry. Lucheng has been defended. My husband would rest in peace knowing this."

Fan Changyu nodded, fighting back the sting in her eyes.

With a sigh, Madam He added, "I heard you're also in the army. If you see Wen Chang, please tell him that neither my husband nor I blame him. He shouldn't torment himself."

Upon further inquiry, Fan Changyu learned that Zheng Wenchang had only regained consciousness this morning due to the heavy blow she had dealt him. He had come to kneel before He Jingyuan's coffin, refusing food or drink, and remained silent until Madam He arrived with her children. Overcome with shame, he had then left, unable to face her.

Fan Changyu agreed without hesitation.

Though she hadn't worked with Zheng Wenchang for long, she knew how deeply he revered He Jingyuan. The loss must have devastated him.

She planned to look for him in the military camp later, but as she left the mourning hall, she spotted him in a secluded corner by the wall, hidden under climbing vines.

His gaze was dark and fixed on her, as if he had been waiting for her.

Fan Changyu was about to approach when A Hui grabbed her arm, stammering, "C-Commander, that man looks really fierce. Did he have a grudge against you? You're still injured..."

Fan Changyu said, "That's General Zheng. Don't be afraid."

Only then did A Hui relax.

Supported by A Hui, Fan Changyu walked closer and called out, "General Zheng."

Zheng Wenchang was leaning against the wall, most of his face hidden in shadow. The faint stubble on his jaw gave him an overall disheveled appearance.

"The Commander played the hero—did you get what you wanted?" He lifted his head, looking at Fan Changyu with a mocking gaze.

Hearing him slander Fan Changyu, A Hui forgot her fear and snapped, "How dare you speak like that? What do you mean by 'playing the hero'? Do you even know the Commander was carried back from the battlefield with half her life gone? If not for her, Lu City wouldn't have held until the Marquis arrived with reinforcements!"

As Zheng Wenchang listened to these reproaches, the mockery and grief in his eyes only deepened. He stared at Fan Changyu and said, "I'd rather have been the one who died outside the city! Instead, I was knocked unconscious, only to wake up and be told the battle was already over—no chance left to avenge my mentor! What a joke!"

Fan Changyu had knocked him out precisely because she feared his grief and impulsiveness would drive him to charge out and throw his life away.

She said coldly, "If Lord He's prized disciple died senselessly on the battlefield out of sheer recklessness, that would be the real joke!"

Her plan had been to buy time until reinforcements arrived. If Zheng Wenchang had charged out, he would have recklessly plunged into enemy lines seeking revenge against Sui Yuanhuai.

Alone, no matter how skilled he was, how could he stand against twenty thousand soldiers? A single volley of arrows would have turned him into a pincushion.

Zheng Wenchang clenched his jaw at Fan Changyu's words, his gaze fixed on her. Suddenly, he took a step forward. A Hui, terrified he might attack Fan Changyu, cried out, "What are you doing?!"

Zheng Wenchang slammed a fist into the wall beside Fan Changyu and coldly spat out, "Once your injuries heal, we'll settle this."

With that, he strode off without a backward glance.

But A Hui's shout, combined with the crowd gathered to mourn He Jingyuan, had drawn many eyes their way.

Whispers spread: "Wasn't that General Zheng and Commander Fan? What happened?"

Someone stammered softly, "I-It looked like General Zheng had Commander Fan cornered against the wall..."

From a distance, the angle made Zheng Wenchang's punch seem more like a forceful pinning.

One person mused, "Could General Zheng have feelings for Commander Fan?"

This remark sent ripples through the crowd. Both were unmarried, worked closely together, and had faced life-and-death situations on the battlefield. Upon reflection, it didn't seem all that surprising.

Fan Changyu left without hearing the gossip, nor did she dwell on Zheng Wenchang's outburst.

It wasn't until she went to Tang Peiyi for a token to visit the imprisoned Yu Qianqian and her child that she learned just how absurd the rumors had become.

The incident began after she paid her respects to He Jingyuan. From the military officers nearby, she learned the location where the families of the rebels were being held. Though she couldn't rescue Yu Qianqian and her child at the moment, she thought she could at least bring them some food and necessities and instruct the jailers to ensure they weren't mistreated in prison.

When she arrived at the prison gate, the guards informed her that she needed a token from either Xie Zheng or Tang Peiyi to enter.

Naturally, Fan Changyu wouldn't ask Xie Zheng for such a favor.

After much effort, she managed to obtain a token from Tang Peiyi by fabricating an excuse. Before she left, however, Tang Peiyi chuckled and said, "I heard that Commander Fan and General Zheng are soon to be wed?"

Fan Changyu was baffled. "General, what do you mean by that?"

Tang Peiyi assumed she was just being coy, given her feminine modesty, and smiled. "No need to hide it from me, Commander Fan. The news about

you and General Zheng has spread throughout the camp. No wonder Lord He transferred General Zheng to Chongzhou to assist you before his passing.”

Fan Changyu grew even more confused. “Are you referring to General Zheng’s declaration that he’d challenge me to a duel once my injuries healed? What does that have to do with Lord He transferring him here?”

Tang Peiyi widened his eyes. “At this point, are you still playing dumb with me?”

Fan Changyu wasn’t pretending—she genuinely had no idea what he was talking about.

Seeing her truly clueless expression, Tang Peiyi also became puzzled. “I heard that you and General Zheng have developed feelings for each other. Yesterday, when he wanted to leave the city to avenge Lord He, you feared for his safety and knocked him out, taking his place instead.”

Fan Changyu felt as if she’d been struck by lightning.

She had finally witnessed how rumors could distort reality beyond recognition.

She recounted the actual events to Tang Peiyi, exasperated. “I was afraid General Zheng would throw his life away for nothing. Deputy General He was also present—you can ask him if you don’t believe me.”

Tang Peiyi hadn’t expected such a misunderstanding. He frowned. “Then why did General Zheng seek you out today?”

The rumor he’d heard was that Zheng Wenchang, upon learning she had taken his place and suffered severe injuries, was both heartbroken and furious. He had allegedly cornered her in public to “demand an explanation.”

Fan Changyu’s eyelid twitched. “He resented me for knocking him out that day and nearly came to blows with me. Only because I was injured did he postpone the fight.”

Tang Peiyi slammed the table in anger. “Outrageous! I’ll reprimand him later!”

Fan Changyu felt this was akin to tattling. If Tang Peiyi really scolded Zheng Wenchang, future encounters would only become more awkward. She quickly said, “Thank you for your concern, General, but it’s better for

me and General Zheng to settle this privately. After all... Lord He's death is truly an insurmountable grief for him."

He Jingyuan had also been a great benefactor to Tang Peiyi. Unable to lead reinforcements in time, Tang Peiyi carried his own guilt and understood Zheng Wenchang's feelings. He sighed. "Very well. You two may resolve this privately."

After leaving Tang Peiyi's presence, Fan Changyu sighed in frustration.

A'Xiang hung her head in remorse. "It's all my fault for shouting. I caused the rumors about you, Commander."

Fan Changyu ruffled A'Xiang's hair. "It's not your fault."

A'Xiang had only yelled out of fear that Zheng Wenchang might attack her. Who could have imagined such a trivial matter would be twisted into such salacious gossip by busybodies?

Upon reaching the prison, Fan Changyu presented her token to the guards. They informed her that only she could enter, so she instructed Ahui to wait outside while she carried bundles of supplies to visit Yu Qianqian.

The jailer led her to the innermost cell and said respectfully, "This is the place. But there are rules from above, and it's difficult for me to bend them. The Commandant may only stay for the duration of one incense stick."

Fan Changyu saw a woman in prison garb huddled in the darkest corner, shielding a child. Though she couldn't make out the woman's face clearly, her disheveled hair suggested she had suffered greatly.

Her heart ached, but she forced herself to remain composed and said to the jailer, "Understood. You may leave now."

Once the jailer had withdrawn, she called out to the woman inside, "Qianqian, I've come to see you. I haven't found a way to get you out yet, but I brought some things for you and Bao'er. Here's the pine nut candy Bao'er likes..."

At the sound of her voice, the woman flinched and clutched the child tighter, burying her face in her knees without responding.

Puzzled, Fan Changyu called again, "Qianqian?"

Still, the woman gave no reply. However, the child in her arms, hearing mention of pine nut candy, peeked up timidly at Fan Changyu.

The moment Fan Changyu saw the child's face, her expression shifted.

This wasn't Yu Bao'er!

Realizing the child had looked up, the woman panicked and quickly pressed the little one's head back against her chest, as if desperate to hide the fact that they were imposters.

But in that brief moment when she lifted her head, Fan Changyu had already glimpsed the stranger's face beneath the tangled hair.

For a moment, she didn't know whether to feel relief or renewed tension.

If the ones brought back weren't Yu Qianqian and her child, then the one who had supposedly been executed couldn't have been Sui Yuanhuai either!

She studied the woman—curled up, head bowed, trembling in the corner—for a long moment before silently passing all the food and bedding she had brought through the bars. Then, without a word, she turned and left the prison.

Yesterday, after Xie Zheng had been summoned away by his personal guard, he must have seen this mother and child. Did he not realize they were imposters, or had he known and simply allowed them to pass as Yu Qianqian and her son?

If it was the former, then she alone knew that remnants of the rebels still existed.

If it was the latter, what was Xie Zheng's purpose in declaring that all the rebels had been eliminated?

Lost in thought, Fan Changyu walked out of the prison with Ahui supporting her.

Suddenly, Ahui tightened her grip on Fan Changyu's uninjured arm and stammered, "C-Commandant."

"Hm?" Fan Changyu snapped out of her reverie and turned to Ahui.

Ahui, looking like a strangled chick, gestured with her eyes toward the path ahead.

Fan Changyu already had a sinking feeling. Sure enough, when she looked up, she saw a group approaching in the distance.

At their head was a man in a deep crimson brocade robe embroidered with swirling clouds, ocean waves, and mountain motifs. His face was as flawless as jade, his eyes cold as distant stars.

It was none other than Xie Zheng.

His hair was pulled back entirely, sharpening the severe lines of his features and erasing the last traces of youthful softness, leaving only an austere, striking handsomeness.

A few civil officials followed behind him, likely on their way to interrogate prisoners.

Fan Changyu cursed inwardly at the unfortunate timing.

Even now, she still didn't know what attitude to adopt when facing him—or how she should even address him.

After a brief moment of consideration, she still clasped her fists in the military salute and said, "Greetings, Marquis."

Unexpectedly, the other party didn't even glance in her direction. His handsome face seemed covered in a layer of frost as he walked past her indifferently, heading straight for the prison.

Fan Changyu was slightly taken aback.

A'xiao called out softly, "Commander, what's wrong?"

Changyu snapped out of her daze, suppressing the faint bitterness in her heart, and calmly replied, "It's nothing. Let's go."

This was how it should be when they met again.

Chapter 118

The pitch-black dungeon was a hellish sight.

The flickering torchlight from the wall niches illuminated the filthy bloodstains on the ground, while the various torture instruments placed on wooden racks were coated in a layer of dark red gore. The stench of decay and blood permeated the chamber, mingling with the endless screams of agony.

"Will you confess or not?"

"Will you confess or not!"

Each lash of the snakeskin whip sent blood spraying into the air.

The man shackled to the torture rack was disheveled, his face covered in blood and filth, barely able to breathe. Yet, every time the venomous whip struck his body, he couldn't suppress his hoarse, agonized screams before finally passing out from the pain.

Beneath the blood-soaked prisoner's garb, fresh wounds had opened, some even revealing tiny shreds of torn flesh.

The jailer wielding the whip had swung it so many times his arms had gone numb. He glared hatefully at the prisoner who, despite enduring dozens of lashes, still refused to talk. A thin layer of cold sweat clung to his temples as he turned fearfully toward the figure observing from the shadows and clasped his fists in salute. "Marquis, this man is stubborn—he still won't confess. If we continue, he might not survive."

Receiving no response, his unease grew. He cautiously lifted his gaze toward the darkness, only to see the man reclining in the Grand Tutor chair, elbow resting on the armrest, fingers lightly supporting his temple. His eyes were half-lidded, long lashes casting faint shadows beneath them, as if lost in thought.

The jailer mustered his courage and called again, "Marquis?"

The next moment, the man who had seemed lost in contemplation abruptly raised his gaze.

Those eyes—cold, ruthless, like a wolf’s—sent a shiver down the jailer’s spine. Trembling, he repeated, "W-we’ve tried all the tortures... he still won’t talk."

Xie Zheng’s icy, gloomy stare swept over the half-dead prisoner. "How many lashes?"

The jailer answered respectfully, "Forty-seven."

The number elicited no reaction from Xie Zheng, save for a faint trace of impatience in his brow. "Shiyi."

Xie Shiyi, standing beside him, stepped forward and gestured to the jailers. Immediately, one of them hauled over a bucket of cold water and doused the blood-drenched prisoner.

The unconscious man slowly stirred, his matted, dripping hair clinging to his face. He could barely stand, held up only by the iron chains binding him. His breath was weak, yet he still instinctively muttered, "I really... know nothing... nothing..."

Xie Shiyi merely smiled. "You have a daughter, married into the Gao family in Jinan."

At these words, the bloodied man’s vacant eyes flickered with terror.

Xie Shiyi continued leisurely, "And your youngest son is studying at Songshan Academy. Let me guess—the Li family promised you your children’s safety and future in exchange for your silence? If you die, your son will be favored in his official career, and your son-in-law will be promoted to the capital?"

"H-how do you know?" the prisoner gasped in horror before realizing his slip. He hastily denied it, "I have no children... I’m alone... I don’t know what you’re talking about..."

Behind him, Xie Zheng, seated in the Grand Tutor chair, had completely lost his patience. His voice was cold and detached: "Since my men can find your children, do you think those hypocritical scholars of the Li family can protect them? Freshly severed heads delivered posthaste to Jizhou Prefecture shouldn’t take more than three days."

As he spoke, he rose leisurely, slightly lowering his head to meet the gaze of the man bound to the torture rack. His sharp phoenix eyes were indifferent yet icy: "My patience has always been thin, Magistrate Liu. Have you thought it through?"

The bloodied man trembled like a sieve, his will utterly shattered. In a quivering voice, he confessed: "They're hidden in Deyue Villa."

The two accompanying scribes were first startled, then overjoyed, swiftly recording the confession on the official document.

With this answer, Xie Zheng's eyes frosted over. Without a backward glance, he strode out of the dungeon, Xie Shiyi hastily following.

Ever since that night when Xie Zheng had warned Li Huaian, he had kept close surveillance on the Li family's movements. However, the Lis were cunning old foxes, acting with extreme caution. It had taken great effort to capture one of Li Huaian's record keepers, only to find the man stubborn beyond belief.

Xie Zheng ordered a thorough investigation into the man's background and discovered he had changed his name after entering the Li family's service—likely to shield his family from repercussions should his deeds come to light. Yet those very family members, known only to the Lis, had become the leverage the Lis used to control him.

Xie Shiyi hurried to keep pace with Xie Zheng and asked, "Marquis, shall we dispatch troops to Deyue Villa immediately?"

Exiting the prison, the wind carried a hint of chill.

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes at the yellow leaves spiraling down from the treetops.

Autumn had arrived.

He replied languidly, "Select three hundred elite cavalry from the Tiger Step Battalion to surround Deyue Villa under the pretext of capturing bandits. Maintain close surveillance on the Li family."

Xie Shiyi hesitated briefly. "Marquis, this matter is of grave importance. Shouldn't we send the Blood-Clad Cavalry instead?"

The eight hundred Blood-Clad Cavalry under Xie Zheng's command were his personal guards, trained by his own hand. The first nineteen, granted the Xie surname, were the finest among them.

If the descendants of the Chengde Crown Prince were truly hidden in Deyue Villa, only Xie Zheng's most trusted forces should undertake this mission.

Yet Xie Zheng's lips curled into a cold smirk. "Deyue Villa is merely bait set by the Lis. Why the haste?"

Xie Shiyi was both shocked and puzzled. Had all the effort to break the Liu family's man been part of a counterploy, a performance for the Lis?

His eyes instantly shone with admiration, his heart surging with fervor as he prepared to follow Xie Zheng. But then the man ahead abruptly ordered, "Keep a close watch on that Zheng general under He Jingyuan's command as well."

His tone was frigid enough to freeze ice—

Li Residence.

Li Huaian, clad in an indigo Confucian robe, sat wearily at his desk, leaning back slightly. His long fingers rested lightly on his brow as he addressed the messenger before him: "Have Wu'an Marquis's men already left for Deyue Villa?"

The subordinate replied, "I witnessed several hundred riders departing Lucheng in secret."

Li Huaian lifted his eyelids, his pale eyes glinting like glass in the dappled sunlight filtering through the window lattice. "Send word to the villa. Have them proceed to the capital at once."

Deyue Villa was merely a decoy. With Wu'an Marquis's forces lured away, the imperial grandson could secretly enter the capital.

This was a stratagem to divert the enemy's attention.

The impeachment memorial against Wei Yan had already been sent to the capital. Once Wei Yan fell from power, they would announce they had found the descendants of the Chengde Crown Prince and "persuade" the Emperor to abdicate. Even if the Wu'an Marquis commanded troops in the northwest, he would be powerless to reverse the situation.

Unless he raised the banner of rebellion himself.

But the Xie Clan had always been loyal to the core. He knew that for the sake of the Xie Clan's ancestors' unblemished reputation, Xie Zheng would never take that step.

Moreover... there were still people in this world who could restrain him.

The messenger had already withdrawn, and the unlatched window was blown open by the evening breeze, letting in a slant of sunset light.

Li Huaian frowned slightly as he gazed at the recently completed painting on his desk.

The painting depicted a snowstorm weighing down green pines across a mountain. Amid the vast expanse of white, a small dot of apricot color on a rugged mountain path was the only bright spot in the entire scene.

Upon closer inspection, it was clearly a woman in an apricot-colored jacket and skirt, walking forward on the rugged path with her back turned. Her face was obscured, and her black hair was frosted with snow from prolonged travel. One bare foot, red from the cold, was exposed.

A general's success is built upon ten thousand bones.

The Li family had come too far to turn back now.

Yet even at this point, he still didn't want to drag her into this.

She was the most sincere and passionate woman he had ever met—like a sunbeam that exposed all the filth and ugliness in the world.

On the fourth day of Fan Changyu's bedridden recovery, Xie Qi and the personal guards she had sent finally escorted Changning and Aunt Zhao to Lucheng. The group had no trouble finding her residence.

When Changning and Aunt Zhao saw Fan Changyu so severely injured, they clung to her, weeping uncontrollably. It took Fan Changyu considerable effort to calm them down.

With more people around, squeezing into the small courtyard allocated by the military for recuperating officers was impractical. Fan Changyu had Xie Qi find a house in the city. Once everything was arranged, she moved in with Aunt Zhao and the others, bringing along the severely injured Xie Wu.

Xie Wu and Xie Qi were as close as brothers. Under Xie Qi's care and Aunt Zhao's daily nourishing soups, Xie Wu's gaunt cheeks from his injuries quickly regained their fullness.

When Changning heard that the rebels had been executed, her big dark eyes widened nervously as she asked Fan Changyu, "Sister, what about Bao'er and his mother?"

Fan Changyu had also been preoccupied with finding Yu Qianqian, but she had been confined to bed rest and knew little of the military's movements.

She could only pat Changning's little topknot and reassure her, "They weren't with the rebels. They must have escaped earlier."

Changning's chubby face scrunched up in worry. "Then... if we can't find Bao'er and his mother, they can't find us either..." She twisted her fingers and asked softly, "Will we ever see them again?"

Fan Changyu replied firmly, "We will."

Only then did Changning cheer up again. "Before Ning Niang was taken away, she told Bao'er that she'd find you and brother-in-law to save him. Ning Niang can't break her promise."

Fan Changyu smiled and ruffled her hair, though her eyes concealed many unspoken worries.

She had yet to hear any news about surviving rebel remnants and didn't know whether Xie Zheng was truly unaware or suppressing the information.

Thinking back to their accidental encounter outside the prison that day, her chest still felt heavy.

Perhaps she just hadn't gotten used to such a reunion.

Still, she wondered whom he had gone to interrogate in the prison that day. Surely it couldn't have been that mother and child...

She was deeply troubled. After He Jingyuan's funeral, she proposed returning to military duties, but Tang Peiyi advised her to take this opportunity to rest longer and wait for the official rewards from the capital before going back.

Fan Changyu found it hard to explain. She wanted to use her military connections to secretly search for Yu Qianqian and her child, and also to find out if Xie Zheng was still pursuing Sui Yuanhuai in secret.

The two of them now had no further contact. After the tragic battle at Lu City, she couldn't bring herself to drive Xie Wu and Xie Qi away again, treating them instead as her own brothers. At present, she had no idea what Xie Zheng was up to.

If Xie Zheng intended to deal with Sui Yuanhuai privately, they might be able to cooperate—as long as Yu Qianqian and her child were spared.

If Xie Zheng knew nothing about this, Fan Changyu felt she would have to find Sui Yuanhuai herself and end the threat once and for all.

Yu Qianqian had already lost the Overflowing Fragrance Pavilion. As a widow with her child, Yu Bao'er, she likely had nowhere to go. Yu Qianqian had once shown her kindness, and now that Fan Changyu had made a name for herself, she was willing to take them in.

Fan Changyu didn't know if she would regret this decision years later, but Yu Bao'er was just an innocent child who had done no wrong. He had been captured and taken to the Changxin Prince Manor alongside his mother. He shouldn't have to pay with his life for a birth he couldn't choose.

Fan Changyu also believed Yu Qianqian would raise Yu Bao'er well.

If, by some chance, Yu Bao'er grew up to be as wicked as the Sui father and son and tried to incite war, the boy would be right under her watch. She wouldn't hesitate to stop him before he could cause disaster.

After several days of frustrated convalescence at home, an unexpected visitor suddenly arrived.

At the time, she was being forced by Aunt Zhao to drink a freshly boiled bowl of old hen soup. Xie Qi entered and announced that Zheng Wenchang had come to visit and was waiting outside.

Fan Changyu wondered what had brought him here unannounced.

Was he here to challenge her to a duel?

If so, her injuries hadn't fully healed yet. Another fight would likely land her back in bed for days.

She said, "Show him in first."

Not long ago, the two of them had been caught up in some absurd rumors in the army. Fan Changyu didn't want anyone seeing them together and stirring up more trouble.

But Xie Qi wore a strange expression. "Commandant, you'd better come see for yourself."

Fan Changyu changed into more presentable clothes and went to the gate, where she saw Zheng Wenchang kneeling shirtless with a bundle of thorny branches strapped to his back. Her eyelids twitched violently.

She quickly motioned for Xie Qi to help him up in her stead. "General Zheng, what is this? Please rise at once!"

Zheng Wenchang remained kneeling, unmoving. Only when he saw Fan Changyu did he clasp his fists and say, "I am ashamed. I have come bearing thorns to seek forgiveness from Commandant Fan. My first offense: on the day the rebels attacked the city, you struck me unconscious, fearing I would act recklessly. Yet I failed to recognize your good intentions and nearly fought you outside Lord He's memorial hall. This was dishonorable."

"My second offense: our quarrel was misunderstood by others, damaging your reputation. This was discourteous. I beg you to whip me with these thorns. Otherwise, I cannot face you now—nor Lord He in the afterlife!"

Zheng Wenchang was always rigidly upright, to the point of being overly inflexible.

Fan Changyu sighed, "General Zheng, there's no need to feel burdened. Lord He treated me with equal kindness, and I understand the state of mind you were in at the time. I never held that day's events against you. If Lord He knew in the afterlife that you've regained your strength, he would be truly comforted. As for those absurd rumors, they're nothing but nonsense—why pay them any heed?"

Zheng Wenchang, usually a cold and unyielding man, now wore a rare expression of shame and lowered his head. "I am ashamed. Despite my years of experience in the army, my vision and temperament still fall short of yours, Commandant."

Fan Changyu replied, "In matters concerning Lord He, General Zheng, your concern simply clouded your judgment. There's nothing to reproach yourself for. I've never taken those rumors seriously, so you needn't blame yourself either. As comrades who both received Lord He's teachings, we should never have let discord come between us. In the days ahead, I hope to learn much from you, General Zheng."

Zheng Wenchang clasped his fists deeply toward her once more. "I dare not presume to teach. In the future, I shall be at your command, Commandant."

With that, she and Zheng Wenchang were fully reconciled.

Though Zheng Wenchang's act of apology had been somewhat exaggerated, it thoroughly dispelled the lingering rumors.

Between her and Zheng Wenchang, beyond their previous camaraderie as fellow soldiers, there now existed an additional bond of shared discipleship under Lord He's guidance.

Half a month later, the army held a victory banquet.

The rebels had all been executed, but the official rewards were delayed. They would have to go to the capital to receive their honors directly from the emperor in the Golden Hall. Moreover, the court was in an uproar over the memorials impeaching Wei Yan, leaving the emperor with no time to draft the reward decrees for the time being.

Not all soldiers could accompany them to the capital, so the victory banquet naturally had to be held in the Jizhou military camp.

As the hero who defended Lucheng, Fan Changyu, despite holding only a fifth-rank position, was seated near the front, directly behind Deputy General He. One seat behind her was Zheng Wenchang, who outranked her by one grade.

The soldiers who had followed Xie Wu out of the city, though of lower rank, were also given seats at the banquet. Apart from Xie Wu, the others seemed torn between joy and unease.

Fan Changyu surmised that the seating was arranged according to merit.

The foremost seat at the head of the hall was conspicuously empty—clearly reserved for Xie Zheng.

Strangely, the first seat on the right side, among the civil officials, was also vacant.

Fan Changyu guessed that spot must belong to Li Huaian.

As the military officers gradually took their seats, the hall grew livelier. Even before the banquet began, many officers came to toast her, as if aware she had performed another great feat and would soon be promoted upon reaching the capital.

Though Fan Changyu's injuries had mostly healed, she insisted on drinking tea instead of wine, citing her wounds.

First, her injuries weren't entirely healed, and second, her alcohol tolerance wasn't exceptional. Once the toasts started, they wouldn't stop—accepting one officer's toast but refusing another's would only invite offense. If she drank them all, she'd likely be passed out before the banquet even began.

Having declined the toasts, she found herself seated between Deputy General He on her left and Zheng Wenchang on her right, leaving her with no one to chat with to pass the time.

If the seating hadn't been fixed, she would have squeezed in beside Xie Wu and the others.

Just as the banquet was about to begin, Xie Zheng arrived right on time. But the seat opposite, meant for Li Huaian, remained empty. Fan Changyu couldn't tell if he was simply late or had decided not to come at all.

To avoid the awkwardness of meeting Xie Zheng's gaze, she kept her head down the entire time, nibbling on the cold dishes already laid out on the low table before her.

By the time the maids filed in, placing the aromatic meat dishes one after another, Fan Changyu had already taken a few bites of the braised pork knuckle. Only then did she hear Xie Zheng's deep voice from the head of the hall: "Lord Li has caught a chill and cannot attend tonight's victory banquet. Nevertheless, let the festivities continue. The rebellion in Chongzhou lasted a year and a half before finally being quelled. You are all heroes of Great Yin. As the marquis, I propose the first toast to you all!"

From the corner of her eye, Changyu noticed those around her rising with cups in hand, so she too stood and raised her cup. As she lifted her gaze, she caught sight of Xie Zheng standing at the front of the hall. For some reason, the phrase "heaven's favored son" suddenly came to mind.

Clad in a black satin robe embroidered with golden pythons, his hair half-bound by a golden crown, his sharp, cold features exuded authority. The wide sleeves of his robe, adorned with five-colored cloud patterns, shimmered brilliantly under the candlelight, as though mountains, rivers, and seas all lay within their folds.

Once upon a time, what Changyu feared most was his radiant brilliance amidst the crowd, while she remained as ordinary as a grain of sand, destined to drift apart from him. That was why she had strived so hard to catch up, to stand beside him.

Now, she had come far enough on that path, but what drove her forward was no longer him.

The wine went down her throat, suddenly stirring a pang of melancholy within her.

Changyu thought to herself that her tolerance for alcohol couldn't possibly be this poor—was she already tipsy after just one cup?

As the banquet commenced, the hall buzzed with the clinking of cups. Deputy General He, Tang Peiyi, and other seasoned officers went to toast Xie Zheng. Zheng Wenchang, perhaps noticing Changyu's solitary focus on the dishes, approached her and said, "Zheng proposes a toast to Commandant Fan."

Changyu raised her teacup in response, drinking in lieu of wine.

No sooner had she set the cup down than she felt an icy gaze land on the top of her head, so palpable it seemed capable of drilling a hole through her scalp.

Instinctively, she looked up toward Xie Zheng, only to find him turned away, speaking quietly to Tang Peiyi.

Puzzled, Changyu wondered if it hadn't been him after all.

Under Xie Zheng's command, military banquets strictly forbade entertainers like dancers.

After three rounds of drinks, the crowd grew pleasantly tipsy. Some musically inclined officers began playing the huqin right at their seats, while the civil officials, inspired by the mood, recited poetry. Later, the drunken crowd broke into military songs.

"Who says we lack robes? We share with our comrades. When the king calls for war, we sharpen our spears..."

The deep, stirring voices rose to the rafters, evoking battles fought as if they were just yesterday. Changyu listened, deeply moved.

The fallen were gone, but the living carried on—there were still long roads ahead.

A drunken officer staggered over to toast Changyu, hiccuping as he declared, "Commandant Fan, you—hic—you gotta drink with old Chen here. I respect you—hic—from the bottom of my heart. Before meeting you, I never believed—hic—a woman could fight on the battlefield."

The man was too far gone to listen to her excuse of being injured and unable to drink. He kept insisting, so Changyu had no choice but to accept the toast.

Little did she know this would open the floodgates. Every officer still standing wobbled to their feet, cups raised, clamoring to toast her.

Fan Changyu forced herself to drink five or six cups before she started feeling lightheaded. Her face flushed red as she waved her hand, saying she couldn't drink anymore.

Xie Zheng, seated at the head of the table, heard the commotion and glanced over, his eyes already tinged with a frosty glint.

Xie Wu noticed the situation and came over, offering to drink in Fan Changyu's stead. However, his status wasn't high enough, and the military officers wouldn't allow it.

Just as Fan Changyu was about to feign drunkenness by collapsing onto the table, Zheng Wenchang suddenly spoke up beside her: "Captain Fan is still recovering from her injuries. I'll drink for her."

With that, he picked up the wine bowl and downed it in one go.

The crowd was stunned for a moment before erupting into teasing laughter.

Though the rumors between him and Fan Changyu had been dispelled after his public apology, this sudden gesture made them sense something fishy again.

Fan Changyu hadn't expected Zheng Wenchang to help her either and was momentarily stunned.

Tang Peiyi glanced over at the commotion and said to Xie Zheng with a wry smile, "That kid..."

But Xie Zheng couldn't muster a smile. The cup in his hand shattered into pieces, the broken porcelain cutting into his fingers as blood welled up.

Noticing the anomaly, Tang Peiyi turned back and saw Xie Zheng, who merely said in a calm voice, "I've had too much to drink and lost my grip. Generals, please continue the feast. This Marquis will excuse himself for a moment."

Watching Xie Zheng's retreating figure through the side door, then glancing at Fan Changyu surrounded by a crowd of officers, Tang Peiyi nudged Deputy General He with his elbow. "Old He, don't you think there's something odd between the Marquis and Commander Fan?"

Deputy General He, recalling what he had witnessed that day, poked at the few remaining peanuts on his plate, pretending to be oblivious. "How would I know...?"

After enduring the round of toasts, Fan Changyu quickly feigned drunkenness and was escorted away by two maids.

Once in a secluded spot, she dismissed the maids and planned to sit somewhere to sober up in the breeze. But after walking a while, the alcohol's delayed effects hit her. Earlier, she had only felt her face burning, but now her steps were unsteady.

Thinking she might wash her face, she looked around but couldn't find a clean room. Instead, she spotted a row of water-filled vats against a wall far from the main hall—reserved for fire emergencies.

Light-headed, she approached a vat, scooped water to splash on her face, and finding it still too hot, plunged her entire head into the water.

Just as she began to feel slightly clearer, someone grabbed her collar and yanked her up, likely mistaking her for a drunk drowning.

After muttering twice that she wasn't drunk, Fan Changyu, still dangling, stared blankly at the frosty face under the moonlight.

It took her a while to recognize who it was. Her alcohol-slowed mind processed the situation before she clumsily clasped her hands in a salute. "Greetings, Marquis."

The grip on her collar suddenly loosened, and Fan Changyu tumbled to the ground, sitting slumped against the wall.

Her body felt as soft as cotton, so the fall didn't hurt. She instinctively brushed off the dust on her clothes.

But for some reason, as she did, an overwhelming sense of grievance welled up. Her eyes stung, and a tear fell.

She stared at the droplet on her hand, not even realizing it was her own tear.

The person beside her crouched down. His moonlit face resembled cold jade, his expression icy. Wiping the tear from her eye, he asked, "Besides 'Marquis,' what else do you call me?"

His tone carried self-mockery and suppressed fury. His fingertips bore wounds, the scent of blood lingering—cuts from the shattered cup at the banquet.

Drunk, Fan Changyu became utterly sluggish. She couldn't recall why she had suddenly wanted to cry. After staring at his handsome face for a long moment, she uttered two words: "Yan Zheng."

She reached up and patted his head. "You're Yan Zheng!"

Xie Zheng's fingers near her face stiffened, the dark depths of his eyes swirling with terrifying intensity.

Unfortunately, Fan Changyu had turned into a drunkard and couldn't see clearly. Her attention was drawn by the scent of blood to his hands covered in wounds. Her delicate brows furrowed as she muttered, "You're bleeding..."

She lowered her head, fumbling with her robe as if searching for the inner lining. Finally finding it, she was about to tear off a corner when suddenly her chin was forcefully seized. Wincing in pain, she was forced to tilt her head up, only to meet a pair of pitch-black eyes before her breath was stolen away.

By the time her teeth were pried open and her lips and tongue ravaged, she belatedly realized what this person before her was doing. Angrily, she pushed against him but couldn't budge him—instead, she found herself pressed against the wall.

Just as Fan Changyu was on the verge of suffocating from lack of air, the person finally released her.

Her lips throbbed, her mind was dazed, but she still remembered her anger and continued pushing, trying to shove him away—to no avail.

She was pulled into a crushing embrace, the force making her bones ache faintly.

The man buried his face in the crook of her neck. Despite his overwhelming dominance, his posture was fragile and desperate, like someone who had wandered the desert too long and finally glimpsed the way home.

"Fan Changyu, I regret it."

Warm tears soaked through her clothes, spreading across Changyu's shoulder.

Chapter 119

Dawn had just broken, and a fine layer of morning dew condensed on the leaves of the purple bamboo in the courtyard.

Fan Changyu groggily opened her eyes, feeling a throbbing pain in her head.

Did I get drunk last night after all?

She frowned and raised a hand to rub her temples. As she breathed, she noticed an unfamiliar scent on the bedding. A jolt went through her, waking her completely. She instinctively looked down, relieved to find her clothes were still properly on.

But what met her eyes was a dark quilt cover with a pattern of rhombic flowers and birds in nests. The gauze canopy, embroidered with interlocking lotus vines, was only half-drawn near the head of the bed. Golden morning light scattered across it, making the dark lotus patterns seem to glow with a brilliant light.

Fan Changyu assumed she had passed out from drinking and been temporarily placed in a room in the City Lord's manor. Breathing a sigh of relief, she pushed herself up into a sitting position.

"You're awake?" A low, hoarse, and clear voice sounded from outside the bed curtains.

Fan Changyu froze. She turned to look, and through the gold-threaded gauze canopy, she could vaguely make out a person sitting before the mullioned window opposite her. He wore a python robe and a jade belt, his black hair half-loose and half-bound by a golden coronet. He had been sitting there for who knows how long, as silent as a statue in the morning light.

Xie Zheng?

Was she in his room?

For a long moment, Fan Changyu's mind was a complete blank.

The post-drunkenness headache was severe. She had no choice but to press a hand to her temple and carefully recall the events of last night.

She remembered feigning drunkenness and being helped out of the front hall by a maid. But later, when she was looking for a place to sober up, it seemed she had truly gotten drunk. The last image in her mind was of herself washing her face in a water vat before being hauled up by Xie Zheng.

He had seen her when she was drunk?

Given their current relationship, why didn't he just have a maid send her to a guest room to rest? Why bring her back to his own room?

Fan Changyu's mind was filled with questions, but she couldn't remember a single thing that happened after she got drunk. Fearing there might have been some misunderstanding, she could only speak first. "My apologies, I was drunk last night. I... I didn't cause you any trouble, did I, Marquis?"

Through the gauze canopy, she couldn't see the expression on the man's face as he sat in the mahogany chair, but she could feel the atmosphere in the room suddenly turn heavy.

Fan Changyu didn't know if it was something she said that had displeased him, or if she had indeed been impolite last night.

She could hear the sounds of early-rising servants moving about in the courtyard. Worried that she would be seen leaving Xie Zheng's room if she waited any longer, she lifted the gold-threaded canopy and got up. As she pulled on her boots, she said, "If I truly caused any offense last night, this subordinate will make amends to the Marquis another day..."

The man, who had been silent all this time, suddenly let out a derisive laugh. "What offense could you cause me?"

He had probably been sitting here all night, as his voice was as hoarse as if his throat were filled with sand. Yet his words were sharp and cold, as if he utterly hated the way she constantly drew a line between them.

Fan Changyu's hands, pulling on her tall boots, paused. A deathly silence spread between them.

After putting on her boots, she looked up. Without the layer of gauze obstructing her view, she could clearly see his pale face. The corners of his

eyes were tinged with scarlet from the sleepless night, and the fingertips of the hand resting before his knee were crusted with dried blood.

Anyone could see his exhaustion, yet he was like a tautly drawn bowstring, making one fear the madness and distortion that would seep out from the cracks once that feigned calm shattered.

Seeing him like this, Fan Changyu felt a dull ache in her heart for some reason.

The Xie Zheng in her memory had always been proud and arrogant. Even when his life had been hanging by a thread and she had found him, he had never shown the slightest hint of weakness.

But now, he made her feel that his pride and causticity, which were like a body full of sharp thorns, were merely a thin layer of ice on a lake's surface. The slightest touch of the sun could make it crack.

As if realizing his own words had been too sharp, Xie Zheng fell silent for two breaths, then rose and walked toward the door. "What do you want to eat?"

His tone was so natural it was as if this was how they were always meant to be, as if the feud between their fathers had never created a rift between them.

Some memories of their past time together were awakened. Fan Changyu had once thought she could face it all calmly, but at this moment, she was still seized by that heart-wrenching sorrow.

"Xie Zheng."

The man, whose hand was already on the door bolt, stopped dead in his tracks at her words.

Fan Changyu looked at his elegant back, took a deep breath, and when she spoke again, her voice was still tinged with hoarseness. "We haven't spoken properly since we parted in Chongzhou. Why don't we take this chance today to clear the air?"

The man with his back to her said nothing, but he showed no intention of leaving, as if waiting for her to continue.

Fan Changyu said, "I am very sorry about General Xie's death."

At the mention of Xie Linshan, Xie Zheng remained silent. His back was to her, so she couldn't see his expression, but the veins on the hand

gripping the door bolt bulged from the force he was exerting.

"I don't blame you for the choice you made that day, or for the words you said. Until the truth of what happened seventeen years ago is thoroughly investigated, I won't ask you to believe my maternal grandfather and my father again. You, out of consideration for Grand Tutor Tao, once said that you would only see me as a fellow apprentice from now on. But I cannot be as detached as you, Marquis."

Fan Changyu stared at his back, her eyes already stinging uncontrollably, but she still enunciated each word seriously. "Let's be strangers from now on. I've imposed on you today."

When her mother was alive, she always said that she was big-hearted, but for the people she truly took to heart, losing any one of them was like losing half her life.

She didn't fall for someone easily, and once she did, how could she let go just because she was told to?

Her father's feud, the imperial marriage decree—too much already stood between them. In the end, there was no going back.

Crack—

The sound of splintering wood came from the door. Xie Zheng had snapped the door bolt.

Fan Changyu's heart instinctively jumped with it.

She saw his blood-crusted fingers, now oozing tiny beads of blood from the force, yet he seemed completely oblivious to the pain. With his back still to her, he asked, "What if I told you I regret it?"

Fan Changyu's pupils widened slightly, not understanding the meaning of his words for a moment. "What?"

Xie Zheng turned around, his eyes nothing but an inky blackness. A crimson bead of blood traced a path over his pale, slender knuckles and fell to the floor, bursting into a tiny blood-flower, like a teardrop of blood.

"I said, I regret it."

He spoke slowly, his tone pale and stubborn.

The words sent a numbing shock through Fan Changyu's heart, followed by an endless bitterness. She remained silent for a long time.

The doorframe blocked the morning light pouring in from outside. Xie Zheng stood there, his entire being seeming to merge with the shadows. Fan Changyu was standing right across from the mullioned window, and the morning sun fell fully upon her, vibrant and warm.

The dividing line between light and dark was like an insurmountable chasm.

After a long while, Fan Changyu heard herself ask in a hoarse voice, "You regret it, so what?"

Xie Zheng watched her quietly, not a glimmer of light visible in his pitch-black pupils. "Can we go back to how we were before? Please?"

He had tried to give her up, but these past days had probably been the greatest torment and pain he had ever endured in his life.

At first, he thought he would slowly get used to it, just as he had been unable to accept his parents' successive deaths as a child. No matter how painful, he could endure it.

If not a day, then a month. If not a month, then a year... But he couldn't even last a month.

The space in his chest was terribly empty. The longer he was away from her, the more that hollowness grew, almost driving him mad.

Endless slaughter and pain couldn't alleviate it in the slightest.

Many times, Xie Zheng wondered if he was already dead.

No, death would be better than this torment.

It was as if she were a part of his very life, so once he lost her, he became lost and dispirited, like a walking corpse.

For countless days and nights, she and the tragic scene of Xie Linshan's death in battle at Jinzhou seventeen years ago appeared alternately in his dreams, making him struggle, drenched in blood, in the endless darkness.

It seemed his life was meant only for revenge, that he was unworthy of a single shred of joy or pity in this world.

But he had received the purest, most ardent love from her.

She was the one who let him know that this world was not only filled with bitterness.

But the image of Xie Linshan's abdomen—disemboweled, its organs scooped out, and finally sewn shut crookedly by a medical officer—and those wounds from swords and axes that cut deep to the bone, also constantly suffocated him.

As he was being driven mad by the torment of hatred and love, he was shocked to realize that he hated her too.

Her father's generation had killed his father! It had made him suffer for half his life.

She had shown him what love was, only to have those budding threads of affection torture him day and night, ensuring he would never know peace for the rest of his life!

At the peak of his hatred, he had thought about taking her with him to die after his great revenge was complete.

If they could not share a bed in life, then they would share a tomb in death.

He would no longer have to endure such pain and torment. On the Bridge of Helplessness, he could hold her hand and go to the next life together.

In their next life, they probably wouldn't be separated by such a bloody, generational feud. Perhaps he could have known her since childhood, his childhood sweetheart... She liked scholars, so he would become a refined scholar, earn a title, and in the year of her hairpin ceremony, marry her and have children...

But it was just a thought.

If he could have borne to hurt her in the slightest, he wouldn't have only said that he would never see her again in this life.

When he saw her again and learned that she had already walked through the gates of hell and back, the terror that made his teeth chatter and his whole body tremble with rage and helplessness—he never wanted to experience that a second time in his life.

Xie Zheng looked at the young woman in military attire standing in the morning light. Even the strands of her hair were dusted with a layer of pale gold, as if she were a deity who had mistakenly wandered into the mortal world.

The scene from last night's banquet, when Zheng Wenchang had toasted her on his behalf, flashed before his eyes again. The jealousy clamoring in his heart grew wildly like weeds.

Could she be a deity for him alone?

A long time passed without an answer from Fan Changyu.

Xie Zheng unconsciously clenched his fists. The faint pain from the wounds on his fingertips made him more clear-headed, and his black eyes grew deeper and more somber.

Fan Changyu was simply stunned.

Go back to how they were before?

How could they go back to how they were before?

The feud between their fathers stood between them. Even if the Jinzhou Massacre from seventeen years ago could eventually be cleared up, the emperor had already decreed a marriage. He was going to marry a princess. What would that make them?

Fan Changyu had heard that some high-ranking officials kept mistresses. Could it be that he wanted her to be his mistress?

Fan Changyu suddenly felt it was hard to breathe. A sharp, piercing pain rose from the bottom of her heart, blurring her vision. She held back the stinging sensation that was madly welling up in her eyes and retorted, "How does the Marquis think we can go back to how we were before?"

"Can the Marquis act as if the matter of Jinzhou never happened? Or can he have His Majesty retract the imperial marriage decree?"

As she spoke the last sentence, even though she had clenched her jaw, a tear she had held back for so long finally escaped and fell heavily to the ground.

Hearing the first half of her question, Xie Zheng's eyes turned frighteningly gloomy. After hearing the second half, he suddenly shot his gaze up. "Who told you the emperor decreed a marriage for me?"

Chapter 120

Before Fan Changyu could answer, he let out a low laugh. "Li Huaian, wasn't it?"

He had cut off one of the decree-announcing eunuch's ears, making the eunuch flee back to the capital in a panic without even unrolling the imperial decree.

The young emperor, concerned with his reputation, would surely suppress the matter.

Since the imperial decree was never announced, his so-called betrothal to the grand princess was nothing more than baseless rumor. The news had not even spread in the capital yet, but she, far away in the Northwest, knew about his betrothal. The only way was through Li Huaian.

Fan Changyu was taken aback for a moment by the ferocity emanating from him, then she looked him straight in the eye and said, "It has nothing to do with who told me. You already have a marriage agreement. You shouldn't have said those things to me. What do you take me for? And what do you take that 'past' you speak of for?"

She had always been slow when it came to matters of the heart, but as she spoke the last sentence, she felt a sharp, sorrowful pang in her chest, and a bitter sting rushed to her eyes.

In her heart, he had always been a good person. Even if the enmity between their fathers meant they had to go their separate ways, she still wished him a smooth life, to continue being admired by the masses, to remain the Wu'an Marquis with his glorious military achievements and a reputation that awed the world.

Even if things were no longer the same, she would not allow anyone to ruin those beautiful memories of the past.

Not even him!

Hearing Fan Changyu's questioning, the ferocity enveloping Xie Zheng stalled, and for a moment, he was lost in a daze.

As the sun rose higher, a sliver of morning light slanted through the mullioned window, casting a warm glow on one side of his jade-like profile. His long, dark lashes were half-lowered, and for an instant, he looked as pure as a child.

After a long while, he finally raised his head to look at Fan Changyu again. His eyes were bloodshot from a sleepless night. Though his face was placid, his calmness at that moment was all the more frightening.

When he stepped forward, Fan Changyu subconsciously took a step back. But she was already standing before the bed, and this retreat sent her back crashing into the bedpost.

All the alarm and momentary confusion in her eyes were captured by the man walking toward her against the light.

Xie Zheng's face still showed no trace of emotion. He only reached out a blood-stained hand to cup Fan Changyu's face, lowering his head slightly to meet her gaze. With eyes that seemed to be covered in a web of blood-red threads, he stared at her quietly. "Did that Li Huaian tell you that I cut off the decree-announcing eunuch's ear and sent him scrambling back to the capital before he could even announce the decree?"

Fan Changyu froze.

His blood-stained fingers gently caressed her cheek as he asked softly, "When we met again in Lucheng, you were distant with me at every turn. It was because of what Li Huaian told you, wasn't it?"

A lump in Fan Changyu's throat kept her from speaking. Only large teardrops rolled down from her eyes.

Xie Zheng wiped them away with his thumb, comforting her in a low voice, "Don't cry."

He was as gentle as he had always been.

Fan Changyu was so gripped by a heart-wrenching sorrow that she could barely breathe. Tears fell like pearls from a broken string. She looked at Xie Zheng, her voice almost pleading, "Don't be like this... Xie Zheng, please don't be like this..."

Her heart wasn't made of stone. She had spent a very, very long time healing the cracks in it, so that when she saw him again, she wouldn't be overwhelmed by a heart-rending grief.

She didn't want to tear open those wounds, the ones that pained her so much she trembled at night, in the face of his tenderness.

If the two of them were destined to have no future, with him shouldering a tragic burden and her a wrongful accusation, then she had to keep moving forward.

Even if she had to break her bones and crawl, she would crawl step by step toward that truth.

Seeing her like this, the crimson in Xie Zheng's eyes deepened.

He wrapped an arm around her shoulder, lowered his head to rest his forehead lightly against hers, and asked stubbornly, "Fan Changyu, let's go back to how we were before, all right?"

Go back to how we were before.

Those words once again leaped into Fan Changyu's ears. Besides heartache, she felt only a sense of powerlessness, as if she were being swept away by fate.

She desperately suppressed her emotions. "Do you no longer care about the truth of the Jinzhou case?"

As her words fell, a dead silence descended between them again.

Fan Changyu could feel the hand gripping her shoulder tighten, and the blood seeping from his fingertips stained her robe red.

They were too close. The scent of blood couldn't mask the clean, crisp fragrance of soap pods on him.

This was likely the closest she would ever be to him again.

Fan Changyu closed her eyes in sorrow, trying to control her trembling breath amidst his overwhelming presence.

Then, a hoarse voice sounded by her ear. "I don't care anymore."

It was weary and broken, a decision seemingly made while drenched in blood, containing a desperate, all-or-nothing ruthlessness that was chilling.

Fan Changyu's pupils trembled. Her vision was blurred by a flood of tears. She tried to open her eyes wide, to see the person before her clearly, and asked through her sobs, "Do you know what you're saying?"

Xie Zheng's blood-red eyes were also filled with pain. He suddenly pulled her fiercely into his embrace, his jaw resting against her temple as he rasped, "Then what do you want me to do?"

"Fan Changyu, you tell me, what can I do?"

He questioned her viciously, out of control, baring his ravaged self for her to see, like a cornered beast driven to desperation.

A tear rolled down from his jaw, wetting her temple and searing her skin.

"I tried to let you go. I used every method I could think of. I truly have no other way..."

He held her so tightly, yet his whole body couldn't stop trembling.

Like a drowning man clutching a life-saving piece of driftwood.

"It doesn't matter if you're Fan Changyu or Meng Changyu. It's not important anymore. Let's just be together, all right?"

Fan Changyu's vision was a blur of tears. Her heart was seized by a different kind of wrenching pain, forcing her to gasp for air. A choked sob escaped her throat.

After two months and seven days, she once again allowed herself to cry wantonly in this embrace.

Warm sunlight streamed through the carved window lattice, and dust motes danced in the light.

The woman, her back pressed against the bedframe, was seized by the waist by the man before her. He captured her chin and kissed her deeply, inch by inch. The entwined-lotus-patterned bed curtains hanging on golden hooks were pulled loose. All her struggles were in vain, and even her sobs became disjointed.

An autumn rain came suddenly. Bean-sized raindrops pattered down, turning the yellow earth of the official road into a muddy mess.

A merchant caravan struggled forward in the downpour. Spotting a ruined temple ahead where they could take shelter, the caravan's carts and horses hurried toward it.

The servants used a dilapidated door panel from inside the temple to start a fire. They cleared a patch of ground and, without bothering to dry

their own soaked clothes, took out stools from the carriage and set them up. Only then did someone go to carefully help the person inside the carriage out.

The wide brim of a large oil-paper umbrella hid the face of the man who alighted, but his dark blue, cloud-patterned brocade robe was exceptionally luxurious. Though it was only the ninth month, a thick cloak was already draped over his shoulders, suggesting a frail constitution.

A man in a snow-blue scholar's robe emerged from the carriage behind. He was elegant and gentle. Before entering the ruined temple to shelter from the rain, he paused and looked back down the road for a while, then finally stepped inside.

The servants and guards all stood watch outside. By the fire in the ruined temple, there was only the cloaked man and a deaf-mute servant who attended to him personally.

Li Huaian said, "Your Highness, please rest for a moment. We must continue on our way as soon as the rain lessens. The Li family's Martial Assassins have suffered heavy casualties to temporarily shake off the Wu'an Marquis's Blood-Clad Cavalry. If they catch up to us again, I'm afraid it will be troublesome."

Qi Min's face was dark as he looked at the handsome young scholar before him. "My people must be brought back to me."

After impersonating Sui Yuanhuai for over a decade and now having shed his shell like a golden cicada, he was no longer the disfigured waste of the Changxin Prince Manor, forced to hide away in the rear courtyard. Soon, he would become the master of this world.

Li Huaian cupped his hands respectfully. "The Li family will do everything in its power to rescue the imperial great-grandson and his birth mother. But right now, Your Highness's safety is of the utmost importance."

The deaf-mute servant boiled hot tea over the fire, steeped it, and served it to Qi Min, only to have him sweep it violently to the ground.

The porcelain shattered, and scalding tea splashed everywhere. A few drops even spattered onto Li Huaian's shoes.

The commotion alerted the guards outside, but Qi Min's own contingent of imperial Shadow Guards stood firm at the temple entrance. Even if the Li family's guards were worried about Li Huaian, they dared not act rashly.

Li Huaian knelt calmly on the dust-covered ground. "Your Highness, please quell your anger."

Qi Min stared at him coldly. "It was your Li family who sent word to me, saying you had already lured Xie Zheng to Bieyue Mountain Villa and that I should set out for the capital as soon as possible. But what was waiting for me on the road? It was the several hundred Blood-Clad Cavalry under Xie Zheng's command and that madman, Sui Yuanqing!"

The Blood-Clad Cavalry was already a force that struck fear into the hearts of all in the Great Yin. And Sui Yuanqing, bent on avenging his mother's murder, was like a god of slaughter incarnate, vowing to take his head.

Qi Min's imperial Shadow Guards were nearly halved, and the experts sent by the Li family were almost completely wiped out, managing to break through the encirclement with only him. Yu Qianqian and Yu Bao'er, however, had fallen into the hands of the Blood-Clad Cavalry.

Upon learning that Xie Zheng had not fallen for the trick, Li Huaian had set off from Lucheng that very night.

The Wu'an Marquis had the authority to mobilize the entire military force of the Northwest. Once the Blood-Clad Cavalry returned with the imperial great-grandson and his mother, he would never have another chance to leave.

Now, listening to Qi Min's reprimand, Li Huaian merely cupped his hands in a calm, almost numb bow. "This matter is your humble servant's fault for failing to realize that the Wu'an Marquis was turning our own plan against us, thereby putting Your Highness in peril."

The game had already progressed to this stage. Every decision he made from now on was simply carrying out the Li family's original plan. He had become too numb to dwell on the rights and wrongs of it all.

The more he displayed such an expression, the more Qi Min's anger grew. He suddenly leaned down and grabbed Li Huaian by the collar.

Though he was a man long afflicted by illness, with fingers paler than a normal person's, his grip possessed a strength no less than that of a healthy adult male.

Perhaps only those imperial Shadow Guards knew that Qi Min had been secretly studying martial arts with them to overcome his frail body.

Besides those imperial Shadow Guards, he trusted no one, including Lan Shi and her son, who had served him for many years.

Qi Min's voice was terrifyingly cold. "Do you think that as long as I reach the capital safely, the Li family has already won? Xie Zheng doesn't dare to rebel in the Northwest on his own, but now that he has that child, let's see if he still dares not to!"

In Li Huaian's calm, placid eyes, other emotions finally stirred.

Qi Min released his collar and ordered coldly, "I don't care what methods your Li family uses. Either bring my people back unharmed, or... kill that child and bring his birth mother back."

Just then, a clap of thunder exploded outside the ruined temple. A flash of lightning streaked across the sky, making even the smiling Buddha statue in its niche seem cold and eerie.

Li Huaian's heart jolted. A cold wind blew in through the dilapidated doorway, and only then did he realize he was chilled to the bone.

He slowly bowed his head. "Your humble servant obeys."

Chapter 121

The sun was high in the sky when Tang Peiyi strode into the courtyard where Xie Zheng was staying. The personal guards standing watch outside stopped him. "General Tang, the Marquis was drunk last night and has not yet risen."

Tang Peiyi was puzzled. Xie Zheng was famous in the army for his ability to hold his liquor. He hadn't drunk that much last night, so how could he be drunk?

Despite his internal complaints, he still cupped his fist. "I heard from my men that Young Master Li seems to have left without a word, returning to the capital ahead of schedule. I found it rather odd and came specifically to discuss the matter with the Marquis."

Though he was a gruff man, he could still clearly see the power struggle between the Li and Wei Factions at court. For Li Huaian to leave without a word, not even attending last night's victory banquet, meant something was definitely amiss.

He had now taken command of the troops in both Chongzhou and Jizhou. Whether he leaned toward the Li Faction or the Wei Faction, a single misstep could lead to eternal damnation.

Rather than picking a side so quickly, it was better to first show goodwill to the Wu'an Marquis, who had removed himself from the affair.

For one, in a certain sense, the Wu'an Marquis could be considered his direct superior.

For another, compared to those civil officials who knew nothing of the hardships on the front lines, he felt that the Wu'an Marquis, being a military man himself, would be more considerate of the soldiers under his command.

Hearing Tang Peiyi's purpose, the personal guard outside the courtyard simply said, "We must trouble General Tang to return and wait for a moment. When the Marquis rises, this subordinate will inform him."

Tang Peiyi nodded and started to walk back, but he happened to run into Xie Wu, who was carrying a stack of clean, folded clothes. He had an impression of Xie Wu and immediately called out to him, "Aren't you Commandant Fan's personal guard? What are you doing here?"

Xie Wu's expression stiffened slightly, and he could only stammer out a lie. "The Commandant got drunk last night and is currently resting in the west wing. I... I was getting a change of clothes for the Commandant."

Tang Peiyi said, "The west wing is that way. You've walked all the way to the east wing."

Xie Wu said stiffly, "This subordinate is foolish and unfamiliar with the layout of the residence. I took a wrong turn."

Tang Peiyi waved his hand. "Alright, alright, hurry and deliver them to Commandant Fan."

Xie Wu could only turn on the spot and walk toward the west wing, clutching the set of new clothes.

After passing through a decorated gateway, Tang Peiyi came face to face with Zheng Wenchang, who cupped his fist toward him and said, "Greetings, my lord."

Zheng Wenchang had taken drinks for Fan Changyu last night and ended up drinking quite a bit himself, passing out at the banquet. He had been temporarily settled in a guest room in the residence by the servants.

Tang Peiyi nodded and asked, "Has Wen Chang also just risen?"

Zheng Wenchang said, "I'm ashamed. I drank too much and overslept."

Tang Peiyi had come to find Xie Zheng first thing in the morning before even having his breakfast, having been alerted by his subordinates. He was just about to go eat, so he invited Zheng Wenchang, "Have you had your morning meal? If not, join me for some."

Zheng Wenchang replied, "I've already eaten over in the west wing."

Hearing that Zheng Wenchang was also in the west wing, Tang Peiyi smiled. "What a coincidence. I heard Commandant Fan was also settled over there."

Hearing this, Zheng Wenchang frowned. "The twelve rooms in the west wing are all occupied by generals from the Tiger Might Battalion. Commandant Fan wasn't there, was she?"

Tang Peiyi recalled Xie Wu carrying a set of clean clothes outside Xie Zheng's courtyard, and then thought back to Xie Zheng's uncharacteristic decision last night. His face became a canvas of colorful expressions.

Seeing Tang Peiyi remain silent for a long while, Zheng Wenchang had no choice but to ask again, "Could General Tang have misheard?"

Tang Peiyi finally just mumbled, "Then I must have been mistaken."

A breeze from an unknown source stirred the gauze curtains, filling the room with a pleasant, warm fragrance.

Fan Changyu was pressed into the bedding, the man's forceful and fierce kiss leaving her breathless.

In the air she breathed, besides the faint scent of blood, was his unique, crisp aura, as if it were wrapped in the morning frost of the northern lands.

What had started as a kiss born of intense emotion had, at some point, changed in nature.

Xie Zheng's breathing had already deepened. No longer satisfied with just sucking and kissing her lips and tongue, he held her jaw with one hand and kissed his way from the corner of her mouth to her chin, then down her fragile neck.

Fan Changyu's neck was very sensitive, likely because it was one of the most vulnerable parts of the human body. Her entire body couldn't help but tremble.

Xie Zheng's thin lips pressed tightly against the delicate, thin skin of her neck, almost able to feel the blood surging beneath that layer of flesh.

His eyes grew darker. Unable to restrain the tingling in his teeth and the frantic desire to bite, he seized a small piece of skin and sucked hard until a red mark formed before he was satisfied.

Fan Changyu was dizzy from the kisses, her whole body burning up. A large hand slipped inside her disheveled lapels. When his scorching palm unintentionally touched the three-inch-long knife scar on her abdomen, she suddenly came to her senses, shoved Xie Zheng away, and tightly clutched her lapels.

Pushed away, Xie Zheng froze for only a moment before asking her, "Were you wounded in the battle at Lucheng?"

Fan Changyu silently nodded.

The gash was too long, stretching from above her navel all the way to her left waist. The scab had mostly fallen off, but it left a very obvious scar, its color a stark contrast to the surrounding skin, its shape twisted like a centipede.

She hadn't paid it much mind before, but when Xie Zheng's palm had brushed over it just now, she had pushed him away almost as a reflex.

She couldn't say why, but she just didn't want him to see it.

The desire in Xie Zheng's eyes had completely faded. He gazed quietly at Fan Changyu and said, "Let me see."

When he had gone to see her before, her wounds were already bandaged. He only knew she had also been injured on her abdomen, but he didn't know how bad it was.

His stare made Fan Changyu uncomfortable. She lowered her gaze, avoiding his eyes. "What military officer doesn't have a few scars? There's nothing to see."

She raised her hand to tie the sash of her front lapel, changing the subject. "I'm a little hungry. I wonder if the kitchen saved any food..."

The hand tying the knot was seized. Xie Zheng stared at her and repeated his earlier words, "Let me see."

Fan Changyu was silent for a while before finally releasing her grip on the sash.

So be it. She could hide it from him for a moment, but not for a lifetime.

The standard umber under-robe for military officers was pushed down to her elbows, hanging loosely between her arms. Her shoulders, as if carved, were slender but not frail, subconsciously bringing to mind bamboo growing from a barren rock face—craggy yet resilient.

On her left collarbone was a faint circle of teeth marks he had left long ago. Her chest was bound with plain cloth, forming an alluring curve. Further down, her waist was lean and slender, her firm muscles showing not a trace of excess fat.

It was a different, more extreme kind of beauty than the willow-soft waists of dancing girls, like a strong, aged liquor that, once tasted, made one unable to ever stomach cloying sweet soups again.

Xie Zheng's gaze fell on the centipede-like scar on her left abdomen. He looked at it in silence for a long while before reaching out to touch it. "Does it still hurt?"

Fan Changyu's skin had been exposed to the air for a while and was a little cool. When his warm fingertips suddenly touched it, it felt like an ant crawling over her, both numb and itchy, making her straighten her upper body in discomfort.

She frowned slightly, trying to keep her voice even. "The scab has already fallen off. It stopped hurting long ago."

As soon as she finished, she wanted to pull her lapels closed, but Xie Zheng didn't withdraw his hand. His eyes were half-lowered, making it impossible to see his expression. His calloused palm gently caressed the long, hideous scar. "What were you thinking when you were injured?"

Fan Changyu recalled the perilous situation that day and was lost in thought for a moment. Then she smiled nonchalantly and said, "There was no time to think about anything. I just felt there were so many people on the other side. Sabers, long halberds, axes, all coming for me. The soldiers who charged out of the city with me fell one after another, but I couldn't save them. I couldn't even save myself..."

As she spoke, she felt the hand on her waist and abdomen suddenly tighten, and she was forcefully pulled into the man's embrace.

Her head was forced to rest on Xie Zheng's shoulder. She could clearly feel his muscles tense up, the murderous aura around him so thick it made the air in the room feel thin.

He said in a hoarse voice, "I was late."

Fan Changyu was slightly stunned, then hugged his lean waist back in a comforting gesture. She rested her face against his chest, listening to his strong heartbeat, and said slowly, "I didn't think you would come then. It's too far from Kangcheng to Lucheng. I charged out to stall for time only because I felt that since Lord He had defended the city with his dead body until reinforcements arrived, I could risk my life to buy another moment, any moment. If I died in battle beneath the city walls, even if I couldn't overturn the verdict for my maternal grandfather, when future generations speak of the Meng family, they won't think the entire Meng clan was a bunch of treacherous villains who brought disaster to the country."

The arm around her waist kept tightening, making the bones in her waist ache faintly.

Xie Zheng's other hand pressed the nape of her neck, pulling her even more snugly against him.

Fan Changyu couldn't see his expression, only hearing him say, "From now on, I won't let you face these things alone again."

A mix of joy and sorrow surged in Fan Changyu's heart. She looked up at him and said earnestly, "I will find out the truth of what happened back then. Wei Yan killed my parents; he must know the hidden story of the Jizhou blood case. Now that he has colluded with the rebels and nearly caused Lucheng to fall into their hands, General Tang and the others all say the Wei Faction is about to fall. When we get to the capital, I will declare my true identity in the throne room, force the emperor to interrogate Wei Yan, and bring the truth of the Jizhou blood case from seventeen years ago to light."

Thinking of the Li family's machinations in the battle of Lucheng, Xie Zheng's eyes darkened. He raised a hand to gently stroke the long hair on Fan Changyu's back. "Wei Yan has been scheming for many years. There is more to the Lucheng matter than meets the eye. The Li Faction is currently denouncing Wei Yan, but it's still uncertain who will be the one to fall."

Fan Changyu looked perplexed. After a slight hesitation, Xie Zheng told her about how the Li family had allowed Wei Yan's subordinate to collude with the enemy.

This was a common tactic of the Li family, just like with the flood relief back then.

The more the people suffered and the more corpses littered the fields, the greater the crimes they could pin on Wei Yan.

Once the denunciation of Wei Yan began, the common people would be grateful to them. The word on the street was that the Li family was the leader of the upright faction, but no one knew that it was these very upright gentlemen who had coldly watched them suffer and die.

After listening, Fan Changyu fell into a long silence.

"So many soldiers died in Chongzhou and outside Lucheng. How can their consciences be clear?"

After a long while, she finally murmured, her hands by her sides clenched into fists.

Grand Tutor Li enjoyed a high reputation among the common people. They all said that while Wei Yan committed evil, only Grand Tutor Li wholeheartedly served the people.

It turned out that his entire good name was manufactured.

She suddenly looked up at Xie Zheng. "What about Li Huaian? Did he run away?"

Xie Zheng already knew about the vile things the Li family had done, and Li Huaian had been absent from last night's victory banquet. It was easy for Fan Changyu to guess that Li Huaian had probably fled.

Xie Zheng gave a faint nod. Seeing how furious she was, he added, "I let him go on purpose."

Fan Changyu's brows furrowed. "Why?"

Because of their embrace, the binding on her chest had been loosened slightly. When Xie Zheng unintentionally glanced down, he caught sight of the ample fullness barely contained by the cloth. His throat bobbed, and he averted his gaze. "To have him lead my men to find someone."

Fan Changyu, completely oblivious, was still lost in a fog. "Find who?"

A cold light glinted in Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes. "Sui Yuanhuai. Or rather, he should be called the Eldest Imperial Grandson, Qi Min."

The amount of information in that sentence was so great that Fan Changyu couldn't process it for a moment.

He knew the Sui Yuanhuai who died was a fake?

But how was this connected to the Eldest Imperial Grandson?

Too many questions piled up in her mind, and she couldn't find a thread to start with. She just frowned and asked, "The emperor doesn't even have a son yet, so where did a grandson come from?"

She had, after all, hired several advisors at great expense. Although she hadn't memorized the complex marital and student-teacher relationships of all the civil and military officials at court, she had at least remembered how many people were in the current imperial family.

Xie Zheng choked slightly. "The Eldest Imperial Grandson I'm talking about is a descendant of Chengde Crown Prince."

Fan Changyu was even more confused. "Didn't that Eldest Imperial Grandson die in the fire at the Eastern Palace seventeen years ago?"

She pondered for a moment and quickly figured out the key point. She looked up at him urgently. "Just like the person who died wasn't Sui Yuanhuai, the one who died in the Eastern Palace seventeen years ago wasn't the Eldest Imperial Grandson either, right?"

Because she had suddenly straightened her back, the shadow between her slightly loosened chest bindings appeared even deeper.

Xie Zheng had meant to answer her, but the sight he saw when he looked down made it impossible for him to look away. His mind felt like an overturned jar of paste, all the blood in his body rushing to his head. A hunger that shot straight to his marrow surged through him, making him wish he could devour the person before him bite by bite.

Noticing his strange gaze, Fan Changyu looked down and finally realized. She hastily crossed her hands to pull her lapels together, her face as red as a boiled shrimp.

She warned him in shame and anger, "Don't look!"

They had kissed many times, and he had kissed her collarbones and shoulders, but beyond that, he had never crossed any further lines.

Earlier, he had been looking at the wound on her abdomen, his eyes filled only with pity and not a single stray thought, which was why she had let her guard down.

Without a word, Xie Zheng pushed her into the bedding and kissed her to his heart's content. After his breathing had calmed slightly, he raised a pair of eyes filled with desire and aggression. "You'll have to show me sooner or later."

Fan Changyu lost control and slapped him off the bed.

The commotion was probably so loud that the personal guards outside the courtyard noticed. A guard hesitated before knocking on the door and forcing himself to speak. "Master, a team from the Blood-Clad Cavalry has returned."

Xie Zheng seemed to have anticipated the news from the guard. After climbing up from the floor, he passed Fan Changyu her outer soft armor. Despite being hit again, he was in an excellent mood. "Don't be angry. I'll take you to see two people you want to see."

Chapter 122

Fan Changyu had drunk too much the previous night and was still reeking of alcohol. After changing into the clean robes brought by Xie Wu, she noticed Xie Zheng ordering his men to prepare a carriage as if he was about to go out. Grabbing two large white steamed buns from the breakfast that had been served, she followed him outside.

This amused Xie Zheng. "Really that hungry?"

Ignoring him, Fan Changyu boarded the carriage and began munching on her bun. The buns from the city lord's residence were soft, fluffy, and sweet—far tastier than the military rations.

Xie Zheng hadn't felt hungry initially, but watching her eat stirred his appetite. Leaning against the opposite side of the carriage, he studied her for a moment before asking, "Are they really that good?"

Considering he hadn't eaten anything since morning either, Fan Changyu generously offered the other bun in her hand. "Here, have one."

Instead of taking it, Xie Zheng leaned forward and caught her other wrist. The half-eaten bun she had been about to bite into was now missing a chunk—snatched by him.

Fan Changyu glared at him furiously, but he chewed and swallowed unperturbed before nodding. "Quite sweet indeed."

The double entendre made her flush with embarrassment. "Picking at others' leftovers!" she snapped.

Xie Zheng raised his eyes. "How does taking a bite of your food equate to 'picking at others' leftovers'?"

Meeting her slightly bewildered gaze, he paused for a beat before suddenly asking, "Did you think 'picking at others' leftovers' meant someone taking a bite after you've eaten something?"

Fan Changyu nodded honestly. "Isn't that what it means?"

Xie Zheng pressed his fingers to his temple in exasperation. "What exactly has that old man been teaching you?"

She muttered under her breath, "I figured this out myself from reading."

This nearly made Xie Zheng laugh in disbelief. His phoenix eyes half-lidded as he gave her a sidelong glance. "Quite the prodigy, aren't you?"

Fan Changyu wasn't stupid—she knew that wasn't a compliment. She quickly finished the last of her bun. "Hiring advisors during wartime costs money. Now that there's no war, I'll get myself a private tutor later."

Xie Zheng said, "No need to go to such trouble."

"'Picking' means to gather; 'leftovers' refers to others' words. Collecting others' words and passing them off as your own—it usually means plagiarism or imitation."

His voice was deep and magnetic, patiently explaining the nuances. The usual military sternness faded, replaced by an elegance Fan Changyu couldn't quite describe.

Noticing her distraction, Xie Zheng flicked her forehead lightly. "Starting today, come study with me for two hours daily. Otherwise, when the old man returns and sees what you've learned, he might keel over from rage."

Rubbing her forehead, Fan Changyu forgot her anger at the mention of Grand Tutor Tao. "Do you have news about your foster father?"

Xie Zheng's expression darkened. "No. But Wei Yan is undoubtedly involved."

His voice turned icy on that last sentence.

Just then, the carriage halted. Xie Shiyi's voice came from ahead: "Master, we've arrived."

Xie Zheng stepped out first and extended a hand for Fan Changyu to take. Dressed in martial attire, she easily leaped down without assistance, then turned to shoot him a faintly triumphant smirk.

Autumn sunlight filtered through the trees, dappling her face. The smile on her lips held a youthful radiance—bright, clear, warm, and vibrant, hovering between boyish charm and girlish innocence.

Seeing her smile, Xie Zheng also curved his lips slightly. "I was just worried you'd pull on your wound."

Fan Changyu waved it off carelessly. "It stopped hurting long ago."

She walked forward along the secluded path strewn with yellow leaves. Xie Zheng followed leisurely a step behind, yet could precisely grasp her hand. "I know. But I'm afraid of you being in pain."

These words struck Fan Changyu's ears, sending an unexpected numbness through her chest.

She turned to look at Xie Zheng, only to find him gazing straight ahead as he said, "We're here."

At the end of the path stood a detached courtyard, guarded by dozens of black-armored soldiers. Upon seeing Xie Zheng, they all knelt on one knee in unison. "Marquis."

Xie Zheng gave a slight nod and ordered, "Open the gate."

As the vermilion-lacquered gates slowly swung open, the mother and son inside the courtyard looked up toward the entrance.

Overjoyed, Fan Changyu hurried forward. "Qianqian?"

Yu Qianqian was equally surprised and delighted, grasping Fan Changyu's hands to examine her. "I never thought I'd see you here again..."

She then urged her noticeably taller son, Yu Bao'er, to greet Fan Changyu. "Bao'er, this is your Aunt Changyu. Aren't you going to say hello?"

Yu Bao'er kept glancing toward the gate, only turning to Fan Changyu after confirming that Xie Zheng was the only one who had entered with her. "Aunt Changyu."

After this greeting, he clenched his hidden sleeve-covered hand and asked with unconscious tension, "Where's Changning?"

Their last parting had been at Changxin Prince Manor nearly half a year ago. He didn't know whether Changning had been rescued or taken elsewhere by those people.

Fan Changyu patted his head. "I just learned you were here too. Ning Niang's at home—I'll bring her over later."

Yu Bao'er visibly relaxed and obediently agreed.

Yu Qianqian, who seemed to have already learned Xie Zheng's identity, appeared somewhat awkward upon seeing him again. "Thank you for your rescue, Marquis."

Xie Zheng sidestepped her bow, saying only, "It was our duty."

This subtle form of address made both Fan Changyu and Yu Qianqian sense something unusual.

Just then, Xie Shiyi hurried into the courtyard, apparently with urgent news but hesitant to speak in front of others.

Xie Zheng said, "You two catch up first."

After Xie Zheng left, Yu Qianqian pulled Fan Changyu to sit down and poured her tea before asking, "The Marquis is still your husband, right?"

After being recaptured by Qi Min, she'd received little information. Now knowing Xie Zheng was Wu'an Marquis, she wasn't clear about their current relationship.

Fan Changyu thoughtfully held her teacup. "Not exactly. Our marriage was fake from the beginning."

Yu Qianqian's hand paused while pouring her own tea. Assuming Fan Changyu was now following Xie Zheng without status, she looked at her with complex, pained eyes. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to bring this up..."

Fan Changyu dismissed it. "It's nothing."

Seeing her genuine indifference, Yu Qianqian relaxed slightly before shaking her head with a wry smile. "You... being so thick-skinned, who knows if it's fortune or misfortune... Never mind. With your military merits, you'll probably get an official position and government salary someday. No need to worry about marriage then."

Fan Changyu looked baffled—why were they suddenly discussing marriage?

Clearing her throat, she said, "That's all far in the future."

Yu Qianqian sighed and asked, "So, you and the Marquis plan to just carry on like this?"

Fan Changyu scratched her head, carefully considering the meaning behind Yu Qianqian's words—"just carry on like this." Grand Tutor Tao hadn't been found yet, Wei Yan hadn't been overthrown, and the Meng family's grievances hadn't been cleared. With so many pressing matters at hand, of course they had to resolve these issues before worrying about marriage.

So Fan Changyu nodded and said, "This is fine for now."

The look of pity in Yu Qianqian's eyes deepened. She smacked Fan Changyu's arm hard and scolded, "You silly girl!"

Then she sighed deeply and advised, "I know the Marquis is a dragon among men, the kind of Unrivaled Hero every woman admires. But one day, he will have to marry. If you follow him like this without any status, you'll only suffer in the end."

Only then did Fan Changyu realize Yu Qianqian had misunderstood. She rubbed the back of her head awkwardly and said, "He actually wants to marry me... I just don't think it's the right time yet..."

Yu Qianqian: "..."

So all her worries had been for nothing.

Pretending to be angry, Yu Qianqian waited as Fan Changyu honestly revealed her background. Yu Qianqian's expression shifted several times before she finally said with complex emotions, "Despite the enmity between your families, the Marquis still treats you this way. His sincerity is as clear as the sun and moon."

Fan Changyu smiled faintly. "I won't let him spend the rest of his life tormented by guilt, nor will I allow my grandfather's name to remain unjustly tarnished."

Moved by Fan Changyu's determination and spirit in that moment, Yu Qianqian also smiled and said, "Then keep investigating. If you hit a dead end, maybe try starting with the Sui family."

Fan Changyu was surprised. "The Sui family?"

Yu Qianqian nodded.

She had only learned Qi Min's true identity after being rescued by the Blood-Clad Cavalry.

Before, she had always found Qi Min's relationship with the Changxin Prince Manor extremely strange. Lan Shi and Zhao Xun appeared to be servants of the manor, yet they were constantly wary of the people there.

At first, she thought it might be because the two Sui brothers didn't get along, given they weren't blood siblings.

But after the Changxin Prince and Sui Yuanqing fell from power one after another, Qi Min staged a golden cicada shedding its shell with her and Bao'er, even going so far as to kill the Changxin Princess, who had treated him like her own son. That was when Yu Qianqian truly realized how terrifying he was.

His face had been splattered with the blood of the Changxin Princess. He gripped the dagger in her still-warm hand to stage her suicide—only for Yu Qianqian to accidentally lift the curtain and witness it. The look he gave her when their eyes met still haunted her nightmares to this day.

He was like a venomous snake lurking in the shadows, waiting for the perfect moment to strike.

Yu Qianqian said, "I've always felt that Qi Min seems to harbor an extraordinary hatred for the Sui family. Back then, when the Chengde Crown Princess chose the Sui family as Qi Min's hiding place, there must have been a reason."

Though the speaker might not have intended it, the listener took it to heart.

After leaving Yu Qianqian, Fan Changyu was lost in thought the entire way back.

Xie Zheng tapped his knuckles against the small table in the carriage and asked, "What's on your mind?"

Fan Changyu replied, "Qianqian said Qi Min seems to despise the Sui family. The Chengde Crown Princess probably didn't hide him there on a whim."

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes. "The Changxin Prince is dead, and Sui Yuanqing is still in my hands. Once we capture Qi Min, we'll interrogate him thoroughly."

Fan Changyu asked, "Earlier, Eleven came to see you. Did he have news about Qi Min?"

Xie Zheng nodded. "The Blood-Clad Cavalry has already followed Li Huaian and found him."

Last time during the Blood-Clad Cavalry's siege, the Li family's Martial Assassins and the royal Shadow Guards around Qi Min managed to escape with him, causing Xie Zheng to lose their trail.

Li Huaian secretly left Lucheng to rendezvous with Qi Min, inadvertently leading Xie Zheng's men straight to them—

The torrential rain had stopped, but water still dripped from the broken temple's eaves, pooling in puddles below that shimmered with a ghastly, rouge-like hue.

Corpses littered the ground, their blood staining the rainwater crimson.

Li Huaian lay at the temple entrance, blood frothing at his lips. Seeing Sui Yuanqing stride toward Qi Min with his spear, he struggled to rise and stop him, but it was too late. His voice was hoarse with agony as he cried, "Your Highness, run! Run—!"

Sui Yuanqing stepped on Li Huaian's hand, grinding his foot into the back of it as he sneered at the man's contorted face. "The Li family sure knows how to raise loyal dogs. Pity their loyalty is wasted on the wrong master."

Step by step, he advanced toward Qi Min, who sat by the fire. The blood-soaked tassel beneath his spearhead left thick, sticky trails of red on the temple's floor tiles as he moved.

Outside, the Blood-Clad Cavalry, having dealt with the remaining Martial Assassins, saw Sui Yuanqing intent on killing Qi Min and shouted, "The Marquis has ordered this man to be taken alive!"

Sui Yuanqing bared his teeth in a grin at the speaker, his eyes alight with the madness and glee of impending vengeance. "What does Xie Zheng's order have to do with me, Sui Yuanqing? You think I fear the poison you lot fed me? Once I kill this bastard, I'll join my father and mother in the afterlife!"

Several Blood-Clad Cavalrymen rushed in to stop him, but he swept them aside with a single swing of his spear.

The tip of his spear now pointed at Qi Min's throat as he sneered, "You've lived like a rat under someone else's name for over a decade. I doubt you have any last words—"

Qi Min calmly called out, "Qing-di."

A vein bulged at Sui Yuanqing's temple. With a sharp twist of his spear, he slashed a bloody gash from the corner of Qi Min's mouth to his cheek.

"You don't get to call me that!" he snarled.

Sui Yuanqing had spent half his life steeped in deceit, but never had he been betrayed so thoroughly.

Over a decade of brotherhood—all a lie!

The elder brother who, despite his scarred face and mercurial temper, had always called him "Qing-di" with warmth and urged him to study hard—also a lie!

Though his lip was split, Qi Min remained composed. He lowered his gaze and said, "At this point, I owe you an apology. Whether you believe it or not, I never intended to harm you."

Those words only poured oil on the fire. In his fury, Sui Yuanqing even discarded his spear, stepping forward to seize Qi Min by the collar and roaring, "Never intended to harm me? Or just never got the chance? My mother treated you as her own—how could you—"

Before he could finish, a sudden chill pierced his chest.

The metallic tang of blood rose in his throat. He looked down to see a dagger buried in his left breast—its hilt gripped in Qi Min's hand.

With great effort, he lifted his head to stare at Qi Min, his smile uglier than tears. "...Never intended... to harm me?"

Without blinking, Qi Min pushed the dagger deeper, watching coldly as Sui Yuanqing's body convulsed. "And you believed that? You deserve this death."

Sui Yuanqing could no longer hold himself up. He collapsed to his knees, tears rolling from his bloodshot eyes. "...I always... always saw you as my brother..."

Qi Min expressionlessly drew his dagger, not sparing another glance at the corpse behind him, and said coldly, "This is what your Su family owes me!"

Li Huaian, who had collapsed at the entrance of the ruined temple, was utterly stunned by this sudden turn of events.

When Qi Min approached him, he paused briefly and said, "I thought you were with these people. Since you've shown loyalty to me, I'll spare your life."

Half of his face was slashed and covered in blood. The way he looked down at people from that angle made him resemble a vicious ghost

wearing human skin.

Under his gaze, Li Huaian felt momentarily paralyzed.

Outside, the Blood-Clad Cavalry sensed danger and prepared to attack Qi Min, but suddenly another group of Shadow Guards descended from the temple roof. Moving like lightning, they swiftly took the lives of those cavalrymen.

Li Huaian broke out in a cold sweat—his Shadow Guards hadn't been wiped out after all!

He had prepared a backup plan from the very beginning!

Qi Min watched coldly as the Shadow Guards retrieved a black iron token from one of the cavalrymen's bodies. Picking it up, he threw it to Li Huaian, his gaze as venomous as a snake's. "Go. Bring my people back to me."

Li Huaian caught the bloodstained token and glanced back at Lan Shi, who had died shielding Qi Min by the fire pit earlier. A chill ran through his entire body.

Would the man the Li family was supporting truly be a wise ruler if he ascended the throne?

Chapter 123

Xie Zheng didn't seem to intend for Tang Peiyi and the others to know that Chengde Crown Prince's descendant was still alive.

To prevent the news from leaking, he temporarily hid Yu Qianqian and her son in a private villa in the city's outskirts. When Changning heard that Bao'er and his mother were in Jizhou, she clamored to see him. Fan Changyu thought it would be good for the two children to have a playmate, so after informing Xie Zheng, she took Changning to the villa.

The children's reunion was not what Fan Changyu had expected. They didn't immediately start playing together. Instead, their eyes reddened, and neither spoke a word.

Fan Changyu teased Changning, "Weren't you clamoring to see Bao'er? Why are you silent now that you've seen him?"

Changning clutched a corner of her clothes, pursed her lips, and then looked at Yu Bao'er, who was standing beside Yu Qianqian. "I didn't lie to you. I told you I'd have my big sister and brother-in-law come save you, didn't I?"

Fan Changyu and Yu Qianqian were both smiling. Only Yu Bao'er gave Changning a slight nod. "I know."

Yu Qianqian said to Fan Changyu, "The children haven't seen each other in a long time, so they seem a bit distant. Let's let them play on their own for a while. They'll warm up to each other soon enough."

She invited Fan Changyu to sit inside, letting Changning and Bao'er play outside.

The courtyard was large, and there were guards outside, so nothing could go wrong.

Changning hung her head and kicked at the ground with the side of her shoe, looking unhappy.

It wasn't for any other reason than the fact that Yu Bao'er, who had been the same height as her, was now half a head taller after just half a year.

She shook a pile of trinkets in her hand and stuffed them all into Yu Bao'er's arms, saying, "These are the new butterflies and katydids Uncle Zhao wove for me. They're all for you."

Yu Bao'er, not knowing how he had upset her, asked, "After that man took you away, he didn't hit you, did he?"

At the mention of being taken to the battlefield by Sui Yuanqing, Changning finally perked up. She sat on a stone stool, gesticulating wildly. "He was so fierce! He put me on a big horse that was several times taller than me and rode with me through the mountains in the dark of night. So many people died, and the ghosts on the mountain were all wailing in the wind..."

Yu Bao'er's expression turned grim. "He took you to a battlefield?"

Changning finally remembered that the place where those people fought was called a battlefield and nodded vigorously. "Luckily, my brother-in-law came to save me! That bad guy couldn't beat my brother-in-law, so he threw me into the air and tried to poke me with his spear, which was as thick as a bowl. But my brother-in-law knocked it away with a weapon even thicker than a pillar!"

As she spoke, she spread her arms wide to show how thick it was.

Yu Bao'er imagined Xie Zheng on horseback, wielding a large pillar as a weapon. He frowned, then said, just as she wished, "Your brother-in-law is really amazing."

Changning proudly puffed out her small chest. "My big sister is the most amazing, and my brother-in-law is the second most amazing. Don't be scared in the future. If any more bad guys come, I'll protect you! My big sister is a general now, and she's in charge of lots of people! Uncle Xiao Wu, Uncle Xiao Qi, and Uncle Xiao Qin..."

As Fan Changyu and Yu Qianqian spoke in the room, she glanced outside and saw the two children sitting on the steps, fiddling with a pile of trinkets and whispering about something.

Yu Qianqian smiled. "Bao'er wasn't shy with strangers before. I don't know what he suffered during his time locked up in the Changxin Prince Manor, but when I saw him again, he no longer liked to smile or talk. I heard they even found playmates for him, but he ignored them. Seeing him able to play with Ning Niang again puts my mind at ease."

"Perhaps he was frightened," Fan Changyu said.

Yu Qianqian said, "I have nothing left to ask for in this life. The only one I worry about is Bao'er."

Fan Changyu heard the worry in her voice about Yu Bao'er's future and comforted her, "Don't be afraid. Bao'er is no longer the remnant of a traitor. He is the descendant of Chengde Crown Prince. No one will dare to do anything to him."

Yu Qianqian gave a bitter smile. "Will the one in the palace tolerate the descendant of Chengde Crown Prince?"

This question stumped Fan Changyu.

The Li family had already joined forces with Qi Min, wanting the young emperor to abdicate. The emperor likely already saw Chengde Crown Prince's descendant as a thorn in his eye, a thorn in his flesh.

Fan Changyu was silent for only a moment before saying, "I will do everything in my power to protect you."

Fan Changyu's impression of the emperor in the palace was not good. Back when the rebellion had not yet been quelled, the emperor had not hesitated to sentence a military officer like her to death just to make Xie Zheng marry the grand princess without worry.

Loyalty, it seemed, was not important. As long as you were in the way, you should be eliminated.

As for Qi Min, he was a man who, in order to topple Wei Yan, could concoct a venomous plot with the Li family that treated the lives of thousands of soldiers as a joke. Fan Changyu didn't think he would be a good emperor if he took the throne either.

Perhaps because she had spent her first dozen or so years as a commoner who only cared about her own survival, Fan Changyu, while revering imperial power, had not reached the point of blind loyalty.

After returning that day, she went specifically to find Xie Zheng. He was dealing with a pile of official documents on his desk, so she sat to one side, lost in thought.

Xie Zheng asked her, "Something on your mind?"

Fan Changyu asked, "What if the emperor wants to kill Bao'er?"

Xie Zheng sneered, "He can barely protect himself right now."

He handed Fan Changyu a letter sent from the capital.

These official documents were written in a convoluted, literary style. Fan Changyu struggled to read it, but when she finally understood its meaning, her eyes widened. "The Li family wants Qi Min to formally appear in the imperial court?"

The letter wasn't about anything else but the fact that officials from the Directorate of Astronomy had observed the stars at night and noticed a change in the Emperor Star.

Meanwhile, several elderly, venerable officials at court all claimed to have dreamt of the Late Emperor at night. The Late Emperor, they said, was weeping, unable to bear the thought of Chengde Crown Prince's descendant wandering among the common people.

Now, the entire capital was abuzz with rumors that the emperor's eldest grandson was not dead. There was also talk that the great floods and droughts of recent years were all because the Son of Heaven's virtue did not match his position.

The common people had long been dissatisfied with Wei Yan's usurpation of imperial power, and the young emperor's impression on the court officials and the world had always been one of weakness and incompetence. Now, there was an outlet for their frustrations. The people were clamoring that the succession of Chengde Crown Prince's heir was the only legitimate path.

The emperor had previously relied on the Li family to suppress Wei Yan, but now the Li family had turned against him. With the little real power he held, he couldn't topple anyone.

Xie Zheng stated with near certainty, "Wei Yan is also setting a trap. The moment the Li family's true intentions are revealed will be the moment Wei Yan closes his net."

The capital, the Imperial Palace.

On the steps below the Dragon Desk in the imperial study, memorials had long been thrown all over the floor. Any cups or utensils that could be smashed had already been smashed.

"Treason! They all want to commit treason!"

With nothing left to smash, Emperor Qi Sheng, enraged, overturned the Dragon Desk itself. His wide dragon robe dragged on the floor, and he accidentally stepped on it, tripping and falling. His forehead struck the steps, drawing blood.

Today's fury was a stark contrast to his initial ecstasy when the Li family's impeachment memorials against Wei Yan had first arrived.

So the Li family's move to topple Wei Yan wasn't at his behest—they had harbored treacherous intentions all along!

A nearby eunuch, trembling with fear, hurried forward to help him up. "Your Majesty, Your Majesty, are you all right?"

Qi Sheng shoved away the eunuch who tried to help him, his expression sinister as he pointed at him. "I know. None of you have ever treated me as the true Son of Heaven. I know everything..."

His expression was so ferocious he looked like he wanted to eat someone.

The eunuch, ignoring the cut he got from the broken porcelain on the floor when he fell, quickly knelt to profess his loyalty. "Your Majesty, my loyalty to you can be witnessed by heaven and earth!"

But Qi Sheng paid him no mind, muttering almost to himself, "That Xie Zheng dares to defy my decree, and now the Li family wants to support another puppet to replace me..."

As he spoke, his face suddenly contorted, and he shrieked hysterically, "I am the true dragon, the Son of Heaven! No one but me will ever sit on that dragon throne!"

The eunuch stared blankly at Qi Sheng's unhinged state, for a moment even suspecting he had gone mad.

But Qi Sheng, dragging his dragon robe with one sleeve half-torn off, began pacing back and forth in the imperial study. He paid no heed to his crooked golden crown, only muttering, "There's still a way... There's still a way..."

The eunuch watched his frenzied state with terror. Thinking of the rumors in the court and among the people, he tried to slip out of the study unnoticed. He had almost reached the door when Qi Sheng, who had been pacing, somehow noticed him. He tilted his head and looked at him. "Where are you going?"

A cold sweat instantly broke out all over the eunuch's body. Having served before the emperor for so many years, he managed not to stutter. "This... this old servant saw that Your Majesty was troubled and wanted to go brew a pot of tea for you."

"Is that so?" Qi Sheng seemed unconvinced. He took the Longquan Sword from a nearby sword rack and dragged its tip along the steps as he walked toward the old eunuch.

The old eunuch was scared out of his wits. His legs went so soft he couldn't walk, and he collapsed to the floor, begging for mercy. "This old servant really was going to brew tea for Your Majesty..."

Qi Sheng looked at him and smiled. "If you were going to brew tea, then go. Why are you trembling like this?"

The sharp tip of the sword pierced the eunuch's leg. The old eunuch let out a miserable scream. Qi Sheng felt the malice clamoring in his heart find an outlet in that scream, and every pore in his body suddenly relaxed in comfort.

In high spirits, he stabbed the old eunuch again. Seeing the fresh blood stain his bright yellow dragon robe red, he laughed with delight. "Such a beautiful color. No wonder those eight hundred personal guards under Xie Zheng are called the Blood-Clad Cavalry."

The old eunuch was already convulsing in pain, trying to crawl away with his hands and feet. But behind him, Qi Sheng, as if having discovered a new toy, began to wield the Longquan Sword like a cleaver. He gripped the hilt with both hands and, as if chopping melons or firewood, swung it with all his pent-up rage at the old eunuch's body.

The old eunuch's initial professions of loyalty and pleas for mercy eventually faded until he could no longer even utter a single word of begging or pleading.

The floor tiles of the great hall were splattered with blood and bits of flesh.

Qi Sheng only stopped when his arms were sore from hacking. He looked at the corpse, which he had chopped into a pile of mangled flesh, threw the sword aside, and called for the young eunuchs to come clean up as he sat back down on the dragon throne, panting.

The young eunuchs who entered the hall turned pale and vomited repeatedly at the sight of the pile of blood and flesh in the center of the hall.

Qi Sheng watched their wretched state, finding it extremely amusing, and finally laughed with glee. "Eunuch Gao had treacherous thoughts against me. He deserved to die! This is the fate of anyone else who dares to have treacherous thoughts against me!"

The group of young eunuchs, their faces ashen, knelt to profess their loyalty.

Qi Sheng watched this scene with extreme satisfaction, feeling a sense of comfort throughout his body. This was the taste of power he craved!

One day, the Li family and the Xie family would also kneel before him like this, wagging their tails and begging for mercy!

But before that, he had to endure for a while longer.

After venting his rage, Qi Sheng had completely calmed down. His face was grim as he said, "Someone, attend to me. I will change my clothes."

The autumn night grew cooler, the cicadas' cries mournful.

Ever since the Li family had impeached him for colluding with rebels, Wei Yan had claimed illness and stopped attending court.

Moonlight cast a frosty white sheen on the stone-paved path of the courtyard, as if a first snow had fallen.

A single flame flickered in the study window. An attendant passed through the layers of imperial guards standing watch outside the courtyard, pushed open the door, and addressed the old man sitting on the floor before a low table, playing chess against himself. "Prime Minister, you have a distinguished guest."

Wei Yan's train of thought was interrupted. His heavily wrinkled eyelids lifted slightly, reflecting the candlelight beside the chessboard. His voice was imposing without being angry. "Did I not give instructions that I am not to see anyone?"

The attendant held up an object with both hands for him to see.

It was a white jade ring carved with a dragon pattern.

This was an item worn by the emperor.

Wei Yan merely glanced at it before looking away, seemingly paying it no mind. In that moment, he had already remembered the move he wanted to make. His old, sinewy index and middle fingers picked up a black stone and placed it on the board, instantly reversing the tide of the entire battle.

He said, "After so many years of learning from that old man Li, he still has no patience."

The attendant didn't dare to reply, waiting for his further instructions.

Wei Yan said, "Since he has come, let him in."

A moment later, Qi Sheng, who had changed into common clothes and was wearing a wide cloak, appeared outside Wei Yan's study.

He tried to enter the study, but the imperial guards in the courtyard crossed their halberds, signaling that he could go no further.

Qi Sheng's face was grim as he stood still for a moment. Thinking of what the Li family was planning to do, he immediately cast aside his pride. Just as he had done countless times over the past dozen years, groveling before Wei Yan, he covered his face and began to weep. "Prime Minister, save me! The Li family wants to depose me and install a new monarch!"

No one in the study made a sound. Through the shadow cast on the screen door, Qi Sheng could tell that Wei Yan was playing chess by himself.

Qi Sheng secretly gritted his teeth and continued to plead with tears streaming down his face, "Prime Minister, I will be obedient. Everything in the past was because I was deceived by the Li family. I know that only the Prime Minister truly has my best interests at heart. The Li family even wants to frame the Prime Minister for colluding with rebels. I will seek justice for the Prime Minister!"

Qi Sheng said all the nice things he could think of, but the figure in the study seemed to turn a deaf ear.

Only then did Qi Sheng truly feel afraid. The thought of being driven off the throne, or even being secretly executed, made him forget his fine words and just sob, his face a mess of tears and snot.

He didn't even know when the study door opened. It wasn't until Wei Yan's deep, authoritative voice cut through the cold autumn night wind and reached his ears: "Your Majesty is the Son of Heaven. You should have the bearing of a Son of Heaven."

Qi Sheng quickly looked up. He saw Wei Yan standing at the study door, dressed in a simple cloth robe, yet possessing the imposing air of a mountain by a chasm. Like a stray dog, he wagged his tail and begged, "Prime Minister, save me..."

Wei Yan cut him off coldly. "Have the rebel armies reached the city walls? Or has Li Sui forced his way into the palace?"

Li Sui was Grand Tutor Li's given name.

Qi Sheng was speechless. For so many years, fearing Wei Yan seemed to have become an instinct carved into his very bones.

"The imperial city still stands, and the palace is secure. What does Your Majesty have to fear?"

Wei Yan continued to question him. His voice was not loud, but it made Qi Sheng feel breathless.

However, with these words, Qi Sheng felt half his worries lift.

He continued to act like a frightened, naive child, looking at Wei Yan helplessly. "It... it was I who lost my composure tonight."

Wei Yan turned and closed the door. "In that case, Your Majesty should return to the palace."

Qi Sheng shouted, "Prime Minister!"

An attendant stepped forward and made a "please" gesture to Qi Sheng. Though respectful, his posture was firm and unyielding.

Qi Sheng stared at the closed study door and continued, "Seventeen years ago, it was the Prime Minister who put me on the throne. I know that only the Prime Minister will always be on my side. In this world, I only trust the Prime Minister."

Qi Sheng's voice was no longer heard from the courtyard; it seemed the attendant had already led him far away. Wei Yan sat before the chessboard, a rare look of deep-seated loathing appearing in his usually inscrutable eyes.

It was unclear whether he loathed Qi Sheng, or the fact that his mouth full of lies so closely resembled a certain person from the past.

A long time later, he finally spoke. "Since the Li family wants the emperor's eldest grandson to appear before the world, release a bait from

the dungeon. If he is truly the descendant of Chengde Crown Prince, he will not remain indifferent to this."

Xie Zheng had been very busy lately; Fan Changyu often didn't see him in the military camp.

Occasionally, she would try to subtly ask Tang Peiyi, but he would also say he didn't know. However, the look in his eyes always made Fan Changyu feel a little uncomfortable, so she couldn't ask any more.

The meritorious soldiers were to enter the capital to receive their enfeoffments. The army was preparing for the journey today. With Tang Peiyi and Deputy General He busy with these matters, Fan Changyu was happy to have some leisure time.

That night, as she slept in her room, she sensed someone approaching. She subtly adjusted her breathing. Just as the person was about to touch her bed, she grabbed their wrist, twisted it back, and was about to pin them down when her knee was hooked and lifted. She lost her balance and fell down with him.

Xie Zheng pulled her into his arms and didn't let go. His voice held a faint weariness as he praised her, "Your alertness is not bad."

The moment her waist was encircled, Fan Changyu guessed it was him. She struggled twice but couldn't break free, so she jabbed his chest with her elbow and asked, "Where have you been the last two days?"

Hearing her question, Xie Zheng opened his eyes in the darkness. "You were looking for me?"

He currently had two places to stay in Jizhou: the military camp and the city lord's manor.

After they had reconciled, Fan Changyu rarely took the initiative to look for him outside of official business. Now, hearing his question, she felt a little embarrassed and said, "I just noticed you were gone for a few days and asked casually."

Xie Zheng didn't expose her, stealing two kisses from her face before letting go. "I had some things to deal with. I went to gather some men and make arrangements."

Fan Changyu asked, "What things?"

Xie Zheng, while unfastening her clothes, said, "News came from the capital. Some of your maternal grandfather's subordinates who were transporting grain back then didn't die. They've been under Wei Yan's control all this time."

The moment Fan Changyu heard it was related to the grain transport incident, her attention was completely captured. When a chill hit her shoulder and she realized what Xie Zheng was doing, she slapped the back of his hand hard and hissed, "What are you doing!"

Xie Zheng felt a bit wronged by the slap. He placed a small iron box in Fan Changyu's hand. "I had someone find this scar-removing ointment for you. I came specially to apply it for you."

Fan Changyu glared, but still said fiercely, "Give me the ointment, I can apply it myself. What do you think you're doing, undressing me without a word?"

Xie Zheng had personally returned to the Xie family estate in Huizhou to arrange for his subordinates to go back to the capital and investigate. He had been exhausted from traveling day and night. He had slipped into her room in Jizhou just to give her the ointment and sleep next to her for a while to catch up on rest.

Lately, whenever his mind was in turmoil, he could only find peace by her side.

But now, seeing her so jumpy and wary, like a fledgling tiger with its fur on end, his eyes suddenly darkened. He pressed her into his arms and kissed her from head to toe, then bit her shoulder resentfully. "You're asking for it."

The bite wasn't light. Fan Changyu winced for a moment, then pulled open his clothes to bite him back.

He seemed to have bathed before coming over. He didn't have any unpleasant sweaty smell; instead, he had the light scent of soap. Fan Changyu's sharp canine teeth tightened, drawing a muffled grunt from him. His whole body tensed up like a rock.

"Get off," Xie Zheng's voice was already off.

Unfortunately, it was night, and his voice was already low. Fan Changyu didn't notice. She gnawed on his shoulder, not yet satisfied, and mumbled, "So you're allowed to bite me, you dog..."

In the next instant, she was flipped over by Xie Zheng, and their positions were reversed.

He didn't say a word, just looked at her once before lowering his head and kissing her fiercely, almost frantically. One hand slipped inside her already loosened collar.

For convenience in the army, Fan Changyu would usually bind her chest. At night, when she rested, she would untie the binding.

Xie Zheng didn't know her dressing habits. He thought she would at least have another layer underneath. When his calloused hand unexpectedly touched a heavy, smooth, warm softness, both of them froze.

Fan Changyu reflexively raised her leg to kick him, but Xie Zheng caught and pinned her leg down.

When he buried his head in the crook of her neck to pant, his breath felt like it was on fire.

Fan Changyu was mortified and furious, hissing, "Get off me!"

Xie Zheng didn't speak, but Fan Changyu felt him squeeze her firmly. She felt like she was about to emit steam and scolded him, "You're shameless!"

The commotion that followed sounded like they were dismantling the bed. Someone's foot kicked the bed frame, making the whole bed seem on the verge of collapse.

Aunt Zhao, getting up in the night, heard the noise from Fan Changyu's room and knocked on the door. "Changyu, what's that noise in your room?"

Fan Changyu said through gritted teeth, "A rat got into the room. I'm killing it!"

Aunt Zhao was puzzled. "Why don't you light a lamp to kill a rat?"

Fan Changyu could only continue to make things up. "I... I have good eyesight. I don't need a lamp. I've already killed the rat. Auntie, you should go back to bed."

Aunt Zhao told her to go to bed early too, then returned to her room.

Because of their recent struggle, Fan Changyu was already covered in a layer of sweat. Their limbs were tangled together, neither able to subdue the other. As Fan Changyu breathed, her chest heaved violently.

Xie Zheng's robes had been pulled apart when she bit his shoulder. Now, with one arm twisted behind Fan Changyu's back, he pressed her into the bedding. The places where their skin touched felt like they were on fire, the flesh and blood beneath sizzling.

Fan Changyu's other hand was pressed against his jaw. If this wasn't mutual destruction, nothing was.

Fan Changyu whispered, "I'll count to three, and we'll let go together."

Xie Zheng replied in a hoarse voice, "Alright."

Fan Changyu then began to count, "One, two... three!"

When the count of three was finished, neither of them had let go of the other.

Fan Changyu accused, "Why didn't you keep your word!"

Xie Zheng only said, "You didn't let go either, did you?"

Both of them fell silent.

After a moment, it was Fan Changyu who spoke, "One of us has to give in. Do you want to stay like this all night?"

"...I wouldn't be against it."

The moment those words were out, Fan Changyu nearly bristled with anger again, saying fiercely, "In your dreams! You're just trying to take advantage of me!"

Xie Zheng's voice was a little hoarse. "The front of my robe has been torn by you."

Fan Changyu's eyes were practically breathing fire. "That's from our fight! It's not like I have improper designs on you!"

The air was silent for a breath or two before Xie Zheng, as if throwing all caution to the wind, suddenly said, "It is true that I have designs on you."

Fan Changyu froze, not expecting him to be so direct right now. She stammered, "It's good that you know."

Unexpectedly, he asked her, "What do you propose we do about it?"

Fan Changyu glared. "Of course, you should let go of me immediately and get out of my room."

Her hand was pressed against Xie Zheng's jaw. She didn't know how he moved, but Fan Changyu only felt him suddenly turn his head, and she lost her hold on his jaw. Instead, her hand was bitten, neither too lightly nor too heavily, by his teeth.

Xie Zheng looked down at her and said, "In your dreams."

Fan Changyu was speechless with anger.

After all this commotion, Xie Zheng was probably tired too. He planted two more kisses on her shoulder, then helped her wrap her lapels properly and pulled her into his arms. "Don't move," he said wearily. "Let me hold you and sleep for a while. I'll leave at dawn and be back in half a month."

When Fan Changyu heard that he had just returned only to leave again for half a month, the anger in her heart dissipated. In the end, she didn't move again and only asked, "Where are you going?"

Lying on his side, Xie Zheng rested his chin on her shoulder, inhaling her scent as he mumbled, "A trip to the capital. Regardless of whether the news that was released is true or false, it concerns the truth behind Jinzhou, so I must go and investigate."

Chapter 124

After two beats of silence, Fan Changyu said, "Since it's related to my maternal grandfather's grain transport, I'll go with you."

In the darkness, Xie Zheng opened his eyes. The truth of what happened seventeen years ago concerned not only him, but also the person before him.

By the moonlight spilling in from the window, he could vaguely make out the contours of Fan Changyu's face. Her eyes were filled with a solemn expression.

One of Xie Zheng's hands was still around her waist. Through the thin fabric, he could faintly feel the raised ridge of the scar on her abdomen.

He didn't know if this trip was a trap.

The group of Heaven-rank Martial Assassins under Wei Yan's command were likely no easier to deal with than the imperial Shadow Guards by Qi Min's side.

He said, "Wait for the little emperor's edict to arrive, then return to the capital with the main army. If you follow me into the capital without an edict and get discovered, it's a beheading offense."

Fan Changyu glared at him. "You think I'm afraid?"

Knowing her temperament, Xie Zheng's lips quirked into a smile, his gaze softening. He took a few deep breaths of the scent of her hair before saying, "I know you're not afraid, but one must always be prepared for any eventuality."

His palm gently caressed the scar at her waist. "The emperor's great-grandson and his mother are still at the other courtyard. I'll be more at ease with you here. If I fall into a trap on this trip and lose contact like the Old Man, you can use this token to mobilize the Blood-Clad Cavalry and the Xie family's forces in Huizhou. If it truly comes to a dead end, don't enter the capital rashly. Persuade Tang Peiyi to enthrone the emperor's great-grandson with you. With the Chengde Crown Prince's bloodline on

your side, even if you have to temporarily retreat to a corner of the northwest, no one in the court will dare brand you as traitors.”

Fan Changyu felt an oval token, warm with his body heat, being pressed into her palm. A complicated feeling arose in her heart. She turned her head to look at Xie Zheng and asked, “What about you?”

Seeing the worry in her eyes, Xie Zheng pulled her into his arms for a tight hug. “I’m just talking about the worst-case scenario. Wei Yan isn’t capable enough to make it a one-way trip for me.”

Fan Changyu’s hand was still clutching the token he had given her, her heart a chaotic mess. She buried her face in his solid chest and instructed in a muffled voice, “You must be careful above all else.”

The front of Xie Zheng’s lapels had been pulled open earlier. As she pressed her cheek against him, the breaths she exhaled as she spoke sprayed across his chest.

He was a young man in his prime, and the person lying beside him was the one he held dearest in his heart.

He endured and endured, his throat bobbing several times. Gazing at the dark canopy of the tent, he said with near self-abandonment, “If you’re really that worried, why don’t you let me leave an heir for the Xie family?”

The warmth in Fan Changyu’s heart stalled. With a deadpan expression, she reached out and viciously pinched his firm waist, earning a muffled, smiling grunt from Xie Zheng. “Murdering your own husband?”

Fan Changyu reached out to pinch him again, but her hand was caught by Xie Zheng.

What had started as playful pushing and shoving ended with her hands and feet pinned to the bed. Xie Zheng propped himself up, looked at her for a few moments, then suddenly lowered his head to kiss her again.

His long, loose hair occasionally brushed against her neck and shoulders, a little cool and a little itchy.

It was different from their previous kisses. He was no longer in a hurry to conquer, but had become extremely patient, so gentle it was as if he were trying to bewitch her.

And Fan Changyu was indeed bewitched by him—

When Fan Changyu woke up the next day, the sun was already high in the sky.

The sunlight pouring in from the door and windows was a bit glaring, and she squinted her eyes in discomfort.

Her chest felt a little heavy, as if something was pressing on it.

Looking closely, she saw it was Changning, lying on top of the quilt.

Aunt Zhao had already washed and tidied her up. Her hair was longer now, and the two tufts on either side of her head were tied neatly, adorned with two small, fluffy bell-shaped flowers.

She propped her chubby chin on her two plump hands and said with a grin, "Big Sister is a big lazybones today. The sun is already on your bottom and you're just getting up."

Fan Changyu was still groggy. She subconsciously wanted to reach out and pat Changning's head, but memories of last night flooded back. She stopped herself from pulling her hand out from under the quilt, her expression turning a little unnatural. "Big Sister is indeed feeling lazy today. Can Ning Niang help me get some water to wash my face?"

Her voice was a little hoarse, likely from just waking up.

It was rare for Changning to be asked to do something by Fan Changyu. Upon hearing her request, she immediately and obediently answered, "Okay!" She hopped off the bed, put on her shoes, picked up the bronze basin from the wooden stand with both hands, and pattered off to the kitchen to find Aunt Zhao.

Once she was alone in the room, Fan Changyu lifted the quilt and sat up. Her inner garment was only loosely draped over her, and a mess of red marks spread from her neck down to her shoulders.

Her chest still ached a little; it must have been bruised by teeth.

Feeling utterly despondent, Fan Changyu ran a hand through her messy hair.

She didn't even know how things had ended up like that last night.

She wanted to change, but when her gaze fell on the fingertips of her right hand, she thought of what Xie Zheng had gotten on her hand last night. Even though it had long been washed clean, she subconsciously wiped her hand on her discarded clothes again.

That's right, he had used her undergarment to wipe his hand last night!

Afraid that things hadn't been cleaned up properly and Changning might discover something, Fan Changyu's eyes scanned the room, searching for the undergarment she had dirtied last night.

She breathed a sigh of relief when she spotted the half-dry garment on the wooden rack.

Then, a strange feeling arose in her heart—he had actually washed her undergarment before he left?

Her cheeks burned. Fan Changyu rubbed her face and, before Changning returned, found a binding strap from the chest of clean clothes to simply bind her chest.

To make it easier to wear military uniforms, Fan Changyu usually bound her chest.

But today, it was a little painful. As Fan Changyu tied the strap, she glanced down. The tips were swollen. She pressed her lips together, recalling the chaos of the latter part of last night. Half shy and half annoyed, she silently cursed Xie Zheng a thousand times in her heart.

Fortunately, it was already autumn. Fan Changyu picked out a robe with a higher collar to cover the marks on her neck.

But during the meal, Aunt Zhao somehow still spotted them with her sharp eyes. Thinking of the noises she had heard last night, Aunt Zhao asked, "Changyu, how come I haven't seen that boy Yan Zheng since you came back from Chongzhou?"

Fan Changyu instantly choked on a mouthful of rice.

Afraid of worrying Aunt Zhao and the others, she had never mentioned her separation from Xie Zheng. As for their true identities, she didn't know where to begin, so she still hadn't revealed the truth to Aunt Zhao and her husband.

At this moment, she could only poke at the rice in her bowl and say vaguely, "He went with the army to Kangcheng to wipe out the remnants of the rebels. He should be back when the army enters the capital later."

Aunt Zhao's expression turned a little strange. She secretly wondered where the marks on Fan Changyu's neck came from, and could only ask indirectly, "You two didn't have a fight, did you?"

Fan Changyu looked bewildered. "No."

Seeing her like this, Aunt Zhao grew even more worried and asked hesitantly, "In the future... are you planning to live with just that boy Yan Zheng, or..."

Fan Changyu misunderstood Aunt Zhao's meaning and said with a frank expression, "Of course I still have to bring Ning Niang and you, Auntie. You and Uncle are like family to me. How could I abandon you?"

Aunt Zhao slapped her thigh in exasperation. "Who's asking you about that? I'm asking, you're not going to be like those ungrateful men who get rich and famous, keeping a few at home and a few more outside, are you?"

Xie Wu, who was sweeping the courtyard, and Xie Qi, who was playing with Changning, both looked horrified when they heard Aunt Zhao's words.

This time, Fan Changyu truly choked, pounding her chest as her face nearly turned beet red.

"You child, eat slower. I just asked you a question, why did you choke..." Aunt Zhao helped pat her back, but seeing it had no effect, she quickly poured Fan Changyu a cup of tea and handed it to her.

After downing the tea, Fan Changyu finally caught her breath.

She asked, bewildered, "Auntie, what nonsense are you talking about?"

Aunt Zhao glanced at Xie Wu and Xie Qi, who were each busy with their own tasks in the courtyard but had their ears pricked up, and pointed a finger at her own neck.

Fan Changyu quickly pulled her collar tighter. She knew she couldn't hide it, but she felt embarrassed about the marks and said with her head hung low, "Yan Zheng came back last night."

Aunt Zhao's face immediately lit up with joy. "Where is he?"

Fan Changyu finished the tea in her cup and said, "He left again."

Afraid that Aunt Zhao would keep asking questions, she put down the cup and walked out. "Auntie, don't worry about all this nonsense. There are still matters in the army. I'm heading to the barracks first."

In truth, there wasn't much going on in the army recently. Afraid of being seen with a neck full of marks and facing more embarrassment, Fan

Changyu decided to go to the other courtyard to see Yu Qianqian and her son instead.

On the third day after Xie Zheng's departure, Fan Changyu learned from Xie Wu that the Blood-Clad Cavalry had captured Li Huaian and had now brought him back.

The thought of the deaths of He Jingyuan and the soldiers outside Lucheng made Fan Changyu's teeth itch with hatred. She wished she could question Li Huaian on the spot.

And she did.

When she saw Li Huaian in Xie Zheng's private prison—dressed in ragged clothes, his hair disheveled, yet sitting calmly on the dry straw—Fan Changyu couldn't suppress the rage rising in her heart. She said coldly, "The ground outside Lucheng is covered with the wrongly deceased bones of loyal men. I wonder if Lord Li has been able to eat or sleep in peace these past few days?"

Li Huaian opened his eyes. Looking at her outside the cell, a flicker of pain and shame seemed to cross his face, which then turned into bitterness. "If I said I haven't had a moment of peace, would Miss Fan believe me?"

The image of He Jingyuan's dead body standing on the Lucheng watchtower, and the soldiers who had followed her out of the city only to fall one by one, were still vivid in Fan Changyu's mind. Her gaze was as sharp and cold as a blade. "Lord Li should save those words for the day the truth comes out, and say them to the tens of thousands of soldiers who died in vain! The people of the world all thought the Li family, like Lord He, were good officials. But it was also your Li family who treated their lives like dirt!"

Li Huaian still just smiled bitterly. "I have always admired Miss Fan's forthright and unrestrained nature, her clear distinction between love and hate. But living in this world, many things cannot be black and white; there are always trade-offs. What the Li family did may be wrong for now, but in another decade or so, it might bring a golden age to the Great Yin."

Fan Changyu clenched her jaw and slammed a fist against the prison wall.

The hard bricks cracked, showering stone fragments onto the ground. Li Huaian's voice came to an abrupt halt.

He raised his head, and when he saw the fury on Fan Changyu's face, he was slightly taken aback.

Fan Changyu looked at him coldly. "What gives you the audacity to say such arrogant words? Is it because you were born into wealth and privilege? Because you don't have to worry about your next meal like the common people? Is it because you've read too many books by sages, so the suffering you see is nothing more than a weightless sentence on a page? It wasn't you who died, nor was it your family. What right do you have to say on their behalf that their deaths were to trade for a golden age for the Great Yin?"

This interrogation left Li Huaian completely stunned.

Fan Changyu gave Li Huaian one last cold, sarcastic look and was about to walk out of the prison when a commotion came from the prison gate ahead.

Several men dressed in Blood-Clad Cavalry uniforms rushed in with bloody sabers, coming face to face with Fan Changyu.

In just one exchange, Fan Changyu realized these men were impostors. She drew the boning knife she always carried at her waist.

The jailbreakers across from her exchanged a look, then raised their sabers and charged at Fan Changyu.

The prison corridor was narrow. Fan Changyu's blade clashed with her opponent's, sending sparks flying. Relying on sheer brute force, she forced the martial assassin back, almost dragging him backward by the blade.

One of the martial assassins tried a sneak attack, but Fan Changyu kicked his arm. His arm was instantly dislocated, and he could no longer hold his saber, which fell to the ground with a metallic clang.

After finishing off the few martial assassins who had fought their way into the prison, Fan Changyu looked at Li Huaian. "Even with Lord Li trapped here, there are still people who would risk their lives to save you. Those soldiers who died outside the city that day, they waited until their deaths, but no one came to their rescue!"

Li Huaian's head was bowed, his messy hair obscuring most of his face. He said, "Go save the emperor's great-grandson and his mother."

Fan Changyu's expression changed slightly. "What do you mean?"

Li Huaian's voice was calm to the point of numbness. "The jailbreak is just a feint."

In a flash, Fan Changyu understood that this was a ploy to lure the tiger from the mountain!

Those men had disguised themselves as the Blood-Clad Cavalry and fought their way to the prison, catching the real Blood-Clad Cavalry off guard. The Blood-Clad Cavalry would definitely mobilize more men to reinforce the prison, tying up all their forces here. If something were to happen at the other courtyard, it would be too late to dispatch anyone!

Fan Changyu rushed out without a moment's delay. She ran into many impostors disguised as Blood-Clad Cavalry. Caught off guard, her arm was cut. Because it was difficult to distinguish friend from foe, she simply swung her knife at anyone she saw from then on.

When Xie Shiyi arrived with his men, he ran into Fan Changyu and was nearly cut down before he could even speak. He quickly raised his saber to block, shouting, "Captain, it's me, Shiyi!"

Fan Changyu clutched her bleeding arm, glanced at the hundred or so men he had brought, and said, "Hurry to the other courtyard! Their real target is the other courtyard!"

Xie Shiyi's face changed drastically. He immediately ordered his subordinates, "A few of you stay here to clean up. The rest of you, follow me to the other courtyard!"

Fan Changyu said, "I'm going too."

Xie Shiyi glanced at Fan Changyu, probably realizing he couldn't stop her. He threw her a bottle of trauma medicine and said, "Then be careful, Captain!"

Chapter 125

Fan Changyu, along with Xie Shiyi and others, galloped at full speed to the villa, but they were ultimately a step too late.

The entire villa was engulfed in flames. At the entrance, several corpses of the Blood-Clad Cavalry lay scattered in disarray, the blood on the steps appearing both desolate and eerily vivid under the firelight.

Holding onto a sliver of hope, Fan Changyu rushed into the villa, calling out, "Qianqian?"

She searched several rooms but found no one. Finally, at the kitchen door, she spotted the unconscious cook and carried her out of the courtyard.

While Xie Shiyi and his men were checking the bodies of the Blood-Clad Cavalry at the entrance, they discovered one man still clinging to life. Xie Shiyi quickly administered a life-saving pill.

The man weakly opened his eyes and, recognizing his comrades, hurriedly recounted what had happened: "Someone disguised as the Blood-Clad Cavalry launched a surprise attack on the villa. We couldn't distinguish friend from foe and were quickly overwhelmed..."

Xie Shiyi asked, "Where are the imperial great-grandson and his mother?"

The man feebly pointed eastward. "They went... east..."

Xie Shiyi immediately reported this to Fan Changyu, who ordered a small group to stay behind and handle the aftermath while the rest continued the pursuit eastward.

The villa was located in the outskirts of the city, making it impossible to seal off the area for a thorough search. If they failed to catch up now, they might lose Yu Qianqian and her son for good.

Fan Changyu was frantic with worry. She mounted her horse and cracked the whip fiercely, charging eastward.

Every member of the Blood-Clad Cavalry was trained as a scout. Xie Shiyi noticed that the bandage on Fan Changyu's hastily treated arm had already been soaked red with fresh blood. He tried to reassure her, "Commander, don't worry too much. There are fresh wheel tracks on the road. They took the imperial great-grandson and his mother in a carriage—we can catch up."

Fan Changyu didn't respond, her lips pressed tightly together.

Yu Qianqian was one of her few friends, and Bao'er was of immense importance to them all. Xie Zheng had already entered the capital—she couldn't afford to let anything happen to Yu Qianqian and her son now.

After galloping relentlessly for over ten miles, a volley of arrows suddenly rained down from the dense forests flanking the official road ahead.

Fan Changyu swiftly raised her blade to block the arrows. Though the elite Blood-Clad Cavalry accompanying her remained unharmed, several of their warhorses were struck and collapsed.

Xie Shiyi cursed bitterly, "They must have heard our hoofbeats and left some men behind to ambush us!"

Fan Changyu glanced at the few dozen remaining Blood-Clad Cavalry and said to Xie Shiyi, "I'll lead a group to continue the pursuit. You deal with those in the woods."

Xie Shiyi knew retrieving the imperial great-grandson and his mother was the top priority. He urged, "Then be careful, Commander!"

Fan Changyu and a contingent of the Blood-Clad Cavalry charged straight down the official road. Arrows whistled toward them from the forests on either side, but they only raised their swords lightly to deflect them.

Those unfortunate enough to be hit rolled to cover and joined Xie Shiyi in clearing out the enemies hidden in the woods.

Using this method, Fan Changyu finally broke through the arrow barrage with a portion of her forces.

Following the wheel tracks, they hadn't gone far before spotting a dozen riders escorting a carriage speeding down the road.

Fan Changyu shouted, "Are there any skilled archers among you? Avoid the carriage and loose your arrows!"

She had read a few military manuals. Though she couldn't recite them word for word, she had spent enough time in the army and fought in over a dozen battles, large and small.

In pursuits like this, momentum was often key. With enough force, they could shatter the enemy's morale from a distance.

Once they closed the distance, the pursuers began firing arrows while chasing—undoubtedly the best way to create momentum.

With arrows suppressing them, the carriage ahead couldn't outrun the single-mounted warhorses. Only seven or eight riders were sent to intercept Fan Changyu and her group.

Long-handled weapons held the advantage on horseback. Fan Changyu swung her Horse-Cutting Sword in a sweeping arc, forcing the approaching Shadow Guard to veer aside before they could even get close.

The Blood-Clad Cavalry, rigorously selected elites, were far superior to the ordinary soldiers who had accompanied Changyu out of the city that day. Though their martial skills couldn't match Xie Wu's, they weren't easily overpowered. Working together, a few of them could hold off a single Shadow Guard—a far better situation than when Changyu had faced over a dozen Shadow Guards alone.

Seizing the moment while most of the intercepting Shadow Guards were occupied by the Blood-Clad Cavalry, Changyu spurred her horse hard and charged toward the carriage ahead.

One of the Shadow Guards riding alongside the carriage suddenly drew his bow and loosed an arrow at Changyu. She cleaved one arrow with her Saber, then pressed herself low against her horse's back as it galloped at full speed.

Seeing he couldn't hit Changyu, the archer aimed for her horse instead.

When her steed was struck and collapsed, Changyu was barely two zhang away from Yu Qianqian's carriage. Gritting her teeth, she hurled a rope that looped around the carriage's eaves. As she leaped from her falling horse, she let the rope's momentum pull her toward the carriage.

A Shadow Guard riding alongside swung his blade at her. Changyu rolled across the carriage roof to evade, and the spot where she had lain

was split in half by the strike.

From inside the carriage came Yu Qianqian's panicked cries for help. Changyu tightened her grip on the rope and slid down, kicking the driver—a Shadow Guard—off the carriage before yanking the curtain aside. "Don't be afraid, Qianqian! It's me!"

Inside, Yu Qianqian clutched the window frame with one hand and held Yu Bao'er tightly with the other, her voice trembling. "Changyu?"

Changyu had barely responded when another Shadow Guard riding parallel to the carriage slashed horizontally at her. She jerked backward just in time, and the blade struck the carriage door instead.

Changyu retaliated with a kick to the man's armpit. Stunned, he felt as if half his ribs had shattered from the impact. Clutching his side in agony, he tumbled from his horse.

Changyu sat up, taking the reins to steer the carriage back while reassuring Yu Qianqian, "Don't worry, I won't let them take you!"

Yu Qianqian glanced through the window at the relentless Shadow Guards closing in and said calmly, "This won't work. Changyu, take Bao'er and ride ahead!"

Before she could push Bao'er toward Changyu, one of the Shadow Guards shot an arrow into the lead horse's foreleg.

The horse whinnied and stumbled forward, dragging the carriage with it until it overturned.

Yu Qianqian and her son were thrown from the carriage, but Changyu shielded them both with her own body. Her back slammed against the rocky cliffside lining the road, the pain draining the color from her face. For a moment, she couldn't even stand.

The heavy carriage scraped along the ground, most of its weight teetering on the cliff's edge before finally plunging over, dragging the arrow-stricken horse down with it.

Yu Qianqian struggled to sit up and noticed that Fan Changyu's clothes had been torn to shreds against the rough rock surface, her back covered in wet blood. Panicked, tears streamed down Yu Qianqian's face as she cried, "Changyu, are you okay?"

Fan Changyu forced her eyes open with great effort. Seeing the Shadow Guards who had been protecting the carriage closing in, she propped herself up with her Horse-Cutting Sword and glared coldly at the nameless Shadow Guard now less than three zhang away. She ordered Yu Qianqian, "Run!"

The Blood-Clad Cavalry, engaged with the other nine Shadow Guards blocking the road, had gained a slight upper hand due to their numerical advantage. If they could reach them, there might still be a chance.

Yu Qianqian knew she had no martial skills—staying would only burden Fan Changyu. With tears in her eyes, she gave Fan Changyu one last desperate glance before grabbing Yu Bao'er's hand and dashing toward the Blood-Clad Cavalry.

Yu Bao'er kept looking back at Fan Changyu. His young face was streaked with blood from scrapes, his pupils reflecting Fan Changyu's silhouette as she struggled to stand with the support of her long blade under the setting sun. The hand not held by Yu Qianqian clenched into a tight fist.

Back in Lucheng, Fan Changyu had fought sixteen Shadow Guards outside the city walls. Only because they had held back, intending to capture her alive, had she lasted so long.

Now, injured and facing five Shadow Guards fighting at full strength, the battle was grueling.

One of the Shadow Guards, seeing Fan Changyu occupied by his four companions, broke away to pursue Yu Qianqian and her son.

The mountain path was steep, and Yu Qianqian's elaborate robes hindered her movement. Tripping over her own skirts, she frantically pushed Yu Bao'er away, urging, "Bao'er, run!"

But Yu Bao'er refused to leave her behind. His small frame acted as a human crutch as he tried to help her up.

In that brief moment, the Shadow Guard caught up.

A furious roar erupted from the Blood-Clad Cavalry: "Captain!"

Xie Wu and Xie Qi had somehow received word and arrived on horseback.

Realizing he couldn't take both mother and son back today, the Shadow Guard's eyes turned ruthless. Without warning, he swung his saber at Yu Bao'er.

Fan Changyu, still entangled with the four Shadow Guards, couldn't break free. But maternal instinct took over—Yu Qianqian threw herself in front of Yu Bao'er the instant she saw the blade.

The saber struck her back, blood splattering across Yu Bao'er's face.

"R-run...!" Yu Qianqian gasped in agony, barely managing those two words.

Yu Bao'er stared at his mother lying in a pool of blood, frozen in shock.

Were they really trying to kill him and his mother?

The Shadow Guard hesitated briefly upon seeing Yu Qianqian take the blow, then recalled Qi Min's orders. His expression darkened as he hastily pulled out a bottle of hemostatic powder and poured it over the wound on Yu Qianqian's back.

When Fan Changyu saw Yu Qianqian struck down, she let out a furious cry. With a series of slashes, she forced back the four Shadow Guards surrounding her, then used her momentum to swing her saber and send the attacker flying.

Exhausted, she still tried to carry Yu Qianqian to safety.

But Yu Qianqian weakly grasped Fan Changyu's hand, her tear-filled eyes pleading. "Take Bao'er... take him away. They won't kill me... but they'll kill him..."

Fan Changyu looked at the trauma medicine spilled all over her back. Though she didn't know exactly what had happened, she understood Yu Qianqian's words were true. Summoning her last ounce of strength, she picked up the seemingly terrified Yu Bao'er beside her and ran toward the direction where Xie Wu and Xie Qi were galloping on horseback.

The four Shadow Guards who had been fighting with Fan Changyu gave chase. Two of them helped Yu Qianqian retreat while the other two raised their sleeves and shot several sleeve arrows at Yu Bao'er in Fan Changyu's arms.

Without hesitation, Fan Changyu shielded Yu Bao'er with her own body.

"Commandant!"

Fortunately, Xie Wu and Xie Qi had caught up. Xie Wu, with one arm disabled, leapt off his horse and single-handedly swung his blade to deflect the incoming arrows. Xie Seven responded by nocking arrows and returning fire at the Shadow Guards.

The thunder of hoofbeats came from the end of the official road—Xie Shiyi and others who had finished clearing the Shadow Guards in the woods were arriving. Seeing reinforcements approach, the remaining Shadow Guards being pursued by the Blood-Clad Cavalry no longer lingered in battle. They pulled out smoke bombs and hurled them forcefully to the ground, instantly filling the road with billowing dust.

By the time the smoke cleared, the Shadow Guards had vanished without a trace.

Xie Shiyi rushed over excitedly upon seeing Xie Wu and Xie Qi. "Fifth Brother! Seventh Brother!" But his expression changed drastically when he noticed Fan Changyu's blood-soaked back. "Commandant, you're injured?"

Xie Wu and Xie Qi's faces also turned grave. Before Xie Zheng left, he had instructed that after his departure, the Blood-Clad Cavalry would follow Fan Changyu's lead in all matters. Yet barely two days after he left, Fan Changyu was already wounded like this.

Fan Changyu herself seemed unfazed. "Just superficial wounds, nothing serious," she said. Looking down at Yu Bao'er, whom she had shielded—now silent and seemingly in shock—she frowned and comforted, "Don't be afraid, Bao'er. I'll find a way to save your mother."

Yu Bao'er buried his face in Fan Changyu's shoulder. Though no sobs were heard, his small frame trembled, his teeth clenched tightly.

Without the carriage, they had to ride back on horseback. Yu Bao'er, still frightened, clung tightly to Fan Changyu's clothes, refusing to let go, so Fan Changyu carried him on her horse.

Despite the heavily fortified villa, Qi Min's men had still found a way in. After much deliberation, Fan Changyu decided to hide Yu Bao'er in the military camp. No matter how capable Qi Min was, he couldn't possibly move through the army as if it were nothing.

No sooner had she settled Yu Bao'er in the camp than Tang Peiyi sent a messenger, summoning Fan Changyu for a discussion. She knew the day's

large-scale movement of the Blood-Clad Cavalry outside the city wouldn't escape Tang Peiyi's notice.

Before leaving, Xie Zheng had said that if pushed to the brink, they could persuade Tang Peiyi to support Yu Bao'er's claim. But clearly, they weren't at that point yet. Fan Changyu was at a loss, unsure whether to reveal Yu Bao'er's identity to Tang Peiyi. Using the excuse of tending to her wounds first, she dismissed Tang Peiyi's personal guard and called for the medic Ahuang to treat the injuries on her back.

Ahuang applied medicine while shedding tears the entire time, making Fan Changyu rather embarrassed. She kept reassuring her that it didn't hurt. But Ahuang said, "The Commandant is a woman of steel who sheds no tears lightly. But these wounds—even I feel the pain looking at them. I'm crying for you, Commandant."

Fan Changyu was both amused and exasperated. However, since A Hui had bandaged her with such meticulous care, the layers of gauze wrapped around her upper body made her look almost half-paralyzed. Thinking about meeting Tang Peiyi soon, she didn't ask to be rebandaged.

When Fan Changyu was carried on a stretcher by two personal guards to see Tang Peiyi, it gave him quite a shock.

He couldn't even sit still and immediately walked over to the stretcher to check on her. "What happened to you, Captain Fan?"

Fan Changyu looked utterly drained. "The bandits outside the city are rampant. I went out to suppress them but accidentally fell off a cliff."

Tang Peiyi had summoned Fan Changyu to ask what she'd been doing outside the city. Now that she'd volunteered an explanation—even if it was a blatant lie—with her injuries so severe, he couldn't interrogate her like a criminal. He merely said, "Jizhou already cleared out the bandits before the New Year. Are there really still such formidable outlaws who could injure you like this?"

Fan Changyu, her face pale, replied, "The terrain on the mountain was complicated... I just slipped and fell..."

She then broke into a fit of violent coughing.

Tang Peiyi could only wave his hand dismissively. "Alright, alright, go back and rest! You stubborn brat—if you were seriously injured, you

could've just sent word! Instead, you had yourself carried here. Now the whole army will gossip about how I mistreated you!"

Fan Changyu weakly clasped her hands on the stretcher. "This subordinate takes her leave..."

She wasn't good at lying, and guilt kept her from meeting Tang Peiyi's eyes.

Tang Peiyi huffed in annoyance. "Enough with the formalities! Get back to your own tent and lie down!"

Only after being carried out of the central military tent did Fan Changyu quietly let out a sigh of relief. She had managed to muddle through today.

Chapter 126

Layers of gauze curtains obscured the view, while the Dragon Brain Incense floating in the air made one drowsy and heavy-headed.

The scent was familiar to Yu Qianqian. Her entire back ached as if split open, yet she lay motionless on the soft bedding, eyes closed, dark lashes lowered, feigning unconsciousness.

A cold, low voice from within the room reached her ears: "The person was taken by Xie Zheng?"

The Shadow Guard kneeling below the low table was drenched in cold sweat as he clasped his fists. "Wu'an Marquis's men seized the Old Members of the Meng Family while we were engaged with Wei Yan's trained underlings. This subordinate deserves punishment, Your Highness."

Crack—

A faint shattering sound echoed—Qi Min had crushed the white jade thumb ring in his hand.

Half his face was cast in shadow, the sharp contours of his features rendered even more sinister in the dim light. He slowly lifted his head and spoke languidly, "You failed? Then why are you still alive to return and face me?"

The air grew thin. A drop of sweat fell from the Shadow Guard's temple onto the floor. In panic, he retrieved an object from his robes and presented it to Qi Min. "When this subordinate rescued the Old Members of the Meng Family from Wei Yan's private prison and revealed our identity, they gave me this."

Another Shadow Guard, hidden in the room's dark corner, stepped forward, took the object held aloft by the kneeling guard, and presented it to Qi Min.

The object was about an inch tall and three inches long, entirely black, shaped like a tiger or leopard, engraved with ancient inscriptions—it was half of a Tiger Tally.

Qi Min recognized its origin from the inscriptions, his long eyes narrowing slightly. "This is the Tiger Tally from Changzhou seventeen years ago."

According to the Great Yin Law, each region had its own tally. Only by obtaining the matching half from the imperial court could one mobilize the local garrison.

He looked down at the kneeling Shadow Guard. "What did the Old Members of the Meng Family say?"

The guard, sensing his life was spared, hurriedly replied, "They begged Your Highness to clear Old General Meng's name!"

Qi Min's brow lifted slightly.

On the bed, Yu Qianqian tensed, straining to hear more, but the conversation outside abruptly ceased.

Qi Min raised a hand, signaling the Shadow Guard to silence himself. Listening to the trembling breaths from behind the layers of curtains, his lips curled faintly. Suddenly, he said, "Dismissed. As for Xuan Jian's arm—you will sever it. Those who dare harm my people must learn their lesson."

Yu Qianqian's heart pounded with dread. Instinct told her that the Xuan Jian Qi Min spoke of was the Shadow Guard who had tried to kill Bao'er.

The kneeling guard asked no questions, merely responding with a "Yes" before withdrawing.

Yu Qianqian heard the door close. She didn't understand why Qi Min had cut short the discussion about the truth of the Jinzhou battle, leaving her anxious yet helpless.

When the sound of slow, heavy footsteps approached the bed, she hurriedly feigned sleep.

The layers of gauze were drawn aside and hooked onto a golden clasp.

Even with her eyes closed, Yu Qianqian could sense the sudden brightness around the bed.

The mattress dipped slightly—she guessed Qi Min had sat down beside her.

Though she kept her eyes shut, she could almost feel his serpent-like gaze sweeping over her. Her entire body instinctively tensed, fingers

beneath the covers clenched so tightly they turned white.

She struggled to maintain her act, unaware that the man seated beside her watched the faint tremors of her lashes with a mocking curl of his lips.

Her back was injured, and after applying medicine, Qi Min didn't even allow the maids to change her clothes. Amid the silver-red Soft Smoke Gauze bedding, half of her bare back revealed snow-white skin, the hideous knife wound adding a touch of ravaged beauty, like a delicate orchid crushed by rough hands.

Qi Min watched the woman desperately pretending to sleep, the curve of his lips deepening slightly as he reached out with a pale, cool hand to trace her spine.

Sure enough, the next moment, goosebumps crawled up Yu Qianqian's arms.

Knowing she could no longer feign sleep, Yu Qianqian opened her watery eyes and shot Qi Min a cold glare. "Take your hand away!"

Instead of withdrawing, Qi Min seized her chin, asking leisurely, "No more pretending?"

Yu Qianqian recoiled as if bitten by a viper, disgust evident in her voice. "If I hadn't pretended, how else would I have heard your schemes? Even a vicious tiger wouldn't harm its own cub. Yet you'd kill your own son—what loyalty do those followers owe you? Aren't they afraid you'll turn on them one day too?"

Qi Min released her chin, his lips quirking indifferently. "Are you angry because I want to kill that little bastard?"

Rage flickered in Yu Qianqian's eyes, but he suddenly leaned closer, his voice icy and mocking. "If you and he had both stayed obediently by my side, I wouldn't have touched him. But you ran away with him and fell into Xie Zheng's hands. Surely someone as clever as you knows Xie Zheng could use him to command the warlords?"

Yu Qianqian remained silent, her face paling further, though her furious glare never wavered.

Qi Min's eyes were cold, reptilian, his thin lips nearly brushing her ear as he taunted, "It's not me who wants him dead. You're the one forcing my hand."

He drew back slightly, savoring the sight of her trembling—whether from fear or fury—and spoke pityingly, "Qianqian, the one who nearly got that child killed was you."

"Lies!" Yu Qianqian spat, her agitation tugging at the wound on her back. Pain flashed across her face, draining more color from her cheeks.

Qi Min frowned slightly, shedding his mockery as he steadied her shoulders. "Don't move. You'll reopen the wound."

Beads of sweat formed on Yu Qianqian's forehead from the pain, but she suddenly let out a scornful laugh. "Qi Min, why don't you just kill me too?"

His fingers dug into her shoulders, nails nearly piercing flesh as he locked eyes with her, his voice dark. "I won't kill you. And you don't want to die either."

Releasing her, he paused, then softened his tone. "If you want children, we'll have more in the future—as many as you like. That child was never meant to be born when he was."

Yu Bao'er had come into this world as his replacement.

He could never love a child who might usurp his place at any moment. That he hadn't killed Bao'er already was the greatest mercy he could offer.

He would have heirs—but only after reclaiming everything that was his, only after securing absolute power.

He loathed anything that threatened him.

Tears welled in Yu Qianqian's eyes as she endured the searing pain in her back. She spat at him viciously, then shut her eyes. "If I'd known it would come to this, I should've let you die by the lake back then!"

The moment the words left her lips, the air around Qi Min turned glacial.

In the end, he merely stared at Yu Qianqian with a cold laugh: "It's far too late for regrets now. You were the one who dragged this demon back into the human world. Everything that follows is only what you deserve!"

He strode away, leaving only the swaying bead curtain on the bed canopy behind him.

Yu Qianqian clutched the bedding, her face still pale from severe injuries, yet her gaze toward the doorway was clear and icy—calm to the

point of indifference.

As soon as Qi Min stepped out of the room, the Shadow Guard waiting outside bowed and addressed him, "Your Highness."

Qi Min replied darkly, "Keep a close watch on her."

The Shadow Guard acknowledged the order respectfully. Only after Qi Min had walked away did he glance at the tightly shut door.

His Highness had always been deeply suspicious. Even Lan Shi, after suggesting he produce an heir, had fallen out of his favor. Only the woman inside the room—who knew what spell she had cast—had remained an exception all these years.

After walking a few steps, Qi Min was approached by the same Shadow Guard who had reported to him earlier, his collar still stained with specks of blood: "Your Highness, as ordered, I have severed one of Xuan Jian's arms."

Qi Min, still toying with the half-piece of the Tiger Tally behind his back, showed no interest in the report. Instead, he asked, "What of the other half of the Tiger Tally?"

Each autumn rain brings deeper chill.

Rootless Water cascaded from the eaves, splashing in puddles along the corridor. The cold wind carried the dampness to the base of the wall, where aged redwood, darkened by the rain, stood. The hem of the young man leaning against the wall bore faint water stains.

The copper wind chimes hanging along the corridor swayed wildly in the wind, their melancholic and fragmented chimes filling the air.

Inside the room, agonized groans occasionally pierced the silence. Xie Zheng seemed not to hear them, his arms crossed as he leaned against the wall, lost in thought while watching the sudden autumn rain.

The cold wind tousled the strands of hair at his temples, and the faint cut on his jade-like face stung in the breeze. His lowered eyes were as sharp as the wound on his face.

After a while, the physician treating the patient inside emerged with his medicine chest. Xie Zhong, who had also been waiting under the eaves, immediately stepped forward to ask, "How is General Zhu?"

Xie Zheng's gaze shifted over indifferently.

The physician shook his head silently and sighed, "The bones and tendons in his legs were broken over a decade ago. The tissue has long since necrotized. There's no hope of him ever walking again."

Xie Zhong, who had lost an arm and a leg himself, understood the pain. After a moment of silence, he only said, "Do your best to treat him."

The physician nodded and left to prepare the medicine.

A servant attending to the patient inside hurried out to summon someone: "Marquis, General Zhu wishes to see you!"

The truth he had long sought was now within reach, yet Xie Zheng hesitated for a moment before stepping into the room.

The physician had scraped away the rotting flesh and redressed the wounds, leaving the stench of blood thick in the air.

The man lying on the bed was bearded, his hair tangled like dry grass, crawling with lice. Aside from a pair of sharp, alert eyes, his features were nearly unrecognizable.

Both his legs were broken, and after seventeen years in a lightless dungeon, they had wasted away to little more than skin and bone.

Xie Zheng looked at this old general who had once served under Meng Shuyuan and his own father, and said simply, "General Zhu, you're home."

Zhu Youchang stared fixedly at Xie Zheng, then suddenly let out a heart-wrenching sob: "Seventeen years... seventeen years have passed! The descendants of General Xie have grown into such towering figures! In my lifetime... I never thought I'd live to see the general's heir again!"

Overcome with grief, this once battle-hardened warrior could only pound the edge of the bed and weep bitterly.

Xie Zhong limped forward to support Zhu Youchang, his eyes red as he asked, "General Zhu, please calm yourself first. Why were you imprisoned by Wei Yan for seventeen years? Was there more to the grain transport delay back then?"

At the mention of the failed grain transport, Zhu Youchang grew even more agitated. Choking back tears, he cried, "That beast Wei Yan is worse than swine! General Meng suffered the most unjust accusation in history! The poor old general died with bitter regret, and the loyal Meng family—not a single descendant remains!"

Chapter 127

It was common knowledge that both of Meng Shuyuan's sons had died in battle, leaving only his youngest daughter who later married a young officer from the army. But after Meng Shuyuan took his own life at Luocheng, his daughter perished when her carriage overturned and plunged off a cliff on her way back from worshiping at a temple, leaving no remains to be found.

Later, the imperial court concluded the case, stating that Meng Shuyuan had delayed military operations to aid disaster victims in Luocheng, leading to the crushing defeat of Xie Linshan and Crown Prince Chengde at Jinzhou. When the public cursed Meng Shuyuan, the most frequent insult was: "It serves him right that the Meng family line was cut off."

Xie Zhong, a retainer of the Xie family, knew full well the gravity of the accusations pinned on the mastermind behind the Jinzhou massacre. Hearing Zhu Youchang claim Meng Shuyuan was wronged, he couldn't help but feel sorrowful. Just as he was about to offer some words of comfort, Xie Zheng, who had been silent until then, suddenly spoke: "Old General Meng's descendants still live."

These words stunned not only Zhu Youchang but even Xie Zhong.

Zhu Youchang, disregarding his crippled legs, tried to rise by bracing against the bed frame, only to be stopped in time by Xie Zhong.

"Marquis, I beg you to tell me—where are Old General Meng's descendants now? Is my sworn sister Lihua... still alive?" Zhu Youchang clasped his fists toward Xie Zheng, his lips trembling between a sob and a smile, hot tears rolling into his unkempt beard.

Xie Zheng didn't know the name of Meng Shuyuan's daughter, but upon hearing "Lihua," he instinctively recalled the name "Lihua" inscribed on Madam Fan's memorial tablet in Lin'an Town.

Lihua, Lihua—it seemed the Fan couple had been too afraid of drawing trouble to even keep their original names.

Meeting Zhu Youchang's earnest gaze, Xie Zheng paused briefly before saying, "General Zhu, please accept my condolences. Old General Meng's beloved daughter is no longer with us, leaving only two granddaughters."

As a key general under Meng Shuyuan and practically his adopted son, Zhu Youchang had been extremely close to Meng's children. Meng Lihua, in particular, was like a younger sister he had watched grow up. Though he had long assumed her dead, Xie Zheng's mention of surviving descendants rekindled hope that she might still be alive.

Now learning of her death, grief overwhelmed him, and he covered his face with a hand, weeping bitterly twice.

Xie Zhong was deeply puzzled by how much Xie Zheng knew about the Meng descendants. Given the Marquis's temperament, even his closest attendants had never dared mention the Meng family in his presence.

How had he uncovered such detailed information about them without revealing a hint of it?

The more Xie Zhong thought, the stranger it seemed, his brows knitting tightly. He wanted to question Xie Zheng but knew this wasn't the time, so he merely patted Zhu Youchang's shoulder and echoed, "General, please accept our condolences."

Zhu Youchang also realized that, given Xie Zheng's position, he would likely have harbored deep hatred for the Meng family before learning the truth. That he knew so much about their descendants—could it be for revenge?

This thought sent Zhu Youchang's heart racing. Suppressing his sorrow, he studied Xie Zheng and asked, "Marquis, may I ask where my two nieces are now?"

Xie Zheng replied, "They are currently safe. The elder is sixteen now. When rebels besieged Lucheng, our army blocked the river upstream of Jizhou to flood them. She once crossed mountains in night rain to ambush rebel scouts, then escorted army provisions to First Line Gorge, where she beheaded Shi Hu, a fierce general under Prince Changxin. She later became the adopted daughter of Grand Tutor Tao Yi and was recommended by him to join the army..."

His voice was low and unhurried as he recounted Fan Changyu's journey in the military. Every scene he briefly mentioned flashed vividly in his mind.

Their reunion at First Line Gorge, where she had sobbed uncontrollably by his bedside; the battlefield strewn with corpses, where she stood atop a pile of bodies, a cleaver in hand, her face fierce and unyielding...

The path of a soldier was not an easy one. The hardships she endured, the blood and tears she shed—he knew them all.

"In the Battle of Chongzhou, she led the right-wing army as the vanguard, saving He Jingyuan from the blade and slaying Changxin Wang on horseback, earning her the rank of fifth-grade Swift Cavalry Commandant. In the Battle of Lucheng, she claimed the name Meng Changyu, volunteered to hold the city to the death, buying time, declaring she would rather die to restore her ancestors' honor."

Zhu Youchang listened as Xie Zheng recounted these events, tears streaming down his face without pause.

When Xie Zheng finished speaking, Zhu Youchang was so choked with emotion that he couldn't speak for a long while. Covering his face, he wept bitterly before finally managing to say in a trembling voice, "This is the General's flesh and blood, the General's flesh and blood!"

Xie Zhong was also deeply shocked. He had long heard rumors of a female general emerging in the northwest, but he never expected her to be the descendant of Meng Shuyuan—and that his own Marquis was so intimately familiar with her background.

Could it be that Xie Zheng had known all along that Meng Shuyuan was wrongly accused in the grain transport incident?

Lost in thought, Xie Zhong failed to steady Zhu Youchang in time, allowing the man to push his hand away and collapse from the edge of the bed.

Zhu Youchang's legs were broken, so he could only kneel by supporting himself with his hands on the ground. He bowed deeply to Xie Zheng.

"General Zhu, what are you doing? Get up quickly!" Xie Zhong stepped forward to help him, but Zhu Youchang refused to rise.

Xie Zheng was also startled by the sudden turn of events and momentarily failed to avoid Zhu Youchang's bow. He crouched down to help the man up himself. "General Zhu, whatever it is, let's talk after you stand."

Still, Zhu Youchang would not rise. This man, who had not shed a single tear even when his legs were broken on the battlefield, now wept as if his heart were being torn apart.

Choking back sobs, he said, "This bow is Old Zhu's way of thanking the Marquis on behalf of the Meng family. The Marquis, unaware of the truth from back then, still allowed that child to carve out a place for herself in the military. Old Zhu thanks the Marquis for his righteousness and magnanimity!"

Xie Linshan had been gutted and hung from the tower of Jinzhou, a memory that still brought common folk to tears when mentioned, cursing the Northern Turks for their barbarity. Xie Zheng, as Xie Linshan's own son, harbored even greater hatred for the mastermind behind the Jinzhou massacre than the people did.

Zhu Youchang didn't know how Xie Zheng could regard the Meng family's descendant in the military with such fairness. In that moment, all he felt was boundless gratitude and respect.

Hearing Zhu Youchang's words, Xie Zheng's hand, which had been helping him up, paused slightly. He asked, "General Zhu, what exactly was the truth back then?"

The memory of those events made Zhu Youchang gnash his teeth in fury. "Back then, it wasn't the old general who disregarded military orders and delayed the grain transport. It was the Sixteenth Prince, who was accompanying the army, obsessed with glory. Seeing only a few thousand Northern Turks guarding Luocheng and tens of thousands of civilians trapped inside, he ignored the old general's orders and insisted on leading a rescue. In the end, the Sixteenth Prince was captured alive. The Northern Turks demanded the old general exchange the army's grain supplies for the prince's life—or else they would use the prince's blood to consecrate their banners!"

Xie Zhong's expression changed drastically, and Xie Zheng's eyes darkened.

Not for any trivial reason, but because, over the past decade, the matter of the Sixteenth Prince seemed to have been deliberately erased—there wasn't even a single historical record of what the Sixteenth Prince had done during the Battle of Luocheng.

When Xie Zheng first heard the rumors and retrieved the case files from the Court of Revision regarding the re-investigation of the Jinzhou incident, the records stated that General Meng Shuyuan of Changshan had disregarded military orders to rescue the 100,000 trapped civilians in Luocheng. In the end, he not only failed to save them but also caused the death of the accompanying Sixteenth Prince. The delay in grain transport indirectly led to the fall of Jinzhou on the frontlines, after which he committed suicide out of guilt.

Yet the Northern Jue forces occupying Luocheng at that time were hardly formidable. Their numbers were small, they lacked supplies, and they could only cling to survival in that confined space by relying on Luocheng's naturally defensible terrain.

The imperial court initially ignored Luocheng for two reasons: first, the situation in Jinzhou was far more critical, and second, the enemy in Luocheng hadn't yet reached desperation—storming the city would have required significant time and effort.

By contrast, holding Jinzhou—the gateway—and keeping the Northern Jue army outside the pass would allow them to later deal with the remaining Northern Jue forces in Luocheng without worry, like closing the door to beat a dog.

This was why Xie Zheng had resented Meng Shuyuan all these years.

Not aiding Luocheng would cost many lives, but losing Jinzhou would leave Great Yin's gates wide open, allowing foreign tribes to sweep in unchecked—resulting in ten or a hundred times more deaths.

It was Meng Shuyuan's momentary womanly compassion that made him defy orders and commit an irreparable mistake!

But now it seemed Meng Shuyuan hadn't acted out of ignorance—was the Sixteenth Prince's involvement the real reason?

Xie Zhong frowned and asked, "Did Old General Meng delay the grain transport to save the Sixteenth Prince?"

Zhu Youchang said urgently, "General Meng was the most trusted veteran under the Grand General—how could he be so reckless? Commander Xie, having campaigned alongside the Grand General, should know our general's character well!"

Xie Linshan had been enfeoffed as the Grand General Protector of the Nation, the only one in all of Great Yin to bear the title “Grand General.”

Xie Zhong, a retainer of the Xie family, had once served as Xie Linshan’s personal guard, holding the rank of commander—hence Zhu Youchang’s use of the old title.

Hearing this, Xie Zhong unconsciously relaxed.

Zhu Youchang said bitterly, “The Marquis is still young and may not know how deeply the Late Emperor doted on the Sixteenth Prince, but Commander Xie should remember.”

He looked at Xie Zhong, who nodded. “The Sixteenth Prince’s maternal clan was powerful, and his mother, Jia Guifei, was the most favored consort in the harem. Back then, it was often rumored that if not for Crown Prince Chengde’s virtue and popularity among officials and commoners alike, the Late Emperor might have named the Sixteenth Prince as heir.”

Xie Zheng remained silent, lowering his gaze to conceal his thoughts.

It was strange that such a dazzling figure as the Sixteenth Prince had left behind only fragments of records after seventeen years.

After Xie Zhong’s corroboration, Zhu Youchang continued, “General Meng dared not ignore the Sixteenth Prince’s life, nor could he delay the grain transport. So he sent an urgent military report to the capital, seeking the Late Emperor’s instructions on rescuing His Highness. Meanwhile, he ordered the main army to continue escorting the grain to Jinzhou, leaving only a small detachment to skirmish outside Luocheng.”

“Two days later, an urgent delivery arrived from the capital—a Tiger Tally and a personal letter from Wei Yan.” At the mention of Wei Yan, Zhu Youchang’s jaw clenched as if he wished to tear the man’s flesh with his teeth. “That vile coward wrote that the Emperor commanded the general to return at once to save the Sixteenth Prince, while grain would be escorted to Jinzhou by troops from Chongzhou.”

Chongzhou was geographically situated between Luocheng and Jinzhou, with both fronts in urgent need. To resolve this pressing crisis, it indeed made the most sense for Meng Shuyuan’s grain transport army to turn back and attack Luocheng, while the forces stationed in Chongzhou escorted provisions to Jinzhou to prevent any delays.

Xie Zheng keenly identified the flaw in this arrangement and asked, "For such a military transfer, with only a personal letter from Wei Yan and not even an imperial decree, did the old general truly believe it?"

Zhu Youchang instinctively reached into his lapel but found nothing, then regretfully pounded the bed frame: "There was the Tiger Tally as proof! But when I was rescued from prison, someone claiming to be from the Chengde Crown Prince's faction appeared. Fearing I wouldn't survive, I hastily gave the tally to that person, begging him to clear General Meng's name!"

Xie Zheng had taken advantage of the chaos when Qi Min's men clashed with Wei Yan's trained martial assassins to extract Zhu Youchang, so he knew Qi Min's people had participated in the jailbreak.

He said, "I've reviewed the court records of Tiger Tally deployments from seventeen years ago. Before Jinzhou fell, there was no record of additional tallies being issued."

Zhu Youchang urgently countered, "There was! Wei Qilin, that ingrate, personally brought the tally and letter then! While I didn't recognize Chongzhou's Tiger Tally, General Meng couldn't possibly have mistaken Changzhou's. He verified both tallies matched before redirecting to Luocheng!"

As the truth of that year was gradually uncovered, Xie Zheng remained eerily composed. He asked, "Two Tiger Tallies deployed at once, with Changzhou's army responsible for grain transport—why was there no imperial decree?"

Zhu Youchang's face twisted in anguish as he recalled: "That ingrate Wei Qilin said since the Sixteenth Prince had caused this disaster, an official decree would make the crime undeniable. Without one, just granting the tallies, if we could hold Jinzhou and retake Luocheng, it would become a glorious achievement to be overlooked. Everyone knew how favored the Sixteenth Prince was. Seeing the tallies and Wei Yan's handwritten letter, we believed his lies!"

Xie Zheng suddenly asked, "Wei Qilin betrayed Old General Meng?"

Zhu Youchang gnashed his teeth: "Wei Qilin was always Wei Yan's lapdog! After seeing the tallies and letter, General Meng temporarily left the grain convoy guarded on the road and led the main force to rescue the Sixteenth Prince at Luocheng, while Wei Qilin took Chongzhou's tally to

mobilize troops there! After days of bitter fighting at Luocheng, what awaited us was news of Jinzhou's fall and the deaths of the Chengde Crown Prince and General Xie!"

Overcome by emotion, Zhu Youchang covered his face: "No Chongzhou troops ever delivered provisions! Jinzhou's soldiers starved until too weak to fight, slaughtered like livestock by the Northern Turks!"

Even Xie Zhong felt his heart grow heavy hearing this long-buried truth.

However one looked at it, Wei Yan was deeply implicated.

Yet Xie Zheng, unaware of this, had been raised by Wei Yan and called him uncle for over a decade!

Xie Zhong glanced complexly at Xie Zheng, whose lowered head kept most of his face shadowed, obscuring his expression. Only his question emerged: "Wei Qilin never returned?"

Zhu Youchang spat venomously: "If that bastard dared show his face, I'd kill him myself!"

Something still didn't add up.

Xie Zheng recalled the letter the martial assassins raised by Wei Yan had gone to Fan Changyu's house to find, and slowly spoke: "Before Old General Meng passed away, apart from giving General Zhu the Changzhou Tiger Tally, did he leave any other instructions?"

Zhu Youchang recalled the events of that day, his heart still aching as if cut by a knife. With reddened eyes, he said: "The battle report of Jinzhou's fall reached the army in the morning. When we went to the general's tent to find him, he was already in utter despair, sitting motionless and unwilling to speak a word. Knowing he blamed himself deeply, I feared he might do something drastic, so I stayed by his side in the tent. It was then that the general handed me the Tiger Tally."

"The general said that from that day onward, the Changzhou Tiger Tally was lost, and that we should wait for the right moment to bring it out again."

"At the time, I didn't understand the meaning behind his words. But in the brief moment I turned away to fetch a meal, the general knelt facing Jinzhou in the tent and took his own life..."

Zhu Youchang choked with sobs: "Soon after, the imperial reprimand arrived. The general had only diverted to Luocheng after receiving the troop deployment order, yet he was accused of disregarding military commands and delaying grain shipments, leading to Jinzhou's tragic defeat!"

Seventeen years later, Zhu Youchang still wept bitterly, crying out from the depths of his soul for Old General Meng: "General Meng was wronged!"

Outside, the heavy rain continued unabated. A cold wind blew through the open doors and windows, bringing in a damp chill so intense it seemed even the heavens mourned this unparalleled injustice suffered by the Meng family.

Xie Zheng helped Zhu Youchang up. Though his expression remained composed, one hand at his side had already clenched into a tight fist. He asked: "General Zhu, with such irrefutable evidence as the Tiger Tally in hand, why didn't you seek justice for Old General Meng back then?"

Zhu Youchang, agitated, replied: "How could I not have thought of it? I wanted to return to the capital and present this matter before His Majesty! But all of General Meng's subordinate generals were demoted several ranks and scattered to various remote postings. I lost any chance to see the emperor! I hoped the Crown Prince would investigate thoroughly, but soon after, a great fire broke out in the Eastern Palace, killing both the Crown Princess and the imperial grandson..."

Zhu Youchang pounded the bed in anguish, his face twisted in pain as he wailed: "My only remaining hope was the old troops under General Xie. At first, I wasn't even sure if Wei Yan was involved—after all, General Xie's wife was his own younger sister! But when I finally managed to connect with General Xie's former subordinates under the pretext of paying respects to the late general, Madam Xie overheard everything. When Wei Yan discovered our plans and had us detained, it was Madam Xie who threatened to take her own life to force Wei Yan to spare us!"

"Who could have imagined that this imprisonment would last seventeen years!" Zhu Youchang cried out in despair.

The cold wind, carrying the scent of rain, swept into the room, stirring the strands of hair across Xie Zheng's forehead. His face was unusually pale as he whispered a name in a voice so quiet only he could hear it: "Mother."

Xie Zhong's expression also changed, his voice filled with shock: "So when Madam Xie ordered us back to the Xie residence in Huizhou back then, it was to prevent us from being implicated in this matter? Then her death..."

Xie Zhong suddenly fell silent mid-sentence, looking at Xie Zheng with unbearable sorrow in his eyes.

Sending Xie Zheng to be raised by Wei Yan—that had been Madam Xie's decision, hadn't it? To ensure Wei Yan would never feel threatened by this child's existence.

Xie Zheng's lips pressed into a thin, icy line. His entire body tensed, tendons standing out sharply as he drove a fist with devastating force into the sturdy huanghuali wood table, reducing it to splinters. From his throat emerged that name, laden with endless hatred and bloodthirsty fury: "Wei Yan—"

Chapter 128

Zhu Youchang was still unaware of the schemes Qi Min had carried out in collusion with the Li family. Indignantly, he said, "Marquis, since the Crown Prince's eldest grandson still lives, with me as a witness and the Tiger Tally in his hands as evidence, we can surely bring down Wei Yan!"

Xie Zhong also lamented the injustice Meng Shuyuan had endured for so many years. But as an outsider, he remained somewhat calmer. He advised, "Marquis, General Zhu, when you think carefully about the events of that year, there are still many unanswered questions. Wei Yan is a formidable opponent. We should deliberate carefully before acting."

Neither Xie Zheng nor Zhu Youchang spoke. Xie Zhong continued, "Wei Qilin was originally a retainer of the Wei family and later became Old General Meng's son-in-law. The Tiger Tally he took to Changzhou was genuine, yet the Marquis now finds no records in the archives regarding its deployment. This suggests that either the Late Emperor indeed deployed it to cover up the Sixteenth Prince's mistake and deliberately omitted it from the Ministry of War's records, or... Wei Yan had already gained such unchecked power back then that he could privately mobilize the Tiger Tally without authorization!"

Outside, the storm raged on, the damp chill of the rain seeping through the air and permeating the room with a clammy heaviness. The truth behind the bloodshed in Jinzhou and the real cause of his mother's death gnawed at Xie Zheng, veins bulging at his temples as a throbbing pain pulsed through his skull.

His refined features were pale with a cold intensity, like snow upon a blade's edge, the corners of his eyes tinged with faint streaks of red. "Going to such lengths to delay Old General Meng's grain shipment—the true aim of the mastermind was to ensure Jinzhou's fall."

Or rather, to ensure the death of the Chengde Crown Prince.

Everyone knew what the fall of Jinzhou would mean for Great Yin.

Even if the Chengde Crown Prince hadn't died in the battle for Jinzhou, he would likely have been stripped of his title upon returning to court.

Xie Linshan had been a casualty in this struggle for imperial power.

Under Xie Zheng's guidance, Xie Zhong quickly grasped the crux of the matter. Horrified, he exclaimed, "Could it be that the Sixteenth Prince deliberately put himself in danger? Just to ensure the Chengde Crown Prince died in Jinzhou and seize the position of Crown Prince?"

Zhu Youchang, a blunt man, wasn't as quick-witted as Xie Zhong. Hearing this, he frowned in confusion. "But wouldn't that be far too reckless? Throwing himself into the tiger's maw—was he so certain the Late Emperor would spare no effort to rescue him?"

In truth, the Sixteenth Prince had indeed died in Luocheng.

Luocheng was easy to defend but hard to attack. When news of Jinzhou's fall reached Luocheng, the imperial army was plunged into despair. With both the Chengde Crown Prince and Xie Linshan dead, morale collapsed entirely.

The Northern Turks within Luocheng, knowing their forces could now advance unimpeded, saw no further use in keeping the Sixteenth Prince as a hostage. They executed him outright as a sacrifice to their banners.

With the most beloved heir and the Late Emperor's favorite son both dead, Zhu Youchang suddenly realized the reasons behind Jinzhou's fall were far from simple.

After Zhu Youchang's remark, Xie Zhong also felt his earlier speculation no longer held water.

He mused, "As the saying goes, 'When the snipe and the clam grapple, the fisherman profits.' Back then, the Late Emperor doted on the Sixteenth Prince, while the Chengde Crown Prince went to Jinzhou to oversee the battle personally, hoping to win the army's loyalty. The Sixteenth Prince, eager to claim military merit, petitioned the Late Emperor soon after and secured a position supervising grain transport to the frontlines. Yet in the end, both the Chengde Crown Prince and the Sixteenth Prince perished..."

Abruptly, he turned to Xie Zheng. "Could it be that another prince was pulling the strings from behind the scenes, fueling the conflict to vie for the throne?"

After a brief moment of thought, Zhu Youchang gritted his teeth and spat out, "Wei Yan! It must be Wei Yan! After the deaths of Crown Prince Chengde and the Sixteenth Prince, the Late Emperor succumbed to grief

and illness. Wei Yan swiftly overrode all opposition to install the powerless Nineteenth Prince on the throne! That beast worse than swine—for the sake of power, he wouldn't even spare his own sister and brother-in-law! If not for fear of public suspicion, he'd have seated himself on that dragon throne!"

Overcome with grief, Zhu Youchang's hoarse voice broke into sobs again: "Wei Qilin truly lives up to being Wei Yan's trained dog. General Meng treated him so well! Sister Lihua was even pregnant at the time—how could he bear to help Wei Yan frame General Meng?"

Fearing Xie Zheng might hold grudges against the Meng descendants because of Wei Qilin, he added, "Marquis, if any of Sister Lihua's surviving children carry Wei Qilin's blood, you need not consider them part of the Wei family. The Meng clan disowns that ungrateful traitor Wei Qilin! They are solely Meng blood!"

When Zhu Youchang mentioned Meng Qilin again, Xie Zheng's pale face showed no emotion. His dark lashes lowered slightly as he only asked, "That handwritten letter Wei Yan sent to Old General Meng could also serve as evidence against him. Do you know its whereabouts, General Zhu?"

Zhu Youchang said with self-reproach, "When news of Jinzhou's fall arrived, chaos swept through the army. I never anticipated Wei Yan would frame General Meng, so I didn't realize the letter's importance then. By the time the imperial reprimand came down, it was already lost..."

The throbbing pain in his head made Xie Zheng frown involuntarily.

The letter had ultimately fallen into Wei Qilin's hands—what else had transpired? But Zhu Youchang knew no more.

The paler Xie Zheng grew, the calmer he appeared. Having obtained the answers he sought, he said, "Wei Yan colluded with rebels and has been impeached by the Li family. He will soon face judgment in the Golden Hall. General Zhu, focus on recovering. The blood debts from seventeen years ago—this Marquis will collect every last one from that Wei dog!"

After leaving Zhu Youchang's quarters, Xie Zhong followed closely behind Xie Zheng, hesitating to speak several times.

The rain lightened, leaving only a curtain of fine droplets dripping from the corridor eaves.

Clad in dark robes with one hand behind his back, Xie Zheng stood silently beneath the eaves, gazing at the lush green bamboo in the courtyard. His handsome features seemed indifferent, yet an oppressive aura of gloom and lethality radiated from him, overwhelming his noble bearing.

After much hesitation, Xie Zhong finally spoke: "Marquis..."

Without lifting his eyelids, Xie Zheng said, "No need to follow me. Dismissed."

Xie Zhong ventured unusually forward: "Madam's actions back then were surely to protect you, Marquis—a last resort. Please don't grieve. If the General and Madam knew of your accomplishments now, they would smile in the afterlife."

Xie Zheng's eyes turned sharply cold and fierce: "Dismissed."

Xie Zhong glanced at Xie Zheng's unyielding back and sighed inwardly.

He had always known—Madam Xie's suicide was an unshakable knot in Xie Zheng's heart.

Now with the truth revealed, it would only bring Xie Zheng greater pain.

For over a decade, he had hated Madam Xie's weakness, hated her cruelty in abandoning him to be raised by their enemies.

Yet Madam Xie had taken her own life after uncovering Wei Yan's conspiracy—to protect Zhu Youchang and the old Xie faction.

Wei Yan could imprison Zhu Youchang and others for a lifetime, but he could never keep his own sister locked away forever. As long as Madam Xie lived, Xie Zheng would eventually learn the truth of what happened that year.

With Wei Yan's methods, he would undoubtedly seek to eradicate the root of the problem.

Madam Xie had chosen to hang herself to save Xie Zheng's life. By leaving a final request for Wei Yan to raise Xie Zheng, she had also placed him directly under Wei Yan's watchful eye, ensuring Wei Yan's complete peace of mind.

A year ago, when Xie Zheng heard the rumors and began reinvestigating the Jinzhou case, Wei Yan had indeed set a deadly trap, intending for him to perish in the rebellion suppression at Chongzhou.

The mother he had both resented and missed for over a decade had actually died for him. Xie Zhong had no idea how much pain this revelation would inflict upon the young man before him, who had shouldered the fate of the Xie family with his slender shoulders since adolescence.

Knowing Xie Zheng's temperament, Xie Zhong found himself at a loss for words of comfort. After clasping his hands in a bow, he finally withdrew.

The vast corridor was now empty, leaving Xie Zheng alone. The cold wind picked up again, driving the fine rain sideways into the covered walkway, brushing against his pale face and leaving only a chilling dampness.

Leaning against a pillar, Xie Zheng lifted one leg and sat on the wooden railing. His long, dark lashes lowered like a fan as he stared unblinkingly at the bamboo leaves in the distance, where rainwater had gathered until it could no longer hold and dripped from the tips.

He tried hard to recall, but he still couldn't remember that woman's face. In his mind, there was only a faint shadow of her smiling gently, as though no sin in this world was beyond her forgiveness.

Yet the last memory she left him was standing at the doorway, watching the hem of her skirt swaying in the air from inside the room.

This scene had tormented him through countless nights, jolting him awake in cold sweat from nightmares.

He had hated her for her weakness and selfishness, but she had gone to her death to protect him.

The cold wind blew strands of hair across his eyelids. Xie Zheng tilted his head slightly, raising a hand to cover his eyes. He remained motionless in that position for a long time.

Wei Mansion

The autumn rain seemed intent on washing away all the filth of the world.

Before the grand gates of Wei Mansion, two lanterns burned, their glow hidden within the thick shadows of the parasol trees like a pair of crimson beastly eyes.

In front of the study window, wild chrysanthemums stood defiantly against the cold wind and mournful rain, their slender stems stubbornly

supporting unopened buds—whether out of pride or sheer obstinacy, it was hard to say.

The entire court knew Wei Yan loved chrysanthemums, yet he disdained rare and precious varieties, favoring instead the wild chrysanthemums that grew freely across mountains and fields.

Throughout the Prime Minister's residence, these wildflowers flourished in abundance, their aggressive growth often overwhelming other plants in the gardens if the servants neglected their care even slightly.

A pool of warm lamplight spread across the desk as the elderly man, his frame still robust despite the chill of the rainy night, reviewed documents in nothing but a thin robe.

Kneeling below, a man drenched in cold sweat reported the day's events:

"...Two groups attempted a prison break. After years of searching for the Tiger Tally of Xunchang to no avail, it turns out Zhu Youchang had sewn it into his severed leg. When the first group helped him escape, they were intercepted by the Tian-ranked operatives. Unable to move quickly due to his legs, Zhu feared holding them back. He picked up a dagger, cut open his own flesh, and retrieved the Tiger Tally for them..."

"Later, another group arrived. Judging by their martial arts style, they must have been from the Xie family. They took advantage of the Tian-ranked warriors chasing the previous group who had stolen the Tiger Tally and rescued Zhu Youchang..."

The old man's brush never paused. The ink strokes, illuminated by the dim candlelight, were bold and powerful—each hook and stroke as unyielding as tempered iron.

At the time, people admired cursive script, while those in officialdom prided themselves on mastering the refined Taige style. Yet Wei Yan was renowned for his Shoujin calligraphy.

His writing mirrored the man himself—lean, sinewy, and unbreakable.

Hearing no response from the old man, the kneeling man below felt cold sweat gather on his brow, growing heavier with each passing moment of silence. When the unknown terror reached its peak, he kowtowed heavily before the desk, pressing his forehead against the icy floor tiles, and said in a trembling voice, "I beg the Prime Minister's punishment!"

The old man finally set down his brush and cast a faint glance downward. "Go to the punishment chamber yourself."

For the Martial Assassins raised in Wei Mansion, a single visit to the punishment chamber was akin to losing half one's life. Yet upon hearing these words, the kneeling man felt only the wild relief of having narrowly escaped death.

After kowtowing once more to the old man, he silently withdrew from the study.

A servant stepped forward to clean the ink brush and murmured, "My Lord, the events of that year... I fear they can no longer be concealed."

Wei Yan rose and paced to the window, letting the cold wind fill his sleeves, making them billow noisily. The flickering candlelight stretched his shadow unnaturally long, like a towering mountain.

Gazing at the wild chrysanthemums swaying in the desolate courtyard rain, he said, "Send word to the palace. It is time for the Western Expedition army to enter the capital and receive their honors."

Chapter 129

As autumn deepened, the northern skies grew colder day by day. In the early mornings, the bare branches of elms and poplars in the courtyard were coated with a layer of white frost.

During the month Fan Changyu spent recovering from her injuries, her clothing had shifted from summer's thin garments to thick autumn attire.

She had injured her back while protecting Yu Qianqian and her child, leaving her temporarily unable to wield weapons. Finding idle bedrest unbearably dull, she turned again to the abstruse Four Books and Five Classics.

Truthfully, she was more interested in military strategy texts. But some of the battle formations mentioned in these works required knowledge of celestial phenomena and geographical terrain, giving Changyu such headaches that she could only progress gradually, starting with beginner-level books first.

Changning had previously learned characters from a private tutor, though her studies had been sporadic at best. Now, seeing Changyu constantly reading with a book in hand and having Yu Bao'er as a playmate, she suddenly regained interest in studying and began competing with Bao'er to see who could recognize more characters.

When Bao'er could already recite simple poems, Changning—unable to match him—felt her competitive spirit flare up and clamored to find a tutor.

The private tutor hired during their temporary stay in Chongzhou hadn't followed them back to Jizhou. With no stable residence at present, Changyu had postponed finding her a new tutor.

Yu Bao'er volunteered to teach Changning, but the child's stubborn pride made her adamantly refuse. Though Changyu hadn't read extensively, her mother had forced her to learn all the characters, so she began teaching Changning herself.

Bao'er, ever studious, visited Changyu's room daily to study alongside them. The two children often competed in reciting poetry, seeing who

could memorize faster—with Bao'er usually coming out ahead. Changning grew so frustrated she nearly cried, but her pride kept the tears at bay. Instead, she'd sneak into Changyu's room at night with her pillow, claiming she wanted to sleep together, when really she sought extra coaching to memorize poems beforehand. Changyu found this both amusing and exasperating.

Through this method, Changning finally bested Bao'er a few times. But Bao'er learned so quickly that after both had mastered one poem per day, he proposed studying two.

Having only won through cheating, Changning felt too guilty to refuse yet couldn't voice a reason, so she just fidgeted with her clothes in silence. Oblivious, Changyu—seeing Changning keeping pace—thought both children were fast learners and agreed to two poems daily.

That day, unsurprisingly, Changning lost again.

When Aunt Zhao brought them snacks, Changning sat facing the corner on a small stool, her little topknot drooping dejectedly.

Aunt Zhao smiled. "What's wrong, Ning Niang? Your pout could hang an oil bottle."

Changyu, lounging in a chair with a book under the autumn sun, answered laughingly, "She lost a poetry recitation contest with Bao'er."

Aunt Zhao called Changning over for osmanthus cakes, chuckling, "Come eat, dear. As Bao'er's little aunt, you should let him win sometimes."

Changning gasped, whipping her head around to stare excitedly at Bao'er. "I'm your little aunt!"

Bao'er, hearing this for the first time, frowned childishly. "Ning Niang is younger than me. Shouldn't she be Changning-meimei?"

Aunt Zhao couldn't stop smiling: "Seniority isn't determined by age. You call Changyu 'Auntie,' and since Ning Niang is Changyu's sister, doesn't that make her your little aunt?"

Changning, clever beyond her years, realized she'd gained an advantage over Yu Bao'er in terms of seniority and immediately brightened up, grinning from ear to ear as she said to Bao'er, "Quick, call me 'Little Aunt!'"

Fan Changyu watched these two mischievous children and couldn't help but shake her head with a chuckle.

Yu Bao'er pursed his lips and suddenly looked at Fan Changyu: "Then I won't call you 'Auntie Changyu' anymore. I'll call you 'Sister Changyu.'"

Fan Changyu had just turned a page in her book when she heard Bao'er's question, finding it both amusing and exasperating: "That won't do."

Bao'er's face, no longer as round as before, furrowed his brows, showing hints of a young boy's demeanor as he asked, "Why not?"

Fan Changyu replied, "If you call me 'sister,' then wouldn't that make me a generation apart from your mother?"

Bao'er fell silent, sulking.

Only Changning was smug, her grin stretching wide.

As the sun rose higher, the morning frost on the eaves and withered branches melted away, and the dawn light spilled into the room. Changning and Bao'er picked up their books and began reciting, swaying their heads rhythmically. Fan Changyu watched them fondly for a while before stretching comfortably in her reclining chair.

Xie Wu entered from the courtyard to report: "Commander, we have an esteemed guest."

Fan Changyu raised her eyebrows slightly, wondering who in Jizhou would come to visit her.

Moments later, Gongsun Yin strolled in from the courtyard, dressed in a white robe with a silver-furred cloak draped over his shoulders, smiling as warmly as a spring breeze in the depths of autumn: "It's truly been a long time since we parted ways on the battlefield at First Line Gorge. Now that Miss Fan has risen to the rank of commander, I can finally congratulate you in person."

Seeing it was Gongsun Yin, Fan Changyu was genuinely surprised. She stood to greet him: "Master Gongsun is indeed a rare visitor."

Bao'er, who had never met Gongsun Yin before, eyed the unfamiliar handsome man warily.

Changning, however, dashed toward Gongsun Yin like a little firecracker, calling out joyfully, "Uncle Gongsun!"

Gongsun Yin ruffled the little bun on Changning's head and remarked earnestly, "Your hair is finally neatly tied up."

Changning shook the bell-adorned velvet flower in her hair and said, "Aunt Zhao did it."

Gongsun Yin replied, "I figured."

Fan Changyu coughed lightly, interrupting the conversation between the grown man and the child: "My humble abode is simple, Master Gongsun. Please make yourself comfortable."

Aunt Zhao, sensing Fan Changyu had official matters to discuss, coaxed the two children to leave with her.

Xie Wu poured tea for Gongsun Yin, and Fan Changyu asked, "Weren't you in Kangcheng, Master? What brings you suddenly to Jizhou?"

Gongsun Yin took a sip of hot tea and raised an eyebrow: "Has Miss Fan not heard the news yet? His Majesty has decreed that all generals who contributed to quelling the rebellion are to go to the capital to receive their honors."

Fan Changyu said, "I've been recovering from my injuries and haven't been on duty at the military camp, so I haven't heard this news yet."

She asked curiously, "Have you come to join the army, Master Gongsun, to travel to the capital together?"

Gongsun Yin flicked open his folding fan and said mysteriously, "The Gongsun family does not involve itself in court affairs. I came here at Xie Jiuhan's request."

Noticing Fan Changyu's momentary confusion, he paused and asked, "Did Xie Zheng never tell you his courtesy name?"

Fan Changyu shook her head. In the past, she hadn't known Xie Zheng's true identity. By the time she found out, they had quickly parted ways, leaving no opportunity to discuss such matters in detail.

She remarked with some novelty, "So his courtesy name is Jiuheng."

Gongsun Yin said sourly, "Grand Tutor Tao personally chose it for him—of course it's good."

Fan Changyu replied, "My foster father also gave me a courtesy name."

Gongsun Yin's strikingly handsome face twisted with jealousy in an instant. Gripping his teacup, he glared at Fan Changyu with deep resentment and said, "Alright, let's drop this topic."

Fan Changyu looked bewildered, unsure why Gongsun Yin was reacting this way.

But it was true that she hadn't received any letters from Xie Zheng in a long time. Before he left for the capital, he had told her that if anything happened to him, she should ignore any summons to the capital and remain in the northwest.

Now that the imperial summons had arrived, and Xie Zheng hadn't completely lost contact, Fan Changyu was uncertain whether to stay put or take Bao'er to the capital as ordered.

She asked, "Why did he send you to Jizhou?"

Gongsun Yin glanced at her and mused, "That... I'll keep it a secret for now. But in the capital, he suddenly started investigating matters related to the Sixteenth Prince. It might have something to do with the truth behind the Jinzhou incident."

At the mention of the Jinzhou massacre, Fan Changyu's heart grew heavy, and she momentarily lost herself in thought.

Gongsun Yin continued, "I came today for two reasons: first, to visit Miss Fan, and second, to meet the descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince."

He tapped his palm lightly with his folded fan and asked, "The child inside earlier—that's the descendant, isn't it?"

Fan Changyu nodded.

Gongsun Yin added, "I heard Miss Fan was badly injured while rescuing that child. Your departure from the city that day caused quite a stir, and now you're bringing the child to the capital. General Tang will surely grow suspicious. Before setting off for the capital, you should think about how to explain the child's origins to him."

Fan Changyu asked, "Do you have any suggestions, Gongsun?"

Gongsun Yin looked at her in surprise, as if realizing how much she had matured during her time in the military. He said, "General Tang is an honest man, and with his connection to Lord He, he can be persuaded."

This actually aligned with Fan Changyu's own thoughts.

Gongsun Yin stayed for less than the time it took to finish a cup of tea before leaving. Changning and Yu Bao'er were playing in the courtyard, and when they saw Gongsun Yin depart, Changning followed him like a little shadow, seeing him all the way to the gate before finally stopping.

Staring into the child's large, glistening black eyes, the usually stingy Gongsun Yin gritted his teeth and gave Changning all the silver he had on him, telling her to buy some candied hawthorns.

Changning sweetly called him "Uncle Gongsun" over and over again.

Generous as ever, she bought the candied hawthorns and didn't forget to share them with Yu Bao'er. But for the first time, Yu Bao'er, who had never rejected anything she offered, refused with a stern face. "Eating too much candy will rot your teeth and make you ugly."

Changning wasn't afraid of rotten teeth, but she was afraid of being ugly. Hesitating, she held the candied hawthorns uncertainly, unsure whether to eat them.

Yu Bao'er continued earnestly, "My mother says that nine out of ten people who randomly buy candy for children are bad people. That man just now looked very suspicious."

Changning's mouth fell open in shock. Clutching the hem of her clothes, she protested anxiously, "Uncle Gongsun isn't like that."

Yu Bao'er suddenly asked, "Are you close with him?"

Changning nodded. Bundled up in thick clothes and having played in the yard for a while, she had worked up a sweat. Her cheeks were flushed pink, and under the sunlight, the fine down on her face was clearly visible, giving her a delicate, rosy complexion that was utterly adorable.

She said, "Uncle Gongsun does my hair really nicely!"

Yu Bao'er looked at the little tufts of her soft hair tied up and pursed his lips slightly. "I can do your hair nicely too in the future," he said.

Changning still couldn't do her own hair and found it quite troublesome. Hearing Yu Bao'er's suggestion, she was intrigued. Her big, grape-like eyes fixed on him as she asked, "Do you know how to do hair?"

Yu Bao'er replied, "I can learn."

The next morning, when Aunt Zhao got up early to tie Changning's hair into little tufts, a small figure stood nearby, watching intently. Aunt Zhao

chuckled and told Yu Bao'er not to rush—they could go out to play only after Changning's hair was done.

Yu Bao'er watched attentively and said, "I'm not in a hurry. Take your time, Auntie."

Aunt Zhao praised the child for being so sensible.

Fan Changyu was completely unaware of all this. Her injuries had fully healed, and on her first day back in the army, Tang Peiyi informed her that they would soon depart for the capital. He then asked her to stay behind, unsurprisingly bringing up the matter of Yu Bao'er.

Fan Changyu clasped her fists and said, "I feel guilty for keeping this from you, General. That child... his background is indeed unusual."

Tang Peiyi sighed. "If you plan to bring the child with the army to the capital, you must give me the full picture. If anything unexpected happens along the way, I won't know how to handle it."

Fan Changyu nodded. "I was thoughtless. That child... is a descendant of His Highness, the Chengde Crown Prince."

At these words, Tang Peiyi was visibly shocked. "But the imperial grandson was said to have died..." He trailed off mid-sentence.

The sudden appearance of this child, protected in secret by the Blood-Clad Cavalry, raised the question: who had been trying to kill him?

Unaware of Qi Min's involvement, Tang Peiyi assumed it was the emperor and broke into a cold sweat.

After pacing back and forth in the tent several times, he said to Fan Changyu, "I understand. You may go. I'll arrange for additional covert protection for the young lord during the march."

Fan Changyu bowed deeply. "Thank you, General."

Tang Peiyi could only point at her helplessly and say, "You..." He sighed. "Preserving this last remnant of the Chengde Crown Prince's bloodline is our duty as subjects."

After two months on the march, the army finally arrived at the capital.

With Tang Peiyi's covert support, Yu Bao'er's carriage was guarded like an iron fortress throughout the journey, and no further incidents occurred.

The troops were stationed at the Western Mountain Camp outside the city, while Tang Peiyi selected only a few hundred meritorious officers to enter the capital with him.

The officials sent by the court to receive them had prepared newly forged Bright Light Armor, ensuring the troops would look splendid and imposing as they entered the city.

After changing and freshening up, the army headed for the northern gate.

Fan Changyu had played a pivotal role in quelling the rebellion. Though the court's official rewards had yet to be announced, the entire capital already knew of the female general from the northwest.

Flag-bearing honor guards led the procession, while crowds lining the streets cheered their triumphant return.

Fan Changyu rode on horseback slightly behind Tang Peiyi, flanked by He Jingyuan's eldest son.

People lined the streets, showering them with flowers. As the only female general in the army, Fan Changyu stood out not only for her striking appearance but also for her dignified demeanor. Many in the crowd eagerly called out to her, their voices filled with admiration and joy as they shouted, "General Fan!"

Some bold young women even threw handkerchiefs directly at Fan Changyu.

Facing such a scene for the first time, she felt somewhat at a loss. Determined not to compromise her authority, she maintained a stern expression on horseback, refusing to smile.

Little did she know that this very solemnity only reinforced the people's image of her as a formidable and awe-inspiring female general.

Among the clamoring crowd, the loudest cheers were for Fan Changyu.

Young women in their prime even wiped away tears, lamenting, "What a pity General Fan is a woman—otherwise, I would surely marry her!"

"Does General Fan have any brothers at home? If I can't marry her, becoming her sister-in-law would be just as good!"

...

The crowd grew so boisterous that the soldiers maintaining order could barely hold back the excited citizens rushing forward to welcome the triumphant army. Yet, amid the sea of thousands, Fan Changyu keenly sensed a gaze directed at her from a teahouse by the street.

She lifted her head to look. Most of the private rooms on the second floor had their windows wide open.

Behind a half-open lattice window, she spotted a familiar figure quietly watching her.

Even the pots of vibrant red chrysanthemums blooming on the windowsill could not overshadow the striking clarity and beauty of his features.

Careful not to draw attention, Fan Changyu allowed only the faintest hint of a smile to touch her lips as she passed by Xie Zheng.

Inside the private room, Xie Zheng gazed at the female general riding down the street, surrounded by cheers and adulation, momentarily lost in thought.

A year ago, in a tavern in Lin'an Town, he had watched her stride past with a butcher's knife in hand, leading a gang of ruffians—a veritable female tyrant.

Now, astride a white horse with silver trappings, clad in armor as she returned victorious with the army amid jubilant cheers, she had become a radiant general, dazzling as the sun.

Watching her upright figure on horseback, as straight and unyielding as bamboo, Xie Zheng allowed himself a faint smile.

Chapter 130

The army passed through Zhengyang Gate and waited silently before the Meridian Gate for the imperial summons.

The towering triple-tiered city platforms connected seamlessly, crowned by the east and west Yanchi Towers and Que Pavilions. The main hall, with its double-eaved yellow glazed tiles, was flanked by Golden Guards clad in armor and swords behind white marble railings—solemn and imposing.

Before these towering platforms and palaces, even the vast square below, capable of holding nearly ten thousand people, seemed cramped.

Fan Changyu gazed up at the palace, monstrous in its grandeur, and wondered whether those who dwelled atop such heights for too long would cease to see the suffering of the common folk, instead viewing their lives as mere ants.

Otherwise, why would the emperor on his dragon throne, while she fought on the frontlines, worry only that she might disrupt his arranged marriage—enough to decide to eliminate her?

Two years ago, during droughts and floods, in his bid to promote the Li family and suppress Wei Yan, he had acted no differently from Qi Min—colluding with the Li family to turn a blind eye as corrupt officials under Wei Yan embezzled layer after layer of disaster relief funds. Only after enough people had died did he turn around and condemn Wei Yan.

The people suffered bitterly, cursing the corrupt officials, praying for their "Heaven" to open its eyes—unaware that their "Heaven" had been watching all along, merely observing with cold indifference.

The emperor was obsessed with political maneuvering, and those seated high in the court halls neither pondered nor worried about the people's hardships—only how to topple their rivals and perpetuate their family's prosperity.

Suddenly, the glazed yellow tiles on the upturned eaves seemed unbearably glaring. Changyu lowered her eyes and clenched her fists.

Once past the Meridian Gate, civil officials could no longer ride in sedan chairs, nor military officers on horseback. While they waited, palace attendants had already come to lead away their warhorses.

Tang Peiyi noticed Changyu's unusual expression and assumed it was nerves from her first audience with the emperor. Glancing back at the majestic palace complex, he said, "The ancients wrote of the 'Jade Capital in the heavens, twelve towers and five cities.' The Jade Capital described in those poems could hardly surpass this. Countless scholars and warriors spend their entire lives without ever earning the right to glimpse such a sight. For Subordinate General Fan to be granted an audience in the Golden Hall at such a young age is already remarkable. We have been summoned to the capital for rewards—there is no need for apprehension. Simply enter the hall and receive your honors."

Changyu offered no explanation, merely clasping her fists in acknowledgment. "Thank you for your guidance, General."

Tang Peiyi patted her shoulder and said nothing more.

After another quarter-hour, the summons finally pierced through the layers of palace walls, reaching beyond the Meridian Gate.

"By decree, General of the Cloud Banner Tang Peiyi and his subordinate generals are summoned to audience—"

The eunuch's voice outside the Golden Hall was shrill and drawn-out.

"By decree, General of the Cloud Banner Tang Peiyi and his subordinate generals are summoned to audience—"

The Golden Guards standing with swords at the foot of the white marble steps boomed with deep, resonant voices.

"By decree, General of the Cloud Banner Tang Peiyi and his subordinate generals are summoned to audience—"

The final proclamation echoed between the ten-zhang-high city platforms flanking the Yanchi Towers, majestic and awe-inspiring.

Even the battle-hardened generals fresh from the blood-soaked northwest couldn't help but feel their hearts tremble, truly understanding what it meant to "face the Son of Heaven."

The eastern gate slowly swung open. With Tang Peiyi at the lead, the military officers filed in orderly ranks behind him. They passed through the

Meridian Gate, crossed the Golden Water Bridge, traversed the Gate of Supreme Harmony, and finally arrived at the Golden Hall where civil and military officials attended court.

Everywhere they looked, vermilion walls and yellow tiles stretched endlessly, the ground paved entirely with white marble—truly worthy of the name "Jade Capital in the heavens."

Many of the accompanying officers were visiting the capital for the first time to see the emperor. The solemnity of the palace pressed down on them so heavily they scarcely dared to breathe.

Fan Changyu followed behind Tang Peiyi, walking side by side with He Jingyuan's eldest son. Burdened by the weight of too many heavy thoughts, she found little interest in the grand palace adorned with gold and jade carvings at every turn.

The white marble steps before the Hall of Golden Chimes were also lined with Golden Guards, each towering and imposing. Yet their eyes held an air of arrogance rather than the blood-soaked ferocity honed on the battlefield.

Upon entering the grand hall, even without looking around, Fan Changyu could sense its resplendent opulence. Civil and military officials stood in two rows along the sides, clearing a path for their audience with the emperor.

However, the positions at the head of both the civil and military officials were empty. Xie Zheng had deliberately requested a delay in returning to the capital, while Wei Yan had claimed illness and had not attended court for many days. Fan Changyu guessed those were likely Wei Yan and Xie Zheng's places.

Tang Peiyi led the military officials in kneeling on one knee, fists clasped in salute. "Long live Your Majesty, ten thousand years!"

Fan Changyu followed suit with a bow. Originally, she had planned to reveal her identity as a descendant of the Meng family right in the Hall of Golden Chimes, forcing the emperor to investigate Wei Yan. But too much had happened since then—the Li family and Wei Yan seemed to have contingencies in place, and Xie Zheng was orchestrating something, advising her to hold back for now.

From atop the massive gilded dragon throne carved with reliefs came the emperor's pleased voice: "Rise—"

Fan Changyu stood behind Tang Peiyi. As she straightened and lifted her gaze, she saw the emperor seated on the throne, clad in bright yellow imperial robes.

He appeared far younger than she had imagined an emperor would be. Wearing the ceremonial crown with hanging beads, his smile unexpectedly gave him an approachable air, more like a young man than the supreme ruler of the realm.

Qi Sheng naturally noticed Fan Changyu as well. Though his expression remained smiling, the way his gaze swept over her made her skin crawl, much like the imperial eunuch who had delivered the decree outside Chongzhou.

Pointing at them, Qi Sheng addressed the assembled courtiers with a laugh. "My esteemed ministers, behold—these are the very pillars of our Great Yin!"

The civil and military officials on either side exchanged glances, murmuring in hushed tones. None echoed the emperor's words. While the civil officials maintained their composure, many among the military ranks wore their discontent openly—though none dared openly refute the emperor in the Hall of Golden Chimes.

The issue lay in the undeserved title of "pillars of the realm."

Such praise might suit the Three Excellencies and Nine Ministers, but among those accompanying Tang Peiyi to the audience, the lowest-ranking was Fan Changyu, a mere fifth-rank Swift Cavalry Commandant.

In the capital, only officials of at least fifth rank holding critical posts were permitted to attend court—and even then, only to observe, not to speak. Local officials had to be of fourth rank or higher to have an audience.

Qi Sheng's words had, unwittingly, made enemies for the military officers who had distinguished themselves in quelling the rebellion.

Even Fan Changyu, new to the officialdom, sensed something amiss. Tang Peiyi, upon hearing the emperor's praise, broke into a cold sweat and hastily clasped his fists. "This humble general and the others are unworthy of such praise. Loyalty to Your Majesty is our duty. Moreover, the true merits in suppressing the rebellion belong to Lord He and the Wu'an Marquis."

He Jingyuan had served with utter devotion his entire life and was now deceased, while Xie Zheng's illustrious military achievements left no room for dispute among the court.

By attributing the emperor's praise to these two, Tang Peiyi made it truly deserved.

Qi Sheng maintained his smile, as if the earlier words of flattery had not been intentional: "Minister He and the Wu'an Marquis are indeed the pillars of Great Yin. With the harsh winter approaching in the north, the Wu'an Marquis has requested to return to Jizhou to inspect the defenses before coming back to the capital. With him guarding our borders, both I and all my ministers can rest easy!"

At these words, the civil and military officials all echoed their agreement.

Qi Sheng then added with a smile, "When Minister Xie arrives in the capital, I shall bestow upon him the Nine Bestowments."

The moment these words were spoken, the ministers exchanged uneasy glances, none daring to speak. The entire court fell into a deathly silence.

Fan Changyu stood with her head bowed below the hall, wondering if the Nine Bestowments were some kind of taboo, given how the officials seemed to avoid the topic.

Fortunately, Qi Sheng quickly moved on: "The death of Minister He at Lucheng grieves me deeply. I have been unable to eat for days. Today, I posthumously confer upon him the title of Duke Jing, to be honored in the Imperial Ancestral Temple. Is his son, He Xiujun, present?"

He Xiujun, who stood beside Fan Changyu, immediately stepped forward, clasping his fists and bowing: "Your humble servant is here."

He Jingyuan had been a scholar-general in life, and his eldest son had inherited his scholarly nature. Though skilled in martial arts, he was more versed in Confucian studies. During He Jingyuan's time in Chongzhou, He Xiujun had managed all affairs in Jizhou, with Zheng Wenchang remaining as his deputy.

Qi Sheng said, "You are a scholar who passed the imperial examinations, and you have trained under your father in Jizhou for many years. Henceforth, you shall take up the position of Governor of Jizhou."

He Xiujun bowed in gratitude: "Your humble servant thanks Your Majesty for this great honor and will strive not to disappoint Your Majesty's expectations."

Qi Sheng motioned for him to return to his place. When his gaze fell upon Tang Peiyi, perhaps having heard something from the eunuch who had gone to Chongzhou to deliver the edict, his smile carried an undercurrent of malice: "Minister Tang displayed great foresight and judiciousness in the campaign to suppress the rebellion. I hereby confer upon you the title of General Who Pacifies the West, along with a thousand taels of gold and a hundred bolts of silk."

After Tang Peiyi stepped forward to express his gratitude, Qi Sheng's attention turned to Fan Changyu.

He said, "I have long heard that Great Yin has produced a female general from among the common people. Step forward and let me see you."

Fan Changyu stepped out and clasped her fists: "General Fan Changyu pays respects to Your Majesty."

Qi Sheng said, "Raise your head."

This caused another stir among the officials. Fan Changyu was a decorated military officer, yet Qi Sheng's frivolous tone made it sound as though he were selecting a concubine.

Fan Changyu's brow furrowed involuntarily. She lifted her head with unwavering determination, her expression devoid of any maidenly shyness, only the hardened demeanor of a seasoned warrior.

Qi Sheng smiled approvingly and praised, "What a splendid war-blossom!"

At this, the ministers' expressions grew even more strained. Even Tang Peiyi broke into a cold sweat for Fan Changyu.

Instead of commending her achievements, the emperor had praised her appearance—an odd remark by any measure. Fan Changyu herself felt an inexplicable unease.

Especially since she knew the emperor on the throne had once harbored thoughts of killing her. Now, under his ambiguous gaze, she felt as though needles pricked her back.

Sure enough, Qi Sheng soon asked, "Are you married, General?"

A wave of revulsion washed over Fan Changyu. Her fists clenched involuntarily, and a surge of anger at being insulted and belittled rose within her. Pressing her lips together, she answered firmly, "Your Majesty, this general already has a husband."

Though Xie Zheng had used a false name when he married into her family, their marriage was officially recorded in the government registers. This was no lie to the emperor.

Qi Sheng seemed rather disappointed and continued asking, "Where is your husband now?"

Fan Changyu replied with neither humility nor arrogance, "During the conscription at the beginning of the year, my husband went to Chongzhou. Worried for his safety, I set out to find him but unexpectedly ended up joining the army myself. The rebellion suppression was brutal, and my husband's fate remains unknown to this day."

In wartime, it was common for soldiers to go missing—some deserted, others were trampled beyond recognition amidst the chaos of battle, and some perished in the wilderness. Such cases were countless.

There was indeed a military register listing "Yan Zheng" as a recruit, but no such person could be found in the army now. Fan Changyu's words were essentially the truth.

Having spoken thus, her journey of a thousand li to find her husband would be seen by anyone as a testament to her deep devotion. Her husband was a soldier who had disappeared during the Battle of Chongzhou, making her the widow of a war hero. If Qi Sheng still spoke flippantly, it would be tantamount to coveting a subject's wife—a clear mark of a tyrant.

Qi Sheng was already well aware of the relationship between Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng. His provocation in the Golden Hall was merely an attempt to vent his anger over Xie Zheng's humiliation of the imperial eunuch who had lost an ear. Now, having been firmly rebutted by Fan Changyu's dignified response and having lost face before the court, he was on the verge of fury.

Forcing a smile, he said, "In my seventeen years on the throne, this is the first time I've seen such a female military talent. Fan Aiqing beheaded Changxin Wang during the Battle of Chongzhou and single-handedly

defended Lucheng until reinforcements arrived. Your contributions are undeniable. I hereby confer upon you the title of General of the Cloud Banner and grant you the honorary rank of Second-Grade Imperial Decree of Honor."

The General of the Cloud Banner was a third-grade military position with real authority, while the Imperial Decree of Honor was a nominal title.

Fan Changyu was likely the first woman in the history of Great Yin to earn such an honor through her own merits. Even the wives of chancellors received theirs by virtue of their husbands' achievements.

Fan Changyu bowed her head in gratitude. "This humble general thanks Your Majesty for your boundless grace."

With rewards concluded, it was time for punishment.

After Fan Changyu returned to her position, the emperor asked wearily, "Do any of my ministers have further matters to report?"

An elderly man with graying hair, who had been standing silently at the forefront of the civil officials, stepped forward holding his ceremonial tablet. "This old servant has a report."

Qi Sheng said, "What does the Grand Tutor wish to report?"

Hearing the title "Grand Tutor," Fan Changyu guessed the old man must be Grand Tutor Li.

Recalling the schemes the Li family had orchestrated with Qi Min, she studied the elderly figure stepping forward. Though she couldn't see his face clearly, his frail frame beneath the crimson crane-patterned official robes resembled a gnarled old pine tree.

He treated the lives of commoners and soldiers as worthless, yet presented himself as a loyal servant who had exhausted himself for the people.

Fan Changyu found it bitterly ironic.

Grand Tutor Li's impassioned voice rang out: "The near-loss of Lucheng, the tragic deaths of countless soldiers, and He Jingyuan's sacrifice—all were due to Wei Yan's collusion with the rebels. This old servant implores Your Majesty to hold Wei Yan accountable and deliver justice for the fallen soldiers and the Duke of Jing!"

With that, he knelt in his robes.

Members of the Li faction immediately followed suit, and soon nearly all the civil officials were kneeling. Even minor officials who wished to remain neutral, seeing the front rows empty, stepped forward and knelt to avoid being ostracized, echoing the cry: "We implore Your Majesty to hold Wei Yan accountable and deliver justice for the fallen soldiers and the Duke of Jing!"

Chapter 131

Tang Peiyi already blamed himself immensely for He Jingyuan's death. Though he had no desire to be entangled with the Li Faction, upon hearing their demands to hold Wei Yan accountable, he immediately knelt down with a sweep of his robes: "This general also implores Your Majesty to thoroughly investigate Prime Minister Wei's collusion with the rebels, to give justice to the soldiers fighting on the frontlines and the people of the realm!"

Once Tang Peiyi knelt, the military officers who had accompanied him to the Golden Luan Hall for their commendations naturally all followed suit.

Qi Sheng leaned his elbow on the armrest of the dragon throne, pressing his temple with visibly displeased expression: "What is the meaning of this? Have you all learned to pressure your emperor now?"

Grand Tutor Li, holding his ceremonial tablet with white hair and beard drooping low, said hoarsely: "We dare not, Your Majesty. But how can we appease the loyal souls beneath the springs if traitors remain unpunished and grievances unresolved? If this old minister does not remonstrate, I would be unworthy of wearing these official robes and receiving Your Majesty's stipend—better to retire and return to my hometown!"

Fan Changyu looked at Grand Tutor Li's thin, bamboo-like back. Had she not known about the Li family's collusion with Qi Min, she might have truly believed that Grand Tutor Li, like He Jingyuan, was a good official concerned for the nation and its people.

A loud "bang" echoed through the hall.

Qi Sheng had grabbed a stack of memorials from the Dragon Desk and hurled them down. He laughed in extreme anger: "Remonstrate if you must, Grand Tutor, but why threaten me with retirement?"

Grand Tutor Li bent his spine even lower: "This old minister dares not!"

In the past, the emperor and Grand Tutor Li had always worked in tandem to suppress Wei Yan. Now, with Grand Tutor Li denouncing Wei

Yan while the emperor fiercely protected him, the entire court witnessed such a scene for the first time.

The sharper-minded officials quickly recalled the recent rumors, silently wondering if the news about finding the descendants of the Chengde Crown Prince was true.

The Wei Faction, previously silent, now sensed the emperor's stance and immediately stepped forward: "The Prime Minister has toiled with great merit, exhausting himself for the Great Yin's realm all these years. Now, worn out by work, he is bedridden at home. Is this how you slander him?"

The Li Faction angrily retorted: "It was the man recommended by the Prime Minister to the army who let the Chongzhou rebels escape, nearly costing us Lucheng! The captured rebel advisor also testified that Wei Yan indeed colluded with them. With both witnesses and evidence present, what more is there to quibble about?"

"Lu Dayi was vainglorious, acting without orders and falling into the rebels' trap. At most, the Prime Minister is guilty of misjudging character—yet you would pin the crime of colluding with rebels on him? Your hearts are vile! How can the words of a rebel advisor be trusted? What if this is the rebels' scheme to sow discord?"

"All your clever words mean nothing! The evidence is irrefutable—you refuse to yield until you see the coffin!"

The two factions in the hall argued fiercely, their shouts nearly escalating to physical blows. Qi Sheng, seemingly plagued by a headache from the noise, bellowed: "Enough!"

The quarreling officials, who had been on the verge of rolling up their sleeves to fight, immediately restrained themselves and returned to their positions, holding their tablets.

Qi Sheng's expression was dark: "What kind of spectacle is this? Do you mistake the Golden Luan Hall for a marketplace?"

The ministers bowed their heads, none daring to speak another word.

Qi Sheng pressed his throbbing temple and declared: "All witnesses in the case of Wei Yan's collusion with rebels shall be temporarily held at the Court of Revision and subjected to a Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts. Court dismissed!"

With that, Qi Sheng flicked his sleeves and strode out of the hall first. The eunuch attending the throne cried out in a shrill voice, "Court dismissed!" before hurrying after the emperor.

The civil and military officials below knelt toward the now-empty dragon throne and chanted: "Long live His Majesty, ten thousand years, ten thousand times ten thousand years!"

Fan Changyu rose along with the other court officials, frowning slightly as she glanced at the lacquered golden dragon throne atop the grand hall.

Would the trial of Wei Yan proceed smoothly?

Outside the hall, Grand Tutor Li's expression was grim. His eldest son followed closely behind and whispered, "Has His Majesty turned to Wei Yan for protection again?"

Having served as Qi Sheng's teacher for over a decade, Grand Tutor Li understood this emperor—who had been forced onto the throne as a child—better than anyone. He shook his head. "This isn't the first time he's done this."

When Qi Sheng first ascended the throne, he was merely a child. While the court officials outwardly revered him, none truly regarded the powerless young emperor with any real respect. To secure his position, Qi Sheng had once obeyed Wei Yan's every command.

As he grew older and realized he was nothing more than a puppet emperor, he began drawing closer to Grand Tutor Li in an attempt to wrest power from Wei Yan.

Perhaps it was precisely because he had never truly held imperial authority that Qi Sheng could no longer tolerate anyone sharing power with him. He had grown too impatient. Before Wei Yan had even fallen, he had already begun guarding against the Li family at every turn—ultimately driving them to ally with Qi Min. Only then did panic set in, forcing him to turn back to Wei Yan in desperation.

As long as Wei Yan remained standing, even if he continued as a puppet emperor, the throne would still be his.

Li Yuanting, Grand Tutor Li's eldest son, sneered. "After scheming against Wei Yan so many times, does he really think Wei Yan will still protect him? When the time comes, they'll both be nothing but defeated strays!"

Grand Tutor Li paused mid-step and cast a measured glance at his son. Realizing his slip, Li Yuanting quickly surveyed their surroundings. The ministers were dispersing in small groups, with no one nearby. He exhaled slightly in relief.

"Remember," Grand Tutor Li said coolly, "careless words invite disaster."

Li Yuanting bowed his head in acknowledgment.

Ahead, at a white marble staircase, Fan Changyu, Tang Peiyi, and a group of rebel-suppressing generals descended. Minor officials offered Tang Peiyi their congratulations as the group walked and conversed, their expressions carefully polite.

Grand Tutor Li's gaze lingered for a moment longer on the red-robed, silver-armored female general, radiant as the sun.

Li Yuanting, already aware of Fan Changyu's true identity, lowered his voice. "They say Wu'an Marquis refused an imperial marriage proposal for this woman, then personally led the Xie family cavalry to rescue her in Lucheng—all while his father's death still hung over him. Truly bewitched."

Grand Tutor Li remained silent. After a few steps, he suddenly asked, "Still no word from Huaian?"

Li Yuanting shook his head. "We've sent more men to search."

With a noncommittal hum, Grand Tutor Li continued forward.

Fan Changyu, Tang Peiyi, and the others were not capital officials and had no residences in the city. The Ministry of Rites arranged for them to stay at the Office of Presentations.

According to Great Yin's official protocols, regional lords summoned to the capital resided at the State Guesthouse, while provincial officials stayed at the Office of Presentations. Though Fan Changyu's group had received official rewards, whether they would remain in the capital or be reassigned still awaited imperial decree.

If retained in the capital, the emperor would either bestow official residences or allocate land for private construction. If reassigned, they would proceed to their provincial posts.

As a third-rank official, Fan Changyu was assigned a private courtyard. Even with Aunt Zhao, her husband, Changning, and Bao'er moving in with her, the space remained far from cramped.

Carpenter Zhao was now a formally registered Army Doctor in the military. Originally, he should have been on duty in the Jizhou army, but with the war over, he felt he had little use staying there. Since Fan Changyu was heading to the capital to receive her imperial appointment, he resigned and accompanied her on the journey.

During the half-day Fan Changyu spent in the palace, the elderly couple, accompanied by Xie Wu and Xie Qi, had already taken Changning and Bao'er for a stroll through the capital's bustling streets.

When Fan Changyu returned, she saw that the snacks Changning had bought nearly covered the entire round table. Before she could scold her, Changning excitedly began gesturing about all the novel things she had seen on the street.

"Big sis, big sis! There were yellow-bearded men who could breathe fire on the street! And people twirling spears, and others smashing big rocks on their chests..." Changning's eyes sparkled as she counted off on her chubby fingers, almost running out of digits.

Seeing her so thrilled, Fan Changyu couldn't bring herself to reprimand her. She merely pinched Changning's rosy cheeks and said, "When you go out to play, don't be mischievous or wander off. Stay with Aunt Zhao and Uncle Xiao Wu, understand?"

Changning nodded hastily, then hugged Fan Changyu's arm and started swinging it. "Big sis, big sis! When will you have time? Let's go play that hoop-tossing game—if you win, you can take home a little rabbit!"

Fan Changyu smiled and asked, "You want to raise a rabbit?"

Changning nodded vigorously. "Feed it until it's fat, then give it to the falcon!"

The answer left Fan Changyu both amused and exasperated. Back when Xie Wu was with her in the army, the gyrfalcon had been fed by Xie Qi and Changning. Later, after Xie Wu was injured and recuperating at home, he also helped with feeding.

Both of them knew how to train gyrfalcons. If Changning overfed the bird during the day, Xie Qi would take it out at night to let it fly longer.

During Fan Changyu's recovery in Lucheng, Aunt Zhao, unable to stay idle, had bought a brood of chicks at the market to raise near the wounded soldier camp, hoping to nourish the injured soldiers. Occasionally, eagles

and falcons would swoop in to steal the chicks, leaving Aunt Zhao distressed. She would sigh deeply every evening upon returning to their courtyard. Later, Xie Qi often had the gyrfalcon patrol the camp area. Whenever other raptors came to snatch chicks, the gyrfalcon would chase them off, sometimes plucking half the feathers from their wings.

Aunt Zhao praised the gyrfalcon's intelligence and promptly rewarded it with a pile of chicken giblets.

After arriving in the capital, to avoid drawing attention, even Xie Qi and Xie Wu dared not take the gyrfalcon out for flights at night. With Aunt Zhao and Changning constantly feeding it, the bird had inevitably grown rounder.

Fan Changyu remarked, "If you keep feeding it like this, your falcon will be too fat to fly."

Aunt Zhao chimed in, "Listen, Ning Niang. We're staying in an official residence here in the capital, without our own place. Raising a rabbit isn't practical. If we leave the capital later, inanimate things are easy to take, but live animals aren't."

Only then did Changning lower her head, twisting her plump fingers in resignation.

Aunt Zhao and her husband pulled Fan Changyu aside to ask about her audience with the emperor. Having lived in a border town most of their lives, they had never imagined setting foot in the capital. Hearing that Fan Changyu had been granted a high-ranking position, they wept and laughed, wiping their tears as they vowed to burn paper offerings to Fan Changyu's parents to share the good news.

Changning squatted outside the door, drawing circles in the dirt with a small stick, her lips pouting as she still thought about the snow-white rabbit in the vendor's cage.

A pair of small embroidered boots appeared in her line of sight as Yu Bao'er stood before her and said, "I'll help you win the rabbit."

Changning pouted unhappily, "You don't even know how to play pitch-pot, and Uncle Xie Qi and Uncle Xiao Wu refused to help me..."

Yu Bao'er replied, "Give me two days. I can learn."

Children's emotions are remarkably sensitive. Without comfort, she might have held it together, but Yu Bao'er's words made Changning's eyes

well up. The cold weather had Aunt Zhao bundle her up in thick layers, and now she crouched on the ground like a soft, round little dumpling—almost resembling a plump rabbit herself. She sniffled, "But what if someone else wins the rabbit today?"

Yu Bao'er said, "The vendor will have other rabbits."

Changning's eyes reddened further as she wiped them and insisted, "But I only want that one little rabbit from today."

Yu Bao'er suddenly asked, "Weren't you just going to feed it to your falcon? Any rabbit would do, wouldn't it?"

Changning hung her head silently, her long lashes glistening with tears, looking utterly pitiful and aggrieved.

Yu Bao'er studied her for a moment before relenting, "Fine, I'll win that exact rabbit for you today. But you have to promise to keep it as a pet and not feed it to your falcon."

Changning thought it over and decided the little rabbit was indeed quite cute, so she nodded vigorously.

"How will you win it?" she asked.

Yu Bao'er replied, "Don't worry about it."

After chatting with Aunt Zhao and her husband for a while, Fan Changyu saw the elderly couple out and intended to ask Xie Wu how to contact Xie Zheng in the capital—only to find him missing.

She stopped Xie Qi, who was tidying the courtyard: "Xiao Qi, where's Xiao Wu?"

Xie Qi leaned on his broom and answered, "The young master said he needed to buy some things and asked Fifth Brother to accompany him."

Given Yu Bao'er's sensitive identity, while Aunt Zhao and her husband still called him Bao'er, Xie Wu and Xie Qi referred to him as "young master."

Concerned about potential mishaps, Fan Changyu pressed, "Only Xiao Wu is with him? Do you know where they went?"

Xie Qi quickly reassured her, "Don't worry, General. The young master said they'd only visit the two streets they went to this morning. General Tang also has people secretly following them."

Fan Changyu relaxed slightly, though she still felt awkward about Xie Qi so readily addressing her as "General." She murmured, "That's good," then asked, "Do you know... where he is right now?"

Though she didn't specify, Xie Qi immediately understood she meant Xie Zheng. "The master entered the capital in secret. We haven't received any messages from him yet. While the Xie family has an estate here, the master is always cautious and likely won't stay there. The generals who quelled the rebellion are temporarily lodged at the Office of Presentations. For now, we can only wait for the master to contact us."

Fan Changyu recalled the figure she'd glimpsed in the tavern window when entering the city. Had he been there specifically to watch the army's arrival?

Noticing her distraction, Xie Qi asked, "Is it urgent, General? Do you need to find the master?"

Fan Changyu shook her head. "It's nothing pressing. You may go back to your work."

Her main concern was Xie Zheng's next steps. The imperial grandson had vanished without a trace, and Yu Qianqian's whereabouts remained unknown.

The emperor was clearly favoring Wei Yan now. With the Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts underway, who knew what the outcome would be?

Whether the Li Faction or the Wei Faction won, Fan Changyu thought the court was rotten to the core.

She returned to her room and closed the door, heaving a quiet sigh—only to hear a deep voice ask, "What did you need me for?"

Startled, she looked up to see a figure leaning against the bedpost, arms crossed.

She exclaimed in surprise, "When did you get here?"

Xie Zheng replied, "I've been here all along."

Seeing the lingering confusion in Fan Changyu's eyes, he raised the disguise mask in his hand.

The bed curtains cast dim shadows, and it wasn't until he stepped forward that Changyu noticed he was wearing the uniform of an Office of

Presentations guard.

He had actually disguised himself as one of the guards here!

Before Changyu could speak, he tossed another set of guard uniforms to her. "Change into this. I'm taking you to meet someone."

With so many eyes watching the Office of Presentations when out-of-town officials entered the capital, every movement and meeting would be reported in detail to the palace.

To avoid those prying eyes, they naturally had to disguise themselves to slip out unnoticed.

Changyu glanced at Xie Zheng. Without the mask, his face remained strikingly handsome, yet she sensed something was off about his mood.

In truth, she'd noticed his unusual demeanor back when she saw him at the tavern upon entering the city, which was why she'd deliberately flashed him a smile as she passed by.

Now holding the guard uniform, Changyu set aside questions about who he wanted her to meet and asked hesitantly, "What's wrong? Did something go wrong with your arrival in the capital—"

Before she could finish, she was pulled into a firm, cold embrace.

Xie Zheng did nothing else but hold her tightly, burying his face in the crook of her neck like a drowning man clinging desperately to a lifeline.

Changyu froze momentarily, her arms still occupied by the uniform, leaving her unable to return the embrace.

She tried to free one hand to gently pat his back and ask what was wrong, but before she could, he pulled her even closer.

"Don't move. Let me hold you for a while."

Xie Zheng's voice carried exhaustion and hoarseness.

For a fleeting moment, it gave Changyu the illusion that he seemed... fragile.

She couldn't quite describe the feeling in her chest, only that it was as if a large hand had clenched around her heart, squeezing it with a dull ache.

Letting the guard uniform drop to the floor, she wrapped her arms around his slender, firm waist. In the same soothing tone she'd used to

comfort Changning during countless nights after their parents' passing, she murmured softly, "Don't be afraid. I'm here."

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After a few breaths, Xie Zheng straightened up. His face, like cold jade, showed no emotion, as if the vulnerability from a moment ago had truly been Fan Changyu's imagination.

He raised a hand to tuck away the stray hairs by her ear and simply said, "Go change your clothes."

No matter how many questions Fan Changyu had, she could only suppress them for now.

The Office of Presentations was full of prying eyes. If she had him wait outside, a guard from the Office of Presentations leaving her room would be seen, and the resulting rumors would not be pleasant.

To avoid unnecessary complications, it was best not to let him leave the room.

She picked up the guard uniform that had fallen to the floor, hesitated for a moment, and then stepped behind the screen.

As she unfastened the soft armor she was wearing, Fan Changyu uneasily poked her head out to glance at the man standing with his back to her.

Except for the night before he entered the capital, even when they had shared a bed, they had always slept fully clothed. She had never undressed in front of him in broad daylight.

Fan Changyu felt very uncomfortable.

Unexpectedly, though Xie Zheng's back was to her, it was as if he had eyes in the back of his head. "Relax, I won't look."

Fan Changyu was suddenly struck with the embarrassment of having judged a gentleman by her own petty standards. She pulled her head back and began to rustle out of her clothes.

But from beyond the screen came the latter half of Xie Zheng's sentence, spoken faintly, "What's to be seen and what's not to be seen, haven't I seen it all?"

Fan Changyu's hand, which was untying her sash, froze. A fierce light entered her eyes, and she gripped the screen behind her, letting out a "crack" as the wood splintered. Through gritted teeth, she said, "Xie. Zheng!"

A very low, soft chuckle came from the other side. "I'm teasing you. Hurry up and change."

Fan Changyu slipped on the guard uniform. As the corner of her eye glanced past the screen again, she frowned unconsciously.

Xie Zheng was doing it on purpose.

It seemed he didn't want her to ask too many questions, so he had deliberately changed the subject.

After Fan Changyu finished changing and came out, she didn't press the matter further. While fastening the vambraces at her cuffs, she asked, "Who are you taking me to see?"

The guard uniform was dark cyan. She had tied all her long hair up into a small bun on top of her head, revealing a long, fair neck. Her features were already strong-willed, giving her a distinct heroic air.

It was just that after the leather belt was cinched, her waist was too slender, not resembling a man's.

Leaning against the openwork carved moon gate that separated the inner and outer rooms, Xie Zheng watched Fan Changyu quietly, his eyes as dark and profound as an ancient well that had never seen the sun. "You'll know when we get there."

As Fan Changyu approached, he raised his veined hand and suddenly began to undo the collar she had just fastened.

Startled, Fan Changyu dodged to the side. The delicate skin of her neck brushed against his cool fingertips, and instantly, she felt half her neck go numb.

She chided in a low voice, "What are you doing?"

Xie Zheng looked down at her. The doors and windows were shut tight, and the dim light in the room made his handsome features appear even more profound.

"Your waist is too thin. You'll be recognized. We need to strap on two pieces of cotton armor."

His voice was very faint. His fingertips moved to the right, and with a hook and a pull, he undid Fan Changyu's collar without any resistance this time.

With such a righteous excuse, Fan Changyu couldn't bring herself to scold him. But he was too close; every breath was filled with his scent—a cold, crisp mix of the northern snows and soap beans. Coupled with the light, teasing touch of his fingertips, the tip of Fan Changyu's nose grew hot and beaded with fine sweat.

As he reached for the leather belt at her waist, Fan Changyu took a step back, unfastening it herself with a deft movement of her hands. "I'll do it myself."

Without the restraint of the leather belt, her outer robe fell open. The snow-white inner garment was very loose, held only by two ties at the front, and the delicate curve of her collarbone was already visible.

The bite mark on her left collarbone had faded to an extreme degree, leaving only two rice-grain-sized impressions.

As she found two pieces of cotton armor and bent her head to tie them around her waist, a loose strand of hair fell forward, landing right on her neck and shoulder.

Xie Zheng reached out to brush the strand away for her. The sensation of the hair being drawn across her skin was indescribably ticklish. Fan Changyu shrank her neck and, frowning slightly, looked up at Xie Zheng just as his calloused fingertips landed on the two faint marks.

Fan Changyu's shoulders flinched again—his fingertips were very cold.

Xie Zheng made no further transgression, but as his gaze swept over her noticeably flatter chest, he asked, "Binding your chest again?"

Although he only had two fingers resting on her collarbone, Fan Changyu had the illusion of a sharp weapon being held to her neck. It felt as if all the strength in her body was being drained away through his fingertips.

She managed to maintain her composure. "It's more convenient for wearing armor."

Xie Zheng gave a faint "en," his fingertips stroking the bite mark on her collarbone intermittently. He suddenly exerted strength in his right arm,

wrapped it around Fan Changyu's waist, and in one motion, lifted her onto the round table.

Caught off guard, Fan Changyu leaned back, only steadying herself by planting her hands on the tabletop. By the time she came to her senses, Xie Zheng was holding her chin and kissing her.

This position left her with no choice but to receive it, and it also made it easier for Xie Zheng to deepen the kiss, his lips and tongue exploring hers.

While kissing her, he even managed to free a hand to securely tie the cotton armor that was about to fall from her waist. As he closed her outer robe and fastened the leather belt, he glanced down at her, bit the collar of her robe over her left shoulder, and pulled it down. He covered the two rice-grain-sized marks with a new red one before pulling her collar back into place.

Fan Changyu's breathing was very unsteady. Though her clothes were no longer disheveled after he had straightened them, her cheeks were flushed crimson, and the knuckles of her hands, braced on the edge of the table, were white from the force.

Xie Zheng lifted his head and pecked her slightly swollen red lips twice more. "If you keep looking at me like that, we won't be going out today."

His voice was deeper than usual, as if he had been drinking, with a magnetic hoarseness.

Fan Changyu's gaze gradually cleared. From her position, she grabbed his lapels, pulled him down to her, and bit down hard on his neck and shoulder.

Xie Zheng let out a soft hiss. Before he could react, Fan Changyu had already released him and jumped off the table.

She took a few steps away before looking back at him, her eyes filled with the wild, untamable spirit of a leopard. "Let's go."

Xie Zheng pulled up his collar to cover the bite mark on his shoulder and neck. He rubbed his fingertips over it lightly before unhurriedly getting up to follow.

Because Xie Zheng had said someone would inform Xie Qi and the others of her whereabouts, Fan Changyu didn't go out of her way to find Xie Qi to explain.

Using the excuse of going out to make purchases, the two entered a shop that sold brushes, ink, and paintings. They were led to the second floor, where a servant brought them clothes to change into.

Fan Changyu stood by the window of the private room, pushing it open a crack. She watched as two members of the Blood-Clad Cavalry, wearing their previous guard uniforms, left. Immediately, several people in plain clothes on the street began to follow them discreetly. She was startled and turned to ask Xie Zheng, "You knew from the start that someone was following us?"

Xie Zheng sat at the table, his long fingers with their faint scabs holding a cup of clear tea. He raised his eyelids slightly. "All guards and servants from the Office of Presentations are followed when they go out."

Fan Changyu understood his meaning. Those people were the palace's eyes.

Even when sending servants or guards out on errands, the emperor would keep a secret watch.

She returned to the round table, which was covered with an exquisite embroidered satin cloth, and sat down. "So where are we going next?"

Just as she finished speaking, the neigh of a horse stopping a carriage came from downstairs.

Xie Zheng put down his teacup. "The carriage is here."

Seeing him stand up, Fan Changyu also picked up the veiled hat the servant had brought and followed him.

This type of veiled hat was worn by noblewomen or young ladies in the capital to cover their faces when they went out. With this hat on, Fan Changyu no longer needed to apply those disguise paints to her face.

As they were leaving, a "husband and wife" from the carriage were being led upstairs by the shop's servant. Fan Changyu noticed that the clothes this "couple" wore were identical to what she and Xie Zheng were wearing.

Seeing the servant give Xie Zheng an almost imperceptible nod as the "couple" entered the private room they had just been in, Fan Changyu guessed that these were also Xie Zheng's people.

Now was not the time to talk. She remained silent and followed Xie Zheng downstairs. After Xie Zheng paid for two scrolls of calligraphy, he led her to the carriage parked by the roadside.

The driver cracked the whip, and after the carriage had traveled some distance through the bustling market, Fan Changyu lifted a corner of the curtain to look back for a while. After confirming that no one was following, she dropped the curtain and asked Xie Zheng, "Are the people in that shop yours?"

Xie Zheng leaned against the carriage wall. The wind blew the curtain at the window, and the flickering light fell on his disguised face, still unable to hide the superiority of his bone structure.

He replied, "That's one of the Zhao Family's businesses."

Fan Changyu still remembered the Zhao Family Bookstore that had opened in Qingping County. She just hadn't expected the Zhao Family to have businesses in the capital as well.

After Xie Zheng closed his eyes to rest, Fan Changyu lifted a small corner of the curtain to observe the street scenes along the way.

The capital was indeed more prosperous than any place she had ever been. No wonder Changning had been so happy upon returning from her outing.

Fan Changyu propped her elbow up and watched for a while, then turned her head to stare at Xie Zheng, whose eyes were lightly closed.

He had something on his mind, but he was unwilling to tell her.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together slightly. She didn't like the feeling of dejection that this realization brought her.

As she was staring at him in a daze, the man who had been resting his eyes suddenly opened them. "What are you looking at me for?"

Caught red-handed, Fan Changyu was half guilty and half embarrassed. She quickly sat up straight and cleared her throat. "I was curious what material your mask is made of."

Making a human-skin mask was not easy. When they left the Office of Presentations, Xie Zheng had worn a human-skin mask that fit the contours of his face, while Fan Changyu had applied some disguise paints.

When they changed at the Bookstore, the paints on her face had been washed off.

Hearing her say this, Xie Zheng raised a hand to his face, peeled off the scarred face mask, and handed it to her.

Fan Changyu took it and rubbed it with her hand, frowning. "I can't tell by touch."

Xie Zheng said, "I thought you would have guessed it was human skin."

Fan Changyu's expression changed in an instant. As her almond eyes widened, her pupils contracted, as if she were truly a startled cat.

Seeing her like this, Xie Zheng lowered his gaze to hide the smile in his eyes. The gloom that had been accumulating in his chest seemed to dissipate a little.

An indescribable look appeared on Fan Changyu's face. Holding the mask with just the tips of her two thumbs, she handed it back to Xie Zheng, her expression conflicted. "They say all debts are cleared upon death. This person is already dead, yet their skin was peeled off to make a mask. It's truly detrimental to one's karmic virtue. You should stop using it in the future."

Xie Zheng propped his head up with one hand, gazing at her and deliberately saying, "But there's no more suitable material than human skin. It has excellent resilience and fits perfectly..."

As he spoke, he pushed the mask Fan Changyu was handing back a little closer to her. "If you don't believe me, try it on."

Fan Changyu's face was about to turn green. She looked at the mask so close to her as if facing a great enemy, her neck stiff. "I won't try it!"

She was like a leopard cat about to bristle.

A few muffled chuckles escaped Xie Zheng's throat. "You actually believed it?"

Fan Changyu realized she had been tricked and glared at him without speaking.

Xie Zheng chuckled in amusement. "It was made by a magician from donkey-hide gelatin."

The wind occasionally lifted a corner of the carriage curtain, revealing that the scenery outside was now the suburbs.

Fan Changyu held the mask in one hand and clenched the other into a fist. When the driver reined in the horse to a stop, she threw the mask at him, followed by a flurry of punches that landed with a "thump, thump."

When Xie Zhong heard the horse's neigh and came out of the villa, he heard a loud "clatter and bang" from inside the carriage parked at the entrance.

A moment later, a young lady in a lotus-root pink silk dress was the first to jump down. With bright eyes and pearly teeth, she was very beautiful, though she looked a bit fierce. But her eyes were clear, and she had a certain gullible honesty about her, making her seem like a spirited girl.

Xie Zhong didn't recognize Fan Changyu, but he figured that since she was brought here by a Blood-Clad Cavalry driver, she probably wasn't an outsider.

A moment later, Xie Zheng emerged from the carriage. For some reason, he had put the scarred face mask back on his face.

Seeing him, Xie Zhong quickly clasped his fist. "Marquis."

Xie Zheng nodded faintly, his voice betraying no abnormality. "How is General Zhu's recovery?"

Xie Zhong replied, "Everything else is fine, but his legs cannot be healed."

This was something the physician had warned them about from the beginning.

Xie Zheng turned his head to look at Fan Changyu, whose anger had not yet completely subsided, and said gently, "The person I wanted you to meet is inside."

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The slight irritation in Fan Changyu's heart instantly dissipated.

She looked at Xie Zheng, then at the one-armed and one-legged uncle who had come out from the village to greet them. Though still puzzled, she pushed open the half-closed courtyard gate and stepped inside with some hesitation.

Xie Zhong stared at Fan Changyu's retreating figure. Noticing her steady gait and measured breathing—unlike that of an ordinary sheltered maiden—he suddenly formed a guess. Turning to Xie Zheng, he asked, "Marquis, could this young lady... be a descendant of the Meng family?"

But... the relationship between the Marquis and this girl seemed somewhat unusual?

Xie Zheng neither confirmed nor denied.

As the sun slanted westward, half his profile and eyelashes were gilded in golden light. His pupils reflected Fan Changyu's distant figure, the emotions in their depths too profound to decipher.

"Later, you'll personally escort her back," he said.

Xie Zhong was momentarily taken aback, then remembered what day it was. His eyes dimmed with sorrow: "When you go there, please take more guards. I fear Wei Yan might—"

"I know my limits."

Xie Zheng cut him off. With one last glance at Fan Changyu's silhouette bathed in sunset glow, he turned and left.

The setting sun stretched his shadow endlessly across the radiant horizon, making his solitary figure appear even more starkly alone.

Upon entering the courtyard, Fan Changyu heard boisterous voices from a half-open room.

"I won't drink this bile-bitter medicine! Bring me liquor!"

"General Zhu, don't make this difficult. The physician strictly warned against alcohol given your chronic ailments."

"By my mother's grave! Seventeen years locked up! If I don't taste strong liquor soon, my tongue'll rust clean off!"

Approaching, Fan Changyu peered through the doorway to see a square-faced, bearded man propped against the bedhead, while a young servant stood bedside holding a bowl of medicine.

Her position blocked some light, drawing attention from within.

The bearded man turned abruptly, eyes reddening as he tentatively called out, "Sister Lihua?"

Unfamiliar with the name, Fan Changyu remained silent by the door.

After scrutinizing her, the man suddenly corrected himself: "No... the eyes aren't Lihua's... and she's long gone..."

Trembling between joy and grief, he asked hoarsely, "You... you're Changyu, aren't you?"

Hearing her name, recalling Xie Zheng's earlier purpose in the capital and today's sudden invitation to meet someone, Fan Changyu guessed this must be one of her grandfather's former subordinates. Emotion welled up uncontrollably.

Stepping inside, she asked, "You know me? May I ask who—"

The man covered his face, his gruff voice breaking: "Heaven has eyes! To let old Zhu see General Meng's descendant before I die!"

Seventeen years of wrongful imprisonment and loss overwhelmed even this battle-hardened veteran. Tears streamed down Zhu Youchang's face as he gazed at Fan Changyu: "I'm your Uncle Zhu. Joined your grandfather's army at fourteen—rose from foot soldier to Tiger-Rousing Captain. Your mother was like a sister to me."

Upon learning that this man was an old friend of her parents, Fan Changyu was overwhelmed with emotion. But as she stood closer, she noticed the thin, frail outline of Zhu Youchang's legs beneath the blanket—far too slight for an adult man's limbs.

Her throat tightened, but she steadied her voice as best she could. "Uncle Zhu, what really happened back then? And your legs... how did they end up like this?"

Zhu Youchang's face darkened with grief and anger. "General Meng's failure in transporting provisions was entirely framed by that traitor Wei Yan! As for these useless legs..." He patted the thin bones beneath the blanket, forcing a bitter smile. "They were injured on the battlefield in Luocheng. No point dwelling on it. At least these past seventeen years without feeling spared me the pain of imprisonment."

Fan Changyu recalled what Xie Zheng's men had said earlier—that Zhu Youchang's legs were beyond healing—and her heart ached.

"Did Wei Yan imprison you for seventeen years?"

At the mention of Wei Yan, Zhu Youchang gnashed his teeth. "As long as the Tiger Tally remained missing, that dog couldn't rest easy. So he locked up anyone who sought to clear General Meng's name or avenge General Xie and the Chengde Crown Prince."

Fan Changyu gasped. "General Xie and the Chengde Crown Prince's deaths were also Wei Yan's doing?"

Zhu Youchang recounted in detail how Wei Yan had used the Tiger Tally and a forged letter to deceive Meng Shuyuan into turning back to Luocheng to rescue the Sixteenth Prince. He then shared the suspicions he and Xie Zheng had pieced together over the years.

"That treacherous snake had ambitions from the start," Zhu Youchang spat. "He must have planned to install a puppet ruler and seize control of the court. Why else would he push for the powerless Nineteenth Prince to ascend the throne after the deaths of the Chengde Crown Prince and the Sixteenth Prince, and the Late Emperor's passing? He used the military influence of the Wei and Xie families to silence all opposition!"

The truth about the supply transport failure and her grandfather's wrongful condemnation left Fan Changyu stunned.

Yet, beyond grief and fury, she sensed there was more to the story.

Her father had lived in Qingping County for over a decade—a quiet, kind-hearted man who sold pork and often undercharged the poor. He helped anyone in need, even giving alms to beggars.

That was why, when Old Scholar Song died and his widow and child knelt in the streets begging for a coffin, her parents had stepped in without hesitation.

If her father had truly been a key general under her grandfather's command, he would have known the catastrophic consequences of delaying the supply transport—for the Meng family, for Jinzhou, and for Great Yin.

Fan Changyu refused to believe he would betray her grandfather for power, aiding Wei Yan's scheme and leaving her grandfather branded a traitor responsible for countless deaths.

Moreover, Yu Qianqian had once mentioned Qi Min's hatred for the Sui family. There might have been a reason the Crown Princess chose the Sui family to help Qi Min escape.

And the troops her father had sought to replace the supply convoy were none other than the Sui family's Chongzhou Army.

Something else must have happened!

Fan Changyu suddenly raised her head to look at Zhu Youchang: "Uncle Zhu, Wei Yan might truly be that treacherous and evil man, but I don't believe my father would help Wei Yan commit such heinous acts! If he had truly wronged my grandfather, my mother would never have forgiven him—how could she have lived in seclusion with him for sixteen years?"

Upon hearing that Meng Lihua had gone into seclusion with Wei Qilin, Zhu Youchang angrily said, "It must have been that cunning Wei Qilin who deceived your mother!"

But Fan Changyu shook her head. "If my mother had known nothing about what happened back then, she wouldn't have followed my father in death after he was forced to take his own life."

Zhu Youchang's eyes reddened, and his voice abruptly changed. "Your mother followed your father in death?"

Fan Changyu lowered her gaze to hide the bitterness in her eyes. "Or rather... she took her own life to protect my younger sister and me."

Zhu Youchang urgently asked, "What exactly happened?"

As the sealed memories resurfaced, Fan Changyu seemed to see again the bleak winter of last year in Lin'an Town—white funeral paper mingling with the falling snow, covering the thin layer of snow on the road as the authorities transported her parents' bodies back on a cart...

Her voice was hoarse as she spoke. "Sixteen years ago, my parents relied on the help of Uncle He Jingyuan to forge household registrations and settle in Qingping County. The handwritten letter Wei Yan sent to my grandfather had always been in my parents' possession.

"Last early winter, under Wei Yan's orders, Uncle He was instructed to take my parents' heads. He had intended to warn them, urging them to flee with my sister and me. But my parents, fearing they would implicate Uncle He and knowing Wei Yan's ruthlessness would never spare Ning Niang and me, chose to end their own lives. They placed the letter in a box and entrusted it to Uncle He, instructing him to hand it over to Wei Yan when he came searching our home. This was to ensure our survival."

Recalling those events, Fan Changyu's throat tightened unbearably. "My parents must have known some inside information, which is why Wei Yan silenced them. But my father would never have betrayed my mother or grandfather! The only ones who might know the truth are the Sui family. Unfortunately, Prince Changxin and his wife are already dead. We can only interrogate the Sui family's servants to see if we can uncover anything."

Others, unfamiliar with Meng Lihua's temperament, might dismiss Fan Changyu's words as mere conjecture.

But Zhu Youchang, who had been as close as a brother to Meng Lihua and knew her better than anyone, said, "I may not trust others, but I trust your mother. She appeared gentle, but at her core, she was unyielding.

"Back then, when your grandfather fell for the enemy's diversion tactic and his camp was ambushed by a group of Northern Jue soldiers, your mother—a seemingly frail woman—killed two intruders in the tent with her wits. If your father hadn't arrived in time, she would have slit her own throat rather than be taken hostage to threaten your grandfather."

As he recounted these memories, Zhu Youchang couldn't hide his sorrow.

Seventeen years had passed. Their old friends had long been buried, and everything had changed beyond recognition.

He looked at Fan Changyu. "You're right. If Wei Qilin had truly betrayed the old general, and if your mother had known, she would have been the first to kill him."

Fan Changyu was momentarily dazed by Zhu Youchang's words.

The mother she remembered had always been gentle and soft-spoken, rarely even raising her voice. The mother Zhu Youchang spoke of—a woman as brilliant as flames—was a side of her she had never seen.

She smiled faintly, feeling proud of such a mother, yet also sorrowful that no matter what her mother had been like, she would never see her again.

Zhu Youchang said, "I've heard about the Sui family's rebellion. If the Sui family truly knew the inside story, wouldn't they have grasped Wei Yan's weakness? When raising the banner of rebellion, they should have announced it to the world."

These words pulled Fan Changyu's thoughts back.

She replied, "Shortly after the Sui family rebelled, rumors did spread about Wei Yan orchestrating the Jinzhou massacre."

It was upon hearing such rumors that Xie Zheng investigated the past events, only to be nearly killed by Wei Yan's schemes on the Chongzhou battlefield.

Fan Changyu felt that all these fragmented clues were slowly connecting.

Zhu Youchang immediately asked, "Were those rumors spread by the Sui family?"

After pondering for a long while, Fan Changyu shook her head. "It's impossible to confirm now. We can only decide after interrogating the Sui family's servants."

Zhu Youchang's earlier words had actually enlightened Fan Changyu. If the Sui family knew the truth of that year and had solid evidence, why didn't they directly expose Wei Yan's crimes to the world?

Instead, they spread baseless rumors?

Recalling what Yu Qianqian had once told her, Fan Changyu could only tentatively speculate on one possibility—the Sui family had also been involved in the Jinzhou case back then!

As for why Wei Yan had left the Sui family as a potential threat until now, the reason remained unknown.

Eager to verify her conjecture, Fan Changyu wished she could return immediately to interrogate the Sui family servants being escorted to the

capital.

After bidding farewell to Zhu Youchang, she hurried out of the courtyard gate, only to see a middle-aged man missing one leg and one arm waiting by the carriage outside.

Unable to clasp his hands in salute due to his missing arm, the man simply nodded to her and said, "This humble servant is Xie Zhong, a retainer of the Xie family. By the Marquis's order, I await the General here to escort you back."

Just the words "Xie family retainer" ensured Fan Changyu would never treat him as a mere servant. Guessing that his missing limbs were likely lost in battle, her respect for him grew.

She nodded slightly in return as a gesture of courtesy.

Noticing Xie Zheng's absence, she couldn't help but ask as she boarded the carriage, "Where has the Marquis gone?"

Xie Zhong, holding the reins with one hand and leaning on a crutch, paused at her question. After studying her for a moment, he hesitated briefly before doing something presumptuous for the first time—acting against Xie Zheng's wishes.

He said, "Today is the anniversary of Madam Xie's passing. The Marquis has likely gone to the Xie family mausoleum."

Xie Zheng had returned to the capital in secret. Paying respects during the day might attract attention from those watching in the shadows, so he had chosen dusk for his visit.

This answer made Fan Changyu's hand, lifting the carriage curtain, freeze—all of Xie Zheng's unusual behavior now made sense.

He had never mentioned a single word about Madam Xie to her. Yet after hearing Zhu Youchang recount the details of that year's imprisonment and Madam Xie's sacrifice, even Fan Changyu, an outsider, felt sorrow. How much more so for Xie Zheng, her son?

His unwillingness to tell her about this was likely because he didn't want her to see him in moments of vulnerability and pain.

Fan Changyu's fingers gripping the thick silk curtain tightened unconsciously. After some thought, she decided it was best to respect Xie Zheng's choice.

Very well, she would return to the Office of Presentations first.

Xie Zhong seemed to have discerned Fan Changyu's decision and continued, "The Blood-Clad Cavalry rescued General Zhu, and Wei Yan already knows the Marquis is currently hiding in the capital. I fear Wei Yan might take this opportunity to set an ambush at the Xie family cemetery. I advised the Marquis to bring more men, but he insists on going alone every year to pay respects. I couldn't persuade him otherwise..."

Fan Changyu's eyes darkened slightly, her lips pressing together. After a brief silence, she asked Xie Zhong, "Can you take me to the Xie family cemetery?"

Chapter 134

The twilight deepened, and the wind blowing from the mountainside carried the chill of early winter.

The Xie family, a century-old lineage of nobility, had their ancestral cemetery occupying half the mountain on the outskirts of the city.

The frost-white moonlight spilled over the stone-paved path, as if a light snow had just fallen.

Amidst the surrounding tombstones that exuded an eerie aura in the night, a figure approached under the moonlight, a lantern swaying in the cold wind, casting a hazy, dim glow.

The figure stopped before the joint tomb of Xie Linshan and his wife. The dark golden embroidery on the brocade boots flickered faintly in the lantern's dim light, barely discernible.

An elderly servant carrying a food box knelt down, opened it, and carefully arranged the offerings on the stone platform before the tomb. "Miss," he murmured, "the Prime Minister has come to see you, bringing your favorite longevity clover cake."

After setting out the three offerings, the old servant took out a flint and some yellow and white ghost money, lighting it slowly in the brazier before the tomb while muttering,

"Old Nie from the main kitchen, who makes the longevity clover cake, has grown increasingly dim-sighted these past two years. Since your marriage, the Prime Minister has kept him employed for twenty-one years just for this pastry. In another couple of years, he'll likely be too old to work and will have to retire."

The flames from the burning ghost money eclipsed the lantern's glow, illuminating the weariness and sorrow in the old servant's eyes.

The engraved calligraphy on the stone tablet became clearly visible—most glaring were the words: "Tomb of Wei Wan, Wife of the Guardian General of the Nation."

Wei Yan, draped in a silver-furred cloak, stood silently before his younger sister's grave, the flickering firelight reflecting in his eyes. After a long while, he finally spoke to the servant, "Wei Quan, you may leave."

The old servant rose and bowed. "Then, as in previous years, this old servant will wait for the Prime Minister at the mountain's crossroads."

Wei Yan gave a slight nod, and the servant left the lantern by the tomb before retreating with a bow.

The wind grew stronger, rustling the hem of Wei Yan's cloak and scattering embers and ashes from the burning ghost money in the brazier.

Wei Yan crouched, picked up a stack of unburned ghost money beside the brazier, and tore it piece by piece, feeding it into the flames.

He remained silent, not uttering a single word of grief, even to this lonely grave.

When Xie Zheng arrived under the cold, watery moonlight, this was the scene he witnessed.

Standing ten paces away, he curled his lips in a mocking sneer, his voice icy and sharp. "You drove her to her death, yet you come here every year to see her. Who are you pretending for? Or are you afraid she rests too peacefully in the afterlife, so you return annually to torment her?"

Wei Yan had recognized the footsteps long before Xie Zheng spoke.

He remained sideways to Xie Zheng, not even lifting his gaze, finishing the burning of the ghost money in his hands before brushing the ashes from his robes and standing.

Only as he passed Xie Zheng did he pause to say, "I had thought you'd lost the courage to come pay respects today, after hiding in the shadows for months."

Xie Zheng's eyes narrowed, cold as a blade, his moonlit face like frost. He smirked derisively. "The Prime Minister visits the Xie family cemetery in the dead of night just to see if this Marquis has come to offer incense?"

He turned his face slightly, his tone dripping with sarcasm. "This Marquis naturally has no fear in coming here. The one who needs to borrow courage is the Prime Minister, is it not? Blood debts must eventually be repaid."

Wei Yan glanced sidelong at Xie Zheng, his expression unreadable, and without another word, he strode away.

He had barely taken two steps when Xie Zheng, his expression cold and somber, fixed his gaze on the rigid tombstones of his parents not far away. The night wind tousled the stray hairs on his forehead, and his eyes, sharp as icy stars, churned with fury. Without warning, he drew his sword and swung it backward toward Wei Yan with a force as vast as a storm, swift as lightning.

"Clang—"

A grating metallic ring pierced the night.

Blades clashed, their shrill resonance sparking embers in the dark.

Martial Assassins hidden around the cemetery emerged, eyeing Xie Zheng as if facing a mortal enemy, shielding Wei Yan securely behind them.

A cold, mocking smile curled Xie Zheng's lips as he glared at Wei Yan, standing beyond a dozen Martial Assassins. Raising his sword, he declared, "Between you and me, it must come to an end. Why not settle it today?"

His eyes flashed with menace as he suddenly closed in on one of the assassins. His sword struck dozens of times in an instant, sparks flying, the sheer force splitting the assassin's palm open. Blood gushed, soaking the hilt, forcing the man to stagger back.

Xie Zheng's handsome face twisted into something ghastly, an aura of bloodlust radiating from him. His sword became a blur as he lashed out, demanding of Wei Yan, "My father supported the Chengde Crown Prince and stood in your way, so you plotted his death. When my mother uncovered your scheme, you sought to kill her too?"

With a final swing, the assassin's blade snapped in two with a sharp "clang."

Terror widened the man's eyes before Xie Zheng's strike cleaved through his waist. He convulsed and collapsed, crimson pooling beneath him.

The mountain wind carried the thick, nauseating stench of blood.

The remaining assassins watched Xie Zheng with growing dread.

These were Heaven-ranked Martial Assassins, the elite accompanying Wei Yan.

Trained by Wei Mansion, even military generals would struggle against them—yet none had lasted half a quarter of an hour against Xie Zheng.

Standing a short distance away, Xie Zheng gripped his bloodied sword, his striking features now marred only by a sinister ferocity, flecks of blood dotting his face.

He asked Wei Yan, "For seventeen years, how have you dared show your face here?"

The wind scattered ashes of burnt ghost money, his black robes outlining his tall frame as if merging with the suffocating darkness.

Wei Yan listened to his accusations in silence.

Flecks of ghost money settled on his shoulders, and in the dim light, the streaks of white at his temples seemed to multiply.

The assassins guarding Wei Yan eyed Xie Zheng warily, blocked by their comrades. One urged, "Chancellor, this place is unsafe. Allow me to escort you away at once?"

Wei Yan raised a hand, signaling the man to stand down.

Though puzzled, the assassin dared not disobey, sheathing his sword and stepping aside.

Wei Yan met Xie Zheng's gaze across the distance, his eyes inscrutable. "Your hatred is justified. If you didn't seek my death, I would have taken your head one day. But you shouldn't have been so reckless as to confront me here."

Brushing ash from his cloak, he added, "Alone, you cannot defeat all my Heaven-ranked assassins. Out of respect for your mother watching, I won't trouble you here—nor disturb her peace."

With that, Wei Yan turned and walked down the stone path, vanishing into the deeper night.

Xie Zheng stood with his sword, suddenly letting out a cold laugh: "When she was alive, you couldn't tolerate her. Now that she's dead, you put on this act—do you truly think she'd know anything from the underworld?"

Wei Yan's figure paused slightly, yet he continued walking forward without uttering a word.

The Martial Assassins surrounding Xie Zheng dared not lower their guard. Their palms gripping their sword hilts were slick with sweat, fearing Xie Zheng might suddenly strike again.

Only after confirming Wei Yan had gone far enough did they point their blades at Xie Zheng, retreating a safe distance before turning and swiftly departing.

The cemetery fell into complete silence once more. As it was early winter, even the chirping of insects had ceased.

A lantern had toppled during the earlier scuffle. The paper shade and bamboo frame had burned to ashes, leaving only the spilled oil on the stone slabs still burning slowly. The faint blue flames cast light on Xie Zheng's blood-spattered face, as if coated with a layer of frost.

He turned his head toward the nearby graves of the Xie couple, standing motionless like a statue.

Memories flashed before his eyes—those sixteen years spent in Wei Mansion had never felt so vivid.

From the age of five, Wei Yan had brought him to the Xie family cemetery every Qingming Festival or death anniversary, leaving the carriage driver and guards at the foot of the mountain.

Wei Yan had said his mother preferred quiet in life, and bringing too many people would disturb her peace.

Afraid of Wei Yan's sternness and resentful of his mother for abandoning him, Xie Zheng had never spoken more than necessary when kneeling before her grave—only burning ghost money and bowing in silence.

Wei Yan was the same, standing wordlessly before the grave for a long time before leaving.

The spilled lantern oil burned out, the blue flames extinguishing with a soft hiss.

Under the cold moonlight, not a single other light remained in the world.

Xie Zheng finally stepped toward his parents' graves. Gazing at the characters "Wei Wan" carved into the cold stone, he reached out to touch

them. His lowered lashes, bathed in moonlight, cast faint shadows beneath his eyes.

Oppression, gloom, suffocation, and hatred engulfed him like a tide, dragging him into an endless abyss.

His other hand, hanging at his side, clenched unconsciously. His jaw tightened, veins bulging at his temples, and a faint crimson hue flickered in his eyes.

From nearby came the sound of hurried footsteps—tap, tap, tap—as if stepping on someone's heartstrings.

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze and saw a small sphere of warm light rushing toward him through the dark night.

He saw the hem of the girl's dress glowing faintly under the lantern's light, her hair whipping in the night wind as she ran, her flushed cheeks and eyes full of worry from her frantic sprint.

A strange feeling—the darkness and heaviness in his heart gradually receded.

One day, though covered in scars, he was finally illuminated by the sun running toward him.

Fan Changyu had caught the scent of blood carried by the wind from the foot of the mountain. Fearing Xie Zheng had been ambushed, she had raced up the slope while Xie Zhong kept watch on Wei Yan's carriage below.

Along the way, she had seen large pools of blood on the ground. Now, noticing the blood on Xie Zheng's face, she quickly raised her lantern to check for injuries, her voice tense with worry: "Are you alright? Did Wei Yan's men ambush you here? Are you hurt?"

She fired off a series of questions in rapid succession, her breath uneven from running too fast, her voice still carrying traces of panting.

As she anxiously checked Xie Zheng for injuries, the man before her merely lowered his gaze, staring at her intently without blinking.

Fan Changyu found no wounds on Xie Zheng's front, but the scent of blood around him was overwhelming. Worried he might be injured on his back, she urged, "Turn around and let me see!"

Xie Zheng didn't move.

Fan Changyu had already learned from Xie Zhong about him receiving 108 lashes at the Xie ancestral hall. Connecting this with his later return to Lucheng to find her, she knew exactly why he had endured those lashes.

The entire way here, she hadn't been able to suppress the stinging in her eyes.

Seeing Xie Zheng's uncooperativeness, her anxiety grew, fearing he might indeed be wounded on his back. In her urgency, she reached out to pull his arm, trying to turn him around for inspection.

Unexpectedly, the man suddenly raised his arm, pressing his hand against the back of her neck and pulling her forcefully into his embrace.

The crushing force around her waist made it difficult for Fan Changyu to even breathe.

The lantern in her hand fell to the ground during the stumble and was instantly engulfed by flames.

"You shouldn't have come."

With her cheek pressed against his cold, unyielding chest, Fan Changyu heard his low, hoarse voice resonate above her head.

Though the words were clearly a rejection, she couldn't shake the illusion that she would never break free from his grasp again.

Chapter 135

The sky was like spilled ink, and all was silent.

The two embraced so closely that they could hear only each other's heartbeats.

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together and suddenly pushed Xie Zheng away with force.

After confirming he was unharmed, the worry that had gnawed at her all this way turned into lingering fear—along with a sudden surge of anger and a sense of grievance she couldn't quite understand herself.

She demanded, "Maybe I shouldn't have come. But if you had truly walked into Wei Yan's trap alone, what would have become of the Xie family? What would have happened to the subordinate generals under your command?"

Xie Zhong had said that Xie Zheng knelt before the ancestral tablets of the Xie Clan's ancestors and endured one hundred and eight lashes. The image of him collapsing in a pool of blood afterward, his back stripped of intact flesh, unable to even stand, seemed to burn before her eyes.

Perhaps it was the mountain wind that stung her eyes, but a faint redness shimmered in them.

She stared at the man before her, her fists clenched so tightly in her sleeves that they trembled uncontrollably. Struggling to maintain her cold composure, she forced out one last question: "And what about me?"

The words made Xie Zheng abruptly lift his gaze, his pupils flickering almost imperceptibly, as if he couldn't believe she would say such a thing.

Fan Changyu's eyes were red-rimmed, her teeth clenched as she glared at him fiercely, like a wounded leopard with nowhere left to run. "From the moment I learned who you were, I never thought of having anything to do with you again. It was you who kept provoking me!"

"Later, you were the one who said we should part ways. With General Xie's death between us, I didn't blame you. But after the victory banquet in

Lu City, you were also the one who told me—whether my surname was Fan or Meng—you only wanted to be with me properly! And now, are you trying to go back on your word again?"

The emotions that had been bottled up in her chest surged forth like a tidal wave, threatening to drown her reason.

Since childhood, Fan Changyu had rarely shown her grievances in front of others. This was the first time she lost control, shouting at him with raw fury, "Xie Zheng, you bastard!"

Why hadn't he brought any men with him?

He didn't have to tell her that today was his mother's death anniversary. After all, there was no concrete proof that her father was innocent. Bringing along the daughter of someone who might be his parents' enemy to pay respects—he would feel ashamed before them.

She didn't blame him for that.

But why had he put himself in danger?

Ever since learning that Xie Zheng had been punished before coming to Lu City to find her, Fan Changyu had understood that Xie Linshan's death would always weigh on his heart like an unshakable mountain.

He never showed it in front of her, but in secret, he was atoning to his parents in his own way.

Had he come here alone tonight for the sake of "atonement" too?

Fan Changyu had always been slow when it came to emotions. When Xie Zhong mentioned that today was his mother's death anniversary, she had only been briefly dazed. But now, the sorrow and grievance she had deliberately suppressed broke free from their cocoon, flooding her heart and tightening her throat.

Her eyes burned with unshed tears. She refused to cry, stubbornly refusing to blink, refusing to let the tears pooling in her eyes fall. Xie Zheng's figure blurred in her vision just a few steps away.

Even though she could no longer see him clearly, she kept her gaze fixed on him, her voice hoarse but resolute. "Without solid evidence, I can't prove my father's innocence to you. Maybe we'll never find proof that reveals the truth. That means my father might always be the one who helped Wei Yan kill General Xie."

"If you stay with me, you'll spend the rest of your life drowning in guilt, trapped in pain and regret."

The chest felt as if a cold wind had torn open a gaping hole, icy and piercingly painful.

Fan Changyu's throat was so parched it ached, the single tear she had been holding back in her eyes spilled over her eyelid and rolled down like shattered pearls, not even lingering on her face.

She took a deep breath and said, "Rather than this, perhaps we should just separate. I don't want this. Watching you suffer alone in agony, my heart feels no better. Maybe you shouldn't have come back for me in the first place. Sometimes, a clean break is better than prolonged pain... Mmm —"

Before she could finish her sentence, someone suddenly grabbed her by the neck and slammed her hard against the trunk of a cypress tree as thick as a bowl in front of the tomb.

Her back ached fiercely, but Fan Changyu had no time to care.

Xie Zheng's scorching breath was right before her. His eyes were bloodshot, his jaw clenched tightly, fierce and savage, like a beast on the verge of madness.

The hand gripping her throat was taut with veins, the force behind it terrifying.

He lowered his head to look at her, as if struggling to control his emotions, to stop himself from harming her. The last shreds of reason wrestled with the black fury roaring in his chest as he spoke with difficulty and resolve, "Don't say such things again..."

For a moment, there was unmistakable hatred in his gaze.

"You're right to call me a scoundrel. Even in death, I'd drag you into my coffin. And you talk to me about separating?"

He let out a soft laugh, his blood-spattered face ethereally beautiful yet deathly pale under the moonlight. Suddenly, he lowered his head and bit down savagely on her shoulder, his eyes filled with near-mad love and desperate resolve.

Fan Changyu gasped in pain, trying to struggle, but he pinned her against the tree with unyielding force.

When Xie Zheng raised his head again, the strands of hair on his forehead were tousled by the wind, his lips stained with blood, his features even more strikingly beautiful—like the demons from folklore that emerged at night to feast on human essence.

He murmured lowly, "Separate? Fan Changyu, why haven't I just chewed you up and swallowed you piece by piece?"

Fan Changyu lifted her eyes, staring at him expressionlessly. Just as he raised a hand to touch her face, she suddenly struck, erupting with force as she seized his wrist and flipped him over with all her might.

Caught off guard, Xie Zheng was thrown to the ground by her brute strength, his back hitting the stone tiles before the tomb with a dull thud.

Before he could rise, Fan Changyu pounced on him like a leopard, one hand locking his throat, her legs pinning his waist, restraining him as firmly as he had restrained her earlier.

She spat through gritted teeth, "Then who was it who knew Wei Yan was watching him yet still came alone to this graveyard, walking right into the trap?"

"You resent my identity, refuse to tell me—couldn't you at least bring more guards?"

By the end, her voice cracked slightly with suppressed emotion. "You feel guilty and remorseful toward General Xie and Madam Xie when you're with me—do you think my heart feels any better?"

Xie Zheng gazed up at the fierce, disheveled girl pinning him down, her hand locked around his throat, and for a moment, he was stunned. Finally understanding the reason behind her earlier words, he raised a hand to press against her back, pulling her forcefully toward him. "It's not what you think..."

Fan Changyu broke free from his embrace, sitting up to glare at him hatefully. "Then tell me what it is."

Xie Zheng, having his hand shaken off by Fan Changyu, didn't get up but lay flat on the green brick ground before the tomb, gazing dimly at the dark night sky as he said, "I never told you about my mother, did I?"

"Not long after my father's coffin returned to the capital, she hanged herself. I was four that year. On the day she died, she made me osmanthus cake, wore her favorite clothes, and painted her brows and lips before the

mirror. She coaxed me out to eat the cake, and by the time I returned, she was already a corpse hanging from the beam."

Fan Changyu was stunned.

"She entrusted me to Wei Yan, and I spent sixteen years living under someone else's roof in Wei Mansion. As a child, Wei Yan's precious son stuffed snakes into my bedding in the height of summer and poured cold well water on my bed in the dead of winter. He also tore up the homework assigned by my tutor..."

"Every time that happened, I would think of her and hate her—hate her for being the matriarch of a great family yet too weak to bear the responsibilities, hate her for being a mother yet abandoning me without fulfilling her duties. On countless nights, I saw the hem of her bright skirt dangling beneath the beam in my nightmares."

Xie Zheng smiled bitterly: "I thought Wei Yan hated me because I was greedy for that plate of osmanthus cake and left my mother, giving her the chance to hang herself. In truth, I hated myself too..."

Hearing him recount his childhood experiences in such a calm tone, as if speaking of someone else's affairs, Fan Changyu unconsciously clenched her hands resting on her knees.

She had only heard from Zhu Youchang that Madam Xie died to protect Xie Zheng and the old Xie family members who participated in exposing Wei Yan, but she hadn't known there were so many misunderstandings between Xie Zheng and his mother.

When her own parents died unexpectedly, she wouldn't have pulled herself together so quickly if not for Changning.

He lost both parents in childhood—it must have felt like the sky had collapsed. Blaming himself for his mother's death while enduring abuse in Wei Mansion...

Fan Changyu recalled how, upon hearing she had once given Song Yan a pair of clay figurines as a child, he had demanded she make him a pair too.

At the time, she had thought him childish, but now she understood a little.

Precisely because he had never received any warmth or comfort growing up, he had wanted even the clay figurines she'd given Song Yan.

Her heart ached fiercely.

Fan Changyu looked at the man lying beside her, reached out, and gently touched his head, saying, "Madam Xie's death wasn't your fault."

Xie Zheng mocked himself: "I hated her for seventeen years before learning she died for me."

"I didn't tell you today was her death anniversary not because of your identity, but because I hadn't figured out how to face her..."

Fan Changyu's heart was in turmoil as she whispered, "I'm sorry."

She had misunderstood him.

Xie Zheng turned his head to look at her and smiled. "Why apologize? I never told you these things—your misunderstanding was inevitable."

He sat up, knees bent, the contours of his shoulder and back muscles evident beneath his robes. "Did Xie Zhong tell you I was here?"

Afraid he would blame the lame old man, Fan Changyu quickly said, "After visiting Uncle Zhu, I couldn't find you and asked him myself."

Xie Zheng said, "His mouth grows looser by the day."

Fan Changyu pressed her lips together. "He was worried about you. No matter what, coming alone to pay respects to Madam Xie was too dangerous."

Xie Zheng lowered his eyes without speaking. The moonlight outlined the contours of his profile, revealing a hint of cold rigidity and stubbornness.

Fan Changyu thought he was still upset about Madam Xie's matter and didn't press further, only saying, "As long as nothing happened, it's fine."

Xie Zheng suddenly spoke: "When I came to pay respects to Mother before, he taught me not to bring others."

Fan Changyu asked in confusion, "Who?"

But Xie Zheng said no more. He stood up and turned to face his parents' gravestones, kneeling to kowtow three times.

Changyu privately speculated about the person he had mentioned. After much thought, the only possible candidate was Wei Yan.

She was secretly startled, wondering why he would still remember Wei Yan's words from the past, knowing full well that Wei Yan was the enemy who had caused his parents' deaths.

But then she considered that Wei Yan was, after all, his uncle. For over a decade, Xie Zheng had regarded him as his only remaining family in this world—even becoming the most effective blade in Wei Yan's hands.

No matter how harshly Wei Yan had treated Xie Zheng, he had never deprived him of martial training or education.

Even now that they were enemies, Xie Zheng probably still harbored unusual feelings toward Wei Yan.

Watching his tall, lean silhouette, Fan Changyu felt particularly complex emotions.

After finishing his kowtows, Xie Zheng stood up and suddenly turned to Fan Changyu. "Kowtow to my parents," he said.

Chapter 136

Fan Changyu stood there dumbfounded, like a silly goose.

Xie Zheng, seeing her rooted to the spot, said, "No need to be shy."

Fan Changyu shot him an annoyed glare but, mindful that they were before the graves of General Xie and Madam Xie, she restrained herself a little more.

She averted her gaze and turned to the tombstones of General Xie and his wife. The thought that she had just been bickering with Xie Zheng in front of their graves made her feel even more awkward.

She knelt down and said, "This junior, Changyu, descendant of Meng Shuyuan, pays respects to the General and Madam."

With that, she kowtowed three times.

Her maternal grandfather had once been a key general under Xie Linshan, so the ties between their families were not shallow.

Xie Zheng listened as she paid respects to his parents as a descendant of the Meng family, his expression unreadable. He simply addressed the silent tombstones in the night: "This is your future daughter-in-law."

Fan Changyu blushed furiously for the first time ever. After rising to her feet, she snapped at Xie Zheng, "Stop talking nonsense."

Xie Zheng raised an eyebrow slightly. "In this lifetime, if I don't marry you, who else would I marry? Sooner or later, you'll be their daughter-in-law. How is that nonsense?"

Fan Changyu decided to ignore him and turned to look back the way they had come. "We've delayed long enough. Let's hurry down the mountain, or Uncle Zhong will start worrying."

The overturned lantern had long since burned out, but in the moonlight, one could faintly make out her crimson earlobes, like fiery red pyracantha berries adorning a snow-covered tree—so vivid they seemed tempting to bite.

Xie Zheng's gaze darkened as he stared at her earlobes.

When Fan Changyu turned back after speaking, she met his unfathomable eyes. She froze for a moment, instinctively pinching her burning earlobes, and urged, "Let's go."

With that, she strode ahead.

Xie Zheng watched her almost fleeing figure, the corners of his lips lifting slightly, before following at a leisurely pace.

Once the hour of Xu passed, the street where the Prime Minister's residence stood fell into dead silence, with scarcely a bark from dogs to be heard.

Wei Yan's carriage stopped at the gate of the residence. A cold wind blew, scattering withered frost-covered leaves from the elm and poplar trees lining the street, adding to the desolate scene.

As Wei Yan stepped down from the carriage using the footstool, Wei Xuan rushed out from the gate, his face anxious as he hurried forward. "Father, you've finally returned..."

Wei Yan's aged yet even more imposing phoenix eyes glanced at his only son, and his first words were a reprimand: "What is this flustered behavior? Where is your decorum?"

Wei Xuan, though arrogant in front of others, had a fear of Wei Yan that seemed ingrained in his bones. Gritting his teeth, he said with sorrow, "Mother is ill. You—"

Wei Yan stepped onto the stone stairs leading to the residence and instructed the old servant following him, "Wei Quan, take my token and summon Physician Hu from the Imperial Hospital."

Wei Xuan trailed closely behind him. Seeing Wei Yan enter the residence and head toward his study, he clenched his fists at his sides and finally shouted at his father's retreating back, "Can't you at least go see Mother?"

This outburst was his protest on behalf of his mother.

The attending servants visibly tensed, not daring to breathe loudly.

This was the first time Wei Xuan had ever defied the father he revered. Stubbornly staring at Wei Yan's back, he choked out, "The physician said Mother is ill from sorrow and worry. She forbade me from coming to you... She said she mustn't trouble you. Please, just go see her..."

Wei Xuan wiped his eyes somewhat awkwardly with the back of his hand. Though he acted like an arrogant tyrant in front of outsiders, before Wei Yan, he always remained as restrained as a child, no matter the circumstances.

Wei Yan halted his steps, casting only a cold glance at Wei Xuan before heading wordlessly toward the study.

The attendants hurried after him, leaving Wei Xuan standing alone in place. He curled his lips in a self-deprecating and sorrowful smile, looking more miserable than if he had been crying.

Steward Wei Quan approached only after everyone had left. "Young master, don't fret," he said. "This old servant has already sent someone to fetch Physician Hu from the Imperial Hospital. The Prime Minister has been swamped with matters recently and truly has no energy left to deal with household affairs."

A vein bulged at Wei Xuan's neck as he clenched his jaw tightly. "Is it because I'm not as promising as Xie Zheng that Father dislikes me and takes it out on Mother as well?"

Wei Quan quickly replied, "Young master, don't speak recklessly. If these words reach the Prime Minister's ears, you'll be punished again."

Wei Xuan burst into laughter, his eyes brimming with resentment. "Punished, then so be it. All these years, the only time he truly looks at me is when he's reprimanding me for my mistakes. I can't compare to Xie Zheng, nor can I match his prized disciples. What about me, aside from sharing his blood, is worth his attention?"

Wei Quan looked at Wei Xuan, whose expression hovered between laughter and tears, with a complicated gaze. "Young master, don't belittle yourself. From the Prime Minister's position, the matters he must consider are endless. It's only natural he has no time for the household. Let this old servant escort you back."

Wei Xuan knew Wei Quan's words held truth.

Sometimes, he didn't know whether he resented Wei Yan or himself.

Wei Yan had no concubines besides his mother, the principal wife.

But for as long as Wei Xuan could remember, Wei Yan only visited his mother's courtyard for the New Year's Eve dinner and never stayed the night. For over a decade, he had resided in his study.

The servants of Wei Mansion were exceedingly proper; none dared to slight his mother. She enjoyed all the dignity befitting a first-rank lady of Imperial decree of honor.

Yet, the older Wei Xuan grew, the more he grieved for his mother.

Wei Yan had never had eyes for his mother. It seemed he was born indifferent to women, caring only for power.

But his mother's family was unremarkable. It was only through Wei Yan's support that his maternal grandfather attained a fifth-rank position in the capital, finally securing a foothold in the city.

In the past, to gain Wei Yan's attention, Wei Xuan had repeatedly acted out—frequenting brothels, keeping singing girls—all the disgraceful deeds one could imagine. Even now, his courtyard was filled with a flock of beauties. He knew all too well the affairs between men and women.

He couldn't understand why, if his father cared only for power, he had married his mother, who had no connections. The Wei family was a centuries-old noble house. In his youth, Wei Yan had even been hailed alongside Xie Linshan as one of the "Twin Jewels of Civil and Military." Had he wished to marry, the capital was full of noble daughters for him to choose from.

Yet, having married his mother, Wei Yan had never taken another woman by his side all these years. Wei Xuan thought perhaps his father had once held some affection for his mother in his youth.

It was only because he, Wei Xuan, had disappointed him that Wei Yan had grown cold toward his mother as well.

Wei Xuan was usually unruly in front of others, but before Wei Quan, his father's longtime servant, he revealed a childlike side. Sitting on the stone steps, he covered his eyes with his hand and said bitterly, "If only I were Xie Zheng. With such an outstanding son, perhaps Father would be happy, wouldn't he?"

His mother was a devout vegetarian who spoke of Wei Yan with great reverence. The most frequent advice she gave him was to study hard, practice martial arts diligently, and become a capable person so he could be of use to his father...

But Wei Yan seemed to dislike children. From a young age, Wei Xuan feared him, yet due to the respect his mother and others showed Wei Yan,

he also harbored a deep admiration for him.

As a child, he had tried his best to excel in everything, hoping to earn a word or two of praise from Wei Yan.

Before Xie Zheng arrived at Wei Mansion, Wei Yan would occasionally treat him kindly. Though strict when tutoring his studies, he never overly reprimanded him.

After Xie Zheng's arrival, Wei Xuan never saw Wei Yan smile at him again. Xie Zheng lived and ate with him, yet every time Wei Yan saw them together, his face would darken.

Xie Zheng was always brilliant, mastering whatever the tutor taught him in no time.

Even when Wei Yan tested them on their studies, Xie Zheng, though nervous, could extrapolate and answer correctly. In contrast, whenever Wei Xuan faced Wei Yan's questions, the moment those sharp phoenix eyes shifted from the book to him, he would tremble uncontrollably, unable to utter a word.

He resented Xie Zheng for making him look foolish and for overshadowing him so completely that Wei Yan's gaze no longer held any approval.

More than once, he wished Xie Zheng had never existed.

So in his childhood, he spared no effort in bullying Xie Zheng. On the rare occasions Wei Yan found out, he was punished by kneeling in the ancestral hall. Afterward, he only intensified his cruelty toward Xie Zheng, who soon became too afraid to even complain.

But it brought him little joy. At first, stuffing snakes and insects into Xie Zheng's bedding would make him scream in terror. Later, Xie Zheng would simply crush them without blinking.

In the bitter cold of winter, he doused Xie Zheng's bedding in freezing well water. Xie Zheng would toss the soaked bedding aside and sleep on the bare wooden planks in his clothes. The next day, even with a high fever, he would still outperform him on the training grounds.

At the academy, he led a group of sycophantic officials' sons to pour ink over Xie Zheng's desk. Behind the rock garden, he and his lackeys beat Xie Zheng mercilessly, grinding his face into the muddy water while sneering, "Xie Linshan's spawn is just trash."

He wished Xie Zheng would stay that way—broken and worthless.

But Xie Zheng never begged for mercy. Even when pinned down by his cronies, with his face pressed into the mud, his gaze remained cold and unsettling, sending shivers down their spines.

Later, Xie Zheng joined the army. When they met again, Xie Zheng returned from the battlefield covered in glory, making him seem even more insignificant by comparison.

On another rainy day, Xie Zheng broke several of his ribs and ground his face into the torrential mud, coldly mocking, "Wei Yan's spawn is nothing special either."

Everything he had once inflicted on Xie Zheng was now returned in kind.

From that moment, his hatred for Xie Zheng grew even fiercer. When news arrived of Xie Zheng's death on the Chongzhou battlefield, no one knew just how overjoyed he was.

But even with Xie Zheng "gone," his own stint in the northwest was a disaster. Instead of successfully taking over Xie Zheng's forces, he plunged the entire region into chaos, giving the Li faction new grounds to impeach Wei Yan.

After all these years, Wei Xuan finally admitted the truth: he had always been jealous of Xie Zheng—so jealous that he hated himself for not being him.

Wei Quan listened to his words and simply said, "The Marquis is the Marquis, and the young master is the young master. There is no need for the young master to compare himself to anyone."

Wei Xuan lowered his head with a bitter smile, gazing at the bamboo shadows cast on the ground. Unwilling to embarrass himself further in front of Wei Quan, he stood up and said, "I'll go back to accompany Mother."

Wei Quan nodded respectfully as he watched him leave.

When Wei Xuan arrived at the courtyard where Madam Wei resided, he heard heart-wrenching coughs coming from inside before even entering the room.

The memory of Wei Yan's cold, retreating figure made his chest ache even more. Seeing a maid carrying a freshly brewed medicine from the

small kitchen, he said, "I'll take it to Mother."

The maid, clearly intimidated by him, dared not refuse and handed him the tray with the medicine bowl respectfully.

Wei Xuan, thick-skinned and unbothered, picked up the blue-and-white porcelain bowl with its gilded rim and strode into the room.

"Mother, time for your medicine," he said as soon as he entered. A servant promptly brought a round stool and placed it by the bed.

Madam Wei, weakened by illness, looked far from well. She was not a beauty in the conventional sense—her features were plain, but years of vegetarianism and Buddhist devotion had lent her a gentle, compassionate air.

She comforted her only son, "It's just an old ailment, nothing serious. A few days of rest, and I'll be fine."

Wei Xuan lowered his head, stirring the dark-brown medicinal brew with a spoon. "Father was very concerned when he heard you were ill. But with the court situation being so uncertain, he had many ministers discussing affairs with him and couldn't get away. That's why he hasn't come to see you yet. But he's already sent for a royal physician from the Imperial Hospital."

At these words, the calm in Madam Wei's eyes flickered. She asked, "You went to see the Prime Minister? Didn't I tell you not to trouble him with such trivial matters...?"

Wei Xuan replied, "I didn't seek him out. The estate isn't that big—how could we hide the fact that you're ill and needed a physician...?"

Madam Wei coughed harder, struggling to speak as she looked at her son. "Don't lie to me. How could you...?"

She sighed, sounding almost resigned. "Why won't you listen to your mother?"

Caught in his lie, Wei Xuan lowered his head in shame, his grip tightening around the medicine bowl. "Mother, is it because I'm useless that you feel too ashamed to ask Father for anything?"

Madam Wei covered her lips with a light cough and said weakly, "Silly child, what nonsense are you saying?"

Wei Xuan raised his head, his eyes red-rimmed. "It's my fault for being so incapable, for not earning Father's favor, that you've been neglected because of me."

Madam Wei paused, a complex emotion swirling in her gaze before she spoke gently, "Don't think such things. The Prime Minister is a man of great responsibilities. A true gentleman doesn't dwell on sentimental matters. You mustn't say such words in front of him."

Wei Xuan retorted bitterly, "But all these years, Father only comes to dine with you during festivals. Don't you feel wronged, Mother?"

For a fleeting moment, a shadow of melancholy crossed Madam Wei's face, as if recalling something from the past. She merely said, "Silly child, don't think like that. Your mother has never felt wronged. The Prime Minister is my benefactor. You must strive to be worthy, like your cousin Xie Zheng, and help shoulder his burdens."

Unaware of the rift between Wei Yan and Xie Zheng—as a woman who stayed out of household affairs, she assumed Xie Zheng was simply stationed in the north and hadn't returned home in years.

Wei Xuan keenly caught one phrase in her words and asked, "Mother, why do you say Father is your benefactor?"

Madam Wei lowered her eyes and did not answer immediately. Covering her lips, she coughed for a long while before saying, "Being born a woman, marriage is like a second rebirth. When I was a maiden, as a concubine-born daughter in the family, I had to endure others' disdain for every piece of clothing and every meal. In the more than twenty years since I married into the Prime Minister's residence, the Prime Minister has treated me well. I am content."

Wei Xuan knew his mother had always been a person who avoided conflict. Silently, he helped Madam Wei drink her medicine and refrained from asking further questions.

By the time Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng returned from the Xie family cemetery, it was nearly Hai hour (9-11 PM). The city gates had already closed, so Fan Changyu had no choice but to wait until they reopened the next morning before returning to the Office of Presentations.

Fortunately, she had already instructed Xie Qi before leaving. Even if she didn't return for the night, there shouldn't be any major issues.

Xie Zhong drove the carriage back to the estate outside the city. As soon as the carriage arrived at the gate, a member of the Blood-Clad Cavalry was waiting outside and presented a letter: "Master, a message from the Grand Princess, sent from the palace."

Xie Zheng reached out to take it. After tearing open the envelope, he quickly scanned the letter under the lantern light by the gate, his eyes instantly turning icy.

Fan Changyu found it strange that he had correspondence with the Grand Princess, but seeing his grim expression, she asked, "What's wrong?"

Xie Zheng handed her the letter, gritting his teeth as he spat out a few words: "Wei Yan once had an illicit affair with a consort!"

Before Fan Changyu could even read the letter, her heart skipped a beat at his words. If Wei Yan had indeed been involved with a consort, did that mean there was now a trail leading to his orchestration of the Jinzhou case seventeen years ago?

Chapter 137

Fan Changyu unfolded the letter. After reading its contents, her brows furrowed unconsciously.

The Eldest Princess had helped investigate the matter of the Sixteenth Prince, but he had been dead for many years. Jia Guifei had also followed the Late Emperor in death not long after the Sixteenth Prince passed away. The new emperor Qi Sheng's favored consorts had long since moved into their original palaces, and the palace servants had been replaced batch after batch. Finding someone who knew the truth from back then was exceedingly difficult.

After many days of secret investigation, the Eldest Princess discovered that an old palace maid on duty in the Cold Palace had once served in Jia Guifei's palace. However, she had supposedly gone mad seventeen years ago and was cast into the Cold Palace to fend for herself.

The Eldest Princess's people made contact with the mad palace maid over several days by bringing her food and clothing. They subtly sensed that the maid was only feigning madness, but she was very vigilant and refused to let her guard down.

When the Eldest Princess's people found an opportune moment to ask about the Sixteenth Prince, the palace maid became noticeably agitated. Feigning madness, she cried out, "Dead, they're all dead, and I'll die too... Wei Yan had an affair with an imperial consort, and anyone who knows must die..."

The Eldest Princess's people couldn't ask anything more before the matron in charge of the Cold Palace entered the courtyard.

Everyone in the palace was shrewd. For the Eldest Princess's people to suddenly start visiting the Cold Palace every few days, and even bring nice things for a mad palace maid, would arouse anyone's suspicion.

The Eldest Princess's people had given the matron of the Cold Palace a considerable bribe, lying that they had happened to pass by the Cold Palace and seen the mad maid eating a bowl of stinking, spoiled rice. Unable to bear the sight, they had offered some help.

Although the matron didn't press the matter, to be safe, the Eldest Princess's people dared not go to the Cold Palace to probe for information again for the time being.

Fan Changyu looked at Xie Zheng and said, "For now, we must first figure out which imperial consort Wei Yan had an affair with..."

Xie Zheng knew what she was suspecting. After the deaths of the Chengde Crown Prince and the Sixteenth Prince, Wei Yan had propped up the nineteenth prince, who had no foundation, to inherit the throne. The nineteenth prince's birth mother was the most suspicious.

He said, "It couldn't have been the young emperor's birth mother. She was just a palace maid who was favored by the Late Emperor in a drunken state. She died from complications after giving birth to him."

The biggest reason Wei Yan supported Qi Sheng's ascension was likely his youth and lack of maternal relatives, which made him easy to control.

That left only one breakthrough: the "mad" palace maid in the Cold Palace.

His eyes were as cold as snow. "I will personally sneak into the Cold Palace."

Fan Changyu recalled the ten-zhang-high city walls she had seen outside the Meridian Gate when she entered the palace for her investiture. "The imperial palace is heavily guarded. Entering without a decree on a normal day will likely be difficult. I heard from General Tang that there will be a victory banquet in the palace soon. Why don't we investigate the Cold Palace then? It would also avoid alerting the enemy."

Worried for Xie Zheng's safety, Xie Zhong also nodded. "The General of the Cloud Banner's considerations are thorough. Marquis, you should make some arrangements first and go on the day of the palace banquet."

Xie Zheng pondered for a moment, then slowly nodded. Without another word, he strode into the courtyard.

Fan Changyu watched his cold and solitary back, a hint of faint worry appearing in her eyes.

She had originally felt that the idea of Wei Yan single-handedly orchestrating the Jinzhou Massacre was debatable. But with the addition of his affair with an imperial consort, it seemed to be a certainty.

Before, she had thought Wei Yan was simply an enemy to Xie Zheng. But tonight's trip to the Xie family mausoleum made her realize that Xie Zheng's feelings toward Wei Yan were actually very complicated.

With every step deeper they dug into the truth of the past, it seemed like they were pushing a knife pressed against his heart an inch further in.

Though they had rushed about until the middle of the night, Fan Changyu and the others had not yet had dinner.

Xie Zhong ordered the kitchen to prepare a meal. Zhu Youchang, plagued by his old ailments, had already gone to sleep, so only Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng were left to eat. But Xie Zheng had not come out since returning to his room, only instructing his men to see to Fan Changyu's arrangements.

Xie Zhong had a servant deliver a separate portion to Xie Zheng's room, but it was sent back untouched.

Xie Zhong understood Xie Zheng's temperament. He sighed helplessly, dismissed the Blood-Clad Cavalryman who had delivered the food, and said to Fan Changyu, "General, please have your meal. Let His Lordship have some time alone."

Fan Changyu thought of the lonely figure of Xie Zheng she had seen standing before General Xie and his wife's tomb when she had rushed to the mausoleum. "I'll take it to him," she said.

A flash of surprise crossed Xie Zhong's eyes, but when he thought of the many special ways Xie Zheng treated her, a relieved smile appeared on his face. "Then I'll have to trouble you, General."

Faced with Xie Zhong's all-knowing gaze, Fan Changyu could only pick up the meal on the tray and quickly ask where Xie Zheng's room was to hide her embarrassment.

The moon was bright and the stars were few. The lanterns under the eaves cast bamboo shadows on the door and stone steps.

Fan Changyu looked at the room, which glowed with a warm light. Holding the carved wooden tray with one hand, she raised the other and knocked on the door.

From a distance inside the room came Xie Zheng's cold and impatient voice. "I said I don't need dinner. Leave!"

"It's me," Fan Changyu said.

The room was quiet for a long while before that clear, low, and raspy voice sounded again. "The door isn't bolted."

Fan Changyu pushed the door open. At first glance, she didn't see anyone in the outer room, only the faint sound of water coming from the clean room. She had intended to come over and offer Xie Zheng a word or two of comfort, but now she suddenly felt a little awkward. With her back to the clean room, she said, "I've put the food on the table for you. Remember to eat after you're done washing up."

No further sound came from the clean room, not even the sound of water.

Fan Changyu was puzzled and worried that something might have happened to Xie Zheng. She had no choice but to call out again, "Xie Zheng?"

Still no answer.

Fan Changyu turned to glare in that direction. "If you don't answer, I'm going to get someone to come in and check on you."

Finally, a low, mellow, and slightly hoarse voice came from within. "Help me pass in the change of clothes by the bed."

A light pink blush crept up Fan Changyu's ears. She turned away. "I'll go get Uncle Zhong to bring them to you."

A loud splash came from the clean room, and the person inside said, "Forget it. I'll get them myself."

This was immediately followed by a dull thud, then the sound of pottery shattering. Even through the cloth curtain, Fan Changyu could smell liquor.

Why would there be liquor in the clean room?

Worried that Xie Zheng was drunk and had slipped while getting out of the bath, and afraid he might get cut by the porcelain shards, Fan Changyu disregarded everything else and quickly lifted the curtain to enter. "Are you alright?"

When she saw the scene inside, Fan Changyu suddenly felt as if she didn't know where to put her hands and feet.

The weather had turned cold, and the entire clean room was filled with a hazy mist. Xie Zheng was leaning against the edge of the bathtub, his handsome face sullen and tinged with a slight drunkenness. A red mark was on his shoulder and back where he had knocked himself. His fine brows were knitted in slight annoyance; he had clearly hit the edge of the tub when he fell.

A liquor jar was shattered outside the tub. Judging by the amount spilled, Xie Zheng must have drunk most of it. Beside it lay another empty, overturned jar.

He had actually drunk two jars of liquor, and from the smell, it was strong liquor. No wonder he looked a little drunk.

Seeing that he wasn't injured, Fan Changyu's heart settled, but the way he looked... was far too alluring.

His half-tied hair was mostly soaked, clinging to his shoulders and back where the curves of his muscles were prominent. It was a combination of handsome beauty and power, easily bringing to mind a beast of the jungle—dangerous and agile.

His long lashes were like fans, dotted with tiny water droplets. Near his neck, on his shoulder, was the bite mark she had left before she went out. It suddenly gave the illusion that this beautiful, perverse beast could be tamed.

Even knowing it was inappropriate, Fan Changyu could feel the heat rushing to her face. She quickly turned her back. "I... I'll go get Uncle Zhong..."

She had just taken a step when a low, hoarse voice sounded from behind her. "No need."

Xie Zheng pressed his temples, which were throbbing faintly. The impatience on his face intensified. Blessed with such a fine appearance, even his angry expression was exceedingly handsome. He said, "I can do it myself."

The water rippled. He pushed himself up forcefully, bracing against the edge of the tub, but his figure was clearly unsteady. He nearly fell again, but fortunately, Fan Changyu heard the commotion and caught him in time.

Feeling the weight of most of his body pressing down on her, Fan Changyu gritted her teeth in frustration. "I've never seen anyone as

stubborn as you!"

Because he was unclothed, Fan Changyu kept her head raised as much as possible, not daring to let her eyes wander.

A drop of water from the damp strands of hair on his forehead fell onto her neck. The cool touch made her shrink back instinctively.

Fan Changyu remembered his clothes were still outside. She fumbled to press down on his shoulders, wanting to push him back into the tub first. "You wait in here. I'll go get you some clean clothes."

The half-drunk man lowered his head slightly, staring at her red lips as they opened and closed. It was unclear if he had heard what she said. Just as she was about to turn and leave again, he pulled her into his arms.

The water on his body soaked through her clothes. Fan Changyu's heart leaped into her throat in an instant, but he only buried his head in the crook of her shoulder. After a long moment, he said hoarsely, "A Yu, you're all I have left."

This was the first time anyone had ever called her that. The overly intimate name left Fan Changyu at a loss for how to respond.

They were too close, and his body was scorching hot. Fan Changyu felt a hot, tingling numbness spread from the side of her neck to half her ear. A strange feeling rose in her heart, as if she were stepping on clouds, light and adrift.

Fan Changyu remained stiff for a long while before she reached out to pat his back reassuringly. "I've always been here."

The skin of his back under her palm was not smooth; she could clearly feel the slight curve of raised scars.

Remembering the one hundred and eight lashes Xie Zhong had told her he had once received, Fan Changyu's eyes flickered. Her tone took on a coaxing quality. "Sit down. I'll help you wash your back."

This was something Fan Changyu would never have offered on a normal day. Xie Zheng seemed about to obediently sit down. The alcohol had slowed his thoughts. The corners of his eyes were tinged with red, and his usually cold face even held a bewitching charm. But perhaps some lingering shred of sobriety made him remember something. He grabbed Fan Changyu's hand, brought it to his lips, and kissed it. "Next time," he said.

Then, he gave his head, which was stinging from the alcohol, a slight shake. He tried to stand up on his own by bracing against the edge of the tub, but Fan Changyu forcefully pressed down on his shoulders. She had already moved behind him and seen his back, which, though the scabs had fallen off, was still a crisscrossing mess of scars.

Fan Changyu froze.

Seeing those twisted, overlapping whip marks with her own eyes, she finally understood what Xie Zhong had meant by "not a single patch of good skin."

She had applied medicine to his back before. Back then, he was as wretched as a stray dog on the street, and the wounds on his body were not as hideous and dense as they were now. Fan Changyu could hardly imagine what this body full of injuries had looked like when it was bloody and raw.

Her heart ached fiercely.

The knife wound that slashed across his entire back was from when he had cut himself to consecrate his blade with blood. It had split open countless times, and the scar was especially wide, ferocious, and terrifying.

When Fan Changyu's fingertips traced over it, they trembled uncontrollably.

Her throat felt tight. She asked him in a hoarse voice, "How long did you plan to hide all these injuries from me?"

Chapter 138

The water in the tub was already half-cold. Feeling the warm, delicate touch of her fingertips on his back, the muscles across Xie Zheng's shoulders and back tensed involuntarily. On the hand resting on the tub's edge, the pale blue veins on its back stood out.

His head still throbbed from the alcohol. Hearing the hoarseness in her voice, he struggled to stay lucid and replied, "It doesn't hurt."

Fan Changyu's fingertip traced down the long scar on his back. Lowering her gaze to the mark, which was nearly half an inch wide, she said, "Of course it doesn't hurt now. What about before it scabbed over?"

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes drooped slightly. The candlelight gilded his thick, dark lashes with a faint, warm glow, and for a moment, the lines of his face seemed to soften.

He appeared lost in thought, his long lashes casting a shadow on his eyelids. He only said, "It didn't hurt before it scabbed over, either."

Fan Changyu felt as if a wad of damp cotton was stuck in her chest. She tilted her head back and blinked, forcing back the stinging sensation that welled in her eyes. Unable to bear the sight of his back, ravaged by whip marks, she turned her head away. Two words rasped from her throat, "Liar."

She said hatefully, "You've tormented yourself into this state. Weren't you afraid of dying on the battlefield? Don't you still have to take revenge on Wei Yan? Is this how you go about seeking vengeance?"

Xie Zheng was silent for a moment before he said slowly, "Only when the wounds on my body hurt did I know I was still alive."

Fan Changyu was taken aback.

His voice was low and raspy as he let out a soft laugh. "When you chased after me from Chongzhou, covered in injuries, and I saw you sitting on horseback crying, I thought, to hell with revenge, I don't care anymore. Just please stop crying. But my surname is Xie, and my father is Xie Linshan. I can barely remember his face, but I still remember his chest and

abdomen, crudely stitched up after being cut open. I remember the shape of the sixty-seven arrow wounds on his body..."

"If I died, perhaps I could be with you with a clear conscience. But as long as I'm alive, I can't have the slightest connection to you."

Hearing him speak of General Xie's death again, Fan Changyu's heart ached with a sour, piercing pain.

She choked out, "I didn't blame you. I didn't blame you that day..."

Even she, an outsider, was overcome with grief upon hearing of General Xie's tragic death, let alone his own son.

Even Zhu Youchang had once thought her father was a traitor, to say nothing of Xie Zheng, who had never met him. She had no way to prove her father's innocence to him without any evidence.

Even now, recalling the situation that day, Fan Changyu was still filled with nothing but suffocating pain and helplessness.

Xie Zheng raised a hand to wipe away the crystalline tear that rolled from her eye. It was unclear if he was drunk or sober as he murmured, "Why are you crying again?"

His thumb caressed her cheek, his half-drunk, deep black eyes reflecting her and the flickering candlelight. "In those days, you were always crying in my dreams, too. At first, I thought that if I just never saw you again for the rest of my life, I could eventually let go."

"But even when I tried my best not to seek out any news about you, you still wouldn't give me peace in my dreams."

"Sometimes, one moment I'd be in Lin'an Town and you'd be smiling and calling my name. The next, you'd be in a wedding dress, about to marry another man. He was handsome and refined, seemed to be a scholar. The calls in the wedding hall to bow to heaven and earth pierced my eardrums. You, with your veil on, bowed with him, the corner of your lips curved up, looking so happy..."

He couldn't continue. The drunken haze in his eyes suddenly turned chillingly fierce. The thumb caressing her cheek pressed harder, yet his harsh tone was laced with a hint of grievance. "You always know how to torture me. What are those injuries I suffered? They're not even half as agonizing as the heartache of seeing you marry someone else in my dreams... I wanted nothing more than to chop that man into a pile of

minced meat. When I woke up and saw the bed canopy, the rage was hard to quell, but I was also very happy."

"I realized then that I couldn't bear to see you marry another. Thankfully, there's still time."

Even with most of his reason eroded by alcohol, he stopped himself from saying the last sentence.

If she had married, he would have annihilated the man's entire clan to take her back! Then he would chop the man who dared to marry her into mincemeat and feed him to the dogs!

She was his! She could only be his!

Anyone who dared to covet her deserved to die!

That sinister, twisted nature that came from his very bones was like the final floodgate in his heart, one he always guarded. He himself loathed it; he couldn't let her know.

If she knew, she would surely avoid him like the plague...

Fan Changyu's cheek stung from the rough caress of Xie Zheng's thumb, but she didn't pull away. Hearing him speak of his time in Kangcheng after they parted, the bitterness in her heart was hard to dispel.

The more she understood this man, the more she realized how difficult that day's choice had been for him.

She grabbed the hand Xie Zheng was using to wipe her tears and pressed it firmly against her own cheek. Her tear-filled eyes, shimmering in the warm candlelight, looked at him with determination as she said in a hoarse voice, "Xie Zheng, from now on, let's be together, properly. And you're not allowed to abuse your body anymore."

When her brilliant eyes stared at someone without blinking, it was as if the entire world lost its color, leaving only the clear, warm, gentle light in their depths. It was like the warm sun on a winter afternoon, slowly melting the icicles hanging from the eaves.

Xie Zheng met her gaze, stunned for a long moment, before he gently stroked her cheek and said, "It wasn't abuse."

Remembering the crisscrossing scars on his back, Fan Changyu still felt a pang of sadness. "Your back is in that state, and you say it wasn't abuse?"

"According to The Xie Clan's code, anyone who commits a great transgression shall receive one hundred and eight lashes, and the sin can be absolved. After taking those one hundred and eight lashes, I could come find you with a clear conscience. In the future, I can also marry you into the Xie family with the three letters and six rites."

Fan Changyu's eyelids trembled. Despite her best efforts to restrain herself, a single, clear tear rolled from her eye and fell into the tub, creating ripples.

No wonder he had told her after the victory banquet in Lucheng that he no longer cared if her surname was Fan or Meng. It turned out he had already atoned in such a way.

She covered her eyes with her hand and tilted her head up slightly, but she couldn't hide the sob in her throat. "What am I supposed to do with you?"

Perhaps because he was drunk, Xie Zheng's eyes were also tinged with red. His voice was deep and hoarse. "I want to take Meng Shi Changyu as my wife. Will you accept?"

The sour, swelling feeling in her chest intensified, yet there was no outlet for it.

Fan Changyu felt the tartness rise all the way to the tip of her nose. She stared at the man, whose black hair was completely soaked and whose beauty was almost demonic, and said earnestly, "If you'll marry me, I'll marry you."

Xie Zheng's jet-black eyes locked onto her without blinking. "No regrets?"

Fan Changyu met his gaze and asked, "Are you thinking of going back on your word already?"

She glared at him, her tone tinged with defiance.

Xie Zheng didn't speak.

A large hand cupped the back of her head, forcing Fan Changyu to bend forward, and then her breath was stolen.

Xie Zheng had drunk a lot of wine. When he pried her teeth apart, the rich taste of alcohol spread between their lips and teeth. Fan Changyu felt it was different from how she felt after drinking.

He kissed her fiercely, sucking on her lips and tongue until they were numb and sore before he released her.

Fan Changyu leaned against the edge of the tub, left with only enough strength to gasp for air.

Her face was flushed from the lack of air, and her apricot-like eyes shimmered with moisture.

The front of her clothes was almost completely soaked, revealing the tight outline of her chest bindings.

Xie Zheng's breath hitched, the darkness in his eyes deepening.

A fire seemed to ignite in the cold air, making the blood surging through his limbs sizzle.

He stood up abruptly, stepping out of the tub in one long stride. He lifted her and placed her on the nearby table. Looking down at Fan Changyu's lips, slightly swollen from his kiss, he covered them again, the darkness in his eyes looking as if it would devour her whole.

Fan Changyu's back hit the screen behind the long table. A muffled grunt had just escaped her when her breath was stolen once more.

Her eyes were full of untamed spirit as she tried to regain the upper hand, but she was pinned down tightly by him. Towards the end, she felt dizzy. A wave of coolness spread across her chest, and as her bindings came loose, she subconsciously wrapped her arms around Xie Zheng's head.

His damp hair brushed against her warm skin, the coldness sending shivers through her and making her shoulders instinctively curl inward.

He was like a wolf that had starved for too long on the frozen plains in the dead of winter, suddenly given a piece of fatty meat, so overwhelmed he didn't know where to start.

His movements were far from gentle, even uncontrollably rough.

Fan Changyu frowned slightly, drawing in a sharp, shallow breath. She patted his firm shoulder, her voice breathy and tinged with softness, "You... be gentle."

The night he left Jizhou, he had bitten her until she was swollen. She hadn't dared to wear her chest bindings for days afterward.

Xie Zheng kissed her lightly and finally released her. When he looked up, his eyes were scarlet, and a vein bulged on his neck, looking rather frightening.

His breath was as scorching as fire, but his voice was steady, though extremely hoarse. "Not afraid?"

Reflecting the candlelight, Fan Changyu's eyes were soft and warm, veiled with a mist like a forest at dawn. It was as if she held the first light of morning in her eyes, warm and bright. She asked him back, "Afraid of what?"

Xie Zheng couldn't resist cupping her jaw and kissing her again. A long while later, he rested his forehead against hers, his scarlet eyes filled with a near self-loathing as he said, "You're the one who decided to marry me. He's not a good person, you know."

Fan Changyu reached out to touch his face and said, "I have eyes. I can tell what kind of person you are."

Xie Zheng said viciously, "What if I'm deliberately putting on an act in front of you?"

Hearing his strange words, Fan Changyu raised her bright eyes and said deliberately, "Then... I'll have to reconsider?"

The large hands on her shoulders tightened abruptly, the force so great it felt like they would crush her shoulder blades. Xie Zheng spoke with a sinister edge, "Too late."

His eyes held a sense of finality and a trace of ruthlessness. Beneath his calm expression hid a brokenness and mockery that even he himself was unaware of. "Fan Changyu, for the rest of your life, you can only be tied to a bastard like me."

Fan Changyu had only meant to tease him. Hearing him talk about himself like that, a pang of pain bloomed in her heart again.

How could she not know what kind of person he was?

She leaned in and planted a kiss on his cheek, saying, "Then let's be tied together. They say the good die young. If you're a bad person, I might even be a little happier."

Chapter 139

The candlelight flickered. Xie Zheng's gaze, fixed on her, was dark and heavy.

He suddenly lunged forward and kissed her, biting at her lips. He controlled the back of her neck with one hand, making it impossible for her to even struggle. The kiss was fierce and savage, with a hint of the tyranny of unleashed shackles.

Fan Changyu, with her head tilted back, could only endure it passively. Her every breath was filled with the crisp, mellow scent of wine from his body and the faint smell of soap from his bath.

Her already slightly swollen lips began to sting from his kiss before he finally released them, his hand gripping her jaw as he continued to kiss his way down.

Fan Changyu's chest heaved violently from the lack of air. Without the binding strip, the curve of her chest became particularly pronounced as it rose and fell. The damp clothes clung to her, half-concealing and half-revealing, outlining an alluring silhouette. The shadow beneath the expanse of snowy skin was enough to make one's blood boil.

Xie Zheng buried his head in the crook of her shoulder, panting heavily. When he looked up again, his eyes were an absurd shade of crimson.

He said, "You asked for this!"

He grabbed her half-damp lapels and ripped them down from her shoulders and arms. The fabric bunched at the crooks of her elbows. Under the dim candlelight, Fan Changyu's skin had the warm, gentle white of jade, but the scars she had brought back from the battlefield on her arms and shoulders now became glaringly conspicuous.

Xie Zheng had never seen her body in its entirety. He knew she had an extremely long knife scar running from her abdomen to her waist, an injury from the battle at Lu City, but he hadn't expected to see so many overlapping scars on her upper arms as well.

The dark lust in his eyes receded slightly. He gently kissed the deepest scar on her shoulder and arm, asking, "How did you get this?"

He knew it must have been from the battlefield, but he didn't know which battle.

The kiss was so light, as gentle as a feather's touch.

During her recovery and the journey to the capital, Fan Changyu had read many books. The phrase "as if looking at a precious treasure" subconsciously came to her mind.

Her long lashes trembled, and her entire heart felt as if it had been soaked in warm water, leaving it soft and warm.

A blush crept onto her face, not from physical arousal, but from a trace of shyness that a normal maiden would feel before the man she loved.

She turned her head slightly, looking at the scar on her upper right arm herself. Though she had never cared much for it before, at this moment, she felt a flicker of thought that the scar was ugly.

She tried to cover it with her hand, feigning a relaxed tone. "This was also from the battle at Lu City. I was lucky the Crown Prince's men wanted to capture me alive back then. If the blade had gone a fraction of an inch lower, this arm of mine would probably have been crippled, just like Xiao Wu's."

Xie Zheng moved her shielding hand aside, bent down, and kissed the scar again. His half-damp bangs and lowered lashes concealed the expression in his eyes. "I'm sorry. I was too late."

Fan Changyu smiled, one hand gently caressing his jade-like profile. "Why are you apologizing again? What military officer doesn't get injured? Since I chose this path, these are things I must go through."

Bringing up the battle of Lu City again, she asked the question that had puzzled her for a long time. "General Tang said you were on your way to escort Sui Yuanqing back to Chongzhou and just happened to be passing through Jizhou. But I calculated the dates. You had just returned to the Xie residence in Huizhou to receive your punishment not long before that. Your wounds were probably still bleeding. Why did you set out in such a hurry?"

A shadow fell over Xie Zheng's eyes, which reflected the candlelight. "The Eldest Princess sent a message to Gongsun Yin, telling him about the

little emperor's decree of marriage. The eunuch sent to Chongzhou to announce the decree also intended to harm you."

Fan Changyu still remembered that eunuch, the one whose gaze had made her skin crawl.

But hearing Xie Zheng himself mention his decreed marriage to the Eldest Princess, and that the Eldest Princess had also passed on such an important message tonight, she felt a subtle and complex emotion in her heart that she couldn't quite identify.

She pressed her lips together slightly and asked, "Are you... very close with the Eldest Princess?"

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes lifted slightly. Hearing what she was really asking, he pinched her cheek. "Not at all. Gongsun Yin is the one who has a past with her. I had to rely on him to get the Eldest Princess to help investigate the matter of the Sixteenth Prince in the palace."

Fan Changyu coughed lightly. "No wonder when I met Gongsun in Jizhou, he said he was on an errand for you. Was it this?"

"No," Xie Zheng said.

The confusion in Fan Changyu's eyes deepened. "Then what was it? Gongsun was so secretive about it at the time, saying he couldn't tell me yet."

Xie Zheng's palm gently caressed the scars on her shoulder and arm. "I really can't tell you yet. You'll know when he comes to the capital."

The more he kept her in suspense, the more curious Fan Changyu became. "Gongsun is coming to the capital later?"

Xie Zheng's calloused palm rubbed its way up her arm. When it touched the bloody bite mark he had viciously left on her before the tomb, he suddenly pressed down hard.

Fan Changyu hissed softly and looked up, meeting his dark, heavy gaze.

"Are you sure you want to talk about other men with me at a time like this?"

Fan Changyu wanted to glare at him, but she was momentarily captivated by his intensely aggressive stare. He took her hand and, through her soaked underpants, pressed it down.

Fan Changyu's face instantly turned completely red.

He had been out of the bath for too long, and his underpants were cold, but the heat underneath was still scorching enough to nearly burn her hand.

Fan Changyu was half shy, half embarrassed. Her mind felt like an overturned pot of paste. She somehow managed to ask, "You only take off your top when you bathe?"

Earlier, afraid of seeing something she shouldn't, she hadn't dared to glance at his lower body at all. Later, dazed from his kisses, she had paid even less attention. It was only now, due to his brazen act, that she realized he was only bare-chested.

Xie Zheng was also taken aback by her ill-timed question. He then explained, "It's a habit from over the years. An assassin doesn't care if you're bathing when they want to take your life. In the early years, I always kept a dagger strapped to my leg, never taking it off."

Fan Changyu remembered when she was fighting in Chongzhou, she had run into him by the river during a nighttime stroll. He had been just as vigilant then.

He must have had a very hard life all these years.

She herself had faced death several times in the dozen or so battles she'd fought to quell rebellions. He had joined the army at a young age, facing the Northern Turks who were as ferocious as wolves and jackals. The dangers he had experienced were likely far greater, which was why he was so vigilant.

The more Fan Changyu thought about it, the heavier her heart felt. Not wanting him to sink into such thoughts as well, she changed the subject. "No wonder you asked me to bring your clothes in earlier..."

By now, Xie Zheng had mostly sobered up. Hearing her words, he just smiled. "You were so hesitant back then. Did you think I wanted to take advantage of you?"

Fan Changyu was a little mortified, but on the principle of never backing down, she glared back defiantly. "Who would know your bathing habits?"

But her earlobes were already bright red.

Xie Zheng stared at her earlobes. Just as he had seen them under the moonlight in the cemetery, they were as vibrant as firethorn berries under a blanket of white snow. Because the candlelight in the room was brighter, he could even see that the shell of her ear was also a tempting shade of pale pink.

His eyes darkened, and his voice grew heavy. "You weren't wrong. I'm always thinking about how to take advantage of you."

As he finished speaking, he leaned over and bit her earlobe.

Fan Changyu had just been stunned by his words, and in the next instant, she let out a low "Ah!"

Her earlobe was both pained and numb. His hot breath fanned across the shell of her ear, a ticklish sensation like ants crawling over her skin. A strange feeling rose through her limbs, as if all her strength was being drained away between his teeth.

Her face was also burning hot; Fan Changyu felt like she was about to be cooked through.

She whispered, "Don't... don't bite..."

Her voice trembled uncontrollably by the end.

As she lost herself in a dazzling white light, he guided her hand out of the cold, damp underpants and inside.

...

When Fan Changyu washed her hands in the tub, using the water from his bath that had long since cooled, her face was still red.

Xie Zheng's breathing had yet to even out. His long, narrow phoenix eyes, usually indifferent and severe, now held a lustrous sheen of satisfaction. He quietly watched the slender, graceful figure not far away. She was in such a hurry to wash her hands that she hadn't even tied her sash properly.

The damp clothes, which he had rumpled, didn't fit well, revealing the pale nape of her neck and a small section of her shoulder and back. The ambiguous red marks scattered across her skin were particularly eye-catching, and her loose black hair falling over them added to the seductive scene.

His Adam's apple bobbed, his eyes dark. He walked straight over and swept her up into his arms.

Fan Changyu was stunned. Her body was suddenly airborne, and she could only instinctively cling to his firm, muscular shoulders. "You..."

Xie Zheng strode out of the clean room. Only when he pressed her down onto the bed in the outer room did he lower his head to kiss her swollen lips. His dark eyes were filled with an aggressive desire, as if he wished he could devour her whole. "It's still early. I was just afraid of hurting you before."

He took her hand and kissed it, then moved to let down the canopy hanging from the golden hooks. Lying in the bedding that carried his scent, Fan Changyu's heart pounded like a drum.

Her peripheral vision caught sight of the food on the round table. She quickly pressed a hand against his chest and said fiercely, "Go eat. If it's cold, have the kitchen heat it up again."

He still hadn't had dinner at this late hour.

Her hand was also sore, still feeling soft and weak.

Xie Zheng's gaze swept over the dishes on the table, and he suddenly asked her, "Have you eaten?"

Fan Changyu wanted to stubbornly say that she had, but her stomach rumbled at the inopportune moment.

Seeing her embarrassed yet prideful expression, Xie Zheng's eyes softened. He chuckled, got up, and pulled her up as well. "Why didn't you eat first?"

Fan Changyu mumbled, "Who knew it would take so long just to come and call you for dinner..."

Xie Zheng suddenly laughed. "I'll take that as a compliment."

Fan Changyu froze. When she realized what he meant, her face shamelessly turned red again, and she could only glare at him resentfully.

Her hair was a mess, and in her current disheveled state, combined with that expression, she looked quite like a little leopard baring its fangs and claws.

Xie Zheng's long eyes darkened slightly. Any look she gave him now was like a hook tugging at his heart. He couldn't resist, pressing her down and kissing her until he'd had his fill before letting go. He said in a hoarse voice, "Don't provoke me."

Her dress was already half-damp. Xie Zheng found a set of his own clothes from a trunk for her. "There are no women's clothes in the villa. Make do with this for now."

Although the two of them had already been almost completely honest with each other in the clean room, that was in a moment of uncontrollable passion. Now, being asked to change in front of him, Fan Changyu still felt embarrassed.

She took the clothes to the clean room. As she changed, she caught sight of the red marks on her body and the faint, lingering scent of photinia in the air. Thinking of all the things he had done while pressing her against the long table, his suppressed gasps seeming to echo in her ears, her face instantly became hot enough to fry an egg.

She had helped him on the night he arrived in the capital, too...

Was it because she had woken up to find him already gone that time, so it wasn't as embarrassing?

Fan Changyu covered her face with her damp clothes for a while. Once she was sure her face was no longer burning, she changed into the clothes Xie Zheng had found for her.

He looked lean, but his clothes were several sizes too big for her. After Fan Changyu put them on, the sleeves were as long as those of an opera singer on stage. She had to roll up the cuffs and pant legs to avoid tripping.

When she came out, Xie Zheng had already put on an outer robe and lit a brazier. The dishes on the table, which had gone cold, were placed on a small iron table and were being warmed over the brazier.

"It'll be ready to eat after warming for a bit..."

Xie Zheng's words trailed off as his gaze swept over to her and suddenly stopped.

His clothes were too big for her. The rolled-up sleeves and pant legs only accentuated how slender her wrists and ankles were. Her cheeks still held a faint pink blush, like peach blossoms blooming on a branch in March. A

few sweat-dampened strands of hair clung to her cheeks, and her almond eyes, as if washed by water, looked at him uneasily, like a small animal that had wandered into a hunting ground.

Fan Changyu tugged at her sleeve, saying awkwardly, "The clothes are a bit big."

Xie Zheng's hand, holding the silver-wrapped Ebony Chopsticks, tightened. He used every ounce of his self-control to tear his gaze away from her and lowered his eyes to continue arranging the chopsticks.

He said, "Make do for now. I'll dry your clothes in a bit."

What he was thinking was, From now on, there's no need to prepare her undergarments. She can just wear mine.

It would be best if she was his, from the inside out.

Fan Changyu was completely unaware of these thoughts. She just found it a little strange that Xie Zheng barely looked at her throughout the meal. Other than placing food in her bowl, he didn't speak. But thinking about what had happened in the clean room, she herself still felt awkward, so she didn't think much of it.

During the meal, Xie Zheng only asked one question: "Did Xie Zhong have you bring the food?"

Afraid he would blame the old man, Fan Changyu said, "I heard you order someone to take the food back, so I volunteered to bring it to you."

Xie Zheng gave a faint "en" and said no more.

The meal prepared for Xie Zheng was already a large portion, and it was late at night. Shared between the two of them, it was just enough to finish without being too full.

After dinner, Xie Zheng cleared the small table and went to the clean room to get Fan Changyu's damp dress, placing it over the brazier to dry.

Fan Changyu watched him do these things with a practiced ease, remembering that time by the river in Chongzhou when he had sat by the fire just like this, drying her soaked clothes for her. The memory overlapped with the scene before her, and a warmth spread through her chest, something so intense it felt like it was about to overflow.

She scratched her head, a little embarrassed. "Um... I can dry it myself."

Xie Zheng didn't even lift his eyelids, only saying, "If you're tired, go lie down on the bed for a while. I'll call you when the clothes are dry."

Perhaps because she had done something naughty, Fan Changyu wasn't sleepy at all now; she felt unusually energetic. It was just the lingering awkwardness that made her squat by the brazier, not knowing where to put her hands and feet.

Xie Zheng seemed to notice her discomfort and said, "There are some military treatises on the bookshelf. They're all ones I've been reading recently. You can take a look."

Just sitting there together in silence wasn't a solution. Reading military books was indeed a good way to pass the time.

Fan Changyu immediately went to the bookshelf, picked up a volume, and sat down opposite Xie Zheng to read. The military books he read were much more obscure and difficult to understand than the ones she had read. Even with his annotations, she had to ask several questions about a single page before she could move on.

Xie Zheng's talent in military strategy was truly heaven-sent. When he explained the obscure concepts, Fan Changyu didn't feel the slightest bit of the confusion she had felt when listening to the tutors she had hired at great expense. She understood everything easily.

To help her understand some historical battles, Xie Zheng even took out several maps for her to compare the terrain.

What had started as a way to avoid awkwardness turned into Fan Changyu completely immersing herself in the military treatise.

When Xie Zheng finished drying her dress and told her to go change in the clean room, she even held him back to ask two more questions before she went.

After changing back into her own dress, Fan Changyu had just picked up the military book again when Xie Zheng went out to call someone to clear the dishes.

Seeing Fan Changyu sitting by the low table reading, with several rolled-up maps and one spread open on the floor, the servant assumed that their Marquis was discussing important military defense matters with the General of the Cloud Banner. They tiptoed in, collected the bowls and chopsticks, and exited the room.

Only then did Xie Zheng say to Fan Changyu, "Where did Xie Zhong arrange for you to stay? I'll walk you over."

Fan Changyu was slightly taken aback. She looked up from the book and said, "The east wing."

His current calm demeanor was a world away from the man in the clean room who had looked like he wanted to swallow her whole. Fan Changyu just felt a strange feeling in her heart.

She saw Xie Zheng stand up, so she followed suit. Just as she reached the door, she was suddenly pinned against the door panel again, her chin seized as he kissed her.

When they parted, Xie Zheng was breathing heavily. He said to her, "I want you to stay, too. But my A Yu will one day be the Marquise of the manor and command the three armies. I must go through the three letters and six rites to marry you, so as not to dishonor you."

He had been drinking earlier, and his passion had been ignited by her words.

But he had completely calmed down during dinner. Xie Zhong had sent her to deliver the meal. If she didn't leave his room tonight, any discerning person would know what had happened.

Even though everyone in this villa was a trusted subordinate willing to die for him, Xie Zheng didn't want them to think that Fan Changyu had simply spent the night in his room like that.

In matters of the heart, she appeared cautious, considering everything before giving her heart away.

But once she truly gave her heart, she didn't care one bit for worldly customs and etiquette.

She had given him her most sincere and passionate self. He could not help but cherish it for her.

His A Yu deserved the best of everything in this world.

Chapter 140

Fan Changyu was stunned for a good while after hearing his words.

Then, she suddenly cupped his face, stood on her tiptoes, and gave him a quick peck on the lips.

Before Xie Zheng could react, she yanked the door open and bounded a few steps away. Only then did she turn back in the dim yellow halo of the lantern under the eaves, her face taut as she forced a calm expression. "Um... I can go back by myself, you don't have to see me out. It's getting late, you should get some rest too."

Without waiting for Xie Zheng's reply, she turned and walked down a small path.

Xie Zheng raised a hand to touch his lips, still somewhat dazed.

With her back to him, he couldn't see the crimson blush covering her face, only the tips of her ears, which glowed a faint pink in the moonlight.

He called out, "Changyu."

Fan Changyu didn't turn her head. She simply raised a hand and waved it, her back still to him. "I said you don't need to see me out. I'll be there in a few more steps."

He tugged his lips into a slight smile and said faintly, "You're going the wrong way. That's the way to the kitchen."

Fan Changyu stumbled and nearly fell.

The air was silent for several breaths before she turned around, walked toward another path with a composed expression, and explained matter-of-factly, "It's too dark. I couldn't see the path clearly."

As she continued walking, she heard a very soft chuckle from Xie Zheng behind her.

Fan Changyu ignored him. She was half annoyed and half embarrassed by her own foolishness. For some reason, her heart was also pounding particularly fast, as if a small deer was trapped inside.

She trudged back to the east wing with her head down. The Blood-Clad Cavalry on night watch at the manor saw her return and immediately brought her hot water to wash up.

After a simple wash, Fan Changyu collapsed onto the bed. Staring at the dark canopy, she recalled the embarrassing incident on her way back and silently pulled the quilt over, covering her head completely.

How could she have made such a fool of herself?

Yet her heart was still thumping wildly. She was mortified, but at the same time, she was enveloped in an indescribable joy.

Perhaps she really was too slow when it came to matters of the heart, or perhaps she had simply had too much on her mind before. Now that everything was out in the open this night, she finally realized that liking Xie Zheng seemed to be an extremely joyful thing.

Just thinking of him made the corners of her lips want to curl up inexplicably.

It got stuffy after being under the covers for too long, and she was just about to poke her head out for some air.

Just then, the window made a soft sound. Fan Changyu was instantly on alert, her hand reaching for the boning knife hidden under her pillow.

A small section of the bed beside her dipped, and Xie Zheng's crisp, cool voice was especially clear in the darkness. "Asleep?"

Fan Changyu released her grip on the knife's handle and poked her head out from under the quilt.

Her hair was mussed, with a few strands sticking up. Her eyes were clear, and her face was flushed from being under the covers for too long. She had a certain charmingly naive air about her. "Why are you here?"

Xie Zheng lay down directly, still fully clothed. A large hand reached under the brocade quilt, wrapped around her waist, and pulled her into his embrace. "Don't worry, no one saw me come over. I'll go back before dawn."

Fan Changyu was slightly taken aback. "Aren't you afraid of the trouble..."

Xie Zheng's firm chest was pressed against her back. He lowered his head, inhaling the faint fragrance of her hair, and said, "It's no trouble."

His breath fanned across the nape of her neck, making her feel a little itchy. She tried to dodge, but Xie Zheng pulled her back into his embrace. After that, however, he was extremely well-behaved, as if he had truly come over just to hold her and sleep.

Fan Changyu had intended to let him be, but after being held like this for a while, she felt something pressing against her from behind. Her expression changed, and she couldn't help but say, "You... why don't you go back to your own room to sleep?"

Xie Zheng held her without moving. When he replied, his voice was deep and husky. "Don't talk. Sleep."

Fan Changyu detected the note of restraint in his voice and didn't dare to move or speak again. She lay there in his arms, feeling like she was sitting on pins and needles. After a while, she must have been truly exhausted, as her breathing gradually evened out.

Listening to her steady breathing, Xie Zheng opened his eyes and gazed at her sleeping face in the darkness. After watching her quietly for a moment, he lowered his head and caught a piece of soft flesh on her neck, grinding it gently with his teeth. He sucked a red mark onto her skin before letting go.

He pressed her more tightly into his embrace, adjusted his position slightly, rested his chin in the hollow of her shoulder, and also closed his eyes, falling into a deep sleep.

When Fan Changyu woke up the next day, Xie Zheng was, as expected, already gone.

After washing up, she went to the front hall to have breakfast with Xie Zheng. It was about time for Xie Zheng to prepare for his "return to the capital." After her talk with Zhu Youchang yesterday, Fan Changyu also wanted to go to the prison to interrogate those loyal servants of the Sui family who had been escorted to the capital, to see if she could get any useful information out of them.

Zhu Youchang was keen to see Changning now that he knew she was also in the capital. But the current situation was unclear. To avoid exposing the manor's location and attracting more of Wei Yan's assassins, it was best to wait until Wei Yan's conviction was settled before arranging a meeting.

A carriage to take Fan Changyu back was already prepared outside the manor. She had arrived empty-handed, but on her return, Xie Zheng gave

her all the annotated military strategy books and several maps from his room.

Fan Changyu didn't refuse and accepted them all with a clear conscience.

Xie Zheng still had to arrange the many details of his "return to the capital." He had to submit a memorial to the young emperor announcing his return, and then lead his army past the Zhengyang Gate. Only then could he appear in the capital in a legitimate and official capacity.

Thus, it was Xie Shiyi who ended up escorting Fan Changyu back.

She had already settled into the carriage when the heavy curtain was suddenly lifted.

Today was a rare day of fine weather. Xie Zheng held the curtain open with one hand, pressing it against the side of the carriage door. The warm sunlight fell on his dark eyelashes, making his stern face look much gentler.

He looked at Fan Changyu and said, "Take these military books back and read them slowly. If there's anything you don't understand, write it down on a piece of paper and ask me next time."

The stack of books rested on Fan Changyu's lap. The one on top was still open, a clear sign that she had started reading the moment she got into the carriage.

She nodded, glanced at Xie Zheng, then her gaze fell back to the open page of the book.

When she was focused on something, she exuded an earnest silliness that was inexplicably endearing. The sunlight shining in from the carriage door was a bit glaring, so her long lashes were half-lowered, forming a fluffy shadow. Her swollen lips looked even fuller.

Xie Zheng looked at her, his long eyes narrowing slightly. He suddenly said, "Is there something you don't understand already? Let me see."

With that, he dropped the curtain and stepped inside.

Fan Changyu stared at him, completely stunned. Since the carriage was right at the manor's entrance, the slightest noise would attract the attention of the guards at the gate. When Xie Zheng pressed the back of

her head and kissed her, she was so startled she didn't dare struggle in the slightest.

When the kiss ended, Xie Zheng glanced at the open military book on her lap. His breathing had yet to steady, but his tone was as crisp and cool as ever, betraying no abnormality. "The highest form of generalship is to balk the enemy's plans; the next best is to prevent the junction of the enemy's forces; the next in order is to fight the enemy's army in the field; and the worst policy of all is to besiege walled cities. To subdue the enemy without fighting is the acme of skill. Therefore, the art of war is to attack the mind."^①

Fan Changyu listened to his sanctimonious summary of the page's strategy, panting slightly as she continued to glare at him.

Her hands were already clenched into fists, but thinking of Zhu Youchang and the others just outside, she ultimately held back.

It was the first time she knew that this man could be so shameless!

Xie Zheng seemed to read her thoughts in her wide, almond-shaped eyes. He tugged his lips into a silent smile, leaned in to kiss her on the lips again, and then said in a low voice, "I'm going."

After Xie Zheng jumped out of the carriage, Xie Shiyi, who had been stroking a horse's mane and checking the reins up front, mounted the driver's seat.

Zhu Youchang, in his wheelchair, was pushed out of the main gate by a Blood-Clad Cavalryman to see Fan Changyu off.

As the carriage drove away, Xie Zheng also mounted his horse and left the manor with several Blood-Clad Cavalrymen to rendezvous with the second wave of the returning army, creating the illusion that he had "just" returned from the northern territories.

Zhu Youchang said with immense gratification, "If the old general knew that his niece Changyu had attained the position of a third-rank official and earned the Marquis's high regard, and that the Meng family could continue to serve the Xie clan loyally, he would be able to smile when he meets General Xie in the netherworld."

Xie Zhong watched the carriage and the horses depart in opposite directions, one south and one north, without a word.

His Marquis's feelings for the General of the Cloud Banner were likely not as simple as mere camaraderie...

Fan Changyu had often been in military camps before, so Aunt Zhao, her husband, and Changning were already used to her being away from home for days at a time.

She had also given instructions to Xie Qi when she left the Office of Presentations yesterday. So when she returned, the old couple and Changning assumed she had been away on some official business and weren't overly worried.

Changning even excitedly held up a rabbit in a woven bamboo basket for her to see. "Big Sis, Big Sis, look at Ning Niang's little rabbit!"

Fan Changyu had previously told Changning not to keep pets, fearing it would be troublesome when they eventually left the capital. But now that the rabbit was already here, she didn't scold her. She just smiled and said, "Did you beg your Uncle Xiao Qi to win this for you, or your Uncle Xiao Wu?"

Changning's large, grape-like eyes shone brightly. She said gleefully, "Bao'er won it for me!"

Fan Changyu was surprised. "Bao'er knows how to play pitch-pot?"

That child wasn't much older than Changning and usually seemed so quiet and well-mannered. He had a good memory for reciting poems and books, but when it came to boisterousness, he wasn't even as playful as Changning.

Xie Wu, who had accompanied Yu Bao'er out yesterday, answered with a smile, "The young master spent the whole afternoon at the vendor's stall playing pitch-pot. He nearly pawned his jade pendant to the vendor, but he finally made a shot. The vendor was so happy he even threw in a rabbit lantern."

So Yu Bao'er had gone out yesterday to be a god of wealth for someone. Fan Changyu didn't know whether to laugh or cry.

She looked at Yu Bao'er, who was standing to the side with his lips pressed together, and crouched down to his level. "When Auntie has time, I'll take you back to that vendor and win back everything on his stall!"

Changning got excited at these words and clapped her hands happily. "Win everything back! Then Ning Niang will set up a stall too, and have

people play pitch-pot!"

Fan Changyu couldn't help but laugh, pinching her soft, chubby cheek. "Is Ning Niang a little money-grubber now? You already know how to make money?"

Changning glanced guiltily at Yu Bao'er and wrung her fingers. "Bao'er spent all his money playing pitch-pot. I'm his little aunt, I have to earn money to give back to him."

This made both Aunt Zhao and Uncle Zhao laugh.

Aunt Zhao praised, "Our Ning Niang is finally acting like a little aunt."

Praised, Changning's eyes narrowed into slits, her lips curled up, and she even puffed out her little chest.

Only Yu Bao'er glanced at Changning, seeming a little unhappy.

After checking on the two little ones, Fan Changyu went back to her room to put away the military books Xie Zheng had given her. Yu Bao'er, however, followed her like a little tail. "Auntie Changyu."

He clenched his fists, hesitating to speak.

Fan Changyu asked, "What is it, Bao'er?"

Yu Bao'er looked at her and said, "I want to learn martial arts."

This question gave Fan Changyu a small headache. Yu Bao'er's status was noble; the hardships of learning martial arts were many, and tumbles and falls were common.

She said, "Learning martial arts is very hard. Why does Bao'er suddenly want to learn?"

Yu Bao'er lowered his long lashes, pressing his lips together without a word. After a long while, he said, "I just want to learn. If I become as strong as Auntie Changyu, I can protect my mother in the future."

The day the imperial grandson's men came to seize Yu Qianqian and her son had, after all, left a considerable shadow in Yu Bao'er's heart.

Hearing him say this, Fan Changyu's expression also turned serious.

She said, "Learning martial arts is hard, but the most valuable part is perseverance. Studying is like rowing a boat upstream; if you don't advance, you fall back. The same goes for martial arts. How about this: I'll

teach you the fundamentals first. If you can endure the hardship and stick with it, I'll teach you other things later."

Yu Bao'er nodded vigorously. "Okay."

Changning, who had been eavesdropping from who-knows-where, suddenly popped out. "Ning Niang wants to learn too! In the future, I'll flatten a bad guy with one punch and knock out a pig with one slap!"

As she spoke, she even brandished her little fists.

Hearing her still remember her old pig-slaughtering days, Fan Changyu couldn't help but press a hand to her forehead.

She said, "Your health isn't good, don't join in this nonsense."

Changning had a wheezing disease and used to have trouble breathing from time to time.

When their mother was pregnant with Fan Changyu, she had experienced the Jizhou incident. Rescued by their father, she had fled all the way to Jizhou, suffering injuries along the way. It was only because Fan Changyu was tough in the womb that she was born without mishap.

But their mother's health never improved despite years of recuperation. It wasn't until Fan Changyu was almost ten that she had Changning. Because the mother was weak, Changning was born small and frail, and with a congenital wheezing disease. Truly, from the moment she started eating solid food, she was constantly taking medicine.

When she was little, they fed her goat's milk, but she hated the gamy taste and refused to drink it. It was Fan Changyu who secretly mixed some sugar into it to coax her to drink.

After Fan Changyu joined the army and earned money, she never stopped paying for Changning's medicine.

When Changning heard Fan Changyu's refusal, she anxiously ran over, grabbing her sleeve and shaking it. "No, no, Ning Niang wants to learn."

Perhaps afraid that Fan Changyu would still disagree, her eyes reddened, and her voice became nasal, as if she was about to cry from grievance at any moment.

Fan Changyu's heart softened. She bent down and stroked Changning's head. "Be good, Ning Niang. Big Sis will find the best physician in the

capital to treat you. If the physician examines you and says you can learn martial arts, then Big Sis will teach you, okay?"

Only then did Changning nod with a wronged expression.

After meeting Zhu Youchang, Fan Changyu now had a lead on investigating Wei Yan and was buried in tasks. But finding a physician for Changning was equally urgent. That very afternoon, she had Xie Wu go out and inquire about famous physicians in the capital.

Fan Changyu went to busy herself. Yu Bao'er looked at the still-unhappy Changning and said, "It's okay if you can't learn martial arts. I'll protect you in the future."

Changning's face puffed up with anger. She said sullenly, "No."

Yu Bao'er asked, "Why not?"

Changning fiddled with the pearl buttons on her clothes with her chubby fingers and said awkwardly, "Then you'll be stronger than me. I'll never be able to beat you."

Yu Bao'er said, "Then in the future, when you hit me, I won't hit back."

Changning's round eyes slanted a glance at him. "Really?"

Yu Bao'er nodded. "Really."

Only then did Changning's lips curl up uncontrollably. She extended her fair, plump little finger. "Then let's pinky-swear. If you go back on your word, you're a little dog."

Yu Bao'er extended his little finger and hooked it with hers, saying solemnly, "Okay, it's a pinky promise."

The Imperial Palace.

Qi Sheng stared at the memorial that had just been delivered to the palace this morning, pacing anxiously around the hall. "Xie Zheng is about to return to the capital, and Wei Yan still hasn't told me what his counter-strategy is for these impeachments against the Li faction..."

His eyes were bloodshot with fury, and he kicked the Dragon Desk. "If Xie Zheng also sides with that old scoundrel from the Li family and the descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince, doesn't his return this time mean he's coming to kick me off this dragon throne?"

"I have to think of a way, think of a way..."

The newly appointed chief eunuch was a slick character. He immediately said fawningly, "Your Majesty, do not worry. The Wu'an Marquis holds great military power. If he truly defects to that descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince, whose authenticity is unknown, it's only to overthrow Wei Yan. Whatever the Chengde Crown Prince's descendant can promise him after usurping the throne, you can promise the Wu'an Marquis right now. As long as the Wu'an Marquis is willing to lend Your Majesty a hand, first to deal with the Li family, then to topple Wei Yan, and you give him the position originally reserved for Wei Yan, it's far better than him having to share power with the Li family after helping the Chengde Crown Prince's descendant."

Ever since Xie Zheng defied the imperial edict and cut off the ear of the eunuch who delivered it, Qi Sheng had held a grudge for this contempt of imperial authority.

He was a thousand, ten thousand times unwilling to let Xie Zheng take Wei Yan's position. But now, it was clear that Wei Yan was no match for the Li family. Qi Sheng was beginning to waver in his belief that Wei Yan could help him keep his throne.

His slightly bulging eyes stared deadly at the eunuch. "I am already on such bad terms with him. Can you think of a way for me to win him over?"

This question stumped the eunuch. Faced with Qi Sheng's man-eating gaze, he could only force a fawning smile and say, "Well, for men, what can be used to win them over but power, treasures, and beauties?"

Saying this was the same as saying nothing.

Qi Sheng, however, sat back down on the dragon throne. Propping his head with one hand, his slightly protruding eyes were webbed with blood vessels. "Beauties? I tried to decree a marriage between him and my Imperial Sister. How did he treat me then?"

The eunuch's eyes darted. He suddenly said, "The Eldest Princess seems to be in contact with the Wu'an Marquis..."

Qi Sheng's eyelids shot up, and he sneered, "He, Xie Zheng, rejected my decreed marriage, yet turns around and communicates with my Imperial Sister. What is he trying to do? Imperial Sister has also disappointed me greatly. I treat her so well, yet she's also looking for a way out for herself?"

His gaze turned cold as he suddenly looked at the eunuch. "And how did you come to know this?"

The eunuch's legs went weak, and he dropped to his knees. "This slave wouldn't dare deceive Your Majesty. This slave has a godson who formed a eunuch-maid pairing with a palace maid in the Eldest Princess's palace. It was that maid who, when she went in to pour tea, unintentionally overheard the Eldest Princess instructing her trusted eunuch to ensure a letter was delivered into the hands of the Wu'an Marquis's men."

Qi Sheng's fingers began to scratch at the armrest of the dragon throne, one tap at a time. The sound of his nails against the metal was particularly grating. "What has Imperial Sister been up to recently?"

The eunuch surreptitiously sized up Qi Sheng and said in a pinched voice, "This slave has heard that people from the Eldest Princess's palace have been frequently visiting the Cold Palace recently, and have gotten quite close to a deranged palace maid from the late Jia Guifei's palace..."

Qi Sheng's fingers dug harder into the armrest. His neatly trimmed nails were ground into jagged notches by the carved reliefs. He murmured, "She's helping Xie Zheng investigate the matter of the Sixteenth Imperial Brother... Why is Xie Zheng investigating the Sixteenth Imperial Brother?"

A piece of his fingernail, unable to bear the pressure, broke off.

This minor pain also caused Qi Sheng, who had been lost in his own thoughts, to abruptly raise his head.

His slightly bulging eyes shone with a terrifying light. The eunuch felt goosebumps rise all over his skin under that gaze.

Qi Sheng spread his lips into a smile, his expression holding a strange excitement. He stared sinisterly at the chief eunuch. "Go, bring that mad palace maid from the Cold Palace to me. Be clean about it. Don't let my Imperial Sister's side hear any wind of this."

Chapter 141

The carved wooden door creaked open, and sunlight poured into the hall through the open doorway and tall latticed windows. Wispy incense smoke rose lazily from the Boshan censer, drifting leisurely through the air.

Princess Qi Zhu, dressed in an elaborate dark blue palace gown, stepped into the small Buddhist chapel set up in her mother's quarters.

Her hair was piled high in an elaborate coiffure adorned with jeweled hairpins, her upturned eyes alluring yet faintly arrogant. Her crimson lips were striking, and a pale blue gauze shawl draped gracefully around her slender waist and arms. Every movement she made exuded charm and elegance.

The most opulent peony of Great Yin, she truly lived up to the title of "a beauty that puts flowers to shame."

At the center of the chapel stood a foot-tall white jade Guanyin statue. Judging by its warm, lustrous sheen, it had been meticulously carved from a single piece of premium mutton-fat jade—undoubtedly priceless.

Qi Zhu gazed at the beautiful woman kneeling on a cushion with her back turned, clad in sandalwood-colored monastic robes, and spoke haughtily, "Mother summoned me. For what purpose?"

An Taifei continued silently reciting Buddhist scriptures, her fingers moving over the prayer beads strung alternately with white jade and jadeite, offering no reply.

The chapel was filled with the heavy, ancient scent of Great Treasury Incense—a fragrance Qi Zhu disliked.

Seeing that her mother had called her here only to leave her standing idly by, Qi Zhu frowned. Usually, her mother treated her this way only when she had done something wrong.

Thinking of the matter she had recently been investigating at Gongsun Yin's request, her clasped hands tightened slightly. But her pride as a princess quickly masked that flicker of unease.

An Taifei finally finished reciting the scripture, rose, and lit a stick of incense before the Guanyin statue before speaking unhurriedly, "What have you been occupied with lately?"

Qi Zhu maintained her composure. "Learning the qin under Qin Shangyi of the Directorate of Music. In my spare time, I've also copied some Buddhist scriptures for you."

An Taifei settled onto a reclining chair, the circle of alternating jade and white jade beads in her hand. She lifted her eyelids slightly, her gaze sweeping over her daughter. "Is that all?"

Mother and daughter shared about half their features in common, but their alluring eyes were identical—though time had etched fine wrinkles at the corners of An Taifei's.

Qi Zhu had been spoiled since childhood and had always been strong-willed. She met her mother's gaze. "If you don't believe me, Mother, why bother asking?"

Hearing her daughter's fiery retort, An Taifei's brow furrowed slightly, and she shook her head with a faint sigh.

She asked, "Why have people from your palace been frequently visiting the Cold Palace lately?"

Qi Zhu's eyelashes fluttered nervously—a telltale sign of guilt—but she stubbornly insisted, "I—I have dozens of maids and eunuchs in my palace. How could I possibly know what they do in private?"

An Taifei's expression darkened completely. "Zhu'er!" she called sharply.

Even the willful Qi Zhu felt a pang of fear when her mother was truly angry. Yet she dared not confess her collaboration with Xie Zheng.

An Taifei was aware that the emperor had arranged a marriage between her and Xie Zheng. But Xie Zheng hadn't even allowed the decree to be read—he had sliced off one of the eunuch's ears in defiance. Such arrogance was beyond measure.

Though few knew of the incident, Xie Zheng's refusal to obey the imperial decree and his contempt for imperial authority had not only humiliated Qi Sheng but also Qi Zhu herself. An Taifei harbored strong disapproval of Xie Zheng.

Secretly, Qi Zhu was delighted. She had been the one to discreetly pass the news to Xie Zheng in the first place. But fearing her mother's reprimand for meddling in court affairs, she had kept silent.

Facing An Taifei, who was visibly suppressing her anger, Qi Zhu carefully weighed her words before speaking: "Someone from my palace happened to discover a former palace maid from Jia Guitaifei's quarters in the Cold Palace. Taking pity on her madness, they offered assistance once or twice, only to hear an astonishing revelation from that deranged woman."

An Taifei's fingers, which had been moving her prayer beads, froze at the mention of a surviving maid from Jia Guitaifei's palace in the Cold Palace, her expression shifting unnaturally.

Qi Zhu cautiously observed her mother's reaction before continuing: "That madwoman claimed that Chancellor Wei Yan once... once defiled the imperial harem, engaging in illicit relations with imperial consorts..."

With a sharp snap, the prayer beads in An Taifei's hands broke apart, scattering pale jade beads across the floor.

"Who else knows of this?"

An Taifei stood abruptly, her voice sharp as she interrogated Qi Zhu, her face twisted with unprecedented severity.

Startled by her mother's rare outburst, Qi Zhu quickly calculated her response: "The matter is far too grave. That maid might simply be spouting nonsense in her madness, and she didn't specify which of Father's consorts was involved with Chancellor Wei. How could I dare speak of this recklessly to others?"

Only then did An Taifei sink back into her chaise lounge, exhaustion evident as she said, "Let this matter rest. Do not pursue it further, and pretend you never heard those mad ramblings."

Qi Zhu found her mother's reaction peculiar and pressed further: "Why? If Wei Yan truly dared commit such treason, this crime alone would warrant exterminating his entire clan and reclaiming imperial power from his grasp."

Though the Great Yin dynasty still bore the Qi surname—making her forever its most noble princess—this nobility depended entirely on the strength of imperial authority.

Under Qi Sheng's reign, with imperial power hollowed out by Wei Yan, the entire royal family had been forced to live at the chancellor's mercy.

An Taifei responded to her daughter's words with a bitter laugh: "Exterminate Wei Yan's clan? If that were possible, the steps of Taiqian Palace wouldn't have run red with blood seventeen years ago."

Taiqian Palace had always served as the imperial bedchamber.

Qi Zhu's alluring eyes widened suddenly: "Wei Yan attempted a coup?"

A chill ran through her limbs: "Then Father... didn't die of illness?"

An Taifei offered no answer, instead kneeling before a Guanyin statue with pressed palms, murmuring: "Ask no more, investigate no further. It was by shutting my palace gates and turning a blind eye that I became the only survivor among the four consorts."

Royal pride stirred within Qi Zhu as she coldly challenged: "Wei Yan has humiliated our house to this extent! Even if my brother proves incompetent, rumors persist that Crown Prince Chengde's line survives. With the Li family, the militarily powerful Wu'an Marquis, and Grandfather's faction—I refuse to believe we cannot overthrow Wei Yan!"

An Taifei lifted her eyelids: "Do you think Jia Guitaifei's family lacked influence? That Jia Min maintained imperial favor into middle age without powerful connections? The Sixteenth Prince nearly contested the throne itself. Yet look at the court today—can you find a single Jia clansman holding office above the fifth rank?"

A shiver crawled down Qi Zhu's spine as she whispered tremulously: "If Wei Yan's power stretches so far... why did he install my brother as emperor?"

Her expression shifted ominously: "Unless my brother is..."

An Taifei interrupted her: "Don't speculate wildly. Wei Yan is nothing but a rabid dog—who knows what schemes he's plotting? You're my only daughter. Stay away from the court's intrigues. As long as our mother-daughter pair and the An family remain uninvolved, we'll be safe."

But Qi Zhu looked at An Taifei and asked, "Mother, do you know which imperial consort had an affair with Wei Yan back then?"

Taiqian Palace.

Qi Sheng observed the trembling palace maid kneeling below the steps. Leaning his chin on one hand from the dragon throne, he asked with amusement, "What did the person who came to see you in the Cold Palace ask about?"

The maid was disheveled, her filthy palace attire stained with large patches of blood—clearly tortured by the eunuchs before being brought here. She no longer dared to feign madness now.

Trembling like a leaf under the gaze of the dragon-robed emperor, she stammered, "N-nothing, Your Majesty... They just took pity on this lowly one and gave me some food..."

Qi Sheng sneered. "You've been acting mad in the Cold Palace for over a decade. Why aren't you mad now?"

The maid shook even more violently, unable to form a reply.

The chief eunuch beside Qi Sheng immediately barked, "You wretched slave! One more lie to His Majesty, and you'll be dragged to the Meridian Gate for execution!"

Terrified, the maid paled and begged, "Spare me, Your Majesty! I... I only did this to survive."

Sobbing and shaking, she confessed, "All the servants who served in Jia Guitaifei's palace died back then. I'd made a mistake earlier and was punished with laundry duty—that's how I escaped. Afraid someone would discover I was the only survivor from her palace, I pretended to be mad and was sent to the Cold Palace to rot."

Though her account sounded sincere, Qi Sheng lounged carelessly in his throne as if uninterested. He ordered the chief eunuch, "Gag her. Another round of torture."

The maid kowtowed desperately, wailing, "Your Majesty, I swear it's the truth! Mmmph—"

Her pleas were cut short as burly eunuchs gagged her and pinned her limbs.

To avoid staining the palace floors, they opted for needles—inserting them under her fingernails.

The agony of ten fingers connected to the heart was unimaginable to those who'd never endured it.

In the palace, this method often proved more effective than flogging.

The first needle made her convulse violently, thrashing against the eunuchs' iron grip. A cotton gag muffled her screams, though she bit through it, blood soaking the cloth.

Qi Sheng gave no reprieve. The needles continued—second, third...

By the end, the maid lay limp, drenched in cold sweat, her needled fingers twitching reflexively. Only faint blood spots dotted the floor. Half-conscious, her lips matched her ashen face.

The chief eunuch fawned, "Your Majesty, the punishment is complete."

Qi Min observed the entire interrogation process. Unlike his earlier disinterest, he now seemed considerably more pleased. "Now answer Us—why were you feigning madness in the Cold Palace?"

The steel needles remained embedded between her fingernails. Under such excruciating pain, the palace maid couldn't think clearly and could only answer instinctively: "To... to protect myself."

Confirming she wasn't lying, Qi Sheng's eyes suddenly gleamed with an unsettling excitement: "Who possessed such capability to silence everyone in Jia Guitaifei's palace?"

Even after enduring pain akin to death, the maid trembled violently at this question, as if touching upon some forbidden truth. With extreme terror, she uttered the name: "It... it was Wei Yan."

The chief eunuch beside them was stunned. After a brief pause, a shadow crossed Qi Sheng's eyes as he pressed further: "Why would Wei Yan kill those in Jia Guitaifei's palace?"

The maid's voice shook uncontrollably: "Not just Jia Guitaifei's palace... everyone who knew about Wei Yan's... defilement of the imperial harem was killed by him."

This revelation struck like a thunderbolt, causing cold sweat to break out on the chief eunuch's forehead. He never imagined such an earth-shattering secret lay hidden within.

Qi Sheng's expression darkened. "You're saying Wei Yan defiled the imperial harem?"

The maid nodded fearfully.

Qi Sheng returned to his dragon throne, his face grim. "Continue the torture."

Having already used the steel needles, the chief eunuch ordered his subordinates to apply finger presses to the maid's hands and feet. Thin rods clamped down on each finger as two burly eunuchs pulled the ropes tight, crushing and even breaking the bones.

Held down by several eunuchs, the maid had no means to struggle. Her tears had long dried up, her teeth biting into the gag cloth had gone numb, and her mouth was filled with the taste of blood.

After this round of torture, the maid collapsed to the ground, unable to kneel any longer, only muttering weakly: "Spare this servant... I've told the truth..."

Qi Sheng remained silent, and the chief eunuch dared not speak without permission, cautiously observing the emperor's expression.

After the deaths of both the Chengde Crown Prince and the Sixteenth Prince at the hands of the Northern Turks, the Late Emperor fell ill and passed away. Wei Yan then seized control of the court, placing the powerless Qi Sheng on the throne.

Combined with the maid's claim that Wei Yan had defiled the imperial harem...

The chief eunuch didn't dare dwell on it further, fearing his own head might not remain on his shoulders after today.

Qi Sheng began unconsciously scratching the golden dragon carvings on the armrests with his nails, his bulging eyes appearing particularly sinister: "Who was the one who committed adultery with Wei Yan?"

The maid, her face deathly pale, confessed: "It... it was Shu Fei."

Qi Sheng suddenly exhaled in relief. Shu Fei was one of the four consorts. According to imperial records, like Jia Guitaifei, she had followed the Late Emperor in death after his passing.

His eyes once again gleamed with an indescribable excitement: "So Wei Yan killed Shu Fei to cover up his disgraceful deeds?"

"This servant doesn't know... Back then, Shu Fei was diagnosed with pregnancy, but the fetus's age didn't match the records in the Chamber of Palace Affairs... The Late Emperor was furious. He had the palace maids in

Shu Fei's quarters beaten to death and imprisoned Shu Fei for questioning. One night, Qingyuan Palace suddenly caught fire—the flames consumed everything, and Shu Fei perished in the blaze. That night, the Golden Guard on patrol... saw Wei Yan."

Qi Sheng sneered coldly, "What a thorough job of destroying both witnesses and evidence. Wei Yan truly is ruthless and cruel."

He fixed his gaze on the palace maid, "Did my imperial father just allow Wei Yan to act so lawlessly?"

The palace maid, her face ashen, replied, "The fire in Consort Shu's palace burned until dawn. By daybreak, Wei Yan led troops to massacre the palace. The late emperor and the noble imperial concubine both fell under Wei Yan's sword..."

Qi Sheng's facial muscles twitched with rage as he said icily, "Excellent. Wei Yan defiled the imperial harem, and when his crimes were exposed, he murdered the emperor to seize power, then slaughtered the palace to silence witnesses. Truly magnificent!"

He made a gesture, and the chief eunuch understood, instructing the junior eunuchs to escort the palace maid out.

When the chief eunuch returned, he cautiously observed Qi Sheng's expression and carefully said, "The Grand Princess is assisting Marquis Wu'an in investigating this matter, likely to overthrow Wei Yan. It's a pity we only have that maid's testimony without concrete evidence."

Qi Sheng suddenly laughed coldly, "I should thank Wei Yan. He's given me a perfect way to control Xie Zheng."

The chief eunuch looked puzzled, but Qi Sheng said no more.

Yet the plan in his heart made his bulging eyes gleam strangely: "The blade forged by Wei Yan will ultimately serve me."

Several days later, Xie Zheng led the triumphant northern expedition army through Zhengyang Gate.

Once again, the entire capital emptied as crowds thronged the main street from the northern city gate to Zhengyang Gate to welcome the victorious troops.

Having received advance notice, Fan Changyu had reserved three private rooms in a street-facing tavern days earlier, wanting to bring

Changning and Bao'er to see Xie Zheng's triumphant return.

As for why she booked three rooms—it started when Xie Wu mentioned concerns about eavesdroppers. Fan Changyu reasoned that if someone might listen through a wall, she could simply reserve the adjacent rooms on both sides.

When Xie Wu and Xie Qi heard her solution, they exchanged silent glances but found the logic sound, so they complied.

Though Aunt Zhao and her husband had been out on the streets recently, ordinary days couldn't compare to today's excitement. Looking down from the tavern window, the street below was packed with people.

Changning and Yu Bao'er, being small, couldn't reach the window without standing on stools to see below.

Worried Yu Bao'er might be spotted by the Crown Prince's men, Fan Changyu had prepared painted masks for both children. Finding them amusing, the two kept the masks on the entire time.

Since the army hadn't reached their section yet, only noisy chatter rose from below. After watching for a while and growing bored, Changning and Yu Bao'er sat at the round table to snack on the ordered pastries and dishes.

When deafening cheers erupted outside the window, the two children squeezed back to look. Aunt Zhao and her husband, also eager to see the spectacle, joined them at the window while keeping an eye on the children.

On their way, Changning had bought a basket of flower petals from a vendor.

Leaning out the window, thrilled by the crowd's enthusiastic cheers, she began scattering petals toward the approaching army.

When she clearly saw the handsome young general riding the tall warhorse, her eyes widened in recognition: "Brother-in-law?"

Tugging Yu Bao'er's sleeve excitedly, she cried, "Bao'er, look! That's my brother-in-law!"

Aunt Zhao and her husband, their eyesight weaker with age, squinted for a long moment before Aunt Zhao said, "That does look like Yan Zheng, doesn't it?"

Carpenter Zhao nodded in agreement, saying, "That's right, it's Yan Zheng."

Aunt Zhao turned around joyfully and said to Fan Changyu, "Changyu, come quick and look! Yan Zheng has made something of himself too. See, he's riding at the very front! How impressive! Has he earned himself a high-ranking position?"

Xie Wu and Xie Qi, upon hearing this, struggled to suppress faint smiles.

Thanks to her height advantage, Fan Changyu had a clear view of the entire street from the back.

She had indeed spotted Xie Zheng, clad in Qilin Shoulder Dark Light Armor, riding at the forefront of the army. But in front of Xie Wu and Xie Qi, she found herself at a loss for words in response to Aunt Zhao's question. She merely coughed twice and said, "He has indeed done well."

In all of Great Yin, no one of his generation had achieved more than he had.

As soon as she finished speaking, perhaps sensing the intense gazes from the tavern window, Xie Zheng suddenly looked up.

Meeting his gaze, Fan Changyu's eyelids twitched, and an inexplicable sense of guilt welled up inside her.

Chapter 142

Changning turned her head excitedly and tugged at Fan Changyu's sleeve, "Sister, is brother-in-law looking at us?"

She strained her voice to shout "Brother-in-law!" twice toward the street below, but the bustling crowd was roaring "Wu'an Marquis," completely drowning out her childish cries.

Just as the army was about to pass beneath the tavern, Xie Zheng gave a slight nod toward the upper floor—whether he'd heard Changning's shouts or was acknowledging Fan Changyu remained unclear.

Adjacent private rooms erupted in brief exclamations as a flurry of objects clattered down from their windows.

"Wu'an Marquis is looking at our young miss!"

"Nonsense! He was clearly nodding at our lady!"

The maidservants accompanying various young ladies argued fervently on their mistresses' behalf, tossing down the flower baskets they'd been holding in their excitement.

Great Yin's customs were liberal, and on such celebratory occasions, it was commonplace for unmarried maidens to throw flowers or handkerchiefs at returning troops. When Fan Changyu had entered the city with Tang Peiyi, she'd been pelted with numerous handkerchiefs herself.

Uncle Zhao and Aunt Zhao watched disapprovingly as young women from every floor showered Xie Zheng with handkerchiefs. "Yan Zheng was looking at us just now, wasn't he?" they grumbled.

Despite her age, Aunt Zhao leaned halfway out the window, shouting, "Yan Zheng! Yan Zheng! Changyu is here!"

Fan Changyu, embarrassed, tried to retreat but was seized by Aunt Zhao, who urged, "Quickly, throw him a handkerchief too!"

Flustered, Fan Changyu protested, "Auntie, perhaps I shouldn't—"

Aunt Zhao glared. "What's there to be shy about? That's your lawfully wedded husband down there. If other girls can throw him handkerchiefs, why can't you?" With that, she pushed Fan Changyu toward the window.

Changning clapped her hands gleefully. "Sister, throw one! Throw one!"

Fan Changyu sighed. "I don't have any handkerchiefs. In the army, I just use a large sweat cloth."

Aunt Zhao was momentarily speechless but persisted, "Well... do you have a sachet or something? Just toss anything down!"

Naturally, Fan Changyu didn't carry sachets either.

After a moment's thought, she untied the russet ribbon from her hair.

Holding the ribbon, Fan Changyu steeled herself and approached the window. Compared to the perfumed, intricately embroidered silk handkerchiefs the other young ladies had thrown, her plain ribbon seemed woefully inadequate—its coarse fabric so unremarkable that no one would bother picking it up if it fell in the street.

She was about to toss it perfunctorily when Xie Zheng suddenly looked up directly at her.

Their eyes met midair. Fan Changyu's heart skipped a beat, and the ribbon in her hand was momentarily forgotten.

Aunt Zhao fretted beside her. "Changyu, throw it! Yan Zheng is watching you!"

Snapping back to reality, Fan Changyu felt her heart pound so violently it might leap from her throat. Clenching her fist, she flung the ribbon downward with the determination of one marching to certain death.

Though her martial arts training ensured perfect aim, the lightweight ribbon caught a sudden gust of wind. Just as it seemed about to sail over Xie Zheng's head, the stern-faced young Marquis raised his hand and effortlessly caught the russet ribbon.

The watching crowd erupted in deafening cheers.

Along the way, countless young women had thrown handkerchiefs at him, and even those that landed right before him hadn't earned a second glance. For him to suddenly reach out and catch a hair ribbon was truly extraordinary.

Xie Zheng expressionlessly tucked the hair ribbon Fan Changyu had thrown into his robe, casting a brief glance in her direction before calmly focusing ahead as he continued riding.

The exclamations from the onlookers and young ladies grew even louder, with some even bursting into tears on the spot.

"Whose hair ribbon was that?"

"Could it be that the Wu'an Marquis has a sweetheart?"

The people lining both sides of the street craned their necks, trying to identify which private room in the tavern the ribbon had come from. But all they saw were three closed windows, making it impossible to tell which distinguished guest had thrown it.

All three private rooms had been reserved by Fan Changyu.

When Xie Zheng caught the ribbon and tucked it away while looking at her, Fan Changyu felt as if lightning had struck her chest. Her heartbeat raced so fast it frightened her, and her mind went momentarily numb.

Almost reflexively, she slammed the window shut and turned back to sit at the round table. Under Aunt Zhao's stunned gaze, her entire face flushed crimson from the neck up to the tips of her ears.

After a moment's pause, Aunt Zhao said with a mix of amusement and exasperation, "You silly girl, you've been married for so long—what are you still so shy about?"

Fan Changyu pinched her burning earlobes without speaking, only her long, dark lashes fluttering incessantly, as if still trembling from the shock.

Even Changning couldn't help laughing. "Sister is shy!"

Xie Wu and Xie Qi stood silently in the corner with their heads bowed, doing their best to blend into the walls.

It took quite a while before Fan Changyu recovered, the flush on her face fading slightly. She pinched Changning's chubby cheek and said, "Our Ning Niang has grown bold, teasing her elder sister now?"

With one cheek pinched by Fan Changyu, Changning's grin still stretched nearly to her other ear. "Big brother looked at you, and you got so scared you shut the window!"

The redness that had just begun to fade from Fan Changyu's face threatened to return at Changning's innocent remark. She put on a stern face. "You cheeky little thing! I closed the window because there were too many eyes around—it could have caused trouble."

Changning stuck out her tongue, not daring to push further.

Carpenter Zhao, still awed by the spectacle he had just witnessed, took a sip of tea before saying, "I heard so many people shouting 'Wu'an Marquis,' but I didn't see him. Is his entourage at the back of the army?"

The cries of the young women had been drowned out by the louder cheers, and with the capital's distinctive accent, Carpenter Zhao hadn't been able to make out much of what was said.

Unfamiliar with the order of precedence in military processions, he recalled that when Fan Changyu and the others had entered the capital, Tang Peiyi had been at the front. Logically, since the Wu'an Marquis held the highest rank, shouldn't he have been leading the procession? Why was Yan Zheng at the head instead?

The fame of the Wu'an Marquis had spread like thunder across Great Yin after he recaptured Jinzhou and reclaimed the twelve counties of Liaodong.

Carpenter Zhao had been eager to catch a glimpse of such a legendary general.

Fan Changyu silently wiped her face.

The moment had finally come...

She scratched her head awkwardly. "Well... Uncle, Auntie, there's something I haven't told you."

Aunt Zhao saw her troubled expression and immediately said, "Child, do you really see your uncle and me as outsiders? Whatever it is, just say it directly."

Fan Changyu looked at the elderly couple and said, "Actually, Yan Zheng is the Wu'an Marquis."

Carpenter Zhao's hand trembled, spilling half a cup of tea on himself. Ignoring the scalding heat, he hastily stood up, shaking his clothes, his aged eyes wide with shock as he stared at Fan Changyu: "What?"

Aunt Zhao's mouth also fell open, her gaze darting between Fan Changyu and Carpenter Zhao, too stunned to utter a word.

Fan Changyu had expected the elderly couple to be surprised upon learning Xie Zheng's true identity, but she hadn't anticipated they'd be this shocked.

Seeing their disbelief, as if doubting their own ears, she repeated: "Yan Zheng is the Wu'an Marquis."

"Good heavens above..."

Carpenter Zhao's legs gave way, and he slumped back into his armchair. Gulping, he asked, "You mean the Wu'an Marquis who reclaimed the twelve counties of Liaodong and slaughtered the barbarians in Jinzhou?"

Fan Changyu nodded.

Aunt Zhao stammered, "I... I heard the Wu'an Marquis has three heads and six arms, eating raw flesh and drinking blood. But Yan... Yan Zheng looks more like the leading actor in an opera troupe. How could he be the Wu'an Marquis?"

Hearing Aunt Zhao's description of what she imagined Xie Zheng to be, Fan Changyu couldn't help but feel both amused and exasperated.

She explained, "Those are just rumors. Generals on the battlefield need fearsome reputations to intimidate the enemy. Even I have been called the 'Ogre' in the army."

Despite Fan Changyu's explanation, the elderly couple needed quite some time to recover from the shock.

Aunt Zhao looked at Fan Changyu and asked, "So... now that Yan Zheng is a Marquis, do we have to kowtow when we see him?"

The question caught Fan Changyu off guard. Back when she was still in Lin'an Town, the first thing that would come to mind when meeting high-ranking officials would probably be how many kowtows were required.

Now, in the imperial court, the only person left who could make her kneel and kowtow was the one sitting on the dragon throne.

Unconsciously, she had come so far on this journey, and for a moment, she felt quite emotional.

She said, "Uncle and Aunt were once his benefactors. He would never accept such formalities from you."

Back then, when Xie Zheng was severely injured, none of the town's physicians dared to treat him. If not for Carpenter Zhao's decades of experience as a veterinarian, prescribing medicine as a last resort, Xie Zheng might not have survived.

Hearing Fan Changyu's words, the elderly Zhao couple seemed to recall their days in Lin'an Town, and their sense of distance from Xie Zheng immediately lessened.

Aunt Zhao looked at Fan Changyu hesitantly, inevitably worrying about her future: "Then... your wedding back then doesn't count anymore?"

What she really wanted to ask was what their plans were now.

When Fan Changyu rose to prominence, Aunt Zhao, knowing the girl she had watched grow up so well, wasn't afraid she would abandon Yan Zheng.

But now that Yan Zheng was a Marquis, Aunt Zhao couldn't help but worry. Those high-ranking officials often kept multiple wives and concubines. Earlier, when the army passed by downstairs, Yan Zheng had accepted the hair ribbon Fan Changyu gave him, showing he still had feelings for her. But she wondered just how deep those feelings ran.

Hearing Aunt Zhao's question, Fan Changyu thought about how their marriage had been a sham from the start, agreed upon by both of them, and nodded.

Aunt Zhao grew anxious at once and said, "Even if the initial marriage was a pretense, you two became husband and wife through hardship. Now that you've achieved prosperity together, how could you possibly part ways?"

Fan Changyu finally understood what Aunt Zhao was hinting at. Recalling Xie Zheng's words that night about wanting to formally marry her, her face flushed slightly. "You're overthinking things," she replied.

Until the truth behind the Jinzhou incident was uncovered, her grandfather's name would remain tarnished.

Only by clearing the Meng family's name could she rightfully stand beside Xie Zheng as a descendant of the Meng family and bring peace to the spirits of her grandfather and parents in the afterlife.

But the political situation in court was complex, and the elderly Zhao couple were simple folk. Explaining too much would only confuse and worry them unnecessarily.

"Don't worry," she reassured. "He's not that kind of person."

With Changyu's assurance, Aunt Zhao felt relieved.

The triumphant army had already gathered before the Meridian Gate awaiting imperial summons, and the bustling crowds in the streets gradually dispersed.

Fan Changyu, the two elderly members of the Zhao family, the two children, along with Xie Qi and Xie Wu, returned to the Office of Presentations.

On the way, Changning spotted a sugar-figure vendor and clamored to buy some. Changyu took her and Bao'er to purchase the treats, with Xie Wu accompanying them in case of any mishaps.

Xie Qi, responsible for driving the carriage, remained with the elderly Zhao couple in the vehicle.

Despite having seen the capital's sights many times, Aunt Zhao couldn't resist peeking through the carriage curtains, marveling at the city's prosperity.

Seeing that Changyu and the children would take a while buying sugar figures, Aunt Zhao thought about the approaching New Year. She decided to buy some red fabric to sew lucky red pouches for the children's New Year money. After informing Xie Qi, she headed to a nearby fabric stall.

As Aunt Zhao browsed the dizzying array of fabrics, she overheard several women nearby gossiping while selecting materials: "Have you heard? When the Wu'an Marquis entered the city, he accepted a handkerchief thrown by a maiden. I wonder which lucky girl in the capital caught his eye!"

Another woman chimed in, "With the entire street packed shoulder-to-shoulder moments before, who could tell which family's daughter threw it? Besides, it was just a handkerchief. Given the Marquis's status, he probably took it casually to avoid embarrassing the girl by discarding it publicly."

"Wait, was it a handkerchief? I heard it was a hair ribbon!" interjected a third woman. "A handkerchief might be acceptable in such circumstances,

but a hair ribbon is different. I'd say the Marquis likely has his eye on someone."

The first speaker continued, "The only truly accomplished beauty in the capital is Grand Tutor Li's youngest daughter. They say the young mistress is sixteen and still unmarried—perhaps she's been waiting for the Wu'an Marquis!"

Aunt Zhao had no intention of joining the conversation, but at these words, she set down the fabric she was examining and addressed the women: "That hair ribbon belongs to my daughter."

The women glanced at Aunt Zhao, then suddenly burst into laughter behind their silk handkerchiefs.

Though Aunt Zhao's clothing wasn't poor quality, it bore no resemblance to the finery worn by wealthy matrons. Her hands, roughened by years of labor, and her provincial accent made the women dismiss her entirely.

One of them teased, "Auntie, how old is your daughter?"

Aunt Zhao calculated Fan Changyu's age and replied, "She'll be seventeen soon."

At this, the women covered their lips and giggled, their exchanged glances full of mockery.

The woman said, "A seventeen-year-old spinster throws a hair ribbon, and the Wu'an Marquis picks it up and tucks it into his robe? Auntie, is your daughter some celestial beauty?"

Though their words weren't explicitly vulgar, the scorn and ridicule in their tone and manner were unmistakable to Aunt Zhao.

Her chest tightened at hearing Fan Changyu mocked like this. Gripping the fabric tighter, she glared at the women and retorted, "My daughter may not be a celestial beauty, but she's a female general who defends our homeland!"

This only made them think she was spouting nonsense. One woman tossed down her fabric, saying, "Has she gone mad? Best not stand too close."

They all stepped back as if afraid Aunt Zhao might harm them.

The vendor, seeing his business slipping away and having heard Aunt Zhao's claims, snatched the fabric from her hands and scolded, "You crazy

old hag, don't ruin my business!"

Though kind-hearted, Aunt Zhao was no pushover. She immediately fired back, "You brat, how unreasonable! I'm buying your goods, and you dare insult me? Everyone, come judge—this man is bullying an old woman in broad daylight! Is there no law anymore?"

The vendor hadn't expected this seemingly meek old woman to be so tough. As a crowd gathered, he hastily explained, "This old hag's gone mad! First, she claims the Wu'an Marquis picked up her daughter's hair ribbon, then says her daughter's a female general, and now she's causing a scene at my stall!"

Aunt Zhao planted her hands on her hips and snapped, "Why can't my daughter be a female general?"

Seizing the opportunity, the vendor excitedly addressed the onlookers, "Did you all hear that? This madwoman's lost her mind! The only female general in Great Yin is the General of the Cloud Banner. Are you saying your daughter is the General of the Cloud Banner?"

The moment he finished, the crowd erupted in jeers and pointing fingers.

"She must be insane! Would a heroine like the General of the Cloud Banner have such an embarrassing mother?"

Aunt Zhao had only lashed out after being insulted and driven away by the vendor. Now, hearing this, she regretted the argument. Fan Changyu served in the court, and even if this didn't cause her trouble, it would surely shame her. Guilt gnawed at Aunt Zhao.

She said, "I'm her neighbor! I watched that girl grow up!"

With that, she tried to leave, but the crowd hemmed her in. Seeing her embarrassment, they refused to let her go.

A weasel-faced man with a thin mustache sneered loudly, "Oh, so you're just the General of the Cloud Banner's neighbor? Well, I'm her uncle!"

The crowd burst into derisive laughter.

Then, a crisp, authoritative woman's voice cut through the noise from beyond the crowd: "Auntie, haven't you picked out the fabric yet?"

The clamor abruptly died down. People instinctively parted, turning to look behind them.

At the back stood a tall woman. In her left arm, she carried a little girl holding a sugar figurine, while her right hand held a little boy clutching a sugar-coated haws on a stick. Both children wore colorful street masks, making them look like twins at first glance.

Fan Changyu felt slightly uneasy under the sudden scrutiny of so many eyes.

After buying the sugar figurines for Changning and Bao'er, she had heard that Aunt Zhao had gone to purchase fabric but hadn't returned for a long time. Seeing the crowd gathered here, she came over to investigate.

To her surprise, the moment she spoke, everyone stared at her with strange expressions, while Aunt Zhao's face instantly darkened. Despite her age and usually unsteady legs, the old woman practically sprinted over, scooped up Yu Bao'er, and urgently said to Fan Changyu, "Hurry! Let's go!"

Baffled, Fan Changyu nevertheless carried Changning and followed Aunt Zhao toward their carriage.

Only then did murmurs arise from the crowd: "That... really is the General of the Cloud Banner?"

Someone confirmed, "Yes, it's her! When the generals from Jizhou entered the capital recently, I saw her at the city gates. She rode a tall horse right behind General Tang—so majestic!"

At these words, the crowd fell into an eerie silence.

After a long pause, someone cautiously ventured, "So... that hair ribbon the Wu'an Marquis keeps in his robe really belongs to the General of the Cloud Banner?"

The vendor and the women who had been buying fabric earlier looked as if they'd seen a ghost.

Who would have thought the bizarre claims of that old out-of-town woman—spoken in broken official dialect—were actually true!

Then, another timid voice piped up: "Those twins the General of the Cloud Banner is carrying... could they be hers and the Wu'an Marquis's?"

The crowd collectively gulped. Had they accidentally stumbled upon a monumental secret today?

Snapping out of his daze, the vendor grabbed several bolts of fabric and chased after Fan Changyu and Aunt Zhao, shouting, "General of the Cloud

Banner! Madam! These fabrics are my gift to you! I was blind earlier—please don't hold it against me!"

Fearing this would bring trouble to Fan Changyu, Aunt Zhao turned and snarled at the vendor, "She's not who you think! You've mistaken her for someone else!"

But her denial only made the situation more suspicious.

The only one completely bewildered throughout this entire episode was Fan Changyu herself.

Chapter 143

It wasn't until they boarded the carriage and Xie Qi cracked the whip to drive away from the bustling market that Aunt Zhao finally let out a long sigh of relief.

Fan Changyu, utterly confused, asked, "Auntie, what exactly is going on?"

Aunt Zhao replied with guilt, "Changyu, I was foolish and might have caused trouble for you."

She recounted the argument she had at the fabric stall, too ashamed to lift her head. "I only spoke up when those women started gossiping about that nonsense—how the hair ribbon Yan Zheng received was from some Miss Li. I didn't expect it to escalate like this..."

Her calloused hands clenched tightly in her sleeves before she finally looked at Fan Changyu and asked, "I've heard that officials can easily be impeached. Will this... will this lead to someone impeaching you or Yan Zheng?"

Carpenter Zhao, worried his wife's actions might bring trouble to Fan Changyu, immediately pointed at Aunt Zhao and scolded, "You, you! At your age, why must you argue over such trivial matters?"

Aunt Zhao, filled with remorse, didn't even retort when her husband berated her.

Fan Changyu reassured her, "It's not a big deal, Auntie. Don't blame yourself. But to avoid unnecessary complications, let's not engage in such arguments in the future."

The emperor, Wei Yan, and even the Li family already knew about her relationship with Xie Zheng. If word got out that Xie Zheng had accepted a hair ribbon from a woman in the city, they would easily guess it was her.

As for the rest, she and Xie Zheng would marry sooner or later, so it didn't matter if the public knew. The trickier part might be her "widowed" status—some would inevitably think she wasn't good enough for Xie Zheng.

But those who thought she wasn't worthy would still feel the same even if they learned that the man she had once married was Xie Zheng.

In the past, Fan Changyu might have been bothered by this. But after enduring the trials of the battlefield, she had grown indifferent to life and death. If she still feared gossip, she would truly be regressing.

Hearing Fan Changyu's words, Aunt Zhao finally relaxed completely, repeatedly saying, "No, no, I won't do it again."

As the carriage smoothly returned to the Office of Presentations, Changning, sitting in Fan Changyu's lap, noticed that Uncle Zhao and Aunt Zhao were unusually quiet. She asked, "Sister, is Brother-in-law also going to the palace to receive official rewards from the emperor?"

She remembered that her sister had gone with the generals to the palace after entering the city that day.

Fan Changyu nodded lightly and replied, "Of course he is."

Only capital officials ranked fifth grade or higher were required to attend daily court sessions. Officials summoned from outside the capital, unless instructed otherwise by the emperor, only needed to stay at the Office of Presentations or handle official business at their respective offices.

Fan Changyu, Tang Peiyi, and the other generals who had just returned from the northwestern battlefield were still in a period of leisure. It was likely the emperor wouldn't assign them new posts until after the new year.

But the political situation in the court was unpredictable. The one seated on the throne had held little real power since ascending. Apart from the truly loyal ministers, the courtiers' reverence for the imperial family was superficial, with most secretly aligning themselves with Wei Yan or the Li family, forming factions.

The young emperor, though mediocre in governance, was ambitious. He had previously tried to ally with the Li family to overthrow Wei Yan, only to act too hastily. Before Wei Yan fell, the Li family saw the knife the emperor had placed at their throats and instead allied with the imperial grandson, Qi Min.

The young emperor now had no choice but to seek Wei Yan's protection again. The outcome of the power struggle between the Wei Faction and

Grand Tutor Li's faction would likely be determined by the Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts regarding Wei Yan's collusion with rebels.

Fan Changyu had been frequenting the Court of Revision these days to attend trial hearings, trying to uncover what the Sui family had done during the Jinzhou Massacre years ago and find clues connecting Wei Yan's current rebel collusion to the orchestrated Jinzhou tragedy.

However, the joint trial was progressing extremely slowly. It would likely take one or two months to conclude.

The variables surrounding the imperial throne remained uncertain months later.

Changning's eyes sparkled upon hearing Fan Changyu's words: "What will His Majesty reward Brother-in-law with?"

This question made Fan Changyu pause in contemplation.

Xie Zheng had been enfeoffed as a marquis by his capping age—a military achievement unmatched in the entire court. During her last audience at the Golden Chime Hall with Tang Peiyi, the emperor had hinted at bestowing Xie Zheng with the Nine Bestowments.

Yet the court officials had remained deathly silent.

She found it strange at the time and later asked Tang Peiyi at the Office of Presentations what the Nine Bestowments signified.

Tang Peiyi answered cryptically: "Since ancient times, only when the Son of Heaven has no higher honors to confer would he grant his subjects the Nine Bestowments—including chariots, ceremonial robes, musical instruments, special palace steps, axes, bows and arrows among nine items, symbolizing supreme imperial authority. But throughout history, those who received them were all treacherous ministers who met untimely ends."

The current court was divided between the Wei Faction and Grand Tutor Li's faction.

Had the emperor's words that day been meant to thrust Xie Zheng into the spotlight, making him a target for both Wei Yan and Grand Tutor Li?

Fan Changyu couldn't help feeling concerned. Adjusting Changning's collar, she merely said, "How would your sister know what rewards the emperor intends to give?"

Clearly unsatisfied with this answer, Changning buried her face in Fan Changyu's arms and pouted.

Occasional gusts of wind lifted the carriage curtain. As Fan Changyu patted her back, her gaze drifted toward the imperial palace beyond the window, brows slightly furrowed.

—The Imperial Palace—

"Announcing the presence of Wu'an Marquis Xie Zheng—"

The summons echoed through the lengthy palace corridors, reverberating between the ten-zhang-high watchtowers flanking the Goose-Wing Tower, solemn and imposing.

Golden Guard soldiers in armor stood in two rigid columns before the Meridian Gate, expressions stern.

At high noon, the glazed tiles on the palace roofs gleamed with golden edges under the sunlight.

Clad in battle armor, Xie Zheng strode slowly through the palace gates that yawned like a beast's maw, his black cloak billowing behind him as if dragging a trail of blood and killing intent.

His expression carried casual indifference edged with cold sharpness. The qilin-head pauldrons on his shoulders appeared ferocious in the sunlight—though an auspicious beast, they seemed imbued with the bloodthirsty malevolence of battlefields, making onlookers avert their eyes.

The red walls and golden tiles lining the palace path momentarily lost their usual majesty and opulence, appearing to bow humbly before him.

When Xie Zheng entered the Golden Chime Hall, all civil and military officials turned to watch his approach.

The foremost position among military officials remained vacant for him. Standing at the head of the civil officials' formation, Grand Tutor Li glanced briefly at Xie Zheng, his wrinkled brow furrowing slightly.

The wolf cub Wei Yan had raised had truly grown up—in terms of audacity and methods, he was every bit Wei Yan's equal in his youth.

Withdrawing his gaze, the Grand Tutor straightened his ceremonial tablet and resumed looking forward impassively.

Xie Zheng ignored all the scrutinizing gazes, lifting his eyes to meet those of the young emperor seated high above in the Golden Hall. Qi Sheng's forced smile faltered slightly when their eyes locked.

The corners of Xie Zheng's lips curled in a faint, mocking tilt. He couldn't even be bothered to perform the full kneeling ceremony, merely inclining his torso slightly forward and clasping his fists in salute. "Your humble servant greets Your Majesty."

Now that he had been enfeoffed as a marquis, he no longer needed to refer to himself as a general in the emperor's presence.

Qi Sheng both feared and secretly loathed him, his teeth gritted behind the strained smile as he said, "Rise quickly, Our beloved minister Xie."

Then, addressing the assembled court officials, he declared, "Minister Xie is a pillar of Great Yin. We hereby grant him the privilege to enter the court with his sword and shoes, to walk without hastening his steps, and to present memorials without being announced by name."

These were privileges he had bestowed upon Xie Zheng ever since his enfeoffment as a marquis. One could say that from that moment on, Qi Sheng had been scheming to drive a wedge between Wei Yan and Xie Zheng, uncle and nephew.

The civil and military officials lining both sides of the hall dared not utter a word in response to Qi Sheng's proclamation.

Surveying the silent court, Qi Sheng's resentment toward the decline of imperial authority deepened. Yet, powerless to change it, he could only offer Xie Zheng a hollow smile and say, "In quelling the rebellion in Chongzhou, Our beloved minister Xie risked life and limb, earning the foremost merit. The Northern Court has also remained peaceful under his guardianship. Today, We specially bestow upon him the Nine Bestowments."

With a light clap of his hands, eunuchs brought forth the prepared rewards on trays draped with yellow silk, presenting them before Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng's gaze swept over the exquisite artifacts held by the eunuchs, his eyes growing even colder. With another slight bow, he said, "Your humble servant thanks Your Majesty for your boundless generosity."

The court session finally concluded without major incident. Members of the Wei Faction, aware of Wei Yan's prolonged absence due to illness and wary of Xie Zheng's temperament and methods, remained silent throughout. The Li Faction, however, regarded Xie Zheng with deep apprehension.

But since Grand Tutor Li had not spoken, his subordinates dared not provoke Xie Zheng recklessly.

Only the eunuchs who had carried the trays of imperial gifts to Xie Zheng trembled uncontrollably even after leaving the hall.

Grand Tutor Li, along with his eldest son and a few trusted disciples, was among the first to depart after the court adjourned.

Once they reached a secluded area near the Golden Water Bridge, his eldest son, Li Yuanting, unable to contain himself, asked, "Father, the Wu'an Marquis's current influence has clearly surpassed Wei Yan's. As long as he remains in the capital, our plans..."

Despite his frustration, Li Yuanting didn't dare finish the thought.

Grand Tutor Li's crane-patterned official robes shimmered brilliantly under the sunlight. Unlike his son's impatience, his steps remained unhurried, his expression unreadable. "Why the haste? The boat will straighten itself when it reaches the bridge."

No sooner had he spoken than a languid yet commanding voice called from behind, "Grand Tutor, a moment."

Grand Tutor Li halted and turned to see the young Martial Marquis approaching leisurely along the white marble steps. With measured calm, he asked, "What instructions does the Marquis have for me?"

Xie Zheng's lips curled slightly. "Instructions are unnecessary. I merely have something to deliver to the Grand Tutor."

As Xie Zheng approached with casual ease, the cluster of civil officials surrounding Grand Tutor Li tensed, swallowing nervously.

Perhaps it was their overactive imaginations, but as Xie Zheng drew near, they felt as if a faint scent of blood enveloped them. The more timid among them even paled.

Grand Tutor Li remained composed, his aged yet sharp eyes fixed on Xie Zheng as he said, "This old man has little personal interaction with the

Marquis. May I ask what item the Marquis wishes to deliver to me?"

Xie Zheng halted his steps three paces away from Grand Tutor Li. With a flick of his wrist, a jade pendant tied with a red cord slipped from his hand, swaying gently in midair. The character "An" was carved into the jade.

Li Yuanting's expression changed drastically the moment he saw the pendant. "This... this is Huai'an's jade pendant!"

Xie Zheng loosened his fingers slightly, causing the pendant to nearly fall to the ground. Fortunately, Li Yuanting reacted swiftly and caught it by the cord.

Xie Zheng said lazily, "Returning the jade intact to Zhao."

Li Yuanting, frantic with worry, shouted at Xie Zheng, "What have you done to my son?"

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze coldly, eyeing the Minister of Revenue with deliberate slowness. "Didn't I just say? Returning the jade intact to Zhao."

Li Yuanting, consumed by paternal anxiety, flushed red with agitation. But Xie Zheng ignored him and turned back to Grand Tutor Li. His long, narrow eyes caught fragments of sunlight, making their depths even more inscrutable. "The item has been returned. I shall take my leave."

As soon as Xie Zheng departed, Li Yuanting couldn't help but exclaim to Grand Tutor Li, "Father, Huai'an has fallen into Xie Zheng's hands! What does this mean?"

Grand Tutor Li watched the retreating figure of the young Martial Marquis, a faint glimmer passing through his aged eyes. "He is threatening me."

Chapter 144

Li Yuanting still didn't understand the implication behind Grand Tutor Li's words when he saw his father already striding toward the palace gates. He hurried after him and asked, "What does he want us to exchange for Huaian?"

Grand Tutor Li's wrinkled eyelids drooped slightly, concealing the depth in his eyes. "Huaian would never betray the Li family."

Li Yuanting froze in place at his father's words.

Never betray the Li family—did that mean even if Li Huaian had fallen into Xie Zheng's hands, the evidence of their involvement in aiding the rebel's escape from Chongzhou and nearly seizing Lucheng wouldn't be exposed?

Was it because Xie Zheng couldn't pry open Huaian's mouth that he specifically used Huaian's jade pendant to negotiate with them?

The official sedan chairs of the Li father and son had already been brought to the street outside the Meridian Gate. Li Yuanting blocked Grand Tutor Li just as he was about to bend down and enter, his emotions visibly agitated. "Father, are you planning to abandon Huaian?"

Grand Tutor Li gave his eldest son a calm, indifferent glance. "Do you think the Li family has any other path to take now?"

From the moment the Li family threw their full support behind the Crown Prince's eldest grandson, they had already become traitorous subjects in the emperor's eyes—ones he wished to exterminate at the first opportunity.

The Crown Prince's eldest grandson also held letters and material evidence of their correspondence, effectively grasping their lifeline. The Li family had no choice but to continue supporting him.

Abandoning Li Huaian was the only way to preserve the Li family's interests to the greatest extent possible.

Even after Grand Tutor Li had entered his sedan chair, Li Yuanting remained rooted to the spot, stunned by those words.

Despite understanding the Li family's current predicament, he still couldn't believe his father would so readily discard the most promising young talent of their generation.

The servants waiting nearby, seeing Grand Tutor Li's sedan chair already departing, cautiously inquired, "My lord, shall we depart?"

Li Yuanting thought of his son, now reduced to a sacrificial pawn, grief surging in his heart. His face ashen, he turned and entered the sedan chair. "Let's go."

The Imperial Palace

After leaving the Golden Luan Hall, Qi Sheng didn't even return to Taiqian Palace before smashing vases and jade artifacts in a side hall.

Only when exhausted did he brace his hands against the table, panting heavily as he glared at the shattered porcelain on the ground. "Does Xie Zheng still show even the slightest respect for Us?"

The attending eunuchs stood frozen in terror. No matter how silver-tongued they might usually be, none dared attempt to flatter this mercurial emperor in such a moment.

After catching his breath, Qi Sheng suddenly chuckled darkly. "Let him revel in his arrogance for now. Xie Zheng's days of comfort are numbered."

For some reason, his mood abruptly improved. He even straightened his dragon robes, disheveled from his earlier tantrum, and said with a curved lip, "Return to Taiqian Palace."

But just as he stepped out of the side hall, a short scream escaped him at the sight of blood spreading across the white marble steps.

Qi Sheng collapsed onto the threshold of the side hall, his terrified pupils reflecting the sight of one of his trusted eunuchs lying dead with wide, staring eyes—and the long sword still dripping blood beside the corpse.

His gaze shifted to the armored figure standing coldly below the hall, sword in hand. Trembling, he demanded, "Wu'an Marquis! D-do you intend to commit regicide and rebellion?"

Xie Zheng flicked his wrist lightly, shaking off the last droplets of blood from his blade. With deliberate slowness, he sheathed the long sword into the empty scabbard of a nearby Golden Guard, paying no heed to the guard's ashen face. Raising his eyes coolly towards Qi Sheng, he said, "Your Majesty wrongs this humble subject. I merely heard this eunuch spreading seductive fallacies to mislead Your Majesty. Since you granted me the power of life and death, I took the liberty of eliminating this scourge for you."

The dead eunuch was none other than the imperial envoy previously sent to supervise the army in Chongzhou.

Acting on Qi Sheng's secret orders, had it not been for the Li family allowing Wei Yan to collaborate with the imperial grandson in executing a golden cicada shedding its shell maneuver—abandoning Chongzhou to attack Lucheng—the eunuch's next move would have been targeting Fan Changyu on the battlefield.

Even when this scheme failed, the eunuch still obstructed Tang Peiyi's attempt to dispatch cavalry reinforcements to Lucheng.

Had Tang Peiyi not stood firm, most of the cavalry would have been taken away under the pretext of reporting to the capital, leaving Lucheng indefensible. After returning to the capital, the eunuch had embellished the events in Chongzhou with malicious exaggerations to Qi Sheng.

Were it not for Tang Peiyi and others securing victory—leaving Qi Sheng no grounds for reprisal—Tang Peiyi and Fan Changyu would have faced severe punishment upon their return to the capital.

Xie Zheng had not found the time to deal with these vermin until now.

Having officially "returned" to the capital today, it was time to settle accounts one by one.

Qi Sheng watched the approaching man with the ease of a leisurely stroll, his face pale as paper. He wanted to call for guards, but the vast palace had only one Golden Guard remaining outside. The rest had mysteriously vanished, likely dismissed by Xie Zheng. Trembling with fear, Qi Sheng's hands shook uncontrollably against the floor as he glared at the nearing figure, his voice a weak bluster: "Y-you... what do you want?"

His pitiful state bore no resemblance to imperial dignity.

A faint sneer flashed in Xie Zheng's eyes as he slightly bent at the waist, offering a hand to Qi Sheng. Blessed with striking features, his slight smile was deceptively charming: "This subject acted against a servant spreading seductive fallacies but inadvertently alarmed Your Majesty. A thousand deaths would not atone for my crime. Allow me to help you up."

To Qi Sheng, that handsome face was more terrifying than any demon.

He dared not accept Xie Zheng's assistance, attempting to rise by gripping the doorframe instead—only for his elbow to be seized in an iron-like grasp.

For the first time, Qi Sheng understood the terrifying strength of a military commander's grip. A muffled groan escaped his throat as pain shot through his arm, sweat beading on his forehead like pearls.

Xie Zheng maintained his thin smile, asking leisurely, "Your Majesty's disrespectful remarks towards the General of the Cloud Banner during court—that too was the eunuch's instigation, no doubt?"

Qi Sheng's heart lurched. He finally realized Xie Zheng's actions today were vengeance for Fan Changyu.

Shock and fury twisted into malice at this blatant disregard for imperial authority—yet all drowned in overwhelming fear. A bead of sweat rolled down his temple as he forced agreement: "Y-yes... that dog of a servant poisoned my ears."

Xie Zheng lifted his dark lashes slightly, finally releasing Qi Sheng's elbow with meaningful emphasis: "That's what I thought best."

The threat in Xie Zheng's words was unmistakable.

Today's visit was a clear warning—to keep his schemes away from Fan Changyu.

No matter how much hatred surged in his heart, the sharp pain in his elbow joint kept Qi Sheng sober enough to refrain from saying anything inappropriate in front of Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng gave him a faint glance, cupping his hands in a perfunctory bow. "With the traitors eliminated, this subject shall take his leave."

Only after Xie Zheng had completely disappeared from sight did Qi Sheng weakly brace himself against the side hall's doorframe to remain

standing. Despite the bitter winter cold, his back was drenched in cold sweat.

The chief eunuch, who had not dared to breathe loudly throughout the entire encounter, finally stepped forward with a pale face to support him, his shrill voice trembling with anger. "That Xie Zheng truly has the heart of a wolf! The Xie family has been loyal for generations—how dare he defy the law like this? Doesn't he fear bringing shame upon his ancestors?"

Qi Sheng's expression darkened. He roughly shoved away the eunuch trying to assist him and muttered in the direction Xie Zheng had departed, "I can no longer tolerate his presence!"

Xie Linshan had once been the capital's garrison commander, and the Xie family still maintained a residence in the city. Thus, Xie Zheng did not need to be assigned new lodgings.

Almost immediately after the court session ended, palace officials arrived to deliver the Nine Bestowments the emperor had granted him.

Xie Zheng merely returned home to change into casual attire, not even bothering to meet the eunuchs sent with the gifts, before heading straight to the Office of Presentations to find Fan Changyu.

But this trip proved fruitless.

Shortly after Fan Changyu had returned with Aunt Zhao and the others, Tang Peiyi had sent someone to summon her.

The progress of the Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts was not only of great concern to Fan Changyu but also to Tang Peiyi, who was determined to seek justice for He Jingyuan. He had been closely monitoring developments at the Court of Revision.

That very day, with Xie Zheng's return to the capital, the Court of Revision had resumed interrogating the captured subordinate generals and servants of the Sui family. Yet again, excessive torture had resulted in another death, though the incident had been suppressed for now and not yet reported to the court.

Tang Peiyi feared that Wei Yan had planted his own people within the Court of Revision. If all key witnesses from the Sui family were to "die suddenly" during the trial, it would become even more impossible to implicate Wei Yan.

Another interrogation was scheduled for that afternoon. Worried that further mishaps might occur, Tang Peiyi decided to bring Fan Changyu, He Jingyuan's eldest son, and Zheng Wenchang to observe the proceedings.

Court of Revision

The winter weather grew colder by the day. As a third-rank military officer, Fan Changyu now had a seat in the observation gallery. Beneath the low table to her left, a charcoal brazier provided warmth.

On the main dais, the presiding judge was the Chief Minister of the Court of Revision, flanked by officials from the Ministry of Justice and the Censorate. Beneath their brocade-covered bench, additional braziers ensured they were even more comfortably warm than those in the observation area below.

The remnants of the rebel forces kneeling below wore nothing but tattered, thin prison garments, their faces and hands blue from the cold, their hair disheveled and filthy.

Seasoned officials at the Court of Revision knew that deep winter was the best time for interrogations. Without even applying torture, simply leaving prisoners to freeze overnight was often enough to break them.

Fan Changyu had been observing for some time. The presiding judges merely went through the motions of questioning, but before answering, each prisoner was dragged out and given thirty heavy strokes of the rod. By the end, their flesh was torn and bleeding.

Tang Peiyi explained that this was the "intimidating rod"—once they had suffered, they would be less likely to lie during questioning.

However, the afternoon session only involved minor underlings. Despite the blood pooling beneath the execution bench outside, no crucial information had been extracted.

During the mid-session break, the observing officials went to the side rooms for tea or stepped outside for fresh air.

Tang Peiyi, seeing no one around, lowered his voice and said, "This morning's interrogation resulted in a death, and now in the afternoon they're only questioning some insignificant servants. Though Wei Yan claims to be ill at home, his reach is still long enough!"

Fan Changyu frowned upon hearing this. "If he has people in the Court of Revision, should we assign more guards to protect that advisor from

Changxin Prince Manor?"

He Jingyuan's eldest son, He Xiujun, said, "Grand Tutor Li's people are more anxious than we are. The Li family won't let him die an unnatural death."

Tang Peiyi nodded in agreement and added, "The Li family is still struggling to find physical evidence against Wei Yan. They'll probably have to interrogate Sui Yuanhuai's concubine again later. With her child as a weakness, she likely can't hide any secrets."

Fan Changyu suddenly asked, "Was Sui Yuanhuai's concubine interrogated this morning?"

She knew full well that the concubine of Sui Yuanhuai imprisoned in the dungeon was a fake, but since Qi Min had used her to replace Yu Qianqian and her child, she must still be from the Sui family.

However, given Qi Min's methods, he would never hand over someone who knew his secrets to the imperial court.

Torture might not extract evidence of Wei Yan's collusion with the Sui family, but whether it would reveal that "Sui Yuanhuai" was still alive remained uncertain.

The emperor was already wary of Xie Zheng and had deliberately obstructed Tang Peiyi when he returned to the capital with the subordinate generals from Jizhou for their first audience.

If this new pretext emerged—that the remnants of the rebels were still alive—then all the generals involved in suppressing the rebellion wouldn't just miss out on rewards; they might even be charged with crimes. The situation would become extremely unfavorable for them.

Fan Changyu clenched her fists, her expression turning grave.

So, Qi Min had dug another pit for them here!

If the Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts proceeded smoothly and Wei Yan was brought down by the Li family, they would also be punished for falsely reporting the extermination of the rebels to claim military merits.

This was truly a plan to kill two birds with one stone!

Noticing Fan Changyu's troubled expression, Tang Peiyi said, "They didn't get to interrogate her. Before summoning Sui Yuanhuai's concubine,

they first questioned one of his attendants, and that attendant was beaten to death. Who would have thought that when the concubine was brought to the courtroom and saw the attendant's corpse on the punishment bench in the courtyard, she fainted on the spot. The Court of Revision officials, fearing she might die of fright, called for a royal physician, and that's how the news got out."

Fan Changyu murmured, "I see."

Preoccupied with her thoughts, she lost interest in the ongoing interrogation and excused herself from the courtroom.

She wandered toward the prison area, but the guards at the entrance, seeing her third-rank military official attire, blocked her path and saluted. "Sir, the prison is a restricted area. You may not proceed further."

Fan Changyu clasped her hands behind her back, lifted her eyelids slightly, and gave a cool nod, exuding the composed demeanor of a seasoned general. She then turned and walked away as if she had merely wandered there absentmindedly.

Prisoners undergoing the Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts could not be interrogated individually without orders, nor were visits permitted.

Fan Changyu intended to survey the Court of Revision's layout and security arrangements to infiltrate it at night.

As she walked along the high wall, discreetly observing the terrain, something suddenly struck her shoulder.

Looking down, she saw a tightly wrapped plum blossom bud lying on the ground.

She looked up and saw Xie Zheng sitting on the gray-tiled wall with one leg bent, casually brushing aside a branch of red plum blossoms that stretched diagonally toward him. His jade-like features, slightly tilted as he gazed at her, rivaled even the vibrant plum blossoms in their brilliance.

His phoenix eyes lowered lazily as he asked, "You've been eyeing everything from the southern wall to the northern one—planning to be a thief?"

Chapter 145

The afternoon sun was dazzlingly bright. Fan Changyu tilted her head back to look at the unfamiliar young man sitting atop the high wall, momentarily lost in thought.

Hearing Xie Zheng's question, she felt a faint embarrassment at having her thoughts exposed.

Her long lashes, gilded by sunlight, fluttered like tiny fans. Having circled the Court of Revision under the scorching sun, her fair cheeks bore a delicate pink flush, with even the fine down visible. Yet she clasped her hands behind her back, assuming a composed demeanor: "What are you doing here?"

Xie Zheng smiled and leaped down from the wall, landing right in front of Fan Changyu: "From the Goose Wing Tower, I saw someone skulking around the Court of Revision walls like a thief. Came to see what petty burglar this might be."

At this teasing remark, Fan Changyu unconsciously clenched a fist, shooting Xie Zheng a warning glare that promised violence if he continued mocking her.

Knowing when to stop, Xie Zheng changed the subject: "Planning a nighttime jailbreak?"

Remembering her scheme, Fan Changyu glanced around. Even after confirming no one was nearby, she took two cautious steps closer and whispered by Xie Zheng's ear: "That impostor pretending to be Yu Qianqian—I heard she'll face further interrogation. I'm afraid she'll reveal Sui Yuanhuai is still alive. I plan to break her out."

Her voice was hushed, her breath brushing lightly against Xie Zheng's ear, sending tingling sensations like insects crawling along its edge.

Xie Zheng leaned slightly to listen, his expression normal though his ears reddened subtly. A hand behind his back clenched tightly, as if restraining something.

Oblivious, Fan Changyu finished and looked up at him: "What do you think?"

Though she'd learned to maintain a stern front to command respect, when speaking to those close to her, her clear, bright eyes still held an honest, somewhat naive charm—like a fierce tiger rolling playfully in snow. Combined with her words, she appeared both simple and dangerous.

Xie Zheng's dark eyes quietly observed the eager young woman before him. With effort, he tore his gaze from her slightly dry lips. The hair ribbon tied around his wrist seemed to burn, the last shreds of reason barely helping him process her plan.

He said, "Breaking out a major prisoner facing Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts—aren't you afraid of investigation?"

Fan Changyu blinked her guileless eyes twice: "Wouldn't suspicion naturally fall on Wei Yan? Military strategy calls this... diverting disaster eastward!"

Xie Zheng couldn't suppress a chuckle. "Your personal military strategy?"

Changyu paused. She'd improvised when the proper term escaped her. His remark flustered her.

She coughed dryly. "Well, that's the general idea."

Xie Zheng leaned against the wall, eyelids slightly lowered as he explained slowly: "The Court of Revision guards change shifts at 3pm. Night jailers number only eighteen, but once a breakout is detected, they'll sound the golden bell. All prison exits will lock, and soldiers will surround the place in impenetrable layers."

Changyu stared blankly, scratching her head in frustration. "So breaking her out is impossible?"

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze slightly: "Break her out."

Changyu: "..."

The night was cold and heavy with dew, and the occasional bark of a dog from somewhere startled the crows perched on the withered branches, sending them fluttering into the air.

The Court of Revision, illuminated by two dim lanterns, stood silently in the darkness like a towering grave.

Deep within the prison, torches flickered in the wall niches, their pine resin scent mingling with the musty odor of a place untouched by sunlight for years, filling the air and making one drowsy.

The prison cells were arranged in a cross-shaped layout, with each branch extending deep inside, housing about twenty to thirty cells. Four jailers, divided into two pairs, patrolled back and forth along a single passageway.

At the intersection of the four passages stood the interrogation room and the duty office. The chief jailer and his deputy usually waited here, ready to receive high-ranking officials who came to interrogate prisoners. In case of a jailbreak, they could quickly sound the alarm bell in the duty office upon hearing any disturbance.

That night, the chief jailer and his deputy sat at a square table, yawning repeatedly.

"I can't take it anymore. I need to splash some cold water on my face to wake up," the deputy jailer said, rising with a yawn.

The chief jailer, propping his head on his elbow, was also struggling to stay awake. "Bring me a basin of water too. This bitter winter makes it so easy to doze off."

The deputy jailer acknowledged and went out to fetch water.

As the chief jailer yawned again, his bleary eyes half-opened to see a tall, dark shadow looming over him.

A chill ran down his spine, but before he could turn around, a swift chop to the back of his neck sent him into unconsciousness.

Two patrolling jailers at the intersection of the passages were about to cry out when a sudden gust of wind seemed to brush past their ears. A sharp pain struck the back of their necks, and they crumpled to the ground, the faint sound of dislocated joints accompanying their fall.

Xie Zheng, having knocked out the chief jailer, turned to see Fan Changyu in a night suit, crouching to reset a jailer's dislocated shoulder.

Meeting Xie Zheng's puzzled gaze, Fan Changyu awkwardly explained, "I didn't notice—hit him too hard and dislocated his shoulder."

The moment the arm was reset, the excruciating pain roused the jailer. But before he could even let out a scream, a swift slap knocked him out

again.

The deputy jailer, returning with a basin of cold water, froze at the sight. The wooden basin slipped from his hands as he opened his mouth to shout "Jailbreak!" But the black-clad figure standing beside the chief jailer moved like a ghost, pressing a finger to his throat like a sword tip while deftly catching the falling basin with his foot and flipping it back up.

The deputy jailer felt a sharp pain in his throat, rendering him unable to utter a sound, no matter how hard he tried. The basin, which had nearly crashed to the ground, was effortlessly caught by the black-clad man, who even managed to scoop back every spilled drop of water into it.

Terrified, the deputy jailer tried to flee, but Fan Changyu sprang forward, striking his neck with her elbow and sending him into unconsciousness with a roll of his eyes.

Fan Changyu exhaled softly and whispered, "The last one."

Before reaching the duty office, they had already slipped in through the window and knocked out the other patrolling jailers.

Xie Zheng retrieved a set of keys of varying lengths from the chief jailer and said, "The Sui family is held in Cell A9."

Fan Changyu followed Xie Zheng down the passage marked with the character "A."

Torches lined the narrow corridor at regular intervals, eliminating the need for lanterns.

Sui Yuanhuai's concubine and only son, as key imperial prisoners, were confined together in a cramped cell.

The iron chains securing the prison cell door were as thick as a baby's arm. Xie Zheng had to try each key from the large bunch one by one. The faint clinking of metal links stirred the prisoners in the adjacent cells awake.

Yet none dared make a sound, uncertain whether the newcomers were here to kill them or to rescue them.

The mother and child held in solitary confinement were in worse shape than when Fan Changyu had first seen them. The woman, now even more disheveled and filthy, clutched her child tightly. Her thin clothing stretched

taut over her emaciated frame, the sharp outlines of her vertebrae visible through the fabric.

Her eyes held no hope as she stared at Xie Zheng and Fan Changyu outside the cell—only terror. Even her arms trembled violently around her child.

To avoid complications, Fan Changyu remained silent, keeping watch at the corridor's end while Xie Zheng worked.

Unexpectedly, an old man with graying hair in a cell across from them suddenly shrieked hysterically, "Prison break! Murder—!"

Through the egg-sized ventilation holes near the ceiling, flickering torchlight swarmed—the guards outside had clearly heard the old man's cries.

Xie Zheng's eyes turned icy, and Fan Changyu tensed instantly.

Originally, they had ample time after discreetly knocking out the jailers with a mild dose of knockout incense. But now, thanks to the old man's outburst, the exits of the Court of Revision would soon be swarmed.

There was no longer enough time to test each key.

Gritting her teeth, Fan Changyu rushed over while Xie Zheng remained composed, still trying keys. "Let me!"

Though she couldn't snap the baby-arm-thick chains, a few powerful kicks at the cell's wooden bars—each as thick as a fist—sent them splintering apart.

Using her physical advantage, she squeezed through the gap, grabbing the woman and child effortlessly, one in each hand, and hauled them out.

At the jagged breach in the cell, she shoved the stunned child into Xie Zheng's arms, hoisted the woman onto her shoulder, and barked, "Go!"

Xie Zheng glanced at the child now in his grip and the woman slung over Fan Changyu's shoulder. He considered offering to carry the woman himself, but recalling her scant clothing, he held his tongue. Instead, he swiftly followed Fan Changyu toward the exit, the child dangling from one hand.

The old man, watching Fan Changyu abduct Sui Yuanhuai's "concubine," grew increasingly agitated—whether out of genuine ignorance of the pair's

true identity, misplaced loyalty, or some other reason. He gripped the cell bars, still screaming, "Help! Prisoners escaping—!"

Xie Zheng frowned slightly. Just before leaving, he cast a cold glance backward.

Outside, the guards had rushed toward the prison at the sound of the alarm. Upon discovering the unconscious jailers, their panic deepened. They hurried to the cells holding the Sui family, only to find all the servants and captured subordinate generals accounted for—except for Sui Yuanhuai's concubine. Cold sweat beaded on the guard captain's forehead.

"Seal all exits!" he roared. "Tear this place apart if you have to!"

Yet when torchlight revealed the shattered, uneven stumps of the cell bars, his shock was undeniable.

What kind of monstrous strength could do this? Just who were these jailbreakers?

Having surveyed the terrain during the day, Fan Changyu quickly located the weakest section of the perimeter wall while carrying the woman and agilely scaled over it.

Xie Zheng followed closely behind, leaping over with the child in hand.

Once outside, fearing the woman might recognize the route, Fan Changyu pulled out a pre-prepared burlap sack from her robe and unceremoniously covered the woman's head—her mouth already stuffed with cotton.

She then handed a smaller sack to Xie Zheng. "Put this on the child too."

The practiced ease of her movements left Xie Zheng silent for a brief moment.

Chapter 146

Fan Changyu noticed Xie Zheng hadn't taken the item and looked up at him in confusion. "What's wrong?"

Xie Zheng accepted the small burlap sack with a peculiar expression. "Nothing."

It was just that this scene felt all too familiar.

The sound of galloping horses and scattered footsteps could already be heard in the distance—the Court of Revision's officers had begun searching the streets.

Not daring to let her guard down for even a moment, Fan Changyu hoisted the person onto her shoulder and said, "We need to leave here quickly!"

Late at night, the streets were under curfew, with every household's doors tightly shut.

The rumble of carriage wheels and the clip-clop of horse hooves would be far too conspicuous in the dead silence of night. To facilitate their escape after the prison break, they hadn't brought a carriage or horses.

If the Court of Revision's officers gave chase on horseback, it would be difficult to shake them off.

Xie Zheng held the child—whose head was also covered with a burlap sack—in one hand and placed his index finger to his lips, letting out a sharp whistle. His personal guards, hiding in the shadows, immediately leaped down from rooftops and trees.

"Divert the pursuers," Xie Zheng said calmly.

Several personal guards, also clad in night suits and carrying large, bulging burlap sacks of unknown contents, split into pairs and swiftly headed toward the approaching officers.

Fan Changyu blinked in surprise. "You had a backup plan?"

Xie Zheng replied, "I couldn't let you take such risks without a foolproof strategy."

The phrase "foolproof strategy" inexplicably made Fan Changyu feel a twinge of guilt.

Both were generals accustomed to strategizing, and by comparison, she seemed to have fallen short. Though her original plan had been quite thorough, who could have predicted that the old man in the prison would suddenly shout and alert the guards outside?

On the battlefield, it was precisely these one-in-a-million mishaps that spelled disaster.

Noticing her sudden flush and silence, Xie Zheng assumed she was embarrassed and couldn't help glancing at her again. His heart tingled strangely, that same ant-biting sensation from earlier in the day returning.

He quickly averted his gaze. "Follow me."

As Fan Changyu followed him through a winding alley, the Court of Revision's officers galloped past on the main street, torches in hand.

From afar, their shouts echoed: "The prison breakers fled toward the east gate! After them!"

"Sir! Sir! Captain Yuan reports seeing two black-clad figures carrying people in North Willow Lane, South Gong Lane, and West Shunkang Ward too!"

"Damn it! How many decoys did they set up? Split up and chase them all—one of them must be real!"

...

Amid the officer's curses, Xie Zheng knocked on the back door of a house hidden in the alley.

An elderly man answered, bowing respectfully without a word and ushering them inside.

Fan Changyu noticed the doors along the corridor bore plaques marked with celestial and earthly branches, deducing this must be an inn.

After being led to a room distinctly different from the others and waiting for the old man to leave, Fan Changyu asked, "This seems to be an inn. Is this also your property?"

Xie Zheng answered, "It's under the Zhao Family's name."

Fan Changyu inwardly marveled. That owner of the Zhao Family Bookstore sure had extensive holdings.

As if reading her thoughts, Xie Zheng said, "The Zhao Family of Xiling made their fortune in the tea trade. During Emperor Chengzu's reign, they were even appointed as imperial merchants. Though they declined afterward, a starved camel is still bigger than a horse."

Fan Changyu nodded thoughtfully.

For some reason, the woman whose head was still covered trembled uncontrollably when Xie Zheng mentioned the Zhao Family.

Xie Zheng frowned slightly and removed the burlap sack from her head. His dark eyes were especially cold and intimidating in the dim candlelight. "Do you know Zhao Xun?"

The woman, still gagged with cotton cloth, paled at the question and shook her head frantically, her eyes brimming with terrified tears.

Just then, a young man's voice came from outside: "I heard of Your Excellency's late-night visit and apologize for any discourtesy. There are matters I wish to discuss—would Your Excellency grant me an audience?"

Fan Changyu recognized the voice as Zhao Xun's and turned her gaze to the woman.

"Think carefully before you answer."

Xie Zheng's indifferent voice cut through the small room like a slow execution.

The room was well-insulated; unless one raised their voice, those outside could hardly hear anything.

Tears welling in her eyes, the woman nodded fearfully.

Fan Changyu exchanged a glance with Xie Zheng. The answer was unexpected, yet upon reflection, it made sense.

Zhao Xun had waited outside for less than half an hour before the door opened.

His ability to take over the Zhao Family at a young age and quietly expand their business across Great Yin spoke to his competence. Without even lifting his head upon entering, he swept a glance with the corner of

his eye before bowing respectfully to Xie Zheng and Fan Changyu with a faint smile. "Greetings to Your Excellencies."

Xie Zheng, disliking small talk, got straight to the point. "Do you recognize this woman?"

Zhao Xun paused, then looked closely at the disheveled mother and child sitting by the bed. His lips curved slightly as he replied, "I do."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids slightly, signaling him to continue.

Zhao Xun said, "While working for the Imperial Grandson, I often visited Changxin Prince Manor. Naturally, I had to conduct business with the Sui Family on the surface and maintain relationships through gifts. I once drank with the manor's steward a few times and saw this woman at his home. She is the steward's daughter-in-law, and her husband was Sui Yuanqing's personal attendant."

Fan Changyu frowned at the woman. "The attendant who was beaten to death earlier—was that your husband?"

The woman nodded, her eyes red.

Fan Changyu had initially thought the old man who suddenly shouted during the prison break was trying to protect Sui Yuanhuai's concubine out of loyalty. Now, she began to piece together the truth. "The old man who called the guards in the prison—was that your father-in-law?"

Too frightened to speak, the woman could only nod again, tears streaming down her cheeks.

Fan Changyu's frown deepened.

No wonder this woman had been used as Yu Qianqian's substitute to die. Even if she hadn't been forced into this role, her family ties would have doomed her and her child regardless.

She asked, "What do you know about the Sui Family's affairs?"

The woman raised her tear-filled eyes. It was clear she had suffered greatly on her journey to the capital, appearing even thinner than when Fan Changyu first saw her in the Lu City prison. Her eyes seemed unusually large, brimming with tears, making her look all the more pitiful and sorrowful.

She likely recognized Fan Changyu as the one who had brought her food and clothing in prison, as she sobbed, "Miss, I'm just a simple woman. I

was born a servant in the Sui household and only stopped working there after marrying my husband. How would I know what the men were up to?"

It seemed nothing useful could be gleaned from this woman, but the old man was the steward of Changxin Prince Manor and likely knew much about the Sui family's affairs.

Keeping this mother and son here would be useful. Once they found an opportunity to rescue the old man later, the grandson could serve as leverage to extract information from him.

Fan Changyu glanced at Xie Zheng, who asked no further questions. Instead, he turned to Zhao Xun and said, "The city is under strict curfew tonight. It's inconvenient to take this pair with us. Can they stay here for now?"

Zhao Xun readily agreed, "Of course, it's no trouble at all. You can come for them whenever you wish."

Xie Zheng gave a slight nod, and Zhao Xun walked to the door, clapping his hands softly. Moments later, the old servant returned.

Zhao Xun instructed, "Take the mother and son inside to settle them. Assign more guards to keep a close watch."

After the woman was led away, Zhao Xun clasped his hands and reported to Xie Zheng, "As you previously instructed me to monitor Wei Mansion discreetly, Wei Yan has been feigning illness at home for months, and his trained lackeys rarely venture out. However, his son Wei Xuan has stirred up trouble again—recently, he got into a fight with the son of Minister Han at Jingque Tower."

Wei Xuan brawling over a courtesan was nothing new, so Xie Zheng remained indifferent.

Noticing this, Zhao Xun quickly added, "I heard it was because Minister Han's son disrespected Madam Wei."

At the mention of Madam Wei, Xie Zheng's dark eyes lifted slightly.

Madam Wei had an almost negligible presence in Wei Mansion. If not for Wei Xuan's constant troublemaking since childhood, Xie Zheng might have nearly forgotten about this aunt of his.

She spent her days in seclusion, chanting Buddhist sutras and never leaving her courtyard. Even the mansion's servants seldom spoke of her.

Why would Minister Han's son suddenly show her disrespect?

Xie Zheng asked, "What happened?"

Zhao Xun hesitated, as if unsure whether to continue. "There have been many impeachment petitions against Wei Yan in court recently. Rumors abound that his days as chancellor are numbered. Some frivolous young nobles have been gossiping that after Wei Mansion is raided, Wei Yan—who keeps no concubines or dancers—won't contribute any new faces to the pleasure quarters, making them less interesting. Then, troublemakers brought up Madam Wei, saying Wei Yan had remained devoted to one wife for twenty years without taking a concubine, so she must still be quite a beauty despite her age..."

Xie Zheng's expression darkened, but Zhao Xun had already started and had no choice but to press on. "Minister Han's son, drunk, joked that Madam Wei wasn't even as attractive as the lowly maids in his household. He claimed she only became Madam Wei because, as a young girl, she went to the military camp to find Wei Yan and ended up pregnant, thus trapping him in marriage. He said her 'skills' must be extraordinary to have kept Wei Yan tied down for over twenty years..."

By the time he finished, Zhao Xun's forehead was damp with cold sweat.

Xie Zheng asked, "How badly did Wei Xuan beat him?"

The voice was indifferent, as if unconcerned about the matter.

Zhao Xun replied, "They say four ribs were broken and one leg fractured. Minister Han has vowed to impeach Wei Xuan."

Xie Zheng's thin lips coldly uttered two words: "Idiots."

Minister Han was aligned with the Li family. His bold threat to impeach Wei Xuan stemmed from knowing Wei Xuan wouldn't dare bring Madam Wei's dishonorable words to court.

Zhao Xun pondered these two words, unable to discern Xie Zheng's stance toward Madam Wei, and could only remain silent.

Logically, since Xie Zheng and Wei Xuan were like fire and water, shouldn't he also disapprove of Madam Wei?

But Xie Zheng only coldly said, "Dismissed."

After Zhao Xun left, Fan Changyu remarked, "Are all those wealthy young masters in the capital so despicable?"

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids to look at her: "Are you defending her?"

Changyu said, "Wei Yan is an evil minister who commits every crime, and Wei Xuan is no good either. But even if Madam Wei is a venomous woman, she can be called wicked or cruel by the world—yet she shouldn't be insulted with such words. As if no matter what wrong a woman commits, she must be branded with that label to satisfy others. But when the Wei father and son have done so much evil, why don't others slander them the same way?"

Xie Zheng lowered his long lashes and remained silent.

Changyu looked at him: "You don't seem happy either. Was Madam Wei good to you?"

Xie Zheng answered, "Not good, but not bad either."

In the past, he loathed Wei Xuan. During the rare family meals on festivals, seeing Madam Wei's saintly smile only made him feel disgusted by her hypocrisy.

But years after leaving Wei Mansion, when he occasionally received winter clothes she had sewn in the northern frontier, he realized Madam Wei might truly not know what Wei Xuan had done to him.

Hearing Xie Zheng's answer, Changyu frowned slightly, thinking that since he lost his mother young, perhaps he had received some maternal care from Madam Wei in his childhood.

But because of what Wei Yan did to his parents, that hatred could never fade.

She rolled up her sleeves: "Should we sneak out tonight and beat up that minister's son again?"

For an official's daughter who dared to confront Wei Yan in the military before marriage—though they had never met—Changyu secretly admired her.

Xie Zheng slowly turned his dark eyes toward her.

Changyu blinked eagerly: "Like father, like son. That minister even has the nerve to impeach—clearly no good himself. He must have let his bastard son bully others all the time. Let's beat him up too so he can't even attend court!"

Chapter 147

Outside the window, the north wind howled, but the room was filled with a warm, gentle light that dispelled the chill of the cold night.

Xie Zheng gazed at the young woman, her bright eyes clear in the candlelight, and the dark, scarred emotions in his heart were miraculously soothed. He slowly raised a hand and, under Fan Changyu's stunned gaze, pressed her into his embrace.

His dark eyes stared calmly in one direction, but beneath that calm, more chilling emotions seemed to be hidden. "It's just the Han Family. There will be plenty of opportunities to deal with them in the future. Tonight has already alerted the soldiers of the Court of Revision, so it's not advisable to go to the Han Family's residence now. You should get some sleep. I'll send you back to the Office of Presentations at the fifth watch of the night."

Living in the Office of Presentations undoubtedly meant exposing her every move to the imperial family's sight.

Fan Changyu had only managed to get out tonight by repeating her old trick of disguising herself as a guard from the Office of Presentations on a procurement trip. At the fifth watch of the night tomorrow morning, the kitchen staff of the Office of Presentations would go out again to purchase ingredients, and Fan Changyu could change her clothes and blend in with them then.

Fan Changyu was half-leaning against Xie Zheng's chest. Having just broken someone out of prison this night, she wasn't sleepy at all. It was just that the way Xie Zheng was holding the back of her neck made it a bit difficult for her to look up. She could only tilt her head up at an awkward angle and say, "I'm not sleepy right now. Since the steward of the Changxin Prince Manor is also in the great prison, why don't we strike while the iron is hot and break him out too?"

When she said this with her large, clear eyes full of sincerity, she looked rather like a teacher's most diligent and earnest student suddenly

announcing with a straight face that he was going to commit murder and arson.

Xie Zheng's hand, which had been stroking her long hair, paused. He was silent for several breaths.

Fan Changyu asked awkwardly, "Is that not possible?"

Xie Zheng raised a hand to press his temple. When he looked down at her, the corners of his mouth lifted slightly without him realizing it. "Not tonight. The Court of Revision is unlike the prisons of other yamen. Once it's on high alert, not even a fly can hope to get out. Although many soldiers are out searching the city for the prison breakers tonight, most of them are from the Five Cities Patrol Command. The Court of Revision will not weaken its defenses. To attempt another prison break now would be walking right into a trap."

Fan Changyu said sheepishly, "Alright then."

She wasn't very clear on the deployment of military forces in the capital and had thought that since many of the Court of Revision's soldiers had been lured away tonight, it would be a perfect, unexpected opportunity for another prison break.

Xie Zheng glanced at her and asked, "It seems you haven't been studying your art of war very diligently?"

Fan Changyu scratched her hair. "How long have I been back in the capital? I'm trapped in the Office of Presentations every day, so I'm just not very clear on the respective duties of the Capital Offices. In the army, I would naturally not be so rash. A single battle concerns the lives of hundreds, even thousands of soldiers! I wouldn't have even suggested this if I weren't certain that with our skills, even if we failed to break the steward out, we would never fall into the hands of the soldiers."

Xie Zheng then asked, "Have you finished reading those books on military strategy I gave you?"

Fan Changyu unconsciously straightened her back, like a student being quizzed on poetry by her teacher. "I've finished two. I've just started the third one."

"Which two have you read?"

Just as Fan Changyu was about to answer Xie Zheng's question, a clamor erupted outside.

"Open up, open up!"

"Officer... this... this won't do! The guests staying at this humble inn are all resting. How can we disturb their sweet dreams in the middle of the night?"

"The Court of Revision has lost a major criminal of the court, and we must now conduct a house-to-house search. If any of you dare to obstruct us, you will all be treated as accomplices of criminals designated by the Emperor!"

Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng were both martial artists with extremely sharp hearing. The moment they heard the commotion outside, their expressions turned grim.

The soldiers had already entered the courtyard. If they went out now, they would surely be discovered. If they were recognized, all their previous efforts would be for naught.

As the soldiers' footsteps approached, Xie Zheng moved with extreme speed. With a flick of his sleeve, he extinguished the candle and looked up at Fan Changyu. "Pour the hot tea from the teapot into the washbasin and replace it with the cold water from there."

Fan Changyu picked up the teapot from the table, poured all the tea into a potted plant in the room, and then filled the pot with the cold water from the basin.

The tea had been brewed by the old man at the inn when he showed them in. Fan Changyu didn't know what Xie Zheng was up to, but with the situation so urgent, she didn't have time to ask and simply did as she was told.

By the time she placed the teapot back on the table, Xie Zheng had already fumbled with and activated some mechanism at the head of the bed. Fan Changyu heard the faint, muffled sound of a stone slab sliding.

By the torchlight shining in from the door and windows, she could just make out that one side of the bed platform had sunk, revealing a hidden compartment barely large enough for two people to lie down in.

Xie Zheng looked at her. "Hide inside."

Just as Fan Changyu lay down, Xie Zheng also activated the mechanism and stepped in.

In a space the size of a coffin, the addition of another person instantly made it as cramped as could be.

Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng were practically neck to neck, shoulder to shoulder. The sound of each other's breathing became clearly audible in the confined space.

Thankfully, it was pitch black inside the hidden compartment, so neither could see the other's face. Staring at each other like this, one on top of the other, would have been far too awkward otherwise.

Fan Changyu caught the faint scent of soap beans on Xie Zheng's clothes, which was tinged with the sharp chill of ice and snow, perhaps due to the harsh winter. He didn't dare put his full weight on her, using one hand to prop himself up slightly, but in this narrow space, the position was undoubtedly strenuous.

Fan Changyu hesitated for a moment before saying, "Why don't I be on top?"

Even though she couldn't see her hand in front of her face, Fan Changyu felt Xie Zheng seem to turn his head sharply to look at her. Because she couldn't see, her perception of her surroundings relied solely on instinct, and the feeling of being stared at by a wild beast in the dark grew more and more distinct. The fine hairs on her arms stood up involuntarily.

When Xie Zheng gripped her waist, her entire body tensed up.

After they had switched positions with some difficulty, both of them were sweating. Fan Changyu thought it must be due to the lack of air circulation; the small, hidden chamber was hot enough to make one's heart race.

She pricked up her ears, trying hard to listen to the commotion outside, but her heart was beating faster at an inopportune moment. She didn't know if it was because her nerves were too taut or for some other reason.

But the drum-like heartbeat was so loud that Fan Changyu suspected Xie Zheng could hear it.

However, it seemed Xie Zheng also had a drum tucked inside his chest; she could hear it with particular clarity as she lay on him.

It wasn't beating as fast as hers, but each beat was extremely heavy, as if it were trying to pound on someone's heart.

Xie Zheng's breathing remained steady, but the breath he exhaled against her ear seemed to have grown hotter.

Fan Changyu's ears were very sensitive, and she subconsciously tried to pull away.

But she had only moved her head a tiny bit when Xie Zheng pressed down hard on her shoulder. His voice was very calm, but in order to keep it low, it was much huskier than usual. "Don't move."

At that very moment, a loud bang came from outside. The door had clearly been kicked open violently.

Fan Changyu instantly dared not move again. She remained lying on Xie Zheng, concentrating on the sounds from outside.

"Officer, this room is empty, no guests are staying here yet!" The innkeeper, who had been following them with a pounding heart, saw that the room showed no signs of being occupied. His eyes flickered, and he immediately began to wail and plead poverty.

The minor officer leading the search ignored him, letting his subordinates roughly open every box and cabinet in the room. After feeling the bedding on the bed for any residual warmth, they yanked it all onto the floor.

Seeing them start to handle the vases and jars on the shelves, as if looking for hidden mechanisms or secret compartments, the innkeeper cried out, "Aiyo, Officer, gently, please! Those are porcelain from the Ge Kiln! If they break, this humble one won't be able to answer to the owner..."

The minor officer still showed no intention of restraining his men. He sat down on a stool with his legs wide apart and lifted the lid of the teapot on the table.

Lying on Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu had just breathed a sigh of relief when the footsteps of the soldiers searching by the bed moved away. But then, a loud crash of shattering porcelain came from outside, followed by a soldier's sharp shout, "How audacious!"

Her heart gave another jolt, and her fingertips unconsciously clenched Xie Zheng's lapel.

As if sensing her nervousness, Xie Zheng's hand on her shoulder moved to the nape of her neck, pressing her to stay as close to him as possible.

His scorching fingers made contact with her delicate skin. Though there was no further transgression, the heat still made Fan Changyu instinctively shrink her neck.

The tip of her nose lightly brushed against the side of Xie Zheng's neck, and his breathing instantly grew heavy.

Fan Changyu felt as if heat was constantly radiating from his body. Her hand was on his chest, and through his not-so-thick arrow-sleeved long robe, she could even feel the sweat underneath.

Why was he still sweating?

Was it because the space was too small and they were squeezed together, making it too hot?

Fan Changyu thought about discreetly moving a little farther away from him to give him more room to breathe, but the hand on the back of her neck was like a branding iron, holding her firmly in place, even showing signs of tightening its grip.

Outside, the innkeeper's terrified voice rang out, "Officer, what's wrong?"

Fan Changyu no longer had the mind to move and just listened intently.

The minor officer slammed his fan-sized palm heavily on the round table. "I've been searching for a criminal late into the night and came here wanting a sip of hot tea. Not only is the tea in your pot cold, you old man, but it has no tea flavor at all. How dare you show such disrespect?"

How could the innkeeper not understand the officer's underlying meaning? Those soldiers from the Five Cities Patrol Command often used various pretexts to extort money from merchants. A search like tonight's would certainly yield nothing from ordinary households, but in a place like an inn or a restaurant where all sorts of people gathered, even if no one was found, the head officer had to be shown some respect.

The innkeeper's face remained terrified, but his eyes had already calmed. He immediately cursed, "Where has that lazy waiter slacked off to again? He didn't even change the pot of cold tea in the room?"

Then he bowed and scraped to the minor officer, "Calm your anger, Officer, calm your anger. This humble one will have someone brew the best tea in the inn for you right away."

While flattering him, he didn't forget to slip a purse into the officer's hand.

The minor officer weighed the purse in his hand, and the anger on his face finally dissipated a little. "Alright, this officer still has important search duties to attend to. I don't have time to drink your tea!"

With that, he stood up to leave. The subordinates who had been rummaging through the room and found nothing followed him out.

The innkeeper glanced at the space under the bed from the corner of his eye before bowing and closing the door as he left, continuing to speak flattering words to see the officer off.

Inside the room, Fan Changyu heard the soldiers' footsteps fading into the distance and let out a huge sigh of relief. Her forehead was covered in a thin layer of sweat, whether from the stuffiness or the heat, she didn't know.

She whispered to Xie Zheng, "They're gone."

The man beneath her didn't answer.

Finding it strange, Fan Changyu reached out a hand to fumble along the stone wall, trying to find the switch to open the hidden compartment and get out. But the hand on the back of her neck suddenly exerted force, a force so fierce and imbued with such resolution that it inexplicably struck a chord of fear in her.

But in the tiny space, even struggling was impossible. She could only be forced to lower her head as her lips were captured in a somewhat savage kiss. It was the kind of kiss that seemed to want to tear her apart and devour her whole. Her teeth were quickly and roughly forced open, and a tongue invaded.

Xie Zheng was like a wild wolf that had starved through an entire harsh winter, then stared at a piece of plump meat for three days without taking a bite. The moment his reason gave out, he could finally no longer suppress the hunger rising from his very bones and bared his sharp teeth to tear into his prey.

Chapter 148

When Zhao Xun received news that the soldiers had withdrawn and rushed back, he saw that the lights in the room were still out.

To prevent the mother and son from being found by the soldiers, he had personally taken them to a secret room beneath the inn, leaving only the innkeeper to deal with things here.

Seeing that there was still no sign of movement in the room, he didn't dare to push the door open rashly. He simply stood outside, cupped his hands, and said, "My lord, my lady, the soldiers who were searching have all left."

The heavy sound of a stone chamber opening came from within the room, accompanied by a dull thud, as if something had slammed hard against a stone wall.

Zhao Xun stood outside the door with his hands cupped, feeling puzzled but not daring to be curious. He just waited quietly to be summoned.

After a good while, the door finally opened. He glanced over without a change in expression and saw that the Wu'an Marquis and the General of the Cloud Banner both looked as normal as ever. The Marquis, likely for the convenience of returning later, was wearing his mask again, while the General of the Cloud Banner's expression was somewhat stern and cold.

After that single glance, Zhao Xun quickly lowered his head again and said, "It will be the fifth watch of the night in half a quarter-hour. A carriage has been prepared at the inn's entrance as the Marquis previously instructed."

As he spoke, he shot a look outside the door. A serving girl immediately entered carrying clothes, respectfully placed them on the table, and then tiptoed back out.

Zhao Xun said, "These are the clothes prepared for the Marquis and the General."

In front of outsiders, to avoid exposing Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng's identities, he addressed them as "my lord" and "my lady." Only when no

one else was around did he use their official titles as a form of respect.

After Zhao Xun withdrew, Xie Zheng stripped off his outer robe, picked up the clothes from the tray, threw them on, and fastened the leather belt. With that, he was changed. He glanced at Fan Changyu and said tactfully, "I'll wait for you outside."

After the door opened and closed again, Fan Changyu picked up the other set of clothes on the tray and ground her back teeth.

That man was no better than a dog!

In the middle of kissing, he had started biting her, as if he wished he could swallow her whole.

As she took off her outer robe and put on the guard uniform, the flickering candlelight illuminated the porcelain-white skin of her neck, making the two red marks on her collarbone particularly glaring. Further down, another mark was half-hidden by the collar of her inner garment, inevitably sparking one's imagination as to whether there were similar marks on the skin completely covered by her clothes.

On the way back to the Office of Presentations, Fan Changyu feigned sleep in the carriage the entire time, not even giving Xie Zheng a single glance as they were about to enter the main gate.

Inside the carriage, Xie Zheng watched her back as she disappeared into the crowd of guards, a silent smile tugging at his lips.

Had he angered her a bit too much?

But after they had parted at the suburban estate last time, the next time he saw her was just yesterday. He felt that the little favor he had collected was far from enough.

Having played the thief for a whole night, Fan Changyu simply washed up and fell asleep the moment her head hit the pillow. When she woke up again, it was almost noon.

She had just finished a meal that served as both breakfast and lunch when someone from Tang Peiyi's side came, saying there was an urgent matter and asking her to go over.

Fan Changyu changed into a set of robes suitable for receiving guests and went to Tang Peiyi's courtyard.

Only upon entering did she realize that He Xiujun and Zheng Wenchang were also there, though all of them looked terrible.

Seeing her arrive, Tang Peiyi ordered his attendants, "Bring General Fan a seat."

A servant in the room brought a chair and placed it next to He Xiujun. After Fan Changyu sat down, she asked, "Has something happened at court again?"

Tang Peiyi slammed his palm on the table with a heavy thud and said angrily, "That Wei Yan is simply outrageously arrogant! Yesterday, in broad daylight, he had a key suspect tortured to death, and then at night, he dared to storm the Court of Revision's prison to break someone out! Does he think the world belongs to the Wei family now?"

Fan Changyu was drinking the tea a servant had handed her. Hearing this, she nearly choked, coughing several times before she recovered.

Facing the gazes of Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and Zheng Wenchang, Fan Changyu felt a pang of guilt. She then placed her teacup heavily on the table and, with an honest-looking face, said, "That's truly too much!"

Only then did the three men retract their gazes.

He Xiujun noticed the faint dark circles under Fan Changyu's eyes and suddenly asked, "Did General Fan not sleep well last night?"

Fan Changyu was not one for lying. She picked up the teacup before her and continued to drink as a cover, saying, "Yes. I was reading a military treatise before bed and found many strategies of attack and stratagem that I didn't understand. I lost track of time while studying them."

Hearing this, He Xiujun grew even more curious. "What military treatise could make General Fan so engrossed as to forget herself?"

Fortunately, she had genuinely read the few military books Xie Zheng had given her a few days ago, so she could now say without blushing or her heart pounding, "I'm ashamed to say, it was the Wuliaozi annotated by the Duke of Wei from the previous dynasty."

Although Xie Zheng had added many new insights on top of those annotations.

He Xiujun said, "No wonder," and smiled. "The Duke of Wei's annotated Wuliaozi is now a sole surviving copy. It's no surprise that General Fan

would forget to eat and sleep after obtaining such a treasure."

Fan Changyu didn't know much about the origins of these military treatises and strategies. She hadn't expected that a book Xie Zheng had casually handed her would be so precious. Surprised, she muttered "I'm ashamed" a few times to placate He Xiujun.

Fearing he would continue to question her, she quickly looked at Tang Peiyi. "Has it been confirmed that it was Wei Yan's men who broke into the prison? Was this matter discussed in the morning court session today?"

Unexpectedly, upon hearing her question, Tang Peiyi turned his head to the side and sighed heavily.

Zheng Wenchang, who was beside them, said, "The Court of Revision joined forces with the Five Cities Patrol Command to search through the night, but they found no evidence. This morning, Minister Han's son was found with his tongue cut out and eyes gouged, hanged in his own room. In the throne hall, Minister Han wept bitterly and begged His Majesty to seek justice, saying his son must have also been killed by Wei Yan, simply because his son had a verbal altercation with Wei Xuan two days ago. But alas, without evidence, there's no way to convict Wei Yan."

Fan Changyu's expression changed instantly.

She already knew that Wei Xuan had gotten into an argument with Minister Han's son and beaten him severely; Zhao Xun had reported it to Xie Zheng last night.

But she had not expected that Minister Han's son would be found dead in his room last night, with his tongue cut out and eyes gouged.

Such cruel methods. Was Wei Yan declaring to all the civil and military officials that his time as the powerful chancellor was not yet over?

Tang Peiyi gave a bitter smile. "The imperial power of the Great Yin has long existed in name only... The current emperor.Sigh..."

Although he didn't say more, everyone present knew what he left unsaid.

Qi Sheng was merely a puppet Wei Yan had placed on the dragon throne. He was still counting on Wei Yan to help him secure his position, so how could he possibly punish Wei Yan?

He Xiujun thought of his father's death, and his hands on the table unconsciously clenched into fists. "If the Li family really finds the

descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince..."

Tang Peiyi immediately cut him off, "Zifu."

Zifu was He Xiujun's courtesy name. He fell silent.

Even if the one sitting on the dragon throne was a monkey, as long as he wore the dragon robe, plotting rebellion was a great crime of disrespect punishable by the extermination of nine generations of one's clan.

Tang Peiyi changed the subject. "Alright, this contest with Wei Yan is not over yet. The war has been tight these past few years, and the national treasury is empty. Word has come from the palace that the victory banquet will be combined with the New Year's banquet. None of you should go out today. Later, people from the palace will come to take your measurements for clothes."

On the way back, Fan Changyu was fraught with worry.

When the Li family impeached Wei Yan, Xie Zheng had said that Wei Yan surely had other moves up his sleeve. Now, at this critical juncture, he dared to order his subordinates to directly kill the son of a third-rank court official. His actions could be described as ruthless and arrogant.

Was he certain that the Court of Revision couldn't find any evidence to convict him, or had he truly become so arrogant that he wouldn't care even if the Court of Revision had both witnesses and material evidence in hand?

If it was the former, it meant Wei Yan still had some reservations.

If it was the latter... what Wei Yan had been plotting after lying low for so long was truly terrifying to contemplate.

Zheng Wenchang came out a step behind her and called out, "General Fan, please wait."

Fan Changyu temporarily reined in her thoughts and turned back to ask, "Does General Zheng need something?"

Zheng Wenchang was a man of few words, but he had a diligent nature. Among He Jingyuan's disciples, his aptitude was not the best, but because of his diligence and hard work, as well as his honest and upright character, he was highly regarded by He Jingyuan.

He said somewhat shyly, "This humble general takes the liberty of asking to borrow the Duke of Wei's annotated Wuliaozi from General Fan for a day."

As if afraid that Fan Changyu hadn't finished reading it and would be reluctant to part with the treasure, he quickly added, "Borrowing it for one night is also fine. This humble general will return it to General Fan tomorrow morning after I've finished copying it."

Since he had put it that way, how could Fan Changyu refuse?

She said, "Alright. I'll have someone send the book to General Zheng's courtyard when I get back. The General doesn't need to rush to return it to me; take your time copying it."

Sole surviving copies were precious, and it was common for people of that time to copy books to circulate and read.

Hearing Fan Changyu's words, Zheng Wenchang felt as if a great weight had been lifted from his heart. He expressed his thanks and returned to his own courtyard, his face glowing.

When Fan Changyu returned, she found the book in her room and had Xie Wu deliver it to Zheng Wenchang.

Just then, the matrons from the palace who were to take her measurements for her court robes arrived. Fan Changyu held out her arms and let them measure her with a soft ruler, but she noticed it was different from when tailor ladies usually took her measurements for ordinary clothes.

The matrons from the Department of Palace Apparel were as meticulous as could be, measuring everything from her forehead down to her ankles, and even taking a measurement around her ribs.

Fan Changyu guessed the ankle measurement was for custom-made official boots, but the head circumference? She was a military official and didn't need to wear an official's hat. What were they measuring her head for?

Fan Changyu had a straightforward personality and asked right away.

The matron in charge of the measurements was a stern-faced woman, but she didn't dare to put on airs in front of a third-rank military general like Fan Changyu. She replied respectfully, "The General also has a set of second-rank imperial decree of honor ceremonial robes that need to be tailored. This head circumference is for making the phoenix coronet."

The headdress that went with the ceremonial robes of a lady with an imperial decree of honor was a phoenix coronet inlaid with pearls and jade.

If Fan Changyu were still an unmarried maiden, the emperor would not have conferred an imperial decree of honor upon her. But because she had previously entered into a fake marriage with Xie Zheng, which was officially recorded at the Ministry of Revenue, and had personally admitted in the throne hall that she had a husband, she was granted this additional honor.

Knowing the purpose of this measurement, Fan Changyu asked no more questions and cooperated with the matrons as they continued to measure.

After each measurement was taken, the matron would quietly instruct a serving girl beside her to record it on paper.

Changning, led by Aunt Zhao, watched from the side, her eyes sparkling and her face flushed with excitement.

Only after the people from the palace had finished their measurements and left did she run over and throw herself into Fan Changyu's arms. "Are they going to make new clothes for Big Sister?"

Fan Changyu said, "They are court robes."

Changning didn't quite understand. She wrapped her hands around Fan Changyu's waist, tilted her head up, and continued to ask, "What are court robes?"

"They are the clothes you wear to see the emperor."

Changning said, "Oh," then asked, "Can Ning Niang see the emperor then?"

Aunt Zhao laughed. "You silly girl, what nonsense are you talking about? The emperor isn't someone just anyone can see. Only high-ranking officials can."

Changning let out a slightly disappointed "Oh," then immediately asked, "Then can Ning Niang become a high-ranking official?"

Fan Changyu squatted down and stroked her head. "Not right now. But if Ning Niang studies hard, by the time you grow up, perhaps women will also be able to enter officialdom."

Having come this far, besides wanting to uncover the truth behind the events in Jinzhou and clear her maternal grandfather's name, Fan Changyu also wanted to add a clause to the Great Yin Law: that women could also inherit their parents' property and establish their own households.

The ones who had nearly driven her and Changning to desperation were the Fan Da family, who had tried to seize the house her parents left behind by relying on the law.

She was resilient and could take a beating. No matter how many pits and bumps were on this road, she had stumbled her way through. But in this world, there were many orphaned girls who had not made it through.

As if encouraged by Fan Changyu's words, Changning immediately started clamoring, "Big Sister, Big Sister, please hire a teacher for Ning Niang! Ning Niang wants to study!"

When Fan Changyu had free time, she could teach the two little ones, but when she was busy, she naturally couldn't manage.

She figured that the palace wouldn't be transferring them out anytime soon, so she said, "Alright. I'll hire a teacher for you tomorrow."

Changning's smile nearly split her face. She tugged on Fan Changyu's sleeve and shook it. "Big Sister is the best!"

Seeing Changning bouncing off to find Yu Bao'er to tell him the good news, Fan Changyu couldn't help but shake her head and chuckle.

Just then, Xie Wu returned from delivering the book. Fan Changyu said to him, "Xiao Wu, keep an eye out for any suitable teachers in the capital. I want to hire a private tutor for Changning and Bao'er to teach them reading and writing for now."

After a pause, she added, "There's no need to hire those famous, profoundly learned teachers. The two children are still young; hiring such a teacher would be a waste of their talent."

Xie Wu agreed to everything, but his expression was a little strange.

Only then did Fan Changyu notice the book in his hand. She asked, puzzled, "Did General Zheng not want it?"

Xie Wu said, "No, that's not it. Back then, Grand Tutor Li's son gifted you several annotated military treatises, and you rewarded them to the generals under you to read. This one was passed to General Zheng. When I went to deliver the book just now, General Zheng had me bring this treatise back, saying he was returning it to you."

Fan Changyu couldn't help but frown. She had almost forgotten about Li Huaian gifting her military books.

She had indeed rewarded those treatises to the men under her command back then. But Zheng Wenchang was a stubborn man; he probably felt bad about borrowing another book from her and so returned this one.

Fan Changyu didn't think much of it. "Forget it. Just put it on the shelf over there."

Xie Wu walked over with the military treatise and glanced at the books Fan Changyu often read on the shelf. Among them were the Four Books that Xie Zheng had annotated for her at the very beginning, as well as the military treatises he had annotated for her later.

Xie Wu hesitated for a moment, then chose the most obscure corner and placed Li Huaian's annotated military treatise there.

In the blink of an eye, it was the day of the New Year's banquet.

What Fan Changyu heard from Tang Peiyi every day was still the Wei Faction and the Li Faction arguing endlessly at court, each sticking to their own views.

But with the deterrent of the tragic death of Minister Han's son, no one, from the imperial court down to the common folk, dared to openly criticize Wei Yan anymore.

Xie Zheng had to prepare for his nighttime investigation of the Cold Palace and deal with the steward he had broken out of the Court of Revision's prison. In the meantime, he was also secretly investigating Grand Tutor Tao's whereabouts. He was too busy to spare a moment, and with various factions watching him closely, he had only managed to sneak into the Office of Presentations to see Fan Changyu once, bringing her a dagger that could cut through iron like mud as a gift.

On the night she was to enter the palace, for some unknown reason, Fan Changyu's left eyelid kept twitching.

Xie Zheng had many plans in place for this New Year's Eve. Fearing an accident, Fan Changyu strapped a small boning knife to her left leg and the dagger that could cut through iron like mud to her right leg before setting out, thinking that if anything happened, she would at least have a sharp weapon for self-defense.

She gave both Changning and Yu Bao'er a large lucky red envelope before finally getting into the carriage bound for the palace with Tang Peiyi

and the others, under Changning's expectant gaze.

Chapter 149

The palace banquet was held in the Hall of Supreme Harmony, an outer court feast where only the emperor and his ministers gathered to dine.

Before entering the grand hall, eunuchs led attendants carrying trays to collect the swords from the military officials one by one.

It was during her first audience with the emperor that Fan Changyu realized they only verified waist tokens and confiscated visible weapons carried on their persons, without conducting individual body searches. Thus, she had strapped a dagger to her leg before leaving home.

Once her long boots were on, no one could tell.

After all, aside from the nobility, those who attended court audiences or tonight's banquet were all distinguished ministers of high rank. If every court session or palace feast required body searches of the officials before they could enter the hall, it would not only be time-consuming and laborious but also damage the dignity of the ministers and the bond between ruler and subject.

The rule prohibiting military officials from carrying weapons into the hall, established across dynasties, served two purposes: to prevent disrespect toward the emperor and to guard against military officials threatening the emperor within the hall.

But what could a single blade brought into the hall truly accomplish for those with rebellious intentions? If someone sought to force the emperor's hand, they would have surely turned the entire Golden Guard of the palace to their side.

Ordinary ministers would never dare risk their heads by secretly bringing weapons into the hall.

Hence, the palace had never instituted body searches for ministers—such treatment was reserved only for low-ranking palace maids and eunuchs.

Fan Changyu's previous visit to the palace had been during the day, when the entire complex already appeared majestic and solemn. Tonight,

with heavy snow swirling, the palace city blazed with lights, hidden within the boundless night like a colossal beast whose scorched hide had cracked open, revealing the glowing red embers beneath—both magnificent and eerily awe-inspiring.

Yet in the shadows untouched by the lights, there lingered endless scars and gloom.

Upon entering the grand hall of Supreme Harmony, attendants guided the ministers to their respective seats.

Civil officials were seated on the left, military officials on the right.

The seats for the Three Excellencies, Nine Ministers, and imperial relatives were all at the front. As a third-rank official, Fan Changyu was led by a eunuch to a middle seat on the right side.

In the entire hall, whether among civil or military officials, Fan Changyu was the only woman.

Her arrival drew gazes from all directions—some curious, others appraising.

Though the courtiers had seen her once before in the throne hall during the court session, she had stood at the very front with Tang Peiyi and others to meet the emperor. Those toward the back could only glimpse the crimson cloak trailing behind her armor. Tonight marked the first time many of these officials truly laid eyes on Fan Changyu.

Kneeling gracefully before the redwood low table, Fan Changyu remained composed and serene. The third-rank scarlet military robe she wore lent her a unique air of valor. Her back was straight as a rod, like a verdant bamboo growing ruggedly among cliffs—having weathered countless trials to root deep and rise tall, she now stood unyielding, showing no trace of timidity among these seasoned ministers.

The emperor had yet to arrive, and the foremost seats in both sections remained empty. The atmosphere in the hall was relatively relaxed, with familiar ministers chatting in small groups.

Fan Changyu had intended to wait quietly for the banquet to begin, but unexpectedly, an unfamiliar young military officer strode directly to her table. "I've long admired General Fan's reputation. During our brief encounter in the throne hall, I barely caught a glimpse of you. Tonight, I'm honored to see you again. Let me toast to you!"

With that, he raised his cup with both hands and drained it in one go, then turned it upside down to show Fan Changyu.

His gesture carried an unmistakable implication: if she refused to drink, she would be slighting him.

At the previous victory banquet in Lucheng, Fan Changyu had been able to decline drinks by citing her injuries, but tonight's palace banquet was attended by officials of at least the fifth rank, making it difficult to refuse such toasts.

The generals in Lucheng had merely been overly enthusiastic, but this military officer came to propose a toast even before the banquet began. Even someone as thick-skinned as Fan Changyu could sense the undercurrents.

Her gaze swept over the officer's fourth-rank court robes as she simply said, "You flatter me, General."

She picked up the cup before her, tilted her head back to drink, then turned it upside down just as the other had done.

The officer immediately praised her: "General Fan has an impressive capacity!"

He Xiujun also noticed something amiss. Worried other officers might approach Fan Changyu to drink, he stood with his cup and said, "General Song, won't you share a drink with me?"

Zheng Wenchang rose as well: "Who do you think you're looking down on? I contributed no less than General Fan in suppressing the rebellion in Chongzhou. General Song, you must drink with me too!"

With Zheng Wenchang's words, the other generals who had come to the capital from Jizhou for the investiture also clamored to drink with the officer.

This time it was the officer's turn to be unable to refuse. He was forced to down seven or eight cups before being allowed to return to his seat.

After this commotion, others who had intended to propose toasts realized that anyone who drank with Fan Changyu would inevitably be subjected to another round from He Xiujun and his group. Not daring to be too bold before the banquet officially began, no one else approached Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu gave Zheng Wenchang a surprised glance. She had previously thought him too rigid, but tonight he proved quite sharp—his act as one of those rough military men was quite convincing.

He Xiujun's seat was next to Fan Changyu's. When things quieted down, he lowered his voice and said, "His Majesty's praise for our Jizhou army in the Golden Hall likely left many generals dissatisfied. They'll surely try to get us thoroughly drunk at tonight's banquet."

Only then did Fan Changyu understand why that officer had suddenly come to propose a toast.

The toast was just a pretext—their real aim was to take turns drinking and intimidate them.

Fortunately, He Xiujun and Zheng Wenchang were sharp enough to block it in time.

Fan Changyu gave a slight nod and said, "I understand."

Her gaze swept across the hall as she considered that those who would actively propose toasts would likely be officials of lower rank or equal standing. Those of higher rank probably wouldn't stoop to such behavior.

As for the lower-ranking officers, their united front from Jizhou should be able to handle them.

Before long, Xie Zheng and Grand Tutor Li arrived at the banquet one after another.

Once again, they met at the entrance of the Taiji Palace hall.

Grand Tutor Li maintained his usual refined demeanor, greeting mildly, "Marquis."

Xie Zheng wore the black court robes of the Martial Marquis, the golden and crimson cloud patterns embroidered on his knee panels shimmering faintly under the candlelight—so intricate they were dizzying. His jade-like face bore a trace of cold weariness as he lazily lifted his eyelids and said, "What a coincidence, meeting you again, Grand Tutor."

He stepped slightly aside, though his tone held none of the respect his words suggested: "As a grand tutor who has served three reigns, you should enter first."

Grand Tutor Li replied, "The Marquis's military achievements are unparalleled, and your contributions in suppressing the rebellion were

extraordinary. Tonight's New Year banquet is also a victory celebration—you should enter first."

Compared to Xie Zheng's arrogance and disrespect, Grand Tutor Li's demeanor could be described as modest and yielding. The faction members following him all wore expressions of indignation. Li Yuanting, who would usually be the first to speak up in such situations, remained unexpectedly silent this time.

Xie Zheng's gaze swept past Grand Tutor Li and landed on Li Yuanting, his eyes flashing with cold mockery.

He said, "Since the Grand Tutor is so accommodating, this Marquis will not decline out of courtesy."

With that, he stepped into the grand hall. One of Grand Tutor Li's disciples, unable to contain his anger, moved forward to speak but was immediately stopped by the Grand Tutor's raised hand.

The outspoken official asked in confusion, "Grand Tutor, are we to tolerate such arrogance? Even Wei Yan never behaved like this in your presence."

Grand Tutor Li's aged eyes, tinged with a faint blue-gray hue, exuded an indescribable coldness. "Youthful arrogance will have its moment, but it will eventually lead to a fall."

The officials of the Li faction exchanged varied expressions at these ambiguous words.

As Xie Zheng and Grand Tutor Li took their seats, the previously noisy Taihe Palace fell silent.

Fan Changyu glanced toward Xie Zheng's seat. Perhaps because she hadn't seen him in a long time, or perhaps it was her first time seeing him in court robes, she found herself momentarily stunned.

She had always believed that the saying "clothes make the man" didn't apply to Xie Zheng. With his naturally striking appearance, even dressed in beggar's rags, he would exude an air of nobility. But these Martial Marquis court robes suited him far too well.

The gold and red embroidery on the black robes shimmered faintly under the candlelight of the hall, making his dark eyes even more intense and his cold demeanor even more pronounced.

As if sensing Fan Changyu's gaze, Xie Zheng turned his eyes toward her, a subtle ripple of emotion flickering in their depths.

She likely didn't realize how dashing and heroic she looked in her crimson military official robes.

All the young noblemen of the capital combined couldn't match the vitality and brightness that seemed to radiate from her brow like the morning sun.

Amid the crowded banquet, their gazes met only briefly before parting, yet Fan Changyu's heart still skipped a beat.

When the emperor arrived, the officials rose and bowed as a mere formality.

Fan Changyu noticed that the officials seemed to hold more reverence for Xie Zheng and Grand Tutor Li than for the emperor himself.

Wei Yan, still claiming illness, was absent from the New Year's banquet. Grand Tutor Li's seat should have been the first among the civil officials, but he had it moved back two feet, not presuming to take Wei Yan's place directly.

Fan Changyu couldn't tell whether this was caution or pretense on Grand Tutor Li's part.

He was the one who had dug the pit for Wei Yan and impeached him. The position seemed within his grasp, yet he adhered strictly to protocol, never overstepping.

It could only be said that this man was exceedingly patient and profoundly calculating.

Perhaps because Fan Changyu had been staring at Grand Tutor Li for too long, the elderly man, who had been eating only soft and easily digestible food, suddenly glanced in her direction.

Fan Changyu didn't avert her gaze, meeting his eyes directly.

One pair of eyes appeared gentle yet fathomless, the other pure and resolute, as if harboring a blazing sun within.

In the end, Grand Tutor Li was the first to look away, his withered hand picking up a pair of wooden chopsticks to slowly eat a bite of bland vegetables.

A crisp sound of shattering porcelain suddenly came from the side where the military officials were seated.

A serving eunuch accidentally spilled wine on Xie Zheng's court robes, startling him so much that his hands trembled, causing the wine jug he was holding to fall to the ground.

All eyes in the banquet hall turned toward the commotion.

The eunuch's face turned deathly pale. Ignoring the spilled wine on the floor, he kowtowed repeatedly like pounding garlic, begging for mercy: "Spare me, Marquis! Spare me, Marquis!"

The emperor seated on the dragon throne observed this scene with barely concealed excitement in his eyes. He immediately called for the Golden Guard outside the hall: "Guards! Drag this slave who dirtied Wu'an Marquis's robes out and behead him!"

The officials stirred with unease, yet none dared to speak in defense.

Fan Changyu, sensing Xie Zheng would likely use this opportunity to leave the banquet, had just frowned when she heard Xie Zheng's cold, unhurried voice: "It was merely spilled wine. Since this is the New Year's banquet, it would be best to avoid bloodshed. Don't you agree, Your Majesty?"

Qi Sheng had no intention of prolonging this matter with Xie Zheng and immediately said, "Since Wu'an Marquis has pleaded for this foolish slave, shouldn't you express your gratitude?"

The eunuch kowtowed frantically: "Thank you, Your Majesty! Thank you, Wu'an Marquis!"

Suppressing the malice in his heart and the wild joy of nearing some desired outcome, Qi Sheng maintained a composed expression as he instructed the eunuch: "Escort Wu'an Marquis to change his robes."

This entire scene had been part of Xie Zheng's plan. After thanking the emperor with a "Gratitude, Your Majesty," he followed the eunuch out of the grand hall.

With Xie Zheng gone, Qi Sheng seemed noticeably happier. In excellent spirits, he raised his cup to the officials: "Since my ascension, Great Yin has faced endless external threats and internal troubles. Thanks to all my loyal ministers, our nation stands strong today, and I have not failed my

ancestors' legacy. Tonight, my ministers shall drink heartily—no one leaves sober!"

His sudden speech naturally compelled the officials to raise their cups in response.

Grand Tutor Li said, "Your Majesty's wisdom is our fortune."

The officials echoed loudly: "Your Majesty is wise!"

Fan Changyu couldn't help but find the word "wise" somewhat ironic when applied to Qi Sheng.

After offering her toast, she returned to her seat, only for her eyelids to begin twitching uncontrollably again.

Chapter 150

A cold moon hung in the sky, its jade-like light spilling down the long flight of stairs.

Fine snowflakes drifted slowly under the dim yellow palace lanterns, landing on black satin boots and instantly melting into faint, damp marks.

A young eunuch led Xie Zheng toward a side hall, a fawning smile on his face. "My Lord Marquis, please watch your step."

A greatcloak edged with fox fur was draped over Xie Zheng's shoulders. His posture was as straight as a pine tree, and the moonlight plating his profile made him appear all the more cold and handsome. A soft "en" escaped his nose.

From beneath his wide, gold-embroidered sleeve, he flicked a pebble. It struck a snow-laden branch not far away. The branch trembled, instantly shaking off its blanket of snow. Startled, the young eunuch craned his neck to look, shouting sharply, "Who's there?"

The next moment, the young eunuch felt a sharp pain at the back of his neck and lost consciousness.

Xie Zheng picked up the lantern the eunuch had dropped. He lifted the cover, blew out the candle inside, then single-handedly hoisted the eunuch up and propped him against a pillar outside a palace hall.

After doing all this, Xie Zheng raised his eyes and swept his cold gaze around the area before yanking off his greatcloak and court robes.

Beneath his robes, he was wearing a night suit.

He took a disguise mask from his robes and put it on, then hid his court attire in a cavity within a rockery in the imperial garden. Following a palace map he had long since memorized, he avoided the patrolling guards, scaled a high wall, and in a few leaps and bounds, arrived at the Cold Palace.

Compared to the festive lanterns and decorations of the other palaces, the Cold Palace was frighteningly desolate. Even the lantern at the main

gate, which cast a palm-sized yellow glow, was covered in dust and draped with cobwebs.

The residents of this Cold Palace were all concubines who had committed grave offenses. They were either mad or dead, and rumors claimed the place was haunted. Aside from the palace staff on duty who would come to toss in food as if feeding dogs, not even the lowest-ranking eunuchs and maids were willing to spare it a second glance.

Following the intelligence provided by the Grand Princess, Xie Zheng vaulted over the high wall of the Cold Palace and easily found the mad palace maid's residence in the Outer Dormitory.

The small room was similarly filled with dust and cobwebs. The only piece of furniture seemed to be the bed by the window. By the moonlight, one could see dry straw peeking out from under the thin, partially uncovered mattress. The palace maid was curled up asleep on it, covered only by a tattered, mildew-spotted thin quilt.

A faint smell of burnt incense and candles lingered in the room. Veneration was forbidden in the palace, so it was likely this maid had been secretly burning ghost money for someone in her own room.

Xie Zheng unfurled the soft sword wrapped around his arm and pointed it directly at the back of the maid's neck. "I know you're awake. If you want to live, don't turn around. I only have one question."

"Who was the imperial concubine who had an affair with Wei Yan back then?"

The palace maid seemed terrified, her body trembling like a sieve. "It was... it was..."

The turn of events happened in an instant. The maid suddenly whipped her head around and flung a handful of powder at Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng quickly turned his head to avoid it, closing his eyes and holding his breath in time to prevent inhaling the unknown powder or getting it in his eyes. The maid, however, seized the opportunity to pull a dagger from under her pillow and stab at him. Xie Zheng instinctively raised his arm to block, sending her flying several meters away.

The maid's back slammed against the wall before she tumbled to the ground, a trickle of blood seeping from the corner of her mouth. Yet, there was no ferocity in her eyes, only boundless seduction. She used her finger

to wipe away the trace of blood from her lips and licked it, her gaze hooking Xie Zheng like a fishhook as she whined, "You're so strong. You've hurt me."

Her voice was sickeningly sweet, like downing a pot of sugar boiled into a thick syrup.

When the maid removed her two fingers from her mouth, they were slick with saliva. She tugged at her clothes, pulling them down bit by bit, and giggled. "Do you want to see where you hurt me?"

Xie Zheng's eyes held only the deep disgust of watching a maggot squirm in a gutter. He sheathed his sword and turned to leave, but the sound of chains came from the main door.

Xie Zheng's eyes turned abruptly sharp. He raised his sword to splinter the door, but in that instant, he found his limbs had gone soft and weak. It was almost impossible to even stand. He braced himself against the wall with one hand, a cold sweat beading on his temple.

The sound of chains also came from the window, followed by a long, thin bamboo tube poking through a small crack. A faint white smoke drifted into the room.

The woman behind him purred, "Are you finding your limbs weak?"

"You've been smelling this Bone-weakening powder since you entered the room. Just now, you fought with me, which accelerated the drug's effect. To think it's only taking hold now... that strong body of yours... it truly makes me crave you..."

The woman simply prostrated herself halfway on the floor, her dark hair unbound. Her plain white nightclothes were open, revealing the bright red dudou and one fragrant shoulder beneath. Her expression was one of unbearable desire as she stared enticingly at Xie Zheng.

Hearing her say he had been smelling it since he entered, Xie Zheng immediately looked at the brazier where the ghost money had been burned. So, the incense and ghost money were to cover up another scent.

The drug took effect as violently as a bursting dam. All the strength in his body seemed to have been drained away. Xie Zheng could no longer even hold himself up against the wall. He slid down to sit, but another reaction was stirring within him. It felt as if a fire was roasting his blood, and his limbs itched as if insects were crawling over them.

It was self-evident what the substance blown in from the bamboo tube was.

The woman also seemed to be affected by the drugged smoke from the tube. Her face, compared to her earlier feigned coquetry, now showed more instinctual reaction. Her seductive eyes were glazed as she slowly crawled toward Xie Zheng. "I feel so awful, help me..."

The drug caused a flush to appear on Xie Zheng's face, even through the disguise mask, but his eyes were unnaturally cold. "Do you want to die?"

His voice was very soft, like the chilling ghostly aura drifting from the River of Oblivion when the gates of the underworld open during the Ghost Festival, sending a shiver up one's spine.

The woman's gaze was already hazy, but his words brought back a sliver of her senses.

She looked at the handsome man sitting at the base of the wall, unable to even stand due to the Bone-weakening powder. What little rationality she had left under the aphrodisiac's influence was quickly consumed. She giggled. "You'll soon want to join me in this mortal ecstasy that is a living death."

Panting, she finally crawled before Xie Zheng. She raised a pair of eyes shimmering with allure, but before she could utter a coquettish complaint, her neck was seized by a large hand that felt like an iron clamp.

The overwhelming scent of blood and the feeling of suffocation finally sobered the woman up. This man had actually dug into his own palm to maintain his clarity!

The woman had not been hit with the Bone-weakening powder and was a trained fighter. She tried to pry Xie Zheng's hand away, only to find it was all in vain.

Xie Zheng gritted his teeth so hard he could taste iron. He stared coldly at the woman struggling in his grasp. "Qi Sheng found a thing like you to impersonate a Cold Palace concubine and replicate Wei Yan's crime on me?"

The woman tried to speak, but only a faint gurgling sound could escape her throat. Her expression shifted from terror to despair. As the fragile bones in her throat broke, Xie Zheng's five fingers gouged several bloody holes directly into the side of her neck.

The woman's eyes were wide open as she collapsed to the floor. The blood flowing from her neck quickly formed a small pool on the ground.

Xie Zheng sat against the wall, panting like a beast. His hand was a bloody mess; it was impossible to tell if the blood was from his own palm or the woman's neck.

The people who had locked the door and window and released the aphrodisiac smoke heard no movement from inside. After a moment's hesitation, one of them unlocked the door, wanting to see what was going on.

However, as he pushed the door open with a lantern in hand, the first thing he saw was the woman's face, her eyes wide open in death, staring toward the door. The eunuch was so frightened his pupils shrank. He hurriedly raised the lantern to find the other person in the room.

A dagger slit his throat, spattering blood. The lantern fell to the ground and was instantly ignited. The firelight illuminated the blood-drenched dagger, its cold, gleaming blade reflecting a pair of grim, icy eyes.

Xie Zheng stepped over the blood-soaked floor and out of the room, blood dripping from the back of his left hand.

The few guards waiting outside the room saw the tragic state of the palace maid and eunuch inside through the wide-open door and couldn't help but feel a chill.

The dose of Bone-weakening powder burned in the room was enough to fell an ox. How could he still walk out? Could he have taken an antidote beforehand?

However, the blood on Xie Zheng's hand and the slight stagger in his steps told them that he had indeed been drugged and was merely forcing himself to stay upright.

The main gate of the Cold Palace had long been locked. One of the guards immediately shouted to a companion behind him, "Set a fire! Draw everyone over here!"

Grand Princess Qi Zhu had been confined by An Taifei for many days.

Tonight was New Year's Eve, and the mother and daughter had only a simple New Year's Eve dinner before An Taifei returned to her small prayer room to continue chanting scriptures.

Qi Zhu was vexed. She flicked her sleeves and left the warm pavilion. An Taifei's old mammy followed her step for step. "Where is the Princess going?"

Having been spoiled for over a decade, Qi Zhu was not one with a good temper. She immediately retorted, "This Princess is feeling stuffed and is going for a walk. Mother has already locked the palace gates, what are you worried about?"

The old mammy was not angered by Qi Zhu's sharp words. She simply curtsied and said, "Then the Princess should take a cloak. The wind and snow are heavy outside, be careful not to catch a chill."

Qi Zhu couldn't be bothered with the people around her mother. Having followed An Taifei for so long, they all seemed to have become bodhisattvas, speaking with the same expression and tone. The sight of them annoyed Qi Zhu to no end.

She took only her personal maids, held her head high, and walked past the mammy.

The old mammy curtsied behind her. "Respectfully seeing the Princess off."

Once outside, Qi Zhu truly felt a bit cold. She stood on a covered bridge, gazing at the cold moon hanging high in the sky, and cradled a bronze, openwork hand warmer, murmuring, "I wonder what that blockhead is doing right now..."

Her voice was too soft for the palace maid standing beside her to hear. The maid asked gently, "What did you say, Princess?"

Qi Zhu pouted. "Nothing. Let's go for a walk in the plum garden."

An Taifei had been favored in her youth. The Late Emperor had specially ordered an entire grove of plum trees to be planted in her palace. Come the harsh winter, the entire garden of plum blossoms would burst into bloom, a breathtaking sight.

Fine snow was falling tonight. The stone paths of the plum grove should have been covered in a thin layer of snow, but the sweeping eunuchs, fearing their masters might have the elegant inclination to admire the plums on New Year's Eve, had cleared the paths early on.

After walking for a while with her maids, Qi Zhu suddenly said, "You all wait here. Don't follow any further. I'm going to hang a sachet for

blessings."

The maids replied in low voices, "Yes."

Qi Zhu walked a short distance alone into the depths of the plum grove and found a branch with exceptionally beautiful blossoms. She took out the sachet filled with her maidenly thoughts from her robes and gently rubbed the embroidery on it. Just as she was about to stand on her toes to hang it, she heard the faint sound of a woman's giggles from behind a rockery obscured by plum branches.

Could someone be having a tryst here?

Qi Zhu's expression changed at once. She was about to erupt, but then she squeezed the sachet in her hand and her expression softened. She intended to pretend she heard nothing and leave, but then she heard a sentence: "Why would I lie to you? The Princess has been watched very closely by the Taifei recently, she hasn't gone anywhere..."

A somewhat effeminate voice sounded, "So no one from the Grand Princess's side has been to the Cold Palace either?"

The woman answered, slightly out of breath, "We servants can't even leave Shouyang Palace without the Taifei's waist token..."

Shouyang was another name for the plum blossom, and An Taifei's palace was named for this very grove.

Qi Zhu shouted sharply, "Who's there? Get out here for this Princess!"

This shout startled not only the man and woman behind the rockery but also the palace staff waiting outside, who hurried over.

Scrambling out from behind the rockery was a palace maid and a eunuch with disheveled clothes. Both were pale with fright and kowtowed to Qi Zhu like pounding garlic. "Princess, spare our lives! Princess, spare our lives!"

Qi Zhu had long known that palace maids and eunuchs sometimes formed eunuch-maid pairings, but at this moment, she only felt disgusted. She recognized the maid as one from her own palace, but the eunuch looked unfamiliar.

She stared coldly at the maid. "You were spying on this Princess?"

The maid trembled like a sieve, her face streaked with tears. "This servant wouldn't dare... This servant wouldn't dare..."

Qi Zhu turned to the eunuch. "Which palace are you from?"

The eunuch glanced up at Qi Zhu before quickly lowering his head again. Though he was afraid, he seemed to have more confidence than the maid. "This servant... this servant is from the Directorate of Ceremonial. Eunuch Gao, who serves His Majesty, is this servant's godfather."

Qi Zhu let out a cold laugh. So, his confidence came from Qi Sheng's head eunuch.

But since he could ask the maid those questions, it was clear that her helping Xie Zheng investigate the mad maid in the Cold Palace had reached Qi Sheng's ears.

A chill shot up her spine, and Qi Zhu felt her knees go weak. She looked at the eunuch with an expression that could eat him alive and ordered sharply, "Tie up this filthy eunuch for this Princess and lock him up!"

Then she turned and strode quickly out of the plum grove, grabbing the hand of one of her trusted maids. "Quick, take my waist token and go to Taiji Palace immediately. Find the General of the Cloud Banner and tell him there's trouble at the Cold Palace!"

The maid ran as fast as she could, but before she could even leave the plum grove, she was stopped by An Taifei and her entourage.

An Taifei looked at her daughter, her elegant face, though marked by the passage of time, now showing clear anger. "Zhu'er, what nonsense are you up to now?"

Qi Zhu said urgently, "Mother! This isn't nonsense! I'm already involved in the matter of the Cold Palace. This isn't like your time, where you could just lock the palace gates and be safe! If the Wu'an Marquis falls into Qi Sheng's trap, he'll blame us for it later! And even if Qi Sheng wins, with his deranged personality, do you think he'll continue to let us live in peace?"

Just then, the palace staff emerged from the plum grove, escorting the palace maid and eunuch who had been having the tryst. Qi Zhu pointed at the two and questioned An Taifei, "Qi Sheng has already extended his reach into our palace. Does Mother still want to stay out of it?"

An Taifei looked at the two, bound and gagged. After weighing the options, she finally said, "Open the palace gates."

Taiji Palace.

The banquet had already seen three rounds of wine. Fan Changyu looked up at Xie Zheng's empty seat, the worry on her brow deepening. Just as she was about to find an excuse to go out and check, a palace maid who came to refill her wine bumped her elbow inconspicuously.

Under the cover of her wide sleeve, Fan Changyu felt something being pressed into her palm. She immediately closed her hand around it.

After the maid left, Fan Changyu feigned a stumble as she stood up. A maid waiting behind her seat came forward to support her and asked where she was going. Fan Changyu used the excuse of needing the privy, and the maid respectfully led her toward it.

After Fan Changyu left her seat, Grand Tutor Li, who sat at the head of the civil officials' section, glanced at her departing back, then at the empty seat at the head of the military officials' section opposite him. His old eyes held an inscrutable emotion.

A moment later, an attendant approached and whispered something in Grand Tutor Li's ear.

The usually unflappable Grand Tutor Li's expression changed for a rare moment. After dismissing the attendant, he rose and cupped his hands toward the emperor above, who was clearly in high spirits. "This old subject is ashamed. Tonight, the sovereign and his subjects are all joyous, drinking to our hearts' content. This old subject should have celebrated with Your Majesty and my colleagues until the new year, but alas, I am old and useless, and I am terribly fatigued. I can only implore Your Majesty to permit this old subject to return to my residence first."

The main show hadn't even started yet. Qi Sheng was clearly very reluctant. "The Grand Tutor is tired. Why not rest for a while in the side hall?"

But Grand Tutor Li repeatedly said, "I am terrified," his words sincere. "Your Majesty is overwhelming this old subject!"

Qi Sheng was in a good mood today and feared his intention to keep him would be too obvious. "If that is the case, then the Grand Tutor may take his leave."

After Grand Tutor Li left the main hall with his son, Qi Sheng swirled his wine cup and said pointedly, "Why has the Wu'an Marquis not returned after going to change his clothes? Could he also be tired and resting somewhere?"

None of the officials dared to respond. Qi Sheng laughed to himself. "My dear ministers, keep drinking. We can't let the mood cool just because the Grand Tutor and the Wu'an Marquis are absent."

At that very moment, a young eunuch came running and stumbling in. "Your Majesty, it's terrible! There's a fire at the Cold Palace!"

Qi Sheng couldn't suppress the excitement in his eyes, but he still put on a furious expression and cursed, "How could there be a fire out of nowhere?"

The eunuch said helplessly, "This... this servant does not know."

Qi Sheng cursed him as "useless" and rose from the dragon throne. "There are still many deposed concubines living in the Cold Palace. At the turn of the new year, we can't have any deaths. Accompany Us to take a look!"

The Son of Heaven himself was going to the Cold Palace, so all the ministers attending the palace banquet had no choice but to go with him.

The snow was falling heavier now, and the wind had picked up. Dressed in a eunuch's uniform, Fan Changyu sprinted along the narrow passage leading to the Cold Palace, her cheeks feeling as if they were being scraped by icy blades.

In the distance, the Cold Palace was a sea of fire, and the oncoming wind carried a burnt smell.

Fan Changyu gritted her teeth, wishing only that she could be faster, even faster.

The note the maid had given her read, "Trouble at the Cold Palace, Wu'an Marquis is in danger." After leaving, she had dismissed the maid who was taking her to the privy and quickly found the one who had passed her the note.

The maid claimed to be one of the Grand Princess's people and even showed her the Grand Princess's waist token. After confirming her identity, Fan Changyu didn't dare to delay for a second.

Her official robes were too conspicuous. On the way, she knocked out a eunuch, stripped him of his clothes, and put them on before rushing straight to the Cold Palace.

The Cold Palace was in a remote location, and tonight was New Year's Eve, so the maids and eunuchs were slacking off. The fire had already been burning for some time before a few scattered eunuchs started carrying buckets to fetch water to fight it.

As Fan Changyu ran, others assumed she was heading to fight the fire and didn't suspect a thing.

She was fast. In just a few breaths, she left the firefighting eunuchs far behind. When she reached the Cold Palace, she found that the fire was in some dilapidated, empty halls used for storing miscellaneous items. The residential area had not yet caught fire.

Fan Changyu ran a few steps forward and at a glance saw the Cold Palace gate, which had a large hole smashed clean through it. A massive lock still hung from the door rings.

On the smashed door, the splintered wooden planks were stained with blood.

There was also a trail of blood on the ground leading into the distance, but the snow was falling heavily now, and it was night, so it was already faintly covered.

Fan Changyu's heart suddenly pounded wildly. She bent down and entered the Cold Palace through the hole in the door. By the light of the distant burning halls, she saw a courtyard full of dead bodies.

There were eunuchs, and there were Golden Guards.

Fan Changyu's entire heart clenched. She didn't dare to call Xie Zheng's name, only shouting loudly, "Yan Zheng? Are you here?"

Seeing signs of a struggle in one of the rooms, she rushed over. At the doorway, she saw a eunuch with his throat slit. In the center of the room was a woman with disheveled clothes and a broken neck.

In an instant, she understood the emperor's plan. A sickening chill rose from the soles of her feet, and extreme rage made the veins on her clenched fists bulge.

"Murder... murder!"

"Quick! Go get help! People are dead in the Cold Palace!"

A chorus of wails and cries erupted from outside. The group of firefighting eunuchs had arrived.

Fan Changyu dared not linger. She guessed that Xie Zheng must have broken through the palace gate and escaped, but he was likely injured and couldn't have gone far.

She directly climbed over a side wall of the Cold Palace and jumped out.

The Cold Palace was not like other places. Areas untouched by the firelight were pitch black, making it impossible to even distinguish the bloodstains on the ground. But Fan Changyu's keen sense of smell detected the scent of blood on the palace wall. Upon closer inspection, there were indeed bloody handprints on the wall.

She held up her hand to compare and, confirming they were Xie Zheng's handprints, she could already taste blood between her teeth.

Just how badly was he injured that he had to support himself against a wall to walk?

Fan Changyu followed the scent of blood, moving forward quickly.

She had to get him away before the Golden Guards arrived!

After taking many detours, she finally saw a figure half-submerged in the water by the rockery of Taiye Lake. Fan Changyu was almost moved to tears of joy. She hurried forward and called in a low voice, "Xie Zheng!"

Xie Zheng's eyes were tightly shut, and he did not respond. His disguise mask was gone, and in the moonlight, his lips were as white as his face.

Fan Changyu's heart leaped in alarm. She reached out to touch his face. "What's wrong with you..."

Before she could finish her sentence, her arm was twisted back, and she was dragged into the water, her throat simultaneously locked in a tight grip.

In that moment of suffocation, Fan Changyu was certain he was using deadly force to kill her. She struggled to pry away the hand choking her, forcing out the words, "It's... me."

In the corner of her eye, all she could see was Xie Zheng's pair of phoenix eyes, so scarlet it was as if the blood vessels within had burst. They were cold and ruthless.

He no longer recognized anyone.

The intense feeling of suffocation weakened Fan Changyu's struggles, but perhaps because the chokehold brought them too close, he caught her scent. Xie Zheng's hand, clamped around her throat, suddenly loosened.

"A Yu?" His face was unusually pale, his wet hair strewn behind him. His soaked lapels were slightly open, revealing his delicate collarbones. Paired with his blood-red eyes, his entire being exuded an indescribable, demonic charm.

His hand, the wounds on it already soaked white, gently caressed the red marks he had left on Fan Changyu's neck. Though his body was as cold as a block of ice from the waters of Taiye Lake, the breath he exhaled was still scorching.

"I'm sorry, I didn't know it was you..."

His voice was incredibly hoarse, as if he were desperately trying to suppress something. Yet, the pads of his fingers stroking the delicate skin of Fan Changyu's neck had already turned searing hot in an instant, causing him to uncontrollably lower his head to kiss her cheek.

His thin lips were as cold as ice, his breath as hot as fire—just like his current state, both bizarre and bewitching.

Fan Changyu had recovered by now and naturally knew these were the symptoms of him being drugged. She leaned back to dodge his lips, helping him up by one arm. "The Cold Palace is on fire. It's not safe here. I'll take you out of the palace first."

A warm sensation met her palm, but it wasn't the heat from his arm—it was blood.

Realizing he was also wounded on his arm, Fan Changyu pushed up his sleeve to look and saw his left arm was densely covered in knife cuts, all soaked white.

He had clearly done it to himself to stay conscious.

Her eyes reddened with anger, and she asked through gritted teeth, "Where else are you hurt?"

Once Xie Zheng relaxed, he no longer had the strength to resist the drug's effects and could only stand steady by leaning on Fan Changyu for support. The fire inside him felt as if it would burn all the blood in his body dry. He gazed at the person right before him, his Adam's apple bobbing. Droplets of water from his soaked, disheveled hair trickled past his eyelids

before falling into the lake. He was as alluring as a demon from legend that subsisted on the life essence of humans.

He could no longer hear what she was asking. Before his eyes were only those red lips, capturing his entire gaze as they opened and closed. He cupped her face directly and kissed her hard.

Chapter 151

When Qi Sheng led a host of court officials in a great procession toward the Cold Palace, what they saw were towering flames and a ground littered with corpses.

The officials broke into an uproar. The fire at the Cold Palace on New Year's Eve was no accident—a murder had also occurred!

When Qi Sheng saw the body of the woman being carried out by the Golden Guard who had gone to fight the fire, his expression had already turned ugly. Clinging to a sliver of hope, he demanded, "What happened? Did someone have the audacity to break into the Cold Palace at night and defile a concubine?"

The commander of the Golden Guard who had gone to extinguish the fire, his forehead beaded with cold sweat, cupped his fist and said, "This subordinate does not know. When we saw the flames from the Cold Palace and rushed over, this was already the scene."

Forgetting his imperial decorum, Qi Sheng's eyes looked ready to split as he roared, "Where is the vile intruder who broke into the Cold Palace?"

The Golden Guard commander bowed even lower. "This subordinate has already dispatched the Golden Guard to search the entire imperial palace. As long as that scoundrel has not yet left the palace, he will surely be caught."

Qi Sheng's face was so grim he looked like he could devour someone.

He had planned it all so meticulously. He had even procured the long-lost forbidden drugs, Bone-weakening powder and Rourouzhi. Why had Xie Zheng still managed to escape?

Wasn't it said that Bone-weakening powder could fell even a wild bull, and Rourouzhi could make a chaste woman more wanton than a courtesan?

Could it be that neither had any effect on Xie Zheng?

The fury of a failed, elaborate plan and the terror of Xie Zheng's potential retaliation tore at Qi Sheng, making his expression increasingly savage. Under the alarmed and bewildered gazes of the officials, he kicked over a half-full bucket of water that had been placed on the ground for firefighting and commanded in a harsh voice, "Search! Even if you have to dig three feet into the ground, you will find that vile intruder for Us!"

The Golden Guard commander accepted the order and led his men to search the entire palace.

Qi Sheng turned around amidst the ever-intensifying flames, his gaze dark as he looked at the panicked faces of his officials. "How outrageous! What do they take my imperial palace for? Tonight, I only banqueted the ministers of the court. All of your servants are waiting outside the Meridian Gate. Could it be that the one who fished in troubled waters and broke into the Cold Palace is one of my beloved ministers?"

The crime of defiling the imperial harem was no small matter. The officials exchanged glances, finding Qi Sheng's words utterly absurd.

Yet Qi Sheng didn't seem to think so at all, continuing with a pointed tone, "To be able to kill so many of my Golden Guard, his martial arts must be extraordinary!"

The only one who had been absent for a long time was the Wu'an Marquis. The implication in Qi Sheng's words was too obvious, causing the officials to fall into an even deeper, fearful silence.

It was true that Qi Sheng was the Son of Heaven, but from the moment he ascended the dragon throne, he had been nothing more than a puppet propped up by Wei Yan. The officials' reverence for him was less than their dread of Xie Zheng.

After all, one was an emperor with no real power, while the other was a border-defending Martial Marquis who commanded hundreds of thousands of troops.

The quicker-witted ones had already figured it out. The great fire tonight was likely a play deliberately staged by Qi Sheng. He had brought them here with the purpose of making them witnesses, to use the power of the entire court to nail a crime worthy of exterminating nine generations of kin onto the Wu'an Marquis.

It was just that some mishap had occurred midway, leading to the current situation.

The officials who understood this were instantly filled with boundless terror. If the Wu'an Marquis fell into Qi Sheng's hands, it would be one thing. But if he escaped this calamity, and they were forced to become "witnesses," wouldn't they be silenced by the Wu'an Marquis later?

In an instant, a great number of officials found their backs soaked with cold sweat.

Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and the others were at the rear of the group. Hearing Qi Sheng's words and thinking of how Xie Zheng had been gone for so long and Fan Changyu had also not returned, they exchanged a look, a shadow of worry clouding their brows.

Taiye Lake.

After being kissed by Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu was frantic with worry that the Golden Guard would search their way over. Xie Zheng was injured, and she didn't dare push him too forcefully, so she was held by the head and kissed for half a breath.

As Xie Zheng's lips moved down, nuzzling and pecking at the side of her neck, Fan Changyu vigilantly scanned the perimeter of Taiye Lake. After confirming that the vicinity was temporarily safe, she seized the opportunity to half-drag, half-pull the barely conscious man out of the water.

During this, Xie Zheng nudged open the collar of her robes, seeking the faint fragrance on her body in an attempt to continue kissing his way down. Fan Changyu, whether from the heat or extreme nervousness, felt her face flush red. She pushed his head away. She wanted to lash out, but knowing he was drugged and not in control of himself, she couldn't bring herself to do it. She could only grit her teeth and say, "Endure it for a little while. I'll get you out of the palace."

She placed him on the ground, his back against a rockery. His face, which had been pale from the soak in the icy lake water, was now flushed with a faint red. His powerful chest heaved violently as he panted. His soaked lapels had fallen slightly open, revealing a section of porcelain-white chest. The snow-white inner shirt on both sides clung to his firm muscles, rendering it almost transparent.

His drenched black hair stuck to his collarbones and shoulders, giving him a clear yet bewitching look. His blood-red eyes no longer held any clarity, but they were fixed on Fan Changyu. "Help me..."

He had been drugged with Bone-weakening powder. Aside from cutting himself with his knife to barely maintain some strength, he found it difficult to even stand up.

He had endured for too long. The blue veins on his neck bulged, as if the blood vessels under his skin were about to burst.

Seeing him like this, Fan Changyu's heart ached. The thought of the emperor's filthy scheme filled her with uncontrollable rage.

She haphazardly wrung out her and Xie Zheng's soaked robes, then cupped his face with her own hands, which were equally cold from the lake water. "Not here. Someone could come at any moment."

His face was alarmingly hot, whether from the drug's effect or a high fever from being in the lake for too long. The moment Fan Changyu's hands touched him, he grabbed her wrist with his own hand, the wound on his palm soaked white, trying to press her closer.

Fan Changyu asked him, "Where did you put your court robes?"

He wasn't wearing his court robes. If he were found by the Golden Guard and the emperor used it to frame him at the Cold Palace, tonight's predicament would still not be resolved.

Perhaps soothed by the coolness of Fan Changyu's hands, Xie Zheng managed to regain a sliver of his senses. As he sucked and kissed her fingers, he answered breathlessly, "In the rockery grotto in the Imperial Garden."

Taiye Lake covered a vast area, divided into an East and West Lake. The East Lake was near the Cold Palace, which was where they were now. The West Lake served as the axis of the entire rear palace. The Imperial Garden was also beside the West Lake, with a stretch of rockery and stone forest even built along its edge.

After learning that Xie Zheng was going to investigate the Cold Palace at night, Fan Changyu had also studied a map of the entire imperial palace.

Therefore, the moment Xie Zheng mentioned the rockery grotto in the Imperial Garden, Fan Changyu immediately knew the location.

With the fire at the Cold Palace, the water in the large vats lining the Imperial Way had been used up. To fetch water more conveniently, the eunuchs and imperial guards fighting the fire would likely come to the East Lake. The West Lake side should be safe for now.

Fan Changyu used her teeth to tear a hole in her eunuch uniform, then ripped it into strips with both hands. She wrapped them around the wounds on Xie Zheng's palm and arm, saying, "I'll take you there now."

The fire at the Cold Palace was immense, and the Golden Guard patrolling nearby had probably rushed over to help. Carrying Xie Zheng on her back, Fan Changyu encountered almost no obstacles on her way to the rockery and stone forest in the Imperial Garden.

If there was any obstacle to speak of, it was Xie Zheng, who kept kissing the nape of her neck and tugging at her collar until it loosened. Fan Changyu nearly stumbled several times before she grimaced and chopped the back of his neck, knocking him unconscious.

After finding the stone grotto, Fan Changyu discovered that while the entrance was narrow, the inside was quite spacious.

Afraid of being detected, she didn't dare light a flint. Fortunately, there was an oval-shaped opening at the top of the grotto. Looking up, she could even see the not-quite-full, cold moon. The moonlight shining in from the opening at the top allowed Fan Changyu to see, albeit faintly.

She found the cloak and court robes Xie Zheng had placed inside earlier. Just as she was about to strip off his soaked clothes and wrap him in these dry ones, the flicker of torches flashed past outside the rockery, followed by the clatter of armor.

"Quick, quick! Seal the palace gates! An assassin has infiltrated the imperial palace! A concubine in the Cold Palace has already been murdered!"

Fan Changyu, holding Xie Zheng, immediately dared not move, afraid of making any sound that would alert the Golden Guard outside.

Unexpectedly, Xie Zheng woke up at this moment. A hoarse, low moan had just escaped his lips when Fan Changyu, in her haste, sealed it with her own.

He latched onto Fan Changyu's tongue almost by instinct. Weakened by the Bone-weakening powder, his kiss was gentler than before, yet it still left Fan Changyu breathless.

His body was much hotter than when they were by Taiye Lake. The blood beneath his skin seemed to be boiling, as if he had reached a critical

point. If this continued, he would soon start bleeding from all seven orifices.

Through their soaked clothes, Fan Changyu could feel him like a branding iron against her.

Their panting grew heavier, yet the sound of footsteps was approaching.

Xie Zheng had completely lost his senses. Fan Changyu let him gnaw on her neck, but her eyes were cold and vigilant, fixed on the grotto entrance. She had even drawn the Boning knife hidden in her long boot.

The footsteps grew closer and closer. Fan Changyu's grip on the knife's hilt couldn't help but tighten. Xie Zheng, who was sucking on a piece of soft flesh on her neck, suddenly lifted his eyes. His blood-red phoenix eyes no longer looked human; they held only a cold, bloody killing intent, like an alpha wolf whose territory had been invaded.

Suddenly, a few shrill cat-cries, like the wails of a baby, came from the top of the rockery.

The Golden Guard who had been searching in this direction let out a sigh of relief and chuckled, "So it's just the palace's stray cats in heat."

He struck the branches near the rockery with his scabbard, startling two cats into howling and scattering in all directions.

The Golden Guard sheathed his sword and walked back. His companion up ahead asked him, "Did you find anything over there?"

The guard replied, "Just two stray cats. A false alarm."

The footsteps faded completely. The taut string in Fan Changyu's mind relaxed, and her whole body went limp. She leaned against Xie Zheng, panting.

The heat from Xie Zheng's body had steamed his water-soaked clothes warm. He lowered his head to kiss Fan Changyu's cheek, his Adam's apple bobbing slightly, sweat beading on his neck.

Fan Changyu gently caressed his cheek, her fingers threading through his hair at his temples. She looked at the corner of his lip, bitten raw from extreme restraint. In her eyes, reflecting the moonlight, was nothing but heartache. She bit her lip and said, "I'll help you."

The Cold Palace.

The Golden Guard who had gone to search quickly returned, holding something in his hands. "Your Majesty, your subjects followed a trail of blood and found this mask by the East Lake of Taiye Lake."

Qi Sheng took the scarred face mask and examined it closely, his face unable to hide his excitement. He asked, "Where is the man?"

The Golden Guard commander lowered his head. "We haven't found him yet. The blood trail ends at the edge of the East Lake. This subordinate suspects the vile intruder escaped by swimming. I am ordering my men to search along Taiye Lake."

Qi Sheng's hand, clutching the mask, suddenly tightened. He cursed the Golden Guard commander, "Useless! You found something from the scoundrel's person, but you couldn't catch him? What use do I have for you bunch of rice buckets? Get back to searching!"

The Golden Guard commander accepted the order and hastily retreated.

The cold moon was desolate, its light scattering like frost.

Fine beads of sweat appeared on Fan Changyu's temples. She turned her head to look at Xie Zheng's profile as he leaned on her shoulder.

He seemed not to have recovered yet. His long, dark eyelashes rested lightly on his eyelids. Two faint blushes bloomed on his pale face, completely devoid of the ferocity from a moment ago when he had gnawed on the soft flesh of her neck as if wanting to swallow her whole. He was quiet and docile.

Fan Changyu's breathing was also not yet steady. She wiped her hands on her soaked eunuch uniform and asked, "Are you better?"

Xie Zheng opened his eyes and nodded slightly. He raised a hand to press the back of her head and kissed her for a good while before letting go.

Just now, aside from their mutual panting, all of Fan Changyu's senses had been almost numb. She had no idea how much time had passed. She just took his court robes and put them on him. "The Golden Guard is searching the entire palace. We have to get out."

His middle layer of clothing was still wet, but his innermost shirt had surprisingly been dried by his body heat.

Xie Zheng, however, said, "Get the court robes wet too."

Fan Changyu frowned. "You'll catch a cold."

Xie Zheng pressed his forehead against hers. "I can't explain it to you right now. Just do as I say."

So Fan Changyu went out, threw his court robes into the water to soak them, wrung them out, and then put them on him. She wrapped the night suit in a large rock and sank it into Taiye Lake.

When all was ready and Fan Changyu helped Xie Zheng out again, she could clearly feel that his steps were still somewhat unsteady. It didn't seem to be purely from the aphrodisiac.

As if knowing what she was thinking, Xie Zheng said, "The effects of the Bone-weakening powder haven't worn off yet."

Fan Changyu's fingers, gripping his wrist, tightened. So he was also drugged with Bone-weakening powder!

No wonder Qi Sheng dared to think he could trap him with just a dozen or so guards outside the Cold Palace.

Fan Changyu squeezed three words through her gritted teeth: "Bastard! Emperor!"

She rarely cursed, and this was the first time Xie Zheng had ever heard her swear with such gnashing teeth.

He glanced at her in surprise. His heart felt as if it had been steeped in a warm spring, dissipating some of the gloom that had risen from being plotted against tonight. He even ended up comforting her, "Let's leave the palace first. We'll keep this debt on Qi Sheng's account for now."

Fan Changyu said no more, but her lips were pressed into a tight line.

In the end, the two did not get their wish. On their way to Taiji Palace, they ran headlong into Qi Sheng, who was leading a host of court officials.

Qi Sheng was fiddling with a leather-like object in his hand. Seeing the two of them, he immediately spoke with a cold smile, "Beloved Minister Xie, you went to change your clothes and never returned. You truly had Us worried."

The flush on Xie Zheng's face had completely faded, leaving only the pallor of excessive blood loss and a long soak in Taiye Lake. He needed Fan Changyu's support to walk, but his voice was as clear and steady as ever. "To have worried Your Majesty is this subject's fault."

Qi Sheng's gaze swept over the court robes on Xie Zheng, which had not been changed. A strange light glinted in his eyes as he pressed on, "We see that Beloved Minister Xie's wine-stained robes have not been changed. We wonder where you have been all this time?"

Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and the others cast worried glances at them.

Seeing the situation, Fan Changyu couldn't help but break into a sweat for Xie Zheng. His reply, however, was exceptionally composed. "I am ashamed. I was being led by a servant to change my clothes when I saw a thief flit over the wall. I thought that no mishap could be allowed to occur at this New Year's Eve banquet, so I went after the thief. Unexpectedly, I was drunk and lacked strength. After being injured by the thief, I carelessly fell into Taiye Lake. If not for the General of the Cloud Banner passing by, I fear I would have become a lost soul in Taiye Lake."

So that was why he had her wet his court robes.

While Fan Changyu was marveling at his ability to lie without batting an eye, the gazes of Qi Sheng and the hundred officials all swept toward her, whose hair and official robes were also soaked.

She acted as a human crutch, bringing out her signature skill. She stared with her large, rather round almond eyes and nodded, looking as honest as could be.

But her palms were slick with cold sweat.

Xie Zheng seemed to sense it. Under the cover of his wide sleeve, he gave her hand a discreet squeeze.

Qi Sheng asked Fan Changyu with a cold smile, "And why would the General of the Cloud Banner appear at Taiye Lake?"

Fan Changyu said with a stern face, "This general drank too much and wished to change my clothes. As soon as I left the hall, I saw fire in the direction of the Cold Palace. This general intended to go help fight the fire. When passing Taiye Lake, I discovered the Marquis who had fallen into the lake."

Receiving such an answer, Qi Sheng's expression became extremely ugly. He held up the disguise mask in his hand. "The Golden Guard followed a trail of blood and found this mask by the East Lake of Taiye Lake. Does Beloved Minister Xie recognize it?"

Xie Zheng looked closely at the mask for a moment and said, "It looks somewhat familiar. Although the thief I fought had his face covered, I remember he had a scar that ran from his brow bone across the bridge of his nose. I suppose that thief was in disguise. This mask must belong to him."

Faced with such sophistry, Qi Sheng was so furious he gritted his teeth. He said with a smile that didn't reach his eyes, "What a coincidence. The scoundrel who broke into the Cold Palace was injured, and Beloved Minister Xie was also injured. I wonder if anyone else saw this thief you speak of?"

He was dead set on pinning the crime of breaking into the Cold Palace on Xie Zheng.

Fan Changyu looked at Qi Sheng, the coldness in her gaze no longer suppressible.

Xie Zheng, however, said calmly, "The eunuch who led me to change my clothes also saw him."

A flash of surprise crossed Fan Changyu's eyes, and even Qi Sheng's expression changed drastically. He demanded, "Where is that eunuch now?"

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes, from which the blood-red color had not yet fully receded, met Qi Sheng's. A faint smile seemed to play at the bottom of his eyes, but beneath that smile was an undisguised, bloody killing intent that made Qi Sheng shiver involuntarily and retract some of the savagery on his face.

Xie Zheng withdrew his gaze and said lightly, "He cried out in alarm upon seeing the thief and was knocked unconscious. He is now in the side hall of Luanfeng Hall."

Qi Sheng's back was soaked with cold sweat. He knew that if Xie Zheng could not be convicted today, then one day it would be his turn to wash his neck and wait for Xie Zheng to come and sever his head.

Even though his heart was filled with fear, he still gritted his teeth and said, "Proceed to Luanfeng Hall."

He was certain Xie Zheng was bluffing.

To avoid arousing Xie Zheng's suspicion, he had not used anyone who knew of the plan for the eunuch guiding Xie Zheng. He knew no thief had

entered the palace, so he concluded that Xie Zheng was making it all up.

As long as he found that eunuch and interrogated him, he could convict Xie Zheng!

Qi Sheng led the crowd at the very front, but his hands, clasped behind his back, were covered in cold sweat.

He kept reassuring himself, I just need to find that eunuch...

The large group proceeded to Luanfeng Hall.

Supporting Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu could clearly feel his arm growing hot again. Although he tried his best to control his breathing, it was still somewhat heavy.

She glanced at Xie Zheng with worry, but he stared straight ahead, his face showing no sign of anything unusual.

Fan Changyu couldn't tell if he was running a high fever from the cold or if the effects of that vile drug were resurfacing. It wasn't the time to talk, so she remained silent. But along the way, Xie Zheng's grip on her arm grew tighter and tighter. Though his eyes were still clear and sharp, sweat had begun to bead on his temples.

The Golden Guard quickly found the eunuch collapsed by a pillar. When the eunuch was woken with a bucket of cold water, his first instinct, based on the commotion he heard before being knocked out, was to shout, "There's an assassin!"

Hearing this, Qi Sheng's expression grew more savage. He kicked the eunuch square in the chest. "You dog slave! What assassin? Explain yourself to Us!"

The eunuch was kicked to the ground, unable to get up for a long time from the pain. Seeing the emperor and a host of ministers surrounding him, his face grew even more panicked.

Xie Zheng spoke up at this moment. "Eunuch, on the way to guide this Marquis to change his clothes, did you or did you not see a thief leap over the wall?"

At the time, the eunuch had only heard a noise from the top of the wall. But having been kicked by Qi Sheng and questioned about an assassin, with so many court officials watching him, he was terrified and his mind

was a complete blank. He immediately went along with Xie Zheng's words, nodding repeatedly. "Yes, yes, yes! Someone did leap over the palace wall!"

With a witness, Xie Zheng could now completely prove his innocence for the night.

Qi Sheng staggered back a step. The eunuch who hastily supported him also looked extremely alarmed.

Qi Sheng's face was ashen. At this moment, only one thought filled his mind: It's over. I'm finished!

A flush had risen on Xie Zheng's face again. He covered his lips and gave a low cough, his cold gaze sweeping lightly over Qi Sheng. "This subject was injured in the fight with that scoundrel and caught a chill from drowning in Taiye Lake. Being ill, I am unable to assist Your Majesty in searching for that scoundrel any further, so I will take my leave from the palace first."

Qi Sheng's mind was buzzing; he couldn't hear what Xie Zheng was saying at all.

Xie Zheng left without receiving Qi Sheng's permission, and none of the court officials dared to make a sound.

Just then, an urgent report came from the long, narrow passage: "Report—An assassin has raided the Court of Revision and abducted the key criminals of the Sui family!"

At these words, the officials broke into an uproar.

Fan Changyu knew it must have been Xie Zheng's men succeeding in their raid on the Court of Revision, and she felt a sense of relief.

Unexpectedly, despite such a major event, there was no ripple on Qi Sheng's face. He didn't even question the Minister of the Court of Revision, who was among the officials at the banquet. Even the announcement for the officials to disperse and return home was relayed by the chief eunuch.

After following Qi Sheng to the Cold Palace, Tang Peiyi and the others had been holding their breath for Xie Zheng. It wasn't until now that they finally let out that breath in relief.

As the group left the palace together, Zheng Wenchang's sharp eyes noticed that the Wu'an Marquis ahead seemed seriously injured. With Fan

Changyu supporting him, most of his weight was leaning on her slender shoulders. Zheng immediately moved to assist.

Tang Peiyi grabbed him by the collar and asked, "What are you doing?"

Zheng Wenchang replied, "The Marquis appears severely injured. How can we let General Fan, a woman, bear his weight alone? I'll go help support him."

The look Tang Peiyi gave him was indescribable, finally saying only, "Stay out of it."

Zheng Wenchang was utterly confused. "Why?"

Beside them, He Xiujun cleared his throat and slung an arm around Zheng's shoulders. "Brother Wenchang, support me instead. I'm a bit drunk."

As Zheng Wenchang was He Jingyuan's protégé and as close as brothers with He Xiujun, he knew perfectly well the latter's alcohol tolerance. He immediately shrugged him off. "You're at least seventy percent away from being drunk!"

Puzzled, he looked at his friend. "Both you and General Tang are acting strangely."

He Xiujun sighed and decided to be direct. "Are you really this dense? Can't you see the Marquis and General Fan are about to announce their happy news?"

Zheng Wenchang frowned deeply. "Because General Fan rescued the Marquis from Taiye Pond and they had physical contact?"

He immediately continued, "This shows you don't understand General Fan. With her magnanimity and spirit, she's no less than any great man. How could she be bound by such trivial etiquette..."

The expressions on Tang Peiyi and He Xiujun's faces grew even more inscrutable.

Had this man noticed nothing unusual back in Lucheng?

Finally, He Xiujun just patted Zheng Wenchang's shoulder and said, "Brother Wenchang, if you ever have trouble finding a wife in the future, come ask your sister-in-law to arrange a match for you."

Standing rooted to the spot as Tang and He walked away, Zheng Wenchang's face showed increasing bewilderment.

What did this have to do with him getting married someday?

Chapter 152

At the palace gates, under everyone's watchful eyes, Fan Changyu could not just openly board the Xie family's carriage.

She handed the rapidly deteriorating Xie Zheng over to Xie Shiyi, who had come forward to meet them. Xie Shiyi saw at a glance that something was wrong with Xie Zheng and asked anxiously, "General, the Master is..."

Time was short. Fan Changyu simply lowered her voice and instructed, "Take him back to the Xie residence immediately, and send someone to fetch a physician."

Fan Changyu tried to pull her hand away, but Xie Zheng gripped her wrist tightly. The bloodshot color in his eyes, which had faded slightly, slowly returned. Under the lights of the palace gate, he looked somewhat menacing at first glance.

Unable to break free, Fan Changyu helped him into the carriage. At the side of the carriage, she whispered to him, "Let go first. I'm not leaving. I'll just go say a few words to Xie Wu and be right back."

The one who had accompanied Fan Changyu into the palace tonight was still Xie Wu, who had gone through life and death with her ever since she was a squad leader.

Only then did Xie Zheng release her. As he collapsed onto the carriage seat, the roots of his hair were soaked with sweat. A faint blush spread across his pale face, and under the soft reflection of the bamboo shadows inside the carriage, he possessed a heart-stopping, magnificent beauty.

Fan Changyu steeled her heart, lowered the carriage curtain, and jumped down. She said to Xie Shiyi, "You go on ahead."

Xie Shiyi seemed to understand something and didn't dare to delay for a moment. He cracked the whip and drove the carriage away.

Many court officials were leaving the palace at this time, and their expressions varied as they witnessed this scene.

Just then, Tang Peiyi also caught up. Seeing Fan Changyu, he called out, "General Fan, shall we return to the Office of Presentations together?"

Fan Changyu looked back, wanting to find Xie Zheng. She feared that if she left with Tang Peiyi and the others, it would be difficult to slip away later. Just as she was about to refuse, she saw He Xiujun give her a meaningful look. Fan Changyu thought they had something to discuss with her, so she nodded. "Alright."

Their carriages headed toward the Office of Presentations together. The officials who came out later saw this and dared not make any wild speculations.

Xie Wu had also seen Fan Changyu helping Xie Zheng out of the palace earlier. As soon as Fan Changyu boarded the carriage, he asked, "General, did something happen at the palace banquet?"

Fan Changyu's nerves had been stretched taut all night, and a dull ache was now throbbing in her head. She pinched the bridge of her nose and said, "It's a long story. In a moment, you'll return to the Office of Presentations alone and let my mother and the others know I'm safe. I'm going to the Xie residence."

She was, after all, still worried about Xie Zheng's condition.

Just as Xie Wu agreed, he suddenly cried "Whoa!"

Fan Changyu heard someone outside call her "dear sister." Lifting the carriage curtain, she saw that Tang Peiyi's and the others' carriage had stopped at a fork in the road.

He Xiujun poked his head out of the carriage window and said to Fan Changyu, "Dear sister Changyu, General Tang, Brother Wen Chang, and I want to go see the New Year's Eve Lantern Festival, so we won't be traveling with you."

She addressed He Jingyuan as "Uncle," so He Xiujun had always regarded himself as an older brother to her.

No matter how slow she was, Fan Changyu understood that Tang Peiyi and the others were helping her out of a predicament.

Her jumping into the Taiye Pond tonight to "save" Xie Zheng would inevitably cause gossip among the court officials. If she left alone, it would surely lead to wild speculation. Leaving with them would, to some extent, silence the wagging tongues.

She was grateful, but now was not the time for thanks. She simply nodded and said, "Then you and General Tang go on, my dear brother. The capital's New Year's Eve night market is a grand spectacle. Once you're familiar with the place, you can bring my sister-in-law to see it again in the future."

He Xiujun smiled and agreed before lowering the carriage curtain.

The north wind howled, sweeping flurries of fine snow through the streets, which were filled with the smell of firecrackers and fireworks.

The clatter of horse hooves and the rumble of wheels were exceptionally clear. A dark shadow seemed to flit past, and the candlelight inside the carriage flickered as a cold draft blew in from the window.

Fan Changyu helped Xie Zheng up. He was leaning against the seat, the corner of his lip once again bitten open and bleeding. Her brows furrowed tightly. "How are you?"

Xie Zheng's every breath felt like fire. After he lifted his blood-red phoenix eyes and clearly saw who it was, he directly raised a hand to press the back of her neck, sealing her lips with a kiss.

The effects of the Bone-weakening powder on him seemed to have dissipated somewhat. The force with which he held her neck was immense, and his lips and teeth ravaged her fiercely. Fan Changyu could only tilt her head back and be forced to endure it.

A moment later, the carriage stopped. Xie Shiyi braced himself and said from outside, "Master, we've arrived."

Fan Changyu pressed her hands against Xie Zheng's chest. A faint, sharp pain arose on her shoulder where his canine teeth were gnawing. She clenched her five fingers tightly on the lapels of his robe, a light pink blush spreading across her face. She pressed her lips together, enduring the strange sensation his kiss sent coursing through her body.

"Take the carriage in through the side gate. Don't disturb anyone else in the residence."

Xie Zheng's eyes were clouded, his voice deep and hoarse.

Receiving the order, Xie Shiyi quickly turned the horse and drove toward the side gate. After he showed the token, a servant of the Xie residence opened the gate, and the carriage entered the estate almost silently, stopping in front of the main courtyard.

Xie Shiyi went to fetch the physician who resided in the estate, while Fan Changyu, after catching her breath, helped Xie Zheng out of the carriage.

The moment they entered the room, she was pinned against the door by Xie Zheng. He kissed and nipped wantonly at her shoulder and neck, his breathing heavy and ragged. His low, mellow voice had lost its usual clarity. "Changyu, A Yu..."

The tender flesh of her neck was ground by his sharp teeth, and it felt as if a string had been pulled taut in the meridians beneath her skin. Even though Fan Changyu clenched her jaw, a fine tremor still traveled from her neck down to her fingertips.

A watery sheen covered her eyes. Without saying a word, she shot Xie Zheng a pained and slightly annoyed glare, which caused the precarious string in his mind to snap with a "crack."

Her third-rank military official's court robe, exquisitely embroidered and of excellent quality, was ripped open in a large tear by his hands. He then lowered his head and kissed the exposed skin.

Fan Changyu's back was pressed against the carved wooden door. Sweat trickled down from her jaw, and her lips were pressed so tightly they turned white.

She gave him a push. "Your injuries... apply medicine first."

Xie Zheng's breathing was very unsteady. He looked up and said okay, but unexpectedly, as soon as he straightened up, he spat out a mouthful of blood and collapsed, his face as white as snow.

Fan Changyu was startled and quickly supported him. "Xie Zheng, what's wrong with you?"

She moved him to the soft couch to lie down and loudly called for Xie Shiyi to hurry with the physician. Her half-damp court robe had been torn open by Xie Zheng, making her unpresentable. She rushed to the chest where Xie Zheng kept his clothes, intending to grab a set of his to wear for the time being. After pulling on an arrow-sleeved long robe, she was surprised to find that it fit her unexpectedly well.

Fan Changyu paused for a moment, then took out several other robes and held them against herself, discovering they all fit perfectly.

This chest of clothes, had he prepared them for her long ago?

Fan Changyu looked at the pale, unconscious man on the soft couch, and her heart ached with a sudden pang of bitterness.

Xie Shiyi quickly returned with the physician. After taking Xie Zheng's pulse, the physician's brow furrowed deeply.

Fan Changyu asked anxiously, "Doctor, how is he?"

The physician pricked Xie Zheng's fingertip with a silver needle to draw a drop of blood. His expression was extremely complicated as he said, "The Marquis is suffering from an excess of heart-fire. This fire originates from the gate of life, travels through the triple burner, and accumulates in the liver and kidneys. It has become so vigorous that it has damaged his internal organs, causing him to vomit blood. By letting blood from the Shangyang acupoint, I can only provide some relief for the Marquis. Ultimately, this only treats the symptoms, not the root cause. If this fire is not dispersed, I fear the Marquis will be in grave danger..."

When Xie Shiyi was seeing the physician out, he knelt before Fan Changyu at the door. He lowered his head, as if he knew his next words were presumptuous, but still said in a choked voice, "I beg the General to save the Marquis."

Fan Changyu sat on a stool, looking at Xie Zheng, who still hadn't woken up even after the physician's acupuncture treatment. She only said, "Get out."

After kowtowing to her, Xie Shiyi closed the door and left.

Fan Changyu walked over and sat down before the soft couch. She leaned over and kissed Xie Zheng's lips, then lifted her head slightly and said to him in a low voice, "You married into my family."

...

That night, the entire imperial city was bustling with excitement. The palace city was brilliantly lit, and the one hundred and eight wards outside the city were also ablaze with lights. The laughter of children and the cries of street vendors could be heard from several streets away.

As the hour of midnight struck, the bells of the Golden Temple in the city began to toll, one after another, distant and lingering, as if announcing to the world that the old year had passed and the new year had arrived.

Tens of thousands of fireworks from the city wards shot up into the snowy night sky in unison. In an instant, the sky was filled with dazzling

colors. Neighbors also set off firecrackers to welcome the new year, and the "crack-crack-pop" sound was incessant, creating a lively atmosphere.

Fan Changyu lay on the warm white marble stone of the hot spring pool, her long hair plastered wetly to her cheeks, her entire body flushed a faint pink. She had already lost count of how many times she had watched the fireworks. Now, she was utterly exhausted, no less than if she had just fought a major battle.

When the person behind her pressed against her back, enveloping her in his arms, and began to peck kisses on her shoulder again, Fan Changyu's shoulder instinctively flinched. She turned her head and asked him, "Hasn't the drug worn off yet?"

Her cheeks were scarlet, and stray strands of sweat-dampened hair clung messily to them. Her lips were swollen, and a watery mist veiled her bright eyes.

Her expression was still stubborn, but it now held a hint of pitifulness.

Xie Zheng looked at her, his eyes bottomlessly deep. His Adam's apple bobbed slowly as he gave a hoarse "Mmm."

The water rippled, and Fan Changyu couldn't help but let out a muffled groan along with it.

She had no strength left, so she simply lay face-down against the wall of the hot spring pool, her head pillowed on her arms as she forced herself to endure.

What she was thinking, however, was that it must be because she had been so busy with various matters since arriving in the capital that she had neglected her martial arts practice. Wasn't Xie Zheng still under the effect of the Bone-weakening powder? How could his stamina be better than hers?

Starting tomorrow, she must practice her martial arts diligently.

That night, there were others who were also sleepless.

After all the ministers who attended the palace banquet had left the palace, an inconspicuous carriage drove out of the Xihua Gate. Its wheels rolled over the thick snow on the road, heading straight for the Prime Minister's residence.

Compared to the festive lanterns and decorations all over the city, the Prime Minister's residence remained solemn. Even the row of red lanterns hanging under the eaves did not add much of a festive air to the estate. In the disquietingly silent night, they instead exuded a gloomy aura.

This time, due to the heavy snow and wind outside, Qi Sheng was finally led into Wei Yan's study.

He didn't even take off his cloak. The fine snow on the brim of his hood melted under the heat of the charcoal fire in the room, leaving mottled wet marks and making him look as pathetic as a stray dog.

Wei Yan sat behind a low table. In this cold night, he still wore a simple, thin cloth garment. A hand, aged yet still sinewy, held a purple-hair brush, writing something on the desk with fluid, powerful strokes, treating the emperor standing below him as if he were nothing.

Qi Sheng, however, couldn't care less. It was unclear whether the New Year's Eve snow was too cold or the fear from his failed plan tonight was too great, but his voice trembled as he spoke, "Prime Minister, save Us, save Us! Xie Zheng wants to commit regicide!"

Wei Yan's brush did not stop, nor did he even lift his eyes as he asked, "Why would he want to kill you?"

Qi Sheng glanced at Wei Yan and said, "He... he was investigating the matter of my sixteenth brother and found a mad palace maid in the Cold Palace who used to serve Jia Guifei. That mad maid said the Prime Minister once had an illicit affair with an imperial concubine!"

As soon as these words were spoken, the purple-hair brush in Wei Yan's hand was squeezed until it cracked. He slowly raised his eyes to look at Qi Sheng, his gaze no different from that of someone looking at a dead man.

Qi Sheng was also startled by that look. He had originally intended to use that palace maid as a bargaining chip to threaten Wei Yan, but he immediately changed his story.

As he lied, he widened his eyes with such force that they became even more prominent. "Xie Zheng was going to find that palace maid to verify the matter. We were afraid he would use this against the Prime Minister, so We devised a plan to frame Xie Zheng for the great crime of having an illicit affair with an imperial concubine and throwing the harem into chaos. The plan was flawless, but somehow he managed to foil it tonight..."

He even began to cry, snot and tears streaming down his face. "Xie Zheng has long harbored dissent! He will definitely kill Us! We did all this for the Prime Minister's sake. Prime Minister, you must save Us!"

Wei Yan set down the cracked purple-hair brush. "So, what did Your Majesty hear from that palace maid?"

This calm, yet murderously chilling tone made Qi Sheng's crying stop abruptly. He froze.

For a moment, he felt as if the images of the uncle and nephew, Xie Zheng and Wei Yan, had overlapped.

Chapter 153

Fan Changyu couldn't remember if she had fainted or fallen asleep from exhaustion in the end. All she knew was that in her daze, she felt a hot, humid rain clinging to her, impossible to shake off no matter how she ran in her dreams.

When she finally awoke, she opened her eyes to find the sky had brightened considerably, and she could faintly hear voices from the outer room.

"...The Li family is bound to get desperate. Wei Yan's backup plan won't be this simple. Notify Gongsun's side that they can make their move."

"As you command."

This was followed by the sound of departing footsteps and the creak of a door opening and closing.

When Xie Zheng returned to the inner chamber, he saw Fan Changyu already sitting up, wrapped in the quilt. The coldness in his eyes melted into a few threads of softness. He walked over to sit on the edge of the bed, tucking a stray strand of her messy hair behind her ear with an action that could not have been more intimate or natural. "You're awake? It's still early, why not sleep a little longer?"

The snowstorm from last night had not stopped, and a layer of snow more than two fingers thick had accumulated outside. The underfloor heating was lit in the room, so it wasn't the least bit cold.

As she sat up, Fan Changyu had noticed she was wearing an ill-fitting inner garment. The collar was so large that it kept sliding off her shoulders.

She glanced down. From her shoulders to her arms, the marks were a tragic sight...

The chaotic memories of last night flooded back. She silently pulled the collar back up. After Xie Zheng entered the room, she sized him up and the first thing she asked was, "Are you all right now?"

Xie Zheng's hand, which had just brushed her hair back, was still resting behind her ear against her snowy neck. Hearing her question, his dark eyes watched her quietly for a moment. He suddenly cupped the back of her neck, drew her closer, and kissed her lips twice before saying in a low voice, "Why are you so endearing?"

Fan Changyu's clear, dark eyes gazed at him candidly. "You held back so much last night you coughed up blood..."

Xie Zheng seemed to adore touching her. His thumb gently caressed the back of her neck as he asked, "What if I hadn't coughed up blood? Would you still have indulged me like that?"

The experience of losing consciousness at the end was too humiliating. Fan Changyu felt it was a disgrace born of her inferior stamina. She awkwardly lowered her head and changed the subject, "I'm a little hungry."

Seeing her like this, a dark glint flashed through Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes. He said, "The kitchen has kept food ready. I'll have someone bring it."

Fan Changyu nodded, but Xie Zheng didn't leave. Instead, he knelt before the bed, took both her hands, and kissed them. His expression was extremely earnest as he said, "For you to be with me just like this, I have ultimately wronged you. Once everything is settled, I will make it up to you with a wedding grander than any the world has ever seen."

Whether one called Fan Changyu broad-minded or said she no longer cared for secular rites after all she had been through, she wasn't actually that concerned about the things Xie Zheng was promising her.

But his solemn words still caused ripples to spread across the lake of her heart, as if a small pebble had been tossed in.

This feeling of being cherished and deeply loved made her feel that even if the road ahead was a mountain of knives and a sea of fire, she would walk it with the man before her without fear.

So she cupped Xie Zheng's head, leaned over, and planted a loud kiss on his forehead. Her face was red, but her eyes were sparkling and clear. "You haven't wronged me. I will marry Xie Zheng, but Yan Zheng married into my family."

Seeing Xie Zheng remain silent, she glared at him, her face flushing. "We haven't divorced yet, unless you plan to go back on your word."

Xie Zheng held her wrist tightly. After a long moment, he looked up and asked her, "Does it still hurt?"

Fan Changyu froze at first. When she realized what Xie Zheng was asking, the tips of her ears turned completely red. Mortified, she threw a punch straight at him with a thud. "Get lost!"

Xie Zheng didn't get angry after taking the punch. He smoothly intercepted her hand, pressed her back into the bedding, and kissed her fiercely for a while. Then he brought her clenched fist to his lips and kissed it, the corners of his eyes and brows filled with an irrepressible mirth and joy. "After you eat, sleep a little more. I'm going to make some arrangements to wrap things up faster. I'll send you back to the Office of Presentations later."

Fan Changyu hadn't even caught her breath yet. Hearing him talk about arrangements, she immediately recalled the conversation she had overheard from the outer room when she first woke up.

She asked, "Did something happen with the Li family again?"

The smile on Xie Zheng's lips was ice-cold. "They were simply played by Wei Yan."

"The strategist the Li family arranged to identify Wei Yan as a collaborator with the rebels was Wei Yan's man all along. During the final trial, he suddenly recanted his testimony, saying the Li family had instructed him to do everything. He even produced incriminating evidence in the form of correspondence."

Fan Changyu was astonished. She certainly knew how tight the security at the Court of Revision was now, after their prison break.

Grand Tutor Li had initially thought Wei Yan wanted to kill the witness. Since Wei Yan had men in the Court of Revision while the Li family only controlled the Western Ministry of Justice, Grand Tutor Li feared Wei Yan would continue to try and assassinate the witness. He had pushed for the Censorate's men to also be stationed at the Court of Revision and had even transferred heavy troops from the Five Armies Garrison to guard it.

Now that the strategist had recanted, one could say that Grand Tutor Li's previous actions were a case of lifting a rock only to drop it on his own foot.

She said, "You said earlier you were afraid the Li family would get desperate. Was it because of this?"

Xie Zheng nodded. "Last night, Xie San led men to the Court of Revision to break someone out and happened to run into the Li family's men luring away the Five Armies Garrison guards outside. They were intending to move against that strategist. They unwittingly foiled the Li family's plan. With their plot to kill the witness and destroy evidence having failed, their only option now is to fight to the bitter end."

Fan Changyu, however, was greatly shocked. "Wei Yan's cunning is far too deep."

She frowned. "He knew from the very beginning that the Li family was plotting against him, and he deliberately left a 'handle' for Qi Min to find, luring the Li family into his trap."

Xie Zheng's brow grew a few shades gloomier. His long eyes lowered slightly, his tone cool and sarcastic. "Hasn't he always been this unscrupulous?"

Fan Changyu squeezed his hand and said, "Your men have already rescued the old steward from the Changxin Prince Manor. We might be able to learn about Wei Yan and the Prince of Changxin's schemes from him. Heaven's net is vast; though its mesh is wide, nothing escapes it. We will eventually find the evidence to convict him."

Xie Zheng looked at the hand she was using to grip his own. The gloom and hostility coiling in his heart dissipated somewhat. He gave a soft "Alright."

After the meal, Fan Changyu did not rest. She went with Xie Zheng to the Xie Manor's private prison to interrogate the steward from the Sui residence.

At first, the steward was extremely tight-lipped. He refused to say anything no matter what they asked, only feigning madness and idiocy.

Later, Xie Zheng had someone bring Zhao Xun and the mother-son pair over. Seeing that his act was useless, the steward refused to speak a word, even with his grandson as a weakness.

Xie Zheng ordered the use of torture. The old man, who looked to be in his declining years, was surprisingly tough. He would rather bite his own

tongue and commit suicide than confess, and his degree of loyalty to the Prince of Changxin truly astonished Fan Changyu.

Xie Zheng also keenly noticed this. The old man was in poor health; any more torture and he would likely die in this prison. He switched to a psychological attack.

The fire in the brazier illuminated the entire dark, damp dungeon. Xie Zheng sat in a Grand Tutor chair, took the hot tea a personal guard handed him, and unhurriedly scraped the lid against the cup twice. In a very casual tone, he said, "Your son has already been beaten to death in court. This Marquis does not like to stain his hands with the blood of a child, but my patience is truly limited. If you continue to be so unappreciative, the men by my side are all experts at death by a thousand cuts. They will slice the flesh from your grandson's body piece by piece to feed the dogs. I guarantee that when they cut to his organs, he will still be alive, able to cry out for you, 'Grandpa'."

After he finished speaking, he raised his eyes and looked at the old man opposite him indifferently through the steam rising from the teacup.

The woman holding the child had already fainted from fright upon hearing Xie Zheng's description. Only the child beside her was left, crying for his "Mama" and "Grandpa." His tender cries were like those of a lamb about to be sent to slaughter, making one's heart clench involuntarily.

Fan Changyu knew that this threat was necessary to break the old man's psychological defenses, so she forced herself to sit in the Grand Tutor chair beside him and watch coldly.

The old man watched his grandson cry on the ground as he tried to shake his mother awake. His own old face was streaked with tears of anguish, but he only said, "Grandpa has let you down. Grandpa has let you down, but Grandpa has no choice..."

Xie Zheng's long eyes narrowed with impatience. He called out, "Shiyi."

Xie Shiyi gestured to the outside. Soon, a servant led in several vicious wolfhounds, drool dripping from their mouths. Upon seeing the small child inside, the hounds began to bark wildly, scaring the child into screaming and crying.

The old man, covered in blood from the torture, had eyes filled with turbid tears. He kowtowed ceaselessly toward Xie Zheng. "The child is innocent! Please give the boy a quick death! His Highness's grace to me is

as heavy as a mountain. Without His Highness, my family would have long ceased to exist. These past decades of my life were borrowed from the King of Hell. This old servant swore an oath never to betray His Highness!"

The wolfhounds, held back by the guards, were almost upon the child, yet the old man, apart from weeping and kowtowing for a quick death for the boy, still wouldn't relent in the slightest.

Fan Changyu looked at Xie Zheng. Xie Zheng made a gesture, and the guard pulled back the wolfhounds that were straining to lunge forward, then retreated.

Fan Changyu said to the old man, "You are utterly loyal to Sui Tuo? But what if the one you are loyal to now is not Sui Tuo's descendant? You don't have to feign madness with me. The one who died in Jizhou was not the real Sui Yuanhuai. Otherwise, you wouldn't have had your daughter-in-law and grandson pretend to be his concubine and child."

The old man's crying stopped short. He stared at Fan Changyu. "What did you mean by that first sentence?"

Fan Changyu glanced at Xie Zheng, then said to the old man, "I mean it was a case of swapping the prince for a leopard cat. Seventeen years ago, during the fire in the Eastern Palace, the Princess of Changxin and her son were also invited to the Eastern Palace. The one who died in the fire was the real Sui Yuanhuai. The one whose face was burned was the imperial eldest grandson. This was a scheme of a golden cicada shedding its shell from the very beginning."

The old man's expression was one of terrified disbelief. He repeated over and over, "How is that possible... How is that possible..."

Fan Changyu continued, "The young Princess of Changxin and Sui Yuanqing also died at his hands."

The old man's body slumped, but a fierce light suddenly erupted in his eyes. "Didn't the Princess Consort commit suicide to cover for the Eldest Young Master? As for the Heir Apparent, he died at your hands! Don't you dare try to trick this old servant with such lies! I won't fall for it!"

Zhao Xun spoke up at the right moment. "I can testify that that person is indeed not the Eldest Young Master of your Changxin Prince Manor."

The old man spat at him viciously. "The words of a traitor cannot be trusted!"

The old man's stubbornness was giving Fan Changyu a headache.

Staying in the dungeon for too long was stifling. When Fan Changyu went outside with Xie Zheng for some fresh air, she kicked at the snow on the ground and sighed, "He's a tough one. What if we can't pry his mouth open?"

She had initially wondered why Xie Zheng hadn't told the old man that Sui Yuanhuai was an imposter and had instead started by threatening him with the child.

After this, she understood. For someone so stubborn, who wouldn't shed a tear until he saw his own coffin, you couldn't convince him without concrete, irrefutable proof.

Fine snow began to drift from the sky again, under a bleak and gloomy overcast.

Snowflakes landed in Fan Changyu's hair. As Xie Zheng reached up to brush them away, he looked down at her and said, "I want to stage a play using the imperial great-grandson. Are you willing?"

Fan Changyu hesitated for a second, then nodded. "As long as Bao'er won't be harmed, I'll go get Bao'er to cooperate."

The old man could disregard his own grandson's life for his loyalty to the Sui family, but he would certainly not ignore Yu Bao'er's safety.

It seemed that using Bao'er was the only way to pry his mouth open.

That afternoon, Fan Changyu secretly returned to the Office of Presentations to pick up Yu Bao'er. Changning hadn't seen her all day, and when she saw her return only to take Yu Bao'er out and not her, she immediately grew so upset that she started shedding tears like pearls.

Helpless, Fan Changyu couldn't persuade Changning no matter what she said. Thinking that Xie Zheng's manor was also safe and that taking Changning along probably wouldn't cause any problems, she informed Aunt Zhao and then, under the pretext of taking the two children out to play, led them out of the Office of Presentations.

Little did she know, it was precisely this twist of fate that allowed both children to avoid a disaster.

Chapter 154

Yu Bao'er was extremely sensible. When Fan Changyu told him they needed to perform an act to trick the old steward of the Sui family into confessing, he immediately nodded in agreement to cooperate.

The dungeon was gloomy and dim. Fan Changyu didn't let Changning follow them inside, instructing Xie Qi to keep her entertained in the manor for a while.

To intimidate the old steward, Xie Zheng ordered Bao'er to be dressed in bloodstained, tattered clothes. His face was painted pale and ashen with disguise paste, even adorned with a few realistic-looking scars.

When Xie Zheng brought Bao'er back into the dungeon, the old steward indeed became extremely agitated. Gripping the prison bars tightly, his wrinkled face twisted in anguish: "Young master... what have you done to the young master?"

Yu Bao'er stood outside the cell covered in "wounds," his eyes hollow and vacant, as if he had endured severe abuse.

Xie Zheng stood behind him with his hands clasped behind his back. The light from the wall sconces cast his shadow over Bao'er, completely enveloping him. In the dim dungeon, the dark golden embroidery on his robes shimmered faintly in the candlelight, his refined features icy cold: "You didn't care when we flayed your grandson's flesh. I wonder if your mouth will remain just as tight when we start slicing this child's flesh."

Hearing this, Yu Bao'er immediately trembled in response, his large, dark eyes filling with genuine fear.

The old steward collapsed to his knees, sobbing uncontrollably against the prison bars, his voice shaking with grief: "Don't hurt the young master, don't touch him! I'll confess anything you want to know..."

After exchanging a glance with Xie Zheng, Fan Changyu questioned the old steward: "Seventeen years ago, when Wei Qilin, the Envoy General of Pacification under General Changshan, took the Tiger Tally to Chongzhou to mobilize troops, why did Chongzhou refuse to send reinforcements?"

The old steward's weeping abruptly ceased upon hearing this. He raised his aged eyes to scrutinize Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu's expression turned severe: "Answer me!"

Xie Shiyi promptly cracked his whip: "How dare you! Who gave you the audacity to stare at the General?"

The whip was carefully controlled—painful enough to hurt but not seriously injure. As it lashed across the old steward's back, the searing pain made him tremble uncontrollably. He lowered his head, not daring to look up again, muttering almost instinctively: "I don't know... what Tiger Tally or troop mobilization... how would an old man like me know such things..."

Fan Changyu frowned deeply, about to speak, when Xie Zheng interjected: "Shiyi."

Xie Shiyi immediately grabbed Yu Bao'er and dragged him outside the cell to the torture chamber. From the old steward's vantage point, he could clearly see the iron cages containing several bloodthirsty hounds, their bars stained with dark, dried blood. After Bao'er let out a bloodcurdling scream, a piece of bloody flesh was thrown into the cages, sending the hounds into a frenzied scramble.

The mere sight of this made the old steward retch violently. He cried out hoarsely: "Stop cutting! Stop! I'll confess, I'll confess everything!"

Xie Zheng looked down coldly at the old man groveling and retching like an insect, his voice slow and deliberate: "Listen well, old fool. The fact that I'm asking you these questions means I already know much. What I ask may not be what I don't know. If you dare lie to me even once, not only will the remaining Sui family scum perish, but your grandson will also be flayed alive and fed to the dogs!"

The old steward's face was as pale as paper, kowtowing repeatedly while weeping, "This old servant dares not anymore, this old servant dares not anymore."

Only then did Xie Zheng slowly ask, "Then tell me, why didn't Chongzhou send troops seventeen years ago?"

The old steward trembled, his cracked lips devoid of much color, and said, "Envoy General of Pacification Wei Qilin did indeed come to Chongzhou with the Tiger Tally and Wei Yan's personal letter. But the

prince said the Tiger Tally was fake. The prince matched the two halves of the tally in front of all the Chongzhou soldiers, and they couldn't fit together at all. The prince suspected Wei Yan of harboring ill intentions and wanted to capture Wei Qilin to hold Wei Yan accountable."

Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng's expressions changed drastically.

From this, it seemed that Wei Yan had indeed been treacherous back then, daring even to forge the Tiger Tally.

But Xie Zheng quickly said, "You're lying. The Tiger Tally Wei Yan ordered Wei Qilin to bring from Meng Shuyuan in Changzhou was genuine. Why would the Chongzhou tally be fake?"

He coldly commanded, "Eleven."

Soon, the sound of a blade cutting flesh came from the torture chamber again. Yu Bao'er screamed for her "mother," and another bloody piece of meat was thrown into the iron cage for the hounds to fight over.

The mother and son serving as Yu Qianqian's substitutes seemed to have been brought over to witness the torture as well. Their hysterical screams joined the cacophony of women and children's piercing cries, filling the dungeon and grating on the eardrums.

The old steward frantically kowtowed on the ground until his forehead bled, wailing, "Don't cut, don't cut! This old servant is telling the truth! I'm just a steward in the prince's household, I don't know that much! After Wei Qilin was captured alive, he escaped not long after. Then came the news of Jinzhou's defeat, followed by the imperial court blaming Old General Meng for the loss, attributing Jinzhou's fall to the failure in grain transport..."

The old steward wept bitterly, "Only then did the prince realize that Wei Qilin had come with the Tiger Tally to mobilize troops to relieve Jinzhou's urgent crisis. But the prince couldn't be certain beforehand that Old General Meng had truly gone to Luocheng. Though there was Wei Yan's personal letter, there wasn't even an imperial decree, and the Tiger Tally for troop mobilization was fake—how could the prince act recklessly?"

After Jinzhou fell, the prince was filled with remorse and quickly led his troops to set up defenses in the cities below Jinzhou, stopping the Northern Jue army's unstoppable advance. The prince intended to plead guilty to the capital once the war stabilized. But soon after, the Eastern Palace caught fire, the Crown Prince and Crown Princess were burned to

death, the princess consort and the eldest young master perished, and the young master's face was half burned..."

At this point, the old steward grew even more grief-stricken, his words dripping with anguish, "The Crown Prince died, the Sixteenth Prince died, and the Eastern Palace suddenly caught fire—how could the prince not understand that the princess consort and the eldest young master had been caught in the crossfire of the princes' struggle for the throne!

If it was truly as Wei Yan's letter claimed—that the Late Emperor wanted to protect Jinzhou and save the Sixteenth Prince, hence resorting to this desperate measure by sending Old General Meng to Luocheng and ordering the prince to transport grain—then why use a fake Tiger Tally to mobilize troops? Or was the tally swapped by someone with ulterior motives, making the prince dare not send troops, leading to Jinzhou's tragedy?"

Fan Changyu felt her limbs grow colder the more she listened, her mind growing faint and muddled. She asked, "When the imperial court concluded the case and pinned all the blame for Jinzhou's defeat on General Meng, didn't Changxin Wang consider exposing the truth?"

The old steward, his eyes clouded with tears, said, "At that time, the prince had not yet been enfeoffed for his merits in halting the northern Jue tribes' southward advance. Though he had been appointed as a general, what could he use to fight against the mastermind behind all this? If Wei Qilin had still been in the prince's hands, perhaps there would have been a witness who could testify against Wei Yan. But the capital outright denied ever sending anyone to Chongzhou to mobilize troops. Even Old General Meng's march to Luocheng was dismissed as his own vainglorious ambition. With no evidence at all, how could the prince reveal the truth to the world?"

So...

Was it Wei Yan who had swapped the Tiger Tally in Chongzhou?

Had he secretly colluded with imperial consorts, then orchestrated the deaths of the Chengde Crown Prince and the Sixteenth Prince, all to monopolize power?

The reason Wei Yan wanted to hunt down her parents was because they were the witnesses who could testify against all his crimes?

Though she had long speculated about various truths, when it was finally laid bare, Fan Changyu felt a dull ache in her head. A chilling sense of suffocation overwhelmed her, leaving her too weak to even scream in release.

Unconsciously, Fan Changyu took a step back. Xie Zheng grasped her wrist, the warmth from his palm seeping into her icy skin, barely steadying her.

The oil in the niche lamp seemed nearly spent, the wick's glow shrinking to the size of a bean, casting the dungeon into deeper shadows.

The dim yellow light carved out Xie Zheng's handsome profile. Holding Fan Changyu's wrist, his long lashes half-lowered, his face betrayed no emotion—so calm it was unnerving. "According to you, Changxin Wang lurked in Chongzhou for years before rebelling, all just to overthrow Wei Yan?"

The old steward nodded. "Half of the prince's life's wish was indeed solely for this."

Xie Zheng pressed on, "Were the rumors linking Wei Yan to the Jinzhou Massacre also spread by Changxin Wang?"

The old steward choked out another "yes," then pleaded, "Marquis, I've answered all your questions truthfully. Please spare the young master, the last of his bloodline..."

Xie Zheng slowly raised his eyes, his gaze icy. "I'll take what you've said as truth for now. But what General of the Cloud Banner told you earlier is also undeniable. The eldest young master your Sui family sheltered for seventeen years was not Sui Tuo's son, but the crown prince's eldest son, smuggled away in a golden cicada shedding its shell."

The old steward froze, his weathered face blank with shock and confusion.

Xie Zheng continued evenly, "If the Sui family were as loyal and innocent as you claim, why did the crown princess choose your household, out of all the nobles at the Eastern Palace banquet, to shelter the crown prince's son? And when the crown prince's son killed Changxin Wang's consort and Sui Yuanqing without hesitation, did he show any gratitude to the Sui family?"

His gaze, devoid of malice yet chilling, fixed on the old steward, who trembled like a leaf, tears and snot streaming down his face. "I truly know nothing of what you speak..."

Xie Zheng withdrew his gaze and said coolly, "Think carefully. What else have you forgotten about the past? After all, the eldest young master you swore loyalty to used the Sui family as a stepping stone to set up Wei Yan, and now he's relying on the Li family to vie for the throne. With Wei Yan's fall, all may rejoice—but Sui Tuo's entire family was sacrificed in his schemes. You claim loyalty to the Sui family. Don't you want revenge?"

The old steward was completely overwhelmed by these revelations. He had genuinely believed that Fan Changyu's claims were part of a scheme with Zhao Xun to deceive him.

Now that he had confessed everything he knew and heard Xie Zheng's words, his aged face bore nothing but desolation and a hollow, hopeless bewilderment.

Xie Zheng didn't miss the slightest shift in the old man's expression. Seeing that he truly seemed to know nothing more, he took Fan Changyu's wrist and led her out of the dungeon at a measured pace. The old steward, as if only now regaining his senses, knelt in the cell and broke into muffled sobs.

Fan Changyu's expression was equally grave.

Outside the cell was the interrogation chamber. Yu Bao'er and Xie Shiyi stood in the blind spots of the adjacent cells, while a tray on the table held freshly butchered, bloodied scraps of pork.

The meat thrown into the wolfhound's cage earlier had been sliced from that very tray.

Yu Bao'er had only been mimicking agonized screams. The mother and son imprisoned in the neighboring cell, like the old steward, could only see the wolfhound's cage from their vantage point. Hearing Yu Bao'er's cries and watching the hound devour the bloody meat, they had believed she was being flayed alive and screamed in terror.

When Yu Bao'er spotted Fan Changyu, she initially moved to greet her but hesitated upon seeing her pallid expression, stopping in place and calling out softly, "Aunt Changyu."

Fan Changyu gave a strained nod. "You've worked hard, Bao'er. Go find Changning to play for now."

Yu Bao'er cast an uneasy glance at Fan Changyu, then at Xie Zheng beside her, before finally following Xie Shiyi out of the dungeon.

Even after all this time, Fan Changyu still felt a suffocating weight in her chest. The interrogation chamber was furnished with a tea table and a Grand Tutor chair. She poured herself a cup of cold tea and gulped it down, her emotions stabilizing slightly. As she reached for a second cup, Xie Zheng pressed his hand over hers, still gripping the teapot.

"Changyu," his voice was low, his large palm completely covering hers as if offering support. "If you're hurting, cry it out."

From the moment she learned the truth about her father's failed rescue mission until now, Fan Changyu had remained composed, though her face had grown noticeably paler.

She lifted her gaze to Xie Zheng, her stubborn eyes tinged with red, yet still tearless. "My grandfather and my father—they were both wronged," she said.

Before, she had lacked the evidence to state this with such certainty and conviction. Now, she could.

Her voice was taut, but Xie Zheng felt an inexplicable sting in his chest.

He pulled her tightly into his embrace. "I'm sorry."

Sorry that, despite bearing burdens no lighter than his own, she had been forced to endure so much alone before the truth could come to light.

Fan Changyu forced back the burning in her eyes, her hands at her sides clenching into fists. "I will clear my grandfather's and my father's names of the disgrace they've carried for seventeen years."

From the moment she learned of her origins, she had never once stopped thinking of this. Back then, she had no proof.

Over and over, she had told herself that no matter how difficult, she would keep walking this path.

Now, with irrefutable evidence confirming what she had always believed, she had taken a massive step toward that goal—yet the flood of emotions left her aching.

How dare he?

Wei Yan, for his own selfish desires, had smeared her grandfather's name for seventeen years!

If she couldn't clear her grandfather's name, he would remain a traitor through the ages!

Even centuries later, people would still point fingers at his legacy.

That was the loyal soul who had fought for Great Yin most of his life!

Back then, because Changxin Wang hadn't dared to make the matter public, Wei Yan had turned a blind eye, allowing her parents to escape and live in hiding for sixteen years.

Now that Changxin Wang had rebelled and brought up past events again, Wei Yan feared her parents might step forward as witnesses. So he spared no effort to have them killed!

Fan Changyu rarely lost control of her emotions, but at this moment, she clearly felt the surging hatred and rage in her heart—like wild horses breaking free, rushing through her veins, churning between her bones, making her knuckles crack audibly.

Xie Zheng's hand on her back didn't loosen in the slightest as he said, "This is your vengeance, and mine too."

Not quite comfort, yet better than comfort.

Fan Changyu took a deep breath, forcibly suppressing the violent emotions in her heart, and looked up at him. "What do you plan to do?"

Just then, Xie Shiyi hurried into the dungeon with Yu Bao'er and Changning, his expression uncharacteristically panicked. Seeing the two embracing, he didn't have time to retreat, only quickly lowering his eyes. "Master, bad news—the Five Armies Garrison has surrounded the Xie residence!"

When Xie Shiyi entered with the children, Fan Changyu had immediately put distance between herself and Xie Zheng. But at this news, she had no room for embarrassment—only a sharp twitch in her brow.

Daring to openly surround the Xie residence... If it wasn't the emperor's order, then someone must be rebelling, fearing Xie Zheng might interfere, and thus striking first.

She looked at Xie Zheng, but he showed no surprise. "Grand Tutor Li is jumping the gun too quickly."

Calmly, he instructed Xie Shiyi, "Take the two children and leave the city through the secret passage first."

Then he turned to Fan Changyu.

She raised an eyebrow, her indomitable spirit and fierceness undeniable. "I'm a general who fought my way up on the battlefield. They're my enemies too—don't even think about telling me to hide with them."

Her unrestrained, radiant demeanor outshone the sun itself.

The way she lifted her brow and met his gaze hooked right into Xie Zheng's heart.

He gave her a long look and simply said, "Come with me."

Chapter 155

Because of the snow, the sky had grown dim earlier than usual.

When Xie Zheng led Fan Changyu into the study, the light was already somewhat faint. Only after lighting the lamps could they see the furnishings inside clearly.

Xie Zheng took a map from the bookshelf, spread it out on the desk, and pointed to it for Fan Changyu. "The Li family's plot against Wei Yan failed; instead, they fell into Wei Yan's trap. As things stand, their only hope for survival is to seize control of the entire capital and enthrone the Imperial Grandson. The platform of the Meridian Gate is no lower than the capital's city gates. If the Li family tries to storm it, they won't succeed in a short time. However, the Li family has operated in the capital for many years, so it's hard to say if they have moles within the Golden Guard.

"Since Wei Yan has pushed the Li family to this point, he must have a countermove prepared. But with me still in the capital, both the Li and Wei families will do everything they can to drag me into this first, lest I become the one who reaps all the benefits."

As Fan Changyu listened to Xie Zheng's analysis of the situation, her hand resting on the desk clenched tighter and tighter.

She looked up and asked, "So the Li family made the first move against you, ordering the Five Armies Garrison to surround the Xie residence?"

The corners of Xie Zheng's lips twitched, but the smile didn't reach his eyes. "This is merely the opening act."

Just then, the personal guard stationed outside the door reported again, "Master, the Five Armies Garrison outside is clamoring to search the residence. They claim someone saw a fugitive from the Court of Revision enter the Marquis's residence last night."

Fan Changyu looked at Xie Zheng with worry in her eyes. Xie Zheng simply said to the guard outside, "Then relay this to the men of the Five Armies Garrison: if they have the guts to break down the gates of my Xie residence, they are more than welcome to break in and search."

After the personal guard acknowledged the order and withdrew, Fan Changyu asked, "Did we really leave a trail?"

The candlelight flickered in Xie Zheng's eyes, but it failed to cast much warmth. "It's just Wei Yan's scheme to drag me into this. The last time you and I broke into the prison, leading the Li family to believe it was Wei Yan who freed the prisoner, I imagine Wei Yan had already begun to lay his plans. Last night, the Blood-Clad Cavalry intercepted that steward from the Sui residence, stumbled upon the Li family killing the strategist who was about to change his testimony, and even learned the location where the letters between the Li family and Qi Min are hidden. With such leverage in my hands, how could the Li family possibly sit still? Whether they have a witness or not, they would have found a pretext to surround the residence."

Fan Changyu also knew full well that the Li family was now committed to this path to the bitter end. Her heart suddenly skipped a beat. "Qi Min knows Bao'er is still with us. Will the Office of Presentations be surrounded too?"

Xie Zheng nodded. "With the military strength of the Five Armies Garrison, surrounding the Office of Presentations is a trivial matter."

Fan Changyu immediately frowned. "General Tang and Aunt Zhao are still at the Office of Presentations..."

Xie Zheng looked up at her. "That is precisely what I need you to do next."

A more solemn expression instantly appeared on Fan Changyu's face.

Xie Zheng's long index finger pointed to the location of the palace gates on the map. "The Five Armies Garrison is divided into five battalions and seventy-two guards, with a force of no less than twenty thousand. Four of these battalions might be used by the Li family, but the commander of the Left Army Battalion, Shen Shen, is on good terms with me, and the Shen family has always been loyal and upright. Xie Shisan will take my token to find him and have him block Wei Yan from mobilizing the Divine Machine Battalion. However, we still need a bait to divert the attention of the Li and Wei families. I gave you the token to command the Blood-Clad Cavalry long ago. When the time comes, you will lead all the Blood-Clad Cavalry from the residence, fight your way back to the Office of Presentations, and get Tang Peiyi and the others out."

Fan Changyu's head shot up. "If I take all the Blood-Clad Cavalry, what about you?"

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes swept toward the snow-swept window, his expression both unrestrained and filled with a languidness that suggested he had long awaited this day. "They won't believe I've assigned all the Blood-Clad Cavalry to you. They'll only assume I have more men hidden in the capital."

At this, he gave a slight lift to the corners of his lips and looked at Fan Changyu. "When falsehood is taken for truth, the truth itself becomes false. Who would dare to gamble everything on an uncertain outcome?"

But Fan Changyu was still worried. "Even if the Li family can only use the troops of four battalions, that's still over fifteen thousand men. How will you deal with them?"

Xie Zheng only said, "Both the Li and Wei families are holding back their trump cards; they won't throw all their forces at me in a life-or-death struggle. And taking a step back, even if it truly comes down to a fight to the death, the several hundred soldiers of the Xie Family Army I brought into the capital can still make them shed a layer of skin."

As Fan Changyu slowly processed what he had said, she suddenly asked, "Why are your men stopping the Divine Machine Battalion, and not the Li family's?"

Xie Zheng raised a hand and lightly touched Fan Changyu's cheek. "The Golden Guard is under the direct command of the young emperor. Wei Yan is now in the same boat as the young emperor, so the Golden Guard will certainly be at his disposal. Adding to that the elites of the Three Thousand Battalion, he can hold the palace and fight the Li family to a stalemate for a short time. But with the cannons and weaponry of the Divine Machine Battalion, no matter how numerous the Five Armies Garrison is, they will ultimately be nothing more than a pile of mangled flesh and broken bones under cannon fire."

He paused here. "When I send Shen Shen, it's less about stopping the Divine Machine Battalion and more about several factions scrambling to seize its weaponry. Understand?"

Only then did Fan Changyu grasp the importance of this deployment. She said, "Then after I rescue General Tang, I'll temporarily hand over all the forces currently available in the capital to him. I'll personally make a

trip to the Western Garden. If General Shen fails to stop the men from the Divine Machine Battalion, I will!"

The weaponry of the Divine Machine Battalion was all stored in the Western苑, outside the palace city.

Xie Zheng stared at her for a good while. Fan Changyu frowned. "You don't believe I can stop them?"

Xie Zheng forcefully pulled her into his embrace. "If you can't stop them, then don't. Just come back to me alive."

Fan Changyu looked up. "Those aren't words you should be saying to a general."

Xie Zheng lowered his head slightly, his bangs casting a faint shadow over his eyelids, concealing the tenderness hidden within his deep, aloof eyes. "You are the general of thousands, but you are also my wife. My instructions are for my wife."

Even knowing the urgency of the current situation, Fan Changyu's heart still skipped a beat when she heard his words. She pressed her lips together and stared at him intently.

"I'm leaving," she said.

She had already reached the door when she suddenly turned back, strode forward, and forcefully grabbed his collar, pulling him down. She planted a heavy kiss on his lips, then lowered her fan-like long lashes and said in a muffled voice, "I know what you have to do."

With that, she pulled open the door and strode away.

Xie Zheng stood rooted to the spot, watching her retreating back. A deep, dark emotion brewed in the depths of his black eyes. "If even the slightest thing happens to her, none of you need to come back either."

A dark shadow seemed to flit away from the room—

With the Blood-Clad Cavalry, each man worth a hundred, clearing the path, the branch of the Five Armies Garrison surrounding the Xie residence was nothing to fear. Fan Changyu and her men quickly tore open a gap and galloped straight for the Office of Presentations.

It was the New Year, and most of the shops along the streets were tightly shut. It was unclear whether the owners had gone home for the festivities or if the great commotion of soldiers coming and going today

had frightened them into closing up. The homes of ordinary folk along the streets were even more securely shuttered.

Because they were such a large, moving target, a portion of the Five Armies Garrison soldiers surrounding the Xie residence broke off to pursue them, successfully ignoring the scouts who were galloping in the opposite direction—

The main gate of the Office of Presentations had long since been smashed open. The commanding officer stood in the courtyard, his hand on the hilt of his sword, shouting coarsely, "Search! If any male child is found, kill him without exception!"

Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and a group of other generals came out upon hearing the commotion. Seeing that the intruders were from the Five Armies Garrison, they didn't dare to clash with them rashly. Tang Peiyi cupped his fist and said, "Might I ask this general, for what reason have you suddenly dispatched troops to the Office of Presentations?"

The officer's rank was several levels below Tang Peiyi's, but at this moment, he only sneered, "The Joint Trial by the Three Supreme Courts has discovered that the mother and son of the rebel who previously escaped from the Court of Revision are being harbored in the Office of Presentations. This general is under orders to conduct a search."

Tang Peiyi was a straightforward man, and seeing the man's contemptuous attitude, his face already showed displeasure. He Xiujun, however, was meticulous and immediately said, "Since you are under orders to search, we hope the general will produce a search warrant to avoid any misunderstanding and preserve harmony."

The officer couldn't produce a warrant and simply said, "Once I have the witness in hand, you can all go to the Court of Revision to see the search warrant!"

He Xiujun exchanged a look with Tang Peiyi and Zheng Wenchang, a shared understanding in their eyes.

He Xiujun chuckled amicably. "What a thing to say, General. Since we were summoned to the capital, we haven't left this Office of Presentations except when summoned by His Majesty. How could a fugitive from the Court of Revision be hiding here? There must be some misunderstanding. It's cold out here. Why not let your men do the searching? General, you

should come inside with us to warm up by the fire and have a cup of tea to ward off the chill."

As he spoke, he moved forward as if to take the officer's elbow.

The officer's eyes flickered, and he was about to refuse when He Xiujun suddenly struck. The hand gripping his arm twisted backward, and with a trip to his feet, the officer was forced to his knees, his hands pinned behind his back.

With perfect coordination, Zheng Wenchang also drew his sword and pressed it against the man's throat, shouting at the soldiers on either side who were attempting to advance, "Back off!"

The officer realized he had been careless and grit his teeth, looking at Tang Peiyi. "Let me find the person and take them away, and we can all go our separate ways. If you insist on wading into these muddy waters, it won't be so easy to get out."

Tang Peiyi stared at him for a long moment before saying simply, "Tie him up!"

Personal guards immediately came forward with ropes and bound the man tightly.

Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and Zheng Wenchang all lived together, so Tang Peiyi knew perfectly well whether they were harboring a male child. Fan Changyu, being a female general, lived in a separate courtyard. Tang Peiyi wasn't sure if Fan Changyu had truly broken someone out of prison in secret, or if this group of soldiers was just using it as a pretext to capture Yu Bao'er.

Holding the officer hostage, the group made their way to Fan Changyu's courtyard. The soldiers who had been searching everywhere, wary of their commander being captured, dared not make any further moves. They only pointed their weapons at Tang Peiyi's party, looking for an opportunity to act.

When they reached Fan Changyu's courtyard, they saw Xie Wu, holding a saber in one hand, protecting an old couple behind him.

With only one hand to wield a weapon and two elderly people to protect, he was clearly at a disadvantage. He was already bleeding, and the doors to the several side rooms in the courtyard were wide open, apparently having been broken into and searched by the soldiers.

Tang Peiyi immediately bellowed, "Stop!"

The soldiers surrounding Xie Wu saw that their commander had been captured. They exchanged glances and all eased their attacks.

Tang Peiyi gave He Xiujun a look. He Xiujun immediately took two personal guards forward to help the elderly Zhao couple. He Xiujun personally supported Xie Wu and asked in a low voice, "Where is the young master?"

Xie Wu replied, "The General took him away in secret."

He Xiujun couldn't help but breathe a sigh of relief at this answer. He turned and questioned the officer from the Five Armies Garrison, "We are residing in this Office of Presentations under imperial decree. You search without a warrant. I'd like to see who's in the right when this is reported to the Court of Revision!"

The commander still insisted, "The son of the rebel who was broken out of the Court of Revision is hidden in the Office of Presentations. By harboring a rebel, could it be that you too have rebellious intentions?"

Tang Peiyi's expression had become quite ugly.

After He Xiujun gave him a subtle nod, Tang Peiyi, knowing that Yu Bao'er was no longer here, immediately patted the face of the tightly bound officer and sneered, "Then let your men search. If they find nothing, you'll be leaving a hand and a foot here."

Hearing this, the officer glanced around. Not seeing Fan Changyu, he shouted, "The remnant of the rebels has already been taken away by the General of the Cloud Banner, hasn't he?"

Just then, the sound of urgent and chaotic horse hooves rang out from outside the Office of Presentations, immediately followed by the clash of weapons.

Tang Peiyi and the others, holding the officer hostage, headed toward the front courtyard. Just as they passed through the ornamental gate, they saw a soldier at the main entrance get kicked so hard he flew sideways down the stone steps, crashing into a flower bed and spitting out a mouthful of blood.

Fan Changyu, dressed in practical attire with a long saber on her back, fought her way in. Seeing that Tang Peiyi and his men had captured the

commander of this troop, she breathed a small sigh of relief and called out, "General Tang!"

Through the main gate, Tang Peiyi saw the Blood-Clad Cavalry outside, locked in a fierce battle with the soldiers. He quickly asked, "Niece Changyu, what is going on?"

Fan Changyu backhanded her blade to cut down a soldier attempting a sneak attack and said concisely, "The Li family is rebelling!"

Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and the others' faces all changed upon hearing this.

Without time to wipe the blood spatter from her face, Fan Changyu strode forward and looked at Tang Peiyi. "The heavens are about to change over this Great Yin. It remains to be seen what General Tang intends to do."

A rare look of gravity appeared on Tang Peiyi's rugged face. After about a breath's time, he looked at Fan Changyu. "What are the Marquis's intentions?"

Fan Changyu's forehead had been grazed during the fight, and a bead of blood slid from her temple to her jaw. Her eyes were cold and resolute. "The one on the dragon throne is an incompetent and virtueless ruler. The one the Li family wants to support, though a descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince, lived as the eldest son of the Changxin Wang in the Sui family for seventeen years. He is the one the Li family colluded with to frame Wei Yan. The siege of Lucheng and Lord He's death were all caused by this. If such a person ascends to the throne, he will be anything but a benevolent ruler."

Only today did Tang Peiyi and the others learn of these hidden details. After a moment of shock, anger surfaced on their faces.

The vicious plot to empty Chongzhou City and besiege Lucheng instead was thought up by the Li family and the Imperial Grandson?

Tang Peiyi looked at Fan Changyu. "The child you've been keeping by your side, isn't he a descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince?"

Fan Changyu said, "That child is the Imperial Grandson's son."

He Xiujun glanced at the captured officer from the Five Armies Garrison, a cold smile appearing on his gentle and refined face. "So the Five Armies

Garrison suddenly surrounded the Office of Presentations because the Imperial Grandson gave the order to kill that child?"

Fan Changyu nodded grimly.

Tang Peiyi had yet to state his position, but with his father's death weighing on him, He Xiujun could be said to hate the Imperial Grandson to the bone. He was the first to side with Fan Changyu. "I will follow the Marquis in supporting the Imperial Great-Grandson!"

Tang Peiyi looked at He Xiujun.

He Xiujun was the eldest and most level-headed of the young men. He cupped his fist towards Tang Peiyi and said:

"This humble general's action is not taken rashly out of anger over my father's death. The Imperial Grandson vies for this realm, yet he lacks a heart that cares for the common people. Like the Li family, he sought to use the lives of thousands of soldiers to fabricate a great crime for Wei Yan. In terms of public duty, he lacks the benevolence of a Son of Heaven. In terms of private matters, he is willing to have his own son killed for the sake of the throne. Even wolves and jackals are not so vicious. If the lands of the Great Yin fall into the hands of such a person, how would it be any different from when Wei Yan controlled the court? What face would we have in the future to meet the soldiers who died in battle outside Lucheng?"

Zheng Wenchang immediately stood with Fan Changyu as well, followed by twos and threes of the Jizhou generals who had entered the capital with them.

The tragedy of the battle of Lucheng was, after all, a great thorn in the hearts of these Jizhou generals.

Tang Peiyi sighed deeply and looked at Fan Changyu. "I don't know if I will regret today's decision in the future, but neither the one Wei Yan supports nor the one the Li family wants to enthrone is worthy of that dragon throne. For today's action, whether it leads to success or failure, I, Tang Peiyi, will follow the Marquis and change the heavens for this Great Yin!"

Only after Tang Peiyi had nodded did Fan Changyu feel her heart finally settle.

With Tang Peiyi's help, Xie Zheng's chances of stabilizing the capital tonight increased by another thirty percent!—

Outside the Office of Presentations, the Blood-Clad Cavalry were still fighting the soldiers of the Five Armies Garrison. A bloody head was thrown out from the main gate, rolling several times on the stone tiles before coming to a stop.

Fan Changyu's horse-cutting sword was still dripping with blood. Under the flickering lamplight, her eyes held the ferocity of a tiger descending a mountain. Her cold, crisp voice tore through the clamor of the cold night, "Zhou Tong, Adjutant of the Right Flank Army, is dead! If you surrender, the crimes of tonight can be forgiven!"

The Five Armies Garrison stationed in the capital was divided into the Central Army, Left and Right Flank Army, and Left and Right Sentry Army battalions, with the Central Army Battalion being the most numerous.

The soldiers, who had been in a chaotic melee, all stopped upon seeing the bloody head.

Tang Peiyi immediately followed up, "This general is about to assist the Wu'an Marquis in apprehending the conspirators. If you do not surrender, all who surrounded the Office of Presentations tonight will be charged with the crime of treason."

This unit of the Right Flank Army, having lost its commander and now hearing these threats, was instantly filled with alarm. After looking around at each other, they all lowered their weapons.

Seeing that the situation at the Office of Presentations had stabilized, Fan Changyu immediately looked at Tang Peiyi. "General Tang, I'll leave this to you."

Tang Peiyi asked, "You're not coming with us to the imperial palace?"

Fan Changyu swung onto her horse, the cold wind lifting the strands of hair that had come loose on her forehead during the fight. "I'm going to stop the Divine Machine Battalion from reinforcing the palace city."

With just that one sentence, Tang Peiyi understood Fan Changyu's intention.

He said, "Then take more men with you!"

As he spoke, he assigned several more men to Fan Changyu, Zheng Wenchang among them.

Fan Changyu did not refuse, only cupping her fist towards Tang Peiyi from horseback. "Thank you, General!"

Fan Changyu led Zheng Wenchang, the others, and the Blood-Clad Cavalry as they galloped towards the Western Garden.

After watching them ride away, Tang Peiyi shouted to the surrendered Right Flank Army, "You will all follow me to 'rescue the emperor'!"—

As dusk deepened, the wind and snow grew heavier. A thin layer of snow had already accumulated on the shades of the lanterns hanging under the eaves.

The dim yellow light from under the eaves cast the swaying shadows of bamboo onto the doors and windows of a lit room. Vaguely visible inside were the blurry figures of two people, each sitting on one side of a low table, playing Go.

One figure was gaunt but graceful, his sparse hair tied in a small bun at the back of his head and secured with a long pin. From time to time, he would stroke the few long, equally sparse strands of his beard.

The other figure was powerfully built, his back as straight as a pine tree even while sitting on a cushion. His movements as he placed his stones were decisive, filled with the aura of a killer.

Both men were like mountains. One was like a high mountain with flowing water, elegant and serene; the other was like Mount Song, majestic and magnificent.

As his gaunt index and middle fingers placed another white stone on the board, Tao Taifu looked at the man opposite him and sighed, or perhaps not. "Yigui, this game... you've walked into a dead end."

Gui, a ritual object made of jade. Yigui was Wei Yan's courtesy name.

In the entire court today, only the weathered old man opposite him dared to call him by this name.

The wind outside was strong, making the bamboo shadows dance wildly. Wei Yan returned the black stone in his hand to the bowl and said only, "Not necessarily. Perhaps by dawn, there will be a way to break the stalemate."

Chapter 156

When Tang Peiyi arrived at the Xie residence with his men, he saw an unknown building in the front courtyard engulfed in flames, the firelight illuminating the sky. The green bricks paving the entrance were already stained crimson with blood, the red hue still creeping outward in winding streams.

The thick snowflakes drifting down from the night sky melted instantly upon touching the scarlet-stained ground.

Corpses lay scattered everywhere. Xie Zheng stood among them, gripping a halberd with one hand. His black armor had long been dyed a dark red by blood, and droplets continued to drip from the ancient qiongqi-patterned blade of his halberd. His head was slightly lowered, obscuring his expression, leaving only the cold, pale half of his jaw visible in the firelight—wild and ruthless.

Behind him stood several hundred guards, their killing intent palpable after the slaughter, appearing like vengeful spirits in the night.

Even Tang Peiyi and his men, seated on horseback, couldn't help but inhale sharply at the sight.

As the blood slowly consumed the snow, spreading toward the street and reaching beneath their horses' hooves, the animals seemed to sense the ominous aura, lifting their hooves and stepping back.

Only then did Xie Zheng raise his eyes, casting a cold glance at Tang Peiyi.

Tang Peiyi clasped his fists from atop his horse. "Marquis," he greeted, but found himself at a loss for further words.

Judging by the corpses at the Xie residence's gate, the forces besieging it had numbered at least five battalions from the Central Army Battalion. A cannon had even been positioned nearby—they had brought firearms—yet all had fallen to the hands of Xie's few hundred guards.

Hadn't it been said that the Wu'an Marquis commanded only eight hundred Blood-Clad Cavalry? Fan Changyu had already taken seven or

eight hundred with her. Who were these men?

Tang Peiyi was utterly stunned.

The blazing firelight illuminated the varied expressions of the men on horseback.

Xie Zheng kicked aside a corpse at his feet, his blood-smeared face eerily calm. "Bringing just two thousand troops and daring to bombard my family's gates." He scoffed. "They truly had a death wish."

Among the seventy-two battalions of the Five Armies Garrison, the Central Army Battalion alone boasted eight thousand men. The Li family had dispatched a quarter of that force to besiege the Xie residence, clearly still wary of Xie Zheng—yet they had still underestimated him.

From the other end of the street came the sound of chaotic hoofbeats, torches weaving together like a dragon.

Both Xie's elite troops, fresh from their bloody battle, and Tang Peiyi's men turned to look. The unfamiliar commander on horseback wore the armor of the Three Thousand Battalion.

Xie Zheng watched coldly, his expression still unnervingly indifferent. He handed his halberd to a guard behind him and casually picked up a crossbow, taking aim. "Here come those hoping to reap the spoils," he remarked lazily.

The blizzard raged, scattering ancestral paper money across the empty streets, lending an eerie air to what should have been a lively New Year's Eve.

Outside the Meridian Gate, the scene was ablaze with light. A sea of soldiers stretched across the plaza flanked by the Yanchi Towers, the front ranks holding thick shields overhead to block arrows fired from the towers above. Without a battering ram in the capital, the soldiers below lifted a massive thousand-jin cauldron from the plaza, slamming it repeatedly against the palace gates.

At the rear of the formation, Grand Tutor Li, clad in an official robe embroidered with cranes, watched the surging tide of soldiers. Beside him stood a pale, gloomy man wrapped in a heavy cloak. "We have men among the Golden Guard," Li said. "The palace gates will fall within the time it takes to burn one stick of incense."

Qi Min's face bore the clear pallor of illness as he lazily lifted his gaze. "No movement from Wu'an Marquis?"

Grand Tutor Li glanced at him, his expression revealing nothing despite the implicit challenge to the Li family's arrangements. "I have already turned four battalions of the Five Armies Garrison to our side. Wu'an Marquis came to the capital without his army, and his personal guard of eight hundred cavalry was taken away by the Meng family's daughter. Even if Xie Zheng is a peerless strategist, without troops, what waves can he stir?"

Qi Min's expression softened slightly.

Grand Tutor Li smiled faintly. "The Imperial Astronomers have also spread word that the droughts and floods in recent years were caused by the disruption of the dragon veins and an illegitimate succession. The people have long resented Wei Yan's grip on the court. The late Chengde Crown Prince's reputation among the populace remains undiminished. As his descendant, Your Highness' ascension is both the will of the people and the wish of the ministers."

Qi Min remained silent, but his eyes reflected the brightly lit Yanshi Tower in the distance.

The thick night seemed to press down on the imperial city, adorned with festive red lanterns, making it appear to crouch as if bowing at his feet.

Seventeen years. He had finally returned to this place.

Qi Min rubbed the jade thumb ring on his finger, his expression calm. Yet in this moment, the sensation of holding everything in his grasp fueled his ambition like the torches blazing between the palace halls, swelling unchecked at the pinnacle of power.

Heaven and earth, the vast cosmos...

The rising and setting of the sun and moon no longer mattered. He was about to become the emperor of this realm.

The palace gates, unable to withstand the assault, finally gave way under the heavy battering of the great cauldron. The troops of the Five Armies Garrison roared as they stormed into the palace, blood splattering across the narrow palace corridors.

As Qi Min followed Grand Tutor Li into the palace, he frowned slightly at the sight of the fallen Golden Guard corpses. His tone was unreadable,

neither mocking nor questioning. "Wei Yan has controlled the court for over a decade, and this is all he could muster?"

The general sent to capture the young emperor at Taiqian Palace returned in haste. "Grand Tutor! Taiqian Palace is empty!"

Both Qi Min and Grand Tutor Li's expressions darkened.

Grand Tutor Li barked, "Then search the entire palace! Find him!"

Though the general obeyed, neither Grand Tutor Li nor Qi Min could ease their unease.

Had the lax palace defenses been a trap to lure them in?

As if confirming their suspicions, the clatter of armor echoed from beyond the palace gates. Climbing Yanshi Tower, they saw nearly two thousand fully armored cavalry assembled in the Meridian Gate square—far superior to ordinary Five Armies Garrison soldiers.

A tall, stern elder strode forward from the cavalry ranks, his hawk-like gaze sweeping over Qi Min and Grand Tutor Li on the tower. "Li Xing has plotted rebellion. These traitorous subjects are to be apprehended at once."

Though Grand Tutor Li's face was grim, he remained composed. Raising his voice, he retorted, "Wei, you old fool! Do you truly believe your meager Three Thousand Battalion can subdue the Five Armies Garrison?"

Wei Yan replied, "Of course not. But you, Grand Tutor, have never commanded troops and thus do not know the stratagem of 'all warfare is based on deception.'"

Before Grand Tutor Li could grasp his meaning, Wei Yan signaled below. The archers on the tower, who had been aiming their arrows downward, instantly turned their bows toward Grand Tutor Li, Qi Min, and their retinue.

Their guards hastily drew their swords, eyeing the archers warily. But arrows were merciless, and the sudden reversal left even the guards visibly shaken.

Among the four battalions that had pledged allegiance to him, two were actually Wei Yan's men! The remaining two battalions and the Li family guards exchanged uneasy glances.

Grand Tutor Li gritted his teeth in unwillingness as he glared at Wei Yan: "These two battalions are yours? Since when?"

Wei Yan stood with his hands behind his back before the military formation, his solid and upright frame outlined by the cold wind: "Grand Tutor Li might ask yourself—if you couldn't even protect your own grandson, what ability do you have to earn the trust of outsiders?"

Grand Tutor Li's jaw tightened. No matter how strong-willed he was, his face couldn't help but pale at this moment.

Qi Min, who had remained silent until now, suddenly clapped his hands and laughed: "Well said. I just wonder if the Prime Minister can still command the loyalty of his troops after his wife and son have been captured."

Wei Yan lifted his gaze coldly toward Qi Min, who showed no fear despite being targeted by countless arrows, instead curling his lips with amusement.

Commotion arose beyond the cavalry formation as a messenger from Wei Mansion arrived on horseback, reporting urgently: "Prime Minister, Wei Mansion has been attacked! The Lady and the young master have been taken!"

The messenger's arm was stained with blood, clearly fresh from a fierce battle.

Wei Yan looked at Qi Min again. The two had clashed before, and Wei Yan knew well that Qi Min commanded a unit of royal Shadow Guards left behind by the late Chengde Crown Prince—Martial Assassins who had once received the Crown Prince's favor, skilled beyond measure and loyal only to Qi Min.

Many of Wei Yan's own top-tier Martial Assassins had fallen to those Shadow Guards.

Qi Min had few men around him—evidently, he had sent them to Wei Mansion.

Grand Tutor Li was overjoyed upon hearing this and immediately taunted Wei Yan: "Wei Yan, let's see if you still care for your wife and child. If you're heartless enough to abandon your only son and cling to power like a eunuch, history will surely mock you for centuries to come."

Before Wei Yan could respond, a languid yet icy voice cut through the cold wind: "The palace tonight is truly... quite lively."

All eyes turned toward the rear of the military formation. The ranks of Wei Yan's cavalry swiftly shifted formation, leveling their spears at a group approaching unhurriedly from the front.

Xie Zheng, clad in bloodstained black armor, led several hundred elite soldiers of the Xie Family Army from the capital, along with Tang Peiyi and others, strolling leisurely toward the official grounds outside the Meridian Gate.

Qi Min had remained composed when Wei Yan appeared outside the palace with the Three Thousand Battalion, but at the sight of Xie Zheng, his expression darkened completely.

He turned to Grand Tutor Li: "Wasn't he supposed to be trapped in Xie Manor?"

Grand Tutor Li, noticing Tang Peiyi and the troops from Jizhou, fumed: "It must be Tang Peiyi who broke the siege! I underestimated those brutes!"

The night was too dark for him to see clearly that Xie Zheng and his elite soldiers seemed drenched in blood, or he might not have been so confident.

Seeing Qi Min's grim expression, he quickly added: "The imperial great-grandson is in Xie Zheng's hands. He likely aims to emulate Wei Yan from seventeen years ago, using tonight's chaos to install that child on the throne. The outcome is still uncertain!"

Qi Min's eyes darkened, his thoughts inscrutable. Suddenly, he called out to Xie Zheng: "Since Wu'an Marquis has joined tonight's festivities, why not ally with me?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer immediately. Qi Min continued: "Seventeen years ago, my father and General Xie fell in battle at Jinzhou. Surely you, too, seek vengeance for that?"

Xie Zheng lifted his gaze lazily. "Your Highness seems to know the truth behind the Battle of Jinzhou?"

Qi Min burst into laughter. "How could I not know?"

He pointed at Wei Yan and declared, "The fall of Jinzhou, the massacre of its citizens, and the cession of the twelve eastern provinces to the barbarians—all were orchestrated by Wei Yan himself in his scheme to seize the Great Yin throne!"

His words plunged the palace into dead silence.

Most of those present knew nothing of the truth behind Jinzhou's tragedy. Even Grand Tutor Li, who had only partial knowledge, felt his eyelids twitch violently at Qi Min's unwavering tone.

The devastation that the fall of Jinzhou had brought upon Great Yin had taken over a decade to recover from. If all of it had truly been Wei Yan's design, then even ten thousand deaths would not suffice to atone for his crimes.

The hatred that had festered in Qi Min's chest for more than a decade finally found its outlet. A hint of crimson tinged the corners of his eyes as he sneered at Wei Yan. "Seventeen years ago, you bathed the imperial palace in blood and thought no one would remember your debauchery and treachery within these walls?"

Wei Yan's expression remained unmoved, but his gaze turned icy. Cutting off Qi Min's words, he issued a cold command: "Storm the city."

Chapter 157

Beneath the palace walls, the dark mass of cavalry and soldiers stirred into motion, while atop the Yanchi Tower, the forces of the two great battalions stood in tense confrontation, poised for battle.

From the military formation behind the Meridian Gate square came the sharp sound of blades being drawn. Wei Yan turned slightly and saw the flickering torchlight reflecting off a sea of cold steel.

Xie Zheng lifted the corner of his lips slightly, twisting the reins in his hand with a lazy yet overwhelmingly oppressive smile. "Let him speak."

He was but a step away from the truth. Though his smile remained composed, his eyes held nothing but endless coldness.

Another wave of commotion rose beyond the crowd as a carriage sped forth. The curtain was lifted, and Shadow Guards emerged, pushing Wei Xuan and Madam Wei out of the carriage. A shout rang out: "Madam Wei and Wei Xuan are here!"

Above the city wall, Qi Min's smile grew increasingly wild. His pale, almost bluish hand pressed against the cold bricks of the battlement as he stared down at Wei Yan. "How fortunate—your wife and son have arrived. I swear, if your men take even one step forward, their heads will roll!"

Madam Wei and Wei Xuan were tightly bound, their mouths gagged with cloth. Madam Wei's eyes were filled with anguish and guilt as she looked at Wei Yan, desperately shaking her head, unable to utter a word beyond muffled cries.

Wei Xuan, on the other hand, was furious to the point of madness. His veins bulged from straining against the ropes binding him, the friction against his neck having already broken the skin, leaving raw wounds.

When Xie Zheng caught sight of Madam Wei, his cold phoenix eyes narrowed slightly, and the faint smirk on his lips tightened imperceptibly.

Wei Yan's followers all turned to him, awaiting his command. After only a moment's silence, he issued the order once more: "Storm the city."

This time, his trusted aides did not hesitate. Drawing their swords, they roared, "Storm the city—"

Instantly, chaos erupted atop the walls as the forces of the Five Armies Garrison clashed, each fighting for their own master. Below, part of the Three Thousand Battalion cavalry charged at the palace gates, which had been barricaded anew, while the rest remained locked in a standoff with Xie Zheng's men.

From the city wall, Qi Min gestured to the Shadow Guard below. The guard immediately removed the gag from Wei Xuan's mouth. Proud and defiant by nature, Wei Xuan, now freed from restraint, snarled like a rabid hyena, his eyes bloodshot as he roared, "If you've got the guts, kill me now!"

The Shadow Guard did not kill him. Instead, he forced him to his knees and drove a blade into his shoulder from behind, twisting it viciously. Blood instantly soaked through his clothes, gushing out in streams.

Wei Xuan let out a piercing scream that shook the air.

By the time the blade was withdrawn, he could barely remain kneeling, collapsing onto the ground. His face was deathly pale, covered in a sheen of sweat, his filthy hair matted with blood from his own wounds.

When he mustered enough strength to speak, his lips trembled, and all he could manage was: "Kill me..."

Beside him, Madam Wei was restrained by another Shadow Guard, still gagged and unable to make a sound. She struggled to reach her son but was held back, her eyes swollen from weeping, on the verge of fainting.

Xie Zheng watched all this coldly, his grip on his halberd tightening.

From the city wall, Qi Min sneered, "The Prime Minister's heart is truly as hard as iron, unmoved even by the life of his own son."

Then, turning his gaze to Madam Wei, who was nearly collapsing from grief, he added leisurely, "But Madam Wei need not despair. After all, this wouldn't be the first time the Prime Minister has killed his own child."

These words undoubtedly stirred up a storm. Not only was Grand Tutor Li beside them horrified, but even Xie Zheng's eyes darkened a few shades.

Wei Yan had another child?

The usually silent Wei Yan suddenly lifted his cold gaze, his voice stern and imposing: "Silence!"

Qi Min's gaze finally returned to Wei Yan, meeting his eyes across the city tower. After seventeen years of vengeance, he felt nothing but exhilaration in his heart. With a light laugh, he said, "What is the Prime Minister afraid of? When you frequented Qinghe Palace to commit adultery with Shu Fei, schemed the Jinzhou Massacre for the sake of the bastard in her belly, and caused the deaths of my father and sixteenth uncle, did you never think of this day?"

Compared to Qi Min's triumphant joy at nearing his revenge, Wei Yan's eyes held nothing but killing intent. He slowly commanded, "Kill everyone present today without exception."

His trusted subordinate fired a signal flare, its long trail of sparks soaring into the sky, only to be shot down by an arrow. The sparks exploded amidst the crowd like a firecracker.

Wei Yan glanced back and saw Xie Zheng seated on horseback, bow in hand, his icy expression laced with bone-deep hatred as he stared at him: "Is this why you killed my parents?"

Qi Min laughed loudly from the city tower: "What does killing his own sister and brother-in-law matter? When the truth came to light, the Late Emperor sought to punish Shu Fei, but Wei Yan set Qinghe Palace ablaze, burning Shu Fei and her unborn child alive to destroy the evidence!"

He emphasized the last four words heavily.

For a moment, the chaotic battlefield at the palace gates seemed to fall silent.

Wei Yan stood in the desolate cold wind, his lips parting to utter only one frigid word: "Kill."

The three forces clashed once more. Seeing that Wei Yan truly seemed indifferent to the lives of Madam Wei and her son, a fierce expression flashed across Qi Min's face. He shouted to the Shadow Guard below the tower: "Since the Prime Minister is so heartless, send Madam Wei and her son to hell first!"

Wei Xuan, upon hearing Qi Min reveal the truth, collapsed in a pool of blood, staring unblinkingly at Wei Yan's distant, indifferent profile. His face

tensed, the veins in his eyes gradually reddening as tears rolled down his cheeks, dripping into the blood below.

When the Shadow Guard's blade descended, he didn't even struggle.

Only Madam Wei continued to shake her head and weep at him, as if trying to speak but gagged.

As the blade swung toward Madam Wei, Xie Zheng swept his halberd, sending the Shadow Guard flying ten feet away.

The strike aimed at Wei Xuan was blocked by a Martial Assassin from Wei Mansion who appeared out of nowhere.

Seven or eight signal flares soared into the night sky—even if arrows were fired to intercept them, it was too late.

The Central Army Battalion and Right Flank Battalion still served the Li family. The Central Army Battalion alone matched the strength of two battalions. Even with the remaining two battalions of the Five Armies Garrison, the Golden Guard, and the Three Thousand Battalion supporting Wei Yan, the forces below the city—Xie Zheng and Tang Peiyi—were tough opponents. The three factions had initially maintained a fragile balance.

But when a deafening explosion erupted from the palace, blasting dozens of Central Army Battalion soldiers into the air, everyone knew the scales had tipped irrevocably in Wei Yan's favor.

The Golden Guard spy bribed by Grand Tutor Li had long since had his throat slit. As Grand Tutor Li watched the artillery and military equipment hauled out from the palace by the Golden Guard commander, his hand trembled faintly as he pointed at Wei Yan: "You... you had already moved the Divine Machine Battalion's weapons into the palace?"

Amid the swirling snow, Wei Yan stood on the imperial path of the Meridian Gate, the blazing firelight casting his shadow long. The cold wind howled through his wide sleeves as he said indifferently, "Without dangling the Divine Machine Battalion as bait, how could I lure you all into fighting over it?"

Qi Min's fingers dug into the crenellations of the city wall, his knuckles white with tension. Gritting his teeth, he glared coldly at Wei Yan below, his expression dark and venomous.

Tang Peiyi and the others also looked grim as they turned to Xie Zheng: "Marquis, General Fan has gone to the Western Garden—could she have

fallen into Wei Yan's trap?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer, his eyes roiling with fury. Suddenly, with a cold shout, he yanked the reins and charged straight at Wei Yan, halberd in hand. The gust of wind from his galloping warhorse left Tang Peiyi gasping.

Tang Peiyi quickly ordered his subordinate generals to follow and provide cover, then turned to He Xiujun: "Nephew, the Marquis and I will hold off Wei Yan here. You must take men to the Western Garden and assist Changyu!"

He Xiujun had just knocked a mounted officer off his horse, a strand of his neatly tied hair now loose and disheveled. He replied hastily, "If Wei Yan has truly set a trap in the Western Garden, sending more men won't help. The only way to save General Fan is to capture Wei Yan himself!"

Tang Peiyi watched Xie Zheng, who fought like a god of war, forcing Wei Yan's generals into retreat. Slapping his horse's flank, he declared, "Then I'll go assist the Marquis!"

A golden mace suddenly swept in from the side. Tang Peiyi barely dodged by leaning flat against his horse's back, only for another heavy mace to strike toward his abdomen. He hastily raised his spear horizontally to block, but the impact sent numbing tremors from his palms down his entire arms.

"General!"

He Xiujun spotted Tang Peiyi's predicament from nearby. With a flick of his white-tasseled spear, he thrust at the assailant's vitals. The man raised his mace to parry, giving Tang Peiyi the chance to spur his horse away and regroup with He Xiujun.

Spitting on the ground, Tang Peiyi muttered, "Damn it, who is this guy? I've served for decades and never seen anyone like him."

The man deflected He Xiujun's spear with his mace, then struck the shaft with a backhanded blow, sending He Xiujun and his horse stumbling back several steps. He Xiujun flexed his numb fingers before gripping the spear again and said, "He's a tough one."

The man only smirked. "He Jingyuan's son? Your skills are far inferior to your father's."

He Xiujun demanded, "You knew my father? Who are you?"

The man replied coldly, "The dead need not remember my name. And the son of a traitor like He Jingyuan is even less worthy of knowing it."

He Xiujun's jaw clenched. Spurred by the insult, he dug his heels into his horse and charged again, spear leveled. "My father lived for the people! What right does a dog of Wei Yan have to judge him? After I kill you, I'll slaughter Wei Yan to avenge my father!"

The man merely tilted his head slightly to evade the spear. His mace swung upward, striking He Xiujun's arm with a force that made him feel as though his bones were cracking. A pained grunt escaped him as the man's horse rammed into his own, followed by another mace blow to his abdomen.

Every organ seemed to rupture from that single blow. He Xiujun spat out a mist of blood as he was sent flying off his horse.

"Nephew—"

Tang Peiyi's eyes nearly split from fury as he roared and charged at the assailant, only to be swiftly struck down from his horse with a swing of the mace.

The man on horseback looked down at Tang Peiyi and He Xiujun with cold mockery. "Revenge? For what? If the Prime Minister hadn't plucked He Jingyuan from the starving refugees back then, he'd still be fighting wild dogs for a bowl of spoiled gruel in the snow. Where would all this glory come from?"

Clutching his agonizing abdomen, He Xiujun glared at him with hatred, struggling to speak. "This... kindness of recognition—my father repaid it with a lifetime of loyalty to Wei Yan. How dare Wei Yan... kill him?"

The man on horseback sneered. "Because if He Jingyuan were still alive, your family wouldn't be receiving promotions and titles today—you'd all be thrown into the imperial prison!"

Done with words, he raised his mace to deliver the fatal blow, but the air was split by the dull clang of heavy weapons colliding.

A halberd engraved with a qiongqi pattern intercepted the golden mace.

The man looked up at the cold-faced youth on horseback who had blocked his weapon with one hand and grinned. "The young Marquis's martial skills have improved over the years. At least you haven't disgraced General Xie's name."

Hearing Wei Yan's men mention Xie Linshan again, Xie Zheng's eyes turned icy, but he spared the man not a single glance, only ordering Tang Peiyi, "Take him away."

Both Tang Peiyi and He Xiujun were injured and knew they were of no use staying, so they supported each other as they retreated to safety.

The man withdrew his mace from Xie Zheng's block, flexed his wrist, and smiled—his eyes sharp with murderous intent. "Wei Sheng may be untalented, but I did serve as the Marquis's martial instructor for a few years. Today, I'll test your skills."

He was one of the oldest Martial Assassins by Wei Yan's side, long granted the Wei surname.

As he spoke, his golden mace triggered some hidden mechanism, transforming into a nine-section golden whip. The iron chains linking each segment lashed out like a venomous serpent striking at Xie Zheng.

Xie Zheng watched coldly as the whip, coiled like a golden python, approached. He didn't even raise his halberd to block, only sidestepping at the last moment as it neared his face. In a flash, he seized the whip mid-air.

Wei Sheng yanked hard, unsurprised when Xie Zheng matched his strength. Instead, he smirked.

The next instant, golden hooks and barbs sprouted from the whip's joints, tearing Xie Zheng's hand into a bloody mess.

The nine-section whip was infamous among weapons for its treachery, often used as a hidden weapon. Wei Sheng's modified version was even deadlier.

Unfazed, he said, "The final lesson I'll teach the Marquis is this: rules only apply to those who follow them. For those who don't, principles and honor are just jokes."

On the city walls, the Golden Guard's firearms suppressed Grand Tutor Li and Qi Min's forces, quickly turning the tide against them.

Qi Min's Shadow Guard, seeing Xie Zheng also struggling against Wei Yan below, urged, "Your Highness, we must escort you to safety! As long as the green hills remain, there will be no shortage of firewood!"

Years of planning had been ruined in a single day. Rebuilding from this would take who knew how long.

Gritting his teeth, Qi Min forced out a single word through his hatred: "Retreat!"

The retreat was more of a desperate flight. Blocking both sides of the palace gate's narrow passage were forces from the two main battalions of the Five Armies Garrison and the Golden Guard, while outside the palace walls, the cavalry of the Three Thousand Battalion waited.

The guards around Qi Min fell one by one. Even with the skilled Shadow Guards clearing the way, their advance became agonizingly slow.

Grand Tutor Li, left behind, called out to him with a face pale from fear—a man who had kept his emotions in check at court for over a decade now betraying panic. "Your Highness!"

Qi Min only glanced back once before continuing forward with his Shadow Guard.

When a cannonball shot from its barrel, soaring over the long palace gate passage before hurtling straight toward Qi Min and his men, the world around him seemed to erupt in noise—yet he could hear nothing.

The most loyal Shadow Guard shouted something as he shoved Qi Min aside. His back slammed against the cold, unyielding city wall, but he felt no pain. His eardrums nearly burst from the explosion, leaving his ears ringing for what felt like an eternity.

Pulled back to his feet and forced to keep running, Qi Min turned his head and caught a glimpse of the massive crater—charred black, chunks of the wall blasted apart. Several of the Shadow Guards who had shielded him lay dead.

Half of Grand Tutor Li's face had been torn away by the blast, yet the remaining half still stared in his direction, eyes wide open.

Countless arrows rained down, dense as a net.

There's no escape...

Qi Min thought despairingly.

Suddenly, memories surfaced—of the Eastern Palace engulfed in flames, his mother pressing his face into a brazier, weeping as she told him, "Min'er, this is the only way you'll survive..."

Seventeen years ago, he had lived by sacrificing half his face to the fire. What would he have to give up now to survive?

When an arrow pierced his chest, he staggered. Under the horrified gaze of his Shadow Guard, he leaned against the icy palace wall and slowly knelt. Blood trickled from his lips, yet his mind was eerily calm.

He laughed hoarsely. "I prided myself on outmaneuvering everyone, yet in the end, I was still no match for that ruthless old fox of the Wei family."

The Shadow Guard leader severed the arrow lodged in his back. "As long as we draw breath, we will get you out!"

Qi Min only shook his head faintly. Sitting slumped against the wall, the sounds of battle below finally reached his ears, growing clearer. He tilted his head, peering through the carved stone balustrade—only to see Xie Zheng surrounded by Wei Sheng and over a dozen of the Wei family's Martial Assassins. A bitter smile touched his lips.

"My father and Xie Linshan died in Jinzhou. Who would've thought that seventeen years later, Xie Zheng and I would still meet our end at the hands of that old bastard Wei Yan?"

Wei Sheng's golden whip concealed a barbed hook—when yanked free, it could rip flesh straight from the bone.

The pain was excruciating—ten fingers linked to the heart—yet Xie Zheng's face only paled slightly. Not a single groan escaped him. His eyes grew colder, deadlier, his grip on the whip tightening further.

A flicker of surprise finally crossed Wei Sheng's face. But before he could react, Xie Zheng twisted the whip around his own hand and pulled hard. Caught off guard, Wei Sheng was yanked from his saddle, stumbling toward him.

Yet Wei Sheng was a seasoned fighter. His other weapon—a golden mace—quickly transformed into a whip at the press of a mechanism, lashing straight for Xie Zheng's neck.

Being entangled by his nine-section whip with concealed golden hooks and barbs around the neck was no different from a death sentence.

Xie Zheng had just raised his halberd to block when another Martial Assassin from the Wei family brandished a sword and pressed toward him. Xie Zheng's halberd was still entwined with Wei Sheng's golden whip. With a mighty swing, he forced Wei Sheng to release his grip and used the halberd's blade to intercept the opponent's sword.

With just one hand, he held the other at bay, making it impossible for the opponent to press down even an inch despite using both hands.

All this happened in the blink of an eye. Wei Sheng, having lost his other golden whip, seized the moment. Grabbing the whip Xie Zheng still held, he swung toward him like a pendulum, his hand forming a claw aimed at Xie Zheng's throat.

This was nearly a fatal situation, but no one expected Xie Zheng to suddenly release the whip in his hand. The half-inch-long barbs dug deep into his palm, and as he abruptly let go, the barbs tore through his flesh under Wei Sheng's full weight, leaving his entire palm a bloody mess.

Yet Xie Zheng used that blood-drenched hand to unerringly seize Wei Sheng's throat, lifting him with one arm.

So much flesh had been scraped away that glimpses of blood-stained finger bones were visible beneath the flowing blood. His face showed no sign of pain, and his eyes even held a trace of cold indifference: "Trash made by trash—nothing more than this."

Not far away, Wei Yan's trusted aide watched the scene with trepidation, swallowing hard before turning to him: "Chancellor, what do you think...?"

Wei Yan's icy gaze lingered on Xie Zheng for a long moment before he said, "Loose the arrows."

The aide hesitated, glancing at Wei Yan again, not daring to act immediately.

Wei Yan still did not look away, standing with his hands behind his back, cold and unyielding like a block of stone or steel. He said icily, "After raising him for over a decade, he grew into nothing but a reckless brute. Daring to bring this meager force to attempt a coup—he should have long been prepared to lose his head."

A short arrow shot out, aimed straight at Xie Zheng's back.

With a sharp "clang," the arrow was deflected by another.

The thunder of hooves echoed from the end of the street. At the forefront rode a female general, her robes drenched in blood, bow in one hand and arrow in the other, not even holding the reins. Her eyes were fierce as a tiger's: "Treacherous old villain!"

The heavy snow had stopped at some point, and a faint red glow pierced the hazy horizon.

Dawn was approaching.

Fan Changyu's hair, fluttering in the cold wind, seemed to shimmer with the same radiant brilliance as the morning sun.

Xie Zheng turned to meet her gaze from afar. Both had endured more than one bloody battle, their faces streaked with drying blood. Their fierce expressions softened only when their eyes met.

Wei Yan narrowed his phoenix eyes slightly as he watched Fan Changyu galloping toward them. After a brief silence, he ordered again, "Loose the arrows."

This time, it was not a single arrow but a swarm like a stirred hornet's nest. Fan Changyu clenched her teeth so hard she nearly drew blood.

Too many! She couldn't possibly block them all!

Fortunately, Xie Zheng was now prepared. He threw Wei Sheng aside, spun his halberd to knock away the Martial Assassin, and deflected the dense rain of arrows.

Wei Sheng, catching his breath after being thrown, picked up a long blade from the ground and lunged again at Xie Zheng's back. Fan Changyu's heart pounded with urgency. She was still several yards away from Xie Zheng. Reaching for an arrow from her quiver, she found it empty and could only shout, "Watch out!"

"Thud—"

The sound of a blade piercing flesh, blood gushing out in rivulets.

But it was not Xie Zheng who was stabbed.

Wei Xuan lowered his head to look at the bloodied blade piercing his chest, then raised his gaze to Xie Zheng with a twisted grin, his face wearing the same arrogant and disdainful expression he always had. "I've been... been brothers with you for... for over ten years," he gasped, "but I never... never once saw you as... as a brother. Today... no, this blade... repays the debt... for saving my mother's life."

With that, he spat blood and collapsed to his knees, his eyes fixed on Wei Yan, filled with the resentment and grievance of a son who had been wronged.

Madam Wei, who had just been untied by Wei Yan's men, stared blankly at the scene. This time, she didn't even cry—she simply fainted on the spot.

Wei Yan's expression remained as cold and unyielding as ever, not a ripple of emotion in his eyes.

Wei Sheng, realizing that Wei Xuan had died by his own hand, froze for a moment. The crossbowmen in the distance exchanged uneasy glances, arrows still nocked, but with no further orders from Wei Yan, none dared to loose another shot.

Xie Zheng watched silently as Wei Xuan knelt before him. Bracing himself on his halberd, he crouched down and used his mangled hand to close Wei Xuan's eyes.

Fan Changyu practically tumbled off her horse in her haste. She shot a glance at Xie Zheng, her fury and lingering fear from moments ago still burning hot. Without hesitation, she raised her Horse-Cutting Sword and charged at Wei Sheng, roaring, "Die, you treacherous cur!"

Her monstrous strength allowed her to wield the massive sword—taller than herself—with sweeping, unrestrained strikes. Wei Sheng, still dazed by Wei Xuan's death and lacking a proper weapon, lost the initiative and was forced into retreat, barely able to defend himself.

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Shen Shen also arrived at this moment with the men of the Left Flank Battalion. Dismounting, he called out to Xie Zheng, "Jiuheng!"

He was slightly out of breath. After a glance at the current situation, his expression turned grim. "The Divine Machine Battalion's firearms aren't in the West Garden!"

His Left Flank Battalion had already lost nearly half its men after clashing with the Divine Machine Battalion and the Right Flank Battalion sent by Grand Tutor Li. To rush here and support Xie Zheng, they had truly put their lives on the line.

"I know."

Xie Zheng rose to his feet, his gaze sweeping over the corpses and blood on the ground before meeting Wei Yan's.

His eyes at that moment were indescribable—icy, placid, and indifferent.

The sky brightened, and the howling north wind whipped up waves of snow. The rosy light filtering through the clouds in the east draped half the imperial city in a layer of golden-red. He stood there, halberd in hand, the blood-splattered side of his face bathed in the golden glow of the dawn. As handsome as a deity, he was also wreathed in the cold, grim aura of a ferocious god or demonic general.

Wei Yan met his gaze in silence for a beat before looking at the Left Flank Battalion soldiers behind him. With the air of one in complete control, he asked coolly, "Do you think adding one Left Flank Battalion can turn the tide today?"

Xie Zheng raised his head languidly and sneered, "Whether it can be turned or not, one has to try to find out."

He gave a faint smile. "This Marquis is rather curious. Since the Prime Minister doesn't even care about the life of his own legitimate son, which bastard are you fighting for this position for?"

A layer of frost instantly coated Wei Yan's pair of stern, phoenix-like eyes. He cursed, "Insolent whelp!"

The smile on Xie Zheng's face, which never reached his eyes, turned utterly frigid. He raised his halberd and pointed it straight at Wei Yan. "You are not qualified to lecture this Marquis!"

Wei Yan seemed to have been thoroughly enraged by Xie Zheng. Instead of immediately dispatching the martial assassins by his side, he barked, "Bring me my blade!"

His subordinates quickly brought over a crescent blade, about eight feet long. The blade was archaic in style, and where it met the hilt, a blackened green dragon was engraved. At a glance, it seemed as if a dark aura swirled around the blade, a terrifying sight.

The long blade, which required two soldiers to carry, was lifted by Wei Yan with a single hand. His wide sleeves billowed in the wind, and his imposing manner was in no way inferior to that of the old generals who had fought on battlefields.

In the distance, upon seeing Wei Yan lift the crescent blade with one hand, He Xiujun looked as if he had seen a ghost. He turned to Tang Peiyi. "Uncle Tang, Wei Yan knows martial arts?"

Tang Peiyi's expression was a little complicated. "He should. In his early years, he was as famous as General Xie and had also defended the northern court. But by the time I joined the army, Lord He was already holding his own under him. He took the path of a civil official, so I never heard about him knowing martial arts."

Over on the other side, after lifting the crescent blade with one hand, Wei Yan looked at Xie Zheng with a stern and cold expression. "Since this old man taught you, I can also discipline you!"

Xie Zheng watched the man charge toward him, dragging the long blade, but he stood his ground without moving. A coldness tinged with hatred surfaced in his eyes. As his five fingers tightened around the long halberd, blood gushed from the palm where a large piece of flesh had been scraped off, dyeing a section of the shaft red.

In the past, he had been instructed by Wei Sheng alongside Wei Xuan and the newly selected martial assassins, and he had also received pointers from Wei Yan.

In terms of martial arts alone, his later fighting style was heavily influenced by Wei Yan. Wei Yan's moves were all about a single, fatal strike, with no superfluous flourishes.

Just as the crescent blade was about to strike a vital point, Xie Zheng raised his halberd and slammed it forward.

Sparks flew as the blade scraped against the side blades of the halberd. Wei Yan spun around, and the blade he swung backhanded hacked into the halberd's shaft. The whip kick Xie Zheng launched was met by Wei Yan's blocking elbow, sending a spray of snow flying from the ground.

The speed of their moves was so swift that it was almost impossible for the naked eye to follow.

Their contest was direct and straightforward, a competition of who was faster and more ruthless.

The personal guards of the Wei and Xie families stood on either side, watching the battle with extreme tension.

When one of Xie Zheng's halberd strikes nearly swept across Wei Yan's neck, Tang Peiyi slapped his thigh and roared, "A good strike! Cut down this old villain!"

Nearby, Fan Changyu, who was locked in combat with Wei Sheng, also let out a fierce cry. Her blade, capable of shattering gold and jade, swung down in a horizontal slash. Even though Wei Sheng managed to retrieve one of his golden maces to block, the immense force still sent him staggering back several steps, his hand between his thumb and forefinger tearing open. He was in a sorry state.

Tang Peiyi felt the stagnant blood that had been stuck in his chest from his earlier injury become less suffocating. Wishing he could grab a blade and join the fight himself, he yelled, "Niece Changyu, keep striking him!"

His overexcitement almost made him choke on a cough of blood, causing the personal guards around him a great deal of anxiety. He Xiujun also patted his back to help him catch his breath.

The Horse-Cutting Sword in Fan Changyu's hands was not light. After that powerful slash, she was almost too exhausted to deliver a second one. But she spun on the spot, using her body's momentum to power the blade, and with a long cry, she brought it down again in a ferocious chop.

Ignoring his torn hand, Wei Sheng raised the golden mace horizontally to block again. This time, however, a sharp crack of breaking metal rang out.

The Horse-Cutting Sword had snapped the modified golden mace in two. If not for two of the Wei Mansion's martial assassins leaping out and kneeling to catch the remaining force of the sword with two of their own blades, Wei Sheng would have been cleaved in half by Fan Changyu's strike.

After delivering that blow, Fan Changyu was also somewhat drained. She stood panting, leaning on the hilt of her sword.

Xie Shiyi and his men stood behind Fan Changyu, glaring at the two Wei Mansion martial assassins opposite them, their stance making it clear that they were ready to fight to the end if the others dared to make a move.

Wei Sheng spat out a mouthful of blood. As he was being helped up by the Wei Mansion's martial assassins, he was still looking at Fan Changyu. "Wei Qilin's spawn?"

He shook off the martial assassins' support, wiped the blood from his mouth with the back of his hand, and said, "You're more capable than your old man. The Prime Minister shouldn't have spared you and your sister's lives back then."

The ferocity in Fan Changyu's eyes had not yet faded. She stared at him coldly and said, "Heaven's net is vast; though its mesh is wide, nothing escapes it. What Wei Yan owes my parents, my maternal grandfather, and the tens of thousands of soldiers who died tragically in Jinzhou, he will have to repay!"

The early sun rose behind her, its myriad rays so brilliant they made it hard to open one's eyes.

When Wei Sheng heard her mention Meng Shuyuan, he suddenly fell silent.

On the other side, after several clashes between Xie Zheng and Wei Yan, Wei Yan slowly began to show signs of fatigue.

He was getting on in years, and in this kind of fight that purely tested stamina and endurance, his body was finally giving out.

Xie Zheng's attacks, on the other hand, grew increasingly vicious. His long halberd jabbed and thrust around Wei Yan like a flourish of a spear,

moving like a soaring dragon. Every flick and parry carried the force of ten thousand catties, forcing Wei Yan to retreat while defending passively.

The Wei Mansion's martial assassins wanted to come to his aid, but for a moment, they couldn't find an opening to squeeze in.

Xie Zheng seemed to be filled with extreme hatred. His jaw was clenched tight, yet he still smiled coldly, his eyes full of mockery. "Discipline me? On whose behalf? On behalf of my father, whom you had killed in Jinzhou? Or my mother, whom you forced to her death?"

As his final question fell, he threw his weapon with immense force.

Beneath his disheveled hair, his eyes were faintly red, perhaps from the cold wind.

The long halberd plunged deep into the hard granite of the Meridian Gate square. Wei Yan barely avoided the fatal blow with a clumsy roll on the ground.

The martial assassins raised by the Wei Mansion quickly helped Wei Yan up and took several steps back, staring at Xie Zheng with extreme vigilance.

The cold wind seared his lungs. Supported by his confidant, Wei Yan coughed violently before raising his eyes to look at Xie Zheng. "Brute force. This old man can no longer match you in it now. But if you think you can win this contest tonight with brute force alone, then that's a joke!"

As his words fell, the crossbowmen on and below the city wall all aimed their crossbows at Xie Zheng and his group. The Golden Guard even rolled out several large cannons and set them up on the city gate's platform.

Shen Shen's expression changed. He immediately commanded the archers of the Left Flank Battalion to draw their bows as well, but they were severely outnumbered. It was almost a cornered beast's struggle.

Wei Yan met Xie Zheng's gaze from afar. For a fleeting moment, there was a martial glint in his eyes, but it was also tinged with a hint of world-weariness.

Tang Peiyi, half-lying on the ground, said to He Xiujun, "That old villain, he infuriates me! If we hadn't been guarding the frontier all this time, with no influence in the capital, when would it be his turn to spout such nonsense!"

He Xiujun coughed a few times, sharing the sentiment of a hero at the end of his road. He only said, "General Shen is a true hero!"

Knowing that Wei Yan had the Divine Machine Battalion's firearms, yet still leading his battered troops to help—that courage alone was enough to command admiration.

Tang Peiyi said, "If we are truly to die here today, the road to the underworld will be filled with heroes as companions. That would be quite a joy!"

Fan Changyu looked at the dark muzzles of the cannons on the city wall and the countless gleaming arrowheads. At this moment, her heart was surprisingly calm. She turned her head to look at Xie Zheng.

The early sun and the firelight from the city wall intertwined on his face, which was covered in traces of blood and soot. He looked cold, stern, and resolute—the most handsome she had ever seen him.

After discovering that the West Garden was a trap set by Wei Yan, she already knew what she would face by rushing here.

She wasn't afraid of death. She was just unwilling to accept it, unwilling to accept that they would lose just like this!

And there was also some... reluctance to let go.

The old folks all said that after death, one had to cross the Bridge of Helplessness and drink Granny Meng's soup to forget everything in this life before being reincarnated.

As she walked over to stand shoulder to shoulder with Xie Zheng, she kept her eyes fixed forward and placed an object, soaked through with blood, into his hand.

Xie Zheng noticed and turned his head slightly to look at her, but Fan Changyu did not look back. She only said softly, "Xie Zheng, do you believe people have a next life?"

"I don't believe in ghosts or gods," his voice was deep and slow.

Fan Changyu continued to look at the opposing soldiers, chatting with him as if it were nothing. "I didn't believe in them either, originally. After my parents passed away, I wanted to believe again."

She paused before saying in an extremely soft voice, "If there really is a next life, come find me."

Xie Zheng's head snapped to the side, and he stared at Fan Changyu with a look that only he himself could understand.

The sky was clearing after the snow. The newly risen sun was not yet warm, and the morning wind carried the scent of gunpowder and ice. After everything fell silent, only the sound of the Wild Goose Wing Tower, which had been bombarded by cannon fire, burning on one side remained.

In this dead silence, a heart was beating tumultuously.

He said out of the blue, "This old thing probably has no more tricks up his sleeve. Then let's not waste any more time with him."

Before Fan Changyu could react to the meaning of his words, a signal flare had already shot into the sky from Xie Zheng's hand.

Everyone present was momentarily stunned by his sudden action.

Xie Zheng glanced coolly at Wei Yan. "The Prime Minister has sat high in the court, unparalleled in his manipulation of power. But in the art of war, I'm afraid you are still lacking."

The muffled clang of armor sounded in the distance, vast and mighty like a tidal wave.

Everyone turned to look and saw an army bearing the "Xie" banner pouring like a tide from several long streets outside the Meridian Gate into the square below. The Golden Guards on the city wall stood higher and had a wider field of vision. Seeing the endless armies on those long streets, their faces turned pale almost instantly.

And this was only the army they could see. Who knew how many more were blocked at the outer city gates, yet to enter. This was truly a force of thousands upon thousands!

Shen Shen's worry turned to joy. He looked at Xie Zheng. "Jiuheng, you were prepared all along?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer, but an elegant man in brocade white robes and a snow-white fox fur cloak emerged from the army, fanning himself with a feather fan. The first thing he said upon seeing Xie Zheng was, "I waited for you half the night and didn't see your signal. I thought you'd been wiped out in the city!"

Then, he gestured with his fan in a shallow bow toward Shen Shen. "Brother Shen, it's truly been many years."

Shen Shen was in a sorry state, but he couldn't help but break into a smile. "Brother Gongsun!"

Xie Zheng, however, gave Gongsun Yin a cool glance. "You were just eager to get into the city to watch the show, weren't you?"

Gongsun Yin wasn't angered by Xie Zheng's retort. He bowed to Fan Changyu. "General Fan."

Fan Changyu was both surprised and delighted. "Gongsun? You've been outside the city all this time?"

Tang Peiyi, He Xiujun, and the others were also stunned beyond words.

Tang Peiyi immediately burst out laughing. "I knew it! Our Marquis is a master of military strategy. How could he possibly be defeated by that old villain Wei Yan!"

He shouted at Wei Yan, "Old villain, have your men surrender at once!"

He Xiujun was also smiling, but his injuries were more severe, and the movement pulled at his internal organs, causing him pain. He could only smile reservedly.

Gongsun Yin gave Fan Changyu a slight nod. Seeing the blood on her face and clothes, he raised an eyebrow. "It seems there was a fierce battle in the city last night."

The army was still pouring into the square like a tide. While they chatted and laughed, the Golden Guards and the soldiers of the Five Armies Garrison on the city wall were having a very hard time. Even though they still held their crossbows, their faces were filled with panic.

This was no longer a matter of being outnumbered. A group of capital soldiers who had only ever trained in the Beijing suburbs, facing the Xie Family Army that had tasted the blood of northern barbarians on the northwestern battlefield—there was no need for a clash. Just this one distant encounter was enough for them to be intimidated by the murderous aura erupting from the thousands of troops below.

The few advisors following Wei Yan were also filled with despair. Only Wei Yan remained as calm as ever, his gaze fixed on Xie Zheng's back through the crowd.

Xie Zheng's face was cold and resolute. He scanned the east and west Wild Goose Wing Towers and announced in a deep voice, "All soldiers who

followed Li and Wei in this rebellion, listen up! Those who lay down their weapons and surrender will be treated with leniency. Those who resist stubbornly will all be charged with treason!"

His voice, like the shattering of sonorous metal and jade, echoed throughout the entire Meridian Gate square.

Anyone could see that Wei Yan's cause was lost.

A Golden Guard dropped his saber, which clattered on the stone tiles. Immediately, the sound of weapons hitting the ground followed one after another, like a string of pearls that had broken. Once the first one fell, the rest could no longer be held back.

In a flash, the only ones still supporting Wei Yan in the Meridian Gate square were the martial assassins raised by the Wei Mansion.

Gongsun Yin gently waved his feather fan. "Prime Minister, you have long held a high position and should know best what it means to go with the flow. Things have come to this. Do you still wish to make a dying struggle?"

Wei Yan looked at Xie Zheng, a myriad of complex emotions in his eyes. In the end, all he said was, "I underestimated you."

Xie Zheng met his gaze coldly without a word.

As the army tightened its encirclement around Wei Yan and his men, the martial assassins beside him drew their weapons, intending to fight a bloody path out. But Wei Yan calmly raised a hand, halting their actions.

A man beside him called out, "Prime Minister!"

Wei Yan only said, "It was I who was one move short and lost the entire game."

When the armored guards escorted Wei Yan and the remnants of the Li faction to the imperial prison, the uncle and nephew almost brushed past each other, but neither said another word.

When one mountain collapses, another will always rise.

The golden glow of the rising sun bathed the imperial city. The soldiers below began to treat the wounded and clear the battlefield. Injured generals like Tang Peiyi and He Xiujun were also carried to the nearby Imperial Academy of Medicine for treatment.

The bloodshed and chaos of the night seemed to fade in the hazy dawn. Only the scorched ground and towers, bombarded by cannon fire, still bore blackened marks, like scars carved into the magnificent imperial city.

Xie Zheng stood quietly between heaven and earth, his long lashes slightly lowered, his thoughts unknown.

On the horizon were auspicious morning clouds. The wind on their faces seemed to have softened, stirring the loose strands of hair by Fan Changyu's ear. She turned her head to look at Xie Zheng. "We've won, haven't we?"

Xie Zheng gave a soft "mm," raising his eyes to look at the ravaged yet majestic towers and palaces before them. A layer of dawn light fell upon his long, thick eyelashes, but the color of his eyes remained deep and profound.

Everything had settled.

Gongsun Yin strolled over and asked, "How should Wei Yan be dealt with?"

Xie Zheng replied, "Lock him up for now."

He no longer had the heart to stay there. The fatigue from a whole night of fighting washed over him. He held Fan Changyu's hand tightly and said to Gongsun, "I'll leave this place to you."

Gongsun Yin glanced at the blood covering his body and, for once, magnanimously agreed. "Fine. I'll handle things here. With all those injuries, you should hurry back and find a physician."

Xie Shiyi cleverly found a carriage. Xie Zheng pulled Fan Changyu by the hand and boarded it. Most of the people present had already left, so not many noticed them. Even those who did were Xie Zheng's subordinates and didn't dare to say or look too much.

Fan Changyu's reactions always seemed to be half a beat slow. Even after getting into the carriage, she was still asking, "Gongsun must have brought at least twenty thousand troops. Yesterday, you said he could set out. It's impossible for Gongsun to have brought his army into the capital so quickly in just one day. They must have been near the capital all along. Was this the matter you said you couldn't tell me about before?"

Xie Shiyi urged the horse on quickly. As the carriage jolted, the curtain swayed, and sunlight shone into the carriage. Fan Changyu was in a

disheveled state, but under her long lashes, which were haloed in a soft golden light, her eyes appeared even more pure and clear.

Xie Zheng propped one hand beside her, watching her quietly. His eyes were deep and dark. He didn't answer, but instead raised the object in his hand and asked her, "What is this?"

Fan Changyu looked at the object in his palm, which was soaked into a clump by blood. Only now did she feel embarrassed. Fortunately, her face was covered in blood and sweat, too dirty to be seen properly, so her blush could be hidden.

She cleared her throat and turned her face away. "Hair."

Xie Zheng's breathing, for some reason, grew heavier. He stared at her without blinking.

Fan Changyu felt as if his gaze could burn a hole in her temple. She pressed her lips together, and thinking of the state of mind she was in when she cut that lock of hair, she felt a bit of bitterness. Throwing caution to the wind, she said, "I heard that only by tying their hair together can a couple be considered husband and wife. After discovering the trap in the West Garden, I thought that going back to find you would most likely be a near-death situation, so I cut a lock of my hair. We've bowed in a wedding ceremony, even if it was fake, we still bowed to heaven and earth, but we haven't tied our hair. If this life is really this short, then tying a lock of hair would mean we've been husband and wife."

Xie Zheng's heavy breaths fanned across Fan Changyu's cheek. He asked in a deep voice, "You knew it was a near-death situation, yet you still came back for me. Weren't you afraid?"

Fan Changyu said, "I was afraid. But my enemy was there, and you were there too. How could I not go?"

She raised a hand to touch his face, still feeling a lingering fear as she thought of the arrows Wei Yan had ordered to be fired. "And it's a good thing I went."

Xie Zheng wanted to say that he would have been fine even if she hadn't come, that he had sent her away from the palace battlefield precisely because he didn't want her in danger, and that he had let the stalemate with Wei Yan drag on because he was afraid Wei Yan or Qi Min had other tricks up their sleeves that would ruin everything. But at this moment, he couldn't say a word.

His chest ached with a sour, swelling feeling, yet it also felt as if he were soaking in a warm spring, a tingling numbness spreading through him. He lowered his head, clutching her hand tightly, his breaths growing heavier one after another. When he looked up again, his gaze had become inexplicably fierce.

That look made Fan Changyu's heart jump. Just as she was wondering how she had provoked him again, the carriage stopped. She lost her balance and stumbled into his arms. From outside, Xie Shiyi's voice came, "Master, General, we've arrived at the Marquis's Mansion."

Xie Zheng pulled Fan Changyu out of the carriage and strode toward the main courtyard.

Seeing this, Xie Shiyi, who had been about to fetch the mansion's physician, couldn't help but slow his steps, scratching the back of his head in an awkward and difficult position.

Should he still go get the physician or not?

As soon as they entered the room, Xie Zheng kicked the door shut. He pushed Fan Changyu down onto the soft couch and leaned over her, no more than half a foot away. Their breaths intertwined. The scent of blood on him stimulated her senses. He seemed to want to kiss her, but then he suddenly stood up and left, finding a dagger from somewhere. He cut a lock from his own long hair and tied it in a dead knot with Fan Changyu's blood-soaked strand.

His voice was deep and hoarse. "To tie our hair as husband and wife, our love will never be in doubt. In life, I will return to you; in death, I will long for you. I wanted to tie our hair on our wedding day. Since you've given it to me early, I won't be giving it back."

Fan Changyu gazed at his stern and handsome features. Though her heart was filled with joy, at this moment, she felt a lump in her throat, and her eyes began to sting. She glared at him. "Who asked you to give it back?"

Xie Zheng only stared at her for a beat before lowering his head to kiss her again, fierce and tender.

They had just been through a bloody battle, and the blood in their veins was still boiling. Seeing her risk her life to save him, hearing her promise of a next life, the surging love in his chest coursed and crashed through his limbs and bones along with his sizzling blood, urgently seeking an outlet.

Amidst the chaos, a trail of blood-stained Armor led from the outer room to the edge of the hot spring in the adjoining chamber. In the hazy mist, as Fan Changyu leaned against the pool's edge with trauma medicine and gauze to bandage his mangled hand, his other hand gripped her waist tightly. The water rippled, and the roots of his hair were soaked with sweat, yet he still locked his deep, dark, intense gaze on her, unwilling to even blink.

Fan Changyu stubbornly pressed her lips together, her eyes veiled with a hazy, watery sheen and her neck covered in sweat. Several times, her hands trembled so much she almost dropped the gauze into the water.

When she finally finished wrapping the gauze, he pressed the back of her neck, making her nestle completely into his embrace. The movements below were not the least bit tender, his eyes dark and bottomless.

Fan Changyu held on until the very end, so exhausted she could only lean on his shoulder. In a daze, she heard him whisper hoarsely next to her ear, "Changyu, my wife."

The blood flowing through the thin layer of his veins was still restless, yet within this warmth, it found the ultimate tranquility and tenderness.

Chapter 159

Fan Changyu remembered that when they returned to the mansion, the sky had just cleared after a snowfall. When she woke up and pushed open the ornate window, she saw it was snowing again outside.

Perhaps because she had slept her fill, she felt refreshed and clear-headed, though her body was still a little sore.

She was also a little hungry.

Fan Changyu went to the trunk with practiced ease to find her own clothes, but after rummaging to the bottom, she found only outer robes, with no matching inner garments.

The parted bed curtains were lifted by a well-defined arm. From forearm to shoulder, it was covered in faint red scratch marks, and there was even a faint bite mark on the shoulder. The man's just-awoken voice was low, rich, and husky. "Not going to sleep a little longer?"

Fan Changyu answered honestly, "I'm hungry."

Xie Zheng seemed to let out a low chuckle. He threw on a robe and got up. The muscles of his waist and abdomen were clearly defined, and the faint red scratches were even more numerous across his sturdy shoulders and back. The armor he wore was stained almost entirely with the blood of others, yet the most severe injury on his own body was just a piece of scraped-off flesh on his left palm.

The chaotic memories from before came flooding back. Fan Changyu lowered her head, not daring to look any further, and only heard him say, "I'll have someone bring food."

Only then did Fan Changyu ask, "Do you have any of my other clothes here?"

Xie Zheng turned back to look at her.

Fan Changyu said, "There are only outer robes in that trunk."

The last time, she could make do with her waterlogged middle layer of clothing, but this time, her garments were thoroughly soaked in blood. Fan

Changyu couldn't possibly make do with them, and the one she was currently wearing was borrowed from him.

Xie Zheng said, "I haven't prepared any yet. Wear mine for now. I'll have a set sent over later."

Fan Changyu didn't think anything was amiss. After a moment's thought, it seemed to be the only option, so she nodded.

A nimble old woman quickly set the table in the outer room. After a simple wash, Fan Changyu ate three bowls of rice before stopping.

The snowy day was gray and gloomy, making it hard to tell the time. After the meal, Fan Changyu looked at the hourglass in Xie Zheng's room and frowned. "It's not even noon yet?"

It was already the Hour of the Dragon when they returned from the palace. He had then fooled around with her for a long time afterward. Fan Changyu felt like she had slept for quite a while. Had only four hours passed?

Xie Zheng was drinking tea. Hearing her question, he suddenly pressed a hand to his lips and gave two low coughs, a rare hint of unease appearing on his handsome face. "It's the second day of the month."

Fan Changyu's large, clear eyes stared blankly for two breaths. When she realized what he meant, her face instantly darkened.

This wasn't just four hours later—a whole day and night had passed!

The Li and Wei Factions had been vanquished, and the little emperor was nowhere to be found. With so many urgent matters at hand, how could he sit so idly by!

Xie Shiyi arrived with a stack of documents for Xie Zheng. Before he even reached the door, he heard a loud series of crashes from inside. He steeled himself and said, "Master, Gongsun says these memorials require your attention."

"I know. Just leave them at the door."

The voice that came from inside was as crisp as ever, but his breathing sounded a little unsteady.

Xie Shiyi's ears turned bright red as he put the things down and left.

Inside the room, Xie Zheng was pinned to the floor by Fan Changyu, who had him in a leg lock around his neck. Gazing at her slightly agape collar, his breathing deepened. "My dear ancestor, now that you've let out your anger, how about you get up? If you don't, we might as well not get up at all today."

Fan Changyu's face was flushed red. She squeezed her legs tighter and glared. "You're still talking nonsense!"

Xie Zheng grabbed one of her feet with his uninjured hand and suddenly exerted his strength. Fan Changyu felt the world spin, and in the next moment, she was the one being pinned down.

A hand slipped inside her wide-open collar and gave a squeeze that was neither light nor heavy. This time, Fan Changyu's face was truly hot enough to smoke. She struggled even harder, snapping, "You... bastard!"

Xie Zheng's breathing had already become ragged. He lowered his head slightly to look at her, his eyes pitch-black. "Haven't we done things more bastardly than this?"

"You!" Fan Changyu was speechless with anger. Now that she was truly at his mercy, she learned to show strategic weakness. "I... I'm still sore."

Her large, clear eyes darted toward the door. "And... Shiyi is looking for you. With so many matters at court, aren't you going to look them over?"

Her timid yet unwilling-to-admit-defeat appearance was utterly endearing. Xie Zheng felt an itch spread from the roots of his teeth. He cupped her jaw and nibbled her lips from the inside out before finally letting her go.

Once freed, Fan Changyu immediately pulled her robes tight and sat far away from him. Looking both annoyed and embarrassed, she said, "I don't want to wear your clothes anymore. I want my own."

Xie Zheng reached out with a long arm and pulled her back, burying his face in the crook of her shoulder and chuckling. "Alright, I'll listen to you."

His breath tickled her shoulder. Fan Changyu expressionlessly pushed his face away. Her eyes were downcast and her lips were pressed tightly together, feeling inexplicably vexed.

He said he would listen to her, but she was clearly the one being bullied!

By the time Xie Zheng brought the memorials Xie Shiyi had left at the door into the room to read, Fan Changyu had already retrieved a broadsword from the armory and was practicing in the courtyard.

As fine snow drifted down, she brandished the broadsword in the courtyard, the air whistling with her movements. With every slash and chop, her eyes glinted with killing intent, as if she were hacking at some person imagined in the vast, snowy sky.

Xie Zheng propped his elbow up and watched for a while, a faint smile gracing his eyes. He then lowered his gaze and continued reading the memorial in his hand.

When he came to one particular document, the end of his eyebrow lifted slightly. "The Military Governor of Lingnan has come to the capital at a time like this?"

Fan Changyu had just finished a set of broadsword forms. Hearing this, she leaned on her sword and turned her head to ask, "Is this Wei Yan's backup plan?"

Xie Zheng shook his head. "The spies report he came to the capital alone."

Just then, Xie Shiyi hurried into the courtyard to report, "Master, Madam Wei requests an audience."

Xie Zheng's eyes narrowed slightly. He simply said, "Show her to the front hall."

A short while later, Xie Zheng went to the front hall with Fan Changyu.

Madam Wei was dressed in plain white mourning clothes. Upon seeing Xie Zheng, she knelt without a word.

Fan Changyu didn't know what was going through Xie Zheng's mind, but she was certainly startled by Madam Wei's sudden action. By the time she came to her senses, Xie Zheng was already reaching out to help her up. "Aunt, what is the meaning of this?"

Madam Wei refused to rise. Her face was exceptionally pale, but she managed a faint smile. "Marquis, please do not address this humble servant so. I am not worthy of it."

Xie Zheng's gaze hardened. "No matter what Wei Yan has done, I will always see you as my aunt."

But Madam Wei shook her head, her expression sorrowful. "This servant is truly unworthy of being called 'aunt' by the Marquis. I was merely granted protection by the Prime Minister, allowing me to live secretly in the Wei Mansion for over twenty years and raise Xuan'er..."

Fan Changyu sensed something unusual. Xie Zheng slowly asked, "What do you mean by that?"

Madam Wei mournfully revealed the hidden truth. "I was originally the daughter of a minor official's concubine; I could never have hoped to marry into the Prime Minister's family. My family arranged for me to be the replacement wife for a sixth-rank official. That official's son was several years older than me... I was unwilling and secretly pledged my life to a household guard. To save money to marry me, he joined the army. When the official came to propose, I was already three months pregnant. When my family found out, they wanted to force me to have an abortion. I ran away to the military camp to find Xuan'er's father, but who would have known that Xuan'er's father had died in battle..."

As Madam Wei spoke of this, her eyes were almost numb, yet clear tears still slid from their corners. She gave a bitter smile. "At that time, I was truly in utter despair. My family chased me to the military camp, saying they would drag me back to be drowned in a pig cage to give the official's family an explanation. I thought, since it was death either way, I might as well end my own life and join Xuan'er's father.

"As I was about to smash my head against a pillar, someone stopped me. The Prime Minister claimed the child in my womb as his own, saying he would come to my home to propose marriage soon. He suppressed the matter of that day, and to this day, very few people know about it. The Prime Minister said that Xuan'er's father was his subordinate general. He had originally intended never to marry again, but his family was pressuring him. It just so happened that I, with a child in my womb, had nowhere else to go. It was a solution that served both our needs."

"Wei Xuan is not Wei Yan's son?" Complex emotions churned in Xie Zheng's eyes.

"He is not." Madam Wei shook her head. "The Prime Minister is a man who abides by propriety. All these years, the only time he would come to my courtyard for a meal was during the new year festivals, and that was only to prevent Xuan'er from being looked down upon by the servants."

She looked at Xie Zheng sorrowfully. "I have come today to beg the Marquis. I am but a woman and do not fully understand the things the Prime Minister has done. But he showed great kindness to both me and Xuan'er, a debt so profound that I can only do my best to repay it. I implore the Marquis, for the sake of Xuan'er taking that blow for you, to spare the Prime Minister's life!"

Fan Changyu was astonished, never expecting so many hidden details behind Madam Wei and Wei Yan's marriage.

The hand with which Xie Zheng was supporting Madam Wei lost its strength. His expression was unreadable as he asked, "Wei Yan... never remarried... for Shu Fei?"

Madam Wei shook her head. "That, I do not know. But for a man of the Prime Minister's character, if he truly had a past with Shu Fei, I do not believe he could have done something like burning Shu Fei and her unborn child to death."

Hearing this, even Fan Changyu, who hated Wei Yan to the bone, began to feel that something was amiss.

Qi Min had said that Wei Yan orchestrated the Jinzhou case, leading to the deaths of the Crown Prince and the Sixteenth Prince, all for Shu Fei and the child in her womb.

Wei Yan had no son. If he later had the power to carry out a bloodbath in the imperial palace, drive the Old Emperor from the throne, and install a rootless child as the new emperor, with such means at his disposal, why would he still burn Shu Fei to death?

She looked at Xie Zheng. He said to Madam Wei, "Wei Yan's crimes will be announced to the world after a full investigation, and he will be dealt with accordingly. Madam, please return for now."

Since he had put it that way, Madam Wei could not plead any further. She kowtowed once more and departed in sorrow.

Only then did Fan Changyu say, "Wei Yan has been captured. I'll take some men to search his mansion and see if we can find anything."

Xie Zheng said, "Gongsun has already searched it once. Wei Yan is a cautious man. Since he decided to force the abdication, he was also prepared for defeat. Any letters that could be destroyed were burned to ashes. Nothing can be found."

At this point, his tone paused slightly as he looked at Fan Changyu. "Teacher was held captive by him in his mansion after entering the capital. He has now been brought back to the Xie residence. You can go see him later."

Fan Changyu was both surprised and delighted. "Foster Father has been found?"

Xie Zheng nodded.

Fan Changyu immediately said, "Then I'll go see Foster Father now."

Xie Zheng had someone lead Fan Changyu over. As soon as she entered the courtyard, she heard Changning slamming the table. "I want Big Sister!"

"Your big sister went to quell a rebellion." It was an old but resonant voice. "You little doll, don't cause trouble. You're deliberately helping that boy disrupt my game!"

Fan Changyu walked quickly to the door and called out, "Ning Niang."

Changning, who had rested her entire chin on the Go board, turned her head almost instantly. Without even bothering to put on her shoes, she ran towards Fan Changyu in her silk socks with her arms outstretched. "Big Sister, hug!"

Fan Changyu lifted Changning with one arm and looked at Tao Taifu. Though he was still scrawny, he didn't seem to have suffered at all. The sorrow she had been brewing on the way over got stuck in her throat. In the end, she could only manage a dry, "Foster Father."

Tao Taifu, holding a game piece, gave a faint "en." He glanced at Fan Changyu and said, "I hear the girl has been promoted to the third rank. Quite an improvement."

Fan Changyu felt she should be modest, so she replied, "It's all because Foster Father taught me well."

Who would have thought that Tao Taifu would languidly lift an eyelid and say, "I didn't teach you much. It was that boy who taught you, wasn't it?"

Perhaps due to the guilt of having slept for a whole day and night, Fan Changyu blushed from her face to the tips of her ears. The base of her neck was probably red too, but she was wearing a rabbit fur scarf to cover the numerous marks there.

Tao Taifu knew this was a simple-minded girl with thin skin. Thinking of her honest nature and how she would inevitably be taken advantage of by that cunning boy in the future, he couldn't help but puff out his beard and glare. "So what if he taught you? What's there to be embarrassed about? Not to mention that he'll have to marry you from my home with a grand eight-bearer sedan chair in the future, but just the fact that he's your senior brother makes it his duty to teach you!"

The moment Fan Changyu heard Tao Taifu's lecture, she subconsciously sat up straight and replied resoundingly, "Foster Father's lesson is right!"

Only then was Tao Taifu satisfied. He softened his tone and said, "Come, sit down and play a game of Go with your foster father."

Yu Bao'er, who had been forced to play for the better part of the day, let out an inaudible sigh of relief and quickly made room for Fan Changyu. "Aunt Changyu, please."

Fan Changyu was speechless.

As she racked her brains for her next move, Tao Taifu continued to ask her intermittently about the situation in the capital. "The Li family has fallen, and that old fellow from the Wei family has also reached this point. You know what that boy plans to do next, don't you?"

Fan Changyu nodded. She was about to place a white stone but suddenly looked up and asked, "Grand Tutor, may I ask you something about Wei Yan?"

Tao Taifu's wrinkled eyelids lifted slightly. "Are you asking for yourself, or for that boy?"

Fan Changyu said, "I'm asking for the truth of what happened seventeen years ago."

Tao Taifu smiled. "You, you..."

He placed the game piece in his hand back into the bowl, picked up the teapot warming on the small red-clay stove, poured a cup, and took a shallow sip before looking at the falling snow outside the window. "That brat has probably gone to the prison to see Wei Yan by now."

Fan Changyu said nothing. She had sensed earlier that Xie Zheng seemed to want to see Wei Yan alone, which was why she had suggested visiting Tao Taifu after Xie Zheng mentioned he was at the residence, giving him time to go see Wei Yan by himself.

Tao Taifu said slowly, "Wei Yan has no son. That brat was raised under his care, and he truly raised him to be exactly like he was in his youth. Once his mind is set on something, not even ten bulls can pull him back..."

Chapter 160

Fan Changyu had witnessed Xie Zheng's stubborn nature, but she didn't know much about Wei Yan. Everything she knew about the powerful chancellor was hearsay, and their only meeting had been on the night of the coup.

She had no way of judging whether the uncle and nephew were alike.

Her first impression of Wei Yan, however, perfectly matched the rumors about him: cold, ruthless, and willing to do anything to achieve his goals.

Unlike Grand Tutor Li, who at first glance possessed the cool, noble character of a Confucian scholar, like a pine tree standing against a clear sky, Wei Yan was a man as cold and hard as a blade's edge or a solid rock, seemingly without a single weakness.

Fan Changyu sat upright on the bamboo mat, hesitating before she spoke. "May I ask, foster father, was there something between Wei Yan and Shu Fei back then?"

Tao Taifu lifted his eyelids and sized Fan Changyu up again. "Why do you ask?"

Fan Changyu recounted the confession of the Cold Palace maid and Qi Min's accusations.

Tao Taifu set down his teacup, his wrinkled hand stroking the rim. A hint of time-worn vicissitudes appeared in his eyes. "I was not in the capital back then, so I am not very clear on what happened in the palace. But since it was that girl from the Qi family, no matter how cruel Wei Yan's heart is, I doubt he could have done something like setting fire to Qinghe Palace."

Seeing the confusion on Fan Changyu's face, he explained, "Shu Fei was a daughter of the Qi family. She and that brat's mother were good friends when they were young ladies. At that time, the Xie family had not yet achieved its current glory. The one propping up the entire Great Yin was Old General Qi. Both Wei Yan and Linshan trained under Old General Qi's command. Later, after Old General Qi passed away, Linshan held up half

the sky in the northwest, while Wei Yan gave up the military for a career in the civil service. The Qi family's girl entered the palace around that time."

Fan Changyu's brow furrowed slightly. According to Tao Taifu, Wei Yan and Shu Fei must have known each other since they were young, and their families seemed to have a good relationship.

With this connection, it made even less sense that Wei Yan, who later went on to massacre the imperial palace, would burn Shu Fei to death.

She mentally estimated Shu Fei's age. Shu Fei should be of the same generation as her own parents, and the Chengde Crown Prince was also of their generation. By that calculation, wouldn't the emperor have been old enough to be Shu Fei's father?

Although she knew that some wealthy old gentlemen would still take several young and beautiful concubines, Fan Changyu couldn't help but frown at the realization. "If Wei Yan was interested in Shu Fei, why didn't he ask for her hand in marriage before she entered the palace?"

Tao Taifu let out a long sigh. "Do you know who the Chengde Crown Prince's birth mother was?"

Fan Changyu shook her head.

Tao Taifu said, "Empress Dowager Xiaozhongsuci of the Qi clan. She was Old General Qi's younger sister and Shu Fei's paternal aunt."

Fan Changyu was stunned for a moment. This meant that Shu Fei and the Chengde Crown Prince were cousins?

Although it wasn't unheard of in past dynasties for an aunt and niece to serve the same man, given the existence of the Chengde Crown Prince and Old General Qi, she figured that Empress Qi, whose son had already been named Crown Prince, wouldn't have needed to bring her own niece into the palace to help secure the emperor's favor.

Her thoughts must have been written all over her face, as Tao Taifu continued, "The imperial court is a pool of muddy water now, but it wasn't much cleaner back then. The chronic illnesses of this dynasty have accumulated from one generation to the next. You clear out the old, but after some years, new ones attach themselves. There's never a time when it can be completely cleansed..."

Tao Taifu sighed softly again, seemingly filled with emotion. "Since you've already traced things to Jia Guifei's palace maid, you should also

know how much favor Jia Guifei received back then. Half the civil and military officials in the court were practically surnamed Jia. In the early years, with Old General Qi as a pillar of the state, the Crown Prince could sit securely in the Eastern Palace no matter how favored the Sixteenth Prince was. Once Old General Qi was gone, the Empress lost her backing, and the Crown Prince's path became difficult.

"The common folk all cursed the consort for bewitching the emperor and her maternal relatives for meddling in politics. After Old General Qi's death, the Empress was also bedridden with illness. Fearing that if she too passed away, the Crown Prince would be left with no support in the inner palace, she used the pretext of needing someone to attend to her illness to bring the Qi family's girl into the palace. I had met that girl. She was brilliant and clever since childhood, well-read, and possessed a beauty that could make fish sink and geese fall. She attended to the Empress's illness for a year. A year later, Empress Qi passed away. Not long after that girl returned home, she was selected to enter the palace with the other young ladies and was granted the title of Fei."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu could only remain silent.

The reason for Shu Fei's entry into the palace was far heavier than she had imagined.

The struggles between the princes for the throne were bloody and deadly. If the Chengde Crown Prince were to fail, the fate of this branch of the Qi family was unknown.

With the lives of her entire family resting on her shoulders, what choice did Shu Fei have?

A thought flashed through her mind, and Fan Changyu suddenly looked up. "Foster father, Wei Yan and General Xie both received Old General Qi's patronage in the army, and they both later supported the Chengde Crown Prince. In the palace, Shu Fei was also helping the Chengde Crown Prince contend with Jia Guifei and her son. Looking at it this way, Shu Fei's death, and the crime of having an affair with her that was pinned on Wei Yan, are both very suspicious!"

Tao Taifu nodded. "If all this was indeed the Jia family's doing, then when Wei Yan seized absolute power, his slaughter of all the court officials surnamed Jia was not just to purge the court."

He sighed softly. "When that brat insisted that Wei Yan was the mastermind behind the Jinzhou Massacre, I thought there might be some hidden story, which is why I personally came to the capital to find Wei Yan. That man has a heart of stone now, but back then, he and Linshan were brothers who entrusted their lives to each other on the battlefield. Otherwise, he would not have betrothed his own sister, whom he doted on like the apple of his eye, to Linshan."

Hearing this, Fan Changyu recalled what Xie Zheng had said when she went to find him at the Xie family's burial grounds—that Wei Yan used to take him to pay respects alone every year, not allowing any servants to follow. For a moment, her heart was a tangle of complex emotions.

She asked, "Did you hear any rumors later about what happened in the palace?"

A trace of bitterness tinged Tao Taifu's gentle and placid smile. "My girl, do you know how long this land of Great Yin was in turmoil after Jinzhou fell and the Northern Turks marched south? The heir apparent died, the generals perished, and the emperor collapsed. Those barbarians intended to use the opportunity to strike directly at the capital! Green hills buried bones, rivers drank blood, and nine out of ten households in the land were empty...

"The front lines resisting the Northern Turks' advance were so tragic. With the very survival of our country at stake, the deaths of a few consorts in the palace were but a few specks of dust washed into the bloody waters of this chaotic world. My own son and daughter also died in the chaos of war. It was only thanks to Jingyuan collecting their bodies that they had a simple coffin and a grave."

A bitter taste filled Fan Changyu's throat, and she lowered her head in shame. "I'm sorry, foster father, I..."

Tao Taifu waved his hand, only saying, "It's all in the past. After the fall of Jinzhou, Great Yin and the Northern Turks fought on and off for another three years. The national treasury was empty, the people were displaced by the flames of war, farmlands were abandoned, and we couldn't even levy military rations from the populace... If the fighting had continued, Great Yin would have collapsed into a heap of loose sand on its own before the foreign tribes even reached the capital. It was at this moment that Wei Yan stood up and single-handedly pushed for the treaty to cede the twelve

commanderies of Liaodong in exchange for twenty years of peace for Great Yin.

"At that time, I told him that in the history books of the future, he would surely be cursed and have his spine pointed at for this act. He replied that a chancellor of a fallen kingdom would also be spat on by later generations. Since he would be cursed either way, he might as well take advantage of the fact that the barbarians beyond the pass had also exhausted their resources after years of fighting, and gamble on the future with these twenty years bought by ceding the land."

Fan Changyu was a general herself and had spent a long time roughing it in military camps. With Tao Taifu's explanation, she could understand the situation at the time.

After Jinzhou fell, Great Yin, like a centipede that dies but never falls, had managed to hold out against the Northern Turks for another three years. During those three years, countless loyal souls like General Xie and Tao Taifu must have stood at the very front to hold on for so long.

But the Northern Turks could no longer sustain the war, and they didn't know how much longer Great Yin could hold on, which was why they agreed to Wei Yan's proposal to cede the twelve commanderies of Liaodong and cease hostilities for twenty years to recuperate.

Perhaps the Northern Turks never imagined that in less than twenty years, Jinzhou would be reclaimed by the descendant of the Xie who had died in battle there, and the twelve commanderies of Liaodong would also be taken back.

Connecting this to Wei Yan's harshness towards Xie Zheng and his request for Tao Taifu to be Xie Zheng's teacher, Fan Changyu felt that she understood Wei Yan less and less. She couldn't tell if his actions were to save Great Yin or simply to protect his own power.

But he had indeed pinned an eternally infamous crime on her maternal grandfather and killed her own parents.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but press her lips together tightly. "Foster father, Wei Yan... is he ultimately a good person, or a wicked one?"

Tao Taifu's complex and magnanimous gaze, which seemed capable of holding a hundred rivers, rested quietly on Fan Changyu. He only said, "People of a certain time can only do what the situation demands. Let their merits and demerits be left for later generations to judge."

Fan Changyu gave a soft sound of assent, her gaze falling to the chessboard before her. She clutched a game piece in her hand and remained silent for a long time.

After leaving Tao Taifu, Fan Changyu took both Changning and Bao'er to Aunt Zhao and her husband. She figured that since Qi Min had been captured along with Grand Tutor Li, finding Yu Qianqian shouldn't be too difficult.

Xie Wu had been injured while protecting Aunt Zhao and her husband, so she summoned Xie Qi and had him arrange for men to search for Yu Qianqian's whereabouts. Xie Qi said that Gongsun Yin had already sent people and found Yu Qianqian. For some reason, however, Qi Min hadn't brought her to the capital, but had instead locked her up in a private villa in a provincial capital. The men sent to retrieve her would need another day or two to return.

Regardless, Fan Changyu felt a sense of relief knowing that Yu Qianqian was safe.

She had always remembered the kindness Yu Qianqian had shown her when she was at her lowest. Even later, when war broke out in Qingping County, Yu Qianqian had thought to bring her and Changning along while fleeing south with Yu Bao'er. How could Fan Changyu not be grateful for her kindness?

She asked Xie Qi about the current situation and learned that Grand Tutor Li was dead for good. Qi Min had been hit by that arrow but was still breathing. Gongsun Yin wasn't sure how Xie Zheng would deal with this descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince, so he had the imperial physicians keep him half-alive for now.

The young emperor had also been found at Wei Yan's residence, but he was acting insane, and it was unclear whether he was truly mad or just feigning it.

The statement that the imperial astronomers had been made to release before Qi Min and Grand Tutor Li's coup—about the "dragon's vein being in disarray and the throne being illegitimately obtained"—was now conveniently paving the way for Bao'er.

The court officials now all followed Xie Zheng's lead. All that was needed was the right moment to push Yu Bao'er onto the throne.

Thinking of the still-murky truth of the Jinzhou incident, Fan Changyu's chest felt tight and stuffy. She decided to go back and practice a set of saber forms to calm down.

In a moment of distraction, she bumped into Xie Zhong, who was limping along, carrying a stack of things toward Xie Zheng's study.

The box in Xie Zhong's hands fell to the ground, and its contents scattered everywhere.

"My apologies, old sir." Fan Changyu felt extremely guilty. Xie Zhong's leg was injured, so she quickly squatted down to help him pick things up.

Xie Zhong's expression had been somewhat cold, but upon seeing it was Fan Changyu, he let down his guard and said in a gentle voice, "It was this old servant who saw the General was lost in thought and didn't dare to interrupt. My legs are not agile, so I failed to get out of the way in time and bumped into the General..."

Fan Changyu was about to offer a word or two of comfort to the old man when her expression changed abruptly. She had seen that among the letters that had fallen out of the box, there were also three Tiger Tallies.

All three Tiger Tallies bore the small seal script characters for Chongzhou, clearly identifying them as Chongzhou's Tiger Tallies.

But why were there three?

Weren't there always only two halves of a Tiger Tally, a left and a right? The left half was given to the commanding general, while the right half remained in the emperor's hands.

Fan Changyu's breathing instantly quickened. As she tried to fit the three tallies together, her hands began to tremble uncontrollably.

The left and right halves of one tally fit together easily, the two halves of the seal script on the seam matching perfectly.

The extra one was a left half!

And the one her father had been tasked with delivering back then was the right half given by the emperor!

The Sui residence's steward had said that Changxin Wang had tried to match the Tiger Tally her father delivered in front of his subordinate generals, and the tally hadn't fit!

So it wasn't that her father had delivered a fake Tiger Tally, but that the one the Sui family had produced was fake!

This realization made the blood in Fan Changyu's entire body feel as if it were rushing in reverse. She shot her head up and asked Xie Zhong, "Where did these things come from?"

Seeing her terribly pale face and her hand gripping the Tiger Tallies so tightly that her knuckles turned white, Xie Zhong quickly replied, "The advisor from the Court of Revision who previously accused Wei Yan later recanted his testimony and implicated the Li family. He also revealed the location where the Sui family hid their correspondence with the Li family. The Marquis had already ordered men to search for this evidence, and it was just sent back from Chongzhou by express courier today."

Upon hearing this, Fan Changyu, without bothering to explain further, began to rummage through the letters. "Old sir, I'm looking for something. I'll explain in detail to Xie Zheng later."

Xie Zhong's attitude was surprisingly calm. "The General may look for whatever you wish. The Marquis gave instructions long ago that the General may freely take and use anything in the residence."

The urgency of uncovering the truth of the seventeen-year-old Jinzhou Massacre overshadowed the faint, strange feeling that rose in Fan Changyu's heart upon hearing those words.

Unfortunately, there was no correspondence between the Wei and Sui families among the letters.

Fan Changyu stared at the three Tiger Tallies in her hand for two breaths, then stood up. "Old sir, I'll borrow these tallies for a moment."

Xie Zhong only said, "The General may take them as you please."

Holding the three Tiger Tallies, Fan Changyu went straight to find Tao Taifu.

When the door was kicked open, Tao Taifu had just poured himself a cup of tea. The loud "thud" made his hand tremble, and the full cup of tea spilled, soaking his robe. He couldn't help but chide, "You girl, didn't you just leave a moment ago? What's the matter, coming back in such a rush..."

Fan Changyu held out the three Tiger Tallies. "Foster father, take a look. Are these Tiger Tallies real or fake!"

Tao Taifu's drooping eyelids shot up. His chiding stopped abruptly, and his expression immediately turned grave. "Let me see."

Fan Changyu handed the tallies over. Tao Taifu held them up to his eyes, examining them carefully in the light from the window before saying, "They are Chongzhou's Tiger Tallies. There's no mistake."

Fan Changyu's hands, hanging at her sides, clenched into tight fists. With her head slightly bowed, her calm voice struggled to suppress something. "The Tiger Tally my father delivered back then was real. It was the Sui family that had ulterior motives!"

Tao Taifu's wrinkled brow furrowed. "This Sui family is truly strange. When he was asked to send troops to turn the tide, he refused. But after Jinzhou fell, he promptly stepped up to fill the breach. If the Sui family was entirely to blame for the loss of Jinzhou, why would that old fellow Wei Yan cover for them?"

Fan Changyu turned and walked out. "The Eldest Imperial Grandson... the Eldest Imperial Grandson is still alive! He hates the Sui family to the bone. Perhaps he knows something!"

Tao Taifu watched Fan Changyu's rapidly departing figure, then turned his gaze to the unfinished game on the chessboard and sighed softly. "Old fellow, oh, old fellow, you truly have been stubborn your whole life. What secret could you possibly have that you must take to your grave?"

In the dim prison, only a single beam of light shone down from the skylight. Fine particles of snow drifted in, coating the ground below in a thin layer.

The clanking of iron chains echoed from the end of the cell block. A pair of brocade boots walked slowly along the green brick path, stopping in front of a cell near the back. The man looked coldly at the upright old man sitting cross-legged inside, saying nothing.

The imperial prison was heavy with cold air. The snowflakes dusting his cloak showed no sign of melting.

Wei Yan opened his stern phoenix eyes and looked at the young man standing outside the cell, the one who was about to become the backbone of Great Yin. He spoke calmly, "To the victor go the spoils. Since you have defeated me, you didn't come here today just to see how I am faring, did you?"

Xie Zheng just watched him quietly, his expression cold and nonchalant. "The Chancellor guessed correctly. This Marquis came today precisely to see what a man who has spent his entire life playing with power looks like after losing it."

Wei Yan sneered. "It seems I have disappointed you."

Xie Zheng tilted his head slightly. His long hair was immaculately bound by a golden coronet. The light from the distant skylight struck his profile, making the contours of his features appear even deeper. His eyes held a bone-deep chill, yet something else seemed to lie in their depths, something one couldn't quite make out. "I wouldn't call it a disappointment. The Chancellor has the heart of a viper and the nature of a wolf. I'm afraid you no longer remember what it is to be human. Why should this Marquis concern himself with something that can't even be considered a person?"

A flash of cold severity instantly appeared in Wei Yan's eyes—not just simple anger, but also a hint of an elder's sternness toward a junior.

Xie Zheng looked down at him with his half-lidded phoenix eyes and said coldly, "Angry? What right do you have to be angry? Or perhaps, the Chancellor wishes to tell this Marquis that you had your reasons for killing your own sister and brother-in-law?"

Wei Yan's facial muscles tensed. He simply closed his eyes and stopped responding.

Xie Zheng continued nonchalantly, "That wife you brought into your residence over twenty years ago came to beg me to spare your life. Only then did I learn that you were indifferent to Wei Xuan's death because he was not your flesh and blood. Were you just as indifferent when you killed my parents?"

He slowly raised his eyes, a mocking smile on his lips, but his voice was filled with cold ridicule. "Or was it that my mother wasn't your real sister either, and that she deserved to be eliminated once she stood in your way?"

His words were exceedingly sharp, and within his cold, mocking phoenix eyes, there was a faint trace of crimson.

"Silence!" Wei Yan suddenly barked, a flash of deep pain flickering through the phoenix eyes so similar to Xie Zheng's.

Xie Zheng lunged forward, grabbing Wei Yan's collar and slamming him, shackles and all, against the cell door. The hatred suppressed beneath his calm demeanor broke through the string of reason in his mind. His expression turned somewhat savage as he roared at Wei Yan, "Then tell me! Why did you kill my parents? You had me call you 'uncle' for over twenty years. Are you worthy?!"

Wei Yan's hands were in iron shackles. Pulled with such force by Xie Zheng, both his temples slammed hard against the wooden posts of the cell, quickly drawing blood. But his eyes only turned abruptly fierce as he said, "It is as you said. They stood in my way, so they deserved to die."

The last two words were spoken with extreme gravity.

Xie Zheng's jaw was clenched tight, his eyes red. The veins on the back of the hand gripping Wei Yan's collar bulged. He forcefully threw Wei Yan aside and scrambled to his feet, looking somewhat disheveled, and spat out three words through gritted teeth: "You're lying!"

Wei Yan fell back onto the straw pile, panting slowly. Hearing this, he offered no further reply.

Xie Zheng slammed his palm heavily on the sturdy wooden post of the cell, his eyes filled with hatred as he stared at Wei Yan. "You disown your own family, single-mindedly obsessed with power. Now that you have no power left, who are you still hiding the truth for?"

Wei Yan still did not answer.

Finally, Xie Zheng stormed away in a fit of anger. When the cell door at the end of the corridor was pulled open and then slammed shut, it made a loud "bang." The chains on it rattled, showing the immense fury of the person who had closed it.

The jailer dared not say or ask much. He fumbled with the chains on the door and reattached the lock.

The heavy snow had not stopped, fluttering down from the skylight that cut a line of white light into the prison.

Wei Yan lay on the pile of dry straw, watching the snowflakes weave through the dim light of the cell, so clean they seemed out of place in the imperial prison.

He closed his eyes.

His path of retreat had been sealed seventeen years ago.

Even if he had to bear eternal infamy, even if he deserved to be sliced by a thousand cuts, it was enough for him to bear it alone.

That person, who was like the spring snow, deserved to depart spotlessly, without a single disgraceful mark left in the annals of history.

Chapter 161

Now the entire imperial palace was under Xie Zheng's control. The events of that night's coup were temporarily announced to the public as Grand Tutor Li and Wei Yan's rebellion, with the emperor falling severely ill from shock. All involved parties had been imprisoned, but the specific charges would wait until the emperor "recovered" to be discussed.

The court officials saw the situation clearly. After the absurd incident at the palace banquet, the emperor's "illness" would likely never improve, and the dragon throne would soon change hands.

Qi Min was severely injured and had been temporarily placed in a detached palace under heavy guard by Gongsun Yin's orders.

In order to seize the firearms of the Divine Machine Battalion, Qi Min had dispatched many elite Shadow Guards to the Western Garden. After a fierce battle with Fan Changyu and the Left Flank Battalion, those Shadow Guards were completely wiped out. The remaining guards protecting Qi Min had also been killed or injured while shielding him from cannon fire and arrows, with only a few survivors now in custody.

When Fan Changyu entered the detached palace, she saw a pale-faced man lying half-dead on the bed, coughing violently.

Fan Changyu had never met Qi Min before but noticed that he bore some resemblance to the young emperor—likely because they were uncle and nephew. Both had an air of deep melancholy in their features.

Noticing her presence, Qi Min finished coughing, leaned against the soft pillow, and spoke weakly yet mockingly: "General of the Cloud Banner? What a rare guest."

As if he weren't a prisoner but still the descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince, destined for the throne.

Fan Changyu had no patience for pretense and cut straight to the point: "What exactly did Wei Yan and the Sui family do in the Jinzhou massacre seventeen years ago?"

Why had the Sui family refused to send troops to aid Jinzhou? And why had Wei Yan, even after the Sui family rebelled, never exposed their failure to act in time?

Qi Min lowered his eyes with a faint smile: "Naturally... they committed acts worse than beasts."

Fan Changyu snapped coldly: "Speak!"

The curve of his lips deepened as he made his terms clear: "With the Blood-Clad Cavalry's sharpness, you must have already found my concubine. If you want to know about Wei Yan and the Sui family's dealings, fine—let me see her."

Fan Changyu immediately retorted: "Dream on!"

Her gaze was icy, sharp as a blade coated in frost.

She still vividly remembered how this man had ruthlessly tried to kill Yu Bao'er—a mere child—to prevent her from falling into their hands.

Yu Qianqian had barely escaped his clutches. Fan Changyu would never let her see this scum again.

Qi Min lowered his eyes: "Then... I have nothing to say."

Suddenly, Fan Changyu drew her sword and pressed it against his throat, her expression frigid: "I'm not here to negotiate with you."

Her time climbing through the ranks—from the military camp to the court—had taught her how to threaten someone with ruthless severity.

Yet Qi Min only smiled faintly: "Since I've fallen into your hands, death is inevitable. If the General of the Cloud Banner only wants my life, go ahead and strike."

He referred to himself with imperial arrogance, exuding pride even in his wretched state, as if telling Fan Changyu there was nothing left to discuss.

Fan Changyu held the sword against him for two breaths, the blade breaking the skin at his neck and drawing blood. Yet not a trace of fear showed in his expression.

With a furious frown, she finally sheathed her sword, pressed her lips tightly together, and left the detached palace without another word.

No sooner had she stepped out of the palace gate than she spotted a figure ascending the white marble steps outside the detached palace. Snowflakes dusted the gold-embroidered cloak draped over his shoulders, his face as cold as jade, eyes dark as lacquer.

Fan Changyu paused in surprise. "What brings you here?"

At the sight of her, the chill in Xie Zheng's eyes softened slightly. Noticing she wore only thin soft armor, he immediately pulled the cloak from his shoulders and wrapped it around her. "I came to investigate some matters in the palace. Heard you were here at the detached palace, so I came to check on you."

The cloak still carried his body warmth and the crisp scent of winter. Changyu, shorter in stature, was nearly swallowed whole by the garment, leaving only her striking face and high-bound long hair exposed—like a young boy sneaking into his elder brother's clothes, her features clear and bright yet undeniably heroic.

She adjusted the cloak and walked shoulder-to-shoulder with Xie Zheng down the steps, recounting the Sui family's forgery of the Tiger Tally and deliberate refusal to send troops. "I thought the imperial eldest grandson might know something, so I came to question him. He demanded to see Qianqian before he'd talk."

At the mention of the forged Tiger Tally, frost instantly returned to Xie Zheng's gaze: "The palace maid from the Cold Palace died three days ago."

Unable to extract information from Wei Yan in the dungeon, he'd turned to investigating the man's connection with Shu Fei.

Changyu wasn't surprised. "The emperor's doing?"

Timing suggested the maid had died right after New Year's Eve.

But Xie Zheng shook his head. "I interrogated Qi Sheng's eunuch. After the Cold Palace scheme failed, Qi Sheng rushed to Wei Yan for protection that very night. That maid was his bargaining chip to force Wei Yan's compliance—he wouldn't be foolish enough to destroy his own lifeline."

Changyu looked at him. "Wei Yan then?"

Xie Zheng remained silent, tacitly confirming.

Utterly perplexed, Changyu mused, "Wei Yan killed that maid before Grand Tutor Li's palace coup—was he afraid his scandal would reach Li?"

Or unwilling to leave any leverage in others' hands?"

Xie Zheng gazed at the snow blanketing distant palace walls, saying only, "He's always been ruthless. Having driven the Li family to desperate measures with the coup, he wouldn't tolerate any remaining threats in the palace."

Recalling Grand Tutor Li's revelation about Wei Yan's sister being close with Shu Fei in their youth, and Wei Yan having served under Old General Qi, Changyu realized Wei Yan and Shu Fei must have known each other before their respective marriages. Combined with Wei Yan's purely nominal marriage, his relationship with Shu Fei appeared increasingly questionable.

Hesitantly, she ventured, "So Wei Yan's affair with Shu Fei... is eighty percent true?"

If false, why would Wei Yan silence the maid after controlling the young emperor?

Xie Zheng remained silent, striding steadily through the heavy snow. Without his cloak against the storm, his usually imposing frame suddenly seemed fragile—like that bereaved child of long ago. After a long pause, he finally spoke with deliberate nonchalance: "Perhaps as Qi Min said—he orchestrated the Jinzhou defeat precisely to sow chaos in the harem and covet the throne."

Changyu glanced sideways at him and abruptly stopped walking.

"What's wrong?"

Xie Zheng turned back. Fine snow settled on his shoulders, the black and gold Coiled Dragon Python Robe accentuating his frost-pale features.

Suddenly Changyu threw her arms around him in a fierce embrace, her voice muffled but firm: "From now on, I'll walk this path with you."

He concealed his emotions masterfully, but in that instant, Changyu had unmistakably sensed his turmoil.

Indeed, no matter how wicked Wei Yan was, he was still the uncle Fan Changyu had called family for over twenty years, his only remaining kin in this world.

Yet this sole relative was also the murderer who had taken his parents' lives.

How could he not grieve? It was just that... he no longer knew how to grieve.

Xie Zheng lowered his gaze, quietly staring at the dark crown of the girl's head nestled against his chest. The force with which she had collided into him had been slight, yet it sent a tremor through his heart, a tingling numbness and faint ache spreading from that quiver all the way to his fingertips.

He remained stiff for a long moment before finally raising a hand to press against the cloak draped over her back, drawing her fully into his embrace. His long lashes, dusted with fine snowflakes, drooped slightly as he murmured stubbornly and earnestly, "Naturally, you won't get away."

Snow fell thick as cotton floss as the two walked side by side back the way they had come.

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After failing to gather any useful information about Shu Fei from the palace maids, Fan Changyu went on Xie Zheng's behalf to visit An Taifei.

To be precise, when Xie Zheng had initially asked Gongsun Yin to facilitate contact with the princess to investigate the Sixteenth Prince, his true aim had been to reach An Taifei.

Though the palace servants had been replaced batch after batch over the years, An Taifei was one of the few consorts who had remained detached from court intrigues since seventeen years ago. She undoubtedly knew more about the events of that time than the average palace servant.

Perhaps because the current political situation had already become clear, An Taifei did not hesitate in the slightest when Fan Changyu stated her purpose for visiting.

"Her Ladyship and Shu Fei were acquainted even before entering the palace. To this day, Her Ladyship still prefers to call her by her maiden name, Rong Yin."

The palace doors were shut tight, leaving the small prayer hall dim and shadowed.

Clad in monastic robes, An Taifei lit incense before carefully replacing the intricately carved gold-inlaid lid of the Boshan censer with her well-maintained, delicate hands. Wisps of blue smoke curled through the perforations, lazily drifting upward into the hall's lofty ceiling.

She paused, her expression tinged with a fleeting melancholy. "She liked it when Her Ladyship called her by that name too."

Fan Changyu sat upright on the opposite side of the low table, silently committing Shu Fei's maiden name, Qi Rongyin, to memory.

It was a rather beautiful name, she thought.

An Taifei returned to the low table and settled gracefully into her seat, every movement exuding the refined composure honed by years of experience. "Her Ladyship entered the palace at the same time as her. Thanks to Empress Dowager Qi's influence, she was immediately granted the rank of consort, while Her Ladyship was only made a jieyu. Back then, Jia Guitaifei enjoyed the Late Emperor's utmost favor, and any consort who caught his eye suffered under her jealousy. Rong Yin once helped Her Ladyship out of a predicament, and after a few such exchanges—along with the bond they had formed in their youth—we grew close."

The clear sound of pouring water accompanied An Taifei as she slid a freshly poured cup of tea toward Fan Changyu. A faint smile touched her lips, as if lost in reminiscence.

"Rong Yin was a woman of exceedingly tranquil temperament, hardly the type to enter the palace and vie for favor to uphold the Qi family's prestige. Yet it was precisely that unassuming nature that made the Late Emperor desperate to lay everything at her feet, much to Jia Guitaifei's envy for a long time."

An Taifei chuckled softly, then shook her head. "Or perhaps it had nothing to do with temperament. After all, what man in this world wouldn't be moved by such beauty? When she wasn't smiling, she was as cold and distant as a night-blooming cereus; when she smiled, she shone as brilliantly as a lotus in bloom. In those days, the capital's most handsome men were Wei Yan and General Xie, the twin pillars of civil and military prowess, while among its beauties, Rong Yin and Wei Wan stood as peerless."

Fan Changyu knew—Wei Wan was Xie Zheng's mother.

Perhaps it was because An Taifei's voice was light yet carried a timeless melancholy that Fan Changyu found herself absorbed in listening to the past events, holding the teacup without taking a single sip.

"In the palace, Rong Yin was never truly happy. No matter what the Late Emperor bestowed upon her, it was difficult to bring a smile to her face.

She loved heights, and the Star-Picking Tower was a place she often visited. Sometimes she would stand there for an entire morning. Later, for reasons unknown, the Late Emperor ordered the tower to be demolished and distanced himself from Rong Yin for quite some time."

"I once asked Rong Yin what she always looked at from the tower. She said she missed home."

An Taifei poured herself a cup of tea, took a small sip, and smiled—though her smile carried the sorrow of years gone by. "I didn't know whether her words were true, but in the second year after she entered the palace, Wei Yan got married and had a son by the end of that year. During the New Year's Eve banquet that year, the Late Emperor had intended to bring her before the court officials, but she fell ill. In the end, it was Jia Guitaifei who accompanied the Late Emperor. Jia Guitaifei thought Rong Yin was showing weakness and became quite smug for a while. During that period, the palace was rather peaceful."

Fan Changyu had already begun to suspect something. She asked, "Was Shu Fei's death truly connected to Wei Yan?"

Chapter 162

Perhaps it was because Fan Changyu's question was too blunt, or perhaps the matter itself was too heavy.

An Taifei's smile gradually faded. She was silent for a long moment before shaking her head and saying, "This old one does not know."

The answer took Fan Changyu by surprise, but then An Taifei continued, "In the early winter of the sixteenth year of Qishun, the war in Jinzhou was critical, and the Sixteenth Prince—who had always sought to contend for the throne against the Crown Prince—caused trouble in Luocheng. Though Jia Guitaifei kept it tightly under wraps, there are no walls in the world that don't leak. This old one still heard some rumors."

She looked at Fan Changyu. "Do you know what trouble the Sixteenth Prince caused?"

Fan Changyu nodded.

If not for the Sixteenth Prince's reckless ambition, which led to him being trapped in Luocheng, her grandfather would not have been caught in that impossible dilemma back then.

An Taifei murmured, "How the Late Emperor handled matters in court, this old one, confined to the inner palace, could not know. But one would think he would not have abandoned the Sixteenth Prince. During that time, Jia Guitaifei also quieted down considerably. The Late Emperor seemed intent on slighting her and stopped visiting her palace, often going to Rong Yin's instead."

"At the time, this old one also thought that after this incident, Jia Guitaifei and the Sixteenth Prince would both lose favor. Once the Crown Prince returned victorious from Jinzhou, what could the Sixteenth Prince possibly use to challenge him for the throne?"

"But then Rong Yin was suddenly found to be with child." An Taifei paused here, whether because she found the events of that year absurd or for some other reason. The hand holding her prayer beads slowed for a beat. "Every imperial physician in the palace was summoned to examine

her, but the estimated month of conception still did not match the records in the Chamber of Palace Affairs."

Fan Changyu's head snapped up.

A shadow of sorrow crossed An Taifei's eyes. "Rong Yin was three months pregnant. Counting backward, the conception would have had to occur around the Mid-Autumn Festival. That year, during the Mid-Autumn banquet, something did happen. Wei Yan drank too much at the palace feast and, in a drunken stupor, violated a palace maid in the waterside pavilion of Taiye Pond. Unfortunately, the Late Emperor and his ministers, who had gone to admire the moon, stumbled upon them. It was said the Late Emperor's expression turned extremely grim, but since it was only a palace maid, he could not make a scene. So, he bestowed the maid upon Wei Yan."

Fan Changyu immediately thought of how Xie Zheng had been framed by the young emperor on New Year's Eve.

Her brows furrowed. "Was Wei Yan set up?"

Otherwise, how could it have been such a coincidence that the Late Emperor and his ministers just happened to pass by?

Moreover, if the child in Shu Fei's womb was not the right age, then the one Wei Yan had violated in his drunken state was not a palace maid at all—it was most likely Shu Fei herself.

An Taifei only sighed. "How could this old one know? But Rong Yin undoubtedly incurred the Emperor's wrath. Every servant in Qingyuan Palace was beaten to death, yet nothing was extracted from them. Rong Yin was imprisoned in Qingyuan Palace, and every day, matrons went to interrogate her... demanding to know with whom she had been intimate. On the night of Laba, a fire suddenly broke out in Qingyuan Palace. When the Golden Guard on patrol rushed to extinguish it, they found Wei Yan nearby."

Fan Changyu was stunned. "Did Wei Yan really set the fire that killed Shu Fei?"

An Taifei said, "That was the rumor in the palace at the time. This old one had been close to Rong Yin, and by the time I heard the news and rushed to Qingyuan Palace, the flames were too fierce to enter."

Fan Changyu noticed An Taifei's voice growing hoarse and looked up to see a single tear glistening at the corner of her eye.

Her voice trembled slightly. "Have you ever seen water thrown onto a fire, only for the flames to leap higher?"

She said, "This old one has. That fire reeked of tung oil."

Fan Changyu frowned. "Was it the Late Emperor who burned Shu Fei to death?"

Imperial Consort An picked up a handkerchief to wipe her tears, barely maintaining a semblance of calm in her voice: "This old one was unable to see Shu Fei one last time. How she passed, I cannot give the general a definitive answer. But her Qingyuan Palace... it was indeed the Golden Guard who doused it with tung oil while fighting the fire."

"At dawn, the palace was surrounded, the sounds of slaughter shaking the heavens. I only survived by tightly shutting the gates of Shouyang Palace. That day, the waters of the moat ran red, and the white marble steps before Taihe Gate could not be cleansed of the stench of blood for a full month afterward. Everyone in the palace was replaced. The Late Emperor and Imperial Consort Jia both succumbed to overwhelming grief. The slaughter in the palace before dawn that day seems to exist only in this old one's memory now, truly like a dream..."

The incense in the burner curled upward in the Buddha hall, and the white jade Guanyin on the altar seemed to exude even greater compassion.

Fan Changyu rose with complex emotions and clasped her hands in salute: "Thank you, Your Highness, for sharing this past."

Stepping out of the small Buddha hall, Fan Changyu took a deep breath of the crisp, cold air filled with snowflakes, gazing absently at the sparrows perched atop the palace walls.

The mysteries surrounding Wei Yan grew ever more tangled.

He had been ordered to mobilize troops but had handed the responsibility to her father midway, returning to the capital himself.

Had he already conspired with Prince Changxin by then, preparing for the fall of Jinzhou, and returned early to control the capital's situation?

If so, given his cunning, he shouldn't have lost composure and sneaked into Shu Fei's Qingyuan Palace at night.

Even stranger—if he had gone to kill Shu Fei to silence her, why did the Late Emperor order the Golden Guard to douse her palace with tung oil?

Fan Changyu frowned deeply. Recalling Shu Fei's words about Wei Yan getting drunk at the Mid-Autumn banquet and assaulting a palace maid—witnessed by the Late Emperor and his ministers—she became increasingly convinced that incident too had been the Late Emperor's scheme.

Had Wei Yan's nighttime visit to Qingyuan Palace been another trap by the Late Emperor? When Wei Yan escaped due to his martial skills, did the enraged emperor burn Shu Fei in retaliation, then frame Wei Yan?

And did Wei Yan launch the palace coup to save himself?

Pondering these questions, Fan Changyu headed to Wenyuan Pavilion to find Xie Zheng. Before leaving Shouyang Palace, she heard someone call from behind: "General Fan, please wait!"

Turning, she saw a magnificently dressed palace beauty approaching. The intricate gold-woven embroidered brocade of her robes bloomed with flowers, her hairpins were floral, and she herself resembled a peony in full splendor. Though her steps were quick, the tassels on her hair ornaments swayed only slightly, exuding natural elegance and nobility.

Assuming this must be the princess, Fan Changyu saluted: "Greetings, Your Highness."

Qi Zhu hurriedly said, "No need for formalities, General."

She handed Fan Changyu an embroidered box: "I stopped you to ask a favor—please deliver this to Gongsun."

Accepting the surprisingly light box, Fan Changyu wondered at its contents but assumed palace restrictions made outside communication difficult. "This general will ensure it reaches Gongsun," she promised.

"Thank you, General." Qi Zhu gave a slight curtsy. As she turned away, her eyes lingered on the box with a trace of melancholy.

Fan Changyu found it somewhat strange. After another glance at the brocade box in her hand, she tucked it into her robe and headed towards the Wenyuan Pavilion.

Xie Zheng had postponed the morning court sessions for several days, citing the young emperor's illness from fright. However, after Gongsun Yin

screened the memorials submitted by court officials, the crucial ones still needed Xie Zheng's final decisions.

Before Changyu even entered the hall, she heard Gongsun Yin's complaints: "The Three Departments and Six Ministries are all urging to conclude Wei Yan's case. Look at this old traitor's confession—does he think this is a game?"

Growing increasingly indignant, he slammed a confession document before Xie Zheng, fanning himself furiously despite the cold weather: "Delaying military orders leading to the fall of Jinzhou—he claims he feared punishment, so he massacred the imperial palace instead. After seizing power, he altered edicts to shift all blame onto Old General Meng. Tell me, who would believe this confession if released? If he delayed military operations, shouldn't he have been on his way to Jinzhou? How did he end up in the capital instead?"

Xie Zheng continued writing calmly at the desk, unmoved.

Gongsun Yin produced a second document from his robe and slapped it onto the desk: "Here! This is his revised confession after I questioned why he returned to the capital early. Now he changes his tune, admitting he orchestrated the Jinzhou massacre himself, claiming it was because he disagreed with Crown Prince Chengde politically. To monopolize power and achieve his grand ambitions, he deliberately gave Wei Qilin a fake Chongzhou Tiger Tally..."

Changyu knew this was likely another false confession forced from Wei Yan. The Tiger Tally her father had carried was genuine.

She stepped inside: "Did Wei Yan confess to defiling the imperial harem?"

"General Fan has returned?" Gongsun Yin glanced toward the entrance, greeting Changyu with a smile before answering: "No, he hasn't. He won't even mention it..."

Only when Changyu entered did the man bent over documents finally look up, pulling out a chair for her. Changyu naturally took her seat beside him.

Gongsun Yin pretended not to notice and continued: "Strangely enough, he's confessed without blinking to countless heinous crimes—both those he committed and those he didn't—yet he persistently avoids this particular charge of debauchery..."

The soft clink of a teacup sounded as Xie Zheng poured tea and handed it over. "The snowstorm outside is heavy. Warm yourself with some tea."

Changyu was indeed thirsty and began gulping it down immediately.

Gongsun Yin's mouth twitched. After all these years of acquaintance, he'd never seen this man voluntarily serve tea to anyone.

Suppressing his reaction, he continued analyzing: "Since the Cold Palace maid who fell into Qi Sheng's hands was also killed by Wei Yan, I suspect his affair with Shu Fei might be true—he's just been covering it up..."

"Dinner is still some time away. If you're hungry, there are some pastries here to tide you over." The cool, clear voice opposite spoke again quietly.

Gongsun Yin watched incredulously as the normally stern man produced a food box from behind him, taking out a plate of pastries for Changyu. He finally couldn't take it anymore.

Just as Changyu accepted the plate, a loud bang sounded.

Turning, she saw Gongsun Yin standing with both hands on the desk, veins throbbing at his temples. "Xie Jiuhang, that's enough!"

Changyu paused, took one pastry for herself, then pushed the entire plate toward Gongsun Yin with innocent almond eyes.

The message was clear: Here, you have some too.

Gongsun Yin nearly fainted from frustration.

To make matters worse, Xie Zheng chose that moment to remark coolly: "Don't mind him."

Gongsun Yin couldn't help but roar: "Xie Jiuhang, there will come a day when you beg me! After all I've said..."

Xie Zheng interrupted him: "Shu Fei was a descendant of the Qi family. Wei Yan once received instruction from Old General Qi."

Gongsun Yin's anger faltered as the broken thread of thought in his mind suddenly connected: "So Wei Yan concealed this matter to protect the Qi family's reputation?"

After all, Old General Qi and all his sons had died in battle. The Qi family truly deserved the title of "a family of loyal martyrs." Even Chengde Crown Prince bore the same steadfast character as the Qi family, earning him immense public support.

For such a loyal and heroic family, having a promiscuous imperial consort would indeed tarnish their name.

Fan Changyu thought for a moment and said: "I actually think Wei Yan did it for Shu Fei's reputation. He had a past with her, and the crimes he committed would leave him infamous for eternity. Admitting an affair with Shu Fei would only drag her name through the mud alongside his for generations to come."

Throughout history, imperial consorts entangled between rulers and ministers have gained notorious reputations, with unofficial records describing them in increasingly vulgar terms, often becoming fodder for idle gossip among ruffians.

Any ordinary woman associated with such scandalous notoriety would have no choice but to drown herself to preserve her virtue.

Gongsun Yin sat back down and said: "If that's truly the case, it's rather strange. For a heartless man like Wei Yan to go this far for a woman?"

Fan Changyu then shared what she had learned from An Taifei with the two men.

Both Xie Zheng and Gongsun Yin fell silent after hearing it.

Fan Changyu said: "If the Late Emperor had indeed set up Wei Yan, then Shu Fei's death and that forced palace coup might also be suspicious. But there's one thing I still don't understand—if Wei Yan cared so much about protecting Shu Fei's reputation even after her death, why did he abandon her and flee alone when he was discovered by the imperial guards during his nighttime visit to Qingyuan Palace?"

Xie Zheng remained silent.

Gongsun Yin rubbed his temples: "Could it be that Wei Yan knew back then that he couldn't save Shu Fei, yet didn't want to die with her either? After tasting power all these years, he felt guilty and wanted to make amends?"

Fan Changyu didn't respond either.

If it really was as Gongsun Yin said, then Wei Yan's current refusal to let Shu Fei's name be tarnished would seem rather laughable.

"In my opinion, we should just close this case," Gongsun Yin suddenly declared.

Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng remained silent.

Gongsun Yin tapped the table with his fan handle: "The masterminds behind the Jinzhou Massacre were undoubtedly Wei Yan and Sui Tuo. The Sui family is extinct, Wei Yan has been executed, and the slander he pinned on Old General Meng has been cleared. With his death, the lives he owed have been repaid. Isn't this a proper resolution for the wronged soldiers of Jinzhou and the people of this land?"

When Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng still didn't speak, Gongsun Yin added: "If we can't pry open Wei Yan's mouth, we can't just drag this on forever. The new ruler... must prepare for his ascension, no?"

After another stretch of silence, a firm and steady voice finally spoke: "We cannot close the case."

Gongsun Yin looked up, and Xie Zheng also turned his gaze.

Sunlight streamed through the half-open window into the hall, clear and bright. The young female general sat upright on a cushion in her soft armor, her long lashes slightly lowered, her features resolute and heroic.

Gongsun Yin asked: "Why?"

Fan Changyu raised her head, her eyes reflecting the morning light like a vast, shimmering sea: "Having reached our current positions, we shouldn't settle for such a muddled conclusion. Even the courtroom of a seventh-rank county magistrate bears the plaque 'Impartial Justice Above All,' demanding fairness and righteousness. Wei Yan killed my parents and tarnished my grandfather's reputation—I hate him to the bone. He committed countless atrocities and deserves death, but not this kind of senseless end."

Her gaze was resolute: "The Bloody Case of Jinzhou needs the truth—the real truth."

Not some hazy notion that with Wei Yan's death, the past grievances would be settled.

Wei Yan's death would only bury the truth forever.

The last trace of casualness vanished from Gongsun Yin's eyes as he regarded Fan Changyu with unprecedented seriousness.

The young woman before him remained as courageous and sincere as ever, yet now her sincerity and bravery carried an added depth—not like

towering mountains, but broader, akin to the vast, unending earth beneath their feet.

Only such fertile ground could nurture peaks that rise abruptly from the plains.

This realization left Gongsun Yin momentarily stunned, until Xie Zheng's voice brought him back.

"Continue investigating the Jinzhou case. As for the new emperor's ascension, begin preparations now." The first statement was directed at Fan Changyu, the second at Gongsun Yin.

Gongsun Yin assented. As he stood, he bowed solemnly to Fan Changyu: "I am ashamed of my earlier words."

His gesture flustered Fan Changyu, who replied, "Gongsun was considering the broader situation."

She handed him the brocade box Qi Zhu had entrusted to her: "I nearly forgot—the Eldest Princess asked me to deliver this to you."

When Gongsun Yin took the box, his eyes darkened slightly. "Did Her Highness have any other message for me?"

Fan Changyu answered truthfully: "No."

"I see. Thank you, General Fan." Gongsun Yin smiled, but his usual carefree demeanor seemed absent.

After Gongsun Yin left, Fan Changyu remarked to Xie Zheng, "Did you notice how strange Gongsun acted after receiving that box?"

Xie Zheng embraced her from behind: "He's avoided the Eldest Princess for years, but time won't wait for her any longer."

Before Fan Changyu could fully grasp his cryptic words, she felt the weight of Xie Zheng's chin resting on her shoulder.

"Thank you," he murmured hoarsely.

With Wei Yan dead, he might never learn the truth about his father's death.

How could she not hate Wei Yan for her parents' deaths and the Meng family's wrongful accusations? His death would have meant true vengeance.

Yet she had rejected Gongsun Yin's proposal.

Fan Changyu turned her head to smile at him: "General Xie and Crown Prince Chengde's wrongful deaths need answers, as do the thousands of soldiers who died in Jinzhou."

She placed her hand over his at her waist, her eyes as pure and sincere as ever: "We'll find the truth together. We always will."

The turning point came after Yu Qianqian arrived in the capital.

Fan Changyu had never mentioned Qi Min to Yu Qianqian, but her and Xie Zheng's extensive investigations into Wei Yan and the Sui family eventually reached Yu Qianqian's ears.

A nation cannot be without a ruler for even a day. When Xie Zheng discussed with Tang Peiyi and others the matter of elevating Yu Bao'er to the throne, they inevitably faced another issue: Qi Min was still clinging to life by a thread.

The question was how to execute this imperial grandson.

Although Yu Bao'er was still young and shared no fatherly bond with Qi Min, Tang Peiyi and the others did not approve of Xie Zheng directly killing Qi Min. They argued that the natural bond between father and son might cause trouble in the future, fearing that Yu Bao'er could be manipulated into resentment.

Fan Changyu was unafraid of this. She stated plainly, "I'll kill him. That child is sensible and knows his birth father was no good man. Even if, in the worst case, he grows to resent me—I was the one who saved him from Qi Min's blade when his own father tried to kill him. I'm not afraid of his hatred."

Xie Zheng silently grasped her wrist, signaling her to stop arguing.

"I'll go," he repeated in a low, firm tone—not seeking opinions, but declaring his decision.

Just as Tang Peiyi was about to protest again, a voice suddenly came from the doorway: "Marquis, esteemed generals, this humble wife can go."

Everyone turned to see a graceful woman push the door open and enter.

Fan Changyu was startled. "Qianqian, why are you here?"

The other generals and advisors were not familiar with Yu Qianqian, but as the prospective Empress Dowager, they regarded her with deference.

Yu Qianqian looked at Fan Changyu and said, "I know you mean well for me. Bao'er and I already owe you and the Marquis too much. Let me be the one to kill Qi Min. It will not only eliminate him but also allow us to extract information about the Sui family's collusion with Wei Yan. There's no downside."

Fan Changyu's remaining objections were silenced by Yu Qianqian's words.

In the end, she could only say, "Then I'll go with you."

Chapter 163

It was a rare day without snow, the sun casting a gentle warmth.

Fan Changyu stood outside the temporary palace's hall, sword in hand, gazing at the withered tree branches stretching wantonly over the courtyard wall. The warm sun slanted down, and on the distant walls and bare branches, a layer of white snow remained. As the sunlight scattered over it, it suffused the scene with a faint golden halo, yet the air was still piercingly damp and cold.

Yu Qianqian entered the inner hall carrying a tureen.

Qi Min seemed to know she was coming today. Unable to get out of bed due to his injuries, he could only lean back against the headboard, a deep purple outer robe with silver-gray accents draped over his shoulders. In the bright light from the window, the silver-gray on the robe faintly revealed a pattern of auspicious clouds and ruyi knots.

His hair seemed to have been tended to as well. Despite being bedridden with severe injuries for many days, it did not look dirty. It was still as it had always been—jet-black, glossy, and like satin.

Only, he had grown much thinner, so much so that he seemed unable to fill out his clothes.

Yu Qianqian glanced at him once before looking away, continuing forward with the tureen.

Qi Min heard her footsteps but did not turn his head. He watched two birds foraging in the snow-melted courtyard, his hand resting on the bedding, stroking the thumb ring on his finger intermittently. His finger bones were long and slender like bamboo joints, but they were so starkly white and emaciated that one worried they would snap under the slightest pressure.

No one spoke. The only sound was the soft clinking of Yu Qianqian placing the tureen on the table and ladling the soup into a fine white porcelain bowl.

"I thought you wouldn't come."

As Yu Qianqian turned from the table with the bowl of soup, she found that he had turned to look at her at some point. His gaze was as dark and somber as ever, like a vulture on a cliff, or a venomous snake emerging from hibernation to hunt.

A gentle curve lifted the corners of Yu Qianqian's mouth, but her eyes were crystal clear, meeting his gaze without a trace of fear. "I had to come see you off on your final journey."

Qi Min's gaze shifted to the bowl of soup in her hand, an unidentifiable emotion churning in his dark eyes. "It's good of you to have gone to the trouble of brewing a tureen of snow clam soup. You've been most thoughtful."

Yu Qianqian smiled. "Even a death row inmate in the great prison gets a last meal before heading to the execution ground, don't they?"

Her words were sharp, and the smile did not reach her eyes.

Qi Min watched her quietly. "I never knew you had such a clever tongue."

She was afraid of pain, of trouble, of death. She was the most obedient person he knew, seemingly a docile person with no opinions of her own. But beneath this facade, she hid a fiercely wild heart; otherwise, she wouldn't have plotted to escape time and again.

Every time she was caught and brought back, she would never become hysterical. She ate when she should eat, drank when she should drink, and slept when she should sleep, never doing anything to make herself suffer. She accepted every punishment he gave, making people think she had become obedient. But if another chance arose, she would still run without a second thought.

He had never seen her looking so radiant and brilliant.

Stirring the soup in the bowl with a spoon, Yu Qianqian said, "There's a lot you don't know."

Unwilling to waste any more words on him, she asked directly, "You hate the Sui family so much. Back then, the Crown Princess used a fire in the Eastern Palace to turn you into the Sui family's eldest young master. Why?"

Qi Min looked at her without speaking, as if finding her coldness somewhat unfamiliar.

Yu Qianqian met his gaze coolly. "This empire belongs to your Qi family. The one who died in Jinzhou back then was your father. Now that the Sui and Wei families are to be convicted, surely you don't still intend to conceal things for your enemies?"

Detecting the faint ridicule in her tone, Qi Min watched her for a moment longer before shifting his gaze away and speaking slowly. "Among the Shadow Guards my father left me, there was one named Fu Qing. He escaped from Jinzhou city back then. When reinforcements and provisions failed to arrive for a long time, my father sent him to Chongzhou to request aid. Sui Tuo refused to dispatch troops and even tried to have him killed with a volley of arrows, saying that once Jinzhou fell, the world should bear the surname Wei."

A subtle flicker of emotion crossed Yu Qianqian's face, but she remained silent. Qi Min's voice continued, devoid of any ripples, as he revealed the hidden truths of the past.

"Fu Qing was originally from the greenwood, known for his lightness skill. He was lucky to escape the Changxin Prince Manor's attempt to kill him, but he was severely injured. While dragging his wounded body to seek aid and deliver the news elsewhere, Jinzhou had already fallen. Both my father and Xie Linshan died in battle. Knowing the situation was lost, he rushed back to the capital to report. By then, the capital was already under Wei Yan's control. My mother in the Eastern Palace had heard about him colluding with Shu Fei to carry out a bloodbath in the imperial palace. With Fu Qing's testimony, her panic intensified."

"Afterward, the fall of Jinzhou was blamed entirely on General Meng Shuyuan. Old Members of the Meng Family came to the Eastern Palace to plead for justice. They had just stepped through the Eastern Palace gates when they became corpses in a pool of blood. The Meng family, from the daughter and son-in-law to their old retainers, were all killed."

As he spoke, the corners of Qi Min's lips curled with ridicule and coldness. "The Eastern Palace knew Wei Yan's secret. He would not have let the Eastern Palace go. Before Wei Yan could make his move, my mother used a great fire to hide me away in the Changxin Prince Manor."

This was the past that had weighed on him, making it hard to breathe for more than a decade.

He gave Yu Qianqian a faint smile. "You see, only by being ruthless enough can a person get everything they want. My mother said that Wei

Yan had always been a wolf with wild ambitions. In the past, when the Late Emperor favored the Sixteenth Prince and suppressed my father at every turn, all the officials of the Eastern Palace were plotting how to help my father regain favor and secure his position as crown prince. Only Wei Yan declared, why not make the Late Emperor 'abdicate'?"

He paused, a momentary daze in his expression. "If Wei Yan had been eliminated back then, perhaps none of this would have happened. My father was just too indecisive, which is why he met such an end. What use is a virtuous reputation? I will not become a person like him."

Yu Qianqian said coldly, "What utter nonsense. You've committed all sorts of beastly acts, and you still want to find a high-sounding reason for yourself!"

Qi Min did not get angry. He only stared at her and said, "You look much better when you're cursing than when you were obedient."

Yu Qianqian frowned deeply, feeling that nauseating chill of a cold, venomous snake coiling against her skin once more. She made no effort to hide her disgust. "Madman!"

Her seemingly frightened appearance seemed to please Qi Min, making him chuckle softly.

Annoyed, Yu Qianqian stood up to leave. He stopped laughing and called out to her in a faint voice, "The soup is already made. Feed it to me. Don't let your efforts go to waste."

He was gravely injured and could not get out of bed, requiring assistance for his daily needs. To prevent any mishaps, Xie Zheng had even ordered him to be given bone-weakening powder. There would be no danger for Yu Qianqian to see him alone.

Yu Qianqian looked back at him. He was leaning against a soft pillow, his expression very calm, as if he didn't know the soup contained a fatal poison. His slender eyes, with sunlight fragmented within them, set against his pale skin that seemed as if it could melt under the sun, gave off a fleeting sense of gentleness and fragility.

Seeing that Yu Qianqian didn't answer, he smiled at her again, deliberately. "Can't bear to do it?"

Yu Qianqian sat back down. She scooped a spoonful of the now-cool snow clam soup from the bowl and brought it to his lips.

Her expression was so calm it was cold. His face betrayed no emotion either. As he took it, he even commented, "It was brewed for the right amount of time. A pity it's gone a bit cold."

Yu Qianqian didn't speak, simply scooping another spoonful and feeding it to him.

He watched her and continued to open his mouth and drink.

The tranquility of this moment was not like one person about to kill another, but rather like a loving couple.

When the bowl was empty, Qi Min smiled and asked, "Is there more?"

Yu Qianqian said, "There's still half a bowl in the tureen."

"Feed it all to me," Qi Min said.

A smile still hung on his lips, no longer sinister, but with a hint of nonchalance. "I won't be able to drink it in the future."

Of course he wouldn't. What future did he have?

Yu Qianqian's hand, stirring the spoon, paused slightly. She only said, "Wait."

When the remaining half bowl of soup from the tureen was also finished, Qi Min leaned against the pillow, his head slightly tilted as he looked at Yu Qianqian. He suddenly said, "I investigated you."

Yu Qianqian raised her eyes to meet his.

He said, "Your name isn't Qianqian. Your family was poor. You have an older brother, and three younger siblings. Your parents didn't give you a name, always calling you Er'ya. You never worked in a restaurant either. To afford a wife for your brother, your family sold you to a human trafficker. You were bought by the Zhao Family and sent to me."

Yu Qianqian remained silent.

The poison was likely taking effect. A faint, dark purple had appeared on Qi Min's lips, but his eyes were still stubbornly fixed on Yu Qianqian. With some difficulty, he said, "I want to know who you are."

Yu Qianqian still did not answer.

He continued on his own, "A lonely ghost? Or... a spirit who has attained the Dao?"

As his raven-black lashes drooped, a ripple finally appeared in his stagnant eyes. "Let me... die with some clarity."

Yu Qianqian replied with perfect calm, "The poison is affecting you, and your memory is failing. I am Yu Er'ya. Before my family sold me to the trafficker, I worked in a restaurant. Qianqian is a name I gave myself."

She rose from the stool and even helped him tuck in the corner of his quilt. "You're tired. Sleep. This poison is gentle; it won't be too painful. You'll fall asleep, and then you won't know anything at all."

As she was about to leave, that starkly white, thin hand suddenly grabbed her wrist. Caught off guard, Yu Qianqian stumbled and fell onto him.

Just as Yu Qianqian was about to cry for help, he clamped his hand tightly around her neck. It was unknown where a man at death's door found such strength, but he instantly choked her so she couldn't make a sound. She tried to pry his arm away but couldn't move it. Her fingertips dug deep into the back of his hand, but he seemed to feel no pain. A blood-red glint suddenly appeared in his eyes. His expression was savage, his eyes filled with hatred and unwillingness. "I prided myself on my ruthlessness, but I'm not even a fraction of you! You never liked me at all! Did you?"

Yu Qianqian was still struggling, but her face had already flushed red from lack of oxygen. Unable to break his grip, she began to claw at the arrow wound on his chest.

Warm blood enveloped Yu Qianqian's fingers. Qi Min let out a muffled groan and loosened his grip on her.

Yu Qianqian fell to the floor, clutching her neck and gasping for air. At that moment, the door was kicked open. Fan Changyu, who had heard the commotion outside, rushed in with a single stride. "Qianqian!"

She helped Yu Qianqian up, her gaze as sharp as a blade, stabbing straight at Qi Min.

Yu Qianqian quickly grabbed Fan Changyu's hand and said, "I'm fine."

Qi Min clutched his chest, leaning against the soft pillow. His gaunt face had taken on a grayish-blue hue from the poison. He clenched his teeth tightly, his bloodshot eyes staring fixedly at Yu Qianqian, a hint of

grievance showing through his daze. "You... what right do you have to treat me like this!"

Blood seeped from the corner of his mouth, soon gushing out in large amounts, staining a large patch of his lapels and bedding red.

Yu Qianqian sat down by the bed and watched Qi Min quietly. Her hair had come undone during the struggle, and the faint blush from suffocation had not yet faded from her face. She looked quite disheveled, but her expression was extremely cold. "Why can't I treat you like this?"

"Does a person like you deserve to be liked by others?"

"You are selfish, cruel, sinister, and moody. Everyone has to serve you with utmost care, for the slightest misstep could mean death. And if you deign to bestow the smallest favor, you expect people to give you their hearts and souls, to be eternally grateful. Where in the world is there such a good deal?"

Qi Min's mouth was full of blood. His eyes were still locked on Yu Qianqian, but he could no longer speak.

Yu Qianqian said calmly, "Have so few people died for you? Besides being suspicious, what have you ever done for them? You were just born into a good life, that's all."

Qi Min continued to stare at her without blinking, his gaze stubborn and mournful.

But Yu Qianqian no longer looked at him. She straightened up and said to Fan Changyu, "Let's go."

Fan Changyu left the hall with Yu Qianqian. Just as she was about to speak to her, Yu Qianqian's legs suddenly gave way. Fortunately, Fan Changyu caught her in time. "Qianqian, what's wrong?"

Yu Qianqian's face was pale, devoid of the calm composure she had shown in front of Qi Min. "It's nothing. I just need a moment."

The hand she used to grip Fan Changyu's was ice-cold. "Poisoning a person, after all, is different from killing a chicken or a fish."

Fan Changyu helped her sit down on the steps and comforted her, "The first time I killed someone, I was so scared I couldn't sleep all night. I'll bring Ning Niang over to stay with you tonight. I have a lot of blood on my

hands, so my baleful aura is strong. Even if he's a royal grandson, he won't dare come near me as a lonely ghost."

Her words sounded like she was coaxing a child. The gloom in Yu Qianqian's heart dissipated a little, and she let out a "pfft" of laughter. "That's right. Changyu, you're a general now."

Fan Changyu scratched her head and smiled sheepishly.

The sun felt warm on their bodies, and Yu Qianqian's cold hands and feet gradually warmed up. She turned her head to look at the heroic and valiant female general beside her. Perhaps Qi Min's final question had stirred up other emotions in her heart after all. She said suddenly, "Changyu, I have a secret."

"Hm?" Fan Changyu turned her head. The sunlight bathed her, her features glowing with a brilliant radiance that inexplicably inspired trust and warmth.

Yu Qianqian said, "I'll only tell you."

Fan Changyu paused for a moment, then said very seriously, "I'll keep it for you."

Yu Qianqian looked at the swallows flying high and low under the setting sun. Her gaze grew distant, tinged with a faint sorrow. "I came here from a very, very distant place, and I can never go back."

"How far?"

"If you started walking now, it would take thousands of years to get back there."

Fan Changyu was astonished. "Then how did you come to the Great Yin Dynasty?"

Yu Qianqian said, "It took about as long as a nap. I opened my eyes, and I was here."

Fan Changyu's expression turned a little strange. She stared at Yu Qianqian for a long while before suddenly saying, "Qianqian, are you a goddess?"

Yu Qianqian laughed again. "Could there be such a useless goddess in this world?"

She looked at Fan Changyu and said, "You look more like a goddess than I do."

Suddenly praised, Fan Changyu felt a little shy and didn't know how to respond for a moment.

Yu Qianqian said, "Where I come from, there was also a very formidable female general in history named Liangyu."

She turned her head to look at Fan Changyu. "Nothing here is good, but with you and Bao'er, it's also okay."

Her eyes curved into a smile. "Hundreds and thousands of years from now, Changyu will surely be a female general whose name is recorded in history."

In the winter of the seventeenth year of the Yongping era, Grand Tutor Li Xing and Chancellor Wei Yan attempted a rebellion. Li Xing was defeated and died in a hail of arrows, while Wei Yan was captured alive.

A month later, Emperor Qi Sheng passed away from illness due to the shock of the palace coup. The descendant of Chengde Crown Prince, who had been living among the common people, was found. Although the enthronement ceremony had not yet been held, he had already moved into the imperial palace with his birth mother, Lady Yu.

The Imperial Prison.

The dim candlelight cast two towering shadows on the wall. The fire in the brazier in the prison corridor was blazing, the firewood crackling as it burned.

Grand Tutor Tao let out a soft sigh as he placed a game piece. "That brat's father died in Jinzhou. No matter what, he needed an answer about what happened back then."

His aged yet sharp eyes quietly studied the person across from him, who was a full cycle younger than himself. In the manner of an elder, he sighed and asked, "Yigui, to bear a lifetime of infamy, what are you after?"

Qi Min was dead. A few of his Shadow Guards remained, Fu Qing among them.

After Xie Zheng's interrogation, the answer he got was consistent with what Yu Qianqian had asked.

Thus, the three Tiger Tallies found in the Sui residence seemed to make sense.

—The Tiger Tallies were real, and the order to move troops was also real. The Sui family had followed Wei Yan's command and did not dispatch troops or transport grain to reinforce Jinzhou.

But a new question now lay before them: if the Sui family was in cahoots with Wei Yan, why was it that when the Sui family later rebelled, they only spread some rumors about Wei Yan's connection to the fall of Jinzhou, instead of directly exposing him?

No matter what others thought, Grand Tutor Tao did not believe Wei Yan had personally orchestrated the Jinzhou incident. However, ever since his defeat in the forced abdication attempt, Wei Yan seemed to have become indifferent to life and death. He confessed to all crimes but refused to say another word about the events of the past.

"I bear responsibility for the deaths of the Crown Prince and Linshan. I am not shouldering this infamy for anyone else."

The oil lamp in the wall niche flickered with a dim yellow light, and the shadow cast by the man before him split the chessboard into light and dark halves.

Wei Yan's strong index and middle fingers held a black piece and placed it on an intersection of the board. His aged voice, made deeper by its hoarseness, betrayed no fluctuation of emotion.

Grand Tutor Tao, however, detected a sharp edge in his words. His wrinkled eyelids lifted. "Because of the matter between you and that Qi girl?"

Wei Yan looked at Grand Tutor Tao.

Grand Tutor Tao then knew that this was likely a reason. He sighed, "Those two children have already asked An Taifei about it. When you retired from the battlefield back then and stayed in the capital, did you really think this old man couldn't see anything?"

Wei Yan was silent for two breaths, only saying, "She was implicated because of me."

Grand Tutor Tao had been to the imperial prison many times, and each time he could get nothing out of Wei Yan. Since he was willing to speak more today, he immediately asked, "What do you mean by that?"

The charcoal in the clay stove burned vigorously. The water in the teapot was bubbling, and white steam billowed from the spout, blurring Wei Yan's features.

In a daze, the powerful chancellor sitting opposite Grand Tutor Tao once again became the cold and untamed youth who had become famous in Jinyang with just a single poem.

He closed his eyes. "I was young and reckless then, and left behind a disaster of words."

Grand Tutor Tao's gaze was stern but kind, yet his heart had already begun to sink.

He had previously told Fan Changyu that Xie Zheng and the young Wei Yan had similar temperaments, but that wasn't entirely true. Because Xie Zheng had lost his parents at a young age and was strictly disciplined by Wei Yan, his disposition was actually more stable.

In his youth, Wei Yan was not just spirited; he could almost be described as arrogant and untamable.

The Wei family of Jinyang was a clan of great prestige for a hundred years. The sons of the family naturally had an extra measure of pride, and as the most outstanding of his generation, the arrogance he carried was even greater.

He placed third in the imperial examination at seventeen but was unwilling to enter the court as an official so soon. Instead, he traveled to famous mountains and great rivers, saying he wanted to continue his studies and also cultivate transcendental knowledge. This angered the old master of the Wei family so much that, to temper his character, he had him tied up and sent to the Qi family's military camp, asking Old General Qi to discipline him on his behalf. It was only then that he became sworn friends with Xie Linshan in the army.

Grand Tutor Tao temporarily suppressed the complex feelings in his heart, stroked his beard, and slowly asked, "What disaster?"

"In the fifteenth year of the Qishun era, there were floods in Jiangnan. The Crown Prince went to provide disaster relief, but the Jia family obstructed him at every turn, delaying the allocation of grain and funds, which resulted in the deaths of more than half of the disaster victims. The Late Emperor was furious, but instead of pursuing the faults of the Sixteenth Prince and the Jia family, he blamed the Crown Prince for

ineffective disaster relief and ordered him to reflect behind closed doors for three months. All the officials under him were punished. The Emperor's favoritism grew more pronounced by the day, and rumors began to circulate in court that the Late Emperor intended to replace the Crown Prince with the Sixteenth Prince. The Crown Prince's honored guests were plotting for him, and I was the one who said to make the Late Emperor 'abdicate'."

Even after so many years, hearing these words still made Grand Tutor Tao's expression change. He pointed a finger at Wei Yan, wanting to say something, but in the end, he only sighed. "You... you were foolish!"

If those words had reached the Late Emperor's ears, it would have been a catastrophe for both the Crown Prince and the entire Wei clan.

But Wei Yan said, "It was not I who was foolish, but the Crown Prince who was indecisive."

His gaze was as stern as a steel blade. The aura of someone long in a high position emerged, imposing without being angry. He said coldly, "If he had the courage to fight for it back then, with the combined power of the Qi, Xie, and Wei families, how could we not have pushed him onto that dragon throne?"

Grand Tutor Tao shook his head. "You have to think from the Crown Prince's position. No matter how much the Late Emperor doted on the Sixteenth Prince, as long as he was the Crown Prince for a day, that position would eventually be his. Forcing the Late Emperor to 'abdicate'—if it failed, it would have meant losing everything."

Wei Yan asked, "And what did he get in the end by waiting?"

After speaking, he suddenly let out a cold laugh. "It was as he wished, though. A virtuous name to his credit, his fragrance to be passed down for a hundred generations!"

Grand Tutor Tao heard the resentment and ridicule in Wei Yan's words, but he sighed helplessly in his heart. When the Late Emperor was still a prince, he was weak. He married Empress Qi and relied on Old General Qi to ascend the throne.

But Old General Qi's prestige in the army was simply too high. Once he was secure on the dragon throne, the Late Emperor grew wary of the Qi family. However, the Qi family had been loyal for generations, and their sons were not profligate dandies. As an emperor, he could find no reason to

move against the Qi family, which was why he exclusively doted on the noble consort and allowed the Jia family to suppress the Qi family.

But how could those involved in the situation back then have foreseen what was to come?

A hint of worldly weariness appeared in Grand Tutor Tao's eyes. "Now that things have come to this, don't play riddles with me anymore. What exactly happened back then?"

A cold wind blew past, and the flame on the wall niche flickered. The shadow Wei Yan cast on the prison wall was towering and straight, exuding an indescribable desolation amidst its cold hardness, like a steadfast rock on a cliff.

He was silent for a long time before he spoke. "It was I who failed to recognize my master for who he was, rashly uttering words that would bring disaster. I was also short-sighted and too trusting, failing to take every precaution. Consequently, those words were passed on to the Late Emperor and the Jia family by the Crown Prince's honored guest, and I remained completely unaware."

Hearing this, Tao Taifu's heart skipped a beat. Behind Wei Yan was the entire Wei clan of Jinyang. Even if the Late Emperor had known what Wei Yan said, he would not have acted on it immediately. He would only have grown more wary and plotted in secret.

Sure enough, in the next moment, Wei Yan retorted with a cold smile, "The Wei clan of Jinyang stands behind me. How could he possibly sentence me to a crime worthy of exterminating my nine relations?"

Tao Taifu was stunned into silence.

Wei Yan enunciated each word, seemingly wrapped in immense hatred, "Naturally, by accusing me of defiling the imperial harem."

The beard on Tao Taifu's chin trembled slightly. It was unclear whether it was from suppressed anger or from finding the matter absurd, but his eyes held a mix of sorrow and complexity.

If the plan was to frame him for the grave crime of defiling the imperial harem, then at the Mid-Autumn Festival banquet in the sixteenth year of Qishun, what the emperor led the court officials to stumble upon should not have been him with an ordinary palace maid...

He feared the original design was to frame him with Shu Fei!

Tao Taifu's lips trembled, and in the end, he could only rasp, "Absurd! How absurd!"

He finally understood the source of Wei Yan's resentment toward the Crown Prince. Wei Yan had indeed misspoken, but since the temperate Crown Prince did not adopt his plan, he should have kept a firm hold on everyone who had heard those words that day. For the words to have spread from the mouth of an honored guest of the Eastern Palace was a failure of the Crown Prince's governance.

Tao Taifu had already faintly guessed the truth of what had happened back then. He asked in a hoarse voice, "Later, the fall of Jinzhou.".. was it the Late Emperor?"

Wei Yan closed his eyes and nodded. "At the time, I thought the disaster at the Mid-Autumn Palace banquet was merely because the Late Emperor held a grudge over my past with Rong Yin. I didn't yet know it was brought on by those words about 'abdication'."

"The Late Emperor suppressed the Crown Prince at every turn. The Crown Prince dared not contend with his father, so he sought to build a reputation for virtue and benevolence among the common people, widely recruiting talented men. Little did he know that this move made the Late Emperor even more wary. Seeing the Crown Prince's reputation among the people grow day by day, the Jia family devised a plan, inciting the common folk to build a living shrine for the Crown Prince."

Tao Taifu was aware of this matter. Back then, the Late Emperor had flown into a rage in the imperial court, even publicly throwing a pile of memorials at the Crown Prince, furiously demanding to know if the Crown Prince already had designs on replacing him.

This scheme by the Sixteenth Prince and Jia Guifei was truly venomous. After this incident, the Crown Prince was stripped of his authority to oversee state affairs.

The dim yellow light of the oil lamp on the prison wall shone on his sparse hair, held by a wooden pin, making it look gray and white at a glance. He sighed heavily. "With the 'abdication' remark preceding it, and the Crown Prince then gathering a virtuous reputation and recruiting talented men, even if the matter of the living shrine was instigated by the Sixteenth Prince's faction, the Late Emperor probably could no longer tolerate the Crown Prince at all. No wonder that year, the Late Emperor used this incident to heavily punish all of the Crown Prince's supporters,

forcing the Crown Prince, in his search for a way out, to volunteer to go to Jinzhou, hoping to use that military achievement to regain imperial favor."

Looking at it now, the Crown Prince's move to go to Jinzhou was like adding fuel to the fire!

After all, in the Late Emperor's eyes, this was the Crown Prince officially trying to get his hands on military power. His reputation among the people had already nearly surpassed his, the emperor's. If he were to gain prestige in the army as well... the words about "abdication" would be about to come true.

A faint mockery appeared in Wei Yan's eyes. "The Jia family was wildly ambitious. How could the Late Emperor not have known? They were merely a dog he had personally raised to balance the power of the Qi family. With the Crown Prince dead in Jinzhou, the Sixteenth Prince naturally couldn't be allowed to live either."

Tao Taifu's pupils shrank, startled by these words.

Did that mean... the Sixteenth Prince being trapped in Luocheng was also arranged by the Late Emperor?

Wei Yan looked at Tao Taifu and said, "The Late Emperor only wanted an obedient son."

Tao Taifu had already sighed countless times in the imperial prison today. It was unclear whether it was from suppressed anger or from finding the matter absurd, but his eyes held a mix of sorrow and complexity.

Since ancient times, the imperial family has always been the most heartless!

In fact, Chengde Crown Prince probably understood the emperor's intentions too well back then, which was why he had always been an obedient son.

But once the emperor's suspicion was aroused, and since he was by no means an incompetent man, it no longer mattered how obedient he was...

Tao Taifu's heart was heavy, distressingly so.

It seemed to be snowing again outside, with a few flakes drifting in from the skylight.

Wei Yan placed another piece on the Go board. "From the moment the Crown Prince went to Jinzhou and the Sixteenth Prince heeded slanderous advice and went to Luocheng, it was already a dead end."

"The Late Emperor used Rong Yin as a bargaining chip to force me back to the capital midway. The blame for the final defeat at Jinzhou could then be placed entirely on my head. With Old General Qi deceased, and Xie Linshan, who had taken over the Qi family's military power, dead, the Wei clan of Jinyang would become traitorous subjects who framed the heir apparent and defiled the imperial harem. Wouldn't they be condemned by all?"

"All that would be left is the Jia family, who had acted tyrannically for years only through his indulgence. What was there to fear? Of all the crimes the Censorate had impeached the Jia family for over the years, he could pick any one of them for severe punishment, and the Jia family's good days would be over."

Tao Taifu's face was filled with a weather-beaten look, and he could not say another word.

A snowflake was carried far by the wind, slowly drifting into the cup by Wei Yan's hand, melting in an instant.

The ripples in the water reflected his pair of cold, silent phoenix eyes. "Rong Yin's pregnancy pulse was fake. It was just a trap to lure me in and make me bear the crime of defiling the imperial harem. She set fire to Qingyuan Palace to help me escape, saying that as long as the Crown Prince was still alive and the Qi clan had not fallen, the Late Emperor would not do anything to her."

The corners of his mouth, etched with the marks of time, held a hint of bitterness. "But I didn't know at the time that the Late Emperor had already made foolproof plans for the Crown Prince to die in Jinzhou. Forcing me to return by threatening to execute her for the capital crime of adultery was the final step of the plan."

"You know what happened after that, Grand Tutor."

"I was the one who washed the imperial palace in blood. I was also the one who pinned the false reputation on Meng Shuyuan. The Late Emperor's plan was truly meticulous. After the Jinzhou incident, all the evidence pointed to me. The first to demand my death were Linshan's old subordinates."

A bitter taste filled Tao Taifu's mouth. He finally understood why Wei Yan never spoke of what happened back then. It was... indefensible.

Chengde Crown Prince and Xie Linshan died in Jinzhou. He had gone to mobilize troops but returned to the capital midway, then immediately washed the palace in blood. No one who heard this would believe Wei Yan was innocent.

Moreover... given his temperament, he would never make the reason for his return to the capital public.

In the end, it was a guilty conscience that made him walk right into the trap when the Late Emperor used Shu Fei to plot against him.

Tao Taifu's figure seemed to slump. He gazed at the snowflakes drifting slowly down from the skylight and let out a long, pained sigh. "A national tragedy..."

A single remark about "abdication" planted the seeds of disaster. The Crown Prince, being kind and gentle, did not adopt the plan, but due to his lax governance, the words reached the Late Emperor's ears, and thus the calamity began.

Looking back at the situation now, who was to blame?

Blame Wei Yan for his disastrous words? Blame the Crown Prince for his poor governance? Blame the Jia family for their venomous living shrine plot? Or blame the Late Emperor for his ruthlessness and cruelty?

In the end, it was all of these things strung together that ultimately led to the bloodbath in Jinzhou.

Later generations desperately sought the truth, but this truth... was truly devastating and bleak.

Compared to Tao Taifu's sorrow, Wei Yan's expression was as cold and hard as ever. "I am not the Crown Prince. If someone wants to kill me, I will eliminate them first."

"The Sui family has lived with their tails between their legs for so many years. I didn't touch them only because with Jinzhou breached, there was no one in the northern borderlands. An army was needed to resist the Northern Turks advancing south. In the fifteenth year of Yongping, I finally forced the Sui family to rebel. I had intended to send someone else to quell the rebellion, but the Sui family first let Xie Zheng hear rumors about the inside story of the Jinzhou bloodbath. If he had behaved himself and not

investigated the events of the past, I would have spared his life as per Wan Mei's last wish. Since he insists on investigating, I have already killed countless members of his Xie clan who investigated the past. One more would not make a difference."

Tao Taifu was so grief-stricken he didn't know what to say.

Wei Yan's eyes grew colder and sharper. "On the day of the palace coup, if he hadn't had another move up his sleeve, his blood would have long since splattered upon the Meridian Gate. Today, I have fallen into his hands. It is a matter of the victor being king and the loser being vanquished. I am willing to accept my defeat."

After speaking, he closed his eyes. Even sitting on a patch of withered grass, his solitary figure stood as majestic as a monolith.

Grand Tutor Li sat alone in silence for a while longer. He placed the final piece on the Go board between them, then rose shakily to his feet and said, "This game of Go is finally over..."

The fine snow drifting down from the skylight landed in his hair. In a daze, it seemed his head was already full of white hair.

As he reached the corner, his trembling steps paused slightly. He spoke in a hoarse voice to the young man who had been standing on this side of the wall all along, "You heard everything?"

It was freezing cold. Icicles hung from the eaves outside the prison. In the dim, shifting light, the lone figure standing silently by the window was speechless.

The firelight from the passageway only illuminated the lower half of his pale, cold, and resolute jaw.

The past, caked in dried blood, was finally uncovered, and the truth it dragged out was just as gory.

But the young child who had been fostered in the Xie residence, often waking from bloody nightmares with startled cries, had walked all the way from a mountain of corpses and a sea of blood to become the man he was today, with a heart as hard as iron. Even the most tragic past laid bare before him could not shake the indifference in his eyes in the slightest.

The fine snow drifting in from the prison skylight had accumulated in a thin layer on the cold, green bricks in the corner. A cold wind blew through the passageway. The not-so-thick brocade robe outlined the young man's

solid and upright frame. No longer thin and frail, he could now hold up the heavens and the earth.

"Thank you, Teacher." His voice was cold, deep, and hoarse.

After bowing to Tao Taifu, Xie Zheng lifted his foot and walked toward the prison exit, step by step, neither rushed nor slow, but steady and firm.

Tao Taifu watched his cold and solitary back, then looked back in the direction of Wei Yan's cell, his eyes filled with desolation. He sighed again.

That old fellow, he had clearly said those last words on purpose.

For seventeen years, he had used himself as a whetstone to finally forge this sharpest blade of the Great Yin dynasty.

Time flew, heroes became history. The Jinzhou case, stained with so much blood, now seemed to be nothing more than a game of Go from the Qishun era. Generals, court officials, emperors, princes... everyone back then was a piece on this board, each scheming for their own ends, fighting until the mountains and rivers were left in ruins.

The last time Tao Taifu had felt such overwhelming sorrow was when he was supervising a battle on the front lines and his wife and children were brutally killed by the blades of a foreign tribe. Today, more than a decade later, the sorrow in his heart was even greater.

He walked slowly toward the prison exit with faltering steps. At the stone window by the corner, he saw a girl as radiant as the sun flip off her horse. With a beaming smile, she stopped and said something to the young man who was walking out of the prison, cloaked in a desolate air. The frost covering the young man's body seemed to slowly melt away. He took the reins from the girl's hand, and the two of them walked away side by side in the swirling snow.

A gentle smile finally surfaced in Tao Taifu's sorrowful eyes.

Thankfully, that blade had found its sheath.

Chapter 164

In the late winter of the eighteenth year of Yongping, Yu Bao'er was officially recorded in the imperial registry, with her mother naming her Yu.

That same spring, the seven-and-a-half-year-old Qi Yu ascended the throne, changing the era name to Yongxing. Wu'an Marquis Xie Zheng became the Prince Regent, assisting in governance.

General of the Cloud Banner Fan Changyu and General of the Western Pacification Tang Peiyi, among others, were rewarded for their merits in quelling the rebellion, each promoted another rank. General of the Cloud Banner Fan Changyu was appointed General of Huaihua and granted the title of First-Rank Guardian of the Nation. Tang Peiyi was enfeoffed as the Earl of Xuanguo, He Xiujun was appointed Military Governor of Jiannan, and Zheng Wenchang was made Commandant of the Upper Prefecture.

The factions of Li and Wei, who had forced their way into the palace during the New Year, were also formally charged.

However, Grand Tutor Li was a great Confucian scholar of the realm, with an extremely high reputation and disciples spread throughout the court and beyond. Many scholars were outraged by his death on the night of the palace siege, believing the Li family must have suffered some unjust grievance. They openly composed poetry and essays subtly mocking Xie Zheng, claiming that his support of the young emperor was merely a ploy to become the next Wei Yan. They lamented that the Li family, devoted to the nation and its people, had met such a tragic end, crying that the Great Yin Dynasty had no future!

When these voices reached Xie Zheng, he remained unmoved. He simply ordered the Ministry of Revenue to report the full inventory of the Li and Wei families' assets—seized after two months of meticulous accounting—during the morning court session.

The self-proclaimed "pure and upright" Li family was found to possess over a million taels of silver, more than 4,000 gold artifacts, over 1,000 jade pieces, more than 2,000 antiques and paintings, tens of thousands of bolts of fine silk, and over a thousand shops, estates, and a million acres of

private farmland—surpassing even the wealth confiscated from the Wei Mansion.

This staggering figure left the entire court in shock. Grand Tutor Li's disciples dared not utter another word, their faces burning with shame during the morning court, wishing they could vanish into the ground.

Though some skepticism lingered among the populace, the silver was indisputably funneled into the national treasury. The Great Yin treasury had been severely depleted by the campaigns to reclaim Jinzhou and the eleven prefectures of Liaodong, as well as the suppression of the Chongzhou rebellion. With this infusion of funds, the court regained some financial flexibility.

To mark the new emperor's ascension, a general amnesty was declared, and annual taxes were reduced for the people. Additionally, at the suggestion of General Fan Changyu of Huaihua, the Great Yin Law was revised to include provisions allowing all children to inherit family property and orphaned women to establish independent households, among other clauses.

During Wei Yan's trial, an extraordinary crime from ages past came to light. The fall of Jinzhou had not been due to General Meng Shuyuan's failure in transporting provisions, but rather because the Sixteenth Prince had been trapped in Luocheng. The old emperor, in his folly, had ordered Meng Shuyuan to rescue the prince, entrusting the critical task of grain transport to Changxin Wang of Chongzhou. Yet Chongzhou never dispatched troops, standing by as Jinzhou fell. Later, when foreign tribes advanced south, Changxin Wang intercepted them with his forces. The court, unwilling to hold him accountable at the time, shifted the blame entirely onto Meng Shuyuan to placate the public.

This truth was eighty percent fact, twenty percent concealment.

Wei Yan was not implicated in the Jinzhou case because he, too, had been one of the old emperor's intended victims in that scheme. To involve him would inevitably drag Shu Fei into the narrative. For this innocent woman caught in the tides of fate, Wei Yan refused to let her name be tarnished in history, and Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng ensured she left no mark in the records. After all, the true culprits of the Jinzhou tragedy were the old emperor and Changxin Wang.

Yet the crimes Wei Yan had committed over the years to consolidate his power were undeniable facts, and he was sentenced to execution in

autumn.

After eighteen years of wrongful accusation, the old general was finally exonerated. The young emperor, moved by Old General Meng's loyalty and righteousness and saddened by his unjust suffering, posthumously honored him as the Duke of Loyalty, granting him a place in the Imperial Ancestral Temple.

The world sighed in regret, filled with remorse for having vilified Old General Meng for over a decade. It was said that on the day the imperial proclamation was announced, many wept for him and spontaneously offered incense in mourning.

Only then did the common people learn that Fan Changyu, the Huaihua Grand General, was actually Old General Meng's granddaughter. The tale of how she had enlisted in the army with a butcher's knife in hand and risen step by step as a heroine to clear her grandfather's name spread from the military camps to the populace, becoming a celebrated legend.

In the teahouses and taverns, no matter when one entered, they would inevitably hear the storyteller slam his wooden block and cry out in a dramatic voice:

"Now let us speak of the Lin'an maiden of the Fan family—her parents met untimely deaths, her younger sister was kidnapped, and her husband was conscripted into the army. Bitter! Tragic! Yet with a butcher's knife in hand, she vanquished bandits, beheaded scouts, and slew enemy generals..."

The wooden block clapped sharply as the storyteller's fervor rose, while the audience listened with rapt attention, their expressions tense as if they were witnessing the events themselves.

Before this fervor could fade, another major event occurred in the capital. The Prince Regent, the sole heir of the martial-noble Xie family and now the most powerful man in court, requested an imperial decree from the young emperor to marry the Huaihua Grand General, Fan Changyu.

Had the Prince Regent sought to marry any other woman, the people might have gossiped, but since it was the Huaihua Grand General, they unanimously praised it as a match made in heaven.

Even the noble ladies of the capital dabbed their tears with handkerchiefs, declaring that only if it were the Huaihua Grand General marrying the Prince Regent would they concede willingly.

This was a hero matched with a hero—though both were also "beauties."

Of course, some busybodies from who-knows-where spread rumors that when the Prince Regent had returned to the capital after quelling the rebellion and was being honored, he had plucked General Fan's hair ribbon from among the countless silk handkerchiefs thrown at him during his parade and calmly tucked it into his robes without batting an eye. Thus, his request for the imperial decree must have been premeditated long ago.

But the entire court knew that the Huaihua Grand General had once been married.

Back when Qi Sheng was on the throne, she had even openly admitted in the throne hall that she had joined the army by accident while searching for her husband. Veterans from Yan, Jizhou, and Chongzhou even swore on their lives that it was all true—when they had been trapped in First Line Gorge, the Huaihua Grand General had charged up the mountain with Jizhou's reinforcements to find her husband.

From the court to the common folk, discussions about the impending marriage between Xie and Fan reached a fever pitch.

Everyone agreed that the Huaihua Grand General had cherished her late husband deeply, and that the Prince Regent, as the newcomer, could hardly compare to the former.

But since men in this world could take multiple wives and concubines, wasn't it only natural for a heroine like the Huaihua Grand General, after losing her humble first husband, to gain a perfect match like the Prince Regent?

Some men even sighed for Changyu's "ill-fated" first husband, saying that if he had lived, he would now be basking in wealth and glory. But since he had died young, it only proved he lacked the fortune to bear such immense blessings.

Still, everyone tacitly believed that in the Huaihua Grand General's heart, the "humble first husband" held more weight than the Prince Regent—after all, they had been through hardship together.

If that first husband were still alive, would the Huaihua Grand General ever have agreed to marry the Prince Regent?

Xie Zheng, who had remained unruffled even when scholars across the land composed satirical verses claiming the Li family had been wronged,

turned ashen upon hearing these folk rumors. After receiving hints from Xie Wu and Xie Qi, Xie Shiyi shrewdly began spreading the word that their prince was indeed the "humble husband" of the great general.

This revelation unsurprisingly caused another uproar.

However, it was soon discovered that Xie family guards were daily distributing silver to beggars in alleyways to spread this tale. The public's mood grew subtly amused, unanimously concluding: The Prince Regent must be utterly smitten with General Huaihua, even eagerly claiming the title of a lowly live-in son-in-law!

Rumor had it an aspiring scholar, unable to secure an official post, cleverly wrote an opera titled *The Female General* about General Huaihua and the Prince Regent to curry favor.

When performed by capital troupes, the opera drew thunderous applause. Onstage, the warrior actress with bold eyebrows, pheasant plumes, and battle flags belted out: "To rescue my husband I left home, never thought I'd join the army and command..."

Upon learning of this, Fan Changyu found it both hilarious and embarrassing. She secretly booked a private box with Xie Zheng to watch a performance.

Outside their curtained booth, gongs and drums clamored as the actress's piercing voice carried every word. Each lyric seemed to resurrect memories—their first snowy encounter, the curling smoke from Fan family's hearth, him teaching her property laws, annotating classics, the vambrace gift before parting, their shared battles... Unknowingly, they'd journeyed so far from that Lin'an townlet.

She unconsciously smiled, teasing Xie Zheng: "Remember in Qingping County? You said you wanted to marry a gentle, virtuous homemaker."

"Golden crown weighs on my brow, longsword shakes heaven's vault..."

The opera reached its climax—drums frenzied, the warrior actress's voice soaring as she dramatically crossed blades with opponents, her swordplay more aesthetic than practical.

Performed nightly to packed houses, their ground-floor box overlooked the circular theater's central stage. Lanterns hung below every window, their glow like fiery trees and luminous dragons when lit.

Turning back, Changyu's half-lit profile glowed warmly against the fading lights. Beyond the open window, the actress portraying her twirled with battle flags and sword—a frozen tableau that struck Xie Zheng's eyes.

Long after, he finally replied: "Mm. But after meeting you, I knew—I only wanted to marry Fan Changyu."

Perhaps it was the lantern light, but Changyu's cheeks suddenly flushed crimson.

As the crowd dispersed post-performance, they waited until nearly everyone had left to avoid recognition and complications.

The moon hung above the willow branches as the two walked side by side on the quiet, chilly street, neither on horseback nor in a sedan chair. The moonlight stretched one's shadow long, and occasionally their shadows intertwined, as if merging into one.

Xie Zheng then firmly took Fan Changyu's hand and never let go.

He said, "There's a golden temple in the city, said to be very efficacious with thriving incense. Would you like to visit?"

It was just past the hour of Xu, still too early to return home, so Fan Changyu nodded.

When they arrived at the temple gate and saw the closed doors along with the notice posted beside it—"No visitors admitted after the hour of You"—both fell silent.

Fan Changyu turned to Xie Zheng. "The temple is closed today. Should we come back another time?"

But Xie Zheng lifted his gaze to the temple's wall, over ten feet high.

Moments later, two agile figures leaped over the temple wall like panthers.

Even after her feet landed on the green bricks inside the temple, Fan Changyu was still a bit dazed.

After walking a short distance with Xie Zheng, she finally remembered why she was puzzled and asked, "We sneaked in over the wall in the middle of the night just to pray to a Bodhisattva?"

Xie Zheng was momentarily taken aback by the question. For the first time, he avoided Fan Changyu's gaze, turning his face away with a light

cough. "The most famous thing in this temple is the Bodhi tree. It's said that all the high-ranking officials and nobles in the capital come here to make wishes and hang wooden tablets."

His finely chiseled jawline tensed slightly under the cold moonlight, as if that could conceal the heavy, erratic beating of his heart, while an inexplicable dampness formed in his palms.

Though called a Bodhi tree, it was practically known throughout the capital as the "Tree of Matrimony," frequented by young men and women praying for love.

Fan Changyu seemed unaware of this. After a brief pause, she smiled and said, "Alright. Given our current status, if we came openly to hang a tablet, who knows what rumors would spread. Might as well sneak in tonight to hang one."

Perhaps her smile under the moonlight was too dazzling, too radiant. Xie Zheng turned his head and quietly watched her for two breaths before withdrawing his deep gaze and leading her onward.

The tree, adorned with red silk ribbons and wooden tablets, stood in the courtyard of the temple's main hall. They found it easily. The wooden tablets and writing tools for wishes were prepared in a side hall nearby, far from the monks' quarters. After entering, Xie Zheng left a large ingot as an offering, then took two wooden tablets and writing tools.

He finished writing quickly and stood aside, waiting for Fan Changyu.

Fan Changyu, however, clutched the brush, deep in thought for a long time. Drawing on all her knowledge, she finally came up with eleven characters.

Afraid Xie Zheng might peek, she shielded her writing with her hand the entire time.

The wooden tablet wasn't large, and her handwriting was bold. She squeezed and squeezed, and though the characters ended up crooked, she managed to fit them all in.

When she finally exhaled and lifted the brush, Xie Zheng chuckled. "What did you write that took so long?"

Fan Changyu turned the tablet away from him, guarding it tightly, the tips of her ears slightly red. Yet she maintained a serious tone. "If you say a wish out loud, it won't come true. Let's just hang it up."

With that, she clasped the tablet between her palms, closed her eyes, and silently murmured something. Then, with a sudden swing of her arm... she flung the tablet to the very top of the towering Bodhi tree.

Others lacked such strength, so most tablets ended up hanging on the middle or lower branches.

Fan Changyu was extremely satisfied with the height. She clapped her hands and turned to Xie Zheng, asking, "What about yours?"

Xie Zheng glanced at the wishing plaque Fan Changyu had tossed and, with an unchanged expression, raised his arm to throw his own. His plaque landed near hers.

Fan Changyu laughed. "Were you also afraid of throwing it too low and letting others see?"

Xie Zheng tilted his head slightly to look at her, his face as cold as jade, his dark eyes deep and unfathomable. "Your plaque looked too lonely up there all by itself. I threw mine up to keep it company."

Fan Changyu was momentarily stunned. Gazing at his refined features bathed in moonlight, she felt her heart race like a startled deer, thumping wildly—even after all this time together.

Though Fan Changyu had been appointed as a general, her official residence was still under construction, so she continued to stay temporarily at the Office of Presentations.

That night, after Xie Zheng escorted her back, he swiftly rode back to the temple. Scaling the wall once more, he climbed to the top of the bodhi tree and retrieved the wishing plaque Fan Changyu had thrown up there.

On the brand-new plaque, the clumsily written ink strokes clearly read: "Morning and night, year after year, I wish to spend them with you."

Xie Shiyi stood guard at the base of the wall, keeping watch for his master. He had no idea what had come over Xie Zheng, but suddenly, his master burst into laughter from the treetop—a laugh so joyous that Xie Shiyi, having served him for so many years, had never heard anything like it.

The laughter not only startled a flock of sparrows but also alarmed the temple's martial monks.

The monks, treating it as a grave threat, searched the area but found no one. Upon entering the main hall, they discovered the ingot Xie Zheng had left earlier. Assuming someone had sneaked in late at night just to offer incense and prayers, they finally relaxed.

The abbot, also disturbed by the commotion, noticed the disturbed ink brush and the missing wishing plaque. Fingering his prayer beads and pressing his palms together in a Buddhist gesture, his deeply wrinkled face broke into a serene, time-worn smile. "The Buddha is merciful. May all lovers in this world be united in the end."

To allow enough time for the six rites of marriage, Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng set their wedding date for the following year.

Before that, she wanted to relocate her parents' graves—hastily buried on a wild slope in Jizhou—back to the Meng family cemetery. With the help of officials from the Imperial Astronomical Bureau, an auspicious date was chosen for the relocation: the ninth month of that year.

When returning to Jizhou, she also requested an imperial plaque inscribed with "Loyalty and Righteousness" from the young emperor in honor of Head Constable Wang and his wife, who had died protecting the people of Qingping County from bandits. She presented the plaque to their daughter, who had married into a neighboring county, and later repaired their graves upon returning home.

When Aunt Zhao heard about it, she wept, recalling the honest and loyal couple. Holding Fan Changyu's hand, she reassured her that with the imperial plaque, even without her parents, Head Constable Wang's daughter would never be mistreated by her in-laws.

In the same month, the remnants of the Li and Wei factions faced their fates—some executed, others exiled.

On the day of the executions, Xie Zheng went alone to see Wei Yan one last time. No one knew what passed between uncle and nephew.

Wei Yan's body was taken away by Qi Xingzhou, the adopted son of Old General Qi and Military Governor of Lingnan. Xie Zheng never showed himself throughout the process, only watching from afar at Shili Slope on the outskirts of the capital as Qi Xingzhou carried Wei Yan's coffin away.

Fan Changyu rushed to Shili Slope upon receiving the news to find Xie Zheng, but by the time she arrived, Qi Xingzhou's carriage had almost disappeared at the end of the official road.

Xie Zheng's expression was unreadable as he said, "Eighteen years ago, he entrusted his own remains to Qi Xingzhou."

"Shu Fei is buried in Lingnan. He must go there too."

...

...

First month of Yongxing Year.

The Prince Regent took a bride, and the Grand General of Huaihua married down. The peach blossoms of early spring stretched for miles, yet still could not match the length of the bridal procession for the Grand General of Huaihua.

Knowing the Grand General had no family left, the common folk spontaneously gathered to send her off. Even people from the surrounding prefectures near the capital came to witness the ceremony, forming a massive procession that extended all the way beyond the city walls.

The long street welcoming the bridal party was carpeted with bright red firecracker remnants and dazzling peach blossom petals. The bustling crowd lining the streets, all beaming with joy, cheered for the "Grand General of Huaihua" and the "Prince Regent," just as they had once welcomed the triumphant army. Some still habitually called Xie Zheng the "Wu'an Marquis." Every sight and sound was filled with nothing but the most heartfelt blessings.

Under the arrangements of the imperial merchant Zhao Xun, the city's taverns and teahouses set up endless feasts, offering free banquets to celebrate the grand wedding of the Grand General and the Prince Regent.

It was no exaggeration to say that even the beggars in the city cleaned themselves up that day, squeezing into the crowd to offer their congratulations.

Fan Changyu had no elder brother, so He Xiujun escorted her as the bridal companion. Riding on horseback and witnessing such grandeur, He Xiujun felt deeply moved and remarked to Zheng Wenchang, who accompanied them, "I dare say even the emperor's future wedding procession won't surpass today's spectacle."

The sincere joy and blessings of the entire Great Yin populace were something no mere power could orchestrate.

Zheng Wenchang replied, "How many peerless heroes like Grand General Fan could this world possibly produce?"

He Xiujun chuckled. "True, my sworn sister is no ordinary woman. The Prince Regent is marrying a grand general."

As he spoke, he glanced at the groom riding at the forefront.

Xie Zheng was clad in crimson wedding robes, his jet-black hair tied up with a golden crown, making him appear even more radiantly handsome. The perpetual frost in his eyes had melted away, and though he remained solemn, the faint joy in his gaze was unmistakable.

The clip-clop of hooves blended with the sounds of gongs, drums, firecrackers, and the cheers of the crowd as the bridal sedan, carried by sixteen bearers, arrived at the gates of the Xie residence.

Fan Changyu held one end of the red silk ribbon and was helped out of the sedan by the matchmaker. The bridal veil obscured her vision, so she couldn't see the scene around her, but she could hear the cheers of the guests.

Though her sight was blocked, her steps remained steady and sure.

Knowing that the person holding the other end of the red silk ribbon was him, Fan Changyu felt not a trace of fear. From the moment she woke up drunk in Lucheng that year, when he had reddened eyes and told her he regretted everything, and she promised to walk the road ahead with him, she had never again considered leaving him to tread the path alone.

Henceforth, whether it be mountains of blades, seas of fire, or quagmires, she would stand shoulder to shoulder with him.

In the wedding hall, Grand Tutor Tao, as Fan Changyu's adoptive father, sat in the place of honor, smiling benevolently at the newlyweds. Behind him were the ancestral tablets of her parents.

Aunt Zhao and her husband brought Changning, while Yu Qianqian accompanied the now-renamed Emperor Qi Yu (formerly Yu Bao'er) and the other guests, all watching the ceremony with joyful smiles.

The master of ceremonies proclaimed, "First bow to heaven and earth—"

Unlike the previous sham marriage when Xie Zheng had hastily bowed to heaven and earth in a daze, all the guests clearly witnessed the usually cold and stern Prince Regent wearing a faint smile at the corners of his

lips. There was even a trace of tenderness hidden in his eyes as he gazed at the bride, as if he had been anticipating this wedding for a very, very long time...

"First bow to the elders—"

Grand Tutor Tao's smile deepened the wrinkles at his eyes as he stroked his beard and nodded, accepting the couple's bow. The old man, who had weathered countless storms in his long life, actually found his eyes growing slightly red at this moment.

Aunt Zhao and Carpenter Zhao stood to the side, one hand holding Changning's, the other constantly wiping their tear-filled eyes, having long since cried themselves into a mess—though these were tears of joy.

And in the hearts of the newlyweds, this moment was also a sincere wish for their departed parents to know: they were married.

"Bow to each other—"

Just like in those years past, as Fan Changyu lowered her head in the bow, a sudden gust of wind from nowhere lifted the corner of her red bridal veil. The bride, adorned in lavish makeup by the palace matrons, curved her crimson lips in a smile. A single glance from her glistening almond eyes, brimming with joy, could intoxicate the very mountains and rivers.

The guests erupted in cheers, but just as the veil threatened to be blown away entirely, a slender, elegant hand reached out to press it back into place. Before the veil settled, Fan Changyu caught a glimpse of the deep, affectionate gaze of the man before her.

Her red lips curved even higher.

This lifetime—it would be him.

The officiant, too, beamed with delight.

"The ceremony is complete! Escort the couple to the bridal chamber—"

Chapter 165

Extra Story One

The world was at peace, and all endeavors were being revived.

With Wei Yan and Grand Tutor Li overthrown, the court had Xie Zheng to lead the military, but the civil officials lacked a pillar to shoulder the responsibilities. Grand Tutor Tao had no choice but to temporarily return to court and resume his duties, waiting until a capable successor emerged before resigning to resume his carefree, reclusive life.

Gongsun Yin, renowned as the "Wise Man of Hejian," also broke his clan's rule against entering officialdom and joined the Hanlin Academy, receiving the additional title of Junior Tutor to instruct the young emperor.

The factions of Li and Wei in the court naturally could not escape long-overdue punishment—some were demoted, others imprisoned. With the Prince Regent's backing, the young emperor was brimming with confidence. In less than a year since his ascension, he had reshuffled the entire court.

Many positions were left vacant, and to fill these gaps, officials who had been marginalized and transferred out of the capital years ago for refusing to take sides were finally given important roles. Those with mediocre achievements but clean records and seniority were temporarily promoted to replace those transferred to regional posts.

However, this wave of promotions left vacancies in local government offices that still needed to be filled. That year, in addition to the regular imperial exam, the young emperor also held an additional special exam. As a result, from the beginning of the year, candidates had flooded the capital like a school of fish crossing a river, filling every inn in the city to capacity.

In March, the wedding of the Prince Regent and the Huaihua General overshadowed public discussions about the imperial exam. It wasn't until the results were announced in April that debates about the exam's outcome and questions boiled over once more.

Outside the drum tower where the results were posted, the crowd was packed shoulder to shoulder that day, with joy and sorrow intermingling. Some, after a decade of arduous study, wept with happiness upon seeing their names on the list, while others, finding themselves unsuccessful, wore expressions of utter devastation.

Many wealthy merchants ordered their servants to keep watch at the street corners where the results were posted. Whenever they spotted a young, handsome, and radiant-faced scholar, they knew he must have passed. They would immediately drag him to a nearby teahouse or tavern, hoping to arrange a marriage with their daughters.

This phenomenon was jokingly referred to by the common folk as "groom-catching under the list."

A young man in a slightly worn indigo-blue robe squeezed through the crowd, scanning the posted result list from top to bottom and back again several times. Yet, he still couldn't find his name. Gradually, his face turned ashen, and his entire demeanor slumped in defeat. Dispirited, he was jostled to the outskirts of the crowd by others checking the results.

"Brother Song!" A young man standing at the street corner recognized the blue-robed scholar and enthusiastically waved at him.

The blue-robed man was none other than Song Yan. He forced a faint smile and cupped his hands in greeting. "Brother Wu."

Seeing Song Yan's expression, the young man immediately knew he had failed again and comforted him, "Brother Song, don't be disheartened. You passed the provincial exam at such a young age—already the envy of many. Ordinary people often spend decades trying to pass the imperial exams. Take my uncle, for example—he failed eleven times before finally securing an official post thanks to this year's special exam."

Brother Wu had failed the provincial exam and was still only a xiucai (scholar). Today, he was checking the results on behalf of his uncle.

At these words, Song Yan's face grew even paler, but he still managed to offer a congratulatory bow.

The young man was about the same age as Song Yan, but coming from a family with modest means and having an uncle who had failed the imperial exam eleven times before him, he took his own failure in stride. However, having been friends with Song Yan for two or three years and knowing his

circumstances, he couldn't help but ask as they walked back together, "Brother Song, what are your plans now?"

A trace of embarrassment flickered across Song Yan's face as he replied, "My mother has passed, and there are no relatives left in the clan. I'll likely stay in the capital, seeking a position as a private tutor or honored guest in some noble household—just a temporary refuge until I can take the exam again in three years."

Back in the small county of Qingping, he had been admired everywhere, even favored by the county magistrate. He had thought himself a phoenix among men. But upon arriving in the capital, he realized that the streets were filled with the illustrious and noble. A wine jar casually tossed in the pleasure quarters could hit several disheartened scholars drowning their sorrows in drink.

It truly echoed the words of Fan Changyu's son-in-law from years past: "The northern geese fly south, but phoenixes crowd the land, leaving no place to alight."

His proud scholarly achievements were utterly unremarkable in the capital of Great Yin, where golden scales—metaphors for the elite—were everywhere. The meager silver gifted by local gentry after he passed the provincial exam, along with the magistrate's subsidy for his journey to the capital, paled in comparison to the finery worn by the wealthy youths.

In his first year in the capital, Song Yan truly felt like a country chicken that had stumbled into a phoenix's nest, constantly on edge, terrified of being looked down upon. The sense of inferiority that had haunted him from adolescence to young adulthood—though it had seemed to fade after he became a provincial scholar—returned with a vengeance in the capital.

Back when he studied at the county school, he had gone to great lengths to hide the fact that his education was funded by a butcher's family, secured through a betrothal to their daughter. Later, in the capital, to mingle with renowned scholars, he had to conceal his shabby origins, forcing himself to attend various poetry gatherings to keep up appearances.

For a scholar like him, with no connections, the only path to a smoother future in the capital was to gain the favor of a high-ranking official. And the most secure bond of all was marriage. To make himself known among the capital's elite, he needed to distinguish himself in poetry circles and then earn a place on the final exam roster—only then could he hope for an

olive branch, rather than being “snatched” as a son-in-law by some mediocre merchant after the results were posted.

For a decade, he had burned the midnight oil, studying relentlessly, and schemed tirelessly to cultivate advantageous connections. He absolutely could not afford to fail in the imperial exams. But sometimes, man’s plans are no match for heaven’s will.

A few days before the exam that year, news reached the capital that Qingping County had been raided by bandits. Learning that his mother and the magistrate’s family had been brutally killed on the road, he was devastated. Distraught, he underperformed in the exams and ultimately failed.

After learning the circumstances, the friends he had made in the capital expressed sympathy, believing he would have passed if not for the tragedy. They were certain he would succeed if he tried again in three years.

Yet this year, he failed once more.

Just thinking about facing those friends who had supported him for the past two or three years made Song Yan’s face burn with shame.

Back then, he could blame his mother’s death. But what excuse did he have for this year’s failure?

Of course he knew what had unsettled him during the examination—the grand wedding between the Prince Regent and General Huaihua in March. The woman he once believed would hinder his career had now become someone he could only yearn for from afar. Even the Prince Regent didn’t mind her previous marriage and had sought imperial permission to wed her.

His withdrawal from the betrothal back then had truly become a colossal joke.

But who could have foreseen what would happen later?

He simply didn’t want to endure hardship anymore, didn’t want his mother to grovel and fawn over others. He wanted to achieve greatness.

He still remembered their childhood friendship. But precisely because he remembered, every time he saw Fan Changyu’s radiant smile, he was reminded of his mother’s subservience—how she had to praise that couple as if they were Bodhisattvas incarnate just for a bowl of food from the Fan family’s charity.

And then there were the whispers behind his back—how the Song family might call themselves scholars, but they only managed to keep food on the table thanks to the Fan butcher's family. Why bother with books? Might as well marry into the Fan family.

Those veiled taunts and sneers had stayed with Song Yan for years. But he could say nothing. Sometimes, he even hated the Fan family.

Hated their hypocritical charity, how it had trapped him and his mother in an inescapable debt of so-called kindness.

Why did the Fan family help him? Wasn't it just a gamble that he might amount to something one day? It was nothing but false benevolence!

When Fan Changyu said she was willing to dissolve their engagement, did she not realize that doing so would brand him as ungrateful? How could he possibly agree to it?

Later, when the Fan couple died and the Changyu sisters were driven to the brink of losing even their home, he had felt a dark, secret satisfaction.

All his life, he had been the one looking up to her, pandering to her. When she was backed into a corner with no way out, would she finally shed that pride and stubbornness and come begging to him?

He had waited. But in the end, all he got was news of her taking in a husband...

Her spine, it seemed, would rather snap straight than bend to him even once.

It was April, and a spring rain had just passed.

Lost in these bitter memories, Song Yan didn't notice the carriage on the street until the young man beside him yanked him aside, barely avoiding a collision.

Even so, the carriage splattered mud all over his robes. The driver, seeing his tattered clothes and lack of the triumphant air of a successful examinee, dismissed him as a poor scholar and spat viciously. "Are you blind?"

"Hey! Watch your tongue!" His companion bristled in his defense, but Song Yan, noting the carriage's opulence, stopped him. "It's probably someone influential. Best not to stir trouble. Let it go."

His friend reluctantly relented. Seeing Song Yan so dejected, he thought for a moment and said, "Brother Song, since you mentioned wanting to work as a private tutor or honored guest for an official's family, I might have a lead. My uncle has been teaching a young girl at the Office of Presentations this past year. Now that he's passed the imperial exams, he'll have to resign. If you're willing, I can ask him to recommend you. Teaching a child won't take much effort, and you'd have time to study for the next exam in three years."

Becoming a tutor or advisor for a high-ranking family sounded simple, but connections were essential—and those required no small amount of silver to secure.

Song Yan's ashen face, which had been devoid of color for half the day, finally showed a hint of joy at this moment. He stopped in his tracks and bowed deeply to the young man: "Brother Wu, your great kindness is something Song Yan... will never forget."

The young man laughed heartily: "With the friendship between us, Brother Song, there's no need for such formalities. My uncle initially wanted me to go, but as a mere scholar, how could I dare step through those gates? It's better to wait until my uncle takes up his post in the prefecture, and I can follow to broaden my horizons. It's only because Brother Song truly has the knowledge that I dared to mention this to you."

Once this matter was settled, three days later, Song Yan went to the Office of Presentations as agreed.

Before he could formally replace the young man's uncle as the private tutor, the official's family naturally had to meet him first and assess his knowledge. Only if they approved would he be allowed to stay.

Song Yan was quite confident about this.

The young man's uncle was a man nearing fifty named Wu Guangkun—stubborn in character and even more rigid in his learning. He had managed to pass the provincial examination solely by rote memorization of past exam questions and numerous flowery essays. After attempting the exams for several years, he finally got lucky.

Later, when sitting for the metropolitan examination, he tried to replicate his previous method, but unfortunately, he never managed to guess the questions correctly again. Fortunately, he encountered an extra examination and finally secured an official position.

Song Yan believed his own knowledge far surpassed Wu Guangkun's.

However, he didn't know who the influential figure was. Wu Guangkun had been rather cryptic about it, saying only that Song Yan would learn the person's identity once he was formally hired.

Having spent years trying to forge connections with the powerful, Song Yan immediately recognized this as an opportunity to climb high.

For today's meeting, he had gone all out, spending his limited silver to have a new dark green robe tailored, all to leave a good impression on the noble.

When Wu Guangkun entered the room to introduce him, Song Yan waited outside, his nervousness no less intense than when he had gone to check the spring examination results a few days prior.

At his age, if he couldn't find a path forward in the capital, the hope of marrying a noblewoman to smooth his future career would become nothing but a distant dream.

Step by step, he had left the small town of Lin'an behind, witnessed the splendor of the capital, and yet his ambitions remained unfulfilled. He was unwilling to return to that backwater.

After waiting anxiously for a while, he was finally summoned inside. Not daring to look around, Song Yan entered with his head bowed and performed a proper bow, his wide green sleeves falling gracefully from his wrists, exuding the demeanor of a Wei-Jin scholar. He tried his best to appear neither servile nor overbearing as he said, "This humble scholar, Song Yan, greets my lord."

For a moment, no one in the room spoke.

Song Yan remained in his bowing posture, but his heart was practically in his throat.

Even the one who had introduced him sensed something amiss. Wu Guangkun stole a glance at the person seated above, worried that they might find Song Yan too young and doubt his knowledge. After all, since he was the one who had recommended Song Yan, if the noble took a dislike to him, it might reflect poorly on himself. So Wu Guangkun spoke up for Song Yan: "Though young, Scholar Song is a provincial graduate—"

"I know," came a crisp, clear voice from above, like the ringing of jade.

Hearing this voice, Song Yan couldn't help but look up. When he saw the heroic female general seated above—dressed in silver-red soft armor, draped in a tea-white brocade robe, with one arm bared in the armor's civil and military sleeves—his face turned as pale as paper.

"Song Yan." Fan Changyu uttered the name calmly, her sharp gaze now tempered to conceal its edge. Her voice betrayed no emotion, yet the commanding presence of one who led thousands of troops was overwhelming even as she simply sat there.

Song Yan managed to meet Fan Changyu's eyes for only a moment before lowering his head in shame. A flood of humiliation washed over him as he bowed deeply once more, his posture as deferential as possible. "This lowly one... Song Yan pays his respects... to the Grand General."

Chapter 166

Extra Story Two

Late spring was often rainy. The wet marks from the night's rain had yet to dry on the courtyard's green bricks. The plants in the flowerbeds, however, were an alluring verdant green after the downpour, and the water droplets on the tips of their leaves refracted a faint golden light in the early sun.

The room's doors were wide open, and a set of bamboo-slat blinds of varying lengths hung under the eaves, letting slivers of morning light into the room.

Song Yan still maintained his posture of a deep bow, the back of his bamboo-green scholar's robe already soaked through with cold sweat.

Amidst the curling fragrance of tea, the floral clusters embroidered with fine, dark silver thread on Fan Changyu's slanted, tea-white brocade robe became indistinct. She lowered her eyes to the cup, which held a few floating brownish-green tea leaves, and took a shallow sip, her expression unreadable.

Wu Guangkun looked at Song Yan, then at Fan Changyu, and his heart screamed that this was not good. He could only force a smile to break the deadlock. "This... Are the Great General and Juren Song old acquaintances?"

Fan Changyu's expression was cold as she said with ambiguous meaning, "This general is not worthy of being called Juren Song's 'old acquaintance.'"

The moment these words were spoken, Wu Guangkun couldn't help but break out in a cold sweat. Song Yan's body stiffened for a breath, then, like a snapped bamboo stalk, he lifted his robes and knelt. When he spoke, it was hard to tell if his voice held more bitterness or more shame. "This Song will never forget the great kindness of the Great General's family. My actions back then..."

Fan Changyu cut him off. "According to the laws of this dynasty, those who hold scholarly titles may see an official without kneeling."

Her gaze swept to her sides. "Help Juren Song up."

Xie Wu, who was waiting nearby, stepped forward and hauled Song Yan up with a single hand. Song Yan's body was suddenly thrown off balance, and he staggered a step before steadying himself. He exuded an air of indescribable discomposure, completely devoid of the feigned calm and composure he had before entering the room.

Wu Guangkun looked embarrassed. He wanted to speak up and plead for him, but he didn't know what kind of grudge existed between Song Yan and the Great General of Huaihua. In the end, he didn't dare to speak rashly again, his small eyes revealing a hint of bewilderment.

Fan Changyu looked at Song Yan. "The money for my father's coffin and your tuition fee has been repaid by you, Juren Song. The Fan and Song families are thus even. There is no 'great kindness' as you claim."

Song Yan stared fixedly at Fan Changyu, who sat in the seat of honor. His eyes, weathered by years of hardship, churned with complex emotions. After a long while, he managed to force out a single word: "Yes."

Even Xie Wu, standing to the side, couldn't help but frown. He didn't know the details of what had happened back in Qingping County, but he felt that the way this failed juren was looking at his Great General was not quite right.

Fan Changyu said, "I am looking for a private tutor to begin Ning Niang's education. You should know that it's impossible for me to hire you."

Wu Guangkun and Xie Wu were both utterly confused by this, but Song Yan once again managed to force out a single "Yes."

"In that case, please leave." Fan Changyu set down her teacup. "Xiao Wu, see them out for me."

Xie Wu immediately made a "please" gesture toward Wu Guangkun and Song Yan.

Wu Guangkun was filled with regret. Fearing he had also offended the noble personage because of Song Yan, he wanted to say something to remedy the situation. But looking at Fan Changyu's completely cold face and Xie Wu's hand gesturing toward the door, he didn't dare to act

presumptuously. He could only wear a fawning yet stiff smile as he was escorted out.

Just as they neared the door, a young girl with her hair in two buns came pattering over from the other end of the corridor. A tall, handsome guard followed behind her. Before she even entered, her loud, milky voice could be heard. "Big Sis! I've finished packing everything in my room!"

Coming face to face with Wu Guangkun and Song Yan, the girl's grin, which had stretched to her ears, receded slightly. She clutched the hem of her dress with her chubby hands and addressed Wu Guangkun somewhat reservedly, "Tutor."

Wu Guangkun felt as if he had seen his savior and immediately replied amiably, "It's Ning Niang..."

Unexpectedly, Changning's gaze fell upon Song Yan walking behind him. Her small, jade-white face immediately fell. Her chubby little hands clenched into pink fists at her sides, and her large, dark, grape-like eyes filled with hostility as she said loudly, "Bad person!"

With that, like a little calf, she huffed and puffed her way to Fan Changyu's side, burying her face in her lap and only glaring at Song Yan from the corner of her eye.

Song Yan's face had turned another shade paler. Xie Wu also sensed something was amiss and secretly glanced at Fan Changyu.

But Fan Changyu only stroked Changning's hair and said, "A child's words are spoken without malice. Xiao Wu, continue to see our guests out."

Xie Wu then led Song Yan and Wu Guangkun out.

Changning's dimpled fingers picked at the lacquered gold pattern on Fan Changyu's leather belt, her lips pouted in displeasure. "Big Sis, what's that bad person doing here?"

When the Song family came to break off the engagement, Changning was over five years old and old enough to remember things. Even though two or three years had passed in a flash, she still clearly remembered the bad people who had bullied her and her Big Sis.

Fan Changyu said, "A person's life is but a hundred years. Fortune's wheel is ever-turning. He failed the imperial examinations and wanted to become your tutor to make a living."

Changning immediately refused. "Ning Niang doesn't want him to teach me!"

Her fair cheeks, tinged with pink, puffed out in anger, and a tuft of hair on top of her head stood up, showing the intensity of her rejection.

Fan Changyu chuckled. "Didn't I send him away?"

Only then was Changning pleased. She tugged on a corner of Fan Changyu's hem and said, "Big Sis is a Great General now, why didn't you have him beaten with a plank?"

Fan Changyu's expression grew a little more serious. She said to Changning earnestly, "Ning Niang, Big Sis is a Great General, but this authority is for protecting the peace of the Great Yin's people, not for carrying out personal vendettas. Do you understand? Song Yan has a poor character, but our grudge with him was settled long ago. He has done nothing wrong now. If Big Sis were to use her position to make things difficult for him because she resents the past, then the one at fault would be Big Sis."

Changning lowered her head and nodded. "Ning Niang will remember."

Fan Changyu said meaningfully, "Everyone chooses their own path. Since we are on a smooth, wide road, there's no need to stray onto a crooked path for the sake of some petty people. This sea of officialdom is full of treacherous currents and hidden reefs. The slightest misstep can lead to eternal damnation. Even if Song Yan manages to squeeze into this sea, there will be plenty of pitfalls waiting for him. We don't need to step on him and add to our own karma."

Changning nodded even more forcefully.

Only then did Fan Changyu ask, "Have you finished packing the things in your room?"

She had just married Xie Zheng last month. Since she had no parents, her maternal grandfather was a loyal minister who had been wronged by the court for over a decade, and her only adoptive father was a noble old official of modest means, there was no one to handle her wedding arrangements. Yu Qianqian had taken it upon herself to organize everything. The dowry had been allocated from the state treasury after discussions with the court officials.

Fan Changyu had lived in the Office of Presentations for nearly two years, and some of the things she had acquired had not yet been moved.

To make it convenient to care for Changning in the future, her Great General's manor had been built right next to the Xie residence. After more than a year, the manor was finally completed. The inner courtyard wall was connected to the Xie residence, almost merging the two manors into one.

She had come over today for two reasons: one was to move the rest of her things from the wedding, and the other was to meet the private tutor recommended by Wu Guangkun.

When Changning heard about it, she immediately insisted on returning to the Office of Presentations with her, declaring that she would pack the things in her own room herself.

She was still young, so hiring a private tutor with a juren degree to start her education was more than sufficient. But Fan Changyu was truly surprised that Wu Guangkun had recommended Song Yan.

"It's all packed! Ning Niang wanted to help Big Sis pack too, but Uncle Xiao Qi wouldn't let me!" Changning said, making a face at Xie Qi.

Xie Qi cupped his fist and replied, "This subordinate did not dare to rashly move some of the books and personal belongings in the General's room."

At Fan Changyu's position, only her trusted aides could handle her letters and documents with her permission. Other servants would not dare to touch those things at all.

Fan Changyu understood Xie Qi's concerns and said, "There's nothing important in the room. Take the books back and put them in the study at the Xie residence. As for the personal belongings, just store them in the General's manor's storeroom for now."

She had already taken all the important documents and items from her room. What remained on the shelves were just some military strategy books, history books, and policy essays she used to read. When Xie Zheng learned she was moving everything over, he had specially cleared out half of the study for her. She would be consulting these books often in the future, so it was better to put them all in the study to save the trouble of looking for them later.

With Fan Changyu's instructions, Xie Qi personally went to pack up the books and personal belongings.

After passing through a decorated gateway, Xie Wu was about to lead Song Yan and Wu Guangkun out of the residence when he saw a group of people descending the steps at the main gate. The man in the lead wore a gold coronet and the python-patterned robe of the Prince Regent. His figure was tall and straight, and the cold, solemn majesty that emanated from his very bones overshadowed his handsome features, striking fear into one's heart with a single glance.

Xie Wu hurriedly led Song Yan and Wu Guangkun to stand at the side of the narrow path, heads bowed, waiting for Xie Zheng to pass.

Xie Zheng knew that Fan Changyu was returning to the Office of Presentations today to move the rest of her things, so he had come over to see how she was doing as soon as he left the palace.

Xie Wu and the two men standing in the narrow path before the decorated gateway were still quite conspicuous. As he was about to walk past, he suddenly stopped, gave them a cursory glance, and asked Xie Wu, "What is this about?"

Xie Wu said, "Miss Changning's private tutor passed the metropolitan examination and came to resign today, recommending a juren in his place. The Great General found him unsuitable and did not hire him, ordering this subordinate to see them out."

Xie Zheng had only asked casually, but upon hearing that Fan Changyu had not hired the recommended private tutor, his intensely oppressive gaze fell upon the man in the green scholar's robe with his head bowed.

It had to be said, this style of dress was the kind of scholar's attire that Xie Zheng disliked the most.

He frowned slightly, and the two men, who had their heads bowed so low they could only see their own toes, began to tremble under his gaze. Perhaps because the man in the green robe was still young, his entire body was shaking like a sieve.

Xie Zheng knew he didn't have a good reputation in the court or among the populace. Ordinary civil officials feared him, so it was only natural for a juren who had yet to enter officialdom to be afraid of him. Since Fan Changyu hadn't hired him anyway, Xie Zheng didn't press for the reason in

front of the two men. He only instructed Xie Wu, "Then see them properly out of the residence."

Only after Xie Zheng had completely passed did Xie Wu lead the two men to continue out of the residence. But the juren in the green robe seemed too frightened by his Prince to walk, his face was ashen, and he looked as if he had died once already.

Xie Wu knew that because of the case that brought down Grand Tutor Li, scholars all over the land held a prejudice against his master. But the Prince had only asked a couple of questions, and it had frightened this juren to such a state. Xie Wu was a little displeased, and his tone grew colder. "The Prince is fair in his rewards and punishments. Even if the Great General did not hire Juren Song, there is no need for you to be so terrified."

Song Yan mumbled an affirmative, but when he lifted his foot to walk again, his legs were still as soft as noodles.

There was no mistake. That voice was the same as the husband Fan Changyu had recruited back then.

At the Lantern Festival that New Year, his line, "The northern geese fly south, but the ground is so full of phoenixes there's no place to land," had remained in Song Yan's memory for years. He would not mistake that voice.

Then he thought of the rumors that had spread among the common folk last year when Fan Changyu and the Prince Regent's engagement was announced—that the Prince Regent was the very same husband she had once recruited. At this thought, Song Yan's face turned ashen.

The terror that suddenly swept over him was even more intense than when he had learned that the dignitary he was to meet today was Fan Changyu.

It was rumored that the Prince Regent was ruthless and bloodthirsty, that the number of lives he had taken was at least eight thousand, if not ten thousand. The private prison in his residence was said to have countless instruments of torture. Prisoners who wouldn't break even after all the tortures in the imperial prison would confess everything in less than half a day in his private prison.

The sun, just out after the rain, was not fierce, but as Song Yan and Wu Guangkun walked out of the Office of Presentations' main gate and down

the steps, he felt dizzy. He looked up at the sky, and the sun seemed to turn into a ring of fire burning straight into his eyes. Beside him, Wu Guangkun was still complaining, asking him if he had offended the Great General in the past. Song Yan's vision went black, and he lost consciousness.

Xie Zheng went to the inner courtyard to find Fan Changyu. Before they could exchange more than a few words, Xie Wu rushed back to report that the juren who had come to apply for the private tutor position had fainted at the entrance of the Office of Presentations.

Fan Changyu couldn't help but frown at the news. She hadn't made things too difficult for Song Yan, so why did he faint after leaving the Office of Presentations?

Seeing her strange expression, Xie Zheng asked, "What's wrong?"

Fan Changyu answered truthfully, "The person Tutor Wu recommended was Song Yan."

Xie Zheng looked at Fan Changyu, clearly not remembering who that was for a moment.

Fan Changyu had to put it another way. "The scholar I was engaged to back in Qingping County."

Xie Zheng's face visibly darkened a shade, his phoenix eyes turning exceptionally cold. "He came to you seeking connections?"

Fan Changyu said, "Finding a tutor for Changning can be a big or small matter. I was afraid that if people knew our residence was hiring, some with ulterior motives might be sent over. So I asked Tutor Wu not to announce it publicly for now and to bring any suitable candidates directly to me. Who knew I would run into Song Yan."

Xie Zheng gave a soft "en," his emotions unreadable.

When Xie Zheng arrived, Changning had gone to find Xie Qi to help pack up the room Fan Changyu used to live in. Fan Changyu gave Xie Wu, who had come to report, a look. After Xie Wu withdrew, she said to Xie Zheng, "You don't seem very happy."

Xie Zheng poured himself a cup of tea, his expression indifferent. He only said, "I'm not."

Fan Changyu's expression became somewhat subtle. She looked at Xie Zheng. "Xie Jiuhan, you can't possibly still be jealous of Song Yan, can

you?"

Xie Zheng's eyelids lifted, and two words escaped his thin lips:
"Ridiculous."

Fan Changyu nodded. "That's true. In terms of talent and learning, you are a man of great strategy and immense knowledge. Other than passing the provincial examination on his first try, he has nothing to boast about. Now he has failed the metropolitan examinations twice and has fallen into such a state. If you were to compare yourself to him, it would truly be lowering your own status."

At first, Fan Changyu's words had a hint of coaxing, but as she continued, she seemed to be genuinely reflecting. "Back then, I knew you were literate and said that when you became a high official in the future, if you ever ran into Song Yan in court, you should suppress him a little to vent my anger. But only two or three years have passed. What seemed like the sky falling back then is now just a shallow pit on the road I've traveled. And does Song Yan even need you or me to suppress him? In this sea of officialdom, a single stumble could cost him half his life."

Her tone was light and calm, as if she had truly let go of the past. Her words completely smoothed over the slight prickliness and gloom in Xie Zheng's heart.

He turned his head slightly, half his body bathed in the warm spring light, which made his face appear fairer. His eyes, touched by a ring of warm sun, also seemed to soften a great deal. The gold thread embroidery on his python robe shimmered with a floating golden glow. Between his long fingers, he held a sky-blue porcelain cup, which still contained half a cup of pale, honey-colored tea. Against this backdrop, his fingertips looked like white jade, exuding an air of indescribable leisure and ease.

He said, "Is everything packed? I'll take you home."

Fan Changyu smiled. "Only the books and some personal belongings from my room are left. Xie Qi is packing them, so he should be almost done."

When the two of them went out, Xie Qi had indeed packed up all the items in Fan Changyu's room. All the books were packed in special book chests.

The two of them returned to the Xie residence with Changning. After their meal, Fan Changyu felt a little drowsy and took Changning with her

for an afternoon nap.

When Xie Zheng entered the study to handle political affairs, he saw several book chests containing Fan Changyu's books piled on the floor. Fearing that the servants, unaware of her reading habits, might place the books in the wrong spots and make it inconvenient for her to find them later, he personally placed them one by one onto the half of the bookshelf he had cleared for her.

The military strategy books Fan Changyu read were basically all selected by Xie Zheng. From simple to complex, he had annotated all of them.

Therefore, when he picked up a volume of military strategy that he had not chosen for her, Xie Zheng couldn't help but take a second look. He opened it and found that it also contained extremely detailed annotations, but the elegant and fluid handwriting was not his.

Xie Zheng's face showed no emotion, but his eyes suddenly turned terrifyingly cold and deep. He sat down behind the desk and spent the entire afternoon meticulously reading that book of military strategy from beginning to end, not missing a single character of the annotations.

After finishing, he calmly ordered someone to summon Xie Wu.

The moment Xie Wu entered the study and saw the familiar book of military strategy on the desk, he froze for an instant, a quick jolt of panic running through him.

That book of military strategy was the one Zheng Wenchang had returned to Fan Changyu back then. The annotations within were all written by Li Huaian, Grand Tutor Li's grandson!

"Who gave her this book?" Xie Zheng sat behind the desk, his voice sounding calm at first, but it was precisely this calmness that made Xie Wu's hair stand on end.

He licked his lips, hesitated for only a breath between lying and telling the truth, and chose the latter. There was nothing between the Great General and Li Huaian. If his master misunderstood because of his deliberate concealment, then he would only have himself to blame for being too clever for his own good.

He said, "It... it was back on the battlefield in Chongzhou. When the Great General was promoted to Swift Cavalry Commandant, the Grand

Tutor's grandson gave it to her as a congratulatory gift for her promotion."

Xie Zheng's expression remained unchanged, but the knuckles of the hand flipping through the book seemed to protrude slightly. An inexplicable pressure emanated from him, making Xie Wu feel as if the air in the study had thinned.

Fearing Xie Zheng would misunderstand, he quickly tried to explain further. "When the Great General received the book, she gifted it to the soldiers under her command. It was only later, when General Zheng borrowed military books from the Great General at the Office of Presentations, that this book was returned along with the others."

Xie Zheng still said nothing.

After a long time, just as Xie Wu felt a drop of cold sweat trickle down his temple, he finally heard Xie Zheng say, "You may leave."

Xie Wu let out a slight sigh of relief, thinking that the matter was over as far as Xie Zheng was concerned.

That night, however, Fan Changyu tasted the bitter consequences.

Both of them were martial artists, so it was inevitable that they had vigorous energy. But most of the time, Fan Changyu could keep up with him. They would often fool around until late at night, and after a satisfying bath, she would be pulled into Xie Zheng's arms to fall into a deep sleep.

Xie Zheng was not a man of many words in that regard. Just like when he practiced martial arts or waged war, his actions were always fiercer than his words. He would restrain her tightly, his attacks deep and heavy.

This night, Fan Changyu was already exhausted, but he seemed insatiable. He would always ask her questions about military strategy when she was too lost in pleasure to think. Of course, Fan Changyu couldn't answer, and he would then have a legitimate reason to continue punishing her.

In the end, Fan Changyu's shattered voice was already tinged with the sob of ultimate pleasure. "Xie Zheng, Xie Jiuhang, that's enough!"

Xie Zheng lowered his head slightly to look at her. His sweat-dampened hair was messily strewn across his forehead, his gaze profound and dark. The prominent Adam's apple on his neck bobbed up and down, swallowing emotions only he knew.

When he lowered his head to kiss her already swollen red lips, his cool, mellow voice held only the endless greed of a wolf as he said hoarsely, "Not enough!"

Far from enough.

It would never be enough!

If there were truly a way in this world, he would probably be unable to resist sucking her marrow dry to satisfy the avarice in his heart.

Chapter 167

Extra Story Three

Fan Changyu had no idea what time it was when she woke up.

Despite her robust physique from years of martial arts training, her entire body ached. As she changed clothes, she glanced at her wrists and unsurprisingly noticed faint blue fingerprints—evidence of Xie Zheng tying her hands to the bedpost last night when she struggled too fiercely.

Such minor injuries didn't hurt much to her; they were nothing compared to the bruises she got during training.

But Xie Zheng last night... had been unusually intense.

Sweat dripped from his eyelids, scalding her skin and making her tremble uncontrollably, yet his obsidian-like eyes never left her, like a wolf fixated on prey finally within its grasp.

After their marriage, his stamina had indeed been outrageous. Before their wedding, they had only been intimate twice—once when he returned from a palace banquet under the influence of drugs, and the other after she rushed to save him following the coup. After that, he had restrained himself.

During their seven-day wedding leave, aside from the third day when she returned to visit Grand Tutor Tao, they barely left their chambers.

By the end of those seven days, the marital bed had to be replaced entirely.

Last night, his fervor had surpassed even those early days of their marriage. For the first time, he had tormented her while quizzing her on military tactics. By the end, Fan Changyu's mind was in complete disarray, unable to recall what he had even asked.

She only vaguely remembered being pushed to the brink, her voice breaking as she pleaded incoherently—only for him to grow even more relentless, his eyes burning red with desire.

When she couldn't take it anymore and tried to kick him, he simply seized her leg and hoisted it over his shoulder...

Fan Changyu cut off the memory, tightening her soft armor with an impassive expression, her knuckles cracking audibly.

She couldn't retaliate today. If her strength couldn't match his, it would only invite humiliation.

A maid outside, likely hearing the noise, lifted the curtain and entered. "General, you're awake?"

Her ears tinged pink as she spoke, avoiding Fan Changyu's gaze. "His Highness instructed us not to disturb your rest before he left this morning. He also requested leave on your behalf for today's court session."

Crack.

Another faint sound from her clenched fingers.

The maid peeked at Fan Changyu but only heard her ask calmly, "What time is it?"

Her voice was just a little hoarse.

"It's youshi (5-7 PM)," the maid replied.

Fan Changyu: "..."

No wonder the sky looked so dim—it was nearly nightfall!

As the maid poured tea, Fan Changyu glanced at the dressing table. Thankfully, not only had the bedding and pillows been replaced, but the table had also been wiped clean...

She disliked servants witnessing intimate matters, so Xie Zheng always took care of tidying up afterward.

The memory of being pressed against the mirror last night still made her ears burn. Fan Changyu averted her eyes, sipping the warm tea to soothe her throat. "Where is His Highness?"

At this hour, Xie Zheng should have long returned from court.

"His Highness came back earlier and sat by your bedside for a while before heading to the study," the maid answered cautiously. "Shall I send word to him?"

"No need," Fan Changyu said. "Bring Ning Niang here and have the stables prepare a carriage. The Empress Dowager has been eager to meet Ning Niang—I'll take her to the palace tonight."

The Huainanzi: Military Strategies states: "When the enemy is strong, engage in battle; when weak, retreat."

Facing an opponent at the peak of their power, she knew she couldn't fight and decided withdrawal was the best course.

The maidservant stared blankly at Fan Changyu, uttering an "Ah," clearly finding it strange that Fan Changyu, after sleeping all day, would wake up and immediately seek refuge in the palace.

Fan Changyu glanced coolly at the maid. "Any questions?"

The maid hurriedly shook her head. "This servant will make the arrangements at once."

By the time Xie Zheng received the news in his study, Fan Changyu's carriage had already departed.

Unusually, he wasn't wearing his usual arrow-sleeved long robe but instead a light-colored scholar's gown, which accentuated his jade-like features with an added touch of refinement. Yet, the cold authority of one long accustomed to power still lingered between his brows, leaving Xie Wu, who had come to deliver the news, momentarily stunned.

Xie Zheng was annotating a book with a brush when he heard the news. He simply said, "She shares a deep bond with the Empress Dowager. Let her go. I'll fetch her in a couple of days."

Xie Wu found the situation peculiar. After their master had discovered the military treatise annotated by Li Huaian, the general had claimed to be bedridden with a chill the very next day, not stepping out all day, and then suddenly decided to visit the Empress Dowager in the palace that evening. It all seemed too coincidental.

Noticing Xie Wu still standing below, Xie Zheng paused his brush and looked up. "Anything else?"

Xie Wu quickly replied, "Nothing. This subordinate takes his leave."

As he bowed and clasped his fists, he caught sight of a book propping up the corner of the desk. From the cover, he could faintly make out the characters for Tiger Strategies .

Wasn't that the very military treatise Li Huaian had annotated for the general...?

Xie Wu's expression turned colorful, but he pretended not to see anything and retreated with a bow.

Only then did Xie Zheng set down his brush on the white porcelain brush rest. He pressed his fingers to his temple and murmured ambiguously, "She runs quite fast."

Meanwhile, after entering the palace, Fan Changyu devoured three bowls of rice at Yu Qianqian's Cining Palace before finally putting down her bowl.

Changning had dozed off in the carriage on the way and was already asleep in a side chamber.

Yu Qianqian, taken aback by Fan Changyu's ravenous appearance, asked in disbelief, "Did the Prince Regent mistreat you? Did he not feed you?"

Fan Changyu waved her hand, unwilling to elaborate. "Qianqian, I'll stay at your Cining Palace for a few days."

Yu Qianqian naturally agreed, but Fan Changyu's sudden arrival and famished state left her puzzled. "Did you quarrel with the Prince Regent?"

Fan Changyu mumbled, "No."

It wasn't a quarrel—it was a "fight," and she hadn't won.

She had no idea what madness had seized Xie Zheng, but to avoid walking into the lion's den again, it was wiser to stay away for now.

Still slightly choked from eating too quickly, she poured herself a cup of tea and gulped it down.

As she tilted her head back, Yu Qianqian caught sight of the faint marks on her neck and instantly understood.

Teasingly, she said, "Our mighty General Fan, who fears nothing in heaven or earth, turns out to be afraid of her wolfish, tiger-like husband at home."

Fan Changyu, caught off guard, coughed violently. Once she recovered, she slumped dejectedly. "Qianqian, you're mocking me too."

Yu Qianqian tapped her forehead. "My silly Yu'er, to hide in my Cining Palace over such a trivial matter—you've truly lost all your general's

dignity."

Fan Changyu clutched her teacup, her ears turning red, as she struggled to find the words. "I... I can't handle him."

Yu Qianqian shot her a reproachful look. "Just because he wants it, you give in? You mustn't indulge a man. Even if you're already in bed, there are plenty of ways to train him like a dog."

Fan Changyu looked utterly bewildered.

Yu Qianqian, seeing this, leaned over with exasperation and whispered a few words into her ear. Fan Changyu's face instantly turned red all the way down to her neck as she stammered, "I did say some soft words."

But it seemed to have the opposite effect—he had nearly shaken her bones apart.

Yu Qianqian gave Fan Changyu a once-over before murmuring, "Well, with the Prince Regent's wolf-like waist, it's no surprise he'd wear you out like this."

This was the first time Fan Changyu had heard such a description. She thought about Xie Zheng's lean, narrow waist, her face flushing even redder, though her eyes betrayed a hint of innocent confusion. "W-wolf-like waist?"

Though no one else was in the hall, Yu Qianqian still glanced around guiltily before clearing her throat and explaining, "It's a saying from where I come from—praising a man's waist."

Fan Changyu fell silent. Xie Zheng's waist strength... was indeed impressive.

Yu Qianqian observed the faint shadows under Fan Changyu's eyes and recalled what Qi Yu had mentioned—that she had taken sick leave from court that morning. After a moment's thought, she advised, "Since the Prince Regent is so... forceful in that regard, don't confront him head-on, but don't be too soft either. The former will only make him want to dominate you, and the latter... the only time you can show weakness to him is in bed—how could he not take full advantage of that?"

Fan Changyu: "..."

Yu Qianqian seemed to think of something else and leaned in to whisper a few more words. Fan Changyu let out a soft "Ah," her clear eyes filled

with fluster, her face burning even hotter.

Yu Qianqian propped her chin on her hand and grinned. "I think this is the only way to keep that man of yours in check."

Then, with a mischievous wink, she pulled out an illustrated manual from a drawer and handed it over. "Take this and study it. Learn a few more positions. When I saw this, I realized the ancients were far more creative than people in my time."

With that, Fan Changyu was ushered into a side chamber, clutching the manual.

Sitting by the bed under the glow of the palace lantern, she flipped through a couple of pages before decisively stuffing it under her pillow and lying down to sleep.

The next morning, Yu Qianqian was awakened by the sound of clashing weapons in the courtyard. After being dressed by her attendants, she opened the door to find Fan Changyu in martial attire, wielding a long staff with fierce precision. Her movements—thrusts, sweeps, jabs, and strikes—flowed seamlessly, drawing the admiring gazes of several blushing palace maids who had gathered along the corridor.

Yawning, Yu Qianqian asked, "Up so early? Couldn't sleep a little longer?"

Fan Changyu lowered her staff, sweat-dampened strands of hair clinging to her forehead. Dressed in a half-armored tunic and a tea-white brocade robe with split sleeves, she exuded a striking aura, her eyes gleaming with an unconscious allure in the morning light.

"I've figured it out," she declared. "No amount of learning compares to the power of a strong fist. Martial training is what's real."

Yu Qianqian: "..."

And just like that, the allure vanished—she was still the same simple-minded girl.

As it was a day of rest, the court officials were exempt from morning assembly.

Qi Yu came to the Cining Palace to pay his respects to Yu Qianqian and learned that Fan Changyu and her sister had stayed overnight. He joined Yu Qianqian for breakfast.

While Fan Changyu and Yu Qianqian chatted about trivial matters, Qi Yu focused on piling all sorts of delicacies into Changning's bowl until it resembled a small mountain.

Changning shoveled food into her mouth as fast as she could, but the mound in her bowl only grew taller. Finally, she huffed in frustration, "Stop! I can't eat all this!"

Her voice drew Fan Changyu and Yu Qianqian's attention to the two little ones.

Qi Yu sat upright with perfect posture. If not for the small mountain of food piled in Changning's bowl, no one would have guessed what he'd done.

Yu Qianqian couldn't help but laugh. "Since Bao'er ascended the throne a year ago, he's only been truly happy when Changning comes to the palace with you. I think the child is too lonely, and the burden on his shoulders is too heavy—that's why his temperament has grown more withdrawn. Just the other day, I discussed with the Junior Tutor about selecting a few study companions for him."

At this point, Yu Qianqian suddenly paused and looked at Fan Changyu. "Aren't you still worrying about finding a private tutor for Ning Niang? How about... letting Ning Niang come to the palace?"

Fan Changyu quickly replied, "Choosing study companions for His Majesty means they'll be learning statecraft under Gongsun to assist him in the future. Ning Niang is still young and mischievous—I fear she might disturb His Majesty instead."

Qi Yu suddenly spoke up. "I won't be disturbed."

Fan Changyu was taken aback. When she looked up, she met a pair of earnest puppy-dog eyes.

Though already a young emperor, the way he gazed at her still carried a hint of pitiful loneliness.

Chapter 168

Extra Story Four

Changning, her chubby fingers clutching the gilded ebony chopsticks, immediately stopped nibbling on the crystal bun in her bowl upon hearing the news. She looked up and asked, "Can Ning Niang study with Bao'er again?"

Over the past two years, she had grown taller, no longer resembling the round-headed, plump little glutinous rice ball she once was. Yet her cheeks still retained their baby fat, rosy and full. Her large eyes were dark as ink, framed by long, delicate lashes. Perhaps due to improved health, her hair had grown thicker and glossier than before, now neatly styled into playful little buns that made her look even more adorable like a doll carved from jade and snow.

Fan Changyu wiped the soup stain from the corner of her mouth with a handkerchief and said, "You mustn't call her that anymore. You should address her as 'His Majesty.'"

Changning stuck out her tongue but quickly corrected herself, "Can Ning Niang study with His Majesty?"

Yu Qianqian smiled and said, "See? Ning Niang also wants to study in the palace with Bao'er. Rather than leaving her alone with those old scholars, why not let her come to the palace? She'll have Bao'er as company. When you and the Prince Regent attend court in the future, you can send Ning Niang to Chongwen Hall. After court and political discussions, you can pick her up on your way home."

After Yu Qianqian's persuasion, coupled with Qi Yu and Changning's pleading eyes, Fan Changyu pondered for a moment before finally agreeing.

For now, both Changning and Qi Yu were still young, so having Changning as a study companion wasn't inappropriate. In a couple of years, as a general, Fan Changyu would inevitably be stationed at the border, and Changning would likely have to leave the capital with her.

As soon as she agreed, after breakfast, Qi Yu eagerly offered to take Changning to Chongwen Hall for a visit first. Yu Qianqian, concerned about the two children, sent her trusted matron to accompany and look after Changning, while she stayed behind with Fan Changyu in Cining Palace to chat about daily matters.

This wasn't Changning's first time in the palace, but it was her first visit to Chongwen Hall, where the young emperor attended lectures and handled state affairs.

Gazing at the resplendent yet solemn hall and the smiling attendants on either side, she clenched her little fists nervously, feeling somewhat out of place.

Noticing this, Qi Yu dismissed the accompanying palace maids and eunuchs to wait outside. He personally led Changning on a tour of Chongwen Hall, saying, "Gongsun has a gentle temperament, and his lessons are straightforward and easy to understand. You needn't be afraid of him..."

Changning, dressed in a light pink high-waisted ruqun with matching ribbons tied around her little buns, bobbed along behind Qi Yu like a plump, animated peach. She immediately retorted, "I'm not afraid of Uncle Gongsun! Uncle Gongsun likes me very much!"

Qi Yu frowned slightly, then added after some thought, "The Empress Dowager will also select a few suitable sons of court officials to serve as my study companions. If they bully you, don't be afraid. I'll stand up for you."

Changning let out an "Ah!" and pointed a chubby finger at the only desk in the hall, adorned with carved golden dragon patterns. "But there's only one desk here."

Back when she and Bao'er studied together in the Office of Presentations, they had always shared a low table. Even if more people joined, though this desk was large, it still wouldn't fit everyone, would it?

Qi Yu explained, "The Imperial Household Department will prepare additional low desks when the time comes."

Changning scrunched up her face in thought before declaring, "Then I'll still share a desk with you!"

After all, they were best friends!

Qi Yu hesitated briefly before finally saying, "No."

Disappointment flooded Changning's dark, expressive eyes. "Why not?"

Qi Yu said, "That is the Dragon Desk. Only I may use it."

Changning's little face fell. "Can't I use it either?"

Qi Yu shook his head.

Changning pinched the corner of her clothes, lowering her head to mutter softly, "Stingy... fine then..."

They used to share everything equally before.

Qi Yu noticed the faint hint of a sob in her voice. When he looked closer, her eyes were indeed as red as the peach-pink dress she wore.

Unsure how he'd upset her, he floundered for an explanation: "You'll have your own desk soon, no need to share anymore."

After a pause, he added, "When no one's around, you can share the Dragon Desk with me."

Changning rubbed her eyes with chubby fingers. "Then when no one's around, can I still call you Bao'er? Calling you 'Your Majesty' makes you seem like a different person."

Children perceive changes in others' attitudes more slowly. Having only ever had this one playmate—the boy who protected her when she was kidnapped by the Sui family, then accompanied them to the capital—she'd always shared everything with him after learning his mother had been taken by bad people.

Suddenly having to follow strict protocols and growing distant felt unnatural to Changning.

Qi Yu studied her before replying, "You may, but you must call me Bao'er gege (older brother)."

Changning's mind worked quickly. Her dark grape-like eyes widened. "You're trying to take advantage! I'm your auntie!"

Their bickering yielded no resolution. Before other study companions could be selected, Changning began attending lectures at Chongwen Hall.

Two days later, during a break in Gongsun Yin's lecture, as he sipped tea to soothe his throat, he watched the young emperor retrieve various

pastries from the Bronze Jian Jar behind him, arranging them all before Changning...

The familiar scene made Gongsun Yin choke on his tea.

Changning had just picked up an Almond Crisp with her plump fingers when she turned concerned eyes toward him. "Did you choke, Gongsun? Drink slower!"

Waving a hand, Gongsun Yin said, "It's nothing."

Demonstrating respect for elders, Changning stood and trotted over with the Almond Crisp. "Have some too!"

Gongsun Yin's expression grew even more peculiar, vividly recalling Fan Changyu's similar behavior at the Wenyuan Pavilion. The sisters were undoubtedly related.

A eunuch announced the Prince Regent's arrival to escort the Huaihua General and her sister home.

Gongsun Yin gave Changning a strange look. "You've both been staying in the palace these two days?"

"Of course!" Changning answered brightly.

His expression grew stranger still.

When Xie Zheng entered, Gongsun Yin's lips curled into a knowing, springlike smile. Anyone could guess Xie Jiuhang had quarreled with his general wife!

Xie Zheng ignored him, offering Qi Yu a slight bow. "Greetings, Your Majesty."

"Please rise, Prince Regent," Qi Yu responded.

Unaware of adult complexities, Changning sweetly called out, "Brother-in-law!"

Xie Zheng replied impassively, "My wife mentioned bringing her younger sister to visit the Empress Dowager. I've come to take her home."

Qi Yu furrowed his little brows and said, "Prince Regent, your timing is rather unfortunate. At the request of Grand Royal Concubine An, Her Majesty has arranged a polo match in the West Garden to help the Grand Princess select a suitable husband. Since the Grand Princess herself will be playing, to ensure her safety, she invited Lady Fan to accompany her."

Upon hearing this, the faces of the two men in the hall turned green—though Gongsun Yin's was decidedly greener, his usual gentle smile freezing stiffly at the corners of his lips.

If the event was meant to help the Grand Princess choose a husband, then the polo field in the West Garden today would undoubtedly be filled with young noblemen from prominent families. Many unmarried noble ladies might also seize this opportunity to find themselves a desirable match.

Xie Zheng cast a brief glance at the rigid-faced Gongsun Yin before cupping his hands and saying, "In that case, I shall also go to the West Garden to join in the excitement."

Qi Yu was still too young to handle state affairs directly. Most governmental matters were first discussed and decided by Xie Zheng and his ministers before being presented to Qi Yu for review, allowing him to learn how to manage such affairs.

Burdened with countless responsibilities, Xie Zheng naturally hadn't heard about the polo match arranged by the Empress Dowager to help the Grand Princess select a husband.

After Xie Zheng left the Chongwen Hall, Gongsun Yin also bowed to Qi Yu and said, "Your Majesty, today's lesson ends here. As for the line from the Book of Documents, 'The mind of man is restless, prone to error; the mind of the Way is subtle, hard to discern. Be discriminating, be undivided, so that you may sincerely hold fast the Mean,' Your Majesty may ponder its meaning and share your insights with me tomorrow. As for Miss Changning, you need only copy this sentence neatly five times. If you also have any thoughts, you may share them tomorrow."

Changning nodded obediently, while Qi Yu gave a dignified nod befitting an emperor. "We have noted it."

After Gongsun Yin withdrew, Changning immediately turned to Qi Yu and asked, "Bao'er, Bao'er, have you ever seen a polo match before?"

Qi Yu hesitated for a moment before shaking his head. "No, I haven't."

Changning's eyes sparkled with excitement. "Let's go watch! My sister and your grand-aunt are both playing today!"

Qi Yu glanced at the assignment Gongsun Yin had left behind and frowned slightly. Interpreting such a profound line was still quite

challenging for him at this stage. To offer meaningful insights, he would need to consult additional texts.

After a brief hesitation, he nodded. "Then We shall order the carriage prepared for the West Garden."

Changning's eyes instantly crinkled with joy, and sweet words poured from her lips like honey. "I knew you were the best, Bao'er! After my sister, you're the one who treats me the best!"

Under Changning's effusive praise, the slight furrow in Qi Yu's brow gradually smoothed away.

Since his ascension to the throne, everyone around him had changed. He was no longer Yu Bao'er—just the "Your Majesty" who sat alone on high, forced to study tirelessly and bear the weight of the Great Yin Empire.

But there was still one person who refused to call him "Your Majesty," who still wished he could be "Yu Bao'er," and who didn't believe their relationship needed to change just because he had become emperor.

Qi Yu was happy.

At least in front of this chubby girl who had accompanied him all the way from Qingping County, he didn't have to maintain a cold, imperial demeanor—

The West Garden boasted the largest royal polo field, and now the viewing stands outside were a dazzling sea of silk and gold, filled with noblewomen and ladies of high rank.

At the very center, beneath a grand canopy with Golden Guards standing by with swords drawn, was the seating area specially arranged for the royal family, offering the best view from the entire high platform.

Fan Changyu, dressed in martial attire, sat to Yu Qianqian's right, while the Grand Princess Qi Zhu sat to her left. The three women were close in age, and at first glance, all were adorned with cloud-like hair and blooming beauty, each possessing their own charm. However, Yu Qianqian, despite her youth, was already the Empress Dowager. Given the grand occasion today, her Pheasant Robe was of a darker hue and somewhat old-fashioned in style.

Qi Zhu had come today to scout for a potential consort, and her makeup was strikingly vivid. A delicate Floral Applique adorned her forehead, her hair was piled high in elegant coils, and she wore a crabapple-colored

palace gown draped with a layer of Golden Thread Gauze Robe, exuding regal opulence.

What surprised many was that Fan Changyu, seated beside this most illustrious peony of Great Yin, was not overshadowed in the slightest.

Having served in the court for over a year now, she had met nearly every official, big and small. Yet, in daily life, no one would associate her with the word "peerless beauty." The most common praises she received in court were "valiant" and "heroic." It was only today, surrounded by beauties, that people suddenly realized her looks were also exceptionally striking.

Her gentle facial features lent her an air of dignified grace rather than sharpness, while her long, dashing eyebrows added a touch of heroic spirit. Though she had almond-shaped eyes, they were not tenderly affectionate but instead radiated composure and resolve—like a great ship at sea that had cast its anchor deep, unshaken by any storm.

So striking was her presence that many noble ladies stopped watching the young men below chasing the ball on horseback. Instead, they leaned forward, half-hiding behind their silk fans, stealing glances at Fan Changyu seated on the high platform.

Turning back, they couldn't help but whisper to their companions: "Oh no, oh no! I find the General of Huaihua even more dashing than those young lords down there. This polo match isn't half as captivating as the general!"

Another noblewoman groaned softly, "I'll never marry someone like the Prince Regent in this lifetime, but could I at least wed a husband like the general?"

Fan Changyu remained oblivious to all this. Though she noticed many eyes on her, she didn't understand why and simply allowed their gazes to wash over her, unperturbed.

When the polo match ended, Yu Qianqian asked Qi Zhu, "Did any young men catch Your Highness's eye?"

Qi Zhu lazily fanned herself and shook her head. "Watching them was far less interesting than watching A Yu!"

Yu Qianqian chuckled. "The next match features Shen Shen, grandson of the Duke of Shen. Rumor has it he was once a figure spoken of in the same

breath as the Prince Regent in his youth. Your Highness might want to take a closer look."

Just then, a stir arose from the men's seating area, though it quickly settled.

Yu Qianqian asked her attendants, "What happened?"

A Golden Guard returned after investigating and reported, "Your Majesty, the Prince Regent and the Junior Tutor have also come to watch the polo match."

Yu Qianqian immediately shot Fan Changyu a teasing glance.

Unfortunately, their seating was too far from the men's section, separated by a sea of people, making it impossible to see what was happening over there.

Qi Zhu suddenly stood up. "Shen Shen is playing? Then I'll join this round as well."

Watching as Qi Zhu promptly led her attendants away to change, Yu Qianqian turned to Fan Changyu in bewilderment. "Could the princess truly have taken a liking to the young master of the Shen family?"

Fan Changyu was equally baffled.

However, she had been invited today specifically to assist and protect Qi Zhu when she took the field. Since Qi Zhu was determined to participate in this match, Fan Changyu naturally had to follow along.

As she and Qi Zhu went to change into the standard martial attire, they passed by the men's seating area, where it was impossible to miss Xie Zheng, who occupied several seats all by himself.

After he took his seat, the surrounding area remained conspicuously empty—save for Gongsun Yin—as no one else dared to sit nearby, making him stand out even more.

Qi Zhu's departure from her seat was quite a spectacle, so Xie Zheng naturally noticed them.

Their gazes met in the air, and for a brief moment, Changyu was stunned.

This... this was the first time she had ever seen Xie Zheng dressed in a snow-white Confucian robe!

Elegant, refined, and peerless—like a true gentleman.

It was as if those hands had never wielded blades or halberds, as though they were meant only to hold brushes and scrolls.

Clearly, she wasn't the only one taken aback. The noble ladies and young men in the stands were equally astonished. However, due to the Prince Regent's formidable reputation in the court, no one dared to openly stare at him, resorting instead to furtive glances like thieves.

Changyu even overheard hushed whispers.

"Why is the Prince Regent dressed in such an elegant Confucian robe?"

"Exactly! When the Prince Regent first arrived, I mistook him for the Junior Tutor!"

"Shh... Rumor has it that the Huaihua General hasn't returned to the Xie residence in two days. I heard the General has always admired the Junior Tutor, but the Prince Regent was too quick in petitioning for the marriage, forcing the General to comply. Now, it seems their relationship is falling apart. The Prince Regent is probably imitating the Junior Tutor's attire to win the General back!"

Changyu stumbled mid-step, nearly face-planting right then and there.

Chapter 169

Extra Story Five

With so many people and prying eyes, and with a considerable distance between them, Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng ultimately only shared a faint glance across the crowd before she followed Qi Zhu to the grand hall for changing.

On the men's side of the viewing stands, a eunuch came to make an announcement. "In the next match, we have Her Highness the Eldest Princess, the Grand General of Huaihua, Young Master Shen, the Prince of Jianning... Are there any gentlemen who wish to participate?"

This was an excellent opportunity for ordinary gentry clans to connect with the powerful and noble, and many young masters immediately responded with flushed faces, eager to join.

A young master who had already played in a previous match lamented, "Why is the Princess only joining the match now?"

A person beside him chuckled. "Young Master Shen is dashing and romantic, and his polo skills are second to none. Perhaps the Princess is also going to admire Young Master Shen's style."

Someone lowered their voice and said sourly, "Then what's the point of watching this next match? The Princess has a noble status, the Grand General of Huaihua has outstanding martial prowess, and Young Master Shen's polo skills are exquisite. With the Grand General and Young Master Shen protecting her, this match is just for the Princess's amusement. Who knows, by the end of the game, a marriage between the Princess and Young Master Shen might be settled."

Gongsun Yin glanced at the extremely conspicuous white robes Xie Zheng was wearing and said through gritted teeth, "Xie Jiuhang, I've helped you with no small number of things, big and small, over the years. How about you return a favor today?"

Xie Zheng turned his head and gave him a faint look.

The grand hall for changing was not far from the polo field. The men changed in the front hall and the women in the rear hall, separated by a courtyard. A young eunuch stood guard at the corner gate to prevent anyone from going to the wrong place.

Fan Changyu was already in a fitted martial attire, so changing was simple for her. But Qi Zhu's palace gown was elaborate, and removing the pearl and jade hair ornaments to restyle her hair was also troublesome. Even with seven or eight maids bustling around her, it still took the time of two cups of tea.

After changing into the crimson martial attire for polo, Fan Changyu went to the courtyard to wait.

She had never played polo before, but having watched a few matches from the stands, she had basically figured out the rules. There were polo balls and mallets in the side hall, so to familiarize herself, Fan Changyu took a mallet and practiced swinging it a few times in the courtyard to get a feel for it.

Today's polo was a military-style game with ten-person teams. As long as one didn't intentionally injure others, hitting the ball with a mallet from horseback into the goal on the field counted as a score.

There was a stone-carved, openwork window on the courtyard wall. Since no one was around, Fan Changyu used the stone window as a goal and struck a ball towards the opening.

Her aim was excellent. The fist-sized ball flew straight through the window, making the palace attendant waiting at the side gasp in applause.

But the applause quickly died away.

The ball that had flown out was intercepted on the other side of the window by a large, well-defined hand.

The afternoon breeze was gentle, causing the hem of the visitor's indigo martial robes to flutter slightly. The hand that caught the ball had faint, prominent veins. Further up, the wrist was clasped by a ruyi-patterned vambrace, and the narrow sleeve outlined the firm muscles of the forearm, which seemed to be brimming with power.

Thinking she had hit someone, Fan Changyu took a few steps forward, about to apologize. "My apologies..."

When the person turned his head, the rest of her words caught in her throat. She looked at Xie Zheng, dressed in indigo martial robes, and said with great surprise, "You're going to play polo too?"

Martial attire actually suited him better. His ink-black hair was all tied up into a topknot cap. Although his expression appeared somewhat cool and aloof, his exquisite features were full of unrestrained, heroic spirit, making it impossible for one to look away.

Xie Zheng walked slowly to the moon gate and raised his arm, tossing the ball he had intercepted back to her. "I was asked by the official in charge to join in the fun."

Fan Changyu caught the ball he threw back and understood the meaning behind his words. Her and Qi Zhu's team was mostly composed of imperial relatives. If the opposing team didn't have someone of high status, they would likely just have to defer and flatter them throughout the match, which would make the game meaningless.

Just as she was about to reply, a man's voice suddenly came from the other side of the moon gate. "Jiuhang! So you're here. I've been looking all over for you!"

The newcomer had handsome brows and bright eyes, and he smiled before he even spoke. It was Shen Shen. He had been looking for Xie Zheng, and then he spotted Fan Changyu practicing in the courtyard. He suddenly broke into a grin. "I was wondering why a busy man like you would suddenly have the leisure to play polo. So you came to accompany the Grand General of Huaihua!"

He was wearing the same crimson martial attire as Fan Changyu, clearly on the same team as her and Qi Zhu. He immediately clapped Xie Zheng hard on the shoulder. "Excellent! It's been years since I last played polo with you. We can finally see who's better on the field in a bit!"

His voice was probably a bit too loud, as Qi Zhu, who was changing inside the hall, also heard him. She came out, having changed into martial attire, and addressed the two of them, "Prince Regent, Young General Shen."

Shen Shen's father had died early. Logically, he could inherit the title of Duke of Shen, so many in the court called him Young Master Shen. But he also held a position in the court, so quite a few people called him General Shen.

Shen Shen cupped his fist with a bright smile. "Greetings, Your Highness."

Through the latticed window, Qi Zhu had also caught a glimpse of a fleeting indigo hem. A trace of gloom flashed in her eyes, but she curved her lips and said, "This princess is also just fond of excitement, which is why I'm joining this one match. My skills are truly not good. I've heard that Young General Shen's polo skills are superb. Might I ask for some guidance?"

Shen Shen was an extremely easygoing person and immediately smiled. "I would be more than happy to be of service."

Qi Zhu looked at Xie Zheng. "Changyu is also playing polo for the first time. The matter of teaching one's own wife should be handled by the Prince Regent himself."

As she spoke, she gave Fan Changyu a teasing smile.

Fan Changyu looked completely baffled. After Qi Zhu took a mallet and walked towards the front, chatting and laughing with Shen Shen, she felt it was strangely awkward for just her and Xie Zheng to be standing there. She said, "I've pretty much finished practicing..."

"Your form when swinging the mallet is incorrect. You could easily get injured on horseback," Xie Zheng interrupted her.

Fan Changyu stared at him, stunned.

Xie Zheng stepped forward and, from behind, took hold of the hand she was using to grip the mallet. He said, "Your wrist should be level, and your waist relaxed. Don't be so tense."

His warm palm clasped her wrist that held the mallet. When his other hand landed on her waist, certain memories suddenly flooded back. Fan Changyu's waist stiffened uncontrollably. Xie Zheng looked down at her. "What's wrong?"

Fan Changyu forced herself to say, "Nothing."

Fortunately, Xie Zheng was truly just teaching her with single-minded focus.

The ball that Fan Changyu hit after mastering the technique flew quite far. When the palace attendant on the side went outside the courtyard wall

to retrieve it, Fan Changyu turned her head and said to Xie Zheng with a smile, "I didn't expect you to know this too!"

A light breeze rustled by, and the scholar tree blossoms fell, blanketing the ground. A few petals landed on Xie Zheng's lapels, but he didn't brush them off. He only raised a hand to pick a tiny blossom from Fan Changyu's hair. "Now that A Yu is happy, will you come back to the residence with your husband today?"

Fan Changyu looked at the man standing tall and elegant under the shower of blossoms. Remembering the words she had overheard when passing the viewing stands, she suddenly broke into a smile. "We'll see how you perform on the field later."

The polo match ultimately went awry. Qi Zhu's horse, for some unknown reason, got spooked on the field and charged straight towards the viewing stands, throwing the scene into chaos.

Fan Changyu was right beside Qi Zhu and could have protected her. But when Gongsun Yin and Shen Shen saw Qi Zhu's horse bolt, they also spurred their horses forward to rescue her. The three of them collided, making things worse. In the end, although Fan Changyu managed to save Qi Zhu, they both fell from their horses and were nearly trampled by the horses charging up from behind. Fortunately, Xie Zheng arrived in time to restrain the oncoming horse.

Gongsun Yin and Shen Shen, the two unlucky souls, collided with each other in the chaos. Both fell from their horses and broke their legs.

What was supposed to be a polo match arranged to find a consort for Qi Zhu ended in such a chaotic mess. Yu Qianqian was also at her wit's end. She ordered people to send the frightened noble ladies and madams back to their residences, summoned the imperial physicians to examine the injured, and ordered a strict investigation into the cause of the spooked horse.

After a thorough investigation, they finally traced it to a noble lady.

The horse Qi Zhu rode was the most docile in the entire stable. A commandery princess was originally supposed to be in that match and ride that very horse. The noble lady held an old grudge against that commandery princess, so she timed it just right to feed the horse fodder laced with drugs.

Who knew that Qi Zhu would suddenly decide to play, forcing the commandery princess to give up the horse, which led to this incident.

Yu Qianqian was furious. Fortunately, when Qi Zhu and Fan Changyu fell, Fan Changyu had protected her, rolling a few times to break the fall, so neither of them was seriously injured.

Only Gongsun Yin and Shen Shen's injuries were more severe.

By the time this matter was handled, it was nearly dusk. Fan Changyu, along with Changning, returned to the residence with Xie Zheng.

After dinner, Fan Changyu came out from her bath but didn't see Xie Zheng. Only after asking the servants did she learn that he had gone to bathe in the clean room near the study.

Fan Changyu found this strange. Since their marriage, Xie Zheng had almost never avoided her to go to the clean room by the study alone. When she went to look for him, she happened to run into Xie Shiyi carrying medicinal wine, about to go in.

Only then did she learn that Xie Zheng had injured his arm while restraining the spooked horse.

Fan Changyu dismissed Xie Shiyi and personally carried the medicinal wine into the study.

Xie Zheng had already finished bathing. His hair was half-dry, and he was wearing only a single layer of clothing, concentrating on writing something at his desk by candlelight.

Hearing footsteps, he looked up. When he saw the medicinal wine in Fan Changyu's hands, his brow furrowed slightly. "The mouths of these servants are getting looser and looser."

Fan Changyu's eyelids lifted slightly. "If you want to raise a group of people who are loyal only to you, then go ahead and raise them."

Her barbed words made Xie Zheng chuckle. He put down his brush. "So angry?"

Fan Changyu placed the medicinal wine on the desk and stared at him coldly. "Why didn't you say you were injured?"

Xie Zheng said, "I injured my arm just by stopping a spooked horse. What if A Yu looks down on me and refuses to come back with me?"

He was still joking at a time like this. Fan Changyu couldn't help but glare at him and said stiffly, "Take off your robe. I'll rub the medicinal wine in for you."

She was genuinely angry. Xie Zheng didn't tease her further. He removed his outer robe, revealing a stretch of honey-toned, firm muscle in the candlelight.

His right arm was already swollen, and on it were two circles of rope burns where the skin had been scraped off. It was from when he had wrapped the reins around his arm to wrestle with the spooked horse.

Fan Changyu poured some medicinal wine into her palm, rubbed her hands together, and then slowly massaged it into his bruised arm. Her brows knitted as she asked him, "Does it hurt?"

Her spring robe was thin. She had just bathed, and her dark hair was simply tied up. As she lowered her head to focus on massaging the medicine for him, a strand fell from behind her ear, half-hiding her pearly white earlobe in a way that was inexplicably alluring. She carried the faint scent of the soap she always used, and the air was tinged with the alcoholic smell of the medicinal wine.

As Xie Zheng gazed at her furrowed brow under the bright candlelight, he suddenly felt his heart grow warm and content. He hadn't been drinking, but he felt a little tipsy.

He smiled faintly and said, "It doesn't hurt."

Fan Changyu sighed helplessly. "You..."

After she finished applying the medicine, she noticed that the robe Xie Zheng had draped over himself was the same snow-white one from the daytime. She asked, "Why were you wearing a scholar's robe today?"

Xie Zheng's phoenix eyes lowered slightly as he answered, "I've never worn one before. Just trying it out."

Then he asked her, "Does it look good?"

Fan Changyu nodded.

He did look good in a scholar's robe.

Xie Zheng's eyes were deep. He pulled up the robe he had taken off for the medicine and suddenly smiled. "Since A Yu likes it, I'll wear it often from now on."

But there didn't seem to be much of a smile in his eyes.

Fan Changyu found it increasingly strange. She frowned and said, "There's no need to go that far..."

Xie Zheng's eyes were dark and profound, his thoughts unreadable. He pressed her down to sit in his lap, resting his chin lightly on her shoulder. "Does A Yu still remember this copy of Tiger Strategy?"

Now that she was sitting at the desk, Fan Changyu could see clearly that he had been making annotations on the pages. Judging by the thickness of the book, it seemed he was almost finished.

Xie Zheng kissed the nape of her neck and said, "Last time I quizzed A Yu on military strategy, there were many things you didn't understand. Once I'm done with the annotations, A Yu can take it and have a good look."

It would have been better if he hadn't brought it up. The moment he did, Fan Changyu shot him a fierce glare and said through gritted teeth, "There won't be a next time!"

Xie Zheng chuckled behind her. "Where has A Yu's mind gone? Your husband simply feels that it is my fault for not even having finished annotating the Six Secret Teachings for you. Besides the Tiger Strategy, I will also find time to annotate the other five volumes of military strategy for you."

Fan Changyu suddenly felt a little embarrassed. Looking at the detailed annotations, she said absentmindedly, "I seem to recall having a copy of Tiger Strategy in my collection."

In the past, she had many difficulties understanding military books on her own, so she had hired many strategists at great expense. Whenever those strategists tried to explain military strategy to her, they looked as if they wanted to bang their heads against a pillar. This made Fan Changyu feel quite embarrassed, so she sent them off to annotate military books for her instead.

The military books Li Huaian had given her, she had passed on to her subordinates as soon as she received them, having no impression at all of which ones he had given her.

Later, when Zheng Wenchang returned that copy of Tiger Strategy, she had casually asked Xie Wu to put it on the bookshelf. When she came

across it again later, she assumed it had been annotated by her former advisors and had long forgotten that Li Huaian had ever given her a military book.

Hearing this, Xie Zheng's eyes grew colder and colder, but he only smiled faintly and said, "Is that so? I didn't see it when I was organizing for you. Perhaps it was lost during the move."

Since he said that, Fan Changyu didn't think any more of it.

She was about to get up, but the man behind her held her waist without any intention of letting go. He kissed the nape of her neck intermittently, his intention all too clear.

Startled, Fan Changyu glared at the man behind her with a touch of anger. "Your arm is injured!"

Xie Zheng left a red mark on the side of her neck. When he looked up, his eyes were bewitchingly dark. His voice was very soft, as if negotiating, yet tinged with a smile, as if bewitching. "Then could A Yu be a little softer-hearted and indulge me this once?"

The desire in his eyes was not heavy, but it was entwined with some extremely deep emotion.

Fan Changyu was stunned speechless by his shameless words. In the end, she didn't dare to struggle with real force. When it was over, she rested her head on her scattered long hair, lying prone on the desk to slowly even her breathing. The robes beneath her were wrinkled beyond recognition.

Xie Zheng kissed her cheek and went to the clean room to fetch water to clean up.

As Fan Changyu regained some strength, she got up, and her sleeve knocked a book scroll off the desk. She bent down to pick it up and only then noticed that another book was propping up the corner of the desk. Carefully identifying the characters on the cover, it clearly read "Tiger Strategy."

Fan Changyu looked at the copy Xie Zheng had re-annotated for her in her hands, then at the one on the floor that had been used to prop up the desk. She picked up the one from the floor as well.

When Xie Zheng returned, he saw Fan Changyu holding two books, comparing them under the candlelight. Hearing his footsteps, she looked

up at him, utterly confused. "Didn't you say this book was lost?"

Xie Zheng's expression didn't change. "It was lost. Where did you find it?"

Fan Changyu's face darkened. "Xie Jiuhan, are you taking me for a fool! Weren't you the one who used it to prop up the desk leg?"

The servants would never dare use a book from the study to prop up a desk leg. It could only have been him!

Xie Zheng stated faintly, "Was it used to prop up the desk leg? I forgot."

Fan Changyu was speechless for a long moment. She thought it over and over but still couldn't figure it out. "What did this military book ever do to you?"

Connecting this to how he had relentlessly tormented her by quizzing her on its contents, Fan Changyu suddenly felt that the problem might lie with this very book.

Hearing this, Xie Zheng stared at her for a long while before finally saying with an extremely faint smile, "It didn't do anything to me."

Fan Changyu knew that Xie Zheng was angry.

When he got angry, he didn't give her the cold shoulder. He would even answer her questions, but his tone would be lukewarm, and he would smile in a way that made her heart panic.

Fan Changyu couldn't figure out what was going on even by the time she went to bed. When she asked Xie Zheng, he would just say "it's nothing" in that light, airy tone.

With him acting like this, it would be strange if it were nothing.

In the darkness of the bed curtains, Fan Changyu glanced at Xie Zheng, who was lying on the outer side, his breathing light and shallow as if he were already asleep. She finally let out a soft sigh and closed her eyes, forcing herself to sleep.

She must have been truly exhausted today, as she fell asleep quickly.

In the middle of the night, however, she was woken by a stifling feeling.

Damp, hot, stuffy.

The person behind her seemed to know she was awake but remained silent. His broad chest and iron-like arms held her in a tight grip, preventing her from moving an inch, while his movements below were exceptionally fierce.

Fan Changyu could endure it at first, but in the end, she bit down hard on her lip, yet muffled moans still escaped, and she nearly tore the bedsheets.

He then turned her face to kiss her. The kisses were also fierce, carrying a hint of punishment and pent-up anger...

Because of the spooked horse incident, both she and Xie Zheng took leave from the morning court session the next day.

When Fan Changyu woke up, Xie Zheng was no longer in the room, but breakfast had been kept warm for her.

Changning was quite dejected for a while after learning that Gongsun Yin had injured his leg and wouldn't be able to lecture at the Chongwen Institute for some time. After Fan Changyu comforted her and found out that Xie Zheng was in the study again, she thought about the delicate situation between them and decided not to go over directly.

Ever since being questioned by Xie Zheng that day, Xie Wu had noticed that something was off between Xie Zheng and Fan Changyu. Today, he finally had a chance to tell Fan Changyu about the military book.

When Fan Changyu learned that the copy of Tiger Strategy had been annotated by Li Huaian, she looked completely stunned. "Wasn't it annotated by the advisors I hired at great expense?"

Xie Wu was on the verge of tears. "No, it was Young Master Li."

Fan Changyu suddenly felt a headache coming on. She finally understood why Xie Zheng had been acting so abnormally these past few days.

The windows of the study in the Xie residence were wide open. The spring sunlight was brilliant, and the plants in the courtyard were lush and green.

Xie Zheng, dressed in a moon-white brocade robe, sat at his desk, engrossed in reviewing the memorials in his hands. Even bathed in the spring light, his features showed not a hint of warmth, only making one feel a cold solemnity.

Suddenly, with a "Haya!" a small wooden puppet jumped onto the windowsill. The puppet wore soft armor with a robe over it, a common outfit for Fan Changyu.

Xie Zheng looked up and saw that the puppet's limbs and torso were controlled by thin strings, a common trick in folk puppetry.

The small puppet raised a long sword. Though crudely made, it unexpectedly exuded an imposing air. A voice came from below. "Once upon a time, there was a young lady who, by a twist of fate, went to battle and became a general."

"An Army Supervisor, knowing she wasn't well-read, gave her some military books. But after she realized the Army Supervisor had approached her from the very beginning only to use her, she no longer considered him a friend and gifted the books he gave her to her soldiers."

Following this narration, a small puppet in a green robe appeared on the windowsill. The small puppet handed a book to the female general puppet, who in turn handed the book to several small puppets with the character for "soldier" pasted on their heads.

"Then one day, a straightforward general asked to borrow a book from her. To show proper etiquette of borrowing and returning, he also returned the military book she had gifted away."

A small puppet with the character "Zheng" on its head offered a book to a puppet with the character "Wu" on its head.

"Once the book was back in her hands, she felt it was improper to push it away again, so she had her subordinate put it away, not even knowing which book had been returned."

"Later on, the young lady got married. Her husband discovered the book and found out it had been annotated by that Army Supervisor."

A much more exquisitely made puppet in a white robe jumped onto the windowsill.

"He was unhappy, but he didn't tell the young lady why he was unhappy, so she couldn't guess. One day, the young lady discovered the military book being used to prop up a desk leg. She didn't remember at all that it was a gift from the Army Supervisor, thinking it was annotated by the advisors she had paid for. When she asked him why he used a book to prop up a desk leg, he became even more unhappy."

The white-robed puppet stomped its feet vigorously on the windowsill.

"So the young lady pondered, why was he unhappy? He even started dressing up as a scholar, a look he used to disdain the most. When the young lady discovered that the military book wasn't annotated by the advisors she had paid for, but was a gift from that Army Supervisor, she finally understood. Her husband was jealous."

The female general puppet walked back and forth on the windowsill with her hands behind her back, looking very troubled. "The young lady thought she had to coax her husband. But her husband was skilled in both literary and martial arts, wise and resourceful, a hero second to none in the world. She couldn't understand why he would be jealous of a mere Army Supervisor."

"After much thought, the young lady felt that she probably rarely expressed her feelings to her husband. So, she went to find him."

The female general puppet walked up to the white-robed puppet. Pulled by the thin strings, the two puppets' heads touched.

"The young lady recently learned a poem, with a line that says, 'Having seen the gentleman, how can I not be glad?' She heard it means that even in wind and rain, seeing you brings joy to her heart. She feels this is exactly how she feels every time she sees her husband, and she thought she should tell him."

The vermilion brush in Xie Zheng's hand had long left a large blot on the paper.

His figure seemed frozen in place, unable to move, yet his heartbeat was more intense than ever before—thump, thump, thump—as if it were about to burst through the flesh of his chest.

When Fan Changyu stood up beneath the window lattice, no matter how vast the world was, his dark eyes reflected only her.

His lady general, bathed in the radiant spring sunlight, leaned on the windowsill with a brilliant smile and said to him, "Xie Zheng, having seen the gentleman, how can I not be glad?"

Chapter 170

Extra Story : Gongsun Chapter 1

Outside the prayer hall, a light drizzle began to fall again. The weather was oppressive, and the incense rising from the Boshan censer seemed to grow heavier too, hanging low in the dimly lit space.

Qi Zhu propped her elbow on the table, watching Grand Royal Concubine An offer incense before the Buddha. Her fingertips, painted with henna, idly played with the cup on the low table as she asked slowly, "Mother, with so many people in this world praying and making wishes to the Buddha, can the Bodhisattva truly hear each one clearly?"

After finishing her offerings, Grand Royal Concubine An gently chided her daughter, "Do not be irreverent before the Buddha."

As she returned to her seat at the low table, she added, "Sincerity is what matters."

Qi Zhu lowered her eyes, still absentmindedly toying with the Crackled-ice-patterned porcelain cup half-filled with tea. The ripples made the tea leaves float and drift—whether it was the water or her heart that was unsettled remained unclear.

Grand Royal Concubine An paused in her prayer beads and asked, "Shu'er, is something troubling you?"

Qi Zhu withdrew her hand and rested her snow-lotus-root-like arms on the table, her delicate golden-orange gauze sleeves pooling on the floor like a blooming Golden lotus. Staring at the white jade Guanyin statue enshrined before the altar, she muttered, "No."

Grand Royal Concubine An pressed, "During the polo match the other day, both the Junior Tutor and Young Master Shen were injured trying to save you, weren't they?"

Qi Zhu pursed her cherry lips. "I am a princess of Great Yin, golden branches and jade leaves. Isn't it natural for them to rush to my aid? Besides, A Yu was there to save me."

A slight frown creased Grand Royal Concubine An's brow. "Shu'er, when did you become so willful and impolite?"

Qi Zhu fell silent, plucking at the petals of a tiny water lily, no larger than a palm, kept in a small porcelain jar nearby.

Knowing her daughter well, Grand Royal Concubine An sighed softly. "The Shen family has been distinguished for generations. Though Young Master Shen may not compare to the Prince Regent, he is widely respected in court for his virtue and has an excellent temperament. He would be a fine match for you. As for the Junior Tutor—though he now lectures the Emperor, the Gongsun clan of Hejian has stayed out of politics for a century, earning renown only among scholars. He placed third in the imperial exams at seventeen but refused an official post, merely to prove that the Gongsun family's legacy endures. He is close to the Prince Regent and, though not as unyielding, shares that scholar's untamed spirit—elusive as the wind. You could never hold him."

The water lily petals crumpled into mush in her pale palm. At last, Qi Zhu replied, "I'll heed your counsel, Mother."

Gathering her pale green silk shawl, she stepped out of the prayer hall. Grand Royal Concubine An watched her daughter's retreating figure and shook her head slightly before kneeling before Guanyin, palms pressed together in prayer. "May the Buddha show mercy..."

...

The drizzle was gentle as Qi Zhu left the hall, dismissing her attendants. She leaned against the leaning rail along the palace corridor, lost in thought as raindrops pattered against the banana leaves outside.

Her first meeting with Gongsun Yin had been when she was fourteen, accompanying her mother on a visit to Hejian.

After embracing Buddhism, her mother had vowed before the Buddha to pay homage at every temple she encountered. When her grandmother fell gravely ill, her mother spent three months at Hejian's famed Guangling Temple, praying for her recovery.

Temple life was dull and austere, with not a trace of meat in the daily meals. For her grandmother's sake, Qi Zhu endured it.

But being surrounded by elderly monks chanting scriptures day after day wearied her. Most of her time was spent wandering the mountain

temple, exploring its historic sites.

At the mountain peak of the temple stood a pavilion known as the Wind and Rain Pavilion, said to have stood for nearly a century, serving as the resting place of the temple's founding monk. Out of curiosity, Qi Zhu had climbed up to take a look.

Born and raised in the gilded halls of the imperial palace, she had seen the grandest palaces the world had to offer, and the pavilion atop the mountain did little to impress her. However, a stone table within the pavilion caught her interest. Carved into its surface was a grid for Elephant chess, with a set of unfinished game laid out using tea-lid-sized stone pieces in blue and white.

In those times, Go was more revered, as Elephant chess, with its two armies facing off, was considered too warlike, lacking the gentlemanly virtues of Go.

Qi Zhu had always been unconventional. She had come across numerous Elephant chess manuals in the Wen Yuan Pavilion's collection. That day, she sat in the Wind and Rain Pavilion for half a day until she finally figured out a move to break the stalemate, shifting one of the blue stone pieces on the board.

For the next couple of days, she nearly forgot about it. Later, out of sheer boredom, she decided to return to the pavilion to play a solitary game. To her surprise, she found that the white stone pieces on the opposite side of the table had also been moved—exactly the countermove expected after her previous breakthrough.

This unexpected delight left Qi Zhu deep in thought as she studied the board. After a long while, she moved another blue stone piece.

Returning that evening, she felt a quiet joy. The next day, climbing back to the pavilion, she found, as expected, that the opposing pieces had advanced once more.

For half a month, she ascended to the Wind and Rain Pavilion daily, engaging in this silent game with her unseen opponent. Sometimes, the opponent's strategy would stump her for days, but when she finally devised a countermove and shifted a piece, the white stones would respond the following day.

It was then that Qi Zhu suddenly wished to meet the person she was playing against.

The next day, she climbed to the pavilion early and waited from sunrise until sunset, but no one came.

Perhaps her last move had been too tricky, and the opponent hadn't found a solution yet? Or maybe they were simply delayed by other matters?

As Qi Zhu, filled with disappointment, prepared to descend, she spotted an elderly monk in gray robes approaching through the fading light. Seeing her in the pavilion, he pressed his palms together in a Buddhist greeting: "Amitabha."

Half surprised and half inexplicably wistful, Qi Zhu asked, "Venerable Master, was it you who has been playing this game with me these past weeks?"

The monk nodded with a serene smile. Noticing she had already made a move on the stone table, he shifted a white stone piece and clasped his hands. "This humble monk did not expect to find such a young lady as his opponent."

Hearing this, Qi Zhu felt a sense of relief. Of course—who else but a monk would be in Guangling Temple every day? Other visitors wouldn't linger for months like her mother, devoted to Buddhist rituals.

The monk's move was cunning, and Qi Zhu couldn't immediately think of a counter. As dusk fell, she bid the monk farewell for the time being.

There were multiple paths down from the Wind and Rain Pavilion, each leading to different halls and guest quarters below.

Not far along her usual route, inspiration struck Qi Zhu with a solution to the game. Eager to make her next move, she hurried back toward the pavilion.

The Wind and Rain Pavilion stood atop a solitary cliff. Before reaching the mountain's summit, one could only glimpse jagged rocks and the corner of its upturned eaves peeking through the dense foliage from below the stone steps.

Qi Zhu heard voices drifting down from the pavilion above.

"...This old monk has fulfilled Young Friend Gongsun's request and helped that female benefactor find peace before her departure." It was the voice of the elderly monk they had encountered earlier.

Qi Zhu's feet seemed rooted to the spot, her heartbeat suddenly racing.

"My gratitude to the venerable master."

Then came a young man's voice—exceptionally warm and clear, like a spring afternoon breeze passing through a courtyard, gentle yet impossible to grasp.

The old monk sighed softly: "This old monk observed that the female benefactor possessed both beauty and wisdom, with remarkable skill in Elephant chess. The two of you formed a connection over an unfinished game at this pavilion—surely this was fate's design. Why must Young Friend Gongsun sever this bond?"

The man laughed: "Yin is but a carefree idler with empty sleeves—how dare I mislead a fair maiden? I hadn't anticipated earlier that my chess opponent would be a young lady."

Qi Zhu could no longer make out the subsequent conversation between the man and the monk. When they departed, she hid behind the jagged rocks with her palace maids, only daring to steal a glance at the pavilion's occupant after they had gone.

The setting sun burned crimson, painting half the mountain in red. Walking beside the elderly monk, the man in snow-white robes with billowing sleeves seemed like an immortal bathed in sunlight.

Qi Zhu stared blankly at that retreating figure—her heart had never pounded so fiercely before.

The old monk had called him "Young Friend Gongsun," and he referred to himself as "Yin."

In the Hejian region, finding someone with the surname Gongsun was hardly difficult.

The Gongsun family of Hejian was a prestigious clan with a century-old legacy. Though none of their members had held official positions for a hundred years, they remained one of Hejian's most prominent families. Their Luyuan Academy could even rival Songshan Academy, renowned as the empire's foremost institution of learning.

Qi Zhu soon learned exactly who Gongsun Yin was—the eldest grandson of the Gongsun family's main lineage. The Gongsun matriarch visited Guangling Temple annually for Buddhist worship each March, and he had accompanied his grandmother on this trip.

Grand Royal Concubine An had always maintained a low profile during temple visits, never requesting the abbot to close the gates to other worshippers. She had even discussed Buddhist teachings with the Gongsun matriarch.

Though Qi Zhu hadn't formally met Gongsun Yin, she had heard numerous rumors about him.

They said he had shown exceptional talent since childhood—beginning his education at three, mastering the Four Books and Five Classics by five, and composing eloquent poetry by seven. All hailed him as Hejian's foremost scholar.

Qi Zhu sought out and studied his widely circulated poems and essays. The more she learned, the stronger her desire to know him grew.

In that hazy encounter, she had fallen for the person who played chess with her.

Now that shadowy figure gradually came into focus—she knew his name was Gongsun Yin.

He likely didn't know what she looked like either. That day in the pavilion, he had only glimpsed a woman's retreating figure before leaving, subsequently entrusting the temple monks to relay his message.

A month later, when Luyuan Academy reopened, Qi Zhu requested permission from her mother to visit her maternal grandparents' home. Knowing her daughter's restless nature, Grand Royal Concubine An considered a month's seclusion on the mountain already remarkable and granted her leave to return to the An family.

But Qi Zhu had no intention of dutifully remaining at the An residence. The An prefect had a wayward son named An Xu—not inherently wicked nor guilty of major offenses, but perpetually occupied with cockfighting and dog racing, utterly uninterested in studies. The prefect had swallowed his pride to secure his son a place at Luyuan Academy, only for the boy to constantly play truant.

Upon hearing that Gongsun Yin was also at Luyuan Academy, Qi Zhu hatched a plan with her unreliable cousin to pull off an impersonation scheme.

She disguised herself as a man to attend the academy in An Xu's stead, while An Xu falsely claimed she had gone to the countryside for leisure,

thus covering for her with the An family and the Grand Imperial Dowager Consort's people.

Though skilled in Elephant chess, Qi Zhu paled in comparison to the students who had studied diligently in poetry and literature. Fortunately, An Xu was already known as a dunce, so she managed to scrape through the entrance exams.

All students at Luyuan Academy lived on campus, most sharing rooms in pairs. With enough silver, one could secure a private room—Qi Zhu naturally spared no expense and successfully obtained her own quarters.

The academy divided its students into three teaching divisions: the Outer Dormitory, Inner Dormitory, and Upper Dormitory.

Perhaps due to Prefect An's influence with the academy's teachers, An Xu—utterly lacking in scholarly merit—was somehow placed in the Upper Dormitory.

Most students here were of lofty character and held little regard for those who gained entry through family influence or bribery. On her first day of lectures, Qi Zhu received no shortage of scornful glances.

Unfazed, she scanned the room, searching only for the figure she had glimpsed that day at the Wind and Rain Pavilion.

Yet after surveying the entire classroom, she found no trace of a similar silhouette and immediately frowned.

A portly son of a wealthy merchant, also thrust into the academy like An Xu, was assigned as her desk-mate by the teachers. The young man, assuming they were cut from the same cloth, nudged Qi Zhu's arm with his brush handle when he noticed her looking around. "What are you searching for, Brother An?"

Qi Zhu replied, "I heard... the eldest grandson of the Gongsun family, renowned as the 'Worthy of Hejian,' is also in the Upper Dormitory. Why don't I see him?"

The chubby boy ducked under the desk to take a bite of the chicken leg he had smuggled from the dining hall that morning before answering with greasy lips, "Ah, you mean Young Master Yin. The students here call him 'Little Teacher.' The academy's headmaster is his great-uncle, and his knowledge rivals many of the instructors. Next class is with Teacher Han—he's probably been summoned to help grade assignments."

Sure enough, when the old bell-ringer struck the bell hanging from the locust tree in the courtyard, every student in the room sat rigidly upright—even the chubby boy dared not nibble on his hidden chicken leg.

Qi Zhu watched as the locust blossoms of early March swirled wildly in the breeze outside the open door. Behind a stern-faced elder walked a young man in a white robe gilded by pale golden sunlight. He carried a stack of thick scrolls, his fingers long and veins pronounced, his features clear and bright, the corners of his lips slightly upturned as if bearing a hint of a smile.

Qi Zhu stared dumbfounded, feeling her heart jolt violently.

Was this the man who had spent nearly a month with her at the Wind and Rain Pavilion, slowly unraveling that unfinished game of chess?

Perhaps her gaze was too intense, for when Gongsun Yin entered the classroom, his spring-like eyes swept over her, pausing imperceptibly for a breath. His brows faintly furrowed before he calmly averted his gaze.

The chubby boy whispered to Qi Zhu, "Don't let Little Teacher's gentle demeanor fool you. Though he greets everyone with a smile, he grades assignments even stricter than the instructors. If you get a 'Ding' grade, you're in for a world of trouble!"

As soon as the chubby boy finished speaking, Qi Zhu heard the stern-faced instructor declare, "I have finished grading the entrance examination papers. All those who received a 'D' grade must copy the Academy Regulations twenty times in the Imperial Library after class!"

As he spoke, he picked up the top sheet from the stack of papers and raised his head, his expression noticeably harsher. "An Xu, D grade!"

Chapter 171

Extra Story: Gongsun Chapter 2

The spring sun in March was dazzling, but Qi Zhu and the little fatty were in a rather foul mood as they were punished to copy the Academy Regulations in the Imperial Library .

The plaque of the Imperial Library , bearing the character "imperial," was personally bestowed by Emperor Chengzu when the academy was first established. Inside, it housed tens of thousands of volumes, including many rare and lost texts that could still be found here. The students thirsted for knowledge, and some unique editions even required months of waiting to borrow.

The Imperial Library had seven floors. Outer Dormitory students could only borrow books from the first floor, Inner Dormitory students had access to the second through fifth floors, while only Upper Dormitory students could borrow books from the fifth floor and above.

Thus, within the academy, Outer Dormitory students admired Inner Dormitory students, who in turn admired Upper Dormitory students. Beyond academic respect, much of this admiration stemmed from the hope of befriending them to borrow books from the upper floors of the Imperial Library .

The Academy Regulations were also a verbose collection of hundreds of articles filled with archaic language. Anyone with slightly poorer scholarship might struggle to understand them—akin to a simplified version of the Dao De Jing .

From birth until now, Qi Zhu had never written so many characters in one go, and she was nearly dizzy from copying.

She had considered having her disguised maidservant copy for her, but it was said that similar incidents had occurred in the academy before. To prevent students from shirking their duties by having their attendants write for them, the instructors specifically assigned them to copy texts in the Imperial Library , under the supervision of Upper Dormitory students.

Naturally, this supervisor was none other than Gongsun Yin .

Other Upper Dormitory students, though aloof and proud, were reluctant to offend the punished students—many of whom were children of nobility or wealthy merchants—for fear of retaliation.

Only Gongsun Yin , the renowned heir of the Gongsun family, feared no such consequences. Moreover, he often spent entire days in the Imperial Library , so the instructors frequently entrusted him with supervising punished students.

Thanks to this, Qi Zhu and the little fatty were permitted to use a private study on the seventh floor of the Imperial Library .

As Qi Zhu bent over her desk copying the Academy Regulations , she occasionally glanced up and caught sight of Gongsun Yin lounging by the window with a book in hand. His white robes pooled on the floor, and his loosely tied dark hair and sleeves were bathed in a golden glow by the setting sun.

Resting his chin on one hand, he lowered his eyes, appearing deeply engrossed in his reading.

Each time she stole a furtive glance like this, Qi Zhu's heart would race for half the day, and when she returned to copying the Academy Regulations , she no longer felt as tired.

Until the little fatty nudged her elbow and whispered, "Brother An, don't you think the sunlight reflecting off the book would bother Brother Gongsun 's eyes?"

Just as Qi Zhu raised her head to take a closer look, an eagle's cry pierced the air. Gongsun Yin , who had seemed to be reading with his chin propped on his hand, suddenly nodded forward.

Then he blinked his drowsy eyes, straightened up, and rubbed his stiff neck. His gaze swept indifferently over Qi Zhu and the little fatty, lingering on them for two breaths before he seemed to remember why they were there. In a tone that was either puzzled or sympathetic, he murmured, "Still not finished?"

Qi Zhu and the little fatty, brushes in hand, froze like startled geese.

Had he been napping by the window this whole time?

Before Qi Zhu could ponder further, a strong gust blew in from the window, scattering the Academy Regulations they had spent the afternoon copying all over the floor. Qi Zhu hastily raised her sleeve to shield herself.

The chubby boy hurried to retrieve his scattered papers: "Ah, my freshly copied 'Academy Regulations'!"

By the window, Gongsun Yin raised an arm to shield himself from the blowing leaves and locust blossoms. Unexpectedly, the diving Gyr Falcon mistook his raised arm as a perch and extended its iron-hook talons to land on it.

Caught completely off guard, Gongsun Yin was knocked back several steps by the force of the raptor's descent, colliding with Qi Zhu's desk before finally tripping over a stool and falling to the ground.

Qi Zhu, standing nearby, had her legs struck by the toppling stool during Gongsun Yin's fall. In the ensuing chaos, she felt a sudden weight on her chest—Gongsun Yin's elbow had accidentally pressed against her bosom.

Horried, Qi Zhu ignored the pain in her legs and immediately pushed him away with all her might.

Gongsun Yin's expression shifted slightly as he moved his arm and propped himself up halfway, his ink-black hair disheveled yet still exuding an elegant charm.

Seemingly unaware of any impropriety, he asked, "My apologies for the fall. Did I hurt you, Brother An?"

Young Qi Zhu, whose chest was tightly bound, assumed he hadn't noticed her true gender and deepened her voice: "No! What kind of man can't handle a little pressure?"

Perhaps overcompensating, she even slapped her own chest emphatically.

A strange glint flickered in Gongsun Yin's eyes before he averted his gaze, murmuring, "Good."

The Gyr Falcon, realizing its mistake, chose not to land on Gongsun Yin's arm again. Instead, it folded its wings and perched on the desk, tilting its head to observe them with beady black eyes.

After standing up, Gongsun Yin lightly tapped the bird's head with his folding fan: "No memory at all. How many times must you cause trouble

here?"

The Gyrfalcon cocked its head and cooed: "Goo?"

Its iron-hooked claws, however, tore through Qi Zhu's painstakingly copied page of "Academy Regulations."

Qi Zhu's heart bled as she wailed: "My copied regulations!"

The bird stared at her with its round eyes and lifted one foot, as if asking, "Is this better?"

Gongsun Yin massaged his temples: "That 'barbarian' has truly made Xue Luan wilder by the day."

He turned to Qi Zhu: "How about this? I'll count all your copying in the Imperial Library today as passed. You can finish the rest another day."

The chubby boy, clutching his retrieved stack of "Academy Regulations," pitifully asked, "Brother Gongsun, what about me?"

Bathed in the golden sunset that accentuated his gentle smile, Gongsun Yin lowered his long lashes and amiably replied, "You too."

On their first day of copying punishments, both Qi Zhu and the chubby boy were permitted to leave early with all their work approved. The boy praised Gongsun Yin all the way to the dining hall, saying he wasn't as strict as rumored.

After all, their teacher would reject any submissions with poor handwriting or errors, forcing recopying.

Qi Zhu remained unusually quiet throughout the walk, until suddenly bursting into inexplicable laughter.

Puzzled, the boy asked, "Brother An, what's so funny?"

Qi Zhu quickly composed herself: "I... I'm just happy today's punishment is over."

The chubby boy nodded approvingly, clasping his hands together: "I'm happy too, truly blessed by the God of Wealth!"

Qi Zhu's lips twitched slightly: "Why the God of Wealth?"

The chubby boy explained: "My family's in business. My father says no matter what happens, just pray to the God of Wealth."

Qi Zhu: "..."

That night, Qi Zhu lay in bed, tossing and turning.

This Gongsun Yin, known as the "One Sage of Hejian" and the direct descendant of the Gongsun family, seemed quite different from the rumors.

Yet perhaps only someone with his carefree and unrestrained temperament could write those astonishingly brilliant and unconventional essays.

Unable to suppress her rising smile, Qi Zhu buried herself completely under the quilt, as if sealing away all the girlish thoughts of that March.

Afterward, whenever classes ended, she and the chubby boy would still go to the private study reserved for Gongsun Yin in the Imperial Library to copy the Academy Regulations. The chubby boy copied faster and faster, while Qi Zhu copied slower and slower.

She feared that once she finished, she would no longer have a legitimate reason to come here.

While they copied, on sunny days, Gongsun Yin would sometimes nap by the window, sometimes read obscure ancient texts or play chess alone, and sometimes lecture and answer questions for Upper Dormitory students who came seeking his guidance.

He was always easygoing and leisurely, never putting on the aloof airs of other Upper Dormitory students, yet he still made everyone feel a certain distance from him.

At least in this academy, Qi Zhu had never seen him get overly close to anyone.

The Gyrfalcon often visited, though. He seemed to have a good relationship with whoever sent him letters.

On the final day of copying the Academy Regulations, Gongsun Yin happened to be playing Elephant chess alone by the window. Qi Zhu made an extremely bold decision and spoke up while he was contemplating his next move.

Gongsun Yin's eyes clearly showed surprise: "Brother An also plays Elephant chess?"

Being looked at like that made Qi Zhu's heartbeat uncontrollably quicken. She forced herself to stay calm and replied, "Just the basics."

Thus, after the months-long game played across the Wind and Rain Pavilion at Guangling Temple, she and Gongsun Yin had their second match in the private study on the seventh floor of the Imperial Library.

That day, they played from afternoon until the lanterns were lit, only stopping when the old librarian came to shoo them away.

It was also the first time Gongsun Yin actively invited her to return to the Imperial Library the next day to continue their game.

That night, Qi Zhu buried herself under the quilt again, so excited she barely slept, yet also feeling a pang of sadness—he didn't seem to remember the girl who had played chess with him in the Wind and Rain Pavilion.

Because of their chess games, she and Gongsun Yin became thoroughly acquainted. Even the Upper Dormitory students who had previously looked down on her as a privileged noble sneaking into the academy now treated her better, all because of Gongsun Yin.

One day, as they played chess, the Gyrfalcon landed on the wide-open windowsill, its nearly half-zhang-long wings making the window frame seem small.

For the first time, Gongsun Yin didn't avoid her presence. He directly took a scroll of paper from the metal tube on the Gyrfalcon's ankle, read it, tucked it into his sleeve, and then called a servant waiting outside the study to take the bird to the kitchen for a plate of minced meat.

Qi Zhu couldn't help but ask curiously, "Is this Gyrfalcon yours?"

Gongsun Yin had just picked up an Elephant chess piece between his fingers when he heard her words. The corners of his lips lifted in a smile, his mood seemingly excellent. "That's a fine idea. Then I must carefully consider how to swindle Xue Luan away from that 'barbarian'."

This wasn't the first time Qi Zhu had heard him mention this "barbarian." As she cautiously placed her piece, she asked, "Is Xue Luan's master a foreigner?"

There were indeed many beyond the borders skilled in taming falcons.

Unexpectedly, Gongsun Yin nearly laughed himself to tears upon hearing this. Just as Qi Zhu grew flustered, she heard him say, "Though he's not a foreigner, he's undoubtedly a savage—wild as a jackal and fierce as a fighting bull."

In her mind, Qi Zhu conjured an image resembling a three-headed, six-armed, green-faced demon from temple murals. Her hand trembled as she placed her piece, unable to comprehend how someone as refined as Gongsun Yin could befriend such a crude and violent man.

Distracted, she quickly lost the match.

Gongsun Yin inquired, "Brother An seems preoccupied?"

Qi Zhu fabricated an excuse: "In my youth, I once read a manual of Elephant chess strategies titled 'Profound Mysteries of Military Strategy.' Unfortunately, what I saw was an incomplete copy, with many ingenious game scenarios missing. I'd heard the Imperial Library houses over ten thousand volumes and hoped to find a complete edition, but to no avail."

Gongsun Yin's hand, toying with a chess piece, paused slightly. "The Imperial Library indeed doesn't have it. However, the Gongsun family's collection contains a complete copy—a treasured possession of my grandfather's, unfortunately not available for loan."

This was the first time Qi Zhu grasped the depth of the Gongsun family's resources. The Imperial Library contained many works even the royal Wen Yuan Pavilion lacked, yet complete editions could be found here.

The chess manual she mentioned was widely believed to be extinct. She'd only ever seen fragments in Wen Yuan Pavilion—never imagining the Gongsun collection actually possessed a full version. As for other rare texts, their numbers must be incalculable.

After a stunned pause, she hurriedly replied, "A gentleman does not take what others cherish, let alone such a lost manual. The elder's protectiveness is only natural."

Gongsun Yin chuckled. Qi Zhu looked up to see the silhouette of returning birds flitting across the sunset-reddened sky. Barefoot and seated by the window, his white robe draped over one bent knee, elbow resting on it, his features gilded by the fading light, he said lazily, "Though it cannot be lent, I can copy the missing sections for you."

Her heart skipped a beat. Little did she know then that the day she received his handwritten copy would mark their parting.

Chapter 172

Extra Story: Gongsun Chapter 3

Qi Zhu's impersonation of her cousin to enter the academy was ultimately discovered.

Her unreliable cousin had gotten into a fight with a wealthy family's son over cockfighting and injured the boy. The wealthy official brought his son to demand an explanation, and it was only then that Prefect An realized his son hadn't been attending the academy at all, but had been running wild outside all this time.

An Xu was dragged home by his father, and naturally, Qi Zhu's deception of attending the academy in his place could no longer be concealed.

As a princess, Qi Zhu commanded respect even from her uncle, Prefect An. He reported the matter to Grand Royal Concubine An, who was still at Guangling Temple praying to Buddha. It was the old maidservant from Grand Royal Concubine An's entourage who personally went to the academy to "escort" Qi Zhu back.

With such an incident occurring, Prefect An could hardly send his son back to the academy without embarrassment. To protect the academy's reputation, it was publicly announced that An Xu had withdrawn voluntarily.

When Qi Zhu was "escorted" into the carriage by her mother's maidservant, the carriage was nearly leaving the academy grounds. She had been quiet and cooperative the entire way, but suddenly, she leaped from the carriage, gathered her skirts, and ran straight toward the Imperial Library.

Her maids and guards tried to pursue her, but unfamiliar with the academy's layout, they couldn't catch up immediately.

The old maidservant sent by Grand Royal Concubine An was Qi Zhu's wet nurse and knew her temperament well. In the end, she only sighed, "Let her go."

Qi Zhu had never run so fast before. The air she gasped burned her lungs, but she dared not stop for even a moment.

She thought, if she could just see him one more time—at least let him know she was the girl who had played chess with him at the Wind and Rain Pavilion.

If she left without any explanation, she would likely regret it for the rest of her life.

It was a rest day, and the academy was closed for the holiday. Some students had gone out, while others remained on the grounds. On the main path leading to the classrooms and the Imperial Library, people occasionally passed by. When they caught sight of the young woman in radiant red silk rushing past, they all stopped and stared, entranced.

The Jiangnan region was known for its beauties, but rarely had anyone seen one as luminous as a mermaid's pearl or as dazzling as the sunset glow. It seemed as if the splendor of mountains and rivers draped upon her would not be excessive.

Qi Zhu entered the Imperial Library directly. As she ran up the wooden staircase, she brushed past several people, uttering countless "excuse me's." None of the students she bumped into showed any anger; instead, they wore expressions of dreamlike bewilderment, as if fearing they had hallucinated from too much reading.

Qi Zhu paid them no mind. By the time she reached the seventh-floor study, she was completely out of breath. She knocked on the door and urgently called out the name that had lingered on her tongue countless times: "Gongsun Yin..."

Her voice trailed off abruptly. The man in white robes was still seated by the window where he usually read and played chess, but this time, he was writing something with an ink brush.

When he saw her, he looked up with a faint smile. "I was just thinking that once I finished copying this chess manual, I could send it to the An residence, and it would likely reach you. I didn't expect you to come in person."

His calm demeanor startled Qi Zhu. "You... knew about my identity all along?"

Gongsun Yin paused his brush. "I only learned of your identity today."

The final character he wrote was slightly smudged by a drop of ink, but he completed it nonetheless. Setting down the brush, he lifted the paper to shake off the excess ink. "I knew you were a young woman, but I didn't realize you were the imperial princess."

For some reason, Qi Zhu felt a lump forming in her throat. She asked, "Then did you know that the person playing chess with you at the Wind and Rain Pavilion in Guangling Temple was also me?"

Gongsun Yin looked at her and smiled with utmost gentleness. "I knew."

With just those words, a tear suddenly fell from Qi Zhu's eye, leaving a small damp stain on the wooden floor.

When Gongsun Yin folded the completed chess manual and handed it to her, she didn't take it. Instead, she stubbornly gazed at him through tear-blurred eyes. "I came to this academy for someone."

Gongsun Yin lowered his eyes slightly and remained silent, offering no further response.

In that moment, an overwhelming sense of grievance surged in Qi Zhu's heart. She was a princess, born to have everything she desired, and had never tasted the bitterness of rejection.

In the end, she didn't even take those pages of the fragmented chess manual. With reddened eyes, she turned and ran without looking back.

A month later, just before she and An Taifei departed for the capital, she received a letter sent from Luyuan Academy to the An residence. Inside were those very pages of the chess manual fragments.

No one knew how many nights she had spent in the quiet darkness, clutching that manual and shedding silent tears.

...

Snapping out of her memories, Qi Zhu watched the rain pouring from the eaves and suddenly smiled bitterly.

She had been trapped by that chess manual for so many years. Though she had long since returned it to its owner through A Yu, it was time she truly moved on.

Before she knew it, June arrived. Grand Royal Concubine An summoned the elderly matriarch of the Shen family to the palace for several

conversations. It seemed the Shen family was also willing to welcome a princess as their daughter-in-law.

When Qi Zhu accompanied Grand Royal Concubine An to the summer retreat at the imperial villa, the assigned escorting general was none other than Shen Shen.

Shen Shen shared one striking similarity with Gongsun Yin—he also loved to smile. But unlike Gongsun Yin’s effortless, spring-like warmth, his smiles were born of innate cheerfulness.

Every time he laughed, it radiated pure sincerity and fervor. With someone like him, even deceiving him felt like a sin.

Qi Zhu often thought his temperament was remarkably similar to Fan Changyu’s. Though not siblings by blood, they were closer than most.

During their stay at the villa, he would often take guards to hunt pheasants in the nearby mountains or catch fish from wild streams, then hand them to the kitchen to prepare delicious meals.

Grand Royal Concubine An, eager to foster a connection between the two, frequently tried to persuade Qi Zhu to join him. But Qi Zhu disliked the scorching sun, found mountain paths difficult to traverse, and hated sweating profusely, so she always declined.

Unable to sway her, Grand Royal Concubine An eventually heard about the upcoming Lantern Festival on Qixi and arranged for Shen Shen to escort Qi Zhu there.

The festival was crowded, and Qi Zhu, dressed in lavish attire, had no desire to jostle through the streets. Instead, she rented a painted boat to admire the Qixi lanterns and the young men and women releasing river lanterns from a distance.

Qi Zhu remained listless throughout, while Shen Shen, keeping her company, spoke little. Both felt awkward.

Out of courtesy, Qi Zhu reluctantly stood with Shen Shen at the bow for a while. Just as she was about to retreat into the cabin, a chorus of excited gasps rose from the riverbanks. Lifting her gaze, she saw a small boat drifting toward them from afar. An old boatman poled from the stern, while at the bow stood a figure as ethereal as an immortal.

Clad in white robes with ink-black hair, he held a folding fan, a faint smile playing on his lips. Amid the flickering lantern lights along the

riverbank, he seemed to have stepped out of a painting.

When Qi Zhu recognized him, her breath caught slightly.

In Great Yin's customs, during Qixi, young men and women could toss flowers at their beloved as a token of affection.

As Gongsun Yin's small boat passed by the shore, the young maidens on the bank eagerly threw flower branches toward him. However, the distance was too great, and most landed in the water, with only a few scattered blossoms reaching the boat.

Gongsun Yin did not pick them up, merely offering a slight bow toward the shore as a polite gesture.

The girls on the bank erupted in excited gasps, their delicate faces flushing pink as they clamored to ask which noble family this young master belonged to.

Qi Zhu watched quietly, feeling a faint tightness in her chest, but eventually, it all settled into calm. Just as she was about to turn away, a voice carried from afar: "This humble official greets Her Highness."

The voice, carried by the night breeze, was gentle and refined.

Qi Zhu lifted her gaze toward the small boat approaching the painted pleasure barge.

The man standing at the bow offered her an elegant salute, his wide sleeves and robes fluttering in the night wind, giving him an ethereal, almost immortal air.

Qi Zhu nodded slightly and replied coolly, "Junior Tutor."

As the boat drew closer, Gongsun Yin retrieved a white-pink peony from his sleeve and presented it to Qi Zhu with a bow. "I heard that on the Qixi Festival, one may offer flowers to their beloved. Yin ventures to present this to Your Highness."

Qi Zhu studied the vibrant peony in his hand for a moment before smiling faintly. "The Junior Tutor is too late. This princess has already accepted flowers from General Shen."

With that, she allowed her maids to assist her back into the cabin. Shen Shen was momentarily stunned, watching Gongsun Yin standing silently with the flower at the bow of his boat. Eventually, he coughed awkwardly. "Ah... Brother Gongsun, forgive my abrupt departure."

Gongsun Yin's lips still held that faint smile, though it seemed tinged with melancholy as he nodded slightly. "Yin has imposed."

As the small boat drifted away, Shen Shen lifted the curtain to enter the barge and unmistakably caught the glimmer of tears in Qi Zhu's eyes. Noticing his arrival, she hastily dabbed them away with a handkerchief.

Shen Shen sat across from Qi Zhu and said, "This humble Shen was presumptuous—I did not prepare flowers, nor did I intend to offer any to Your Highness."

His words bordered on rudeness, and the palace maid at Qi Zhu's side was about to reprimand him when he continued, "I know Your Highness came boating today at Grand Royal Concubine An's behest. Shen is but a rough soldier with little refinement. For Your Highness to endure my company is truly beneath you."

Qi Zhu quickly replied, "General Shen must not belittle yourself. Today, this princess came of her own will."

Shen Shen simply smiled at her. "Shen is a blunt man, so I'll speak plainly—Your Highness must forgive my lack of tact. I have a younger sister whose temperament resembles yours. Watching Your Highness quarrel with the Junior Tutor feels no different from watching my own sister. Though I do not know what misunderstanding lies between you, matters of marriage should not be decided in a moment of anger."

Qi Zhu suppressed the ache rising in her throat and shook her head. "This princess is not acting out of anger."

Shen Shen sighed softly. "If Your Highness had truly moved on, you would not be so heartbroken."

After their Qixi Festival boat outing, Qi Zhu and Shen Shen grew closer, though their relationship remained platonic. To Qi Zhu, someone so similar to Fan Changyu felt more like an elder brother.

Grand Royal Concubine An, unaware of this, was delighted to see their rapport improving.

As autumn approached, urgent reports arrived from the northern border once more. The throne of Great Yin had changed hands, and Wu'an Marquis, who had long guarded the frontier, returned to the capital to assist the young emperor. Seizing what they saw as a rare opportunity, the

Northern Turks repeatedly harassed the Great Yin civilians near Jinzhou, bringing the two sides to the brink of war.

Qi Yu was still young, and without Xie Zheng holding the court in the capital, chaos would surely ensue. After deliberation, the court first dispatched General Tang Peiyi of the Western Pacification to lead troops to the northern frontier, with General Fan Changyu of the Huaihua following with provisions.

Qi Zhu and Grand Royal Concubine An, upon receiving the news, also hurried back to the palace early.

Fan Changyu was heading to the northern frontier for battle, so naturally, she couldn't take Changning along. Upon hearing she would be separated from her elder sister for years, Changning clung to her waist and cried until she was a tearful mess.

Fan Changyu promised to send her letters every month via the Gyrfalcon, finally soothing the little tearful bundle.

Yu Qianqian knew Xie Zheng had countless matters to handle and likely couldn't spare much attention for Changning, so she proposed bringing Changning into the palace. Aunt Zhao was also granted permission to enter the palace together.

Two days before Fan Changyu's departure from the capital, Changning was still crying uncontrollably. Qi Zhu, whenever she had time, would go to the Cining Palace to help comfort the child.

Occasionally, Qi Yu was also there. Perhaps because children understand each other better, he always found ways to cheer Changning up.

The delicate little girl, her grape-like eyes swollen like walnuts, rubbed her eyes and asked pitifully, "When will Gongsun return to teach? Before leaving, A-jie told Ning Niang to study hard. Ning Niang must listen to A-jie..."

As she spoke, she began sniffing again, her large, dark eyes brimming with endless tears. She wiped them clumsily with her chubby hands, a sight that tugged at the heart.

Qi Yu said, "Gongsun is ill. He's been attending court meetings recently despite his condition. Once he recovers, he'll return to the Chongwen Hall to teach."

After wiping Changning's tears, Qi Zhu's hand holding the handkerchief suddenly tightened. "The Junior Tutor is ill?"

Qi Yu nodded. "He's been sick for over a month. Even the imperial physicians haven't been able to cure him."

On her way back from the Cining Palace, Qi Zhu was lost in thought. Her long-calm heart suddenly felt unsettled again.

Over a month? Counting back, he must have fallen ill after the Qixi Festival.

How could he have gotten sick? Was it from the river breeze that day?

In the following days, whenever she had time, Qi Zhu would take Changning to play. Changning had an excellent memory. Even if momentarily distracted by the new toys Qi Zhu brought, she would soon sit on the courtyard steps, her chubby arms resting on her knees, her hands cupping her chin, and her head full of tiny buns tilted upward as she gazed at the sky.

Occasionally, when a falcon flew by, her eyes would sparkle, only to dim again when she realized it wasn't the Gyrfalcon.

She was even mature enough not to cry in front of others. Only occasionally, upon waking in the morning or from a nap, as if momentarily forgetting her sister's departure, would golden tears well up in her eyes. But before anyone noticed, she would secretly wipe them away.

Qi Zhu genuinely cared for the child and gave her all the childhood toys she had collected in her palace.

Because she visited often, she also frequently heard court updates from the Empress Dowager and her son.

For instance, the northern frontier campaign was not going smoothly. General Tang Peiyi of the Western Pacification, after a forced march, was severely wounded in the initial battle due to exhaustion. Fortunately, Fan Changyu arrived with reinforcements in time, stabilizing the situation. However, the entire burden of defending against the invaders now fell squarely on Fan Changyu's shoulders.

For instance, the Prince Regent's methods had grown increasingly ruthless and cruel. When it came to military supplies for the northern frontier, no official dared make the slightest mistake, fearing they might become the Prince Regent's next target.

Or how the Junior Tutor had taught Qi Yu something new, devised some fresh national policy...

Though these were but fragments of news about that person, Qi Zhu found inexplicable comfort in them.

The Prince Regent would spare time every half-month to meet Changning at Chongwen Hall. Usually, Yu Qianqian would have her maidservant escort Changning there, but today the old woman happened to suffer a recurrence of her chronic back pain and couldn't get out of bed.

Having recently grown quite close to Changning, Qi Zhu offered to accompany her instead.

Unnoticed, winter had descended upon the imperial city once more.

As Qi Zhu waited outside the hall for Changning, a cold gust swept by, chilling her to the bone.

Clutching her brass-wired hand warmer tighter, she was about to stroll nearby when she spotted Gongsun Yin in white robes ascending the white marble steps with several officials, apparently heading to Chongwen Hall for political discussions.

Upon seeing her, they all bowed respectfully: "Greetings to the Grand Princess."

Since the inner court didn't interfere with state affairs, Qi Zhu merely nodded in acknowledgment.

But Gongsun Yin remained standing, telling his colleagues: "Gentlemen, please wait for me in the side hall first."

The officials exchanged glances but complied and withdrew.

Qi Zhu held her hand warmer tightly. Though winter was bitterly cold, her palms suddenly grew damp with sweat.

Gongsun Yin's gaze was gentle and composed. He still appeared unwell—his complexion poor, his frame noticeably thinner—yet he carried himself with newfound steadiness: "Might Your Highness spare a moment for conversation?"

They walked slowly through the small garden outside Chongwen Hall. Gongsun Yin began: "I heard Your Highness and General Shen are to be wed soon?"

Qi Zhu's grip on the warmer tightened. She stopped abruptly, her beautiful eyes turning frosty: "Did the Junior Tutor summon me out here just to offer premature congratulations?"

Gongsun Yin studied her intently, his refined features clearly pained as he replied: "If true, this humble official should indeed offer congratulations. But there are other matters I wish to discuss."

He continued walking. After a moment's hesitation, Qi Zhu followed.

The southwest wind blew fiercely. Gongsun Yin, still recovering from illness, occasionally inhaled cold air that triggered quiet coughs: "A century ago, the Gongsun family flourished greatly. Two empresses—one for Emperor Chengzu, another for Emperor Xuan—came from our house. But towering trees attract the wind. Our family's fate proved worse than the Qi family's seventeen years ago. When dragon robes were 'discovered' in the Eastern Palace, Crown Prince Shaoyang was stripped of titles. Two Gongsun empresses hanged themselves in the palace... The main lineage was exterminated through executions and exile. Even the plaque for the 'Imperial Library' at Luyuan Academy was nearly reclaimed by the throne... Later investigation revealed it was all a prince's fabricated scheme."

Here Gongsun Yin smiled bitterly: "What frame-up could be so flawless? The truth was simply that the emperor could no longer tolerate the Gongsun family's power. Our branch lineage survived by clinging to Luyuan Academy for a century, with the first clan rule being 'No member shall enter government service.'"

Qi Zhu stood stunned.

Gongsun Yin gazed at her and said slowly, "On your first day at the academy, I could tell you were a girl. It wasn't until we played that game of chess in the Imperial Library that I realized you were also the one I met at the Wind and Rain Pavilion in Guangling Temple."

The corners of his lips curved slightly, his eyes tinged with the obscure melancholy of time passed: "I admired that girl, only to later discover she was the princess of this dynasty."

The question she had asked him years ago in Luyuan Academy's Imperial Library finally received its answer today, yet Qi Zhu only felt her throat tighten.

Gongsun Yin continued to watch her with a faint smile, though it seemed fragile under the thin sunlight: "I will never enter officialdom in this lifetime—how could I dare to mislead her?"

Qi Zhu's eyes had already reddened, her breathing trembling faintly. She stared at him: "What do you mean by telling me all this now?"

A cold breeze stirred Gongsun Yin's snow-white robes as he stood there like a gaunt yet resilient pine: "After helping Jiuling overthrow Wei Yan and the Li family, I returned to Hejian and spent a day and night persuading my grandfather to amend our clan's rules, allowing our kin to serve in court. But to avoid repeating past mistakes, I will resign once His Majesty's power is firmly established."

"The year you returned to the capital, I placed third in the imperial examinations and entered the palace. Seeing the towering palaces where you resided, I never dared to ask if you would be willing to travel the land with me and live in seclusion. Today, I wish to be bold—when I resign and return home, would you be willing to join me as carefree wanderers?"

He smiled again: "The Gongsun family's centuries of endeavors have left us with modest means—enough to ensure you won't suffer hardship. Though Hejian can't compare to the capital's splendor..."

His smiles had always been gentle yet tinged with fox-like calculation, but now it seemed like a fragile mask barely concealing the shattered emotions beneath.

Qi Zhu coldly raised her eyes: "What if I say no?"

Gongsun Yin's smile stiffened before he finally clasped his hands with difficulty: "Then I have spoken presumptuously."

Qi Zhu ignored him, clutching her hand warmer as she hurried away.

Gongsun Yin remained where he stood, feeling an icy chill seep into his chest, covering his lips to suppress a low cough.

"Gongsun, you blockhead!"

A playful voice called from behind.

Pale-faced, Gongsun Yin turned to see Qi Zhu, her expression no longer able to suppress a smile as she declared with charming arrogance: "This princess demands your family's library—all ten thousand volumes—as betrothal gifts!"

Gongsun Yin froze momentarily before slowly breaking into a smile, replying softly: "Agreed."

...

Having just met her brother-in-law, Changning and Qi Yu hid behind a rockery, watching the scene unfold. Changning whispered to Qi Yu: "Is Uncle Gongsun going to marry the princess?"

Qi Yu nodded, his young face solemn as he pressed his lips together: "When I come into power, I won't act against the Prince Regent or Gongsun."

He added unhappily: "Only incompetent emperors distrust their ministers."

For a better view, Changning crouched by the rockery while Qi Yu stood behind her.

She tilted her head up to ask: "Then can you make me a princess someday?"

Qi Yu looked down at her: "You want to be a princess?"

Changning nodded eagerly: "Yes! Like Aunt Zhu—so majestic! The groom has to offer his family's wealth as betrothal gifts!"

Qi Yu frowned slightly: "This empire is mine—no one has more to offer than I do. Why not be my empress instead?"

Changning blinked her large, dark eyes in surprise: "Then will you give me this palace as betrothal gifts?"

Qi Yu said: "The realm itself."

Changning looked puzzled: "What's the realm?"

Qi Yu said, "From the lands where your sister wages war, to this imperial palace, and even further south—all of it is mine. If you become my empress, it will be yours too."

Changning tried to imagine just how vast that territory must be. She counted on her fingers for a long while before finally exclaiming in astonishment, "Even a falcon would take days to fly across it all?"

Qi Yu nodded.

In the end, Changning reluctantly agreed, "Alright then. To make sure you don't go back on your word, let's pinky promise."

"Pinky swear, a hundred years, no take-backs! Whoever breaks it is a puppy!"

That year's New Year's Eve, Changning spent in the palace with Yu Qianqian, her child, and Aunt Zhao. Her brother-in-law had settled all affairs in the capital before entrusting them to Gongsun Yin and his trusted aides, freeing himself for half a month to ride swiftly northward to find her elder sister.

The following autumn, the Grand Princess married the Junior Tutor.

After the new year, the Huaihua General returned victorious from the frontier. Throughout the year, she had repelled over twenty attacks from the Northern Turks. In the northern borders, alongside the "Xie" banner, she raised another Commander's Flag that struck fear into the Northern Turks—the "Huaihua" banner. The court, acknowledging her origins in Qingping County, ennobled her as the Qingping Marquis.

That same year, the twelve-year-old young emperor assumed personal rule. Xie Zheng resigned as Prince Regent and, together with his wife, the Qingping Marquis Fan Changyu, returned to guard the northern borders.

On the day the couple left the capital, the citizens, just as during their wedding, voluntarily gathered outside the city to bid them farewell.

The young emperor also rode out in his carriage to see them off. Changning, now much taller over the years, waved to him from her carriage.

When Qi Yu stepped forward to hand Changning the farewell gift entrusted to him by the Empress Dowager, his little finger lightly hooked hers. After a silent moment, he said, "Remember our promise."

Changning held the bundle he handed her without speaking, her cheeks slowly reddening as she avoided his gaze.

After Fan Changyu bid farewell to Qi Zhu, who had also come to see them off, she rode back to the carriage. The young emperor then turned to her and the stern man behind her, saying, "Aunt Changyu and Uncle, may you have a smooth journey."

Fan Changyu smiled. "Thank you for your kind words, Your Majesty."

Xie Zheng gave a slight nod. "With the realm at peace, Your Majesty may now act freely. The court has many capable ministers like Gongsun, Shen Shen, He Xiujun, and Lu Bai. Consult them in all matters. My wife and I will guard the northern borders for Your Majesty."

The young emperor bowed solemnly to the Martial Marquis, who had held the reins of power for years before fully relinquishing them to him. "Uncle and Aunt's great kindness is etched in Yu'er's heart. Yu'er will be a good emperor, worthy of Uncle and Gongsun's teachings."

Xie Zheng said no more, only patting the young emperor's still slender shoulder.

As the army set off northward, Fan Changyu rode alongside the carriage, looking at her sister, now blossomed into a young woman leaning against the window. She smiled and asked, "What did His Majesty say to Ning Niang?"

Changning gazed at her elder sister with smiling eyes. "It's a secret."

Fan Changyu chuckled and didn't press further, urging her horse forward to catch up with Xie Zheng riding ahead.

Under the setting sun, amidst lush grass, the two rode side by side. The Gyr Falcon soaring in the sky was now accompanied by a slightly mottled White Falcon.

Fan Changyu asked the man beside her, "Where shall we go first upon returning north?"

"Yanzhou."

She raised an eyebrow. "Why?"

The man lightly tugged the reins, the muscles of his forearm beneath his archer's sleeves flexing slightly. His strikingly handsome face, though cold and imposing, had drawn many gazes along the way. Only when he looked at the woman beside him did a hint of tenderness appear in his eyes. "To take you to see the sunrise at Mount Yan."

Fan Changyu laughed. "And then hunt at Huizhou's hunting grounds?"

Xie Zheng gave a soft "Mm."

It was what he had once promised her.

Under the slanting sunlight, after riding ahead of the army, the female marquis on horseback grabbed her husband's collar and kissed him.

Birds chirped, and the mountains were awash with blooming flowers—a perfect spring scene.

On that autumn day in the sixteenth year of Yongping, they had once lost each other amidst a sea of reeds.

In the spring of the fourth year of Yongxing, they journeyed north together and were never parted again.

Chapter 173

Extra Story: Qi Min Chapter

When Qi Min was still the carefree imperial grandson of the Eastern Palace, his daily thoughts revolved only around completing the lessons left by his father, and his worries extended no further than how to coax his mother into letting him play a little longer with the kickball.

The fall of Jinzhou and the battle report announcing his father's death shattered the fragile peace the Eastern Palace had maintained.

His father was dead. He was heartbroken, but his mother's grief seemed far deeper than his own.

The Eastern Palace was slowly but steadily losing its people.

His father's honored guests often came to the Eastern Palace in secret to discuss important matters with his mother. Each time they left, the look in her eyes when she gazed at him grew heavier.

He was still young and did not understand what it meant, but at night, when his mother stayed by his side, she often lay awake for hours.

Even when she dozed off, the slightest movement from him would startle her awake. She would hold him tightly, murmuring something like, "I will make sure he lives," her face streaked with silent tears.

He was only four or five years old at the time. Thinking her sorrow was solely for his father's death, he patted her shoulder and promised he would protect her when he grew up. But his words only made her weep harder.

It wasn't until the fire swept through the Eastern Palace that he finally understood what his mother had been planning all along.

The distant glow of the burning palace dyed his vision red. His mother pressed him into a brazier herself, the searing heat of the coals sending spasms of pain through his bones. He screamed until his voice gave out.

His mother wept into his ear, begging him to "live, no matter what," but the only thought in his mind was: It hurts too much. Living hurts too much. Just let me die.

The agony nearly drove him unconscious. The scorching heat on his face seemed to seep into his skull, burning his very brain.

When the Shadow Guard his father had left behind carried him to safety, he clung to the man's shoulders and watched as his mother overturned the brazier. The flames quickly licked up the silk tablecloth, and his mother took a candle to the layers of drapes hanging in the main hall.

The fire slowly devoured the entire palace. By then, he was too broken to make a sound. Instinctively, he reached out toward his mother, wanting to save her—but she only smiled gently at him through the flames. Too far to hear her words, he barely made out the shape of her lips: Live.

(Two)

When he woke again, it was in a completely unfamiliar place. The pain was still there—his whole body ached, but his face and head burned as if fire still smoldered beneath his skin. The agony was so unbearable he wished he could bash his head against a pillar until it split open. His vision swam, blurred.

His mind was hazy, and he weakly called out, "Mother..."

But this time, there was no warm embrace, no gentle hand to comfort him.

Amid the clamor of unfamiliar voices, he heard someone sob, "Poor Huaige... the Crown Princess is already gone..."

Later, when the others had left, only one person remained by his bedside, holding his hand. She whispered to him, "Your Highness, this servant is Lan Shi, once a close attendant of the Crown Princess. Her Highness entrusted you to my care. From now on, your mother is no longer the Crown Princess, but the Princess of Changxin. In this Changxin Prince Manor, trust no one but me. I will protect you."

He was still in pain, tears like molten lava rolled from the corners of his eyes, slipping into his temples. Wherever the wet trails passed, his skin burned with a searing agony.

He heard that voice continue to speak softly to him, "Don't cry."

Qi Min didn't know whether he was crying from the pain or from the grief of remembering his mother had perished in the fire. He only felt an overwhelming, all-consuming pain—inside and out...

The hand holding his was warm, but nothing like his mother's.

From then on, he had neither a father nor a mother.

(3)

Due to the burns and the memory of his mother dying in the flames, Qi Min developed an extreme fear of fire after his vision returned.

At night, even the flicker of a candle would send him into hysterical screams, smashing anything within reach.

From then on, his courtyard plunged into darkness as soon as night fell. The servants, afraid of disturbing him, walked in utter silence, turning his residence into a lifeless tomb.

Anything hot triggered his terror. He would only eat cold meals and drink cold medicine, even insisting on cold water for washing and bathing.

He would rather suffer from chills than touch anything warm.

In the countless days and nights after losing his mother, he became just as she had been in the Eastern Palace—unable to sleep, startled awake by the slightest rustle of wind outside.

His nerves were always on edge, and for a time, he was even afraid to sleep—terrified he might reveal something in his nightmares.

Later, as his wounds healed slightly, the layers of white bandages wrapped around him were removed. When a maid entered to bring water for his washing, she screamed in fright and dropped the basin.

An elderly matron came to see what had happened, but upon seeing him, her legs gave way in fear.

In the end, it was Aunt Lan who scolded the others away and personally fetched water to tend to him.

Every reflective surface in the room had been removed, so he couldn't see his own appearance. But the burn scars on his arms—uneven, fleshy red patches—were undeniably hideous and repulsive.

His stepmother—his "mother's" younger sister, who had married into the manor—visited him once. She was so horrified she didn't even step inside, paling at the doorway. Rumor had it she couldn't eat for days afterward.

He remained silent throughout, until one day when Aunt Lan forgot to take away the washbasin after tending to him. He caught a glimpse of his

reflection in the water.

The reflection was blurry, but it still terrified him enough to kick the bronze basin over.

Having not spoken for so long, his voice emerged as a hoarse, grating scream.

That wasn't him. He remembered what he used to look like—his father had even commissioned a portrait of him and his mother. He had been delicate-featured, with rosy lips and pearly teeth. He wasn't the grotesque thing in that basin!

Aunt Lan rushed in at the sound and held him, comforting him for a long time.

But his temperament grew increasingly dark, solitary, and volatile. The slightest look of fear from a serving maid could send him into a rage, ordering her beaten to death with sticks.

He became sensitive, irritable, and quick to anger, afraid to see people and terrified of their shocked or horrified gazes.

Qi Min felt he wasn't even like a rat scurrying across the street—but a diseased rat covered in mange, its fur patchy and revolting.

The only benefit of those burns was that Prince Changxin and his wife no longer visited him so easily.

The new princess consort, whether out of genuine sisterly affection for the late princess consort or because she recognized that although he was the "legitimate eldest son" of Changxin Wang, he was already a cripple who posed no threat to her or the child in her womb, was willing to build a reputation for herself as virtuous. Even though she never visited him again, she never shortchanged him in terms of daily necessities for his courtyard.

Aunt Lan's husband was a merchant with extensive connections, and she soon found him a renowned physician from the martial world.

The physician said that fortunately, he was still young, and the burned skin could be replaced and would heal properly.

The pain of skinning, known as one of the ten most brutal tortures, was cruel and bloody. The extent of his burns was vast, making it impossible to replace all at once.

The dead skin on his body was gradually replaced over several years.

The agony of flesh being cut away could only be understood by those who had experienced it firsthand.

His hands and feet were tightly bound to the bed, and the wooden gag in his mouth was bitten out of shape.

It was excruciating.

Countless times, he thought it would be better to just die, but death eluded him.

Then revenge it was. All this pain was bestowed upon him by his enemies, and his mother had died for his sake. He had to take revenge!

(4)

By the time Qi Min had completely replaced all his burned skin, the new princess consort's son was already running around.

Over the years, the household had grown accustomed to his unpredictable moods. Because of the burns on his face, he had worn a mask for years. Even after his facial skin had healed, he never removed the mask in front of anyone at Changxin Prince Manor.

The household assumed the physician had failed to cure him and, fearing his displeasure, never dared to gossip about it.

The new princess consort was shrewd enough not to mention it either. Her son had already been named heir. Perhaps out of pity for this "orphan of her sister," she occasionally showed him some compassion, often urging her healthy, lively son to befriend him.

Qi Min felt nothing but disgust.

The entire Changxin Prince Manor was his enemy!

Her healthy, adorable son only reminded him of his own monstrous appearance, filling him with envy and hatred.

Sui Yuanqing could practice martial arts, ride horses, and shoot arrows, while he was plagued with chronic illnesses, relying on medicine day after day.

He wanted to learn martial arts too, but even Aunt Lan, who usually sided with him, refused, saying his body was too weak.

Only Fu Qing, the Shadow Guard left by his father, was willing to teach him in secret.

From then on, he vaguely understood that only Fu Qing would obey his commands unconditionally. Aunt Lan was loyal to him, but she could still refuse him.

(5)

Qi Min truly began to doubt Lan Shi's loyalty when he was seventeen. After secretly practicing martial arts, he overexerted himself and triggered his chronic illness again.

Illness struck like a collapsing mountain, and the physician said his condition was dire.

Though delirious, his mind was clear. He overheard the servants telling Lan Shi that they shouldn't have let him undergo skin replacement, as the immense suffering had further ruined his health.

He had always believed Lan Shi found the physician for him out of pity, but he heard her say, "If we hadn't replaced his skin, with his face burned beyond recognition, how could he ever sit on that throne?"

So it wasn't for him—it was for the throne.

Lan Shi also said that while his health was still manageable, they should select a few women for him to leave behind an heir. If anything happened to him, there wouldn't be chaos.

Qi Min had never felt such bitter irony. His heart turned cold, so cold it terrified him.

So Lan Shi wasn't loyal to him at all. Her loyalty was only to his identity as the bloodline of Chengde Crown Prince.

Even if it wasn't him, but another person with his father's bloodline, Lan Shi would have served with the same dedication.

When his health improved slightly, a bevy of beauties—some plump, some slender—were sent to his courtyard.

He flew into a rage, and though Lan Shi seemed to respect him, she never wavered in her determination to ensure he left behind an heir.

Lan Shi always claimed it was for the sake of their grand revenge. He sneered and asked if she was hoping for his death. Lan Shi knelt and

tearfully denied it, even citing numerous examples of noble houses vying for power, insisting that an heir was the greatest assurance for their cause.

In the end, he relented—not because he was convinced by Lan Shi’s arguments.

It was simply that his power had not yet reached the point where he could fully control the Zhao Family. The forces his mother had left him all obeyed Lan Shi’s orders.

The only ones he could truly rely on were the Shadow Guards his father had left in the Eastern Palace. But if he killed Lan Shi and her son, the Zhao Family’s intricate game would collapse. So he had to keep them alive, letting them continue to work for him—for now.

Filled with disgust, he chose the most timid and docile woman from the selection Lan Shi had sent.

Perhaps due to his notorious reputation for cruelty, the woman was terrified of him. When she came to his chambers, she trembled uncontrollably, never daring to look at him.

Qi Min felt sick—not just at the thought of siring an heir, but suddenly, even his own identity disgusted him.

The stepmother of the household kept a Persian cat, a tribute from foreign lands. She adored it so much that, to preserve its noble bloodline, she had specially arranged for it to mate with several beautiful white cats.

Qi Min felt like that Persian cat, dragged away for breeding.

He didn’t even get a clear look at the woman who came to serve him. Lan Shi, fearing his poor health, had even drugged him—so he had almost no memory of what happened.

When he woke, the bed was stained with blood, the woman lying pale and unconscious beside him. He didn’t know whether she had fainted from fear or pain.

The world spun before his eyes, the nausea overwhelming, making him wish he could peel off his own skin.

He truly was nothing more than livestock, drugged just to get the job done.

He unleashed the worst fury he had ever known, ordering everything in that room burned to ashes. He submerged himself in the icy lake until his

skin wrinkled, yet still felt tainted, unable to wash away the filth clinging to him.

The woman who had served him fell gravely ill afterward, her mind dulled, as if she had turned into a simpleton.

The servants whispered that she had been frightened into madness, making them fear him even more.

Qi Min felt nothing but revulsion. There wasn't a moment when he didn't want to kill that woman—she had seen him reduced to a drugged beast.

Every time he remembered, his violent impulses surged uncontrollably. Only killing could ease it slightly.

After this incident, Lan Shi seemed to realize she had crossed a line. She became more restrained, adopting a pained expression in his presence—as if she were the loyal servant misunderstood in her devotion to their cause.

But Qi Min only wanted to grind that saintly face of hers into the mud, to drug her too and make her understand what it felt like to be treated as breeding stock.

When he decided to kill the woman who had served him, the servants assumed she had failed to please him and dared not question it.

Lan Shi didn't interfere this time—a small concession on her part.

However, that woman was truly fortunate. Her monthly cycle had stopped, and she was diagnosed with Pregnancy Pulse.

He could no longer kill her.

He knew that Lan Shi would soon have other options.

From this moment on, he grew increasingly wary of Lan Shi and her son.

As long as that woman gave birth to a male child, his position could be replaced at any time.

Upon learning that one of his concubines was pregnant, the stepmother Consort also began to guard against him, using the pretext of adding more servants to his courtyard to plant spies around him.

His health was poor, and he could no longer compete with Sui Yuanqing. But if he had a son, things might be different.

The stepmother Consort appeared magnanimous—Changxin Prince Manor was filled with countless concubines, yet she never showed jealousy. But while Changxin Wang's concubines bore him many daughters, not a single one had given him a son.

Changxin Wang might have suspected something, but without evidence, he had once kept a group of women outside the manor. Among them, some had borne him sons.

The descendants of the Prince's household naturally could not be raised by disreputable outsiders. They would all be brought back to the manor, just like his "good younger brother" Sui Yuanqing, and trained from childhood by martial instructors.

However, those children who were brought back always died young from various causes—or, like him, grew up sickly and weak.

Qi Min believed Changxin Wang must have known something, but the reason he hadn't broken with the Consort was likely due to the influence of her family.

With Sui Yuanqing as his only capable son, Changxin Wang naturally had to raise him well. Whatever Xie Zheng, the son of Xie Linshan—who was raised by Wei Yan—studied, Changxin Wang would immediately arrange for Sui Yuanqing to learn the same.

Qi Min knew full well that his father's death had been orchestrated by Wei Yan and Changxin Wang, those two great villains. He loathed them to the core, but one held overwhelming power at court, overshadowing the emperor's authority, while the other ruled as a virtual king in the northwest. For now, he could do nothing against them.

Yet Qi Min keenly sensed that Wei Yan and Changxin Wang must have fallen out. However, since they had once colluded, each held damning evidence against the other, maintaining a facade of peace.

Changxin Wang had raised Sui Yuanqing in Xie Zheng's mold precisely so that Sui Yuanqing could understand his opponent and, in the future, counter the blade Wei Yan had forged on the battlefield.

Qi Min bided his time, but a vague plan for revenge began to take shape.

He needed to escalate the conflict between Changxin Wang and Wei Yan, let them tear each other apart first, then uncover evidence of their collusion and expose them both.

At court, the Li family, known as the leaders of the upright faction, held a reputation for virtue and opposed the factions of Wei and Sui.

Unfortunately, the puppet emperor on the throne also had ambitions. He had long married a daughter of the Li family, and Grand Tutor Li served as the emperor's teacher.

If Qi Min rashly approached the Li family, compared to the puppet emperor who already had ties of mentorship and marriage with Grand Tutor Li, he would merely be an outsider.

Thus, to secure the Li family as an ally, he first had to dismantle their alliance with the young emperor.

(6)

Qi Min crossed paths with the woman carrying his child again on a moonlit night, three months after her Pregnancy Pulse diagnosis.

During this time, he had to guard against Lan Shi and her son, as well as the stepmother Consort, while beginning to lay the groundwork to further inflame the conflict between the Sui and Wei families and drive a wedge between the puppet emperor and the Li family. It was truly a web of schemes.

He understood that he could no longer rely on Lan Shi or the Zhao Family. He had to expand his own power to avoid being treated as nothing more than breeding stock.

Despite his fear of fire, he forced himself to confront it—though his methods were undeniably cruel.

His way of overcoming fear was to personally burn alive those who betrayed him or exposed themselves as spies.

The piercing, agonized screams assaulted his eardrums. The faces twisted by flames, shifting from tearful pleas for mercy to curses and condemnations against him. The scent of burning flesh in the air gradually turned from something almost fragrant to the acrid stench of char.

Even though the fire was far from him, the old burns on his body seemed to sear with pain anew. In such moments, he allowed no one to witness his wretched state.

He dismissed everyone, locking himself inside a stone chamber. Outside the iron bars, he left a bonfire—the very thing that terrified him—and

curled up in a corner like a beast, alone in facing the nightmares born from the great fire of his childhood in the Eastern Palace.

In his memories, the face of his mother, burned alive in the Eastern Palace, sometimes morphed into the blurred yet horrifying reflection of his own burned visage he had once seen in a basin of water. Other times, it became the faces of those he had burned to death.

Day after day, he shut himself inside the stone chamber, struggling awake from nightmares filled with flames and the scars of charcoal burns. Each time, he emerged pale, his clothes soaked in cold sweat. His temperament grew visibly more paranoid, violent, and brooding.

Once, while confronting his fear of fire alone, he was driven to madness.

The old burns ached unbearably at the sight of flames, as though he were back in that moment when he had nearly been burned to death.

Even the renowned physician who examined him could offer no cure.

Having secretly trained in martial arts with the Shadow Guard for years, in his frenzy, he broke through the stone chamber's door. The guards outside, fearing they might harm him, hesitated to stop him, and in that moment, he seized a blade and gravely wounded one of them.

Phantom pain wracked his entire body. Convinced he was burning alive, he leaped into the frozen pond without a second thought. In his agony, he even forgot to hold his breath, and icy water rushed into his nose.

Too weak to struggle or save himself, he believed he would truly die there.

But then, a slender yet warm hand grasped him as he sank deeper into the frigid depths.

At first, he didn't know who the woman saving him was—only that she was so frail, yet still fought to pull him toward the pond's edge.

After dragging him ashore, she pressed on his chest and abdomen, thinking he had drowned. Then, for some reason, she bent down and kissed him.

Qi Min had no memory of ever being this close to anyone. His only experience with intimacy had been under the influence of drugs, and the aftermath—a room reeking of blood and cloying incense—still sickened him to recall.

Since then, he had even despised contact with women.

But this person was different. Her lips were soft and warm, and her scent was not unpleasant.

After kissing him for a while, she pressed on his chest again, her soaked hair dripping cold droplets onto his face. Her voice was urgent: "Wake up! Don't die here like this!"

Qi Min lay there for a long time before finally regaining some strength. He coughed up water and opened his eyes, catching a glimpse of his rescuer under the moonlight.

She looked gentle and obedient.

This was his first impression of that woman—from the arch of her brows to the contours of her features, there was a hint of docile obedience, yet her eyes held an audacious boldness and unrestrained freedom, as if she had never been bound by any rules.

For the first time, Qi Min understood what it felt like to be hooked by someone's gaze, right in the depths of his heart.

She just looked at him like that, and he felt an itch in his chest.

Realizing he was awake, she sighed in relief and plopped down on the ground without hesitation, wringing out her soaked skirt and hair while muttering, "Thank goodness you're awake. Buddha above, saving a life counts as a good deed. I hope the Bodhisattva blesses me and everything goes smoothly..."

Listening to her rambling, Qi Min struggled to ask, "Who are you?"

She had seen him in such a wretched state—by all rights, he should kill her.

Yet, at this moment, his heart was unexpectedly calm. Even her audacious act of kissing him for so long didn't stir much disgust in him.

Perhaps it was because she had just saved him, or perhaps she was the first person in years who looked at him without the fear one would show a monster.

Or maybe he was just too weak right now.

In any case, Qi Min's mind hadn't yet conjured the thought of killing her.

The girl rolled her eyes and countered, "And who are you? What are you doing jumping into this pond in the middle of the night?"

She looked sweet and soft, but she had some wits about her.

Qi Min's courtyard was built in the quietest part of the prince's estate, with the Frozen Pond and the purple bamboo grove connecting to the back mountain.

Assuming she was a low-ranking maid from his own courtyard—given her attire and her presence here at night—he lied, "I'm a guard from the estate. The young master craved fish and ordered me to catch some from the pond."

The girl's eyes widened in shock. "He wants fish in the middle of the night?"

A mocking smile tugged at his lips. "Yes. If I don't catch any, I probably won't live to see tomorrow."

The servants in the estate trembled at the mention of him, fearing him like a demon. This story should coax plenty of curses from her.

But the girl only frowned and muttered, "This damned place eats people alive."

She said nothing more, picking up a large bundle she had set aside before entering the water and saying, "It's pitch black out here. Don't go fishing anymore. I'm leaving. Since I saved your life, do me a favor—pretend you never saw me tonight."

Qi Min finally understood why she was here so late at night when he noticed the bundle in her hands.

Sitting up halfway, he leaned against a bamboo stalk and said, "Servants who flee the estate are beaten to death as a warning to others."

Her bold steps faltered slightly, and she turned to eye him suspiciously. "I saved you. You're not thinking of reporting me, are you?"

Uncharacteristically patient, he even smiled slightly. "No. I'm just reminding you of the rules."

The girl stood still for a moment before suddenly walking back toward him. Her bundle had no rope, so after rummaging, she pulled out belts from a few sets of clothes. She used them to tie his hands to the bamboo behind him, then stuffed a robe into his mouth.

Qi Min was stunned by her actions. Had he not just endured a bout of phantom pain and weakened from nearly drowning, he would've snapped her neck the moment she tried to touch him.

After finishing, she crouched in front of him and said, "Thanks for the reminder. I don't know you, and I can't take you with me. To keep you from snitching, I'll tie you up. That way, when you're found tomorrow, you can explain yourself and avoid being accused as my accomplice."

He was gagged, his eyes cold as ice yet burning with fury, letting out two muffled groans.

The woman pointed at herself. "Me? Don't you worry about that. By the time the household realizes I'm gone tomorrow, I should already be beyond Chongzhou's city gates!"

She hoisted her bundle again and walked deeper into the bamboo grove, waving her hand behind her with remarkable nonchalance.

Qi Min stared blankly at her retreating figure. For the first time in his life, he had been treated this way. He ought to have been furious, but for some reason, he couldn't muster any anger at all.

The woman bore him no malice, and there was something inexplicably compelling about her.

Naturally, she didn't succeed in escaping the prince's estate either.

Not long after she left, the Shadow Guards, having discovered the disturbance in the stone chamber, followed the trail and found him. Horrified, they quickly untied him.

Uncharacteristically, Qi Min didn't fly into a rage. Instead, he ordered them to take the estate's guards and bring back unharmed the maidservant who had fled from the back mountain.

The Shadow Guards worked with great efficiency. By the time he had changed his clothes in his room, the woman had already been captured.

And they brought back another piece of news: she wasn't some lowly servant girl, but the woman who carried his bloodline.

This answer left Qi Min stunned for a long time.

His first thought was, that woman didn't recognize him either?

This realization displeased him.

He had been disgusted by the woman who drugged him to consummate their union and loathed the unborn child in her womb—even though it was his own flesh and blood.

No one would like someone who could threaten their life and status at any moment.

A young tiger, once grown, would be driven from its territory before it could challenge the Tiger King.

Before this night, he had only thought about when to kill the woman and the child in her womb.

But after this night, he suddenly felt a flicker of interest in her.

She was already pregnant, yet she dared to run. It seemed she didn't want to be confined here either?

In her, he saw something he himself yearned for: freedom.

(7)

Qi Min wasn't in a hurry to see the woman, nor did he order any punishment for her.

To be precise, he hadn't yet decided how to deal with her.

Lan Shi couldn't quite grasp his feelings toward the woman, but seeing that he didn't seem to despise her as much as before, she took the initiative to share more information. For instance, the woman's surname was Yu, she had no given name, and her family was so poor that her parents had sold her.

Qi Min paid little attention to these details. He was methodically escalating the friction between Wei Yan and the Prince of Changxin.

Only occasionally, in the dead of night, after solitary martial practice, when he soaked in the frozen pond to soothe the bruises from training, would he inexplicably recall the woman's kiss.

She was his first woman, and perhaps he didn't find her as repulsive as he thought?

A month later, Qi Min finally inquired about the woman's recent condition.

His subordinates wore slightly odd expressions, only saying that she was "doing well."

Qi Min didn't understand what "doing well" meant, so he went to see for himself in the courtyard where she lived—and finally understood.

She was always quietly and leisurely going about her own business. Finding the nourishing meals from the kitchen unpalatable, yet unwilling to deal with cooking fumes during her pregnancy, she even instructed the cooks on how to prepare the dishes.

As if she weren't the same person who had once slung a bundle over her shoulder and tried to flee in the dead of night.

Hmm, she had become obedient.

Or perhaps, she was always trying to make herself as comfortable as possible.

When she learned he was the legendary "Eldest Young Master," she was indeed surprised for quite some time, but soon calmed down. She promptly admitted her mistakes when necessary and never missed a bite of her meals.

Qi Min felt as though he had punched cotton—his force met with no resistance.

Still, it was rather amusing.

She was the only person in the manor who truly wasn't afraid of him. Even when he sat right across from her, she could eat and drink heartily, completely disregarding him.

It was precisely this casualness that made Qi Min enjoy her company more and more.

She was respectful toward him, yet not overly so.

Like a cat that always wanted to puff up in defiance but had no choice but to suppress its temper, letting itself be molded however others pleased.

At times, he even began to think that having his eldest son born to a woman like her wasn't so hard to accept after all.

Because of the peace and tranquility he found in her presence, the humiliation and loathing he once felt from being drugged gradually faded.

But soon, he tasted the bitterness of betrayal.

That woman had fled.

She took all the gold and silver jewelry he had bestowed upon her, along with her personal attendants and a Shadow Guard from Changxin Prince Manor who often ran errands for her, vanishing without a trace.

He sent Shadow Guards to search for her, but they only traced her as far as a merchant caravan that had left the border, heading toward the Western Regions.

Qi Min was furious, grinding his teeth in anger.

For five full years, he used the Zhao Family's connections to search for her beyond the border.

During this time, Lan Shi did urge him to select a few more concubines to his liking.

But by then, he had already built up his own power and was no longer as helpless as before, forced to obey Lan Shi's every arrangement.

How could he tolerate being treated like a puppet again?

Lan Shi hit a hard wall and sensed his growing dissatisfaction with both her and the Zhao Family, so she dared not push further.

(8)

News of that woman surfaced again in Qingping County.

When Qi Min received Zhao Xun's letter, he nearly laughed in anger. He had always assumed she had fled beyond the border—never expecting that the trail she deliberately left behind years ago had been a decoy. All this time, she had been hiding in Jizhou.

That woman had even borne him a son.

While Lan Shi and her son were overjoyed, Qi Min, as he set off for Jizhou, only thought indifferently—should that little bastard be killed or spared?

At the time, Sui Yuanqing was disguised as an official sent to collect grain taxes, deliberately stirring chaos in Jizhou to incite public outrage. Once the enraged populace rose up, they would collaborate from within to help Changxin Wang seize control of Jizhou.

Upon learning that his runaway concubine had opened a tavern in Qingping County, Sui Yuanqing immediately took control of the local

magistrate, arrested everyone in the tavern, and threw them into prison before sending word to him.

He saw that woman again on the night of the Qingping County uprising.

His men secretly brought her to a manor.

Only then did he learn she had taken a name for herself—Yu Qianqian.

When he asked about their son's whereabouts, she refused to speak.

Five years later, he touched her for the second time, driven by an inexplicable mix of anger and the joy of reclaiming what was lost.

He suddenly realized that he didn't actually despise the act between men and women—as long as it was with her.

She remained bound to his bed all night, and by the next day, news of Sui Yuanqing's defeat and uncertain fate reached the estate.

Though he had already sent Zhao Xun to investigate her thoroughly in secret, she had once perfectly deceived him and escaped. This time, he had no intention of taking her back directly.

One was that the son she bore him had yet to be found, and the other was his desire to uncover what other forces she had hidden over the years.

So he deliberately left an opening, feigning the appearance that after Sui Yuanqing's defeat, they too had to hastily withdraw from Jizhou, giving her the opportunity to flee.

His men secretly followed her, watching as she hurriedly sold her tavern at a discount, dismissed its staff, and fled with only a few loyal maids and guards.

She had indeed hidden her son well—entrusting him to a lone butcher's daughter in the town.

Only after confirming that Yu Qianqian had no more hidden cards did he lead his troops to intercept her on the main route to Jiangnan.

Watching the hope in her eyes fade into resigned despair was rather amusing.

He thought he needed to punish her—only then would she learn her lesson and abandon any further thoughts of escape.

Knowing how much she valued the child, he ordered his men to separate them in confinement.

At first, he had found her pleasing because she asked nothing of him. She had never sought to take anything from him.

Being with her made him feel relaxed and safe.

But now, precisely because she still asked nothing of him, his agitation grew worse by the day.

—Her lack of demands meant there was nothing about him that could make her stay.

Except for the child. Only that child.

Qi Min despised Yu Bao'er—not only because he was the humiliating product of being drugged like livestock, but also because he was healthy, lively, and cherished by his mother.

Most importantly, he seemed to monopolize all of Yu Qianqian's love.

He was, in truth, bitterly jealous of his own child.

(9)

Soon, he tasted the sweetness of leverage.

He left an empty city in Chongzhou, and when his troops marched on Lucheng, Yu Qianqian softened toward him for the first time.

Meng Shuyuan's granddaughter fought desperately outside the city, holding the line. He knew she was buying time—initially, he had intended for his Shadow Guards to capture her alive, as she could serve as a bargaining chip against the Wu'an Marquis. But as the delay dragged on and Lucheng remained unconquered, his patience wore thin, and he truly considered killing her.

It was Yu Qianqian who deliberately drew his attention, luring him forward.

She begged him to spare the Meng girl's life.

Heaven knew how delighted he felt at that moment, yet an inexplicable fury also gripped him, burning in his chest.

To her, it seemed, everyone was more important than him.

Suddenly, he wanted to know—what it would feel like to be the one she held dearest.

Just the thought made his chest burn with warmth, filling him with pleasure.

A pity he never got the chance.

The plan to seize Lucheng ultimately failed. No one had expected Xie Zheng, who had been stationed in Kangcheng, to suddenly appear in Lucheng.

Just as, seventeen years ago, his mother had ensured his survival by making him Sui Yuanhuai.

With a single move—the golden cicada shedding its shell—he shed the identity of the rebel's son.

He took her into hiding at a location the Li Family had long prepared, successfully evading the Wu'an Marquis's repeated searches.

During this time, something happened that infuriated Qi Min—Zhao Xun had betrayed him.

He thought he should have dealt with Lan Shi and her son long ago. Otherwise, he wouldn't have been powerless against the Zhao Family after Zhao Xun secured the Wu'an Marquis's backing.

All the efforts he had made in earlier years to dismantle the puppet emperor's alliance with the Li Family had ultimately paved the way for the Wu'an Marquis instead.

Although the Zhao Family were mere merchants, they indeed had some capabilities—even managing to establish connections with the chief eunuch serving the puppet emperor.

With the decline of imperial authority, the eunuchs working in the palace had all begun seeking alternative paths for themselves.

Years earlier, the Zhao Family had already uncovered some information. For instance, the young woman the Li Family had sent into the palace had not conceived a child for years. It was clear that after Wei Yan stripped him of his power, the puppet emperor, while outwardly submitting to the Li Family, secretly guarded against them.

The puppet emperor also feared that the Li Family might one day become a second Wei Family.

Qi Min had once mocked himself, saying that the puppet emperor on the throne was in a situation eerily similar to his own.

Neither of them dared to have their own heirs, afraid they would be easily replaced.

What could completely shatter the alliance between the puppet emperor and the Li Family were the dozen or so urgent reports about the severe droughts and floods in Guanzhong and Jiangnan, held by the chief eunuch.

The officials Wei Yan had sent were responsible for disaster relief, while the Li faction dispatched overseers to accompany them. The lower-ranking officials embezzled relief funds, and the Li faction's overseers turned a blind eye, even helping to cover up the severity of the disaster.

This had been part of the puppet emperor and the Li Family's plan from the start—to let more people die in the disaster, then pin the blame on Wei Yan and sever another of his limbs.

However, Grand Tutor Li was cautious. Fearing that the puppet emperor might later turn the tables and accuse the Li Family of dereliction of duty, he had written over a dozen urgent reports and sent them to the capital.

The chief eunuch was a shrewd man. Of course, he knew the emperor did not want to see those reports. If they were brought to light, either the original plan would collapse, or the emperor would have to swallow this bitter pill for the Li Family, bearing the stain of imperial misconduct—but in that case, the chief eunuch's career would also be over.

So the chief eunuch had no choice but to risk his life and act as the middleman, suppressing all the urgent reports.

Obtaining those reports meant obtaining evidence of imperial misconduct—and also seizing one of the Li Family's vital weaknesses.

Qi Min had long coveted this evidence of wrongdoing from the chief eunuch, but in the end, it was Zhao Xun who presented it to Xie Zheng.

Later, when Lan Shi died under the swords of the Blood-Clad Cavalry to protect him, he felt not the slightest ripple of emotion in his heart.

—Her loyalty was not to him, but only to the bloodline of the Chengde Crown Prince.

Qi Min even mocked himself with the thought that if Yu Bao'er hadn't still been in Xie Zheng's hands, Lan Shi probably wouldn't have risked her

life to protect him.

During the assassination attempt at the ruined temple, he had also killed Sui Yuanqing.

Sui Yuanqing had hated him to the very end. He could have revealed the whole truth—told him what Changxin Wang Sui Tuo and Wei Yan had done, those unspeakable atrocities. He could have told him how his mother, to ensure his survival, had burned herself alive in the Eastern Palace, suffering no less than the true Changxin Wang's wife and child.

But he said nothing. He was too stingy to give that answer.

If he revealed the truth, he would seem like nothing more than a pitiful worm who had lurked in Changxin Prince Manor all these years just for revenge.

Wasn't it more satisfying to let Sui Yuanqing die consumed by hatred and resentment?

(10)

After clashing with the Blood-Clad Cavalry, Qi Min finally managed to seize Yu Qianqian back through a scheme, though he failed to kill Yu Bao'er, who remained in Xie Zheng's hands.

Yu Qianqian was severely injured. In a fit of rage, he ordered the Shadow Guard who had harmed her to be punished.

Yu Qianqian was colder toward him than ever before. She still couldn't understand why he insisted on killing her child.

She threw a tantrum, refusing to take her medicine or treat her wounds, as if she knew he no longer had Yu Bao'er in his grasp and could do nothing to her.

It was then that Qi Min suddenly realized Yu Qianqian had no attachment to this world at all.

Apart from those she cared about, she despised everything here.

When she refused to cooperate with her treatment, he touched her.

Between the two of them, she was the one who truly loathed intimacy.

Under such coercion, she finally agreed to take her medicine and treat her wounds. Back then, she would always calmly tell him, "If you don't let me die, one day, I will kill you."

Qi Min remembered the sunlight that day was particularly warm. Sitting by the bed with the medicine bowl in hand, even his perpetually pale fingertips felt a rare warmth under the sun's rays.

He smiled and replied, "Everyone dies eventually. Compared to dying by someone else's hand, dying by yours doesn't seem so bad."

Stirring the spoon idly, he continued casually, "When the time comes, make me some soup and poison it."

At the time, Yu Qianqian simply looked at him as if he were insane.

Later, she truly came with her homemade soup to send him off on his final journey.

(11)

The failure of the palace coup didn't affect Qi Min as much as one might expect.

When the dust finally settled, he actually felt a sense of relief.

His life had been too exhausting. As a child, he had to burn his entire face and half his body's flesh, watching his mother perish in the flames, just to steal a few decades of survival.

For over a decade, he endured the phantom pain of those burns, treading on thin ice every day... What difference was there between this and death?

Yet he dared not speak of death, nor could he show even a hint of vulnerability before anyone.

He was the descendant of the Chengde Crown Prince, destined to reclaim the throne. A crown prince must maintain his dignity—how could he show weakness?

He couldn't die either. His mother had sacrificed her life to give him this slim chance at survival. He had to drag each of his enemies down to hell and seize that dragon throne in the capital.

Now, he was finally free.

The arrow wound in his chest tormented him. Though he knew Xie Zheng was deliberately keeping him alive, he never considered ending it himself. He wanted to see Yu Qianqian one last time.

They had made a promise—he had to drink her soup before departing.

When she arrived, he answered the old questions she wanted to ask on behalf of others, and he drank the soup she had prepared.

He wanted to ask her who she really was, but she avoided the question.

When he realized she had never harbored even a shred of sincerity toward him, he couldn't understand why he was suddenly overwhelmed with immense bitterness and rage.

He was about to die, yet she couldn't even bother to pretend or lie to him!

At the peak of his hatred, he even thought of taking her with him.

This was what she owed him!

But in the end, he was too weak. He couldn't harm her.

Later, when she knelt before him and calmly told him he didn't deserve to be loved, he felt a pang of sorrow in his daze.

He wanted to say that his mother had left too soon. His entire childhood and adolescence had been spent in pain. Those around him revered him, feared him, and spoke endlessly of revenge. No one taught him what love was, nor how to show compassion to subordinates.

A child who threatened his position and his life—of course, he couldn't let them live.

He had spent these years like a rat in the gutter, constantly on edge. He could never become the kind of upright person she spoke of.

In this world, apart from his mother, truly no one had ever treated him with genuine kindness.

She seemed startled for a moment when she saw the tears in his eyes, then turned and left without looking back.

Qi Min lay alone in the vast, empty hall, feeling the poison slowly corrode his organs, thick streams of blood spilling from the corners of his mouth.

Perhaps because he had endured the pain of fire since childhood and had been tormented by phantom pain all these years, when the poison coursed through his limbs and slowly devoured his life, he didn't feel much discomfort.

His consciousness grew hazy, his body falling endlessly into the darkness, dragging him into a dream from which he would never wake.

Just like when he had nearly drowned in the frozen pond all those years ago.

Only this time, there was no warm hand to pull him back.

The corners of his eyes stung, and his chest felt unbearably hollow.

In his daze, he heard her voice outside the hall.

“Changyu, I have a secret.”

“I came here from a place very, very far away, and I can never go back.”

Her voice was heavy, as if she were speaking to someone outside—or perhaps, taking the chance to speak to him: “From now on, it would take thousands of years of walking to return there.”

The hollow ache in his chest seemed to ease a little.

Qi Min’s bloodstained lips twitched with effort, his already fading eyes slowly closing.

The answer he had sought—he had finally received it.

Chapter 174

Extra Story: Li Huai'an Chapter

In the early spring of the eighteenth year of Yonghe, the Li and Wei factions' failed rebellion was quelled, and all involved were executed.

Those sentenced to immediate beheading were temporarily held in the imperial prison for execution in autumn, while those exiled were escorted by officials to their designated locations by early March.

The Li family's crime of rebellion was grave, and the implicated nine clans spanned far and wide, entangling numerous intricate marital connections—effectively encompassing half the court and many retired Confucian scholars.

To demonstrate benevolence upon his ascension, the new emperor issued a general pardon. Ultimately, only the three closest clans of the rebellious Li and Wei families were executed—namely, blood relatives, marital relatives, and maternal and paternal lineages.

Those beyond the three clans but within the nine were exiled three thousand li away.

Li Huaian, as the grandson of Grand Tutor Li, fell within the five clans.

After being captured by Xie Zheng in Jizhou, he had been imprisoned and tortured. Though he appeared to be nothing more than a frail scholar, his resolve was unyielding. Even Gongsun Yin personally attempted to extract information from him but failed.

At the time, he lay wounded on a pile of straw in his cell, his breath forming white mist in the bitter winter cold.

To Gongsun Yin, who had come to persuade him, he only smiled bitterly and said, "Your esteemed reputation precedes you, Huaian has long admired you. I simply never imagined our first meeting would be under such circumstances."

"What the Li family has done is an unforgivable crime. The world may revile us, anyone may push against this crumbling wall—but Huaian

cannot. For over twenty years, I have lived under the shelter of my clan's grace. As the Li family's great house collapses, I may be crushed beneath its ruins, but I will not be the force that brings it down. I know I am a sinner, and in death, I willingly descend into Avīci Hell. I beg you, sir... to grant me this."

Gongsun Yin gazed at the man in a bloodstained blue robe and said slowly, "The Li family has already abandoned you. Is this worth it?"

Li Huaian answered with a faint smile, "Twenty years of nurturing—that is enough."

Determined to die and lacking the physical resilience of a martial artist, further torture proved futile.

Only after the Li family's sentencing was he transferred to the Court of Revision's prison.

That spring, shortly after the emperor's enthronement, Li Huaian set out on the road to exile alongside the Li clansmen beyond the three closest generations.

Born into silk and satin, these people had thought the sky had fallen when their homes were raided and they were imprisoned. But only upon truly embarking on exile did they realize how much suffering existed in the world—what they had endured before was nothing in comparison.

The officials were harsh, enforcing strict daily travel quotas. Those who lagged behind were whipped with leather lashes, polished to a shine from years of use. A single strike could raise a swollen welt across half one's back, lingering for days.

In prison, bribing the jailers with silver could secure a decent meal. But on the road, conditions were dire. Most of their hidden savings had already been extorted by the jailers, leaving little to offer the escorting officials. Their daily fare consisted of nearly inedible blackened cornbread, often insufficient to stave off hunger.

Within days, the exiled Li clansmen had all visibly thinned, their faces haggard and gaunt, their former noble bearing utterly gone.

The young children, unable to walk far, were carried in turns by the adults.

With worn-out shoes and no replacements, Li Huaian's feet soon blistered from the relentless march—let alone the women among the

exiles.

He watched helplessly as his young nephews fell ill one after another.

He didn't have a single copper coin left to his name. When he tried to persuade other clan members who still had some savings to pool money for medicine for the children, all he received were complaints of hardship and curses.

Grand Tutor Li's children had all been sentenced to execution in autumn, leaving Li Huaian, the eldest grandson of the Li family, as the sole remaining direct descendant. All the implicated collateral branches and distant relatives who had once clung to the Li family tree—now uprooted—faced confiscation of property and exile, cursing and resenting the Li family without exception.

When Li Huaian knelt on the ground, kowtowing and begging his clansmen to pool their savings to save his feverish nephews, he was spat upon and beaten by resentful relatives who harbored hatred for the main branch of the Li family.

If not for the intervention of the guards, Li Huaian would have been too injured to walk for days.

On that chilly spring night, he wrapped his only tattered coat around his delirious, feverish nephew for warmth. Holding the child against the broken door of the post station, he stared blankly at the pitch-black sky visible through the cracks.

The little nephew curled in his arms, cheeks flushed red from fever, yet still shivering and murmuring about the cold.

Li Huaian futilely tightened the coat around the child. His own lips and face had turned blue from the cold, and his bony shoulder blades protruded sharply through his thin robe, like a withered bamboo stalk on the verge of death. Gently patting the boy's back, he whispered soothing words.

The child weakly opened his eyes and asked, "What are you looking at, Uncle?"

Li Huaian's voice was hoarse. "At the sins of the Li family."

The boy's voice was as faint as a dying kitten's, his eyelids slowly drooping. "What's that?"

Li Huaian's chest tightened, his throat bitter. Gazing at the night sky, he said mournfully, "The Li family did many wrongs... killed many innocent people. I was thinking... whether those ordinary folk who suffered because of us... felt just as helpless and desperate when facing separation and death..."

He couldn't continue. Looking down, he realized the child in his arms had stopped breathing. Unable to contain his grief any longer, he buried his face against the small body and let out a choked sob.

"I should be the one to die... I should be the one punished..."

That night, stifled weeping echoed intermittently from the post station's woodshed.

After his nephew's death, Li Huaian fell gravely ill.

He became gaunt and hollow-eyed, bearing no resemblance to the refined, noble young master of the Li family he once was.

The guards escorting the exiled prisoners thought he wouldn't survive, yet Li Huaian clung to life, enduring all the way to Suzhou.

He grew taciturn, often spending entire days without speaking to anyone.

But he quietly performed many small kindnesses. The exiled prisoners barely had enough food for themselves; to stave off hunger, they would split a single steamed bun in half, saving one portion for later. Yet whenever Li Huaian encountered beggars along the way, he often gave away his own precious half portion.

Occasionally, when someone dared to speak to him, he would teach them a few characters, even naming some of the beggar children.

Both the guards and his fellow exiles regarded him as a joke—a clay idol fording a river, incapable of saving himself yet still finding time to pity those beggars.

Li Huaian never explained anything, stubbornly persisting in his ways.

When a clansman saw him always saving half a steamed bun to give to the next beggar he encountered, they simply snatched it from him.

After being beaten, he went to the river to wash the blood from his face. The guard watching him, disgusted by his calm composure, sneered: "Young Master Li, you've fallen so low yourself, who are you pretending to

be kind for? As if the corruption cases during the Guanzhong drought and Jiangnan floods, or the Luchang massacre colluding with rebels, weren't all orchestrated by your Li family?"

The water murmured as Li Huaian gazed at his blurred reflection in the stream, dirty hair obscuring his bitter expression: "You're right, officer. The Li family's crimes concern tens of thousands of lives—they can never be atoned for. But this guilty man feels remorse. Rather than dying to escape it, I wish to do something for the people betrayed by my family, to repay our sins."

The guard was momentarily stunned by his words, then laughed scornfully.

But Li Huaian remained indifferent to such mockery, quietly continuing his actions. At first, the guards and fellow prisoners treated him as entertainment, but eventually, finding his reactions dull, they stopped bothering to provoke him.

The hardships of exile wore his cloth shoes to tatters within two months of leaving the capital. Learning to weave straw sandals from an old man at a post station, his feet—once accustomed to fine boots—blistered and calloused until they no longer felt the straw's prick.

The hands that once held brushes to paint were now rough and cracked.

Along the way, he made straw sandals for many clansmen.

Yet when the Li clan reached Suzhou in December, of the hundred who began the journey, few survived.

Such was exile—"death penalty spared, living penalty unavoidable."

Suzhou, in the desolate northwest frontier, was a barren land of deserts, with earthen-walled towns only where water allowed.

Most inhabitants were border soldiers or exiled convicts; few locals endured this harsh place.

With the new emperor's ascension, Wu'an Marquis returned from the frontier to assist the young ruler as Prince Regent, while barbarian tribes grew restless.

After repeated raids, Suzhou's commander ordered fortifications strengthened, and Li Huaian's group of new exiles was sent to repair the walls.

A frail scholar, unable to lift heavy loads, Li Huaian was whipped severely on his first day, his back striped with wounds. The next day, he was driven back to work.

His slender frame buckling under heavy bricks, he once fell and damaged one. The overseer flew into a rage, lashing him mercilessly—each strike burned like a scorpion's sting.

Often he thought he might die there, yet he felt no resentment.

The cold night his nephew died of illness, he suddenly understood the helplessness of commoners who lost everything to the Li family's schemes.

Only by enduring suffering firsthand does one truly know its taste.

The toil of rebuilding walls paled beside being hacked apart or trampled if the city fell.

Yet it was in the hellish crucible of war that the Li family had once personally orchestrated such suffering.

In the past, Li Huaian had served as an Army Supervisor sent to oversee the frontlines. He had witnessed the horrors of war and felt moments of pity and doubt. But recalling his grandfather's words—that overthrowing Wei Yan was for the sake of bringing a better life to more common people—he chose to turn a blind eye.

Now, as he became the one laying each brick and stone, he finally understood the suffering and struggles endured by the common folk and soldiers coldly sacrificed by the Li family.

He also comprehended the fury Fan Changyu and Xie Zheng had felt upon learning that everything had been the Li family's doing.

One came from the lowest rungs of society, the other had joined the military in his youth—no one understood better than they did the harsh realities faced by the common people and soldiers at the bottom.

The Li family's schemes had effortlessly destroyed countless families barely clinging to survival.

The more he realized this, the heavier the mountain of guilt weighed upon Li Huaian.

In the end, his awakening had come too late.

Dying here would not absolve even a fraction of his sins, but it was the best end he could hope for.

Yet he did not die.

The young officer guarding the city, upon learning he was Grand Tutor Li's grandson, regarded him with disdain. But given that barely a handful in the entire border town were literate, Li Huaian was tasked with organizing the rosters of exiled convicts and low-ranking soldiers while assisting in fortifying the city defenses.

The burly, ill-tempered squad leader barked, "You better sort these damn rosters properly! Anyone under my command—be they soldier or convict—who dies defending these walls when the barbarians come, deserves to have their name remembered!"

After the hardships endured during his exile, Li Huaian had thought himself numb to any stirrings of emotion. Yet the squad leader's words sent a surge of bitterness and reverence rising from his chest to his throat.

He bowed deeply to the squad leader, his eyes moist as he lowered his head. "This guilty man will not fail in his duty."

It was guilt.

The Battle of Lu City—how many such officers and soldiers had perished because of the Li family's schemes?

In early the second year of Yongxing, the border town of Suzhou suffered a surprise attack. It was Li Huaian's first time facing the cold blades and savage roars of the barbarians. Paralyzed with fear, he stood frozen on the battlements, unable to flee or raise a weapon, deaf even to the squad leader's hoarse shouts. None of the exiled men moved an inch.

Blood sprayed like rain. Living men one moment, corpses beneath blades the next.

The unfinished defenses could not withstand the barbarians' ferocious assault. When the hot-tempered squad leader saw the earthen walls of the border town could not hold, he roared at his soldiers to cover the retreat as the rest evacuated the civilians to Suzhou's main city.

The raid ended when Suzhou's reinforcements arrived in time. After plundering valuables and grain, the barbarians withdrew from the captured town without lingering.

But the squad leader died on the battlements. The officer who had once whipped Li Huaian during the fortifications fell defending the gates. Countless others—soldiers Li Huaian knew and didn't know—held the line with their lives until reinforcements came.

For the first time since the night his nephew died during the exile, Li Huaian wept uncontrollably again.

Not for family this time, but for the loyal bones strewn across the earth.

He felt not only guilt—but a regret deeper than any he had ever known.

Countless soldiers had sacrificed their lives to defend this peace—how could internal strife within the court reignite conflict?

In that battle, he had been crippled by a barbarian's blade, but he managed to save an infant for a civilian woman.

The woman had died under the barbarian's sword, her last words telling him only that the child's father was in the army, surnamed Cheng.

When reinforcements arrived, Li Huaian protected the child and barely escaped with his life. But when he searched the army for the child's father, he learned that the man had also died on the city walls.

The child became an orphan.

Li Huaian adopted the child and named him Cheng Lang.

Lang—a gemstone as beautiful as jade.

It was said that a gentleman should be like jade. He hoped the child would grow into a truly upright man.

The Northern Turks grew increasingly restless. That year, not only Suzhou but also Jinzhou and Yanzhou suffered frequent raids.

By autumn, Tang Peiyi had been appointed commander to suppress the increasingly rampant foreign tribes. Fan Changyu, now a general, followed with the supply convoy.

Hearing news of Fan Changyu again, Li Huaian felt as though lifetimes had passed. When he learned she had married Xie Zheng, a pang of bitterness struck his heart before giving way to acceptance.

In this world, aside from the Wu'an Marquis, he truly could not think of a second man worthy of her brilliance.

Those two had been bound by fate since birth—truly a match made by heaven.

In a remote border town of Suzhou, Li Huaian helped the newly assigned garrison captain organize documents and strategize on fortifying the city. Because his insights were valuable and his knowledge vast, despite his status as a convict, the captain made an exception and promoted him to Record Keeper. Seeing his lameness, the captain also spared him from the grueling labor of construction.

But after expressing his gratitude, Li Huaian still went to the city gates every day without fail, carrying bricks or assisting the craftsmen.

Only when both body and mind were exhausted could he find some peace, feeling as though he were atoning for his sins.

For years afterward, he remained in that border town, seeing off one garrison captain after another. The captains, having benefited greatly from his counsel, all wished to take him away from the frontier and keep him as a permanent advisor. But Li Huaian declined each time.

He said he was a sinner, and he had come here to atone.

Later, the war ended. The female general who had held the northwest alone for years repelled countless Northern Turk invasions—so much so that the sight of her Commander's Flag eventually deterred them from further attacks. In the end, her military achievements earned her a marquessate.

With no more battles at the border and the city's defenses complete, Li Huaian started a private school in his humble farmhouse, teaching local children to read and write without charging tuition.

The female marquis and her husband, the marquis, retired from the political whirlpool of the court and returned to the northwest, guarding Great Yin's great frontier together.

Suzhou and Huizhou were only a few hundred miles apart, yet Li Huaian never saw those two again.

He could not face his old friends.

But he heard many stories about them. In the sixth year of Yongxing, the female marquis gave birth to twins—a daughter named Xie Congyun and a son named Meng Xingchuan.

The bloodlines of the two loyal families wrongfully slaughtered in the Jinzhou case would live on forever.

He also heard they had adopted many orphaned children of fallen soldiers. Those who knew their original surnames kept them; those who didn't took the surnames Xie, Fan, or Meng, all raised as their own.

...

Sixteen years of wind, frost, rain, and snow passed in the blink of an eye.

By the time Li Huaian reached forty, he was already gravely ill, his temples as white as a man in his sixties.

For days, heavy snow had been falling. After catching a chill at the onset of winter, he had been bedridden for half a month with no signs of improvement.

The child he had adopted years ago had now come of age.

When Cheng Lang brought in water to wipe his face, he calmly and weakly instructed his own funeral arrangements: "When I'm gone, there's no need for elaborate funeral rites. Just bury me hastily on the back hill."

Cheng Lang's eyes stung, but he forced a composed tone: "Master, don't speak nonsense. It's just a chill—a few more doses of medicine and you'll recover."

Li Huaian wouldn't allow Cheng Lang to call him foster father. He said he was but a sinner, and the only reason he still lived was to atone for his crimes, insisting Cheng Lang address him simply as "Master."

"I know my own body... cough..." Before he could finish, a fit of coughing wracked his frail, hunched frame, like a spent candle in the cold night, ready to be extinguished by the slightest breeze.

Cheng Lang patted his back to ease his breathing, holding back his reddened eyes: "This spring, many children in the city still wish to come to you for their first lessons. You're still strong—you'll recover soon!"

As if afraid Li Huaian would continue with his funeral arrangements, he added: "Today, the city lord's residence hosted two distinguished guests. Though one was a woman, Magistrate Liu addressed both as 'Young Marquis.' Quite unusual—they must be from the Xie family of Huizhou. The young lady, upon hearing from Magistrate Liu how you've taught the

villagers without tuition fees for over a decade, said she wished to visit you someday..."

Cheng Lang rambled on about his observations at the city lord's residence, but Li Huaian could no longer hear him clearly.

Exiled to this bitter, cold land for twenty years, he had not seen a single familiar face. Now, with his time running short, the children of old acquaintances had arrived here.

Amid his scars of guilt, a sudden wave of sorrow overwhelmed him.

Just then, a knock came at the courtyard gate.

"Is Master Li at home?"

Cheng Lang set down the towel and glanced outside: "I'll get it."

Opening the gate, he found people from the city lord's residence and a group of young men and women standing outside. At the forefront were the twin siblings he had met earlier that day—the two distinguished guests.

Though twins, their appearances and temperaments were nothing alike.

One wore crimson riding attire, with almond eyes and a delicate nose, radiant as the sun. The other was clad in dark, fitted robes, refined and reserved, mature beyond his years.

Though Cheng Lang worked at the city lord's residence, he had never encountered such noble figures before and was momentarily at a loss.

The city lord's son quickly interjected: "Brother Cheng, after you left early today, the two Young Marquises heard of Master's grave illness and came especially to see him."

The crimson-clad girl immediately clasped her fists: "We apologize for the intrusion without prior notice."

Cheng Lang assured them it was no trouble and led them into the courtyard.

Li Huaian had already heard the commotion outside. When Cheng Lang brought the two into the room, his gaze lingered on the bright-eyed girl in red, lost in thought for a long moment.

She was the spitting image of that female marquis from years past.

The girl and the boy clasped their fists toward Li Huaian: "We apologize for disturbing you, venerable sir."

But Li Huaian only smiled at them. As he smiled, tears welled in his already clouded eyes. He said, "The sins of the Li family... I can never atone for them all..."

The young girl seemed to know who he was and said, "The calamity back then was not caused by your efforts alone, old sir. You have remained here for over twenty years, going to the city gates to oversee battles and offer strategies whenever war broke out. For years, you have worked tirelessly to secure trade routes for the city's people and taught countless impoverished students to read and write. Your achievements cannot erase the Li family's past mistakes, but they are enough to leave you with a clear conscience."

Li Huaian looked at the black-robed youth standing beside the young girl.

The youth's brows and eyes bore a striking resemblance to the Martial Marquis who had intimidated the Northern Jue for over two decades. He gave Li Huaian a slight nod.

Through them, Li Huaian seemed to catch a glimpse of old friends. His eyes remained brimming with tears, yet he smiled again—a smile tinged with the relief of release.

That night, the old man, who had spent half his life atoning for his sins, passed away with a faint smile on his lips.

His funeral was kept simple, as per his final wishes. The local townsfolk, aware of his lifelong repentance and remorse, did not extol his virtues. Only the students he had once taught planted peach or plum trees on the hillside where he was buried.

The following spring, the entire mountainside bloomed with a riot of peach and plum blossoms.

Chapter 175

Extra Story: Wei Yan Chapter

In the early spring, the cold lingered as the ice and snow had just begun to melt.

Under the dark, water-like night sky, a faint light still flickered in the study of Wei Mansion. The steward knocked on the door and reported from outside, "Prime Minister, the young master is having nightmares again, crying and fussing uncontrollably..."

The study was cold and quiet. Beside the huanghuali desk stood a bronze crane candlestick, its tray already filled with layers of melted wax. The dim yellow glow of the half-burned candle cast a somber light. Wei Yan sat behind the desk, his lean jawline appearing even more rigid in the warm candlelight.

He seemed to be reading, but at the sound of the steward's voice, he lifted his gaze from the pages and stared absently at the nearly spent candle in the bronze crane candlestick. After a long pause, he finally spoke coldly, "What are the servants doing? Can't even soothe a child?"

The steward hesitated before replying, "The young master was crying for his mother, but when he remembered that she had passed away with his father, he started crying for his uncle... That's why this old servant dared to disturb the Prime Minister."

At the mention of "uncle," a flicker of anguish and pain crossed Wei Yan's face. He closed his eyes, taking a long moment to compose himself before standing and pulling open the study door. His expression was now devoid of any emotion. "Let's go see him."

The Great General Xie Linshan and the Chengde Crown Prince had died in battle at Jinzhou. Not long after, Madam Xie, unable to bear the loss of her husband, chose to "follow him in death," entrusting her four-year-old son to her elder brother, Wei Yan.

The young master of the Xie family had been brought to Wei Mansion to be cared for, residing in Linxuan Pavilion.

As soon as Wei Yan stepped into the courtyard, he heard the sound of a child's sobbing from inside the room: "Uncle... I want Uncle..."

The cries were intermittent, the voice already hoarse, like a young beast wailing in despair.

Hearing the child's cries, even the steward's eyes dimmed with sorrow and pity.

Yet Wei Yan's face remained cold, his profile bathed in the pale moonlight as if covered in frost.

He pushed open the door. Inside, the child—still round with baby fat—stopped crying the moment he saw him, stretching out his arms in desperate reliance. "Uncle..."

The maids attending to him quickly bowed to Wei Yan. "Prime Minister."

Each of them kept their heads lowered, their expressions anxious and hurried, as if fearing Wei Yan would blame them for failing to care for the young master properly.

Wei Yan's cold gaze fell on his nephew, whose eyes were swollen from crying. His first words were a stern rebuke: "A man does not cry. What is this behavior?"

Xie Zheng seemed startled by his uncle's harsh tone. The hand he had stretched out withdrew, clutching the quilt beneath him instead. His large, dark eyes, brimming with tears, stared blankly at the cold-faced man before him. His lips pressed tightly together, afraid to let out another sob, but fat teardrops still rolled uncontrollably down his cheeks, leaving damp stains on the bedding.

Fearing further reprimand, he quickly lowered his head, using his chubby little arm to clumsily wipe his eyes.

His father was dead. His mother had abandoned him. And now, even his uncle—who had once doted on him—no longer seemed to care for him...

One of the maids, unable to bear the sight, whispered softly, "The young master had a nightmare... He was frightened..."

A sharp glance from Wei Yan silenced her instantly. She bowed her head, not daring to speak another word.

His voice was icy as he commanded, "Replace all the female servants in Linxuan Pavilion with male attendants. A boy raised among women will

never amount to anything."

Several maids in the room quickly knelt down to beg for mercy. Little Xie Zheng, sensing something, forgot his fear and clutched at the corner of Wei Yan's sleeve, sobbing, "Uncle... please don't send the nannies away... Zheng promises not to cry anymore..."

Wei Yan looked down at his nephew, his gaze as cold as ice: "You cry half the night over a mere nightmare—how do you expect to avenge your father, who was gutted by the Northern Turks and hung from the city walls? The Xie family breeds no cowards, and neither does the Wei family!"

His piercing stare bore into the child: "If you remain this spineless your whole life, the court can raise you like a pig or a dog on the military merits your father left behind. You'll never want for anything."

With that, he slammed the door and left.

Even the steward frowned at these words. Glancing at Wei Yan's retreating figure, then at the child sitting frozen on the bed as if stunned by the scolding, he sighed softly and said to Xie Zheng, "Young Master, don't take it to heart. The Prime Minister... he's just grieving after the young lady's passing. He only wishes for you to grow strong quickly, to march north and reclaim Jinzhou, to avenge General Xie."

The four-year-old child hung his head, his frail shoulders trembling with sobs like a bow made of tender branches, nearly snapping under sudden strain.

"Uncle... hates me..."

His voice was young yet hoarse, as if weeping blood: "If I hadn't gone out to eat Osmanthus cake and left Mother... she wouldn't have... taken her own life alone in the room..."

His sobs grew heavier: "I didn't watch over her... Uncle hates me..."

The steward's expression grew even more complicated. "The young lady chose this path herself. It's not your fault, Young Master. The Prime Minister... doesn't blame you either."

Little Xie Zheng only shook his head, curling into a ball on the bed, his small, fragile frame heartbreaking to behold.

The steward sighed, tucked the blankets around him, and left the room with heavy steps.

At the end of the covered corridor, a solitary figure stood with hands clasped behind his back, buffeted by the cold wind.

The steward approached and said, "The young master is still so young. Your harshness only wounds him further. He blames himself for not watching over the young lady that day... and believes you hate him for it..."

Wei Yan gazed at the bamboo shadows swaying in the night breeze and replied indifferently, "Then let him believe it."

The steward looked pained. "Why must you do this?"

The lanterns under the eaves swayed in the wind, casting flickering yellow light. Wei Yan's dark robes billowed like sails, accentuating his tall, lean frame. He spoke slowly: "The imperial court is a murky pool—full of pitfalls, deceit, and undercurrents. If he only wishes to live a life of idle luxury, I could indulge him. But he seeks the battlefield and the court. If I don't temper him, I'd only be sending him to the slaughter."

"Wei Quan, if he lacks ruthlessness, he'll never sit in my seat."

"Even if I yield it to him, will others do the same?"

The steward understood his master's painstaking intentions and fell silent. After a long pause, he said sorrowfully, "So you'll let the young master resent you like this?"

Wei Yan gave a faint smile. "It's better if he hates and resents me."

The steward stared at him in surprise.

Then, in a voice almost too soft to hear, Wei Yan murmured, "One day, he'll uncover the truth."

Those crimes, one after another, pinned on him by the Late Emperor—sins he could never erase no matter how hard he tried for the rest of his life.

The steward thought of Wei Wan's death, and his eyes dimmed with sorrow.

The young mistress died resenting the Prime Minister, convinced he was the mastermind behind the deaths of General Xie and the Crown Prince...

By the fourth watch, a fierce wind had risen, rattling the loosely shut window shutters against the frames. The child on the bed seemed to have

fallen into another nightmare, clutching at the blankets unconsciously, murmuring incoherently for "Father, Mother."

The man who had been sitting in the Grand Tutor chair in the corner for who knew how long stood up. He walked to the window and closed it, then turned to gaze silently at the child on the bed, whose forehead was now drenched in cold sweat, illuminated by the faint glow of an oil lamp outside the canopy bed.

He took a handkerchief as if to wipe away the sweat, but the child let out a sharp cry and suddenly sat up, gasping for breath.

Wei Yan withdrew the hand holding the handkerchief behind his back and stood by the bed, his expression cold as he watched his nephew, drenched in sweat like a drowning victim.

The small child looked at him, lips parting as if to call out, but upon seeing his expression, fell silent.

The gaze directed at him held only bewildered wariness and awe—none of the former dependence remained.

Like a young beast driven from its den.

Wei Yan's voice was icy: "I've found you a martial arts instructor. You'll start training at the Martial Arts Academy tomorrow."

As he stepped out of the room, his personal guard handed him a cloak and asked softly, "Your Excellency stayed up half the night watching over the young master. Would you like to rest for a while?"

Wei Yan glanced at the sky. "Prepare my court robes. It's time to go to the palace."

At the moon gate, the leader of the Martial Assassins, Wei Sheng, hurried over to report: "Your Excellency, we caught several intruder attempting to break into the residence last night—all remnants of the Xie faction. Should we throw them into the dungeon as well?"

A sharp glint flashed in Wei Yan's eyes. "Weren't the Xie remnants all sent back to Huizhou by A'Wan?"

Wei Sheng clasped his fists. "These are from the Xie branch families. Somehow they got wind of things. After being captured, they cursed Your Excellency, saying... they'd never let the young master recognize a thief as his father..."

Wei Yan paused slightly in adjusting his cloak, his expression growing even colder. "Interrogate them to find out who leaked the information. Once you have the answer, there's no need to keep them alive."

Wei Sheng was momentarily taken aback. Previously, his master had always ordered such captives imprisoned—why the sudden command to eliminate them?

Then he recalled that these people had sought to approach the young master. It was after learning the "truth" from them, coupled with the Jia family's spies pushing the young master into the lotus pond to frame Wei Yan for the attempted murder, that the young mistress had been forced to leave a suicide note and hang herself to protect both the young master and the uninformed Xie remnants. In that moment, Wei Sheng understood his master's hatred.

His master loathed the Sui and Jia families for inciting the Xie remnants, and despised those remnants who had used the "truth" to corner the young mistress.

With the young mistress gone, his master would never allow them near the young master again.

The core Xie remnants had already been sent back to their ancestral home in Huizhou by the young mistress before her death—her final act to preserve what remained of the Xie forces and pave the way for the young master's future.

Now these Xie branch family members had come knocking, walking straight into the jaws of their master's wrath.

Wei Sheng withdrew after receiving his orders, and Wei Yan strode toward the mansion gate. The steward came to see him off, and as Wei Yan stepped into the official sedan chair, he suddenly added another command: "Have the child from Osmanthus Garden moved to Linxuan Pavilion."

The steward nodded in acknowledgment, understanding Wei Yan's intent, and said with a smile, "Young Master Xuan is usually quite lively. With his cousin having just lost both parents, having a companion might help him become more cheerful and avoid nightly nightmares."

Wei Yan remained silent, lowering the sedan curtain. The bearers, former Martial Assassins, lifted the sedan chair with steady steps onto the still dimly lit street.

Flanking the sedan were over a dozen mansion guards, each with a longsword at their waist, their breaths steady and stances firm—elite warriors meticulously selected from the ranks of Martial Assassins.

With the young emperor on the throne, Wei Yan held the Son of Heaven to command the nobles. The war south of Jinzhou was intensifying. Though the Sui family led troops to block the Northern Turks' advance south, they seized the opportunity to make exorbitant demands for money and grain from the court. Meanwhile, in the capital, the Jia family—a centipede that refused to die—lay in wait, ready to strike at Wei Yan and seize power from him.

Since ascending to the position of prime minister and acting as regent, Wei Yan had already survived over a dozen assassination attempts.

Everyone sought his weaknesses, his fatal flaws. One misstep, and the entire Wei and Xie clans would face eternal damnation.

As the sedan chair reached Bronze Sparrow Street, cold arrows and a gust of wind struck simultaneously toward the sedan.

Dozens of black-clad figures leaped down from the buildings on either side, their blades reflecting a chilling gleam under the sedan's lanterns.

The guards surrounding the sedan drew their swords, weaving an impenetrable net of steel that blocked all the poison-tipped arrows before clashing head-on with the descending assassins.

Splattered blood stained the frost-covered bluestone tiles of Bronze Sparrow Street.

One assassin, taking advantage of the Martial Assassins being occupied, lunged at the sedan with his blade. The fierce wind from his strike tore through the embroidered curtain, but the blade could advance no further.

The veins on the assassin's temples bulged from the strain, yet the man inside the sedan merely twisted his wrist, forcing the assassin into a midair flip. The blade snapped with a metallic clang, and as the assassin landed, the broken half of the blade hurled from the sedan ended his life.

Outside, the Martial Assassins dispatched the last of the attackers, their blood splashing across half the sedan curtain.

Wei Yan pushed aside the curtain and stepped out, his brocade boots sinking into the thick, dark-red blood. The rising sun in the east burst forth

in a crimson struggle through the gray clouds, casting a golden glow over the distant palace towers.

Against the radiant dawn, Wei Yan's handsome face was cold and ruthless.

He stepped forward, treading through the blood-stained morning light, striding toward the towering imperial palace.

This journey would last eighteen years.

The grudges of old were repaid, one by one.

He stabilized the realm, purged the unworthy, and forged the sharpest blade in the world—one even he could not break. Thus, no one else could ever challenge its wielder.

Meeting old acquaintances now, he felt no shame.

Whether his destination was the Jade Terrace or the depths of hell, his heart was at peace.

The merits and faults, the glory and disgrace of this life—let posterity judge, condemn, curse, or lament. Once dust returns to earth and bones lie silent, what concern was it of his?

Chapter 176

Extra Story: Younger Sister

The blizzard raged like swirling cotton, the howling wind resembling the wails of ghosts and wolves.

Wei Yan lay with his eyes closed on a pile of withered grass, inwardly amused. Truly, age made one nostalgic—the wind outside this prison cell almost made him feel as if he were back in the northern frontier.

How many years had it been since that old man dragged him to the Qi family's military camp, where he and Xie Linshan had guarded the northern borders together?

But those had been good days.

Old General Qi was still alive then, Rong Yin had not yet entered the palace, and Linshan and the Crown Prince had not perished in Jinzhou...

The happiest days of his life had been in that time.

His eyelids grew heavy, and Wei Yan allowed himself to drift into sleep amidst the relentless howl of wind and snow.

In his daze, he sensed someone approaching, draping something over him to shield against the biting cold that seemed capable of flaying skin from flesh.

Wei Yan wondered—was it a prison guard?

But as a condemned man, the guards wouldn't casually offer him extra clothing. Had they received instructions from Grand Tutor Tao or Xie Zheng?

Before he could finish his muddled thoughts, the person who had covered him did not leave. Instead, they hesitated, then reached out as if to touch him. Wei Yan caught a faint scent, something between orchids and camellias.

Years of walking on thin ice had honed his instincts. Almost reflexively, his hand shot up and seized the intruding wrist, his sharp phoenix eyes

snapping open.

But the face he saw was one that only appeared in his midnight dreams.

The woman wore a pear-white winter coat embroidered with lotus petals, her shoulders delicate, her waist slender as if bound by silk. Her features were like a landscape painting, soft and graceful. Her wrist was still trapped in his grip, her fair face a mix of alarm and bashfulness at being caught. Biting her lower lip, she said, "I saw Third Brother sleeping here, so I brought you a cloak..."

Wei Yan had an elder brother who died young, as well as a half-brother from a concubine, making him the third son in his family.

The Wei and Qi families had been close, and Qi Rongyin had called him "Third Brother" since childhood.

He stared at the woman before him for a long moment before speaking. "You haven't visited my dreams in so many years. Have you come tonight because you know my time is near?"

Rong Yin frowned, her embarrassment momentarily forgotten. The hand he held twisted slightly, her warm, smooth palm pressing against his forehead. "Third Brother, why are you talking nonsense? Have you caught a fever?"

The skin beneath her palm was indeed burning. Her expression darkened at once, and she called to a maid standing guard at the corner of the city wall, "Lanyue, fetch the Army Doctor! Third Brother has a fever!"

Wei Yan looked up and saw a sky full of stars, along with the Qi family banner atop the city wall, illuminated by the glow of braziers. Only then did he realize he had been sleeping against the battlement. Around him were soldiers dozing with their weapons, their faces and bodies still stained with blood—clearly, a fierce battle had just taken place.

This dream felt too real, just like those years he had spent in the north.

As Rong Yin moved to stand, Wei Yan tightened his grip on her hand.

Puzzled, she looked at him—he had been acting strangely since waking. "Third Brother?"

Wei Yan spoke slowly, "Don't go. Let me look at you a little longer. Eighteen years... Every time you've appeared in my dreams, you've never stayed to talk..."

"What are you saying? What eighteen years?" The confusion in Rong Yin's eyes deepened, but she soothed him nonetheless. "I won't leave. I'll just fetch some water to wipe your face."

Due to the cold, Wei Yan's head was indeed throbbing with pain. He raised his other hand to press against his temple.

Seeing this, Qi Rongyin withdrew the hand he had been gripping and descended the city wall to fetch water.

Wei Yan's gaze instinctively followed her, afraid she might disappear. Beside him, a general with blood and dust streaked across his face, who had been feigning sleep, opened his eyes and laughed, "Wei Zhonglang, it seems good fortune is near for you, isn't it?"

Wei Yan remembered that during his time in the Qi family's military camp, he had held the rank of Zhonglang General, and his comrades often addressed him as "Wei Zhonglang."

The man before him was unfamiliar. Squinting, Wei Yan studied him for a while before recognizing him as the later Shaanxi Protectorate Commissioner. They had indeed shared camaraderie during their time in the Qi family's camp.

But their interactions had dwindled afterward.

How strange—dreaming of Qi Rongyin was one thing, but why would he dream of this man as well?

Faintly, Wei Yan sensed that tonight's dream was different from those before.

He tried to rise, leaning against the wall, when a sharp pain shot through his hand. Looking down, he saw his palm wrapped in bloodstained bandages.

Earlier, upon opening his eyes and seeing Qi Rongyin, his mind had been entirely preoccupied, oblivious even to the pain in his hand. Now, clenching his fist again, the needle-like sting returned, and Wei Yan finally realized something was amiss.

Could pain in a dream feel this real?

Qi Rongyin returned with a basin of water, leading the Army Doctor up the city wall. Softly, she said, "Third Brother Wei has developed a high

fever. With Father and Elder Brother still pursuing the enemy, he mustn't fall ill now. Army Doctor, please examine him."

Hearing this, Wei Yan frowned. Old General Qi and the young general were still chasing the enemy?

In his memory, only once had Old General Qi acted on faulty intelligence, leading the father and sons to pursue the enemy together—and it was during that pursuit that the Qi family perished on the battlefield.

As the Army Doctor took his pulse, Wei Yan remained lost in a haze of thoughts.

After the examination, the physician retrieved a silver needle from his pouch. "The city has run out of medicine for cold damage. Since the Zhonglang's fever persists, this old man can only relieve it slightly by bleeding the Shangyang acupoint."

The needle pierced his fingertip, the pain unmistakably sharp.

Too real for a dream!

A suspicion formed in Wei Yan's mind, like a sword cleaving through the fog in his consciousness. A surge of wild joy overwhelmed him.

As the physician withdrew the needle, ignoring the pain in his fingertip, Wei Yan tightly grasped Qi Rongyin's hand. Tears glimmered in his usually calm eyes. "Rongyin, Rongyin... it's really you..."

His grip was so strong it hurt her delicate bones.

Her elegant brows, like distant mountains, furrowed slightly. "Of course it's me. What's wrong, Third Brother? You were only napping on the wall, yet you keep speaking nonsense upon waking..."

The Qi family were key border defenders. With the northern invaders attacking, Qi Rongyin had brought physicians to treat the wounded at the city gates.

Wei Yan laughed hoarsely, a mix of disheveled joy.

Qi Rongyin and the soldiers on the wall exchanged puzzled glances.

But Wei Yan quickly pulled himself up by the battlements and said to her, "I can't explain now. Quickly muster three thousand elite troops—we must ride out!"

If he had truly been reborn, this was the battle where Old General Qi and his sons, seeing the northern prince retreat, gave chase intending to capture him—only to fall into an ambush and die in the desert!

Qi Rongyin, having followed her father and brother beyond the pass, was keenly aware of military affairs and immediately sensed something amiss. "Are my father and brother in danger?" she asked.

Wei Yan, suppressing the throbbing pain in his temples from the chaotic memories, countered with a question instead of answering: "How long have they been out of the city?"

Qi Rongyin replied, "It's already been an hour."

Wei Yan's expression darkened. He didn't know if he could still alter the fate of the Qi father and son dying in battle, but since the heavens had granted him a second chance, he would fight with all his might. He commanded in a low voice, "Muster the troops and prepare the horses!"

Qi Rongyin's heart pounded wildly. Somewhere deep inside, she felt that something was wrong.

On the battlefield, sometimes just a few minutes' advantage could determine the outcome of a battle.

With her father and brother's lives at stake, she didn't have time to ask too many questions. She quickly ordered the deputy general left in the city to gather whatever soldiers were still fit to fight.

However, the troops in the city had just endured a fierce battle. The remaining elite forces had followed the Qi father and son in pursuit of the enemy. Even counting the wounded who could barely fight, they barely managed to assemble three thousand men, most of whom were exhausted.

If they rushed over such a long distance, even if they caught up in time to rescue the Qi father and son, facing the vicious Northern Turks, who were as fierce as wolves, it was uncertain whether they would be walking into a trap.

But Wei Yan remembered that in his previous life, Xie Linshan had already received news of Yanzhou's plight at this time and was rushing here with the Xie family's Iron Cavalry from Huizhou.

In his past life, he had fallen ill with this very cold. By the time Xie Linshan arrived with reinforcements, the battle at Yanzhou had already been won. The old general and his son had pursued the fleeing enemy and

captured the Northern Turk prince. But after waiting a long time without seeing Old General Qi return, they went to investigate. Following the traces of the army's detour, they circled around and finally found the bloodstained "Qi" banner and the corpses strewn across Mawang Slope.

The Northern Turks' ambush had taken place at Mawang Slope. If he marched at full speed now, he could save a lot of time that would otherwise be wasted tracking the army's hoofprints in circles. As long as they could hold out a little longer and send scouts to find Xie Linshan's forces, once the Xie family's Iron Cavalry arrived, the Northern Turks' scheme would fail.

As Wei Yan rode out of the city, he summoned his trusted aide and ordered him to gallop at full speed toward the main road from Huizhou to Yanzhou. If he encountered Xie Linshan, he was to tell him to head for Mawang Slope.

The aide, puzzled by the order, blurted out, "Master, how do you know General Xie will bring reinforcements?"

Wei Yan shot him a cold glare, and the aide felt a chill down his spine. He dared not ask further and quickly clasped his fists. "I'll deliver the message at once!"

With that, he spurred his horse toward the Huizhou road.

Wei Yan tugged on the reins, momentarily lost in thought. Indeed, before the bloodshed in Jinzhou, those around him had still dared to speak to him so casually.

Later, all those who had followed him died, and those who replaced them never dared to speak out of turn.

The memories brought bitterness to his heart. Wei Yan steeled himself and was about to order the troops to march when he heard a frantic call from the city gates: "Third Brother!"

Wei Yan reined in his horse and turned to see Qi Rongyin, wrapped in a snow fox fur cloak, running toward him through the slush.

Her cheeks were flushed from the cold wind and her haste.

Wei Yan yanked the reins, turning his horse toward Qi Rongyin. The warhorse halted five paces away from her, its front hooves rearing high and shaking off snowflakes.

Qi Rongyin handed him a peace talisman adorned with tassels: "Third Brother, take this peace talisman with you. You must return safely!"

She didn't know why Wei Yan had suddenly and urgently mobilized troops to leave the city, but she could sense the danger he was heading into.

As Wei Yan bent down to take the talisman, he also tightly grasped Qi Rongyin's hand, which was reddened from the cold. His face still bore the bloodstains from the previous battle, and he looked at her with a gaze she couldn't decipher—deep, laden with pain and sorrow. "Rong Yin," he said, "once this battle is over, let's get married, alright?"

The young girl, barely sixteen, stood frozen for a moment before finally curving her lips into a smile. "Alright," she replied.

The flush from the wind on her cheeks masked her shyness.

Wei Yan gave her hand another firm squeeze before grabbing the talisman, turning his horse around, and shouting, "Full speed ahead to Mawang Slope!"

A maid quickly opened an oil-paper umbrella to shield Qi Rongyin from the snowflakes falling like goose feathers, urging her, "Miss, let's return to the city first."

Qi Rongyin pressed her slender, pale hand to her chest, watching as Wei Yan led the remaining three thousand soldiers out of the city. A shadow of worry crossed her brow. "Lanyue," she murmured, "I don't know why, but ever since Third Brother mentioned mobilizing troops to leave the city, my heart has been uneasy. He's been acting strangely since he woke up—he must be hiding something from me..."

By the time the army reached the vicinity of Mawang Slope, the ground was already littered with corpses.

The soldiers accompanying Wei Yan were stunned at the sight of such devastation, evidence of yet another brutal battle.

Had their pursuing forces been ambushed?

Wei Yan's blood ran cold at the scene, but years of high command had honed his composure, leaving his expression unreadable. He only ordered in a low voice, "Find the Commander's Flag!"

His subordinates hurriedly searched the battlefield strewn with corpses for the flag.

Moments later, they reported back: "Colonel, the Qi family's Commander's Flag isn't here! Neither General Qi nor his men have been found!"

Wei Yan felt the weight on his chest lighten slightly—the absence of the flag and the Qi family meant they might still be alive.

But if they had broken through, they were likely still being pursued by the Northern Turks.

He barked, "All scouts, fan out and search for retreating hoofprints around the battlefield."

The army's scouts galloped off in all directions to investigate.

Soon, one scout raced back: "Colonel, there are scattered hoofprints beyond the mountain!"

Wei Yan dug his heels into his horse's flank, his stern face twisting with urgency. "After them!"

As they crossed a gentle slope, the distant clamor of battle echoed from beyond the mountain.

The army accelerated over the ridge, and from the steep slope, Wei Yan saw the Qi family's forces below, struggling desperately within the tightening encirclement of the Northern Turks.

The once-mighty army of ten thousand now appeared reduced to mere hundreds.

The Qi family's banner stood unyielding at the center, but the Northern Turks circled them in a taiji formation, using their horses' momentum to cut down layer after layer of the outermost defenders.

Cornered, exhausted, and with no hope of escape, the Qi troops could barely fight back—they were practically lambs to the slaughter.

The deputy general accompanying Wei Yan grew frantic. "Colonel," he urged, "we must save General Qi and his men at once!"

Wei Yan clenched his jaw, his gaze fixed on the Northern Turks' forces tightening their encirclement below. He barked, "Reform the battle

formation! These three thousand men must occupy the entire hill ahead. Plant banners in the shrubbery behind us and set up all the war drums!"

He had brought only three thousand battered troops. Charging down now would be suicide.

Their only chance was to create an illusion of strength, to intimidate the Northern Turks first.

The deputy general immediately went to deploy the orders.

As the war drums were set up, Wei Yan commanded, "Sound the horns!"

The soldier with a bronze animal horn at his waist took a deep breath and blew—"Woo—woo—"

The long, resonant notes echoed across the battlefield below.

Fortunately, the mountain hollow was shaped like a trumpet, amplifying the sound as the north wind carried it downward, creating echoes from all directions.

The tightening Northern Turk forces slowed, turning to look up the slope.

"Beat the drums!" Wei Yan roared again.

The soldiers standing before the massive, man-high drums swung their mallets.

"Boom—"

"Boom-boom—"

The thunderous drumbeats shook the ground like a storm.

The Northern Turk ranks below visibly stirred. At first glance, the entire slope seemed filled with Great Yin reinforcements, banners fluttering in the shrubbery. The sheer implied numbers gave the Northern Turks pause.

With the ruse in place, only a desperate fight remained.

Wei Yan dug his heels into his horse's flank, leading the charge downhill. His crescent-moon Saber, forged of fine steel, cleaved through the northern winds as he bellowed, "Attack—!"

Behind him, three thousand soldiers followed, charging down Horse King Slope.

Though three thousand couldn't match the earth-shaking force of ten thousand, the thunderous drumbeats terrified many Northern Turks.

Seizing this advantage, Wei Yan quickly tore a gap in their encirclement.

But three thousand exhausted troops could only do so much.

Though the initial feint caught the Northern Turks off guard, their commanders soon realized the true numbers and adjusted. They pulled back the battered front lines, sending flanking forces to seal the gap, aiming to trap this sudden "reinforcement."

The deputy general, fighting desperately, shouted to Wei Yan, "Commandant, these savages mean to box us in too!"

From the distant Qi family forces, surrounded by Northern Turks, a hoarse cry came: "Commandant Wei! The general orders you to retreat with your men!"

Wei Yan cut down a blocking Northern Turk officer, his eyes burning with fury as he pressed forward.

"Commandant, retreat!" the deputy urged through gritted teeth. "Don't throw lives away recklessly! Preserve these brave men—we'll make the Northern Turks pay in blood another day! If they seal the gap, we die for nothing!"

Wei Yan, now blood-mad, turned and snarled, "Reinforcements are coming! Hold for one more quarter of an hour!"

The deputy, knowing the Wei and Qi families' close ties, assumed he was lying to save Old General Qi and nearly cursed in frustration—

Then the ground trembled beneath their horses' hooves, rocks shaking loose. This time, the earth truly shook.

Amid the deep, resonant drumbeats, an overwhelming roar erupted from behind: "Kill—"

The sheer force of the sound alone made eardrums ache.

The deputy general turned his head in alarm and saw a vast black iron cavalry charging down from Horse King Slope like a raging flood.

At the horizon where snow met sky, a fluttering "Xie" banner advanced with the black tide.

At the forefront rode a young general on a silver-saddled white steed—his face divine yet his expression demonic, his crimson cloak whipping violently in the icy wind, striking awe into all who beheld him.

The Northern Turks below, still attempting to tighten their encirclement, froze in terror at the battle cries behind them. Before they could reorganize their ranks to counterattack, the Xie Family's Iron Cavalry plunged down like a sharp wedge, tearing their formation apart.

The exhausted Qi Family Army, trapped at the center of the enemy's ranks, nearly wept with joy at the sight of the "Xie" banner. "The Xie Family's Iron Cavalry! General Xie has brought reinforcements!"

Someone let out a triumphant cry. Though their arms were numb and weak from prolonged combat, they raised their swords once more and fought their way toward the reinforcements, inching forward with desperate resolve.

Wei Yan's heart finally settled at the sight of the Xie Family Army Flag. His feverish body, worn from relentless battles, left him dazed and unsteady.

The deputy general asked in astonishment, "Captain, how did you know General Xie's reinforcements were coming?"

Wei Yan didn't answer, gripping his blade as he pressed forward toward the Qi Family Army's encirclement.

When the two forces converged, his eyes immediately found Old General Qi, surrounded by his personal guard—though the old general clutched his waist, his hand already stained crimson with blood.

A severe wound, unmistakably.

Wei Yan's chest tightened. He urged his horse forward and called out, "General!"

Old General Qi, his hair and beard streaked with white, bore a formidable and dignified presence—though now his lips were pale, and he leaned heavily on his eldest son for support.

Recognizing Wei Yan, his expression softened slightly. "You and Linshan have come."

Wei Yan dismounted, his face twisting with grief at the sight of the unstanched wound. His eyes burned. "How... were you injured?"

To Wei Yan, Old General Qi was both mentor and father.

In his past life, it had been Wei Yan's own careless words that ignited the old emperor's long-held suspicions of the Qi family. To weaken the Crown Prince's faction, the emperor had struck first against them.

It wasn't until the Northern Turks attacked Jinzhou again—forcing the emperor to reluctantly return the Qi family's military authority to Xie Linshan—that they uncovered the truth: the deaths of the Qi father and son had also been the old emperor's doing.

Even with a second chance... could he still not save General Qi?

Qi Xianhui, the eldest son, supported his father with bloodshot eyes. "That traitor Xu Ce—even if he was trampled to death beneath the hooves of battle, it wouldn't be enough to quell my hatred for the sword he drove into my father!"

Wei Yan's head snapped up. "Xu Ce wounded the General?"

Qi Xianhui ground his teeth. "The bastard ambushed him!"

His lips trembled with fury as he took in his father's ashen face—pale from blood loss. He turned away, barely holding back tears.

In his previous life, Wei Yan had only discovered that Xu Ce of the Qi Family Army, acting on the Old Emperor's orders, had falsified military reports. Knowing full well that the Northern Turks had set an ambush, Xu Ce still lured the Qi father and son into pursuing the enemy. Yet Wei Yan had never known that the fatal wound on Old General Qi's body was also inflicted by Xu Ce.

Rage surged through him, making his blood boil, but he forced himself to stay calm. "First, we return to Yanzhou City," he said. "The general's injuries require immediate treatment."

The Northern Turks knew when to retreat. Seeing that Great Yin's reinforcements had arrived and the Xie Family's Iron Cavalry was unstoppable, they realized their attempt to trap and annihilate the Qi Family Army was hopeless. Immediately, they sounded the retreat.

When Xie Linshan arrived clad in bloodstained armor, he saw Old General Qi's ashen face and tensed immediately. "Is the general injured?"

Wei Yan lifted his gaze to the young general, whose demeanor was still bright and spirited despite the circumstances. The biting northern wind

had left his eyes dry and slightly reddened. He called out, “Linshan?”

Eighteen years of cold moons and warm suns had worn away at his lifespan, blurring the memory of his old friend’s face. All he could recall was the sight of his corpse being transported back from Yanzhou—covered in axe and blade wounds, blackened arrow holes, and a chest and abdomen that had been split open and crudely stitched back together...

That was a young commander whom even Old General Qi had once declared, with a few more years of tempering, might surpass his own achievements. Yet in the end, he had met such a wretched fate!

Now, it truly felt like a reunion across lifetimes.

Seeing the redness in Wei Yan’s eyes, Xie Linshan assumed it was due to concern for Old General Qi and asked at once, “Yigui, who wounded the general?”

Wei Yan forced himself to steady his thoughts. “There’s a traitor in the Qi family’s army. It’s a long story, but the general’s injuries are urgent. We’ll speak more once we return to the city.”

Xie Linshan knew Old General Qi’s condition couldn’t afford delay and nodded.

By the time Wei Yan and Xie Linshan escorted the remnants of the Qi family’s army back to Yanzhou, dusk had fallen.

Qi Rongyin spotted the returning troops from the city walls and rushed down. Seeing her brother’s bloodied face and Old General Qi being carried on a makeshift stretcher of branches and vines by his personal guards, her face instantly paled.

Gathering her skirts, she approached with forced composure. “What happened to Father?”

Qi Xianhui’s throat tightened. He couldn’t bring himself to offer his younger sister any comforting words, turning his face aside to suppress his grief.

It was Wei Yan who spoke. “The general was wounded by the traitor Xu Ce. Let the Army Doctor examine him first.”

The group carried Old General Qi into the city lord’s residence. As the Army Doctor tended to him, Qi Rongyin and her brother remained steadfast by his bedside.

Servants brought in basins of water, only to carry out basins of bloodied water moments later. Not a word was spoken; the atmosphere in the room was suffocating.

Everyone knew Old General Qi's condition was dire.

Wei Yan and Xie Linshan stood with arms crossed at the doorway. After a glance at the Qi siblings inside, Xie Linshan said to Wei Yan, "Yigui, may we speak privately?"

Wei Yan knew what Xie Linshan wanted to ask and nodded, following him away.

Once they reached a secluded spot, Xie Linshan cut straight to the point. "Yigui, how did you know I was leading troops to Yanzhou? And how did you know the Northern Turks would ambush the general at Mawang Slope? On our way back, I sent scouts to survey the terrain. The general was lured by the Northern Turks in a wide detour before reaching Mawang Slope."

Though the rescue had succeeded, Xie Linshan was acutely aware that without Wei Yan's advance warning—directing him straight to Mawang Slope—he would never have arrived in time by following the army's trail.

Wei Yan met his friend's gaze, a tumult of unspoken emotions flickering in his eyes. Finally, he said, "Linshan, you know I don't believe in the supernatural. But something inexplicable has indeed happened to me."

"After a brutal battle, I closed my eyes for a brief rest on the city walls, exhausted. What followed was like watching the rest of my life unfold in a blur. Today's peril faced by Old General Qi and his son—do you truly believe Xu Ce alone could have orchestrated it?"

Xie Linshan caught the implication, his expression sharpening. "The Jia family?"

Jia Guifei was currently at the height of imperial favor, and the Jia family rose to prominence along with her. The Sixteenth Prince sought to contend for the throne with the Crown Prince, and the covert and overt struggles between the Jia and Qi families had been ongoing for quite some time.

Yet Wei Yan shook his head. After two lifetimes, he finally voiced the guilt that had tormented him for most of his life to an old friend: "It was my words about 'abdication' that reached His Majesty's ears."

Xie Linshan's pupils contracted sharply as he abruptly turned to look at Wei Yan. "So it was His Majesty who wanted the Qi family dead?"

Wei Yan closed his eyes heavily. "The Qi family held significant military power. The one in the palace fears the Crown Prince to such an extent, and with an honored guest from the Eastern Palace leaking my 'abdication' remarks, to deal with the Crown Prince, the first to be eliminated would naturally be the Qi family. Without military power, no matter how high the Crown Prince's reputation among the people, he would ultimately remain just the 'Crown Prince.'"

Xie Linshan fell silent, his expression grim and terrifying.

Wei Yan continued, "If everything unfolds as I saw in my dream, the annihilation of the Qi family in battle is only the beginning. By the time the Crown Prince uncovers the truth, the Crown Prince, the Xie family, and I, Wei Yan, will all be eradicated by that virtue-less ruler on the throne."

Xie Linshan frowned. "Since being named Crown Prince, His Highness has always been benevolent and tolerant. Despite repeated suppression by the Sixteenth Prince and the Jia family, he has never acted rashly. Even if your reckless words reached the palace, what fault could he possibly find to topple the Eastern Palace and the Wei and Xie families in one fell swoop?"

Recalling what the Old Emperor had done to the Qi family, Xie Linshan's expression turned cold. "Are they framing the Crown Prince with the charge of treason?"

Throughout history, only the crime of treason could thoroughly eradicate a crown prince's faction.

Wei Yan gave a bitter smile. "Worse than what you imagine."

Xie Linshan was stunned, unable to fathom what crime could be greater than treason.

Wei Yan said, "Soon, the Northern Turks will invade Jinzhou again. With the Qi family gone, you will replace them to defend Jinzhou. That tyrant will have no choice but to hand over the Qi family's military power to you. Empress Qi will fall gravely ill, and to prevent the Qi family from losing all influence in the palace after her passing, leaving the Crown Prince without support, she will summon Rong Yin into the palace. Envious of the Crown Prince's popularity among the people, the Sixteenth Prince will incite the populace to build a living shrine for him. The tyrant will seize this

opportunity to accuse the Crown Prince, stripping him of his regency powers."

"To seek a way out, the Crown Prince will volunteer to lead the northern campaign personally. In the Qi family's army, he will uncover the truth about their annihilation. Cornered, the tyrant will, to conceal his own misdeeds, orchestrate delays in the supply convoy. In the end, Jinzhou will fall, and both you and the Crown Prince will perish under the Northern Turks' blades. The blame for the delayed supplies and the fall of Jinzhou will be pinned on me."

Xie Linshan felt his hair stand on end and exclaimed, "Preposterous!"

After a moment to compose himself, he asked, "Is there any evidence? Proof that Xu Ce was acting under orders from the palace?"

Wei Yan replied, "Xu Ce already died on the battlefield, but his son will rank within the top ten in this year's imperial examinations. Xu Ce's son lacks true talent. If you, Linshan, care to look into his usual poetry and essays, you'll see the extent of his scholarly abilities."

The Old Emperor's methods were meticulous. In their previous lives, Wei Yan and Xie Linshan had not easily traced the matter to Xu Ce, especially since Xu Ce, along with the Qi family's father and son and the ten thousand soldiers who pursued the enemy that day, had all perished in the Northern Turks' ambush—and were posthumously honored as loyal martyrs.

It was only later, when the Crown Prince suffered repeated suppression from the Old Emperor and voluntarily relocated to Jinzhou, leaving his remaining faction in the capital out of imperial favor, that they attempted to recruit a few upright officials from the court to serve as their "eyes and ears" in the capital. It was during this selection process that they came across Xu Ce's son.

A top-ten ranking in the imperial examinations was an achievement that would make one stand out anywhere.

At the time, Xu Ce's son was merely a compiler in the Hanlin Academy, but if he harbored ambitions, there would be ample opportunities for future success. Moreover, his father had been a loyal general under the Qi family. After careful consideration, they deemed Xu Ce's son the most suitable candidate for their purposes.

Unexpectedly, during their detailed investigation of him, they discovered his mediocre talents—hardly the caliber of someone who could rank in the

top tier of the examinations.

Following the trail, they uncovered the truth behind the deaths of the Qi father and son in battle.

With one month remaining before the examination results were announced, Wei Yan and Xie Linshan, after deliberation, decided to temporarily conceal the matter from the hot-tempered Qi Xianhui.

Old General Qi's injuries were severe, and though he barely survived, he could no longer wield weapons. Fearing it would dishearten the old general and lacking concrete evidence, the two refrained from informing him until the matter was settled.

But they had already begun investigating Xu Ce's son.

By the time the examination results were announced, the imperial decree summoning them to the capital for their appointments had also arrived.

Old General Qi, still recovering from his injuries, was unfit for the long journey, so his son Qi Xianhui went to the capital in his stead. Aware of his declining years, the old general also entrusted the Tiger Tally to his eldest son, instructing him to return it to the emperor.

The Old Emperor had ascended the throne entirely through the military power of the Qi family. Though Old General Qi could no longer take to the battlefield, Qi Xianhui remained a formidable presence.

If the emperor were to reclaim the Tiger Tally now, it would reveal his intent to discard allies once their usefulness ended—a move that would alienate his ministers. The Old Emperor wouldn't act so hastily and risk losing their loyalty.

Thus, the Tiger Tally would most likely remain in Qi Xianhui's hands.

After the three arrived in the capital, Wei Yan and Xie Linshan were often seen visiting various taverns together, much to Qi Xianhui's displeasure.

Back in the army, the three had been close brothers. Why, upon returning to the capital, had they suddenly grown distant, excluding him from their outings?

Qi Xianhui sulked for days, but the two seemed utterly oblivious, infuriating him to the point where he shattered several flagstones in the

Office of Presentations courtyard during spear practice.

After observing them for two more days, he realized something was amiss!

Whenever they went out, they even switched carriages midway—utterly suspicious!

Qi Xianhui decided to tail them secretly and was stunned to find them entering a brothel together.

Furious, he stormed in after them and kicked down their door.

Built like his father—tall and powerfully built—his mighty kick tore the door clean off its hinges.

His booming voice made the teacups rattle: "Wei Yan, you listen here! How dare you visit a brothel while courting my sister? Do you think our Qi army of a hundred thousand men can't find her a worthy husband? No wonder you've been avoiding me—you've been whoring around!"

Caught off guard by this tirade in the midst of their covert investigation, Wei Yan and Xie Linshan had no choice. One dragged Qi Xianhui inside to avoid a public spectacle, while the other clamped a hand over his mouth.

After much pulling and shoving, they finally got him into the room.

The manager of the brothel, sensing the situation was getting out of hand, stepped in to take control. He shooed away the onlookers with a jest about an elder brother catching his future brother-in-law visiting a brothel and flying into a rage. He then stationed clever attendants at nearby entrances to prevent eavesdropping.

Wei Yan went to prop up the dismantled door panel, while Xie Linshan alone held down Qi Xianhui, inadvertently loosening the hand covering his mouth.

Qi Xianhui threw back his head and howled, "Don't think you can drag me into your filth! I'm a married man! I must keep myself pure!"

Xie Linshan promptly pulled out a tablecloth and stuffed it into Qi Xianhui's mouth.

Qi Xianhui grunted, his eyes practically fire breathing with rage.

Xie Linshan said, "Brother Xianhui, my apologies. Brother Yigui and I came here not for pleasure but for urgent matters. The Office of

Presentations has too many ears, so we had no choice but to resort to this."

As he spoke, he placed a stack of documents before Qi Xianhui. "Brother Xianhui, take a look."

Qi Xianhui flipped through a couple of pages and immediately protested, "I've hated reading all my life! What's the point of showing me these poems?"

Wei Yan said, "This person, who usually only produces crude and shoddy verses, ranked in the top ten of the recent Imperial exam. Don't you find that suspicious, Brother Xianhui?"

Qi Xianhui frowned. "So he cheated on the exam?"

Wei Yan replied, "He is Xu Ce's son."

Qi Xianhui's face twisted in fury. "That traitor Xu Ce! I've already drafted a battle report on behalf of my father and submitted it to His Majesty. The son of a criminal dares to dream of entering officialdom through exam fraud?"

Wei Yan and Xie Linshan exchanged glances, both falling silent for a moment.

Xie Linshan said, "The palace exam is personally overseen by His Majesty. There's no way to cheat there."

Qi Xianhui finally caught on, albeit belatedly. "So His Majesty helped him secure this ranking?"

This conclusion clearly baffled him. He looked up at Xie and Wei and asked, "Why? Why would His Majesty help the son of a traitor cheat?"

Wei Yan then explained, "That battle report accusing Xu Ce has been temporarily withheld by the Crown Prince and hasn't reached His Majesty yet."

Qi Xianhui's mind was in turmoil.

His Majesty didn't know about Xu Ce's betrayal yet and was helping Xu Ce's son cheat...

A chill ran down Qi Xianhui's spine. "Xu Ce is His Majesty's man?"

Xie and Wei remained silent, tacitly confirming it.

Qi Xianhui slammed the octagonal table hard and cursed, "Absurd! The Qi family has fought tooth and nail for him. How dare he—"

He was about to raise his voice again when Wei Yan quickly covered his mouth. "I understand your grief and anger, Brother Xianhui, but this brothel isn't entirely free of eavesdroppers. Best to watch your words."

Qi Xianhui finally calmed down.

Seeing he had quieted, Wei Yan removed his hand from Qi Xianhui's mouth.

Qi Xianhui's temples bulged with veins as he suppressed his rage and hatred. "What's your plan?"

After exchanging another glance with Xie Linshan, Wei Yan said, "His Highness already knows about how you and the general nearly died in Yanzhou. You hold the Tiger Tally for the Qi family's hundred thousand troops, and Linshan commands the Xie Family Army from Huizhou. Now we're just waiting for His Highness's approval."

What they were waiting for approval for went without saying.

The Old Emperor could no longer tolerate the Qi family and sought to reclaim military power by exterminating them. Without the Qi family, the Crown Prince would be nothing.

The emperor had already placed a blade at the Crown Prince's throat.

Wei Yan knew that given the Crown Prince's gentle and benevolent nature, making this decision would take considerable struggle. But in the end, he would have only one path to take.

After all, to yield again would be to send the Eastern Palace and the Qi family down the path of death once more.

Though Qi Xianhui had just been enraged by the news that the emperor intended to harm his entire family, after hearing Wei Yan and Xie Linshan calmly lay out their plans, he still felt a chill creeping through his limbs.

Rebellion—a crime punishable by the extermination of nine generations—was a single misstep away from the annihilation of his entire clan.

But when he thought of the Qi family soldiers who had died on the battlefield, and how both he and his father had narrowly escaped death, if Wei Yan and Xie Linshan were willing to stake everything, what did the Qi family have to fear?

Qi Xianhui quickly clenched his fists and declared, "Such a tyrant is unworthy of the Qi family shedding blood on the battlefield for him!"

He turned to Wei Yan. "Aside from the Five Armies Garrison, the Divine Machine Battalion in the capital is another formidable force."

Wei Yan replied, "Leave that to me and Linshan."

After this discussion, the Xie, Wei, and Qi families were essentially aligned in their plan to force the Old Emperor to "abdicate."

However, due to Qi Xianhui's loud outburst that day, rumors spread about Wei Yan and Xie Linshan visiting brothels.

Many noblewomen in the capital wept over this, unable to believe that the "Twin Jades of the Capital" were also men who frequented such places!

The next day, when Wei Yan encountered Qi Rongyin at the Office of Presentations and tried to speak to her, she didn't even glance his way. Holding a round fan, she walked past him with a cold expression.

When Xie Linshan came looking for Wei Yan, he was carrying a large bouquet of crabapple blossoms. Seeing Wei Yan, he awkwardly rubbed his nose and said, "A-Wan heard about my visit to the brothel and refuses to see me. Could you give these flowers to her for me and... put in a good word?"

Wei Yan said, "You've reminded me—I'll ask Xianhui to plead my case with Rongyin."

But when Wei Yan sought out Qi Xianhui and explained his request, Qi Xianhui wore a pained expression. "All my belongings have been thrown out of my wife's room, and she's even drafted divorce papers for me to sign."

Xie Linshan: "..."

Wei Yan: "..."

A shared sense of desolation settled over them.

Qi Xianhui rubbed his temples in frustration. "Rongyin cried all night with her sister-in-law and said she wants to call off the engagement. Since our plan hasn't succeeded yet, I can't tell them the truth. Today, the Duke of Qing's residence is hosting a flower banquet, and my wife took Rongyin there. They even invited Miss Wei, saying they'd help her pick a suitable husband at the banquet."

Wei Yan and Xie Linshan's expressions darkened instantly. They clasped their fists in unison. "We take our leave."

...

In the late spring of the sixteenth year of Qishun, the Old Emperor fell "gravely ill." The Sixteenth Prince and the Jia family conspired to rebel but were captured by Crown Prince Chengde, along with key generals like Wei Yan, Xie Linshan, and Qi Xianhui.

The Late Emperor, unable to bear the shock of discovering that his beloved concubine and favored son harbored such treacherous ambitions, "failed to recover" and passed away.

Crown Prince Chengde, the rightful heir, was urged by his officials to ascend the throne, ushering in the Qinghe era.

That same year, the new emperor arranged marriages for his two most trusted ministers, Wei Yan and Xie Linshan, and personally presided over their weddings.

Not long after, the Northern Jue invaded again. Xie Linshan took his wife, Wei Wan, to guard the border at Jinzhou, while Wei Yan remained in the capital. Concerned for his sister's safety, he assigned his most capable retainer, Wei Qilin, to serve under Xie Linshan and protect Wei Wan.

Three years later, the northern frontier was secured, and peace reigned across the land. Xie Linshan returned to the capital with his wife to visit family, bringing along a bright-eyed, fair-skinned toddler.

The child had been born while Xie Linshan was away at war. A passing magician claimed the boy's fate was extraordinarily strong and that an ordinary name wouldn't suffice to balance it. Thus, Xie Linshan named him "Zheng" (Conquest).

When Wei Wan returned home for a short stay, Wei Qilin approached Wei Yan with a request: "Master, this humble general has taken a liking to a young lady and wishes to ask you to act as a matchmaker on my behalf."

At the time, Wei Yan was dressed in refined Confucian robes, painting in his study. Hearing this, his brush paused slightly as he asked, "Which family's daughter?"

Wei Qilin replied, "The only daughter of Old General Meng Shuyuan, the Changshan General under General Xie's command."

Wei Yan raised his eyes: "You wish to marry their daughter?"

The rough-skinned general grinned sheepishly and said, "This humble general wishes to be taken in as a son-in-law."

A gentle breeze blew through the open lattice window, rustling the rice paper on the painting desk.

Wei Yan seemed to smile as well and said, "Very well."

Chapter 177

Extra Story: Supporting Each Other

The autumn breeze was gentle, carrying the fragrance of osmanthus throughout the courtyard.

Four-year-old Xie Zheng practiced thrusting motions with a small wooden sword in the yard, swinging it repeatedly until his arms grew sore, yet he refused to stop.

Under the blazing sun, his chubby cheeks flushed pink, and a fine layer of sweat beaded on his forehead. His eyes held a stubborn determination and focus far beyond his years.

Wei Wan sat on the leaning rail beneath the corridor, leisurely fanning herself with a flower and bird fan adorned with a green jade tassel. She sighed helplessly to Meng Lihua beside her, "A few days ago, his father pointed out that his sword techniques were sloppy. Ever since, aside from eating, studying, and sleeping, he's been clutching that wooden sword to practice whenever he gets a chance. He's been this stubborn since he was little—nothing like me or his father. He takes after his uncle instead."

Wei Qilin had been assigned to Wei Wan by Wei Yan, making him part of her maternal family. He was highly valued under Xie Linshan's command and had become son-in-law to Meng Shuyuan, a veteran general under Xie Linshan, further strengthening the close ties between the Xie and Meng families.

Wei Qilin was accompanying Xie Linshan on a border inspection and wouldn't return for months. Knowing Meng Lihua was heavily pregnant and fearing she might grow lonely at home, Wei Wan had invited her over for company, chatting to pass the time and sharing child-rearing wisdom.

Over time, the two had become close friends.

Meng Lihua chuckled at Wei Wan's words. "They say a nephew takes after his uncle—there's truth to that."

She rubbed her rounded belly. "This little one in me is quite lazy. Even at this stage, it hardly moves. I think it must be a quiet girl. But when her

father tries to tease her, she kicks so fiercely it kept him up all night. The next day, he came to me with a long face, asking what we'd do if it turned out to be a boy."

Wei Wan couldn't help but laugh. "General Wei wants a daughter?"

Meng Lihua's eyes held a mix of amusement and exasperation. "The moment the pregnancy was confirmed, he started brainstorming names. Despite barely knowing a handful of characters, he had his Record Keepers flipping through books for days before proudly announcing to me that if it's a girl, she'll be named Changyu. He's also been collecting clothes for her from infancy up to her first birthday—already filled several trunks."

Wei Wan smiled. "And if it's a boy?"

Meng Lihua's expression turned complicated. "He said boys are tough, so we'd just call him 'Iron Egg' or 'Iron Ox' for the time being. Once he's older, his grandfather can give him a proper name."

Wei Wan hadn't expected the usually steady and reliable Wei Qilin to be like this in private. Leaning against the rail, she laughed until tears nearly spilled from her eyes. "It seems General Wei truly adores daughters."

Her gaze then shifted to her young son practicing swordsmanship outside the corridor. "I've heard of an old folk belief—children under five can tell whether a pregnant woman is carrying a girl or a boy."

Meng Lihua looked surprised. "Such a thing exists?"

Wei Wan grinned. "Shall we test it?"

She called out to her son, "Zheng'er, come here to Mother."

Hearing her voice, Xie Zheng turned and saw his mother beckoning from the corridor. He sheathed his wooden sword and approached. "Mother, you called?"

Wei Wan wiped his sweaty face with a handkerchief, her voice gentle. "Aren't you afraid of the sun? Look at all this sweat."

Xie Zheng roughly wiped his face with his sleeve. "I'm fine."

Wei Wan had a servant bring him a cup of honeyed flower tea, then asked, "Zheng'er, would you like a little brother or sister?"

Xie Zheng answered bluntly, "No."

Wei Wan asked, "Why?"

The child frowned slightly and said, "Crying is annoying."

Over the years, the key generals under Xie Linshan had gradually started families. Since they were frequently away on campaigns and there were no decent schools in the frontier regions, Xie Linshan had arranged for the children of his officers to attend a private school at the Xie residence, ensuring their education and easing their fathers' concerns.

In the classroom, Xie Zheng was most often subjected to the endless wails of the younger children, who could cry for half a day without stopping.

He had no desire for a younger brother or sister. If there were a little one at home who screamed all day, he doubted he'd ever get a peaceful night's sleep.

Wei Wan had only asked casually, but the child's unexpected response left her stifling laughter.

She coaxed her son, "Then how about a little brother or sister from Auntie Meng's family to play with you? Do you think Auntie Meng is carrying a brother or sister?"

Xie Zheng tilted his head to look at the round bulge beneath Meng Lihua's skirt, then answered with a serious expression, "A sister."

He had no idea whether the baby was a boy or a girl, but he figured a sister would be less troublesome. Otherwise, it might be like General Liu's son—always provoking him, then howling like a slaughtered pig after getting beaten before running home to tattle. When word reached his father, Xie Zheng would end up getting scolded again.

Meng Lihua gently stroked her belly with a tender smile. "I'm also hoping for a daughter."

Wei Wan teased her son, "If it really is a sister, how about you marry her later and bring her home as my daughter-in-law?"

The little boy, still unaware of what marriage meant, frowned. "Why would she have to be your daughter-in-law?"

Wei Wan and Meng Lihua both laughed at his innocent words.

Wei Wan pinched her son's slightly puffed cheeks and said, "Because I'd like her."

Xie Zheng seemed to consider this seriously before replying, "Okay."

This response only made Wei Wan and Meng Lihua laugh even harder.

Three months later, Meng Lihua indeed gave birth to a daughter.

When the news reached the Xie residence, Wei Wan was momentarily surprised before delightedly preparing a generous array of gifts to send to the Meng household in celebration.

Xie Zheng, who had been studying by the window, suddenly asked, "Mother, did Auntie Meng have her baby?"

"Yes, Zheng'er. Are you thinking about your little wife already?" Wei Wan continued teasing him mischievously.

Xie Zheng pressed his lips together, gripping his book silently.

That night, back in his room, he pulled out a blank notebook from his desk drawer, ground some ink, and wrote a line on the first page:

Birthday: 11th day of the first month, Qinghe Year 5.

It wasn't until the hundred-day celebration that Xie Zheng finally met the little sister who had spent ten months in Auntie Meng's belly.

In the lively front hall, a crowd of women surrounded the tiny bundle in swaddling clothes, chatting and laughing. Xie Zheng, standing beside his mother, found it all incredibly dull. When he glanced at the baby, he noticed she seemed just as uninterested—though fair and adorable, her eyelids drooped sleepily, as if she might doze off at any moment. No matter who held her, she didn't cry.

The women praised her as an easy child before launching into stories about how troublesome their own children were.

Meng Lihua smiled in response, but seeing her daughter's lack of energy, she assumed the baby was sleepy. Unable to leave her guests, she handed the child to the nursemaid and instructed her to take the baby to a side room for a nap.

Xie Zheng thought the little one was lazy, not sleepy.

Seeing the little one being carried away, he followed out of the front hall, wanting to take a stroll outside.

The nanny noticed him and asked cheerfully, "Has the young master come to see the little miss? The wind and snow are fierce out there—come inside to see her."

Xie Zheng felt that refusing would make him seem insincere, so after a brief consideration, he toddled into the side room.

The little one had been placed in the cradle. Spotting a stranger enter, she simply stared at him with those lazy, sleepy eyes.

The nanny tucked a silk quilt around her and moved the tiger-head cloth toy and rattle to one side of the cradle.

Seeing Xie Zheng standing by the cradle, she handed him the rattle and said with a smile, "Young master, why don't you play with our little miss?"

Xie Zheng remembered that when he was three, his mother had still used this very toy to amuse him. He found the dong-dong-dong noise unbearably loud and would reach out to grab it, hoping she'd stop shaking it.

But the adults, seeing him reach for it whenever it made noise, mistook his actions for delight and shook it even more enthusiastically.

It hadn't been a pleasant experience.

Xie Zheng didn't take the rattle. "I'll just look," he said.

He stared at the little one, and the little one stared back.

The nanny said, "Our little miss has a sweet temper—she rarely cries or fusses, though she does love her naps. Once she falls asleep, young master mustn't disturb her."

Xie Zheng said, "She's not sleepy."

He waved his hand in front of the little one. Perhaps because, from birth until now, she'd only seen adults, the sudden appearance of a much smaller person playing with her intrigued her. The baby girl in the cradle suddenly reached out and grabbed the finger wiggling before her.

Xie Zheng tried to pull free but couldn't.

Afraid of making the soft little creature cry, he didn't dare use too much force.

Yet the chubby little hand gripping his finger was as soft as milk curd but surprisingly strong, holding on firmly.

Finding it novel, Xie Zheng didn't pull away. Instead, he gave her plump little hand a gentle squeeze.

The little one seemed delighted, kicking her legs and stretching her other arm, even breaking into a grin.

The nanny chuckled. "Our little miss likes the young master!"

The next moment, however, the tiny thing in the cradle grabbed Xie Zheng's finger and stuffed it into her mouth.

Xie Zheng's expression darkened instantly. He yanked his hand free, scowled at the drool on his fingertip, and marched straight to the washbasin to scrub it clean.

Whether startled or upset at losing her toy, the little one in the cradle suddenly burst into loud, vigorous wails—not the usual high-pitched cries of an infant but full-throated, powerful sobs.

The nanny tried to soothe her with the rattle and the tiger-head toy, but nothing worked. Even after picking her up and pacing around the room, the baby wouldn't stop crying.

Xie Zheng, having just washed his hands, glared at the little one before finally resigning himself and offering his finger again.

The little one stopped crying at once. Tears still clung to her long lashes as she began sucking his finger with gusto.

Xie Zheng was taken aback, then turned to the nanny. "She's hungry."

The nanny blinked. "The mistress fed the little miss less than half an hour ago. She shouldn't be hungry so soon."

Even so, she sent someone to the kitchen to warm a bowl of goat's milk.

When Meng Lihua was unwell and couldn't nurse, she would temporarily feed the child warm goat's milk instead.

With so many guests today, the nanny knew Meng Lihua likely couldn't get away, so she first tried soothing the little one with goat's milk.

A maid quickly brought over a bowl of warmed goat's milk. The nanny dipped a spoon and brought it to the baby's lips, who indeed spat out her fingers to chase after the spoon.

The nanny exclaimed in surprise, "The young miss really was hungry!"

She fed the child over half a bowl with the spoon before the little one started dodging, refusing more.

Wiping the baby's mouth with a silk handkerchief, the nanny chuckled, "A big appetite is good—makes for a strong body. This young miss may have tiny hands and feet, but she's quite strong!"

The infant in the rocking cradle, as if understanding the adults were playing with her, obligingly kicked at the silk quilt covering her and waved her chubby little hands.

Xie Zheng thought the child must truly be tired this time—those plump paws gradually lost their vigor as they waved, and her eyelids slowly drooped.

Eat then sleep—he found this little one quite lazy indeed.

Though when she cried, she didn't seem quite so annoying?

Returning that day, Xie Zheng added another page to his little notebook: Gluttonous, sleepy, lazy.

After a pause, he appended: Easy to raise—

Time flew, and in the blink of an eye, Xie Zheng turned eleven.

For children of ordinary officials at his age, they'd be pressured to take the imperial exams—studying for years to qualify as government students before advancing further.

Scholar, provincial graduate, palace graduate—each major hurdle clearly lay ahead.

Since Xie Zheng would join the military later, he didn't need to take the exams, but Xie Linshan remained strict about his studies.

Fortunately, he'd been studious since childhood, earning consistent praise from academy teachers.

With no great scholars beyond the frontier, Xie Linshan discussed with Wei Wan about sending him to Luyuan Academy or back to the capital's Imperial College in a couple years.

Xie Zheng paid this no mind—either destination suited him equally.

At ten, he'd taken several personal guards and spent months traversing Great Yin's northern border by horse, living rough, frightening his mother to tears. When he finally returned mud-streaked, his father punished him with ancestral hall kneeling before he could even eat.

Over the years, his various misadventures earned frequent paternal reprimands.

His father often told his mother the boy was strong-willed, wild-natured, and uncontainable—once he stood taller than a horse's back, they'd toss him into military training.

Xie Zheng actually longed to join the army now—hardships notwithstanding, it offered vast freedom.

But at his current age, the troops would only see Xie Linshan's son.

Unwilling to leverage that identity, wanting to forge his own path, he'd need to wait a few more years until he matched common soldiers' stature to enlist anonymously as a foot soldier.

Nowadays, academy studies merely passed the time.

After class one day, someone called out: "Brother Xie, help me with something."

Xie Zheng lazily lifted his gaze to regard the all-brawn-no-brains fellow.

The caller was General Liu's son, Liu Xuan.

Incidentally, General Liu originally served under Xie Zheng's uncle, but when the latter remained in the capital as a civil official, he reassigned Liu to the Xie Family Army.

Liu Xuan had been a troublemaker since childhood, becoming the little tyrant of the academy. In earlier years, seeing that Xie Zheng didn't fear him like others did, he had picked fights with Xie Zheng several times. But each time, he ended up beaten black and blue, snot and tears streaming down his face as his parents dragged him home.

Though reckless, he was extremely concerned about face. After getting beaten too many times, he deluded himself into becoming Xie Zheng's lackey.

Xie Zheng knew he must have stirred up trouble again and indifferently tossed out two words: "No time."

Liu Xuan panicked, quickly catching up to him. "Brother Xie, I really had no choice but to come to you. One of my little brothers got beaten up—his eyes were so black and blue they didn't fade for days. My mother warned me not to cause trouble. But just now, that same little brother came crying

to me again, saying he got beaten once more. His nose bled so much it soaked a whole handkerchief! How can anyone bully people like this?"

"I asked him who did it, but he stammered and said the person was connected to the Xie family. He refused to tell me the truth. I bet it's some reckless brat using the Xie name to throw his weight around in the academy!"

Xie Zheng had no intention of getting involved in this mess. If things went south and word reached Xie Linshan, he'd be punished again.

But at this point, he lazily raised an eyebrow and said, "Let's take a look."

He didn't like provoking trouble, but if someone was using the Xie family's name to bully students in the academy, he had to step in.

They found Liu Xuan's eight-year-old brother and asked him to lead them to the person who had beaten him. But the child clutched his clothes, refusing outright—first saying the person was from the Xie family and he feared retaliation. When Liu Xuan pointed at Xie Zheng and said a Xie was right here, the boy then claimed it was too late and the culprit must have already left.

Liu Xuan, furious, kicked his younger brother in the rear. "How the hell did I end up with such a coward for a brother?"

He stormed into his brother's classroom instead, kicking the door open like a bully. "Listen up! Who here claims to be a Xie relative and beat up my brother?"

The younger brother, dragged along by him, nearly buried his head in the ground at the outburst. His nose was still bleeding, but he was too flustered to wipe it, his face burning red.

The classroom was filled with children no older than seven or eight.

At first, they exchanged bewildered glances. But under Liu Xuan's aggressive glare, the timid ones pointed toward a little girl sitting by the window, gripping a brush as she painstakingly copied text, her brows slightly furrowed as if wrestling with something.

Changyu was growing frustrated with the brush in her hand.

The rabbit-hair tip was too soft. If she pressed too lightly, the teacher scolded her for writing characters without strength, often making her

recopy. But if she pressed too hard, the bristles splayed out, leaving only a few thick, clumsy strokes per page.

Liu Xuan's sudden roar startled the child in front of her, who jolted and bumped into her desk. The page of characters she had struggled to complete was now marred by a hideous ink blot.

Changyu stared at the blot for a long moment before lifting her head, her small face darkening as she glared at the person who had kicked the door open.

Behind him, leaning against the wooden railing of the corridor, stood a boy in a russet-red archer's robe. He looked about twelve or thirteen, with refined features and an air of nobility.

Xie Zheng was already tall for his age, and among this crowd of little sprouts, he stood out like a crane among chickens.

The moment Liu Xuan had dragged him to this classroom of brats, he had sensed trouble. Now, spotting the Meng family's daughter, his eyelid twitched violently.

No matter how he thought about it, he never expected that the one who beat up Liu Xuan's younger brother was actually that girl.

Liu Xuan was clearly stunned too. The little girl looked sweet and adorable, a whole half head shorter than his own brother. How could she have beaten Liu Cheng until he was black and blue?

He immediately roared at the child who pointed her out: "What nonsense are you spouting? Do you believe I'll—"

But the well-behaved girl, who looked like a porcelain doll, suddenly spoke up: "It was me."

Liu Xuan's words got stuck in his throat.

Looking at the girl who was a full half head shorter than his brother, he promptly gave his sibling a sharp knock on the head and scolded fiercely: "Didn't you say the one who beat you was a tall, sturdy brat? You lied and made me lose face with you, didn't you?"

The child covered his head, two trails of nose blood hanging down, and burst into loud sobs: "I couldn't beat her, and you kept questioning me, so I lied..."

Liu Xuan gave him another knock: "You feel ashamed losing to a little girl, but lying isn't shameful?"

His brother just covered his head and cried, saying nothing more.

Xie Zheng, standing outside, asked: "Why did she hit you?"

The child hemmed and hawed, unwilling to speak.

Changyu glared fiercely at Xie Zheng, seeming to understand that he had come earlier to back up Liu Xuan and his brother, and said: "He pulled my hair and smeared ink on my book. I'll beat him every time I see him."

Liu Xuan's expression changed, and he slapped his brother again: "You useless thing, bullying a girl and then daring to come back and lie?"

Xie Zheng noticed the clearly disheaped flower-bud bun on Changyu's head and unconsciously frowned. He looked down at the child: "This is my sister."

The child was already terrified, staring at Xie Zheng with teary eyes.

Liu Xuan's anger also faltered, and he stiffly asked Xie Zheng: "When did Madam Xie give you a sister?"

Xie Zheng didn't answer, only looking at the child: "Apologize."

The child, crying with snot and tears, blubbered to Changyu: "I'm sorry... I won't dare do it again..."

Xie Zheng walked over and half-knelt beside Changyu's desk, asking her: "Do you accept his apology?"

Changyu pursed her lips and stared at him, her chubby little face full of displeasure: "Did you come here to scold me with them?"

Xie Zheng now only wanted to throw Liu Xuan under a horse's hooves to be trampled. He gave Liu Xuan a look, and Liu Xuan wisely led the group of little brats out of the classroom before Xie Zheng said: "I didn't know they were talking about you..."

Changyu, her small face tense, interrupted him: "You bully people with them at the academy! I'm telling Uncle Xie!"

Xie Zheng rubbed his forehead: "That's not how 'bully people' is used."

Changyu glared at him angrily.

Xie Zheng had no choice but to continue patiently: "It's really not what you think. Don't tell my father about today."

Changyu said: "This is the guilty conscience of a thief!"

Xie Zheng felt his head about to explode, not knowing whether to be angry or amused at her words: "You've learned quite a few phrases since starting school. Today was really a misunderstanding. How about I take you to Xu's Restaurant for braised pork knuckle later?"

Changyu snorted and turned her face away.

Xie Zheng compromised further: "I'll buy you hibiscus cake from Tang's Shop too."

The snow-powdered little girl finally pointed at the ink-stained paper on the desk, her big dark eyes looking at him: "I still have to rewrite the homework the teacher assigned..."

Xie Zheng knew this was coming. He sighed: "I'll write it for you."

After leaving the academy, the pair bought a pile of hibiscus cakes, sugar-coated haws on sticks, and osmanthus candy before heading to Xu's Restaurant.

Changyu munched on the freshly braised pork knuckle, her mouth glistening with grease, while Xie Zheng resignedly copied texts for her beside her.

Before leaving, noticing the disheveled flower bud bun on one side of her head, Xie Zheng worried Meng Lihua might ask about her hair and bring up how he'd been tricked by that scoundrel Liu Xuan. He fussed with her hair for a long time, trying to redo the flower bud bun.

But his hands were clumsy, and in the end, he only managed to tie an awkward, messy little knot.

Changyu reached up to touch it and said, "Ugly."

Xie Zheng was almost too exasperated to be angry anymore. Pinching her cheek, he said, "This is my first time doing someone's hair. It's not bad for a first try. Have you ever seen any other boy who knows how to tie hair?"

Changyu retorted stubbornly, "My daddy does it very nicely."

Xie Zheng scoffed lightly, "Your father has a daughter. I don't have a daughter—why would I practice doing hair?"

Changyu thought about it and realized that made sense.

When Xie Zheng walked her home, as they neared her doorstep, he reminded her, "Remember to keep today's events a secret, or I'll never buy you braised pork knuckle again."

Changyu waved her hand at him, "Got it, got it."

After a brief silence, he added, "If anyone at the academy dares to bully you again, you have to tell me."

Changyu asked puzzled, "Why should I tell you?"

Xie Zheng ruffled her hair haphazardly, "So I can stand up for you."

Changyu replied very earnestly, "But I already hit them."

"..."

The teenage boy pinched both her cheeks, "You still have to tell me even if you hit them."

Chapter 178

Extra Story: Reunion

Another day passed, and Xie Zheng walked out of school listlessly, with Liu Xuan trailing behind him like a foolish dog, practically circling him and wagging an invisible tail.

"Brother Xie, that trick shot you made in the arrow toss last time won the prize at the grand opening of Jinxiu Tower. It left that kid from General Hu's family dumbfounded. Are you going to the hunting trip this time?"

The spring sunlight was radiant, dappling through the trees onto the young man's delicate features. His raven-black eyelashes seemed dusted with a layer of light, and his dark pupils appeared slightly lighter under the sun, though the lazy expression in them remained unchanged.

He tossed out two words indifferently: "Not going."

Most of these young noblemen's hunting trips only skirted the edges of the hunting grounds, bagging a few pheasants or rabbits—was this some kind of childish game?

Xie Zheng couldn't be bothered to join such a frivolous event.

Liu Xuan scratched the back of his head, looking troubled. "But I already made a bet with that Hu kid. If you don't go and I lose in the hunt, the twenty taels of silver I've saved up will be gone..."

Xie Zheng didn't even spare him a glance. "That's your problem."

"Hey, Brother Xie, you—"

Just as Liu Xuan was about to continue his wheedling, he noticed Xie Zheng suddenly narrow his eyes at something in the distance before striding over.

Following his gaze, Liu Xuan saw the little girl they'd met before standing under the shade of a tree by the upper courtyard gate, a small cloth bag of books slung over her shoulder. Her large, dark eyes were framed by thick, long lashes, and her slightly puffed cheeks were pink and soft, like a sticky rice cake doll.

This time, however, the two buns on her head were almost completely undone, and there was a long, thin scratch near her eye, as if someone had clawed her with their nails.

Liu Xuan's heart sank. Could it be his useless younger brother's doing again?

Torn between bolting and going over to ask, he ultimately mustered his courage and followed.

As soon as he approached, he heard Xie Zheng ask, "What happened?"

His tone was decidedly cold.

Liu Xuan cautiously studied Xie Zheng's expression. The latter was looking down at the girl, who was much shorter than him, his face unreadable—whether patient or impatient, his mood clearly wasn't good.

While Liu Xuan was inwardly nervous, the little girl showed no fear at all. "Got into a fight with a new kid at school."

Xie Zheng frowned. "Who?"

Changyu lowered her head slightly, tracing circles on the ground with the tip of her shoe. "I think his surname is Qi. I heard his servant call him 'Young Master.'"

Xie Zheng's frown deepened.

A Qi? Recently, only Prince Gong had visited the northwest as an imperial envoy, delivering the imperial decree conferring the title of Marquis of Guanshan upon Xie Linshan.

He crouched down slightly. "Was it Prince Gong's son who hit you?"

Changyu clutched the hem of her clothes, replying stiffly, "Don't know. Maybe."

Relieved it wasn't his idiot brother's doing, Liu Xuan immediately rolled up his sleeves. "Royalty or not, bullying a little girl is wrong! Come on, Brother Xie, let's go get justice for our little sister Changyu!"

Changyu stayed rooted to the spot.

Xie Zheng, who knew her well, felt his eyelid twitch. "How badly did you hurt him?"

Only then did Changyu murmur, "He bled. Lost a tooth."

Xie Zheng pressed his fingers to his forehead.

Liu Xuan hadn't expected this seemingly soft and easy-to-bully little girl to strike so viciously. He stammered as he looked at Xie Zheng, "What do we do, Brother Xie? Prince Gong is the emperor's uncle. Your sister just beat up the emperor's cousin..."

Xie Zheng was pondering countermeasures when Liu Xuan's incessant chatter grated on his nerves. Raising his eyes sharply, he snapped, "Shut up first!"

Liu Xuan immediately fell silent, even miming zipping his lips.

Xie Zheng had no time for him and continued questioning Changyu, "How did your conflict with Prince Gong's heir begin?"

Changyu pressed her lips together without answering. Her lowered head cast long lashes over her eyes, sunlight filtering through to create fan-shaped shadows on her eyelids.

Xie Zheng frowned. "Surely you didn't strike first?"

Changyu shook her head.

Controlling his temper, Xie Zheng said, "If you're in trouble, you must at least give me a reason for your actions so I can help clean up the mess. If this isn't handled properly, even your parents taking you to apologize to Prince Gong's heir might not resolve it."

The girl remained stubbornly silent, though a faint redness had begun rimming her eyes.

After a long pause, she finally said, "I'll only tell you."

Xie Zheng gave Liu Xuan a look, and the latter obediently retreated further away.

Eyeing the inexplicably resistant child, Xie Zheng said, "Speak."

Changyu tightened her grip on her clothes. "He tried to pull down my pants."

Xie Zheng's mind exploded in shock. "What?" he barked.

His uncontrolled volume drew curious looks from passing students and even the distant Liu Xuan.

Suppressing his fury, Xie Zheng examined the child's foreign-style attire and softened his tone. "What happened?"

The redness in the girl's eyes deepened, though she stubbornly refused to cry. "I practice martial arts with Father, so I wore foreign clothes. He mocked me for dressing like a boy and said I must be one. When I went to the privy to change, he brought people to corner me and tried to pull down my pants to check..."

Her voice finally cracked slightly. "I got scared, so I couldn't control my strength when hitting back."

Xie Zheng gently wiped away the tears the girl was fighting to hold back. "You hit well," he said gently.

The girl looked up in stunned silence at the youth before her.

A mild breeze stirred the young man's ink-black hair and robes as he asked, "How many people know about this?"

"Only him and his two lackeys," she answered. "It happened when I left archery class to change."

Xie Zheng's voice remained gentle but carried an undercurrent that chilled the bones. "Did he succeed?"

She shook her head. "I punched them until they cried when they pushed me toward the corner."

Tucking a stray lock behind her ear, Xie Zheng said simply, "Good. Had he succeeded, I'd have gouged his eyes out."

Giving her shoulder a reassuring pat, he added, "Don't be afraid. It's over now."

Perhaps it was the accumulated fear finally finding release in comfort, but Changyu finally allowed herself to cry. "But...his father is a prince. Have I caused big trouble?"

Continuing to wipe her tears, Xie Zheng said coldly, "Even if his father were the emperor, he had no right to commit such outrage."

His anger hadn't subsided yet, so he only warned, "You mustn't tell anyone else about this. If others find out he tried to pull down your pants—whether he succeeded or not—you'll have no choice but to marry that scoundrel in the future."

The little girl seemed frightened, her lips pressing tighter together as tears welled up in her eyes.

Xie Zheng's heart softened slightly, and he gentled his tone. "Don't be afraid. Leave this matter to me."

He then called over Liu Xuan. "Keep an eye on my sister for me. Take her to Xu's Restaurant first—I have some business to attend to."

Liu Xuan scratched his head. "Brother Xie, what are you going to do at a time like this?"

Xie Zheng simply replied, "None of your concern."

In the end, Liu Xuan took Changyu to Xu's Restaurant. The twenty taels of silver he had yet to lose in the hunting competition were instead spent on braised pork knuckle at the restaurant.

But even after ordering a table full of the restaurant's signature dishes, he didn't see the child take a single bite. Instead, she leaned against the windowsill, staring longingly in the direction of the academy.

Liu Xuan tried to comfort her. "Don't worry about Brother Xie. Even if the other party is the Prince of Gong's heir, General Xie and Minister Wei are currently the emperor's most trusted officials. General Xie has even been enfeoffed as the Marquis of Guanshan. As long as Brother Xie says you're his sister, the Prince of Gong won't escalate the matter if he knows what's good for him."

The little girl remained silent, still clinging to the windowsill as she looked down.

Curious, Liu Xuan asked, "Did you push the Prince of Gong's heir and make him lose a tooth?"

The girl finally shook her head.

Liu Xuan was puzzled. "Then was it from bumping into something?"

The girl raised her small fist and answered truthfully, "Punched."

Liu Xuan: "..... ? ? ?"

After a long pause, he suddenly said, "Uh... Changyu, little sister, try punching me."

Changyu shook her head.

Liu Xuan stubbornly refused to believe it and continued persuading her. "It's fine, I can take it. Go ahead and hit me!"

By the time Xie Zheng arrived at Xu's Restaurant, he found Changyu sitting obediently on a stool while Liu Xuan's face was half-swollen like a pig's head, pressing a cold, wet handkerchief to his cheek.

When he saw Xie Zheng, he slurred, "Brother Xie, you're here..."

Xie Zheng frowned at Liu Xuan's badly swollen face and asked, "Did you get into another fight on the way here?"

Liu Xuan chuckled awkwardly. "No, I heard Changyu say she knocked out the Prince of Gong's heir's tooth with one punch, so I asked her to try hitting my face."

Xie Zheng immediately gave Liu Xuan a look as if he were an idiot.

Liu Xuan grimaced in pain, pressing the wet handkerchief to his cheek and inhaling sharply. "I didn't expect... Changyu's strength to be this great. It's almost on par with yours, Brother Xie..."

When Xie Zheng pulled out a stool and sat beside Changyu, she twisted her fingers nervously and murmured, "I didn't mean to..."

She had only hit him because he kept insisting.

Xie Zheng scoffed and said to Liu Xuan, "Don't feel guilty. He deserved it."

Liu Xuan, not wanting Changyu to blame herself, hissed through the pain. "Yeah, it doesn't actually hurt that much. The swelling will go down by tomorrow..."

But the pain must have been unbearable, because his mouth was slightly twisted as he said to Xie Zheng, "Brother Xie, since you're here, I'll head back first..."

He needed to hurry home and apply some medicine—it hurt like hell.

Xie Zheng glanced at the table full of dishes, then untied the purse from his waist and tossed it to Liu Xuan. "Go see a physician."

Liu Xuan reached out to catch it, feeling the weighty heft of the pouch in his hand. His face immediately lit up with joy, though half of it was swollen, and one eye was squinted into a slit, making him look rather comical. "Thanks, brother."

After Liu Xuan left, Xie Zheng turned to Changyu and asked, "Why haven't you touched any of these dishes? Not hungry?"

Changyu nodded slightly.

Xie Zheng stood up. "Then I'll take you to the West Market for a stroll."

Changyu clutched the cloth bag containing her books, remaining seated on the stool without moving.

Xie Zheng bent down and pinched her cheek. "Throwing a tantrum?"

Changyu shook her head, pressing her lips together before murmuring, "The Prince Gong's heir..."

Xie Zheng's hand, which had been on her cheek, moved to the top of her head, ruffling her already loose bun into further disarray. "Don't worry, I've taken care of it."

Changyu eyed him with a mix of doubt and hope.

Xie Zheng chuckled. "Don't trust me?"

Changyu shook her head again, her soft hair brushing against the back of Xie Zheng's hand as it swayed with the motion.

Xie Zheng paused for a moment before saying, "Forgot to tie your hair back..."

After fashioning two messy little buns atop her head, the young man extended his hand. "Let's go."

Changyu took his hand and hopped off the stool. The lopsided buns wobbled as she walked, giving her an adorably clumsy look.

The West Market was primarily a livestock trading hub, filled with horses, cattle, and related goods like saddles, whips, swords, and slingshots. Changyu had always frequented the East Market, with its flower shops, bird vendors, and snack stalls—this was her first time in the West Market.

Xie Zheng took her through every game available, from archery to pitch-pot. Initially, Changyu remained sullen, preoccupied with her worries, but soon she was swept up in the fun. She won a pile of prizes—kites, porcelain figurines, small drums—and even got to ride horseback with Xie Zheng for a few laps around the field.

By the time they headed back, the sun was already dipping below the horizon.

Exhausted from the day's excitement, her feet sore and eyelids heavy, Changyu plopped onto a roadside stone block and refused to move. "I need to rest before walking again."

Xie Zheng watched her head droop sleepily like a pecking chick and patted his pockets helplessly. "I don't have a single copper coin left to hire a carriage for you."

Changyu, barely able to keep her eyes open, mumbled, "I can walk back myself."

Amused yet sympathetic, Xie Zheng thought of what she'd been through that day. He stroked her hair, then crouched in front of her. "Hop on. I'll carry you back."

Changyu stared at the broad back of the young man before her, wrestling briefly with sleepiness before finally giving in and climbing onto his back.

Xie Zheng carried her home under the fading glow of sunset, listening to her steady breathing behind him. He sighed softly. "What's to become of you, little troublemaker, once I'm off to the military camp?"

Changyu slept straight through until the next morning. At breakfast, her mother was as gentle as ever, and her father only spoke briefly about military affairs—neither mentioned the incident with the Prince Gong's heir.

Changyu exhaled quietly in relief.

It seemed her parents were unaware that she'd knocked out one of the heir's teeth. She wondered how Xie Zheng had managed to keep it under wraps.

At the academy, she struggled to focus during morning classes, her mind preoccupied with visiting Xie Zheng afterward to ask what he'd done the day before.

As soon as morning classes ended, she was about to head to the upper courtyard when her deskmate called out, "Changyu, Changyu! Did you hear? That arrogant Prince Gong's heir got beaten up by the young Marquis yesterday. They even stripped him and his two lackeys naked and

threw them out onto the street! How humiliating! I bet that Prince Gong's heir won't dare show his face at the academy again!"

Changyu froze for a moment, not even managing to reply before clenching her small fists and dashing straight toward the upper courtyard.

The windowsills in the upper courtyard were high, and she had to stand on tiptoe to peer inside.

An older student inside noticed the shadow moving outside the window and, seeing it wasn't a patrolling teacher, relaxed and called out, "Whose little sister is out there?"

The academy had been established by the Xie family, and the children of military officers were sent here for their early education. Many of the students in the upper and lower courtyards were siblings.

Xie Zheng's seat was empty. When Liu Xuan spotted Changyu, he stepped outside and asked, "Looking for Xie?"

Changyu nodded.

The swelling on Liu Xuan's face had subsided somewhat today, but a bruise remained. He said, "Xie didn't come to the academy today. I heard about what happened with Prince Gong's heir."

He gave Changyu a puzzled look. "How did he bully you? You already knocked out one of his teeth, and Xie still beat him black and blue before stripping him and tossing him onto the street. Word is, Prince Gong's consort went crying to the Xie residence yesterday afternoon demanding an explanation. I reckon Xie's bound to get punished for this."

After hearing this, Changyu turned on her heel to run back.

Liu Xuan called after her, "Where are you going?"

Changyu answered, "Back!"

By the time she returned to the lower courtyard, the teacher was already inside the classroom, holding a copy of *The Analects*. "Today, we'll study the Xue'er chapter," he announced.

Noticing Changyu standing at the doorway, he smiled kindly. "Hurry and take your seat."

She had always been well-behaved in the academy. Though her handwriting wasn't the best, she had never neglected her studies or

skipped class. The teachers all adored this earnest, sweet-natured girl.

Changyu clutched her stomach with both hands, trying her best to look pained. "Teacher, my stomach hurts."

She rarely lied, but the teacher, seeing her adorable, snow-white face and considering her usual good behavior, didn't suspect a thing. He immediately said, "Then I'll have someone escort you home."

Changyu nodded, picked up her small satchel, and followed the instructor out of the academy.

On the carriage ride home, as they passed the Xie residence, Changyu asked the coachman to let her off there.

The coachman hesitated. "This... I must see you safely home, miss."

Changyu replied seriously, "My mother is visiting Uncle Xie. I'm going to see her."

Only then did the coachman relent, watching her enter the Xie family's gate before driving off.

Changyu and her mother were frequent guests at the Xie residence, and the gatekeeper recognized her. Seeing her enter with her little satchel, he smiled and asked, "Miss Meng, what brings you here?"

Changyu fiddled with the strap of her bag. "I'm here to see Big Brother."

The gatekeeper chuckled awkwardly. "The young Marquis got into trouble. The Marquis punished him with a whipping, and he's kneeling in the ancestral hall now. Perhaps you could come another day?"

At this, Changyu's lips pressed tightly together. "I want to see him."

The gatekeeper looked troubled. "The Marquis gave strict orders—no one is to go near the ancestral hall. Please don't make things difficult for me, Miss Meng."

Changyu quickly changed tack. "Then I want to see Aunt Xie."

This time, the gatekeeper didn't stop her and asked eagerly, "Shall I have someone show you the way?"

Changyu, already walking forward with her small satchel, replied, "No need, I remember the way."

Past the ornamental gate, there were two paths—one leading to the inner courtyard and the other to the western wing. But with a detour, one could reach the Xie family ancestral hall.

Having visited the Xie residence many times, Changyu was familiar with these routes.

She took the detour straight to the ancestral hall. Guards stood at the main entrance, so she circled to the back wall, removed her small satchel, and pushed it through a dog hole before squeezing in herself.

The spring chill was biting. Xie Zheng, who had returned the previous night, had been given ten lashes by Xie Linshan, denied food and water, and made to kneel in the ancestral hall overnight in thin clothing. Now, he was burning with fever.

His head was heavy, and after kneeling for so long, a dull ache spread through his knees.

In his daze, he thought he heard a faint creak from the door behind him.

Xie Linshan had ordered that no one was to visit or bring him food or water. His mother, furious over his beating of the Prince of Gong's son, hadn't pleaded for him either. Who would come to the ancestral hall to see him now?

Xie Zheng curled his lips in self-mockery, not even bothering to open his eyes.

Yet footsteps approached from behind and stopped in front of him.

A small, unexpectedly cool and soft hand pressed against his forehead.

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids to see the little girl who should have been at school frowning down at him. "You're burning up! I'll go get help!"

Changyu turned to leave, but he grabbed her wrist. "Don't."

His voice was hoarse from the fever, his handsome features weary.

Changyu insisted, "But you're sick!"

She tried to pry his scorching-hot fingers off her wrist. "Uncle Xie punished you because you beat the Prince of Gong's son, right? I'll tell him—that boy bullied me first!"

The boy's grip didn't loosen. Suppressing his headache, he scolded, "Little fool, didn't I tell you not to tell anyone about this?"

Changyu asked, confused, "Not even Uncle Xie and Aunt Xie?"

He didn't answer, only saying, "I already taught that ugly fatso and his two friends a lesson. They won't dare spread this around. I beat him up, stripped him, and threw him into the street—that's revenge enough for you. This punishment is nothing."

Changyu noticed the bloodstains on his torn clothing from the whip lashes. Her nose stung. "You should've told them the truth."

Xie Zheng was too weak. His eyelids drooped shut as he muttered, "Little fool, I said no telling means no telling."

"If the Prince of Gong and his wife find out, they might shamelessly demand you marry that pig-headed brat. It'd ruin your reputation—not worth it, understand? This punishment is necessary to show the Prince of Gong's family. Telling them would only make my mother and the old man feel worse."

Changyu stared at the gruesome whip marks on his back, fighting back tears. "Does it hurt? I brought wound medicine. Let me apply it for you."

After she started practicing with the blade, cuts and scrapes became common. Her satchel always held *tpabma* medicine alongside her books.

Changyu pulled out the bottle of *tpabma* medicine and began cleaning the wounds on Xie Zheng's back. The blood had already clotted, causing the torn fabric to stick firmly to the flesh of the wounds. Any attempt to pull it away felt like tearing off a layer of skin.

She dampened the fabric clinging tightly to the wounds with water from her flask, then carefully peeled it away.

Even so, she still heard Xie Zheng's muffled groan.

Flustered, she said, "Does it hurt? I'll be gentler..."

Xie Zheng's cheeks were flushed from the fever, and a fine layer of sweat had formed on his forehead. He lifted his eyelids and said, "Are you peeling off a snail shell with how slow you're taking this?"

With that, he grabbed the blood-crusted fabric stuck to his flesh and yanked it down forcefully. Fresh beads of blood welled up from the wounds, but he paid no mind.

"Apply the medicine," he said.

Changyu was applying the tpabma medicine powder to him, her lips pressed tightly together the entire time. "It's bleeding..."

Xie Zheng kept his eyes shut, enduring the pain with sweat pouring down his face, forcing out two words through gritted teeth: "Doesn't hurt."

After finishing the treatment, perhaps because the cold seeped in after sweating so much, Xie Zheng's fever spiked even higher.

He still refused to let Changyu call for help. Even though he was practically burning up like a piece of charcoal, he kept murmuring incoherently about feeling cold.

Changyu draped her little cloak over him, but it didn't seem to help.

The eight-year-old girl didn't know how to reduce a fever. Hearing him say he was cold, she crouched beside him, cupped one of his hands in hers, and blew warm breath onto it, rubbing his fingers to warm them up.

When Madam Xie came to check on her son, who had been punished by kneeling in the ancestral hall, she found the two children curled up together, fast asleep.

Later, Madam Xie teased her son about it, saying that even though he'd been beaten, at least his future wife skipped school to see him—so it was worth it.

For the first time, Xie Zheng responded to his mother with complete seriousness: "Mother, Changyu is older now. Please don't joke about such things anymore. I only see her as a younger sister."

When he was a child, he didn't understand what marriage meant. Hearing his mother's playful remarks back then, he had assumed it just meant there would be one more little sister in the household for him to take care of.

Now that he was growing up and gaining awareness—and having watched that girl grow up alongside him—he naturally couldn't take Madam Xie and Changyu's mother's casual banter seriously.

Madam Xie hadn't expected her lighthearted teasing to be met with such a formal response from her son. She paused for a moment before saying, "Alright, alright, I'll remember that."

As Madam Xie carried the medicine bowl out, she spotted Changyu standing by the door, holding a small box. She wasn't sure how much the

girl had overheard of her conversation with Xie Zheng, but assuming she was still too young to understand, Madam Xie smiled and greeted her warmly: "Changyu, here to see your Xie Zheng gege?"

The little girl nodded obediently.

Madam Xie said, "He just took his medicine. He's inside—go talk to him."

Changyu gave a soft "Mm," then stepped over the threshold, box in hand, and entered the inner room.

Xie Zheng was leaning against a pillow, coughing. When he saw her, he said weakly, "Just sit by the table. Don't come closer—I still have this cold. Don't let me pass it to you."

Ignoring him, Changyu placed the box on the small bedside table before stepping back a few paces. "I heard you haven't had an appetite, so I bought you a box of candied orange peel."

Xie Zheng coughed lightly and smirked. "Rare of you to buy me something. What's the occasion?"

Changyu didn't answer. She sat quietly on the embroidered stool for a while before suddenly blurting out, "Thank you."

The smile vanished from Xie Zheng's lips. "You caught the fever too? Is it frying your brain?"

Changyu muttered, "If you keep scolding me, I'll tell Aunt Xie."

Xie Zheng shot her a sidelong glance. "If you don't want to be scolded, then watch what you say."

Changyu grumbled, "What's wrong with thanking you..."

Xie Zheng scoffed. "After all the messes I've cleaned up for you, when have you ever thanked me? Meng Changyu, who are you acting so distant with?"

The little girl hung her head and stayed silent on the embroidered stool. After a long pause, she finally mumbled, "Xie Zheng... you'll be my brother forever, right?"

Xie Zheng found the child particularly odd today. "Unless my parents give me another sister, who else would I have besides you?"

Changyu fiddled with the tassels on her clothes, silent for a moment before lifting her head with a bright smile. "Then it's settled! You'll be my brother for life!"

Xie Zheng thought the child had been frightened by the incident with the Prince Gong's heir. After coughing twice, he chuckled, "Naturally."

The child, who had previously been rather aloof, turned back at the doorway as she left and waved at him with a smile. "Goodbye, Brother Xie Zheng!"

Madam Xie arrived with freshly brewed medicine and noticed Changyu's departure. She smiled at Xie Zheng, "I see Changyu has grown much closer to you. I've never heard her call you so affectionately before."

Xie Zheng watched the little girl's retreating figure without a word.

This child... something felt off.

But Xie Zheng didn't have much time to dwell on it, as war broke out beyond the frontier again. Xie Linshan and Wei Qilin led their troops away overnight.

The Northern Jue had a new king, eager to prove his worth and suppress rebellious chieftains in his tribe. The new king launched a surprise attack on Jinzhou.

The assault was fierce. Before leaving, Xie Linshan even ordered the evacuation of civilians from the city and instructed his family guards to escort Madam Xie back to the capital.

Unfortunately, a spring rain fell that day, making the journey along the official road difficult. A cargo carriage's wheels got stuck in the mud, and the guards, wearing bamboo hats and raincoats, shouted as they pushed the wheels.

Madam Xie and Meng Lihua personally stepped out to inspect the situation.

Changyu, listening to the thunder and rain, curled up drowsily in the carriage.

Suddenly, a flash of white lightning illuminated the interior, revealing a figure lifting the carriage curtain to look at her.

Changyu rubbed her eyes, thinking she was seeing things. Realizing it wasn't an illusion, she quickly said, "You haven't recovered from your cold

—you shouldn't be out in the rain. Come inside the carriage first..."

"Tell my mother I've gone to Jinzhou."

The boy interrupted her.

Changyu froze. "But Jinzhou is at war..."

He grinned, raising the silver halberd in his hand. "Exactly why I must go."

Tilting his head slightly, he studied her under the dim glow of the glass lamp inside the carriage and said, "I'm off."

With a tug of the reins, he vanished into the rainy night with his halberd.

By the time Changyu returned to the capital, it was three months before she received another letter from Xie Zheng.

In it, he wrote that the battle in Jinzhou was progressing smoothly, though the Northern Jue's offensive was fierce. After nearly a decade of silence, this war was bound to drag on.

He also mentioned meeting a skilled bowyer in the army who had crafted a small horn bow for her, which would likely reach the capital by autumn.

As seasons passed, the wooden box where Changyu kept letters from the north gradually filled with a thick stack of correspondence.

She received the exquisite redwood bow, but from the second year onward, the letters grew fewer. Most news about Xie Zheng came from Madam Xie—how he had distinguished himself in battle, slain a Northern Jue general, or nearly captured a prince...

Time flowed like water, and the distance between the two youths grew ever wider.

When Changyu turned ten, the enlightened emperor, valuing both civil and martial arts, promoted women's education by establishing the Female Class House at the Imperial College.

To set an example, the emperor sent his princes and princesses to study at the Imperial College. The civil and military officials naturally couldn't let the emperor lose face, so they enrolled their own daughters of appropriate age as well.

When Madam Xie learned that Changyu was going to study at the Imperial College, she was genuinely happy for her. Having no daughters of her own, she had watched Changyu grow up and treated her like her own child.

While discussing this with Meng Lihua, she couldn't stop praising: "The current Chancellor of the Imperial College is truly an extraordinary figure—the venerable Gongsun. It's said His Majesty sent imperial envoys and high-ranking ministers multiple times to invite him out of retirement, but all were politely declined. Later, during His Majesty's southern tour, he personally visited the Gongsun family in Hejian before finally persuading the old master."

"The Gongsun family of Hejian—what profound heritage they possess! Even the rarest lost manuscripts can find their rubbings in their library. That His Majesty could recruit such talent is truly a blessing for Great Yin!"

Thus Changyu studied at the Imperial College for several years. Because she always achieved top marks in archery and equestrian classes, Qi Zhu and other noble girls who couldn't even draw their bows would often pitifully seek her help.

Over the years, all the noble daughters of the capital came to regard her as a close friend. Whenever there were poetry gatherings, they never forgot to send her invitations.

After years of study, Changyu still developed headaches whenever she had to compose poetry, usually finding excuses to decline whenever possible.

On this day, she was about to refuse the Flower Appreciation Invitation from the Marquis of Jinwen's residence as usual, but Qi Zhu was also attending. Claiming she wouldn't know any noble girls at the banquet, she insisted Changyu accompany her.

Meng Lihua was quite pleased to hear her daughter was willing to attend. Teasing her younger daughter, she said: "Good. Come the new year, you'll be having your coming-of-age ceremony—it's time to start considering marriage prospects."

Changyu poked her little sister's rosy cheeks, saying only: "It's still early, Mother!"

Meng Lihua looked at her two daughters, one big and one small, and smiled: "Not early at all. It seems like just yesterday you were Ning Niang's age, constantly getting into trouble with the young Marquis cleaning up after you. In the blink of an eye, you've become a young lady."

With Changyu entertaining Changning, Meng Lihua stood to organize clothes from the chest: "Your father wrote recently—another great victory in battle. The northern frontier is essentially secured. The young Marquis's reputation has resounded throughout the court these years. This time he's coming to the capital to receive honors on behalf of your Uncle Xie."

Changyu's fingers paused slightly in the cat's cradle game with her sister, absentmindedly murmuring "Mm."

Changning pouted unhappily: "Sister, sister! You messed up!"

Meng Lihua laughed at the sight: "Mother will play with Ning Niang later. Your sister needs to change for the flower gathering at the Marquis of Jinwen's residence today."

Changning immediately blinked: "Can Ning Niang go too?"

Meng Lihua shook her head.

Changning's little face fell: "Why not?"

Kneeling, Meng Lihua tapped her nose: "When our Ning Niang is a bit older, then you can go..."

The flower gathering at the Marquis of Jinwen's residence was, unsurprisingly, lively.

Talented scholars and beautiful ladies drank wine, composed poetry, and reveled in refined pleasures.

Qi Zhu seemed to be looking for someone at the banquet. Unable to find them, she remained disinterested until finally hiding in a corner with Changyu to watch the noble girls showcase their talents.

Though young, she belonged to the same generation as the current emperor—even the empress had to address her as "Princess." No guest at the residence dared show her disrespect.

However, the Marchioness of Jinwen was determined to play matchmaker today. She proposed having noble girls write the first half of poems on wooden tablets anonymously, then having maids deliver them to

the gentlemen's section where scholars would select and complete the verses.

This plan was well-received by the noble ladies, as it merely involved passing around wooden tablets. Even if no one filled in their poems, it wouldn't be embarrassing, and they could still assess the talents and calligraphy of the scholars through the verses written on the tablets.

Since the method was proposed by the wife of Duke Wen of Jin, Qi Zhu couldn't very well refuse to participate.

She wasn't skilled at composing poetry either, and after scratching her head in frustration with Changyu for a long while, they exchanged helpless glances before finally managing to cobble together a couple of lines.

When handing the tablet to the maidservant of Duke Wen's household, Qi Zhu deliberately put on a haughty air and said, "When these tablets are collected later, bring mine to me first so I can find my own."

The maidservant hastily agreed.

Once the maidservant had left, Qi Zhu slumped her shoulders and whispered to Changyu, "We'll retrieve ours first. Even if no one fills in the verses, no one will notice our embarrassment."

When the wooden tablets were returned, Qi Zhu found hers and, scanning it, couldn't suppress the joy that lit up her eyes and brows.

Changyu, however, frowned at the elegant and refined handwriting beneath her own barely passable two lines.

Qi Zhu peeked over and teased, "The calligraphy is graceful and dignified, and the verse isn't without substance. The person who filled this must be quite talented. I think A Yu should meet them."

Changyu frowned. "No, I don't have a knack for literary pursuits..."

Qi Zhu studied the half-finished verse again, and her expression suddenly turned odd. "You know, this handwriting looks a bit like Li Huaian's."

Changyu gasped.

After examining the tablet closely, Qi Zhu declared, "No mistake about it! I've copied his homework often enough—it's definitely his!"

Turning back to Changyu, Qi Zhu's smile took on a teasing edge. "A Yu, your handwriting is quite distinctive among the noble ladies too! Do you think that taciturn Li Huaian deliberately picked your tablet to fill in?"

Changyu sighed. "He was probably forced into it, just like us. He's ranked among the capital's top scholars—if he didn't fill in a verse, people would surely pester him. Writing for someone else might cause misunderstandings, and since he's more familiar with the two of us, and yours was already taken, he ended up choosing mine."

This explanation gave Qi Zhu pause, and she nodded. "That's possible."

The latter half of the poetry activity involved the noble ladies, if they wished, sending servants with the wooden tablets to the gentlemen's side to inquire about the identities of those who had filled in their verses. Once the ladies learned who the gentlemen were, they could assess their talents, looks, and family backgrounds before deciding whether to pursue an acquaintance. If interested, the servants would then inform the favored gentleman of the lady's identity.

If both parties took a liking to each other through this process, a match was practically made.

Qi Zhu seemed to already know who had filled in her verse and didn't send anyone to inquire. Before long, however, a maidservant approached and whispered something to her. Unable to contain her delight, Qi Zhu coughed lightly and said to Changyu, "A Yu, I'm going to meet someone. Play by yourself for a while."

Changyu nodded.

But once Qi Zhu left, other noble ladies inevitably came to socialize with Changyu, and she was eventually dragged behind a screen to sneak a peek at several of the capital's renowned scholars.

The noble ladies chattered excitedly: "I've heard that not only scholars from the capital are attending this banquet, but also several distinguished young lords from noble families!"

Changyu paid no heed to any of it. Seizing an opportunity, she slipped away to the crabapple grove in Duke Wen of Jin's estate to find some peace.

Duke Wen was a man of refined tastes, fond of brewing tea and discussing philosophy in his daily life. The gardens of his estate were also

crafted with ingenuity. The crabapple grove featured winding streams for floating wine cups and layered rockeries. Crabapple petals blown by the wind drifted into the water, creating a picturesque scene of falling blossoms and flowing streams.

Not far away stood a waterside pavilion. Changyu leaned over the rail, plucked a lotus leaf, placed it over her face, and lay down on the leaning rail for a nap.

The sunlight was just right, warm and soothing, making it all too easy to feel drowsy.

But the moment she lay down, something struck the lotus leaf covering her face.

The impact was light, as if it were just a bud or seed blown by the wind.

Changyu ignored it, merely scratching her cheek before settling back to sleep. Yet again, something struck the lotus leaf on her face.

Frowning, she sat up and glanced around the pavilion but saw no one.

Just as she was puzzled, another crabapple bud came flying toward the top of her head.

Changyu looked up and finally spotted the culprit.

The pavilion adjoined a high stone platform, but the area around it was densely planted with rare and precious flowers and trees, lush and verdant, making it difficult to see the platform from the pavilion.

The young man who had thrown the bud at her stood leaning against a crabapple tree, arms crossed. Dressed in black robes with intricate patterns that shimmered in the sunlight, his Diéxiè belt hung with jade pendants and pearls that glinted dazzlingly under the sun.

Changyu raised a hand to shield her eyes.

The young man seemed to chuckle. His strikingly handsome features still bore traces of the past, and his lazy demeanor matched her memories. Without waiting for her to greet him, he quirked a corner of his lips and drawled, "After all these years, don't recognize me anymore?"

Changyu stared at him for a long moment before blurting out a single word: "Brother."

The moment the word left her mouth, the two fell into silence, eyeing each other awkwardly. It felt unnatural, yet no other term seemed more fitting.

Xie Zheng pushed aside the branches and leaped down from the platform.

Changyu asked stiffly, "What are you doing here?"

Xie Zheng glanced at the wooden tablet she had placed by the leaning rail and replied with a sardonic smile, "Heard you were here picking a husband for yourself. Thought I'd help vet the candidates."

He had rushed back from the northern frontier, dusty and weary. After meeting with Madam Xie, he mentioned bringing gifts for Changyu and wanted to deliver them. But upon learning from Madam Xie that she had gone to Duke Wen's flower banquet, he tagged along using his friend Shen Shen's invitation.

Changyu sensed a barb in his words but couldn't fathom why. She answered truthfully, "I haven't really looked much..."

Noticing his gaze fixed on the wooden tablet by the rail, she guiltily hid it behind her back, afraid he'd see her terrible handwriting and embarrassing poetry and scold her for it.

Xie Zheng continued to smile, though his grin now seemed laced with knives.

He couldn't quite name the emotion stirring in his chest. He had traveled all the way from the north, bringing her all sorts of treats and trinkets. From afar at the banquet, he'd noticed she had grown taller and felt oddly pleased.

But now, face to face, she treated him with none of the closeness they once shared. This realization suddenly irritated him.

And seeing her sneakily hide the poetry she'd composed with someone else at the banquet only stoked his frustration.

After years of training in the military, he had learned to rein in his emotions. With an air of nonchalance, he said to the now-grown girl, "If you didn't find anyone suitable, let's go. I'll take you home."

The two walked side by side out of the waterside pavilion. Unable to find a suitable topic for conversation, they remained silent the entire way.

At a corner, they came across a refined and elegant man in a pale violet scholar's robe. Upon seeing Changyu, the man first greeted her with a smile and a bow. When his gaze shifted to Xie Zheng, there was a hint of hesitation. "And this is...?"

Changyu replied, "My brother."

The young man seemed to exhale slightly in relief, then bowed properly to Xie Zheng with a mix of nervousness and shyness. "Greetings, Elder Brother."

Xie Zheng: "..."

Chapter 179

Extra Story: If Line

After leaving the Duke of Jinwen's residence and boarding the carriage, Xie Zheng did not speak another word.

Changyu attempted several times to break the awkward and peculiar atmosphere, but Xie Zheng sat upright on the other side of the carriage, seemingly resting with his eyes closed. Fearing she might disturb him, she ultimately remained silent as well.

As the carriage passed through the bustling market, a mere curtain separated the noisy, lively outside from the silent, chilly interior.

Changyu sat properly on the soft silk-covered seat, occasionally stealing glances at the person seated opposite her.

Regarding this "brother" who had vanished from her life for over five years and suddenly reappeared, she was somewhat troubled about how to interact with him.

In her younger, more naive days, her earliest impression of Xie Zheng was of Madam Xie holding her and teasingly pointing to a young boy practicing swordplay in the courtyard, laughing as she said, "A Yu, look quickly! Our A Yu's little husband is practicing with his sword!"

As she grew older, whenever she accompanied her mother to the Xie residence, Madam Xie would always cheerfully tease her: "Has my future daughter-in-law come to visit me again?"

Once, she took a liking to Xie Zheng's small wooden sword. The two of them tugged at it from either end, neither willing to let go, their faces flushed with exertion. Madam Xie scolded Xie Zheng: "You foolish boy! Your mother said she'd let A Yu be your wife someday—is this how you bully your own little bride?"

And so, the small wooden sword that Xie Zheng had practiced with for years ended up in her possession.

When her mother admonished her, saying she shouldn't so rudely demand others' belongings, she returned the wooden sword to Xie Zheng. The boy, still childish in appearance, merely turned his face away and said, "If I gave it to you, it's yours."

Back then, they were both young and ignorant. Because of Madam Xie's constant playful remarks, they felt they ought to interact the way their own parents did.

Even though they didn't live together, it seemed only natural that he should be good to her.

If she caused trouble, it was only right that he should clean up the mess.

Later, when she attended the academy and learned about filial piety, brotherly respect, loyalty, trust, propriety, righteousness, integrity, and shame, she gradually realized that such behavior was improper.

Men and women should maintain proper boundaries unless there were parental arrangements and matchmakers' words.

As for Madam Xie's frequent teasing remarks, even at a young age, she couldn't quite determine whether they counted as parental arrangements.

But she rarely troubled Xie Zheng after that, resolving matters on her own whenever possible.

The only time she actively sought Xie Zheng's help was when she struck the son of Prince Gong.

To this day, she still remembered the boy's thin yet resilient back as he knelt in the ancestral hall, the torn whip marks and dark red scabs on his clothes, the faint halo of light streaming through the hall's doorway and falling on his shoulders and dark hair, his pale jaw, and his words: "Consider it venting your anger. This punishment is nothing."

That feeling—as if her heart had been struck by a heavy drum—never occurred again.

But when she went to visit him during his recovery, she overheard him telling Madam Xie that he only saw her as a younger sister.

Though he claimed to see her as a sister, they shared no blood relation whatsoever. Changyu felt they should still maintain a polite and respectful distance.

She treated him politely, yet he seemed displeased, even scolding her once.

The question of how to continue interacting with him left her even more bewildered.

Before she could find the most appropriate approach, she accompanied her mother and Madam Xie back to the capital, while Xie Zheng, rebellious by nature, joined the military camp.

Over the next five years, exchanging letters of mutual concern had been manageable enough.

Now that this living, breathing person had suddenly appeared beside her, with looks and temperament completely transformed from before, the question that had troubled her back then seemed even more troublesome now.

Changyu slightly furrowed her brows, and just as her gaze swept over Xie Zheng's face again, the person who had been resting with closed eyes suddenly opened them.

Their eyes met directly.

Changyu cleared her throat and asked, "Is the carriage too bumpy to sleep comfortably?"

The person opposite remained silent for a moment before countering with a question: "Who was that person at Duke Wen of Jin's residence earlier?"

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Changyu answered honestly, "A classmate from the academy, Li Huaian, grandson of Grand Scholar Li."

The wind rustled the carriage curtains, casting shifting patterns of light and shadow across Xie Zheng's jade-like face. His eyes were half-lowered, long lashes veiling his expression as he asked ambiguously, "Are you two close?"

Changyu instinctively straightened her posture.

Only one thought crossed her mind: if he found out she often copied Li Huaian's arithmetic homework with Qi Zhu, she'd definitely get scolded.

She immediately cleared her throat lightly, "We're just classmates, sharing ordinary schoolmate camaraderie."

Xie Zheng narrowed his eyes slightly at her transparent attempt to cover up.

The restlessness in his chest intensified, and he closed his eyes again in irritation.

Seeing his silence, Changyu ventured another question, "Since your return, have you visited Aunt Xie yet?"

A faint "hmph" escaped Xie Zheng's nostrils.

His tone was decidedly cold.

Changyu realized she'd asked a foolish question—of course his first visit would be to Madam Xie. She remained silent for the rest of the journey.

Fortunately, the carriage soon arrived at the Meng residence. Before alighting, Changyu politely asked, "Would you like to come in for some tea, brother?"

Calling him "brother" still felt somewhat awkward on her tongue.

Xie Zheng finally opened his eyes, "I need to visit my uncle's residence first. I'll pay respects to Aunt Meng another day."

Changyu nodded, waving as she jumped down from the carriage, "Goodbye then, brother!"

Xie Zheng's brow seemed to furrow slightly. Without a word, he dropped the carriage curtain and departed.

Watching the receding carriage from the entrance, Changyu murmured with confusion, "Did his temper grow along with his height?"

Upon entering the residence, a snow-white bundle came flying toward her.

"Sister! Sister! There's a huge bird at home!" After hugging Changning's legs tightly, the child excitedly gestured with outstretched hands.

Looking toward the courtyard, Changyu indeed spotted a Gyr Falcon confined in a cage.

It wasn't the one Xie Zheng had used to deliver letters to her—this one was slightly smaller, seemingly not fully grown, pure white with only slightly mottled tail feathers that made it quite distinctive.

Her face lit up with delight as she hurriedly asked Meng Lihua, "Mother, where did this come from?"

Meng Lihua smiled, "The young Marquis sent it, said it's a gift for you."

The smile on Changyu's face faded slightly. Approaching the cage, she reached out to stroke the Gyr Falcon's head, but the fierce bird immediately tried to peck her.

Meng Lihua exclaimed urgently, "Don't touch it! The young Marquis said this Gyr Falcon is unfamiliar with people, needs to be tamed with a whistle —"

Changyu grabbed the Gyr Falcon by its neck and smacked its head twice. The bird let out a piercing cry, losing several neck feathers in its struggle.

When Changyu reached to pet its head again, the bird stood with ruffled neck feathers, not daring to move.

She turned to Meng Lihua and declared, "It's behaved now."

Meng Lihua: "..."

After playing with the Gyr Falcon for a while, Changyu returned to her own courtyard, climbing onto the roof to lie on the blue tiles while gazing blankly at the clear blue sky.

She truly didn't like the capital at all.

There were too many rules here, too many complications.

When she first attended the Imperial College, the Prince of Gong's son was also there. Though he didn't dare provoke her openly, he secretly forbade other girls her age from associating with her.

The daughter of a Record Keeper who had become somewhat close to her was bullied and harassed by him leading a group of young lackeys. Unable to swallow her anger, she beat up the son of Prince Gong again. However, this matter was only resolved after Madam Xie intervened to plead on her behalf, and her mother took her to apologize to the son of Prince Gong.

Her mother punished her by making her kneel on a stone slab to reflect on her mistakes, but she insisted she had done nothing wrong.

Her mother's expression at the time seemed deeply sorrowful, yet she still told her, "A Yu, in this world, sometimes it is also wrong to act beyond one's capabilities when one lacks the ability."

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At the time, she didn't fully understand. But when she returned to the Imperial College and found all the other girls avoiding her, even the Record Keeper's daughter keeping her distance, she finally felt hurt and wronged.

She vaguely realized that here, sincerity and frankness weren't needed. One had to follow the rules set by these people, otherwise they would be ostracized as an outsider.

Later, she unexpectedly became close friends with Qi Zhu, and those girls who had previously avoided her gradually began to approach her.

She knew the reason was that Qi Zhu's status was more noble than that of the Crown Prince's son.

By approaching her now, they wouldn't be targeted by the Crown Prince's son anymore, and could even befriend Qi Zhu instead.

Ultimately, it all boiled down to "seeking advantage and avoiding harm."

She didn't like this place, where everyone lived behind a mask.

During these five years, whenever she felt down, she would practice with her sword. Only in those moments of full-force chopping did she feel truly free.

Sometimes she even envied Xie Zheng. Was he so clever that he had known all along what awaited him upon returning to the capital, choosing instead to remain beyond the frontier?

The young maiden in the bloom of her youth rested her head on her arm, chewing on a blade of grass as she closed her eyes in the warm sunlight.

If only she could return to the northern lands too.

Wei Mansion.

Xie Zheng entered the front courtyard and was led by the steward through a covered corridor, where he encountered a young man in crimson

official robes. Though he appeared barely twenty, his bearing already carried the steadiness cultivated through officialdom's ups and downs.

His features were handsome, but at first glance, one could tell he was a man of particularly reserved nature.

Xie Zheng called out from afar: "Cousin, are you heading out?"

Wei Shubai gave him a slight nod: "With the floods in Jiangnan, His Majesty has entrusted this important matter to the Crown Prince. The Eastern Palace must quickly draft plans, so I'll have to postpone welcoming you until later."

He had passed the imperial examination at seventeen and now served as a Crown Prince's advisor.

Xie Zheng smiled: "State affairs take precedence. I won't be leaving the capital anytime soon now that I'm back - we'll have plenty of time to meet."

Wei Shubai acknowledged this and added: "Mother and your aunt are busy in the kitchen, Father is in his study. You may go straight there."

In the third month of spring, the courtyard plants flourished with vitality.

Xie Zheng sat in a round-backed chair near the wall, watching the middle-aged man handling documents with his brush. He said: "Over these five years, Father has been wearing down the Northern Turks. With only twenty percent more supplies than ordinary border troops, he's fought them this long until their national strength is depleted. Now if the court would just allocate sufficient funds and provisions, we could strike directly at the Northern Turks' heartland. For those old fossils at court to propose truce now would only allow the Northern Turks to recuperate and return stronger in a few years."

"I've come to the capital on Father's behalf to persuade His Majesty to continue the campaign and eliminate the Northern Turk threat once and for all."

The middle-aged man finally set down his brush after finishing the last document. When he looked up, his sharp phoenix eyes were identical to Xie Zheng's, though the corners now bore wrinkles carved by time: "Do you truly believe it's only those old fossils opposing the continuation of this war?"

Xie Zheng's expression tightened abruptly, his gaze turning sharply keen.

Wei Yan set aside the approved document and looked at his nephew with a complicated expression. "I know your father has been fighting moderately these years to completely exhaust the Northern Jue, making them believe they can take this fat piece of meat and luring them to repeatedly invade, draining their national strength. But in His Majesty's eyes, it may not be seen that way."

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Xie Zheng's hand, resting on the arm of the round-backed chair, unconsciously clenched into a fist. "Father has always been loyal to His Majesty!"

Wei Yan, however, abruptly changed the subject. "Do you know why the Crown Prince has yet to appoint a Crown Princess?"

Xie Zheng frowned slightly. "Rumors say the Crown Prince is particularly fond of a concubine, to the extent that even his eldest son was born to her."

Wei Yan took a slow sip of tea and asked, "Do you believe that?"

Xie Zheng's brow furrowed even tighter. "The Crown Prince is wise and virtuous—he is not the type to be blinded by lust. Could it be that the delay in appointing a Crown Princess is also related to His Majesty?"

Wei Yan's gaze grew particularly complex. "After sitting on that high throne for so long, one likely forgets what they were like in the past."

Xie Zheng remained silent, waiting for Wei Yan to continue.

Wei Yan rose from the Grand Tutor chair and walked to the window, clasping his hands behind his back as he gazed at the wild chrysanthemums filling the courtyard, his eyes deep and distant. "Twenty years ago, His Majesty was much like the current Crown Prince—virtuous, sincere, and benevolent. But back then, the Late Emperor was wary of the Qi family and the Eastern Palace, favoring the Jia mother and son to suppress the Crown Prince. His Majesty tread on thin ice at every step. Later, during the Taiqian Palace coup, it was only through the combined efforts of the Qi, Xie, and Wei families that His Majesty was pushed onto the dragon throne."

"His Majesty remembers the meritorious service of the Qi, Xie, and Wei families in supporting his ascension. But judging by his attitude toward the Eastern Palace over the years, he is also wary of history repeating itself. The Empress's family comes from a civil official background and has repeatedly tried to secure a military-affiliated marriage for the Crown

Prince, only to face repeated setbacks and even lose imperial favor. The Empress may not yet understand His Majesty's intentions, but the Crown Prince has seen through it. That is why, all these years, he has remained with only one concubine and never mentioned appointing a Crown Princess."

Wei Yan turned to look at Xie Zheng. "If he is so wary of his own son, how could he possibly trust and rely entirely on a non-imperial marquis commanding hundreds of thousands of troops stationed far in the northwest? The prominence of your Xie family has long surpassed that of the Qi family. If the hilt of the blade remains firmly in his grasp, he might indulge it. But if he senses that this blade is no longer obedient, have you considered the fate of the Xie family?"

Xie Zheng sat silently in the round-backed chair, his expression cold.

Wei Yan said, "Set aside the plan to counterattack the Northern Jue for now. Even if you bring it up when His Majesty summons you, he can use the recent floods in Jiangnan as an excuse to delay."

Xie Zheng stood up and bowed solemnly to Wei Yan. "Thank you for your guidance, Uncle. I understand."

Wei Yan watched his nephew's retreating figure as he left the study, his eyes, etched with the passage of twenty years, momentarily tinged with melancholy.

In his previous life, by this time, that child had long since turned against him.

Lowering his gaze to the memorial on the corner of the desk about the Jiangnan floods, his eyes held a trace of deep contemplation.

The most unfathomable thing in this world is truly the human heart.

Who could have predicted that the once-renowned Chengde Crown Prince, after sitting on the dragon throne for twenty years, would also begin to fear his own sons and military generals?

Yet, having been indecisive for most of his life, soft-hearted and overly concerned with his reputation, even if he now harbors such wariness, he lacks the means to take decisive action.

As for the one in the Eastern Palace...

Wei Yan recalled the methods of the Crown Prince's eldest son, who had allied with the Li family in his previous life, and tapped his knuckles lightly against the windowsill.

—

Xie Zheng had not expected that, upon arriving in the capital, he would meet the Crown Prince before even seeing the Emperor.

That night, Wei Yan returned home under the moonlight and stars.

Watching the man disguised as Wei Yan's attendant, Xie Zheng cupped his hands in salute after Wei Yan closed the doors and windows: "Greetings, Your Highness the Crown Prince."

Dressed in plain cloth, Qi Min still exuded an air of nobility as he gestured for Xie Zheng to rise: "Marquis, please dispense with formalities. I have long heard of your valor, and seeing you today confirms your extraordinary bearing."

Xie Zheng simply replied: "Your Highness flatters me."

Qi Min motioned for Xie Zheng to be seated. Only after Wei Yan returned did he smile modestly and say: "It was my eagerness to meet heroes that compelled Shu Bai to bring me to see you without prior notice. I hope you won't find my visit too abrupt."

Xie Zheng chuckled, his bright eyes reflecting the spirited confidence unique to youth: "Your Highness's gesture truly makes me feel undeservingly honored."

With the exchange of courtesies, both parties understood each other's stance clearly.

Qi Min stated: "I know you came to the capital regarding military supplies for the campaign against Northern Jue. His Majesty, benevolent to all under heaven, wishes to avoid further conflict and intends to accept Northern Jue's peace proposal. However, I believe negotiation would only be letting the tiger return to the mountains. Great Yin has been recuperating for years, and while Marquis Guan Shan has been containing Northern Jue these five years, no major battles have been fought. Given Great Yin's current national strength, engaging Northern Jue in a decisive battle is entirely feasible."

Xie Zheng straightened his expression and asked: "What is Your Highness's esteemed opinion?"

Qi Min responded: "Esteemed opinion is hardly the term. Marquis Guan Shan is renowned throughout the land, and you, young Marquis, achieved fame in your youth—known throughout court and country. I thought: while Marquis Guan Shan guards Great Yin's territory in the northwest, if you were to hold a nominal post in the capital to instruct those arrogant young nobles here, with both father and son serving Great Yin, His Majesty would surely be pleased."

Understanding Qi Min's implication, Xie Zheng's smile faded slightly: "Thank you for your guidance, Your Highness. I will carefully consider your proposal."

With this, Qi Min rose to take his leave. As he fastened his cloak and reached the door, he glanced back at Xie Zheng: "My risky visit today was indeed motivated by a desire to connect with heroes. My own circumstances aren't much better than yours."

Only after Wei Yan saw Qi Min out did Xie Zheng allow himself to lean back in the chair, one arm draped over his eyes, his lips pressed tightly together.

The Crown Prince's meaning was clear: the Xie father and son had gained excessive renown in court and military circles. If he remained in the capital holding a sinecure, his presence as a hostage might reassure the Emperor about Xie Linshan's loyalty.

When Wei Yan returned, Xie Zheng remained in the same position.

Wei Yan sat by the window, picking up a book to browse: "Resenting me?"

Xie Zheng lowered his arm from his eyes and answered listlessly: "No."

Wei Yan said: "The Crown Prince will be a wise ruler. Introducing you to him, I'm not afraid you'll hold it against me."

Recalling what Wei Yan had told him during the day, Xie Zheng looked up at his cousin: "How many other military commanders has the Crown Prince secretly contacted?"

Wei Yan's gaze lifted from the book pages, finally showing some surprise: "You're quite perceptive. Besides you, the only other family in the capital worthy of the Crown Prince's proactive outreach is the Shen family."

Xie Zheng looked at him inquiringly about the outcome.

Wei Subai said helplessly, "Lord Shen Guo is a loyal minister, but after all, he is a veteran official who has served three dynasties and has far-sighted vision. Although Shen Shen was once as renowned as you in earlier years, later he only gained a reputation as a wastrel. The reason was that he was betrayed by a courtesan, and from then on, he never recovered."

Xie Zheng's expression became somewhat indescribable: "Shen Shen... it couldn't be that bad."

Wei Subai glanced at Xie Zheng: "When the Crown Prince's honored guests were discussing strategies for you and your uncle today, someone suggested that you also pretend to be heartbroken and become a wastrel and libertine to put His Majesty at ease. I said it wouldn't work—the Shen family has already used this tactic, and if you use it again, it would be redundant. Moreover, if you have a girl you fancy, she might misunderstand, and I'm afraid you'd be annoyed again..."

Xie Zheng interrupted Wei Subai: "I've been in the military camp for five years—where would I find a girl I fancy?"

Wei Subai laughed: "I often hear Auntie mention you and General Meng's daughter. I thought you were childhood sweethearts, innocent playmates."

Xie Zheng recalled the girl he met today who kept calling him "elder brother," and felt an inexplicable tightness in his chest. Hearing Wei Subai's words now made it even worse. A trace of impatience flickered across his refined features: "What nonsense are you talking about? A troublemaker since she could walk—only Mother likes her and treats her kindly."

Wei Subai looked at Xie Zheng and smiled meaningfully: "I think Miss Meng is sincere and pure-hearted, which is rare and precious."

Xie Zheng remembered the little girl from his memories, and for some reason, her current appearance surfaced in his mind, adding to his irritation. He only said: "I see her as a younger sister."

Wei Subai hummed in acknowledgment, "That would suit Mother's wishes. She often tells Auntie that she wants to find a good match for Miss Meng. But Auntie says she can't bear to part with her, and hopes you might come to your senses in a few years when you return. Otherwise, she'll have to watch the daughter-in-law she raised since childhood become someone else's."

Xie Zheng frowned: "I've long told Mother that I only see her as a younger sister."

As soon as he said this, his heart grew even more unsettled. Impatiently, he raised his eyebrows: "What's with you today, cousin? Why keep talking about this?"

Wei Subai smiled: "You're almost nineteen now. In another year, you'll be of age—it's time to think about marriage."

Xie Zheng lifted his eyelids: "You're not in a hurry, cousin, so why should I be?"

Seeing him turn the topic back on himself, Wei Subai knew when to stop: "Fine, I won't discuss this with you anymore. It's late tonight—go back to your room and rest."

Wei Subai left with his wide sleeves flowing, but Xie Zheng couldn't sleep.

He left his room and sat leaning against a pillar on the wooden rail of the Wei Mansion's waterside pavilion, one leg propped up. Gazing at the full moon reflected in the water, he inexplicably recalled the scene today at the Jin Wengong Mansion's pavilion where he encountered Changyu.

The girl was tall and slender, dressed in a pomegranate-red skirt. As she lay on the leaning rail, half of her skirt trailed on the ground. Green lotus leaves covered her face, leaving only her dark hair cascading over the long bench, like a red carp stranded on shore.

The moon's reflection in the water seemed to transform into the girl's face—bright and captivating features, yet gazing at him with a slightly silly smile.

Xie Zheng frowned and tossed a stone into the water. The ripples scattered, and the bright, charming face in the water disappeared along with them.

Changyu saw Xie Zheng again during the archery class at the Imperial College.

While changing into their equestrian attire, the noble ladies chattered incessantly about the new martial arts instructor.

But Changyu had never concerned herself with such matters, so she paid no attention. It wasn't until they lined up on the training field and saw

him that she was taken aback.

Their previous martial arts instructor, his face stern beneath a thick beard, announced: "Instructor Xie is a general who has fought beyond the frontier, slain Northern Jue barbarians, and achieved illustrious military exploits. His archery skills are renowned for hitting the bull's-eye from a hundred paces. Henceforth, Instructor Xie will teach you archery. Do not slack off!"

The students responded in unison, though the female disciples' replies were noticeably more enthusiastic.

Xie Zheng remained expressionless throughout. Only after the martial arts instructor finished his lecture did he speak his first words, his face cold: "Run ten laps around the training field."

This left everyone dumbfounded. A chorus of "Ah?" echoed, as if they thought the new instructor had misspoken out of ignorance.

But Xie Zheng showed no intention of retracting his order. Thus, the group of young men and women had no choice but to resign themselves and start running laps around the field.

As luck would have it, Qi Zhu had taken leave that day. The princes, seeing the noble ladies all running laps, couldn't bring themselves to admit they couldn't complete the task. The noble ladies, observing that the pampered princes remained silent, dared not complain either.

By the fourth lap, one of the frailer princes turned pale and declared he couldn't go on, and was led away by a eunuch waiting outside the field.

Seeing even a prince give up, the noble ladies also began to drop out one after another, claiming they couldn't run anymore.

In the first archery class under the new instructor, less than one-tenth of the original students remained to practice archery.

When Xie Zheng explained the essentials of archery, he seemed utterly unconcerned about how many were left. After his brief instruction, he had them practice individually for a short while before examining them one by one on their target shooting.

While practicing, Changyu even overheard two princes grumbling: "Why did this living Yama come to be our martial arts instructor instead of staying on the battlefield to kill barbarians? What a waste of talent!"

Changyu also felt it was a waste for Xie Zheng to teach at the Imperial College.

A man as untamed and free-spirited as him belonged in the vast frontiers. Why had he taken up such a duty?

Distracted by these thoughts, when it was her turn to shoot, she missed the target entirely.

Xie Zheng's face darkened as if he wanted to devour someone.

He immediately ordered the other students to continue practicing while he focused solely on Changyu.

The few princes and officials' sons who hadn't yet taken their turns shooting looked at Changyu with grateful eyes.

Standing on the archery range aiming at the target, Changyu felt a chill run down her spine.

After shooting three arrows that all hit the bull's-eye, she turned to look at Xie Zheng, awaiting his verdict.

Xie Zheng's words fell like hailstones: "Your eyes aren't blind, and your hands aren't broken. How did you manage to miss like that earlier?"

Changyu replied honestly: "I was distracted."

Xie Zheng's expression turned even colder: "You can get distracted while drawing a bow and releasing an arrow? What were you thinking about?"

Nearby, the noble ladies' fantasies about Xie Zheng had completely shattered. They looked at Changyu with immense sympathy as she endured his scolding: "Instructor Xie is too harsh! Changyu is still a young lady—how can he be so severe?"

"My mother was right—you really can't judge a man by his looks. Instructor Xie may be exceptionally handsome, but with such a terrible temper and being a military man, who knows if he might hit someone when angered!"

At these words, the noble ladies who had been watching Xie Zheng and Changyu from a distance grew even paler, collectively taking several steps backward.

On the archery field, Changyu was also feeling somewhat aggrieved by Xie Zheng's series of cold remarks. When he questioned her again, she

answered honestly, "I was thinking about you..."

The bronze bell rang, signaling the end of the archery class.

Interrupted by the bell, Changyu was about to finish her unfinished sentence when she noticed Xie Zheng's anger falter, as if stunned by her half-spoken words. His expression turned extremely peculiar, and he only said, "Stop indulging in wild fantasies!"

Changyu realized he had misunderstood and hurriedly said, "I didn't..."

But Xie Zheng raised his hand to stop her, seemingly unwilling to hear more, and stated, "Today's lesson ends here."

Changyu watched helplessly as he walked away with an icy demeanor, nearly stumbling and falling face-first on the steps outside the training ground.

Changyu scratched her head, "Did I really make him that angry?"

What she had meant to say was, "I was thinking about why you came here."

Because of the incident during the archery class, Changyu felt gloomy all day.

She believed Xie Zheng must have misunderstood her words. Since he was so angry, she needed to clarify things with him.

Her classmates, seeing her dejected, assumed she had been severely reprimanded by Xie Zheng and expressed their indignation on her behalf: "Instructor Xie is too strict! He really doesn't consider a young lady's dignity at all!"

"Exactly! No wonder my mother says no matter how handsome someone looks, if they're from the military, they're mostly rough and uncouth!"

"Changyu, I have some Almond Crisp for you. Don't be upset."

"Here, have my plum wine candied fruits!"

"And my pine nut thin biscuits!"

...

In the end, Changyu was bewildered as she received a book bag full of snacks from the noble young ladies.

Li Huaian, a student from the neighboring Upper Jia Academy, had likely also heard about Changyu being scolded by the martial instructor. Since Qi Zhu wasn't around today, he proactively waited for Changyu outside the academy. When he saw her, he handed over his abacus homework as familiarly as ever: "I've finished the problems the instructor assigned today."

Taking the exercise book, Changyu reciprocated by pulling out a handful of candies given to her by the noble young ladies from her book bag and said sincerely, "Thank you."

Li Huaian, holding the candies, was at a loss and could only reply with a mix of amusement and exasperation, "Thank you, Miss Meng."

Changyu waved her hand, "No need, no need."

Turning around, she noticed someone standing by the moon gate whom she hadn't seen before. His face was like cold jade, his eyebrows dark as ink, and his gaze was piercingly cold, fixed squarely on the two of them.

Changyu's skin prickled with tension, feeling as if she had been caught red-handed copying homework by Xie Zheng.

Li Huaian, however, felt that the young man's gaze was so icy and gloomy it seemed as though he wanted to sever the hands holding the candies.

Just as Changyu was struggling to find words to break the awkward silence, she saw Xie Zheng cast a cold glance at her before turning and walking away.

Fearful that Xie Zheng would report this to her mother—who would surely be angry, and even more humiliated if Ning Niang found out she had copied abacus homework—she quickly retrieved Li Huaian's abacus booklet and returned it to him. "I'm sorry, my elder brother saw us. I won't take this booklet home."

After returning the booklet, she grabbed her book bag and hurriedly chased after Xie Zheng.

She ran all the way out of the academy without spotting him. As she was looking around, a cold voice came from nearby: "Over here."

Changyu turned and saw the person leaning against the stone lion beside the academy with arms crossed, and immediately breathed a sigh of relief. She walked over and said, "I thought you had already left."

Xie Zheng glanced at her coldly. "Wouldn't leaving be more convenient for you two?"

Changyu grew angry, frowning at him. "What nonsense are you talking about? I won't copy his arithmetic homework anymore. Is it necessary for you to mock me like this?"

Xie Zheng knew he had spoken recklessly, his rationality nearly overwhelmed by that inexplicable surge of fury.

He fell silent for a moment before asking, "How long has this been going on?"

The anger that had just flared up in Changyu immediately vanished, replaced by guilt. She hung her head and traced circles on the ground with her toe. "Since last year when we studied the 'Commercial Calculations' chapter of the Nine Chapters on Mathematical Art. I kept making mistakes and was scolded by the teacher several times, so I started copying his homework with the Eldest Princess..."

Qi Zhu felt that as a princess of the nation, being reprimanded by the teacher was embarrassing, so she brought Changyu along to copy the homework.

Changyu thought that since Qi Zhu was copying, refusing to do so would be disrespectful to her, so she joined in.

Xie Zheng stared at her. "You learn all the wrong things..."

Changyu didn't explain further, and since she had indeed copied, she drooped her head and said dejectedly, "I know I was wrong. Please don't tell my mother."

With her head bowed, looking obedient and ready to be scolded, and him maintaining a cold expression like a villain, passing students frequently glanced their way.

Xie Zheng's temple twitched twice. Keeping a stern face, he asked, "You can't solve commercial calculation problems?"

Changyu whispered, "Now there are also the equation chapter and the Pythagorean theorem chapter."

Xie Zheng: "..."

Finally, he rubbed his forehead and prepared to take her to a tavern as he used to in the northern lands, but for some reason he paused and asked,

"Where do you usually copy his homework?"

Changyu confessed honestly, "We were afraid of being seen at the academy, so the Eldest Princess and I would book a private room at Ruyi Tavern on the street corner."

Xie Zheng's expression turned even colder. "Convenient for you to gnaw on a pig's trotter too, right?"

A unique anger, as if something precious had been stolen from their past, surged in his heart. Xie Zheng didn't know why he was so furious.

But the thought that someone had taken his place during the five years he was away made his chest tighten inexplicably, filling him with immense malice toward that person.

It was as if that person were a thief who had stolen his most treasured possession.

The current distance between him and Changyu was all because of that thief.

Changyu thought he was angry because she copied Li Huaian's arithmetic homework and went to the tavern for good food, so she quickly explained, "I didn't eat."

Qi Zhu was an elegant person who would at most order a pot of tea and a few snacks.

Xie Zheng snorted, finally stopping his sarcasm.

But he didn't take her to a tavern private room either. As he led Changyu back, they passed by a riverbank planted with weeping willows and featuring a pavilion with stone tables and stools.

He took Changyu inside, crossed his arms, and said, "We'll study here. Speak up if you encounter any problems."

Changyu obediently took out her writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone. As she prepared to start writing, she looked up at him hesitantly.

Xie Zheng frowned and asked, "What's wrong?"

Changyu said cautiously, "What if I don't know how to solve any of them?"

Xie Zheng took a deep breath, restraining his temper as he asked, "What have you been learning at the Imperial College all these years?"

Changyu whispered, "I missed just one lesson in arithmetic class, and then I couldn't understand anything after that..."

Xie Zheng looked up at her and said, "You don't know any of it, yet you dare to copy someone else's homework?"

Changyu, both guilty and helpless, replied, "It's because I don't know it that I copied..."

Xie Zheng glared at her fiercely, "Stay away from that Li family boy from now on. He gives you the answers when you don't know them—he's full of bad intentions. When I helped you copy those poems and essays before, it was only because you had already memorized them perfectly that I wrote them for you."

Even Li Huaian was scolded along with her, and Changyu actually felt quite guilty. But now that she was caught in a vulnerable position, she didn't dare speak loudly. She just hung her head and listened to the lecture, appearing so meek and pitiful.

Xie Zheng glanced at her and finally stopped his scolding, saying, "Take out your book. Today I'll start teaching you again from the 'Shang Gong' chapter."

Changyu took out the book. Without even looking at it, Xie Zheng directly explained: "'Shang' means estimation. 'Gong' refers to labor and time. So 'Shang Gong' is calculating the size of objects to estimate the manpower required for engineering projects. For instance, with continuous warfare in the northern regions, city walls need annual repairs. Determining how much earth and stone craftsmen should gather—all this must be calculated using Shang Gong methods."

Changyu, who had been drooping listlessly, instantly became focused upon hearing Xie Zheng's explanation.

Xie Zheng's voice continued: "'Chuan di' means excavating earth, 'jian' refers to compacted soil, 'rang' is loose soil, 'xu' is ruined earth. To calculate loose soil from excavated earth, multiply by five; for compacted soil, multiply by three—all divided by four..."

He taught from midday until sunset, and Changyu finally grasped the Shang Gong chapter, even accurately solving the problems left by their teacher.

This put Changyu in high spirits. Noticing his lips were nearly parched from speaking, she generously bought a bunch of longans from an old man poling a boat selling them along the river.

Xie Zheng turned his face away: "I don't like sweet things."

"What a pity," Changyu said regretfully. "Then I'll have to eat them for you."

She plucked one from the trimmed branch, squeezed it between both hands, and the translucent white flesh popped out. Its refreshing sweetness filled her mouth as she ate.

Xie Zheng sat on the wooden railing of the pavilion with one knee bent, leaning against a pillar as if watching the river winding into the distance under the setting sun. Yet his gaze occasionally drifted sideways, lingering on the girl squatting on a stone stool, her hands stained with longan juice.

As she bit at the fruit flesh being squeezed out, the corner of her mouth brushed against the longan skin, picking up a speck of dust from the peel like a tiny mole forming there.

The more Xie Zheng looked, the more it bothered him—or rather, that tiny stain hooked onto his heart like a barb, itching and irritating him.

When his gaze swept over again, he finally frowned and spoke: "You've got something dirty at the corner of your mouth."

"Hmm?" Hearing this, Changyu wiped with her hand and turned her head: "Gone now?"

Xie Zheng glanced and said, "Still there."

Changyu wiped more vigorously, rubbing the corner of her mouth red.

"Come here," Xie Zheng frowned.

Changyu obediently approached. When his index finger brushed her mouth corner, both froze momentarily.

The sunset dyed the entire river red, her face flushed too. Only the corner of her mouth, from eating too many longans, seemed moist when his thumb brushed over it.

Xie Zheng caught a whiff of fresh sweetness, like the fragrance of longan flesh.

"Done." As he withdrew his hand, he hid it behind his back, for the first time not daring to look directly at the girl before him.

His heart pounded like war drums, just like his first time on the battlefield.

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That night, Xie Zheng inexplicably had a dream.

In the dream, they were still at the riverside pavilion. Changyu held a bunch of longans, eating them, her rosy lips glistening with the sweet juice of the fruit like peach petals adorned with morning dew in March.

She opened her clear, bright almond eyes and asked him: "Is there something on my lips?"

He stared at her clean lips, wanting to say no, yet inexplicably began panting. Uncontrollably, he cupped the back of her neck and kissed her with some roughness...

When Xie Zheng jolted awake from the dream, his expression was extremely grim. He threw off the covers and went to the adjoining room to take a cold bath.

Changyu didn't see Xie Zheng for several consecutive days. She no longer followed him to Ruyi Tavern to copy Li Huaian's arithmetic homework. When Qi Zhu learned that her "elder brother" had discovered this, she felt quite sympathetic toward Changyu.

But soon Qi Zhu also stopped copying Li Huaian's homework.

Changyu found this somewhat strange. Qi Zhu feared nothing and no one, and only her mother could manage to control her.

However, Qi Zhu blushed and stammered, saying that their teacher had found out and was displeased.

Changyu knew that the teacher Qi Zhu cared about was none other than the young Master Gongsun, who had only placed third in the imperial examinations two years prior and was currently temporarily assigned to teach at the Imperial College.

How Teacher Gongsun discovered that Qi Zhu was copying homework, Changyu didn't know. But now Qi Zhu went to Teacher Gongsun for extra arithmetic lessons every day after school, and Changyu felt rather envious.

Wondering if Xie Zheng thought she was too foolish, Changyu noticed that he had been avoiding her afterward, as if afraid to continue teaching her.

When Li Huaian learned that Changyu needed to intensively study arithmetic, he kindly offered to teach her.

Changyu thought that once she mastered it, she could finally hold her head high in front of Xie Zheng.

Unfortunately, on the very first day Li Huaian was teaching her, Xie Zheng came again to pick her up after school.

Seeing the young man standing by the door, his gaze cold enough to freeze ice, Li Huaian swallowed hard while holding the textbook and said, "Miss... Miss Meng, your elder brother is here. Perhaps I should teach you another day?"

Seeing that Xie Zheng seemed to be in an extremely bad mood and knowing he already held prejudices against Li Huaian, Changyu feared implicating the innocent and nodded.

After Li Huaian left, she pursed her lips and said, "I wasn't copying his homework. I was learning the chapter on equitable transportation from him."

"Oh? How's the learning going?" Xie Zheng lifted his eyes to look at her. His tone sounded calm, yet somehow this calmness was intimidating.

Changyu said, "I haven't mastered it yet."

Xie Zheng said, "Let's go back. I'll teach you."

Changyu looked up at him in surprise: "I thought you found me too stupid and didn't want to teach me anymore."

Xie Zheng looked at her with a cold smile: "You are indeed stupid, so from now on, don't make assumptions."

Changyu: "..."

Unable to contain her anger, she said: "I sent you a return gift, but you refused to see me. If that's not you avoiding me because you didn't want to teach me, then what was it?"

Xie Zheng paused in his steps, and Changyu nearly bumped into his hard back.

He turned around, and Changyu looked up to meet his gaze, only seeing his bottomless dark eyes.

He said: "I've been thinking about some things. Once I figure them out, I can see you."

Changyu asked in confusion: "What things?"

Xie Zheng, however, said: "You wouldn't want to know right now."

Changyu found this baffling.

But under Xie Zheng's "earnest teaching," her arithmetic studies earned her the top grade of A1 by the end of the academic year.

Changyu only heard fragments about court affairs from her mother and classmates. She knew that a tough battle was imminent beyond the frontier, that Uncle Xie would lead her father and grandfather beyond the pass to fight the Northern Turks, and that her father wouldn't be able to return to the capital this year to celebrate the New Year with her, her mother, and sister.

Since Madam Xie would be visiting her maternal family on the first day of the new year, she asked Meng Lihua to bring Changyu and her sister to the Xie residence to celebrate New Year's Eve together.

Over the years, whenever Wei Qilin did not return to the capital for the New Year festivities, they had celebrated in this manner. However, this year, with Xie Zheng joining them, the atmosphere seemed livelier than before.

Changning clamored to watch fireworks. While Madam Xie and Meng Lihua were still chatting at the dinner table, Changyu and Xie Zheng had already taken Changning to the courtyard to set off firecrackers and fireworks.

The two older ones indulged the little one in their boisterous play until Changning, tired out like a little piglet, grew drowsy.

Changyu wrapped her in a thick blanket and laid her down to sleep on the soft couch in the warm pavilion.

Having drunk too much fruit wine during the meal, and after running around in the snow and setting off firecrackers outside, Changyu's face was flushed—whether from the wind or the lingering effects of the alcohol—and her mind grew hazy.

There were no extra blankets in the warm pavilion, but a charcoal brazier was placed under the low table. She leaned over the table to rest for a while, waiting for Meng Lihua and Madam Xie to finish their conversation so they could all return home together.

When Xie Zheng came looking for them, he found both the older and younger girls fast asleep in the warm pavilion.

Outside, the wind and snow were fierce. He unfastened his cloak and draped it over Changyu's shoulders.

Changyu murmured something indistinctly in her sleep, but the wine had left her deeply unconscious, and she did not wake.

Xie Zheng gazed down at her flushed face in the candlelight, his eyes lingering on her full lips.

In the flickering candlelight, the young man rose with a soft sigh. After one last glance at the girl sleeping peacefully at the table, he quietly closed the door of the warm pavilion and left. Only then did the girl's long, closed eyelashes flutter slightly.

Her already rosy lips appeared slightly swollen in the candlelight.

Shortly after the New Year, before Changyu could celebrate her coming-of-age ceremony, tragic news arrived from beyond the frontier: her grandfather had been severely wounded in battle.

Meng Lihua was frantic with worry, but the frontier was thousands of miles from the capital. As a woman of delicate health, with a young daughter not yet five years old, she could not immediately pack up and travel to her father's side to care for him.

Changyu offered to go in her mother's place to visit her grandfather beyond the frontier. Meng Lihua knew that her daughter had trained in martial arts with her father since childhood and had never neglected her skills with the blade even after moving to the capital, often sparring with the estate guards. After careful consideration, she finally agreed.

On the day Changyu set out northward, Xie Zheng rode out of the city to see her off, accompanying her for over ten li.

At their parting, he handed her a token. "This token can mobilize my personal guards. If you encounter any difficulties on your journey, do not hesitate to seek their help."

Changyu clutched the token and asked, "You're giving it to me, but what about you?"

The wind and snow were too fierce. Seated on his horse, Xie Zheng glanced back toward the capital and said, "I cannot return for now."

Changyu only vaguely understood his meaning, faintly guessing that Xie Linshan's successful campaign against the Northern Jue might be related to Xie Zheng's role as a martial instructor at the Imperial College.

Xie Zheng said no more. Leaning over from his horse, he took advantage of his long reach to pat her head, just as he had when they were children. "When you see Old General Meng, give him my regards."

Changyu murmured an acknowledgment.

Xie Zheng then took a brocade box from his robes and handed it to her. "Your birthday is in a few days. I had intended to give this to you as a coming-of-age gift on the day, but I must present it to you now."

Changyu opened the box and found an exquisitely crafted jade hairpin. The pin was pure white, save for a splash of pigeon's blood red at the end, like the first glow of sunrise—a touch that brought the entire piece to life.

She frowned. "This is too precious..."

The quality of the jade alone made it clear that this was no ordinary piece.

Xie Zheng scoffed, "For your coming-of-age ceremony, would I give you something unworthy?"

Changyu seemed to recall something and fell silent.

Xie Zheng, however, looked at her with unusual seriousness. "When you come of age, I have something to say to you."

Changyu lowered her gaze and gave a slight nod.

Xie Zheng reined his horse back a few steps. "Go now. Be careful on the road."

The carriage had traveled far across the snow-covered ground when Changyu lifted the curtain to look back. She could still see the young man standing tall on the low slope, his posture straight as an ancient cypress.

—

Yet Xie Zheng never expected that this parting would nearly cost him the girl forever.

At the end of February, urgent battlefield reports from the northern frontier once again raced eight hundred li to the capital.

The emperor was furious after reading the reports, and the entire court was shaken.

General Sui Tuo, dissatisfied with Xie Linshan's order for him to remain garrisoned inside the pass, had led his troops deep into the desert in pursuit of the enemy, hoping to claim military merit. A cornered Northern Turk army, after days without supplies and driven by desperation, turned to attack Jinzhou—only to find the city poorly defended.

Overjoyed, the Northern Turk forces launched a ferocious assault like starving wolves closing in on prey.

The severely wounded Meng Shuyuan ordered the evacuation of the city's civilians and donned his armor, preparing to defend the city walls to the death. But his granddaughter, who had been attending to him in the army, unexpectedly produced a token, rallied a group of elite soldiers, and commanded the personal guards to escort Meng Shuyuan to safety. She then put on his armor and took charge of the defense on the city walls.

When they could no longer hold the line, she led the remaining troops in a feint retreat to lure the enemy away, buying more time for the civilians to escape. In the end, the Northern Turks forced her over a cliff, and her fate remained unknown.

Xie Linshan returned with the main army in time to reinforce Jinzhou. The city was saved, and the civilians had sufficient time to evacuate with few casualties. But despite sending numerous search parties for Meng Shuyuan's granddaughter, there was still no news.

When Meng Lihua first heard the tragic news, she nearly wept herself unconscious. Wei Wan stayed by her side without leaving.

Upon hearing the news, Xie Zheng immediately rode post-haste to the palace.

No one knew what he said to the emperor. After leaving the palace, he didn't even return home, only instructing his attendant to relay a message before galloping northward.

A journey that usually took three to five days even for an eight-hundred-li urgent courier, Xie Zheng covered in just two and a half days, riding day and night until he reached the cliff where Changyu had fallen.

Fortunately, a great river flowed below. He followed it downstream, asking everyone he met along the way. Half a month later, he finally found her in a small town called Lin'an.

An elderly couple named Zhao had discovered her by the frozen river. Thinking she was already frozen to death, they kindly intended to bury the unknown girl—only to find she still clung to a thread of life.

The old man, a former veterinarian, tried a desperate remedy as a last resort. Against all odds, the girl's stubborn will to live pulled her through.

After half a month of hardship and exposure, a disheveled Xie Zheng stood at the gate of the Zhao family's small courtyard. A snow-white Gyr Falcon landed on a nearby rooftop, beneath which a dilapidated wooden window stood half-open.

Inside, by the window, a girl wrapped in a patched, worn-out coat sat on the bed, holding a chipped medicine bowl. Her brows were tightly furrowed as she struggled to drink the bitter brew.

Xie Zheng's eyes suddenly reddened.

He took a step forward, but as the tension in his heart eased, the exhaustion and chill of nearly half a month without rest overwhelmed him. Darkness swept over his vision, and he lost consciousness.

Changyu heard a loud "thud" and turned to see the young man collapsed at the doorway. Holding the medicine bowl, she exchanged a bewildered look with the elderly woman keeping vigil by the bed.

—

When Xie Zheng woke again, he found only the old man surnamed Zhao tending to him at the bedside. Suppressing a cough from the lingering chill, he rasped out, "Where is the young lady I was looking for?"

The old man replied, "That young lady injured her leg and still can't leave her bed. She's resting in the next room."

Xie Zheng tilted his head to glance out the window. After days of heavy snow, the sun had finally emerged. Sunlight filtered through the paper-

covered wooden window, offering little warmth yet bringing a comforting glow to the heart.

When the old man left for his carpentry work, Xie Zheng struggled to drape a coat over his shoulders and stepped out of the room.

The window of the opposite room remained open. Bathed in sunlight, the young woman sat grooming the snow-white feathers of the Gyr Falcon perched on the windowsill with her still-scabbed fingers, occasionally murmuring something with a soft smile.

Xie Zheng leaned against the doorframe watching her for a long time.

Noticing him at last, Changyu turned her head: "You're awake? Your chill hasn't subsided—don't stand in the wind, or the fever might return tonight."

His gaze remained fixed on her, voice gravely serious: "I almost thought I'd lost you."

Changyu paused briefly before smiling: "What if you truly couldn't find me?"

Xie Zheng responded: "I'd have found you regardless. Alive or dead."

Still smiling, she asked: "And now that you have?"

Xie Zheng said: "I wish to ask if you'd marry me."

Tilting her head, Changyu inquired: "Is this what you meant that day when you saw me off from the capital? Something you wanted to tell me after I came of age?"

The pale, ailing youth leaning against the doorframe answered slowly: "Yes."

His expression was resolute and unyielding.

Changyu asked: "What if I refuse?"

Xie Zheng replied: "While your leg is injured and you can't run away, I'd carry you back to wed."

Changyu laughed again: "Since when are you so overbearing?"

With utter sincerity, Xie Zheng stated: "I've never been a good man."

Frowning slightly, Changyu patted her own head: "How strange. I feel like you've said this to me before."

She broke into another laugh: "Speaking of which, while I was unconscious from my injury, I had the most peculiar dream. In it, you were the one wounded and stranded here, while I became a butcher's daughter."

Listening quietly, Xie Zheng said: "If I could truly take your place in suffering, I would."

But Changyu shook her head: "The dream was too bitter. You lost your parents, I lost mine. The present is better."

Xie Zheng chided gently: "Silly girl, dreams are never real."

Nodding in agreement, Changyu said: "Right, it must have been false—in the dream, you even married into my family! How absurd..."

Xie Zheng fell silent for a breath, looking up at her with an indescribable expression: "What exactly do you usually think about?"

Changyu immediately raised three fingers: "Heaven as my witness, I never imagined you marrying into my family—"

Xie Zheng abruptly interrupted: "Was Li Huaian in your dream?"

Being an honest soul, Changyu nodded earnestly: "Yes."

Watching Xie Zheng's face darken, she added in confusion: "But in the dream, I never copied his homework. It was you who taught me to read."

Just as Xie Zheng began to feel somewhat appeased, he heard her mumble: "Though in the dream, I also had a fiancé..."

Xie Zheng's temple twitched as he barked an order to someone unseen, "Prepare the carriage at once! Tie her up and bring her back to the residence!"

Changyu watched several shadow guards drop from the roof and immediately clung to the windowsill in alarm, glaring at him. "What are you doing?"

Xie Zheng gritted his teeth fiercely. "Taking you back to get married!"

Better to act now than risk complications later!

Changyu clung to the windowsill and wailed, "No! I want to go to the battlefield, slay enemies, and become a general!"



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Pursuit of Jade (Chasing Jade)

逐玉 · Zhu Yu

by Tuan Zi Lai Xi (团子❀)

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